David (Chapter 1)

Wednesday, 26 January 2022 9:19 PM

The roar of the crowd was becoming louder as I approach to the gate leading to the coliseum field. With every foot I take, the cheers of every person is getting louder. There excitement is even more effusive since no one knows who the other opponent is. I myself am confused who the Citradels elders have been hiding all this time. Kafar says this person is a hidden weapon of Citradel and supposedly formidable enough to have kept the Hive commander away from their home for years. It's difficult to imagine anyone tougher than Marina among all the Citradels people. It's unbelievable that someone stronger than him or the Hive commander has gone unnoticed all these years. Who is it? Why have they been kept secrete for so long? As I reach in front of the gate, I mumble to myself, Its time.

Ahead me, I can see a glimmer of golden radiating in the air. Hmm. Weird. I focused a bit more and allowed my eyes to fill up more radiations. The golden slimmer was not filled up in front of me, but it was shaped in a silhouette of a person. I immediately stopped. What's this now. Someone trying to stop me ? No. Whoever is here isn't moving, instead they are just waiting. Perhaps for me. Are they a spy. Do I ignore and move on. That would be best. I walked a little closer and saw a new smaller glimmer coming out. This one however, I knew. In fact, we had just clashed recently. I stopped and called out, what's this Blake.

Ahead me a voice responds, Huh damn. You can see me. The golden glimmer started to dissipate and Blake remined behind. He was waiting beside the gate. He was wearing his casuals jeans and a jacket on top. He was leaning against the wall, arms folded and a leg pulled up resting against the wall. It looked like he was waiting for me. I say, You have almost completely hidden your Kuret and everything around you. Blake smiles a little and says, its because of this. He pulls out a small glowing item from his jacket pockets. He opens his palm to reveal a white stone shining not too bright, but enough to catch attention of an eye. I had never seen this before, but I its no brainer to guess that it's a something Marina created. Blake continues, it's a Kuritine to hide the wielders smell, noise and temperature. Yet you managed to see me here. Impressive as ever. It took you what, 5 seconds to figure it out. He scoffs. He raises his hand which held the Kuritine, Marina gave me this to cover my Kuret and other physical presence for a while if I consciously keep my Kuret down.

I ask why?, he says, I wanted to sneak into the Citradels side of rooms and find who you were going to fight. As soon as I heard him walked towards him in shock. I faced him closer, I said, you did what! Blake are you serious? Tell me you didn't spy on them. Blake pulls him palm on the air saying, calm down David. I didn't want to spy on them. But you understand how unsettling this is right? They still haven't revealed their so called prized champion. I replied, That's not a good reason for you to spy on them, dude. If you get caught and they feel violated, they might just pull the plug out of this tournament. We have worked a lot to reach here. I don't want to them to leave for any reason and waste this opportunity. I quickly recalled all the agreements and compromises we had to make just to make this tournament happen so out in the open.

Blake continues, I know. I don't want to risk this also. But it's unfair that they know you and tell nothing about their champion. I know that you also understand how much at a disadvantage they have kept you. Not knowing who your opponent is the worst. Citradel knows how you fight, your style and your power. Others told me that Kafar didn't even bat his eyes when we duked it out on the field. I don't want to sound boastful, but people find you, me and Marina objectively stronger. Kafar wasn't much bothered by my defeat. He scoffs, and it's someone claimed to be stronger than Marina or the Hive Commander. Where were they when we were fighting a year back. Someone who Kafar thinks is stronger than me and you, why they have kept it a secrete and are ready to reveal now. I couldn't possibly just idly sit by and let them have that advantage.

Even when I am angry at him, I knew there was truth in what he said. Not knowing who my opponent is the biggest challenge. Most of my battles are dependent on knowing who I am fighting against. My shadow leader training was all about knowing how my enemy would think, their strategy and how to out maneuver them. It was a vital part for all my missions. I took a moment before asking, you said we. Who all colluded behind my back?

Blake smirks saying, Everyone. I replied, excuse me? When you said everyone you mean. He continues, dude, everyone in the war room decided it was worth the risk. Vanessa, Nathanial, Cass, Matt, Catherine. Hell, even Sierra agreed. I was taken aback when I heard her name. She was supposed to be the voice of reason. I can't believe she didn't stop this. He goes on, and I wouldn't say we did it behind your back. We knew if we told you before you would throw a fit. We didn't want to worry you while you were preparing. We needed your head in the game. So I volunteered to do a little spy on them. I shook my head in disbelief. I said, you are damn right. I would have stopped you guys from pulling a stunt like this. Jeopardizing everything we worked for?. He didn't reply immediately. He says after a moment, believe me. We all discussed at great length. But we agreed, not knowing is much worst. I was about to rebuke him but I held myself. I didn't want to be mad at him and others when they were just looking out for me.

Before I could say anything, he closed his eyes and sighs, well, it doesn't matter now. I already checked their war room about two hours back, I didn't find any person who hasn't participated in the matches. Can you believe it? I risked infiltrating the other side of the coliseum for naught. I looked everywhere, but I couldn't find anyone who was powerful than Derek. I could feel only his Kuret the strongest amongst all. I know this person has to be inside the coliseum, but they also like me has found a way to hide myself. After about 10 minutes, I gave up and went back to others. Told them I couldn't find that person. Others thought it would be wise to not tell you about this. They told me not to tell you.

But you have, I said. He nods, yes. I wanted to let you know that whoever this person is, he or she is very skilled at hiding his Kuret. And that's a bad match for you. Your powers react on others Kuret. And if that person can hide it so well, who knows what other tricks will be shown in the actual battle. I looked over to the gate. The crowds noise were slowly diminishing. It's almost time. I faced Blake again, Look. I appreciate you guys doing this for me. But you shouldn't have. Or maybe you should told me sooner. Blake sighs, I know. Believe me. We wanted you to be in on it. Our search would have been more efficient. Especially when I am not very the expert in infiltrating places. I usually just kick the main door, you know. He laughs, you have no idea how we managed to snuck in their room. We had to bribe one of the engineers who laid out the Kuretine and the circuits underground. With those layout plans, we found a secrete passage on-

I cut him off, on the 3 level where we are running the Kuritine stones to hide and protect this place. He looked shocked. I continue, that passage was small enough for only one person to fit. Let me guess, you had to crawl all the way in that passage to the other side right? Because we running so many detection system in this place, you didn't use any Kuret and crawled with your bare hands and legs. You reached to the sewer crossing, used that path to cross the other side. I closed my eyes, about 300 meters left, then 100 meters to right and finally 200 meters straight you found the upper basement manhole that opens to the room adjacent to war room.

Blake had his mouth hanging out, how the hell did you know. His eyebrows pushed together, dude. What, how?. I open my eyes and sigh, I told you. I wish you would have told me sooner about this. I know all this because I just used the same route just half an hour back. Blake pulled himself away from the wall and walked towards me, you did what! You have got to be kidding me. It was now my turn to feel a little guilty, yeah. I did. And like you guys, I wasn't planning on telling anyone about this.

Blake was in shock now, Damn. You gave me so much crap about taking too much risk when you did the same. I raise my hand. I was more prepared. Unlike you, I wouldn't be caught using my Kuret. I didn't need any layout of the underground passages. So I have much better chance of not getting detected. You on the other hand took a lot more risk than I did. I could see Blake was ticked off. I thought he would still be angry, but he chortles, I can't believe you also did something stupid, man. I rebuked, hey it was not stupid. It was a calculated risk. I wanted to know who I will be fighting. I know Kafar doesn't think me as a problem. He believes whoever the person is, they must be so powerful that not even my Kuret can stop. I thought about the risks, but I decided if I can get even a hint like which house this person belongs to or what his Kuret is, its worth it.

Blake nodded, yeah I guess, if I were in your position I would also do the same. I mean, I know I did it anyway, but I wouldn't have told others. In case I get caught, there is always plausible deniability. Yeah, exactly, I replied. I knew If I got caught, I could somehow persuade them saying it was a rash move and blame it on adrenaline. I shrug my shoulders, but like you I couldn't find anyone who seemed like the next opponent. Blake replies, really. You also couldn't find him?. I said, yeah. In fact, I think that contestants also don't know this mystery wild card entry is supposed to be. I suspect apart from Kafar and his circle, only Derek would know who it is.

Blake says, will he? We already asked him, he didn't give a straight answer, just said that it will be revealed soon enough. I think he just trying to be mysterious and actually doesn't know who it is. I shook my head, no. He definitely knows who it is. After our match was over on the field, he said to me privately to be very careful against the Citradels champion. I got the feeling that he knows how strong this person is. Derek is very smart guy and he knows my strength. And yet he warns me about this mystery person. No way he warns me about someone he never met. I bet he knows, but I think he was promised not to tell anyone who it is.

Blake faces the gate now where the stadium is almost silent, I don't know. He could be just saying that scare you off. Get you to rattle before the match. After thinking over a moment I said, a mind game before the fight ? maybe. I don't think he was lying or manipulating me. I face towards the gate and walked closer. I could now see strands of red and orange flowing around. It's the scent of all the suspense and excitement in the air. Even with the barrier erected, people's presence are still reaching me. I close my eyes for a second to tune out the lights in front of me. I can't afford to have any distractions now. I have a big disadvantage of having no clue who my opponent is.

Blake says anxiously, if this person is not in the war room half hour back, then where the hell are they hiding him. He walks behind me, don't tell me that he will be brought from outside the barrier now. I replied, no. The barrier will remain unchanged until our match is over. We made an agreement with Citradel that we will not risk people's safety. The barrier will not be tampered for the next 3 hours. Blakes says, I know. Then where is this person. I walk towards the gap of the gate to peep. I could see few people on the ground running around with Kuretines in their hand. They were using it to even out the grounds. Some patches of land lay bare. The grass on those spots were uprooted when me and Blakes fought last week. They must be growing those grass back to make the field even again. Only 3 people were on the whole field. They are almost done.

I said, there's only one place where he or she is hiding out now. Blake says, where ? I said, isn't it obvious, in the crowd. I point my finger up. He shook his head, no. Not possible, all the people sitting out there have been vetted rigorously. Everyone's Id and Kuret have been logged to make sure no uninvited guest is here. And they are not allowed to interfere with this match. There is a protective barrier added. Marina doesn't want a repeat of last time, so she has added physical charms to the barrier. Whoever it is, they can't just force themselves on the field now. I have seen the charms casted by Marina. I don't care how strong this person is, they can't break it easily.

I move my eyes towards the crowd now. Oh, I think this person thinks it can be broken. There are 85,000 people gathered here. I bet Kafar somehow managed to hide this person in the crowd. Kafar has been blatantly vague in answering everyone's question. And he has a flare for being mysterious. So its not a stretch to think he will reveal his champion in a dramatic way. I take a breadth, he will most definitely will want to demonstrate this persons strength before the match starts. He wants to dominate this match by making me afraid. Blake replies to my theory, it sounds like something Kafar would do. But Marina's charms are not only strong, it heals on its own also. And at a fast rate. You may be able to break it easily with your black Kuret, and so could I, but I would waste a lot of Kuret in that process. Not a good strategy when there you have a match. If this person does it, they would be wasting a lot of Kuret for just trying to show off.

Or they have a lot of Kuret to use, I said. I have some theories on which the house bloodline this person might belong to. If its one of them, then I know ways to fight them. But something tells me its someone totally unexpected. I face back to Blake, its good that barrier is self healing. I think we are going to need it when this person drops into the field and creates a whole. This person, whoever it is, if they are willing to go along with Kafars theatrics, must also want to show that they will dominate the match. What best way to do that by showing something only I could do.

Blake ponders a while hearing me, yeah. It make senses. It's twisted and arrogant, but that's just right by Kafar's alley. All these months we have known him, still can't figure that guy. I said, you got that right. The only good thing is that no matter who wins this match, our both cities will finally merge. And others outside will join along with us. Blake pauses for a second, yeah. I hope so. But are you sure you are okay with loosing. Winning all the matches up until now, defeating me, Derek, Catherine and Jess. I doubt you would want to stop so close to being the strongest person on this planet.

I guffawed, this again. I told you. I am not interested in gaining any title like that. Blake says, you say that, but you could have then let yourself defeated in our match. I was about to interject, but he didn't let me, I am sure you could have given up without showing that and let everyone believe I won. I remained silent on his remark. Its true, there was a moment near the end where I thought it would be better to just give up. But couldn't do it. I replied, I don't know why I didn't do that. But its definitely not because I want to be the strongest. Blake shook his head, denials not a good look on dude. You need to own it. Blake prodded me with his eyes focused on me. I couldn't find a response to those piercing eyes. He continues, it takes more than just power to win. I should know better than anyone. If anyone other than you had defeated me, I would have not forgiven myself. I am glad that it was you. You should, no, need to win this match. Do you understand?

I felt his bruised ego hearing about his defeat. I told repeatedly that our match could have gone either way. Its easy to know that he doesn't want me to lose now. His expectations on me is causing me to feel such nervousness not felt since our war with Hive Commander. Do I really want to win this match so badly that I would let not let my pride go. I looked at Blake who was waiting for me, I won't deny that my actions have been quite contradictory to what I had initially planned. My plan was to just clear to a certain matches and clear out as much as many powerful Citradel warriors. It would have been actually efficient for me to give up our match and let you fight in this match. I sighed, I guess I am wrangled between my head and my emotions. No matter the outcome of the match, our cities will be joining now. I look at him, I am not saying that I won't fight seriously, but if I am at a big disadvantage, I might forfeit the match. He almost glared at me now, I continued, I am just managing expectations here. You know I don't fight battles going just with wits alone.

Blake looked like he was about to go on a rant, but he held back and then a moment later says, yeah. I can't argue now can I. I lost, you won. You get to decide what you want to do now. He showed a little understanding of my thoughts, and continues. But also you decided to continue our match to the bitter end. We both really went out you know, no punches pulled back, right? It looked like he was probing something from me. I ignored his intent though, I know. As I said, if decide to fight, you don't have to worry about me not begin serious. As frustrating it is, even if I know that its best to give up, I don't think I will be doing that when the moment comes.

He nods after hearing my reassuring words, and remember, you are a Shadow strategist. Never in the history of entire Shadows has a strategist even beaten an attacker. He makes a fist in his hand and punches me in the shoulder, I bet there is no one you cannot defeat with that big brain of yours. I smirk on his comment, Ah, you do know your position was meant to be strongest right? He pulls his hand, yeah well I guess the shadow council didn't realize your potential, otherwise my predecessor would have given you my title.

This made my smile disappear. I didn't want to recall the person who preceded Blake. Even after all the therapies, I still haven't gotten him out of my mind. I can't even get to talk with Vanessa about him. Even if wanted to I don't know where to begin. Blake caught my sullen expression, hey snap out of it. I looked at him. He continues, you have to eventually tell me why you refuse to talk about other Shadows. I don't want to push you much because whenever we talk about our past, you become distant and moody. But one of these days, you will have to tell me what is bothering you so much.

I didn't know what to say. I want to tell him, but I can't show him the other petty side. The part of me who still resents that person. I reply, I am working on that, believe me. Trust me, you will be the first person I tell when I am ready. I turn towards the gap from the gate. Lets pick this conversation up later. Those people have cleared out. Soon there's a big siren and all the people in the crowd became silent. I took a long breadth and said, its show time. Blake walks behind me and keeps him hand on my shoulder, finally. We get to see who this person is and why all the secrecy. What's so damn important that they couldn't have a fair match.

I almost lost my footing when I heard him, I turned to face him and shouted, wait, how do you know about that. Who told you about this. Blake was laughing, its fine, no one told me. During the last moment in our match, I saw you doing something weird. I wasn't conscious enough to understand what you were doing. I thought I was imagining it at the time, but later I recalled that you were truing to pull off one more trick. I wasn't even sure till now. Your reaction says I was right. He made a disapproving sound now, I can't believe after all we did in our battle, you still kept something hidden. I guess, you wanted to save it till now right?

I turn to the open field. Blakes words kept lingering in my mind, the strongest person on the planet. Do I even want this tittle. I never thought I would have the chance to be the strongest. Considering how I started in Medrine and on earth, this feels unreal. I clenched my teeth and made a fist from my hands. Can't let anything distract me. With these thoughts, I stepped outside into the field for the final time.

Vanessa (Chapter 2)

Thursday, 27 January 2022 11:46 AM

I was sitting in the VIP room with everyone waiting for the big reveal. Among us only Kafar wasn't worrying about the match. He had a gleeful smile all the time he sat on his chair. I couldn't possibly understand why he was so content with the thought that this champion of Citradel is the strongest. Derek was also here, placed beside Kafar. He kept a much better composure than Kafar. He was watching the ground, checking the progress of the last minute clean up of the field.

In front of our room, there were eight screens put up against the wall. Each screen covering different angles of the field. Josh said it was essential that they record every moment of this fight. He claimed that no matter the victor, the whole battle recording will make people believe in our strength. Personally, I didn't understand why sending out the battle recording is necessary. It's a great risk if these recordings somehow reached the hands of HIVE or ECHO. It may even end up over the internet for Humans to see. Ned, however, thought it was a great idea. He told people can make up their own stories when recounting the battle to others. Its important that the real battle to be shown if we need others trust. He explained this many times to me, but I am still wary of this idea. We are basically depending on this Movie to persuade people all over the world to join us.

Ned shifted uneasily beside me and asks, how much longer Kafar? I think people are beginning to become restless. You need to tell who your secrete contestant is now. Ned was a little impatient, I couldn't blame him. Everyone here was eager to who this person was and why didn't they had to participate in the previous matches like we did. Kafar turns his head to Ned and says, he is not a contestant. He is the ultimate warrior. Ned moved his lips to scorn, clearly not amused by Kafar response.

Derek pitches in, just give it couple of more minutes. We are almost finished up fixing the ground. He faces Kafar, you can proceed to the podium. I will ask the guys to sound the siren when we are ready. We also need to tell him to get ready now. Everyone eyes caught Derek's attention. I knew it. He does knew who this person was. I said out loud, so it's a He. Who is it? Its almost time now. There is no point in hiding his identity now. Kafar clicks his mouth in defiance, you all have been waiting for a week, I think you can manage for a couple of few more minutes. He smiles as he stands up, all right Derek. I will prepare for the announcement. I don't think he needs to be told anything, he has been anticipating this fight since David and Blakes battle. I worry he might not be able to contain himself. I gave strict instructions not to show himself until the right time. He starts walking towards the back door. And remember, you cannot tell everyone who he is until I do. You understand? Kafar held the door open and was waiting for Derek's reply.

Derek let out a big sigh, yes. I understand. Leave now. Kafar took a moment as he glares at Derek and a moment later exits. Derek faces to the window glass overseeing the grass. Matt behind me says, what a douche. Man, isn't he doing a little overkill with this whole mystery guy. I don't see what's the big deal is. Marina who had been continuously casting a charm repeatably on the barrier stops for a moment, and what's this request of adding additional charms on top of this barrier. Its already fortified with 4 different properties of charm. I know David's Kuret cancels out others, but this barrier is specially made for him. It will reseal any holes David makes during the battle instantaneously.

Derek didn't respond immediately. In front of us, the royals were sitting. Nathan who has been silent all this time says, well ? I don't know how, but I still can't read your aura. You and Kafar have been very secretive. Maybe now you can tell us what this is all about. Derek faces all of us, Ah. Sorry. I want to tell you guys, but you heard Kafar right? He made it clear. I have my reasons why I can't go behind his back. He pauses to gather this words. He then looks over Marina, It's not David I am worried about breaking the barrier, Marina, it's the other guy. Believe me when I say this, if we don't have a strong enough barrier, he could break it during the battle. He could unintentionally harm the spectators. I don't want to risk it.

I took a moment before asking, if you can't tell who it is then can you at least tell if this person stronger than Blake or David ? Derek draws his eyes to me. He replied, if we talk in terms of Kuret, then Blake is the strongest. If we compare skills, then I say David is leagues above other two. He takes a short breath, but this particular persons enormous strength trumps others by a huge margin. I have seen it my from own eyes. I have never met another person that can match his strength.

I was a little shocked to hear this from Derek. I have came to realize Derek can easily be a Medrine commander after his battle with David. He may be even at a generals level. For him to say this makes me a worry a lot. Cassandra sitting beside Matt said, don't count out David yet. He has beaten people before who were thought they were stronger than him. She kept her eyes focusing on Nathans back. Nathan immediately turns to face her, ouch. That was a little rude. But I won't deny it. He has surprised me many times before. Jess besides Nathan agrees, yeah. And don't forget about what we all agreed to do. I am sure that David knows who he will be fighting by now.

Derek chortles a little hearing Jess, you mean your little convolution of spying on the Citradels side of the rooms? My eyes widen and I put my hands on the chair rest in uneasiness. Everyone grew anxious as soon as he said it. I can't believe that Derek already knew. Ned spoke first with a stern voice, what you are taking about Derek. He was trying to deny this. But Derek remained unconvinced. We will never do something so underhanded. Derek raises his palm in the air, don't worry. I have not told Kafar about it. Fortunately, I run the security of this coliseum and I kept it under wraps. He became a little serious, but what were you all thinking. If Blake was caught by someone else, Kafar would have leveraged it against you all. He turns to Catherine, if you all really wanted to do it without getting caught, why didn't you go instead?

Catherine has said much for the last couple of hours. Not just today, she has been a distant ever since her battle with David. I wanted to ask her if something is bothering her, but it felt personnel. Maybe she and Robb have a couples quarrel. But I didn't want to intrude so I kept to myself. She speaks, Ah. There has been some complications. I can't use my Kuret for longer than a minute. I, she took a long breadth before continuing, I think it's a side effect of my battle with David. I ask her, really ? But that match was weeks ago. Are you sure its not something else. Catherine vehemently shook her head, no. I am sure, Brain told me that it could take some more days for me to recover my Kuret. I just need some rest. That's all.

She is usually better at lying. But even I can tell she is speaking evasively. She did look tired. There were small dark circles under her eyes, has she not been sleeping much? There was clearly something going on she didn't want to talk about. Derek also wasn't satisfied with her answer but didn't ask her further, Okay, I hope you get well soon. We can't have an Omega commander on the sidelines if we run into another war. Catherine nods and mumbles, thanks. She quietly leans back to her chair. I wanted to ask her right away what's going on with her, but we already had enough drama going on here. Derek says, look, you guys need to be careful from now on around Kafar. Not just during this tournament, but also when our cities join. I know you guys run your city in your own way, but he has been running Citradel over a decade in secrete. He will do absolutely anything, and I mean anything to keep people safe. Be very careful next time. If you are going to do something, do it in a way he doesn't find out.

Derek warning about Kafar shows he is very serious. I could hear it in his voice. Marina spoke, yeah. Derek's right. I have known him almost as long as Derek has. He may be a little extreme, but he has done that to keep us safe. You guys shouldn't have done something behind his back. I said to her, you are just annoyed that we didn't tell you what we were planning, right. She shouts, you damn right. When Derek just asked for a single Kuritine to hide his presence, I didn't thought it was for this. Brain asks, that's on you know. What do you think he would use something to hide especially today?. Marina was a little frustrated, well I, I thought it was for..she stopped and then shook her head, forget that. You guys should have told me what you guys were planning, I would have prepared a better Kuretine, I have a bunch of charms to hide someone. Derek stops her, I told you Marina. As long as Kafar is here, we need to make sure you and I don't get caught doing something he thinks is a betrayal.

Tess spoke, hold on, if you already know that Blake went to spy on your people, so does that mean Blake found him? Derek says, no. By the time Blake made it the other side, he was already moved away from our side of the coliseum. You guys just have bad luck. I thought you might do something like this and so I told Kafar beforehand. He told me he would take care of it. I said, wait then where is he? Derek shook his head, no clue. Derek looks over the field. A moment later he pulls out his radio device and says, okay Grover. The field is now ready, sound the siren now. The person on the other end replies, you sure. David is at his gate, but we still haven't found our champion. Derek says, that's fine. Go ahead. Kafar orders. There was a long pause and then the voice replied, Ah okay boss.

A moment later a loud siren filled the air around us. 10 seconds later the siren slowed and so did the noise from the crowd. Everyone gathered here stood up from their seat. Everyone is looking on their right gate, anticipating who will emerge. Derek says, Marina I think its enough. You can stop now. Marina makes one last movement of her hands and pulls away. She let a big sigh, fhew, I think this is my strongest charm I have casted ever. It may be even stronger than one we have in both the cities. And with so many caster near the field borders, it is robust enough that even an army of tanks can't break it. Derek says, that's great. Thanks for doing this. He scoffs a little, you don't know how close you are with tanks as an analogy. He raises his hand and pours out Kuret on it. I thought he was about to do something but he kept staring at it and deeply in thought.

I ask him, you have fought him before. Derek puts out the Kuret in his hand and looks to me. He says, Yes. Only once. But it was enough to know the monstrous gap in our strength. Matt asks, really. He is that much powerful above you?. Derek nods, oh yes. No disrespect to you guys, but he can defeat all of us on one on one. No matter how much Kuret you can control or how skilled you are, there is no defense against his attacks. This might be the worst compatibility for David as an opponent. David's biggest weakness is his stamina. On the other hand. He stops himself. He pauses and says, I guess you will all find out in a minute.

Nathan asks, he must have left quite the impression on you from just one fight. Derek had a somber voice as he replied, yeah. Do you how long our fight lasted? Everyone faces to him at him in eagerness. He left a loud noise as he breathes heavily. Our fight was over in 2 minutes. I said, what. You are joking right. I found my jaw hanging a little open. He kept his same expression, I am not exaggerating it. Before even I could think of a way to beat him, he was all over me in an instant. He raised his palm and points two fingers, 2 punches. That's all it took to knock me out cold. And trust me, I went all in with my Kuret from the start unlike my battles here. But none of it mattered, I woke up an hour later with 5 broken ribs and a concussion to my head. I never asked for a rematch because I realized it won't matter. He could have even killed me if he went beyond kept attacking.

Everyone were silent hearing this. Derek decided to talk about him now, he could have told this long time back. David would have benefited from knowing this. Kafar must have something on him. He is letting us know so much about him just before the match. I kept hoping David would find some way to beat this guy. But someone who could beat Derek so easily, can David hold his ground. David struggled against Derek at the beginning. Although that's because David was wary of Derek and hiding his trump card till the end. But will it work against this person. I hear a door opening and jarring me out from my thoughts. It was Blake who entered in.

He looked at all our expressions and then said, why do I feel a wired vibe here. Derek raises his finger to him, you should know I already know you tried to spy to find who Citradels champion is. Blake was taken aback, say what. I would never do that. He tries to smile his way out of this. I said, he already knows Blake. He guessed we would do something like this and Kafar moved him somewhere else.

Blake was surprised, really. Blake and Derek had a staring contest for a while. Blake then says, okay. Then you guys already know that this was a bust. He then chuckles a little, well since we are all in mood of telling secretes, I told David about what we planned just now. And guess what, turns out David already had a plan of his own. He went over the Citradels rooms to find his person just 30 minutes ago on his own. I was the least surprised to hear this than others. I smiled in my mind. That's so like David. I knew it, David also didn't want to fight without knowing who it was. Matt snickers and mumbles, classic. Derek shouts, what. Seriously. He pushed his hand in his pocket and pulled out his tablet. He was furiously tapping and scrolling on it. Wait, he says, I don't see any alarm tripped or anything in the censor. There nothing unusual in the cameras we installed. How in the world did he moved in and out without no one noticing?

Blake shrugs his shoulders, no idea. I didn't ask. We were more worried about where our other finalist would be now. David thinks his person will be making a bold statement of power and blast his way through the barrier from somewhere in the crowd. I say, what. That's crazy. David really thinks someone will jump out of the crowd ?. Derek lets out a small shriek, damn it. Why didn't I thought about it too. He turns towards the whispering people, he has done something like this before. He wanted to show his crazy strength in a manner that will woo all the Medrines here and instill fear to his opponent at the same time. He turns to Marina, I hope your barrier holds strong.

Marina who usually is outspoken kept mumbling to herself. Blake says, sounds like you know the person. Derek says, yes. I know him, I fought him once and he beat me in an instant. Blake was surprised, for real. That's not good. David did say you might have much him battled him before. Blake looks over to the ground. Everyone follow his suit and we see David walking out to the middle of the ground. The crowd went berserk and starting calling out his name in excitement. The other gate was already opened, but no one came out.

Blake starts walking slowly from behind us and stands next to Derek, tell me honestly. Can David win? Derek didn't move is gaze away from the middle of the field where David stands, if there is a chance of beating this guy, then David's the only one who could figure out. Everyone had a silent agreement amongst ourselves. Soon we heard a voice over the speakers. It was Kafar.

Welcome everyone to the final match of this tournament. I am Kafar, the council leader of Citradel. The crowd grew silent as he started talking. I turn towards the middle screen over the wall. He was standing on the podium specially requested by him to be made for this match. Kafar had done a wardrobe change and was now wearing something ceremonial. It was a radiant gown of gold color and lines of threads beaded with shining stones. Likely a Kuritine. He continues as he speaks over his microphone attached to his neck as he steps forward, I am very grateful to have been given this opportunity to host this match. I have been witnessing all the matches and I am beyond impressed with the so many talented people participating from both the cities. The number of Kurets we have seen over this month is the most ever since we arrived on Earth. Please give a big round of applause to all those contestants who worked hard and gave their best. He paused as the coliseum was filled with claps and cries of excitement.

Kafar raises his hands in air, the crowd settles down. Now, you all have seen so many people showing their strength. I believe that once our cities merge, with such powerful individuals, we will be on a path to gain what we lost all those years back on Medrine. There was a roar of approval from the crowd. We will not be anymore cowering from HIVE or the Humans anymore. We will have a society that can finally stand and fight back our oppressors. His comment made another roar of cheers from the crowd. He takes a second, then says, Now. I don't want to delay any longer. I know people have been waiting for this match for a long time. I want you all to remember, that no matter who the victory goes to today, we all are one people and this match will show that we have people that can keep you safe in our city. The crowd gives another round of cheers.

Blake says ahead me, wow. He already thinks that we will be moving to Citradel. Look at that confidence. Matt says, dude. That’s overconfidence. I say, maybe. All I can tell is that I haven't seen David this worried before, I said looking over the left screen which showed David in the middle. He was standing and looking up to Kafar. His body posture remained confident, but we could see he had some doubt in his face. Cassandra says, well that’s to be expected. David always had a plan before he enters a battle. Derek says, This will be a tough fight for him.

Kafar then waves his hand towards the middle of the field, and without wasting more time. Let me introduce to our champions. First champion, you all already know him. The champion of the new Medrine city and the one who defeated the Hive leader, David. The crowed lets out a huge cry of excitement in response. They have seen him before in the stadium, but I guess being introduced by someone has more effect. David pulls out a smile on his face and waves around to the people. Kafar continues, like many I found the last match exhilarating. So many twists and turns. Both Blake and David are tremendous Medrines. Both have Kurets that defies our natural understanding. Perhaps the most unexpected result was that someone from a royal bloodline and a mythical true alpha was defeated by someone who remained in the dark until few years back.

Blake smirks, that guy really knows how to add salt to my wounds. He could have skipped this. Catherine broke silence after a while, ignore him Blake. He is just trying to add more flare. Nathan says, this ways he is setting a much more flare when David looses. Their champion would then be considered unrivaled. He chuckles on that thought. Blakes says, although what he is saying is the truth. In the end, David won. I could hear a frustration in his voice. It’s the same when I lost to Marina. I really wanted to fight David in the stadium. I guess it was never meant to be.

Kafar says, but that’s just the nature of how these battles work. There can only be one victor. And today will not be any different. Its safe to say that whoever wins today will be considered the strongest among all Medrines. The crowed went wild hearing this. This is what all of them have been waiting for. Kafar continues, and now its time to reveal our champion. He pauses until the crowd becomes silent. Everyone here become still and quite. We could only hear faint noises of our breathing as we starred at the screen.

He says, I know you all have questions why we didn't have him participate in the match like how others did. Well, there is good reason for that. You see our champion comes from a bloodline that is so ancient that many believe they are a myth. In fact at one point in our Medrine history, they were worshiped as deities. But during the destruction of our planet, they were forced to come out of hiding to save others and themselves. Every member of this house is very strong. But alas, with such great strength comes with a bigger weakness. You see, they can't use Kuret for a certain period of time. During this Kuret blackout, they are very weak. They need a lot of rest and time to recover. Their bodies goes through alternating cycles like sun and moon over weeks. That’s why our champion couldn't join the matches until today, he couldn't use his Kuret till today.

At this revelation the people starting to whispers. I said out loud, an ancient house? I don't know any bloodline that has goes through a Kuret blackout. I looked over others, they were just as clueless as me. Kafar says, I couldn't let him reveal himself to others because there was risk. Kafar sighs a little, although he is our important guardian who has kept Citradel safe for years, he doesn't want any help from me and refuses to have bodyguards. So we made a deal that he would remain hidden until his Kuret returns. Kafar then raises his fist over his head, but do not make the mistake of thinking that this makes him weak. Once he recovers, our believed champion is undefeatable. Not even the Hive leader could defeat him. His overwhelming strength has kept Hives out of our city for years. The Hives even gave a nickname to him, hivanukes, which means killer of hives in their language.

I immediately stirred up when I heard the name. I turned to Blake, Tessa and Nathan. Didn't that Hive leader say this name when we fought him last year. Blakes ponders on this a while and says, yeah. I remember. When we had him in our trap, he kept spouting nonsense things. I never imagined hivanukes was this guys nickname. Tessa says, this explains why he didn't help us that time. He couldn't use his Kuret. Isn't that right Derek. Derek nods, yeah. When were fighting that day, his was still in recovery. It takes him months to recover once he uses his Kuret. He was frustrated that he couldn't help us that day. Nathan cries, did you just say months. Oh man, that is one hell of a drawback of such power. Derek says, yeah. That’s why even the people of Citradel don't know who he is. Almost all the time, he is a fragile guy. But when his Kuret recovers, he is a monster.

I had been praying silently for David's win all this time. I have now serious doubts. When a Kuret has a big weakness, the trade off is that much bigger. Kafar continues, please welcome our champion now. I become still as I listened to him, the protector of Citradel, Charles of the house Heraknus.

David (Chapter 3)

Thursday, 27 January 2022 5:18 PM

As soon as I heard the name of the house my legs felt like giving up. My mind automatically tuned out the noise from the crowd. I couldn't think for a moment, my whole mind went blank for few seconds. The name of that house gave me chills that ran from the back of my head to by legs. My brain went deep to recall I conversation I had with Zakerine on Medrine when we were working on our secrete book. We ran so many hypotheticals and how we would fight them. We covered so many different houses, listing their weakness and strengths. One time we would talked about houses who we didn't think were real.

Hey, how about Heraknus people, how do we fight them, I recall asking her. She looked at me funny and said, we are not fighting a imaginary bloodline you idiot. I replied, hey, what if they are real. We need to have some contingency if one day we have to fight them. Zakerine thought I had lost my mind, seriously? I nodded my head with seriousness. She laughs, okay our shadow strategist. What do you think we should do when we have to fight someone. I was thinking hard, well if I have believe the legends about Heraknus house, there is some rumors that they are the ones that eradicated the giant Kuret monsters that reeked havoc some centuries back. Those Kuret monsters were some science experiments gone wrong and no one could stop them. So Heraknus house took the responsibilities of killing them.

She says, really. Do tell me where you found this piece of information. I was a little hesitant to say, I heard it from her. She laughs more loudly now, haha, so you now believe that crackpot. Listen to me David, trust me when I say she is crazy. I reply to her, but she is one of us. She replies, exactly. You haven't spent much time with her as I have. She has a very morbid way of looking at life. She pushes her lips together, So she now believes in Heraknus. Then she shook her head, doesn't matter. Look don't you think that if they ever existed we would have known by now. We are the most secrete organization in the world, if there was evidence of their existence, we would have known.

I kept pondering for some time, you know what. I don't think they are imaginary. The way she told me, described them, its almost as if she has met one. Zakerine says, yeah well, she must be very good in telling stories, enough to have convinced others to allow such a creepy person in Shadow. She leans towards me, if you are serious about writing this house down, then we would have to make a new category for this. I was relieved that she finally agreed. I ask, so what should we put them under, mythical ? She looked like she was thinking one very intently, then she says, how about get the hell away when you meet one. She starts laughing. I let out a sigh. Its enough for today, we are not going anywhere. I close the book and throw it towards her. She catches it immediately, hey don't be so mad. I am serious, we don't have a clue what they can do if they are real. The only thing I know is that they are were though to be powerful than alphas. But besides that, we don't know what their Kurets do, what shapes it takes or what effect they have. We should better focus on houses we do know about. Thinking about a house we don't know anything is just waste of time.

So you really think we should run away if we meet one. She nods, yes. You know better than anyone, there's nothing more dangerous than an enemy we know nothing about. She had a point. If I ever meet one, I should just run away and get backup. Why waste time on something we don't think is real. She keeps the book on the table beside our bed. She says, now. Will we keep discussing about some imaginary stuff or do something real. She brings a big smile. I laughed, what do you have in mind ? She leans forwards, well we could visit the place you said we would go. I start to lean forward as well, nah, it will take time. How about we do something that is much closer. We both were close enough to hear our heartbeats. She snickers, yeah, I was just thinking the same. I closed my eyes and leaned in forward to bring my lips on her.

Before I get sucked further into my memory, I dragged myself out. I can't let her divert my focus anymore. Not when the house she scoffed as imaginary is what I will be fighting now. The moment Kafar said his name, there was a muffled explosion. I immediately looked to my right. A small part of the stadium was covered in white smoke. My first thought was that it was an attack, but I saw only glimmer of white strands. There is no fire, just smoke. A camouflage for their champion. Really, they are pulling out all the stops to make this match like a movie. I began to move towards that smoke, there was a huge silhouette figure under that cloud of smoke. The smoke then flew inwards towards the field, crashing to the barrier. There was a large thumb sound, like something heavy hit a wall, then there was another sound that rocked the whole barrier. Finally, on the third sound the barrier gave up and there was a crash sound like a big thick glass shattered into pieces. The smoke and its occupant crossed the barrier and was about to land on the field in front of me. The hole left on the barrier already started to reseal.

I was too stunned to move. My guess was right that this champion would do something like this. Honestly, I hoped that I would see the glimmers of Charles Kuret. But nothing, I see only the white strands of smoke flowing. I was shocked to see that he broke the barrier without his Kuret. He punched it only 3 times. That is an insane amount of power. The second he landed the ground beneath my feet shook a little. I unconsciously, took a step back. My instincts was going wild, perhaps telling me to run away. The smoke starts to clear out. At the same time, it starts to move towards me. I could still see the figure inside, but somehow it was becoming smaller in size as it approached to me.

Everyone in the crowd were silent, waiting to see his him properly. I took a heavy gulp as I took another step back to the middle of the field. Then a voice came from the smoke, greetings friend. You have no idea how long I have been waiting to meet you. The last of the smoke clears. What left remaining is a man who looks like he is in his forties. He was about 6 feet tall and had few scars on his right side of his face. He had silver hair and cut short to give a military look. He was grinning like a child given candy, he was probably excited to be out in the open after all this time. He was wearing something weird. It was too baggy for his size. He had simple black trousers and jacket on top. If he was wearing a correct size one, it would like he was out for jogging in his sports clothes. He says, sorry for the theatrics, but I couldn't break my promise to Kafar to give an entrance that will surprise everyone.

Well, mission accomplished I said in my mind. He then raises his fist in the air, hello everyone. He shouts so loud that I am sure the whole stadium can hear him. I am Charles of house Heraknus. After his declaration there was silence in the crowd. It could have been due to utter shock or confusion. A second later there are whispers everywhere. We are meeting someone who is considered to be a legend, not real. Kafar continues, I understand the confusion. But let me assure you all, the house of Heraknus is not a myth. They are very real. They have hid themselves for centuries in Medrine. And were forced out in the open when Hive attached Medrine. They were invaluable during the rescue of people from cities. I was shocked to hear this. Somewhere back in my mind I was also trying to figure out a plan. But none came to me. I have no clue what Heraknus can do. Only thing I know for certain is that they are ridiculously strong.

Kafar continues, they have been with Citradel all this time on Earth. But as I have already told you, their Kuret is not consistent. So we made sure they remained well protected until it was safe to reveal their existence. Citradel gave them sanctuary and in return Heraknus Medrines have been protecting our cities by being part of our main and a secrete troop. I looked over to Charles, he has been smiling and gazing all around to the people in the crowd. Kafar says, when the news of Hive leaders death reached Citradel, we realized that the Hive forces have been trimmed down and finally Heraknus had an opportunity to finally come out of shadows of Medrine history. The house of Heraknus have been patiently waiting for everyone to know about them. And the opportunity came in the form of a tournament. However, the timings didn't align to Charles Kuret return and so we had to arranged for him to fight directly with the winner of the regular matches. I apologies to everyone here, but I had to do this to protect Charles and his house.

At his last statement a cold sweat ran through my neck. I cleared my throat before approaching the myth standing in front of me, Ah excuse me. Charles suddenly became excited to hear me and walked towards me. Kafar also stopped his speech when he heard me call out to Charles. Charles walked closer to me and raised his hand to me, please, call me Charles. As I look at this hand, I thought about how we never had any formal introduction in the matches till now, so I was little hesitant to take his hand, if he is really powerful he could crush my hand like a toothpick. He didn't seem to have any sinister intentions. And Kafar is still at the podium, he has more to speak. So the match hasn't started yet. I didn't want to take any chances, so I pulled a small amount of Kuret on my right hand. It was thin enough to be invisible to the eye.

I shook his hand with a little uneasiness, Ah, okay Charles. As soon as we shook hands, he said, wow, so this is what your famous Kuret can do huh. Impossible. I poured very less amount of Kuret in my hand, no one should have been able to detect it. I immediately pulled away my hand way from him. I didn't want to come across as rude, but I have know no clue what he might do. He just laughs, don't worry kid. I don't believe in deception. I prefer to strike my enemy looking in the eye. I just thought I know you a little before we start our match.

He showed me a smile that had no malice or trick. He was just wanting to meet. I felt a little relieved, Ah. Sorry. I am a little nervous. I don't usually meet some myths everyday. Much alone fight one, I thought. He replies, don't sweat it kid. As you can see we not myths. He waves his arms gesturing his body, we are just a well hidden house who have remained a secrete over centuries.

I was completely enthralled as he recounted his story. I never imagined Kafar had managed to kept Heraknus a secrete all this time. I brought myself to speak a second later, Kafar said you have battled the Hive leader. Is that true? This brought his smile back, Yes. I fought him three times. I am surprised he never mentioned me all the times you battled him. I guess he didn't want others to how I close he came to death. He managed to wriggle his way out from our grasp every time. When I heard from Derek last year about your plan to take him down. I wanted to be there, but my Kuret was not yet recovered. I sent the rest of my house members to your aid, but by the time they reached, the war was already over. I was surprised to know you killed him. A feat that I never accomplished. He then looks over to the VIP room and says, I am very grateful that you all defeated him. Earth is better off without him. Hive are in a state of chaos, they don't have a leader to mobilize. And from this state of confusion we have been able to eradicate a lot of Hives headquarters.

The people now didn't just whisper, they were talking amongst themselves. They were finally able to raise their voices after such a shocking revelation of Heraknus. Charles faces back to me, I have been wanting to meet you for a long time. And not just you, Derek has told me great things about the true alpha Blake, the omegas Catherine, Vanessa, Jess and Nathan, they are all powerful. I wish I could have fought them before. But my stupid body hadn't recovered yet.

I can only imagine what others might be feeling up there in the room after being praised by a legendary person. I ask, speaking of Derek. I guess he is not the strongest person in whole Citradel right? That was another lie right? I mean, if I believe the stories I have about you guys, every member of Heraknus house is as strong as an alpha. He laughs at my question, I am humbled that you think we are so great. But the truth is that Derek is indeed the strongest person from Citradel. As I said earlier, my house members have erratic control over Kuret on Earth. I am sure Derek could have win against me if he gets more powerful. He is already skilled enough that he didn’t go down the first punch with my full power. The only other person I had to fight seriously other than the Hive leader. As expected of the son of the great savior of Medrine.

My throat went dry. Did he just imply that he had to punch Derek one more than others to defeat him. Derek, the same guy who gave me trouble. And I am to fight him? This is crazy. There was a silence between the two of us. There was so much tension in the air around me, I began to see my own yellow glimmer from my body. Fear. Kafar took the moment to continue his speech, there you have it people. Our two champions have finally met each other and exchanged their greetings. Huh, what is he taking about, I thought. There was no greet. I am trying best to hide my fear. I know I should be glad that we have such a powerful house to fight against Hive and Echo. But first I have to somehow get through this match. The crowd suddenly cheered in ecstasy. They must have finally came to the realization that they will see something hidden for over a decade on Earth and centuries on Medrine.

Kafar says, I know people still have many questions for us and Charles, but for now keep them aside and pay attention to their fight. Charles has been dying to show us the most glorious fight for some time now. A lot of people started to jump from their seat unable to control their excitement. I was almost envious of the people sitting there. They get to watch safely from a distance, while I have to fight. I shook my head trying get my head straight. Enough with the distracting thoughts, I knew the other person would be someone stronger. I was hoping that it was a house which I know about. Heraknus bloodline never occurred to me as a possibility. That means I have to improvise as we battle and learn about his fighting style.

Charles walks back to the other end of the circle drawn in the middle of the field, hey kid. Don't let the myth about our house get to you. He spoke as he starts walking, do not let yourself be concerned about our house being different than others. Remember this while we fight. I don't want you to worry about anything else. Just keep your attention on me. Its like he felt my worries. And giving advice to your opponent, he sounds like a wise person. He doesn't have any ulterior motive other than just to fight me. Charles reached his spot and looked up to Kafar. He then raises his fist to him and gives him a thumbs up. Kafar says, okay. Charles has told he is ready. Best of luck to both the champions. I hope the powers you two will show reaches to all the people here. He waves to the crowd and then walks back getting down from the podium.

Me and Charles where intensely staring each other. It was like we were waiting for a signal to start. A sign which was never going to come. Charles now donned a serious face. He has now fully composed himself for a serious battle. I on the other hand am just trying to keep it together. Formulating a plan of attack. I know his punches packs a great deal, so avoiding that them be my primary concern. There were other things popping up in my mind, like what was that huge shadow I saw when he entered. And how is he hiding his Kuret. I can only glimmers coming out his flesh and bones, no hint of any Kuret hidden beneath. But I had a question that was much more pressing.

I think Charles picked on that. I can see you are dying to ask me a question. If that's what is stopping you, then I will gladly answer. He must have incredible six sense to figure it out. I replied, sorry. Its just you have been taking about your house like someone who is a leader. I paused thinking he might correct me. But he didn't. I began to worry as I continue, and you said that your house is not different than others. So does that mean that there is an alpha in the house of Heraknus and, I swallow hard, that alpha is you?

Charles broke his expression to give a small smirk, you think that house of Heraknus would just let anyone fight you. No. I have seen your matches. You have a strange power, yet you have brought down many powerful foes with that power. It would not be justice if the person to fight you is not the strongest in the house. He closes his eyes and opens it a second later. His Kuret tattoos over his necks start to shine. Shit. His eyes start to brighten with a brown Kuret, you guessed right. I am indeed an alpha of house Heraknus. And I, will be you challenging you as the leader of my house. So lets have some fun.

My freaking bad luck. I not only have to fight a bloodline we know nothing about, it had to be their boss.

Vanessa (Chapter 4)

Thursday, 27 January 2022 10:59 PM

Something incredible is going on. I was completely in shock when Kafar announced who their champion was. What's more is that David has to fight the alpha of Heraknus. We were all standing in awe watching the screen on the right as Charles shows his brown Kuret. It was a dense Kuret, meaning he intends to fight David with his full power from the start. His Kuret then starts to warp around his torso. The more he pulled out his Kuret the more his Kuret started to wrap around him completely. He is doing something. I looked over David on the other screen. He now kept both his hands in a defensive form in front of his face. I could tell he is nervous and a little frightened. But I know he must be strategizing already.

Marina said, holy shit. My Barrier. She had a hand on her mouth, I added so many layers. One person should have not been able to break it. Even David would find it difficult to go through with his Kuret. All it took was 3 hits by him to break through. She looked over to Derek with an astonished expression, he was living in Citradel with us? Impossible. I have used a scouring spell many, how did it not pick his Kuret? Derek replies, your charms would only pick people who had access to Kuret. Heraknus people would usually stay in Citradel when they are going through their blackout. When they have access, Charles mobilizes his people outside the city. There are two reasons for that. Kafar had promised to keep them hidden even from people living inside. And if Hive found us and any Heraknus has to fight, they can't fight in a crowded city. He pauses a little and says, they are messy when it comes to fighting.

Nathan was the first to speak, what in the world. Derek, you are one hell of a secrete keeper. I can't believe this is the champion that Citradel has been hiding for so many years. He gives a little nervous laugh, I am almost glad that its David and not me down there who is fighting. I was taken back from his comment, is this the same Nathan who does not fear anyone else. Nathan smirks, well if I also have to fear someone, don't I? Vanessa, we know house Heraknus was always real. We have stories about them in books about them in the royal family. There are no other evidence, these stories are the only source left.

Blake cuts in, yeah. He is right, but we were also told they died out. No one has seen them in centuries. It was easy to rule them as dead. Tessa says, I can't believe I am watching a living Heraknus alpha. That would mean that there are others also alive. She gazes over others, do you know what that means ? I said, it means we have now the single most powerful house ever with us. She nodded, yeah. I heard stories that if a group of them ever got together to fight, they can reshape the landscapes. I am not even joking, out of all the Medrine houses, they are clearly the strongest.

Derek says, they were once but now. He ponders over a somnolent voice, you guys heard what Kafar talked about Heraknus right? I know few of them. On a good day, they can manage to use their Kurets consistently for a scant few minutes. But it can just comes and goes on a whim. That’s dangerous in a battle. If even for couple of seconds their form reverts, they are vulnerable. They have been trying to adapt to their new limitations. And those who have somehow able to maintain it for long time, once their Kuret runs out, they have to wait for weeks to recover. Imagine how frustrating it is that they are once considered to be the strongest Medrines and now Earth has stripped their power considerably.

Blake hesitantly asks, then Charles is also not as powerful as before right? Then maybe David has a chance of winning. Derek didn't responds immediately. Charles, he is different. He is an alpha. While I don't know how powerful he was at Medrine, he claims that his strength hasn't deterred, only the amount of time to recover has gone up. I ask Derek, how much time does he needs to recover? Derek responds, he told me that back on Medrine it would take about a month equivalent of Earth time. But here, he now needs about 6 months. Holy crap. I can't believe that his body was so much effected by Earths atmosphere. Cassandra asks, then how long can he fight without losing his Kuret interrupting ? If even if its for a second, David might use that window to beat him.

Derek shook his head, well I can't say its not a possibility but Charles can use his Kuret constantly for more than few hours. His alpha powers gives him an incredible stamina and endurance. The more this battle is stretched out, the more his odds of winning will increase. I remembered what Derek was taking about earlier, you said that Davis one weakness is his stamina and makes this the worst match up. He nods. Blake agrees, I agree David doesn't have the stamina as we do. But his Kuret tips the odds to him too. If David keeps hitting him with his black Kuret, Charles will start to loose more and more Kuret. He might have stamina, but no one has been able to defend against David's Kuret.

I think it might not be completely one sided battle, yeah that’s right. David can still win. Everyone was waiting for Derek to say something. But he kept silent and watched as Charles was now covered completely from head to toe with his Kuret. Derek finally answers, I honestly don't know what will happen in the battle. I don't want to pick sides here, I have great respect for Charles. I also want David to win. However, the odds doesn't look good. It would have been different story if any of you guys were fighting Charles. Physical attacks are key for victory against. David has only one Kuret attack that will allow him to attack materialistically. But he can pull that off couple of times. And I don't think that would be enough to defeat Charles.

He turns towards us and sits back on his chair, well now its up to David to figure out a way to survive and defeat him. As for Charles, he might take the battle initially a little slow. He fights simple but he is not stupid. He will keep his some distance from David at first to judge how his Kuret will react to him. David's Kuret is unlike ever seen, he will be cautious in the beginning. He then looks over us, you all should also take a seat. This battle will not be over like mine. At least I hope so.

He was right, we shouldn't lose our hope just yet. Everyone went back to their seat. My eyes were glued to the screen where Charles Kuret was now slowly taking the shape of his body. Its been almost a minute since he started to wrap his Kuret around him. Is this a delaying tactics, Derek what is Charles doing. Its been a minute. Does it take this much long every time he uses his Kuret. Derek says no, its very quick, but the time to transform becomes tougher next turn and takes more time due to that. He already transformed once when he broke the barrier, so its taking a little longer this time.

Catherine asked, there's the word transform again. What do you mean he will transform, is it similar to how I do it? Derek thinks for a moment, not entirely. You can shapeshift into any person or an extension of it. Heraknus, they can't turn into anyone. Their forms are determined at birth. Jess says, I don't understand. What will he transform into then. Blake says, hold on. Then what I was told in the stories wasn't an exaggeration? They really turn into massive beasts.

His words made everyone gasps a little. Matt says, don't be ridiculous, they don't turn really into beasts, right Derek. Matt small laugh broke into shock when Derek was a little wary of replying, you will soon get to see his form, he said in the end. Everyone was kept their thoughts for a little longer as we watched Charles brown Kuret take shape of something tall and humanoid. The door behind us opened. A voice came, oh I am just in time. So glad I didn't miss it. It was Kafar. He was in the same clothes he wore when he was giving his speech. He walked to us and took his place beside Marina and Derek, so what do you all think about Charles. I hope Derek didn't tell you guys after I left.

Marina says, no he didn't tell us. I understand why you wanted to keep it a secrete from everyone until today. But why did you ask him to keep it a secrete from us just when you were going to tell everyone anyway in a minute. Kafar brings up a smile, oh that was for just fun. I could only imagine your faces when I was the one who told you all. Derek doesn't have a flare for drama, he would have left something important out. Derek faces him, and what would that be? He replied its emotion boy. I created a build up that made his reveal even more astounding.

I looked at David. He now has wrapped a little bit of his Kuret from the elbows up to this fist in order to cancel out some of the Charles Kuret reaching to him. He didn't use much Kuret like he usually does, and I understand why. Charles was barely letting his Kuret run rampant like ours do. He was somehow keeping it close to his body. His Kuret control is unbelievable. Nor Marina or Blake have such fine control over our Kuret. I have never seen such a massive swirl of dense Kuret from a single Medrine.

Soon Charles form start to grow. Its happening now. I see the brown Kuret dwindling into thinner threads and falling into Charles new form. I gulped as I ask, how big will he become ?. Derek turned his head to me and was about to answer me, but Kafar beat him to it, oh its not done yet. I say he has a few more inches left. Seriously, I replied. He really turns to a beast then. Derek continues, the actual height is actually never a constant. Their form remains the same but If they have more control over their Kuret, a Heraknus can grow bigger. Alphas naturally have more control, so Charles is visibly bigger than others. He has been waiting for this day for quite some time. I think we are about to witness his biggest form yet.

Kafar pats his hand on Derek, well said my boy. Now that I think about it, he did say he had been preparing from yesterday night. So who knows how big he might become. Charles form become less humanoid now. He had longer and broader legs which were more bent towards the knees. His waist become wider along with his torso. His chest had the most growth and was buffed to point that a grown person could fit into it. His arms now reached his knees, each having muscles shaped like a chucks of big rocks aligned from his shoulders to his wrists. Behind me Matt cries out, holy shit. Is that a tail growing behind?

I turned towards a different monitor which showed a different angle. The brown Kuret was still swirling around his body and he skin was still hidden. And there it was, clearly visible a tail protruding out behind his back. My god, what is he turning into. Blake leaned towards the monitor and said, hold on to something folks, I think its not just a tail, its tails. His words became reality when the tail we were watching split into two. A moment later, those two tails splits further and now he has four tails. I hold Ned's hand more tightly as I saw the tails grow longer than his actual body. This is insane, he already has an unbelievable control over Kuret, now his body is becoming beast like.

The first feature we get to see of Charles complete form are his legs. His feet has big feet, he was covered in brown fur, there was also big round muscles around his calves and thighs. As I look closer I realize there were some shinny things attached all over his muscles and mixed in those furs. Kuretines. I gasp at that thought. His body has condensed so much Kuret formed into solid forms and attached to his skin. Slowly the upper body also started to show. The over sized pants he was wearing made sense now. The pants had become very small shorts, just enough to cover his upper thighs. It looked like someone would wear in a marathon. I couldn't tell where his waist started in all those muscles and fur, but his torso was visible. He has fur covered most of it, but I could see perfect abs formed up there. Blake let out a whistle, dude. That man is ripped.

Behind Charles, his tails were less covered in fur. They were much neater than rest of his body. There was sharp edge at the end of his tail. Shit, each tail had grown a Kuritine and was shaped like a spere. I don't know if Charles was doing it unconsciously or not, his tails were not at all still. They kept moving and wagging in different directions. Even with four tails, they moved with such synchronization that they didn't entangle themselves. His upper back looked like mountain slope with boulders of muscles in shape of rocks stacked on top of each other. He arms are long and big. They look very similar to his legs. This biceps was bulging out like someone attached it from outside. His arm were also covered with Kuretines. His hands, no I couldn’t them hands anymore. They were more like claws. He had no nails, which he didn't need because his fingers were covered in Kuritine. Those fingers looked like it could tear up metal.

Finally we get to see his form above neck. His neck was relatively shorter to his body proportion and his neck muscles were large, but all that didn't matter once his face was revealed. His entire head was covered in pieces of Kuretines. His ears were pointed and I could swear the tips were shining with Kuritine. His nose was big and we could see his nostrils, but they were also covered with stones. He opened his eyes, that the only part of this body that resembled human. His eyes remained the same, they must have grown to his head size, but they retained his iris features. His mouth was shaped like a like a wolfs, his jaws was more square shaped and protruding. I have no doubt that those teethes shown whenever he breathes out are also having Kuretines. The top of his head was more flat than a persons and he had less fur there. He had no extra hair on the back of this head.

Looking at this complete form, he was easily 10 feet tall. He was so massive and tall that would make any warrior afraid of him. Marina cries out, what the hell did he transform into. He is like some cross between a large Gorilla and a Lion. Marina paints quite the picture. Charles is looking like a true beast. Kafar argues, don't match his features to animals, girl. His form is what he was born with. He has no control over it. He chastised to her. He continues, their form are mostly reflected where they were born. Instead of animals, the terrains plays a lot more role into their forms. Charles told me he was born near a mountain cliff on a winters night. So he had developed fur and body shape in response.

And the Kuretines all over his body ?, I ask. Derek says, that’s common among all Heraknus. Their bodies contain large amount of Kuret. Large enough that they only allow little outlets to pour out. So some of it grows out of their body. This also depends on the persons control over Kuret, the more control he has, the more he will keep Kuret inside and more Kuretines will be formed. Nathan asks, he is practically bathed in that stuff. So does that mean he is at the top of his game today? Derek says, you can say that. I have never seen these many Kuretines on Charles before. Today he has really gone far out.

Kafar claps his hands in joy and chortles, okay. The match starts now. He looks over to us, anyone care for drinks and snacks? He pulled out a box and a bottle besides his chair and waved it to us. None of us were in a mood to drink or eat. I can't believe Kafar is treating this like a game. But then again, he thinks Charles already won. No ? Okay fine, you guys are in shock, so give it some time. He puts away those item, how about a wager then?

We were shocked by his blatant disregard. Cassandra asks, you want to gamble on the winner? He nods, why not. You can worry about David all you want, but that will not change the outcome of this battle. Blake leans over towards him, you sure are full of confidence that Charles will be the victor. Maybe you need to consider that David could win. Kafar smirks, of course I know there is a certainty, boy. But I find it hard to believe he will come up with a way to defeat our champion. David fights more with brains than brawns. He needs both to win against someone as powerful as Heraknus alpha. You have seen him only transform now. Wait till you see him in action. Tell him Derek, what do you think.

Derek looked like he didn't want to say anything. He manages to put his thoughts to words, think of him like a walking disaster. He can cause earthquake under his feet, his punches can tear apart metals, his jaws can crush rocks into powder and those tails can strangle up people in four different ways. Right now what you have is a Medrine who is a lethal killing machine. When we fought, I was barely able to block his first attack. His second one was even more powerful. I thought he killed me for a second. With me he choose to just use his fist, he has other limbs to use for attack. Charles will definitely prepare to use all his limbs. He wants everyone to show what Heraknus are capable, now that they have come out of hiding after centuries. It must be what is driving him to focus and control Kuret much better.

Kafar says, see. Derek understands what David is facing. So how about it, lets make this match more interesting by betting. I am not being immoral you see, its just we can't do anything but watch our champions fight. He might not be immoral, but he was really getting on my nerves. Nathan speaks first, I am in. Everyone looks at him, what ? He is right, no point worrying about David. He can't see us. He most definitely doesn't know us wagering, so what's the harm. Kafar says, excellent. So who do you think will win. Nathan responds, maybe I hold a personal grudge or something, I am betting on Charles. Kafar smile got bigger.

I was not surprised, that was no brainer for Nathan to bet on. Beside him Jess sat thinking for a moment, I thought for sure she would side with her husband, but she surprised everyone. I bet on David. Nathan glanced to her, She says what. You have your reasons, I have mine. He has a plan. He always does. Blake beside her speaks, I know for a fact that he still has one ace on his hand which he hasn't reveled during mine or Derek match. I am betting on David.

Derek said, really. He said that? He was surprised to hear as was everyone. Blake nods, yup. I don't know what it is, but he must have it kept hidden so that Charles wouldn't know about it. Derek then faces towards David. In many ways he and David share many similar characteristics. He looked at Kafar who was waiting for his response. Really, you want me to pick one?. Kafar says, of course. Derek sighs, fine. I pick Charles then. I don't think David would go down easily but I have never seen Charles defeated.

I could tell it was a tough decision for him. He must have wanted to say David, but felt some pressure from Kafar. Marina said, well I am betting on David. Mark my words, he will be knocking him to ground. Well, that was obvious, I thought. Me too, Matt says. David will be the winner. I know it. Beside her Cassandra said, I am with David too. I don't care if Charles is some war god or something, David will beat him. Everyone knew they both would pick David. Catherine took some thought before saying, I think David is going to hate me for saying it, but I am betting on Charles.

Now that was a surprise. She has been friends with David for long time. Why she didn't bet on him? I thought I ask her about it, but Ned beside me said, I am also betting on Charles. I was shocked to hear him. I let go of his hand, what why? He says looking at me apologetically, keeping my personal feeling about our city aside, objectively, David odds are not looking good. Just look at that Charles. He looks like he wanted he could eat David in one go. I pity David, but I think he will lose.

Hearing those words felt like betrayal to me. He is speaking honestly, and I can understand why he thinks this. It still was shocking to know he gave up on David. I was the remaining one, but I didn't had to give any thoughts. I am betting on David. I don't know how, but he will win this. Hearing my claim Kafar laughed, that’s the spirit. You need to enjoy this. So we have 6 bets for David and 5 bets for Charles. But remember, once the match starts, you guys can always change your bets. This is getting exciting.

Nathan nonchalantly says, hold on we made the bets but haven't put up anything. Don't tell me we are gambling on money. Kafar says, of course its not money. That would too cheap. Lets see what will the winner get. He began thinking about it. I immediately said, how about the winners get a no objection favor from each of the losers team. Nathan says, whow, that’s a good one. It could be any favor then? He smiles. I say, obviously something reasonable. Jess poked him on his stomach to stop his immature behavior.

Kafar agrees, yes. That would do nicely. What do you others think. Everyone murmured in agreement. I know what I want from Ned. I want him to apologies to me and to David once he wins. Ned kept his eyes away from mine. Derek says, if all the frivolity is done, then lets see the match. Charles is now ready to make his first move. Everyone shifted with uneasiness on their chair and face the screen as the final match started.

David (Chapter 5)

Sunday, 30 January 2022 10:36 PM

What in the world is going on here. A scrawny man is turning into some type of beast. His form is unlike any animal I have ever seen. Either on Medrine or Earth. His Kuret was so dense and controlled, hardly anything is getting wasted. I was defending myself with Kuret in my arms, but I expelled it after few seconds. There was no extra Kuret for me to block in the air. Their was only one glimmer coming out of Charles, strands of blue and violet. He is totally clam and composed. No hint of doubt or fear. Meanwhile, my body was oozing with doubt, fear and anxiety. I tried to clam my mind, but my body wasn't listening. My instincts was at odds with what I want. It was telling me to run.

When Charles dispelled his brown Kuret. I saw his full form. Shit. His is around 10 feet tall. He has 4 tails, long legs and arms, big jaws and claws. I could have never guessed that their Kuret allows them to transform into beasts. As Charles breathes, he exhales so much so that I could hear the sound of the wind even from such distance. His eyes was glued to me like its hunting its prey. Oh no, don't tell me he becomes more animalistic in this form. Charles opens his massive jaws, this is what it means to be a Heraknus. He says while raising both his arms to his torse, like a showman presenting to an audience. His voice is so much deeper now. It felt like his voice travelled great deal of muscles. He continues, David, you could have attacked me during my transformation, but you didn't. Why?

I gulped as I thought about it. He had a point, why was I just standing when I could have attacked. Even if I didn't know that he would take this form, I knew he would be becoming something dangerous. And yet I let him. Sure I was stuck with fear, but I wasn't completely frozen. I have been so many situations where I felt fear and still fought. One attack. Maybe that would be the end of it. As I keep asking these question to myself I realized my true feeling. I not going to lie, I reply, I was completely in shock seeing so much visible Kuret. But that’s not why I couldn't attack you. I choose not to. I can see you have been waiting for this moment for a long time. Even if I had win when you were not ready, its not really a win. Till now I wasn't sure, but I don't think I want to win like that.

Hearing my response Charles took his right leg and stomped on the ground hard. I felt the vibrations of that even here from the ground. What did I say that made him mad? There was a small glimmer of red coming out from him now. He says, you would show such compassion to your enemy? He shouts at me. I took a moment to say, we are not enemies. We are not fighting for our lives here. I don't know how people from Heraknus fight, but I have my own way of fighting. I get to choose my own battles and how I do it. So don't think that I made a mistake of letting you turn into this form. If I am to win, I need to do defeat you completely. Even when that means to let you become something that was a mistake.

Charles was now growling. Or was he breathing in from his mouth, it was difficult to know. He kept staring at me like I had given him a wrong answer. I saw the red glimmer around him fade, he then laughs. I was a little shocked at this reaction. Compared to his normal laugh, when he laughs now with his deep voice its still frightening. He says, that was a good answer. That was me testing you. And just like how have your way of fighting, so do I. I wanted to know if you are honest to yourself. You didn't deny you were scared of my Kuret form. People can say a lot of things before, but their true character comes out only when they are actually faced with something they fear. While we have remained in secrete for centuries, that doesn't mean we haven't fought other people and their houses. I have fought many people in my life too. I am sure your heart and mind are telling you to not fight me. Even though you are trying to hide your fear, I can see it as plain as day in your voice. But, not many stand their ground when facing me. I don't know what reasons you still have for fighting me even after you seen my Kuret. Whatever they are, it makes you a worthy opponent.

Wow, this guy. Either he is childish, or he is wise beyond his years. I can't figure out which one he is. But he is now becoming more of a person than a myth in my mind. He then takes a step forward. This time he doesn't uses much force on his steps. He starting walking slowly to me, I will give you one more chance. If you want to surrender, now's your chance. There will be no chance once we battle. Or to be clear, I will not give you a chance. His presence become even more intimidating as he came closer towards me as think about his offer. I began to weigh my choices. He has the worst compatibility for my Kuret. Like Vanessa, his Kurets effect are physical in nature. My usual Kuret attack cannot cancel the force behind his raw strength. There is chance that if I get close enough and wrap my Kuret around him completely, it might disrupt his Kuret. Maybe enough to revert to his normal state. He said himself that their access to Kuret is not consistent. So there is a chance.

He came close enough to see his claws and tails clearly. My strategy seemed impossible now after I saw Kuretines attached to it. No way I can get close to him without risking getting shredded by those claws or pierced by his tails. I have to fight him from distance. It would work more efficiently against someone who uses Kuret attacks. I am sure Charles uses his body to attack.

I began to run out of ideas. Only if I had time and had known more about Heraknus weakness beforehand, I would have more chances. Maybe I should give up. There is no harm in backing out now. No one will be question me if I surrender now. That would mean we will live in Citradel. Kafar has somehow managed to operate with Humans living in his city. More people can live similarly. Catherine can raise her baby with Robb in a city with both Humans and Medrines. It would be perfect for the baby to have such an environment. Maybe we can figure out a way to live with Humans.

My thoughts were interrupted by a conversation I had with James on the day he died. We were talking about how Medrones will live with Humans. He said, it’s a good dream kid. Humans and Medrone living together in one place. Maybe it will happen in future, but not now. Its impossible. You haven't seen what I have seen. Our species have many similarities, but there many glaring differences. Its like you are asking a Chimpanzee to live with King Kong. I asked him which species is what in his reference. He laughs a says, doesn't matter. My point is this planet is not ready to hold two sentient beings. Medrones will eventually have to find a new home. Earth human history is still dwarf compared to Medrines. We need to grow, both technologically and humanity. We are neither ready to know existence of aliens nor ready to handle the other wordily powers you guys have.

I prefer Medrones and Humans stay separate for the time being. Humans are aliens for Medrones also you know. They need to work on getting their bearings. It will take years, but it will happen with a Medrine society isolated from humans. Trust me kid, our species are not yet ready to live together. Your leaders made a wise decision to not let all humans know about your existence. Maybe one day, probably decades or even centuries, humans will be ready. But right now, it would only bring destructions to both species.

I remembers our talks. Even though it was in my memories, it just sat there. When we decided to rebuild our home on the Island, it makes sense why he believed we should remain separate. Its not bigotry or discrimination, its just that Medrines has a different society, just like humans. That means the way forward has to be from our own hands. Our previous generation, this generation and the next generation are already caught in the struggle. I can't let our future generation be dependent on humans and humans on us. We have to move forward. The first step is to build ourselves a home on Earth separate from humans. I can't throw away the match now. If I loose, then we will not make real progress.

With this reasoning, I decided to not to give up. All the while feeling that I am not being honest with my reasoning. Blakes words kept bothering me. Do I really have such a big ego that I can't through away this match. How badly does this match's result matter to me. I can't understand my own feeling. I stop my thoughts going crazy and took a breadth. Well, whatever my reasons. I have already decided what I want to do. I should now focus on the upcoming hurdle and nothing else.

I resolved myself for the fight I have to win. I need to win this match even if my opponent is from a house long hidden from history. Charles was now 5 steps away from me, I completely tuned away everything around me. I have zero strategies. I don’t know any of his Kuret weakness. I felt my resolve weaking. Before I had any more thought of doubts, I did something unexpected. I never done battles without knowing about my enemy or without a plan. But I have to now.

Immediately I draw my Kuret out into my right fist. Charles saw me doing it but did nothing. I blast a large amount of Kuret onto him. I was being foolish, but I know what I was doing. I am didn't want to cower back in anxiety so I did something ridiculous to make sure I can't go back now. I ran backwards to keep some distance between us and I kept increasing the intensity of my attack. My Kuret wraps around his entire body. I don’t know why but Charles didn't move a muscle, he kept still. Between all that facial fur and Kuretines, it was impossible to tell what his expression was like. But the glimmer around him was still blue. What a guy, even when I attack him suddenly he remains calm. I finally made a stand about 50 metes away from him and then shouted, thanks for the offer Charles. But I think you have my answer.

Oddly, it was a little satisfying. I done something totally random, without any plan. I have to improvise until I figure out a plan. I thought for sure Charles would have at least tried to escape from my Kuret prison. But he was allowing himself being covered with my Kuret. A moment later he says, This actually surprised me. For a second I thought you were about to give up. He then starts to laugh, all right, you wish to battle me, then I will give you one that will be will go down as one of the best in the history of Medrine. He then faces his jaws towards the sky and shouts so loudly that my eardrums were about to torn off. That was no Kuret assisted scream, that was a cry of excitement from the glimmer of violet around him now. What the hell is that. Is he trying me behave like an animal now. His voice has probably filled the entire coliseum. From the basements to the top floors, and every Medrine must have felt the intense passion in his voice.

He finishes his cry of declaration and then faces me. He barks at me, David! From this point on, we will not be talking anymore. We will let our fight do all the talking. Do you understand me. I got shivers down my spine as he made his point. But that's to be expected. He is an alpha. He is representing his house who have emerged after so long. He wants to make the best impression in front of all these Medrines. I already resolved myself to fight against his dominating presence. I have to win this for all our future. I shout back in response, I understand Charles. And know this, I am going to win this battle. I somehow find myself grinning. Maybe I have finally lost my mind in the face of overwhelming odds.

Charles made his move. His tails started to curl around his waist. The tails made few laps around his big gut and then he starts to bend forward on his arms to the ground. What is he planning? My Kuret should be effecting him. He was now on all 4 limbs with his tails now curled up on his waist. Suddenly he starts dashing towards me completely ignoring the Kuret wall I put up to confine him. What is happening, shouldn't he be at least weakened by my Kuret. I was already flabbergasted when I first attacked him and his form remained unchanged. And now even after passing through my Kuret, he doesn't appear to have lost Kuret. Impossible.

I wanted to understand how he is impervious to me Kuret, however, I have no time to deal with that. In front of me is a massive beast charging at me a speed which contradicts his body. He ran like a Cheetah covering the distance between us in seconds. I planned to dodge out of his way but suddenly the tails he had wrapped around himself earlier opened up and now covered his sides and blocked my escape routes. What the hell. Those tails were long, he was covering his left and right each side with two. Shit. He was cornering me. The only way is backwards now, but there's no time to use my Kuret to whisk away. I realize I was still maintaining my Kuret on the empty ground behind him. Charles has been running along side the line of my Kuret flow.

Suddenly I had a dangerous thought, there is a way out. I can use this Kuret to draw me in. This means I have to run towards Charles and not away from him. I really have lost my mind if this is my best chance. I didn't have time to think about it. Charles was just 5 meter away from me. I take my left hand and join the Kuret from my right. I wrap my Kuret around my arms like two ropes and let myself be dragged towards Charles.

I don't know if he was surprised to see me do this or not, but he kept going. I had only one chance of getting out of his trap, before he could attack, slide away from underneath him. Its risky, but the space beneath is the only place not guarded. I was dragged by my Kuret head first. I recalled that he had raised his left hand when he was declaring himself to the people, he must be lefty. That means there's a good chance he will use his left claw to attack. I keep me eyes on of his left arm. Charles was now close enough to attack. He let our a war cry from his mouth. His jaw was wide open and baring his teeth's. I didn't even want to know what those jaws and teeth's could do. I didn't let myself distract from this and kept my focus on that arm. He will attack me with his arm and not with his jaws. His arms have more range and was much quicker.

My guess was right as I saw him raising his left arm with claws going in for the kill. I used the force from my Kuret to turn my myself on my left. His claw misses me by few inches and get dragged under him. I willed my Kuret to drag me faster. I become faster as my arms and chest are being dragged on the field. In a second, I came out and felt him getting away from him. I could still see a violet glimmer around me. His tails. I saw from the corner of my eyes, 4 shadows in form of snakes on the grass. He doesn't want me to leave. This is bad, I can't dodge against 4 of those spear ends.

I did the only thing that came into my mind, I released a giant wave of Kuret from my whole body. This tail was the only part of him that was less covered in Kuritine. That means it should not be as robust as the rest of him. I saw the violet glimmers now just above me. I close my eyes bracing myself for the 4 spears coming at me. I felt a small prick on my back, my mind instantly went wild. Shit. What if his tails were also impervious, I am literally screwed then.

I kept waiting for the sharp prick on my back to create holes in me, but I didn't feel them come. All I felt was something more like toothpicks on my back. Holy shit. It worked. I wanted to see what happened to his tail, but not right now. I have to get away from him first. I open my eyes and saw the wall of Kuret that I had thrown earlier getting closer. The Kuret around me also started to subside back into me. Soon I slowed down and reached the place where I thought I had trapped Charles. I hastily gather myself up and turn back to Charles. I was still worried about that attack, so I use my arms to check for any damage in my back. Fortunately, there were no holes. There were only 4 pointed impression my clothes. I managed to save myself from being skewered. Relieved I survived this first attack unscathed, I focus my attention to Charles now.

He was still on his four limbs standing on the ground. His tails behind had become thinner and smaller. The Kuritine on the end of those tails were gone. Now that am a little calmed, I see some of the places were I saw the Kuretines on his body have also been effected. Few have shrunken, other smaller ones have been disintegrated. So my Kuret does work on him. I just need to be closer to him so that my Kuret doesn't thin out as the farther away from I am from him. His Kuret is different from others. My Kuret effects others the same away if I am close or farther away. I can cancel their Kuret from any distance. But to fight him I need to be closer. Great, how the hell am I going to manage that.

I get into my combat position. I will not myself be taken off guard again. I got away this time. I thought he would be slow for his size. But he is fast. Not fast as Blake, but fast enough that I can't use my Kuret Sphere. I need to somehow create some time for me to prepare. It needs to be big enough to hold at least fifteen to twenty attacks. I have never gone that far. But anything less will not give me enough variety and strength of those attacks. I have to also be careful when to use my Kuret dome. I can't use both of them together frequently. I have to choose the timing carefully, otherwise I would be wasting my stamina.

I take a deep breath now. I have multiple glimmers floating around me. I can't fight with so much anxiety and conflicts. There has to be a way to defeat him. I recall back on Medrine, Hanson teaching me that everyone enemy can be defeated. It can take time and patience. But if you gather your wits, a path will be revealed. He was right. For a long time we thought the hive leader was unbeatable. We killed him. And now he have to worry about the Hive King. Someday I will be fighting him. I need to become stronger if we have to survive.

I face Charles who hasn't moved from his spot now. He then pulls himself up and stands on his legs. My eyes widen as I see is chest. There damage to his chest. A portion of his fur was gone. His brown colored skin was bare and no Kuretines was present there. However, there was no blood. Did I do that ? When did that happen. He wasn't effected when he crossed the wall I conjured. And I only wrapped my Kuret around me after I slide away under him and was being attacked by his tail. I tried recalling if I did something before then. Nothing, I was only thinking about my Kuret pulling me faster. I am sure I didn't attack him. Then how did he receive damage. Hold on, it doesn't matter how. I bought some time. Now I should be able to do it.

I bring my arms and extend them with my palms out keeping them equidistant from my chest. I need to make this one big. I take in a short breath before I start to push my Kuret into both palms. I slowly start to bring my arms forward. The Kuret around my arms becomes denser gradually. I will my Kuret to shape in form of a sphere. The edges start to become slightly visible. I have never attempted to make such a big one before. But if the my theory is correct, as long at the ratio remains the same, I will get the same result. It means more of my Kuret has to be condensed. I began to pull out more Kuret into the sphere.

Suddenly I hear Charles shouting. I saw red glimmers coming from him. My focus broke a little as I turn to him. His was facing his jaws towards the sky as he was shouting and he kept his body in place. I gaze upon his chest. His fur was growing back. What. Behind him, his tails were gradually becoming bigger to their normal state. I saw his condensed brown Kuret floating around his body, like shades of winds wrapping over his chest and tails. The pointed end of the tails began to grow another Kuritine. He can heal himself? Few seconds later his chest was now covered in fur and Kuretines. Somehow it looked like there were more of those Kuretines on than before. You have got to be kidding me.

Charles said their bodies have weak compositions. So his Kuret has increased it drastically to this much extent. The Kuret floating on him slowly fall backs into skin after he finishes his recovery. As I see his Kuret being absorbed into him body, I realize his skin and furs all over his body is made of Kuret. It's not his real flesh. I recalled the time he was transforming. His Kuret flow is different from Catherine's when she changes. Her Kuret flows from inside, changing the bones and organs from the inside. Charles was almost opposite. His Kuret came from outside and he bathed in it. All the Kuret was absorbed, I thought he undergo transformation like Catherine did. Instead, he is actually wrapped in a cocoon of Kuret and made this form. His real body is inside all that skin and muscles. So no matter how much I destroy the outer shell, as long he is safe inside, he can heal this Kuret body endlessly.

I was marveled at this revelation. I can't believe such a bloodline exists where the Kuret becomes so dense around the user, it not only becomes physical, it has shapes, colors and strength. Those muscles make a lot more sense now, a Medrine can't have body structure like that. No matter how much buff you get. Then to make some serious damage to him, I need my attacks to go much deeper on his Kuret skin and cut his actual skin. I don't know if those injuries can heal or not, at least now I know superficial surface attacks are meaningless.

A fully healed Charles now faces me and same as last time, he began dashing at me with all four limbs. Dammit. I thought I had time. I dispel my sphere around my arms and my Kuret pulls back into my body. I quickly gather Kuret behind me back and throw it far enough behind me. Until I have found a way to cut through all that Kuret, I have to keep dodging him, try to understand his fighting pattern and come up with a plan. In an instant he was in front of me with his jaws opened, he wants to take a bite out of me now. I wasn't as much scared as before and it helped me to remain calm. I have fought Blake, who was much more faster then Charles. I learned how to move faster from our battle. I need to dodge it the precise moment so that he doesn't get a chance to attack me twice.

As soon as my Kuret was now far enough to pull me back and he leaned forward with his jaws, I pulled myself on my Kuret and flew away as his bites together on spot where my shoulder was. All he chomped was empty air. I brought my elbows up to guard myself in case he tries to attach me with his tails. But it never came. I was able to dodge his assault a second time. Once I covered some distance, I stopped. I started beathing a little faster as my Kuret gets falls back into me.

Around the field there was a glimmer of orange now. Frustration. I saw Charles coming charging towards me again. I may not be as scared as the beginning, but I still am nervous to proceed. I have no choice for now but to keep dodging his attacks until I find a way.

David (Chapter 6)

Monday, 31 January 2022 12:12 PM

Charles is getting a little agitated after the seventh time I was whisked away to safely. There were small strands of red and orange now mixed within the blue glimmers around him. I was under the impression that he is calm always. But with every attack, he was becoming less and less mindful. Must be that he hasn't fought for this long other than the Hive leader. I wonder how long did he manage to keep with Charles attack. I still haven't figured out a way to attack under that dense Kuret. I had to keep my focus on running away for now.

Charles was now charging at me for the eight time. This time he leapt into the air as he came close to me. His kept his jaws close this time, instead he raised both his arms at me. I don't understand what he was planning, but jumping in air will not give him any advantage. I had my Kuret ready in my left arm to pull me away. Before his claws could reach me, I slide away to my left. I thought that was the end of this attack but then I hear a big whooshing sound, like a big rope was being waved in air. I turn my eyes towards him. He was still in mid air, yet he was able to change his direction by striking his tails on the ground. His tails had grouped together and hit the ground with enough force to propel him towards me.

How in the hell. His tails shouldn't have this much strength. His body weight is possibly 10 times the weight of all his tails. I couldn't understand how he did what he did. There was no time to figure it out. He was now above me one more time with both his claws aimed to my head. His large body was flying above my head and I was covered completely by his shadow. I tugged on my Kuret to go faster, but it would be pointless. He caught me by surprise again. I can't let those claws hit me. Even after getting blocked by my Kuret, one of those punches are deadly.

My mind went blank. I couldn't see a way out. Somehow my instincts kicked in, refusing to let him attack me. I have am not that good at acrobatics and what my I thought of evading seemed impossible. With no other choice I raised my legs above my torso and swing them over towards Charles. I was aiming to place my foot on each side of Charles shoulder. I stopped my pull on the Kuret from my arm and started to recede back. I clenched my jaw preparing to pull myself above with my legs using Charles as support. It was tenuous effort, even on ground it would be difficult. I put all my strength over my calves to push myself above. With tremendous effort I pulled myself above just his claws nearly misses me behind my back. I was now floating above Charles head. I somehow found my footing on his back and kicked myself forward to leave Charles behind. I raises both my arms out and poured Kuret to it.

His tails which were grouped together below me started to unravel, he must be planning to hit me with his tail again. Not this time, I mumbled as I threw my Kuret towards his tails. I blasted those tails with a dense Kuret. In the back of my mind, I knew I was wasting my Kuret. But I had no choice. My Kuret overpowered his tails and they start to disintegrate in front of me. By the time those tail came swinging in front of me, they had lost mass and strength. They were thin threads as it strikes me. I started to descend safely down behind Charles. I didn't waste my time to check on what he planned to do next. I blasted a big amount of Kuret from my chest aimed straight to the other side. My feet land on the grass and I crouch down on my knees as my weight pulls me down. I felt my Kuret had reached a safe distance. I allowed my Kuret to drag me by the torso.

In a few seconds, I landed about 20 meters away from Charles. My breathing had become a little ragged now. Damn. I used too much Kuret in pulling of this stunt. I starting breathing from my mouth to take in more air. I sweating now from the cheeks. I use the black of my palm to wipe them off. This is nuts. I barely managed to save myself. I never expected he would be able to change his direction in mid air. My breathing becomes slower and I clam down a little. Time to face him again.

Charles is standing on the place he landed after he leapt in air. He had his head turned towards his tails and was staring at them. His tails were already healed half way. They began becoming thicker and those Kuretines grew back. Shit. How much Kuret does this guy have. I hit his tails with so much Kuret and yet he is just shrugging it off like it was a just an inconvenience. I grind my teeth a little as I became angrier. What am I supposed to do now. If this goes on, I will run out of my Kuret and stamina before he does. So far both of us has not suffered any injuries, but his endurance is much higher than mine. I have to soon begin attacking instead of defending.

Charles healed his tails. He pushes himself above and stands on two feet. He then lets out another big howl that fills the stadium. I didn't even need to rely on seeing any glimmer to know he was getting mad now. Once he finishes his cry, he faces me. He was baring his teeth in anger. His was breathing now from both his nostrils and mouth. Is he also getting tired or that's just how his animal side shows his anger. I believe it's the latter. He then raises his arms above his hands and extends outs his claws. What's he doing now? Behind him, his tails also followed his arms and stood up straight. With his tails now comparable to his height, they were almost twice his height. He lets out another howl and faces to his hands.

My eyes must be deceiving me, but I swear I see his claws becoming bigger. Both his arms didn't showed any visible change, but his hand and fingers started to grow bigger. What!. I gulped more once I saw his tails. They starting becoming thicker. The Kuritine at the end of those tails starting shrinking. Is he pulling the Kuret out of them and using it to make his tails bigger. I looked over to his right arm, the Kuretines that grew over his arm were shrinking in size. He can use those Kuretines to make adjustments to his Kuret body. While it was impressive, what's he trying to accomplish. Making his tails and hands heavier will make him slow. Soon he was done making those changes. He then kneels down on his feet and thrusts his giant claws into ground. Behind his tails do the same action and strike the ground.

He creates a mini quake with this. I could feel a small tremor under my feet. What is he planning with this. He howls again with his jaws wide open. I could even see is big tongue hanging out from it. The ground starting shaking a little. I was horrified at his strength. His 2 arms and 4 tails could generate so much strength. I bet the he was shaking the whole field. Charles let out another howl. A moment later, the ground around him starts to crack. The grass around those cracks gets uprooted. The loose soils starts to slide away as he began lifting a big chunks of soil.

Holy crap. I was completely frozen as I see him lifting a big size of a piece of Earth and lift it over his head. Behind him, his tails had also pulled pieces of ground and he had wrapped his tails around those pieces firmly. Those pieces were smaller compared to the one he lifted. This claws were giving him support lift the boulder that was almost the size of a car. Suddenly he thrusts his head to the boulder in front of him. His head cracks the big boulder like an egg. The cracks started to seep deeper inside and using his claws he splits the massive boulder into two pieces. Each of them held by each claw. He starts running towards me with his two feet's instead of his usual four limbs. He intends to throw those rocks at me once I start running.

I was enthralled as Charles ran towards me. There are 4 small one and 2 big ones in his arsenal to throw at me. He is considerably slower, but I can't just dodge the usual way. As soon as I pick a direction, he will throw one of the rocks at me in that direction. Even when I dodge that, he has other 5 to block my path. Since he can carry such big boulders of Earth so easily, I am guessing he can throw at any distance them with his humongous strength. There was no running away from this.

I sighed. I was getting a little annoyed with myself for running away each time he attacks. Charles will keep trying out new ways to attack and each time they becomes more ferocious. I can't keep just dodging them. I need to go on the offensive. Maybe now it is time. He is slow and all his limbs are occupied. I think now's the right time to use my Kuret dome. I don't want to make it big, just about a meter big room. I recalled I was able to pull it off for a few seconds when I gave Blake the finishing blow. I was exhausted that time, so I could muster only that little room. I should be able to make one now.

I grip my fist hard. This it, an opportunity I didn't want to lose it. I starting running to him. It was a little suicidal running to a 10 feet tall giant with rock projectiles with him. As I ran I concentrated on covering my body with Kuret. My Kuret kept flowing out from my body. I focused on keeping a small space filled with Kuret. But I wasn't able to hold it much for long. Kuret seeped out from the sphere while I try to add layers of Kuret. I kept trying to keep it steady, but I kept failing. I wasn't surprised I couldn't keep it stable, I have never made a small dome intentionally. My Kuret is not like others. I can't keep it condensed and stable together. Time is running out, with both of charging towards each other, the distance keeps getting shorter. So is my hope.

I gave up on in restricting the dome. I will waste a lot of energy doing this, so I have to keep it for only few seconds instead of a minute. I began yelling and let out a burst of my Kuret from all my body. I kept pulling more and more, the space around me becomes darker. I first focused to wrap my Kuret around my legs and arms. As soon we were close, Charles hurled his right claw boulder at me. The huge chunk of soil and rocks is thrown in the air aimed at me. It was leaving behind a trail of this soil and grass in the air scraped off from the sides. I gather my Kuret around my right hand and conjure up a big sheet of Kuret around my arm. I stopped running and make my stand with my feet planted firmly on the ground. I swing my arm towards the left tugging along the sheet of Kuret. My Kuret makes contact to the boulder. The rock was heavy, I could feel it from my Kuret. But I had created enough force to knock it away from my direction. The boulder makes a whooshing noise as it gets deflected towards my left.

I saw Charles wagging one of his tail in front of me. Round 2 of this attack. I am wasting energy blocking these attacks. I need to get closer. I gather Kuret around my back and legs to propel me forward. I intended to go only a little faster, however, for some reason I was moving much faster towards Charles. I have never flown at this speed inside my dome before. Whatever the reason, I was accelerating faster than those rocks would hit me. I was able to dodge by flanking to my right when the second boulder was launched at me. With this speed, I don't have to block the boulder, I can just circumvent through them.

Charles was now preparing to throw another boulder from his left tail. I didn't want to give him that chance, he has one free arm, but he can't keep the boulders balanced. I join my hands together in front of me and willed to form a spear as I spread my hands apart. The spear was initially thin, but I started to pour Kuret from my hands. It was a little unstable but dense enough to have a physical effect. I took the spear in my right hand and aim it to his right leg. I let out small air from my mouth as I pushed it away from my hand. I kept pouring Kuret behind its trail, making it stronger and faster.

Charles threw his 3rd boulder at it path. It struck at the tip of my Kuret spear. Mine was more powerful, it pierced it from the inside and kept going. Charles was now vulnerable. I thought for sure he would get hit, but at the last moment, he pushed down the boulder he had kept in his right hand to the ground and it used a shield. I didn't have the time to go around the boulder so I pushed it inside that rock. This one was much bigger than the other one. There was too many things to pierce through. By the time it came out from the other end, Charles had jumped to the sky. His jump was high enough that he safety was hovering above while my spear misses him on the ground.

Charles now air borne, plans to use two remains boulders. He doesn't throw them this time, instead he kept the boulders wrapped around his tail and swung them from both his sides. I raised up my elbows in front of my chest and gather the Kuret I had thrown to become a shield now. I kept pulling the Kuret back from the path I had thrown earlier and the shield became bigger. I clench my jaw and tighten my fist to brace of the dual attack. So soon as the boulders touches me, I expand my Kuret gathered in my arms and block them. I was being sandwiched between the two rocks. A moment later the boulder broke apart and fell away into pieces. I was sweating now. My heart starting beating loudly against my ribs.

I haven't made a scratch on him. He doesn't even look tiered. All I am doing is wasting my stamina. Charles is descending in front of me. He had his gigantic claw ready to thrust into my face. Really, does he indent to kill me. I don't have time to get away. There's only one way now. I gather more Kuret on the shield I had made. I made it bigger and thicker to withstand his attack. I gather some Kuret around my feet and back to give me extra support.

Charles let out a huge growl as he slices the air with those five Kuretines. The claws make contact on my shield. I felt an immense pressure. Even if his body is made out of Kuret, the force with which Charles hit me is unreal. I felt like my weight had increased by 10 folds. I saw my feet getting pushed down from his attack and it buried a little on the ground. My whole body was vibrating, trying to hold it together. My heart was now dancing in my chest. Sweat now dripped from the back of my neck. I had my eyes closed all this time to focus on keeping my Kuret shield stable. A second later, I felt another attack on the shield. The force of this was same as the previous one. He must have used his other arm. My mind is almost ready give up the Kuret. I was breathing hard. This attack now pushed me further into the ground. Shit. If I hadn't used my Kuret shield, he would have already killed me once. I felt his attack recede, finally, I felt a little relieved. I have a chance to get away now. His claws must have broken after coming in contact with my Kuret.

A surprise came in another attack. The force of this attack didn't change. He still had that monstrous strength in each punch. It came not from the above, but from straight ahead. Impossible. I thought for sure his claws will break or at least become weaker, but it looked like he wasn't even effected. I continued to struggle as I kept my Kuret up against his attack. I had to now gather some Kuret behind my back to give me support as his onslaught continues. I could see his gimmer of his body punching non stop, like he was a wild animal attacking . His tongue was out the side of his jaw like he was enjoying this. The claws in his hand were shining continuously. Charles was flowing his brown Kuret like water on a stream on his arm. The claws broke when it touched my Kuret. Almost immediately, he was healing them with the brown Kuret flowing around his arm.

He can do this? I assumed that it takes time for him to regenerate. For all my previous attacks, he took few seconds before attacking. This is almost instantaneously. Did he deliberately slowed his recovery as a distraction? No, he said earlier he doesn't like deception. Then how. I couldn't give much thoughts between the barrage of attacks that kept coming. My arms were getting tired. He must have now attacked about a dozen now. He kept attacking with such ferocious intent.

I can't keep this up. I should have fled earlier. A minute must have gone by now. I can't believe I thought I could have managed with just few seconds of my Kuret dome. I have wasted too much of my stamina for just defending. I can't believe the stupid decision I made when I attacked him. I let my emotion take over. I didn't had any real plan, now I am deep trouble. His attacks haven't slow down. How much Kuret does he have. He must have more than Blake, Nathan and Tessa combined. My control was starting to waver. The shield in front of me was becoming thinner and weaker. Another couple of bouts and he would have broken through it. I have to get away now.

I am almost out of time now. I looked for a chance between his attack. Once I got one, I yelled with adrenaline running in me, I blasted the lasts of my Kuret around the shield outwards. The Kuret was enough dense to have physically pushed Charles back before he could attack again. I felt the dome getting smaller now. The Kuret that was floating in air was coming back to me. I need to keep some distance from Charles. He was so massive that he barely moved from his place. I took a big gulp of air as I jumped off the ground. I gathered as much I could from Kuret in the air on my hands and threw it towards Charles. He felt the full blast of my attack. This time, my attack had much more force so was pushed back further away. And because I had leapt into the air, I was also propelled backwards from the attack.

I kept grunting as I flew in opposite direction from Charles. The Kuret kept pouring out from me to the Kuret attack going. I saw Charles had brought his elbows in front of his chest to defend his body against the black Kuret. His feet was being dragged across the field uprooting the grass from the roots leaving a visible path on the ground. My Kuret became weaker. It slowly started to come back to my arms instead of out. Soon it became weak to not have any physical strength.

I fall back to ground when my Kuret dome was gone. My Kuret was still flowing into my chest, but it was now having no strength. My legs suddenly grew weak and I had to crouch down on one knee. I place both my fists, knuckles to the ground to give me support. I was panting hard. My heart was beating loudly, my ear drums beating in sync with it. Sweat now came to my lower back. My whole body was still reeling from the effects of his attacks. I was gasping of air.

My Kuret was back inside me. I raise my head to Charles. Charles still had his arms raised. However, my attack had reduced the size of his arms considerably. The fur and the Kuretines were completely gone. His Kuret muscles and size was also diminished. His arms were deformed compared to the rest of his body. They looks like his normal arms. He slowly pulls them down. Wow, that's a surprise. It was not just his arms that took the brunt of my attack. His jaws was cut down in half. His chin and shoulders looked like they were carved out with a sword. His beefed up chest was no longer bulky. All the brown skin was exposed now.

I let out a sigh, at least I was able to do some damage. Even if it was not physical damage, he must have lost some Kuret. I don't believe he has unlimited Kuret. He must have some limit. Charles stood at his place and wrapped brown Kuret over his body. His Kuret began healing the parts of his body. His Kuret started circling around him. Both his arms were now covered completely and gradually they grew back to its original size. I still haven't landed a single critical attack on him. I have somehow been able to defend from those claws. His Kuret now travel up his body fixing his chest and face.

I disheartened face the ground below me. This fight is crazy. I may have bought a few seconds until he heals. However, its not enough. I try to pull out my Kuret. Only a small amount would come out. My body was coming down from the adrenaline and started to sore a little. My heartbeats slowly subsided. I was taking in deep breathes to calm myself. I was desperately searching for ideas to buy more time. I am in the worst situation. I shouldn't have used Kuret dome without a clear plan. What the hell was I thinking.

I peaked at Charles from the corner of my eye. He was almost done healing himself. His fur and Kuretines had grown back on his chest. He was now healing his face. Not good. I haven't found a way to buy time. There is no place to hide in this big open field. I got angry. I pull my right arm and punch the ground with my fist. So my only option is to surrender now? No. I can't. Not now. Not after so much has happened. Then what should I do. My only hope of defeating Charles is to use the Kuret sphere. I need time to create one. For that I need create distance from Charles and make him slow. I can't find a way for either that to happen.

Charles Kuret was dissipating now. He had fully healed to his former state. Crap. Here we go again. I had calmed a little but the panic to face him without my reduced Kuret was keeping me agitated. As soon as the last of his Kuret went away, he looks up and howls. What's the point of doing this. He should not be feeling pain when its just his Kuret being damaged. Every part of his body was covered by thick Kuret. Wait, that's not true. There is one thing that is still exposed. His eyes. Unlike the rest of his body, his eyes is not covered with any Kuret. What if I manage to slow him down for some time by attacking his eyes. They had grown a little bigger when he transformed, so it makes an easier target.

But how do I attack them. I immediately looked over the ground near me. Of course. Charles has been rampaging all over the field. There are patches of baren land where grass were uprooted and exposed soil. I look over the place where he had thrown that massive boulders to defend himself from my spear attack. I bet there is a rock strong enough to throw. The only problem is that it is about 50 meters away on my right. I have to run to that place before Charles catches to me. It needs to be a very fast run. I couldn't think of any better plan. So I didn't waste another second. I stood up even though my body was weighing me down a little. With a last ditch effort, I dash for the holes in the ground.

Vanessa (Chapter 7)

Wednesday, 2 February 2022 1:49 PM

I am completely shocked that David made the first move. What made him do that. And it was not just me, everyone here felt it was unlike his usual approach. Charles had offered him a chance to give up, but David's reply came in form of him using his Kuret to trap him. I was the first to say, this is the first time he made the first move. I though he would keep some distance before attacking.

Ned beside me says, what's he thinking? Does he think he can cancel out the Kuret from Charles body. Will that even work with such a massive body? Ned had voted against David. And I was annoyed with him. How can he support a stranger over our friend. Ned has been planning for almost a year for Citradel to join us. It was his dream. He had said many times I will win this tournament and make his dream come true. But ever since my defeat he has become a little sad. Did he really want only me to win. It shouldn't matter who wins amongst us.

Kafar who had starting drinking, took a sip from the glass and says with a smile, dear boy, do you really think that Charles body is made up of real flesh? He lets out a small laugh. Cass asks, what's that supposed to mean? He replies, aren't you from a house that boasts physical abilities when use your Kuret. Does using your Kuret changes you body in any visible way? Cass shook her face, no. My bloodline Kuret strengthens the muscle fibers and organs in our bodies. She looks over to the screen, but this is house Heraknus. The amount of Kuret he just released now is no where near the amount we use. And his Kuret is so much condensed. Her eyes widen and faces him again, are you saying that body is actually made out of Kuret?

What. That’s unbelievable. I can understand Kuret taking physical shape like Jess's bloodline. But its entirely different to have varied sizes, skin and color. Jess asks, that’s not possible. Sure, Kuret can become visible if Kuret is dense enough. But Charles has furs, skin and muscles. A Kuret cannot do that. It can't create complex physical features. She pauses a little to think it over, I mean, at least I have not heard such a Kuret in existence.

Derek pitches in, its true. Kuret cannot do that. But Heraknus bloodline Kuret is a little different. For vast majority of Medrones, Kuret is something pulled in from the atmosphere. The tiny ambient Kuret floating in the air is absorbed by the body. That happens continues during a fight too. However, Heraknus don't do that. They have an uncanny ability that allows them to keep the Kuret they recovered into their body until it runs out. They can't pull in the ambient Kuret from the air. Charles told me that’s a trade off for having high endurance and control over Kuret.

Wow. That’s incredible. Blake asks, but that still doesn't explain this body changes. How does having Kuret stored up inside the body allows the person to become, he couldn't think of a analogy, so he pointed his palm to Charles, well him. Derek nods, yeah. Believe me, I was also skeptical at first about this whole Kuret turned flesh thing. This what Charles told me, he looks over to Blake. Because their Kuret stay inside their bodies all the time, the Kuret has formed a symbiotic relationship with the body. Now there's a give and a gain from this. Heraknus Kuren, you could say its mutated a bit to change form to a physical state. Their Kuret have adopted some of the properties of their physical body. It’s a little difficult to understand, much less accept this, it is how they turn their Kuret into bodies.

I was mesmerized by Derek's explanation. That incredible. Never I imagined a house like this ever existed on Medrine. I then ask, so does that mean that their bodies have same stuff like weight and strength. Derek nods, oh you bet. Those punches he gave me had the real physical power. And not only power, his body is covered in fat skin and big muscles. So his defensive capability is also real.

Matt says, if what you are saying is true. Then David has this match in the bag. His Kuret will easily remove that body if its made of Kuret. Right? It doesn't matter Charles has more endurance, once his Kuren is drained out of his body, he will become weak. Derek looks to him and replies, if only that was true. I told earlier that Kuret becomes physically real right? That means parts of his body are not Kuret anymore. They have become real enough to be immune to David's Kuret. Brain was visibly astounded, are you kidding me? But even if his body had become real, it was still made from Kuret. So it can't be that he is not vulnerable from David's attack?

Derek takes a second to answer, honestly. I have no idea. Parts of his body is still Kuret. Those Kuretines are proof of that. But Heraknus is not only the bloodline with a strange Kuret. David's Kuret is also difficult to comprehend. There is not even a mention of this Kuret in any books I have read. And like Charles, David's Kuret also always reside in his body. When we fought last year against the Hive leaders army, when the anti-Kuret bomb denoted, only David was still able to use his Kuret. So his Kuret is eerily similar to Charles and yet so different because he doesn't change like him. So I am curious to see if his Kuret will even work against Charles.

Derek made some excellent points. I wanted to know more about him, but a sudden shout from Charles changed my focus to him. He was still wrapped inside the Kuret. He was now ready to make his move. I wondered what he would do to get out of David's Kuret cage. He wrapped his tails around him, then crouches down forward to stand on all four limbs. What came next surprising. He just crossed the barrier, ignoring the repercussions. He ran out the other side and ran towards David. He was fast like a Cheetah. Blake says, whoa. What is Charles thinking? Won't running through David's Kuret cause damage to is body? No one had any answer of that. Then we say his body remained unchanged. There was no visible damage anywhere. Nathan said, well we got our answer. David's Kuret doesn't affect Charles.

I can't believe Charles is not even weakened a little. Anyone else would have their Kuret drained out of them for some time. Heraknus are truly extraordinary. We see Charles approaching towards David fast, something that should have been unlikely due to his size. David was visibly panicked seeing Charles running over to him. He must have been terrified. Anyone would be frozen when a beast is running towards you. David made a posture that looked like he was ready to dodge the attack by running sideways. Then Charles expands his tails towards his sides and blocks David's movement. Damn. David was getting cornered now.

Kafar was wooing now, is the match already over with this first attack? I wanted to shout at him but held myself. Charles had almost closed the distance between them. Finally David made his move. He let himself pulled by his Kuret he threw earlier and flew straight. Straight towards Charles. What. I tightened my fist nervously. What is he doing? Is he really thinking for fighting head on. His Kuret didn't work on Charles, so what his plan. I couldn't think anymore when they were close enough to exchange punches. Charles raises his arm and bares his claws at David. Somehow David manages to dodge that attack and hugs the ground. His Kuret kept pulling him as he slides away underneath Charles body.

The whole crowd roared in excitement. I had unconsciously held my breadth when Charles had attacked. I let out my breath in relief. I thought David managed to get away, but Charles tails now were aimed at him. Those Kuretines on the end were sharp and thick. David is immune to Kuret, but not from the force of the attacks. David was probably aware of the danger from the air, but he was still trying to get away first. I almost closed my eyes in hopelessness. At the last second, David let out a big wave of Kuret from his body. Because his Kuret was close to David's body, it was dense. His Kuret blocked the four tails from reaching him. A moment later they even started to slim down in size. David's Kuret does works on Charles.

David's Kuret suddenly did something unexpected. He had radiated Kuret all around his body, but now all that Kuret around him circled around his body. Like a river going around a rock, his Kuret moved to a single point, his back that was facing the sky. All the Kuret collected on his back was released a moment later towards Charles. Charles had turned around to chase David, but he didn't get that chance. He was struck with the Kuret David released behind him. Charles was caught off guard. He couldn't defend himself from this.

The black Kuret pushed him back a little, Charles was able to withstand the force. Few seconds later, David was slowing down at some distance. His Kuret was being pulled back to him. The Kuret David throw earlier left Charles. What remained behind was a damaged body of Charles. Some of his Kuretines on the body were gone. Charles then stands up on his legs. His chest fur was gone. The brown skin was exposed. He didn’t look critically injured, but it proves that David's Kuret works.

Matt sighs, fhew. that was too close. I can't believe David choose to run at Charles. I bet that must of surprised Charles. He laughs and the asks, and what the hell was that attack? I have never seen David do something like this. Jess continues, who by the way is not immune. I don't understand what David did, but look. Charles took damage. His tails have shrunken and his some of the Kuret was removed from his body. Charles may have a real body, but he is still vulnerable.

Derek says, no one in their right mind would charge at Charles in this form. He smirk a little, but that was the right decision. He couldn't retreat, he couldn't run sideways. This was his only choice, wish I had done the same in our battle. He mumbles something to himself. Nathan turns to Kafar and says, so I guess David's Kuret does work on Charles. Is it too late to change my vote? He asks with a little smile. Kafar was still calm. I thought for sure he would be worried as his champion isn't as invulnerable as he claimed, don't worry. Even if that black Kuret works on him, Charles is still standing. As long as Charles doesn't revert to his normal self, the match will never be over. He looks towards David, although, I must admit I didn't expect David to get away safely without getting hit.

When did David learn to do that attack. He never used it in his previous matches. As I wondered over my thoughts, David was doing something weird after noticing Charles taking damage. Ned asks, what is David doing now. It looks like he gathering his Kuret around his hands in a ball shape. Yeah, David had his arms raised in front and was pulling his Kuret in the space between.

Blake shouts, oh hell yeah. He raises his fist to his neck in excitement, this is what I saw him doing in our match. I remember David doing this hand gestures. This is the ace up his sleeves I was talking about. Marina asks, Really. What is he doing? Blake says, no clue. He never told me what is this. All I know for certain is that if he kept it hidden for so long, even during our match, it must be something really powerful. Catherine says, I don't know Blake, it looks a lot like when David creates that dome. He is just gathering his Kuret in one place. How is it different from then.

Derek who had his eyes glued to the screen at David says, this is definitely different. His dome involves using the Kuret he already released. Very much like Blake. But this, I can see he is not just gathering Kuret. He is slowly increasing the amount. Its almost as if he is pushing it inside. I ask, whatever David is doing, I don't think Charles will just stand by watching. He needs to hurry it up. I looked over to Charles who now was gathering Kuret around him. What's he up to now. I was curious about something. I ask Kafar, earlier you said that long as Charles doesn't revert back he will be okay. What do you mean by a that. Surely he will be in trouble if David attacks him like this continuously. Sooner or later, all the Kuret in his body will be chipped away piece by piece.

Kafar responds, you will know what I meant soon. Just watch. I look to Charles on the screen. His chest and tails were wrapped with brown Kuret similar to what happened when he was transforming. Oh no. This can't be good. Few seconds later, the Kuret vanishes and his injures are no longer there. The fur had grown back, the tails have gone back to their original size. Marina says, oh crap. Charles can heal himself so fast ? A second later Charles let out a war cry and starts running again on his limbs towards David.

Derek says, yes. He can heal his body as many times he wants. Even if it is real flesh, it was originally grown from Kuret. Heraknus have incredible amount of Kuret. Their alpha has even more. This was not enough to seriously injure him. I was shocked at that. So even if David's Kuret works, it is not enough to take Charles down. David was probably as shocked as us. He saw Charles running at him. Whatever he was planning, he had no choice but to drop it.

Matt says, damn. David was so close. Now he will probably have to duke it out with Charles. I thought David would attack again. Instead, he choose to run away. He threw his Kuret behind and got pulled back before Charles could land another attack on him. The crowd let out another wave of noise as David narrowly misses his claws. Blake says, ah, why is he running? Can't he just fight like he did earlier? If he does, he can gain some distance and try that Kuret ball thing again.

Charles didn't waste a second as he followed David. Again, instead of fighting David ran away. I ask, what is going on. Why isn't David fighting back. His earlier attack worked. Why does he keep running away. The same thing happened at the fourth attempt. David let his Kuret drag him away from Charles attack path. Whatever be the actual reason, I think David has no choice but to run for now.

Blake says, how long can David keep it up ? Derek shrugs at him, I am not sure. This is not good. David dodges two more times Charles attack. How long will he keep running away. After another few clashes, Kafar says, whoo. That was a close one. I thought for sure Charles would get him this time.

Derek kept silent at that remark. I don't think he should feel bad. Derek is the second strongest person from Citradel. Charles is just too powerful. I look over to the screen where David landed safely away yet another time. He might be under pressure right now, but he always find a way to overcome it. At least I hope. His next assault looked to have the same result. However, this time he jumped into the air and came with both his arms raised. This was a weird choice. David pulled away from this air attack. I wasn't noticing this earlier, Charles had grouped his tails together. As he was floating in air he thrust his clubbed tail to the ground and changed his direction. What.

I held my breath again as I saw Charles now looming above David. David is still pulling away, but Charles is faster. My eyes squint at the thought of those sharp claws heading at David's head. At the last moment, David locked his feet on Charles shoulder and kicked himself upon Charles back. My jaw open little seeing this ridiculous display of acrobatics. David jumped on top of Charles and kicked himself away. Just like last time, those tails were aimed at him again. He blasts a ray of black Kuret to deflect them. Those tails lost lot of Kuret and became thin. David let out another blast of Kuret away from him and flew towards its direction.

I let out a big sigh, this is nuts, I say, this was way to freaking close. At least David can handle those tails. Derek says, yes. Charles tails are indeed having the least amount of Kuret. So a normal bust of Kuret wave up close must be enough to cancel his Kuret. David landed few meters away. What will you do now David, I thought to myself.

Charles took a couple of seconds to heal his and let out another howl. Marina says, what's up with this werewolf act. Why does he keep shouting. Don't tell me he really is part animal when he changes. Kafar says, don't be ridiculous girl. He is not doing it because he wants to. He is letting out the pain he has been receiving.

Blake faced to Kafar, what pain? He is healing himself with Kuret. Why would that cause pain. Derek says, its not just the pain of regrowing limbs. He is also letting out the pain through shouting for all the damages David has been giving him. I was curious now. Why would he feel pain. That’s not his real body. Beside me Ned snapped his fingers, I got it. You said earlier that Kuret and his body are linked. Because of that his Kuret turns to real flesh. But that goes both ways, any damage his Kuret gets, he feels the pain of that attack. Right?

Derek nods in agreement, Yes, that’s correct. The Kuret turned flesh has become just as much as part of his body like his real limbs. He feels pain when the Kuret gets chopped off from him. Usually, the Kuret on his skin is so tough that it can withstand a lot of physical attacks. But David normal attacks are not physical, they rip apart the persons Kurets. If David gets close enough to attack with some more Kuret, he could do some serious damage to Charles.

Kafar says, that’s not a major weakness Derek. Trust me, our champion has extraordinary endurance. Yes, he feels pain. But that amount of pain is superficial. His stamina and strength more than makes up for this. Derek nods, that’s true. It would take a lot of time to completely drain an Heraknus alpha's Kuren. Not even David can match up to that level. Besides, Charles is a veteran. He is used to getting his Kuren blown off by other Medrones. Those howls are just for him to release his mind of the mental pain since his physical pain is no more.

The more I learn about Heraknus, the more incredible they are. Sure they have their own unique weakness, but their strength is more than enough to tip the scale in their favor. Charles, after healing his tails, stood up again on his legs. He raises both his arms above his head and the tails behind him stood up straight too. I have seen enough to know that Charles is always does something shocking when his previous attacks doesn't pan out. A moment later, his hands and claws were wrapped up in Kuret. So were his tails. He was already healed, what he doing this for? I got my answer when is claws and tails started to grow in size. They kept growing gradually and finally the Kuret dispelled. His claws were massive now. The tails were thicker and the Kuretines at the end were gone.

Ned asks, Derek, I thought you said their form doesn't changes. What is this then? Derek says, no. If you see carefully, his basic form hasn't changed. All he did was augment parts of his body. This is something only an alpha of Heraknus can do. Of course, there are limits to what extend he can change their size. This is manageable for him. I ask, okay, but why did he do this. Won't it make him slower with those big hands? Derek says, Charles doesn't fight in a complicated way. He goes by his instincts and whims. Whatever he is doing must have simple reasons. And I think you can see what he is doing.

I looked to the screen. He thrusts his massive claws into the ground. The four tails did the same. Then Charles lets out a big howl. Then came tremors. The wall of our rooms slightly shake. Wait what. I looked outside the window where people sat. The crowd also had grown a little silent and began whispering instead. Did they also feel this mini earthquake? The vibration stopped when Charles pulled out a massive piece of soil rock from the ground. A second later, the tails also dug out pieces of rocks. They were smaller in comparison to what was in his hand. That one was as large as a truck.

Marina jumps on her chair, holy shit. Did I just see a Medrone pull out a massive boulder from the ground just with his strength? Cassandra says, that’s probably twice or thrice the size I can manage. This is insane. I wasn't sure until now whose house had more physical strength, mine or his. This clears up that debate. To think our was considered the strongest physical types till now. She shook her head shocked at this feat. Matt tries to comfort her by patting on her back, whoa, its not a contest you know. She nodded slightly.

I think I had maxed out my capacity to be surprised. I thought Charles would hurl this massive rock towards David. But he headbutts the boulder on his hands instead. The boulder starts to crack and splits into two. Now he had 2 rocks in his hands. A moment later he starts running on his legs to David. He was slower this time. Derek says, what I tell you. He attacks are simple. He just relies on his brute strength. Nathan, says, yeah. Simple but insane. No one would think of doing this. David can't just run away like earlier. I bet he can throw those rocks quite far and with speed.

We were patiently waiting for David to run away. He had no choice but to dodge this. In a completely opposite move, he starts running to Charles. Blakes, what is this now. He asks when we see David pulling out his Kuret in his hands. It looked like he was trying to gather more Kuret but they fell threw. Is he trying that Kuret ball thing again ? Blake asks. No one had any idea. A couple of seconds later released a massive amount of Kuret from his entire body. His Kuret began filling the air around him making it darker. I ask, Hold on, is this what I think it is?

Blake says, yeah. It his Kuret dome.. Derek says, maybe he has a plan? What could it be. He mumbles. David doesn't do something without having a plan of attack. He must have a reason. Soon they both get close enough of each other. Charles make the first move with throwing one of the boulder from his hands. Just as Nathan thought, Charles had thrown it with such power that it flew fast. David didn't have the time dodge this so he creates a big sheet of Kuret and hits the boulder from the side. I thought the boulder would break from the collision, but David managed to throw it off course.

Charles then prepares to throw a boulder from his tails. He dodges this one with his speed. Charles prepares to launch another one from his tails. In response, David creates a spear from his hands made of Kuret and throws it forwards. The spear pierces through the boulder and flies towards Charles. To defend against that, he shields himself with the boulder he had in hand. The spear dugs into the larger boulder, but by the time it came out, Charles had jumped in the air. I am amazed to see that a being of that much height and weight was able to jump so high. He easily crossed the boulder and hovers on top of David and launching two more remaining boulders from his side.

I thought David would now run. He surprised me as he creates a Kuret shield making his stand. The boulders crush David in between, but his Kuret was stronger. The boulder breaks apart. Now he should run away. But he still didn't. He stood there to prepare for Charles punches from those large claws. I felt annoyed. Why is David fighting like this. He is so methodical and calculating. He makes very move with the intend to win. But this is unlike him.

Charles throws a punch on the shield around David. The impact creates a humming shockwave that was felt far away even to us. The dust from the ground around them few away from the shockwave generated. My eyes widen in worry. This was a powerful punch. I have never seen two Medrones stir up this much without Kuret. The wall around us vibrate for the second time. David's shield held up. He was a little pushed to the ground, but he was okay. I let out a sign in relief. Then Charles attacks with his other fist. Another shockwaves is flown from the field.

David managed to defend against that as well. Charles lands in front of David. Now's the chance, run David. I mumble. I don't know what's going on with him, but he has used his dome at the wrong time. He may not even realize what he did the first time they clashed. Whatever he planned to use his Kuret Dome for isn't working. David should have run when he got the chance, but he didn't. He just stood there, his Kuret still wrapped the front side. Charles took this opportunity and started attacking him.

Charles shouldn't have been able to attack consecutive times. Those black Kuret should have declawed him and damaged his hands. But Charles didn't seem to care. He kept punching on the shield. The shockwaves radiated from the field to the entire stadium. The dirt on the ground started to vibrate in a rhythm, shooting into the air at the wave generated from the impact. The vibrations continued to happen on the walls of our room. I could now feel it passing into my chair and trembled my body.

Jess says, what the hell is going on here. Charles punches are so strong, I can feel from so far away. I ask Marina, I thought the barrier would block all physical attributes. That includes shockwaves coming from the inside. Marina nods, it does. It will even bounces back any Kuret induced wave attack launched at it. After another wave from a punch she continues, these shockwaves are not coming from the air. They are coming from the ground. I didn't think it was important to put the barrier inside the ground too.

Matt asks, hold on. Does this mean that without the barrier there would have been even more tremors? Holy crap. Then anyone standing inside the barrier must be blown away from sound pressure. Another wave vibrated the walls. Incredible, to do have such effect from this distance. Its unimaginable. Blake says, its not just Charles. David's also part of the reason for this. That shield he conjured up, to be able to withstand so many attacks, it has to be stronger than any Earth metal.

Kafar says, how long do you think David can keep this up? Soon he will run out of time, and he won't be able to use his Kuret for a few seconds. Then what? He asks Derek. Derek didn't have a reply from him. He was completely focused on the screen that showed David struggling. I am worried about that too. Does he have a plan for that? David had now taken more than a dozen of the Charles punches. Suddenly he blasted a wave of his Kuret from all his body. That pushed Charles a little back. David now jumps up to the air, his Kuret assisting him, and then he gathers Kuret on his hands. He then thrusts all of it towards Charles.

Charles is now being dragged away on the field. David flew backwards. His dome was now getting smaller and Kuret from the air started coming back to him. A few seconds later, they both slow down and stop. David's Kuret was now retreating back. He fell to his knees exhausted from all the punches Charles thew. I turned my gaze to Charles now. Whoa. This is by far the most we have seen him taking damage. His arms had shrunk, his beefed up chest was gone. His jaw was cut down in half. Almost all the Kuretines on his body were gone. His tail was the only part that remained unaffected. But all this damage was still not enough. He brought out his brown Kuret and wrapped it around him once more. He started healing himself.

Sadly, David couldn't recover like that. He wasn't injured in anyway, but he was looking tiered. He used too much of his Kuret and probably used up too much energy and stamina. I gripped the side arm tightly. Thinking about Ned's comment about David earlier made me realize I am a little angry at myself. That could have been me fighting Charles instead of David. Ned had been supporting so much, I somehow convinced myself that I would become the winner. I had to make my peace a week ago when Blake and David fought, but I couldn't help feeling I could have won if I tried a little more. As soon as I thought that, I chided myself. Everyone here has lost their match. Everyone gave their 100% and still lost. I can't be the only one feeling this. Besides, I don't think even I could have done any better than David. Sure, all my attacks are physical and could be fired from a safe distance away from his grasp. But Charles Kuret body is too perfect. He could have easily blocked all my attacks or heal himself. Our match would probably be long, but Charles would have the advantage of endurance.

Nathan says, David's has lost now. He has no way defending Charles now. He doesn't have time to recover enough to use his Kuret. He pauses for a second, He still gave a pretty good fight. I bet fighting someone like Heraknus

can make anyone lose their will. Its time for David to give up. I wanted to refute Nathan, but I couldn't find the words. He was arrogant and presumptuous, but not wrong. David has made some mistakes. He must be really be feeling the pressure of fighting someone doesn't know anything about.

Blake says, I know its looking a little bleak. But I know David can still pull out of this. Don't forgot, at times like this he pulls out some crazy shit. A title like Shadow strategist is the hardest one to obtain amongst the other shadows. Don't count him out yet. Blake was still confident. His faith on David didn't look even a bit shaken. It was admirable that he was loyal to his friend even now. Meanwhile, I almost gave up on David. I don't want to anymore.

Nathan looked like he wanted to say something. But he remained silent. Everyone were on the edge, trying to hold themselves from loosing hope. No one other than Blake offered any hopeful thoughts. We just sat here staring on the screen. Charles was nearly healed. David was now back on his feet and running somewhere right of Charles.

I mumble to myself, come on David. Don't give up. It was almost a silent prayer, which I hoped it would reach him.

David (Chapter 8)

Monday, 7 February 2022 2:56 PM

Stupid. Stupid. Stupid. I kept saying it to myself as he ran to the debris. I can't believe I had no choice but to come up with this dump plan of throwing rocks at him. I am supposed to be one of the smart peoples in this island. Smart my ass. This whole fight I have been nothing but struggling. I kept attacking without any plan. I kept running away when I should have fought. And because of all my mistakes, I am stuck in such an unbelievable situation. I need to buy at least a minute to recover a some of my Kuret.

I see from the corner of my eyes that Charles was on my tail. He is much faster than me and will be on me in a few seconds. He is not even trying to pull his punch's and keeps attacking at my vital places on my body. He is aiming at my neck and head. He really is trying to kill me. He must know the rules of this tournament. Yet he attacks me with such dangerous intent. I don't even want to know what he might do to me without my Kuret to protect me.

I see that big boulder Charles has unearthed earlier coming closer. I hastily scanned for couple of rocks that were small enough to throw. Behind me Charles was gaining on me. I saw blue and a hint of red glimmers coming from him. He must have been getting agitated. He was totally calm in the beginning. But now he is getting annoyed. I also saw bunch of other glimmers coming out of me. Resentment, anger and pity. I didn't want to focus to much on that, because nothing good will come out now.

I found couple of rocks that could work. They looked like stones and were size that could fit in my palm. Two of them were fallen on the ground and three were stuck to the boulder. I reached the boulder and thrust my both my hands to dug them out. Two of them came out, but one was firmly stuck. I moved one to get the ones lying on the ground. Just as I picked those stones, I felt tremor from the ground. Charles was now close. My heart which had cooled down a bit was back to beating hard. If this doesn't work, I might be waking next in hospital. Or worse, not even wake up.

I have two stones in each hand. And I have only one chance. I need to attack both his eyes at the same time. I am never been an expert in hitting targets with small objects. I can do it with a gun, but never with my hands. Never needed to learn. I can't throw them from far and I definitely can't when he is on top of me. As I kept racking my brain for an answer, I hid behind the boulder obstructing Charles path. Dammit. What do I do. I ran all the probable ways to attack in my mind, but none worked. With the speed Charles is running towards me, the targets are moving constantly. The chances of hitting his eyes is very less. If his reflexes are good, he might even dodge them.

Suddenly the words speed and reflexes rang a bell in my mind. That's it. It was the only idea I thought of so I wasted no time in doing it. Charles was dangerously close. I faced to the boulder and looked for ways to climb up. Fortunately, I have been doing my fair share of mountain climbing. When I found few steps that could hold me, I climbed up. I need to be at least 7 feet above the ground. The tremors and red glimmer increased in the air. He is almost here. I jump a little and catch a spot of protruding rock with my wrists. It was insanely difficult to climb with stones in my hand. The root and loose soil slide as I pull my self up. I felt my elbows scratching from the larger rocks and cuts my skin. I bit my lip to suppress the pain. I can't stop now. I push myself from another spot.

I open my eyes and focus on to the ground. Somehow I made it to about 3 and half feet. That will have to do, because now I can hear Charles breath. He is just opposite to this boulder. Okay, the timing needs to be to the point. If I jump before he would see me coming. If I jump later, he will catch me. I listen to Charles strides and the glimmers slowing becoming larger. I was able to judge where he was coming from and how fast. I have only few seconds before he comes around from the left. This is it.

I waited for another 3 seconds and when then I let my instincts do the rest. I jumped off the boulder to the right side. In a fraction of second as I was hovering on top, my eyes flicker on the body of Charles coming into view slowly. He didn't see me yet. He had slowed down to a halt to turn to his left. I anticipated where his head might come from based on this height. I kept picturing what distance his eyes from the top of his head.

I was running completely on instinct as I pull my hands back in preparation to throw them to the point where his eyes would come in another half a second. His head slowly comes into my view now. This is it. Even with everything happening so fast, I could feel every heartbeat coming from my chest. Once my elbows reached as far as I could, I now pushed them forward. I aimed my fists to the place my instincts told his move to. I didn't have any thought to second guess. I throw those stones and they flew into that direction. Charles eyes now came into my view. His pupils turns to me hovering in air and I could see was about to leap in air. He pushed his legs into the ground to give him boast. He didn't even brought his tails of arms in front of him to defend against the stone. His mind must not have registered it. Or he didn't care. Whatever the reason, the stone flew towards his eyes unobstructed. I held my breath as I see the stone coming in contact to him.

I was only 1% sure this would work. But my eyes couldn't believe when one stone each from my fists hits the bullseye mark. They rocks were quite strong, but his eye socket was stronger. At the moment of contact, it broke into several little pieces and scattered around his eyes. His eye big lids came rushing down to protect, but the damage was done. Tiny pieces lodged into the edges of his eyes. His eyes now was closed.

I was about to crash against him. I put my elbows in front of me in cross shape as I prepared to land of the side of his torso. I hit his skin. It was damn hard. I felt the pressure on my elbows and abdomen. The Kuretines dug into my skins. I couldn't register pain because of all the adrenaline. The Kuretines slowly crushed and began fading after coming into contact. I may not have access to my Kuret, but even in my natural state, my body cancels Kuret.

Charles let out a big howl when I start to roll off from him. I was rolled sideways as his momentum kept him running forward. I tuck my head forward as I brace the impact of hitting the ground. My back lands on the ground first. I kept rolling to my left for few turns before I finally stop rolling and halt on my elbows. I hesitantly turn my head forward to Charles. He was now standing up on his legs and raising his fingers to his head completely forgetting those claws. The claws creates scratch marks he tried removing the dust and rock pieces lodged in his eye and eye lids. Upon realizing that his claws did even more damage, he lets out another big howl.

I almost let a laugh seeing my ridiculous plan worked. And Charles even hurt himself further. But I have no time to do that. I need to get away as far as possible from him. Where? This is an open field. If he opens his eyes for even a fraction of second he could see where I am running to. There is no place to hide. My eyes move to the boulder. Hold on. I do have a place to hide from his broken vision. The large hole in the ground he dug up to attack earlier.

I waste no time in getting up. I could feel that I had bruises all over my body, but the pain was for the moment pushed down for the moment. I ran to the opposite side of the boulder where Charles had thrown. It was a little far but I had become faster, completely taken over by the blood rushing into my legs and hips. Charles kept howling into the sky. So he can't heal his real body. This must buy some time.

I reached halfway to the big hole on the ground when there was another massive cry from Charles. Now I saw only red glimmer coming from his direction. His shout was different than others. I turn my head to check what was going on. His eyes were still closed but he was now on all fours. His tails stood up straight and he kept wagging it in the air. Brown Kuret came out from his body and starting circulating him. They kept swirling in a spiral pattern towards the top his tails. Suddenly those tails started to grow in length. They became longer and longer.

I realize what he was planning to do. I turned my head around and kept running. While I ran, I could see the glimmers of those tails beginning to cover the entire arena. Those glimmers were gaining height even as I get further away. There was another big howl. I am almost there. I didn't bother to check how close the glimmer of those tails were and became of them. All I knew I had to jump into that hole before they reach me. I heard a loud whooshing sound. I risked a little as I turn my eyes hesitantly back.

They were now the size of almost 8 story building and they generated so much sound when they swing in the air. The Kuret around them had dissipated. A moment later, those tail end gradually bend to the ground, in all four different directions. The tail ends began speeding and taggling along the rest of the behind like a snake flying the sky. Now that he was incapacitated for some time, he wants to catch me with those tails.

I was nearly there. I could feel the cracks underneath my feet caused from the epicenter of that massive ground displacement. And I saw a glimmer of one tail forming in behind me on the grass. Its coming right at me from above. Shit. The hold came into my view now. It was bare and damp inside. The hole was not deep, but it was wide and big enough to fit about couple of people easily. The broken roots and loose rocks were covered at the surface. I barely made it in time when I jumped off the edge of the hole and slide down on my back to the bottom. The roots and stones stuck on the uprooted surface bruise me all over my body.

But I managed to save myself from the tail that swept from the right and went to the left covering all the air above my head. I was breathing hard and fast. My mind and body was on overdrive. I had to make a conscious effort to calm down. It takes several seconds to slow down my body.

When I finally cool down enough, I inspect my surrounding. I was surrounded by debris of stones, roots and loose soil. The hole created by Charles was in a shape of nearly a bowl. I was lying near the edge of the bottom. I move my eyes to my body to check for any bleeding. I had cuts and bruises on my leg and arms. I could feel the blood color glimmer coming from my behind. I have few cuts there as well. My face was drenched in sweat. I had a couple of bruises on the sides of my neck. There was cut on the left side of my head. I closed my eyes to help me get over the wave of soreness flowing over my body.

My breathing slows down. When the adrenaline starts to leave, I began feeling the pain of those cuts. Fortunately, none of the them are dangerous enough of losing too much blood. My body felt a little tired now. Above me I heard Charles running around the ground and howling. His footsteps were now much heavier. So were his tails. They kept making loud noised as they swept through the entire field searching me. That means Charles is still blind. For now. I let out a small sigh and open my eyes. My chest started to beat less now after realizing I have bought some time.

Once my mind became a little free, I rejoiced that this actually worked. I can't believe my luck. I wanted to peak to the top and see how far Charles was, but I didn't want to risk it. From his footsteps and glimmer, he is far enough from me. Lets keep it that way for a while. After a moment my bliss crashed down when I realize the people in the coliseum saw my pathetic state. I don't have any style of fighting in any of my matches, but never I had to run and hide. I could imagine everyone reaction in the VIP room. Would they be feeling confused or shocked at me. I am myself ashamed. I should have never charged in with my dome without a plan. I let my anger control me.

I have never been in such a situation where I didn't have some sort of plan ever since I got my memories. At the very least I didn't do so many stupid things in the span of few minutes. From the moment Charles came crashing from the barrier I have been doubting myself and loosing confidence. Because of that I made mistakes. This thought made me recall a talk I had with Hanson back during my Shadow training.

I was with Hanson in a observation room above the training area. There were monitors and control panels for various battle situations and environment creations. We both were looking below from the glass pane where two people were training. One was a young 12 years old right Blake. He was training for his shadow attacker role. He was dressed in the standard shadow uniform, but he wasn't wearing a mask. His opponent was his predecessor. The most brutal shadow member and probably the worst Medrone I have ever met. But I didn't know his real identity at the time. He was wearing his mask. Only the Hanson knew who he really is. A shadow rule forbids revealing their identity to even other members. With the exception of the shadow strategist. Since Hansen choose me, I am having a rare position that allows me to know about others from my generations shadow members.

The training session was in its climax. Blake was fighting a veteran, the outcome was pretty obvious. Blake and I had formulated a plan for this training session. I remember he didn't trust me much since he had to reveal who he was, but I can't tell him about me. Yet after weeks of wariness, we began to develop some trust. We came up with various battle plans to help him prepare for today. In the beginning, was doing great. He kept a safe

distance from which he attacked. His Kuret didn't have the same control as today, so it was mainly bursts of straight Kurets thrown to the other guy. He was making good progress, but as expected, he couldn't match the experience of his opponent. He become slower and his attacks grew weaker. I had expected this, even if he has more stamina than most Medrones, he isn't used to fighting efficiently.

I already told him that it was impossible from him to win. All we could achieve is to make sure he didn't lose straight away. Blake kept attacking with his Kuret at his predecessor. Blake kept dodging the attacks sent back as a response. He was getting tired. But Blake didn't give up. He kept going, trying to at least land one attack on him. Hanson clicked on the microphone on the control panel and said, stop. This training session is now over. Blake completely ignored Hansen and went for another attack. That was a mistake. The next second he was thrown back far into the wall. His body limped as he fell back to the ground. I saw his hands moving as he laid on the ground, he is still conscious.

Then the worst guy in Medrone history spoke, brat. He said the training is over. We don't have a place in Shadows for arrogant kids who think they are above rules. One more shitty act like this and I might just kill you. You understand? Blake didn't respond. He continued, puny kid. He turns his back to him and starts walking to the door, and that performance was pathetic. I bet you and the that worthless kid planned those funny attacks. Let me tell you, if this the best you both came up with, you better run back to your mommies. This is not place for children who think they have a little modicum of talent. He said nothing else as he walked out.

I was furious at him. I wished I could have punched him. But that was impossible. He wouldn't need to raise a finger to kill me. I looked over Blake. He was still lying on the ground face forward. He probably has few ribs broken and a concussion to head. I moved to the stairs leading down to the training area. Hansen stops me, don't. Leave him for a while. I rebuked him, what. He needs help. He is badly injured. Hansen says, good. Then he understands the consequences of not listening. I couldn't believe what he was saying. I reply, that was totally uncalled for. Blake got a little carried away, but he didn't have to suffer so much for that one tiny thing.

Hansen pauses for a moment before saying, I understand kid. Believe me I do. But you need to let Blake understand for himself how his predecessor operates. They will be on missions on the field together. You need to let Blake understand the dynamic of their relationship. If you keep butting in, then Blake will never learn. That’s a not good for the mission. I ask, there is no relationship. That guy is a monster. He treats kids like they are worthless. I can never understand how such a guy became a shadow. If no one stops him, he might just end up killing Blake.

Hansen holds his palm up, that’s enough David. I understand your concerns, but you cannot speak such things out loud. He looks over to where he had exited, and not just because he is your senior. Even I don't know what he might do to you if he heard you say such things about him. Hansen then looks at me, you need to understand that every shadow was selected for a good reason. And its not for their personality. You need to learn that if are to replace me. He then speaks into the microphone, Blake, you did well for your fifth session. But you must learn from your mistakes. You let your emotions dictate your actions in a situation where it was not needed. You made a mistake. Until you realize that, you will not grow. He pauses for a moment, you are hurt. Tell me if you need help.

No response came from Blake. His royal pride didn't want him to accept help. After couple of seconds Hansen said, fine. You can lay there until you find your resolve and walk out to the med bay yourself. He closed the microphone. Blake didn't move a muscle. I could see he was still breathing erratically, he was conscious and listing but choose to lie there for some time.

I was still angry. I never predicted he would do something like this. If I had known maybe I could have warn Blake not to have such outbursts. Hansen saw me and says, its not your fault kid. You can't predict peoples reaction all the time. I reply, but isn't that my job. To understand how an enemy thinks and how to defeat them. I look over to Blake, I knew Blake couldn't beat him. I spent hours convincing him that it was enough to show his progress instead of trying to win. I told him from his previous training sessions it was that its pointless to try to win. So instead we came up with ways to make sure he doesn't get defeated early in match. I asked him to give up once he was out of moves. But he kept going. Why couldn't he just listen to me.

Hansen says, not everyone fight with logic. Your job isn't just to understand the enemy, but to know your allies too. You were convincing something impossible to Blake. He is a kid from royal houses. Surely you understand that having such a status means people are expecting great things from him. Blakes also knows this. People will not know about him being a Shadow. Yet he keeps pushing because he wants to show his strength and show he is worthy to his parents, to others and even to himself.

I say, and because of that attitude he is lying on the ground. He should have stick the plan and just given up when there was no chance of winning. Hansen shook his head, its not that easy. It sounds logically an easy choice to give up in the face of 100% failure. I think even Blake knew he wasn't going to win. But that doesn't matter. His heart defied that logic to continue fighting. I grew irritated, you don't need to quote human philosophy to me. Heart is an organ, it doesn't make decisions for us. Its just a simple metaphor people use it for excuse when they don't want to deal with explaining why they can't be rational. Its all here, I point to my head, all the emotions. Feelings. Logic. Neurons firing and making decisions. Everything can be controlled if their mind is strong. If Blake just had swallowed his pride, he would have not been beaten so many times. He kept doing the same mistakes.

Hansen, that’s where you are wrong. He didn't make the same mistake. That plan you helped him make, while it was complicated and difficult, Blake still learned it and used it. That shows that he understood who is was facing and he needed help from you to overcame it. And in part it worked. His moves were more refined and unpredictable than earlier. Blake lasted longer than any of his previous spars. I say, but that didn't change the outcome. He still got plumed into the ground when I explicitly told not to go overboard against him. I didn't wanted him to bleed out again this time. But look, he is now lying in the ground.

Hansen says, the outcome was never going to change. Blake couldn't let himself be constrained by that outcome. He keeps pushing and pushing his limits. I know what you think, there is no logical reason to do something that ends with the same result over and over. Hansen knew exactly what I was thinking. But that’s how some people live. He then looks at me, this even more true for us. Our actions has massive impacts on nations and other people. So we have to keep learning. Failure and mistakes are the best way to learn. Without knowing about yourself, you stop growing. You become weaker and you can't defeat your enemy. We have to constantly challenge ourselves, accept our mistakes and learn from it. You need to learn about peoples nature to help others do the same. And for that, you need start thinking not just logically, but with emotion.

I was listening to Hansen with great care. He is so much wiser than me, but I still wasn't satisfied, isn't my job to not make a mistake? You said it yourself, we have to do our jobs without any mistakes otherwise it would cause problems for all people. How can we make sure that our mission is successful all the time then? If I tell other Shadows to do something thing this way and instead they disobey me, how will we work together?

Hansen says, I think you have been misconceived what you are supposed to do with what you think you should do. You are not supposed to become someone who doesn't make mistakes. You are here to make sure that even if something goes wrong, you can still can fix it. Let me tell you something. There is no perfect win, no perfect mission, no outcome which is perfect. There will always be regret and second guessing. Not even I have had complete successful missions. There is always something nagging in my mind. Maybe I could have done this, then I wouldn't have to do that. With the impact our actions hold, its not a surprise that completing missions that have great implications are bulletproof.

Listen to me very carefully David, you will make mistakes. Great ones. Small ones. Some will be out of your control. Others will be because of your decisions. One day soon, you will face a big challenge. I don't know what form it will be, but all your strategies and tricks will not aid you. You will make mistakes then. Unless you can accept them and move on, you will be stuck. Doomed to repeat. Blake pushes ahead even after facing obstacles over and over because he wants to become more stronger as Blake, not as a Shadow.

I pondered on this. Becoming stronger as a person. I couldn't relate to that. Because I don't have anything else than being a shadow. I have no Kuret, no family, no bloodline house. I am literally no one. And that’s what drove me to join Shadow. Because I had no goals. No prospective of becoming someone great. Instead I had only one dream. I have only told Hansen about it. It was what I wanted to use for my final wish once I retire from Shadows. Hansen says, I understand its difficult for you to understand this. You will meet other Shadows soon. Their selection is almost done. In few weeks, all five of the next generation of Shadow will be chosen. And you have to lead them.

I was just a kid with no family, what did I know about responsibilities. I ask, why did you choose me. I still haven't gotten a proper reason from you. It can't be just because I am smart. There are plenty of smarter people to choose from. I don’t have even a little bit of Kuret. On the contrary, I cancel out Kurets with my touch. Then why did you choose me. I can't even do my job properly.

Hansen just stares at me as I had a meltdown. He slowly walks towards me, no. You are the best person for this. It doesn't matter you don't have Kuret. Its not what is needed or necessary to get the job done. He then places his hands on me, I choose you because of many reasons. I can't tell all of them now. But I think its time to tell you one of the reasons. I look up eagerly to him, I choose you because you know what it means to be powerless. You can't fight, but you found other ways to do with Kuretines. Only a person with great ingenuity can reach to where you are now. Right now you are inexperienced. But I can know someday you will grow into a person who just doesn't just plain, but will fight to execute it.

I let out a small laugh hearing this, you must be joking. I never thought you have such humor. I can never battle, not like Blake, or like you or other Shadows. I can only stand behind everyone and send them to fight. Hansen was quite for a while, maybe. But one day you will have to face something or someone on your own. I just hope that day you remember my advice. It is okay to stubble down now and then. You need to have confidence in yourself, not in your strategies. I tried my best to understand what he meant. I have never been with same people for long, so naturally I don't know much about peoples behavior. But I realize now that I have to consider people themselves when making a plan.

There was a movement below us. I looked over to the training area. Blake finally got up and starting walking. He was limping a little. He could move his right arm and used his left to hold by the elbows for balance. His left ankle was probably broken too. Even though it would take only few hours for him to heal, its still too excessive to attack on a kid like this. And this is not the first time him doing so despicable too. I resolved myself and made another personnel goal. Someday, I don't know how. I am going to kill that guy.

I open my eyes and I found myself temporarily disoriented. I looked over my surroundings, I was still in the pit. I got my bearing as I realize the predicament I am stuck in. Last year when I got my memories, they were not completely cogent. Since then, I have been able to recall them with clarity. Could Hansen secretly see the future? He was spot on when he said I would face something like this. He was correct, I kept making blunders and wrong choices ever since Charles came crashing in. I have been doubting myself continuously and lost confidence. All my battles were based on the faith I had in my strategies. What a self-reflection realization to know that I didn't have confidence in my own abilities once I am left without any plans.

My thoughts were interrupted with the tremors becoming stronger. Charles is nearby. My body tensed up as his foots step become closer. He couldn't have regained his sight so quickly, could he? About 45 seconds had passed since I hid. And I still haven't recovered my Kuret yet. I need to move out of the pit. I quickly dismissed that idea. What good will that do. If he can see, he will attack me as soon as I come out. I remained inside the pit hoping he is just passing by.

A moment later Charles body came into view. He came from the other side of the pit. His tails were still circulating the whole field. He was walking on all four limbs now. I hesitantly gaze to his forehead. I feel relieved to see he still has kept his eyes shut. He still can't see. Knowing that I immediately hold my breath. He will hear me if I keep breathing loudly instead. He had his head leaned forward and pointing is ears forward. I slowly place my left hand on my mouth. If I remain silent, he might move away.

Charles came closer to the pit slowing after checking the ground with his left hand. Shit. If he continues this path he might fall inside with me. Even if doesn't he will realize there is a perfectly hole in the ground from me to hide. I have to send him away. I turn my eyes around the ground my body is hugging. I found a small rock near to my right. I slowly move my right hand to pick it up. Charles took two more steps towards the pit. I pulled back my arm as slowly and silently I could and throw it to above to my left. I wanted Charles to run a little farther away so I had to throw it with much force.

I waited patiently for the stone to hit the ground. Meanwhile Charles was just a foot away from the edge. If he takes one more step he will sense the hole. Just when he is about to put his left arm forward, we hear a small enough thump in the ground. Charles immediately turns his head towards the noise. A second later he turns and starts running to the source. When he was far enough, I remove my hand and took in a big gulp of air. Too close.

Almost a minute and half now and I still can't use Kuret. Crap. Hansen's voice remained fresh in my mind. He was right, I need to accept my decisions. I have made a fool out of myself. More so, everyone have seen me failing and running away. I can't change that. But I can stop being resentful. I have to remove all doubts if I am going to win now. I have to have faith in me that I will find a way to beat him. I tighten both my fists in anger. I should have kept my distance but also fought him. Running away continuously just made Charles dominate this match further.

I don't have strategies or plans. I don't know any weakness Heraknus Kuret have. But what I can do is keep trying. Its going to be trail and error from here on out. If I can't fight the usual way, then there is only way. I hated myself for recalling that worst guys advice. But I am desperate. He is without a doubt the most despicable Medrone ever to have born, but he was the strongest Medrone when he was alive. I smile a little at that thought, correction, I thought he was the strongest, but clearly Heraknus were alive then. That helped to accept his advice. Fight like your enemy, become your enemy and then destroy your enemy.

If my usual tactics of fighting opposite to my opponents can't beat Charles, then I have on choice to fight like he does. Rely on pure strength completely. That means I need to up my game. The glaring weakness I have is my inability to have physical attacks continuously. I need to learn how to do it. This made me recall James. He used to say that a battle is just like a training. Only different is that if you don't learn quickly and use it to your knowledge in the fight, you will die. That is so true here.

For the first time since the match started, I began to feel a little hope. Hope that I even if I keep failing and have no real plan, I will still have enough confidence to continue fighting.

David (Chapter 9)

Wednesday, 9 February 2022 1:46 PM

Almost a 2 minute passed since my retreat. I still don't have access to my Kuret. I should have been able to use at least a little bit. I don't know why I can't. I know I used the dome too haphazardly just now, but I didn't keep it up for too long. Just about a minute. My body should have recovered enough now. I raise my arms and try to summon a bit of Kuret. Nothing. Its like I am blocked. What's the hold up?

I look up into the sky. I began feeling a little despair. I know I made a self resolve to not give up, but I couldn't help feeling irritated. How in the hell am I supposed to fight Charles with power that matches his strength. I know I can tip the scales in my favor once I use the Kuret sphere. But I don't have the time to pull that off. I can't pull another premature decision to use that. I have to use it when the time is right. For now, I need way to bring the match and even our odds first.

I gave another try. I close my eyes and focus on my instincts and praying to pull out at least a Kuret size of my palms. I open my eyes. I am staring at vacant air. Dammit. What's going on here. Any second Charles will be able to see again. The same trick work twice again. If he finds me in this state, doesn't matter what I do, I am done. Suddenly I realize something, wait. I start at my arms and then to my legs. What if my body is not the issue. It could be phycological. I understand what's going on. I have the yips !

My last tussle with Charles has made me unconsciously scared of him. I blasted him with so much Kuret, but he just walked it off. He later healed himself, and all that effort I made was for nothing. Not Derek or Blake were came back after that attack. Its no wonder that I am nervous fight him. I never thought I would have to overcome such a mental block. This never happened to me ever since we left from the valley four years ago. In spite of such a set back, a small laugh came out from my lips. My list of problems keeps getting longer. When I finally made my mind to fight however I can, I am too scared to do it.

Technically, I know what I need to do to get over this. I need to confront Charles head on. Buts that’s a stupidity on a whole other level. I need to find a way to make my Kuret physically materialize without having a backlash. With all the research I have done, I still couldn't find away to do it. The main problem remains that my Kuret is a complete mystery. There is no mention of a black Kuret than cancels out Kuret. It makes it harder to develop my powers. That’s why I have been copying others. Except for my combat knowledge, all my Kuret abilities have been a derivative of others. With the exception for the Kuret sphere, I have no fundamentals of my own that I can use regularly.

Two and half minutes passed. Still no sign of Charles. This is getting dangerous now. Any moment he will come looking for me in this hole. He is already scouring the entire field with his tails. I sighed. His tails can be augments to increase size and length. Not just the tails, but the arms too. Its not surprising if he can change his legs too. All he needs to do is pour more Kuret into it. Suddenly I eyes widen and jaw open a little when I realize something about Charles Kuret.

His Kuret is also not like others. His brown Kuret wraps around him like a mini tornado hugging his body and he stays in the eye of it. I began recalling all the time he healed himself. The first time when we clashed, I was somehow able to blow away a portion of his chest. When he started healing himself, he never kept his Kuret still. He kept it moving around his torse in a circular fashion. Every other Medrone I have seen heal or use Kuret for attacking doesn't need to keep their Kuret moving continuously. Their Kuret just sort of takes different shapes and sizes. Once it gains enough Kuret mass it becomes dense. Charles isn't doing that.

It was like my soul had been invigorated. I feel I am on to something very important. I began recalling all the times he healed or used Kuret to change his claws, arms or tails. Every time he used his Kuret, it was never still. I don't know if it’s the nature of his Kuret or if he is control it that way. Whatever the reason, the Kuret never remains still. When he was attacking me with barrage of fists, he was flowing his Kuret from his arms into his hands. Instead of directly wrapping his hands in Kuret, he had to move Kuret from his chest. When he made he arms and tails bigger, the Kuret flowed around his torso in a spiral form to the ends. When he heals, a lot of other parts of his body are wrapped in Kuret, even the parts that were unaffected. Same thing happened when he made his tails the length of a building.

His Kuret doesn't come out of the place he attacks or heals. It flows into from other places. It never remains still. Always moving and coalescing into a stronger form. So strong that it becomes real enough to become physical. I have been basing all my abilities from seeing others. Mainly copying Blake because our Kurets are similar in nature. But now I think its not enough. Blakes can maintain his Kuret in space without further effort. I can't. Neither does Charles.

Okay, now I am getting somewhere. My Kuret dome basically increases the density of my surrounding, but its cost too much energy and stamina. If I can somehow make my Kuret also move constantly, then maybe I don't need to exhort to create much pressure to make my Kuret physical. The problem is I have never be able to move my Kuret in such a tight manner around me. Its too erratic to be controlled so accurately. I can give it shape and direct it wherever I want, but the shape is arbitrary. Its like a fire. I can control the speed, direction and amount. Never its shape.

I need to be able to shape it into spinning Kuret and then group them together to give shape. Such a fine control has been out of my grasp. As I went through my thoughts I kept picturing Charles Kuret. I made another realization, Charles is pulling out Kuret from all his body. The amount depends how far it is from his target, but he definitely pulls out Kuret from entire body. He has to be bringing out small amount of Kuret from all his body, then grouping it together as it swirls around him and finally it becomes strong to become physical to replace the damaged parts.

I stare at the sky above me. This is way too much complicated for me at this moment. Even if this theory is correct, its not like I have the time to practice it. I can release Kuret from my entire body. I can even control the amount I release. But making it move around my body instead out in the air is very difficult. I don't even know where to start. I have always pulled in Kuret back into me before releasing it from the different part of my body. I don't have a clue on how to keep it floating on me. Its became a habit of mine to pull it back in before releasing another blast. There is a push and pull nature of my Kuret. Making it stable was completely unattainable.

My mind went on wild run trying to figure this problem. I was so much engrossed that I didn't realize the ground was shaking little. I was to too late to do anything. The soil was trembling on my left. The roots and rocks starts to get loose and slide down. A moment later the shaking becomes to much and with blast noise, the soil broke with a force. A long brown Kuritine edged rope came out from the ground. Charles tail. I was so much engrossed in my thoughts that I didn't saw the glimmers from his tails coming closer to me. I tried to get away, but the tail already sweeping the whole from the left side and making its way to me.

His tail made contact before I could run away. Upon contact, the tails starts to bend and began twisting around my legs swiftly. It was too long and fast for me to get away. His tail had completely gripped my legs. I wrapped my fingers on the tail trying to pull it out away. But it was too strong. How is he touching me? My body naturally cancels out Kuret. I focus on the back of the tail. I could see brown Kuret flowing from the end where it came out from the ground. He is continuously pouring Kuret into the parts in contact with me.

I kept trying to pull it away, hopping he can't maintain his Kuret on me for long. I need just one second to get away. Unfortunately, I didn't get that. The tail suddenly drags me in the air above me by the legs. I am being dragged out of the ground straight up with my arms dangling beneath my head. I see the world upside down. The ground was up and sky was below me. My hair was falling away from my head. Pretty sure even if I was standing on my feet, they would have stood up straight from the fear I am feeling right now.

I saw Charles standing at some distance on his legs. All his tails were buried into the ground. Huh? It took me second to locate his eyes. They were partially open. He must have realized I was hiding inside the ground and used his tail to search inside now. He kept me locked in the air at some height. He let out a loud howl and the tails that were buried started to pull out from the ground. The tails broke the surface, leaving big scars on the grass. All the soil were uprooted along its length. The ground looks like a spider web. Each crack was deep. How much strength does this guy have to make cause so much destruction.

The other tails fly toward me. I try to wriggle my way out before they attack me. I concentrated to pull out Kuret. Even a little is enough. Nothing happened. God damn yips. How can I fight if I am so scared now. It was too late, the tails were now in front of me. I am like a fish stuck dangling on the rope and 3 sharp harpoons are going to run me through. I close my eyes in response. A moment later I felt the tails reaching me. But they didn't pierce me. I open my eyes. He was wrapping the other tails on me. One tail slither on my arms and wrap them. Then it pulls to up behind my back. One tails began wrapping my torso to bind my arms behind me. The other one wraps me by the chest.

I became completely immobilized after a while. All the tails were pulling in Kuret from Charles continuously to keep it from weakening. The tails began dragging me forward. Charles is pulling me in. I have no chance of dodging this one. Blood is rushing into my brain as I was upside down. Pressure increased inside my ears. The wind now pricked my face as Charles increased the pace. I can't use my Kuret and now I can't run away.

I have about few seconds before he pulls close enough to do whatever he plans to do. My thoughts went on lightening speed. I don't want to give up, I have already accepted the bad choices I made. I don't want to loose after coming so far. I cannot be defeated like this. Think. Think. I have to be missing something. A way. A trick. Anything to gather my Kuret from my body. I saw Charles body becoming bigger now as I flew close. He had his hands raised in front, ready to attack me. No. No. Come on, think David. What am I missing? I moved my eyes away from Charles in nervousness and stared down to the sky. I saw the tails wrapped on me. I haven't seen it this close with his Kuret before. The Kuret was disappearing from being in close proximity to me, but before it did I saw some bits of Kuret were clashing and overlapping each other as they move.

I had assumed Charles Kuret was completely in sync, but looking so closely I saw his Kuret was not always moving together. A huge portion of his Kuret was flowing randomly. Some even broke off the path and vaporized into air. Like sparks of fire from burning a wood. An idea came into my mind. Maybe the extra blood to my head invertedly helped me think. I moved my eyes back to Charles. I didn't focus how many seconds I had. I yelled out a war cry. I don't want to give up now. And I don't need to be scared anymore now that I have found a way.

As soon as my resolve strengthened, I felt the spark of Kuret returning to me. I gave no thought enjoying its return, instead I released a tiny bit of Kuret from my entire body. I focused on releasing it only for a fraction of a second and then will it to be pulled in back. I never tried pushing and pulling it back so tightly, but somehow I was able to manage it. The Kuret begin pulling back, before it touched my skin and force it again out from the same spots. Again I pull it back in before it stretches further. This was so weird. It like I was stretching a rubber band. Somewhere in the back of mind I was hoping that the tails would become loose. But Charles had been pushing incredible amount of Kuret into them. It would take my full blast to remove them. I haven't recovered enough to do that. I have no choice to make this work.

I gave it a couple more rounds. Come on. On the sixth try I finally felt something. My Kuret didn't felt like pushed or pulled. It was vibrating furiously up and down on my body. Its almost as if its dancing on my skin. Its creating spikes when it extends and hollows out at the bottom. This happens too fast and its impossible to see with the eyes or the glimmers. I could only feel it. At last. I put every bit of brain power I could muster and focus on moving it to my face. I imagined how Charles uses his Kuret. I willed it to move the same way. It didn't happen. All it did was made me loose few parts of the stable Kuret on my body. Dammit. I can't use the same way as Charles. I have to figure out what suits my body.

Times up. I was face to face with him now. The only thing of me he hadn't wrapped with his tail was my face. And that’s where he planned to smack his claws with. He really is trying to kill me. In the last second I open my jaw and once again let out a cry. Charles claws was now coming right at my face. My mind went blank in that moment. I didn't know what compelled me to do it, I released the Kuret I have been holding it. In that split second, all the Kuret over my body began running wild. They formed into a thin Kuret threads and were running around my body like electricity. There was no synchronization or pattern. Every Kuret thread moved around a random direction.

What's shocking is that even in that frenzy state, they were actually heading in the same direction. To my face. It was pure instincts, there is no reason or logic on I how am able to do this. The threads were coming from different paths from my body, however, they somehow culminated at the same point at my forehead. The threads combined on my temple and it started to become thicker and darker. In that second my whole face was covered with my Kuret. Charles claws struck my face once I had dawned a Kuret mask.

I thought I was done for. Even with this last minute miracle, the Kuret wouldn't be strong enough to defend from getting my head crushed. I felt incredible pressure when his claws came with in full contact. Somehow the Kuret formed on face was still holding. Not just that, the Kuretines on the claw immediately broke when it touched my Kuret. I may be imagining but I swear I could see his cracks forming on the skin. They spread back further his wrists up above this arm.

Meanwhile, I was being pushed back from the force of the attack. I could feel the pressure on my face. But he never made touched my skin. His hands were definitely on my head. Is this really happening? My Kuret is actually dense enough to protect me from his attacks. And I am not even using my usual Kuret dome. I didn't have the presence of mind to enjoy this momentous victory. I was still wrapped to the tails and now starting to swing backwards into the air. I didn't want to be a punching sandbag for his next attack.

Once I swung back far enough and his claw left my face, I focused to compel the Kuret I gathered to move over the rest of my body and cut those tails. My Kuret complied, but the not way I thought it would. I thought the condensed Kuret would just slide to rest of my body. Instead it split into those sperate threads again. They move in random direction from my head down to my neck. What the hell. Good news, my Kuret didn't fall back inside our away from my body. Bad news, they are swarming in all random frenzied directions. I saw Charles preparing to attack me from his other hand.

No way in hell I let him hit me again. I can probably gather the Kuret again on my face, but I would be stuck here defending myself continuously. Been there, done that. Will not repeat that same mistake again. I came up with a crazy idea. The Kurets running around my body were not strong enough to be dense. They can still work on his tails though. I yelled out once more and willed them to go faster. My Kuret listened to me and the threads sliding on my body ran faster.

My body felt like it was run over by ropes of electricity. Some were twisting around my arms or running in circles on my chest. Soon my legs were wrapped with circular disks too. I start to descend forward after reaching a certain height. Charles was ready to throw his other punch. Come on, hurry. My Kuret ran rampant on my body. Their speed was crazy fast. Even I could only track some of them. The next second I could feel the tails loosening. Hell yeah.

I kept focusing on my Kuret to go faster and wilder. The tails began to shrink. Even with the support they got from Charles continuously pouring Kuret, my Kuret was dominating. I could wiggle my arms a little now. My legs were becoming loose from the grip. I starting flexing my shoulders and clenched my teeth as I push my arms out. I came dangerously close to his other punch. Just before his claws reached my face, I came loose. The momentum of my fall carried me forward and I slip down towards earth. I saved my head, but now his claws were aimed at my chest. Coincidently at my heart.

I mentally force my Kuret running rampant to gather on my chest. This is going to hurt, but its better than having a hole. Because I had been making my Kuret faster, they gather up almost twice as fast earlier. I barely made it in time when the claws came in contact to my chest. I felt my lungs being crushed by a large rod poking on my chest. My skin starting throbbing. But just like before, there was only pressure. No physical contact to my skin. No bruise. No blood. The Kuret formed on my chest was shaped like a shield. Part of an armor. It was wide covering the area of my chest that came in contact with his fist and at the same time it was strong.

Same thing happened to Charles this claw as earlier. The Kuretines didn't get to make a scratch on me before disintegrating. This time, his fingers were broken and cracks went back into his up his arms to elbows. But the force remained unchanged. Without the tails keeping me stable, Charles is pushing me with tremendous force. My arms and legs float ahead of me as I am hurl backwards into the sky. I was knocked at least 15 feet above ground. My back of the face felt the wind kissing as I am fly away. I still am inverted and I see Charles moving higher and smaller from my view.

A few seconds later, the Kuret I had gathered dispelled. I consciously forced them to not come back inside me. So they now keep circulating my body. Their speed had reduced but at least they are still here and stable. I am not out of the woods yet. My body is in a bad position. The wind pressure is making it difficult me to extend my arms and cause resistance to slow down. If this goes when I hit the ground, I might break my spine. I started to descend backwards into the ground now. I roll my eyes above and see the ground approaching fast. I gather the Kuret threads to my back to form a shield. My back instantly gets covered by Kuret.

No. Its not big enough. I was able to only cover my lower back. But the rest of my back is exposed. With this much speed, I can't break my fall with so little Kuret. I see the ground coming closer now. Momentum and gravity tilted my body and rotated me with my back to the ground. My hands and legs were wriggling in air uncontrollably. I had my teeth clenched bracing for an impact. No, I can't let the impact to happen. The fall will break several bones.

I came up with another idea from my bag of miracles. I willed my Kuret strapped on my back to pull me up. I should be able to push my Kuret forward now that it is solid and powerful enough to give me physical support. I close my eyes and focused on that single command. I order my Kuret to push me up. I began feeling a resistance forming behind me. Its working. Its slow and weak, but its working. I don't have enough Kuret yet to give it more boast. I could feel I am about the ground in the next second. I yelled to give one last big push to my Kuret.

With a sudden jerk, my Kuret pushed me up. My arms and legs swing down a little from the upward force. It was enough to counteract the gravity and for a split moment, I was just hovering in the air. I hastily pulled swung my arms forward to momentum to my legs. In the last second, my legs straightened out and I came crashing down to earth. My balance was skewed, so I crouched my head forward and wrap my arms around my face. I summersaulted on my back as I rolled on the ground.

Finally I stop after a turn on my back. I was dragged a little forward from the fall. Soon I came to a complete stop. I let go of my arms and let them fall into the ground. I was facing the sky now. My arms and legs lazily rested. My breath was ragged. I am breathing from my mouth. Adrenaline was pumping my heart to the limit. My mind finally slowed down from the intense minute that I just went through. I know I shouldn't be resting, but I wanted a couple of seconds to myself. A laugh came from my mouth as I finally was able to enjoy my new powered up Kuret.

David (Chapter 10)

Wednesday, 9 February 2022 10:08 PM

My bliss came to a sudden halt when I heard a howl from Charles at some distance. Come on. Can't I get couple of few more seconds to rest. I turn my head above to see what he was up to. His tails were waving in the air. The parts that I broke free from were healing now. I thought I cut completely them before. I must have instead only made them smaller and light enough to escape. He was also pouring his Kuret onto his hands to heal the broken fingers and cracks.

I push myself above from the ground. I had new bruises and lesions over by body. But none which I can't handle. My Kuret was still running wildly on my body. I finally get to inspect them closely. I raise my palm closer to my eyes. The Kuret threads were like electricity running around my body only a couple milli centimeter above my skin. They were floating in complete random directions. And somehow they never intersected each other at any point. When I focus on one particular thread I could make a circuit. It was not totally random. The total movement are random, but the individual Kuret threads had some pattern.

They were quick like lightening and thick like fire. Both the ends were capped off abruptly. And I could feel that those threads themselves were vibrating. They behaved like the water surface that was ran through a earthquake. They formed irregular spikes with varied size and height. Yet they maintained shape. I felt like a child seeing candy for the first time. I have never seen my Kuret doing this. I somehow have been able to change the nature of my Kuret. That should have been impossible. You can change size, color, shape, type and power of a Kuret. But never its nature. In this regard my Kuret is even much unique and weirder than Heraknus.

But I have notices few limitations with this. First, I can't keep the Kuret together for long. Second, I can't move it together. I still have to break it into threads and gather it in another place. I sigh, I changed the nature of my Kuret, yet I still have movement issue. On the plus side, I can now shape my Kuret into physical entity without taxing too much on my body. I can share the burden with mental effort now. I can also make shape my Kuret incredibly fast.

I turn my hand into fist and try to pull out more Kuret. Nothing changes. Damn. So I can only use this much amount to fight for a while. I look up to check on Charles. He is healed up now and ready to face me. The glimmer around him now had strands of pink. Confusion. I couldn't help stop from laughing a little. I bet he wasn't expecting this. I know I wasn't. Charles uses his tails to attack this time. His large tails were now pointing at me and speed up to me.

I would be sweating to face this ten minutes before. Not anymore. I have to stall for time to recover my Kuret completely. And I have confidence that I can do it. The tails came together in my direction. His tails are a big problem. He can fight from a distance as long he has such long tails. While I can only fight in close proximity temporary. I should cut his tails off first. I raise my arms and brace myself. I will gather my Kuret in my right arm and cut the tails. It will take time for them to grow. I would then use that time to sprint across to Charles and fight hand to hand.

The tails were now speeding up and wrapped with Kuret to boast their durability. When I saw the brown Kuret swirling on those tails I realize something. He is constantly pouring Kuret into the tails. That means he is wasting Kuret. He might have huge amount of Kuret, but its not unlimited. There has to be limit. He already used so much to make his tails longer. Now he is constantly coating them with his Kuret. This is the perfect chance to let him exhaust his Kuret supply as much as possible.

This is the solution to all my problems. I have been a little hesitant to fight him so early after just learning and using my new technique. I have to get some practice before I use it on him. And the more I chip away his tails, the more Kuret he use to heal up. I went into a defensive form for now. The tails come at from above. I waited at the last second to gather my Kuret at my right side of my waist. Kuret gathered there at a lightening speed. I made it push me to my left just as the tails fly by my side. All right, I have more mobility now.

The tails bend and curve back to me a second later. I make my Kuret to gather at my abdomen now. A black cover forms in front of me and I push myself back. I am testing how far and how fast I can make my Kuret move me. Since I had used very little Kuret, I didn't have much speed. However, it was enough to be ahead of the tails. I was counting the seconds in my head when the Kuret broke into pieces and my escape came to a sudden halt. I have a rough estimate how much fast I can move.

The tails were gaining on me. I have tested horizontal movement. How about vertical displacements? I have been wondering for a while ever since I stopped my fall. In theory I should be able use my Kuret as a boost and jump high. I gather Kuret on my back. When the tails were close enough, I bend my knees and swing my arms to jump in the air. My timing was little off with my Kuret and I was thrusted into the air much earlier than I actually wanted to jumped. However, I wasn't to much bothered because I had jumped about 6 feet from the ground and passed over the tails from above. I began my fall down now. This time I focused on my timing. I moved my arms and legs in appropriate position before pulling my Kuret behind me. The result was similar to have created a cushion under my feet as the force slowed me enough to land safely on ground. I stumble a little forward when my legs hit the ground. I need to practice my jumping and landing timings more.

The tails curved again towards my back now. I tried pulling out more Kuret from my body. No dice. Come on. I don't have the yips anymore. Nor am I bothered with the mistakes I made early in the fight. So its definitely not a mental block. So there really was a physical issue also with my Kuret access. Maybe I have blown a short fuse. I kept thinking for reasons, but the four spears heading to me jarred me out of it. The tails now changed positions. Two came from top and other two from below. And now Charles had spread them far apart. He plans to block me if I move or jump out of the way.

Well, since I can't dodge them, I have no choice but to fight them. I pull Kuret into my right hand. This is my first time gathering Kuret into any of my limb. The Kuret throws sparks around my arm, travelling from different paths from my body. I wore my Kuret like a boxing glove now. It was small and only covered till my wrist. But it was strong. Stronger from any previous ones I have shaped my Kuret into. I could feel the vibrations coming off it. I knew it was there, but never felt it with my fingers before. It sort of have a tingly feeling. I was a little curious as to how it feels when I touch it. I don't have time for that.

The tails came close to me. The best place to jump is in the middle. I removed the Kuret in my hand and gathered it on my back me to give a boast. I turned my hands to a fist and dove into the gap of the four tails. I tuck my elbows together and summersaulted forward. I land on my back and roll forward. In a swift posture I stand up and pushed me again to one of the tails moving ahead. I quickly catch up to the one on the right. I raised my right hand forward and gather the Kuret there. I slowed down a bit since I removed my Kuret from by back, but I had enough momentum to reach my fist to the tip of the tail.

The moment my Kuret filled fist struck the Kuritine, it crumbles into pieces. Surprisingly I didn't feel any resistance from the Kuritine. I think it broke even before I could apply any pressure. I stop moving in the next second and stood staring at the Kuret in my hand as it broke into threads and resumed its random circulation. The vibrations, I guessed. They are so minute and fast that the edge of the surface has become like a small version of a saw. That’s why Charles hands started cracking instead of just shrinking in size.

I look above to the Kuritine I destroyed. Charles had already begin healing it. He had that hovering it still for a while. Ahead, the other 3 tails came at me. This time however Charles made them come from different angles on the ground at the same level. He is now limiting my escape options. Well I could just jump away in the air. But Charles has seen me do it. If I jump and the forth tail comes at me when I am floating in air, that will be troublesome. I was anyway not interested in doing that. I wanted to try something after I realized about the vibrations.

I gather Kuret again on my right fist. I join my left palm to the side of the fist making a pose of Karate. I was little tensed thinking that the surface would cut my palm. But I didn't feel any pain. I was mentally relieved knowing I didn't hurt myself. Don't know why I thought my own Kuret would hurt me. Now that I have joined my two hands I focus on moving my Kuret from my right to left hand. If I am correct about this Kuret nature, then any part of my body can allow the Kuret threads to travel as long it is connected physically. So joining my hands should work the same.

I was rewarded when my theory worked. The Kuret from my right started breaking into threads and flowed into my left. There were black sparks as they crossed the small gap between them. Those sparks didn't join other threads and instead gets absorbed back into my skin. I guess even a millimeter of gap is enough for some Kuret to lose their perpetual continuation and fall back inside me. However, most moved successfully moved. Once I saw almost halved moved. I pull apart my hands.

I should have done this when I don't have three spears coming at me. The Kuret in both my hand became unstable. I tried focusing to keep it going. My Kuret refused. The Kuret on both my hands began fluctuating. They broke into pieces and then join back. The sparks from them also began to increase. I am loosing Kuret. But I have to learn to use Kuret from more than just one place. I would be at a serious disadvantage if I only have one area of Kuret gathered when I fight Charles. The tails are closing in on me.

Come on. The Kuret on my hands were in no mood to listen to me. Some of the Kuret at the edge broke away from the rest and ran back into my arms and continued its motion. My eyes widen. I understand now. I am not used to have two different areas covered in Kuret yet. How about I start small then? I release the mental pressure I had kept from breaking apart. The Kuret on the edges of my arm slowly began chipping off and they ran back up my arm. I kept looking for the optimum amount which I could manage. Finally I felt this would be enough.

What remained were just my fingers. All my ten fingers were wrapped in Kuret which were stable. Is this a joke? What the hell can I do just with my fingers. I had no time to think. The tails reached me. Huh, fine. Lets try this. I grouped all my fingers together extending them straight. I raise my arms in opposite directions. Just when the tails came close I twisted my hips as fast as I could. Imagine my hand like a knife. I targeted the closest tail first. My right palm slashed the Kuritine into tiny pieces. I didn't had to apply much force since I already knew my Kuret is stronger. I crouch down as the rest of the tail pass over my head.

The second closest one came from my right. I push my right hand into the ground to support me as I half cartwheeled and swung my left hand from the top. I aimed by palm to smash it from top to bottom. Once I destroyed that, I fall on my right side on the ground. The tail harmlessly flew above my bent knees. The third one changed position as it saw my lying on the ground. It initially went up and gained some height. Then it came down at high speed aimed to my face.

I could dodge it if I gather my Kuret on my back and pull me away. But then I would loose the Kuret in my hands. I need to make my body and mind used to this feeling so later I can fight with more than just one limb. So I extend my arm above my head, prepared to catch it as soon as it comes near. Unnecessary risk, a rational part of me thought. True. But I was confident. I didn't want to waste this resolve. I took in a little breath when the tail came at me.

I caught the tail just in time. My Kuret broke the Kuritine even before I gripped it tight with my hands. After a second the portion of the tail I had caught disintegrated. Charles pulled out his tail back before I could do further damage. I take no time in getting up and looking at the tails positions now. With all the tails Kuretines destroyed, more Kuret was being poured into the ends. The one which I destroyed first was already healed. But Charles didn't use it to attack. He kept it hovering in air while he worked on healing the others.

I have been thinking for a while, why is he choosing to use such a long tail. He used it to drag me out from the pit, but what's the point having such long tails chase me now ? Why doesn't he shorten it back to its original size. Won't that save him so much Kuret and energy. Is there a reason he can't? I realize that must be it. All the time he made parts of his body big, he didn't change back immediately. Or rather he couldn't. I have been blasting Kurets at him that time. So my Kuret had chipped off the excessive Kuret. He then heals them back to their normal size.

But why doesn't he cut those tails himself? He can regrow them to their normal size. The answer came to me when he said earlier that their bodies can't absorb Kuret during battle. If he cuts those tails, he will loose a lot of Kuret that will just turn into ambient Kuret in air. Its much better to use them instead of removing it. He must have thought I would keep trimming it away during the battle. That also explains why he is attacking me with his tails and not directly confronting me. He wants me to cut it off piece by piece. That way his extra Kuret isn't wasted, it would be traded off for wasting my energy.

That means if I keep destroying only his Kuretines he would keep healing it repeatedly. This would definitely be a problem if I was running scared and no idea what to do. But now I feel like my body was rejuvenated with new power, so I didn’t feel as tiered as earlier. As for my stamina, as long as I don't exhaust my body with too much energy, I should be okay. Then all I have to do is keep breaking those Kuretines until I am able to gather more Kuret than just my fingers. I can practice more. I am sure James is laughing from his grave that I took his silly quote to heart.

The Kuret in my fingers were gathered for too long. I didn't even notice when they broke and turned to threads spinning back into my arms. I try to squeeze out some more Kuret from my body. But nothing came. I grew a little worried. What's the deal. Its been almost 3 more minutes since I pulled my Kuret out. I should have recovered and been able to pull some Kuret out. I wonder what's going on with my body. My thoughts were interrupted with loud noise.

Charles let out a big howl now. I saw the glimmers around him. There was no blue anymore. There were shades of violet and red in the mix. He is slowly becoming mad. I turn to see the tails. All of them healed and Charles got ready to attack me again. My mind went into alert when Charles does something different. He wrapped the end of the tails together. The tails wrap each other, turn for a while and then stops. Charles had now clubbed his Kuritines spears together. He intends to give his attacks more effective by combining them.

The tails more forward in unison. They were in complete sync and were identical to the same speed as one tails. Charles was aiming at me from above. What should I do now? Dodge or fight. How about a third option to defend myself. I have already felt Charles punches. Twice. I barely was able to defend then. I need to be able to defend against him later. I conjure my Kuret in front of my chest. The Kuret threads run to my front and joined to form a shield. This shield is smaller in size than others. I did loose some Kuret when I tried to use it on my hands. I just hope this is enough to block the tails.

I tightened my fist and raise them slightly forward ready to take in the blunt of the attack. I stiff my legs in the ground. I take in a deep breath and clench my teeth just before the tails struck me. The Kuretines cracked and shattered almost immediately. But the sheer force was enough to push me back. The tails didn't stop and continued to drag me on the field. I felt the pressure on my chest, like it is poking a big heavy metal rod to me. Yet the Kuret didn't broke. It was blocking the four Kuritines from puncturing wound on my skin. The strength of the collision vibrated to my lungs and I gasp out loud.

I was being dragged much further away now. Charles isn't stopping. He is keeping up the pressure. The end of the tails that was pushing me were cracking on the surface and disappearing. Damn, Charles planned this to shorten his tails. Charles had kept his tails curled up at some places. So I can't tell how much of the tail has been shortened. I to buy some more time. I willed my Kuret on my chest to push me away towards right. I felt the tug from my chest that pulled me out of the tails attack path. I stumble and use my legs to get my bearing as I stop. The tails kept going ahead with its momentum.

The Kuret on my chest lost its stability and it broke into pieces. I sigh, that was close. Any second longer and I would have had to take the blunt of that attack without the Kurets protection. This was good experiment. I now know that once my Kuret is gathered, its insanely strong. As long as it is stable, I can withstand virtually any attack thrown at me. Both physical and Kuret attacks. Although, I still have to feel the force behind those attacks. I think I have a way to take on those crazy attacks without getting pushed back. But I need to be able to use multiple Kurets shaped at the same time. I don't have either the experience or the Kuret to do that right now.

The tails turn back to me. Even though I have shortened the tails a little bit, it was still long. The Kuritines starts to regrow. I raise my left arm and gather the Kuret in my hand. I have to understand this new ability of mine. I have been seriously lucky to have survived this long against a Heraknus alpha. My luck will soon or later run out. I join my right hand to my left fist. Its maybe a good thing I can't pull out more Kuret. I have a tough time maintaining Kuret in both hands with just some Kuret. I probably can't maintain shape will all my Kuret. Perhaps that’s why I can't release more Kuret. I need to first learn and control this much Kuret before going full power.

I still have to figure out Charles weakness. I may have no real plan, but a way to get one has opened up. I am not feeling hopeless now. My Kuret on left hand travel to right hand. I pull it apart once it was halved at each hand. I am able to wrap just my fingers. I need to now focus on keeping it stable for longer time. Once I get my full Kuret back, I should be able to cover more of my arms. With time I should be able to cover my whole body with Kuret.

I turn to Charles. The glimmers around him are now having multiple shades. He is a little impatient too. He must want to fight me directly. I feel the same way. Just wait for a little while Charles. By the time your tails are shortened, I will have enough control to make this an even match.

Vanessa (Chapter 11)

Thursday, 10 February 2022 1:15 PM

I didn't expect David to do something like this. He must been real desperate to try this. I saw him clinging to the boulder and jump in the air just as Charles come up to him. He had couple of stones on his hand and with some incredible luck, he blinded Charles for some time. I was relived he didn't give up. But I was still not sure what his plan was. Did he even have one ? I kept asking this question for a while now. Charles was writhing in pain. David took that opportunity and ran way. I gazed over to the other screen wondering where is running off to.

I saw the mini crater that Charles created when he pulled out that massive rock. David has to be running over there. I look at Charles who was still howling but also using his Kuret on his tails. In his pain he brought his claws to his face instinctively and scrapped his skin around the eyes. He howled once more in pain. Well, that was silly. His Kuret wrapped around the tails and they started to grow longer. What. Is there no limit to what he can do? The tails gradually became so long, it probably reached halfway to the barrier. Those tails then fall from sky and Charles makes them scatter on the ground in different directions.

The tails began sweeping the whole field. One was almost caught up to David. Just at the last second, he dived into the hole. The tail missed him in the nick of time. David curls up towards the edge of the bowl shaped crater and rests there for a while. Kafar says, damn. He got away again. I can't believe David's luck. He was this close to getting captured. He shows this thumb and index finger and gestures a little gap between them. Blake asks, you are pretty calm. Didn't your champion get hit on the eyes? There are no Kurets to protect them. On top of that he even injured a little bit himself. I bet he can't see now.

Kafar was still gleeful, this is not the first time someone tried to attack him on his eyes you know. When he transforms, his eyes is coated with a thin layer of Kuret to protect him. They are the size of the contact lenses, although a little brittle. He should have been able to protect himself. He sighs, but no one has ever caught him off guard like this. David managed to attack from very close. So yes, I believe for the time being he can't see. David has bought several seconds. Maybe even a minute.

Derek says, Charles is used to people attacking him on his eyes. He has ways to deal with that. He points to the enlarges tails, that is one way. David made a smart move to hide out in that hole. Charles is too much of a straightforward guy. I bet he will scour the field without realizing to check the hole he himself created for some time. Nathan says, yeah, okay. So David has bought some time. Big deal. Once he gets his Kuret back, it will be same old thing.

I said, unless he is working out a different way. He has to be planning something. I look at the different screen which showed David from a different angle. He was bleeding a little from the bruises. He looked more exhausted than beat up. He hasn't landed any significant blow to Charles the entire match. Charles has kept him defensive all the time. On top of that, Heraknus is supposed to have huge amount of Kuret. A long fight is not good for David. Blake asks, I hope you are right. Right now David is in a tight corner.

Catherine asks, how long can Charles make those tails. Doesn't he need to use too much Kuret to make it big and then use a lot of energy to control it? I know from my own experience that it puts too much of strain on the body. Why will he go this far then? Derek took several seconds to answer, like I have been saying. Charles isn't someone to use strategies or tricks. He fighting style is rudimentary. He can't fight smartly, so he has trained to fight by pushing his limits of Kuret consumption. I agree its too much Kuret to use and control at the same time. That’s just the way he fights.

I ask, then how can anyone beat him? He is alpha, so does that mean only his bloodline members can overpower him? I wondered if anyone of us would have had a chance if it was one of us down there. Kafar says, yes. Only other Heraknus can fight him. Even then one is not enough. I have seen couple of times their training sessions. I have seen Charles fighting 10 Heraknus alone. Only then does the battle be even. Matt shouts, did you just say 10 people? Derek told every member is as powerful as regular alphas. So does that make Charles a super alpha?

Cassandra beside her pokes hard on his shoulder, don't say stuff like this. I am already worried about David fighting a beast. Now I have to imagine him fighting 10 of them. Matt says, then maybe Blake would have been a better challenger for Charles right? He faces Blake, I mean a true alpha and a Heraknus alpha would be a good match up. Blake didn't respond immediately. I know what he might be thinking. I am feeling the same resentment of loosing.

I think all of us had been thinking that Blake would have better chance of winning than David. David did beat Blake, but just barely. Both of their Kuret are literally polar opposites. David only won because he caught Blake off guard in the last second. Blake turns to Derek, well? You know a lot about David, Charles and me. What do you think. Would I have a better chance. Kafar was also curious to know as he looked lot interested in this question. Derek looks to him. He looks to all of us and then faces him again.

He sighs, honestly. I don't mean any disrespect to David. But yes, I think Blake would have much better chances. You have speed and power. An abnormal amount of Kuret that affects both the Kuret and physical properties of others. You are an alpha, so you have high regeneration and stamina. In terms of abilities, you have much better compatibility than David. He then looks to David, David's Kuret is unstable and metaphysical. He has stamina equivalent of human. He has no self healing abilities. I say he has half the necessary things to defeat a power house like Charles.

No one said for couple of seconds. I wondered if David just had a bad luck of fighting Charles. David was lying on the dirt with a pained expression. He looks so frustrated. I would be too if I was hiding in the middle of a match. Maybe he is trying to find any weakness Charles has. I ask Derek, do you know any weakness Charles has? Something in his Kuret or his body. Now Derek looks a little frustrated, no. He doesn't have a weakness. I was shocked to hear this. I reply, that’s not possible. Everyone has one. Derek says, believe me. I have thought about it a lot. The only weak point Heraknus have is outside a battle, when they don't have Kuret and are in recovery. Within a battlefield, they are perfect warriors.

I swallowed a little terrified that Charles may not have any weakness. How incredible Heraknus are. No wonder Kafar has kept them a secret for so long. Marina asks, what about thing David did first time they clashed. And that Kuret ball. David still has some plays left. Don't just think he is out of the game. David never does anything he doesn't believe will go his way. If he thought there was not even a 1% chance of winning, he would have given up in the beginning. I still believe in David.

Marina words were more convincing than her voice. Its clear to she was hesitant to give hope. Ned faces Kafar, tell me something. How many Heraknus are alive? Are all of them in Citradel. Ned asks completely ignoring what we were talking about. I was mad at him. He might have completely given up on David. Kafar says, including Charles there are 678 Heraknus still alive. And yes, all of them are in Citradel. They never separated even once after coming to earth. Ned asks, how many of them are fighters? I don't think all of them are keen on fighting.

Kafar nods, yes. Each one of them are powerful, but not all have the mind of a soldier. Last I heard they were about 26 who are in training. Derek says, its 76 now. One left recently. You know, his daughter. I ask, Charles has a daughter? Ned then asks, and she doesn't want to fight anymore. Isn't she in the next line of alpha. Derek didn't say anything. He looked as if he was hiding something. Kafar says, not to worry. Charles has 5 children. His daughter is the second oldest. He has a son who he said will inherit this alpha bloodline.

I wanted to know more about Charles children. But before I could ask Matt says, whoa. Okay, cut the chatter people. I think Charles is about to find David. I turned to the screen. Charles was walking around the field now. He had is tails searching, but he also kept moving in random directions. He is close to the hole. One more step and he will fall below. David was on the other side of the edge of the bottom. There was silence in the room. Everyone were watching in suspense. David had not recovered. I was sure of it. David confirmed me when he threw a stone away from him and Charles. Just at the moment Charles would have stepped inside, the voice of the stone hitting the ground caught his attention. Charles immediately turn his head to that direction and ran. As he ran, he aimed the tails ahead to catch him. Everyone but him knew that all he would catch is air.

Matt says, That was close. I think this is the first match where David had to rely on luck so much. When do you suppose he will get his Kuret back. It's already been over 3 minutes. Nobody had any answer. David had told that it depends on the use, the longer it was used, the more time he would need to recover. He roughly spent about a minute using that Kuret dome. So 3 minutes should have been enough. Yet he is hiding in the hole. Has something gone wrong?

I really wanted some support from Ned on this. He had completely given up on David. I had keeping my anger inside and tried to ignore Ned for a while. But now that match is stuck for a while, I couldn't keep it in anymore. I whisper to him, can you at least try showing a little supportive of David in front of everyone? Ned nonchalantly looked at me and whispered back, how is that fair? Do you want me not have an opinion on something as serious this? I reply, I don't care that you voted against David. I am mad that you are behaving like David has already lost this match. You don't even think he can win this. Others, except for Kafar, are at least having doubts. You could show some consideration.

He looked at me in shock and tilted his head a little, you have to be kidding me. Do you not see what I am seeing. David hasn't even landed one attack on Charles in this entire match. All he has been doing is running around and defending himself. And now, he is hiding in a hole. I don't know if David has a plan or not. But anyone can see that he is loosing. He is basically relying on his luck. Its really hard to believe that he might just turn this around now. He was getting a angry and his voice became loud enough for others to hear. He continues, you have no idea how much I need for us to win this. Its so difficult for me to see David loosing. I feel like I am loosing. I don't know what else you want me to say.

I am so mad at him. I know couples fight, and we have several, but I couldn't let this one slide. My voice also got louder. So say you, I bet other people also believe in David. Every Medrone on Earth knows David. They know David's strength. Just because he is now fighting some god, doesn't mean he is weak. Ned wasn't moderating his voice now. Oh, you really know what others think, do you? Let me tell you something, you need to know that not all people know David like we do. No matter how powerful he is or what he is done, they don't have the same history as us. So don't just single me out from all them and tell me to be open minded. I was about to rebuke him, but others were now looking at us. I don't think Ned was even a little mortified by our fight.

Nathan whispers, trouble in paradise. He makes a smirk as he said. I rolled my eyes at him. Ned then pulls out his phone from his pocket, if you don't believe me. Lets check the poll shall we? He turns to his mobile and starts to type on the screen. I was confused, what poll?. He says, you don't think its just us who made a bet right? Everyone in the stadium has a voting device with them for this match alone. Kafar shouted, Ned. You just ruined the surprise. We agreed not to let others know until the match near the end.

Ned didn't reply to him. He kept typing on the screen. Blake says, wait. So everyone in this stadium making a bet? Why didn't you tell us. Kafar was a little annoyed at Ned. But he turned away, ah fine. It doesn't matter now. I got you all also put a chip in the bet. He turns to Blake, its not just the people here. All the communities we know about were given a encrypted tablet to watch this match live stream. They also are voting regularly. I was really shocked to hear this. This is not a sports match that should be live streamed at home.

Derek asks, you didn't tell me this when you asked my team to deliver those devices to all the Medrones we contacted. You told that was a secure device to contact us in case of emergencies. Kafar nodded, yes. That is absolutely true. They can contact us using that in case they think they were found by Echo or Hive. But John and his people came up with this idea to share this battle with them too. He suggested just showing the match highlights in a video recording will not be much enticing as a live match. People will invest their time when watching the whole match live. Giving their time would mean they would have expectations. When we give choices, those expectations becomes reality. And that can lead to chance for them to realize the potential in reforming our Medrone society. Now obviously, not all will be interested, but most will find enough reasons to join us. That will cause others to join. And slowly we will pull all Medrones on Earth to gather in one place finally after more than 16 years. John's team gave a pretty solid argument why its so much beneficial to broadcast this to all the Medrones scattered over the world.

Tessa shifts uneasily on her seat says, why would you risk this. If Hive or Echo were to find the live stream, doesn't matter how much encrypted it is, they will figure out this location. Right now we have the most Medrones gathered at one place ever on Earth. Kafar raises his palm in air, oh believe me. We have went to great lengths to make sure this is safe. And that’s why I pulled in Ned. I needed his expertise to help us make sure that no one except for a Medrone can see this.

I face to Ned, so you agreed. Let me guess, in return you promised not to tell us? Ned was still working on his mobile. He didn't remove his eyes from his mobile as he says angrily, yes. I was a little against it. But then I realized you all would just freak out if had told you. So I agreed to only tell you all once the match was over. He pauses, but now you accuse me of being inconsiderate. You actually want everyone to what you want to believe. You think everyone one will be with David because he is strong. Right. He finally stops typing and looks up to me and says, so lets see how many people you should be actually be mad at and not just me. Ned was furious now. He turned to screen at the bottom left. He raises his finger at that screen, I asked one my tech guys to project the polls we have been circulating.

The screen that was showing an angle of David resting in the pit went blank. A moment later, a different screen popped up. There was something written on it, but I couldn't read it from my dyslexia. Ned knowing this starts to explain what's shown there. He says, there's a single question writing on it. Who do you think will most likely win? I could make out that below that question, there is a brown, black and white horizontal line grouped together like a train. The length of black was so less that it would be negligible. Ned says, 83 % for Charles. 8% for David. And the rest who didn't vote.

Ned continues, I think its pretty self explanatory. But let me spell it out for you. He eyes me for a short second and reads from the screen. The brown line is Charles. Black is David. And white is people who didn't vote or undecided. So, he turns to face me, what do you know? It looks like I shouldn't be the only one you should be asking to be more considerate of David. You have, he waves his hands to the crowd outside the window, 83% of the people to convince that David can still win. He then leans back to the seat and says, don't get angry at me because David is loosing. If you want to be mad, be mad for all the people here. He faces away from me and looks back to the monitor.

I am shocked seeing at the numbers. Practically none of the people think David can win. Its possible the 8% are the people who knows David personally. Maybe people who met him. But others believe Charles will win. I didn't want to be, but I was now mad at all those people. I know its not fair, they choose the one they think will win. I shouldn't be mad at them. For some reason, I couldn't stop being angry though. It felt like a betrayal somehow. After everything David's gone through, he doesn't have the majority support.

I was furious at Ned. I was also painfully aware that everyone was watching us fight. Ned really is angry with me. He has never shown so much anger before. I wanted to chew more at him but I stopped myself before I make a more drama for others. I look back at the monitor where the percentage kept changing. Does that mean people could change their vote at any time? I guess Kafar wanted only us to be unchangeable on our vote. Matt interrupts my thoughts, okay so if you guys are done with your love quarrel. I have a question, why only this match are you guys doing all this huh? Why not for all our matches. Wouldn't showing all our matches show that David and Charles aren't the only ones strong? He was annoyed. I think everyone was after hearing this.

Kafar for the first time didn't reply immediately. He was silent, trying to come up with some answer. Derek says, its obvious isn't it. Nathan nods, huh. I see. So you only wanted everyone to know about Charles. Its not just enough to let the people here know about him. This match is like some big reveal of Heraknus Medrones to others. You basically advertised to all Medrones that you have a godly weapon. A weapon only present at Citradel. So people would naturally want to move there. He smirks, wow. This was a diabolical but simple plan. I should have thought of this when I was running the valley. Would have saved me a lot of pain. He gripped his knees probably reminiscing the time he was paralyzed for a while.

Blake says, really. Is that true? He waited for Kafar. He finally sighed and replied, I know what you all are thinking. I have never hidden my opinion that no matter who among you all wins, my champion would be victorious. So I did a little monopoly on that. He shrug his shoulder, could we have shown your battles too. Yes. We could have. We couldn't take the risk of showing all the matches. Too much broadcasting and our safety would be jeopardized. The more matches to be shown, the more data to be dispersed around the globe. And we also found that people generally only want to see the last match. So we took all those reasons when making decision to only this match.

I say, bullshit. You can throw all the rehearsed reasoning at us. I am not buying for a second that you did it because of what, logistics issues? You only care about people joining to Citradel. I didn't even care checking Kafars expression. I look at Ned who was kind of sulking, you knew all this and you still agreed? He says, now its not the time to show your hurt ego. That goes for all of you. He turns to face others, all of us have been in the fight for more than 15 years. You guys were already well known and have reputations. I didn't thought that we would need to garner more.

Marina says, not David. He just popped in everyone radars only 3 year back. Ned nods, Yes. This way people will know more about him. But I never expected him to fight a Heraknus alpha. If I had known then maybe. He didn't finish off the sentence. Blake says, wait. Let me understand this correctly. You couldn't do all this in a week after my match. What you are talking would takes weeks, maybe months to prepare. That means you couldn't have possibly known David would be fighting in the final. Yet you went this plan. So it can't be that you did for David's sake too.

Ned stares at Blake. A moment later sighs, fine. I wasn't thinking of David. I had. His sentence softened at the end, I had a different reason. We waited for him to elaborate. He didn't. Cassandra ask, that it. That's all you have to say? Ned says, it’s a good reason. Cassandra says, oh. It’s a good reason. Well that’s clears every thing. She faces me, do you know why? I gave some thought. I couldn't think of any reason why Ned went along with this. All I know is that he worked very hard for this. So why would he not support David. I shook my head.

I could feel the tension high in the air around us. Derek broke that and says, All of you need to calm down. What's done is done. We will have enough time to throw blame and feel guilty later. You all do know that there is a match going on right? So if its not too much trouble, shut it down. Wow, I thought. Derek voice had a sense of authority that was very hard to ignore. He faces me and continues, numbers aren't absolute. You need to focus on the two people fighting down there, not others. So stop getting so angry at anyone who doesn't believe your ideals. He then faces to Kafar, and you. I know that you did this just for showing off Charles to all. But your plan could backfire if Charles looses. Kafar had something to say but Derek raises his palms at him, don't. You have already expressed your views several times about David having no chance winning. I don't want to hear it again. I am just letting you know, even if only 0.3 % people think David will win, its not zero. So you better prepare for that eventuality regardless of what you think.

Derek was pulling out no tolerance bullshit now. He sometimes remind me of David. Derek then turns and faces others, and you all don't need to be worried or angry that people didn't get to see your match. Be glad they didn't, they would see you winning matches, but also the ones you lost. So stop showing your pride is hurt or whatever. We all don't need to show others we are strong. They already know. Stop your whining. Derek then turns back the screen that showed Charles now standing still. He says, I don't know if its fate or luck or something. The two people that needs the most attention are there right now on the field. Using their match to pull in people can go in either ones favor. Right now all we can do is better give these two the respect and watch till the end.

Derek voice had little haughtiness, still, he is right. I have been shamelessly fighting with Ned when its not the appropriate place or time. Ned said he had good reasons, I just hope that's actually a right one. I bet others were surprised to hear Derek be the voice of reason. Matt and Cassandra were whispering to each other. So were Nathan and Tessa. Blake was thinking about something looking at the poll screen. Catherine and Marina had glued their eyes to David. Kafar showed some uneasiness now, like a student scolding his teacher he kept rolling his fingers in palm. Maybe what Derek told rattled him a little.

Derek breaks the silence once more, David's time is up. I think Charles is beginning see now. I turned to the monitor. The camera had zoomed in to Charles face. His eye lids were flickering. A few seconds later, he was able to open his eyes a little. It was enough for him to roll his eyes around the field. After a full 360 view, he howled at the sky frustrated not finding David. He then slowly looks at the direction where he made the hole in ground, possibly realizing where David had been hiding all this time.

Vanessa (Chapter 12)

Tuesday, 15 February 2022 2:39 PM

Charles commands one of the nearest tails to hover out in the sky above. Then he makes it fall with the pointed edge first into the ground. The tail buried deep into the ground. The tail keeps digging in the ground. I realize what Charles was planning. I looked over to David hoping he would sense the tails approaching to him underground. David didn't move. He was gazing at the other side of the pit. From his face he looked he was lost in thoughts. He wasn't even blinking. Is he okay ?, I thought. I have seen him in immersed in thoughts before. Never he would space out in middle of a fight.

I held my breath when Charles tail came out from the edge of the pit. David finally woke up from his day dream, but it was too late. Charles had him already wrapped him by his legs and pulled him out from the pit feet first. Shit. What were you thinking David? David was held upside down in the air. Charles brought his other tails towards him. David was trying to break free before the other tails attack him. David's naturally cancels all Kuret on contact. Charles has been continuously showering his tail with Kuret to keep his tail from breaking. The other tails were also glowing with brown Kuret. When they got closer to David, he pulled his elbow up to his torso and defend himself.

Charles had a different plan. His tails didn't attack, instead of attacking Charles was wrapping his tails all around his body. He made one tails pull his arms behind and wrapped it with another tail to his waist. David was completely at Charles mercy. Charles made sure David couldn't escape anymore. The tails then move David in the same upside down position to Charles direction. David kept struggling, trying to wriggle out his confinement. He didn't have any luck.

Cassandra spoke softly, come on David. She was nervously shaking her legs. Matt puts his hand on her knees trying to calm her. Then he takes her hand in his. I was turmoiled inside. There was some jealously in me that Ned didn't do the same thing for me. I buried it deep inside my thoughts as David become closer to Charles. Charles had raised his left arm in arm and his claws ready to attack. But the way he aimed, he must he planning to attack his face.

I had big tug in my gut. I shouted, is Charles planning to kill David ? That is a dangerous position he intends to attack David. I looked at Kafar, stop this match now. Charles is going to kill David. I stood up from my chair and faced the screen horrified. Others followed suite when they realize Charles is taking this too far. Then I face Kafar, call off Charles now. This is supposed to be a match without any kill shots. Kafar was visibly worried now, I. He was stammering, I can't. No one can stop Charles when he is in this form. I immediately say, useless. Then tell the other Heraknus to stop him. I don't care if this is against the rule, Charles is breaking one now. We need someone to stop him. I was now shouting orders.

Kafar says, there's no time. We will never reach out to them and break through the barrier in time. I moved my eyes to David now. He is panicking now. Its clear he is also confused and scared. Seeing him I reached the limit of my patience. I immediately call my Kuret. My body is filled with Kuret around me. I summon a gust of wind in my right hand. It was slowly building up pressure. But it wasn't strong enough to blow away the left wall of the room. Dammit. I should have been outside.

I faced the windows and aimed my arms to them. Fine, I say, I will go there myself. Before I could shoot the wind gathered in my hand, Derek shouts over the wind spinning in the room. Stop. You might hurt the people sitting outside. I didn't care, I thought. David is in serious danger. I will not let him die here. Derek was also panicking. He says, I thought Charles would be holding back a little. I was wrong. He really is crazy enough to attack David when he can't defend himself. Vanessa , I will go. Derek summons his Kuret out now, I told Charles to not let his get carried away so much that it cloud his judgement. I don't even know if he even remembers that David can't heal. This is outrageous.

A moment later he phases into the front wall where the monitors were hung. I could see from the windows he was descending down. If he thinks I will just stand here and wait, he is dead wrong. I face Marina, bring down the barrier. Now. Before I asked, Marina was already waving her hand in the air and creating a Charm, shit. No. No. I, she takes a second, I can't bring it down. The barrier has too many layers to break it down in such a short time. I responded, Don't say that. Bring it down, Now.

Blake also had summoned his Kuret and the room was filled with blue Kuret, Vanessa. Lets go. We will break through the barrier. We don't have time to wait. Marina, come with us. Help us make weaken the barrier a little to give us a path. Hurry. Marina nods, you got it. She waved her left fingers and casted a charm. She starting floating in air and moved forward. I face to Cassandra, break the wall above us. The debris will fall only on us, not on the crowd. Cassandra was up on her feet. Her eyes filled with red Kuret, yeah. Got it.

Cassandra was about to jump with her Kuret filled fist. Nathan then shouts, You guys will not reach in time. Charles just made his tails move faster now. My Kuret was rattling in air. I felt sparks of electricity from my fist discharging in air. Nathan was right. David was now just a few steps away. No one can reach him now. Not even Derek. David let a cry as soon as Charles brought down his claws to his approaching face. I froze in my place. My anger quickly turned into horror when the claw was less than a second away from David's head.

I unconsciously closed my eyes and turned my face away. I can't watch this. No. No. David can't die. Don't you dare die. Not yet. I.I couldn't even form thoughts. I heard from the monitors a big thumping sound. No! I forced my eyes open. Please no. When I noticed David still wrapped in Charles tails, my hopes crushed. David was punched back and the tails were swinging him back. I couldn't understand what I was seeing. Charles raised his others arm and prepared to attack once more.

No. I screamed out. But my body was still frozen. I watched helplessly when Charles was about to hit David a second time. Charles had made David loose from this tails for some reason. Charles hit him right on his chest and there's another thumping sound. My heart was beating like crazy. I was seeing things but couldn't understand anything. David was sent flying into the air. His body was limp as he flew in air. His arms and legs just floundered in air. He was attacked twice. One on his face and once on his chest. He must have crushed bones and bleeding all over.

I couldn't do anything as David's body continues to fall down straight to the ground. If he wasn't dead, he will be if he falls from this height. Come on Derek, please save him. Derek never showed up. All I saw was David falling his back facing the ground. My eyes swell up with moist when he was just about to hit the ground. No, he can't die. Then David body did something unbelievable. David was floating in the sky now. I don't know what's going on, but David was hovering in the air for a while.

The next moment he starts falling again. He is now able to crouch down and managed to roll away on the ground. He gets dragged a little further away from his landing spot. When he finally stops, he is idly lying on the ground. Oh god, don't tell me he his dead. I shout to others, get help. David needs paramedics now. We need get him to the nearest human hospital. No one were listening to me. Everyone were watching the screen confused at something. I asked, what the hell are guys doing. I was irritated now. Fine, I said. I will carry him and fly him away. I ran to the window. Again, before I could blast the window away, I felt someone pull on my left arm.

Wait Vanessa. It was Ned. He shouted, look. Just look at David. I shoved his arm away in anger. I asked, what. He is bleeding all over. We don't have time. Matt says, ah. Vanessa, I don't think that’s blood over his body. I started back at the screen, what do you mean?. My mouth stopped moving when I saw black sparks running over his body. I thought that was his blood coming out. It was his Kuret. He was somehow making them run it like sparks, no more like small threads all over his body.

I focus on his face. He wasn't bleeding. There was no blood. He didn't look like any of his bones in his head were broken either. I moved to his stomach. He was breathing and I saw his chest rising up and down. Same like his face, he wasn't bleeding from the impact. What is going on. Blake who was hovering in the air like Marina, starts to level down to his feet. What the hell just happened. Catherine, who had one hand on her mouth and the other one on her stomach. She puts her arms away and asks, is David okay? What just happened.

Cassandra who had her alter ego taken over asks, is that David's Kuret on his body? When did he do that? I was too shocked to remember the details. Tessa says, just before Charles hit him. He got his Kuret back. He was releasing it from all his body, but he didn't blast it right away. The next second I saw the Kuret around him moved to his face and chest at the moment Charles attacked him. Nathan says, its similar to what he did the very first time he got away from Charles. But this, he gulps a little, was so much faster. I almost didn't see it happening. Just like this, he snaps his fingers, those Kuret sparks swarmed from all over his body to his face. And somehow it protected David.

Marina says, this is new. She then sighs, then he is okay. Dammit. David almost gave me a heart attack. She lets go of the charms in her finger and comes down on the floor. Matt says, he looks like he is on fire. I have never seen his Kuret become so thin and small. I let out sigh of relief. I pulled my arm down and released my Kuret. The gust of wind circulating in the room dissipated. I was overjoyed to know he wasn't dead. David actually pulled a new trick at the last second. David was lying on the ground when he starts to smirk. Is he for real? He nearly died and he finds that amusing. I felt a relief wash over my body looking at him smile. I calmed down the sudden adrenaline coursing in me.

Then my anger rose up. I face back to Kafar, stop this match now. Charles just tried to kill David. He failed for now. That will not stop him to try again. Kafar was a lot anxious in the whole ordeal, I told you. We can't. Charles will not listen to anyone now that he is fighting with David. He was too worked up about it months. If someone were to get in his way, he would just blast past them. He might even try to kill them. My anger was boiling, oh you don't need to worry Charles accidently killing you. I might just do it now. I walked towards with the intend of punching his teeth's out.

Blake comes in between us and grabs me by the arms to keep me apart from Kafar. Kafar took steps back scared a little with my hostility. Blake says, don't Vanessa. Control yourself. This is not the place to fight the leader of Citradel. Don't do something you will regret later. He is making his reasoning firm as he tightly gripped my arms to keep me back. I shove him away in anger and take few steps back, you think we just let this slide away? The rules were setup to make the matches realistic. We agreed there will be no murderous intentions or attacks. That is violation of that. He needs to be disqualified now.

Blake kept staring at me. I could see he was angry too. He then turns away to Kafar, well. You have nothing to say? She is right. He should be disqualified now. Charles may be from a legendary bloodline, but he is not above the rules we set here. And If Charles doesn't agree with it, tries to resist, I will personally go down there to put him down. Kafar was visibly shaken with this. I am sure he never thought that Charles would actual try to kill a defenseless David.

Kafar spoke with hesitation, I never thought Charles would go this far. You are right, according to the rules, this should be considered as a violent act and have him disqualified. But you need to understand, this is being live streamed to entire Medrones on Earth. If we have this match end on a technicality, then we wouldn't achieve the very thing we did this for. People may not join us. We need to give them a proper match that ends in a conclusion. I shout, are you serious. You want to continue this match for such a reason? This is not gambling. We are talking about David's life. I took one more step to towards him. Kafar could see my hostility coming out from me and my Kuret.

Nathan spoke, why don't we let David decide? He has to know that Charles broke the rules. It should be up to him to know the risk and still wants to continue the match. Bickering amongst ourselves is just waste of time. I was still angry to hear any rationalization thoughts on continuing this match. Kafar immediately pitches in, precisely. It should be David who wants to end the match right now if he wants. I rebuked him, and what if Charles doesn't like it when David calls for violation? Do you think your crazy over zealous champion would thrown in towel ? I don't think so. We need to get in there and end the match right away before Charles another attempt on David's life.

Ned behind me says, yeah. Vanessa, I agree with Nathan. It should be David's call to pull of plug on this match. I turn to him in anger, what. Are you not seeing what I am? Come on you guys. I turn to face others, are the rest of you all thinking the same then? Am I the only one who sees how crazy it is to let this supposedly friendly match turn into this? Everyone were hesitant to answer me immediately. A moment later Derek phased from the right wall into room. Fhew, he says, that was a close call. Amazing David pulled off something at the last minute. He lets go of his Kuret and then looks at the tense atmosphere. Let me guess, he continues, some of you want to end the match right?

I nod at him, it would be reckless to let Charles continue and keep endangering David. Derek nods slightly in agreement, I know. I feel the same way. Kafar interrupts him, Derek we can't let the match end this way. You know how hard we have worked to make this tournament happen. People will not join Citradel or the Island if we stop the match now. Derek says, we don't know that. Maybe reveling Charles would be enough for people to join us. Not to forget that all of us here also showcased our abilities. Maybe that’s enough for people to join.

But not everyone, Ned says. We need every Medrone on the entire planet to believe in our abilities to keep them safe. He takes a short breath and then looks at me, bottom line, it means David and Charles need to finish this with a proper conclusion. He said that with a straight face. It was troubling to see him not being bothered too much about David nearly dying. Does Ned thought David would make it out safety ? I was getting angrier now. I didn't understand why Ned is prioritizing this above David life.

I faced others hoping to get enough votes to end this match before it gets worse. Everyone were anxious and little confused, but no one came up with any answer. Blake asks, so I guess this silence means we are hoping David to decide, huh ? I mean, its clear to us that Charles took it far, if David wants to he can end the match either forfeiting or calling out Charles. Blake shrugs his shoulders telling us. Kafar was about to say something but instead he just turns to the screen.

We all faced to the screen. Charles was healing his arms. After lying down for few seconds, David was got up. His Kuret was running all over this body like small black sparks. Whatever he did must be a surprising to him because he was starting his arms, legs and chest. I was amazed to see David pulling off a miracle in the middle of the match. He found a way to use his Kuret for offense without the dome. However, the surprising thing was he wasn't ending the match. He was already preparing for the next round.

I was a little taken aback by his behavior. This isn't the first time David risked his life, but this is the first time it was with a friendly. Why isn't he backing down ?, Jess asks, does he plan to continue then. Kafar lets out a small sigh, subtle but enough to notice his burden relieved, then I guess the battle continues. He then looks at everyone, David made his choice, so then there is no objection here. I was almost blurted out Kafar to screw off, Derek cuts in, lets continue with the match for now. David made his decision. Derek then faces me, but if Charles does something like that again, we are calling this whole thing off, agreed. He glares at Kafar and then to Ned.

They both took a moment. A slight nod came from both of them. Everyone got back into their seats. I was the only one remaining standing. After few seconds, I too gave up and sat down. Ned beside me leans forward, but I pull my palm in front of him signaling him to not say whatever he was thinking of saying to me. Ned looks at directly at my eyes and then pulls back. With the anxious atmosphere dissipated, we turn our gazes back to the screen.

Matt says, looks like David's pulling out some crazy trick up his sleeve. David is now running and jumping around the tails instead of running away.

David (Chapter 13)

Wednesday, January 17, 2024 00:02

I can't catch a break for even a second. Its bad enough that I have four tails to keep track of with their glimmers, I have to even make sure not to cut the tails and mistakenly end this unexpected opportunity. Still, for the first time since our fight started, I am beginning to feel like myself again. I am not fully in control of the situation, but I am not panicking recklessly anymore. I have been dodging and breaking the Kuretines repeatedly dozens of times now. I have almost grasped the patterns of the attacks. I caught early on that Charles wasn't making any complex movements. There were so many chances where he could have strike me and catch my limbs though I would instantly free myself before the tail could catch me- yet the tails just kept coming at me with straightforward attacks. After a few rounds of those attacks, I figured out the simple pattern where he is attacking with the nearest tail near me. Even if the Kuretines were not healed, he would use them to attack me.

A tail was coming dead straight to my face from ahead, the Kuritine at the edge was already cracked and had become brittle, but the speed itself is enough to pierce my face. Is Charles not even bothering to not hide his intent to kill me. Or does he think this is not enough to put me down. Either way, I can't let him keep dominating this fight. I have been slowly improving my Kuret control. I gotten better at this new form of Kuret wrapped around my fingers. I raise my right hand and my fingers to block the tail in front of my eyes. The Kuretine he attacked with wasn't healed fully, so it didn't have the usual sharpness. I braced for the impact as the force with which it came pushed me back a little. I managed to hold my ground.

I saw a glimmer approaching from behind me. I didn't have time to block it using my arms, so instead I moved my Kuret wrapped in my left hand to my back. After so many times, I have now gotten a instinctive feel for moving my Kuret on my body. The Kuret formed moments before the tail attacked me on by lower back. I saw glimmers of the Kuretines breaking apart and I was lunged ahead by the force as I staggered to keep my balance. The attacks kept coming since then.

After another minute, I started to think what Charles plan is. I understand that he doesn't want to loose the tails, but why isn't he attacking me directly and instead only using his tails. By now he must have realized that if he keeps this up, he will continue to loose huge amounts of Kuret. He can attack me directly while keeping his tails intact like he was doing a while back. What's changed. In the middle of my thoughts two tails were coming from the opposite sides of me. Since I have been focusing on slashing and dodging all this time, I have used more stamina than I should. I could have dodged them, but I thought of an idea to figure what's Charles plan is here. I need to force him to get a reaction to understand his strange behavior.

I pulled up both my hands up and waited as the tails as they pummeled into my palms. The Kuretines on the tails were dried up to a point they there brittle as a pencil now. Instead of letting go, I grabbed the tail end with my hands. I could see the brown Kuret flowing into the Kuritine, trying to heal the damages I caused. By my natural Kuret in my palm doesn't allow to fix those cracks in the Kuritine. I heard Charles letting out a small growl feeling his tails getting caught. I softly spoke, oh how the tables have turned.

The other two tails just were swaying above in the air now. I turn to face Charles, he was just standing on his legs with his arms hanging on his side. I couldn't make out the expression under all those Kuretines on his face. The glimmers coming out from his body was covering whatever was coming from his own body. I hoped I could get hints about his plan from a cold read. I am still clueless about his plan. A few seconds passed by and still no movement. We both just stood here, me holding his two tails, and he just staring at me.

Is he making a plan of attack. Might be. After seeing my Kurets new form, he must be wary. But why isn't he attacking with the two free tails then. Charles seems to be a person who relies on instinct. I have seen only simple attacks without any deceptions or clever tricks. Something weird is going on here. Is he suddenly tired ? No, that can't be. With his ridiculous amount of Kuret, he could go on for hours. My eyes widen up when I thought of a reason, Kafar said Heraknus have inconsistent access to Kuret during battle. I dart my eyes to the tails, the brown Kuret is still pouring in. However, now that I am holding the Kuritine end so close to me, I could see the brown glimmer getting dimmer. Not only that, the Kuret is flowing slowly into it.

I then face Charles. I gazed around his entire body. I peered deep into the air around him to check the glimmer and saw its shrinking, albeit small. Almost negligible, if it was anyone else, they wouldn't see the Kuret changing. But I could tell that the Kuret coming out of his actual body is slow. I made a small smirk. I was right. Charles has momentarily lost his constant access to Kuret. While I was stalling with training my Kuret attacks, he too has been stalling to buy time and regain this Kuret control.

Now is my chance. I can't let this chance go by. I let go of the two tails and sprinted towards Charles. As I ran, the tails behind me started to move again and followed me. He must be trying to grab me and hold me down. Not happening. As I run, I willed the Kuret on my fingers to move around my ancles. I had a thought a while back on how to go about this. It should be along the same principle as I get pulled away from by Kuret. But instead of a pulling, pushing is possible now given the solidity of my new Kuret form. A moment later, the Kuret wrap around my ancles like accessories.

The tails were almost top of me. Just before they could grab me, I focused on the Kuret on my right leg to push forward. It felt like my legs were tied to a speeding boat as got lunged forward uncontrollably. The force was enough to make be jump and hover over the ground for few seconds. As I swayed in air I was turning around in wrong direction. Immediately I let the Kuret on the other leg push me forward to correct my direction. It was like my legs had a mind of its own.

Shit. Shit. I can't do this properly in the middle of the battle. I land on my right leg almost loosing my balance. With a swift motion of leaning ahead, I pivot my body and lean forward a bit to keep running. I realize its too unrealistic of me to try any of this this now. So instead I plan to push myself only in when needed and with less force. The little stunt was enough to widen the gap from the tails behind me and at the same time close the gap between Charles and me. I thought Charles would just stay still, but he also began to run in my direction. This is my third time charging into him like this. I don't know if he was surprised to see me doing this or not. But this will not be a repeat like those other times.

I rough outline of a plan was framing in my head. I can't match up with his explosive power. To counter, I have speed. Unlike the times we fought with bare hands, I plan to only act reactive for now until I find a proper moment to strike. As much as I want to land my Kuret attacks right away, while his Kuret is unstable, I can't mess this up. No need to act impatiently.

We both were heading for a violent collision in a few moment. Charles was now leaning forward with his arms in front, ready to cleave my face off with those claws. I duck on the left and roll away as his claws slashes the air where I was just running. I slide across the grass to his right and jump back right up. Charles without turning to me swings his left leg around from his side and aim to kick on my torso. I didn't want to get blunt force of his attack so I pulled back and his foot with sharp Kuretines as nails missed me few inches.

Charles turned around to face me. He took off from the ground while pulling his arms high in air, joined his hands. Seeing the glimmer of the Kuret coming off his arms, I could predict he was aiming for a crushing blow to my face with just brute strength. I can't afford to get hit with this, even with my Kuret blocking it. But I didn't want to dodge it either because an opportunity had appeared. He arms were away and his legs in the air away from this abdomen. Out of all the places on his body, he had the most Kuret, his physical mass, centered there. That means if I chip away as much as possible here, he would loose a lot of the Kuret reserve he stored up for healing his other body parts.

Its dangerous, but I got no choice. I don't know when another opportunity will show up. I closed my eyes to see the glimmers. I then immediately gathered all my Kuret on my left foot. This time I felt the Kuret was covered only till my heels. That has to be enough. Gritting my teeth I lunged in the air at the howling giant. I brought my left leg around and willed to push it hard as much as possible. I felt a huge tug on my leg and I started to spin. Shit, I don't have any control on it and my aim was definitely shot. I saw the glimmer of his arms coming down hard on me. Just in the last moment of complete desperation, I bent my knees and swayed my arms behind to pull my body backwards.

In a moment of confusion, his hands missed my shoulders but they graze my right waist. The force of friction cause my clothing rip apart and cause a sharp piercing pain on the skin. I yelp in pain but resolved to push it down for now. My left leg kept tugging me along and with nothing to protect himself with, Charles felt the full force of my kick on his face. Shit, I missed my mark. I could see the brown Kuret getting crushed under my foot. Charles starts to howl in pain as the Kuritines on his face to starts disintegrating. With his head stopping my motion, I was now falling down with Charles on top of me. Crap. While still in pain from Charles attack, I pulled the Kuret to my back and willed to push ahead narrowly missing his falling legs behind me. I bring my arms up to brace for the impact as I slid across the grass. Charles behind me stumbles a little but remain standing on the ground. He was now howling more in pain with orange glimmer around his face.

I came to stop as rolled into a stop. The rush of adrenaline was still in my veins. I had completely messed up the attack on his chest. But at least now he can't see me coming. I got up and kicked off the ground once again. I didn't open my eyes. I need to be the gimmers be my guide for a while longer. I saw the tails now swaying in the air in between us in a frenzy. Is Charles making them to keep us separated. No, he is impulsively wagging his tail to protect himself. I could make a dash for him and avoid getting hit by those tails. But I would waste too much energy getting to him.

I made a risky move to attack him from above. I still had my Kuret on my back. I jumped up and made myself push up above. I had to put enough force to bridge the gap between me and Charles. I am still not used to this movement, so my arms and legs dangle a little bit as is glide in the air. The air seeped into my slightly opened mouth and I could feel the air pushing into my throat. Note to myself, never jump like this with an open mouth. I was rising in the air, but not enough to jump over the tails Infront of me.

I didn't know if this would work, but I pushed myself once more. I felt a smaller tug from behind this time. It was then I realized that I can't do consecutive pushes with same strength. At least not with level of Kuret I have now. It was not strong like the one before, but it was enough to raise me over the last tail hovering in the air. I safely cross the tails and start to fall on Charles back. He was writhing facing away from me and resting on his arms above guarding his face. I could see the gimmers of brown flowing into his face.

I was hoping to take another shot at that chest. I changed my target to his lower back. The second best place where majority of his Kuret is formed - around his waist. As I fall I pull my Kuret into my right elbow. I plan to use gravity to my advantage and deliver a crushing blow. I saw those orange glimmers around his head dissipate a little. Not good. Charles must have felt my presence coming from above and starts to move away. I couldn't change my direction so I just kept going.

Charles was crawling away from me, but not fast enough. I instead land my elbow on this right leg, straight in the middle of his calf. As soon as my elbow connected I could feel the Kuret getting crushed under my pressure. I positioned myself to brace my fall as my right side of the body to hit the ground. Since those legs were large, it made my body pivot and absorb majority of the momentum I carried. I still felt all the air I had gulped thrown out in a rush as I hit the ground. I braced my right abdomen to take the hit. The pain sent shivers to my body.

I saw enormous amounts of orange glimmer around Charles now. His Kuret was now getting stripped away mercilessly by my Kuret. A large amount of Kuret was getting churned away from his leg. Charles howls were loud enough to make me go deaf. His Kuret was slow to heal and his desperation to get away could be felt from him. I was definitely chopping off his Kuret supply and I wanted to keep going, but I saw the tails coming for me. Must be an instinctive defense mechanism. I had to get away. I pulled away my right arm and got up disoriented from the shock of falling.

I wanted to run away hastily, but the shock on my legs was still not gone. I should not done this without the usual coating of my Kuret to protect my body. I gritted my teeth as I had no choice but to brace from the impact of those tails head on. Since I hadn't attacked the tails for a while, those Kuretines were healed. They were considerably smaller and blunt at the end, but getting hit without protection would be bad. My heartbeats took a higher beat when I saw all the tails coming at me from different directions.

I can block only two of them. I won't be able to dodge the other two. I was running out of options. I pulled my arms in front of my face. There is only one option. I have to pull out more Kuret right now. I plunged deep into my thoughts to focus at the last few second I had. This is my only hope. My body should be attuned to this new Kuret form. I kept focusing on pulling on more of my Kuret. I felt nothing. I couldn't feel the Kuret forming on my body. With a frustrated cry, I tighter my fist even more. Work dammit, I shouted into the air.

Just as the tails reached from different directions. A wave of Kuret finally conjured around me. This was not the new threads of Kuret, but my most basic burst of Kuret. If those tails were in their original state, I would have been if much more trouble. But with those Kuretines chipped and Charles unstable Kuret, the Kuret blast was just enough to disintegrate those Kuretines and the tails bounced back away after getting it by my Kuret wall.

I breath of relieve washed all over by body. I was able finally able to call upon my Kuret. I think I also realized what was going on with my Kuret. But I shelved those thoughts for now. I faced to the now incapacitated Charles lying on the ground. The brown Kuret was flowing on the leg I attacked. Unfortunately, the wound wasn't deep enough to have enough damage. At the very least I got him tapped out for few seconds. I didn't wait another second to let those tails or Charles recover more. This is best time to keep up the offensive.

I forced my legs to move after the shock subsided. I ran to Charles thinking over the best course of attack. He is guarding his chest with his arms while resting on his left knee. His face is partially healed and he is now focused on healing his leg. And based on the amount of brown glimmer lost, its best to assume his Kuret is still unstable. I focused on the gimmers however around him. I need to attack now to the point where his defenses were the least on his chest.

I caught an area close his left ribs where he was drawing out the his Kuret the most to heal the damages I delt. That’s where I will focus my attacks. I came dashing close to him. With his mobility cut short, I had a slight advantage. I still have to make sure not to get hit by any of this attacks right now. I don't have any defenses available to me. Even a single attack would be the end of me. As I get close enough, Charles makes a big growl at me. I still couldn't see read the glimmers with that banged face, but I bet he is not thrilled.

Charles makes the first move and throws his right fist to slash my face, I gather my Kuret to the left side of my arm and will it to push hard blocking the claws away from me. The force of that punch was pushing me back, but I didn't relent and kept going. Finally the force of my arm dominated and I swatted his arm away. I take the momentum of that force and launch a punch from my right arm to his chest. Charles reflectively, brought his left arm to defend his ribs. I gather my Kuret about my fist. While I was faster, he was still bigger. I couldn't land a punch on his ribs and instead struck his arm. My fist dub deep into his arm and started to strip off Kurets.

Charles took this opportunity and lunged forward with his broken mouth forward. I could see his mouth still hadn't healed, but those Kuretines in his mouth were still dangerous. He was about to take a bit out of my right shoulder. I was getting better at controlling my Kuret, I saw where he was going to attack me and covered that area with my Kuret. He bit into now my Kuret covered shoulder and he jerked backed away after getting hitting a mouth full of my Kuret.

I didn't wasn't going to let this opportunity slip away and brought another left punch. Charles face, his eyes in particular, shouldn't have been able to follow my movements, but somehow he did and brought his right arm again to defend. He blocked me again at the expense of my Kuret on my hand stripping away his Kuret. We kept going this hand to hand combine couple of times. I know I am not making a mistake by making any obvious moves, but Charles is able to counter it and attack me after healing his arms enough.

We kept going this even longer. I couldn't fathom how he is fighting just with intuition guiding him. While I kept him on defensive, this is just a momentary weakness. Once his Kuret is stable again, he will be on offensive again. I think he also know if I land a blow on that chest, he would lose a big chunk of his Kuret. We both kept each other on our toes. I haven't done this much martial arts since the beginning of this tournament against any opponents. After a dozen of the blocks, Charles leaned back a little. I saw the brown glimmers around him getting even smaller now. I have to do it now.

Charles probably felt my intent and raised both his arms to thrown down a barrage of slashes. I didn't give him that opportunity. I focused and made another Kuret wave blast around me. Since I have been tempering it inside me for long after the previous one. This blast was more powerful. Charles never got to land those arms on me. I saw glimmers of his brown Kuret dissipating at the contact of my Kuret hitting him.

He was thrown back a little with the sheer force I blasted. This is it. With all my energy, I pour my entire Kuret into my right fist as I prepare to punch on that rib. Charles didn't even get time to defend this time. My fist connected successfully on his chest. I lean forward to use the full weight of my body on the punch. Those large Kuritines peaking out his skin crackle under my knuckles and his Kuret gets blasts away. Charles let the biggest howl I have ever heard as I kept drilling hole into his chest.

My teeth shiver to keep going with the attack. Few moments later, I saw the glimmer of the tails behind me coming again. Not again. Those damn tails keep getting in my way. I finally landed a decisive punch on him, I can't just back away now. I wanted to throw another Kuret blast. But I know that the one I threw just now sapped away too much stamina to make another one. The tails won't be stopped this time. I had a make a decision fast. Charles wasn't backing either. He was trying to push me back, even with so much Kuret leaking out him, he was still big and strong.

Dammit. I spatted those words as I pulled myself back and start to run away. The tails were faster, so I had to gather my Kuret on my back and make myself push away as far as possible. I came to halt and staggering on the ground once I came to a safe distance. My breathing was heavy. I needed a moment to gather myself before I make another more. I finally opened my eyes. I saw Charles sitting on this knees now with his arms swaying on his side. He was in worse shape than I could have imagined. His brown skin had holes many places on his body where I punched and kicked just now. His leg which I attacked first hadn't healed and had been shaved down considerably. All most of the Kuritines on body had been gone. There was a large hole on his chest that I had attacked. His faced was completely bashed in with broken and crumbling Kuritines, his tongue weirdly hanging out of his broken mouth grasping for air. His arms and shoulders also seemed smaller.

I smiled unconsciously. As I kept breathing from my mouth, a small laughter come from me. I had been sweating buckets, some seep into my mouth. I immediately spat it out once I tasted the salt in my mouth. Even so I couldn't stop from chuckling. I didn't know why I was feeling this weird reaction. I was no where near a clear victory. I spent too much stamina. I got cut from my side a little bit. Yet I couldn't stop the jubilation I was feeling. I felt I like this fight has been going for hours. I still have so many unresolved mental issues, but I didn't care for them this time. I need to keep this pressure and finish his match as soon as possible.

I gathered myself and slowed my breathing. This isn't over yet, I said. I resolve myself for another round of relentless attack. I was about to sprint forward, then I stopped when I saw a huge amount of brown glimmers in front of him. Oh no. I closed my eyes to see clearly. I saw a huge amount of glimmer coming out of Charles now. This was so much more than what I have been seeing it blinded me a little. I opened my eyes to check it out. Charles Kuret was now flowing faster into this body now. The places were I attacked starts to fade away. The hole I made on his chest starts to fill up in seconds.

I pushed my lips in frustration. Charles Kuret is stable again. Charles whole body starts to grow bigger again. His leg heals up and he stands up again. His tails began to recover their strength and Kuretines on the end shine with even more luster and sharpness. His face is completely healed and so is his chest. As I looked in disbelieve, his entire body is healed up in seconds without any trace of his old withered self. Dammit. I lost the golden opportunity. He will be even more dangerous now since he knows my attack can hurt him.

My short-lived joy took a even deeper dive. I realized that I wasn't covered in my Kuret sparks anywhere. Shivers went through my spine. What the hell. I tried to pull on those sparks of Kuret, but none came. This is seriously the worst time to have a power outage again. Charles lets out a big howl and prepares to take a stance to chase me. Seeing him I reflexively take a step back. That last attack I did with my fist and then the force to back away must have drained the Kuret sparks out of my body. And now I am defenseless again. What the shit.

I didn't have anywhere to run anymore. That same trick with hitting his eyes won't work again. A thought came in this desperate situation. I should just give up now. I did the best I could. I even overcome one my hang-ups on irrational fears. That should be enough. Fighting further would be dangerous even if I get my Kuret back. This battle helped me to grow by leaps. I should be just satisfied with this. I just need to raise my hand and say the words to end this match.

But neither my arms or my mouth moved. Was I in so much shock to not move. No. That’s not it. Even in this frenzied situation, I wasn't willing to give up. I was in utter shock with myself now. How badly do I want to win this match. Even risk my life. What gives. Questions keep popping in my mind. Why can't I just this go. I made it till here. It is okay to leave now. I have done enough to show other Medrines our strength. That’s the ultimate goal. It shouldn't matter now who wins.

A large howl came from Charles snapping me out my thoughts. He was now charging straight at me directly. My body tensed up facing now a powered up Charles without my Kuret. My mind was still in turmoil. What is going on with me. I want to end this match. But can't. I thought I accepted that I can't while back, but it seems I still had lingering doubts. I can't keep myself stretched in two directions. I have to commit to myself now for real. Its abundantly clear now I won't end this match like this. Either I am going down or Charles.

I closed my eyes to resolve myself. I try to tune the thumping sound Charles was making as he was running at me. I take a deep breathes. I am sure others would be thinking I have gone crazy not moving while Charles is pressing forward. I need this moment to clear all my thoughts. If I need to continue, I need to make sure I don't doubt myself again. Charles was dangerously close. If it was just few minutes back, I would have been scared shitless. But after dealing those damages, he is not undefeatable. There has to be a way. He must have a weakness. Everyone does. People can only hide their weakness the best they can.

So what's Charles. So far the only thing that worked was due to his Kuret instability. I have to find it no matter what. An idea came to my mind on how to find it. But that is not possible without my Kuret sphere. Charles was so close that he made the Earth shake under his feet. I have to fight him on equal grounds until I find an opportunity to make my move. But how. Without my new Kuret form, I can't block his moves. Then I recalled what I realized about my Kuret.

I open my eyes and look my hands as I raise it in front of me. When I was defending against those tails, I remembered that I was just relying on just my new Kuret form and instinctively blasted a wave. I need to go back to the basics. I should listen to what my body is telling me. I pulled off a high level move and then forgot about the other skills I have. I make my hands into a mist. I need start again. Build my Kuret from the ground up. I thought training the new Kuret form was the way to win. I was only half right. I can't treat my other techniques I have learned, honed, and used over the years as anything different than the new one. I need to learn how to add this new Kuret into my existing skill set.

As in response to my conclusion, my Kuret finally flared all around me and I was wrapped up again with the usual glow I have. That’s right. The new form of Kuret I learned isn't different at all that what I have been doing in my whole life. Its just the next level I need to learn and master. Charles had reached me and jumped up high again to stop me for evading. But I was ready now. I threw a line of Kuret from my right arm and let it pull me away before Charles claws reach me.

I glide along the grass as is avoid the claws again. I reach a safe distance and recall the Kuret back. Hell yeah, I shout. I will not be wavering anymore. Charles lands on the ground kicking up dirt and rocks from the place I

was standing.

I am getting little excited to face off Charles. I even had a grin on my face. Weird. An unexpected development of emotions came over me.

David (Chapter 14)

Friday, January 19, 2024 13:45

Charles closed the gap in few seconds and I dodged his attack by gliding away on my left. Unlike the last time, I wasn't going to get agitated and instead focus on running away for a while till I come up with a plan. I won't rush ahead until I learn to control this new Kuret to match Charles raw power. We kept this game of dangerous tag for a while. It helped that Charles kept his attacks very simple to avoid. He kept coming at me with those ferocious killing slashes and kicks. Yet his attacks were straightforward aims. Now that I have overcome the distraught of fighting someone unknown with no plan, I didn't given in to fear. I was eagerly waiting for an opportunity to attack while I was on defensive.

After a couple of close encounters, Charles brought his fists the ground with a roar. The ground shake on that contact and cracks formed on the grass like a spider web. Was that frustration. No. I could see the ground split into large pieces of dirt. Oh, hear we go again. Charles switched tactics, he is trying to corner with ground projectiles. Suddenly Charles leapt into the air raising his arms up in the air his claws began to grew bigger again. His jump is now even more powerful after stabilizing his Kuret. He was now hovering quite high up in the air. The tails that he had been not using to attack me for a while start to move again. He made his tails aim the ground instead of me. The four Kuritines hit the ground where Charles had just cracked the earth and began to dug into the ground. This is new.

Charles must have jumped high into air to get enough momentum to thrust his tails into the ground deep inside. Charles falls back down stomping the ground and creating even more cracks under his feet's. The ground shook once more. I assumed that he would dig up pieces of ground to throw at me next, but instead he begins to ran towards with me. I had an pretty good idea what is was planning to do now. I saw the glimmers of the tails under the ground borrowing through the dirt and heading towards me. I throw a Kuret line from behind my back and let myself get pulled back before Charles reaches me.

Charles was waiting for me to back away. He uses his right claws and thrusts into the ground. The ground tore apart and a piece of boulder the size of his arm split apart. Charles uses that pieces to fling it towards me. Damn. Did he get more powerful. No. He is getting more dangerous now. The boulder flew straight at me with uncanny speed. It chased me as I slid backwards on the grass. I could also see a glimmer of one of the tail chasing me from below. I throw a Kuret line to my right from the arm, curving my direction and dodging that boulder. It hits the grounds and cracks at the impact.

I braced for the tail as it rose from the ground in front of me. The Kuritine was aimed at my legs. He is trying to stop me from running away. Behind me, I saw Charles speeding up again. He had dug up another piece of ground from his other claw and preparing to throw at me. I can't let him capture me. I raise both my arms up throw my Kuret straight up. Flying up vertical on the air is slower compared to horizontal movement, but I didn't want the tail catching me. I lunged up getting pulled by my Kuret. The Kuritine on his tail miss me as I rise up.

I saw the glimmers of the rock Charles just dug up coming at me now. I was still flying straight above when the rock come flying at me. I brace my legs for the impact and force them side apart hoping the rock would fly underneath my legs. I couldn't completely evade the rock. The rock scraps the back of my knees a little. I get a sharp pain from the spot it scratched. But I managed to avoid major wound and got a bruise instead. My Kuret was still not powerful enough to protect me from non-Kuret physical attacks. I still am at a disadvantage.

The Kuret on my arms gather back in and I start to fall back on the ground. Charles wasn't giving me anymore chances. Another tail tore through the earth from where I was going to land. I can't stop my fall in his Kuret form. I saw Charles still coming at me from the side. I clench my teeth knowing I have only one move left. I pulled my arms below and aimed at Charles. The Kuret line flew at him with more speed. Since Charles is basically a big ball of Kuret mass, my Kuret would be attracted to it much stronger. As my fall begins to speed up, the Kuret from arms began to pull me down as well. The tug I was feeling on my arms was getting stronger as I fall.

The tail that was soaring in the air at me missed me as I began to fall sideways like a pendulum. I was now falling on a collision path towards Charles. Charles is running on all fours. He didn't even seem one bit fazed as I flew down to him. The air pressing against my face begin to heat as blood rushed to my face. I can't get away this time. The pull on my arms is to strong for me dodge now. I prepared myself with tightening up every muscle I could on my body.

The moment we were about the clash, Charles leaps a little into air with his claws raised in air preparing to pierce them right through me. Not happening. I mentally prepared for a dangerous collision and cried out as I blast my surrounding with Kuret dome. I wasn't planning to make it large. Just enough to cover my whole body enough with a physical barrier. I couldn't do this the last time. But since then I had a clue. I can't just let the Kuret grow out, instead I needed to keep it vibrating as it flowed out. I recalled the feeling when I was able to make the Kuret on my body vibrate and create the sparks. I want to make sure the Kuret doesn’t grow bigger. By vibrating it, I want to slow its size, condense it into more a physical form.

I felt relief when my theory worked out. The Kuret around me didn't grow big and the vibrations I focused on creating made the dome smaller. Just enough to cover my body head to toe. I bring my arms in front of my face and bring my knees to my stomach. This is going to be one hell of a clash. I braced for the impact. This newly constructed dome held better than I expected when I struck against Charles. He had his claws in front of me, but they were instantly blown back away at that impact. The Kuritines on his arms crumbles as I pushed them back.

Even as I wasn't directly touching his body, the impact vibrated through my entire body. His arms got pushed back, and the force I crashed into him kept me going. He was now getting his arms crushed between us. Charles was howling my ears off as he tried to push me away. Charles was struggling with his legs stuck on ground to keep himself up. Even with this arms pinned, he held his ground. I was loosing momentum slowly. My Kuret dome was disappearing now. I wanted this go on for little longer, however I still don't full control over this. I need to get away.

I lean back as my Kuret slowly begins to go back inside me. I pull out my legs and arms preparing to get away. I land on the ground, the disorientation of that attacking was hitting me. Just then Charles with his mangled arms tried to stop me. I felt a cold shiver as he was about to grab me from the sides. His arms were not even half the original size, and yet he wasn't going to let me leave. Hell no. I can't get caught now. I raise my arms to Charles and throw my Kuret line just few inches above Charles shoulder and pull me up.

I must have definitely surprised Charles with this move. I didn't have a choice but to escape this way, since I was seeing the glimmer of his tail coming at me from the behind. I get pulled up into the air before Charles arms gets me. I was pulled straight towards his head. He opened his mouth and snared me with those Kuritines. I didn't do this without a plan. As I got closer to Charles face I bow my head down and drew out another Kuret dome. I know I wasn't recovered enough to pull out another powerful one. I didn't need one. I just needed a small one. Small enough to cover just the top of my skull.

My concentration went through the roof as I was desperate. The Kuret came out of my temple and quickly covered my head like a cap. Since I was focusing on a small area, it was quick to form. The vibrating Kuret formed a strong barrier as I essentially head butted straight into Charles face. The force from my pull on my arms was just enough to overpower Charles. I felt a big pressure on my skull as I cracked my head into Charles. I saw his Kuretines breaking apart and I pushed him back. Charles lets out a big yelp with the second time me breaking his face and mouths. I flew past him as he couldn't stop himself from tumbling down.

The Kuret on my head quickly goes away, just as quickly it had appeared. I could only do it for few seconds, yet it was powerful enough to stop him. I was almost flying in air as I glide over the ground. Behind me Charles had taken a hit straight to his face and now stumbled down on his ass still managing to avoid falling on his back. I came to a slow halt when I was far away. I land on my legs, but I stumbled as I put my weight under by feet. Argh. I think I sprained my right foot a little when I crashed into him. I fall on both my knees forward as I couldn't keep my balance. I used my arms to support my fall.

My breathing was now ragged. Sweat kept pouring from my throbbing head. I could feel a little bit of blood trickling from the side of my temple. I nicked one the Kuritines when I struck against his face. That was a bit reckless. I had no other choice though. I open my eyes to take a peak again at Charles. He was already getting up. But he was considerably slow. His arms were already getting healed, and so was his smushed in face. A smirk formed at the corner in my mouth. I am slowly beginning to pressure him. But not yet. I have only managed to put up a good defense. I bought couple of seconds before Charles would be up again. I need to continue to keep this up and let me use up his Kuret as much as possible. I must have took a significant amount of his Kuret by now. I don't know how much, but there must be a limit.

I close my eyes back and scanned for the other tails underground. The three other tails were nearby me, but they didn't approach me yet. Charles must be focusing on healing himself first. I need to plan my next moves. It was the right decision to be on the defensive. While I continuously dodging his attacks, I had came up with the idea that I need to first vibrate my Kuret and incorporate it into my usual attacks before learning to change my Kuret form. I didn't plan to experiment it like this, nevertheless it was still fruitful. My Kuret dome was finally smaller and much stronger. What's more is that I can do it multiple times in succession. I don't have fine control the strength, but as long I keep it small, I could match up to Charles attacks.

Few seconds passed and Charles was back again with his healed body. I really need to do something about that pesky healing. I can't damage him badly enough when can keep healing those Kuritines on his body. I need to break into that cocoon of Kuret body and hit his real body inside. Now I know that I can overpower his strength momentarily. If I can just stop him from healing even for one or two seconds, I just might be able to land an actual blow. With that in mind, I formed a new plan. I can't defeat him the next couple of blows. Instead I plan to throw a single attack powerful enough when an opportunity occurs. An attack timed just right when his healing doesn't catch up.

For that I plan to cut off his healing for a while. An idea come to me. After having a feel to what vibrating my Kuret dome, I should next do the same to my Kuret when I throw it to help me move around. If the Kuret I throw around get stronger, I just might be able to stop his Kuret flowing on his body. I know that I can't make all my Kuret vibrate so I have to do it only when I am close enough to him. Charles was on the move again. He was running on his limbs with same intensity as before. Around my feet, the tails began to move as well. I want my body to first recover a little. I get back up and inspect my sprained feet. I felt the blood rush up on my vein. I felt the skin burning a little as the bruised surface began to throb. Fortunately, it wasn't paining too much. I need to keep a level head now and not give into the pain and fear now. Especially not when I can still win this fight.

I throw a Kuret line from my left arm let me pull away before Charles catches up to me. I want to at least give my body a minute to settle down before the next encounter. Charles changes direction when I move out from his path. He had grown his claws big again, ready to throw pieces of earth at me. I saw glimmers of two tails from opposite directions travelling inside the ground. Something was different, I could see the glimmers circling instead of coming straight at me. Charles is planning something.

I came to halt when I was a bit further away. I need to check whatever Charles was cooking first before I make my next move. I focus on seeing the glimmers of his tails inside the ground. All the four tails were digging their ways into the ground, but not in any particular direction. There was no pattern to it, looked like random directions. What is he trying to do now. I focuses deep into one of the tails to observe its movements. The one closest to me was moving in a spiral shape. Its almost like Charles is making his tails go crazy. I slightly shook my head, no. Charles attacks are simple, but not random. I didn't get a chance to conclude what those were doing as Charles was approaching me. He had dug up two boulders on each of this claws and preparing to hit me with them.

I throw a Kuret line from my right arm and began running away. Just as I slid across to Charles left, he threw on his boulder. But not at me, he threw it far away in the direction I was going. He plans to stop me from escaping. I was about to change my direction to my left. I saw another glimmer coming to the other side. Charles has thrown the other one in another direction. I see what he is trying to do now. He is trying to corner me further. Is that his plan, he only stop me from going in two directions. I have one more direction to run to. I could try to jump over those boulders, but I didn't want to risk getting caught in the air.

I threw a Kuret line on the last direction. Charles didn't try to stop this path, he kept chasing me from behind. I get that he is trying to limit my options to run away, but is that all. I don't see any of the glimmers of the tails following me from inside the ground. I am faster than Charles, so he can't be just thinking he will catch me. After gaining enough distance, I land on ground. As soon as I step foot on the ground, I felt the ground beneath me shook. The ground began to splinter into cracks and its start to fall apart. What in the hell. I was sure that his tails were no where near me when I land. In a total state of shock, I was sinking down in what looked like a dug out hidden pit.

Suddenly I recalled Charles making those weird motions with his tails inside the ground. That’s what he was doing. He was making traps for me. Ah, I never thought Charles would do something this clever. He must have noticed that I can track his tails even inside the ground. I think he purposefully lured me here so that I land in a place he kept his tails away. This is not good. With my footing lost, I was slipping inside the hole and was momentarily getting sucked in. Meanwhile, Charles glimmer was on the move. He would be on top of me any second. I had pieces of dirt and rocks sticking at me as I slide down. How big did he made this hole. I didn't wait to find out.

I pull my arms above and let my Kuret throw up in the air. I wanted to void getting caught in the air, so I made it shorter. I get pulled into the air away from the sinking ground. One problem solved, but the other one was fast approaching. Charles was not letting me leave. I wish I had more time to recover before I fought head on, I guess that’s just naïve. He had one claw already raised and ready to slash me with an upper cut. With my arms tied up, I used the only thing to defend myself with, my legs. I raise my right knee to block the path his claws were coming from. With a short breadth, I began forming a Kuret dome from that knee. Just as I learned, I will the Kuret to vibrate faster as I made the Kuret flow out. My Kuret obeyed me and was now covering from my lower thigh to my ancles. With loud bang, my leg met his claw. The clash broke his claws again, but he didn't even stop. The claw came at me so much force that I was thrown backwards.

Since Charles had his entire body weight on his side, that attack made be push back hard. That force of the impact was lessened due to my Kuret protection, but I was flung back uncontrollability. I was spinning sideways as I went down. I was going to hit the ground soon. But before I did, I saw Charles preparing to attack with the his other claw. He had them swung from bellow with an undercut this time. If I had my eyes open, I would not have been able to block it due to the disorientation of my spinning vision.

I could see the glimmer of his arm coming in from behind me. I didn't have the time to throw a Kuret line and run away. I also didn't have the time to create the dome, so I cover my entire back with Kuret to prepare a Kuret blast instead. I blast my Kuret backwards, the Kuritines on his arms gets crushed and breaking but does not disintegrate. Shit. My Kuret blasts are not powerful enough to completely break them. I brace myself for the worst. His claws hit me and I felt sharp pain as some of the Kuritine pierced my skin. My skin was burned as blood dripped out from my lower back. I bit my lips in agony.

Charles kept going and flung me up in the air with such a force that took the wind out of me. I was thrown in the air with my arms and legs swaying behind from the force. With the pain searing from my back, I had few seconds before I fall back into the ground. He got me good this time. I saw the glimmer of my blood tricking out from the wound I just got. If I hadn't made that Kuret wave, I would have gotten a much serious wound. I got hurt, but he didn't pierce it too deep. My Kuret had damaged his claws. He was only able to wound on the surface tissue. But the pain I got from my lower rib was far worse. The power behind those arms were unreal. I can only hope he didn't break any of my bones.

I couldn't inspect further as I began to fall to the ground. I muster up another layer of Kuret on my upper back and throw a Kuret line straight up. The fall began to slow down and came to near halt just as I hit the earth. As I land, I coughed up the dirt around my face when I let out the air from my lips. I lay there for a second letting the shock of that attack wash over my body. I saw Charles glimmer approaching me fast. With an irritated feeling I immediately stood up with my arms supporting me. I felt the new bruise I got on my back throbbing with even more pain now.

I was relieved to not see any broken bones. But this not boding well. I have been slowing racking up wounds. I haven't gotten any serious would yet, but I can't keep this up. I threw a Kuret line from my left arm and run away before Charles next attack. This has gotten a lot trickier. Charles must have dug up other holes. I have to be now even careful where to land. I scan the ground and try to pick up any glimmers of dug up grounds. My effort was in vain, I can't tell the difference in the glimmers from places which are safe and those which are not. I see the same glimmers around everywhere. I might be able to figure out if I was close enough, but I can't do that without landing on that area first.

I open my eyes in desperation. If I can't rely on glimmers, then I will just eye ball it. My Kuret line was running out. I had to make a decision. I land on nearby ground with caution and ready to slide away in case I got caught again. But nothing changed. I landed on a safe place. I let a sigh of relief. I turn around to inspect the ground nearby. I caught glimpse of some suspicious looking patches of grasses. They had been cut short. No, they had sunk below a little from the underground hole. Yes, that’s it. By looking at the grass I can predict where to land. That meant I can no longer land on places where Charles has been digging up the boulders and leaving bare debris behind with no grass.

I threw another Kuret line from my back and flew away before Charles catches up to me. I close my eyes after noting down the safe area I plan to go. I saw glimmers of two tails approaching at me from the same direction as Charles. The tails burst through the ground out in the air just in front of Charles as he ran in front of them. What's this now. I was bamboozled as Charles leapt into air and uses his claws to slash the Kuritines from his tails. In a swift motion, he plucked it away from his tails. Then he threw one of them straight at me. Whoa.

The Kuretine he threw came at me with too much speed. I didn't have time to change direction. I crouch my head down behind just in time as the Kuritine flew past above me. I could hear the air hissing as it flew in the air. I saw the glimmer of the other Kuritine Charles threw. It was heading towards my gut. I let out a burst of Kuret wave towards the approaching projectile. The Kuritine broke into pieces before it reached me. I reach the area I wanted to land on. I hit the ground on my ass though. I quickly got up in haste.

I saw the other tails approaching me directly. It was now becoming dangerous to run away now. How long can I keep this up before I Charles catches me. He keeps attacking me in ways I don’t know. This is the biggest disadvantage of not knowing who I my opponent was. While he was able to observe me for long enough to know certain parts of my powers. I was feeling little frustrated thinking about Kafar's speech. Was it really the only reason that Charles couldn't access his Kuret for which he was kept hidden. I quickly dispel those thoughts. There's no point thinking about it now. Even if I knew who I was going to fight beforehand, the result would have been the same. Adding the name didn't solve the fundamental problem that I had no clue about the way Charles fight.

My hands tighten up with anger. At this rate I am going to be lose. And not just the match. Maybe even my life if he kept coming with those killing attacks. I have to go on the offensive now. I got no choice. I thought if I keep running away, there would be opportunities where I could use my new attacks. But its now clear Charles has stepped up his game. Ever since getting that beatdown when his Kuret was unstable and later with that cannon ball attack, he has become more meticulous and ferocious. The chances of him making mistakes or giving me opening is becoming scarce. On top of all that, I have been getting hurt more and more.

I let out an irritated sound from my mouth. Its come down to this. I can't slip up even once now. The tails were close enough now. I also realize that these tails are now becoming to much of a bother to deal with. I wanted to let Charles waste Kuret on them as much as possible, but now the situations changed. I have decided its for the best to cut those tails now. The tails fly out from the ground near my legs and go straight to my torso. I let out a small Kuret blast to push them away. Then I grab on to the tails in the middle. As soon as I made in contact, the tail begins to crumble under my skin.

Charles didn't flinch as I grabbed his tails. The next second, the tail section in my hand gets cut off and disintegrates. The head part of the tail falls to the ground slowly dissolving into the air. The rest seeped back into the ground. With that, I began sprinting to Charles, now, with no intension of dodging or running away anymore.

David (Chapter 15)

Saturday, January 20, 2024 13:54

My Kuret is also responding to me better than ever. And I have decided not to buy time anymore, so all I have to do is completely focus on offense. So far I was able to put my Kuret domes for only few seconds. I will need it for longer time if I am going to stand a chance against Charles monstrous strength. The biggest difference in us is out height and weight, giving him an unparallel advantage over power. No matter how strong I wrap my Kuret around me, without the physical force behind it, it won't make much difference. I need to find a way to become faster. I got speed going for me for the moment, if I can just find a way to utilize it, I might me able to overpower him at times.

As we both ran at each other, I kept track of the tails under the ground. The tails were keeping a distance from me at the moment. Charles most likely plan to use them if I try to ran away in some direction. I thought about my plan a bit. I made a decision to cut those tails off before I start attacking Charles. I don't want to keep diverting my attention to ambush attacks from those tails. The most direct way was to cut all four tails from base on his body, but that will be very difficult.

We will be in a striking position in a second. Before Charles claws reach me I had thrown a Kuret line from my right arm and slid away in the narrow gap of his other arm. I used our confrontation as a distraction and went to my actual target, the closest tail beside me digging inside the ground. Charles came to an abrupt halt and began to change his direction. I already created a fair amount of gap between us. I was focusing on the tail now. The amount of glimmer I see made me believe its not that deep, maybe just 1 meter. I was coming to a halt near that area. I had also peaked a little with my eyes before landing to make sure it wasn't a hidden pit he dug.

I crouch down and lay both my arms on the ground. I have only few seconds before Charles catches me. I focus on the Kuret on my hands. I take a deep breath and began imagining what I need my Kuret to do. My purpose is not to create a Kuret dome which will go in all direction, instead I want to fire a targeted Kuret into the ground and cut the tail in half. I throw a Kuret line inside the ground where the tail was moving. I saw pieces of glimmers stripping off from Charles tails, but it was too slow. Almost immediately, brown Kuret was flowing and healing the portion I damaged.

I was expecting this to happen. I already saw my basic Kuret is ineffective against Charles Kuret. What came next is the core of my plan. Just like before, I began vibrating the Kuret I had thrown. There was a hard resistance, much more than when I did with the Kuret dome. Agh, making it to vibrate further away from my body is very arduous. I gritted my teeth as I continue to press on. A couple of seconds passed by, but I still couldn't make the Kuret inside the ground hard enough to cut the tail completely. I was out of time. Charles came dashing from my right.

Dammit. I stood back up and turn towards the next tail from here. I saw a different tail section at the edge of the arena. I didn't want to go there because if Charles corners me there, it will be difficult to evade. But I needed the extra time to think. So I made a risky decision and threw a Kuret with my left arm and slid towards that ground. Charles lets out a growl as I slip away from him again. I wonder why he is not trying to throw rocks at me now. Surely he must know what I am trying to do by now. Does he plan to keep chase me like this. Whatever his reason was, I was glad. I didn't want extra stuff to worry about.

As I came to a halt midway, I threw a Kuret line from my right arm after taking a single step. I kept thinking as fast I could on how make my Kuret stronger away from my body. I have to figure this out. Vibration is the key no doubt about it. But something else is missing for it to work outside my body. I kept racking my brain to look for clues. I recalled Blake's, Nate's and Jess's Kuret. Their Kuret form are the closest to mine. But so far I have never seen them having problem to solidify Kuret outside the body. They seem to do it intuitively. I should be able to do it too, at least that’s the theory. What's the difference between the Kuret form I use and they use.

I hurriedly came to the ground near the edge of the dome. I waste no time and place both my hands on the ground. I push out a Kuret line from my arms and vibrate them again. My Kuret hit the tail, and same like last time, it didn't cut the tail completely. An idea came to my mind. I am vibrating my Kuret after I throw it, but what happens if I throw the Kuret while its vibrating. It had to be more effective when my Kuret is moving while also vibrating. I need to try this. I pull my Kuret back into my hands.

My heart starts to beat faster with anticipation as I take deep breathes. I image just my right hand covered in a small dome, then I vibrate them like I have been doing. The Kuret on my hands fluctuate in consistency as I never tried this before. I turn my hand into a fist instead and place my knuckles in the ground. The Kuret on my hand becomes denser with the vibration keeping it steading. With another breadth, pull my arm up and punch the ground. I willed my Kuret to flow out as I struck the ground.

My Kuret was unstable, but, it was working. I could feel the ground I was crouching on shake a little. The Kuret flew out of my hand and it was actually digging slowly inside the ground. Incredible. It actually worked. This tail was closer to the surface, so my Kuret reached faster. As soon as it hit, the tail was sliced in the middle. A small roar come from the side, Charles. He has a slight glimmer of orange flowing out of him. I took a mental noted of this because I realized something.

I was relieved that it worked. The Kuret I has thrown had stopped vibrating and turns to its old form as it retreats back into my fist. So just like everything, I can only do this for few seconds and only at a small distance. But now I have something that could work against Charles. One part of tail I cut off slowly begins to disintegrates. That confirms that my Kuret really cut his Kuret body without him able to heal it. I stood back up. Charles was near the arena edge now. I threw a Kuret line from both my arms to the other direction. I didn't want to face him just yet. I need to know the extent of this new skill and while I do that, I should keep cutting of his tails.

There was something more I realized. Charles felt a little pain when I had cut his tail. Till now I thought he didn't want to dispose of those massive tails because he couldn't reabsorb the Kuret lost. But perhaps, there is more to it than that. He must be feeling pain whenever I damage the tail body. Even if I don't directly attack his real body, he would still feel pain if I cut pieces off his Kuret body. This must be another trade off for being able to make an actual Kuret body. I smirk on this realization. This means, if I keep cutting off his tails, keep shortening it little by little. He would feel mental pain. He might be able to physically heal himself, but the growing mental fatigue is something he will accumulate continuously. That’s one of the keys to my win. I now have one more reason to keep chipping off more and more of his Kuret body.

This might not be all that simple though. Charles must have developed enough mental resistance to such an obvious weak point. He must have trained to be resistant against pain. All the time I gauged out Kurets from his body, he must have felt pain from there too. I just didn't see it often because of his overwhelming brown glimmer that masks the glimmers from his real body. And yet, he keeps coming. He must have a high mental fortitude. But everyone has a limit. After I take a certain amount of Kuret, it must cause enough damage to his mind and body both.

I came to halt when I saw section of a tail underneath me which was closer to its end. Lets keep this up. I will target the tails from the top down, cutting it off little by little. I got ready for another Kuret punch, a term I just coined now. With my mind still fresh from few seconds ago, I was able to pull it off without a hitch. My Kuret flew down, albeit not smoothly, but it was enough to cut the tail again. Charles lets out a growl has he approaches me. He must have braced himself for this as I saw very less orange glimmer on him.

I threw another Kuret line in the direction I saw the glimmer of another tail. I reach the area and threw another Kuret punch without missing a beat. I continue to do this couple of times. Charles was getting more impatient with me running around cutting his tails in pieces instead in one go. He was gunning for me much faster, trying to grab on. He also stopped attacking with his tails, that would just make it easier for me to cut them off. After cutting down my 10th, I was in a sliding across an area close to where Charles had dug a pit. There was a tail section hiding in the ground there. Charles must have moved it there purposefully to ambush me.

I took a quick look around of my surrounding. Its not just this area, Charles moved nearly all of his underground tails near the hidden pits. Clever plan. So Charles is capable of tricking also. Maybe he always was and finally getting serious enough to think it through. Unfortunately, its not good enough. I already had came up with an idea to deal with this. The only change is that now I had to do it for all the pits he dug earlier. I came to a halt few meters before the hole. I take a deep breath as I focus on pulling out Kuret from my foot. I plan to cut tail with my leg instead of my fist. Just I have been doing, I steadily wrap my foot with a miniature Kuret dome and will it to vibrate.

My Kuret comes out in uneven shape. Its not a proper sphere nor flames. Its somewhere in between, an amorphous shape. I didn't care about the efficacy of my Kuret at the moment, so I throw an Kuret line over the pit. As I slide across the ground, I wait for the opportune moment. Just as I reach above the grass hiding the tail, I raise my leg a little above my knees behind. I mimicked the motion of kicking an imaginary ball, I will my Kuret to grow as I slid over the grass. In one swift motion, I kicked the air while extending my Kuret. My Kuret control over my foot was the worst, but it was strong enough to cut the tail inside. I made a smile as I came to a stop over a safe area.

Behind me Charles had grown his claws again and preparing to throw the pieces of ground. He is finally doing it. But this didn't stop me from cutting the tails. Charles kept throwing pieces of rocks at me, however, now that I know where the pit he dugs were, I was able to stay clear of those flying projectiles. At this point, it didn't matter how many rocks he would hurl at me, it wouldn't change my plan. About a dozen cuts later, his tails had finally shorten to almost his original size. To be honest, they were still longer than how it was, but cutting them shorter would mean getting more closer to him. I decided it wasn't worth the effort to cut it further.

I came to a halt at a safe ground after I safely dodge a rock thrown at my head. Its time, I mumble as I face the incoming Charles. Over this entire course of trimming his tail, I had gotten enough handle on my Kuret form. I am able to Kuret vibration and extend it a little bit over a distance from my arms and legs. I honestly wanted to get more familiar, but delaying it more would drain even more of my stamina. I was breathing hard with my face covered in thick sweat. My face is flushed with blood and my chest is beating hard.

I think I spent about half of my endurance. Maybe even more. I will probably last only a some more time before I am completely down for the count. If it was any other situation, I would have just high tailed out of here because I don't know what will happen next. I hate fighting without knowing an opponents weakness, especially, when I still don't what his real weakness is after exchanging so many blows. Well, nothing can be done now. I will have to just to figure it out as I go on the offensive now.

Charles roar made me bring out of my thoughts. He was a little faster. Perhaps due his tails shortening. Or maybe he knows that I will fight him and got excited. In my mind I was still holding back my desire to fight him head on, and that’s probably my justification avoid him temporarily and cut down the tails first. But now there's no excuse for me to avoid him head on. I focus on getting my breathing down and calm the nervous acting up. I patiently waited for Charles to reach me this time wanting even the extra seconds to clam down. The clock slows ticks slowly in my mind as Charles keeps getting closer.

This is it. We are now coming to the final parts of our showdown. I focus just on Charles glimmer, trying to find places on his body that has less Kuret mass. Since his Kuret is stable now, there is no point in focusing on just depleting his Kuret. Instead I will now change my plan to start attacking places where he has slow Kuret healing or less protection. But with so much Kuret around him, I couldn't find any good particular spot to attack. Then I have to figure this out as we exchange blows. I brace myself, raise my arms above my chest and tighten my fist.

Charles this time was going for a head on collision. He had a half opened mouth exposing those Kuritines underneath them. So he is going for more dangerous attacks. My fingers shiver a little in my hands. No turning back now. I formed a dome on both my hands. Kuret flows out and I vibrate. The vibrations could now be even felt over the hairs on my skin. I must be vibrating my Kuret more vigorously at the sight of him. I have to stay clam no matter what. One mistake and I am done.

Charles lunged forward at me head first aiming to take bit at my left shoulder. I saw this coming from his movements. In response, I move quickly to my side to avoid his bite. His teeth bites the air where my shoulder was. Then I tighten all the muscle I could muster on my right arm and throw an undercut punch. I put my entire body weight under that punch by letting my body fall in the opposite direction.

I was aiming for his throat thinking he would not expect me to hit him where the Kuretines have grown the most. I took the risk and attacked here thinking this would be closest path to his real body inside. My first connected to

his Kuret flesh. His Kuretines immediately crumbs into tiny pieces. I yell out a little as I extend my Kuret from my fist. Unlike the tails, I felt something very hard obstructing my path. I was expecting that, his body was naturally going to be more covered in Kuret.

Because of my movements, I couldn't see exactly how effective my punch was. I quickly push myself to hug the ground before Charles arms could grab me. Charles jumps are so long and huge, one can easily hide out under him as he passed over my head. I throw a Kuret line from my other arm to get some distance from Charles. As I slid away, I saw Charles glimmer spiraling around the Kuritines I crushed. But there was no visible glimmer of pain. It didn't work. Charles landed on his four limbs and shakes his head a little, like he was shrugging off that attack.

Shit. Not a good start. I didn't want to wallow much in disappointment so I came to a halt and got up. I threw another Kuret line from my other arm towards Charles hurrying to get him from behind. I prepare my other arm to try once more. Charles didn't stop to heal himself first, he got up on him legs and bared his claws at me. I let go of my Kuret line and poured more Kuret into my fist. If that amount of Kuret I attacked him earlier is not enough, I need to go big.

My control was failing as I make the Kuret dome on my fist bigger. But I didn't have any other choice, so I keep focusing on making sure the vibrations hold the dome on my hand smaller. I throw out my Kuret from my fist as my punch connects to his. His claws immediately disintegrates, but he doesn't budge. Instead his overwhelming force cause me stagger back and throw my balance off. I had left jumped in the air to reduce the counter force, but it was enough to throw me backwards. I felt the shock of that punch over my bones. Fortunately, I had chipped enough of his Kuret body on his arm and cut down the power of that fist, otherwise I would broken my arm.

I was thrown into air. I didn't want to my effort go to waste. The dome I had on my arm was getting smaller, but it wasn't gone completely. I have to get at least one more hit in before I get away. I instinctively throw a short Kuret line from my chest and I got pulled towards Charles. I saw his other arm trying to stop me. With a burst of energy, I tried to put up another Kuret dome on my leg hoping to kick away. I didn't even how much successful I was, but I managed to kick him at the wrist and cleared my path. My dome on my hand was now much smaller.

I decided to change my attack. With my free hand I grab on to the largest Kuritine back of his head. I grip it around my hand and pull myself closer. I pull my wrist closer to my chest, focus on putting my Kuret my elbow. The dome was still stronger on my elbow. I shout out once more as I extend out my Kuret and land my elbow to his forehead. His Kuritines on the face was completely crushed and continue to press on. I was hoping to at least push him down. But he was still standing strong.

All I was focusing was to put as much as pressure I could into my arm. Charles bark was smushed under my Kuret. A moment later I felt his tails glimmer grabbing me at both my legs. Shit. I didn't pay attention to his tails. A big careless mistake. The next moment he yanked me off his face and I let go my arms. His tails pull my to his side and I got pulled away horizontally. He makes me spin behind me and throws me up in the air. I felt my blood turning to my head as I was thrown up side down.

I saw the sky below and ground above me. I was too much focused on his arms and legs, I completely ignored his tails. Will not make a mistake like that again. The glimmers around Charles face was hastily running around. But for the first time, I saw another glimmer coming out of him. I saw sparks of blues flowing inwards is face. I grinned a little, despite my current airborne condition. That attack now just connected to his actual body. Those gimmers I saw was his nerves sending pain signals to his body.

I thought of another attack. I didn't want to waste this opportunity that Charles gave me just now. With the arms there were dangling below my head, I threw a Kuret line towards Charles. I pull slowly slows down my acceleration to the sky. I see Charles other two tails moving below me. They were wrapping around two rocks lying nearby. Even without his eyes, Charles was trying to attack my just by sensing my movement. His tails lift those two rocks in the air.

I was coming to a slow halt and then began to change direction. As I start to fall back down, I twist my body and position myself to attack. Charles throws one of the rocks at me. I was surprised how good his aim was considering he wasn't even seeing. But it wasn't enough to change my direction. The rock passed me from a little distance safety. The second rock he throw, however, was flying straight at me. In anticipation, I had thrown another Kuret line from my chest pointing below ground. My two Kuret lines pulls me in different direction, and I curve down as I fall. I narrowly pass by the rocks coming at me.

Now my path was unobstructed. I twist my body a little and join my legs together. If one limb is not strong enough, how about I use both of them together. With my legs anchored, I form a Kuret dome around my feet. My teeth grind in anticipation. I need to create a more bigger and denser Kuret. The vibrations from the Kuret was whistling in the air as I swing. I kept focusing on my Kuret till the moment I connected my foot against Charles backside.

Charles was trying to move away sensing my approach. But he was too big and I was coming in too hot for him to dodge this. My legs connected his Kuret body from behind on his back with a loud bang. I was right to drop kick him with both my legs. While the dome wasn't consistent, this was still my strongest attack I have felt. The Kuret I extended from my legs cuts deep inside his body. Charles with his half healed mouth howls vigorously. I felt Charles getting pushed ahead under the force I was hitting with.

Seeing Charles slowing loosing balance, I got a rush of adrenaline and will the Kuret on my arms to pull me stronger against him. My Kuret had definitely chopping off more Kuret he could replace. I now saw even more spark of blue glimmers from his back. I was hitting him on his actual body now. My teeth quiver with the push I am making. Charles finally gives into my pressure. Instead of toppling forward, he bends forwards to crouch down. With his body no longer stopping me, I got pulled away above him in the air. I bring my arms to cover my face from the debris lying all over the place. I slid over the grass for a distance and came a stop.

I see Charles glimmers running overtime. I take a peak with my eyes. Charles was crouching down and squatting his legs. This was the first time I saw so many Kuritines destroyed on his body. His face was still not healed, when I elbowed him, I was aiming for his eyes. I don't know if I actually hit him there or not. And if I did, would it heal faster?. The time I attacked his eyes with stones was around when Kuret was unstable. So maybe that was pure luck back then and he could heal his eyes faster now.

His Kuret behind his back shaved away so much that it looked like a large scope was taken out. I thought I didn't made the right choice attacking on his back where, like his chest, he had a lot of Kuret. But my the kick from both legs had enough Kuret to gauge out a substantial amount of Kuret. Even with my eyes open, I could visibly see large amount of Kuret flowing into it and still not healing faster. The pain he felt when I connected to his actual body must be a enough to rattle him at least a little.

I take a moment to inspect my body. I only had some new cuts on my arms, curtesy of my recklessly grabbing those pointy Kuritines and elbowing him straight at the Kuritines guarding his eyes. Everything else considered, I think I made it out without too much damage. I grinned a little as I get up. I face Charles thinking of my next move. I wanted to launch an attack immediately, but I also needed a second to shrug off the disorientation I am feeling.

As I was thinking about my next plan of action, my eyes accidently picked up a thin strand of red glimmer in the air. For a moment I was got worried that I was bleeding other than my head and back. But the glimmer coming off me was at a different direction. In a moment of confusion, I look around the ground behind me and didn't see the origin of this glimmer. I close my eyes and focus on tracking this. I followed the thin strand of red and traced it coming from in front of me.

Wait really. I began to feel excitement swell inside me. Was that last attack so strong that I actually able to make Charles bleed. I hastily focus on the back he was healing. But surprisingly, that wasn't the origin. Huh, my excitement took a turn and instead I was puzzled. I then gaze over his arm. There was a small cut where the red glimmer was coming out of. The cut was so small that the Kuret had already been healed over, but I could still see a small but clear line of red glimmer out from his wrist.

My eyes flew open in complete bewilderment. Did he accidently cut himself. No, that’s impossible. Then I did that. When did I do that. I recalled the time when I was pulling myself closer to Charles face. He tried to block me with that arm and kicked it away. That’s the only moment I connected to that arm. Hold on, that kick had barely enough dome. I was splitting my main focus into the bigger dome on my arm. What's going on, the elbow to the face and the kick to back didn't make him bleed. But I managed to make him bleed, even a little, over a half baked Kuret kick.

I turn my gaze to my left foot. What did I do. I tried to recall what I did special there. I racked my memories. I don't think I even put much thought when I was actually doing it. Then a answer came into my mind. What if at that moment, when I didn't have time to create a bigger dome, I made such a small dome while vibrating that it broke. But it didn't disappear, instead it turned to the Kuret thread and created my new Kuret form. It was probably not stable for even a full second, but in that moment I kicked him, my Kuret vibrated so strong it broke the Kuretines on his wrist. Not just that, it was powerful enough to make that scratch.

At that realization, I half opened my mouth to take in more air as I breathe. I finally got a hint into how to combine all my Kuret skills into the new form I wanted. My sweat slips inside into my mouth a little, but I didn't care. I was getting a new rush of excitement I had never felt since the match started. It felt like eternity fighting him, but I now it felt even slower. If I can do that again, learn and then do it on my entire body I would finally have a decent change of winning.

Charles would be done healing in few more seconds. I began to prepare a plan after this discovery. I softly say into the air, Get ready Charles. You are going down.

Blake (Chapter 16)

Tuesday, January 23, 2024 22:11

The atmosphere in this room is filled with tension. People didn't even look away from the screens even for a second. It had been now 24 minutes since the battle started. The longest battle we ever saw was between Vanessa and Marina than went for around 30 minutes. Looking at both Charles and David, it doesn't like this match will stop anytime soon. Some time back, Kafar had started drinking. He was tensed earlier about Charles getting disqualified, but when we decided to leave it to David to choose, he has started enjoying himself seeing David struggle. A little too much actually.

David had started fighting against the tail instead of fighting Charles directly for some reason. He kept dodging and slashing with his hands. Ned asks, what is going on here. Charles doesn't need to use his tails to fight. Why is he going about in such a difficult way. No one gave an answer to him. I was also curious about it, but I was more focused on what David was doing. He had wrapped himself with Kuret around his hand. No, just his fingers. This is the first time I have seen him doing this. He never did something like this even in our match. Is that what he was hiding. No, why would he wait so late in the game then.

I chuckle a little after realizing a bit, I don't know about Charles, but I am almost sure that David is doing some sort of training. I spoke up giving my thoughts. Matt asks, huh. What. You are not serious are you. He is right in the middle of a match ?. I reply, think about it. Have you ever seen that type of black Kuret on him before. Look at him dodging and slashing those tails. He is moving uncoordinated. I might be wrong, but he is not fully in control. So he must be stalling for time and getting used to this first.

Vanessa asks me, is that the ace up his sleeve he was hiding. The one you mentioned earlier. I shook in response, I honesty can't say for sure. But I don't think this is it. Tessa who was looking at a different monitor that focuses on Charles asks, is it me or is something strange going on with Charles?. Cass asks, strange how. He might not be moving much, but I don't see any difference in his power. Everyone look to the other monitor. Kafar sets his drink down, Charles is no fool. He must be testing David after seeing his strange new techniques. Kafar showed indifference to Tessa's question.

Tessa replies, I don't think that’s all. I can't see well from the monitor, but I can sense something happening to his Kuret even from here. Its very small, but there is definitely a change in his Kuret levels. I wasn't sure what Tessa was going on, but she wouldn't say something without any reason. I turn over to the window and stare at the arena directly. I pulled in Kuret into my eyes and focused on Charles. The aura coming off his Kuret body was basically blinding. It was like a Kuret tornado with him in the eye of the storm.

But then I caught something. The aura around him was not stable. It was flickering and running wild. His Kuret usually would be in control. Like Tessa said, his Kuret was behaving strange. Nathan spoke to me, you see it too cousin. Nathan was also gazing at the arena and checking the same stuff I was seeing. I nod, yes. Its as you say Tessa, something is going on with Charles. His Kuret is running wild, almost unstable. Kafar stood up immediately from his seat, wait. What. No. That’s impossible. He ran frantically to the window and stares at his champion. He shouts, Derek. Can you check.

Derek cuts him off, way ahead of you. I turn to him. He was fiddling in fingers on tablet. A few seconds later he says, wow. Derek makes a small smile. But it disappears before Kafar sees that. Kafar, you might want to sit down for this. The sensors we placed on his body shows that he is effected from the Kuret blockage. Kafar eyes widen in shock. He walks to Derek and takes away the tablet from his hands and checks it for himself. Derek then looks at the monitor with a little smirk, so even the alpha can't avoid this. He takes a pause to think and then continues, You guys are right, his Kuret is unstable temporarily. Maybe he is stalling David for time to recover by using tails to attack meanwhile.

Cass chuckles a little, that’s incredible. So that means Charles got weaker then right. David will be on the offence now. Ned cuts in, even if that’s true. David might not even know Charles state. Vanessa beside him replies, there is no way that David won't pick that up. I am telling you, he will not let this opportunity go. She eyed Ned as he affirms her words. Ned was about to something curt back to her. I spoke before their private feud turns to another quarrel, we just have to wait and see. Hearing my words, they both backed down.

Kafar who was silently going over the screen, this is impossible. It has never happened before to Charles. He never had a Kuret block in the middle of a fight. He was probably in denial. It was a little amusing seeing Kafar panic again when he just leisurely drinking just a minute back. I didn't notice it, but Marina beside me standing and performing a Charm. I turned to her, what are you doing. She speaks, when you mentioned Charles Kuret was unstable, I wanted to confirm it. She takes few more seconds and completes the charm.

In front of her, the Kuret she drew turned into a figure of Charles. Marina continues, I linked up his Kuret form from within the dome to his. We can see his current Kuret state. She then points to a 3D figure of Charles that was projected from inside the dome. The projection showed Charles Kurets flowing out. Then as we kept monitoring, the Kuret began to decrease. Marina had her hands in the air trying to sense Charles Kuret, yeah. I think I got it. Its just an estimate, but Charles lost about a nearly half his usual Kuret. If David attacks, Charles would be fighting at half his strength.

I was amazed Marina able to figure out so quickly. Derek ask her, can you tell how long will he be effected. Marina presses her lips together trying to figure that out, I have no idea. This is my first time seeing a Heraknus you know. Just be glad I could tell about his much. All I know is that Charles is running on half the strength for now. Derek's taken aback with her irritated response, um, okay.

Vanessa lets out small chuckle suddenly, guys look. David is on the move. I turn back to the monitor, so did everyone. David was running straight at him. Did he realize Charles got weaker, or was this just a coincidence. Charles didn't move from his spot but instead used his tails to attack David from below. David didn't attack them, instead he jumps forward. It was strange though, it wasn't a normal jump. Its like was not able to control his own body and fumbling around the air. Whatever he did, it was enough to get away from the tails.

David goes on the offensive, starting with dodging Charles attacks. He was fighting without his full black Kuret, which seemed odd to me. Why would he do this so risky. David didn't stop his barrage of attacks. Charles leaps in air to attack, to which David jumps himself up and attack his face. Whatever David was training paid of, he shattered almost all the Kuritines on his head. He get a small side cut from Charles before he runs away. David was successful in landing the first blow in this exchange.

But he wasn't going to stop just yet. Charles had brought his tails to stop David in his tracks. David's again does the strange movements to hop over them. Its was very clear to me that David was struggling to control this new power of his. David while falling down, attacks Charles leg and Charles lets out a howl louder than ever. Everyone here were in awe seeing this incredible spectacle. The most shocked was Kafar. I could see panic in his face now. David defends himself with his Kuret before the tails was able to grab him. Cass lets a out relief of sigh beside me, that was too close.

David makes some distance between them. He was on a hot streak now. With two consecutive hits, Charles was slowly getting cornered. They both began a hand to combat. It was incredible seeing them duking out from here. Which Charles on his knees, he was still large and tall. Compared to him, David was not even half his size. And yet, David held in ground. Derek says, I am now sure David knows about Charles getting weaker. No way he didn't notice it. He wouldn't so fervor to continue attacking like this if he didn't.

Kafar takes a small gulp and tried frantically to correct his expression, why is this happening. Charles never been effected by Kuret block fighting anyone ever. Vanessa replies, well he has never fought someone like David before either. Everyone here, save few, couldn't help smile a little at that. Everyone here knows David finds a way in matter the situation. Marina giggles a little beside me, ah, Kafar, our champion is now in real trouble now. She nods her head to point to the hologram in front of her, Charles is at around one-fourth of his Kuret level.

We stared at the hologram and saw the Kuret around Charles dwindling down. Every time David attacked him, the Kuret from his body emptied out. Kafar was expressionless now. I think he might be finally realizing that Charles could lose this. After almost 2 minutes of continues attacks, David finds an opening. He blasts a Kuret wave and then punches Charles square in the chest. The punch itself was not strong, but his black Kuret was continually blowing off large amount of Kuret from Charles body.

Even more surprising was Charles not backing down. Even when getting cornered, he wasn't giving up. He made his tails crawl from behind and chase David. David ran away before he gets caught. Charles was in a worse shape now. Marina whistles beside me, oh boy. Charles is now just running on Kuret fumes now. His big showy body is just for show. He is almost tapped out. The hologram showed very less Kuret on Charles body. Everyone were tethering the edge now. Is this it, I spoke out loud without knowing.

David took a few seconds to shrug off his exhaustion. He then runs off towards Charles. This could be the end of this match. Marina makes a sharp cry from her mouth, oh shit. I dart my eyes back to her. The hologram she maintained was now showing Kuret coming back from inside Charles. I ask, wait does this mean. She reluctantly nods, yeah. His Kuret block is over. Matt brings his fist to the table beside him, damn. So close. We stare back at the monitor. David must have also realized like us when he stops in his tracks.

Kafar lets out a big sigh of relief. Oh jeez, I got worried a lot more than I like to admit. He walks and slumps back to his chair. Ned says, well don't get too comfortable just yet. All this has shown that Charles is not invisible. If another Kuret block happens, he will be done. While that premonition sounded dreadful to Kafar, to those who want David to win felt like a hope to hang on. Marina dispels the hologram of Charles Infront of her. I just confirmed he has recovered all his Kuret. He is still loosing Kuret from David's attack. But, its not as fast it was like these few minutes.

We return to our seats as Charles continues to heal himself. Seeing the new progression of the match, Nathan pulls out a drink from the table beside him. He tries offering to Jess, but she denies a little nervousness. I stare at him puzzled. He shrugs when he sees me, what. This is getting interesting by the minute. Its not everyday you see a mythical house's Alpha fight, let alone seeing getting his ass handed to him and to be saved by luck in the last second.

Nathan adopted a little of Kafar's style and decided to enjoy the time now. At least, Nathan is not showing his displeasure openly unlike Kafar. I decided to leave Nathan to his devices. I agree a little bit with Nathan though. I couldn't believe a battle like this was happening. Both of them were showing incredible fight. Derek says, well this officially marks the longest match of the tournament. He enlarges the clock on the screen. The number goes past 30 minutes now.

Matt says, it sucks that David ran out of luck, but I gotta say. This is the most interesting fight of all the ones happened. I mean, if you ignore that blatant killing attempt by Charles. I had to agree with him on this. I still thought David should have called the match off that time, but we left it to him. So far David's barely managing to avoid fatal blows. But how long can he keep it up. Charles had healed and sprinting towards David. Meanwhile, David didn't move.

Marina says, hey. That black Kuret on his hands are gone. That’s bad right. She was right, David must have blown his Kuret out from that last attack. I got nervous seeing him doing nothing and just standing there. Vanessa asks, what is he doing. She was understandably panicking, so was I. Just before Charles strikes him David Kuret black flames covers his body and he runs away with his Kuret. I let out a sigh. David hasn't lost it then. He was just waiting to get his Kuret back. He wasn't using that new Kuret he was just using, but at least he was back to his original Kuret.

I am curious about what was up with his Kuret. Is he really trying to figure out some stuff in the middle of this fight. I chuckle a little at that thought, no one other than David would be so crazy to do this.

Vanessa (Chapter 17)

Wednesday, January 24, 2024 00:25

I thought the fight between David and Blake was insane, but this is another level. When Derek mentioned about it being becoming longer than my own match, it stung me. I know it was ridiculous to feel this way, but I was a little frustrating that David broke that record of me and Marina's match. I wanted something to go by with a mark or something in this tournament, even with the loss I was carrying. But now this match is the longest. I don't even how good my matchup with Charles would be if I was the on ground instead. Then I quickly remove those thoughts from my mind. There was no point now dwelling in the past.

Up in the screen, David had began zipping around the ground running away from Charles now. I don't blame his choice to keep a distance. David didn't know how close he was winning this match. Or maybe he did. But now he must be taking a beat and strategizing his next moves. Charles moves had regained his earlier power. He kept up the chase, but David was able to evade his every attacks. After few seconds, Charles switched up his moves. He punches the earth and takes off to the skies. As he floats in air, he brings those long tails of his and pushes them inside the ground.

What's this now, Cass voices her concern. David wary of this kept hid distance further away. Charles starts to chase him again, but this time he uses his claws to chip off a piece of ground and flung it towards David. David effortlessly dodges it, but then he gets cornered by a tail coming at him. He was getting smashed between another boulder hurled at him and a tail. He decided to jump off the air to avoid getting caught in between. Nathan says, woha, that was a close one. He then takes a sip of his drink.

I wanted to tell him off for his new rude behavior, how can he be so cavalier about this match. But I kept it to myself. I turned to focus on the fight. David wasn't out of the woods yet. Charles hurls another rock at him. I thought David would not be able to dodge this one, but he just managed to slip away. But now he was falling straight to Charles. What this now, Cass voices here concern now at David. David came crashing into Charles with his Kuret. David had wrapped himself with his Kuret in one of his dome. The clash made a loud bang, like a bell hitting the surface.

Booya, Marina claps at this. Her face glees with joy, that's got to hurt, even for Charles. I agreed. Charles couldn't defend against that. He was trying to stop with his arms, but the force and David's black Kuret had the upper hand here. He got another chunk full of Kuret sliced off him. David backs away after he looses his momentum. Charles tried to grab him, but with another wave of Kuret, David protects himself. I thought for sure we would run away, but instead he instead goes for a head-butt to Charles face. I was confused to see why he did that.

Then I saw the reason, the tails were coming up from behind David. Oh, that’s why. Incredible, David must be using his synesthesia at overtime. Blake says, That looked painful. That was one way to get away, I guess. I think everyone were thinking the same. David managed yet again to get away. Matt exciting says, guys check out at the poll. David's vote has shot up to 23%. Charles at 78% now. I couldn't help but smile a little at that. It was a small change, but it was enough to show that people are beginning to believe David can win.

Ned beside me didn't bother to check the stats. Instead he was deep in thought staring at the other screen with a blank expression. What is it, I ask. I nudged him a little to explain. He didn't turn face me nor did he reply to me. I wanted to prod even more, but I ignored it. I didn't want others to see us argue again. Whatever Ned's problem is with David, I will deal with it after the match is over. I diverted my attention back to the screen once David started moving again.

Charles and David went back again to their earlier cat and mouse chase for a bit. David was sliding around the ground avoiding getting caught by Charles or the rocks thrown at him. It looked like Charles had randomly thrown rocks and chasing his tails after David, but then it became clear it wasn't that simple. Once David stopped moving, he was pulled down into the ground. I hands tense up seeing David fall into what looked like a hole dug, wait what's going on, I ask. The others were also puzzled by this.

David managed to pull himself up with his Kuret before he got buried in the ground. Charles had covered the distance with David immobilized for few seconds. He threw a big boulder at the flying David, which he narrowly dodges. But then he couldn't dodge Charles frontal attack. They both clash, and David got flung back hard with a punch from Charles. I hear Cass's gasping at that sight. David was thrown in the air at quite some distance. My hand turned into a fist in desperation seeing him falling into the ground.

Fortunately, he used his Kuret to break his fall. I felt a little relief seeing David still moving. Nathan says, hot damn. I nearly chocked on my drink. Charles got him good this time. He gulps the liquid down his throat, that was quite a trick Charles concocted. Any guesses to how he dug that hole? I gave it a thought, and realized there is one way he could do that. Derek was the first to answer, using his tails to dug a hidden trap. I never thought Charles would do something like this.

Blake continuous on, a very simple but an effective trap. He pushed David to that trap by blocking his other escape routes. He then sighs with worry, I just hope David didn't got hurt too badly. I was worried about that too, David must be now collecting lot of wounds from all of Charles attacks. David started to move. I watched nervously hopping he didn't get hurt badly with that fall. He had got new bruises on his face, but he didn't stumble down or anything like that. So he is alright, that’s good.

Charles made another unexpected move and used the Kuritines on his tail to hurl it at David. They managed to almost pierce David, but he protected himself with his Kuret. Kafar says puzzled, that was a surprise. I thought I knew about all of Charles fighting behavior. He must be getting impatient. It was hard to know if he was being truthful or not, but there's no doubt that Charles was getting dangerous now. David throws his Kuret and runs away before Charles catches him. David has gotten a little slow reacting. Was it just my imagination ? Or is he getting tried more. Derek says, he must be wary about the hidden holes Charles has placed under the ground. No wonder he is a bit slow in reacting now. Derek picked up on what I was feeling too. I was right, David has become a little slower because of this, but that doesn't mean he isn't getting tiered from this prolonged battle.

I was becoming more worried about his wounds also. He doesn't heal like us. It would be really bad if has something like internal bleeding. I ask Marina, hey, is it possible to check David's condition like how did for Charles just now ? Marina shook her head with no delay, sorry. No can do. I tried it long time back when David and Jess fought, but as I expected it didn't work. There is no way to check up on him due his black Kuret, she takes a pause, at least not with Kuret.

What do you mean, Blake asks. You have a different way then. Marina was hesitant to say immediately. Blake waited for her to reply. After a moment she says, fine. Before the tournament started, David gave me this. Marina pulls up her sleave and shows a smartwatch on her wrist. I recognized it was the one David keeps it on himself. I guess, he gave it to Marina for safekeeping. Cass asks her, hey isn't that David's. Why do you have that. Marina replies, he asked me to keep it hidden. She then looks around us, ah, don't tell David that I told you guys. If he finds out, he might never trust me again. She makes an apologetic expression.

That stuck a nerve. Why didn't David gave it to me to keep it safe. Then a second later I was became uneasy realizing I was feeling such a ridiculous jealously at Marina. I shoved them down and ask her focusing on the immediate issue, does that mean you can check on David's condition. Marina pulls the sleave back on over the watch, yes and no, she replies. David didn't give me any controls. He just said that if he is seriously injured, his watch will alert me. Until then, I can't operate it. So if David has any serious injury, we will know.

Derek speaks, why didn't you tell us about this in any of the previous matches. She shrugs a little, He told me not to tell anyone. I guess he didn't want people to know where he hide it. I don't know if you know, but when you were back in Citradel a couple of weeks ago, David's stuff was ransacked. Some of his stuff was also stolen. So he was extra cautious and asked me to keep it hidden. Blake says, but you didn't. You just told us now. Marina rolls her eyes, yeah well, you made me tell you. And besides, it’s the end of the tournament. It shouldn't be a problem now.

Derek shook his head at her response, that is just cra-. He doesn't finish and chooses to ignore her for now. I understand David wanted someone trustworthy to keep it hidden. But why didn't he give it to Cass, Catherine, Blake or me. We have been together the longest with him. I didn't want the uneasy feeling coming up again, so I shoved them back in. I turned to Ned beside me. As soon as I saw him, he turned his gaze away from Marina and back to the screen. What was that reaction.

I didn't get to ask him. We returned back our focus to David who was now trying something new. Whenever he creates some distance from Charles, he would place his arms down the ground. What's he trying to do now. Whatever he was trying to do, Charles was not going to let him do for more than few seconds. But David was also not letting that stop, he kept doing it. After few times, I saw him switching gears and now he was punching the ground. I thought about what David was planning.

Blake snaps his fingers, brilliant. David is tracking the tails underground. He is cutting them off slowly. I turned to him, seriously. Blake nods, yeah. I don't know how exactly David is doing, but I can see the aura of the Kuret on the tails getting cut off in pieces. Derek chips in, that’s a good strategy. The tails must be a big hinderance to David now. And the way you say he is cutting the tails in pieces instead in one go means he figured it out that Charles feels pain whenever his Kuret body gets wounded. He then smirks a little and says in soft tone, impressive as ever. He noticed that subtle detail.

Kafar says, wait. What are you saying. How can he know where the tails are? He can't see or sense Kuret right. He looks around us demanding an explanation. I didn't believe it. Kafar didn't knew about David's synesthesia. David asked to keep us quite about it, but I thought Derek or Marina would have told Kafar about it. They actually kept their promise. After a moment of silence, Nathan says, does it matter how David is doing it, Kafar. How he is doing it doesn't change what is doing. He takes in another sip, I am curious to know though what David will do after when this is done. Are we finally going to see full on one-on-one confrontation now.

Nathan unexpectedly steered the conversation away from Kafar's question. I was glad to know Nathan didn't tell about David's synesthesia. Kafar wasn't going to let it go so easily, but he also knew knowing this won't change the battle happening right now. David was switching up his attacks now, he was now using his legs to kick his Kuret into ground. David was hopping all over the ground cutting off the hidden tails. This must be getting exhausting. I just hope he has enough stamina left after running so much.

The short round of tail chopping came to end. David stopped and let Charles chase him. He got ready to fight him now. He now covers his hand with his Kuret. But it was dense, like how he uses his Kuret dome. Blake says, he finally learned how to make that move of his smaller. That’s what he was doing for a while now. He was really learning it in the middle of the fight. That's just nuts. I had to agree with him. David's a genius no doubt, but this bordering ridiculousness. If it was anyone other than a mythical alpha, it would be more believable. But this is unbelievable. What's driving David so much to risk so much.

They both soon clash. David made the first move by attacking Charles, but it didn't look like it had any effect. Charles Kuritines broke near this throat, but he didn't back down. David goes for another punch, but Charles stops him with his massive claws. David then goes closer to him. Then atmosphere here heated up instantly as they began close quarter battle. David found an opportunity and landed his elbow straight into Charles face. The Kuret on his arm was the biggest seen. The much Kuret was now crushing his head.

Matt exclaims, hell yeah. That was awesome. He cheers seeing Charles struggling. I hoped Charles would go down now, but off course, it wasn't going to be so easy. Charles grabbed David's leg by his tail. David was pulled back and he was thrown into the air. I was terrified for a moment thinking Charles was going to smash David to the ground. David was thrown upside down. David should take step back, but he didn't. Instead he throws his Kuret and aims it towards Charles.

Jess says, look out, he is not done yet. David begins to fall back down, but he was flying towards Charles. Charles hadn't fully healed his head and had his back turned towards David. But that didn't stop Charles form attacking with two rock his tail threw. David dodges them in the nick of time. He positions his body to dive legs first. He covered his legs with his Kuret. Bang, Charles lets out a loud roar on the contact. Matt lets out a hooting sound

seeing Charles getting struck a second time in a row.

It was clear David had an upper hand and yet he didn't back down. Instead he crouches down to avoid falling down. David slipped away from Charles and come to a halt lying on the ground. That must be exhausting, I thought. Suddenly an electronic beeping sound flare in front of me. I saw Derek pulling out tablet he had set aside at the table. The noise was coming from that. Kafar leaned forward from his seat, what is it Derek. Derek didn't respond immediately. He was glued to the screen and scrolling the screen with his fingers.

After a few second he raises his head with out a surprised expression. He then doesn't say anything and instead raises the tablet for Kafar to read. Blake asks, what is it. Did something happen to Charles. Derek didn't face Blake, he was just staring at the monitor. He then says, Charles sensors indicate that he got a scratch. Kafar pulled away the tablet from Derek hand with a new nervous look I have never seen before. Matt asks, huh, that’s it. Dude, half of Charles back is gone. And you worried about a scratch?

Derek responds, you don't understand. He is bleeding a little from that scratch. Matt waited with expression saying so what. Derek continues, David managed to attack him on his actual body, not just his Kuret body. The real implication suddenly dawned on us. I was feeling a little bliss hearing that. David's relentless attacks finally did something. And based on Kafar's dismayed look it was even more important event. I ask, so what does this mean exactly for Charles.

Ned who wore a pained expression says, it means Charles can get hurt which he can't heal so easily. Is that it. He spoke so strangely like he was trying to be not be effected by his own words. Derek nods, yes. I told you earlier that Heraknus actual bodies are weak. When transformed, they still have that weakness to an extend. They can't heal themselves fast enough like their Kuret body. On top of that, their endurance takes a hit every time they have to heal their own body.

Cass asks without hiding her happiness, so what happens when Charles gets a wound much more severe than a scratch. Derek didn't respond to her. Maybe he didn't know what would happen. Blake asks to Kafar, you might want to consider what's going to happen if you lose your champion Kafar. The complete confidence you had that made us believe he was invincible is beginning to fall apart. Blake was trying to hide his chuckle as he said. Kafar remained expressionless for a moment.

Nathan spoke up, the real question is whether David can pull this off again. I am not saying he can't, but he only managed to make a small scratch after all his attacks. Don't believe its going to be so easy. He looks straight at Blake saying this, but I'll say this is now gotten a hell lot of interesting. Even when he was betting against David, Nathan must be feeling he made the wrong person to bet on. It didn't matter to me though. I know that if David didn't think he would have a chance of winning, he would have called it off already.

David behavior seems to be all over the place during the first phase of battle. And now its looks like David is slowly making a comeback, with a full gear in revenge. Marina's sharp voice pulls me out of my thoughts, what the hell is David doing? I gaze over to the screen. I think everyone watching this battle right now were completely bamboozled.

David (Chapter 18)

Wednesday, January 24, 2024 18:18

Charles was going to heal in few more seconds. I made sure the time I bought was used well by preparing to plan my next set of attacks. I took a long breath of air to clam my nerves down. This is going to be the most difficult part I tried till now. I raise my palms facing to my chest and turn it into a fist. I grit my teeth as I start to pull out my Kuret from the entire body. I wasn't trying for making a Kuret dome. I come a crucial realization that the Kuret dome I make is a forced form of the Kuret I learned. The small dome I create is highly unstable, but by making it go bigger, I reduce that instability as I push more Kuret out into the air. The dome becomes solid after a certain level of my Kuret filled in the air. While this works, I am continuously releasing large amounts of Kuret to offset the instability and that takes a toll on my body.

After having learned about the unlocked Kuret new form and a clue I just got, I don't need to make Kuret domes. I need to instead harness that instability with vibrations instead. What I want now is to make the Kuret flames to vibrate like how I do with the Kuret dome. It's insanely tough to make it vibrate from my entire body that didn't have a fixed shape. But this is the only way. After few seconds I realized its impossible to do it right now. I wasn't making any progress. I change my focus just on my arms then.

I kept the Kuret flames wrapped around my body as is while I begin vibrating the Kuret on my arms. This was much easier to control. The flames on my arms was slowly vibrating. I recalled the feeling when I extending my Kuret through the dome when I was attacking earlier. I pictured the same here, just without the dome. The Kuret on my arms were slowly grouping together, but then abruptly split apart. It was never going to be easy. I tried few more times. It kept ending the same way. I am missing something. Its like the answer was just at the tip of my tongue.

Charles was all healed up. He turns to me and wastes no time in attacking me again. The back that was damaged was now healed. Not only that, but he now had grown a lot more Kuritines around his body. He knows I can hurt him now. This must be his way of putting up a more robust defense. This meant I have to figure this out. I can't keep relying on pure luck and intuition alone. Charles was reducing the distance between us now.

An idea came to my mind as I saw Charles coming at me. I focused on moving my Kuret around my arms. I never tried moving the Kuret flames before, but I was able to do it earlier with the sparks. Maybe now I can do it in this form also. I willed my Kuret to move, and it starts to move ever so slowly. I didn't wait for it to move faster and willed the Kuret to vibrate immediately. Then something completely unexpected happened. The Kuret on my arms began to behave weird. The Kuret had grouped together like I had intended, but I didn't have much control over them. Those Kuret groups together were clashing with other Kuret going in different directions. What I achieved was having Kuret wrapped in arms that were running totally wild and colliding each other. What's more is that it when they struck, they created the Kuret spark I had learned earlier, but they would instantly become part of the flames.

I essentially made my arm covered with exploding Kuret with almost zero control. I had to keep my arms away from each other to reduce the blocked vision I had from Kuret bursting in front of me. This is was not at all how I expected to fight Charles. I got no choice now. Charles came crashing to me. He used two of his tails to attack first, clearly wary of my arms. I throw a Kuret line from my back preparing to back away. But the Kuret immediately breaks apart before I can move. Shit. It has to be a side effect of my uncontrolled Kuret.

The two Kuritines were aimed at my legs to impale me. I jumped up in response. Without my Kuret to raise me, I only got to hop only little in air. Charles already had the other tail ready. He aimed one at my chest. I didn't have way to evade it, so I use my right arm to shield from the incoming tail. My arm was still exploding Kuret sparks all over. I was worried for a moment the Kuret on my arm wasn't stronger. Much to my utter surprise, the Kuritine was disintegrating before it even hit me.

I wasn't throwing a Kuret wave nor was the sparks touching, but the Kuritine was destroyed before it reached me. By the time the tail touched me, the Kuritine was destroyed and Kuret from the rest of the tail was being stripped off. I felt only a little of the force of the tail. I fall back to the ground near the tails he was slowly retracting back and stagger a little to find my balance. What the hell just happened. I didn't have time think. Charles himself was now coming at me with his claws.

I defended myself again with both my arms in front. The claw comes slashing through the air and struck my exploding Kuret arm. Unlike the Kuritine earlier, the claws don't disintegrate, but they still began cracking before clashing. I was worried about the force it was coming with, but the Kuret in my arms were actually pushing me forward a little and creating a countering force to keep me grounded. I still felt a lot of pressure, however soon it began to fade. The more time I was in contact, the claws was breaking faster. The brown glimmer rushing in to heal Charles was not enough to keep up with my Kuret damage.

Charles pulled back his arm in hurry before I could damage him further. He then brings his other claws and attacks me from sideways. I was able to see it coming and pulled my left arm vertically sideways to block it. The claws miss my head few inches. The claws began breaking the same way again. After 3 continuous times, I was sure this wasn't pure luck. My Kuret is doing something I never seen before. I need to get away for a and take moment to figure this out. Charles kept his barrage of slashes going few times more.

Each time I was able to defend myself. The first reason was the enormous force of those claws was cut down considerably when I break them and second was my arms was pushing me. Its like the time I was able to make myself push with I had the Kuret sparks covering me. So this must be close to it. Maybe an uncontrollable version of that. I didn't have enough time to think more when I kept defending myself. Charles slashes were overwhelming, I was on alert every second to see the glimmers of his Kuret and predict his next attack. After a while, Charles changes his attacks. He pulls both his arms back sideway and prepares a dual claw attack coming from the side.

This won't be good. I shift my legs to brace for the for a more powerful force. Both the claws strike at the same time coming from opposite direction. As expected he had more power on this. I got pushed back after getting hit. The glimmers of the tail was coming from my the side. He was trying to catch me by my waist. No, not happening. I didn't know if had the bare minimum power, but I didn't have a choice. I take my right arm and will it to push my ahead towards Charles.

The tug I felt from the arm made me panic a little. I was pushed forward with a sudden impulse that was nothing I felt earlier. My body pivots forward and my fist lands on Charles lower right chest. My Kuret began moving even more faster. That made more eruptions of Kuret spark. Charles roars as my Kuret ran wild on my fist. The Kuritines on him broke easily, then I was stripping off his Kuret underneath. Charles stumbles a little back after my hit. He was shaken, but still didn't back down.

I was able to make a gap between him and me. The tail was around my waist almost tightening up. The flames around my body must have at least slowed it down. I used my free left arm to push me sideways. I felt the same powerful tug as I was dragged away from Charles. My head leans to the other side from the sudden acceleration. My left arm was pushing with such force my legs starts to dangle a little in the air. The tail that wrapped me by the waist tighten up. But my Kuret flames and the force with which I was pulled away caused the tail snap behind me. The tail piece wrapped around me was instantly disappeared in thin air. The push of my arm went longer too, I forced it to stop when I got some distance away from Charles.

I land on the grass and struggle a little to get a grip on my footing. Holy shit. I saw brown glimmers pouring in on the chest wound I just did. I also the streaks of blue glimmers around his chest. He definitely felt that. This is insane. I open my eyes and gaze over my arms. Even after using so much Kuret, they were still running wild. The Kuret flames around me was still covering me. Whoa. I unlocked something astounding. I took note of few things immediately when I saw my Kuret up close.

I was unconsciously blowing Kuret waves with the Kuret moving on my arms. That’s why it broke the Kuritines on Charles tails before it even touched me. Same with the claws. But the claws were stronger, so they only cracked. Secondly, I also had formed a dome under the rotating and erupting Kuret sparks. I was more confused than excited right now. When did I do that. I explicitly made sure not to create one. And the third, the Kuret covering on the arms were exactly same as the ones I formed on my fingers from a while ago. In fact, with more Kuret formed, it was considerably stronger than before. This is unbelievable.

I realized something about the Kuret sparks. The one I used earlier was not the true form I needed. Like everything, they were just one part of the whole solution. That’s why I couldn't pull out more Kuret covering with those sparks. I was essentially using left overs of this unattained Kuret form back then. I was right to believe that I needed to build up Kuret from the start. I have basically clubbed all my Kuret techniques into one single form. But this made it that much hard to control it.

Charles healed up and came at him. Charles didn't attack with his tails this time. He was coming himself. His tails were swaying in the air behind him. One of the tails has shortened considerably. I recalled that the tail he tried to grab me with earlier cut off so easily, like it was nothing. That means I no longer have to bother with those tails anymore. I felt a rush of adrenaline swelling up in me. While this is not at all how I pictured my Kuret would behave, but the power up I got went beyond my expectations.

Charles is charging with a head-butt. He had grown a thicker Kuritine on the top of his head. He is getting impatient. I was prepared for this. I wanted to test out this new combined Kurets strength. I raise my left arm towards Charles will it push forward. This time, I braced myself for the sudden speed I got pushed. I may not be able to throw Kuret lines anymore, but looks like I don't need it anymore. This is much powerful and quicker to move around now. I prepared my right fist to make a blow.

Just as we were about to struck, I stop my left arms push and instead focus on pushing my arm as I twist and land a punch aimed at his head. I aimed the punch to land sideways to avoid a straight on collision. With the movement of my arm and the Kurets force I made, it made me twist around in the air as I follow the path of my hand. Out Kurets impact causes a bang that vibrated around us through the air. I felt the shockwave it created on my skin and the glimmers around the air gets filled with broken Kuretines coming off Charles body.

No matter how I attacked, Charles was clearly stronger. I was immediately thrown sideways from the impact. Even with my right arm still pushing ahead, the strength I faced was much greater. I struggle as I tried to keep my feet on the ground as I get slid backwards. I kept my right arm Kuret going pushing me forward to stop me from blown away. I felt the shock of that impact on my entire body. If wasn't having this Kuret infused arm, it would have been shattered.

Charles wasn't fairing good either. I didn't strike him down, but he was stumbling sideways trying to regain balance with his limbs. I opened one eye to check out my surrounding. Charles head had seen better days. I had completely destroyed the Kuritines on his head and cracked few on his neck. His Kuret body had also cracked a little near his jaw and around his side. There was a large chunk of Kuret missing as well. I see large amounts of blue glimmers flowing around his head. I even saw a small amount of red glimmer coming off. I felt a little happy now. Nice start. I got him to bleed again. I need to keep this up. Once I stop to a halt, I take a moment to gather myself.

I saw Charles tails coming at me. I decided I can ignore them completely now as I ran straight into them. The Kuritines pointed at me began to crack as I approach with my arms guarding me. By the time I was crossing them, the tails had lost the Kurets and holes were appearing on them. Charles made them pull back in a hurry. I smiled as I saw orange glimmers around him. It was such a great burden off my shoulder not to deal with these tails again. Of course, if he makes them more thicker with Kuret, I still would have to deal with them. But I doubt Charles would risk wasting more Kuret like that.

I reach Charles just as he completed healing his head. He made the first move with digging both his claws into the ground and hurling two big boulders at me. I bring my right arm and make my Kuret push me away. I dodge the first rock. The second followed next, I raised my other arm's Kuret and dodge in the other direction. I brought a jab to Charles throat, Charles lower his mouth to guard it and chomped down on my arm instead. That was

unexpected. The Kuritine teeth tried to bite into my skin. But the Kuret dome on my skin held strong.

I felt the pressure of having my hand stuck in between stones. It stung a lot. But at least I didn't have any holes in my hand. Charles wasn't letting my hand go. Even with so much my Kuret blasting on his face, he kept my arm pinned. Charles brought his claws trying to strike me. I use my one free wrist and made the Kuret to push it against the incoming attack with force. His claws clashes with my arm blocking my body. I somehow held my ground. We were in a deadlock. But he still had a free arm. I tried to break away from his mouth before he uses it.

Charles wasn't making it easy. I was panicking now. He raised his other arm in the air and preparing to slash me from my defenseless side. He moved his other claws to cut me up. Shit. I yelled out loud and willed to push the Kuret on my right arm, not forward, but backward. This was now stronger than Charles bite and I freed my hand. I immediately brought to defend myself from the incoming claws. The claws struck me and I was thrown sideways. I didn't had the time to put force on my Kuret and got pushed back.

I felt pricking pains on my arm. I grit my teeth in pain. Charles pulled away his other arm and was thrown away to his side. I fall down straight into the ground on my shoulders. My arms swayed away from me and get rolled above my head. The impact made my body shiver with a sharp pain. I saw Charles glimmer around me not giving me any second to get away. He raised his leg up in the air and begins to stomp on me. I made a ditch effort and willed the Kuret on my arm to push me the hell out of here. A sudden force pushed me backwards in hurry. I barely managed to get way just has his leg hits the ground. That impact shacked the area and I slid away on the grass.

I made it in the nick of time. I turn my eyes up and check up on Charles. His arms has thinned. His mouth, what remained, was crumbling away. His Kuritines breaking apart and falling in pieces. He is going to heal his arms and mouth first. At least that’s what I thought, but then Charles turns to me and takes off to the skies. While I was sliding on the grass, collecting debris on me, Charles was leaping into the air at my direction. Charles shadow quickly approaches me from above. Damn it. I was racking my brain for a new plan. I saw something at the corner of my eye. I was near a grassy area where the grasses had sunken a little. I was at the edge of the hidden hole Charles had dug up earlier.

An idea come to me. As I was sliding on the grass, I made my hands into fist and hammered a quick blow, infused with Kuret, to the ground. The ground starts to crack quickly and the ground tore up. I was pulled inside it. I stopped the Kuret on my arms to push and started rolling inside the ground. Above my Charles came down expecting to crush me. But due to the hole he himself had dug earlier, he misses me as the target and instead stomps on the rocks falling of the side. The dirt and rocks gets obliterated under his feet. I was avoided the same fate by some quick thinking. A huge sound filled the air along with a small cloud of dust around us.

Because of Charles forced entry to the hole, the ground shook, rumbling and spreading the hole bigger. I began crawling and pushing the debris off me before Charles gets me. The dirt stick on my face and I blew dust off my mouth. I tasted some dirt on my mouth also. I need to hurry up. Charles had sunken into the ground a little due to the fall. He was slashing off the rocks restricting him. Now's the chance. I raise both my arms in the air and pray I can do it.

I focus on pulling me out of his hole with the Kuret. I felt relief when the Kuret listened to me and raised me above the ground. I flew straight up in the air with my arms leading me. Charles saw me leaving and tried to grab hold of me with his arms. I mustered every strength I had and raised my legs above me to my knees. His claws just grazes me slightly. I was now hover up in the air. I came to a halt and then I pulled my arms down to the front. I blew another Kuret push and went backwards.

I need to put some real distance now. I was literally flying in the air horizontally in the air for a moment. A ridiculous thought came into my mind. Maybe I can now fly. I shoved that silly thought aside for now. I will the Kuret to stop and fall back to the ground. I didn't have the time to brace the fall properly so I fall on my back. I took deep breathes after a complete stop. The situation is becoming more precarious by the minute. I saw Charles shoving the rocks aside and pulling himself out of the hole.

His Kuret had began healing his Kuret body wounds. I wanted to take more time to rest up, but now's not the time. I slowly got up inspecting for any wounds. I was some new glimmers of red coming off me. I received a new cut from my ribs on the side. It wasn't big, but I could feel it probably cracked my rib bone a little. It was slowing hurting now, however the pain isn't too much. I can't let myself get hurst like that again. A new small bruise was now on my thighs and calves. I also got nicked from the rocks when I was falling down on my back.

I stumble a little getting up. I can't get more hurt. Any more than this and I will severely reduce my mobility. The Kuret was still good on my arms, though the Kuret sparks were still going off around me. I got some understanding of this power now. I noted something peculiar. While I had bruises over my body, my arms were protected. I still felt a bit of pain from the pressure, but it was just on my skin. Even after that barrage of slashes and Charles bite, I wasn't hurt badly on my arms. Compared to my other limbs, it was almost nothing.

That means I need to cover myself entirely with this Kuret form. That’s the only way to get stronger, faster and studier. If it worked, I would be able to handle more of Charles blows. I began focusing on a daunting task.

David (Chapter 19)

Saturday, January 27, 2024 22:02

Charles took a little to get out of the hole. The problem was his landing, plus the weight had caused him to get buried a little in the weakened soil. His movements is also causing rocks and debris to fall on him from the sides. It's a little funny that he got trapped in his own trap. I thought of pulling out my trump card now. Then I decided against it. This was not going to stop him not even for a minute. I need at least two full minute to prepare for that. Anything less than that, it wouldn't work.

So I decided to stick with the current plan. Which was an hurdle of its own. Once I took a beat for a moment, I got up and got into the work. Moving the Kuret on my whole body was not working. The Kuret flames didn't listen to me. I was hopping to let my instincts guide me, but it wasn't happening. I needed to think it through. I have few seconds before Charles comes back up. In a search of a solution, I come up with an idea. Just like I just focused on my arms, I should focus on turning my Kuret on specific areas. Once that happens, I take some time to get adapted with the addition. And then move on the next. This is the slowest, but the most efficient way to build up my strength.

It was no brainer to pick the Kuret on my legs first. Not only will it help with my mobility, but I another way to attack that works on Charles Kuret body. I focused the Kuret on my legs till around the lower thigh to move. My intuition was right. I was able to move the Kuret on my legs. However, it was way to slow and hard to vibrate. So I choose to only do first my right leg. With less mental arduous task, I was able to move the Kuret and vibrate faster. A moment later the Kuret wild went. Just like earlier, almost instantly my Kuret fused together and began causing the sparks. Charles crawled out of the hole and started running at me.

I took a small breath of relief it was working. I now have 3 limbs with strong Kuret covering. But the struggle to take this form made me realize this isn't going to be a simple way of addition. With body part covered with the new Kuret form, the more time and energy it will take for me to work on the next. So covering my left leg is going to take more time. While the situation is still not optimal, it was gradually becoming better. I can work with what I have. Charles catch me off guard this time with his disregard of Kuret body. He also didn't wait for his healing to finish before attacking. He is switching up his fighting style. Meaning I have to throw away whatever I have learned about him up till now and be ready of anything unexpected.

I stayed my ground waiting for him. He was running on his legs this time. He was a bit slow due to this, because he was carrying two big boulders on each hand. They were much bigger than his usual ones. I waited for him to throw at me, but he kept running. If he was trying to restrict my movement, it would be best to throw it from a distance. He wasn't doing that. I was right on the money about him changing his usual tactics. I scanned for anything suspicious around him. But nothing looked concerning. His tails was still the same as last time I saw. The Kuritines on his body also had the same amount of glimmer. The next second he would be on me. I pulled my arms ahead in front of me, bracing for whatever is going to happen. In the off chance that Charles had a simple plan to just crush me with the boulders, I would just pull away behind.

Just half a second before he brought those boulders in front of me, I caught small gimmers of brown of glimmers coming off the rock. But inside the rock. It was so thin that I was able to notice only after coming near. I immediately ascertained what he was trying to do. I decided not to dodge this, instead I brought my arms to defend against one the boulders he thrusted forward. The force was overwhelming, I was able to counteract with a the force my Kuret.

The clash caused debris to fall of the boulder. I kept pushing the boulder back. If I was correct, I need to destroy the Kuret he was growing inside. I kept an eye for the other boulder also while pushing the boulder. With neither of us backing down, we kept this contest of endurance. It went for few seconds. The burst of energy I had pushed with my Kuret was quickly sapping away. I can't keep going anymore. The glimmers coming from inside this boulder was nearly done. I took a risk and made my new Kuret on the leg to force a kick into the boulder.

I felt my foot stuck into the piece of earth and small shivers went up till my hip. Thankfully, with the new Kuret protection, none of the fingers are broken. I hope. The kick was severely lacking in power, but I only needed to created a small gap between the boulder and his arm. And it worked, with the contact broken, the rest of Kuret remaining that Charles was flowing inside the rock became undone. I took this time to position my left arm away from us. I wanted to destroy the other Kuret inside the other rock before I back away, but the glimmers on the inside was strong now. I couldn't destroy it just with the Kuret waves anymore. So decided it wasn't worth the risk and my Kuret whisked me away and began creating some distance.

I halt at a distance. Charles lets go off the rock he tried to crush me with and carried the other one. A moment later, Charles out a roar. With his free hand, he stuck the boulder and it starts to crack slowly. Pieces of debris falls of his arm and the structure inside is revealed. When I saw what Charles was trying to cook inside the boulder, I was right to destroy the Kuret inside instead of running away. I only wish I had enough Kuret to destroy both of them.

Charles had grown a Kuritine structure on his arm. From his wrist up, he had created an intricate Kuritine that spread like a dears horns. It grew in random directions and there were numerous endings. It was big and thick, shining off the sunlight from it. Charles arm now had dozens of claws instead of that one set on his hand. I noticed earlier that he was using the holes and small paths in boulder to create this. Like it was a cocoon. He first poured very little amount of Kuritine inside. Then, once Kuritine turned and twisted following the gaps inside the entire rock, he poured in an enormous amount of Kuret. Doing this led him to create this, which has extended his reach. Not to forget that it was more dangerous now.

If that wasn't enough, I saw glimmers of Kuret being put into it continuously. Every passing moment, the Kuritines was becoming condensed. Incredible. For a moment, I was mesmerized by the aesthetics of the Kuretines he created. Then I was a little relieved that I stopped Charles from making this on his other arm. I bet he was thinking I would be running away instead of blocking that. Charles begins to run at me. I assumed that the added Kuretines weight on his harm would slow him down, but he was still running on his usual speed. Maybe even a little faster, no doubt due to the zeal he must be feeling to use that new weapon.

I choose to observe for a while I remain defensive. Charles charges while raising his Kuretine horn arm in air. I dodge away as he struck on the ground beside me. The force of his normal claws was already overwhelming, but now it was a hundred times more destructive. The sheer force caused causes a strong vibration on my feet. Charles basically rip the ground apart into pieces. There was now even disenable wind pressure flowing out from the collision. The wind made my hair sway away in the air.

What the hell. No matter how strong my Kuret was now, I won't be able to stop that. Even as Charles had struck the ground he was pouring Kuret into his horns. Just how much is he going to make it strong. I want to attack him while he Kuretine horn is now on the ground. I twisted my hip and aimed my leg to his chest. He brings he wrist to defend. I force the Kuret on my leg to push it with force. I struck him on the hard Kuritines on his arm. Even with the force I was throwing at him at this position, it wasn't enough. He was able to force me back once I started loose power on my kick.

As I pull my leg away, I brought fist to his head this time. Charles ducks his head sideways to avoid. That surprised me. I bring my other fist from underneath to the chest, but he blocks me again with this large arm. I tried a couple more punches and kicks. Charles had never avoided my attacks before, but he is avoiding some of my blows. After a few more tries, Charles begins to use pull other arm from the ground. I had no intention to fight that Kuretine horns right now. I decided to back for now. I used my arms to pull back. Charles wasn't going to let me go easy though.

He wasn't just pulling his arm out, he was pulling the ground also. Shit. Realizing his attack, I brought my arms to guard my face in anticipation. He hurls a large amount of small thin pieces of rocks at me. The projectiles was small in size, so they flew faster. I felt many hitting my arms as I was pushing myself back. Few hit on my abdomen. A large on just grazed me on my waist, tearing my skin and leaving being a small line of blood. I bit my lip to push the pain.

I managed to avoid more injuries and fall back after gaining some distance. I began to breath more erratically now. Not good. Even if can predict what's coming, there's no point if I am not fast enough to react. I understood Charles thoughts now. I have delt some powerful blows on him now. So he is actively trying to avoid getting hit. He also wants to attack with something I can't break easily, unlike the claws or Kuritines on his body. While it’s great that he is starting to feel pressure from me now, its become more troublesome to deal with him now.

Charles was charging at me with his Kuritine horn raised again. Since he is now opting a little bit of defensive approach, he will not let me destroy that Kuritine horns easily. I hoped when we had the short bout, the Kuret waves I was throwing would at least crack the Kuritines. But it never happened. Charles was continuously pouring with Kuret inside them. Even when my Kuret is not hurting him, he still pushes Kuret inside. He is definitely not stingy with Kuret anymore.

If I wait till I finally learn to cover my entire body with the new Kuret, it would be too late. I need to use my remaining stamina more efficiently. At the moment, there is only thing way to destroy that Kuretine horn. I need to stay engaging in combat near him. With enough time, even his Kuret wouldn't be able to handle it. It will be very tough to continuously be in combat for long time with him. There was no other choice too. I could use the Kuret dome. I would be able to destroy the Kuritine horn. But it would be drain me even faster. In a battle of endurance, that would be disastrous for me.

Charles this time lunges is the air as he reaches me. I avoid it ducking down and slip away to my side. Charles lands on the other side as the horns slashes the air. I felt another small breeze of air on me. Those slashes are no joke. Charles lands on his legs and turns to face me. He brings his other arms claws at me. I brought my wrist to defend. I manage to put enough force to keep me going. He is about to slash me with his horns. I use the Kuret on my leg to pull me away.

I used the kick to thrust me up a little into the air and I avoid the horns as I hover above. I aim for a punch on his face. Charles used his normal claws to block it. With my free arm I try another punch. Charles avoids again by ducking down his head. I was waiting for this. Using the Kuret on my leg that was raising me, I pushed it once more. Using the arm facing downward, I will my Kuret to pull me down. With a clockwise motion of the Kuret on my leg and on my arm, I do a summersault in the air and aim my leg on his head. I have never tried a coordinated attack like this, I kept hoping it was just enough to connect.

With no thing to defend in the path, the tip of my foot struck the side of his head. The two force I was making my Kuret push, created a strong kick. The moment I kicked his jaw, it broke the Kuritines immediately. The clash produced large amount of blue glimmers form his mouth. In repones, Charles was going to slash me from the below with his horns. I rushed in with in mind to take the hit by guarding myself with my arms. But I really wanted to avoid it completely. Those Kuretine were not still cracking.

I was falling with my face down and arms up. With desperation I willed the Kuret to push back the incoming assault as much as possible. The slash came from the side. We both collide and I could feel the incredible power behind it. As I was in the air, I was being pushed to the side. The incredible amount of force was making me shake. I was trying to push my Kuret as mush as possible, but it was futile. Charles was clearly superior in terms of raw power.

I didn't want to get blown away. Not again. With a bust of rush filled with anger, I shout out demanding more Kuret out of my arms. The Kuret on my arms suddenly begin to expand. It was hard to comprehend what I was doing right now. The Kuret on my arms were running faster than ever as it starts to expand. I was pulling out more Kuret from my body now. The arms on my arm were beginning to take shape. It was thinning outward and spreading a little out from my body. I don't know what I am doing on instinct. Whatever it was, there was more Kuret for me use now.

I couldn't push the horn back right away, so instead I use the Kuret Infront of me and angle it slightly to deflect the horns. The Kuritines slip out from the side and stumble falling into the ground face first. I twisted my arms that was still pushing, bend it pointing up the air, and pull me up so I land straight. I crash on the ground with my knees to break my fall and slid across the grass. I was aware behind me Charles didn't wait to heal his face. He uses

his other claws from up and aimed to rip my head off.

The Kuret on my arms had begin to shrunk as I was absorbing it back inside. I had no other choice though. I bring my both my arms up and make a cross with them to defend the incoming attack. I braced for the crushing blow I was receiving. He had me pinned me into the ground now. I was surely breaking the claws on his hand, yet he kept the me pinned down with the rest of his Kuret arm. I knew what he was trying to do. I panicked as he raised his other arm up and preparing to bring down the Kuretine horns on me again. With the angle I was being held in, he was going to swing his arm and slash me from down.

My body was shaking and not just because of the arms he was making me pinned with. I need to do protect myself. This won't be pretty if he gets me. Forget about the Kuret on my leg. I focused on the Kuret on my chest. With a desperate cry for urgency, I willed the Kuret flames around my torso to move and vibrate. With so much happening I don't know if it was working. I saw the glimmers of the Kuretines coming at me. It stuck me square in chest. I had unconsciously held my breadth as it collided.

I thought I was done for sure. But miraculously, I was still alive. I am blocking the Kuretine horns on the path. I hesitantly look down, thinking he had buried his Kuritine on my chest. But where the flames were originally flowing out of me, was now replaced with Kuret dome on my skin. Immediately, another Kuret layer forms outside and they began colliding against each other. Holy shit. I barely managed it. I thought I was done with just covering the new Kuret on my chest, but then I started to feel something odd.

It was like the new Kuret on my chest was trying to pull in the other flames running on me. As if the originating Kuret now was spreading out. I want to investigate this new feeling, but the unfathomed amount of force I was feeling started to become even stronger. Charles was pouring even more glimmer into his Kuritine horns. I wasn't able to block him anymore. He pulls his arm that was pinning me and pushed me back. The Kuritine horns had began to crack a little. Unfortunately it wasn't enough to break it completely. With another rush of strength, Charles pushed me back and was thrown back.

His slash cause me to skid backwards and I get dragged away on the ground. I brace myself as I feel pulling out the grass and unearthing the surface of the ground. I should have felt a lot of pain, but the Kuret running on my back was protecting me. I slowly came to a halt after a while. I nervously started to move. I was sure I had broken few, if not, all my bones. After checking for injuries, shockingly, I made it without any broken bones. My hands tremble a little as began to get up.

It wasn't just my hands, my legs were still shaking. That attack caused a mini earthquake on my body. I had also collected new set of bruises on my leg. But it was dumb luck that I got away with just this, even if some dripped few drops of blood. I couldn't fully shake of the attack, so instead I fall back and sat on my ass for a moment. I needed to bring my breathing under control. I was sweating too much also on my forehead. I wanted to wipe them off, so I intensively bring my fingers head to wipe them.

I jerked back in reflex realizing that exploding Kuret sparks would hurt me. But nothing happened. I don't know why, but I was irrationally fearing that my own Kuret would hurt me. When I checked nothing happened, I continued and wiped the sweat off before it drips into my eyes. I had a lot thoughts to unpack, but I first focused on Charles. I wanted to see his next move, but he didn't come at me directly. There was a blue glimmers coming off his hand. I also glint of red coming of his deformed hand. Because he kept me down for long, his arms was in worst shape I ever seen. His entire hand is gone!

There was a open Kuret wound at the end of his wrist. He was had his elbow in the air and began healing it. Whoa, that’s got to hurt. Even if didn't see the red glimmers of blood, it was clear that I did some serious damage. I doubt I hurt his actual hand since he Kuret arms are too long. But my Kuret must have been powerful enough to give him scratches on his real hand. I hoped that the Kuret horn would have broken, but I only managed to create some superficial cracks on them. The cracks were disappearing slowly.

The jaw that I broke was half healed already. I saw red glimmers from there also. So that kick was worth the risk. I bought a lot of time now. Even Charles can't ignore the hand and attack me. They way he is healing, I maybe bought enough time before the next round. I didn't waste a single moment and inspect my body. The Kuret on my chest was running rampant. But what caught my attention was that the small distance still having Kuret flames on the shoulder. The Kuret on my arms and chest were trying to connect to each other.

That’s the odd feeling I was getting. I focused on my Kuret around my shoulders. I was breathing from my mouth, so I focused on that. My body was trying to do something. I tried to feel what my Kuret was doing. It was like I was reaching for something just within my reach. As soon I try to reach it, it slips away. After few more seconds, I shut both my eyes to focus even further. I am very close. I have nearly understood it. My deep thoughts began forming an image. I visualize the flames to change. Not to put them out, but instead make it stronger by grouping it.

I suddenly a rush of blood flowing into my face. The next moment, I open my eyes. I understand a little bit what I need my Kuret to do. I let my instincts go forward, it was like removing something I was restricting. The Kuret on my whole body rush out. This is it. The Kuret on my chest began spreading all around my body. First my shoulders form a dome, then it crawls up to my neck. The new Kuret was spreading everywhere. To my lower back, then to my remaining leg.

In the next few seconds, even my head was covered with the new Kuret. Holy shit. I am covered from head to toe with the mini erupting sparks. I waved my arms around to get a feel for it. I wanted to get back on my feet. Then I thought to test out and use this new energizing feeling. I forced the Kuret on my back to push me up. The force I was thrown up was nothing I ever felt. I even tried to use as less force I could. And yet I was thrown up in air few feet above.

I straighten out my legs and plant my feet on ground. This is insane. Is this really my own Kuret. This power is a whole new level. I tried to think on why I wasn't able to do this a while back. What was the difference. Then I recalled that I pulled out an excess of Kuret from my arms when I was shielding myself. That desperate attempt must have done something. I think that shook me out of whatever was blocking me. The new Kuret I turned on my chest not only protected me, it spread across my whole body.

There were still many mysteries about this. Like how I am able to do something I couldn't even imagine doing just an hour back. What's up with my Kuret. What unexpected stuff will it be doing next. I pushed all those thoughts down. I was in a middle of the match right now. I have no time to dissect and understand my Kuret. I just have to go along with this for now. Especially now that I had reached to what I had envisioned ever since I learned my new Kuret form. I can now keep continuing this fight for a little longer.

Charles wasn't fully healed. He was about halfway done with the palm. I wasn't going to wait anymore. I am now suddenly bursting with rush of excitement. Now's the time to get the upper hand. I bring my breathing under control and began sprinting. I hadn't fully recovered enough of the shock on my body of the last clash, but I choose to power through. To make a point, I thought to close the distance faster. I willed the Kuret on my entire body to push me ahead.

On hindsight, I should not have done that. My entire body went beyond my control and I got dragged across the ground. I am almost flying to Charles. The speed I was flung forward was a little terrifying. What’s even more surprising was that I am enjoy this.

David (Chapter 20)

Sunday, January 28, 2024 13:57

I bet Charles was more surprised by this than me. I am closing the distance between us quickly. But I was also loosing the momentum I started with. I wanted to attack with full force. I willed to put a stop on my Kuret push. Even without my Kuret acting on it, I wasn't slowing down fast enough. I decided to put reverse force and pull backwards on my Kuret. I felt another power tug and came an abrupt stop. The sudden deceleration makes me stagger when my feet touch the ground.

I clearly don't have fine control over this new Kuret. I have to make sure not to over do it. While this new power up is a new advantage, if I have lose control, it could become a disadvantage instead. Once I gained my balance I focused on making my Kuret push only my legs. Like the last time I tried on the Kuret on my leg, I was having a hard time coordinating my running. I can't even call this running, I was almost jumping and leaping as I put one feet in front of another.

In a moment I was near striking range of Charles. He is hand was almost healed. His Kuret fingers were growing. I needed to use this opportunity where he doesn't have the claws on his hand yet. His mouth was healed. He even created more number of Kuritines on his jaws now. He covered his entire jaw with an extra layer of Kuretine that now showed sharp edges near the entrance of his mouth. He now has a more ferocious jaw strength. I made the first move this time and bring a Kuret infused punch to his lower abdomen.

Charles prepared to block me with his Kuretine horn, slashing for the side. Both are attacks connect and throw vibrations in the air. The momentum my Kuret created was just enough to match up with his power. It lasted only for a moment, I began to loose the power on my fist. I pull back and prepare for a kick to his chest. Charles extends his arm to the side once I let go of my hand. He uses the Kuritine horns again for a block by brining his arm back inside in opposite direction. Another clash occurs, forcing both of us to another standstill.

I pull back with a short tug on my Kuret on the back side of my body. Charles leans back a little and prepares to land a kick on me. Instead of defending the kick, I open both my hands and catch his leg from the side before his face could stomp on my face. I had made the Kuret on just my hand to push towards each other, immobilizing the leg I caught between. The Kuritines on his skin began crumbling into dust. Charles lets out a growl as I began to tore out chunks of Kuret out of his leg. Charles tried to pull his leg back, but I had already forced another Kuret push from the front and canceled his strength.

With his leg caught, he brings out the horns to slash me from the side. I didn't want to get hit by that just yet. I let of my hands, I decided to at least get a hit on his leg. I turned my right hand into a fist. With a short burst of force, I push the Kuret downwards and struck into his knees from the up. Charles roars when my fist connects. The Kuritine protecting his knees was blown away instantly on contact. I let go of his legs. He begins to stumble a little, now that he lost balance, his Kuritine horn misses me and it slashes in the open air. Charles gets pulled back a little to regain his balance.

I also pull back a little in order to prepare for my next attack. Charles didn't wait to heal the would, which was radiating blue and small red glimmers. I willed my Kuret to push me up in the air angled to his head. When I get airborne, I pull out my left arm and aim to punch his chest. Charles brings his not healed hand to block. He puts a stop my fist with his wrist. I saw him bringing his Kuritine horns from the side to attack me. I use a Kuret forced kick to his arm and push it away before it reaches me.

I twist my body sideways and force Kuret to push me even higher. As I fly above, I raise my knee of the other leg and force it forward. My body tilts sideways due to the poorly coordinated attack, but at least my knees struck his jaws right in the middle. Charles tried to dodge it, but grabbed the back of his head with arm. I interlocked his head inside my arm. I have essentially wrapped myself around his neck. My attack begins to break his protective Kuretine on his jaw. Charles mouth was getting smushed in.

Charles grabs me other leg with his arm and tries to pull me away. I wasn’t going to let him do that. With my open arm, I will the Kuret from the entire arm to push me backwards. This created an angle with which he begins to lean backwards. Despite the power I was exerting, he wasn't falling down. Seeing that I at least his upper body bent backward to a degree, I made the Kuret on my entire body to pull me down. The sudden overwhelming strength was too much. Even for Charles. I successfully made him lose his balance and we began to fall backwards on his back.

Charles growls silently under my knees trying to get free. His grip on my leg also becomes undone. Which loud thumping sound, he falls on the ground. Just before he hit the ground, I made my Kuret on my body to pull me up. Charles groans since for the first time, I made him fall down on his ass. Blue glimmers came running from his face. Orange ones from his entire body. A little streak of new red glimmer was now flowing from his jaws and neck. I floated in the air above him for a second. The weight of his body causes the dust and dirt to get blown away.

I reversed the direction and forced my Kuret to push down. I get pulled to earth with the full weight of my body. I gather my hand into a fist and push out my elbow in front of me. Charles didn't have time to block this. I struck my elbow straight near his jugular. The Kuretines couldn't put up a decent defense and I chocked him on the base of his neck. The contact is sending shivers down on my whole body. Charles body jerks up in response. I grit my teeth hard, keeping up the pressure. Charles blue glimmers was flowing out hard now.

Charles gets his bearing a second later and lunches his Kuritine horns on me. I put my other hand and block it with the back of my wrist. The force was little much for me right now. I couldn't keep Charles on this choke hold. The Kuritine horns made me push away from him. I get blown away a little distance and slid across the grass. My breathing was out of control now. I has heaving once I came to a stop. I decided to lie for a little while. I grown as I force my shoulders up and make me rest on my back.

That was intense. While I was feeling excited that I finally made the mighty being fall on his ass, I expended way too much energy. The glimmers on Charles was becoming intense. I saw a substantial amount of red glimmers around his neck now. He was also lying down like me for a moment. His Kuret is already healing his mouth and neck. My attack on his upper body also caused Kuritines on rest of the body to crumble away. I saw few broken portions of his Kuritine horns.

Nice. By keeping up the close combat, I was beginning to damage those Kuretines now. I bet the Kuret waves around me is even more powerful. But this had caused my whole body feeling like it has been pummeled. I slowly got up before I let the exhaustion take all over me. I plant my foot on the ground and crouch a little forward. I rest on hands on my knees to support my posture. My chest rose up and down hard. My heart beats was filling up the glimmer around my body. My body was aching a bit now. Since I still lacked complete control over my Kuret, I was taxing my body lot.

I gaze upon Charles. His Kuret was healing his body. He doesn't stand right away. Instead, while supporting on one knee, he raises his arm with the Kuritine horns up in the air. He is up to something again. Charles the uses his other arm to struck his other wrist that was fused with the horns. The Kuritine horns break apart on the contact. The Kuretines fall on the ground like a flower shedding his leaf. Charles freed hand begins healing.

I started at him while he starts to break the Kuretines under his fist. I could only be shocked at this. He continuous to break down the Kuritines. I noticed he wasn't completely destroying it, instead he was only breaking at the joints where they diverged. I began to realize what he was trying to do. I thought to attack him now before he finishes this plan of his. But I was still exhausted. I needed time to recover every bit of stamina I could for what's coming next.

After breaking the large Kuritines into smaller pieces. He then grabs one of them. Using the Kuretine like a knife, he jabs himself on the other arm. This wasn't what I expected exactly him doing. Charles glimmer showed he felt little bit of pain. Once he removes his hand from the Kuritine, it begins to heal with Kuret. The Kuretine stuck out his skin like a large thorn. He then takes another piece and sticks it on his leg this time. So that’s his plan. He knows now that those regular Kuritines on his body stand no chance against me anymore. So with the Kuret he made on his hand, he is going to plant it everywhere on his body.

Charles begins to continue this in various places on his body. He plans to hit me with that strong Kuritine now. It would have been manageable for me to destroy it if they were just Kuretines. But once he plants it on his body, Charles pours Kuret inside them. That means the toughness will remain unchanged. He was placing the Kuretine on various places over his body. On his arms, hands, legs and chest. He then brings his tails forward. Till now I had ignored the tails completely, but he sticks the Kuritine on the ends. He then pour large amounts of Kuret on the tails making this thicker.

Dammit. I knew that if made those tails stronger, I could no longer ignore them anymore. Especially now with a deadly Kuritines at the end. I really wanted to stop him from distributing the Kuretine on his body, but I needed to recover a little. While this had become a little more dangerous, it wasn't something new. Charles is becoming more and more wary of me. He too like me is adapting to the situation and preparing in consideration. After about half a minute, Charles got up. He was now sporting with shinny new Kuritines on his Kuret body. He had a set placed on the knees, feet, elbows and shoulders. On his hand, instead of growing claws, he kept his hands a fist and stuck larger sized Kuretines on his wrist. They were protruding from his hand like a knife on top of his knuckles.

He also placed a bunch of them on his chest, definitely to protect his real body inside there. Behind him, the four tails were wagging in the air, showcasing a new Kuritine spears. Charles preparation was complete. This will be now even tougher. With those Kuritines, I can't just attack on him recklessly. Not unless I want to get skewered first. Thankfully, I was able to clam down with the time he spent preparing. But I was no where in peak condition. I was dangerously running low on endurance.

My plan hasn't changed since the beginning. I need to deal a blow powerful enough that it would take him least a minute to heal. Maybe two. I can then use my ace. Once I do that, I won't have to put too much strain on my body. So I will use all my remaining energy I have let and aim to deliver crushing blows. Now that I have achieved this Kuret form. I just maybe able to do it. Charles roars and then sprints towards me. I take a final deep breath and calm my nerves.

Charles reaches near me. He starts by jabbing with the Kuritine on his arm. I choose to dodge the incoming attack by stepping to the side. With those Kuritines covering his body, I need to wait for the correct opportunity to hit back. Charles uses his tails from under his legs to attack me. I force my Kuret to push me back before it reaches. Next, he tries to kick me. I block the kick with both hands while making my Kuret push me up in the air. Charles prepares for another jab to my head. I dodge to my right in the air. His tails try to attack me from the side, before they struck me, I thrust myself to the ground in haste.

I crouch down on the ground as his tails flew above me. He tries for a round kick aimed at my chest. While supporting my arm on the ground, I propel up in the air again. The kick hits the ground uprooting the grass and dirt. I decided to first analyze his attack patterns. We spend few more blows like this. While I wasn't making any headways with continuously dodging, I was able to slowly understand his new way of attacking. Whenever he attacks, he is only using the parts of this body that have that Kuritine. Which made sense, he went to long lengths to get it.

His attacks have become aggressive too. Since he has now disregarding his priority for healing, he isn't shying away from risky attacks that exposes his unprotected body. I should be able to exploit this. Charles goes for a elbow attack on my shoulder, I shove aside to avoid it. His tails tried to grab my legs. I jump into the air to avoid them. Charles goes to jab me from both his fist. I pull my arms in front of me and thrust backwards as his Kuritine connects. I narrowly saved getting shoved by him.

We kept going like this for long time now. Charles was slowly getting impatient. Yes, that’s good. I want him to make a mistake. I been tempering this long, wasting a lot energy just dodging because I need make every attack count from now on. Every time Charles think he is close to nabbing , skewering or stomping me, I evade them. Even when attacking would have been much more ideal. All this to land a single but powerful attack. After I dodge a kick from him, he tried to plunder me with both his fist Kuritines.

I saw an opportunity with this. Instead of backing away, I come closer to him. I stop myself just few inches in front of me. His arms flew past me and he thrusts those Kuretines into the ground. I stand now underneath his body, him facing me down. I raise my right fist and aim for his unprotected lower chest. I took a half a second to recall the feeling I had when I was cutting Charles tails and then recently when I formed the shield to protect with my new Kuret.

I twist my hip to provide my upper body with power and thrust my arm straight into his abdomen. The moment I came my fist connected to his Kuret body, I yelled out a little to push out Kuret from my fist. My Kuret comes out from my punch and digs into his Kuret body. The punch causes ripples of brown Kuret glimmers waves originating from under my fist. I grit my teeth hard to keep going. Charles lets out a loud roar above me. I didn't let it waver me. With another short yell, I will the Kuret on my arm to thrust once more.

More Kuret flows out of my fist into his body. A burst of blue glimmers comes out of Charles body. Charles roar was deafening. As he got desperate, he tried to push me away with his tails. But I wasn't done yet. I force my entire body to thrust forward now. The impulsive power of my Kuret caused Charles to stagger. It was so great that I felt shivers back on my entire body. And it was just enough to shove Charles backwards. His tails tried swirling on my foot, but the thrust caused him to lose balance his tails get swayed away.

I was loosing power slowly. One last time. I grunted aloud when I thrusted my Kuret ahead. The Kuret blown into his body suddenly tore out from the other side of his back. The glimmers of red flow in front of my eyes, covering my vision. I decided to back away for now. Charles was yelling loudly. I pushed myself back in haste. Even with such a painful blow, Charles had the gall to try jabbing me. I was a bit slow in reacting and he managed to struck me in my face.

I was panicking like hell. I bring my other fist from below and thrust into his arms before he could penetrate my Kuret. My fist blow away his arm upwards, but the damage was done. I could feel that the Kuretine had managed to pierce me. My face instantly throbs in fire. Shit. I went backwards to make distance. Once I came to halt, I crouch down on one arm. I head bowed down in pain. That was too close. My face was on fire. I saw glimmers of a new red line coming from the side of my temple to the cheek.

Holy shit. One more inch to the left, and he would have cut my ears off. The Kuret dome on my face remained intact. That Kuritine was so tough that even with such a protection, he managed to cut my skin. The only good thing is that the cut I got was not too deep. The blood drips from my head to the side of my neck. It could have been much worse. Speaking of worse, I think Charles was facing a much difficult time. He was down on both his knees and had one arm hugging the wound I had given. The fist he attacked me in the last second had a broken Kuretine on it. Ah, I didn't notice I was able to break it while I was running back.

What was even terrifying was seeing drops of blood coming out of the hole I made. The glimmers of red coming out from there confirmed that it was actually blood. Charles expression under the Kuritine was definitely a pained one. I think this was the first serious wound he suffered. His Kuret healing was not fast enough to cover the gaping hole I created. He must be healing his real body first. I was glad that my Kuret flowed out from my fist was powerful. I didn't expect I would be able to fully skewer it from inside, but then again the Kuret in the form is much more stronger than the ones I was using earlier.

I made the right decision to dodge all of Charles attacks for the right moment to attack. I had bought a little time with Charles healing. I could try to stall for time and let him heal. But no. I need to do it once again. Just once. Then I will use my final attack. My whole body was now aching more now. I think I would only last for few more minutes now. The only way I can win is now if I wound his legs seriously.

Ignoring the soreness of my body and began sprinting at him. I need to pull out even more power. I recalled the moment when I hit him. The Kuret on my hand had temporarily increased in speed. It even caused more Kuret sparks. I could feel that there was a moment when my Kuret vibrated so fast that it looked like it was completely still. It was terrifyingly calm and condensed. Compared to then, the Kuret on my body were still running wild in random directions. I got an idea about controlling these rampant directions.

I have managed to pull out this strong Kuret, but I think its still not complete yet. The Kuret sparks I am causing is a clear reason, since its was unnecessary and superfluous. So if the first step was combining all the Kuret techniques I have learnt, the second step must be to control it even further. I realize that I have to try this out while I fight Charles. All the major steps I have made were in the heat of the battle. I will just have to trust my instincts for now.

I jumped into air when I came close to Charles and made myself propel in air continuously until I was hovering above his height. He hasn't healed completely, so couldn't move out of the drop kick I aimed at his chest. Charles uses his free arm and blocks my leg. I keep pushing forward. This is the final stretch. Victory is now within my grasp.

David (Chapter 21)

Sunday, January 28, 2024 22:16

Charles choose to ignore healing and decided to give his attention to me instead. That’s exactly what I thought he would do. Two tails comes from below to impale me. I let go of my leg and push to the side dodging them. The tails flew up past me. I used this movement to land a punch on his head. He brings his other fist to block me. He still had the Kuritine on this fist. I concentrated to pull out more Kuret from my arm. Still reeling from the zone, I was able to pour out more Kuret of my arm. I will it to shape it into a sheet instead of wrapping my arm. I had done this instinctively last time, but I was able to consciously do it this time.

This feeling is eerily familiar to how I use my Kuret dome. A thin Kuret shield in the shape of my arm form around it. Just in the nick of time, I saved my arm from getting pierced. The clash causes shockwaves of wind and sound in the air. My Kuret was able to block the Kuritine on his hand. Since I worked on creating the shield, I didn't have time to propel with Kuret. I was pushed thrown back into the air from the pressure. The shield on my arm had gone. I felt shivers on my arm. On the good side, the Kuritine on his hand cracked and broke in half.

I didn't waste this opportunity and decided to attack immediately. While still in air, I propel forward. I raise my fist and aim his face. Charles bring both his arms to defend. He fell for it. Gravity was pulling me down and I pushed myself further down. My fist instead connected to the ribs where the Kuritine was not placed. I focused on pouring my Kuret out at the impact. Charles growls and staggers behind. I had hoped my attack went deep, but all I saw was blue glimmers.

It was too shallow. Dammit. Well it did took three continuous thrusts last time. Charles regains his balance and brings both of his fists down on my back. I twist my body and push myself away. I wasn't fast enough. One of the fist caught me in my lower back. I was pushed down to the ground. Just before the impact, I slowed my fall with a burst of Kuret push. I land on the ground face first. Charles thrusts his foot towards me. In a desperate attempt, I push my entire body above and I was yet again propelled into air. His kick misses me by few inches.

While I hover in air, one of his tail attack my from the side. I wasn't fast enough, I used my arms to protect myself. The Kuretine on the tails is not stronger like the others, so I wasn't pierced through. I made Kuret on my body push me backwards. I get thrown backwards. I tilt my body a little and fall back on my legs. Whoa, I was airborne for quite sometime. Fatigue is catching up to me now. My movements was sluggish and I am now reacting less quickly now. I tried to control my breathing. I know I have become impatient attacking him. But I have no choice, I need to stop him while I still have gas in the tank.

Charles wasn't itching to attack me right away. After that brief struggle, he resumed healing his wound. I have to risk letting him heal now. I had something new in my mind to try. When I formed the shield earlier, my Kuret became still again. I think that’s the trick to get to stabilize my Kuret. I focused on pushing out Kuret from my entire body. There was too much resistance by my body. But I didn't let it stop me. I focused on putting more effort into throwing Kuret out of my body.

A few seconds later, it happened. The Kuret flows outwards in all direction. Meanwhile, the Kuret on my body move and began vibrating faster. I felt a rush of adrenaline kicking in as I keep pouring out more Kuret. My control was loosing, but the desperation kept me going. I pictured what I wanted my Kuret to do. I wanted to cover my body in Kuret that I had used earlier on my fingers. That has to be the actual form my Kuret must be trying to become. But this time it will be without the Kuret sparks. Kuret would just cover my body while keeping this new form intact.

It was too hard trying to make my Kuret do this. I am missing something. I racked my mind trying to find the answer. Maybe I can't do it yet. Then it means I should focus on somewhere midway completion. I don't have to cover my entire body. I can just cover only essential places in need to protect and move it around like I did earlier. With this idea, I focused on covering certain areas. I felt my Kuret obeying me this time. Kuret around me in the air began swirling and rotating. The Kuret outside spins around me, creating a small gust of wind.

I was anxious about this a bit, but continued on. The Kuret picks up pace and it was blowing the dust off the ground. I kept rotating the Kuret around me. Slowly, the Kuret begins to shrink and it begins to fall back on me. It was vibrating fast, then it began to stabilize. Steadily, the Kuret starts to cover my body. This time it was covered in rings. Kuret formed round groups of rings that wrapped around my arms, legs and stomach. Kuret rings appeared over my forehead like a head band. Another two of them wrapped around my face in a cross shape, covering my eyes, ran through my nose, checks and then my neck.

This was not I expected it would appear, but the energy I felt from the Kuret was calm but powerful. I could feel that the Kuret was still vibrating, its just that it was so minute and fast, it couldn't be seen anymore with naked eye. So that’s why it looked like it was still. Another thing I noticed, the Kuret was still moving in circles on my skin. But it was just running the surface of my skin, there was an outer layer of Kuret that was completely stable. The Kuret was just as denser than the form I had just now, I could just tell this was much more stronger now because it was more stable.

More rings covered my body. A few seconds later, the all Kuret around me turned to mini armor. There a slow humming noise coming from my Kuret. The Kuret sparks were no longer happening. The Kuret that grouped together were not crashing into one another anymore. There were few places where my skin was exposed now. Around my upper back, ankles, shoulders and other places that usually don't come in contact during a fight. I managed to protect my joints at the very least. Even with exposed parts of my body, I could feel I am generating a more power now.

Charles was almost done healing. I used up all the time I bought earlier. But it was worth it. I decided to test this out first. I wanted to try something and also confirm if I can fight in this form that showed new openings to my skin. There was a boulder lying near by me. I walked there, letting my body get adjusted to his yet another Kuret form. I turn my hand into a fist. Immediately, the Kuret rings on my hand come together and join together to form a fully covered first. It was definitely like the time I learned about vibrating my Kuret.

I raised my arm back a little. I was a little nervous and anxious to see what would happens next. The Kuret on my hand bursts out and shaped into a dagger. I was imagining it in my mind, but I had no idea that it would actually work. The Kuret formed into a small dagger around my fist. It was just like when I use my Kuret dome. I then willed the Kuret from my arm to thrust forward. My Kuret listened and I threw a jab aimed at the boulder. The force I felt created a backlash of wind flowing backwards.
☐The moment my fist connected, my fist went through inside the surface blasting the surface apart. The debris gets thrown off and I gouged out a large position of the top of the boulder. Holy s
and they turn back into rings on my hand. Incredible power. I am now getting burst of excitement. I looked at my hand, there wasn't a scratch. I didn't feel much pain when I punched. This is insane. My Kuret now can effect physical matter now without taking too much of my energy. Not just that, I can use powerful attacks without feeling the rebound of the shock.

I turn to face Charles again. He was done healing completely. But I can see the faint red glimmers still coming from the wound. I even when I am not attacking right now, there is orange glimmers around him. He may have healed his Kuret body, but that blow did serious damage to him. With both his Kuretines broken on the wrists, he falls on all fours and charges at me. I was ready for him. I wish I could have fought him in this form from the beginning. I would have the enough energy to spare to defeat him. Sadly, I can't do that. I can feel that transforming this Kuret pushed me to my absolute limit.

In fact, I was sure I can keep this up for only two minutes max. If I don't stop him in this time, I will lose. I am sure M would now be showing my vitals to Marina by now. After so much struggle, I wasn't going to stop. So now I am just leaving that decision to others to stop me if the time comes. Charles was opening his attack this time with his tails. All the four tails were positioned forward to strike fast. I decided its time to cut those tails off completely. With a plan of attack, I sprinted towards him.

I waited until he was very close to me, then I willed my Kuret to thrust forward. I heard a whooshing sound when I blasted off the ground. My face felt the air on my face, draining the blood from my face. What the shit. I flew so fast that I hardly had time to notice I crossed the tails. The tails tried to attack me, but I left them in dust as I flew past them. This is way stronger the power I just had. Charles brought one of his arm up and tries to throw his claws at me. I wasn't even using my legs, so I had no way to use them to dodge. So instead, I used my Kuret to push down and slide across the grass. Charles claws reach me as I was sliding underneath him. With my wrist, I created a small shield of Kuret. The claws struck and broke immediately. I didn't even feel much of his power in that attack. Did he get weaker. No, the answers obvious. This form is crazy strong.

I safely slide between his legs and exit from his shadow. I urge my Kuret to reverse direction and push me up. My Kuret immediately stops my movement. The abrupt halt caused a little pain on my legs. Shit. I have no experience of a power like this. I need to be more careful. I stagger on my feet and turn back to face Charles. I took off the ground and made my Kuret to thrust me into the air. A powerful tug plucked me into the sky. At this point, I am basically at mercy of my Kuret. Its like I am controlling my own body movements with Kuret.

I was thrown in air so high that it felt I was actually flying. Charles wasn't going to stop this from attacking. He dug his claws into the ground and dug out boulders. He throws one at me as I hover in air. I could I have easily dodged it, but then I had a different idea. As the large rock flies at me, I raise my arms in front of me. I pull out Kuret from my arms and make them strengthen my hands. Layers of Kuret wrap on top of each other. I am wearing think gloves made of Kuret. I brace to catch the boulder in my arms.

The boulder hit me straight and the force of the impact knocks me back. But then I push forward to stop, then rotate myself along with the boulder to counteract the remaining force. Using the force of the swing I made from my Kuret, I throw the rock back to the direction it came. I can't believe it worked. I didn’t do it properly, the rock didn't have enough speed. Charles was able break the rock into pieces with his fist. Well, this was my first try. My fall was beginning. Charles was preparing to another boulder at me. With one open eye, I look for a safe place to land. A spot with grass caught my attention. Yes, this will work. I had initially jumped this high to locate this with a birds-eye view to begin with. The boulder catching stuff was just to throw Charles off a little.

I decided to change the direction of my fall and aim at a distance further away from Charles. From the glimmer coming behind me, I didn't even had to look to evade the boulder thrown at me. With a reverse thrust of power, I break my fall and land on my feet. Charles was running straight at me unfazed. Did he not know about it. Or he does know and just didn't care about it. His tails had wrapped more boulders to be thrown. I turn to face him and began running. I choose to run on my legs for the time being.

When we got close, he throws one boulder with a tail. In response, I wrap my arm with more Kuret and swat the rock away with my wrist. I was waiting to see if Charles would leap into air, but he didn't. He hadn't noticed it then. That’s great. I turn my fist with Kuret into a long spear and struck the ground just few meters away. The ground cracks on impact and begins to sink. Charles was way not fast enough to avoid the crumbling ground, he was slipping inside. I propelled forward into the air, avoiding sinking inside. Charles tried to jump outside, but he was not quick to react and I was already on him. I twist my body and lean forward. Using the Kuret on my leg, I made a sweeping attack in the air and hit both his arms.

Charles couldn't dodge this with his size and especially when he is slipping. Charles arms gets pushed inside with my attacked. The Kuretines on his body didn't even put enough resistance to defend me. Blue glimmers flow out of the impact. With a Kuret push from the rest of my body, I thrust sideways avoiding his falling body. Once clear, I thrust again forward to his back. The tails had been struck to the ground behind him to support him from falling down. Of course, his weight was too much for his tail to handle. He would have to make the tails more stronger like he did during the start of the match.

While I flew to his back, I transformed the Kuret on side of my palm into a thin sharp edge, like a knife. I hoped this Kuret was sharp enough to cut all the tails in go. With one swift motion of my hand, I slash at the base of the tails on his back. I felt the tails giving resistance, but I had enough force to pierce them all. Charles below me roars in pain as the tails starts to disappear. Without them, he falls harder into the pit inside. I came crashing to the edge of the pit on the grass. Fortunately, the Kuret armor protected the side I hit and reduced the pain.

Charles continued to growl as he was caught inside his own trap. While this was going as planned, I could feel my Kuret control loosening. I am tiering too quickly than predicted. I have only a couple of seconds before I get tapped out. I was breathing too hard. I had to ignore the aching body also. This is it. Without standing up, I make my Kuret thrusts me inside to Charles who fell face first inside. The hole on the ground had began slow down it's

shaking. Charles was trying to get up, but just like last time, he was caught with some boulders on him. The tail I cut didn't grow, instead Charles just the healed the open would. He won't be regrowing his tail then.

I raise my arms and turn both my Kuret fist into pointy edges. I aim to cut his legs so that he can't get up. Charles should have not been able to dodge this, but he forcibility turned his body to his side. I missed his leg and jab my fist into the ground instead. He then tries to kick me, my only one arm to defend, I was pushed backwards. I hit the rocks behind me. I made the Kuret behind me to gather together and protect me. Charles using one arm supporting the ground, tries to get up.

No you don't, I thought. I thrust forward again and aim for the arm that is supporting him. Charles brings his other arm to defend me. His claws come slashing from the side, I swatted it away with my fist. Just when I was about to cut the arm, he thrusts his jaws in front. Using his tough Kuritine teeth, he bites me in the shoulder. He had planted some of the few hard Kuritine on his jaws. I managed to cover my entire upper body with Kuret anticipating this. But his bite didn't waver. I saw his brown glimmer flowing continuously into his jaws strengthening him.

With the fist I initially planned to hit his arm, I used it to hit him in the face. At the impact I wrap more Kuret on my fist to increase the damage. The Kuretines on his face and head disintegrates completely. His head gets pushed aside from the force, but he still managed to keep his jaws locked on me. I decided to push myself back. The force pulls me behind and Charles couldn't keep me pinned anymore. I thought to attack again to his arm. Then Charles roars, the brief struggle gave him the time to use both his arms and he was now on his knees trying to get up.

No, if he gets out of this hole, I will not be able to another chance to restrict his movement again like this. With my entire body, I let myself thrust straight into Charles large body. I tilt a little sideways and aim for a shoulder crush. I was aware of those hard Kuritine on his body, but I couldn't care about them anymore. Charles didn't have full balance as he blocked me with his arms. And yet due to his size, I wasn't able to push him back. My mouth that was open for breathing, begins to take in more air with the push I was making.

We were in a deadlock for few seconds. This is not good. I wanted to do another thrust, but it isn't going to change much. I have no choice but to back away. But the moment I do, he will get up and crawl out of this pit. In desperation, an idea came to me. A very dangerous one. I didn't have time to second guess. I let go of the push. Instead, I made a complete reverse push with full force. Charles didn't get a chance to grab me. My relentless attacks had stripped off a lot of his Kuret body.

I then angled to be pushed up. I was reverse flying straight up in the air. I didn't know how much speed I needed, so I kept pushing myself higher. Charles on the ground slowly shrinks in height. I have no clue how high was going. I could vaguely see of the arena's seating area edge at the end beside me. Wow, I was close enough to the edge of barrier then. I didn't stop here, this is most likely my last attack. I was pushing my body with each push. I am trying something very dangerous. I have never went this high without any equipment. So many things can go wrong if this doesn't work properly.

Above me, I could finally glimmer of the barrier. At last, I could tell exactly how high I was. 0.85 miles above the surface. Holy crap. I could see the entire arena from here. With I final push above, I reach and hit the barrier on my back. Seeing the unbelievably height, I shut my eyes before I panic even more than I am right now. My body was trembling with a mix of anxiety. When my decent begins, my nervous dial shoots up. No turning back. As I fall, I position my body to point downwards.

I maintain the angle of body with my Kuret pushing sideways. It was tricky getting the proper angle as I fall. I barely managed to my body still as I fell face down. I place my arms behind me to the side. When the time comes, I will pull it forward. I willed the Kuret to cover my entire body to reduce the drag as much as possible. The speed picks up terrifyingly fast. Even with my Kuret covering me, I could feel the wind pressure begins to increase. Without the Kuret on my skin, I would have been just swaying uncontrollably in the air. I saw Charles glimmer becoming closer. He had crawled out of the pit.

Meanwhile my fall was frightening fast. I didn't have M with me, so I couldn't tell if had reached terminal velocity of gravity. I needed to time this perfectly, otherwise, I can't stop myself at this height and speed if I miss. Once the ground was becoming closer. I decided to do it now. I willed the entire Kuret on my body to push me down. The sudden acceleration knocked the wind out of me. I small cry came out of my mouth. Crap. This is madness. I have jumped from height before. But this is the first time doing with a parachute or flying gear. I have nothing but just my Kuret.

On the ground Charles was glimmer was becoming closer. I was close to the ground now. I yelled once more when I thrusted once again downwards. The acceleration kicked the speed a notch again. Charles decided to avoid this. He went on all fours and begins running. My hands tremble hard in fear now. Knowing what I had to and actually doing it is completely separate. I pull my arms above my head. The drag was making it difficult. With a small burst of Kuret, I push them forward.

Now comes the hard part. I began to push myself from the side. I sudden thrust pushes me to the side, but I remained vertical. Shit. Please work, dammit. I kept thrusting the side with every ounce of energy I had. Just as I was too close to the ground, my decant begins to curve. Hell yeah, I was now slowly curving down. My body strained under the never experienced pressure. I angled my Kuret to push me forward and became horizontal a moment later. At last. I was flying at top speed parallel to ground.

I made sure to angle my decent in the direction of Charles. Charles and I were going to collide into each other if don't change our path. I was ninety nine percent sure Charles wasn't going to evade this. Not because he thought he could stop me, but he knows that he isn't fast enough to dodge with the speed I have. Charles kept going forward. I was right. He wasn't going to back down now. Neither was I. As I flew at him, I kept speeding up with my Kuret. This is it. We became close to our inevitable clash.

Charles leaped to the air and raised both his arms to throw a punch instead of his usual claws. It didn't matter what he does, I am have to crush whatever he throws at me. I formed large Kuret around my arms. I tried to make the edge as sharp I could. With a final bust of Kuret push, we collide. The collision shook my entire body. It created a huge sound that made my ears ringing. The shockwave created blasted an wind that flowed out from all direction. The pressure I felt was maddening. If it weren't for the Kuret protection, I definitely would have broken my bones.

For few seconds, our clash is canceling out each others power. Then I could feel Charles getting weaker. Blood rose to my face and with another push I yelled out another Kuret thrust. Charles couldn't stop me anymore. His arms gets slapped away. I thrust the Kuret on my arms into his chest. Red glimmers comes off the point of impact. I pressed on with my assault. With no ground to support him, he was thrown backwards in the air. Due to his large size, he wasn't going fast.

My own speed had dwindled down considerably. But I had enough momentum to push Charles back. The ringing in my ears continued drowning Charles roars flowing in the air. I was sure this was enough to bring Charles down, but was managing to keep himself balanced. Dammit, he never gives up. Charles foot starts to drag on the ground. Even with everything going on, he is trying to stop me. I was now furious. How much longer will this go. I was at my limit. Anger swelled my entire thoughts.

I am not going to let this end like this. I let of Charles and began a reverse thrust to decelerate my speed. A weaker tug pulled me away from Charles. I was now clearly loosing power. A had few seconds now. Charles was still getting dragged across the field. I used the anger I felt to power through a set of continuous thrust towards Charles. Even with my ears blocked, I heard the wind blown away at my sudden speed. I kept propelling forward towards Charles.

With a loud yell, I take my fist and aim to his face. Charles tried bringing his arms to his face to defend himself. I wasn't going to let him do that. His arms was mangled from the assault, so just as I reach him I twist my hip and push his arms away with my other hand. The Kuret on my hand forced his arms away. Continuing the motion, I land my fist straight into his jaws. The impact vibrated my arm. A sharp pain rose from my fingers. Charles couldn't dodge this. He was thrown back hard.

As continues getting dragged, he begins to fell backwards now. Not enough, I thought. I pushed myself back a little and prepared for a reverse kick to his neck. The Kuret force was considerably less now. But it didn't stop me. My heel kicks into this throat and he gets push down further. He can't stop his fall now. Before he falls completely, I push downwards behind his back where he is going to fall. I was completely controlling my body like a puppet with my Kuret now. I skid across the grass and raise my arms above.

I don't know if had enough left in the tank. But I have to do this. I force my Kuret on my fist to turn into spears. I couldn't feel if the turned or not. Charles body on top of me. I was going to get crushed under his weight. As soon as his back connects, I yell and push my Kuret further. My Kuret tore inside his body and in one thrust it pierced him. I wasn't focusing on Charles glimmers to see I was making any damage or not. I was too anger to care at the moment if my Kuret cut his real body.

His body starts to tumble on me. I pushed myself out of the way before I get pinned beneath him. I can feel my Kuret dwindling on my body. Just one more. I force myself to push ahead, my feet gets dragged on the ground. I kept my Kuret spears in my fists. I joined my two hands together and fused the Kuret spears. I was now holding a Kuret shaped sword. I raise my arms and yell as I sung hard on his knees. I see the hard Kuritine there getting crushed and my Kuret slashed into his Kuret body.

Just then Charles brought he other knee from the side and kicks me to my stomach. Dammit. I was too focused that I didn't ignored his glimmer coming. My arms sway apart and the Kuret sword becomes undone. My Kuret on my body was disappearing slowly. The knee kick knocked the wind out of me. In a moment of desperation, I willed the Kuret on my chest to turn into spikes. The spikes tore into the knee breaking the Kuretine. But that’s all I could do and was thrown away from blow.

I was getting dragged back across the ground. My head hurt, my entire body was paining. All the soreness I was ignoring came rushing in all together. All my anger and frustration was slowly turning to nauseous and drowsiness. Oh no. I was going to lose consciousness. I can't let this happen. With what little Kuret remained on me, I will it to push me back further away from Charles as much as possible. I was slowly losing sense of time and feeling. I don't even know what happened to Charles. Did I do enough to take him out.

I vaguely sensed that I came to halt. A few second later my mind went blank from the exhaustion.

Blake (Chapter 22)

Monday, January 29, 2024 22:32

David has been surprising everyone with completely unexpected moves many times in this match. But this one was the biggest. His arms were covered with his black Kuret, on top of that thin Kuret strands were coming off him. I tried to see into him using my aura, but nothing came. Whatever he did, it was still his own power. Cassandra exclaims, whoa. I have never seen this before. I was thinking the same. Maybe this is what he was trying to do at the end of our match. But I felt this wasn't it. Its like he trying to figure out his own powers in the middle of all this.

Everyone here were hooked to the screen. None could dare speak and interrupt the confrontation happening between. They began fighting once they both were ready. Charles made the first move, attacking with this tails. David was able to evade them easily. It looked like the Kuritines on the end were breaking before it hit David. I am in awe seeing Charles continued a barrage of claw attacks and David deftly blocked each time. Their battle had taken a big turn now. David had been on the defensive for a lot of time, but he is actively on the offensive now.

Charles kept throwing boulders, punches, kicks and even once tried to bite David. To counter, David jumped, dodged and even blocked few of his attacks without backing down. Near the end of this relentless attacks, David skid across the grass trying to get away from Charles who was coming at him from above. Just when I thought David was cornered, he punches the ground and it splits apart. Both he and Charles fell into the pit. Matt says, huh, wait. Is that another hole Charles dug earlier. Did David get caught.

It may have looked like that, but David flew away before Charles could grab him. Meanwhile, Charles is struggling to get out of the pit. I said, no. It wasn't Charles trap this time. Its David. Nathan begins laughing, quite the devils luck he has. Using his opponents own trap to use against them. He takes in a sip as he gulps down the drink in his glass. Vanessa retorts, you really think that was luck. David must somehow know where all the traps are hidden. Nathan just shrugs at her saying, yeah, whatever you say. Vanessa looked like she was going to rebuke Nathan on his flippant behavior.

Tess cuts in the conversation, do you think Charles even knows where all the traps he made. He used his tails to create them, so shouldn't he be aware of them. Why did he get caught himself. Tess made a valid point. I looked at Derek. He shook his head, maybe not. I am not sure. Charles is clever sometimes, but he isn't smart. David's a certified genius, so it isn't a surprise he can outperform Charles in some aspects. I totally agreed with Derek on this. David's slowly taking control of the situation. Kafar is siting silently with the tablet on his hand. I was sure he would jump at the chance to rebuke Derek and praise his Champion. But he didn't even open his mouth. He must be still worried to see David give a wound to Charles.

While Charles digs himself out, David was preparing himself with covering one of his leg with this Kuret form. Marina asks, is something wrong with David. Why doesn't he cover himself completely with this wild Kuret. I take a moment to think before response, I think because he is figuring this out for the first time. After a pause I continue, I don't think this what he has been hiding the whole tournament. If it was, he wouldn't be struggling so much. A nagging suspicion came to me. Is it possible that David… no. He isn't there yet. At least I don't think so. The whole step need for that is messed up. I push that ridiculous thought for now. Marina says, okay. But that's crazy, he shouldn't try something like this right now. I nodded with her, yeah. David's is behaving a little strange, no doubt.

Out conversion came to stop when Charles comes out of the pit carrying two boulders on him. I heard Matt saying, oh hear we go again. I bet everyone thought Charles would throw them. We were thrown a back little when he didn't and even more shocked when David didn't evade his assault. Instead, David rushed into one the boulder and tries to push it away from Charles. Cass speaks, what's going on now. Somethings weird. She wasn't wrong. David didn't attack the second boulder, or rather couldn't. He created some distance between them. Charles shocks everyone when he breaks the boulder on his arm himself.

What the hell is that, I exclaim. Charles had was fused to a Kuritine structure that looked so similar to an Earth dears horns. There were intricate and spanned dozens of sharp edges. They looked different than his usual Kuret. Derek who was shocked speaks up, This is getting dangerous. Charles must be feeling cornered to use this. Vanessa asks, you have seen this before. He nods, not exactly. I have heard about it during his battle against the Hives. But I was told he uses a different way to create them, like using a Kuritine rock or something that uses Kuret. I never expected to see it here though. I didn't think he would do it this way, I guess without his usual battle weapons, this would be a substitute.

I ask, is it powerful. Derek nods instantly, for sure. You see the Kuritine glowing even at the screen. They are different from the ones on his body. They are continuously supplied with Kuret inside, so they only become stronger with every second. Vanessa asks, isn't he worried about depleting his Kuret. Marina responds to his before Derek, I don't think he is worried about that. When I scanned Charles earlier, I could feel the endless amount of Kuret supply. I don't he is has even hit his half point. Matt says, jeez. That’s insane. How's David's supposed to beat this. Nathan asks, well you can always choose to switch your vote. He shows a gleeful smile.

I ignored him. Vanessa didn't, maybe you need to do that. David's not out of the game yet, and he is beating whatever Charles is throwing at him. The exchanges among us is getting heated. It was quieted when David and Charles resumed their attacks. Using his latest Kuritine weapon, Charles continues to slash David. David was able to block those Kuritines, but he couldn't destroy them. Those black Kuret only broke the Kuritines on his body. David switched gears and attacks his chests and face.

All this time, David's been the one who evades at every turn. But now Charles was avoid getting hit by David now. I could tell Charles is now threatened by David so much so, he can't just choose to block his attacks anymore. The intense battle was raging onwards. They both kept going with their relentless attacks. I could see David gaining momentum slowly in this battle. Especially since now with his new Kuret, he can move faster. His jumps are letting him soar in air for longer time.

This is nothing like our battle. I knew I would be at disadvantage if we fought at close range, so whenever I could I kept attacking David from a distance. But with Charles, both of them have advantage at close combat. Their fight however, is clear exchange of hand to hand combat. Does David thinks he can beat him like this. I was alerted back to reality when David does some crazy aerobatics and lands a kick to Charles face. Matt says, ouch. That was an epic kick. In your face.

Charles responds with his Kuritine horns. I thought David would be flung back from this one. But he created a Kuret shield from his arms and blocked that from skewering him. I exclaimed, that’s just like when he uses his dome to create physical objects. What is going on. No one gave me an answer right away. The battle was coming to a head. Charles used his fist to pin down David before he could escape. David arms were getting crushed under Charles arms. Or that was supposed to be. But my eyes widen in horror when I see Charles hand breaking.

Charles couldn't keep this for long, he went for another attack with his horns. This is bad, David's can't defend this one, Cass screams. Against all odds, David managed to block the horns. The Kuret on his chest turned into the wild Kuret in last second and protected. I let out a sigh of relief when David slid backwards and rested on the ground. Vanessa says, that was too close. David's making me crazy with all these close calls. I agreed and added, David's pushing his luck for sure.

They both looked exhausted a little. Charles was taking time to heal is hand and David was resting a little. The tablet on Kafar's hand begins to ping again. Kafar immediately opens up and rolls his eyes on the screen. Derek asks him, what is it. He shouldn't be hurt too badly from his. Kafar takes a moment to respond, he is bleeding a little from his mouth. I don't see his hand or arm hurt. But. He pauses a little. His expression darkens, with constantly healing himself, his blood pressure is erratic. His Kuret is not effected right now. However, he couldn't finish. Derek offers, you think if this continuous like this, he will suffer from another Kuret blockage.

When Kafar didn't respond on that, we know Derek was right on the mark. Marina got excited, so if Charles Kuret becomes unstable once more, he would be in serious trouble right. Derek hesitantly nods after looking at Kafar, if David continuous like this, then there's a strong chance Charles could lose. Kafar couldn't refute even this. Everyone here were delighted to hear that David's gaining the upper hand. Nathan says, well. Vanessa , I think you might be right. I might just change my vote now.

I looked at Nathan smiling even more. I followed his eye line to the monitor focused on David. I gulped a little when I see his Kuret flames slowly vanishing and replaced by that wild Kuret. Matt says, he is transforming his Kuret again. Damn man, David's Kuret is going for a roller coaster ride. I was enthralled with this change. When his entire body got covered, he was now a big mass of wild black Kuret. Thin Kuret sparks flowing out of him everywhere. He entire body looked like mini volcanoes.

Cass says, I'll be honest, this creeps me out a little. I know its just David's Kuret. But it looks ridiculous and menacing at the same time. She was right. I turned to face the window and looked into him directly. From the aura, I could tell the ambient Kuret around was pushed out. He is creating a pure black hole of Kuret void around him. The only time I have seen like this when he fought Derek and I with his dome. Has he really figured out to make his Kuret condense without the dome. It means he can move around more freely without the area of the dome to restrict him.

My conclusion was verified when David dashed towards Charles. He wasn't running, he was almost flying at him. But what was shocking is the speed he moved at. He covered the distance between way to fast. Charles was put on defensive with this new power. Charles had to defend David's attacks for a while with his Kuritine horns. David catches Charles kick gives a punch to his knees. The tablet on Kafar hands pings again. David is not even giving an inch, he jumps and latches on Charles neck. Charles tries his best to kick David off, but he kicked the arm with Kuritines horn.

David knees straight into Charles face. Whoa. David is overpowering Charles. For the first time we see Charles falling back on his back. Kafar's tablet pings once more. Matt cheers on, whoa. That was nuts. But that didn't stop here. David flew up and back down giving a choke hold on Charles neck. I never thought I see Charles struggle so much. Charles managed to break away from David with his Kuritine horns. David blocked it but was thrown back. Damn, I said, David was a beast on this one. Charles didn't even get one hit on him this time.

Kafar's tablet stops pinging. His expression was darkened. It's a little crazy to think to know that he went from blissfully enjoying when the match begin to such worried state. Vanessa asks, so Kafar. How's the champion of yours faring now. Kafar couldn't manage a response. Derek answers, don't just think David can keep this up. He is been fighting for too long. He has to be getting tired by now. Vanessa replies, yeah, but look can you honestly think David doesn't know it. He must have a plan for this.

Nathan says, you have a lot to say what David thinks, huh? Vanessa opened her mouth, but held back once more. Is it just me or Nathan is actively trying to provoke Vanessa lot more than recently. Marina says, whoa. Charles is doing something new again. I am not going to lie, I thought he lost his mind when he broke those Kuritines himself. I thought he went so mad that he did something reckless. But then he starts to stuck those Kuritines on his own body. I was now sure he lost his mind.

Derek spoke up immediately, hold on. This is too much. Kafar is Charles vitals okay. Kafar nods after checking, yes. He isn't himself. But this is taking it far, why would he intentionally hurt his Kuret body like this. I ask, I take it this is he hasn't done before. Derek nods, yeah. I mean, at least I have never seen him doing this before. He then takes a moment, this is a little dangerous, those Kuritines are strong enough to handle David's new form. Charles must be getting frustrated now.

Cass turns to Marina, is David fine. With all his face covered, I can't tell if got any bruises or cuts. Marina looks at her wrist, sorry. Until the watch opens up, I can't say. And with him being covered with his Kuret, I can't do a charm to detect his physical presence. I add, and I can't see any Kuret aura on him anyway. Matt asks, its fine then right. As long as the watch doesn't ring, David is still strong enough to kick Charles Kuret ass. A small giggle pass among the crowed. Vanessa murmurs, David has to have plan right. Maybe she was asking herself this.

While Charles was slowly placing the Kuritine on his body, David was resting up once again. He will be hitting his limit soon. Its amazing that he is able to fight this long without a Medrines stamina. He must really want to win the fight. I recalled the conversation we had earlier. He wasn't really sure back then that he needed to win badly. Something must have changed to risk his life like this to win now. I made sure to remember and ask David this once the match is over. Whatever be the outcome.

After a minute, Charles was ready. The Kuritine were shining over his body. Its like he added a spikes on his already tough armor. Here we go. What will David do now. I think his best bet is to use his Kuret to form physical objects. Fighting head on will be a challenge now. Charles makes a dash to David with a jab. David dodges them. Charles attacks continuous on, but David only keeps dodging them. After couple of moves, I realize this must be what he choose to do for now. Matt exclaims, what's David thinking. He should be offensive like he was till now. Fighting like this will just waste energy.

Cass beside him agrees, yeah. That’s reckless now isn't it. I reply, I don't think so. Any body would be wary of those Kuritines. He can't attack like that. Charles is cleverly adapting to the situation just as well as David if not better. The battle rages on like this. David continued to block or dodge his attacks for quite a while. Then he made a move. He caught Charles off guard and punched his stomach. Charles roars loudly with that single attack. Marina cheers, yeah. That’s what's you call a classic David.

I smiled at her words. She wasn't wrong. David always fights hand to hand combat with efficiency. He had to be waiting for this opportunity. I thought he would make another attack, but then something unbelievable happened. His black Kuret came out of Charles back. My expression turned anxious seeing that black sphere coming out through Charles. Kafar's tablet loudly rings. What the hell is happening now. Did David pierce through Charles hard Kuret body.

Everyone were clearly shocked by this. Kafar was the most. He jumped off his chair with tablet in hand, you can't be serious. This is not possible. I thought this had to be it, Charles must be done. But he didn't give in. He brought a punch and David couldn't dodge this. He got punched straight in the face. My thoughts turned sour again seeing David thrown away. This is crazy. Charles wasn't backing down even in this state. David comes to a stop. He lies on his back for a while. Derek pulls away the tablet from Kafar's hand in haste.

After a moment he says, Charles got wounded badly. He then pauses. We remained silent to let him continue, but he is already healing himself. It wasn't a fatal wound. Kafar, you can calm down. The Charles we know isn't going to lose like this. Kafar's expression showed relieved after hearing this, are you sure. But that black Kuret went straight through him. Derek responds, I don't think that was strong enough to tear his body completely. David probably didn't make his Kuret completely solid.

Nathan sets his drink aside, I don't know what I should be shocked for. David seemingly wounding Charles this badly. Or Charles still going even after such a wound. I say, yeah, if it was any other alpha, it would be bad but not deadly, Charles on the other hand. I trailed off. Vanessa continuous, what will happen now. Will Charles himself instantly or will it be slow. Derek thinks for a moment, I don't know. I know he has received deadly wounds before. He fought in the war at the last day on Medrone. And he also fought countless Hives on Earth too. Even the commander multiple times. But I have never seen him battle up close. You will have to ask other Heraknus how fast Charles would heal a wound like this.

Charles kept his hand on the wound to probably stop the bleeding. Tess says, this is getting wild by the minute. And I think people feel the same way. Look at the updating voting's now. David's win votes was now at thirty-five percent. It was less way less than Charles sixty-one percent. Considering that only few voted for him at the beginning of the match, this is an incredible change of events. I can't say for sure David is winning, but he isn't making Charles easy to beat him. The large difference in there powers that was there at the start has now been reduced considerably.

Suddenly a beeping sound came from myside. It was a different sound that Kafar's tablet. I turned towards Marina, where the noise was coming from. Maine looks at us with confused look, then she gasps. She pulls the watch out of her sleeve. The watch was glowing up. I said, that’s not boding well.

Vanessa (Chapter 23)

Tuesday, January 30, 2024 23:53

I can't believe the person fighting in front me is David. The same guy who I met all those years ago who was struggling against a single Hive. Now he has become such a terrifying force that he can now fight at the same level on true alphas and mythical alphas. I can only be in awe. His Kuret had been strange since I met him, but now, I can't believe the various transformations it has gone through. All what's even more ridiculous is that he is getting strong in this fight.

It was shocking to see David turning his arms into a something like a Kuret hurricane. Then he later turned his entire body into one, I could hardly recognize him in that form. I think that David was hiding this power. But Blake is very sure this wasn't it. Then it is completely bonkers that David is pushing so hard and is actually discovering a completely new power right here. And what a power it is. I was sure Charles was done when David gutted him. Even then he still wasn't going down. Charles was equally impressive if not more. Only if David had fought Charles like this from beginning then David wouldn't be struggling like this.

I know David is getting tiered. His usual sharpness in reactions is slow now. This must be too much for him. The timer showed we crossed the forty minutes mark. David's has to be hitting his limit. After that last attack, he was lying on the ground. Charles couldn't ignore his wound and just continue attacking like he was doing a while back. This wound must be serious enough that he stayed back to heal. David slowly got up. He couldn't even stand properly and resting his hands on his knees. I got anxious seeing him this worn out.
Then the watch on Marina's wrist flared up. My expressions hardened hearing this. Does this mean that last punch David received was serious. Marina raised her wrist. The watch screens glows and then the hologram comes out of it. A 3D anatomy of a body showed in that hologram. It was David's. Then I heard the sound of the AI I have gotten used to, entering orange alert. Recognized current user Marina. Authorized limited access, granted. Then hologram begins to show details on the halo body.

There are different colored lines drawn across the hologram. After few seconds the entire body gets covered with colors. Some places had red other were spread wider. There was yellow and orange in various places. On the head, near the chest, and then his limbs. This was the state of David's right now. I saw the most red was on the side of his face and his chest. That must be where he was hurt the most. M continuous, diagnostic completed. Boss muscles have sprained all around his body. He has a small tear on his femur bone. His fingers on his hand and foot have sprained. His right ancle is sprained. Bleeding from 8 different wounds. Boss has suffered several mild injuries but no threatening ones. I felt relief hearing this. But then next moment I realized that M wouldn't act now if something wasn't right.

She continuous, however, requesting to stand by for medical treatment. I blurt out, what. You mean, we should stop this fight now? M continuous, inconclusive. I don't have enough evidence to see he needs to get treatment right away. However, boss has added this protocol whenever a certain threshold is crossed. Marina asks, what should I do then. M responds, I will be making real time changes to the medications and stiches he will need for his cryo bath. However, since I can't tell boss about his current condition, he has requested you to help him with telling him.
Marina asks a little worried now, how. I can't intervene in this match directly. He won't be able to hear or see me from the edge of the barrier. And I can't use a charm near him to speak through. His Kuret is cancelling the ambient Kuret around him. M says, you need to create a smoke of at least 15 different Kuretines together at the edge of the barrier. Boss will sense these many different Kurets at the same place. He said when he sees that signal, no matter what happens or the situations is, he will forfeit the match immediately.

I get it, David would see with his synesthesia and understand that he has to stop. I ask, so when do we know it’s the right time to pull the plug on this? I don't want to see David getting hurt badly, but stopping before will also be bad. M continuous, in the current state condition, boss can continue the fight. Orange alert is still in effect. However, I would recommend to inform boss when I go into red alert. Depending on the condition, I would advice to signal boss immediately with no delay. Otherwise, boss will be taking serious risk.

A moment of silence came over the room. David was finally gaining momentum on wining this fight, but now a new wrinkle threated it. Blake asks to Derek, will Charles be able stop himself when he sees David giving up. Derek takes a moment to reply, he should. But there is a small chance he wouldn't care and continue. If his was calm, I would be more sure. But seeing him now, I am not sure. He then turns to Blake, it would be prudent to have a backup plan for both Charles and David. This tournament has been seen situations were people in no condition to fight anymore don't stop in the heat of the battle and needlessly risk their life.

That was definitely a light jab to me. I know Derek wasn't trying to single me out. Besides, he was right. Blake nods, its highly unlikely that David would make a irrational decision and ignore his own plan to stop. But I agree with you. Its best to stop him, even if we want to forcibly. Blake then looks around us a moment and then takes a moment to think. Marina says, I will go to the arena's nearby barrier now. I need to prepare for the signal. Blake turns to her, yeah. Since you have the watch, we will follow your lead. You can go ahead, we will behind you in a minute. Marina nods and walks out through the door in a hurry.

Kafar asks, remind me again how David will be able to see this signal? More than half the time, he keeps his eyes closed. Can he really see Kuret, why does he need to close his eyes then. I don't know what to tell Kafar regarding David's secret. Blake choose to give an evasive answer to his question, he will be able to see it. He wouldn't ask us to do this if couldn't see it. Kafar remained confused a little. He let it lie for the moment. Blake then asks to Derek, you think you can help me stop Charles in case we need to intervene.

Derek asks, why me. Blake answers, he doesn't know any of us. At least he hasn't spoken to us. So I want to bring you in. Seeing you might just be enough to stop him. Derek thinks for a moment. Blake continuous, I would ask Kafar for this role, but bringing a non-combatant would be dangerous. So how about it. Derek nods and then looks at Kafar, he is right. Its best if Blake and I both stop him if the time comes. What do you think. Kafar looked at Derek. Not responding immediately, he faces the healing Charles on the screen.

He must be happy a little seeing that we were preparing for David's possible defeat. If was he wasn't showing in his face. He must be hiding it, or likely thinking the odds of Charles loosing. A moment later he says, Okay. I don't want Charles to win like this, but it would be bad if tries any more attempts to kill David. He then stares intently at Derek, but don't stop the match until the last second. We need to give people a clear victory. If they saw us stopping it before it was absolutely necessary, it would defeat the entire purpose of this tournament.
He didn't have to remind us that. We were painfully aware that this was just a glorified entertainment for people to see us and increase the odds of joining our communities. Derek nods, I understand. I don't want David and Charles to feel cheated. A pause later he says, but Kafar, you need to be prepared for any conclusion. I am not saying Charles would lose, but just be ready for anything. Just like we are planning for David, we might choose to decide to stop the match if Charles is going to far or risking his life too. Kafar just nods in response. Blake says, okay. Good. So the two of us on Charles duty. And as for David…
I stood up before he could continue, I will do it. My Kuret is the only thing that would be most effective on David. Ned beside me finally looks at me. He had been so silent this whole time. I think we was avoiding talking to me to make sure we don't fight again. He spoke just then, you sure. Maybe I should help you. I raise my hand, no. My Kuret is hard to control. You would just get in the way. Cassandra then speaks, you shouldn't do this alone. If I could do it, I would, but my Kuret is also a bad match for David.

Matt stood up, I'll help you. I was about to refute him, but he stops me. Don't worry. I am not going to use your Kuret. I will go and copy a Kuret different Kuret that physically intervenes. And its safer for two people to be David too. The more people, the better. It was hard to argue with his point. Ned sighs, fine you both can go. At the risk of being repetitive, just step in when absolutely necessary. Okay. He eyes me when he said that. It was a reminder to me of my own match. I didn't want to get into with Ned with everyone here so I gave him a nod in agreement.
Blake continuous, ah, I was going to ask for your help anyways Vanessa. Its good we agreed. Lets leave immediately before they David and Charles began fighting again. Matt says, ah guys, we should hurry up. They are starting again. I turned to the screen. David wasn't waiting for Charles to heal and rest up. He jumped into air and attacked with his knee to Charles. Charles blocked it with his arms. Blakes exclaims, huh. I really thought David was going to buy more time. Maybe his trying to wrap up as soon as possible.

I was thinking the same. Its no coincidence that M alerted us a while back and David springs back in action early. I say, we have to hurry. I turn to Blake, lets avoid the staircase and just jump. Matt says, hey. Not everyone can fly you know. I need to find the right Kuret to use on David. Maybe even on Charles. Derek walks to us, you both hurry up. Matt and I will catch up. We turn to the screen and see David zipping around Charles in mid air attacking and dodging. Blake says, lets move now.

Cassandra stands up to Matt, make sure David doesn't get hurt okay. Matt nods, don't worry. I got this. He gives a quick kiss on her cheek. Derek opens the door and walks away. Behind him, Matt follows. Blake prepares to open the window we were going to use earlier to stop the match. I face down to Ned. He wasn't looking at me anymore. I got annoyed at his behavior. I am not saying I wanted a relationship like Matt and Cass, but he could be more appreciative of me. I decided to leave just like this and walk.

As I walk, I turn sideways to Nathan, you don't plan on helping? You and Blake together would be more efficient. Nathan just smirks a little, too many people will create unnecessary confusion. Besides, you'll got this. He raises his drinks, and someone needs to keep the others here accompanied here. He points his head slightly to Ned and Kafar. I didn't know exactly what he meant. Maybe he doesn't want to help David out of resentment. Or maybe it was something else. I didn't care anyway.

Blake says, lets go. He covers himself with blue Kuret and jumps out the window. I walk beside Catherine. Like Ned hadn't spoken for a long time. She wore a worried and nervous expression, but never expressed it in words. She was one of David's best friend, and yet I was confused why she remained quite all this time when we are worried about David. She didn't say anything to Blake, me or anyone as we left. Something is definitely eating her up. I wanted to know what it is causing her to be like this. I'll ask her later.

Tess says, good luck. Keep the those guys safe. Jess chips in, and stop the match immediately when David gets injured okay. Without his Medrine healing, it could turn nasty quickly. I nodded, we will make sure this doesn't become worse. See in guys in some time then. I turned to look at Ned once more hopping for some sort of reaction out of him. But he doesn't say anything to me. I gave up a little mad and turned my back to him. I put my legs on the window edge and push myself outside.

I turn on my Kuret and blew a gust of window around me. I saw Blakes flying near the edge of the wall below me. I followed his direction and began my decent. We couldn't feel it from the window, but the noise coming from the crowd in the stadium was ecstatic. People were cheering, yelling and discussing amongst themselves. Blake and I stuck close to the wall as to avoid as much as attention from the people. It would be bad to cause unnecessary chaos. As I glid in air, I turn my gaze up and see David and Charles fight up close.

David was attacking his stomach with Charles defensives down. Charles didn't go down on that punch, he instead starts to attack David with his arm. David gets caught and he was thrown down to the ground. I was a little taken aback when I saw David flying up in air dodging Charles kick. Charles attacked next with his tail. David avoided them and backed away. I touched the ground and started to running towards the edge of the arena gate. I saw Marina standing nearby where there was a little more space than other area.

She was already casting charms to prepare the signal. Ahead me Blake was running also and reached Marina first. I turned my gaze to the arena. Being so close now, the ground looked like a war zone. The ground that was even before the match was torn in various places. There were pieces of land torn apart and debris were lying everywhere. We have seen the arena getting destroyed many times, but they usually have much less damage than this. This is solely due to Charles. A lot of his attacks involve digging up holes and pulling out rocks from the ground.

Inside the barrier, the brief exchange came to halt again. Charles didn't attack back, he looked he wasn't finished healing the wound. Why did David stop. He was now just standing on the ground. Few seconds later I reach Blake and Marina. The watch on Marina's wrist was still showing David's condition. I couldn't tell if he got new injuries. I saw more yellow around his body. Blake says, looks like they are resting a bit before they begin again. That’s good for us.

I step in and ask, is it done Marina. She was working with just one hand while keeping the hand with the watch raised on her side, almost. Not so easy with one hand. She was clearly trying to be sarcastic. There are hardly any people who can cast with one hand. She was waving in air and creating Kuret circuits in the air. She continuous, throw me some of your Kuret you two. It would save me some time. Blake and I raise our arms to her. We both pour out Kuret in the air.

Marina's charm sucks our Kuret straight in. A Kuretine was being formed in the middle of her charm. Once Marina points its enough, we stop our Kurets. She says, okay. Few more to go. She focuses on completing the rest. Different shades of Kuret flow out from her charms into the Kuritine. Blake asks to me, you okay. You look pissed. I didn't know my face was showing like. I think my mind was still reeling with thoughts of Ned. I didn't want to get into this, its nothing. He says hesitantly, okay. Just don't get distracted for now.

I know he was right, but I still glared at him. He must know it was about me and Ned. I turn my gaze to David to avoid any further conversation and focused on David. He was trying something again. At the sight of David, I let go of my relationship problems. I need to be here for David now. Blake says, what's David up to now. Honestly, the guy wasn't this motivated during our match you know. I couldn't reply immediately. On some level, I agreed with Blake. David has been pulling out unexpected techniques this match.

In the latest one, he had covered himself in a mini tornado of Kuret. He was standing in the middle of the Kuret storm. Beside me Marina exclaims, okay. All done. One Kuritine with a cocktail of 22 Kuret signatures done. She then turns ahead to the barrier, okay once I break this, I will lower the barrier here for you guys and then… she stops when saw David, what the hell is going on. I didn't understand Marina's shock. David was doing something again, but it shouldn't be such a shock.

Blake gulps a little, you can sense it too Marina. She nods slightly. I was confused, what's going on. What are you guys seeing. Blake says, whatever David is doing, its pushing away the whole Kuret in the air away from him. And I am not taking how when he uses his dome. The side of his entire arena is now deprived of Kuret. I turned back to the arena, say what. David is Kuret is effecting this much now. Marina nods, yes. A moment later she says, if this continuous to grow like this, it would start to effect the barrier soon.

I was stunned at this. I didn't see David's Kuret much away from him. Meaning his invisible Kuret was leaking out to farther reaches. Is David's trying to become even stronger. Marina then says, wait. I see its slowing down. Blakes says, not just slowing, its shrinking back. Like its collapsing on itself. The storm around David was becoming smaller too. We kept our eyes glued to him. David was slowly making the storm smaller. Soon it was just few inches outside his body.

Then his Kuret around him collapses completely. Blake says, wow. All that Kuret he was pushing out is gone now. I sense the ambient Kuret is filling up the space inside again. Marina backs his words, yup. I can tell that all that wild Kuret he was throwing out in the air is gone now. So that it, his new transformation. I couldn't say even when we saw it. David was now covered in pieces of armor around his body. Unlike his previous form, he was not completely covered. There were few places on his body where his skin was exposed. It looked like he was wearing large pieces of Kuret rings on him. He had one on his face that looked like bandana.

But the most distinctive feature of this transformation was that it wasn't running wild anymore. Instead his Kuret was stable. Wrapped around him like a semi armor, not unlike the flames that are usually on him. Is this form really powerful than the one from before. I wasn't convinced this was more powerful. David walks and stands beside a nearby boulder lying on the ground. He punches the boulder leaving as anxious. If it were a normal punch, it would have been bad. But he head created a dagger looking shape from his fist when he put his hand through the rock. The top of the rock was blown away, leaving behind a visible hole.

Blake exclaims, whoa whoa. Did that really happened. I gulp a little replying, it sure is. David's managed to make his Kuret dense enough to shape his Kuret to physically attack. Blake nods, yeah. Without his Kuret dome. Damn, this changes stuff. Marina says, I don't think it’s the way we want though. Look at this. We turn to see Marina looking worried at the hologram. It showed more yellow area inside his body. The red area on his face and stomach spread further also. M beeps in, boss vitals have taken a big hit. Detecting increased the pain receptors from his wounds. Also detecting high BP and high repository activity. Conclusion, boss is tiring out rapidly. Switching to critical orange mode.

The hologram grams blinks away and is instead replaced by a new hologram of David's body. This one showed similar stuff like before. M continues, monitoring boss's vitals in millisecond time accuracy. Be advised for red alert approaching. Marina then looks up, ah so we are still good, right? Blake doesn't reply. I answer, we just have to play this by the ear. If it becomes dangerous, we will stop this right. No matter what David tells us. Agreed. They both nod in response. Marina replies, yeah. Its not like its over yet.

From the side of the barrier edge, I see Derek running to us with a tablet in hand. We all set, ask us when he approached us. Marina says, yup. All ready. Derek says, good. I also got a backup tablet of Charles to monitor his condition as well. I don't know what's going to happen, but better to be prepared for anything. I looked behind him hoping to see Matt. Derek says, Matt will be soon. I gave an advice on whom to copy his Kuret from. He will be here in a minute. I was already prepared to head in even if Matt wasn't here. But I wasn't naïve to know I could handle David alone, better to have a two man team stopping him.

We all turn our gaze to David when moves. Enough time had passed for Charles to heal his wound. My mouth hug out a little when I saw David move incredibly fast. What, I gasp loudly. Charles was preparing to attack with his tails, but David flew past them easily. That was unreal. He is now almost as fast as us now. Charles attacks with his claws, David ducks down and blocks them with a shield on his arm. He slid underneath Charles like he did the first time they both clashed.

The from behind, he jumps into the air. His movements weren't like he anything human anymore. He was flying in air. Marina says, holy shit. David can fly now. I was too shocked to respond. Blake scoffs at this sight, nothing surprises me anymore. Derek says, technically, he is not flying. It looks he using his Kuret to throw him up. Marina says, yeah that’s same as flying. David flew up to a height, meanwhile Charles threw a large boulder at him. David should have dodged it. But he choose to catch it and then hurls it back to Charles on the ground.

Charles wasn't fazed much with that when he broke the boulder. David begins falling down to a direction away from Charles. Charles chases after him. A moment later David lands and then runs towards Charles. Charles threw a rock at David. David again didn't dodge it, he instead blocks it away from his path. They were heading for another collision, or it would have been if not for David punching the ground with his Kuret. The ground spit opens and they both get dragged inside.

Derek shouts, unbelievable. It happened again. Yeah, I thought. David used Charles trap again. Tess was right on the money when she asked if Charles himself knows where the traps are laid. Its not even funny anymore that Charles got caught a second time. Charles tried to get out, he was stopped by David with a leg sweep. He floated in the air while he cuts off the tails from Charles behind. Charles lets out a roar as he fails to get out and falls inside the pit.

David lands near the edge and then jumps into the pit immediately. Blake says, he is trying to pin him inside. Brilliant. David's trying to somewhat restricted Charles movement inside. David begins his barrage of attacks on Charles. The tablet on Derek starts beeping. He looks at it without saying anything. Even when lying down, Charles kept blocking David's attacks. He even chomped on David's to stop him. My fist tightened up when I heard M beeping instead. M says, boss's vitals are declining. Detecting high levels of muscle spams now. His movements are causing tendon pains.

I kept my eyes focused on David. Matt isn't here yet, but I will not wait. As soon as M gives the signal I will jump in. David's attacks didn't stop. He punched Charles in the face to get away. Charles lets go his jaws from Charles neck. David then thrusts himself at Charles. He should have been wary of the Kuritine on Charles body. Looking at his desperate attacks, he isn't worried about them anymore. I can only pray that those Kuretines can't handle David's new Kuret transformation.

David then backs away as Charles falls on one knee. David didn't attack immediately, instead he flies backwards in the air. I thought he just wanted to gain some distance before attacking, but he kept rising in the air. After a certain height I got worried, hey. What the hell is David thinking. Even after flying so high, he didn't stop. He kept going higher. Blake shouts, holy shit. Is he going to do what I think he is planning. Marina exclaims, now you can't deny it. Someone has joined the flying Medrine club.

Derek was shocked so much he too couldn't remain calm anymore, what in the world. How high is he planning to go. David wasn't stopping at all. His figure is getting smaller every second. Behind me, Matt came running, hey, sorry for the delay. Got the Kuret though. He looks at us and turns his head up in our direction, what are you guys looking at. Blake replies, at David. Matt confused asked, come on. Don't kid around. He then frantically looks around the arena. Only Charles could be seen in the ground crawling out of the pit.

Matt voice trembles a little asking, hey seriously. Where the hell is David. I ask, you didn't see him flying up in the air. Matt yelled, what. David's flying. His voice stammered and then he looks up, I was inside the stadium to find a guard. I didn't see, he stops when he spots a small figure up in the air, god damn. Is that really David. How the hell did he reach up there. Scratch that. What is planning to do. Blake says, why would anyone fly up so high. You know what he is planning.

Marina says, whoa. I turn to her thinking she saw something on that hologram, what. Is it David. She nods, yeah. I just felt the him near the barrier. His Kuret is tearing small holes on the barrier. I am a little relieved to hear, but at the same I was horrified he flew to that height on his first try. Marina continuous, looks like he is travelling to the top most point of the barrier, the center. Blake says worried, this is too much for David. He has never flown before. This could turn ugly real quick. He turns to Marina, can you make a door for us just in case.

Marina nods, yeah. Good thinking. She points to the Kuritine floating in the air, grab this will you. Blake plucks the Kuritine in his hand. Marina raises both her hands and begins to create a charm. Matt exclaims, Vanessa, should I copy your Kuret. The one I have now won't be of help catching a falling David. I shook my head, no. My normal Kuret is complicated already enough, it will dangerous for you to try flying like this. Matt urges, but you alone will be not enough. Blake cuts in, if that happens I will back you Vanessa. If I see David is in more danger, me and Matt can switch our roles.

I nod in agreement. I turn my gaze up to the center of the barrier. Sure hope you know what you are doing David, I murmur.

Vanessa (Chapter 24)

Wednesday, January 31, 2024 18:33

All our gaze were up in the sky. Not just the five of us here, but every person in the stadium had there eyes glued to the sky. A few seconds later Marina says, David just reached the barrier at the top. I felt the a big hole healing just now. Oh my, he actually fly up all the way there. Dang it. She was excited, but a little scared too. I was the same. David's risking way to much to win. Blake says, okay, he has taken all the runway distance. He turns to Marina, is it opened yet.

Marina hands waved around fervently now, nearly done. You guys should get ready. I take a step little closer the Barrier. The mild humming noise was coming off. Matt and I stood near one of the opening Marina is making. Blake and Derek stood two step away from us which had the other opening. Okay, its ready, Marina said stopping her charm. I will provide support from here to both of you guys in case something goes wrong. Derek says, hopefully nothing happens.

We were on our toes now waiting for David to return back to ground. Behind us the crowd is restless pointing their fingers to the sky. The nearest people on the seats were standing and cheering loudly. I couldn't hear whom over the ruckus. At this point, I didn't even care if David loses. We just have to make sure he doesn't get hurt badly. Or worse. This match isn't worth risking his life. Blake speaks, heads up. I can see David now. I squished my eyes to try and focus on the dark figure falling from sky. A wave of excitement roars from the crowd. People stood up from their seats with a sudden shot of revitalization.

David has covered himself entirely with his black Kuret. He was falling his face first. I could tell the way is swaying around a little that he doesn't have complete control on his. Why did you go this far David, I speak to myself. I called on my Kuret. I raise my hands and open my palm outwards ready to fly. I can do this. I am the fastest one here. I can catch up to his speed. Suddenly a noise came from above us. It sounded like something small exploded in the air. The sound made my body shook with fear.

What in the hell, Matt raises his arm and puts it behind his head exasperated, is it me or did David just became faster. He was right, David suddenly picked up his speed. Another small noise same a second later. Blake yells, shit. That’s David. The sound is coming from him when he propels himself to get faster. David was too fast now. I am petrified at the speed when there's a third noise. He was falling way to fast. Derek shouts, is that on purpose. This can't be right. He can't be doing something this crazy.

Oh, but he is. I wasn't going to wait anymore. Even if David can aim for Charles, if he misses or Charles dodges he will not be able to stop this speed. I poured Kuret around me and focused on creating a hurricane. To match the speed I need to create a lot of power. I took a step at the barrier. Blake called me just before I stepped in, Vanessa. Wait. Look. David was still falling, but he was also getting pushed sideways. He tried few times more. He is trying curve his fall.

But I didn't want to risk that. Blake yells, Vanessa don't. Not yet. Give it few more seconds, I think David is making it work. Blake grabbed me by the shoulder. I shoved his arm back, don't. What if he can't. Blake replies, what if he can. Just wait for a second. I wasn't going to. Derek shouts, look. David's changing his direction. He is controlling his fall. David's fall was slowly but surely aching. A few seconds later he was almost flying horizontal, heading towards Charles. Incredibly, Charles chose to run away on all fours. He was running away from David's trajectory.

However, when David changed his direction, it was to the opposite side of Charles path. Charles should have evaded this. But he didn't change his path. He instead pick up his pace and running faster. He was stomping the ground so fast, I could feel the shakes here. Matt laughs, oh yeah. He raises his fist in air to cheer on, come on David. Kick his mystical alpha ass. The crowd went wild seeing the two on a collision course. David poured more Kuret into his arms. My hearts begins thumping faster than ever.

If falling from such a height wasn't enough, David sped up even faster with another couple of small wind blasts. Marina yells, oh my god. Charles leaps to the air and ready to thrown down his fist from both the arms. Then the two clashed. The shock created a wind that blow the debris away on the ground. The sound of them colliding vibrated the air and even came through the barrier to us. Incredibly, both of them stayed in the air for few seconds. But then Charles was thrown back.

I shouted, Do it David. I make a fist and raises it near my head in joy. Blake yells, that’s it, yeah. Charles was now getting dragged across the field, David pushing him back. I was so anxious a second ago, but now all I could do was grin. I spoke, he actually did it. My god, David is nuts. Charles was helplessly getting dragged across the field. David's Kuret suddenly pierced through Charles body and a small black Kuret spear sticks out from Charles back. The tablet on Derek's hand blazed up with continuous ringing noise.

Behind us a different, but similar noise flared up. Marina shouts, shit. I turned to Marina. All the noise coming from the crowd drowned out M's voice. Its was definitely not good based on Marina's expression. I turn my gaze back to David. Should we get stop this match now. No, I controlled myself. Even if I want to, I can't David to miss this incredible chance he risked his life for. I will at least see this all the way through. David was slowing down now. Charles was still getting dragged back, he was even using his leg to stop his fall.

David was flying behind a little. Is it done, David? I asked him in my mind. But against my expectation, he propelled again with a small wind noise. This one was a continuous set of blasts, like he was accelerating in successions. David's not done yet. He goes in for Charles face with a punch. Charles defense fails when David swats them away. He punches hard into Charles face from the side. The ringing noise continued from the tablet, and so did from the watch.

I didn't want to get worried by checking on M, so I just waited for the right moment to get David myself. David then drop kicks on Charles neck. Charles could no longer stay on his feet. He was falling backwards. I was sure this is it. But against all expectation, David dropped to ground and slides on the ground behind Charles. What. His body is moving so strangely I couldn't fathom how he is doing this. He sits on his knees and raises his arms. Two Kuret spears launch from his arms and pierces Charles from the behind.

Even with the crowd behind us, we could hear Charles loud painful roar. Just before Charles falls on the ground, David slips out. This has to be it. And yet David goes beyond. He jumps into the air and lands nears his legs. He still had his Kuret spears on his hand. He joined his hands and the spears joined into a sword looking shape. In one swift strike, he cut his knees. Marina cries out, holy mother of god. No freaking mercy. I was shocked beyond reason at this display of his sheer will.

But nothing lasts long, Charles in a desperate attempt knees him in the stomach. David couldn't block this and he was thrown away. No. No. His body leaned forward lifelessly when got dragged away far. I shout, enough is enough. We need to stop this match now. Derek shouts, wait don't. I wasn't going to listen to anyway now. I prepared for a wind to carry me. But then the wind gets disrupted. I see Derek raising his arm at me with his Kuret. What, I shouted at him.

Just listen to me. Don't do something rash now. Blakes steps beside him, no Derek. This is enough now. Even I can't let this continue anymore. David's in critical condition now. He points back, M just now said his condition triggered M's red mode. Meaning we are stopping this match now. I know its not ideal, but David loosing is the least of our worries now.

Blake raised his palm to him, Charles in a similar situation. I noticed it when he first collided with David. That clash made Charles trigger his Kuret blackout. So I am asking not to do it for David's sake too. If you go and stop this match now, you just might waste all his effort, especially when he has potentially won the match. His fervent voice made us snap out of our zeal. I took a moment to consider. I didn't want to wait, but if what Derek said was remotely true, then…

Like me, Blake is also thinking. We couldn't decide right away. I turned my eyes back to David. He was now lying on the ground face first. His Kuret was now gone. He wasn't even moving. Fear swept like a wave of tremor over my body. Marina shouts, Vanessa,. David's not what you are thinking. Calm down. He only got knocked out. I turned to Marina. She raised he wrist to me. The hologram M was showing now had turned to red in the background. It also showed a clock beside it now. The image had been blown up to show the brain. There was many colored lines zipping around the holo. I didn't understand the writing on the air M is showing us. I ask, are you sure. M replies, boss is in a temporary state of unconscious. Yes. The most recent blow shook his entire body. He isn't in immediate danger right now.

My fear changed to wave of huge relief. I had even stopped my breathing a little and took a breath back in. Matt asks, buts that’s just as bad right. If David's lost consciousness, then he has lost the match right. We should just get him now. I reply, yes. Lets go Matt. Derek cuts in, don't. Listen. Don't stop the match now. I was annoyed now. I yelled, what are you saying now. Didn't you hear David's knocked out. He can't fight now. The match is over. He shook his head vehemently, no you don't understand. Charles is incapacitated too. He raises his tablet and shows us, those attacks did so many damage to Charles that he can't move right now.

What, I retorted. I turn to Charles body. He was moving, but still lying on the ground with low howls coming of his broken jaws. Derek continuous, believe me. I am not doing this just for Charles. If David's condition worsened, we will stop this match. But now that Charles is also down, he won't attack immediately. With all the wounds Charles got now, and on top of his Kuret blockage back again, I bet he can't even right now. So just trust me. We can't stop the match now.

Derek's pleads us with stern but worried voice. I wanted to rebuke. Then I thought to get some more proof. Blake turn to M, are you sure that David will be fine. We don't need to get him treated right away. M responds, boss is not in immediate danger. Confirmed. He hasn't lost too much blood. All this injuries are either superficial or can be treated right away. I am continuously changing the medicine dosage he will require based on his vitals. Boss's brain activity is fluctuating. There is a possibility he might wake up.

I calmed down more after hearing this. I took a step back from the barrier. Derek says, believe it or not, Charles is in almost an exact situation. He got couple of serious wounds from David's Kuret attacks. He should be able heal them in time, but right now he can't even move right now due his Kuret blackout. His healing is way to too slow. If he can't control his Kuret properly, he might just revert back to his original form and won't be able to fight anymore.

Blakes shakes his head in disbelief, just as Nathan said, David's luck is incredible. He chuckles nervously, I can't believe the guy. Just when he is goes down, and now completely defenseless, Charles shares the same fate. I took a moment to think. Luck or not. What are we supposed to do now. Marina asks interrupting my thoughts, but where does leaves us. David's a sleeping beauty. And the beast isn't moving. I wasn't amused at all her clever choice of words. Matt says, what's with this timer M. Don't tell me that when it hits zero, something happens to David.

M says, The timer is a safeguard by boss. If he doesn't wake up in the next three minutes and twenty two seconds, he will not wake up anytime soon. If the neural activity in his brain doesn't go up before it zero, he will be go into deep rem sleep. It will be impossible to continue the match. Boss added this timer in the red alert mode for a situation of attrition. Matt says, bloody hell David. He even thought of such a thing.

Derek says, if you guys remember. We added a rule about this also. If both the fighters are down for more than five minutes, the match would end in draw. The fight resumes when one get backs up. He then takes a moment, in this case its even possible, whoever is just able to stand up, will become the winner straight away. I ask him, how long do you think Charles will not be able to move. He looks at his screen, I have no idea. I have never seen Charles beaten to this extend. I don't even know if can fight after he heals his wounds.

Marina ask, so they are in, what's the term you say in chess… I respond, statement. She clicks her finger at me, yes. That. We just wait then. Blake says, I don't know what else to do. I had a thought. I said, okay look. If Charles wakes up first before the 5 minutes countdown ends. Then we stop the match right. Derek nods, provided David also can't wake up and is no shape of fighting. I shook my head, no. Even if he wakes up, I don't think we should let him continue the match. He gave M those instructions right. He will stop when Marina blasts the Kuritine.
Derek says, yes. That’s what he plans to do. But all I am saying if David wakes up along with Charles, he might be able to continue the match. I was shocked to hear this. How could Derek think David can continue fighting after this long. Blake says, look Derek. David's been fighting for almost 45 minutes now. He has lost all his stamina, there is no way he can fight now. The only way he can win right now is if Charles doesn't get back up, David somehow wakes up and the time runs out. I won't let David continue this. Even if David decides to fight, we should just put an end to it.

Derek turns to M, you say if David doesn't wake up before your count down hits zero, he will not wake up soon. I agree with that. But what happens if he does wake up before. Is there a chance he would rest up a little while and be able to continue. M responds, boss didn't put any protocol for this. However, if boss wakes up and the diagnosis I run shows some positive vitals, then yes its possible, I will revert back to orange alert mode. I would still mention that the chance of that happening is very low.

Derek nods, yes. That’s all I am saying. Trust me guys, I am not saying this because I am following Kafar's order or because I am on Charles side. All I want is to give David one more chance. You have seen how much he has gone all out in this match. I can't point my finger on it yet, but he wouldn't go this far just because he doesn't want people to move to Citradel. I think more like he just wants to win. Whether its for pride, ego or for some other vanity reason, I got no clue. But don't you think you can give him least one more chance.

Derek pleading desperately to us. I didn't want to budge from this. But his words got me good. He was right that David's never been this desperate to win. Its different when he fought against Nathan, Hives or Echo's. He had to risk his life fighting them. But he shouldn't have to do the same in this match. Maybe like Derek suggested, David got his own reason. Blake says, I understand Derek. I know what you mean, when I spoke with David earlier. He wasn't even sure he would go full out or fight this desperate to win. He then sighs and turns to me, so what now Vanessa. Shall we give one more chance to David if he wakes up.

Even if he asks me like this I can't decide. I never thought I would have to decide something like this here. Marina asks, lets give not give up Vanessa. David's struggled this far. Lets give him one more chance. You never know, he might wake up and give up anyway. She turns to Derek, you won't have a problem if David does that, right. Derek nods, absolutely. Its David's choice completely. If he gives up, I won't stop you anymore. I only ask to not let David chance of winning slip by. Even if its very slim.

I know he was right, but I still unsure. Blake say, we are at two and half minute mark according to M. At this point, I don't think David can even wake up. But what happens if he did. What happens if Charles also wakes up. How crazy would they have to be to continue fighting. Then I chided myself. I have no right to even think that given I myself also went far. Maybe not to the extent David has gone. Or maybe I am getting too much emotional. Its all David's fault. I am frustrated so much its maddening. Why can't he just let this go. What's he trying to prove anyways. I sigh after resolving my thoughts, okay. Fine. One more chance. That’s it. The moment David wakes up, I will be watching him like a hawk. If I get even a hint of something strange, I am pulling the plug on this. I don't care if you pull out another cop out.

They all agree with me. Matt says, that’s all well and all. But is David's even going to wake up ? If he doesn't, then the best case is that the match ends in a draw. Otherwise, if Charles wakes up, he wins. Only way David has a chance of wining is he wakes up in about, he peaks at the timer, two minutes now. Blake says, I would have never guessed the finals would be like this. Both our fighters are down. And anyone of them can win if just got back up. I don't know whether to be amazed or shocked by this. Marina says, how crazy it would be if they still continue the match, right. I scoff at her. Even though I agreed to wait for now, I highly doubt it will happen.

Blake (Chapter 25)

Thursday, February 1, 2024 01:23

As the time ticks, the tense atmosphere only increases. The crowd was restless with some shouting at them to wake up. I turn to Derek, what do you think Kafar will do. Will he allow for Charles to lose like this. He responds, he won't have a say. You heard me earlier, right, whatever I decide he go along with that. I am not blindly following Kafar, you know. We just have an arrangement. Once our cities merge, I can't wait to change the management. Matt slaps his back, I knew it. You don't like Kafar too.

Derek responds, its not like that. We need Kafar in the management, there is no doubt in that. But I will finally be able to get out of our personnel arrangement. Matt nods, yeah, he is one hell of jerk of boss I bet. Marina says, just imagine his face if David wins. I wish I was there to see if that happens. Vanessa says, you might. Don't forget we are recording the entire stadium. That include that VIP room. Marina smirks at that, oh yeah. Totally forgot. That’s even more awesome. I get to play it on repeat. I couldn't help a small chuckle hearing that.

Derek says, I bet that would be really amusing. His expression harden a little, but in all seriousness, we have a minute and half for David to wake up and two minutes left for a draw. I know I asked to play this out, but its looking grim now. He looks at the tablet, Charles isn't faring well too. If he can't get up in the next two minutes, this match is officially a draw. Marina asks, ah just throwing out a question here. If this does end in a draw, what happens to our cities. We still merge or not. We going for the person who delt the most damages. Or the person who has less injury. Or are we going to have another match or even the whole tournament. Like what's the rule we made for the finals.

I shrug, good question. I don't think we made any rule for this. We never thought the finals would be so evenly matched. Derek nods, Kafar didn't even thought for a second that Charles would be defeated. Vanessa asks, so we have to figure out something else. Matt exclaims, what a pain. I know I lost, but I don't want to fight again in front of everyone. Come on David, wake the hell up, dude. Marina says, one minute left. I don't understand this brain stuff. M, just tell us if David is going to wake up or not.

M responds, brain activity is subsiding slowly now. Chances of boss waking up is less than ten percent. Marina clicks her mouth, seriously. Come on David. Vanessa asks, look David is too tired. He never struggled this long with anyone else before. I not saying I want David to lose the match, but I just hope he doesn't wake up for his own sake. I could understand her concern well. If it weren't for Derek, she would be already running and get David treated immediately.

30 seconds left. I kept thinking that David would wake up. But maybe is too exhausted to fight now. To be honest, it was just our wishful thinking that David can still win at this point. Even if gets up, Charles has another minute. Even if doesn't heal immediately, Charles is way too strong for David. I don't know what kind of power David is hiding, but what could he do when he probably won't be able to move properly. The five of us keep our eyes fixed on the timer, now down to 10 seconds now.

We were anxious now. In a few seconds, we would have no choice but to make David forfeit. The countdown hits zero, and nothing changes. David is still unconscious. Marina says, dammit. This sucks. Matt stomps with his leg, oh come on. Derek doesn't say anything. I let out a sigh, well, that it then. I turn to Vanessa. She was mostly relieved than dismayed. Given her priority for David's safety, that is not surprising. She turns to David's lying on the ground.

She says walking into the barrier, look, I am not happy about this. I didn't want for David to lose like this. Lets just get this over with. Maybe things would have been different if David fought…, suddenly a loud noise around us. M says, boss's neural activity is spiking. He is stirring and waking up. Marina screams, hell yeah. David's' back. I let out a shout, surprised on my own emotion. Derek chuckles a little, I really thought he was done. Matt raises his arms up in air overjoyed, oya. He's back baby.

Vanessa's reaction was the best one. She places her palm on her forehead and sighs loudly. Then mumbles, I can't even deal with this. He is just a pain…she trails off. She bows her head a little frustrated, but I could tell she was laughing a little too. She walks back to us and raises her head. A little bit of her smile remained, fine. He woke up. But I am telling you, if David's going to fight again, he better not do be reckless again. I nod excited, agreed. I then turn to Charles. What about Charles, is his Kuret still blocked.

Derek takes a look into his tablet. A moment later he waves his hand in air, yeah. The best I can see, he is still not healing fast. Marina, you could probably can figure it out better. Marina says, way ahead of you. She had already started casting a charm similar to what she did earlier in the room. A moment later Charles figure conjured up. She says, the Kuret on him is running at half strength like last time. She takes a moment to analyze further, yeah, all his Kuret is going towards his wounds at half capacity. But unlike last time, he has too many wounds. He Kuret should be depleting faster, but he is somehow keeping himself just stable.

Matt scoffs, David isn't the only one not giving up huh. Have to admit, Charles is just as determined as David. Marina says, yeah. But I don't know how long he can keep this up. Suddenly the crowd let out a roar of cheer that vibrated from the entire stadium. I turned to the arena. David got up. He was covered in dirt and blood. Small lines of blood run on his face. There was blood around his stomach too. But since he was able to stand, even if he was leaning forward a little, he must be feeling okay.

Once he got his bearing and stood properly, he looks around frantically around until he spots Charles. After a few seconds, he catches our presence. We all waved him back. Matt screams, hey, shake it off. Marina shouts, get your ass up and win this already. Marina always got a way of words. I call on my Kuret. I use my Kuret to write just one word in the air. Win. I couldn't see his face from here, but that got to cheer him up. Derek smiles, but chose not to say anything. Probably wary of Kafar a little. Vanessa on the other hand went with a different response.

She shouts, you're crazy. I cracked up a hearing that. She is way too honest with her feelings. Others also got a good laugh hearing that. I don't know if David heard us, especially with the crowd going nuts behind us. David takes some time and then responds in a way which is simple and yet electrifying. He raised both his arms up and give us the two thumps up. The crowd goes wild once again seeing this. A never before atmosphere erupted among the crowd. People started to clap and a lot of them turned on their Kuret in excitement. Marina whistles, whoa. A wave a excitement has completely eclipsed the previous gloomy atmosphere.

Vanessa turns to us, M, is he okay to continue. M responds, with boss expect the unexpected. His vitals are still weak. However, its just strong enough for me to switch back to critical orange mode now. I would strongly suggest to be alert every second. The four of us, save Vanessa, felt relief hearing that. Vanessa was visibly frustrated. But after moment she couldn't help a smile, she says, typical David. How in the hell he is going to fight Charles in that state.

Matt says, that's if Charles makes a come back. For all we know, he is going to revert back any second. I ask Marina, any change on Charles. She shook her head, nothing. Still the same. At best it’s coin toss. If his Kuret stabilizes before he succumbs to his wound and before the clock runs out, he will make a recovery. Otherwise, he will revert back and lose. Derek, I hope you are ready with treating Charles. Derek nods, yeah. Since his body gets weak after matches anyways, so we have stand by medics dedicated for him. But I don't think they expected him to be injured this much. I messaged them a while back to be prepare for everything. So we are good to treat Charles.

I ask M, I hope it’s the same for David. M responds, boss current physical vitals are being considered every second. I am correcting his needed treatment in real time. All the injures are within the limits of the cryo bath. Vanessa says, that’s good to hear. We might just need it now. I think so too. I look at David, he was walking slowly towards a large boulder nearby. He slumped on the ground beside it, supporting his back on the large piece of rock. He brings one knee up and takes a resting posture.

Derek says, yeah. I would have done the same. Just wait out for now. Considering David's injuries, he probably would be more tired If he walked all the way to Charles and try to attack. Matt says, less than a minute left. Any chance of Charles waking up now. Marina shrugs, lets wait till the last second. The last time he got back his Kuret, it was within seconds. Vanessa says, come on. Don't jinx it. Marina responds, believe me, I want Charles not to get back up. I am just telling you what I know.

For the second time, we were conscious of another countdown. But this one we wanted it to go faster. Charles is wriggling on the ground, but he couldn't get up. Just a little more. 20 seconds. A wave of excitement flowed in the crowd with the countdown so close. 10 seconds, we were focused on Marina's charm. Charles Kuret was still low. Just when the countdown hit zero, Charles is still lying on the ground. Yeah, I waved my fist in air with excitement. Matt was jumping in joy, hot damn. The entire stadium erupts in frenzy. People are howling and shouting at the top of their voices.

Marina lets go of the Charm and shouts in enjoyment, booya. David won. Even Vanessa couldn't stop her excitement, bastard actually did it. He won against a freaking Heraknus alpha. Derek claps his hands while smiling, I can't believe Charles lost. Marina screams, you better believe it. Vanessa says, come on. Lets go get David. I nod my head with zeal, yeah. We all started to walk inside the dome. I looked at David. I can't see his face from here, I bet he is must be ecstatic. He was still sitting on the ground. Must be totally exhausted. Suddenly, there was a continuous pinging notifications coming from us. Then the same sound slowly started come from the crowd.

I turned back confused, What's going on. Derek chuckles while saying, don't know. Maybe the announcement of the winner I guess. Let me check. He looks at the tablet. Vanessa was already ahead me walking. She was more worried about David than the message. A moment later Derek stops laughing and angrily said, What. His sudden change in tone made us look at him. Vanessa stops in her steps and turns back, what the hold up. Derek's expression showed utter shock now.

I turned to look at the tablet. There was a message written, As per the rule, since one fighter is down, they will be given 5 minutes to get back. Unless the fighter is able to resume in this time limit, he will be disqualified and the victory goes to the person left standing. My joy crashed and burned after reading. What is this, I ask Derek. Others got worried and walked to us. The crowd also was also slowly quieting down. Derek then raised his head and closed his eyes dismayed, Kafar, he said.

Marina asks, wait. What's going on. She and Matt then read the message. Marina yells, this is bullshit. What's going on. Matt asks, what's with this. What in the actually hell. Vanessa's face darked hearing us, what's going on. What's does it say. Derek opens his eyes looking dejected, we had a rule that if one fighter goes down, but not completely, then he or she has 5 minutes to get resume fighting or get disqualified. Vanessa confused asked, yeah, didn't we just have the countdown.

Derek speaks with a stern voice, no. Technically that countdown was for a draw. Now its for a fighter disabled situation. Vanessa rebukes, what. That doesn't makes sense. Isn't the two same. Derek shook his head slowly, as I said, technically no. It’s a very clever loophole. Blake spats, it's a very scummy loophole. I grit my teeth with anger. Marina and Matt throw their arms around in frustration. Marina says, this is ridiculous. So not only did Charles got the 5 minutes, gets this 5 minutes to get his Kuret back. Matt yells, man this is absolute bull. We gotta stop this. David won. He can't do this.

I turned to Vanessa, who didn't say anything. She was pissed. I mean, like really pissed. She wasn't blinking and her eyes were throwing daggers at certain someone in the VIP room. I thought what to do now. Should we pull out David from this or let it continue. I couldn't decided what's the right thing to do. While technically the rule made sense, it was just nothing but a technicality. It clearly showed there was a bias against David here. Soon small people within the crowd began wooing, while others instead cheered. A mixed reaction to this announcement. Kafar is playing a very dangerous game here. He might be technically correct, but he is not showing impartiality. Would he show a similar consideration if Charles had got up before David did. We have Derek here, maybe he could have thought of it. But it would have to go through Kafar still, since he was the manager of the tournament. I shook my head disregarding my thought. There's no point in thinking about that.

I hesitantly ask Marina, what are the chances that Charles doesn't gets his Kuret in the next 5 minutes. She was cursing at the VIP room from here, clearly to Kafar, then turns to me. She sighs and answers, I don't know. But I highly doubt he will remain like this forever. I honestly don't think if David has enough luck for another turn. Matt kicks dirt from his foot in fury, come on. How much of this bullshit we should tolerate guys. First Charles existence was hidden from us, then he got away with a clear violation of the match rules and now this. Isn't this a match a little to much stacked against David.

Everyone were sure to think the same. However, our feelings weren't going to change the rules. If even they were twisted in ones favor. Behind us two people were walking to us from the arena gate. I could hear one of them swearing out loud as they approached. It was Jess and Cass. Cass is shouting on top of her lungs, let me go back now. I need to punch that arrogant little sorry of a man. Jess held Cass arms while walking, almost dragging Cass with her as they walk. Jess sighs, for the love of god. Calm down. You might kill him without knowing. Just forget it.

Matt turned around and asked, what's going on. He walked towards Cass who was throwing a fit. Jess says annoyed, control your girlfriend. Cass shouts back, let go. I don't need to be manhandled. She frees her arm from Jess. Jess makes a pleading expression with her face at Matt. A moment later Matt walks and grabs Cass's hand. He says, Mel, I think I have an idea what's going on. Try to get a hold of yourself. No matter how much we want to kick the day lights out of him, we cannot. Cass tried to pull her arm away, but Matt held firmly. She barks, shut up. Cass asked me to kill him. Matt eyes widen, really. I don't believe that. Not the kill part, but that she asked you for it. Mel grunted and then said, ah fine. She didn't ask anything. But she did call on me, so it meant she wanted me to do it.

Matt sighs and says a little forcefully, please don't make things more complicated. The situations already chaotic enough. Cass looks around to us. Her anger didn't quell down completely, but she stopped her tantrum a little bit. Matt let goes her arm. Cass puts her arms in a cross while muttering in low tone. I turn to Jess, thanks for helping with Cass. Jess nods, yeah, to be honest the room had become a little too much for me as well. I thought it would be best if we both come to you guys. You know, we have the team David here after all. She tilts her head towards Derek, except you of course.

We were silent for few seconds. In the last couple of minutes, our emotions have been a roller coaster ride. Marina says, we have 4 minutes now. She had once again casted Charles Kuret figure. She continues, so far no change in his Kuret. Matt asks, dammit. Well on the plus side, David's gotten time to recover. Vanessa finally breaks her silence, I can't take it anymore. Looks like she was in her thoughts about something. She just turned her back to us and starting to walk again to the barrier door. Vanessa, I ask, where are you going. She didn't stop, while answering with a cold voice, where do you think I am going. I am going to tell David about this and stop this match. He already won. This bullshit. I don't care if this within rules or not. Kafar had enough time to send that message after David woke up, but he sent it only after the countdown was over. You know what that means.

Derek spoke, I was thinking the same. He should have started the next countdown immediately when David woke up. But by waiting till the end, he gave at least a minute extra. In a situation like this, even a single minute might be enough to change the outcome. He shook his head with a little disappointment, I know Kafar's can be a little haughty, but never this devious. I didn't even realize that until Derek pointed out. Shit. How low Kafar's willing to go for Charles. Derek wasn't even trying to stop Vanessa unlike the other times. Does that mean he also thought we should end this match.

Cass scoffs, what are you saying. Kafar didn't do this. Yeah, he was the one who sent that message, but it was your boyfriend's idea, Vanessa. Vanessa stops walking and turns to her, what. Say that again. Cass shrugs, what. My eyes witch at this, wait, is that right. I ask Jess. She nods, just at the 30 seconds mark, Ned got a text message from someone and told Kafar about the rule. He said the rules didn't tell that one supersedes the other, so there's no problem having two countdowns like that. Well, not morally at least. Kafar had no idea about it until then. He was panicking so much and when he heard Ned's idea, he practically jumped out of his seat and sent out the message without checking with other admins first.

I was now even more angry. I don't know if Ned did it intentionally or not, but I am little shocked to see him go this far. I turn to Vanessa. In fact everybody's gaze were at her. Vanessa's was infuriated hearing this. Her hands turns turn to fist. Her anger is clearly now redirected to Ned. I don't know what's going on between them, but this clearly isn't helping. I spoke, Vanessa. Don't do it. Whatever you are thinking, just don't. No one is denying this is a terrible and a dirty tactics. But you agreed to give David a chance if Charles wakes up. So nothing has changed. We just have to wait another 3 minutes.

Vanessa didn't agree, but she didn't disagree also. I think she is more angry towards Ned right now than worrying about David. I'll taking anything to keep her from doing anything rash like stopping the match. Marina says, hey guys, what about David. Shouldn't we till him about this. Derek suddenly exclaims, shit. I was so focused this, I totally forgot about informing this to David. Everyone turns to the stadium. He was now standing up, leaning against the rock on his back.

I say to others, I got this one. I call on my Kuret. My hands covers with Kuret. I open my palm and make the Kuret to create words in the air. I wanted to keep it short to avoid wasting time, so the I drew the words - 3 min. Few seconds later David saw my message. Then I began preparing to change the Kuret to form other words. Then I saw David using his Kuret. I stopped for the moment to see what he was doing. He had is Kuret wrapped on his arm, however, only till his elbow. It’s was just the Kuret flames initially. Then it changed to the wild Kuret. Then finally, the latest form of his transformation happened.

What's he thinking. If he is still willing to fight, he should wait until Charles gets up. He should save his strength as much as possible. Vanessa breaking out of her thoughts said, he really is planning to continue this. Why is he not forfeiting. If Charles heals, he can't fight properly. I wanted to confirm David was prepared for this. In fact, I think everyone of Team David wanted to know it. I changed the message I was going to write and instead ask, sure with a question mark.

David either didn't see my question or he ignored it. He was now walking, albeit slowly towards the other side of Charles. He walks for some time and then halts near the edge of the barrier. He turns his back to the barrier and raises one arm up. The Kuret on his arm begins to flow out of him. They slowly spread out and began forming words. He wrote in our language. A few seconds later the crowd slowly begins to yell in excitement. I am surprised to see him this confident even in such a situation.

Vanessa asks under the noise of the crowd, what did he write. Marina says with a smile, he wrote a declaration of war in our language. To be exact, it means to will win no matter what thrown at him. It's like a popular motto from my and David's nation. A moment later she her smile turns a little awkward and says, ah, I mean I told him about this a while back. I didn't think he remembered it. Nice save Marina. She almost let it slip that he remembers Medrine.

Derek bluntly spoke, of course. David already figured it out. He probably this would turn like this even before it happened. Just think about it. He saw the crowd and us when then clock went zero. Yet he didn't show any excitement. No one, not even David, will be this humble when they win against a Heraknus alpha. He then turns to me, you know what that means if I am right. I take a moment to consider and then it hit me, he was prepared all this time to not forfeit the match. Derek nods agreeing with me.

While David's determination has always been rock steady, this match had thrown too many hurdles at him. Its beyond my imagine how he can keep it together even when the odds are against him. Vanessa says with a stern voice, this doesn't change anything. Even if David's ready to fight, lets stick to our previous agreement. We will stop the match when it becomes too dangerous. I answer, yeah. I totally agree with you. If Charles gets up, we should all be ready to step in anytime. I turn to Marina, we have about 2 minutes now. Is Charles close to getting his Kuret back.

Marina shook her head, it's not back. She focused a little more towards her charm, I learned what I need to keep an eye on from the last time when his Kuret starting coming back. At the moment I can't sense that. Matt says, so we still have a chance he won't get up, right. Marina couldn't answer that. Cass shouts, well someone believes this match isn't over just yet. Cass shook her towards David. Our gazes met David. He is already preparing for the battle.

He had his arms outstretched away in opposite direction. A layer of Kuret flows from his arm. The Kuret above him turns into a large round sphere. Then he slowly brings his arms closer, while the Kuret above begins rotating. My eyes immediately widen at those movements of arm. Those are the similar ones he tried to do in our match and earlier against Charles. Is he finally going to reveal it now. The Kuret above him suddenly starts to spin. Then it begins to collapse in size.

The Kuret around him suddenly turns to a storm. The Kuret from above merged into below and now there is a mini storm in front of him. The storm begins to rotate even faster now. The Kuret sparks we had seen earlier begins to come off the storm. The storm ever so slowly continues to shrink in size. Matt shouts, I know I will sound like a broken record, what the hell is this now. I take a moment and reply, this is it. I am certain of it. This is the power he has been hiding till now.

Everyone were surprised at my answer. Jess asks, this the one you mentioned earlier. Have you seen it before. I shook my head, no. I only recognize those specific movement of his hands. This is my first time seeing it in action. Vanessa asks, its about damn time. Why can't he didn't this do earlier. She takes a pause and then asks, a better question, why is he even doing it. Charles isn't ready to fight yet. I don't know. There were times when he could have done used it. Why only now.

Derek snaps his finger, time. He needed time to prepare. His answer caught our attention. He continuous, yeah. That’s it. That’s the only thing that makes sense why he waited this long. Whatever he is planning must take a shit load of time. Earlier I said David decided to wait out the countdown. I am half right. He was using the time to rest as well. At least whatever he could get from these mere minutes. And once he was ready, he does this. Derek made sense. But then another question came to mind.

The same question Vanessa asks a little irritated, how would David know he will be fighting Charles. We got what, a minute left, right ? She raises her eyes to Matt for confirmation. Matt nods and raises a single index finger. Vanessa continuous, it doesn't makes sense. Derek agrees, yeah. I don't understand that. Maybe David is just planning for a worst case. Or Maybe he can see something with his Synesthesia that we cannot see, something even Marina can't sense.

It made sense. David never does things recklessly. Well lately in the match, he had been in the beginning a little. But when given ample time, he always comes up with the best path. Even with David's declaration of war, it didn't stop use from feeling anxious. We were actually even more nervous at the 40 second mark. We kept our eyes glued to Marina's charm. So far nothing changed. Maybe all this worry was for naught and Charles wouldn't get his Kuret back.

However, reality is a bitch. At the 30 second mark, Marina yells, shucks. You have got to be shitting me. She spats her words out. Everyone steps closer to Marina. She says, I don't know how. But god damn, David might be a prophet for this one. Charles Kuret is coming back to him. Those were not the words we dreaded to hear. Everyone showed visible expression of distraught. Even Derek, on Charles side looked a disappointed. Vanessa turned her gaze to the arena in silence. Soon Charles will get back up and David would have to fight him again. So much for wishing that this would end without any more danger.

David (Chapter 26)

Monday, February 5, 2024 16:53

I am running. My feet hurts, my breathing is rampant and I feel my face burning from all the fires. I couldn't figure out where I am or where I am running to. But my body is too heavy to move. I am able to slowly recognize my surroundings. I see building half broken and burning. People lying on the streets and bleeding. Some were stuck inside the buildings that were falling apart. The red sky is covered with smoke and dust. I could hear ships flying above me in the sky being chased by other ships. The ship in pursuit launches a beam of blue energy that hits the ship running away. The ship catches fire on its wings and falls out of the sky. The ship descends in my direction. My breathing becomes more erratic when I see the ship falling on top of me.

I stop and turned back to run in the opposite direction. I tried looking around to find safely, but there is none. All the underground passages have collapsed and the buildings are falling apart on itself. Then the slow fear of my imminent death swept over me like never before. The ship crashes to the edge of the buildings and few of its body gets torn out in pieces. The pieces burned and were now falling even faster. I kept pushing my legs forward even when my bare feet were bleeding. I am never going to escape from the shadow of the pieces of building and the ship forming one me. I closed my eyes in shock and panic. I recalled thinking, this is where I will die. The shock of my death made me lose consciousness. My vision is blurry and my ears stops working. Just when I am about to be crushed by the falling ship debris, I hear someone's voice. I can't recognize who it is, but something felt familiar. The mysterious voice said, finally found you. My mind went hazy next.

Then suddenly I am being carried by someone. I felt my body shake as the person held me in the arms. My vision clears and I could see the face. I heard my own weak voice, Hansen. He looks down on me and replies, good, you are awake. I was worried you wouldn't. But thankfully you got treated before you lost too much blood. I roll my eyes to my legs. Just below my knee, there is a cloth wrapped around it. It was completely bloodied, but it stopped from more blood loss. I manage other words, what happened. Where am I.

He responds, you were in Langton. Someone found you and brought you to us just in time. I turn my head around to see people running around us. They were carrying other kids with this. Some carried on their arms, others used their Kurets to haul them as they ran. We were in a forest. The trees were burning and the path were covered in ashes. I turn my face to where Hansen is running to. There is a ship in front of this. I know this ship. I have seen it before. Hansen says, its almost a miracle you are here. This is the dantlement base hidden in Tangela empire. I can't believe he actually managed to bring you here in time.

My headache is so worse I couldn't make sense out the things happen. Who is Hansen talking about. Why am I on the opposite side of the planet. I felt something on my arm. I lift my arms up. It hurt when I moved. My whole body is so heavy I feel I am dying. I saw something on my elbow. It's some kind of bracelet. It was a purple colored stone shaped ornament. It had some words edged on it which I couldn't read as my shook from the running. I have never seen this before. How did I get it. I ask Hansen meekly, who. He doesn't reply me.

Suddenly we clear out of the forest clearing. The ship is in full view. It was massive and there is large entrance on the side. Others quickly hurried inside with the kids. I couldn't see who all were here, but some faces were familiar. Hansen halts near the entrance and then puts me down on the ground. My body lumps helplessly on the cold ashes, leaves and broken branches on the ground. Hansen says, this is as far I go. I grown and face to him, what. I couldn't see Hanses face completely. It's so hazy that I began feeling frustrated on why I can't remember it.

He says, you don't have to worry about me anymore. I knew from the beginning that this was my last job, to get you to this ship. I have fulfilled my promise. What promise, I wanted to ask. But my throat is paining. Hansen says, in time you will understand this. You once asked me how I know you will become strong, it's because I have seen your future. I never believed in fate. But now I know that you have a destiny to fulfill. You just have to trust me. Among all the shadows, no, all of Medrones, you have the greatest potential. I have witnessed it with my own eyes. I don't know when or how, you will find your path.

What's he walking about. I don't understand a word of what he is saying. I am the weakest of all the Medrones. I can't even use any Kuret. Behind him, another person approaches. I know him. I take some time to find his name. Its Brandon. The only senior who has helped me the most, guiding me throughout the college. He stops running when he sees us, you made it Hansen. He then turns to me. His face is also blurred out. Why can't I remember them properly. He says, you are here too. I can't believe this. He actually rescued you.

I ask with a cough, who. Brandon says, don't you know, its…Hansen cuts him off, don't. Its better if he doesn't know. You understand what he explained to you right. Brandon replies, he did. But I thought that…Hansen stop his, whatever happens is up to this young Medrone now. We shouldn't influence his path anymore than it already has been. A moment later Brandon says, okay. I don't understand most of it, but I know the stakes. He turns to me, Ryzen, I know this must be confusing for you. But just know that you are important. We can't tell you how we know. But know that you are.

I am in complete loss. What are they talking about. All my life I have been a loser until I became shadows, and that is only due to my intellect. Suddenly a forest behind them erupts in fire. The ground shook with the explosion. With my weak body lying on the ground, I felt the tremors all over me. Hansen says, they are close. They need to leave now. I croak, leave. Where. Hansen shouts, to Earth. This ship is going to take few people including you ahead. My head is throbbing even more when I heard the name Earth. My life's goal. But this is not how it's supposed to happen.

The forest erupts with another explosion. Brandon says, shit. They are getting closer. Hansen, tell the crew to take off. Hansen replies, what about your siblings. His voice turns grim, I couldn't find John. He got separated from Catherine before they arrived. I will look for him, but Catherine will have to take Johns place for now. Hansen says, okay. I believe all the kids are here. I'll inform the crew. Hansen is getting out of my view. I blurt out some blood calling his name to make him stop. He turns to me, Ryzen, remember what I said earlier. You are the best student I have had. You are now far more important than me. Don't forgot all the things I have taught you. This won't be easy for you. You'll be in lot of pain, you'll may even go mad, but then you will become strong.

With those cryptic partying words, he left us. I tried to move my arms and get up. I wanted to stop him. But my own weight was giving me pain. Brandon says, don't get up. You lost a lot of blood. I'll also need to leave Ryzen. I need to find my brother. He took my arms and carried me by my shoulders. My voice is gone at this point. I am so much in pain. I kept trying to call Hansen back in my mind. But I couldn't from any words with my mouth. Ryzen, Brandon asks, I need a favor from you. Its an unreasonable ask, but please take care of Catherine for me. If don't find John and I don't make it, she will be all alone. We have spoiled her rotten a bit too much. He makes a small laugh, she is not the strongest, but she has the biggest heart of us. I don't want to lose that part of herself. I can't imagine how much pain she will be. But I will be relieved if I know you are there for her.

I want to say no. Brandon can board the ship with his sister. Why can't he come with me. Why can't Hansen come with me. Why are they saying goodbye like this. No words came from my mouth. I couldn't even move my head anymore. Brandon continues, Just promise me you will do whatever you can to protect her. Please do it for me. I was too torn inside. His heartfelt request made me want to hide away. But I couldn't run away. This might be the last time we see each other. I blinked my eyes. He says, thanks you. I didn't want to put this on you, but you are the only one who could do it. Like Hansen said, you will need to get stronger. Not for Catherine. But for yourself too. Hansen is right you know. I don't know when, but you will become the biggest weapon against Hive.

I still don't understand them. Why are they choosing me. He carries me through the door. Behind him I heard my name being called out. Brandon turned us around just before we head inside. A person was running at us. She is carrying a small black box in one hand. Once got closer I could recognize the voice. It's Zakerine. My heart beats faster realizing she was safe. But before she could reach us the ground around us erupted when a bean of energy hit us. The whole ship vibrated and we fall off the door.

My mind went hazy again. All I feel is confusion, pain and more frustration on why I am not able to remember more. Remember? Is this a memory. Yes. This is a dream. I am dreaming right now. I heard Zakerine calling me in darkness. Wake up, she screams. I felt her warm hands on my face. She keeps calling my name and all I could see is darkness. She screams, wake up. You can't die. You have to get up right now. Her screams keeps me barely conscious. I don't want to lose her. I get all the courage I could muster and try to get out of this darkness. Her voice gives me the power I need. She screams one last time, wake the hell up.

At that moment, my eyes flutter trying to open. I feel cold on my cheeks. Then a moment later, my whole body felt cold. Where am I ? For few moments, I am caught up in the nightmare. I need to find Zakerine. She needs me. I need her. Then it all came crashing down when I realized what is going on. It's all a dream. No, a memory and nightmare. I can't save her. I can't save Hansen or Brandon, they are already dead. I felt brief but sudden anger swell in me. And then regret. I should have made her come with me. Then I calm down a moment later. I have already felt the pain of losing them already a year ago when my memories returned.

I gather myself before I completely get lost in my memories. The intense nightmare had caused me to sweat. That's the cold I am feeling. But where am I. What was I doing. My hearing is hazy. But I can see lights in front of me. Different colored lights. Just then, my eyes slowly open up. The world was turned on its side. I saw the sky on the right and ground on left. My breathing blows a little dirt away. Like a bolt of lightening hitting me suddenly everything made sense. I am in the middle of a match. I am fighting Charles. Did I also dream me flying in the sky.

No, that's real. I gather my strength and begin moving my body. I am lying on my stomach. Holy shit. I am completely awake. I recalled all the events that happened. Did I lost consciousness in the middle of a fight. I close my eyes and look for Charles glimmers. I could see his glimmer. He is farther away from me and not moving. What happened. How long was I out for. I don't understand. Why am I still here. I was knocked out, I should have lost the match already. Why am I waking up in the arena.

I focus on Charles brown glimmer, it's weak. Looks like my last attack did a big number on him. I see glimmers of his Kuret coming off him and healing him. Shit. Even after all that, he still isn't down. Dammit. This is too much. I should just quit the match already. I am here lying on ground, completely drained while Charles is healing himself. What chance do I have. Then it occurred to me, why isn't he attacking me. He could have ignored healing himself and just attacked me.

Something doesn't make sense. I slowly moved my body. My body felt like a brick, so heavy with sourness. It took me few seconds to roll over and lie on my back. My chest and stomach feels a lighter after being crushed underneath. My breathing is a little erratic, but considerably less constricted. My eyes flew open. I took a moment to recall the nightmare I just had. I have been getting pieces of my memories of the last day of Medrine back ever since I got my memories. I never full recalled the specific emotions or the details of the conversation. Until now. I only remembered the broader stokes of that time. Hansen saving me, Brandon carrying me and Zakerine giving me that box containing my only inheritance before they all died.

I could now remember the conversations just before we left Medrine. What in world were they taking about. I think I remember Hansen talking about destiny. Did he really said that. Hansen is the smartest I know apart from Zakerine. And we both shared the many similar sentiments. We never believed fate or destiny are real. Only coincidence and luck are real. For him to ignore logic and suddenly believe it doesn't makes sense. What did he know about me did he know that made him say that. Did he knew I had Kuret. Did he knew I was actually born on Earth. Did he knew my body would get stronger and even grant me special abilities. No. I didn't knew those things about myself until these past few years on Earth.

Even Brandon spoke I would become stronger. What did the previous generation of the shadows knew about my future. What's even crazier is that some of its becoming true. On Medrine I was undoubtedly the weakest Medrone. At least in terms of combat. But look at me right now. I am somehow at the level of some very incredible people. If my past self could see me now, he would just laugh it off like pure coincidence. But is it really. I suddenly can't believe in fate. But I believe they had faith in me, even when I didn't. While I didn't plan or want to become stronger, I have unconsciously been guided by their words. Even if I didn't remember it, my brain has been secretly using the emotions of that day to keep me going all this time. Is that why wanted this so badly. Because I owe them my life and get stronger for their sacrifice. Maybe. Maybe something else. But its definitely part of the reason. I want to be the strongest Medrone. A new emotion is rising in me. The need to become the best no matter happens. I won't stop. I don't think I can stop.

I tried to recall the conversation with Zakerine, but the memories are still hazy. I know we spoke more than what I remember. Maybe in time I will remember them too. I feel I am on the cusp of understand all my baggage. My PTSD and night terrors is tied to the last day on Medrine. Maybe recovering all the memories of that day is what will finally cure me. For now, I need to bring my focus to the match. Both Charles and I are still inside the arena. No one has won yet. I still have a chance.

I open my eyes. My body is too tired. I am covered in bruises and bleeding a bit. If I was in worse condition, then M would have definitely told Marina. I already programmed M to tell others to forcibly make me quit if I get more injuries than acceptable. I am awake now, M, would have detected that. And yet I don't see any signal from Marina. Unexpectedly, I smile a little. This means even with my current injuries, I can still fight a bit more. Then I starting to laugh. I can't believe I still have chance to win when I was knocked out cold. What are the chances of that.

But nothing will happen if keep lying here. I struggle a little getting up. But with deep breathing, I kept pushing oxygen in my blood and muscles. I carefully get up hoping to avoid any further injury with any cracked bone. I am so relieved to know that fall didn't broke any bone in my body. Holy god. I flew up so high, managed to attack Charles and somehow avoided getting my bones crushed. This is no luck. My new transformed Kuret protected me. That is incredible. This opens a whole new avenue for me. That Kuret form is the badass. And very difficult to control as well. All the movement caused by my Kuret sprained my body. It will probably take some intense training to learn it properly.

Once I got up I looked over to Charles. He is lying on ground, writhing in pain. I could red, yellow and blue Kurets coming off him even from here. One of his leg is mangled in odd shake. The other one is bleeding. His face and abdomen also is bleeding. I couldn't believe I did that. I even managed to wound him with the spikes when he kicked me. I started to laugh even more. Not because of the wounds, but because I finally realized why he is lying down. Now that I have a clear head, I can see the Kuret glimmers off him. Its not just weaker, its shrinking and fluctuating. He is having another Kuret blackout. Now this is luck. We knocked each other out. And since the match is still going on, I woke before M's red mode ended and the match five minute countdown.

All this time I have ignoring crowd in the stadium. But now that I am not focused on attacking or defending, I could see the glimmers of the Medrones coming off. My ears were filled with the crowds intense shouting. I couldn't tell from this far if they were cheering for me or Charles. But considering the situation, it had to be for me. I regained my confidence now. Then I caught glimmers of five recognizable individuals. They were standing near the barrier edge. There were two holes made.

I understood immediately. Marina made preparations to intervene if things went sideways. Actually things had already went off the rails already way earlier. I freaking flew for the first time in my life. I am sure they would have stopped the match seeing me fall with such less control. I can see its Vanessa, Blake, Derek and Matt. The way they stood, I could glean their plan. Vanessa and Matt would rescue or stop me while the other two were on Charles duty. Derek and Blake there made sense why the match hasn't ended yet. Especially Derek, he has a cool head and uses good judgement. They are why the other three haven't ended the match.

Suddenly all of them beginning waving at me. They were shouting something at me. Why are they shouting like that, I can't hear them at all. But seeing them so excited made me feel better. Blake even wrote win with his Kuret. My ego took a big boast seeing that. Even Vanessa was shouting with that looked it could be a cheer. But I am not convinced. Knowing her, and all the risky decisions I been taking, she is more likely reproaching me. Marina and Matt were visibly the most excited to see me.

I felt the urge to respond to their enthusiasm. Maybe this would answer the best how I am feeling right now. I raised two thumps up in the air. The crowd goes wild once again. And all five glimmers coming off them become a little stronger. Well that definitely made my day a little better. Then I turn back to Charles. Well, lets see figure out what's happening with the match. Since the countdown started, if Charles doesn't get up when time runs out, I win. But his Kuret blackout has been going for long now. I still don't know how long I was knocked out for. Maybe there's only 2 minutes left. Or even 5 seconds. Is this how I win. I contemplate about it a little. While I want to beat Charles fairly with my new found confidence, it wouldn't matter if he doesn't get back up. A wins a still win though. We can always fight another time.

But I something kept nagging me. I don't think some people want the match to end like this. Especially the ones behind the scenes meddling in my life and the tournament. Whoever spiked Marina and Blakes drinks earlier are still a mystery. But the intention is clear, control the flow of the matches. I don't think its Kafar. His personality might come out as a rude and annoying. But he wouldn't do something that drastic. Someone is behind him or controlling him. Whoever is supporting Kafar, they must have similar interests aligned. I have been suspicions why they would resort to such lengths to drop Blake and Marina out of the game like that.

I didn't had the answer then. But now, I think I do. The final ultimate champion of Citradel is a Heraknus alpha. Whoever is behind this wanted to make sure Marina and Blakes to drop out because they are probably the only people among all the Medrones alive powerful enough to possibly defeat Charles. It makes perfect sense now. Even if Charles is from a mythical bloodline, Blake and Marina are pretty powerful themselves. A dual Kuret true alpha with overdrive. And a prodigy caster alpha with overdrive. They didn't want these two compete against Charles. There is conspiracy going on here.

I need to figure this out immediately. But I also need to rest for the moment. If I am wrong about it, there is a chance I would win without doing anything. I have time, at least until the current countdown ends. I turn eyes around to look for a good place to rest. There is a large boulder nearby. It might the one Charles had attacked early in the match. I take small movements and walk over that area. Once I reach, I lean my back against it and slip down on ground. I pull one knee up and keep my hand on it. I close my eyes and lay back my head along the rock. This is no way comfortable, but it is sufficient. I don't know how much time I have. Every second of rest my body gets is crucial.

I take a deep dive into my thoughts to confirm this theory. If Marina had lost, Vanessa would have advanced. Would they had poisoned Blake even if he was fighting Vanessa. I don't can't be sure of that completely, however, the chances are high. Marina was poisoned because she was a potential finalist. It makes sense Blake would have been poisoned too since he was too a potential finalist. So regardless of whether Vanessa or Marina won, Blake was always supposed to get poisoned. But he wasn't when he fought against Marina. It could only mean one thing, they didn't care who won with its Marina or Blake. Even if they poisoned one of them, they are both potential dangers to Charles. That has to be the reason they weren't targeted then. They would just target the one who goes to the semi-finals. Which is what happened.

The entire plot is slowly sense to me now. Derek or I weren't spiked for our match. So again, they didn't care who won. If Derek had won he would be fighting against Blake or Vanessa or Marina. They wanted Marina and Blake to lose before semi final. Then Vanessa would become the one of the finalist among the three. And the other one would be me or Derek. What would have happened in a match between Derek and Vanessa. I don't want to belittle them. If Derek won against Vanessa, then the whole tournament is moot anyways. Derek already said he wasn't strongest in Citradel, so even if the finals happened, Derek looses and we all move to Citradel. Lets suppose Charles didn't want to fight or forfeits the match against Derek, the result is the same, we all move to Citradel.

Then what about a match between me and Vanessa. Honestly, I am not sure who would win. I might be a little biased, but I do have my ace against Vanessa. Apart from Derek, her Kuret is the best advantage over my Kuret. So I developed a plan against both of them. If someone asked me before this match what my chances were, I say 60/40. But now after learning my new Kuret transformation, I think its more like 90/10 in my favor. I don't think Vanessa is so much weaker than me, but objectively speaking me winning is more likely. I don't think she would be able handle my trump card.

I am digressing now, so I change my thoughts. Lets assume Vanessa had won against me or Derek. She then faces Charles. Charles would definitely fight her. I might be a little rude, but I don't think she can win against Charles. So Charles wins again and we move to Citradel. So we have now 2 of 3 scenarios which favors Citradel winning always if their planned had worked without interruption. And finally it comes to a scenario where I win and I battle with Charles. Since I uncovered the poison in the drinks, I don't know if they were planning to poison me in the finals. More likely not. The whole world knows Marina, Blake, Derek, Vanessa, Nathan, Tessa, Catherine were the favorites for the finals. Its bad luck of draw Catherine got matched up early with me. She could have defeated June and be in semi-finals.

Even if I was titled a dark horse, I wasn't a real threat for Charles. I laughed a little more now. I figured out the entire plot against us. They waited until the last rounds of matches to evade suspicion. It would be too much of a shock to eliminate Blake and Marina in the beginning. They had everything planned it very carefully. Making sure Charles win every scenario. But what they didn't expect is me. I figured out something wrong with Marina before she left and asked her to clean her blood. I didn't know she was poisoned back then, doesn't matter, Marina cleaned her blood at my request and dissolved the poison unknown to both of us. Then I stopped Blake from drinking the poisoned water. Interrupting their plan again.

But what's ridiculous is that this is match is still within a possibility in their plan and they believed I am going to be defeated. So even though their plan has been disrupted considerably, I am still inadvertently within the predicted matchups. Whoever is behind this is a true mastermind genius. To make such a devious strategy, I have to find who it is. Hopefully the spy I have employed is getting closer. Lets forget about the identity for now. I bet they never thought I would win against Blake or even become someone a threat to Charles. So this leads to my final conclusion. They will do whatever they can to make sure I lose. The violation that Charles did by almost killing me was a problem, but the match never stopped. I don't know if its because of Kafar's or others. Its possible its the person or people behind this whole conspiracy. Then they also can't have Charles loosing like this with his Kuret blocked.

If they are fine with incredibly dangerous plans to make sure Marina and Blake gets eliminated, they are not beyond bending the rules blatantly. They can't have Charles lose like this. They want desperately for Charles to win and for us to move to Citradel. So how they go about it. I quickly went through the rules once again. Loopholes, there has to be some here. As I spent time thinking about it, I saw glimmers of small light blue all over the stadium. I opened my eyes and gaze over the crowd. Something has happened. The excitement they had had gone down a little, in fact I felt mixed glimmers of emotions coming off people. What was that glimmer, I could faintly hear some sound flowing all around the stadium.

Few seconds later I realized it was a notifications sent to all the people tablet. I turned my eyes to the five nearest people. The excitement they showed earlier had was no longer there anymore. I saw Marina kicking the ground, Matt shoving his arm in the air. Those movements doesn’t look like people who are happy with something. Did we hit the countdown. I didn't know, but something had clearly changed. No one is coming in to stop the match. I waited for few more seconds, but none of them came through the door.

I see two new glimmers in the mix. It's Jess and Cass. It looked like Jess was dragging Cass with her. Then I think Vanessa was stopped from coming inside the barrier. I can't be sure from here. It’s a shot in the dark, but I think something unexpected has happened with the results. I feel like I hit bullseye when I thought this match won't be over like that. Someone found a loophole with the match. As I went through the rules, I found 3 rules that could have been applied now.

I decided to be prepared just in case. I got up from the ground and leaned my back against it. Being knocked unconscious and having this much rest has given me much needed respite. I am no where near battle ready. But I don't need to be. If I am right about the loopholes, there is chance I will have to fight soon. And even if Charles gets his Kuret back, those wounds will take long time to heal. I have bought enough time to use my trump card now.

First one, they will postpone the match because of violations from both us. Charles tried to kill me earlier, and now my arial strike could also be considered a violation. So they should disqualify both of us. But since this is finals, they instead postpone it. Second one, its very clever and scummy. They would run a new countdown for a opponent down situation. This would provide Charles the time to possibly recover his Kuret back. Since we never mentioned the rules for draw or disqualification don't supersede one another, this is possible. And third, delay the match by creating a medical emergency for Charles due to his Kuret blackout. That way they could say the match has to be delayed further until he recuperates.

My moneys on the first one. The other two are way two risky. It would show clear bias against me. They would be interrupted that Charles is given preferential treatment. At least with the first loophole, both of us are equally blamed for violations. Its also possible there are some other loopholes I am missing. With such limited time and no communication, I have no idea what's going to happen next exactly. I kept close eyes on the seven individuals now. Maybe they would provide some useful hints.

After some more time, I saw Blake writing 3 min with his Kuret. God dammit. Loophole number two wins. They intentionally choose a risky move. Was that a statement that they didn't care how it looks like as long as I lose. But this confirmation proves everything I deduced was true. I also immediately understood one thing. Our match will never end in a draw or disqualification. Even if the match gets postponed, they will make sure this doesn't end any other way than a clear decisive victor. I should be totally furious that someone is targeting me to lose. But unexpectedly I am not. When I woke up, I wanted to win at all cost. That feeling hasn't gone away even after knowing someone has been manipulating the match against us. In fact, I am more confident than before. Weird.

Hansen and Brandon words have effected me quite a bit. I have to meet their expecting. I will be one step closer once I win against Charles. I will win against anything thrown at me. Be it Charles or whoever's hiding in the

shadows. I am briming with complete determination. I spoke out loud, its time to finally reveal my trump card. I have the perfect opportunity to use it. To be honest I wanted to keep it hidden if possible. But the only other option would be use my new Kuret transformation.

That’s not happening. I am way to tired to use it now. And even if could use it, it would be a risky gamble. The transformation is completely in a whole new level. I need to study it and train properly. For which I don't have the time to do right now. But like Vanessa says, nothing goes according to plan every time. Using my ace would open a can of whole new problems later. I initially planed to use it against Hive only. Using it now would accelerate the situation I want to create way earlier than I thought.

But then I almost used it against Blake. And now, without it I can't beat Charles. So clearly, my personnel emotions are taking priority right now. Whether revealing is correct or not, I didn't have the luxury to think anymore. One thing is fore sure, I am going to shock the entire world.

Vanessa (Chapter 27)

Saturday, February 3, 2024 01:25

Nothing works out the way we want things to happen. My emotions were such in turmoil, I didn't know what I am supposed to feel. I was worried sick about David. Then he finally woke up, I got angry at him. Then even more when I had to agree to wait this out. Then Jess tells me Ned went out of his way to help Charles. I understood a little that he only did it because he picked Charles. And I made my peace with it. But what turns me mad is that he wants David to lose this much.

Maybe I was reading too much into it. But his earlier outburst showed his true emotions. I thought I could keep it together, but I am mad at myself also for not being able to stop getting mad at Ned. The only thing that made me break out of the swirl of emotions was David declaration. Its incredible, he believes he can still win the against the all powerful Charles. I can't help being impressed with him right now. To think that when I met him all those years ago, struggling against someone like Toby, and now he is powerful enough to stand against a mythical alpha.

But that didn't stop me from being any less mad at him. He also has never been this reckless before. Is winning matters so to much him. I don't think anyone would call him out for forfeiting now. Everyone knew exactly just how crazy strong he has become. I still had some unresolved regret for not being able to fight him during the tournament. How would that outcome would be now that I have seen what's he capable of now. Everyone thinks my Kuret had the best chance of beating his. Even I thought I had advantage over him. But now, after seeing his sudden growth. I am not so sure.

I felt more unsure about our hypothetical match when I saw David finally reveling his trump card. I can't figure out how this new Kuret storm he brew gives him edge. Maybe like Derek said, he needed time to prepare. It wouldn't be surprising if his Kuret does something unexpected next. He kept making the storm smaller around him. Maybe he is trying to prepare his Kuret to take a physical shape that helps with his exhausted body. With so many transformations, I can't be even sure of anything.

It didn't made sense to do this when Charles is still down. What did he see with his Synesthesia. And finally in the last seconds, Charles Kuret comes back. Like I saw earlier, Charles Kuret begins filling in the charm Marina had created. What little hope we had that David would win without fighting any further, they were gone just like that. Matt yells frustrated, oh come on. Why does this happen just at the last moments. Marina shook her head with pouting her lips, it’s a freaking joke, that’s what it is.

We turn our heads to the arena, now towards Charles. His Kuret begins to move faster. Those wounds on him were finally getting healed. With slow movements, he got up. The crowd goes wild again. People are shouting and getting excited at the sight of Charles giving a loud roar. He didn't move immediately, instead he remained still as he continued to recover his missing Kuret body. Blake says dejected, all that time David spent wearing him down as much as possible, every wound he has, all will be for naught in some time. That is perhaps the most terrifying and maddening power of a Heraknus. The only thing David managed to do was buy enough time to recover a little and prepare his Kuret.

I knew exactly how Blake felt. I was frustrated at this as well. David might have the best Kuret to fight against Charles, but even then its not enough. On the other hand, David didn't seem effected by this. He continued to work on making that Kuret storm smaller. I wondered what kind of new Kuret form are we going to see. Sure hope its enough to bring down Charles. Otherwise, I am charging in and stopping this match. Marina collapses her charm and scoffs, Charles got back his full access to Kuret.

I ask her, keep an for David's injuries with M. The moment anything happens let us know. Marina nods and raises her wrist to show M's hologram to everyone. It had a little less colors around his body, that’s a good sign at least. Perhaps getting about 5 minutes of rest did just enough to keep him going. Matt walks to me and stands on my left. Blake and Derek stand against the other barrier door. Marina, Jess and Cass hung a little behind us. Charles was almost healed after another minute. His wound had closed and the Kuritines were growing on his body. Behind him, his tail regrew to the original size. They were sporting new Kuritines on the ends. And just like that, he was all healed up.

Blake says, get ready guys. Charles lets out a ferocious roar and begins charging on David on all fours. The way he moved hardly made sense because he was lying on the ground so helpless for the last 10 minutes. He doesn't even look like someone who was in trouble just now. Meanwhile, David didn't even bother to move. He was still working on the Kuret storm. He probably decided to not evade anymore, not with all his remaining stamina. David is now within Charles range. Everyone here leans forward towards the barrier in case of any trouble. I am a nervous recked than even before. Charles leaps into the air when he got close and brings his claws to slash David.

What happened next went beyond my wildest expectation. Just at the last moment, David's Kuret storm broke a little and made a hole. A bright white ray burst out, it hits Charles right in the middle. I couldn't believe what I am seeing. Charles was thrown backwards before his claws could reach David. The white light threw him backwards with a tremendous force. Charles arms and legs sways in air helplessly as he gets dragged away from David. He gowns as he was dragged away. In a desperate attempt, Charles tried to stop himself with his feet and tails. The grounds tears up when he couldn't find enough grip to stop himself. And soon enough, Charles was heading towards a collision course towards the barrier.

Marina shrieks, holy mother of god. A large thump sound vibrated the entire arena when Charles gets hit with the barrier. He was helplessly getting crushed between the invisible wall and the white ray crushing him. Charles looked like a wild animal trapped and trying desperate to get out. What the freaking hell. What's going on. It wasn't just us. The entire crowd had gone quieted down to almost silence. What did David do. Is that white light is his Kuret. No. This isn't his Kuret.

Matt shouts, what the hell. How is David doing this. From the barrier door, we could small gust of wind escaping from the incredible power of that white. Jess cries, hey don't tell me this is what I think it is. Is not possible, right. My jaw hung down. I don't understand what's going on. I yell, Marina, what the hell is David doing. Can you tell. Marina shouts, I am clueless. A moment later she says, one thing is for sure, that white light, its Kuret. Not David's black Kuret, but it’s a the most purest form of Kuret. The one I used against you in our match. But not at this scale or this powerful.

Derek, who usually remained calm seeing David's every transformation, finally couldn't stop from freaking out, impossible. Its just not possible. He has anti-Kuret. How is it possible for him to use normal Kuret. Pure Kuret on top of that. I don't understand this at all. Cass shouts while laughing loudly, freaking hell. This is nuts. Someone tell me this not a dream right. To be honest, I was feeling like that as well. Blake responds, nope. This is real. What in the world David do in that Kuret storm.

Marina says, all the normal Kuret around him gets broken down. I don't even sense much Kuret around him in the air. I don't sense Kuret inside that storm. Not like I ever could. But as soon as the white light leaves, I could tell that its Kuret. Then she starts to laugh hysterically, I can't believe what's I am seeing. I noticed something on Charles. My pull my jaw back and ask, hey guy, doesn't it look like Charles Kuret body is cracking. His Kuret is leaking out. It looked like that. Charles was getting hit with pure Kuret. His Kuret couldn't hold properly against the pressure he was feeling from both side.

Now Blake starts to chuckle a little, freaking shit. Look at David, he is getting dragged away too. My eyes turn to David. Like Blake said, the force of that Kuret ray was too much for him. He was slowly getting dragged away. But Matt asks, whoa whoa. Is he okay. David wasn't struggling, unlike Charles. He let himself get skid across the ground. He is getting dragged back towards the opposite end of the barrier. A few seconds later, he was stuck on the barrier on his back, like Charles.

Derek, controlling his shock a little says, Marina. This is bad. The barrier will break if this continues. I don't know how that white Kuret is coming out, but his black Kuret is still there. Marina shakes off her smile and instead bites her teeth, oh shit. We made the barrier in consideration to David's Kuret. If it was just him, the barrier would hold. However, she turns to Charles, he also getting putting pressure on the barrier. Blake immediately says, this is not good. If Charles is thrown outside, he will hit the people sitting on the stadium.

He turn behind, Jess, Cass, come with Derek and me. We will go and get the people around that area to evacuate. Derek agreed, yes. Lets go hurry. Derek's turns to me, but I cut him off before I could say, Matt and I got David. You guys focus on that. Derek gives a slight node and turns his back to me. The four them began to sprint around the barrier edge. People around us were shocked to see this unbelievable spectacle. Some continued to cheer and some straight up began yelling in panic.

Only me, Matt and Marina stood here. Marina had begun casting a charm. Her charm created a pieces of Kuret and they flew to be merged with the barrier. Matt asks her, tell me it will hold. Marina didn't respond immediately. She was in zone and solely focused on strengthening the weaking barrier. I shout back into the air, what the hell are you doing David. Stop this now. It was waste to say when he couldn't hear me. He needed to be stopped. I turn to Matt, lets go to David. Let others deal with Charles and Marina can keep working on fixing the damages. I don't know if we can stop David, but its better than to just stand here and do nothing. Matt nods, Yeah. He turns to Marina, you good Marina. Marina nods her head signaling us to go. We both waste no time and began sprinting towards David. We had to cover quite some distance, but I hope we could reach David before the barrier gives in. Matt shouts, Vanessa, look. Matt running beside me points to the white Kuret in the middle of the arena.

The beam was slowly tilting upwards. I spat out, what. I twist my head and look at Charles. Charles was getting pushed up in the air along the barrier. Matt grunts, what’s this now. A moment later I realized what's happening, David is trying to move Charles up in the air to avoid the people on the stadium. Matt replies, what. Why doesn't he just stops it altogether. We covered some more distance before realizing something, maybe he can't control it. I mean it’s a white Kuret. David can only control his black Kuret.

Matt shrieks, freaking hell David. I could see David now. He was covered in dirt all over. He had torn his clothes in too many places. He was covered in stains of his own blood. His face was a picture of utter hell with blood covered on one side and bruises on the other side. He was leaning on his back against the barrier. Both his arms were still inside the Kuret storm. Its as if he is trying to stop the Kuret storm from getting pushed back. He was slowly trying to move the white Kuret above.

The barrier around was becoming incredibly unstable. Marina won't be able to keep it together for long. I just hope others are able to move the people out of the way in time and David keeps moving Charles higher. The white bean was now almost close to the edge of the stadium. I saw Blake using his Kuret to move people out of their seats. Jess created a Kuret slide for people to hop on and get down quickly. Derek made the air denser and carried people on top of it to safely. Cass, on the other hand, wasn't that delicate with her approach. She was actually hurling people out of their seats and throwing them down. Blake worked double time to catch the people flying in the air and making them land safely.

There were other guards helping out there as well. I saw one flying away with carrying few people. Another one was manipulating the cement to melt the seats and create a better path for people to run. Good thing we have capable Medrine here to protect the crowd. We were now close to David. I yell out loud, David. Stop this before you hurt anyone. David didn’t turn around and instead shouts back, help me. I don't have control over this. Shit, I was right. He really can't control the white Kuret. The barrier had too many holes. And wherever they weren't, cracks had appeared.

We both came to a halt once we were behind him. Matt asks, what do we need to do. David says, I am going to be pushed out any second now. Vanessa, create a tornado behind me to keep me getting blasted away to the arena wall. I already figured he wanted me to do something like that. I had formed a small gust of wind. He grunts a little, Matt get prepared to grab me from behind and make sure I don't get pushed away. Matt replies, you got it. He runs behind David. I channel more Kuret into the air and form a tornado strong enough to counter the force David was facing.

The people on the seats besides us had already been evacuated by the guards. With a sudden thumping sound, the barrier behind David broke. David was hurled backwards. Matt catches David with his arms on David's back. I yell, Matt hold on. Matt nods when I push the tornado behind him. The combined effort of us both kept David from getting pushed back further. David is biting his teeth hard, almost there. Just one more push. With a yell, David moved the white Kuret even higher.

In the opposite direction, the barrier finally broke. Charles was thrown outside. With nothing to stop him, he was bashed near the edge of the stadium. The building begins to shake and crumble away in pieces. Good thing Charles crashed near the top of the stadium. People had time to get clear away from that area. Charles was thrown out, leaving behind an chunk of the edge stadium gauged out. After few seconds, the white Kuret becomes thinner. Just then David dispels his Kuret storm.

The white Kuret is finally cut from the source. Without it anymore, my tornado pushed Matt and David forward uncontrollably. David yells, Vanessa. Oh shit. I was distracted and didn't realize I still have my tornado. I quickly dispel the tornado. But I was too late. Matt and David were thrown into the air a little. With a wave of my arm, I through a gust of wind from the other direction. They both get hit by it and get pulled down. Fortunately, they were not too high. Matt managed to grab David just before the fall and lounged himself underneath him.

David lands with his back against Matts back when they hit the ground. I ran towards them as they fall like dominos on ground and roll off the grass. Matt grunts face first into the ground. David rolled away and lies on his back. I cry, oh shit. David. I am so sorry. Are you okay. I panic a little as I crotch down near David's face. David bellows a little, argh. Its okay. I used my Kuret to break my fall a little. I put my hands on his arm giving him support to get up. Beside me Matt gowns, oh don't worry. I am also okay. He turns to the side and lies back on his ground. He had dirt covered on his face, he spats out dirt from his mouth, my Kuret didn't work when you landed on me. Thanks for that.

David stumbles a little when I help him up, he says, Sorry. I had no other choice. He turns to me, appreciate the save. I don't know what would have happened if you guy hadn't come over here. Seeing him up close and safe, I felt a little relieved and calmed down from all the anxiety I had. I nod as he lets go of me to give Matt an arm and helps him up. He pulled Matt up. Matt dusts off the dirt on him, Thanks. But dude, just what the hell is going…Then like a bubble bursting all my emotions comes to the surface.

I blurt out before he could finish, David. What the hell. Have you gone crazy. David turned to me with a little surprised look. Really, it shouldn't come a shock for him. I continue, do you how many times you were almost killed. What's were you thinking attacking doing all those insane stunts to defend against Charles. What's going on with your Kuret. You transformed so many times, it feels completely different now. And why the hell did you fly so high. You got yourself almost got killed with that. Do you have any idea how much me, and others were worried about you when you didn't wake up. Do you know any idea how close we came to stopping the match. I can't even begin to understand what you have been thinking all this time. I take a short breath, and what in the name of god was that white Kuret.

David was bamboozled with my questions. No, he is probably shocked to see me so overwhelmed as I spoke. To be honest, I surprised myself. I even shocked Matt with my ranting. David composed his expression, I am sorry. That’s I can say. I am sure my actions worried you. He pauses and then says, to all of you. And I will explain it later. Or at least try to. So calm down, Vanessa. He smiles a little. He had the nerve be so clam about the situation, even finding it amusing. It was annoying the hell out of me.

However letting all my thoughts made me feel better. I sigh and shook my head, you ass. How the hell are you so clam right now. Matt continues, yeah dude. You can't even fathom what been happening in the VIP room upstairs. I know you were having a terrible time here, but it wasn't exactly a picnic for us too you know. David smirks a little, I bet. And I will hear all about it later. But we are still middle in the match. I need to finish this. Hearing him say that, my jaw opened a little unconsciously. I spit out, what. Have you lost your mind, you want to continue.

Matt is also shocked to hear that, shut the freak up man. You literally blasted Charles out of the stadium. You already won. David shook his head, nope. Technically, both Charles and I were thrown out of the bounds together. So basically its a draw. He sighs a little, no way that Charles or Kafar going to stop the match. I yelled out him, you think we will allow you to continue the match in your condition. You are clearly exhausted, got injuries everywhere and taken beating all over.

David replies, the only other way is to forfeit the match. He takes a pause and says softly, And for personnel reasons, I have decided to win this match no matter what. I was shocked to hear him say with such determination. His earlier actions showed his will, but when he showed it in words, he was oozing with confidence. I go so far to say he was a little bit arrogant too. Something seen very rarely on him. Matt asks, wait what. What the hell happened during the match dude.

David bluntly says, many things happened. And yet I don't know myself for sure. What I know is that I am defeating Charles at all cost now. He then turns his back to us and faces the arena. He closed his eyes and stood there for a few seconds like that. Both Matt and I were too stunned to speak. This is something I can't believe David saying with so much confidence. Does he think his trick with white Kuret is making him complacent. A moment later I thought threw that thought. Even if he was a boastful here, he wouldn't fight without a plan.

He opens his eyes a moment later and lets out a long breath, that’s a relief. No one got hurt. Everyone reacted fast enough to move people away. So he was checking up the crowd with his Synesthesia. Matt says, look. Even if you say you want to win, there's no point if the match doesn't continue. David responds, do you really think Kafar will allow the match to end like this. His can't have his prized champion, who by the way is okay and will soon be back, end the match like this. I don’t know exactly what's been going with others. But I can made pretty good guess. He continues, you guys tried to stop this match when Charles violated the rule by almost intentionally killing me. But Kafar, maybe even Derek, put a stop to that. And now you all couldn't stop Kafar after figuring out that loophole.

He is right. He figured it almost all of it. But he didn't know it was Ned who brought it up the loophole. I wanted to correct him, but I couldn't do it. I was actually ashamed a little. I couldn't tell him Ned voted against him. Matt says, ah. Yeah pretty much right. Except it wasn't… I cut in before he would say further, but Kafar won't allow the match continue when people safely is compromised. I couldn't believe I am covering for Ned here. Matt understood my intention not wanting to reveal that. David looked at me a little trying to figure out my rudeness.

Then he says, you think that will stop him. With the lengths he has gone to conduct his match, hiding Charles, making out him to be an ultimate weapon and even stretching out the rules. He then looks to the ground, no one got hurt. And yes, I am at fault for that danger. But clearly, it was an accident. I actually surprised my own power with that. Anyways, the solution to avoid this again is simple. Erect an even stronger barrier. Tell Marina to use the Arvada spell that uses physical Kuret properties instead of the one she used. She will understand. A moment later he says, she will be reluctant a little so let her know that I will be owing her big for making her do that.

I didn't understand how he knew what it was or how he knows it would work. They must have discussed it earlier. Matt says, hold on. You say Kafar will do whatever he can to keep the match from being a draw. I am not sold on that. I mean, that was just a lucky fluke when, he paused to look at me and then clears his throat, I mean, finding that loophole. You don't have to continue the match. We can put an end or at least postpone the match for a while. We can figure out a way to stop this, especially if you want to.

David thinks for a moment, maybe if we had more time. But like I told you. I also don't want to end the match like this. He takes a pause, and besides, do you think that was the only way to continue the match in that moment. I know of two other ways Kafar could have made sure Charles or I weren't disqualified. I knew after I woke up, that no matter what happens the match will continue until we have one clear victor. And that works perfectly for me since I also want that.

I couldn't speak for a while. I ask, what do you mean there were other ways. How could… he raises his hand to stop me, don't get me wrong, it would have great if I was wrong and the match ended there. While I want to win, I know Charles is too much for me in my state. If there was an easy way to end this match, I would have done it already. I don't want to risk this much when I am not even fighting Hive or Echo. But in every scenario I can think of, there will always be trick, a loophole, a way for Kafar to keep continuing the match. So I have no choice but to resolve myself. I can either forfeit myself or purposefully lose to end this match immediately. None of which I will do it myself.

Matt says, how can you know that Kafar or someone will keep getting in the way of ending the match. David replies, I can't answer that at the moment. You'll have to just trust me. A moment of silence came between us. The people around the stadium were buzzing and moving around. Loud chatters of confusion and shouting were erupting among the people. But the guards were coordinating the people to adjust the rowdy crowd. The hole that tread the stadium had stabilized. Some guards were roaming around there to inspect the damage.

David suddenly says, he is back. A sound of roar filled the air around us. It was Charles. Large thumping noise could be head coming from the arena gates. David starts to walk inside the ground. Matt says, whoa dude. Hold up. You are serious about this. David nods while leaving us, just trust me. I know what I am doing now. I know you guys saw me fumbling at the beginning of our fight, but now I am in control. I am totally stunned seeing him like this. His arrogance and blatant disregard of danger was something I never seen before.

I ask before he leaves, you could die. You hear me. If something goes wrong, you might die. You think you can still win in your condition. David stops in his tracks. He turns he head to me. There's a deep silence between us. He then finally breaks it, I won't die. That’s a promise, if things go beyond my expectation and becomes incredible risky, I will drop out. But until then, I have a way to win, even now. He smirks as he says, this is nothing. Wait till you see my complete trick. A small shiver went down my spine hearing those word. I shriek, what. You are kidding right. I don't even know how you can use white Kuret. David ignored my question and continues walking, trust me. Wait for the announcement telling the match will resume, tell Marina what I told you. And oh yeah. On more thing.

He takes some time to say the words, what you saw was just the tip of the iceberg. Tell others you haven't seen the real shit yet. With those parting words David left us speechless and walked away. Me and Matt turn towards each other and lock our eyes in utter shock. Matt whispers to me, Vanessa, what the freak just happened.

Vanessa (Chapter 28)

Saturday, February 3, 2024 20:50

What just happened. Matt and I just started each other and to David's back as he walks away slowly. I came here thinking I would be able to stop David, but now all I could was see him continue fighting in such a state. Matt clears his throat, jeez. What now. He is asking my advise. I am confused as hell at the moment. I am almost tempted to knock David down and carry him back. I can tell everyone that last attacked knocked him out. Matt would definitely cover for me if I did it. Then, I recalled David's unshakable confidence. He said he still has more to us. I think I had my fill of surprises for today.

I reply, as much I want David to quit, he isn't going to listen to us. So for now, we got no choice but to let him continue if the match resumes. Matt eyes widen, and you are okay with that. I shook my head, absolutely not. But David didn't left me with much choice. So lets just had to Marina and tell her about that barrier. Matt nods slightly mixed with an anxious look. We both began walking back the way we came from. The crowd was restless than ever. Some people were asking the guards what's happening, others were arguing something. Matt sees me checking up on people, what a mess, right. If David's right, then we should be hearing from Kafar and the admins about their decision with the match.

I reply, I still can't believe we will allow this match to continue after that accident. Suddenly Charles barged out of the arena gate. The doors tore away from the hinges as he emerges out. The doors lands on opposite sides of him. He had appeared from a distance, and yet we could see Charles Kuret body was shredded in pieces. That pure Kuret blast crushed all his Kuretines and shaved off Kuret over his body. His jaws and face was healing, but we could see it almost cut in half. His body had even shrunken in size. Two of his tails were cut of in the middle. Charles roars loudly and sprints into the arena. I got worried that he might attack David immediately. But he stops in his tracks after entering inside some distance.

He did something unexpected, he sat down on the ground. His ached body breathes heavily and his arms hung on the sides. Matt whistles, wow. Not even Charles is able to shake that attack off. I reply, I am actually relieved to see even Charles has to rest and heal from getting hit from that pure Kuret beam. We both resume our journey back. I turned to see David. He was back again preparing another Kuret storm. I stammer a little seeing him, seriously. That wasn't a one off attack. I was sure that David would be too tiered to try this again or had to wait some more time before doing it again. Matt answers, man, if we see more attacks like that, then maybe David will win.

I wasn't sure. David might be a little over his head with his attitude. I am still reeling a little bit with his sudden demeanor change. Looks like his Kuret wasn't the only thing that transformed during the match. We arrived back at the spot we left earlier. Marina is still here. But she wasn't alone anymore. Nathan and Ned were here as well. They were in the middle of a conversing when we came. Nathan is speaking Marina, to the officials. I left after they wanted just the admins in the room. Nathan turns to me and raises his head up. He asks, you guys are back. So how's our mighty warrior. Still in the game. He asks with a smile.

I ask him instead, what are you guys doing here. Ned didn't respond. He instead looked behind me and watched David. I didn't know what I would do if I keep talking to him, so I choose to just ignore him for now. Nathan replies, I was just explaining to Marina that Kafar in a call with all the officials. They our discussing on how to proceed. Since it was none of my business, they kicked us out. Matt asks, where's Catherine and Tessa. Nathan says, they went to help others on the stadium. We had enough people helping, so I just thought to get a better view of the action. And he just tagged along with me. He turns to Ned.

Ned then turns to me, is David willing to continue this match. I had to control myself from going busker. He had the nerve ask about the match, not caring about David or how he used that white Kuret. Matt probably sensed my anger and steps in, ah. We spoke a little with David and boy, not only wants to continue the match, but he straight up told us he is going to win. All three of them got taken back hearing David's intention. Marina spoke up with a smirk, he must be very confident after that last attack.

Matt replies, try cocky. You should see the way he talked, all covered in busied and bloodied clothes, and yet not a shred of doubt. He has overblown confidence. Marina widened her eyes, really. I find that hard to believe he would behave like this. I back him, its true. I have seen him scared, confident and sometimes even vicious before during a match. I point the last part towards Nathan who just stood there with even a bigger smile, but never like this before. Nathan waves his hand in air and snaps his fingers, oh. I needed to see that. When I saw that pure Kuret blast I spilled my drink. And then there's Kafar, who had been on edge ever since David woke up first. He went complete mental after seeing Charles thrown off the stadium. He laughs out, man that was some insane trick David pulled off. Matt and Marina snickers thinking about it. I was too much focused on Ned to care about Kafar's attitude. He continues, it could have been a clear victory for David, but sadly, both of them where thrown out of the bounds nearly the same time and were back inside the arena within two minutes.

I finally gathered my thoughts and asked Ned, why aren't you there with Kafar in the room. You are handling the broadcasting and media right. Surely you should have a say. Ned takes some time to respond to me, I actually don't have any authority. They are hosting this tournament while I am just handling the logistics of the media. I don't hold a vote on how to veer matches. I scoff, bet you just want to see Charles win no matter huh. He replies, what do you meant by that. I retort, don't deny it. You could have stayed quite when the countdown started, but chose to tell Kafar about that loophole.

Ned stares at me for a second before replying, that’s not fair. You can't be mad when you already know I supported Charles. I shook my head in anger, supporting is fine. But going out of your way to come up with such a scummy way that is a clear bias against David. I am not just talking about you. Both you and Kafar are showing too much partiality. I was almost yelling at him now. I am angry too much to remain calm all the way. Ned didn't respond back. He just looked away and started at the arena.

Oh no you didn't. He just ignored me. The nerve. I was to bite his head off, then Nathan raises his arm. Oye, that’s enough Vanessa. Take your lovers spat later. This is not the place to being doing this. I am about to aim my anger at Nathan instead now. Matt steps in before I could say more, Marina. David asked to you to create another barrier. A more powerful. Marina turns her arms to cross nonchalantly, forget it. I won't make a powerful barrier all alone. I will call others to help me. Matt says, David asked you personally for something called a Averna charm.

Marina chuckles hearing that, huh. Seriously, David thinks I would use waste a powerful charm on this match. I mean, I could use do it. I would be wasting a lot of my personnel stack of precious Kuretine if I do that. Nathan asks, will it be able to handle those Kuret blasts. Marina thinks for a moment, yeah. If I made an Averna barrier, it would be nearly impossible to break. Even for David. This is a self sustaining Kuret siphoning top grade barrier. Matt replies, sounds good to me. Then do it.

Marina shook her head, you crazy. I told you, something this powerful would cost me some precious Kuritines. I have them in case of emergency. Nathan says, this is an emergency you know. She rebukes, no. An emergency is like when Hive or Echo attack us. I can't use it for here. I would be wasting when I could need it for actual emergency. Its not easy to make or come by the Kuritines needed for this. Just forget it guys. I will ask others to help me make barrier again and hopefully make it stronger.

I recalled something David said, he said you would be reluctant. So mentioned about him owing you. Marina stared at me with suspicious eyes. A moment later she opens her arms and smirks a little, your serious. Well that changes. If he said that, then it means he is knows what I want from him. Marina pulls out a smile. I got curious, what is it. Marina says, sorry. Its between the two of us. Marina thinks for some time. She then finally makes up her mind. Fine, David got a deal. I will invoke the charm. Ned says, wait for the announcement first. It should going out soon.

Nathan turns to him with a suspicious expression, you say like you already know what they will say. Ned didn't reply him. I almost pressed for more from Ned, but I doubted he would say anything to me as well. Marina asks Matt about our conversation with David. Nathan got interested as well and listened in. With just Ned and me, our silence made me awkward. Ned finally spoke, I don't know what's got you so mad at me. But I know whatever I say will know make you even more mad or you won't believe me. So we should finish our conversation later. He was about to turn and walk away.

I asked puzzled, where are you going. He replies, to check with my team. I need to go over the details with them and make sure all the Medrines watching the match don't drop the live streaming. I am thinking to give a message explaining the situation. Hopefully, by the time crowd cools down, we will have an announcement. He didn't wait for me to reply or anything. He just walked away coldly from me. He is mad at me. Well, that’s make the two of us. I can't believe he choose to just walk away. But after thinking about it, maybe its for the better. If we say something that can't be taken back, we would have another argument.

I turn back to the ground to squash my feelings about Ned. Marina suddenly bursts into laughing, he said that. Matt replies, yeah those were his exact words. Nathan also laughs, whoa, looks like David finally wore his big pants. If he says he has more powerful stuff to show us, maybe he really can put money where his mouth his. Matt replies, jury's still out on that. On that note, we saw a group of people heading towards us. It’s the others. Blake, Derek, Jess, Cass. And now Tessa and Catherine are tagging along with them.

When they reach close to us, I ask to Blake, is everything under control. Blake sees Nathan who gives a light nod and then turns to me, yeah. We moved people around a bit and made them sit away from that damage area. Marina asks, no one got hurt right. Derek replies, thankfully no. We got there in time. Your barrier held out just long enough time to move people away. Jess says coming to a halt near Nathan, we helped enough so left the rest with the guards. Cass then excitedly says, you all missed that epic moment when that bastard Charles was thrown out of stadium. He looked like such a helpless monkey lizard howling when he landed on the ground outside. She laughs when she recalls that scene.

Matt says, oh really. I bet you that you guys missed something even more interesting. Blakes asks to me, what is he talking about. Is it David. Catherine after long time asked me, how is he doing. Blake saw you guys leaving him, so I can only guess if he is okay. Marina says, oh please. Let me tell what them. She pleads to Matt and me. I had no interest in explain such a messy situation. Matt motioned for Marina to convey her own take of the story. After about a minute, more shocked expression popped on peoples face.

Derek spits out, what. This wasn't him going all out. Blake eye twitches a little, is it weird that I am little scared now. I mean, won't this mean it will become even more dangerous. Catherine asks, I know I supported Charles, but I don't want David to try something even more reckless. I tell her, try stopping him. He isn't listening to me or Matt. I think no matter what, this won't end until there is only person standing. Catherine scoffs, that’s insane. Matt says, right. Blake asks Marina, I sure hope this new powerful barrier of yours will hold Marina.

Marina raises her hand in defense, oh trust me. It will definitely work. Let me tell you the part that you can understand. The charm is so convoluted and dangerous that anyone not trained properly will get a nasty backlash. I can't ask others to help with something this dangerous. In fact, I will only be able to do it if I overdrive. That made my mouth twitch. I recalled our battle when she went overdrive. If Marina needs to into use that, then this must a very powerful charm indeed. Blake eyebrows raises, seriously. You can't do it without it. Marina nods and Blakes asks her, sure you have recovered enough to go into overdrive this soon.

Blakes and Marina match was about a month back, but overdrive takes a huge toll on the users body. Even after their bodies heal, they may not be able to use it soon. Marina puts her finger on her lips and thinks for a moment, I might be able to pull it off just for couple of minutes. That’s more than enough for me to cast this single charm. Blake nods with a surprised expression, wow. I actually tried to go into overdrive myself just a while back, but I couldn't do it. Blake pride took a hit on his own words.

Marina replies apologetically, don't beat yourself up too much. I just have more practice with my mine that’s all. You will soon learn it. Blake slightly nods with a little embarrassment. I can almost imagine his feeling. He won against Marina with his overdrive, but just barely. And yet he is still playing catch up with her in certain aspects. I could almost relate it to me and David. But then I chided myself. David's now probably leagues above me. Nathan says, okay, if you two overdrive users are done flexing and looking down us mere mortals, I think its about time. Nathan gets everyone's attention. He was facing to the podium that was used an hour earlier. Kafar was back again standing on it.

For a guy who shows his true emotions to us, he is someone who can immediately pull out a diplomatic and stern attitude when needed. He turns the mike on his collar on and speak, hello. Yes, great. Everyone. Please could I your attention. The crowd begins to quiet down hearing his voice. Few seconds later he continues, first of all, let me say that no one got injured in the last accident. Few people are little shaken, but nothing physical happened. The quick thinking of our finalists and guards ensured everyone's safety. So I give a heartful thanks to their efforts. He pauses and raises his hands and begins to clap.

Slowly everyone in the crowd begin clapping and cheering for all the people who helped. The people nearest to us from the stadium were raising their arms in air and praising us. With everyone on the spotlight, we all waved back delighted with the appreciation we got. Matt asks, hey, Nathan, why are you taking waving your hand. You didn't help at all. Nathan scoffs, of course I did. I gave you all my moral support you know. Almost everyone rolled their eyes on him. The claps slows down soon. Kafar takes the center again.

He says, thank you again for keeping us safe. He clears his throat, after reviewing the last moments of that curious and shocking attack from David, we concluded that it was accidental. As were any of the possible violations during the battle. Its good we were far away from people to hear, because I spoke out, really. He thinks Charles violations were not intentional. I let out a breath of anger in my voice. Others whisper in agreement hearing me. Blake says, he is just covering his own ass with that. Kafar continues, in regards to the disruption of the match. We had a talk with the admins, we even took a survey of our viewers about whether to stop or to continue this match. He takes a longer pause. Everyone on the stadium were anxious to hear the verdict.

But the ones with me here, pretty much had already guessed it already. He continues, we will continue the match. The crowd goes wild and people wariness left immediately. He waves his arms and wait for people to calm down. A moment later he says, both the fighters were thrown outside the bounds, but there were back inside within 2 minutes. So none of them are disqualified. The crowd cheers once again at that message. He continues, however, we also know that continuing the match without protection would be dangerous. This tournament doesn't mean anything if we can't keep people safe. Because the goal of this tournament is to show our current strength and create a safe environment. We also can't have our fighters fight restrained. So we will only start after we create another barrier and adjust it for the extra protection. We will soon have it ready before our fighters get impatient. Hopefully, before they bring the whole stadium down. Haha.

That joke is in poor taste. Yet few people in the crowd laughed at that. Kafar left the podium and went inside. Derek says, Marina, you heard him. The match continues, so you erect that charm now. Marina asks, is it okay. Kafar didn't spoke with me yet. Derek nods, don't worry about it. I will message him now. Besides, he would have approached you anyways instead of the other casters. Marina nods, okay. She then pouts a little, David better make sure to keep the end of his deal. When I said I could do it, that doesn't mean it will not make my body sore like hell. She sighs, anyways, guys give me some space.

Everyone back away from Marina few step back. Marina first creates a charm to open her Kuret vault. She sticks her hand in and pulls out a large but thin stick. It wasn't just a stick, once both the ends were out, it had Kuritines stuck on its side. There were about a dozen of them, all in different colors. The Kuretines were small, but even I could feel the incredible amount of Kuret it was radiating. The upper end of the stick had one large Kuritine of green color. It was carefully sculpted in a shape of flower looking pattern.

She closes her vault and sticks the other end into ground. Marina closes her eyes and puts her hands on the Kuretine rod. A moment later charms starts to gather around her. Having seen this up close many times before, I thought I would get used to see it. But no. It still amazes me every time. I usually would forgot that Marina is in a league of her own because of her frivolous behavior. But ever since our fight, I can't deny she is powerful. She is on par with Blake, and maybe even Charles. A thought came to me, David is also included among these top tier group of people. I felt even more regret of my own loss. The roles have reversed between me and David over the years. How very cruel and true.

Marina overdrive starts and her body begins to cover with numerous circuits of Kuret charms. The Kuret radiating from her starts begins to make physical waves around us. And soon she was fully consumed with her charms. The rod begins to disappear as it slowly turns into Kuret mist. Marina absorbs the Kuret into her own body via the charms. Once the Kuretines also turn into mist, Marina starts to floats into sky. She was slowly ascends into air. Soon the entire rod is gone. The Kuret mist is slowly swirling inside her. Once it was completely absorbed, she raised her arms in front of her. A moment later a green colored Kuret flows out from her hands. She then flies straight up into the air.

We turn our gazes up in the air following her path. She was flying to the center of the arena. David and Charles were standing on the opposite ends of the arena. Once she gained some height. She falls straight between the two people and hits the ground. Suddenly a large green colored Kuret flowed out from the impact and immediately gulfed the entire arena. The green Kuret begins to flow in every direction. Including towards David. I got worried a little thinking his Kuret storm would break her charm. But the green Kuret that didn't pass through him, connect from behind him keeping the charm intact. Soon the green Kuret slows its growth and becomes still around the same place the previous barrier was placed.

The crowd which were mesmerized by this giant charm began cheering for this amazing display. I saw Marina flying from inside her barrier. At the edge of the barrier, instead of creating a door she just phased through the barrier and come from other side to us. She gracefully settles down on her feet. Immediately, she dispel her overdrive. She stumbles once she reverts back to her normal self. I was the closest to her and caught her by her shoulders when was falling back. Whoa, Marina. Are you okay.

Marina gave a thumbs up and then tried to smile but her mouth only turned half way up. A okay, she murmurs. He eyes were droopy a little and couldn't walk on her own. She definitely pushed herself. I supported her while I took her near the arena wall and let her rest on the ground. Others made way for us. Marina says, thanks Vanessa. She settles down and leans on the all. She says a little meekly, I am embarrassed. After all that talk, I didn't think this would make me this drained. I said, don't worry it. Trust me, I of all people know what you did wasn't easy. Marina smiles at me. She says, I think I need to start working out now.

I couldn't tell if she was joking or serious. Derek comes from behind, that was great. Thanks for this. Here, drink this. Should help with your sourness. He handed a bottle that containing liquid Kuret. Marina take it from his hand, you don't need to thank me. David's the one I want to hear it from. That and what he owes me now. She gulps down the drink. Derek asks, must be pretty something equally important. Marina nods, lets just say if I had that before my match with Blake, I would have won instead no question. I guess she was already feeling better to try act tough in her weakened state.

Behind me Blake snorts, is that right. Awfully sure of yourself. Marina smiles with small giggle, you got lucky, nothing else. She drinks for the liquid. Her skin was regaining her lost color. Nathan then speaks, again. Cool it with your egos. Let me ask something more important. How strong is this one. We can't have another crisis on our hands. Marina brings out a devious smile, why not don't you try it yourself. Hit the barrier with everything you got. If you make even a small dent, I will give you anything from my secret stash.

Nathan begins flexes his arms in repones, challenge accepted. He grins and walks to the edge. I retort, Nathan this isn't time to play. Nathan replies, this is a valid question you know. If I can make a dent on it, bet your ass Charles or David will break it again. I turn to Derek to help out. He says, let him do it. I was about to suggest it anyway. Its important to test it out before they start fighting again. Once we confirm its power, we will tell Kafar to resume the match. It made sense when Derek says it. But that didn't exempt from their childish behaviors.

Nathan stands near the barrier. He raised one arm in the air and covers himself with Kuret. Then swings down his fit bursting out with Kuret. The Kuret should have clashed the barrier, but just when it made contact, his Kuret was siphoned off his arm and gets absorbed by the barrier. Nathans Kuret less fist touches the barrier. Instantly he was thrown back. Whoa. He grunts as he gets dragged away and lands on his ass near Tessa. Shit, he gasps. Tessa chuckles a little, you all right. She gave him her hand. Nathan reluctantly takes it and pulls himself up. He looked a little rattled, but then brings his usual expression, okay. Its strong. Why didn't you tell me it would do that. He asks annoyed at Marina.

Marina smiled in response, you didn't ask. Nathan thought he was going to bite back, but instead he nods. Yeah, should have asked before. My bad. He walks back to Jess's side. She asks, sure you okay. He nods, yeah. Nothing just a little bruised ego. Marina laughs a little with his comment and then says, anyone else care for a try. No one responded thinking she was just joking. She pouts, hey I am not kidding. Derek said we need to be absolutely sure it will hold. So shouldn't we test it more.

Derek sighs a moment later, yeah. She's right. All though I know she is enjoying this. Marina doesn't even denies it. She looks at me, I immediately say, ah no. Thanks I am good. I doubt you made a barrier that is weak against non Kuret attacks. She makes a slight disappointed look. This girl, at least hide your intentions. Blake offers his turn, I'll do it. He turns to Derek, how about we both try it together. That would be a much better way to know that it will hold against both David and Charles.

Derek thinks for a moment and then replies, yeah. That would conform its strength much accurately. Nathan whispers softly to Jess, was that a jab at me saying mine was weak. Jess shushes her husband. Boys, I grumble a little. They both walk to the barrier and take a stance to prepare themselves. Blakes calls out to Marina, hey is your bet still on the table. Marina immediately says, get the freak out. With the two of you, the barrier won't break, but I can't guarantee it won't create dents. Blakes replies, ah. Fine. Blake pours out Kuret on his arm and makes it solid. Derek pulls one arm back keeping his palm open. He makes the air dense and positions to throw it from his palm.

Blake says, on three. One. Two. Three. They both land their attacks on the barrier. The barrier tried to siphon away Kuret from them, but the force and amount this time was a bit more than Nathans. It couldn't absorb the attack completely. Blakes Kuret was still on him. But even he couldn't break the barrier. All he could do was bend it inside and stretch it inside. Derek had the same result. His attack was a slightly targeted a smaller spot, it bent the barrier more with a sharper depth, but it didn't break.

After seeing the blowback from Nathan attempt, they were braced themselves when they were flung back. They manage to keep themselves stand upright. Blake says, damn Marina. This is good. Derek agreed, yes. I didn't expect it to be stretch like that. Marina bows her head with a gesture of appreciation, thanks. She raises her head, I told you earlier. This the top of the line, ultra grade level stuff. I snort at her, really. You just smashed some words together. She smirks, whatever. The point is it works good on both Kuret and non Kuret attacks.

Matt asks, what about David's black Kuret. He threw a white Kuret. But lets not forget his actual Kuret is the black one. Marinas says, no worries there, this barrier will heal the missing portions much faster than the previous ones. So David can keep punching or kicking with his black Kuret, the worst could happen is that he could tear small holes which will close within seconds. Derek nods, Great. I think this would work fine. He pulls out his tablet from his pocket and begins typing on it.

Catherine asks, um guys. I know we were all busy with the barrier stuff, but there's something I should tell you. We turned at her. She points to the arena, I have keeping on eye on both Charles and David. Neither have moved an inch and have been having a sort of staring contest. The short amusing atmosphere we had for a while changed instantly. We were painfully reminded that the match is still happening. I turn my gaze to the two people left inside the barrier. She is right. David was completely focused on making his Kuret storm. In fact, now its even smaller than last time. He must have been concentrating on that all this time.

Charles on the hand, was fully healed. He was making his Kuritine shine even more now. He is pouring more Kuret inside it. Like the one he made with his horns. The only thing that was keeping from attacking was probably us to finish this. Matt says, I know what you mean. They didn't even seem concerned when Kafar give his little speech, nor when Marina created the barrier. Blake asks, I don't know if this is good or bad development. They both are giving a complete different vibe now. I think everyone could feel it.

Vanessa (Chapter 29)

Sunday, February 4, 2024 17:02

Marina beside me pulls her up taking support from the wall. I ask her, what are doing, you look like you still need rest. Marina replies, who cares about that. Before the match begins, I need to give the four of you with charms so that you could pass through the barrier when needed. Derek says, good thinking. Marina creates a charm to her Kuret vault and pulls four Kuretines the size of a peanut. She says, take this. It'll let pass immediately without needing a door. Me, Matt, Derek and Blake take one each from Marina. The Kuritine felt cold on my skin. It is so small, yet I could hardly believe the amount of Kuret it was radiating. She continues, a warning though. This will only work once. So don't go barging inside without being absolutely sure. I don't have many of these. So use it carefully.

Few seconds later, Kafar comes back to the podium. He speak, everyone. Thank you for your patience. We have made the preparation. So will resume - Kuret was cut off. Looks like Charles hit his limit of patience. He roars loudly and begins charging towards David. Kafar's rest of the statement gets crushed the voices of the excited audience. Kafar waved his hand and walked away from the podium. Blake yells, ah damn. Hear we go again. Guys get in position. Derek and Blake stood together while me and Matt waited some distance beside them. I can't recall how many times we have gotten anxious seeing Charles charge across the ground like this. Charles had prepared something more this time. He made his tails much thicker and grown the Kuretine at the end much bigger. This was to counter that white Kuret blast. He would be able to stop himself from being dragged away.

How will David make sure he hits Charles again though. Charles knows what's coming now, he can dodge it. Though that Kuret blast is fast, he can still evade it if he had the distance. They were in striking distance. Charles jumps into the air this time. I assumed he would use his claws to attack, but he twists in the air has jumping. He instead uses that jump to use his tails to have more momentum to attack from below. The four tails swing in tight circles with their pointy Kuritine ends aimed at David's body. Meanwhile, David didn't try to dodge it. All this time, he remained fixed on the same position.

My mouth twitches in fear. What the hell is David doing just standing there. Shouldn't he shoot the Kuret blast by now. Just then, David's Kuret storm shakes a little and throws out a Kuret blast. But it was no longer white. It was blue. My eyes widen at this. A cold shiver went through my spine. The blue Kuret instead of blasted in a single beam, spread out like wave of water in the air. The Kuret wave hits Charles and his tails, pushed them away from David. The blue Kuret was so strong that Charles was thrown away like he bounced off a wall. He falls back on ground on his side and stops himself with his arms before he gets dragged away. The blue Kuret stops from the Kuret storm and it disappears within seconds.

The crowd was becoming silent after seeing this new attack. I could even hear my own breath as everyone here were beyond shocked here. Why is it this shocking, its not because the Kuret wasn't a blast or white this time. But because it was a different Kuret itself. It was no longer pure. It had changed its nature. Nathan breaks the silence, who had his smile just till now turns sour, what the freak. Blake had his jaw hung low. Matt is freaking out, holy hell. That Kuret. Marina despite being weekend was so shocked that she put her hand on her mouth. Others were showing signs that was mix of shock and awe.

Meanwhile my mind went to a complete blank trying to comprehend what just happened. David used Nathan and Blakes Kuret. To be accurate, their bloodline Kuret. Tessa asks hesitantly ah, isn't that your Kuret Blake. Yours too Nathan. They both were too stunned to speak. Cass snickers, don't tell me that David's actually from a royal bloodline too. She then laughs nervously, has he hidden his past till now. Blake closes his mouth and replies, don't be ridiculous. Derek had turned to a stone, asks, Marina, did you sense what David did.

Marina pulls her hand away and shook her head slowly, no. I didn't sense any thing. Derek turns to Nathan, did you see anything within the Kuret aura. Nathan lips twitches, nothing. There's no normal Kuret on David even now. Jess shrieks, what does this mean. No one knew the answer. In the arena, Charles gets up. Some of his Kuritines were broken from the blue Kuret impact. He dugs his claws into the ground and pulls out two large boulders. The then grabs few more with this tails. Honestly, what's even more shocking is Charles not fazed by what he saw and just continues fighting like it was nothing.

He charges again at David. But instead of a head on collision, he throws all six boulders at David in consecutive throws. He did this to make sure at least few would go through after the blue Kuret wave pushes the first few away, leaving David unprotected against the last ones. David shakes his Kuret storm again. I was expecting another blue Kuret, instead a yellow shade Kuret pours out. I gulp a little seeing the new Kuret. This one created a shockwave of sound that vibrated through the entire arena.

The noise was so loud that the green barrier vibrated along with the noise creating a small humming. The rocks hurled at David bursts right out in the sky before it was anywhere close to him. I tried blinking my eyes thinking my eyes were playing tricks on me. David didn't just pull out one bloodline Kuret, he pulled out another one. Despite the insane stuff happening, Charles yet again starts running towards David. How can Charles be not shocked by what's going on.

This time, David's Kuret storm shakes before Charles reaches him. My eyes widen when a third different Kuret comes out. This one was greenish with a hint of blue. I shout, what. My hands tremble a little with shock. That was my Kuret. Immediately, lightening flows out from in the air away from the Kuret storm. The lightening flies out straight and instantly strikes on Charles. He lets out a loud roar when he gets hit. We could feel the land vibrate a little from that lightening strike. Charles stunned from the attack falls on his legs and takes his arms to support himself.

I put my hands on my temple to support my burning head. What the freak is going on. Blake shouts, No way. This, this is exactly like what Marina did in my match. Blakes words triggered the memories of my own match. Yeah, he is right. Marina used her overdrive to throw multiple Kurets on both of us. Everyone turned their eyes to Marina. Marina twists her head swaying left to right from everyone burning gazes. She shook her head vehemently, don't look at me. I didn't do anything. David can't cast Kuret, remember. Whatever the freak is going on, its all David.

This is too much. For an instant I was hoping David took the help of Marina. But she was right, David can't cast Kuret. So what in the hell is going on. A ringing noise comes from Derek. Derek pulls out the tablet from his jacket. This was the same sound whenever Charles gets injured. Derek says in low voice, that lightening strike did a whole lot of damage than I thought. The current went through his entire body, his real body too. We should have been happy to see that one attack was so powerful that Charles got hit badly. Instead, everyone is too stunned to be enjoying this. A moment later I realized some thing about that last attck, that lightening strike was more power than mine. I could feel it from here that when David used my Kuret, it was very potent. I have never created a lightening this strong without any clouds. I was very sure of it, the sky is completely clear. There's nothing in the atmosphere to augment the lightening strike.

A moment later Blake also says, since you mentioned, that first Kuret he used. Ours, he points to him and Nathan, was also incredibly strong. David only used it for few seconds, but in that time the Kuret he used was too strong. It would take me much more time for me to throw a blast like the one he used. Nathan nods slightly, same. Its as if he is skipping many steps and directly using strong Kuret. Tessa asks nervously, this doesn't makes sense. How is he using our Kuret. Better yet, how is David using them at such a high level. Matt asks hesitantly, does it means his black Kuret is actually not only anti-Kuret. Its something else. Derek replies, no possible. David's Kuret is strange, but everything we know about it shows that its not compatible with Kuret.

Blake asks a little annoyed, so what does this mean. He can now use any Kuret. Mines, yours or anyone, like Matt's and Ned's bloodline. Derek didn't have an answer for it. Catherine says with a stern voice, it looks like we have new omega among us. Just think about it a little. Her words shocked us to our core. I thought she is just saying it because of his strange power. Then I recalled omegas like me and Catherine's, who don't have other people using the same Kuret, can develop sometimes unique abilities. My elemental control and her ability to change Kuret nature in her body.

I always knew David's power was strange. It would make even more sense if it was unique and he was actually an omega from beginning. Especially when we have not found anyone of the same bloodline as David. But there are too many flaws in that theory. He doesn't display any of the qualities of an alpha, let alone an omega. He doesn't heal, has no Kuret symbol on his body or even owns a bloodline marker. But then how is it that he has already bested so many alphas, against an omega, even against a true alpha in overdrive. He is now on par with a mythical alpha. If you ask someone who could do this, they would know it had to be someone like them.

Suddenly the intense silence after that comment was overwhelmed by the crowd breaking out of their haze of confusion. The whole stadium erupted in chaos. People were shouting, yelling and even jumping like crazy. Some were running downstairs, probably to get a better view. This was the biggest level of excitement we had seen. Marina was the first of us to go along with the flow. She begins to giggle and then it becomes to a full blown laugh. She becomes so hysterical that small tears from her eyes, I don't know if David's an omega or an alpha or something else. He is kicking Charles mystical ass. She bows her head a little, this is freaking ridiculous. Her emotions is becoming infectious. Everyone begins to break out of the confusion and joins her with slow laughs.

I couldn't help myself. I burst out laughing too. With so much happening with me and Ned, then with David, I finally hit my limit. I don't understand how David's doing this, but like Marina said, he is winning against Charles. Even the guys from Team Charles were laughing. Derek chuckles, just when you think you know someone. David surprises the hell out of everyone with something outrageous again. I replied with laughter, that’s just David. Matt and Cass raised their arms up. Cass shout, gets his furry ass, David. Matt shouts, freak him up.

Seeing their enthusiasm, everyone begins to join in. I shout out, come on, you crazy genius. Marina shouts after me, drag his ass out of here. Blake goes next yelling, show who's the boss now. Everyone shouts with such zeal, David must had heard us from here. Even if he did, he didn't showed us. Charles was already back up after healing from the shock. He just stood there for a while. I get another laugh out of this, yes. Finally, a real reaction from Charles. He must be thinking how to deal with such crazy attacks now. I know the exact feeling. When I fought against Marina's overdrive, I couldn't tell what was happening. At least with Matt and Ned, you know what Kuret they have. But its insanely tough to defend when you have no idea what's coming next.

But David wasn't going to wait. He already prepared for another Kuret. The Kuret storm throws out a new grey Kuret. Like a rocket it was thrown straight up to the sky. The Kuret explodes and throws a plethora of spikes of Kuret everywhere. The spikes fall like rain from the sky covering the entire arena. Some hit the barrier and they turn to dust. Others hit the ground in a barrage of continuous projectiles. Charles tried running away from getting hit, but the sheer number of spikes can't be outrun no matter how fast someone was. Charles growls when his body gets struck by dozens of those spikes. Meanwhile, David didn't need to dodge. The Kuret storm was protecting from any of the spikes falling on him.

Matt, who biting his index finger shouts out loud, holy smokes. What's the hell is this. Anyone knows which bloodline Kuret is this. Tessa replies with wide eyes, its from a bloodline in Tegna's nation. I don't know the name, but I remember someone in our family got married into. He must be using the Kuret from that bloodline. But this is not what had seen earlier. The guy was only able to create few dozens. Not hundreds. The tablet on Derek rings more. Charles is now pinned on the ground in a crouching position with his back to the sky and protecting his face and chest from the spikes falling. Dozen of the spike fall into those hidden traps and they land was getting buried there. Cass says, that’s take care of the those pesky traps. Derek says, not that it matters. David doesn't look like he doesn't plan to move always.

Few seconds later the spike rain ends. The arena is completed destroyed. With all the hidden traps from Charles gone, the ground was torn in various places. And now those Kuretine spikes created a land of spikes. They made movement for Charles incredibly difficult. Marina glees and says, nice. Charles will not be able to move freely. Derek replies, think again. Charles got up as soon as the spikes rain had ended. He was already on his way to David once again. He didn't wait to heal first. As he moved, he clawed all the spikes out of his way. He would slash, kick and even bite the spikes as he sprinted without difficulty. Derek says, the best this did is make Charles slower.

He's right. Charles cutting through those forest of spikes with ease at the cost of a little speed. Maybe that’s David plan. David throws another Kuret out of his storm. This one is a red color one and threw hundreds of thin

laser around the arena. This looked familiar. Jess shrieks a little, hey, he is using mine now. I am in complete awe. David's using so many Kuret in such successions, it's goes beyond even what Ned's bloodline can do. The red lasers when hit the spikes, they burst and disintegrates in a grey Kuret dust. One by one all the spikes were getting destroyed up in smoke. Charles halts his assaults when he gets hits with those red Kuret. I thought it would at least destabilize his Kuret body. But apart from the Kuritines disintegrating, nothing happened to his Kuret body.

Jess says, god. Even my Kuret is over powered. Nathan besides her says, and just look at Charles. He is completely fine. His Kuret body is incredibly dense. I can't believe how Charles is still so unaffected by all this. I mean, David's doing something insane, and yet Charles is just bulldozing everything thrown at him. The arena is temporarily covered in a thick smoke of grey Kuret dust. The visibility becomes near zero for few seconds.

Matt says, whoa. Whoa. This is nuts. Few seconds later the dust was clearing. Something even more unbelievable happened. David's not where he was few seconds ago. I looked over the entire arena, but no sign of him. I shout, were the hell did he go. Everyone panic at the sight of him missing. I even check the sky just in case, but it was clear, no sign of him flying. Blake yells, what the hell. The crowd behind us slow down their voices in murmurs of confusion. Soon the entire smoke clears. The whole arena is empty save Charles. Charles howls loudly. He begins to run in random directions on all four limbs. His tails waving around him.

Beside me Marina creates a charm. She then waves her over the entire arena. She freaks out a moment, holy shit. I can't sense him anywhere. Derek says, he has to be using a Kuret. I ask him disbelieve, a Kuret that even works on himself. Especially with that black Kuret storm. Derek puts his fingers on his forehead trying to figure out. He shrugs his shoulders when he couldn't find answer. Charles finally stops running around realizing he was getting nowhere like this. He growls and slowly his tails begins to grow larger. I shook my head and said, ah shit. Hear we go again. I knew what he was trying to do. He already done this in the match when he was trying to find David.

His tails grew to huge size once again. He then swings them around the ground sending them in search. Blake says, is he hiding in one those holes. I mean that’s the only place he can hide, isn't it. Think about it, those spikes reveled all the traps. He can now safety run without falling into them anymore. He is right. David must have jumped into one of them. Marina asks, even if he is inside one of them, I still can't sense him. I am not talking about his Kuret. I ran a body heat search too, the only signal I pick up is Charles. Derek turns to her suddenly, are you saying he is able to evade both physical and Kuret detection. Marina shakes her head with a big smile now, Yeah. I can't believe he has a way to avoid me too. A moment later she says, let me go into overdrive once again. I bet I find him then.

I put my hands on Marina, don't do it. Even if you find him, its not going to change the match in any way. Plus, you might knock yourself out over the exhaustion this time. We might need your help with the barrier or something like that again. So don't waste your energy. Marina mauls on my words for a while and nods slightly, yeah. You got a point. She then giggles, guess I got excited that whatever stealth Kuret he is using is so powerful that even I, with best Kuret sense, can't find him. Blake says, I feel you Marina. I can't even find him using aura. Can you Nate. Nathan turned his head around a little. He then brings his arm up in defeat, Nope. I can't believe what I am seeing. Or rather, not able to see.

Derek scoffs a little, that’s how he went undetected earlier. He used the same way when to visit other wing to scope out Charles. He smirks a little, not bad. Not bad at all. Matt says, whoa. Guys is it just me or the grounds becoming a bit weird. Everyone turns to the arena's ground. Even I could feel it. It was radiating Kuret, like a gas. It was coming from the entire arena. Marina shrieks, got him. She had a charm on her arm. It showed a small spot of black and violet color. Marina says, yeah, he is hiding in one of the holes. But whatever Kuret he was using to hide it's gone. He is using something else now.

Charles also figured out something was wrong. He stops his tails from flying in the air. He keeps them fly up in the air without touching the ground anymore. The violet Kuret was flowing out from the ground like a gas coming out of a busted pipe. Marina says, guys. Take a look at this. I turned to her charm. At the first glance, it looked like the violet Kuret was flowing in random directions. But then few seconds later I realized it wasn't random. Derek also realizes it, David is pushing out this Kuret using the path that Charles dug with his tails earlier in the match. He then turns away to look at the ground and says, he didn't jump into the hole just to hide. All the traps are connected underground. Even if some paths have crumbled away, a large number of paths must still be intact underground.

I asks, this is what, a delivery system for the Kuret to spread to over entire arena. Derek nods, yes. Maximum coverage. And the best part, David is doing this all from one single place. This all feels like a…I finish his sentence, David's strategy. It must be. Blake says, he used those spike to uncover all the hidden traps. Jess says, he used my Kuret to create a distraction. Marina says, and then he is using Charles own holes to use it against him. Hot damn. That’s one nasty plan he cooked up. Derek mumbles, like a chess master, he already has all his moves played out in his mind. Blake says, then against a player like Charles, who only fights with simple strategies... I say, David's got the edge by a mile.

Everyone on Team Charles had to agree that Charles is getting cornered now. Nathan smirks, I should really change my vote now. He turns to others who voted Charles, how about it. Whether he is serious or not, no one could figure it out. Just then a huge wave of Kuret appears on the arena. The violet Kuret coming out of the ground begins to join together to form huge crystals of Kuritine floating in the air. They were shaped into snowflake like design. I turn to Marina, what is that. I have never seen this type of Kuret. Marina waves her charm around the Kuret. I waited for her to respond. She closes her eyes to sense the Kuret. She says, I have never seen this Kuret. It going to take time analyzing it. Unless someone already knows what this Kuret is.

No one responds. David pulled out another unknown Kuret. Blake asks, un-freaking-believable. Just how many unique Kuret is David going to use. The crystals were forming all around the arena. They were all spread in random directions. One of the Charles tails swaying in the air comes in contact with one Kuritine crystal. The Kuritine shines instantly and without any warning explodes. The explosion blasted a large amount of Kuret around the origin and the tail that came in contact instantly disintegrated. Charles gowns loudly when his tail becomes cut so suddenly. The explosion created a powerful wind, I felt it hitting barrier in front of us. Matt cries with his arms behind his head interlocked, freak. Now we know what those Kuritines do. They are freaking bombs.

I gulp a little. The explosion was fairly far away from us, and yet it could be felt all the way to us. Marina says, well. I don't recognize which Kuret bloodline this belong to, but I can tell that the Kuret is highly compressed to form those crystals. And its incredibly unstable, it will explode like that when another Kuret comes in contact against it. Catherine asks, just where did he find these many crazy Kurets. Nathan asks, those bombs might be strong. But its easy to defend against. Look, Charles is already doing it. Charles remained still on his place and then brings all this tails around him. Those long tails avoid the crystals floating in the air and coils them around his own body. He starting wearing his tails around him like a extra layers of protection.

Jess says, well that is unexpectedly a little clever plan. Limiting his chances of touching and at the same time protecting against the explosions. Nathan says, yeah, and now that he knows where David is, we can just avoid them and attack David. I ask, will it be that simple. This is David we are talking about. Nathan couldn't deny and nods slightly. Charles begins navigating cautiously in those Kuretine bombs landmine and is slowly closing in on David. Unexpectedly, David himself comes out of the hole he was hiding in. His Kuret storm was still intact as he slowly crawls out.

Charles picks up the pace seeing him out in the open. Tessa asks, why did he came out himself. If he was buying time, he could have just stayed hidden. To answer her, David's Kurets storm begins shaking. A second later, a dark blue colored Kuret comes out. The Kuret flows out like a comet, its head covered in Kuret and then tail burning off the Kuret in its trail. David aimed it straight at Charles. I didn't feel any incredible power coming from that Kuret. Then something changes on the ground. The crystals floating in the air begin to move in the direction of the Kuret David just threw.

My eyes couldn't keep up with all the wild stuff happening. This left me in utter awe. The entire Kuritine crystals floating on the arena are pulled in by that dark blue Kuret and which was heading straight towards Charles. Charles tried to get run away. But there is no where to run. The Kuret comet hit him on his legs. And then the crystals follow behind. I realized this moment David's entire plan. The Kuritine crystals begins exploding on contact with Charles. But that was just one, like a hail of targeted bombs, dozens of Kuritine keep rushing in and exploding on Charles.

The continuous explosions shook the entire arena. The explosion even reached the barrier. The force created small dents on it. The explosion continuous on like fireworks. Under the sound of those explosions, Derek tablets ringed frequently. I was too engrossed with this spectacle to care about that. I couldn't keep track of how many bombs kept exploding on Charles. Everyone here were freaking out. Matt was yelling something inaudible to Cass. Everyone did. I too shouted at the top of voice to ask Marina how many more Kuretines are left. She couldn't hear me under the noise.

I was about to come closer to her ear, but then the bombing finally stop. The barrier vibrations slows down. The ground near Charles has turned into a mini creator. A huge dust cloud swirls around in the air. Charles is still not visible under all the dust. On the other hand David is still fine. He wasn't pulled in like those Kuritine bombs. His own Kuret must have protected him. Once the noises of explosion is over, a new wave of noise erupts from the whole stadium. People couldn't keep still after seeing such a thing.

I don't think anyone expected the match would turn out like this. I almost feel bad of Charles now. The tables wasn't only turned, it was broken completely by David.

Blake (Chapter 30)

Monday, February 5, 2024 00:18

Freaking shit. Is this happening for real. Not one, not two but several Kurets were popping up in front of me. I felt all the hairs on me stand up in shock when he had first used my Kuret. Even though he only used half of my bloodline Kuret, it was still didn't make any sense how he did that. I rejected Cass's ridiculous thought that David is actually from the royal bloodline. But actually I couldn't dismiss it completely. Then he pulled out a another Kuret. That completely shattered any possibility.

One after another, he kept using others Kuret with such ease. Just what the freak is happening in the Kuret storm. I can't see any aura until the Kuret actually comes out of it. David had such a trick up his sleeve. Even when I laughed it out like others, I couldn't believe he didn't use it during our match. I don't know how much more tough it would have been, but it would have increased David's chances of winning. Derek's theory that it takes lots of time made sense. In all our previous matches, he never had enough time to prepare that Kuret storm. He spent almost a quarter of an hour fighting Charles to get this chance. Seriously, this was worth the trade off.

Once the bombing stopped. I turned to look over Charles. He wasn't visible, so I used aura to check up on him. He is lying inside that crater. He was lying face first on the ground. I couldn't tell how badly he was hurt. But then again I didn't need to. Beside me Derek's tablet had been ringing nonstop. Derek catches me looking at his tablet. He says with a surprised look, even with all that bombing, he still has his Kuret body. But he got hurt pretty bad. He got multiple injuries that are bleeding. I never imagined Charles taking such a beating. I turn back to the arena. The dust clears and shows Charles getting up on the ground.

His body is badly torn apart. There were scratches everywhere and a lot of his Kuret body was gauged out. All his tails were blown off. He stands up slowly and begins healing himself. What a freak. He sustained so many damages, and yet its not enough to bring him down. I said to everyone, I know we think David's winning. But lets not forget that Charles is somehow keeping up with these relentless attacks. Matt says, what the freak was that. I am still shaking you know. He is clearly freaking out seeing those many large explosions so close.

Vanessa asks Marina, check with M if David's okay. I saw he didn't caught up in any of those explosions, but just need to make sure. Marina nods and brings out the watch. M pops out with the holo of David. M says, orange critical mode still in effect. Boss vitals are holding steady. I don't detect any further injury on him. I detect slight increase in inflammations of muscles on his palm. But they are minor. Vanessa expression shows relief. I got an idea. I ask M, hey do you know how David is able to use others Kurets. M flashes a little and then speak, invalid authority. Information restricted.

I didn't think I would hit the mark. I ask with little impatience, come on. Its already out now. David is using it in front of the whole world. How is he doing this. M repeats the same answer. I gesture Marina to ask. Maybe David programmed M to reveal it to Marina only. Marina asks, hey. David gave you to me. So can tell me. She asks coyly. M responds, temporary user doesn't have authority outside the privileges given. Information restricted. I wave up my hands in air frustrated a little. God damn David, you really need to work on keeping your secrets. M blinks away the holo back inside the watch.

Nathan says, I am actually a little speechless. Not sure what surprises me more, David using so many Kurets or the fact that he isn't even exhausted already. Jess beside him says, don't forget that all the Kurets he is using are incredibly strong. What the hell was that last one anyway. I didn't know any Kuret that sucks in so many stuff. Catherine speaks with confusion in her voice, it doesn't work like that. It pulls in just the Kuret induced stuff in its vicinity towards that dark blue Kuret. Tess asks her, you know about that Kuret.

She nods slowly, my eldest brother had a friend from the bloodline. I have seen it couple of time when they used to hang out. But when I saw her using it, it was nothing like this. I mean, she could only pull in Kuret from very small distance. She used it to just collect tiny broken pieces of Kuret covered stuff floating in air. But this is completely on a different scale. David pulled in all those Kuret crystals from the entire arena. Maybe the alpha of the bloodline could do it. But considering David has been continuously using a powered up version of our Kuret, I have doubts if even the alpha could do it.

Marina spats out, shit. You are telling us that David turned a vacuum clear type Kuret into jumbo magnet of Kuretines. Freak. Catherine shrugs a little gesturing maybe. Nathan turns to Catherine, are you sure about this Kuret. Catherine nods, yes. I told you the scale of this too big, but this definitely from that bloodline. Why. Nathen had a tensed expression, because when you told about this Kuret power, I remembered the bloodline. But that’s not the issue. He turns to face David, that bloodlines extinct now.

Vanessa ask, what do you mean. Nathan replies, it means what I said. They are no Madrones with that Kuret anymore. I ask him now, how do know. Derek asks after me, and why does it matter. Nathan continues, I know they are not on alive anymore because I searched for them extensively when I was, ah, he nervously peeks at Vanessa, ah, during my research I needed them their help. I spent close to four month searching all over Earth for their Kuret signature. We never got any hit. Without their Kuret, we had to change our plans considerably. So that’s why I know they are now extinct.

His research. He is talking about the experiments he ran when is was ruling over the valley. Vanessa asks, okay. Even if that’s true, why are you talking about it. Nathan shook his head a little, don't you understand. I thought David is somehow copying our Kuret. I can't say how is boasting them, but I thought at least the bloodlines he is copying from are here. A moment later I realized what Nathan is getting at, you mean bloodlines that are here and alive. Nathan nods and a huge realization hit me, David is not only copying Kurets from bloodlines that are alive, he is even using the ones from that are extinct.

This made everyone tense up immediately. Marina shrieks, shut the freak up. Are you serious. Even I can't use Kuret from bloodlines which are no longer alive. Matt shook his head with eyes closed in horror, not just you. My bloodline can't do that, Ned's can't do that as well. I don’t think anyone can do it. Tessa speaks next with confusion in her voice, except for David then. The surprises keep coming like a wave. With each revelations of David's new power becomes even more mysterious.

Vanessa says, that’s where that complete confidence comes from. She looks at David, he planned this out from the start. Even if know we know he can use others Kurets, he can use extinct Kurets also. Meaning the next Kuret he pulls out his ass might be something people have forgotten or know nothing about. Its one thing to defend against what's going to happen after seeing the Kuret. But can what can you do when even after seeing the Kuret you don't know what it will do. Marina slaps her palm on her temple, freak this. She starts chuckling, I can't believe David's been holding out such a power this long. He kept it hidden right till the finals. Charles isn't the only monster now.

I had the same thoughts as her. He almost used it in our match. Even if had got back up, I don't think the result would be any different. I bit my teeth hard. Me and Marina are the only one know he remembers his past. Did something from his memories helped him unlock this power. But he told pretty much all important stuff. He said he didn't even knew he had black Kuret on Medrine. I know he didn't lie to us. Maybe he knows something about those extinct Kuret. But that would be just knowledge of their existence. How does that help him do this.

Everyone of us are shocked and excited at the same time. David has an out of the world power now. He is too strong for Charles now. Derek interrupts my thoughts, look, I have no clue how David's doing it. But nothing is all powerful. There are limits and weakness. I turn to him, what do you mean weakness. This is the ultimate power. He can channel into any Kuret he wants in existence. Derek shook his head, no. Not any or every Kuret is at his disposal. I been trying to figure his for some time. I don't have all the details, but I reached some conclusions. First of all, if he had access to all Kurets, why doesn't he just blows everything he got at Charles directly. Why did he make such an elaborate plan to corner Charles leading to that Kuret bombing.

He takes a pause and then continues, why doesn't he blows all the Kurets on Charles nonstop. The answer is because he can't. If he can do that, then match would be over by now. No one can defend against barrage of super charged Kuret attacks. I was actually thinking David should have used Heraknus Kuret to transform himself. That comment scared me a little. Derek continues, obviously he can't do it. Because his Kuret is still anti Kuret. But that made me realize, he can't use any Kuret that physically changes or augments his body in any way.

He made sense. We had apparently jumped the gun a little. I nod, yeah. I didn't think of that. Derek says, right. Also I bet he can't control the Kuret that comes out of his Kuret storm. David's hiding it every good. I also almost missed it. When he used your Kuret, he should have been able to redirect just to block Charles. But instead he threw the Kuret everywhere. I initially thought it was just because he didn't have time, but then later, the way he created those exploding crystals and use the extinct Kuret, I realized he has been always throwing out Kuret, like the white Kuret he threw in the beginning. He can't control any of the Kuret that comes out of his Kuret storm. I am sure David's choices of Kuret are limited.

I gotta hand it to Derek to be able to figure it out so quickly. While have been freaking out, he is able to remain calm enough to think things over. Vanessa asks, then it means he didn't control the lightening he threw. Derek says, yes. He just aimed at Charles. Same with yours, he faces Jess, if he wanted to destabilize the spikes with your Kuret, he should have only targeted the spikes on the ground, but he sent the beam in all direction. Marina says, so basically David is just throwing those Kuret around, making everyone believe he is using them freely.

Derek replies, exactly. Devious isn't it. I only figured it out just now. I ask him, so he can't use all Kurets or control them. I understand that. But they are over powered Kuret, right. With all that powered up Kuret, he can just aim at Charles or his targets. Derek raises his hands in air, I am only telling you what I think. I don't have a freaking clue on how he is using other Kurets let alone how he is giving them a boast. And even if we now know this, it doesn't make it any less dangerous. If David had used it during my match, I would have lost much quicker and even more spectacularly without a doubt in my mind.

Catherine says, shucks. I can't even image what I would have done if he pulled his out during our match. Jess chuckles, I don't even want to think about it. I am the same opinion as them. Even with those limits, he is still a freaking menace. Marina speaks, huh. So at least he isn't able to control those Kuret. Thank the gods. I was almost on the verge of collapse thinking my ultimate move was stolen. Vanessa asks, that's what worried you the most. Marina shrugs a little, well yeah. How would you feel if he was suddenly able to control the weather like you, huh.

Vanessa stammers at Marina's words, oh. I never thought like that. She got nervous a little. It felt like Marina brought up a sore topic for Vanessa. I understood a little how they both felt. Both of their Kuret are extremely unique, especially Vanessa with quintuple Kuret like nature. If David could copy hers or Marina's Kuret completely, their Kuret status would be no longer unique. Even I was almost felt sudden jealous at David when he used my Kuret. He is already strong with his anti-Kuret, he would practically be invincible if was able to freely use all our Kurets. Honestly, it's a relief to know David isn't eclipsing our powers completely.

Charles had finished his healing, meanwhile David hadn't made a move yet. Tessa asks, it's curious that David didn't attack immediately. Why did he wait till this long. Charles is injured. Shouldn't he be attacking right away. I suggested an answer, maybe he can't Kuret in successions. Vanessa offers another explanation, or he is trying to wear down Charles slowly by making him use his Kuret as much as possible. Derek says, you both could be right. Marina asks, but he would wasting his energy if he keeps this up. Derek shook his head, at this point only David knows what's he doing.

Cass says, that gorilla is doing something new again. Just then Charles growls. The Kuritine on his body begins to shine. His Kuret is physically coming out of his body. Gradually, his body begins to become bigger. With every Kuret coming out of him, more Kuret body was being formed. His legs grew, then his arms. His head and neck grew thicker. The jaws become longer. More Kuritine teeth grew inside his mother. He has undergone yet again a bizarre transformation. His tails is the only thing that didn't become bigger. He is now almost fives times the size now. Catherine shrieks, whoa. He turned into a Godzilla. It wasn't a total exaggeration. Charles is perhaps 40 feet tall now.

Vanessa asks to Derek, didn't you say that the Kuret becomes part of Charles body. Then adding more Kuret body won't backfire with that more pain when it gets blasted away. Derek didn't have an aware right away. He had his face hooked on Charles massive body, like the rest of us. Charles didn't just stop here, the Kuritines on his body grows more thicker and longer. As they grow they something different, they started to twist and bend. Whoa.

Slowly his entire body is wrapping in layer of Kuritine. They grew like ropes around him. Seeing this new form I said, David isn't the only pulling out total random and unexpected moves. Charles keeps coming with new ways. Its not the same, but I have to admit Charles is just as unpredictable. The crowd behind us creates a new wave of shouts and cheering seeing Charles large body.

Derek says after a moment, I have never seen Charles doing this. Tessa says, this is obviously to block all the Kurets David's throwing at him, but like Vanessa said, he is risking it all with such a large body. Matt says with a disheartening voice, this is exactly what happens when you corner someone. They become dangerous. Catherine asks, but why now. If he was capable of growing this big, why not do it early. I reply, you notice David's not using his black Kuret anymore right. Maybe David won't or can't use his Kuret with all the other Kurets. So Charles is no longer concerned about his Kuret body getting stripped off. Derek adds on, and David's hardly moved at all during his attacks. Even if Charles has become slow, he has gotten more edge now.

Soon enough, Charles gigantic body is now armored with Kuritines all over him like a armor. This new terrifying look has to be the most dangerous form Charles has taken. His Kuritines, long tails and Kuret horns seems nothing in comparison now. Charles roars, the voice comes out a bit different, much deeper and louder, due to so much Kuret body. He takes a step towards. As soon as he stomps the ground, the entire arena shook. Not just the arena, the entire stadium as well. Everyone becomes tensed seeing this. I could feel visible dirt vibrating off the arena as he keeps walking. My eyes move anxiously as his towering figure moves leaving mini quakes as he goes, what the hell. Tessa nervously suggests, ah guys, I think we should back away from the arena a little.

I think everyone thought like her for a moment. But Vanessa replies, if you want to leave, that’s fine. Me and Matt will be stay here to pull out David. Matt nervously looks at her, ah, we will? You want to enter inside where Charles could kill us with one step. Vanessa nods, Charles doesn't matter. All he got is height and weight. We can move faster than him and grab David. Matt didn't respond to her right away. The poor guy is actually terrified he had to enter the ring. I got an idea. I say, Derek, switch with Matt. At this point, even if Charles can see you, he won't be able to stop. So its better if two physical Kuret users keep an eye on David.

Derek probably thought the same, because he agreed almost immediately. He nods, yes. That makes sense. Honestly, I am not thrilled about stopping Charles as he is right now. Matt shrieks a little, ah, I don't know if I can help stopping Charles. I reply, you don't worry about that. You only need to support me by copying my powers now. Matt didn't looked convinced. So I add, I will go into overdrive if I have to. I honestly don't know if can do it. But maybe if push comes to shove, I might be able to do it for few seconds. Matt looks a little less nervous. He turns to Vanessa who nods, yeah. That’s fine. Derek and I can cover David. Matt nods and then he and Derek switch the places. Matt places his hands on my shoulder and copies my Kuret.

Matt speaks lightly, ah thanks. I know I shouldn't be wimping here, but come on. This is nuts. I nod in response, it's okay. I get you are overwhelmed. He faces to Charles now. Unlike the 3 of us, he isn't even an alpha. Its no wonder he's feeling out of place when Charles has become so dangerous. Nathan asks, yeah, that’s well and good, but what about our safety. He turns to Marina, that barrier is strong, but please tell me it will still hold if Charles attacks it.

Marina had been quite for a while ever since she saw Charles gigantic form. She had casted a charm unknown to us and been fiddling with something. She had a little frustrating look on her. She says, the Kuret on Charles is off the charts. I know he supposed to got an incredible amount of Kuret endurance. But this is just maddening. She turns to Nathan, the barrier will hold. But now I can't guarantee anymore. Jess asks her, can you make it stronger. Marina shook her head, no way. Even with other casters help, we can't add more layers to it. It will take hours and more preparation to make it stronger. Nathan scoffs a little, that’s not good. Vanessa says, do you know else is not what's not good. David is still not moving. He is standing in the same he has been all this while.

She is right, we are nervous, while David's behavior is totally opposite. He just stands there. We saw him move earlier with his stealth Kuret. Why doesn't he do that. With Charles so slow, he can easily run away with his Kuret storm. Meanwhile, Charles is dangerously close to David. There's like two more step between them now. David's Kuret storm finally goes into action. This time a purple shade of Kuret comes out. This one comes out a sheet of thin cloth and slowly unfurls in the air. What's this Kuret. I have never seen it.

Derek spats, again some obscure Kuret. The Kuret sheet begins to unwrap like a cloth and straighten out a sheet of large wall directly opposite Charles. Marina freaks out, is David really thinking to stop Charles with that thin Kuret wall. Charles takes his final step. His large arm raises in the air and begins to land on David's down on the ground. Because of his large frame, the punch takes time as it descends directly at David. But before the fist even comes below his waist, the large wall moves forward and hits Charles entire body.

I really thought the Kuret wall would stop Charles, but it broke instantly when it came in contact with it. Charles didn't even had to block or attack it, it broke on its own against his armor. Matt shouts, what the hell. The wall is completely useless against Charles. I see both Vanessa and Derek lean forward a little, readying themselves to get inside. I panicked seeing David still not moving away. What is he thinking, that wall didn't do shit against Charles. Then unexpectedly, the broken pieces of wall began swirling in the air. They started move, pieces were flying and joining together.

Just then David Kuret storm shouts out a greenish Kuret. The Kuret instantly turns into wall of thick ice in front of David. He used Vanessa's Kuret again. The punch comes in contact with that large iceberg. The ice breaks away in pieces as Charles fist goes through it. But the ice was too strong, Charles wrists stops just few inches from David. The surface of the ice is melting into gas at the contact. Charles large fist is covered in snow now. I let out a sigh, David managed to stop that. Charles slowly begins to pull out his hand back up. David finally made up his mind and backs away in hurry gradually creating distance from Charles.

Vanessa yells, damn him. I almost made my mind to get inside. Why did he wait so long. Good question. Derek beside her says, what's those broken pieces doing. The pieces were not only grouping, they were now forming into some shape. David while walking back in reverse, decides to throw another Kuret from this storm. This time he throws mine. Blue Kuret comes out filling out the entire space between the two of them. Just like last time, my Kuret is way too powerful in such a quick time. In fact, it’s the same intensity. What the shit. I had been thinking those Kurets power should be decreasing, but instead, they are at the same level.

David keeps filling up the space with my Kuret as he backs away. Charles didn't immediately return attack. He instead becomes wary of the Kuret forming a figure in front of him. David finishes off throwing my Kuret. He immediately throws out a new maroon Kuret that comes out like a beam. This one belongs to one of us here. Jess cries, what the hell is this now. He has now used both of Kurets. The Kuret beam hits my Kuret inside the air. The bean breaks at contact and turns into waves that mix inside.

Matt freaks out, what the hell is going on. David's is using so many Kurets suddenly. I couldn't believe what my eyes were seeing. I have never seen so many different aura coming off this strong, and all from a single source. Jess and my Kuret are now mixing in the air like paints thrown in a wall. On top of that, the Kuret wall pieces were shaping into a large figure around all the Kurets flowing in the air. Its almost at the size of Charles. Marina begins to laugh, freaking shit. Is that what I think it is. I couldn't ask her what she meant. But what's even more shocking about the situation is that David isn't done.

David continues to fire more Kuret. He shoots a Kuret of tortoise color. This one, again was one of our Kurets. Matt feverously asks, wait huh. What's my Kuret doing here. The most unexpected of Kuret came out.
And another paint gets mixed into our Kurets. But then this one creates a change in the amalgamation of our Kurets. Matts Kurets begins to change into my and Jesses Kurets. What the freak. I can't believe this. David is using Matts Kuret to turn more of mine and Jesses Kuret quantity.

I was sure this the end. How wrong I was. David fire off even more. This one was a grey colored one. The Kuret shoots out a web into the air. This one I knew. One of the participant used this Kuret. It can stick any Kuret into anything physical. But she only did it block her opponents Kuret in short intervals. This is nothing like that. The Kuret begins to covers the entire mixed Kurets filled in the air. Vanessa shouts, what the hell is David trying to create. Marina replies, I think I know what. Don't you see what that first Kuret David shot like a wall is shaping like.

I was too mesmerized by the sheer number of Kurets thrown here. When Marina said that, I began noticing some noticeable features of the pieces forming. A head, legs and arms. My mouth opens halfway in total shock. Matt raised both his arms up in air shouting, freak this. Even Charles is probably too stunned to react. He just stood there as another Charles made of purple color is forming. All the Kuret David threw later, mine, Jess, Matt and the last one were inside the duplicate Charles. The pieces were slowing becoming solid and encapsuling all the Kuret inside.

Suddenly another Kuret is thrown by David. I am too shocked already to be surprised anymore. This one is blue. But not my Kuret. It was shot like a large beam straight at the duplicate Charles. The Kuret breaks into smaller threads when it came in contact. This one spread across the whole body outside like a network of ropes. Soon enough the duplicate Charles begins to solidify completely. What David has sculpted is a perfect replication of Charles. The same height and size. The blue ropes acted like a cloth lining on the purple body. Some places on the surfaces had small holes, which showed my and Jesses Kuret.

Nathan says, freak. Now we have two gigantic beings inside the barrier. I am about this close to getting the hell away from here. I couldn't disagree. But even when after all this crazy stuff I asked, but that’s just a dummy right. How the hell is David going to make it move. Its just a statue of Charles. Right. I could tell my own voice is hesitant asking this. Against all expectations, David throws another Kuret. At this point he has crossed what's possible. No one person can do what he is doing. This Kuret threw like a bullet into the air. But it wasn't aimed at his creation. Nor was it aimed at Charles. It was aimed to the ground between the two Charles. Instantly the Kuret lights up and covers the arena and turns the ground into a shining white light. The white light begins to move on the ground. The light slowly begins to roll into a white line connecting the two Charles from the ground.

Another Kuret which I have no idea. The white Kuret finally turns into a single thread connecting the shadows of the two Charles. Marina shouts, freak. He actually used that. I turned to her, what. You know that white Kuret. She nods, yeah. One my cousins husband uses that Kuret. Derek asks, well, what the hell does that one do. Even Derek is clueless at this. Marina turns her lips to a nervous smile, well. You will know when you see it working. The statue that was still till now suddenly begins to move. My eyes twitch at that sight.

Cass shouts, freak. That scared the shit out of me. She wasn't alone. The duplicate Charles moved, but he didn't do much movement. Instead he like Charles is just standing. Then I noticed that shadow connecting the white light. I instantly recognized what just happened. I used my aura to confirm it. I see mix of too many Kurets coming off that Charles, but the way it moved. Its exactly like the original ones. I put two of my palms against the side of temple, god dammit. Its mirroring the original. That white Kuret is using the shadow connect their movements.

Everyone here are too stunned to speak. We kept waiting any more Kuret to come out. But none did. Finally, David is done. I let out a sigh and pull my hand, this is just insane. Vanessa says, get it together guys. She says that, but her expression betrays by showing clear panic. That was meant more for herself. Charles finally makes his move. Immediately the duplicate moves in perfect sync. Every movement of their stride and arm moves are exactly same, but in complete opposite direction.

They both move towards each other. Charles not showing any signs of stopping keeps stomping and shaking the earth. What's even worse, the shaking is now doubled. When David used my Kuret to create mass for the duplicate. With an equal if not more weight, the stomps of the duplicate was added to the originals. The whole stadium is now shaking hard. Even the barrier is vibrating hard. But this stop the people from going wild. They were making vibes of their own as they shout, scream and jump in excitement.

With both Charles covering the distance coming at each other, they cover the distance faster even with slow strides. Charles goes for a punch with his right arm. Duplicate Charles mimics the movements with its own arm. Its eerily too see two large figures doing the same movement mirrors. Everyone watches in awe they the two fist connects. The clash creates a loud boom of noise and the shockwaves reaches all the way to use from the barrier. Charles Kuritine covering him on the arm cracks a little in places. Meanwhile, the duplicates surface also cracks. But neither of them get serious damages.

Charles pulls his arms back and the duplicates does the same. Charles tried to turn and move away from the duplicate trying to move towards David. But Charles had to face harsh reality that your mirror reflections follow your exact movements. The duplicate copycats his movements and blocks his path. Matt yells, this is crazy. This is some next level shit. Charles can't attack David when he got this bodyguard. Vanessa shrieks, what the hell is he doing. I turned to David. His Kuret storm had finally broken down. The storm slowly disappears and the Kuret gets back inside him.

Tessa says, looks like he finally stopped. What an insane power he has using that storm looking thing. David started walking now. He turns his back to the two towering giants and slowly creates even more distance. He halts near a spot where there is a broken small boulder lying. He puts one leg on it, bending his knees on it and rests one elbow on it. He crouches a little forward and rest his chin on his palm.

Vanessa shouts with a small laugh, just look at him so leisurely chilling out like that. Even I had to smile on that ridiculous scene. His is just resting in that position while watching the two giant Charles duking it out. Nathan nervously asks Marina, ah, I know you said the barrier will hold with one Charles. How about now. Marina begins laughing nervously, to be honest, I am not sure anymore. Charles Kuret level is too much. But that duplicate is no less, both their combined Kuret strength…I can't imagine what's going to happen.

Vanessa (Chapter 31)

Wednesday, February 7, 2024 21:55

I think its safe to say David has shocked the whole world with this. No one was expected the match like this. The match is already now past one hour. Almost the double of the previous record holder. What's even worse knowing that I am outclassed in every way as that the match is heating up every second. In my match, I was actually dragging it out, but this one is becoming increasingly dangerous and insane. Charles revealed another transformation that blows out all his previous ones.

Then David ones ups him again. After using so many Kurets in succession, he has created a duplicate of Charles. Arena suddenly becomes smaller when seeing two tall monsters fighting in unison. Charles kept trying to punch his way out. But every attack has been blocked with equal power. Charles even tried a head butt, only to became a dual head butt clash. The only thing that achieved is some Kuritines breaking on Charles and some cracks forming on the duplicates body.

I couldn't keep my thoughts in a single file. So much has happened in the past hour it, yet it feels we have been watching the fight go on for hours. The blows the two create keeps creating loud sounds. Few even created strong wind that blew away the dirt on the ground. The two kept going at each other non stop. Meanwhile, David had the nerve to just relax and observe the watch from the sidelines. This is not the first time in the tournament that a fighter fought from a distance. Many Medrones have Kuret that work over large distance or use substitutes to fight in some way. But this is the first time that one is just chilling outside the main fight without an ongoing effort.

Marina says laughing, just look at him. I would give money just to able to zoom on his face. Derek says with a big smile, you know what. That’s something I want to see too. Its not everyday you see something like this. Even on Medrine this would be standing out. Charles tried for a kick aimed to his duplicates stomach. The mirror copies it and stops it in mid air. Another sound of Kurets clashing fills the air. Jess asks, why doesn't Charles just stop moving. If he does that, that other one will also stop. Then he can just wait it out to lose Kuret. I can see Kuret leaking out of it slowly.

Derek says, the same with Charles. If he waits, he is using too much Kuret continuously for too long. Even he would tire out controlling so much Kuret. Blake says, so whether Charles fight or not, he is blocked from attacking David. I said, this has to be the most ridiculous thing David's pulled out from his bag of tricks. He first used multiple Kurets in succession, and now he combined multiple Kurets. Matt says, what the hell, is David a dual Kuret user on top of an omega now.

Marina laughs at that, nice one. Blake says, the juries still out on that. However David is doing it, he breaking away all the norms of how we use our Kuret. The two Charles attack each others fist again for the dozenth time. Its about almost 2 minutes this has been going on, and neither of the two Charles are stopping. They both have numerous broken Kurets on the surface. Charles wasn't healing the broken parts, I guess his healing is not included in his gigantification. The arena has become a ring for their boxing match. Charles couldn't make fast movies with his size, so he remained the same place for long time.

Charles tried a different approach. He brings both his arms up in air trying to grab his counterpart. I chuckle a little thinking what will that do. The counterpart did the same and now they both have each other arms locked in air. Charles with his mouth forward leans forward and tried to take a bite. The duplicate did the same. Before their mouths could crash into together into a wired kiss, their heads struck first and they come to a standstill yet again. Cass laughs out loudly, okay. This might be an instance match, but this is just too damn funny.

I couldn't fully deny her. Since David is unexpectedly sitting this out, I am actually relieved he isn't doing anything more dangerous. His new power is too much of a mystery for me, but I understood from Derek that he can't control those Kurets. That means he is not wasting any energy while the duplicate Charles is autonomously mirroring the originals moves. He really is just going to rest up until they both run out of steam. Suddenly Charles bending his knees and crotches down a little. He then gradually pushes up. He is trying to jump. My amusing mood came to a sudden stop.

I ask, what happens when Charles breaks away from his shadow. Before someone could answer, Charles leaps into air a little. I get nervous thinking that breaking away his contact with ground, his shadow would also break the connection. But the white light didn't break. The duplicate followed the original and they both jump with their hands and head joined. They both land back on ground even more earthquake. The ground on arena actually cracked in pieces and created mini creators on their feet.

Marina laughs once the ground stops shaking, that might have worked if he blocked the sun. You can escape from ground, but not your shadow. I have seen it few times used by my relative, obviously, not at this level. The only way to break the connection is to remove the shadow. Blake replies, which isn't going to happen in broad daylight. Marina nods, actually there are number of ways to break that white light, but none of which Charles can do. And just like that the giants continued to duke it out.

Catherine cries with giggles, check out David. I turn his spot. David had removed his elbow from his knees and is actually doing a slow clap with his hands. He is waving his entire arm and making a show out of this gesture. I couldn't stop myself from bursting out a laugh. No one could hold it. David behavior is not only showing arrogance but now blatant amusement at Charles helplessness. I tried to clam down, trying to reason that this is still a match and is still very much dangerous, but the comical scene is just too much for me. I blurt out, that’s the same guy who was unconscious just 10 minutes ago.

Blakes says, I can't believe he is so ballsy to enjoy himself in the middle of the match. David brings his hands down and then folds them into a cross. Marina yells, what the hell. Is he for real. Nathan says, freak you David. This too boring for you?. 3 minutes passed away like this. The two Charles were still going at each other. Even the people behind us were laughing at this. This match has been a roller coaster of my emotions. And now this. I was now even more mad at David for putting me through all this.

Both the Charles had gotten scratches from the continues attacks. Charles tried bunch of things to break out of this. He tried running back and running ahead faster trying to evade the imposter. Obviously, no matter how fast or slow he will go, the mirrored Charles would do the same movements. Charles tried next to grab boulders from ground and hurled at the imposter. This one had a better result since the mirrored Charles boulders crumbles more faster than Charles. The ground near the duplicate must be too damaged already. More pieces of ground hit the duplicate than Charles. This would be alarming that a weakness was found. But then those projectiles didn't do much damage on either of them. Even if more pieces hit duplicate Charles, the blue Kuret outside on the surface and that white sticky Kuret inside, both kept the body intact.

Matt says, holy shit balls. Is this not going to ever end. We are now at 4 minutes since this started. Blake asks Marina, every Kuret has limits. Just how long will that white Kuret last. Marina waves her hand on air, freak if I know. I analyzed the Kuret level of that connection. Its definitely loosing its consistency, but slowly. Like all the Kurets David's been throwing, this over powered one should have lasted only about half a minute at this size. Its lasted eight times more than normal. Its too unreal for me. If I wasn't here, I wouldn't believe that such a powerful quality was produced from someone other than the alpha.

Just then I noticed David moving. I call out everyone attention, guys, David's finally on the move. The situation is still tense that a single movement from David can change the direction of the match. I thought he is going to use his Kuret storm again. But instead, he used his normal Kuret flames. Matt exclaims, what. After all this crap, he is using something basic. David throws a Kuret line into the ground ahead and zips across the field. He aimed to the center of the two giants fighting.

Everyone got instantly regain their composure. David throws another Kuret line and drags further into their position. I am actually not happy seeing him heading straight into them. He should have stayed until the duplicate Charles broke down. But he must have seen his creation reaching the limit soon. The two Charles were now having too many damages. Charles Kuretines had broken in places revealing his skin underneath. Some even had holes on his skins. The duplicate also had torn purple Kurets. Those blue Kurets holding it together had been torn in places were hanging out like strings. Blakes and Jess's Kuret were leaking out more often now. Maybe they both of them have to a similar limit.

Charles sees David heading towards him and tried to grab him from the ground. Like a dutiful bodyguard the double blocks his approaching his hand. David didn't need to evade that. When he approaches to the side of the double, he throws a new Kuret line, straight up. Once reached some height, he slowed down a bit, but then immediately sends out another Kuret line up. Blake yells, whoa. Is that really his plan. I also understood David's intention. With a couple more Kuret lines, he gradually climbed up the duplicates body and finally lands near the neck.

I have no clue what made David do this. When he lands on the Kuret, his contact gradually begins to creates small cracks on the surface. His body naturally breaks Kurets. Yet he intentionally chose to do this. Nathans asks, what's the hell is he going to do now. Charles had his eye on David all the time. Once he saw David just standing on the neck, he tried to grab him in reflex. Of course, this isn't going to work out. The duplicate mimicked the same motion and stopped Charles.

Charles tried two more times, but he was just wasting his energy. Marina asks, what the is David trying to do. He is literally riding on the duplicates body. Then Charles stops attacking directly. He moved his own arm on his own neck. I instantly froze for a second. Shit, Charles realized he doesn't need to attack David directly. Since the duplicate is copying him, he can just grab David my gesturing on his own neck. I was a little worried about that when David first landed there.

I almost thought to ran inside the barrier thinking David would be grabbed by his own creation. Just before the arm would reach him, David throws a Kuret line angled down to the ground. He aimed his Kuret straight into the spot with the white Kuret is thinning out. His black Kuret lands on the Kuret on ground and cuts the connection. What. David cut the connection himself. Charles claws reached his own neck trying to grab empty air. However, with the connection gone, the duplicate couldn't mimic the movement. The arm is frozen in its place.

Jess says, whoa. That was a close one. David broke it himself. Derek says, the Kuret was weakening right. So it was anyway not efficient anymore. Marina nods, yeah. Its been running almost 5 minutes, I could sense it would going to break after maybe another minute. I ask, if there was another minute, why did he risk climbing and cutting the connection sooner. Matt says, yeah. Doesn't makes sense right. Blake then says, ah, this is David we are talking about, he has been doing outrageous things for more than half of the match.

Nathan says with a little nervous look, you mean something like this. David's Kuret is expanding. His is making his flames move like snake around the duplicate. Matt cries, holy shit balls. Don't tell me he going to do that. I thought I had my fill of surprises, but hell no. David is pouring his Kuret all around the duplicate like strings around his legs, torso, arms and neck. The black Kuret was creating even more cracks on contact, but the body is still holding for the moment.

Soon David's Kuret covered all the necessary joints on the duplicates body. David himself had sunken a little on the neck. But now he had vines of black Kuret covering the entire purple surface. Marina laughs with her arms up in air, this is absolute nuts. This is just too unrealistic. For some brief time, David's black Kuret and other Kurets are working together. Charles now free from the lock he was on for so long begins to attack with a punch.

The arm that was raised to grab David moves. Freaking hell. David is actually controlling the entire body with his Kuret. The arm intercepts the path of the punch. David had made few black vines on hand, he used them to open the palm and catch that punch. Then with a swift motion, he raised his other arm from below with a fist. Charles had been fighting too long with mirrored attacks. He couldn't prepare for a move that wasn't his. The fist hits square at Charles chin.

The punch broke the Kuritines on that area, with the black Kuret wrapped on his fist, even the skin was broken in. But that wasn't the shocking part. The weight of that fist was apparently too much. Charles was thrown back from that force. He was close to the barrier near, his head crash against the barrier. The contact begins to siphon off the excess Kuret off Charles. David doesn't stop there, he goes for a kick from the base of the foot.

The foot moved a little wobbly as it rises in the air. David has never manipulated such a big body before, he obviously doesn't have fine control. But he didn't need it. With such a size, the body would land its target anyways. Charles is trying to stop his fall by trying to grab on to the barrier with both arms. Wrong move. The barrier not only is siphoning the Kuret on contact, its even repelling back a little. The barrier begins to wobble now. Its stretching and showing visible bends on contact.

The kick from the duplicate lands straight at the Charles chest. Charles body gets pushed back even further. His entire back is in contact with the barrier. Derek says, he is trying to make Charles lose Kuret as much as possible. Marina laughs nervously seeing the two of the duking out, look, I am not responsible if they continue like this. Had I known this was going to happen I would have used all my Kuritines to make the barrier. Blakes says, its okay. Looks like its holding.

I ask, for now. But look at the two kaiju's. Blake says, David is also on the same boat. His Kuret his constantly creating more cracks on that surface. Is he trying to maintaining the status quo with a draw. Derek says, possibly. I didn't see him seeing us, but he must have noticed when we tried to test that barrier. Catherine asks, so he knew this barrier sucks off Kuret on contact. Derek nods, I am not sure. But look, his is trying to pin Charles against the barrier.

Charles falls on his ass at the edge. He tried to get up, but then David had prepared for a blow with both the hands joined. He brings down the fist straight at the chest again. The same spot. The hammer fist caused another loud noise inside the barrier. Charles back gets pushed even further. I say, David's trying to pull out Charles from his Kuret body. Derek eyes widen at that realization, whoa. Your right. He must have located Charles real body inside that.

Charles back was dangerously getting his Kuret siphoned off. The barrier behind him is wobbling, but it managed to remain intact after absorbing that Kuret from Charles. With David covering the fists with his Kuret, the Charles chest is even more exposed. The last punch created a large whole. At that point David lets of the Kuret controlling the body. He crawls of out the sinking neck. I am too much in haze to do anything at the movement. David kicks off the neck and falls from the duplicates body. The body was leaning forward and begins to fall on Charles.

David's Kuret around the body comes off like smoke and begins to go back inside David. As he falls, David throws a Kuret line to the air and begins to swings down slowing his fall. Charles tried to block the falling body on himself with this arms, but the duplicates surface had too much damage that it began breaking. First the blue Kuret becomes undone and then purple surface. This spilled out all the Kurets holding inside onto Charles. The grey sticky Kuret begins to spread out along with Blakes and Tessa's Kuret. Charles hands gets covered in all the Kuret, and soon all the Kurets gets spreads on his upper body.

Unbelievably, just as the duplicate body gets dismembered into Kuret pieces, David lands on the ground on his feet safety. David turns keeps his back to Charles and then makes a showy gesture of cleaning his hands like his job is completed. The people who had been shouting in excitement were even more animated seeing him like this. Everyone were half amused and half shocked at this display. I even let out a little laughter seeing David do that. Charles is stuck against the barrier, while David softly landed. Soon all the black Kuret comes back in David. Blake is the first one to speak out, that was something else. Marina giggles, that was epic. She makes a gesture with her fingers showing an okay sign.

Derek who is in a daze says, this is not only epic, but a also strategic plan. Just look at Charles. I turned my eyes to Charles. His entire body had been covered with Kuret mixed, but that’s not all. The grey Kuret had made Charles stuck to the ground. His entire lower body is now stuck to the ground, his arms as well. Only his upper body and neck remined free. But the back of the body was constantly getting zapped from the barrier. Charles should have been able to free himself with his size, but Blakes and Jess's Kuret were still sticking against Charles creating a pressure from its weight.

I had forgotten how many times I have been shocked in this match, yet still couldn't believe this happened. Even with such an enormous body, Charles couldn't defeat David. A new unexpected feeling came from me. Fear. That and complete new respect for him. David has broken past all his limits in this match and leveled up unbelievably. I couldn't take my eye off him during the whole ordeal. David had become tired and was crowing down with his hands on the knees.

Nathan says with smirks, David's exhausted huh. That little, actually big, stunt must of sapped all the energy he had stored up since he woke back up. He is right. David might have shown out of the world capabilities, but he isn't immune to fatigue. He had to be reaching the limit. However, M hadn't showed up once during all this. It meant he is not at any grave risk. Blake says, what's Charles going to do now. His body is stuck right, shouldn't he just ditch it now.

Derek says, not so easy. He feels the pain from his Kuret body right. He risked awful lot making himself so big. The blowback of cutting of the Kuret would be too much for him. He didn't even cut the tails himself in the middle of the match when David was cutting it up in pieces. He will likely wait until the Kuret tying him is gone and he frees himself. Matt asks, even with the barrier is continuously cutting away his Kuret? Derek nods, unless he does something unexpected, Charles can't avoid it. David planned this one also very carefully.

I have to admit David has been almost unstoppable since the second half of the match. Ever since his Kuret threads and exploding Kuret, he had slowly been gaining on Charles. And now, David might have pulled ahead finally. All of Charles attacks have gone unaffected. The only way David would lose the match is if he forfeits himself or gets too much exhausted. But he already said is not going to quit. David straightens up and stands for a while facing Charles body.

Blake says, oh. Is he going to pull another Kuret storm. Everyone turned their attention to David. David is once again preparing a Kuret storm. But this time something has changed. He isn't making it bigger. Instead this one his just around his height. Nathan asks, what happened. Did the fuel run out of tank. Blake reply, is he really though or is he making it smaller on purpose. We couldn't say for sure. David takes a while to prepare it. But since it is smaller, the Kuret is rotating faster and shrinking quicker.

About a minute passed and David had prepared a smaller Kuret storm. I thought he would attack immediately, but then he begins walking. His pace is slow, but he had the time. Charles had been struggling against the restraints, but the Kuret still hadn't loosed its strength. David makes his way from the side where less Kuret surrounded Charles. He halts when he gets close enough to the hole he had gauged from Charles chest. The Kuret storm finally shakes and then a Kuret comes off it.

It's a orange colored Kuret. This one came out like machine gun, firing off dozens of small but incredibly fast Kuret shaped bullets. Nathan says, hey that’s the same Kuret I fought against early in the matches. I remembered. Nathans opponent had a Kuret that fires off in small but fast projectiles. And just like always, the number of projectiles coming off is way more than then. Few seconds in, David stops the assault. The hole he fired on became more bigger. It something is now exposed out.

It's Charles. His normal Kuret body from the neck up is completely exposed. Matt shouts with a loud laugh, freak. Charles looks those people who are buried in the beaches. He is not that far off. The rest of Charles is still inside that gigantic body, only his head popped out. I say, David must have targeted with his Kuret to just have his head exposed. Blake nods, definitely. But what's he going to do now. Then David prepares for another Kuret. This is one is pink in color and flows out in the air like a gas.

Seeing that color made me recall the hideous scene that happened couple of years back. Nathan had captured Blake, Matt, Catherine and Cass. Nathan used that Ruby alpha girl with her seduction Kuret. This is the last place I expected to see it again. Blake exclaims, what the shit. Isn't that Ruby's Kuret. Nathan smile had gone now and replaced with shock, yes. But why is David using it. I can't believe he is resorting to such nasty Kuret. The Kuret flows in air and soon covers Charles face.

Matt suddenly bursts out laughing, holy balls. Is David going to ask Charles to drop out. The comment took everyone by surprise. I nervously ask Derek, is that even allowed. Derek face looked like he had a huge problem to solve. Few seconds later he says, I think yes. Even though Charles does it against his will, he is under a Kuret influence. Marina yells, hell yeah. This is such a classic David move. Make his opponent drop out. I don't like the Kuret he is using it, but whatever. Whatever gives him the win I am in.

Nathan nervously asks, even if Charles obeys and drops out. Would the guys upstairs consider it. I mean they allowed a stupid loophole, so what's to stop them again. Blake says, but its in the rules that if you make the other opponent drop out anyway you win. Tessa says, sure. But I think we have been thinking dropouts in forms of something like keeping them outside the arena for more than 2 minutes. Or keeping them constrained until they give up. Will it be even considered a drop out when Charles says its unwillingly.

I wanted to believe this would end with Charles declaration, but I also know both David and guys upstairs are not going to make the match end like this. David stops the pink Kuret. Charles couldn't stop the Kuret in air from flowing into him. Charles tried to turn his head away, but unfortunately, this Kuret doesn't need to be inhaled. It will be absorbed through skin. Now that even this hideous Kuret is boasted, it would be more effective against Charles.

Suddenly David storms shakes. Another Kuret flows out like a gas. This one is green in color. I didn't recognize this one. The green one also slowly spreads out in the air above Charles. The air is filled with two types of Kuret. I turn to Marina, what's up with that green one. She says, give me a sec. She draws a cast and waves her around to sense it. A few seconds later she says, whoa. I have heard about it, but never knew it actually existed. Sheesh. What is David planning to use this one for.

Derek asks curiously, what is it. Marina replies, believe it or not. It's something like truth detection. Instead of working on your heartbeats, it attaches to the Kuret inside your blood and detect lies. Nathan spats out, seriously. There's a Kuret like that. Marina shrugs, I guess. I have only heard from my grandfather about this. This is highly unreliable since the Kuret reacting to lie is not easily detected or reliable. I shook my head, not for David. He can use his synesthesia to check for lies. Like the way he tell our lies.

Derek asks, okay. But why would he use a compulsion Kuret and a lie detecting Kuret. If he is just going to make Charles drop out, what's that got to do with Charles lying. A thought came to me, Marina. Is there a way to hear their conversation. Marina looks at me, seriously. Isn't that against the rules or something. She turns to Derek. He takes a moment and says, if we don't speak to David, we are fine. But its better if we keep to ourselves. I don't want Kafar to know we are doing this.

Marina nods, okay. I can actually use the barrier as a medium and skip making any complicated charm. She starts to create a new charm. David stops the green Kuret a while later. Suddenly, the Kuret storm breaks apart. Blakes says, that’s it. He was only able to use 3 Kurets with that one. Derek nods, yeah. Looks like if he makes the storm smaller, he can't produce much Kuret. David then starts walking towards Charles. And then without waiting for a second, he begins climbing's his body.

I hurriedly ask, Marina how long. David's heading to Charles now. Marina replies, I know. I know. Just few more seconds. David didn't even need to use his Kuret for making foothold. The Kuret on the surface was mostly Blakes and Jess's Kuret, they were crumbling slowly on contact giving David enough room stuck his foot and hands. He reaches the top with ease and walks on top of Charles uninterrupted. He walks near where Charles head is exposed . He then leans down, takes a knee and rests his hands on his things.

Marina shouts, done. We can hear him now. Everyone walks closer to Marina in anticipation. At first we heard only some hushing noise. Then I realized that’s David's and Charles breathing. Few seconds later David's voice comes out from the charm, didn't expect this to happen huh Charles. I'll be honest, I didn't think I was going to make it few times. I went through some crazy stuff figuring out my Kuret. But I do have to thank you though. If it weren't for you, I would have never figured it out. And because of that, I have improved significantly. I can't believe it worked out like this almost perfectly. You really screwed your Kuret when you went into Kuret blackout a second time huh.

David's talking they were already buddies. He continues, you even tried to hide it when you created this massive Kuret body. That was a little unexpected. But that just confirmed me that your Kuret control has plummeted hasn't it. Constantly losing Kuret and repeated healing has taken a lot of toll on you. You tried to hide by doing something reckless. I won't deny it wasn't my luck. But I actually did plan to use a clone of you from the beginning, but with your size, I had no choice but to increase the scale of the Kuret attacks. That drained me completely you know. David takes a big breath, we both are in the same boat you know. I am totally exhausted and your Kuret controls for shit.

He continues after a sigh, so how about it Charles, what is your weakness. Tell me how I can beat you right now.

David (Chapter 32)

Thursday, February 8, 2024 20:27

I never expected my Kuret blast would go wild like this. The moment I fired off the white Kuret out of my newly powered up Kuret storm, I knew I couldn't turn off the output. The power is so much that I couldn't stop it with my own Kuret. I managed to blast Charles away before he could attack me, but I had a new problem. The barriers going to break. I couldn't stop the white Kuret and Charles would probably be thrown out into the crowd. In a desperate attempt, I thought a way to get out of this situation. I had been making a counter balance with my Kuret storm, I turned it off slowly making me push back towards the barrier. To this work, I would also break the barrier this side. This is definitely shatter the entire barrier.

I hit my back against the barrier. It begins to fizz out a little and then begins to crack under the pressure. Shit. I need to hurry up. I tried to push my Kuret up. I took a lot of effort to change the Kuret beam. I had no idea my new Kuret transformation would become this powerful to create this strong Kuret. Slowly, I make the white Kuret beam move up. But the barrier behind me is going to break soon. The I saw two glimmers approaching me from the side. Its Vanessa and Matt. They must be here to get me out. It was my luck, they could help me out. Ahead me Charles is slowly pushed upwards against the barrier. Just some more height and he will be above the stadium. On the other side, others have begin to clear out people.

It is actually a miracle that no one got hurt. Once Vanessa and Matt got here, they helped me out just in the nick of time. Charles was thrown far outside the stadium after seconds of my own exit. I had to take emergency action when Vanessa's Kuret tornado pushed me into air. I couldn't risk breaking any bones or getting seriously injured so I covered part of my body with Kuret and willed it to push up. I barely managed to land on Matt like an air bag. I felt a little guilt for using Matt like that, but this had to be done. Charles isn't down yet. The match will continue.

Our conversation made me realize others had also picked up a little on Kafar's intention. I get even more confirmation that this match will not end in any other way except for a clear victory. But that’s all right. I have already made up my mind that I am going to win this no matter what. My new overblown confidence had definitely shocked them. When Vanessa told I will die if continue this I contemplated a little. Its true that I am being very rash and brazen. But I can't stop now. Not when I am so close to shutting down Charles for good. So I gave her an answer I think she wanted. I didn't want to deceive her, but I was sure if spoke freely she would interfere with our match. I don't want others to get caught up this.

The truth is I am not going to forfeit this match no matter what happened, even if its dangerous. Hansen and Brandon, their words had an unimaginably hold on me. At the beginning I was surprised at myself, but then it started to feel right. Like I am beginning to own my thoughts. It like something weighing me down had been finally broken. I am not just Ryzen, or David from Earth. I am both and more now. And Charles has given me the perfect stage. I already showed one part of this power. And now that I got a first hand experience of how powerful this has become after my Kuret transformation, I am both prepared and excited.

Charles had barged inside the arena and chose to wait out first. Good. I need will get the time I need to prepare the Kuret storm again. As I focused on making my Kuret storm, I caught glimpses of new people gathering at the edge of barrier. Now that people were safely evacuated, others came back. Now in toe will rest of the gang. For some reason Ned left them. I guessed he must have went to get on top with getting this match continue streaming world wide. The whole VIP room is now here, except for Ned and Kafar. I bet Kafar got shocked with I threw Charles outside.

But the real shows about to start. Now that I have decided to reveal my full powers, I won't pull any punches. I have kept reaffirming my drive to win, but I know its not going to be easy. The set of Kurets I will pull out will seriously impact the flow of the match. While we waited for the match to resume, Charles focuses on healing his body and I on my Kuret. Soon Kafar himself came and made an announcement about continuing the match. I was right when I thought they would call out both of our violations. However, it’s a little surprising to hear that they are chalking it up to accidents. The only accident was my last attack with Kuret blast. No way people will believe all the stuff Charles did or the arial attack I did were just accidental. We both were intentionally doing them.

But it doesn't matter what actually happened if we don't deny Kafar's words. People will choose to believe him in the end. And its not like we both were going to admit it anyways. I could tell both us wanted to keep going without interruptions from others. Once the barrier was set, our fight is going to resume any second. With all this available time, I had figured out on the best way to make my new Kuret work. I can't be sure, but its possible I might be able to create dozen or so Kurets. I have never been to create to beyond 4 or 5 Kurets. So this is my biggest creation yet. And the glimmers of the Kuret coming from inside is the most pure Kuret I have managed to create. So the Kurets I fire will have to be strongest too. I couldn't help a smile at this realization. The Kurets I am going to fire is on par with alphas or omegas, perhaps even more powerful.

I want to win this no matter what, but I also know I can't be reckless. I need to make sure every Kuret I use has a purpose in bringing down Charles. That means I need to make a strategy to makes sure I don't waste needless energy and prolong the match any longer than necessary. If I has not exhausted myself already this much, I would have come up with dozens of plans. But right now my options are very limited. I don't have the energy to move around and pretty sure I can only make another Kuret storm of this size one more time.

So lets plan this carefully. I began devising my strategy into three parts. The first one will be to make Charles lose as much as Kuret as possible. He doesn't know what's coming next, so he won't be able to prepare all my attacks. It will also help with learning my Kuret control. I have never tried to fire this powerful Kuret before. I need to get some degree of control before the final phase of my plan. And If I can get in some serious hits that drops his endurance while I try to figure my Kuret, that would be a good bonus.

Then, the second part is to somehow trap Charles long enough for me to extract the information from him. I knew from beginning that figuring out his weakness is going to be extremely hard if not impossible. It would be a different case if he was from a bloodline that was relatively known. But Heraknus has been considered almost extinct in Medrine history. So far, the only weakness he has shown is those Kuret blackouts. But are they really a weakness. Sure, if he were fighting multiple people he would most certainly defeated. But in a one on one, its not the same.

During his first Kuret control, he was able to keep his body stable, even if his Kuret control had taken a hit. It may have looked like I was keeping up with him because I somehow managed to use those Kuret sparks. But he managed to bring his Kuret control back in minutes. Then the second time. That was just me being incredibly lucky. I got in several hits before his Kuret got out of control. If hadn't made those blows, or had been slower, he wouldn't have had this much trouble. He would have at least be able to move like the previous time. And then I would have lost without a doubt because I was completely helpless for so much time. So I am really sure this is not his real weakness. Maybe it could be part of it, but there has to be something else.

I don't have the time nor energy to figure it out during this match. So I should just take the easy route and just ask him directly. I will use the compulsion Kuret to make him tell his weakness. I also thought to back it up with a lie detector Kuret to make sure he isn't lying about it. I had a small thought that I could just force Charles into quitting. Even if I set aside my pride of winning like it, I highly doubted Kafar and the mystery people backing him would just let this end. They will argue that Charles was made to say it unwillingly. If I wanted to, I can counter it by telling them so many others have already tried it and some won in a similar way. That conversion would be highly controversial. So its pointless to think about it when I can't guarantee wining like that.

The final phase of my plan is actually a blank right now. Once I know Charles weakness, I will use my last Kuret storm to defeat him. This is not even a plan, just a regular guide for anyone wanting to win. But I didn't want to make any unnecessary assumptions or conclusions until I hear it from Charles. If I make some strategies just from some half baked clues about his weakness, it will instead me who bites the dust. I do have some a rough outline of might need, like evading, trapping, attacking or blocking against him. But I will not make any real plan until I have more critical understanding of what makes Charles tick. In this case, no plan is the best plan.

After a while Marina fly towards us. She is in overdrive when she lands on the center of the arena. A green Kuret erupts from her and it expands in all direction. I could see strong glimmer coming off the barrier, it meant this is way tougher than the last one. That’s good, I don't need to worry about people's safety for now. The green barrier zips past through me, even though my Kuret storm should have completely shattered it, the hole instantly begins to close behind me. Marina kept her end of the deal. She must have used most of her stash. I know what she will ask her in return. I actually think she is ready for it after seeing her fight against Vanessa and Blake. I haven't given her yet not because she isn't worthy of it, but because she wasn't ready yet. But now, she needs it to become even stronger.

I gathered my thoughts to focus on Charles now. Any second now, the match will resume. In the corner of my view, I saw the glimmers of others testing out the barrier. Nathan couldn't put a dent on it. Blake and Derek managed to only bend it a little. But what's more important is I saw the glimmers of their Kuret getting absorbed by the barrier. This is one impressive barrier Marina constructed. And one that I plan to fully use it for myself. Charles body is made up of Kuret, it would be really bad for him to get hit by that barrier. I changed my second phase of the plan accordingly.

Then finally the moment came. Kafar made his announcement and Charles made his move before he could finish it. Its actually understandable. Charles must be patently waiting and healing all this time, he can't wait even a single second anymore. I couldn't say that I had the same outlook. I wished I had more time, but I can work with what I got. The first Kuret I chose was Blakes. I bet no one expected me to use their Kurets. Would the be surprised or shocked. Maybe both.

My first phase of the strategy went not to bad. What I planned on how it would end did happen, but there were few changes I had to during the batter. Some Kuret worked even more better than expected. When I used Vanessa's Kuret, I had no way of knowing what will come out. It could have been wind, fire, water or ice. But it was lightening that came out. I honestly wasn't expecting that. Some worked less effective than others, the Kuret spikes I had laid out should have bought me more time. But Charles just powered through the arena. I knew that this wouldn't stop him, but his movement wasn't as restricted as I had hoped. That’s why I had to resort to use the stealth Kuret I didn't initially include it in my plan. This one is incredibly powerful, but because I have to use it continuously to hide, I would be using too much Kuret.

Nevertheless, I did manage to create those Kuret crystals in time before Charles could find me. I wished I could spare more Kuret to create even larger number of those bombs, but I need to save it for other Kurets. Once I hit Charles with the magnetic Kuret, I had finished the first part of my plan. And boy did it turn out pretty well. The bombardment had done a whole lot of damage on Charles. I could see from the glimmers Charles kept his Kuret body healing in overtime to reduce the impact. If he hadn't, the Kuret bombs would have struck his real body. Its actually crazy that Charles managed to survive at the end without serious injury. The only other people I think could make it out from that is, Blake, Marina and, well me.

I was hoping to at least incapacitate in some way. But his endurance is beyond rational. How deep does his Kuret supply goes. When all the dust clears, he is already healing all the places where red glimmers were coming from his body. I didn't let this stop me though. My first plan wasn't to drive him into corner. It was to cut down his Kuret as much as possible. And even though he still has Kuret in reserve, I must have made him use a big portion of it. Additionally, I got bare minimum handle over my Kuret attacks. I wasn't sure how my Kuret storm would hold out in this new form, but I managed to work without relearning everything from the scratch. So that’s good.

However, there is one weakness I just realized. After using about half a dozen Kurets, the Kuret inside has become a little unstable. I don't know exactly how it happened. I kept the rotation, vibration and everything in near equilibrium. Maybe its because I am too tried, or I don't have full control over it yet. Whatever the reason, its good I noticed this limit now. I kept focusing on making it stable while Charles is healing his body. That’s the next hitch in my plan, I wanted to keep on the assault on his weak body, wear him even further. It is what it is. I am have been extremely lucky that my first time experimental Kuret has hold out this far. My Kuret might be resonating with my emotions, who knows, at this point anything is possible.

While we both waited, I saw glimmers of everyone around us with total confusion and more excitement. The people closest to were even laughing at one point. Can't say I didn't see that coming. Once the shock is over, the next thing is laughing at such a ridiculous power. Marina must be freaking out right now. I figuratively and literally stole her power. Well, to be fair I only stole an idea from her after seeing her match with Blake. Obviously I can't use other Kurets like her, Matt or Ned. Would they eventually figure it out this weakness. Maybe they already do.

Some time later, Charles healed his body. But the problem is the Kuret inside is still not stable. With this amount of Kuret, its going to take a bit more time. Coincidently, Charles didn't attack me next. I could the Kuret glimmer on him behaving weirdly. It’s a little slow and not efficient anymore. He still had the same amount of glimmer is see on him. But its like his control on his Kuret has become difficult. I wasn't imagining it. I looked all around him and could see slivers of glimmers slipping out of him which doesn't happen unless my Kuret comes in contact.

This made be happy. My plan had cracks, but unexpected results sometimes gives new opportunities. After loosing so much Kuret, Charles has lost some control over it. All my attacks, from my Kuret, his blackouts and now this. It must have finally pushed past his limit. This is great, he is loosing steam. But that doesn't mean I should be reckless. He has only lost quality, but not the quantity. He might be become even more dangerous in his attacks now in his state. And it turned out to be right. Even after healing, he didn't stop adding Kuret. Gradually, he kept on adding more and more Kuret on him. Like a balloon getting pumped with air, he grows into a completely five story building.

Damn. My gaze move slowly up has his figure grew in height. He didn't stop just there, he even started cover himself with his Kuritine. Instead of sticking it out like spikes, they began curving on the skin and began covering all over him. He made himself a Kuritine armor. If it was me just an hour ago, I would have been in a would of trouble. But now, I could only think how I will relish in the idea of beating him down. Charles took a good decision in choosing this Godzilla form. I am not moving much like most of the match, plus all my attacks are others Kuret and not mine. He decided to risk creating a bigger target for defense and power.

There is no doubt in my mind that Charles is fighting such a way to hide that his Kuret control is not as good as before. I could see the Kuret glimmer coming out of him everywhere, but he assumes that everyone interprets that’s just a by product of his massive size. But I notices his Kuret behavior way before he transformed. Too slow Charles, I am not so naïve to not notice it. This development is both good and bad. The good part is huge Kuret body is now a part of him, so he can't discard it like when he didn't cut his tail off. On the other hand, the downside is that I have to use all the remaining Kuret on him. I didn't have to strategize an entire new sequence of Kurets, but the scale has gone up considerably. And I would most likely drain out after I do it. I didn't think I would have to use all the remaining Kuret so soon.

Well, no matter. I can still make it work. Once he is trapped, I will have the time to create another Kuret storm. But my immediate problem is that the Kuret inside is still not stable. Charles on the other hand was already on the move. His giant steps create earthquakes. God damn. He made the land termer with his normal form, but now its full blown quake. His every step is creating mini craters. The only upshot to this is that he is taking his sweet time to walk here. I am really in a pinch here. I concentrated more to make the Kuret stable.

Charles is only 3 steps away. Come on. Don't betray me my Kuret. I didn't know if my Kuret actually heard me, but the storm is becoming stable again. Nice. Just in time too. Charles had raised his arm to crush me. I decided to first throw the shape copying Kuret on him. Him being so close would make the Kuret copy his shape even better. Once I threw it, I instinctively threw Vanessa's Kuret. This time I was saved by a thick iceberg. I was glad it was something sturdy. If fire or water came out, I would not have blocked his punch all the way.

That punch managed to almost get me. It was way to close. I began to walk in reverse as I threw all the other Kurets. Considering I have never tried this before at this size, it went perfectly. I managed to copy his size and strength almost equally. I think I even shocked Charles with this. He didn't make any moves as I worked my magic. And once it was over, I added the final touch. A white shadow Kuret to connect the two of them. I could feel I am running on fumes, so I decided to make the Kuret stronger so that it remains longer. If I am going to take a brief timeout, I need to make its long.

Once the last of Kuret from inside is gone, I let the Kuret storm go. That was intense. Even though it wasn't physically demanding to fire all the Kurets, its mentally exhausting. I didn't plan use all the Kuret for this, but Charles latest transformation forced me. At least now I can get some time off and gather some more strength. I looked around for somewhere good to rest up. I choose a small rock lying to my side. With leg over it, I let my back relax on my knee. I am grinning all the time Charles fought his clone. Charles tried so many things to get the clone out of his way, it was becoming amusing.

Charles then tried to jump up thinking disconnecting from the shadow would stop the mirroring. A decent try for Charles. That actually warranted an applaud. I couldn't help myself when I do a big showy gesture of clapping my hands. Charles didn't had a choice but to keep this up. Its's so insane that I managed to find a way to sit out in a battle when I am in it. If Charles hadn't made himself this big, I would have more Kuret to use while he fought the clone. My original plan was to make him fight his clone, while I keep firing off all remaining Kurets on him. I fold my arms in a cross to wait out as long as I could.

Too bad it didn't go the way I wanted. But hey, at least I got rest up a bit. Charles and the clone kept going at each other for minutes. It blew my mind that the all the Kurets I thought of in this rushed situation is working so well. This just goes to show you what the Kuret at their respective highest level could achieve. After about three minutes both the Charles had sustained a lot of damages. Because of the way Charles kept attacking, he got hurt in unexpected ways. He has wounds that are not healing everywhere. His Kuret control is really taken a big hit.

After another minute, I saw the Kuret glimmers of my Kuret clone becoming weaker. While the inside three Kuret were still holding out, the purple shell, the blue ropes and white Kuret connecting them is weakening. I decided I need to intervene now while the Kuret body is still relatively working. I don't need to waste energy on transforming my Kuret, so I call on my Kuret fire to wrap my arms. I throw a Kuret line and began working my up to the two giants. Charles had the gall to try and grab me when he sees me coming. Doesn’t he get it mirror doesn't work like that. Obviously, the clone mimicked his hand and it blocks him.

With nothing to stop me, I threw a Kuret line on top of the clone. I still haven't gotten used to flying, even though I already done it a while back. It's not safe to use something so risky, but I didn't have a choice. I have to take control of the body before it becomes any more weaker. I reach the top and land near the neck. I dug my right hand into the reck grabbing it with my Kuret. I kept my Kuret as small as possible to keep from damaging the surface and just strong enough for me to hold on. It is very strange to stand here like this. I felt like I had climbed a tall moving building that is fighting another one. The clothes I had torn in places when in contact to the Kuret, begins to form cracks on the surface. I had to open both my eyes here because so much glimmer of the Kuret is coming, its blinding me.

The wind kisses my face and my hair sway around in air. Its eerily like I am manning a boat rocking on waves. Charles still didn't understand how mirror worked when he tried to grab me. It's incredible how amusing this had become. But it has to end. After couple of tries Charles realized how silly he is being. He tried to grab me by moving his hand to his own shoulder. Well, this had been a good show. Time for the finale to start. I throw a Kuret line to the ground and cut the white Kuret line connecting their shadows.

The arm of the clone stops before it could grab me. Now for another difficult part. I blast a wave of Kuret around me. I need to use my transformed Kuret to grab the clones body. Just as I had learned, I first vibrate the Kuret as it expands. Then I make it rotate around the body to keep it stable. The Kuret around me obeyed as I wanted. Its incredible. The Kuret flames gradually turns to condense and then finally becoming physically solid. I didn't need it to strong, so I willed them to be shaped into thin ropes. Then I used them to go around the body under me. I don't have enough strength to cover the entire body, so I will just wrap it in the essential places. The knees to walk and kick. The shoulder joints and elbow to punch. I made some extra Kuret covering near the foot and hand to give some extra damage to Charles.

I couldn't believe I am able to make my Kuret work like this in my first try. I don't have proper control on using it on large distance. And yet its just barely enough to do simple stuff. I have been trying so many new things in the match I have lost count. But this is one tops all my ideas. I am going to control a Kuret body with my anti-Kuret. There wasn't even a second where I wasn't grinning ear to ear. I even chuckle in between trying to imagine how it must be looking for others.

I bet Charles didn't even thought I would try this. I want to enjoy this so much. But the timer on this temporary control has started. Not only I need to save my energy, but I have to finish this faster before my Kuret weakens the body further. I can't have the Kuret inside spill outside before I am ready. Charles comes out of his trance and attacks with a punch. With simple commands of pushing and pulling, I control the arm already in air. I use the Kuret on the joints to be pushed ahead, then the Kuret on the hand to open up the palm. Using very simple movement I just manage to block Charles punch. It's good that Charles is so slow. I wouldn't have been able to stop it if not for that. My Kuret wrapped there already begin to damage his armor. But that wasn't all I wanted.

Up close, I see some odd glimmer coming from a spot on his chest. The glimmer was a little denser than other parts of his body. I realize that Charles must be hiding there. Great, I found him quicker than I thought. Using the free arm, I pull it up for an undercut jab. Since I am not fully in control, my aim is just a guess. But by timing the Kuret thrusts, I managed to hit a fist into his jaw instead of the chest. The moment it struck, a loud bang came out of it. The shockwave it created moved all over the place. Charles should have been able to dodge it. But funny thing happens when you fight a mirrored clone for too long. You get so used to same attacks, you can't break out of that habit immediately. I laughed out a little once Charles stumbles back towards the barrier.

As he falls back, he pulls his arms to the side and tried to grab it and stop his fall. I bet he never expected the barrier would not only push his hand away, but also take his Kuret on contact. I needed to make sure he doesn't back away. So I prepare for a kick. This is one is even more tricky. The whole body is stumbling forward when I willed the Kuret around the knee to move up. My view becomes tilted to a side as the body leans forward. Just one more hit in on the chest. I focus all my Kuret on the leg to move, ignoring the falling clone's body. My breathing had become suddenly fast from all this. If I had more time, I would have come up with a much better plan that wasn't this tiring. I didn't even have a backup plan, everything is riding on this.

Charles is too much distracted to block this kick. The clones kick hit him around the place I Charles is hiding. Hell yeah. This is going to work out just as I wanted. Charles was now on his ass with his back against the barrier. I let go of the Kuret control. I drew in deep breathes from my lungs. It's even hurting a little now. But I am ignoring it completely. I couldn't keep my excitement under control when this risky plan actually worked. I need to get out of here before the clones surface breaks. I crawl out of the hole I had sunken down on the shoulder. I turn my back on Charles lying body and jump out. The wind feels so cold on my skin. I am half drenched in sweat. Its weird I didn't even hesitate before jumping off. Doing something like this had become something of a obvious thing for me. Like breathing.

Before I crash land horribly, I throw a Kuret line from my back upwards. The line puts me into a small arc and I land on my feet safely. Behind me, I saw the glimmer of my clone body falling apart. The Kurets I used inside now showered on Charles. Charles tried to grab the clone, but it is useless. The body didn't have any form anymore now that its purpose is fulfilled. This is too good for it to be true. This was a rushed plan from the start, and yet it worked. Charles slowly begins to get stuck to the ground from the sticky Kuret I had thrown in the mix.

I couldn't stop from making a gesture with hands on a job well done. My palm hurt a little bit with this. I may have a little too overenthusiastically. But its all good. I turn to face Charles. The hole I made wasn't healing and neither was he able to get out of the Kuret I had tied with. This is the opportunity I needed. I wished I didn't have to use up all the Kuret before. Oh well, I will make a smaller Kuret storm. And then after I recover some energy, I will create another Kuret storm on full power.

Charles struggled to get out, but his efforts were in vain. Good. That gave me time to focus on preparing a Kuret storm. I raise my arms up and began working on my Kuret storm. I just need only two, no, three Kuret blast. So I should be able to make it a bit faster. About a minute gone, I finished creating it. The Kuret storm is not completely stable. I should hurry before its gone. I slowly walk towards the exposed chest. As I had guessed from the glimmers, Charles body is not completely out yet. Good thing I prepared for an additional Kuret blast. I create a Kuret from one the participants that fought Nathan. The Kuret shoot out like a machine gun. The efficiency of this Kuret had dropped due to such a slapdash rush job.

I become a little worried that I didn't have enough power. But then I saw his glimmer becoming more clear. I immediately stopped the Kuret when I see his head out. I just need that part to be exposed. Then I blast the air on with Ruby's Kuret. Initially I had planned for a alternate compelling Kuret, but that one required more Kuret. When I had to let go of the Kuret storm earlier, I decided to change the Kuret to this. I am not so sure about the effect of this Charles. But Ruby was able to influence not just guys, even girls. Since her Kuret interferes with the people's pheromones, I should still be able to pull out information from Charles. Evan Nathan had enough faith on Ruby to use it against us way back then.

Once I am sure that enough Kuret has been absorbed by Charles, I blast the final Kuret on him. I can't control Ruby's Kuret like she does when compelling us, so I have to use another Kuret to know if the words coming out of

Charles mouth is the truth or not. Charles continuous to struggle under the second Kuret gas I blast him with. Once I see the glimmers of both the Kurets seeping inside his real body, I let go of the Kuret storm. My entire body is so sore, I just want to finish this an lay down. Maybe I actually can. Charles isn't going anywhere. I may have bought about 5 or 7 minutes before the Kurets on him disappears. I should use that time to strategies and rest up.

But not yet. I stand up straight and walk to nearest place where I can climb inside the hole I made on his chest. My arms are in pain. I am really abusing them so much with the Kuret storm. But I won't let it stop me. I grab on Blakes and Jess's Kuret covering around Charles chest and haul myself up. After a few seconds of arduous task of climbing, I reach the small tunnel on above. I see Charles head peaking out from the neck up. He had no Kuritine on head, only his raw Kuret body remained. He is wriggling when he sees me. I don't know how much control he has on this giant body when he doesn't have his head connected. Can he still move it if he is rest of his body still intact with the giant Kuret body. I can't be certain. It matter though. He is completely helpless right now.

I take few steps toward him in all this uneven Kuret skin and take a knee near his head. I had to wait for a while until I catch my breath. I don't want to sound like I am too tried. I even wipe off a some sweat dripping near my jaw. This is very important for my final plan. I need to use all the tricks and lies I have to get him to tell his weakness. Few seconds in silence, then I began talking and finally brought up the big question,
so how about it Charles, what is your weakness. Tell me how I can beat you right now.

David (Chapter 33)

Saturday, February 10, 2024 21:00

Charles didn't answer me right away. Did Ruby's Kuret didn't work. No I could see traces of pink glimmer on Charles. So he must be resisting. Like how Blake was doing in the beginning. I need to keep talking and get him to open his mouth. First I need to make him talk about anything, once that happens the Kuret will take over and compel him more. I continue my efforts on sweet talking Charles, you don't have to be shy you know. Just tell me what's your weakness. I know there is one.

Charles voices come muffled under his Kuret body. Maybe he can't speak in this Kuret body. No, that can't be. His mouth opens up from outside, so it wouldn't be just for biting. The noise he is making is to resist speaking. Good. I ask, you don't want to tell me your secret. Fine. I can wait for a while. I got some time to kill. It's a lie. I can't waste too much time here. But if hastily approach him, I would waste this golden chance. I clear my throat, why don't we talk about your bloodline, Heraknus. You guys have been hiding all for countless generations on Medrine. Regardless of the situation on Earth for hiding for the past decade, you didn't need to hide on Medrine. So what gives. Why didn't you want people to know you existed.

More stiffened noise comes from Charles. I should keep going this track, come on. You guys are out of the closet now. And Medrines sadly gone. So there is no reason to keep the reason a secret anymore. Charles shook his head for the first, like he is physically trying to stop from speaking. Nice. Just a little more, I have a theory. Tell me if I am wrong okay. I didn't plan this to go this long, so I didn't have anything good to talk. At this point I am just fibbing. But as long I keep him engaged like this, whether I say something real or just lies, he should finally give into the compulsion. I continue, I think some few centuries ago, you guys did something, or was done something to you that made you guys hide your entire bloodline from others. You guys did such a good job of it that people turned you to urban legends.

This is already obvious something happened in Medrine history to make them into hiding. I plan to just keep him in suspense and believe I will eventually get to the truth without him. I add more bullshit, what did you guys do. Or maybe not do. Maybe your ancestors killed a whole bunch of people. Huh, is that it. Maybe there was some internal strife and you guys had a cold war. Am I close. Charles faint voices comes out, but it wasn't audible. He is desperately trying to keep his moth shut. I said, is that a no. Hum, I thought for sure that was it. Because of your ancestors crime, you couldn't reveal your existence and become a target. Hum, nah. Your right, this can't be the reason. People turned Heraknus into to a bed time story, so they had forgotten all about you. Maybe the old families like royals knew about you.

I take a sigh feigning my dissatisfaction, then what is it Charles. Huh, do you guys just hate other bloodlines. Maybe you guys think that your Kuret makes you all so much better than us. I mean, I can't deny it. Heraknus Kuret is just to insane. When the alpha is this strong, the rest of the members must be strong also. I tried a different approach now. Do you guys look down on other bloodlines. I actually don't care for the reason right now. I just want a reaction from him. I think provoking him might be more successful seeing how much he is trying to hold back. I was right on the money. Charles finally broke.

The same voice I heard him from the beginning of the match comes out, no! That’s not the reason we have hidden all these time. His voice came out rushed and forced. He is almost yelling at me. I didn't care for his attitude. I made him finally talk. I lean forward a little and rebuke, why don't you enlighten me Charles. If you don't want to talk about your weakness, you can tell me why you guys are in hiding. Charles retorts, you have no idea what our bloodlines have been burdened with. If you knew, you would agree that hiding was the best way for everyone.

I jumped on that chance, so why don't you unburden yourself right here. Just tell me what's your weakness. How can I beat you. You can tell me all about your reasons later. Charles voice become muffled again. But he couldn't keep it like that or long. A few seconds later he blurts out, you keep asking for my weakness. I don't have one. I chuckle a little at that, yeah. Nice one. Unfortunately I don't believe you Charles. You're a liar. Charles couldn't keep himself from talking anymore, no lies. Its the truth. Heraknus alphas have no weakness. We are warriors that can fight for hours continuously.

My mind is telling me he is still lying. But my eyes see a different story. The green Kuret I threw on him earlier wasn't reacting. I didn't see any change in the glimmer inside Charles body. I grew silent for a moment. That’s not possible. He must be still hiding it. But the compulsion is working now. He is telling truth now. My expression darken. I ask him irritated, I don't believe you. There is not a single being in existence that is completely invincible. Your bloodline give you incredible power, but you also have big limits. You guys have to wait for a long to recover your Kuret in your original bodies. You guys have Kuret blackouts in middle of the match. You even lost some of your Kuret control. I don't…

Charles cuts me off, that is only happening on Earth. What's the term you guys have used it, ah. He thinks for a second, the humanization. We didn't have this limit back on Medrine. We only had a minor instability in our Kuret bodies. But that has been severely effected on earth. And as for my Kuret control, you are right. I did lose some control. But as you can see, I can still fight longer even in this state. I have never fought someone like you in my entire life. The only other person to push me such length was my late mother, the previous alpha. So I am telling you the truth, I don't have any weakness as long as I can use Kuret.

My eye is twitching now. This is not what I expected to hear from Charles. The green Kuret on his body didn't react. He is telling the truth. Freaking hell. Is this really happening. I can't believe Charles only weakness was really his Kuret blackouts, that actually was because he is on Earth. Does this mean on Medrine they were unstoppable. I shook my head. Freak no. If such a bloodline really existed, why did Medrones lose the battle against Hive. With these guys they would have completely crushed the enemy.

I said, I refuse to believe that you Charles are unbeatable. You say you don't have a weakness, then tell me how someone from not the Heraknus bloodline win against you. Charles didn't respond immediately. He then says, I don't know. For the first time, I saw the green Kuret glimmers running wild inside Charles. I sliver of hope came. So there must be a way to beat him even when he doesn't have a weakness. I urge him, Charles. You are lying again. Come on. You know there's a way for me to beat you. Tell me. You want to unburden some of the stuff weighing on you.

Charles tries to fight a little more. But then he blurts, keep fighting me and make me use all my Kuret. That's the only way I can be stopped. As long as I have Kuret, I will get up every time. I will heal all the wounds on my Kuret body and keep fighting even with my Kuret control lacking. He wasn't lying. He believes this is the only way to beat him. This is also not what I wanted to hear. No way I can keep fighting like this, not against is seemingly unlimited Kuret endurance. Freak. What the hell should I do now. The way things are going, I will have to use my last Kuret storm without any real strategy. That’s really the worst case scenario. Once I finish off all my Kuret blasts, I will be done. Is this it. There is no other way. Maybe I have to face reality and swallow my ego to forfeit the match right now.

Then what about all the confidence I showed Vanessa and Matt. I made them believe I will win this no matter what. I can pictures Vanessas, Blakes, Marina's and others faces when they try to console me later. Ned, Kafar, Nathan, and who knows other would pity me. I grit my teeth in frustration. God damn. The strategy I made was too flimsy. I should have thought of something, a backup incase this interrogation was a failure. Can't believe I let my ego or pride or whatever messed up my head. My emotions had taken a dark turn now.

Charles speaks his mind for the first time, don't tell me you still planning to continue. Even after what I said. I couldn't tell what Charles saw on my face that made him say that. Perhaps he interpreted my anger and somber look as just frustration. But when I think about it, he might be right. I could just end this match now. But if I am going to lose, at least I want go all out. Even if it’s a hopeless cause, its better than quitting now. I have come this far, I will take it through. And who knows, if I am extremely lucky, I'll win. I brought back some of my weekend determination. I think hearing Charles surprised, gave me some more push to continue on. I can't let all my efforts go to waste like this.

I made up my mind. I take a deep breath and calm my emotions. I can't panic and lose control of myself. I am still in the game. If there is even a one percent chance of wining, you bet your ass I will go looking for it. So I need to pull out whatever information I can from him before the Kurets disappear from his system. But what should I even ask. What will he be attacking me next with. He can just change it later once this compulsion wore out. I need some way that can end this match end quickly. Any other method will not work with my remaining stamina. I keep thinking of a way. A moment later I realized I could ask him a different approach. I ask, tell me how to use up all your Kuret completely in one go. You said as long you have your Kuret, you will continue fighting. So if I make you use all your remaining Kuret all at once and if I beat it, victory will be mine.

Charles shook his head with whispers trying to escape from his mouth. I force him, you have used your Kuret so much already. There must be something you have that will make you use your remaining Kuret continuously. Tell me how I can make you do that. Charles wriggles his head more furiously. Then second later he says with a pressured voice, I…don't…know. There is nothing…don't…know. I didn't even need to see the green Kuret glimmers to know he is lying.

I say with stern voice, just let it out Charles. You will be unburned even more. Tell the way to make your Kuret use all at once. I swear, I could hear Charles teeth grinding to keep himself from speaking. I got a even more curious by this reaction. What could be so huge that he is trying so much to hide. Then suddenly Charles couldn't keep the lid on it anymore. Never in my wildest thoughts did I expect to hear the words. He stammers, overdrive. He pauses a little trying to stop. But he continues despite his will, if I go into overdrive then I would lose large amounts of Kuret every second. Then the only way I lose is if you are able to survive until my overdrive ends.

What. The. Freak. He can use overdrive. My jaw flew open unconsciously in response. My eyes widen with shock. Did I hear him right. I close my jaws and swallow hard. I ask, are you serious. You can overdrive. And once its over, you loose all your Kuret. Charles nods his head in defeat, yes. I can do overdrive. If you managed to keep up with me till the end, you win. No reaction on the green Kuret. He is speaking the truth. Shit. In a way it makes sense. If he has Kuret blackouts in this form as the weakness, his overdrive must have even more limitations.

Then I become more nervous realizing that overdrive meant he gets even more stronger than his current form. I ask hesitantly, does your overdrive works like Blake and Marina. Does it power up your Kuret to even a greater height. Charles nods, yes. My overdrive…He abruptly stops himself. He wiggles his head instead. Ah shit. I didn't notice that the compulsion Kuret on him has weakened. He is coming out of it. Damn it. I didn't get into more details. I got up and started to back away to the opening of the hole.

I need to get some distance before Charles gets up. I didn't have the patience to climb down normally, so I jump off directly while throwing a small Kuret line to the sky. I stagger hard as I touch the ground. I slowly began walking. But my legs were heavy. Not because of the wounds, but because of the impossible task ahead of me. I am only managing against Charles for the moment, fighting him in his overdrive would be overkill. But if that’s the only for me to win, I have no other choice. The prospect of fighting him in his overdrive is too crazy to even to think about. I don't know where to begin.

I understand some of how overdrive works from Blake and Marina. If it works similarly like theirs, then Charles overdrive form should be completely bathed with his Kuret. What kind of insane form will he take on. I halt after gaining some distance. I turn my back against a boulder lying and lean on it. Is this really going to happen. I need to fight another overdrive user. With Blake I saw him use earlier against Marina, so I could strategize in advance. I even cooked up plans that would have worked against Marina if ever got matched up. But now, this is too dangerous. Without knowing what how is Kuret powered up looks like, I would have to just wing it. In my current condition, there is no way it will happen.

So what should I do. Huh, I grunt in frustration. I don't want to stop now. But I know I can't beat his overdrive. Maybe once I learn my new Kuret transformation I might be able to handle his overdrive. And if I can master my Kuret storm, I would definitely have more chances. Shit. Such an impossible situation. I distract myself a little to avoid this grim future and turn my gaze to others. Everyone had hurdled up together around a person. I saw Marina's glimmer in the middle. What are they doing. I focused a little more too her charms glimmers coming from her. She casted a charm. What's that for.

I saw faint glimmer connecting her charm and the barrier. I followed with my eyes the path of the glimmer, all the way to the backside of the barrier where Charles is stuck at the moment. A moment later I realize that going on. I let out a sigh. They were watching us. Must have been curious to what I do with Ruby's and the other Kuret. So they head that shocking reveal. The existence of the 3rd overdrive user. This is so unreal. Among the 10 billion Medrones, only 10 or 11 people could use overdrive at a given time. And we have 3 of them here all together. I know its not a coincidence since our species is on the brink of extinction, more unusual and powerful people would be observable now.

This tournament already has shown hundreds of alphas, 18 omegas and 1 true alpha. In the mix comes a mythical alpha. And the icing on top the cake, 3 overdrive users. This had to be the most powerful group of Medrones ever be in one place, both on Medrine and Earth. Thinking about the statistics makes be laugh a little. How ridiculous was that I came in top among all these people. Some people have said I have been lucky so far, but is really though. I believe I have been lucky, but that's not why I am fighting Charles and not someone else. The memories of my past, the people I made promises to and their sacrifices have pushed me here. Maybe I have been trying to suppress that desire to win unconsciously. Maybe now that I know people like Hansen had such unexplainable faith, it made me stronger all these years, even when I didn't remember them.

I take in more air from my mouth. I have to fight Charles. I need to surpass him. Those people who died to keep me safe on the last day, they said to survive. To grow stronger. And I have to answer their faith on me. That meant fighting even when the odds are against me. Ah, freak it. I shook my head and face Charles giant body. Since the beginning this has been a impossible battle. If I think about it, nothing about the situation has changed. What had changed is me. My Kuret. And my reasons to win. I speak out to myself, you got this. I raise my hands and prepare for my final Kuret storm.

I initially planned to rest for a while. But I scrapped off that plan. I need to make an even bigger Kuret storm now. One that will hold at least 2 dozen Kuret blasts. I need to use the compulsion Kuret I planed earlier and make Charles go into overdrive forcefully. Then I need to keep him away from me for all the time and maybe even trap him again. I need to avoid a direct confrontation as much as possible. I am basically savaging for scraps from the shattered strategy I devised earlier. I came up few important Kurets I have to use no matter what. I rack my brain trying to recall what other powerful immobilizing Kurets I can use.

In the middle of my thoughts, a loud roar comes from Charles. He brakes my attention and I avert my eyes to him. His glimmers showed sparks of blue and orange as he continuous to howl. Whoa, what's he doing on. Is he inflicting pain on himself. Then I notice his glimmer moving. Holy shit. He is trying to break out of his giant body. What. The glimmers around him swirl more on him. Why is he trying to break out now. He feels real pain when his Kuret body gets cut off. The amount of blue Kuret keeps increasing as he tries to slash out the other Kuret crawling out.

This is bad. I didn't think he would become this desperate now. What happened. Does he plan to finish me before I could make my move. Even risking so much pain. I am way to stunned at Charles reckless behavior. My Kuret storm is no way near complete. I only just started. I need at least 4 or 5 minutes to make it bigger. I have only seconds now. God dammit. I thought of another idea. I have to take on even a greater risk and use my Kuret transformation. Without this Kuret storm, that's the only other power that can beat him down.

But can I even do it. Charles lets out another loud growl. He is almost out now. Shit. No choice. I have to do it. I let go of the Kuret storm and turn my hand into fist. I wait to absorb all my Kuret inside me. I am a little nervous to try this. M hasn't gone into red mode, but I bet once I do this she will alert others. They will stop this match and make me forfeit. I don't want to let them get in my way, but I can't exactly stop them either. What the hell I should do. I have to risk it and hope my body can handle the Kuret transformation.

I began pouring out my Kuret around me in a wave. Just like I learned since then, I repeat the exact same process. Keep making it vibrate and rotate it at the same time. My Kuret obeyed me ever so slightly. I am mentally exhausted now from all the Kuret blasts. This is way to difficult for me. I kept concentrating hoping to make it work. But then with a last loud bark, Charles comes out free from the hole in the chest. The giant Kuret body instantly begins to crack and slowly shatters in pieces. Then it begins to turn to Kuret dust.

Charles comes out flying and lands on the grass. His body which had no Kuritine looked like he was wearing a large brown skin colored cloth. He then starts to run towards me. The mind sends out an alarm to my entire body. Holy mother. What should I do. I ditch my idea to cover my entire body and just focus on my arms. The Kuret dome forming around me breaks apart and slowly condenses to just my arms. Charles isn't waiting to heal his body. He kept running at me at top speed. Orange and blue glimmers is still coming off him. Holy shit, just when did he got so desperate to win.

I concentrated hard on the Kuret over my arms. But even this much was too tiering for me. So I changed my effort once again and just go with the wild Kuret. Its inefficient, but its at least faster to make it. As I expand my Kuret, I vibrate it and rotate it. Like I thought, this was much easier and faster to make. My arms was covered once again with the exploding Kurets in few seconds. But I could tell the power coming off it is way to less than before. Also, I could only cover till my elbow.

I grit my teeth hard. Fine, I will just use this to win. I don't even know how I can be still stubborn about winning. I didn't have time to think anymore. Charles is within his reach. But something unexpected happened as he came rushing in. He is yelling at me, stop. We need to talk for a moment. That almost broke my concentration, what the did he say. His voice and his behavior didn't match at all. He is coming at me with gusto, no way he is asking me to listen to him. I must be hearing things.

Choosing to ignore him, I let the Kuret on my arms thrust me forward. The familiar sensation of my Kuret gave me more confidence now. For some reason Charles had slowed down a little and wasn't even trying to attack me. Maybe I did hear him right. But I won't stop. Charles comes to an abrupt halt and pulls his arms to defend against me. I pulled my right arm in and prepared to throw down a fist. He doesn't have those Kuritine protection and his Kuret body is weak. Meaning both our Kuret is not strong, so I should be able to keep up the status quo.

I land a punch on his arms protecting hoping they gets crushed. But the power is too less. The moment it clashed, I could tell it didn't have the explosive strength my punches had earlier. His guard remained upon our contact. Charles barks out, wait. David. Cease fire. I want to talk. I am literally bamboozled. What the hell is there is talk about. I use my other arm's Kuret to pull me back and gain some distance. Charles didn't follow up with an immediate attack. I don't know what he wants to discuss. But I can't let this opportunity go to waste.

I land on my feet a distance away. My breathing becomes labored. Shit. Just one punch and I am already dead tired. I knew this was way to much for my body to handle. M must definitely gone to red mode. Anytime now others would barge in and make me forfeit. I press my lips in angered. This is not how its supposed to end. I yell out in frustration and let my Kuret thrust me ahead again. I will just throw both my fist into him in a straight on collision. Then suddenly Charles body begins to smoke.

I abruptly make my Kuret to stop. The rough movement caused me stumble controllably when my feet touch the ground. Charles Kuret body slowly turns to dust, mimicking the exact thing happening to his giant body. I see the glimmer of his Kuret subsiding inside. What's going on. A sudden overwhelming thought came to me. Was he trying to confuse me by saying those things and is actually going into overdrive. No, Charles is too much of a simple minded guy to try such a tactic.

I decided to wait a little more. I kept the Kuret on my arms ready for anything. But I wasn't ready for this. Charles comes out of the Kuret dust. Not his Kuret body, but his real body. He had clothes torn in places. They had stains of blood all over him. His skin was bruised in multiple place. He had one eye closed from a nasty swelling under his cheek. He had one arm crossed on his chest supporting his other arm. I thought I was looking bad, but Charles is in a worse condition. Its unbelievable he fought me such condition. Wait, the most shocking thing is that he has let go of his Kuret body.

He spats a spit to his side and faces me with a big smile, that was one of the most exciting and terrifying battle I had to fight. Just what are you son. I was too much in shock to respond. What's going on. Is he quitting? That can't be right. He said I had to make him use up all the Kuret, that's the only way to win. But he just stopped his using Kuret himself. I shook away my confused thoughts and regain my sense. He did say he wanted to talk. So maybe I should just wait and see what he wants.

I answer him, what I am doesn't matter. You should be asking who I am. I am the one who will be winning this match. I showed all the conviction I had in my voice. Charles smile becomes even bigger and chuckles. Its crazy he finds it amusing considering in his own face full of bruises. His laughter dims down, such overwhelming confidence. I honestly don't know what happened to you since we started this match. But clearly you are no longer the same person I met before our match. Just what in the world happened. First your Kuret becomes suddenly grows stronger. You take on a strange form. And I was told you use anti-Kuret. But ever since our match resumed, you are using so many others Kurets. What's up with that.

I unconsciously smirk at his confusion, bet you didn't see that coming. Charles nods, that totally shook me to my bones, you know. Derek told me only few people in this tournament could do something like that. But what you did goes even beyond that. How in the hell did you do that. Honestly, it was amusing to see Charles so confused. It made me forget a little about my own confusion about this absurd situation. I wasn't going to give him my secrets, it doesn't matter how I can do it. You only need to worry that I can use it.

Charles snickers, true. I doubt if you would have told the truth anyway. He then pauses and shakes he head to the side and cracks his neck. He continues, speaking of truth. The biggest twist of all was you making me spill my guts out. I never thought you would just make me tell you like that. That might be the most craziest thing you have done in our entire battle. Despite his tone annoyed, he seemed to be still enjoying. What a guy. He continuous, my overdrive is actually a secret even in my own bloodline. Only my family and few trusted others know about it.

That's a surprise, why would you want to hide it. Only hand full of alphas can go into overdrive. He nods, yes. Well, my overdrive a little special. My great-grandfather could do it. We never got to meet, but I know of him from others. Gaining more power is one part of it. But there is a catch. As you already know, our bloodline is already powerful. A Heraknus overdrive user would be essentially unstoppable. I reply, jeez. If you are going to just make me listen how powerful your overdrive form is, you might as well just tell me the way to stop you as well. I make small smirk at my witty remark.
Charles smiles at me, trust me kid. I am not being rude here. I already told you that my overdrive is the best way to beat me in short time, right. The reason why I hide it is part of it. He takes a breath, since you made me reveal my secret, I have no reason to keep it hidden anymore. Our overdrive is powerful, but dangerous. After our conversation, I got worried that you would use some Kuret to force me into my overdrive. I purposefully took on a lot of pain to rush here and stop you from doing it.

I am confused at his reasoning. Dangerous?, I asked him confused. I shook my head, Charles. I don't know if you have been aware of your own actions. I lost count how many times you tried to really kill me. If you are worried about becoming more dangerous, you shouldn't have bothered to stop me. This battle from beginning has been incredibly dangerous for me. Charles shook head, no. No. I mean, yes I did some mistakes. I can't deny that. He makes an apologetic voice. I got too much worked up in my Heraknus form. You kept bringing up powerful attacks, that kept pressuring me and I pulled out some reckless attacks. For that I am regretful and apologize.

Only some attempts. Try about a dozen. His apology felt sincere. But no way in hell is it acceptable. Saying sorry that he almost killed me so many times in what was is a friendly match is crazy. Charles continuous, also I am not saying its dangerous to you. Well, it is. But that's not what I am worried about. I said its dangerous for others. The people on this island. The ones sitting on the stadium. That left me speechless for a second, what. What do you mean. He replies, the reason I have to keep my overdrive a secret is because its dangerous to everyone when use it. I become too violent. An inner beast born from our Kuret bloodline takes over me completely. You wouldn't be fighting me, but an animal driven on pure instinct. Hunting and killing any prey I find on way.

My eyes widen in shock, what. Are you serious. It's really that dangerous. Charles nods, yes. I am telling the truth. You asked me about why Heraknus have been hiding for so long on Medrine. This played a part in it. He pauses like he recalled something nasty. He says, if you want, I can tell you the whole story about our past. But lets keep it for after this match. Now you know why it was absolute necessary to stop you before you forced me go into overdrive. I shook my head, but we have a strong barrier. You wouldn't be harming anyone. He nods slightly, maybe. But unfortunately I don't know for sure I wouldn't just break it away. I ask, why would even try to attack it while I would be inside.

Charles says, I don't know why but when I am go into overdrive, my instincts drives me to hunt and kill anyone who isn't smelling like my blood. I would attack anyone who wouldn't have the same Kuret scent as mine. Meaning I would become violent anyone who is isn't my immediate blood relationship. My grandfather use to tell stories about his father. Whenever his father would go into overdrive, he would lose all sense of things. Only the primal instincts remain. A powerful primal urge to eliminate all others who aren't their parents or children. My grandfather and his siblings were only the ones who could stop him from attacking others. And even then, the best they could keep him restrained until the overdrive is over. In an attempts to control his overdrive he tried to train himself, but always ended in failure. It also endangered others. So I was told to keep it hidden in our alpha line until you would master it.

I was a little enthralled in this story. What an incredible situation the Heraknus are in. He continuous, my grandfather and mother didn't show any signs of overdrive, but then I began showing signs of it when I hit puberty. I was so happy to know I had the potential. But then grandfather told me the stories. Then, well, I become less happy about it. He lets out a big sigh, after a lot of convincing, they agreed to let me train it after couple of years. The first time I was finally able to go into overdrive was just few years before Hive came. I don't even recall what I did during the time. Thankfully my grandfather had the expertise and experience, so my family was able to keep me restrained. I never managed to train it more than 3 times on Medrine.

I realized something. He said earlier he looses a lot of Kuret every second. I ask, its because you lose all your Kuret all at once. And once its gone, you have wait months before you try it again. That's why training your overdrive had been so difficult. Especially now on Earth which has put even more restriction on your Kuret. Charles had a surprises look in his one opened eye, whoa. That's right. You really figured me out huh. He shook his head slightly, its like you said. Earth has made us weaker, no doubt about it. But now that Kuret is flowing in the Earths air more now due to our presence, we have slowly been getting better control. However, not completely. I never stopped wanting to learn my overdrive. Especially when I now need to avenge my late wife. His voice broke a little and turned somber.

Damn. This took an unexpected but all too familiar turn. I reply, I am really sorry for your loss. I understand how you feel better than anyone. Charles replies, thanks kid. Its been some time since I had got over the grief of her death. My kids had to grow in an alien planet without her. Even when I got remarried, I never stopped wanting revenge on Hive. And the best way to make sure Hives never reach my family every again is to master this overdrive. I have tried it to learn it few more times in Earth. But still I haven't gotten control over it. My kids are not strong enough to stop me in that form, so I clued in some of my trusted friends and capable people into my secret and help me keep restrained. It takes at least dozen of my people to keep me from turning into mayhem. They have to keep rotating amongst them in turns, until my Kuret is depleted.

He turns to the side facing the crowd, if I go into overdrive right here. I can't even imagine how much dangerous it will become for others. I only brought my wife and kids with me. And some close friends of my family. Without the special equipment's and guards here to protect others, this could easily become a massacre. And the worst part is that with so many different Kuret scents, I might be even more berserk. This is total nuts. I can't believe I came this close to unleashing a true monster.

He then faces me, of course. I know there are some exceptionally powerful people that might be able to stop me. Especially that group of people you are close with. If both Marina and Blakes had their own overdrives in full form, I might let them handle me my overdrive. But that's still dangerous. They least should be made aware of the risk well in advance. I gulp a little hearing him. If what he said was true, then he was right to stop me. Blakes not learnt to control his overdrive and Marina hasn't recovered enough to use hers. It's a little perplexing that every known overdrive user is having problem with that. Its an incredible power, but it comes with its own risk.

A moment later I ask, but where does that leave us. I can understand you not wanting to go into overdrive here. But also understand that I will defeat you no matter what. Charles slurps a little hearing me, are you serious. You still want to fight me when I just told that I become so violent that I lose all sense of reason. Honestly, out of all the things I have heard from Charles, that's the least of my worries. I reply, I already told you. I was in danger since the beginning. I have been in various life and death situations. From my perspective, this is just another added difficulty I have solve and overcome.

Charles one eye widen. A moment later he say, kid. I thought were supposed to be some genius. You are willing to risk your own life over such a thing when its not even Hive you are up against. I reply with a scoff, I am not being reckless here. I have considered the risk. Honestly, I am a little scared. But this isn't something new. Last six years of my life has been one crazy dangerous ride. At this point, even after knowing your situation, its not different than the other crazier stuff I have been up to. I am sure Derek or Kafar or someone has told you of some of the insane things we have gone through. I have managed to survive through. Some with luck, some due to others and but also due to own skill. So try not to underestimate me. I might not know how powerful you will become, but I have been fighting powerful people all my time on Earth.

My unshakable confidence left him speechless. Few second later he says, you are total nuts Kid. My own family gets scared of me when I use my overdrive. And you expect me to believe you can handle me all alone. I remain unfazed at that provocation, I don't know what I will or will not do. But I do know that if I don't even try, then I already lost. Charles then smiles, damn Kid. Just what have you been through to become like this. I don't believe a few years of fighting would make you so much battle hardened. I know you don't remember your past, but what kind of life did you lead on Medrine.

I could tell him about it. But what will that accomplish. I doubt he would be bothered by the fact that I was a shadow like Blake. I choose to remain silent on this topic. He scratches the side of his temple a little, your right about one thing. This a tough situation we are in. Should we keep continue fighting like this, or should I really go into overdrive and hope people will be safe. I really wanted to say the latter option. But I am not crazy to endanger others safety at the cost of my selfishness. Also, I am very much doubting how well I can handle in my current state. I began thinking for ways to resume our match without causing a lot of fuzz.

Charles then suddenly snaps his fingers that jar me out my thoughts. He brings out a smile, I got it. I know what we should do now. I got curious to know what this new outrageous suggestion he was about to give. He chuckles, you should me some real guts David. I am beyond impressed by the fire in your eyes. Even more than those ridiculous Kuret powers you hold. So I have decided, if someone has even a small chance of surviving this all alone, it might be just be you. His compliment made a little happy despite how childish it was to feel like this. It felt like I am become worthy enough in eyes.

He then turns to the crowd, but I can't make this decision alone. I need to bring Kafar here. I scoff at that suggestion, seriously, you want to what, take a leisure break in the middle of our match and bring in him to make a strategic plan. He shrugs his shoulders, why not. Its our match. We can do whatever the hell we want, right. If we both agree to take a break to discuss the rest of our match, it shouldn't be a problem right. He wasn't completely wrong. Technically speaking, based on the rules if both of us are not willing to fight, we get disqualified. But in the finals, where the rules have bend so many times, I doubt they will disqualify both of us.

After a couple of moments to ponder this ridiculous idea of his, I decided its worth exploring. At the very least, I would get some respite. I turn to him, okay. I'll go with you for the moment. What is your idea. He says, I don't want to get your hopes up until I ask Kafar a question first and hear the answer. Once he does, I will tell everyone about my idea. You can even choose to reject it and we would resume our battle, of course, without making me go into overdrive.

Interesting proposition. I nod, okay. Lets do it then. I can't wait to hear your plan.

Vanessa (Chapter 34)

Sunday, February 11, 2024 12:29

Every word coming out of David mouth is making us nervous now. Marina whispers, what the hell. You just asked him for his weakness directly. Crazy with a capital K. It was totally unbelievable. Everyone here were sure he was going to make Charles drop out. But I nagging suspicion that David was planning something else. He tries to further prod Charles from opening up. Charles kept his mouth shut. David changes the topic and instead talk about Heraknus reasons for hiding on Medrine.

Derek says to me, he is purposefully chatting on unrelated topic to open up Charles. No wonder David has been talking non stop. Charles would eventually slip up. I still couldn't understand why David doesn't just make Charles drop out. Why does he want to continue risking so much for this match. And then it finally happened. Charles mental defense broke and he begins to talk. What he said made us incredibly anxious. Nathan scoffs, who is Charles trying to fool. He doesn't have a weakness. No way that possible.

I was also shocked to hear this. Even David didn't buy it. He keeps up the conversation and telling Charles not to lie. But Charles talks how his bloodline has effected on Earth and their only weakness is that Kuret blackouts. We didn't hear David's words for a while. I can almost feel the grim expression he mut have in his face. Blake nervously asks, Charles has to be lying right. I mean he has to be some sort of flaws right. Derek replies in slow voice, maybe all their limitations have been evolved to be only when they don't use their Kuret. They are basically humans when they don't use their Kuret. I say that’s pretty much the biggest drawback of their powers.

I shook my head, but what when they are in combat. Are they really invincible. Derek didn't respond. Tessa offers, maybe if there were a group of going against Charles, he would lose. Charles already admitted he lost a lot of his Kuret and even slowly beginning to lose his Kuret control. But he still as lot of Kuret reverse. The only to make him use up all is to keep fighting him until its over. Matt shrieks, but that’s not possible in a one-on-one. David's too exhausted. Tessa nods at him, yes. It seems rather difficult for one person to do it, isn't it.

The atmosphere around us had yet again changed. Now Team David is the one who were distressed with the latest turn of events. Even if David is currently on a hot streak, he can't keep up with Charles endurance. He doesn't even have our Kuret stamina to boast him. Just him being able to do this much after getting knocked out goes beyond anything humanly possible. David had remained silent for long now. Blake asks, is he going to make Charles drop out then. Derek replies in low voice, I don't see any other choice David has. He must have been banking a lot on this plan. The best way for David to win is to force Charles now when he still under compulsion.

I wasn't sure about it. Something tells me David is not going to do it. I was proven correct when he instead asks for a way to use up all of Charles Kuret in one go. That was a ludicrous idea. One that just might work out. Its borderline insane that David still wasn't giving up and grasping for anything he could. Everyone here got tense hearing Charles stammering. I lean even more trying to hear Charles voice stammering. Then his voice finally comes, overdrive. One word that rocked me my whole mind. He continues to tell that’s the only way for him to use up all his Kuret in short time.

Everyone here were completely speechless. David was no exception. I could hear the shock in his voice when he asks again to confirm if that’s true. Charles says he can use overdrive and if David survives that, he would lose. David becomes silent again, no doubt trying to comprehend what we just heard. Matt raises both his palm to his temple, sweet mother. He can overdrive. What the actual freak. Marina and Blake were visibly shocked to know they have another overdrive user joining their extremely rare group. Marina had her mouth half opened and Blake eyes were wide. Catherine puts her hand on her forehead, my heads going to explode now. Of course Charles can do overdrive too. She emphases the last part more to show her sarcasm. Nathan asks, hot damn. Just when you think this match can't become crazier. Jess asks hesitantly, so what's going to happen now. Tessa replies, anyone's guess now.

I am confused and perhaps more shocked. This is not how I thought we would finding the 3rd existence of an overdrive user. Somewhere in my mind, I had a ridiculous but small hope that I would be the one to achieve it next. Charles becoming one doesn't mean it will never happen to me, but its like I am slowly getting left behind by everyone. Few years ago, only I and handful of others were the only powerful Medrone known to everyone. But now, I am nowhere near them. What's more disgusting is that I can't stop being jealous of them. I have no right to be mad at them, but I couldn't help it. Especially now that David is fighting at their level.

I ask, no, almost pray, David don't do anything stupid. Either drop out or make Charles to drop out. A moment later he asks Charles if his overdrive is like others. I can't think for a second hearing David's still not backing down. Charles says yes and then grunts suddenly. We hear a shuffling noise. I turn my eyes to the arena and see David coming out. He jumps off the giant wound and begins to walk away. Derek says in low tone, I guess the compulsion wore off. Marina calls out with nervous voice, is this really happening. Is Charles also an overdrive user.

Blake shook off his frozen expression, didn't David use a lie detecting Kuret. If Charles was lying, David would know. He clicks his tongue, as incredulous it may look. Charles at least believes himself that he can overdrive. Whether he is delusion or not, that is what he believes. Right. He turns to Derek. He nods in response. Cass asks him, hey. Did you knew about this. You know this freak the longest of us. Derek shook his vehemently, this is the first time I heard. I ask him, but can he do it.

Derek didn't have an answer for us. Nathan asks with a smirk, what do you all think David will do. You all heard him. If David chose to force Charles into overdrive, there is chance he might win. Tess says, yeah. But I don't think his overdrive will be walk in the park. In his condition, David is too weak to beat Charles. Marina says with harsh voice, okay. Now even I don't want David to fight anymore. I am more worried now that even Marina is feeling the pressure. I turn to Blake. He looks me and says, I wouldn't want David should fight Charles in his state. Fighting me is one thing. But Charles is already so powerful, his overdrive will be too much to handle for any one person.

I am finally relieved that others are on the same level as me. There is too much danger for David to continue this. I can't let his stubbornness get him killed. I turn to Derek, I know we agreed to give David chance, but you have to admit this has gone longer now. I don't know what's David's going to do, but we can't let him make Charles go into overdrive. Derek doesn't give me an answer. He looks to me and to David. He must realize we have to end the match now before David gets killed.

Derek then turns back to me, you are right. I wanted to let David fight to his content. But this too much of risk. Kafar will not be happy with this, but it's much better than David getting badly hurt or worse, dying. I become less anxious now when he too understood the risk David is putting himself in. Suddenly Charles loud roar comes through the Charm. His normal voice is already loud, the speaker so close to use made his want to cover our ears. Marina hurriedly closes her Charm. I turn back to the arena. Charles was wriggling out of the Kuret body while grunting with pain.

Catherine shouts, what the hell. Why is Charles doing that. Suddenly Charles is not going to wait around, instead he is getting out of the trap David created for him. I turn to David. My eyes twitched at what he was trying to do. The crazy guy was trying to make to create his Kuret storm. I was too shocked to be mad at him. Few seconds later Charles comes out the hole in the giants chest. Charles didn't have Kuritines or any hair made of Kuret. His entire body looked like a animal with his fur shredded off. Just a brown skin covered with few wounds. Beside him, the giant body begins to crumble and slowly turns to Kuret dust. Without waiting to heal, he begins to charge at David.

The sudden change in the pace of the battle let me dazed for a second. I ask others in a nervous tone, is Charles going to use overdrive himself now. Blake spats, no way. This can't be it. It's not as easy as it looks you know. You can't just snap your fingers and go into overdrive. I reply, then what's with the sudden change in Charles. He just tore off from the giant Kuret body to chase after David. Marina says, he's gone feral. At this point, anything is possible, I thought. I have to go inside now and stop the match.

But I momentarily stop when David changed his Kuret. Instead of using his storm, he prepares a dome around him. Derek says, I think he is trying to use his new Kuret transformation. I said, yeah. But I can tell its not same anymore. He had more Kuret around him earlier. Blake agrees with me, yeah. Its definitely weaker. Marina says, should we just stop the match now. Matt asks, but if Charles is not going to use his overdrive, then its still fine right. David might be able to continue like this.

I wish we had that luxury to think like that. And then suddenly Marina's wrist begins beeping. Marinas pull out her arm. M pops out and says. Red alert mode initialized. The same stuff that she showed us earlier was back again. I can't read what's displayed, but its definitely not good. M says, boss's heart rate is too high. He is having trouble with steady breathing now. He hasn't lost much blood, but the risk of infection and shock has become immanent. If boss doesn't stop over-exerting in the next minute, his vitals would drop considerably. Please stand by for emergency actions.

This made my chest hurt. David's finally pushed past his limit now. I turned my eyes to arena. David had already wrapped his arm with his exploding Kuret and zipping at Charles. I can't believe David is still not giving up. I can't watch this. I need to stop him. I saw Charles slowing down near David. I was too much worried about David to care about that. I pushed off the ground and ran towards the barrier. I had the Kuritine Marina gave me in my hand. I didn't even waste to stop a moment when I come near the barrier.

The Kuritine in my hand biggens to shine. My entire body gets covered with a small layer of Kuret. When I hit the barrier, the barrier didn't stop me. Instead, the Kuret layer I had on me begins to create a thin door ahead me. I pass through it without much resistance. From the corner of my eye, I saw Derek behind me also running towards the barrier. I turn my gaze back ahead. David landed a punch on Charles who blocked it with his arm. David backs away, but Charles doesn't move. Instead, there is smoke coming out of him now.

I didn’t even think to halt for a second seeing something bizarre. But then Charles real body comes out. I abruptly stop my run and let go of the hurricane I was using to propel forward. What, I ask aloud. Both of them have stopped fighting and looked like they are talking. What just happened. Charles was no longer using his Kuret. I couldn't see his properly from this far. But his clothes were torn in places. He had gotten blood on him in places. His face also looked a little weird. What's happening, why did Charles suddenly stop using his Kuret body.

I should have gone to David now they have stopped fighting. But there's a small chance that Charles is actually surrendering. If I back away now, then people might not notice that I am inside the barrier. I take less conspicuous movements and steps back to others. Derek was almost inside the barrier. He stopped one step before entering himself. The Kuritine on my hand was gone, so I can't leave now. I wasn't going to leave anyways. I turn my face to others and gesture with my hands to know what happened. Matt shook his head and spoke something in audible. I didn't realize the barrier even silences the voices from outside. Actually, now that I think about it, I don't hear the noise from the crowd too.

I gesture my fingers to my ear to tell them I don't hear anything. Blake raises his palm to me and points to Marina. She is in the middle of casting a charm. I turn my back to others and face the arena. They are definitely talking about something. David had let go of his Kuret on his arms. He wouldn't do that if it wasn't needed. Or maybe he become so tired that he can't use his Kuret anymore. Whatever's going on, they have temporarily stopped their fighting. Few seconds later, I see the barrier near me forms a small charm. Then I hear Marina's voice from it, can you hear me now. I nod, yes. I see Matt shoving Nathan aside and speaking into the charm, what's going on. They stopped fighting. Is Charles giving up.

He had the same thought as me. I turn my back to them saying, I have no idea. I can't hear them. Derek voice comes next, stay vigilant Vanessa. I don't think Charles is giving up. They are talking way too long for a simple surrender. Blake asks, Marina can you create another charm for us to hear. She replies, not if you want everyone to see a charm forming near them. The best bet would be just to have someone from the bloodline of binocular eyes and who can lip read. No one here can do that. We have no choice to wait for now. I had a hard time keeping myself still. I lost count how many times I have been stopped or decided not to intervene now. Usually it was David who makes me mad, but this one was due to Charles.

They had a long discussion. A minute gone by like this. Nathan asks, what is going on. The crowd is beginning to become more restless. Jess says, can hardly blame them. We have been seeing a high intensity battle for so long, even when they both were down earlier. Now suddenly they are chatty. Tessa asks, isn't there a rule that if both fighters are not engaged in battle for too long, they both get disqualified. Matt says, please don't tell they both are going to drop out like this. Cass smirks, you think that stupid what's his face would do that.

She had a point. Its become evident that the match can't end like this. So what are those two doing then. Another minute went by like this. The suspense has been killing me. Can't believe that them not fighting would make me worry this much. Marina asks, ah, Vanessa maybe you should go to them and ask what's the hold up. To be honest, I was thinking the same. Then Derek says in hurry, don't. I mean don't interfere when they still have time. Its almost 2 minutes now, so they have 3 more minutes before the are disqualified. At least according to the rules. They are not fighting, so lets wait for now. M's gone back to her that orange alert, so David is not in danger yet. In fact, he might be stretching this purposefully to buy time and recover some lost energy.

Yeah, that’s also true. David's not actively fighting. So its fine. But what could they be talking about so much. Others on the other side were whispering and discussing possibilities of their discussion. Were they trying just chatting each about each others skills. Could be. Then finally something changes after about another minute. David was waving his arm to us. Charles beside him faces us. David raised his hands up and gestures a T with his arm. I am a little shocked to see this. Marina shouts, what. They are asking for break. Right now. Nathan laughs, what do they think. This is not a game, they can't just ask for a break. I ask, should I go to them now.

Blake says, maybe. Looks like this finished up their talk. Derek pitches in, ah, I know that was obvious, but I don't know they are thinking. We can't just stop this match like this. Marina, open a charm near them so we can hear them. Marina asks, really. What about not wanting to interfere the match. He replies, things have changed since then. Charles is not stopping David, so he also wants the same. We can't just take a break without knowing the reason. After a short pause he continues, but I don't want to you to get into trouble. So just open a one way channel like you did last time. We will only hear them and they can't hear us.

Marina thinks for moment. She agrees and starts to prepare another charm. She says, okay, I am going to extend this charm to them, like a conference call. The charm on my side of the barrier brightens up. I turn my eyes to the two men inside the arena. A small charm begins to appear near them. It was behind Charles. Charles turns and walks to it from the side. David saw it too comes closer. Charles voice comes out, ah, what is this. Its been so long, I had forgotten his normal voice.

Then David's voice comes out, that’s Marina's work. She was using that to hear my interrogation earlier. Very much like a pepping tom. Marina scoffs, damn. I got caught. Charles chuckles a little, really. I didn't notice it. Well, it doesn't matter if they heard it. If you go with my idea everyone will know about it anyway. Charles idea. Is that what they have been discussing. David clears his throats, so here's the short version of what we talked about. Charles says he can't go into overdrive right now. And after hearing his reasons, I understand why he can't. But I can't defeat him without it. So he wants to propose something. But he can't do until he talks to Kafar about something.

Huh, I spoke aloud. That’s what they have discussing this long about. David says, oh. So this just one way channel. Nice thinking. Don't want to interfere too much. I get it. But now we want a strategic break, so to speak. Charles says next, Derek, I need you to go and get Kafar here right now. I understand its little out of the norm, but I need him here before making a decision. Everyone turn to Derek who was even more clueless now. He was thinking hard on what to do. Then David spoke, you must be confused. That’s understandable. I figured even Kafar would be reluctant. So tell him this message from me, if doesn't come here in the next 2 minutes I will knock out Charles right now. I don't like to win this way, but I'll do it. From the rules, we had about 5 minutes to resume fighting. He needs to make some sort of announcement about taking a short break in the remaining time. Tell him I said it okay.

David made this demand like a dictator. Charles asks, really. If you were okay wining like that you could have just knocked me out as soon as I let go of my Kuret body. David clicks he tongue, obviously I am not going to do that. You know that, they know it. But Kafar doesn't. In his mind if I do it, he can't spin this any other way than my clear victory. So come guys. The clocks ticking. Derek a moment later says, huh. I guess I need to go talk to Kafar. Excuse me all. He had a stern look on him, but he did what he was asked. He walks away back inside the stadium.

Charles ask, did I miss something. Why do you think Kafar will do it to stop me from losing. David chuckles, come on. You do know what's going on here right. You heard the announcement he made earlier. A moment Charles, yes. I heard him, but I don't get it. After few seconds David with a confused voice, wait. You really don't get what I am getting at. What about the time you were lying on the ground, you didn’t find it strange you weren't disqualified. Charles is still confused, what about it. I got up before the timer right. So I was safe then.

I got a little annoyed at Charles now. Doesn't he realize he got such favorable treatment in this match. Marina shouts, oh hell no. Charles doesn't know he was saved by a loophole. I am just as shocked as her. Then David says, ah. Never mind. Forget I said anything. You don't need to worry about it now. You'll know what I am talking about it later. David chose to let it lie for now. I didn't get why he didn't tell Charles about it. Charles should know that if Ned and Kafar hadn't intervened, David would already be the winner.

Charles replies, ah, okay. If you say so. I see him moving to his side and bit and sat near on a boulder on the ground, well. We don't have anything to do for now. How about I ask your friends to bring me something to drink. I am suddenly parched. I also wouldn't mind getting a some of the those tasty refreshments I saw outside today. What it called, yes, oreikitines. I almost laughed as Charles made such an outrageous ask. He knows we can't just interfere with the match. David didn't respond, but I could tell from Charles voice that he was giving Charles a look, what. I really am thirsty. Besides, what's the harm since we are asking for a break anyways.

A few seconds later David laughs, yeah. You got a point. Actually, can someone grab my bag from the room where we kept our stuff. I have a cocktail of energy drink I made for myself. I don't know how much it will help me right now, but I feel like I am about to croak again if I don't get at least some water. I looked to others and ask, are we really doing this. I mean, if they are really taking a break, it should be okay right. No one knew if they should consider their request. Then David says, oh. Right. You can get the stuff, but don't need to bring it us yet. We can wait till after Kafar makes the announcement.

Jess says, if he really would allow it. We don't know he will do it right. Nathan says, lets get them some water at least. They both sound like they really need it. Matt says, I know where David kept his bag. I'll get it then. He nods at Cass and scurries away inside the stadium. David noticed that from there, thanks Matt. And someone else can maybe get something for Charles too. This time Nathan offers unexpectedly, I usually get others to get me stuff, but I am feeling a little magnanimous right now, so I think I will get it for him.

No one stopped him as he left us to get Charles some snacks, but it is strange he would offer to be an errand boy. David chuckles, really. He offered huh. Must be on Charles side for sure. David has probably no idea about the bet made, or how true he was. Charles asks, appreciate it man. He then groans a little, Ah, my shoulder is killing me. Did you really need to use so much force. David scoffs, you must be a comedian. You will heal soon enough, I won't. Despite how we both look, I am in worse shape than you right now. At least David was aware of how messed up he was right now. Charles replies, point made. Shouldn't be complaining I guess. I do have to admit, if my mother saw me right now, she would beret me constantly on how I got wounded this badly by an outsider.

David says, your mother was the previous alpha right, did she made to Earth by any chance. Charles replies, no. Both my parents and my wife didn't make it. David says, that’s rough. Sorry. Charles says, no need to be sorry. Many of us have become orphan now. I guess I didn't think about Charles family. Looks like David knew something more about Charles than us. Maybe that’s what they were discussing earlier. David asks, but you got all your kids with you I hope. Charles says, yes. I have five children with me right now. Two of them born here on Earth. David replies, whoa. Quite a big family you got here. I don't know where you guys were hiding in Citradel, but must not be great for them to be raised in secrecy and on an alien planet.

Charles says with a stern voice, exactly. I didn't want to continue to keep them hidden, almost caged. Now that our existence is out in the open, I hope it will become better for them. For all our bloodline. David asks, speaking of bloodline maybe now you can tell me how you guys hid…he gets cut off by a microphone noise. I turn my back to them. Even though barrier muffles most of the noises, the loud voices still make it. I see Kafar coming into the podium. He began speaking to the confused masses, everyone, please may I have attention. He waits for the crowd to quite down. Then he speaks, it looks like we have some problem with the match. As you all know, we don't allow breaks in middle of the match, but seeing as we have hit one hour mark and still don't have clear victor, we decided to allow a short break. Once we know more about the fighters condition, we will let you know immediately. I will personally be heading down to check on the situation. So please remain seated for a short interval. Thank you.

He then walks back inside. I turn to others. Blake says, well. That sounded almost reasonable. Marina says with a smile, so then its official. Should we all go inside and meet them. I have few question to ask Charles and about a million for David. Tessa says, I don't think it’s a good idea for all of us to just waltz in. We don't know what going to happen, so you should be here. Marina scoffs at her. Blake says, you can listen in from here anyways. Plus I don't think we have all the time to chat. Once Kafar comes down, it will be all business.

I ask, what's the idea Charles is talking about. Catherine asks, Vanessa. You are already inside. You should go ahead. I really wanted to go, but I am still hesitant about meeting Charles a little. Another overdrive user is here. Its a little childish, but I feel uneasy now that I know about it. Blake says, yeah. You have been worried about David the most. Best you check on him now. Once Matt brings David's stuff, I will bring it to you. I face him for a while through the barrier, thanks. Blake nods and began walking away from them.

Now that things had cooled down, I didn't need to hurry up. I took my time navigating the torn arena. The holes all over the place made it not possible to walk straight towards them. Their were boulders lying everywhere. Then I crossed the place where David attacked Charles after flying up in the air. The entire arena was a giant mess. Grasses were torn away, debris everywhere and some holes were surprisingly deep. Few seconds in, I could hear them now. Charles says, well. Well. Who do we have here. He is still siting on the rock when he addressed me.

Charles looked worse up close. One side of his face had swollen and had only one eye open. His bruises were more visible now. I could see clear signs of bloodied clothes on him. How in the world is Charles still able to talk let alone laugh in such a condition. He might be healing, but its way too slow for an alpha. Guess he really is like a human when he reverts back. A trait common with David and Blake. I walk up little nervous. David turns to me with a little smile, you already know her, but let me. This is Vanessa, the omega of her bloodline Ozarek. Charles gets up on my arrival, of course. I don't need an introduction for this charming young Medrone. I have known your battles against Hives. Its my regret that I couldn't help you out.

I stuttered a little hearing his smooth and pleasing voice, no, its okay. Thanks. Nice to finally meet you in person. Its a little weird meeting you like this though. I have only heard stories about you and its so unreal to see you even fight up close. Charles chuckles, kind of you to say dear. But you don't have to sugar coat it. He turns to David, this guy here has whopped my ass. I am actually embarrassed. The first public appearance of our bloodline after centauries, and immediately I let him make a mockery out of me. I never imagined such a humble guy was that violent person all this time. In my mind I had pictured him to be something of a hard core personality.

I reply, no. No. Believe me, no one is thinking like this. If you knew how many people are cheering for you even now, you can tell they are in awe of you in every way. I can understand why Citradel has been protected so well all these years. You guys might just be the perfect warriors to protect the city. I then face David, you just had the bad luck of fighting this crazy genius. Charles laughs, is that so. I guess I am the one with bad luck. David smiles at me, I only heard you saying I am genius. He had the nerve to be amusing now. He looks like he is actually enjoying himself. I thought to hit him in the neck, but looking at his injuries, he might just get knocked out that easily.

David says, okay. Jokes aside, I do have to ask, did Kafar mention anything specifics about us. We couldn't hear him properly from his far due to the barrier. I reply, he didn't say much. Just that since you guys having been fighting for more than an hour and still no victor, he will asses the situation himself. David shakes his head slightly, okay. So that’s good. He then faces Charles, how sure are you that Kafar will give you the answer you need. Charles thinks for a moment, its not like I am expecting something from him. I just want to know his honest thoughts about it. If it works for me, I will tell you my idea. David raises an eyebrow, huh. I see. So something that you only need to know from Kafar. Best I can guess is something about the deal you had with him.

Charles smiles, bulls eye. Nothing gets past you huh. He turns to me pointing his finger at him. I chuckle a little, you can say that again. I walk over towards David and lean a little to whisper, can I talk to you a little. David turns to face me with a expression saying he expected me to ask him. He replies, sure. Charles do you mind. Charles raises his arms, not at all. Please, I am sure she must have tons of things to ask you. You bet ass I am. David waves

and we walk a little away from Charles.

Once we were earshot away from Charles. I blurt out to him, what the freak David. You said you had more to show us, you didn't say it meant you were doing breaking the laws of Kuret. You have any idea the roller coaster of emotions we gone through ever since that first stunt with pure Kuret blast. At least with your Kuret transformation was your own Kuret. So how are you able to use my Kuret. Blakes, and others. David smirks a little, I know I shouldn't be enjoying this, but I can't help it. I knew well in advance that this would create a big stir.

I honestly wanted to kick him on the knees. Suddenly he got a ego big enough the size of his head. David raises his arm up in air, whoa. Okay. Too far. Sorry. Its just I got carried away seeing you so much frustrated. It's a little funny. I rebuke, do you have any idea how close you came to be disqualified. If it weren't for others, I would have dragged you already outside. David replies, yeah. I can imagine my behaviors has changed a little. I almost yelled, at him, little. You must be out of your mind. You are almost always logical in your decisions. But you have completely thrown it away. You were ready to fight in your condition against an overdrive user. On top of that he is a Heraknus, a mythical bloodline. You must have hit your head pretty bad to decide to continue like this.

David nods, you maybe be right about hitting my head. I actually had a …he pauses suddenly. Well, that's nothing to go into right now. I am sorry though. I can't tell you all the reasons for doing this. Not because its personnel, but I am still figuring it out myself. But I appreciate your patience for not making me drop from the match. I know its no excuse, but thanks for giving me chances, even though you had no reason to. And just like that, those few words made me loose my temper. David might have changed a little, but he is still him. I reply, you are not getting off easily next time. I think when you made that promise you intentionally lied, or at least told half truths. You planned to make risky decisions from the beginning, completely ignoring my warnings.

David eyes widen at me, ah. No. His voice came out shaken. I knew it. I don't know what I wanted to do, grab his neck in anger and hug him seeing his is okay. David replies, ah, sorry. I just didn't want to you to think I was going to lose. I didn't want you to stop me. You are right, I wasn't serious about forfeiting if it became dangerous. But I was promising about winning this match. At this I urge him to answer, why. Why its important. He turns away from my eyes, I…well, I just do. Lets leave it that. You know me, I don't lie or hide without good reasons.

I would understand for most things, sure. But what could make him push so hard against Charles. I don't think David is going to open up, even if keep pestering him, he still wouldn't share it with me. Maybe no one. After a while I realize its best to leave it. Its not like I haven't kept things from others for personnel reasons. I sigh, okay. I won't ask again. But if you are going to be stubborn about it, I'll also be the same. I will drag you out of here the moment you are injured gravely.

David replies, I'll hold on to your decision then. It definitely makes me feel at ease a bit more knowing you are looking out for me. I smiled at him, you have become a pain in the ass. David shakes his head a little, oh, its nice reversal that I don't have to think that you the same way. That comment was a cheap jab at me. I lightly stab my elbow at his arm. David takes one step back, okay. Okay. Message received. Loud and clear. Seeing him so unfazed by the precarious situation he was in is insane. But somehow the ooze of confidence he is showing makes me want to believe he can actually win.

Vanessa (Chapter 35)

Sunday, February 11, 2024 21:23

I cross my arm and ask, so. You still haven't told me how you are able to use others Kuret. David twitches his mouth trying to form words. I immediately ask, and don't say you can't tell me. You already showed us your tricks to the whole world. Its even live streaming to everywhere. I can imagine everyone coming up to you demanding an explanation on how its possible for your anti-Kuret to create so many other Kurets. David a moment later says, it's not that its something I want to keep it a secret. But its hard to explain. You said I was breaking laws of Kuret. Sadly I am not doing something so preposterous.

I get a little impatient now. He continuous before I show it in my face, the technical details of the exact way I do it is riddled with math and science. What, I shriek out hearing those unexpected words. He says, its true. I am not creating Kuret okay. That's just simply not possible. But what I am doing is capturing the ambient Kuret floating in the air with my Kuret. My Kuret works like magnet of same poles with normal Kuret. So instead of letting the Kuret run away, I entrap it within my Kuret. Like a bowl scoping up Kuret from the air. I then form a mini dome, a sphere around the captured Kuret. I use my Kuret to condense trapped Kuret inside enough that it solidifies into a small mass of pure Kuret. This is the source of all my Kuret blasts.

I couldn't believe he said all this with a straight face. I raise my palm in confusion, wait. I am confused. How is that possible. Even if you capture it with your Kuret, wouldn't it just escape. David replies, no. That's the core of this trick. I told you, I am using math and science. But its not simple. I had to use run simulation with M to use 3D geometry, spatial computational, vector in higher dimensions, thermodynamics. I could keep listing all the stuff, but I don't want to confuse you more.

He very non subtly implied I didn't understand any of those words. Worse part is he wasn't wrong. I only heard about these things in passing during the college we attended few years back. I reply, you are serious. You are saying you used Earth science to make it work. David nods, yes. It took a while to figure the mechanics behind it. It took time, effort and whole lot of patience. Honestly, at times I wasn't sure I could do it. But after several tries, I was able to do it. Even now, it only works after a painstaking amount of time.

I couldn't believe what I heard. No maybe I can. He does this sort of thing always. I can't help being impressed by him. He used Earth knowledge to make something of Medrine work. That's no easy feat. But then I realize this doesn't explain everything. I ask, okay. I guess it sort of makes sense how you managed to use pure Kuret blast. But what about turning them into other Kurets. How do you explain that. Earth knowledge can't help with that. David nods that one was a combination of Earth and Medrine knowledge. But, he looks around him, I can't tell you how I did it. At least not now. Not here. I don't know who it could be, but someone might be listening in. He walks to my side and turns towards the back of a small boulder lying nearby. There was another charm floating in that air there. What's this, it looked similar to the charm Marina casted earlier.

David leans in, and I don't mean you guys. And yes, I know you were listening on me talking. I am little disappointed Marina. I thought you were ready for it, but if you can't keep even such a simple charm hidden, you clearly are not ready for it. David then faced Marina directly. I turn along with him. I see Marina raising her arms in a fit and stomping the ground hard. She must be cursing too. David chuckles, just kidding. He straighten his back, I will keep the end of my bargain as promised. I doubt anyone else other than Blake or Nathan would have seen it.

I got curious, wait, who else do you mean. David shrugs I don't know who. But someone has been interfering with the matches. Not just mine but others too. Blake and Marina were almost poisoned. And my battle with Charles is also manipulated someway. So for the time being I am keeping this part a secret in case someone is watching me right now. Whatever I told you earlier, anyone would have eventually figured out. They would notice that whenever I use my Kuret storm, the Kuret around me disappears instead of being repelled. Reveling that piece of info doesn't change things for me.

I was surprised that he was revealing his tricks so easily. It makes sense that he doesn't want to give any more secrets. I sigh, okay. I'll need an explanation later. He nods, thanks. A moment later he asks, can we get back to Charles. I need to ask him something. I replies, yeah. I done. For now. I stress on that last part. He got the message. We both went back to Charles who looked so board sitting alone. He smiles at our return, so good chat. Got anything good from him. He asks me.

I waved my hand a little, with him its always a half way compromise. Charles replies, I see. Well, being cautious is what keeps one alive. Especially in such dangerous times. David asks, thanks, but I don't she meant it that. She probably meant it something along the line of reprimanding me later for making her worry this much. It's a little eerie to hear how easily he figured my behavior. Charles chuckles, oh I understand the sentiment. I am little nervous to face my wife right now. She must be worried about this also.

I ask him, should I ask others to get her here. He shakes his head, no. That's all right. I don't think its necessary. Besides, she knows I will be winning in the end. David retorts, now whose awfully full of themselves. You don't think she might be nervous seeing how this match has gone. Charles shifts his body a little, nah. Okay, maybe a little. Honestly, if you bring her here. She might try to stop the match too. He then stares straight at David, but obviously I can't have that. Not when a great opportunity has come at me.

Oh god. Its not just David. Both of them are raring to just go. I sigh. How can I show them enough reason to not make this a life and death match. David clears his throat, anyways. I was about to ask you a question before Kafar interrupted us. He takes a step to his side, I know you have been hiding in Medrine for so centuries, but I can't believe no one knew about you. Medrine isn't that big that you can hide this long unnoticed. Unless you practice polygamy, you need other Medrones to continue the bloodline. So you can't have been completely cut off from society. How come no one heard about you. Charles thinks for a second. He says, its not people didn't know about us. The royal family knows about us. A couple of other groups of people know. And yes, we didn't hide away in some underground or in sea for centuries.

He continues, we did however occupy mountains and valleys that were difficult to be habituated by regular people. So with some help from neighboring villages, our ancestors have found a way to keep us hidden. David presses on, okay. Are you sure people knew? Blake, Nathan and Rose are from royal bloodline. And I don't think they heard about you. And especially Blake, he is a shadow. If an organization like shadow didn't know you existed, then I can't imagine anyone else knew. Charles scratches his chin, ah. I have heard about this shadow group back on Medrine. Never had the pleasure of meeting any of them. But I assure you, the royals know about me. I have even met few people of my parents generation.

He leans back and tries to recall some memories, we even fought against a royal once when I was a kid. I ask, really. Who was it. Charles thinks a little, I don't remember his name. He had barged inside one of the village who helped us and stirred up some trouble. So my mother went to kick him out. I imagine that particular royal didn't know about us then, but he definitely learned about us. I reply shocked, wow. So you guys can just force a royal out without causing an international incident. He shrugs, honestly. It wasn't a big deal of us. And I do think he was reprimanded by his elders for doing something this reckless under our domain. He turns to David, so yes. To answer your question, a lot of people in high places knew about us.

David is silent is for some time. Is it that hard for him to believe they couldn't remain in hiding. I ask him, are you still not convinced. David turns to me, no. I understand. It's just hard for me to believe Blake didn't know such a huge secret. I got confused here, how do you know he doesn't know. He looks a little shaken at that, I mean, its pretty obvious he didn't tell you guys anything. Must be Derek who explained stuff. Right. He was right. Yet I am a little suspicious of this behavior. He is making it a bit more personnel than he should. I said, maybe Blake or Nathan were too little to be told this secret. You know. And maybe Shadows also didn't know about Heraknus, I don't see the problem.

David says, its not a problem. Just got curious that's all. Charles continuous, speaking of people who I have met, I actually fought one not from the royal bloodline. Now this guy was a pain in my ass. Let me tell you, after my mother and David, he was the toughest person I fought. Now what was his name. I forgot, but not his Kuret. Its funny actually…I raise my palm to him, sorry to interrupt. I think your snacks are here. My eyes picked up one person carrying a bag approaching the others. It was Matt, he got David's bag. From the other side of the barrier edge, I saw Nathan walking with a large paper bag on his arms. He must have brought the eatables for Charles.

Charles smiles and says, finally. I am starving. Hope he got the one I wanted to try. One thing I will say, you guys put a lot of effort in making sure people get here. I never imagined to see our Medrine culture being reawakened here. The food here looks like they were really from Medrine. Even the drinks too. And I can't believe you guys even showed that amazing opening drama of our home. It somewhat feels we got a piece of Medrine here now. David nods, of course, this is one of the biggest event in over a decade for all Medrones on Earth. I don't know how much Kafar has told you, but we got all riding on this tournament. Not just the results, but making sure people come safety arrive here. And for those who can't, they can view it without compromising our existence. A butt load of money and time went into preparation.

Charles nods, oh I know. A lot of my bloodline members were called for escorting them till here. Even when I came, I was put with special guards since I didn't have Kuret until then. I asked him a question that's been bugging me for some time, isn't it a little too unfair that you guys can't use Kuret for so long. I mean I heard on Earth it got worsened, but did you guys try to figure a way to work around this huge weakness. Charles nods, you are not the first person to ask me. Even Derek asked me. All I can say its out Kuret bloodline, nothing can be done about it. We did try various ways to overcome it, but so far nothings worked.

I ask, I ask because if you had your Kuret all the time, you would be an incredible asset to all of us. But if we are attacked at the wrong time, you would be instead be in danger yourselves. He replies, believe me. No one is frustrated more than me. I couldn't even join you guys last year in that war against Hive. And even before then, I had to rely on Derek and others to keep us safe few times. He didn't need to say it in words. His pained expression showed a clear pain and frustration over this. I can't believe someone so incredibly strong still can't be relied on so easily.

David says, I don't know if it would help, but maybe now that we are trying to pool all of us together. Maybe someone can help come up with a solution for your problem. I mean, more people means more ideas. And maybe just maybe someday you guys will figure it out. Charles replies, yes. I hope for the same. Part of the reason I agreed to enter into this tournament. David smirks, I thought you said you came to fight strong people like Blake, Marina, Nathan, Tessa and Vanessa. Charles laughs, that too obviously. But I didn't get to fight them you know. Instead I got stuck with you.

David smiles, like Vanessa said, its your bad luck. He replies, you know people usually are more scared at the prospect of fighting a Heraknus alpha. Even that royal guy who messed up earlier had to face my mother when he got her attention. After a good beating, he ran away after so fast that he left some of his valuable stuff behind. David says, oh don't worry about me being scared. I already am scared. What, he didn't look one bit. He then smiles, I am scared how popular I would go down in Medrines history by becoming first ever to beat a Heraknus alpha on overdrive.

Freak. That was so bad. But's what's so crazy about it is he didn't even show one bit of concern or fear in his voice. It was like saying such a thing was easy as saying he likes a fruit. Charles stared at him for a second, then he laughs. Chills, he says, I got the chills when you said that. Love the confidence. Even when you are so arrogant right now. Makes me believe you are correct for the only person for this. Their intense glare is making me nervous now. I turn back to others.

There has been some more movement among them. Nathan finally meets up with them. Then Blakes alone separates from the group. He carried one bag in hand and the paper bag on other. He then walks across the barrier inside. So he was one to come here. Marina would be furious not being included with us. I face back to David, how long are we going to wait before Kafar joins. Its been more than 5 minutes now. David says, he must be discussing with other admins about something. Some damage control maybe. But shouldn't be much longer now. He can't keep us waiting for long too. Charles says, and if Derek told about my request, he might know what I am going to talk to him. He might be just preparing himself for it.

I want to know what's so important he needs to know from Kafar. From ahead Blake reached us, hey. Special delivery. Sorry we didn't bring in immediately. Marina was insisting hard to meet you. Took some time to convince before she cooled down and agreed. I bet she was furious. Its not everyday you have 3 overdrive users in the same place. David says, no problem. I will make it up her, so don't worry about her. He faces Charles, I don't think I

need introductions for him too.

Charles got up from his seat and walks towards Blake. Blake hurriedly thrusts the contents on his arms to David beside him. David stumbles while struggling suddenly to keep them from falling, dude. Chill. David whispers. I help David by taking the bag from his hand. Charles says, of course. The royal prince is the most famous person who is also a dazzling true alpha. Blakes shakes his hand and looked surprised once he saw his face. He tries to put out words but it was a little stammered. Ah, thanks. I put down the bag down, not what you were expecting huh.

Blake says, ah, yeah a bit. I mean we only heard all your conversations. And now that we are up close. Ah, how do I put it. They let their hands go. Charles offers, you don't have to hide it kid. I look like hell. There is no other way to explain it. Blake nervously laughs and turns to me. I shrug gesturing just go with it. David hands over the paper bag to Charles, I noticed you gave both of them compliments. But you didn't say anything to me. You have been just complaining to me.

Charles takes the bag from him and laughs, I am not nice to people who are a pain in my ass. David says, oh yeah. I don't find you that much of a pain in my ass, you know, since I will be defeating you soon enough. David grins a little. They were proud of themselves with such ego checks. Blakes looks confused and rolls his eyes to both of them, ah, so being here is just as tense as hearing you both. Charles smirks while he takes out a plastic cup from the bag and pulls out the lid, smells good. He takes a sip from it and gulps down the content on his throat. He puts his hand down and smiles, ah, this is simply divine. I don't think we have anything like this in Citradel. He starts drinking more.

David took a knee and was scrummaging in the bag. There were dozens of bottles with some labels on them. I can't read them, but they were color coded. He finds the one he was searching for, a bottle with blue marks on it. He uncaps it and begins to drink it. Something went wrong, he turns to his side and immediately spits the liquid out. I ask, what happened. David wipes the liquid dripping from his lips, ah shit. I knew it was going to be bad, but didn't expect this. It's so bad he even coughed a little. I took the bottle from his hand took a smell from the edge. My nostril flares up with a bunch of mix of different disinfecting stuff, it smelled like a hospital & dead body at the same time in here.

I pull it away from my face a second later, shit. Are you sure you should be drinking this. David stops heaving and takes the bottle from me, this tastes so bad because of all the different mixtures of medicines and energy boosting ingredients. I couldn't make it taste better or add sweeteners without reducing its efficacy. He takes a big breath and slowly gulps down that disgusting liquid. His face turned sour when he drank, but he kept drinking despite the taste. Blake asks Charles, should you guys be so frivolous. You know you are still in the middle of the match.

Charles is now biting into one of the sandwiches. He chomps down on it while speaking with a half filled mouth, its necessary for me. Kafar mentioned we have been fighting for an hour, even if we did spend some time lying on the ground, I have spent too much of my Kuret. I am probably at a third of my original strength. I reply, really. You told David you could fight for hours. Charles nods while taking another bite, yes. But that's only if I don't suffer another Kuret blackout. Getting hit with it twice has made me vulnerable to another one. And as you already heard, my Kuret control has weakened. I thought I could replenish even some of my energy while we still have some time.

David finishes the entire bottle in ago. He pulls out another smaller bottle from the bag. This one looked like plain water. He first rinses his mouth with that water and then drinks it half way to the bottles size. He spats, guh. That was a weird experience. He puts the bottle back inside the bag. He then leans back to a boulder and lays his head back. He then closes his eyes, okay. I am going to some shut eyes for a minute. Wake me up when Kafar crosses the barrier. Blake asks, you sure. What if you accidently doze off and don't wake up. David without opening his eyes says, not going to happen. The drink I just had will soon take effect and keep me awake. I just need some time for my mind to calm down.

Blake looks at me asking my opinion. I reply, its fine I guess. Blake a little unsure. We both decided to leave David side for a bit. Charles says, so the rumors were true, he doesn't even have our stamina. I just thought it was exaugurated to make him look bad. I reply, no, its true. Most of the time he has Human limits. Charles clicks his tongue, damn. He's got just as a badly effect from Earth. Blake says, yeah. He looks at me with a suspicious look. I shook my head. Its best not to tell Charles what really effected David on Earth. I change the topic before Charles continues this line of discussion, Charles. I wanted to ask you a question ever since we heard you could overdrive.

Charles turns to me and waits for me ask, is there anyway to learn to overdrive. Others have said it just happened. Is the same for you. Or did you somehow learned to do it. Charles looks at with one curious eye. He nods, I see. You want to achieve overdrive, isn't it. My expression gave away my intent. Charles says, I didn't learn it. It's sort of just happened. My small hope got crushed hearing him. Dammit, I thought he might have triggered it differently. Charles continuous, I actually don't know if anyone in my alpha line tried to learn it. But with my own experience having used it, I am sure its not something you can figure it out. He turns to Blake, you must know it about it as well, right. Its harsh, but its probably just a luck of the draw. Some alpha's are just more predisposed than other since birth.

Blake nods slightly, yes. My father use to tell stories of those who could do it. No one knew exactly how they did it, the storis only tell what happens after they achieve it. Charles nods, yes. Same with me. I felt a brief moment of anger. I really thought I would get some clue. But even Charles didn't have any idea. Marina did say that there is no way to force it. I didn't want to wait for it, if it ever to even happen. I still am jealous that these guys are so lucky to get picked my fate. I would kill for that chance.

Charles speaks to Blake, its actually nice to talk to someone about this other than my family. We need as many people who could do it. Although, I was really surprised when you used it against Marina. Until then, she was the only I knew apart from me. Blake smiles, I accidently unlocked it few months ago. I actually wanted to keep it hidden until my match with David. But she was just too powerful to defeat without it. And that’s what got to me in the end. David figured out my overdrive. Charles nods with understanding, I was here for your match. It looked like you had trouble using your overdrive. Blakes says, yeah. Marina says it takes years to master it.

Charles replies, different people need different time to master it. You probably would have won if you had full control. Blake says, maybe. But I not so sure after what I just saw. David pulled out some crazy stuff now. Even when we all heard what he just explained how he did it to Vanessa, I still have hard time believing him. Charles asks, really. Can I ask how he did that. David himself said its not a big secret, so its fine to share. I said, he used Earth science to do it. I am not sure what that meant exactly, but obviously it works. Charles looked at me with an incredulous look, is that how. What an trendy idea. A lot of people are trying to mix Earth and Medrine science. But most of them have been for food, architecture or technology. First time I am hearing something like being used for Kuret. Kid's a genius no doubt about it.

I said, he has been like that for years. You think we would be used to it, but no. Today we got a bunch of reveals no one expected. Blake says, true. And not just from him. You being here might become even more stir amongst others after the tournament. Charles smiles, we will definitely have to deal with the repercussions of coming out of hiding after centuries. Although everyone in our bloodline is prepared. Many are still reserved, but we all collective decided its for the good. We have to actively work with others to win against Hive. And this tournament showed a good number of powerful warriors. I ask, anyone caught your eye. I mean besides us. Charles says, that’s a good question.

He starts thinking for a moment. Then he says, I don't want to speculate just because of these matches, where we can't use weapons and have rules. However, some have definitely stand out more than others. The girl who uses her Kuret to create shadow warriors. I liked how she summoned armies to battle for her. Then there is one man who was can run fast. He was also interesting. And then there's was that guy who could use multiple Kurets. He wasn't an alpha, but he used some interesting techniques. He should have learned some more close combat. I turn my gaze away hearing that. Charles had to be talking about Ned. Well, Ned is strong in his own way.

Blake says, yeah, he was a little tricky. Charles replies, David and Marina used strangely similar way of using multiple Kurets, but they both are worlds apart compared to him. I press my lips together hoping to avoid talking about Ned. Charles notices my sudden change in mood, oh, is one of your friends. I didn't mean to diminish him like that. Like I said, I didn't like to judge others based on just one match. I turn to him again and hastily replied, no. Its okay. I know what you meant. I am not angry about it. It shouldn't be a bother to let him know he is my boyfriend. But weirdly I didn't want to since we both are fighting.

Blake clears his throat, Kafar's sure taking his sweet time isn't he. How long can we keep this break to continue. I gave him a thankful look to focus on something else. He continues, the more time it takes, David will be more exhausted. I don't think his power nap will actually help with his fatigue. Charles replies, I also hope to finish it quicker. He thinks for a moment before saying, you both care a lot about David. That’s good he has good allies. Have you known him for long. We both nod in unison. I said, we have known him for years. Though Cassandra knows him the longest. They were brought up together by some Human guardians for almost a decade when they arrived on Earth. Charles replies, I see. So he was one the few lucky ones to stay in society undetected. He got any family.

Blake replies, no. None we know at least. I reply, maybe when he regains his lost memories, he might remember someone here. Charles asks after a moment, is he married. Or got any partner. Okay, this a weird line of questioning. Why does that matter right now. I shook my head, no. Charles eye widen with a little surprise, really. That’s interesting. What is, I wanted to ask him, but I kept it to myself. He continues to wonder for a moment. Then faces us, how about you both. Blake chuckles, I have been a busy with a lot of things managing the Island.

I didn't want to say anything on this matter. Charles thankfully didn't press on me and says, you young people are wasting time you know. You never know what's going to happen. Better to live your life much you can. I met my wife here on Earth few years after our arrival. If she wasn't there for me, I would have gone crazy with getting revenge. And who knows what would have happened to my kids. Our prioritize might be to fight Hive, but don't forget to live. So many people died to get us here. They would want to live your life to the fullest.

His words made me recall my parents and brother. I don't remember my parents all too well, but my brother would have wanted a different life for me. In a way, my whole life has been defined due to his death. And all others who saved me. Blake says, I understand your sentiment. Believe me, its not something I am ignoring solely because we are in war with Hive. But right now we don't have the enough luxury to indulge so easily. At least, I don't have. Maybe once we have a bit more stability in our lives. He said it like he had given some serious thoughts about it.

I reply, and no offense Charles but you guys had it easier in Citradel. I know you were the ones protecting it, but Hives didn't attack you guys all too often. Having a place to call home is something we didn't have. Most of us outside had to hidden, or be on the move constantly. Our life on Earth hasn't been easy for dating you know. Charles says, I can't deny that. I won't pretend I understand your own personnel situations outside Citradel. We have been lucky to form our community early on. Maybe I should change my statement a little bit and instead say that once our two communities join, you should look for better lives. And not just you, your friends over their too. When Charles faces them, everyone wave their arms in response. I didn't realize they are still hearing our conversation.

Blake says, well, that’s what we are hoping. I turn to David. He was still leaning against the boulder with his eyes shut. I try to imagine what would David do when he finally gets a place to live. Ever sine last home at Wisconsin was gone, he basically never stayed in one place for long. At least I stayed with Nathen in the valley for whole two years, even if it was against my will. Blake and others also stayed in Europe as a headquarter to rally others during the time. Since David became a criminal among Humans, he hasn't been able to remain in one place for too long. He had to keep moving or go into hiding to avoid capture. I don't know anyone who's life was more tumultuous than his right now on Earth. But it should change once we all start living in one city.

Maybe its because Charles asked us just now, I began to wonder if David will try to date someone. It's curious, would David be finally be open to try it. His last relationship was with that Human girl, Christina. That ended so bad, he shot her father, went spiraling and almost killed Nathan at the end. But that was years ago, would he try to find someone new. We have been working together a lot for a while. Its wired I never asked him once about it. Sometimes, I feel he avoids talking about that with me purposely. Maybe that was just my imagination.

Looking at David made me recall about his conversation with Charles earlier. I turn back to Charles and ask, I forgot to ask, what were you two discussing earlier about your overdrive. He didn't tell us any of the details.

Charles asks, oh you didn't hear that part huh. We both shook our head. He continuous, well it’s a little sore topic. I guess I can tell you now. Its about risks involved in my overdrive risks. I asks, risks. You have risks. Charles says hesitantly, yes. And not just for me. Everyone. Me and Blake look at each other confused. Blake asks, what do you mean by that. Charles is about to reply, but then he stops and tilts his head his side.

I turn to his gaze and saw some movement at the edge of the barrier. People had hurdled up near the edge of the stadium which had the gates. Once it opened fully, two people come out it. Its Derek and Kafar. Charles says, they are finally here. I'll tell you the risks as soon I talk with Kafar. Charles hurriedly finishes the rest of his food. I turn and walk to David. David resting face made me hesitate a little. The moment I wake him up, we will again be thrown into a battle mode. I don't know if I can keep seeing him act so rashly. This sudden change in attitude is something I never expected to see in him.

But on the other hand, he has never been this powerful either. Strong enough to be in the same league as alphas and omegas. Maybe if he is lucky, he might just win this and become the next crown after my brother. If there was even a chance, I want David to win. With that resolve, I put my hands on his shoulders. David, they are here. David stirs a little and then his eyes flew open. His eyes flutter for a second and then he stands back on his feet. I take my hands away and point to the two walking people now walking to our friends.

David says, thanks. He cracks his neck a little, ah. This was a much needed break. I ask, you got any rest. He replies, some. At the very least I think my nerves have settled down a bit. Don't think I can use my new Kuret though. That last attempt took everything out of me in one go. I ask, can you win with just your Kuret storm. David thinks for a moment. He then finally says, I will make it work at all cost. Even if I have to go against his overdrive, I know I will win.

I couldn't form a response to that. He still has maintained his strong confidence. I shouldn't get in his way anymore.

Blake(Chapter 36)

Tuesday, February 13, 2024 22:10

Charles hurries up finishing the rest of his food before Kafar arrives. With this short break, his swelling had now visibly subsisted on his face. Even his bad eye is opened half way. Some of his bruises and scratches were also healed partially. Its eerie that Charles is similar like me. We are both alphas who don't heal faster in our normal state. But there is one crucial difference. Now that I am this close, I could read his Kuret aura much better. His body is a paradox. He has enormous amounts of Kuret reserve, but the output is so low right now that it's almost negligible. On the other hand, being one step above a regular alpha, I have full access to my Kuret and heal way faster than other alphas. Charles may have large Kuret to draw on, but his access is slow. It becomes a bit faster when he takes on his Kuret body. But its still relatively slower than many alphas.

That's why he takes a lot of time to form his Kuret body. Setting aside his Kuret endurance, his Kuret is fundamentally even slower than mine or Nathans. It may look like his healing ability is superior, but its not. It’s the consistent availability of Kuret. That is the reason why Charles is so incredibly powerful. Everyone has limits, we use Kuret for healing our wounds or use it for attacking. We have to thin it and choose which one to focus more on when we fight. But he doesn't need to. He can do both without any effort. I could feel that even with a third of his Kuret remaining, his Kuret body would be just as strong.

At my side, David and Vanessa walk back to us. David looked the same as few minutes back, obviously because his wounds doesn't heal like us. But his eyes had regained some spark. That short nap must have taken away a little of his mental fatigue. David asks, glad to see someone is enjoying. Charles gobbles down the last piece, it delicious. I need ask my Kids to bring me more of these later. He crumbs up the empty bag and throws it away towards the debris. He asks, did you get any rest.

David answers, if I am being honest. David shakes his shoulders back and rotates his arm slightly, I want to just go and sleep for days. And I will, once this is over. Charles nods. I turn my gaze to others at the edge. It looks like Matt is giving Kafar that Kuritine to pass through the barrier. Soon after, Derek and Kafar begin to walk towards the barrier and cross it. Vanessa asks, is it just me or Kafar looks a little angry. I reply, you are not wrong. They both are now zigzagging towards us to avoid the holes on the ground.

David asks Charles, what if Kafar doesn't answer you questions or lies about it in some way. Will you still be able to make a decision. That’s a good question. Charles still hasn't told us what he wants from Kafar. And David's right, if Kafar sees his champion in any disadvantage, he would say or do anything to change the situation. Charles replies, it doesn't matter. Whatever he says, I'll treat that as his feelings about it and make a decision. What a straightforward approach, weirdly suits his style.

Few moments later, they both arrive at our spot. As soon as they saw Charles, Derek asks first, are you all right. That wound on your face doesn't look good. Charles touches his fingers to his face. He replies, it’s sore. Its much better now. Derek nods in relief. Kafar doesn't say anything for the moment. But his expression clearly showed irritation. Derek then turns to David, what about you. David replies, nothing I can't handle. Derek was more surprised to hear this. Derek asks, I won't ask you to explain the weird powers you shown us, but advice you caution against going overboard.

David replies showing his teeth, the only person you need to be worried is Charles. I have everything in control. Not even they were expecting David to be so cocky. Kafar stares with curious gaze at David, then he turns to Charles and asks, what's going on Charles. Why did you both ask for a break. You have any idea how much others are nervous right now. We have too many unforeseen events occurring in this match. Vanessa rebukes, oh please. Don't blame them, if it weren't for you, this match would already be over. David should have won earlier, its you who keep dragging this match. She is furious, not that I blame her. She might be also directing some of the anger of Ned here.

Kafar replies with a scoff, don't start with me again. We did nothing wrong. And you all would have done the same for David. Don't go accusing others just because you don't like the rules. Vanessa got pissed at Kafar indifferent attitude. She takes a step forward, but David grabbed her arm stopping her. He says firmly, Vanessa. That’s enough. This isn't the place or time to do this. Vanessa looks for moment at him. Then clicks her tongue and nods. He lets go of her arm. He says, lets get on with this shall we.

Kafar ignores Vanessa's attitude and turns to Charles, so what is it. Charles, who was silent and thinking something, broke out of his thoughts and replies, David wants to fight me in my overdrive. Kafar eyes widened at this and turns over to David for a second. He asks, why are telling him about your overdrive. There's something I noticed from his aura, he should have been way more agitated. I ask, so you already knew that Charles can overdrive. Kafar doesn't respond to me. Derek also is surprised. Charles continuous, yes. He is one of the few outside my family who knows about it. In fact we agreed that I will not use it in the tournament. He knows the risks it would put on all the people here.

He mentioned some risks again. What is that. Before I can ask to explain, Kafar says, you can't be serious. His face was confused and scared. He asks, if you use it here then…. Charles raises his palm to him before Kafar continuous to freak out, why do you think I purposefully let all that Kuret go to waste earlier. I needed to stop him from forcing me into overdrive. Even with so many guards and other warriors here, its way to dangerous without any preparation. And that’s what I want to discuss now.

Derek asks, you said there are risks. But its not just you guys, its everyone. I don't understand. How. Charles clears his throat, I can't control my overdrive. I didn't understand why would that put everyone at risk. Hell, even I can't control my own overdrive. David chips in, its not way you are thinking Blake. Looks like his overdrive is bit more unstable than yours. David read my thoughts like a book. I ask Charles, you mean you what, go out of control.

Kafar answers me instead, yes. That’s exactly how his overdrive works right now. I have seen it for myself once before. He looses all sense of himself, attacks anyone who he sees, doesn't matter they are friend or foe. He doesn’t stop until his Kuret goes out. Whoa. That’s too much. I didn't expect Charles overdrive is this damaged. To lose control of themselves when you are overflowed with Kuret in your body, that has to be the double edge sword thing I have heard about overdrive ever. Vanessa shrieks, so if he can goes nuts and attack others, even when he is just supposed to be fighting one person. David says, yeah, that's what he told me. He will attack everyone except for his own flesh and blood it seems. That was a convenient limitation of his sense of self. It has something to do something with instincts.

Kafar asks, and you expect us to allow this. Charles replies, I am considering it. David is the only person since we left from Medrine to challenge me on equal footing. Not even against the Hive leader warranted me to use it. But against him, its different. After witnessing his absurd strength, he just might be able to handle it. Its worked out for him too since the best way of defeating me right now is to make me overdrive. He takes a moment to sigh, you see, I enormous power up with this, but I also continues to loose Kuret more consistently. So if I am trapped or restrained until the end, I will lose undoubtedly.

So that’s what's going on right now. David was thinking to use some compulsion Kuret on Charles to force him into overdrive and defeat him. But he didn't knew about these risks, so Charles took painful measures to stop him. Derek asks, you said you are considering it to use it now. Why the change of heart if you know its too risky to use it. Charles reply, I want to tell my idea. It is a little bit dangerous, sure. But I believe this is the perfect opportunity for me to use it here. David asks, I have a feeling that you want to do it more than just winning this match, given with the risks involved.

Charles nods back, yes. I told you earlier right, I have tried to learn my overdrive many times now. But never been successfully been able to gain consciousness. And I have a theory on how to overcome it. If there were no person in the vicinity, my full focus would be on that one individual. Meaning, my senses wouldn't be all over the place, but instead just locked onto that one person. If such a situation were to happen, there is a good chance that with reduced burden on my senses, I could essentially wake up from the primal instincts overloading my brain. I never met anyone who would be able to withstand my overdrive all by themselves. So this has always been just a theory. But it’s the only way I believe I can control it.

That unexpectedly made sense. It has to be frustrating not being able to control your greatest weapon. Anyone would be trying all the ways they could to overcome their weakness. I ask, so you plan to use David to wake up in your overdrive. Charles nods, I am sure he isn't the only one who might be able to keep up with me in that state. Maybe you or Marina can do it too. But since we are in a tournament, wouldn't you agree it’s the best opportunity using him. Also I need to repair the damage he caused to Heraknus alpha's reputation. He smiles at his own words.

Everyone has to be in shock to hear that Charles his putting everyone at such risks for this. But its hard to argue too at the same time. With a similar frustration of not being able to control ones greatest power, I understood what he must be feeling like. Charles must have been looking for someone to help him out. Even if its in a match. Vanessa got a little mad hearing this, so you want to use David to get stronger. You sure you and him are not related. David smirks at her. David had the gall to be so amused by this. Derek asks to David, and you are okay with this. David shrugs and chuckles, I didn't know Charles was thinking to use me. But I don't care. I am in no position to tell anyone on how to get stronger. I basically learn from others every opportunity I can get. If anything, imagine how strong our forces would become if he had 3 overdrive users. Hive won't know what hit them.

I think David is the one who should be the most bothered by these risks. He is already ready to risk his life for the small chance he wins or Charles controls his overdrive. Kafar says angrily, this is utter nonsense. Charles, you can't be actually thinking about this. Even if we clear out every single person here, we can't have David fight you alone. He will die for sure. David scoffs at Kafar but doesn't say anything. I ask, now you are worried about David. Kafar replies, of course I am. You would be too if you had seen what I witnessed those years ago. I am want Charles win, but with David dying.

Its shocking that I couldn't be a hundred percent sure about that from his aura. I want to believe he is worried about David's safely, but I also can't say for certain he just doesn't want to make Charles a murderer in front of the whole world. David says, whoa. Who said anything about dying. I will be the one to win. Okay. Do I look worried about dying. His arrogance might be the most craziest part in this discussion. Just what the hell happened to him battling Charles to change his attitude like this. Vanessa tried to say something, but David gestures her to stop. He says, I know this is dangerous. But lets first see if Charles is even going to do use it. He still hasn't made his mind about it yet. So first lets just hear him out.

Everyone's eyes abruptly fell on Charles. He takes a few seconds to prepare his words, Kafar. I want to know what are your plans for my bloodline not that we are out from hiding. Kafar says, that’s what you wanted to know from me. We already discussed what's going to change in Citradel. Charles shook his head, no. You assume that we will remain in Citradel. He turns to David, it pains me a little to say this. The way things are, I honestly don't know how the match will continue. I might loose with or without my overdrive. David grins at this. Charles continuous, and despite the way you are behaving, I know you also shaking in his boots, so to speak. You keep saying you will win. I don't doubt your resolve, but I know you don't know how you are going to beat me. At least not yet. You must to be in the same boat as me.

David's grin fades out. A small somber expression dawns on his face. A second later he says, the boots thing is debatable. But…he takes a short sigh, yeah. I agree, if. I am really unlucky it might come down to a coin flip at the end. Charles nods. He turns back to Kafar, if I loose and we move here, what's are yours plans for my bloodline. Kafar was left in silence for a bit. Then he asks, why are you asking this. You said you won't loose to anyone before your match. Even if you are backed into a corner, you always get back and strike down your opponent. Don't tell you are thinking about loosing purposely.

Charles replies, no way. I am not backing down in any way. You know me better than that. I am asking you because I am an alpha. Me winning here or losing might be important to all Medrones, but I have a responsibility to my bloodline. And top it off, I am the first alpha to have been put in such a situation where our existence has been reveled after centuries. I need to know what's going to happen to my bloodline if we move here. Kafar mauls over this for a moment. He turns to David and then back to Charles.

I think I understand Charles a little better now. He might be an alpha from a mystical bloodline, but that’s just how people told them in their stories. In all honesty, they seem like regular bloodline like any other. They just are more powerful, but also have more weaknesses. Kafar finally says, I never thought this could happen. He shook his head, I will make sure to keep our agreement as is. I got curious, what do you mean. What's your plan. Kafar didn't respond. I pursue it a little more, look. You already revealed your champion out in the open. And someone is going to lose here. So there's no point keeping it a secret. What's the different in telling us now or later.

Kafar relented and says, I will make sure that their bloodline are given preferential treatment. Their bloodline doesn't have too many fighters. Many of their people are so weakened in their normal bodies that they could die from a bullet. I promised to give them better protection. Each and every Heraknus will be able to live now without fear and the isolation from hiding. He turns to David, my plan is to give them a section of Citradel itself. A fully state of the art security and enmities to them. They have had to live in hiding all these years due to their Kuret weakened. But now, they have regained enough strength to be the most elite force. And since we are going to ask them to risk their lives even more now, they will be compensated appropriately.

So Kafar is basically going to give them a special place in the hierarchy of our community. Like the royal bloodline. I understood the importance of Heraknus warriors. But the way Kafar is wanting things, its different than how we plan to make it work here. Charles asks, can you even say that when you know what kind of society this island aspires to be. Kafar turns to me now. He says with some reluctant, you know I am right. They are too powerful of a bloodline to be not protected. I didn't think Charles had any chance of loosing, so we never discussed about this before when we were in talks about joining our communities.

I didn't respond. I wanted to say something, but I couldn't say it in front of Charles. And also, Charles said he just wanted to hear from Kafar. Charles turns to me. He asks, well. Do you believe the same. Shit, out of luck. I ask, why ask me now. I thought you only wanted to pick on Kafar's brain for this. Charles replies, but since the young prince is already here, its not too much to ask your take on this. I wasn't sure what to say here. This isn't something I can just say without knowing all the facts. We just only learned of Heraknus existence.

David interrupts my thoughts, you don't have to say anything you don't want to. But this isn't any serious discussion. You heard earlier Charles just needed to know Kafar's answer. Whether it’s the right one or not, it didn't matter. No one is going to held it against you if for anything you say. You can even choose to not say anything. He is right. I don't need to say anything right now. It might not be a formal setting, but if I say something Kafar doesn't like, he might just hold a grudge. But then again, it is still a private conversation. Even if others are listening in, whatever I say now is set in stones.

I turn to Charles, I'll be honest. Its not fair for you to be asking me so soon after you just revealed your existence. I don’t know why you stayed hidden in Medrine for centuries. I am not privy to all those facts. He then turns to Kafar, but it doesn't matter. They are on Earth now. And I know at part of the reason they hid here. I take a pause and gather my thoughts on the matter. I am definitely letting out my personnel thoughts into it. But that’s what Charles wants so I shouldn't hold back.

I turn back to Charles, the society we want right now is based on simple idea. Everyone is equal right now. It doesn't matter if your bloodline has thinned or you're omega. Everyone is suffering the same fate right now. In an ideal scenario, yeah, some bloodlines should have more priorities than others. But we are not there yet. We need to get rid of Hive before we can achieve some a society. So to answer Kafar. No, we will not give Heraknus any priority more than needed.

Kafar stammers a bit, what. Are you serious, didn't you see how powerful he is. I reply, I understand their bloodline is strong, but aren't we having this conservation because they have so many weaknesses. This is just how I am seeing, but from my view you guys aren't all that different than other bloodline. Sure, you guys have incredible perks. But I have never seen or heard more serious weakness. In the wrong place and time, there's a possibility every member of your bloodline could become helpless at the same time. That's not only dangerous for you, but also for everyone around you. And yes, I know its not something you control. But you aren't the only ones like that. So many of other bloodlines have similar problems. We can't keep giving each and everyone protection.

I didn't even see Kafar's aura to tell this is annoying him. But he asked me, so he should expect to hear my answer. I continue, it may not be fair or right. But that’s the reality we are in. We are going to protect everyone with the same resources and not just the selected ones. No matter who they are, we want to treat everyone the same way. Because if we don't, this will be a repeat of Valley. And no one wants that. I don't know if Nathan is still listening to me, but I am sure he regrets the way he handled things. Even if he doesn't regrets it, he must at least know its wrong.

I add, our entire species is at war, whether you are actively in the war or not. That means we need to let go sacrifice certain things. Like privileges or some level of safety. I am not saying that we won't do anything to protect your bloodline, but we won't do everything. We have an entire species to save, not just one bloodline. Even if it’s a one as strong as yours. I decided to stop here. I had few more things to say, but they were along the same lines. They were thoughts for if David won the match.

Kafar replies, I don't understand. We need to keep Heraknus safe. They are key to winning the war. I respond, I don't disagree. But they alone can't vanquish Hive. There are other people just as powerful as Heraknus, maybe not as powerful as Charles. There are people who are strong in their own way. Are you saying you will protecting them too differently. Kafar didn't answer. I continue, its obvious you wants to keep our most powerful weapon protected. And maybe we will. Like I said, this are just my thoughts. Who knows what people will decide. But if given me the choice, I would do it this way. Its not fair, but that’s just our reality.

Finally there was a moment of silence. David broke it by saying, nicely said. And to believe you thought you weren't ready for this. He smiles at me. He has been doing it amusingly for a while now, but this one felt genuine. I don't know if I am ready to be king. But at least I know where I stand, different from Kafar. I wonder if he had similar philosophies in Citradel. It would be interesting to know he protected certain bloodlines more closely than others or not. But that’s for a later time.

I wait for Charles who had been listening me without interruption. He then asks with a stern voice, so you believe that our bloodline is the same as others. You don't believe we are special. That’s all what he took from the whole conversation. I shook my head, I don't think like that. Yours looks special, but I think its because you guys were thought to be extinct. If I break down your powers carefully, the perks you have is balanced with an equally if not more limitations. On Medrine, bloodlines were made especial due to certain individuals. Most of the times, its their were alphas. But sometimes, anomalies are born. The bloodline become more popular or recognized due to someone other than their alpha. We could have that same trait on Earth, but sadly we don't have the numbers. So all of us on the island believe strength in individuals and groups. Not solely on the bloodline.

Charles looks at me with an intensity that begins to feel uneasy. His aura is so low due to his Kuret output, I couldn't tell if he is angry or sad or something else. Charles finally nods his head, okay. I understand. He turns to David, what do you think of all this. You must have your own opinion. Oh great, now its David's turn. David nods his head, I don't have anything to add to this. I agree with him. Charles asks again, so you don't also believe we are special bloodline. David didn't had to think long for this. Looks like he already anticipated this question.

He says, I'll ask you a question. What do you even mean by special bloodline. Does it mean you guys are so powerful we should follow you into battle always. Or does it mean you have so many weaknesses that you need to be protected always. Or is it somewhere in between. Charles doesn't say anything. David continuous, if your answer is the third one, it just means you are same as others. All the time I have been fighting you, I didn't treat you like something mythical. Its true I struggled. Like a lot. The only thing going in my mind was to find ways of winning. At least for me, that is the same way I fought against Derek and Blake. If I was so bothered by the fact that your bloodline is too special to be beaten, I would have already given up or lost. Your bloodline is strong, but so are others in this tournament.

Whoa. Me saying it from the outside is one thing. Its easy to say something like that when you are not overwhelmed and give into the fear. But he is the facing Charles. I wasn't sure how David's been feeling all this time. But I think he has been doing what he always does, treats it like problem than needs to be can solved. He must have definitely thought of giving up many times. Yet in the end, he has resolved enough to win against Charles. I see, he has been looking at him just as an alpha. Not as an alpha of a mystical line. This is something only David can do.

Kafar turns to Charles, they don't know your actual worth. One day, you will cure that weakness of Kuret blackouts. Maybe even be able to reduce the time to recover your Kuret to days instead of months. Charles replies, yes. Maybe. Charles takes a look at us. I thought maybe he wanted to hear Derek's or Vanessa's thoughts as well. But then instead of asking them, he turns to David. His stoic look finally breaks apart and makes a smile, all right. I have made a decision. You got your wish kid, get ready to face me at my full power.

Vanessa (Chapter 37)

Friday, February 16, 2024 23:08

Things escalated so quickly, my mind is in a turmoil. I didn't realize that Charles was this concerned about his bloodline. When I think about it, he must be actually feeling very stressed by this change. Imagine being part of a secret bloodline. He had to live in secrecy while also managing his bloodline. Then not only he lost his home, but the planet too. Now stranded on Earth, they still had to hide due his Kuret effected. Suddenly bringing about a change like this will certainly shift their paradigm. Charles, being their alpha, has a duty.

Its due to that he wants the best for his people. Kafar's agreement looked enticing for sure. But like Blake said, its not fair. We don't have the luxury of keeping one bloodline above others just because people believe they are mystical. Me, Catherine the other omegas are sole survivors of our bloodline. If Kafar thought really to protect special bloodlines, he would have to do it for us too. But that's just not possible. He can't just let one particular bloodline be assigned more important than others. This sort of thing was normal in Medrine, but we are not in Medrine anymore. Things have changed drastically and become more dangerous.

When David told us his take about it, I wasn't even surprised. Its so like him to be able to handle things his way under such crazy circumstances. I had a feeling his approach had been methodical, like playing a god damn chess. He was a little under duress in the beginning of the match. Made some rash decisions and made mistakes. But that's totally normal for anyone in his position. Who wouldn't be a struggle to fight someone like Charles. But he got better, got stronger, then insanely stronger. So much so that he did reckless attacks risking sometimes his life. The difference now from the start is that he has a reason to win desperately. I still can't understand what it is, but clearly he has gotten this powerful because of it.

Charles got to hear both sides. He finally made a decision. Something unexpected. Kafar yells in confusion, what are you saying. He said he won't be treating you anything special. Charles nods back, yes. That's want I want. Blake is confused. David tried to hide it, but I can tell he also wasn't sure of this. Kafar was speechless. Charles says, I never believed we needed to be protected more than others. If we did, what's the point in us being powerful when he have Kuret. Its fine to be treated differently because we have hidden this long, but I don't want the reason to be because of our powers. They saw me fight, so I thought to ask them what they think about my bloodline. I am actually felt relieved that they both felt like me.

What is going on. Is Charles saying he believes his own bloodline is a normal one. He continuous, I agreed to this if we remain in Citradel. With the Humans more close by, I want additional protection for my bloodline. But I don't think its needed here on this Island. I want us to have a normal life as much as possible. If we are suddenly thrusted into a spotlight straight from the shadows, unreasonable expectations would be set us. You were right David. We are not an all powerful bloodline nor do we need protection. In that sense, we are just like other bloodlines. Trying to survive just like others in an foreign planet.

Kafar asks nervously, hold on. I still don't…David cuts him off, its done Kafar. Deal with it. You answered, Charles heard and now its decided. Usually I am more patient, but you'll have to forgive me because I am way to tired right now. You should just listen to Charles idea. David gave a sharp look to Kafar that said, get with the flow or beat it. Kafar tried to put his annoyance into words. Derek then suggests, look. Its their battle. And whatever discussion happened here was nothing but opinions. No one is laying down ground rules for we will have make our society yet. This was something Charles just wanted to know for his own bloodline. So for now, let it slide.

Upon Derek's suggestion, Kafar ate his words. He didn't say anything more. Just gave an look of mix of confusion and anger. Charles faces David, I asked his selfish request for a break because I had to lay out my responsibility as an alpha. My reasons to continue from this point onwards shouldn't cause problems for my family, my bloodline. Now I am sure that whether I win or nor, we will have people around us who are open to see as equals. David nods at this, its good to know that you believe in our ideals too. So lets hear your idea.

Charles says, we need to fight in remote isolation. Need people to back away few miles so that I don't go hunting them in my overdrive state. This you already figured it out. But I need to emphasize one thing, there is a real chance you will die. I am not exaggerating it enough when I say that the danger you will be facing might just be the most difficult you ever faced. The way Charles spoke was way to serious than how he was worried earlier. My eyes widen a little hearing that. I ask, you are serious, aren't you. Charles nods, yes. I am. Look, since you don't heal like us, you might suffer some injury so severe that you die before people can come get you.

I know David is trying to keep his confidence up, but even he couldn't deny this. He says, I told you, I am aware of the risks. I won't chicken out just because someone new is trying to kill me. All I have to say for that is, get in line. Hive have tried to kill me, Humans tried to kill me. Hell, even Medrones have come after me. Fear of death is the least of my problems. David must have a screw loose now. He says he understand the risks, but does he. I ask him, no way. This is too dangerous David. If Charles saying you could die, even after all the times he came close to get you, you need to know the its too serious now.

Blake backs me up firmly, there is not enough good reason to risk your life for it. David replies, if I don't do this, I may not win at all. Then we have no choice but to move to Citradel. The life of millions of Medrones hangs in the balance. Us forming a society on the island, away from Human interference, isn't that a good enough reason. I reply, but you'll live. You will have more opportunities to save lives by living. He replies with a ominous tone, one persons life isn't worth everyone. You and Blake know that the best way to keep fighting is to first get all us safe in one place. And that has to be an isolated region, here. This island.

I am mad at him right now. How can he just say his life is not important. I reply angered, are you for real. You don't know how important you are. David shakes his head, this isn't about me. We all are taking risks. Maybe some more than others. But doesn't mean I should walk away. Blake asks nervously, is what you meant Charles. Risks for David. You want us others to be away from you two, leaving David all alone. Charles nods, I will bring in some specialized gears for people to use. They have worked on me before, even at my worst, so they should work here too. But like I said, they people to be far away, otherwise I could target them instead. Something could go wrong until I get restrained.

I couldn't believe this is what's happening. David's going be locked in the barrier with Charles, with no help from the outside. This is insane. This is not going to happen. David says, enough guys. You guys have trusted me this far. So a little more faith now. I am not being suicidal. I am not going to die okay. Besides, it's not for you to decide. Its my decision. I need to decide what's best for everyone. I reply, you mean you right. For some selfish reason, you are using that as an excuse. You want to just want to win that badly.

David looks at me with sudden intensity. I might have hit the bullseye. He can try to disguise his reasons, but I am sure of the actual one. David says, you might be right. But at least my selfishness to win no matter the cost is aligned with a purpose serving others. I am not blinded so much like others. I could hear a subtle tone his voice directly at my own selfish behavior during my match. I wanted to tell him that was different. But was it really. I wanted so badly to win, I risked more than I should. If it wasn't called off, I would have continued and probably bled to death. Is the same for him. Is something driving him so bad he rather die than give up.

Blake takes over when I become too stunned to speak. He asks, this is a little crazy David. Even for you. You are willing to die for hope that the island is the best place for us. Maybe Citradel could also be better. You don't have to bet on you life like this will doom our future. David shook his head, this will. We cannot hope to win against Hive if we are still surrounded my Human interference constantly. We have already gone through this months back. You know that. That's why we even agreed to this ridiculous tournament. And don't forget in the beginning I didn't even wanted to battle here. I was sure, you, Marina or Vanessa will be strong enough to win. But then I did. My reasons were different back then from now, but I don't regret it. And it turned out to have an unexpected outcome with my new Kuret transformation.

He sighs and then says, I don't want you guys to take this wrong way. But right now, I am the one here. Not you, not Blake or Derek. But me. I didn't get till to this point in my life solely on luck or playing it safe. Every important things I have done, has always been dangerous. All the freaking time. So you need to trust me and let me decide. I have never seen such a emotional and calculative David at the same time. He is even not shying off from flaunting his own achievements to make his point. Its incredibly frustrating to hear and even more to know they were true.

But it didn't make me any less mad. Is this actually going to happen. He might actually die at the hands of someone who doesn't even want him dead. David continues before Blake or me could stop him, so Charles. How are we going to do this. Announce people to back way to the island edge. Or maybe even ship them out completely. Charles asks, are you sure then. You made up mind. Even when you are in mortal danger. David nods in response. I couldn't even say anything. David's words about selfish behavior still hung on me. I want to desperately stop this, but I can't. Not when he is doing something not so different than me.

Charles says, let me tell the entire plan at least. We won't fight today. Not even tomorrow. David arms that were in cross comes open, say what now. Charles says, we will fight in a months time. Kafar asks, what are you saying Charles. If you are already made up your mind for using your overdrive. Why do you want to delay it. Charles says, I need time to recuperate. The Kuret I have lost will need that much time to recover completely. David asks, you want to recover your entire Kuret. Why. Charles says, simple reason. I want to go into overdrive with my entire Kuret. Give me the most time I can spend in my overdrive. The more Kuret I have, the more time I would have in my overdrive and the more chance of gaining consciousness.

Its incredibly bold of Charles to ask this. Giving himself the time to prepare is nothing but even more selfishness than David. David didn't respond, instead he ponders on it. David tilts a head slightly on hearing this sudden new development. Blake shrieks, you want to postpone the match. Is that even possible. He turns to Kafar. Kafar is full on panic mode now. Way too much things must be going on his head to answer. Derek answers instead, I am not saying we should do this, but we can tell everyone that Charles is going to use his overdrive. So he needs time to use it. He turns to Charles, I assume that's what you meant when you said everyone will know about your overdrive.

Charles replies, yes. There is no point in hiding it now or later when I am going to use it. You can tell others about the risks too. I have nothing to hide or be ashamed about it. Its just how my alpha Kuret behaves. In fact, the more people are informed the better they understand the risk of being near me. Blake asks, and you need a full month do regain your lost Kuret. Charles replies, regretfully yes. The Kuret recovery is much slower for our bloodline. Blake turns to David, at the very least you will have a whole month to recover then.

I ask him, wait. So you all on board now. Blake says with annoyance, hell no. But you heard him. He isn't going to listen to us. At for the moment, we can't stop him. Short of physically restraining him ourselves all the time, I don't know what we can do. The only way we can truly stop this if we agree to move to Citradel now. But its not just David, I don't think people will agree to it. We worked hard to build this city here. Bringing people from all over the world, stealing resources we need from Humans undetected and even rebuilding our technology. Too much is at stake to change our progress by moving to Citradel. If David's going to do this, I can't deny it anymore, we need this win. I reply, so what. We should just let this happen. I turn to David, you are willing to die, when you are not even facing Hive as your enemy.

David looks at me but doesn't respond. What is going on his head right now. Charles says, you still have a out kid. I told you earlier, you can reject this idea and we can continue this match as is. I reply, that's right. Its much safer to fight Charles like this. Derek says, you might even win. You know that winning now or winning after a month don't have the same risks. You can choose for a safer option. David finally broke his silence, I don't understand one thing Charles. A months will also give me time not only to recover, but to work on my Kuret. I can't say how much, but I will become way stronger than now. Same as you. I can't believe he is ignoring us like this. Was he even listening when he heard me pleading.

Charles says, that's why it should work out well for the both of us. This gives us an equal advantage for winning and loosing. David shook his head, nope. That's were you are wrong. I am trying to weigh my options. But I don't see how this is good for the both of us. I never seen your overdrive. Meanwhile, you know all my tricks. Even if I was lying and hiding something more, you still have the edge on power. A month won't be enough time to learn my new Kuret forms. Not completely. And lets say I continue this match without making you overdrive, I would be fighting with that same disadvantage. You will not go into overdrive, but maybe you will pull out some unknown form yet again.

I am a little relieved David is still level headed even when being so stubborn. Charles nods slightly thinking at the same time. David continues, and don't get me started on how things have been not been equal for us. You had been hidden until the finals, while I had to take a long and painful route to get here. You have gotten the chance to see me fight others and now with you. A month time will give you more ways to deal with me and than I can against you. And there have been numerous violations from you. Even if there were not intentional, it shouldn't have been allowed. He turns to a nervous Kafar. David says, I am not accusing you specifically. I don't care about

it much right now anyways. But I can't ignore it too. I only bring this up to prove that fighting now or fighting after a month, we both don't have the same footing as you say.

He raises his arms up, again. It's not something I am blaming you Charles. I am just telling you what I think. I want to win against you completely, but its meaningless if I recover in a month and my chances doesn't change. I am desperate to win, not to die. I could just continue this current battle which is much safer. From my view, with these conditions, I don't see the merit in risking so much. Now if you plan to do it now instead of waiting for a month, I am game.

Charles thinks about it for a moment. Then he shakes his head, tempting. But no. I won't to do it now. I want to get the best chance and use this opportunity to recover first. David replies, yeah. Well, you see the dilemma I am here right. I gotta admit, David made sense even he is being so stubborn. His wrapped sense of danger is still somehow sensible enough to know differences of the risks involved. Charles thinks about it for a long time. It was a agonizing to wait for him to respond. Then he says, I never thought it like this. I thought you would agree to it right way if it meant getting stronger. But you are right. You were at disadvantage from the beginning. And I feel like I have been given lot more help that I should have gotten. He then turns to Kafar, so lets fix that.

Kafar asks in nervous tone, what do you mean by that. He smiles and then turns to David, I'll sweeten this proposal. If you agree to it, I am going to declare my loss. Did I hear him right. That was the most outrageous thing he has said till now. He is willing to forfeit the match to make the real fight happen later. Kafar yells, you can't. Charles says, why not. Am I also a participant here. I maybe a wild card entry, but the rules will apply to me the same. If I don't want to, I can choose to give up now. Kafar is shaken at this. So were everyone who heard this incredible turn of events.

David asks sternly with a frown, even if you give up like this. I don’t think people, specifically from Citradel, and the admins would accept the match to end like this. They might choose not to move here. I don't know if you realize just how much was risked to keep the match going. Charles nods, I think I am beginning to understand that. Earlier you asked me something about my Kuret blackout when I was lying on ground. I don't fully understand what happened, but now that I think about it, I might have been stuck like that for longer than I thought. Maybe I should I have lost then and there. Am I wrong. He looks over to us.

He did realize something was wrong. Kafar replies in haste, no. You didn't loose then. You were just lucky. That’s all. His desperate pleas looked more desperate than insincere. Charles replies, even if that’s not the case, I am still willing to give up. He turns to face David, and as for people not choosing to come here. You might be right. To make sure you actually win this match, I am also willing to bring my bloodline to this Island immediately when you agree to it. Kafar was stammering on his words, you what. You can't do that.

This is becoming too tense now. Charles says, why not. Our current deal is over now. We are not in hiding anymore, we don't need the same protection anymore. What I want is a place for my bloodline to be with other strong people. I know there are many Citradel people who are strong, but the people here are more experienced with the Hive. They have been constantly fighting Hive and even won a war without our support. We need to learn from them more than they from us. I am doing this not just for me, but for everyone.

I ask, buts that’s just your bloodline. What about others. They might still remain in Citradel. Blake replies, no, not true. Citradel didn't know their protector until now. They knew someone has been protecting them all this time, but not their identity. Now every Medrone knows about them. If they move here, then its almost certain people will also come here. They can't live in a place where the people who protected them all this time suddenly leave. Do you believe the same. He asks Derek.

Derek like us is reeling from the shift in the conversation. He then replies, yes. I do. Some people might think to stay behind, but in the end safety in numbers is what matters. It might not be pretty or smooth process. But if Charles moves here, I don't think people will remain in Citradel anymore. How unexpectedly devious of you Charles. Charles replies, thanks kid. I do sometimes get pretty good ideas now and then. So David, what do you think now. Doesn't this make us even now. You no longer have to worry about anything other than our fight anymore.

David had a bewildered expression. Even he never thought this could happen. He asks, you are serious. You are okay giving up and letting your people come here. Charles nod, yes. Once I realized that you might be the one who could handle my overdrive, I am become less concerned with this tournament. I still want to show how powerful a Heraknus alpha truly is, and now I can do it without being concerned about the consequences for my bloodline. Same as you. If when I give up now, its still only a technical victory for you. You too would not accept it as a complete victory.

I ask him, if this is want you want, you can just let someone else fight you later. Blake or Marina would be more compatible to fight you in a caged match. David doesn't need to be only one fighting you right. Charles shook his head, no. At this moment, David is the only one whose the best for this. Marina's the granddaughter of Gordan. She is the been tasked to be the architect for rebuilding our culture. She is way to important to risk herself when our society is only forming. And the young prince here also has many responsibilities now. He needs to be here to lead the new Medrine community. And unfortunately, I don't know anyone else other than the 3 of you who could have a chance of surviving my overdrive. So it has to be David. I am not saying he isn't important, but only he has shown such an adnominal will to win.

I turn my eyes to David. My face was confused visibly now. He must be trying hard to decide. This new addition had definitely thrown out all the odds stacked against David. If David agrees to it, we have effectively moved all the people to the Island. Kafar shrieks, Charles, you are making a rash decision here. You can't selfishly choose to do this. Think about others, not just your own bloodline. Charles replies, I can't take responsibility for everyone. I have made my priorities known to you from the start. And if you think about it, this will can still benefit everyone. Maybe not the way you want, but its still a possibility. Same as when people would had people move to Citradel.

Kafar shook his head, not like this. If you do this, it will make people divide even further. We can't let it happen. Charles replies, you might be right. But as said earlier, I can't take complete responsibility for others. I have to be looking out for my people first. Kafar asks pleading now, at least don't do this without discussing it other admins. With your people. Charles replies, I don't need to get approval about this from people. I can do what I want here. Unlike Medrine, we don't have a society with stringent rules. No laws to obey or repercussions when we break it. And as for my bloodline, they have already seen how strong the island people. Some may not like how I decided, but they will understand it once I talk to them later.

Blake asks, what if even after that they don't agree to come. Charles thinks for a moment before replying, I don't think that’s going to happen. I not just an alpha they follow, they trust me enough to make the right decision. But just in case if it did happen. He turns to David, I wouldn't have kept my end of the bargain and so you wouldn't need to fight me anymore. I am not sure what would happen with our two communities in that case, but at least you won't have to risk your life for this.

This is nuts. Charles is giving a lot of leeway for David accept it. With such terms, its hard not for him to take it. In his mind, he has to decide if this is worth the risk. Kafar yells, I can't believe you are willing to go this far. Charles says, I am not only one you know. With all the insane stunts this kid has been doing in this match, I don't know who is more willing to put everything on the line. Charles wasn't wrong, they both have eerily the same attitude on this matter. Kafar shifts his body and looks at us with fervor eyes. He must be angry at this situation. His worst possible outcome might become reality if Charles ends this tournament right now.

David is still thinking what to do. He says to Charles, quite the conundrum you have put me in Charles. I can chose to risk with my life a month later, but at least our future would be have better chance of surviving. On the other hand, if I continue this match, I am leaving the outcome to luck. A relatively safer way, but no guarantee of my win. He forms a smirk on his mouth and whispers, I honestly don't know what's the right way. He rolls his eyes to me. I thought he was going to ask me to help him out. But he just started straight without blinking.

He has to know how what I will say. I don't want him to fight such a freak all alone. If we are not there to intervene their match, he could very well die. I still can't believe he would rather do something irrational than continue fighting now. I wanted to let David decide this, but my mind had already made up. I told him, you already know what my thoughts are on this right. Don't do this David. Please. Getting people here is important, but not by putting your life in danger intentionally. I turn to Blake and Derek to say something. But of them didn't say anything. Rather, they couldn't. I face David back. He kept his eyes on me all the time. I couldn't keep it together and ask, what are you looking for me to say. I will never say what you want. I will never agree to this.

David says with a small chuckle, figures. That was just a wishful thinking I guess. He was really wanting me to push him and accept this deal. If I can't stop him, I am sure as hell will not going to help him decide what he really wants. Kafar suddenly yells, wait David. Blake said you all don't have all the facts of Charles and overdrive right. Maybe you need to hear some of it now. You will know how exactly ridiculous it is to face him alone with his overdrive. Charles asks, Kafar, what do you doing.

Kafar barks out, if I also can't stop you. At least I can tell David what's waiting for him next. He turns to David, I can't tell anything specific about his overdrive. I have only seen it briefly, so even if tell something about it, you won't benefit from it. But I just remembered something now. He turns to me now, you don't want to David fight too right. Then you being here is good thing. I ask, what does that mean. He says, while on Earth, no Medrone has been able to challenge him, but only some people have stood against Charles on Medrine. His mother, his uncle, a royal alpha and one more.

Blake joins in suddenly, say that now. A royal alpha. You mean my dad. Kafar shook his head, no. You and Nathan's grandfather. Back then Charles was young and wasn't even an alpha. So it isn't fair comparison. His mother and uncle on the other hand weren't a target when he goes overdrive, so its still not meaningful. But the last one, this one came in contact when Charles was an alpha and undergoing his overdrive training. Charles told me he was the only one who made him overdrive.

David asks, you said only your mother would be able to handle you in that state. Charles looks at Kafar for a second before responding, yes. That’s right. I told you about someone gave me a lot of trouble. He was too powerful for me to beat, so I made a rash decision to go into overdrive. But my mother was the one who reined me in the end. David ask, who was it that made you decide to use it. And why were you even fighting this person anyways.

Kafar cuts in before Charles could answer, the reason of their confrontation is not important. But it’s the person you should know. He turns to me again, it was Wagner. Your brother, the previous crown. My entire body shiver a little hearing his name here. I ask hesitantly, what. I turn to Charles to look for an answer. Charles takes one more look at Kafar and then to me, yes. It was him. It was years before we left Medrine, but I remember it him quite clearly. He used the same Kuret as you, but as an alpha not as an omega, I gather you had born by then. You inherited his Kuret, but he was the first alpha of your bloodline. He was in a league of his own. Next to my mother and David, he is the only person I ever wanted to use my overdrive on.
I can't believe Wagner fought him. Why did he though. Why didn't he even tell anyone about it. Told me. Charles continuous, we had a similar situation of stalemate, like David is with me now. But he chose to push further and use his own overdrive. So I had no choice but to use mine then. At that statement I froze. I blurt out, he did what. He could overdrive. Charles looked curious at me, you don't know. That's strange. I thought you knew. Blakes asks, are you sure that he did. No one knew he already achieved it. Charles looks around us. Our confused face gave him an answer, hum. This is surprising, did he keep it hidden.

I can't believe my own brother hid such a thing from me. How can he not tell me he fought a Heraknus or he could overdrive. Dammit. I know it wasn't the time to be feeling this, but I became extremely jealous of him now. He already did something I am not able to do. Kafar interrupts the sudden tense atmosphere, the important thing is that now you know that the strongest Medrone on Earth, even with his overdrive couldn't beat Charles in his own overdrive state. Wagner was defeated in no time. Maybe he didn't want to share with others that he lost and so he never spoke of this. He turns to David, you, who isn't even an alpha or omega has no chance of beating him. You will get killed.

Is that really it. I couldn't believe Wagner would be ashamed of his defeat. I turn to David who had frozen still. What happened to him. His eyes was glued to Kafar. His body is frozen, not moving even an inch. But then I noticed his fingers trembling a little. Wait. Is he scared. Is Kafar obvious plan to scare him actually working. I got concerned and ask, are you all right. He doesn't say anything. He ignores me. Blake asks, ah. You all right there. You look like you are about to throw up.

Even others notice this visible change on David. Kafar blatantly becomes rude, yes. That’s right. You must have hear how strong Wagner was. He was the strongest one in the whole planet and still couldn't defeat Charles.

Charles raised his hand to him, wait a second Kafar. This isn't…He gets cut off by David's hurried voice, is it true Charles. You met him and even fought him. For the first time I hear nervousness in his voice. Charles looks a bit uneasy at this. He nods, yes. I did. I am not lying. But you need to know…David interrupts his again, prove it. I won't take just your word for it. Tell me something about him only people who fought him would know.

This is a strange ask. What's going on with David. Charles asks, did you knew him on Medrine. But I thought you don't remember your past. David yells with a certain force that shocked everyone of us, just tell me. How I know doesn’t matter right now. Charles was taken aback from this sudden outburst from him. Does he remember my brother. Why didn't he ever mention that. Now that I think about it. Whenever I bring my brother, he evades the entire topic with some reason. What's going on David. How do you know about him, I ask him. David doesn't respond to me. He was focused completely on Charles. Charles looks over to us. Even Kafar was not certain what's going on now.

Charles scratches his forehead for a moment, I am not sure what to tell you. Lets see. He closes his eyes for a second to think and then says, yeah. I found something very peculiar about him. I remember he ditched his weapon early on when he figured it wasn't going to work on me. He did said something aloud to me, about it being not strong enough to break my body and mind. That was wired thing to say. No one would throw away any weapon.

David Kuret immediately erupts in flame beside me. I instinctively take a few step back away from him. I shriek, David. What are you doing. Everyone expect Charles takes a step away from his Kuret that was enveloping him. The moment I saw his face, I couldn't believe it. He looked pissed. His mouth was turned hard from gritting his teeth. His eyes had such anger and madness I never seen it before. Blake shouts, whoa. What happened. Derek asks, somethings wrong. Kafar nervously laughs, yes. Looks like he is realizing just how fruitless this endeavor is.

David begins walking slowly between us. His Kuret roared wildly around him. He comes closer to Charles and then a moment later quells down his Kuret. He says, I accept your conditions. Lets do it. A month later we will duke it out.

David (Chapter 38)

Saturday, September 6, 2025 12:45

I can't think, maybe can't even breathe. My heart is beating so loud that I can't hear anything else. This is the opportunity I thought that was never going to get. When Kafar revealed about that guy fighting Charles, my thoughts became a singularly focused on finding the authenticity and not a plot by Kafar to make me back off. Charles answer was proof enough that Kafar was telling the truth. I can't believe that there is someone alive who fought that psychopath. What's more, he couldn't beat Charles. If could beat Charles, it would mean I beat him.

It didn't make me a second longer to make my decision after this revelation. My Kuret was leaking from me, partly excited and anxious, as I walked towards Charles. Other were trying speaking to me, but I couldn't hear them. My breathing had tuned everything out. Finally I told him, I accept your conditions. Lets do it. A month later we will duke it out. Charles was visibly taken aback by my sudden change in demeanor. I kept waiting for him to reply back as he gather back his composure. He hesitantly asks, are you all right, kid. I don't know why you are acting like this, but maybe you should take a moment.

I replied, I am fine. I gritted my teeth and the corner of my mouth formed into a big smile involuntary. I continued, no. I am actually great. I have a chance to beat down someone that the previous crown couldn't beat. I am not letting this opportunity go to waste. No way in hell. Charles eyes focused on me, then he looked to others. None were speaking, just waiting. Charles broke the silence after a sigh, look, that’s not the whole story. Kafar left out somethings. I cut him off, I don't care. The other unnecessary details are a little interest to me. I only care about our fight now. So lets agree to the conditions you laid out.

Charles silent breathing is heavy and long. He was clearly wary of me. Blake and others were also stunned by my attitude. But I cared not. Even with my brain getting hotter by the second, I was aware that I was having an episode. Soon I will be getting a panic attack. I need to get this out of the way out better my breakdown. Kafar cuts in with a nervous and anxious voice, are you absolutely sure you want to do this. He turns to Charles once he realized I wasn't going to respond to him, Charles, you do this and you expose everything. After keeping it a secrete for so long, are you really ready to reveal it now?

Charles looks to him but doesn’t respond. He is still contemplating his decision. He turns to me and lightly shook his head, all right. I don't understand what's going on with you. Its got nothing to do me anyways. Fine David. You got yourself a deal. He raised his arm. Others around were shocked by this development. My smile become even wider, probably becoming menacing. I took his arm and shook it. Kafar was the most vocal about opposing this. Others were silently witnessing and someone was even cussing.

A moment later I take back my hand and say, I can't wait for our rematch. Charles lightly nodded with a little nervousness. He turns towards the building with admins and raised his hand in air. He then gestures that he is giving up. I saw glimmers of confusion coming in the air from the crowd. I bet the entire stadium is in an uproar. The admins are the ones who are most shocked to have seen this conclusion to the match.

I could feel my veins popping in my head, my breathing erratic. I was definitely going towards a breakdown. With all the exhaustion, I may even pass out soon. My legs suddenly felt weak. Actually I have been struggling to stand now. My left leg stung a little and out of no where my knee gave out. Beside me Blake caught me with this hands on my arms before I fell down. He shrieks, whoa. What happened.

My Kuret was receding back in. I was able to clam myself a little now that the Charles had given up. I could hear others now. I look up to Blake who had a serious face on him. I murmur, get me out of here. Hurry. I pleaded. Blake was stunned and then a moment later nodded sternly. Vanessa and Derek looked over to me in stupor. Kafar was angrily watching Charles and was ignoring me. Blake looks over to others, I am talking him to infirmary. He is finally hitting his limit. He turns to Kafar, David is the winner after this. You can't stop this now. Kafar ignored him and had his eyes focused solely on Charles. Charles and Kafar were now in heated argument a moment later.

I could feel my hands shaking. Shit. I can't let others know about me. Not right now. With Blake's support, we both turned and start to walk away. Blake could definitely tell something was wrong with me. Thankfully, he didn't ask me. Even if he did, I wouldn't tell him when others are listening in. I couldn't tell what Vanessa and Derek were doing. One thing was certain though, Vanessa was no doubt mad at me. But there was no sign of her following us. I was thankful for that. I am in no state to handle it right now.

We came close to the barrier. On the other side, our friends were waiting. Since the barrier was still eructed, we couldn't cross it yet. I wanted to hurry the hell out of here. My chest started to ache now. My legs were almost giving up as I lost strength. Blake grabbed hold of me firmly, shit, he muffles. He turns to others and signals Marina to remove the barrier. I looked up with my twitching eyes. Marina had raised her shoulders asking what's going on. Blake mouths hurry up to her. Marina was bamboozled. She looked over to Blake and then finally to me.

She took a few seconds to understand and nods panicking seeing my state. She turns to others and signs them to back away from her. She uses her Kuret and starts to create a charm. I don't know what exactly her plan was. This barrier is extremely tough. I don't think it can't be taken down fast, especially without her overdrive. At this point, both my legs had lost strength. Blake felt a sudden tug of weight from my slumped body. I brings his own Kuret to support with one arm, dammit. Try to hold on a little longer. I understand you want to leave before anyone sees you like this. I'll help as much as I can.

All I could muster was a slight node. Blake pretty much caught on to my plight now. Ahead of us, Marina was continuing with her casting. I could vaguely make out circuits of Kuret coming out of her hands. I had even started to sweat excessively and fogging my eyes. Shit. This might be the biggest breakdown I ever experienced. This cannot be happening at a worst timing, for all of Medrines to see. I have kept this weakness hidden all the tournament. I might let it being slide if it got exposed later, but I still have a final showdown.

Fortunately, I had a good excuse of exhaustion. People seeing me would just assume I am tired and had to be carried out. I had little room to think about it though. My mind was becoming jumbled and thoughts incoherent. I am running out of time. Marinas charm was finally completed. She walked towards the barrier wall. The invisible kuret begins twist and funnel out towards Marina. A moment later a hole opened up through which we could pass though.

Though, something was odd. The cornucopia of glimmers coming off were not disappearing, instead it was just being scooped into sheet of kuret enveloping Marina. Blake and I didn't waste time and crossed the barrier. The sudden change in surrounding made my body jerk. The loud noise which was earlier dulled down was now completely deafening. Crowd of people were shouting with such zeal it was unclear whether they were mad or congratulating me. I tried best not to look up and instead just focused on going inside.

Others scrammed around us. Nathan asks, what the hell just happened to you? Cass asks, David, what's happening. Her voice filled with concern. Matt and others still kept their distance, due to Marina shouting, don't come near me. It was as though she was making the barrier kuret curled up in her charm. Why was she still holding it. She looks at others, I can't let go of this. If I do, they both will just be pulled back in by this. I can't disperse this Kuret yet. A little of the barrier kuret left her charm and form a thin sheet of wall Infront of the two us as we walked.

I could feel a slight tug from the front trying to push me and Blake back inside. Blake says, you are slipping a little Marina. Marina curses a little and says, I know, I know. She starts to walk behind us. She continuous, guys, don't follow us. I need some space. I will follow them inside to make sure the barrier doesn't pull them back. Tell the others inside to wait for a little while until I come back. Tessa speaks, understood. Just do whatever you can for them right now. David doesn't looks too good.

I bet, I grumbled. Others watched us in confusion as the three of us pass the corridor door I used to enter inside. The noise slowly begins to fade down. The familiar noise of my breathing and heart beats begins to rise up. At this point Blake is completely dragging my lifeless body though the hallway. Marina walks in close behind us with the Kuret barrier in tow, what happened. Is he okay. Away from others she finally asks. Blake replies, I have no freaking clue. One minute he was okay, then the next second he was not. His kuret leaked out and he started to shake badly. I can't believe his injury worsened so suddenly without M warning. I thought she mentioned he was okay.

Marina waves her wrist a little, M wake up. What's going on. I thought he wasn't in danger. The watch glows up and M comes out, boss's stats are crashing. Diagnosis confirm its not physical injury, but a psychological. Preparing countermeasures with sedatives. Blakes immediately speaks up, what. How can this be. M didn't respond, but only showed my heart rate and other stats. Marina asks, oh come on. Just tell us. Your boss is looking pale now. M response didn't change, causing Marina to snap with a irritated sigh.

The three of us pass though the inside of the building now. There were some staffs now visible. They tried to approach us, some confused and others clapping. Blake waved his free arm around them, sorry people. The winner is too exhausted to talk right now. Thankfully, due to my sudden departure, the people inside had not mobilized completely. Only the essential people were inside. Majority of them would be either outside or gathering to move inside.

A group of people came and began gathering around us. They were the security for the participants. The head person Jackson came up and takes a quick look at us. He nods then instructs others to form around the three of us. Give us some space, he shouts to the oncoming people. He turns to Blake, what happened. Blake responds, we need to go to the infirmary quickly. It might not look like it, but his injuries are worse than they appear. He needs to get inside his personal suspension tank.

Jackson replies, I see. Okay. Lets cut through the stair case from the left end of the building instead of using this one. I saw few people from the stadium beginning to come inside. It will be a longer route, but we can avoid people for now. Blake says, lead the way. Using the five security guys, the three of us make way from the slowing buzzing staff in a tight formation. Blakes turns back to Marina and asks, how long will you have to keep this up? Marina replies, a minute more. I don't have those stones from before to create doors in the barrier, so next best thing is to take a piece out of it and let it slowly disintegrate.

Blake asks, okay. As soon as this done, you can head back to take down the entire thing. Marina clicks her tongue, after all that effort to make it. She turns to face me and hold back whatever she was about to say more, well, whatever. At the very least it was a good opportunity to test it out. She turns to Jackson, how much farther. He points to the straight ahead on the turn on the hallway. We were able to pace up from here out since there were very less people now.

My head started to hurt now. Vision was blurry to tell what direction we were going. I was completely at the mercy of others now. I grabbed my left chest. It felt like my chest was about to burst open. This is just a panic attack. I kept reminding myself. The rational part of me knew this was my PTSD, yet my body was crashing out. I don't know how long I could hold it together now.

After what felt like eternity, I saw the glimmers of medicines. We were close. We came to a halt near the entrance. I heard Blake saying beside me, thanks everyone. I will help David inside. Don't let anyone inside. Jackson waves his hand to others guard the door, understood. You do what you need to. Marina says, its done. She dispels the Kuret as the door open for us. She says, I think I better stick with you until David stabilizes. Since I got M with me.

Blake takes a moment to consider, good thinking. We might need M. As we cross the minimal staffs inside, Blake murmurs to her to avoid people hearing us, I don't know how, but I think David's having a heart attack. He is panicking more visibly now. Marina didn't hold back her shout, what. That can't be. She looks to M, the hologram didn't mention anything. She replies, its not possible. M is not showing anything. Just a high hear rate. Blake replies, but look, he is grabbing his chest like this.

We rushed to my private room that was dedicated for me. All the equipment here were carefully calibrated for me. I only ever needed for rest and bandages before. But this time, the suspension tank was already up and running. Now that we were completely away from others, I spoke up, its not a heart attack. By voice was basically trembling at this point. Even I could barely hear my own voice. The two of them turn to me. Blake was near me and heard the most, what was that.

He leaned to my neck to hear more clearly. But at that moment, I couldn't keep my nausea down anymore. I could feel the gag reflex coming on. Marina saw me and immediately understood. Shit. She conjured up a charm to pull the dustbin from the corner to her. Blake saw this and let goes of me. My body slump down like a rock. I already couldn't feel my legs, so with one free arm keeping me steady on the floor, I threw up into the bin Infront. The glimmers and smell of my own stomach contents hit me with force.

Blake and Marina take a step back. My mouth filled with the familiar yet disgusting taste. I emptied out my stomach after several seconds. Spit comes out from the corner of my mouth. Shit. I began shaking now uncountably, my left hand still clutching my chest. I push the bin away and slump down face first. Marina calls out, David no. Blake grabs me by my shoulders, pulling me up and shouts, what's going on M. Their voices were now filled with terror. M didn't respond.

Once Blake helps me out straighten up, I try to speak up again, panic attack. It was all I could muster. This time Blake heard me, are you serious. You know what's happening to you. I gave a slight now. Or maybe not. My whole body was shutting down, it was hard to tell anything. Blake pulls me up towards the suspension device. Marina opens the lid and warm air gushes out from the inside. Blake uses his Kuret to push me up and place me inside. M finally speaks up, confirmed boss inside. Starting up the process.

After finally resting inside my tank, my body finally gave out. My hands and legs begin to shake. My heart is pounding like crazy. A nanobot wire comes out floating on the water with a needle to inject me in my left arm. I could hardly tell the needle inside my vein. Blake lets goes of my body as he paces me inside. The water begins to fill inside from the bottom. All I could feel was it was warm and getting splashed around from all my shaking. Marina was about to close the lid. With my available arm, I lift it up and wave at her to stop.

She askes concerned, what, something wrong. I tried to speak, but my throat was in no mood to listen. Blake asks, something you need us do. I think I nodded. I couldn't tell. I didn't want others to know about me like this, but I didn't have much choice. M can't diagnosis my PTSD properly, only manage the symptoms. I need help from Dr Drew here. With a shaking hand, I point to Marina's wrist. Marina confused brought her arm near my palm. I don't know if M will even register this gesture with all this tremors, but I had little options.

I begin slowly making air gestures with my fingers. Both of them realized a moment later that I was motioning something to M. The sedative was finally taking effect. For the first time since letting go of Charles hand, I felt my breathing calming down. But that also meant I was going to be unconscious soon. With every bit of focus I could manage, I complete the unlock sequence. M speaks out, confirmed raised authority. Boss's PTSD and medication history is now available.

Marina freaks out, PTSD. What the hell. Blake turns to me and asks, what does this mean. He leans closer to me thinking I would respond. But no voice would come from me. Marina shouts, ah. Freak it. We will ask him later. Let M work on him first. Blake pulls away, yeah right. He grabs my arm hanging out at the edge and pulls in inside placing on my stomach. Marina closes the lid with the water now filling up my neck. I could feel the nanobots surfing in the water around me.

My mind finally begins to drift off to slumber.

Vanessa (Chapter 39)

Sunday, September 7, 2025 17:25

Derek beside me asks, that was weird right? It isn't just me. I replied, you mean how David was behaving or how Blake had to help him walk out of here. Derek hesitantly says, both. I agreed. Something was definitely wrong with him. As soon as my brother was mentioned his air changed around him. What does that mean. I wanted to follow them and asked him. But the anger I feel towards him was pushing down my urge. Honestly, whatever the reason, he shouldn't have taken agreed to this ridiculous condition.

I saw Marina walking away with Blake and David inside. She was using a charm to take a piece of the barrier with her. The hole she left behind was already closing. Looking at that I turned to Derek saying, looks like we will be spending a little more inside. Derek was also watching them leave inside. He nods, seems like it. He took some steps away from Charles and Kafar's discussion, which is basically Kafar berating mostly now. I tuned out most of it since it was all around the same lines of reconsidering this.

I asks, so what happens now? We can't just do nothing while those two argue. I ask Derek, the tournament over now with Charles surrender, right. What's the point in their argument now. Derek took a moment to respond, I guess the first thing we should notify the admins about it. We are not able to contact them directly from inside the barrier. Whatever happens later, for now, the match has ended, like you said. He faced the two behind one more time. I thought he would finally intervene, but instead he just observes them. A moment later he sighs, this is no good. Kafar is getting too much agitated.

I wondered what to do about them. Derek faces me, lets leave them. I am not getting between them. Let Kafar say his peace. We should go to others. I was more than happy to leave them be. I was occupied with other thoughts in my mind. We began walking to the barrier wall. I turned to Derek and asked him before we reached the edge, do you have any idea what happened to David. He looked so, well, different. Why did he ask about my brother. Derek replied, I don't know. I was shocked as well. Maybe he recalled some memories or something like that.

I ask back, about Wagner? How. David never said he knew him. He asks, did he ever tell you he don't know him. I tried remembering. But yeah, he has always been evasive about his time on Medrine. I felt a tinge of anger now, but to know about Wagner's fighting. That means he was close enough to know him personally. My voice started to get filled with jealousy, even I didn't about that body or spirit breaking stuff. How does David know about it. Derek didn't say anything. He was instead surprised by my tone rising.

Derek replies after giving a thought, they both attended the same college. As an alumni, they could have met back then. I reply, but why hide that fact. A second later, I got even angrier, I can't also believe that my own brother hid he could overdrive. What's up with that. Derek says, all good questions. Maybe David can answer them. Clearly he is knows more than he is letting on. Besides, I more concerned with that sudden exhaustion. That almost looked like, he trails off. He then shook his head and mumbles, no that can't be right. Why now of all times.

It wasn't like I didn't share his concern, but I was too much stuck on David's other peculiar behaviors. I have seen David hurt enough times to know he always find a way to get back up. We reach the wall. Now few more people had gathered around. All the admins. They were talking to Nathan and others, trying to understand what really happened. We all had to wait until Marina takes down the barrier. I zoned off from the their muted discussion. I was too hung up on other things. With so much going on, it’s going to be chaos for a while.

Next few minutes went by a sense of trepidation in the air. I saw Blake and Marina returning a while later. The admins all started asking questions to them. While Blake spoke, Marina started to work on removing the barrier. Derek says, looks like the people are going to be kept in suspense for a while. After a while other staffs came outside, among them Ned. He was walking with a tablet in hand now. The discussion was completely led by Blake taking the lead. I saw him talking as other listened quietly.

Derek asks me with a grim voice, listen, I need a favor from you. I faced him wondering what it was. He usually doesn't ask others in such a serious tone. He continuous, can you keep the stuff about few Medrones on Medrine knowing about Heraknus existence a secret. So far Kafar has only told bare minimum to some people. There's going to be backlash after today on why Heraknus were hidden. Both back on Medrine and now on Earth. You heard some part of it from Charles, but not the whole facts. I don't want to create unnecessary rumors or half details being spread among people.

I understood what he meant but at the same time I wondered how not telling will persuade people. He continuous, its not just you. Others who listened in the conversation also shouldn't keep a lid on it. At least until Kafar or Charles himself explain the situation. After weighing the chaos it could create I gathered that was the best thing to do. I reply, you are right. This will be much better coming from them. Dereks nods, thanks. Please tell others to do the same. I reply, you got it.

After ten minutes of us staring at the barrier, it finally came down. The noise from the crowd also begin to stir around us. The enthusiasm had faded a little, I could tell. People were now just waiting for some kind of announcement. Behind us, I saw Charles and Kafar finally walking to us. They saw the barrier coming down and must have figured times up. From Kafar's expression I could tell he was totally annoyed. Charles on the other hand doesn't look that different. I could judge that nothing changed between them.

The admins came walking to Charles. The head admin, Reinhart spoke first, Charles, we heard from Blake about the situation. Are you sure weren't pressured or leveraged to surrender. Is it really your own decision. Charles looks at him after a quick look over from Kafar. He clears his throat, let me be clear. It is unequivocally my decision to give up. No one made me. The other admins behind Reinhart became a little restless. Ned remained expressionless. I wondered what he was really thinking. Was he frustrated, or was he just didn't care. Hard to tell with him sometimes. He didn't even look at me once coming here. My mood turned even sour after all that David did.

Reinhart understood immediately what to do next. He talks to a person beside him. After confirming something with him he turns to Kafar, we have a proposition of sorts. Kafar straightened up body hearing a possibility of a way out. Reinhart continuous, as I understand there is some kind of understanding between David and Charles on fighting a month later. I don't know the whole details. Regardless, we can call the tournament officially over with David's victory.

Kafar looked like he wanted to rebuke something, but he kept his composure. The person beside Reinhart spoke now, we can then call the match next month a extended match. We can spin this into a two-part event. Since we didn't a proper resolution and also suffered an accident, we tell people that a much more secure and grander second half of the event is waiting in line. Reinhart takes over, If done right this can actually pull in more interested people. The viewership on this match has been extremely effective. By creating such a twist we might have a bigger impact.

Honestly, I didn't care how they wanted to plan this. I actually wanted to leave, but it would be a little rude now that I have stayed here so long. At least I would stay until everyone agrees on something. Kafar spoke calmy, this could work. But should we really say mention David's the winner then. Shouldn't we wait until next month. That type of response was pretty much I expected from him. He is clearly trying to whatever he can to avoid tarnishing his champion name.

Reinhart says, no. Charles clearly gave the signal to give up. We can't just ignore him. It would create unnecessary confusion telling he didn't win. No matter how much we want to, this final match was already a like a bonus match with Charles as a wild card entry. Declaring David the winner of this one half of the bonus event a winner would be best thing to do here. Another admin spoke up, look. We can declare a technical win for David. This would actually make people also not satisfied. That will help in keeping the interest of people going until next month. He turns to Reinhart, we still need to have bigger discussion.

Reinhart replies, absolutely. Right now, I just need to confirm from Kafar and the participants. Do you guys agree to this. Kafar was quite, trying to analyze the situation with his myopic view. Charles didn't need to wait, I have no problem. If you want to keep the next match as part of the tournament, that's your call. He turns to Kafar, but the deal I made with David doesn't change. Kafar clicks his tongue, I get it already. He shook his head dismayed, fine. Yeah, I don't see a better option here.

Reinhart says, great. Moving on then. He turns to Blake standing beside. Can you see to it that David also agrees to it. Blake replies hesitantly, well, that's um. He trailed off. I got a little concerned wondering what's going on with David. Just then Marina chips in, David said he is okay with anything as long as Charles honors his part of the deal. Reinhart replies, that's all fine. I still like to know deal these two have in detail. But that’s later. A staff person gave a Kuretine speaker to Reinhart.

He turns it on and faces the crowd. Two other staff person come front. They had a camera on both their persons. Clear out some space people, one said. We are about to tell everyone in the stadium. People cleared out of the way. I walked a little further away from Ned. I still haven't forgotten that he and I aren't on the best of terms right now. Reinhart begins speaking, hi there everyone. His face got plastered on the stadium screen and his voice enclosed the entire stadium.

How crazy this match was people. That was probably the most thrilling, head scratching and without a doubt the most exciting event of this entire tournament. At that people all over cheered in huge roar. He continuous, I have never witness such as obscene display of strength and determination. Don't you all agree. The wild shouting the crowd answers that question. He laughs and continuous, but there is always a single winner. And after hearing from the people here, we have come to a conclusion.

The stadium quiets down in suspense. Reinhart gleefully shouts, with Charles surrender, the winner is David. The crowd goes wild with frenzy. People are shouting and jumping across the entire stadium. Their enthusiasm is to be expected. Everyone here knew that there was more, so no one were actually enjoying. Reinhart speaks along, unfortunately, David had to deal with his injuries. We will soon get him in front of a camera as soon as possible. He then clears this throat, but there is actually another announcement we want everyone to know right now.

This tournament is not yet over guys. He pauses a while to give people to digest that new twist. He continuous, in a completely unscripted and surprising development, there is another match going to happen people. This was just one half of this final tournament match. He pauses once again before speaking. David won this, and yet Charles has a chance to take back the title of winner. What you all are about to witness next is even bigger and crazier. Charles surrendered this one because he wants to save his strength for next battle with David.

He is cleverly creating suspense and anticipation from the people. I didn't know what all things Blake told the admins, but they must enough to hyping the crowd this much. He continuous, and Charles did that because, he trails off a little, get ready for this everyone. Our Heraknus alpha wants to fight with his overdrive. How insane that is. The shocked people so much that a short while people stopped speaking. And then suddenly, the entire stadium burst into a hysteria.

You heard it right people. Charles has to save his Kuret to show us his full power. This created another round of buzz among the people. He laughs, I assure you, the second half is surely going to be even grandiose. He pauses, we will tell you everything in detail later once we go over few logistics. We will also answer all the questions people have in couple of days. So keep a lookout for our messages. He takes a step back and continuous, and with that I congratulate David for this stunning and unprecedent winning. He has shown something mysterious. But don't forgot Charles is coming for you with something even powerful. He is aiming to take that win away from you. He closes off by saying, and thanks everyone coming today. It was a truly great experience seeing so many people here. See you all next time.

People shouting reaches its peak with this. Reinhart pulls away his mike and hands to another admin. He speaks, all right everyone. Please wait for your designated officer at the exit. Officers, we will let you know the further

details later. For now, please guide people back to your assigned hideouts. Thanks you again. I see the security taking lead and guiding people towards the exit.

Finally, the tumultuous came to a close. People on the stadium might be enjoying this, but the atmosphere here was less joyous. The admins didn't know the whole thing with David. But none of us had forgotten. Kafar and Charles took their leave with few admins and went inside the building. Rinhart was speaking with rest of the staff people, giving them orders. I wasn't interested so drifted away from others, walking back. But then the VIP room people gathered around. Tessa asks, Marina what happened to David. Blake was vague about his condition.

I figured I at least listen this. I was mad at David, but I was also concerned when Blake talked about David. Marina looks over to Blake. They both shared a silent agreements of sorts. She tells others, he is fine. We got him into his nanobot chamber. She raised her wrist to show the watch, M said he is resting now. She takes a sigh then, but that guy was actually more exhausted than he was showing. Turns out he close to passing while Blake carried him to the infirmary.

Nathan smirks, figures. It was visible he was in a terrible shape. But was that really it. Matt asks, yeah. I swear, I saw him shaking a little bit. Catherine says, yeah, what was that about. I have never seen him like that. Blake clarifies, all fatigue guys. Like Marina said, he was so drained out, I was practically carrying him. I wonder though. He was already acting very differently before Blake escorted him out. Nathan asks, and what about that confrontation I saw between David and Charles just before they agreed on the deal.

The three of us who saw him didn't utter a word. It was really difficult to say since no one clearly knows what is going with David. At one point people looked at me as well. I wasn't going to give any answer here. Derek helps out for us, he got just excited to know not even the former crown couldn't beat Charles. I guess you can say he became overzealous. Catherine asks, so much that he agreed to fight with his overdrive? What was he thinking. Derek shrugged his shoulders not knowing the reason.

I had enough of this. Others were going to continue get info from us. Blake and Derek would be enough to tell them. I stepped back deciding to leave finally. I thought about visiting David later, but then decided against it. That freaking dickhead is completely off his bonkers. Being angry him doesn't even begin how I feel. Such recklessness makes me wonder if he got dumber by hitting his head. Marina said he is resting, that’s good enough for now.

Behind me Ned sneaked up to me, you are leaving. I didn't turn, instead said, yeah. That’s right. I don't have anything particular to say, nor do I need to know. I want to be alone right now for a bit. Ned didn't stop me. Instead he kept following me. Didn't he get what I am getting at. I said out flatly, that means you too. I don't want to talk to you also. So leave me. Ned didn't listen to me. I got irritated when he kept following me back in the corridor of the building.

I shout annoyed, I told you to leave me alone. Ned replies, we should talk. I understand you are upset with me, but I want to talk about… I cut him off. I don't freaking care. I am going back home. I don't have anything to say to you right now. So just leave me alone. My anger was spilling into my voice. Even Ned heard it and finally stopped following me. I was finally by myself, except of the usual staffs around me, I was able to get some alone time.

I have so many things to figure out. I don't know even if talking to David would help. Would he give me straight answers or not. I was left wondering what should I do now.

Blake (Chapter 40)

Sunday, September 7, 2025 22:38

Marina and I are staring at M's hologram screen. It shows David's heartrate slowing down. After two minutes she says, boss's vitals are under normal now. He just entered into REM sleep. Scanning for all the internal and external injuries. Programming the nanobots for epidermal reconstruction. I saw a red ooze flowing into the water. That's the nanobots I heard from David about. I had never seen them, only heard from him. The red bots begins to cover all the places where he is bleeding and bruised. Marina says, so its all good now, right.

I make a quick look all over the submerged water. Then turn my eyes to display screen hooked up to that tank. It showed a wired framework of Davids body. It was showing the nanobots seeping on the skin on his injuries. I couldn't begin to understand all the other details shown here. I say, I guess yes. So far I don't hear any alarm ringing. Marina tells me, you know this is the first time I have seen this in action. I have asked him so many times to check it out. And he just brushed me off.

I smirked hearing that, same here. The guy keeps too many things under wraps. I get that its his job and all. But at least he could trust us more. Marina scoffs, that's absolutely true. She turns to her wrist, and what was that about his PTSD. Care to share now? I too wanted to know and got closer to Marina. M speaks out, boss has been having sessions with Dr. Drew every other week. He has been diagnosed with PTSD, and other issues related to identity crisis, nightmare scares and mental health.

Holy shit. I can't believe what I am hearing. Marina curses a little asking, that's bullshit. Everyone was vetted for their physical and phycological state before they entered the tournament. I add on, that's right. PTSD is one of the thing we definitely check. M responds, boss had improved considerably and was believed that he cleared for it. Other symptoms were carefully masked to avoid detection. I reply, you mean he lied. M responds, its not a lie if one doesn't check for those symptoms.

This is ridiculous. I can't believe he has been participating despite with such a mental state. Marina overwhelmed asks, I don't believe this. Did you know about. I rebuked her, hell no. If I had, I would have asked him to drop out. I take a step back and put my palm on my forehead. I immediately recalled something that I had found odd. I ask Marina who was still a little shocked by this, do you remember he was reluctant in the beginning to join the tournament.

Marina thinks for a moment, yeah. Now that you mention, he said he won't do it. But then something changed and he join in the last week. I corrected her, actually he said that he can't, not won't. I think that was because of this. Marina asks, but then what changed. She turns to M, why did he join the tournament when he was clearly sick. M replies, boss initially didn't plan to join. However after a session with Dr. Drew, he decided to do it. I ask confused, I don't understand. Did the doctor told him to do it. M replies, I don't have their conversation recorded. Boss didn't want my decisions be effected by Dr. Drew's evaluations. I only the bare minimum. A therapy protocol was put in place that manages his symptoms.

I ask, explain how. M responds, using the bots in his body, I continuously monitor for early signs of PTSD or nightmare scares. Based on the situation, I implement a series of controlled medicines to help curb the symptoms. This very protocol was developed by the inputs from Dr. Drew to keep boss functional. Marina spats out, functional. Jeez. Seriously, didn't you just say he has been doing better. How bad was it before. M elaborates, boss has been in therapy ever since the war with the Hive leader.

Wait, hold on, I waived my hand, you are telling me he has been in therapy for a year. Marina shouts, how the hell no one knew. M responds, 10 months to be exact. And since boss was vital to the Island's infrastructure, he deemed it necessary to not have any weakness be exploited. I got a little angry at that, how is that a weakness. So many people in the Island have gotten psychological help. Sure, it would not be a good look for him. But how doesn't that make a threat for him. M responds, the issue is not that people finding about his diagnosis. The problem is how he is getting treated.

Marina shook her head, I don't understand. How is that a problem. M responds, for boss to get the best help, he had to divulge some sensitive information about his past. He has me running an ancillary protocol to monitor Dr. Drews activities to make sure they don't get leaked. Both of us were silent for a while trying to process this. I looked over to Marina. Once our eyes met, we had the same realization. David had to reveal some of his past, that includes his role in Shadow.

I was stunned. David had to become vulnerable to treat his illness. I finally understood why he kept it a secrete for so long. Marina had the same thought, so that means he told his doctor things. Secret things. M tells, correct. Keeping them a secret meant that boss had to keep his issues a secret as well. I let out a sigh, well. I wasn't expecting this. But I do understand. Marina clicks her tongue, I guess. Why not tell us about it. We would have kept it a secret. Did he thought we would just go gossiping about it.

I tell her, I agree. He put himself in risky situations despite knowing he could have a panic attack. M responds, actually boss hasn't had a panic attack for 4 months. Ever since he joined the tournament. I was flabbergasted to hear this. So he really was better then. Then what actually triggered him to relapse. I ask M, so then what happened. Why did he have one now. Is it related to Wagner. M responded, information restricted at current authority. I shook my head mumbling, I should have expected that. Marina instead screamed out, oh hell no. She shook her wrist in frustration.

M didn't respond. Marina got furious, I am not sure who I am mad at, this AI or the boss who doesn't share things with his friends. I understood her frustration. But I also know David. I tell her, you know how paranoid David is. It should not be a surprise he would keep something this personal from others. Marina wasn't calming down, but at least I think I made her realize this is how David does things. I ask M, what can you tell us. M responds, I don't have all the details. Marina spats out, even if you did, you wouldn't tell us. M responds, correct.

I gotta admire the M's consistency. She continuous, I can tell you that boss has had 18 sessions. All of them at Dr. Drews house, at 7 PM to 9 PM Wednesdays. The last one was 2 weeks before the deadline of joining the tournament trails. During those time, all the communications from and to the house are closed off. There are no records saved or new directives for me. Marina asks me, do you think this doctor can tell us more. I was actually thinking the same. I pulled out my phone and opened up the app that I have for accessing public information.

Marina leaned on the screen as I search for a Drew with the hospitals directory. That's odd. I went through it multiple times, but didn't find anyone with the name. Marina asks, hey. There is no one named Drew here. Don't tell me that name is an alias. M responds, no. Dr. Drew is her real name. I ask, but how do you explain this. I turned my phone to M that showed no results on my screen. A moment later M explains, Dr. Drew is not registered in the hospital directory. Both of us let out a confused, huh?

M explains, Dr. Drew is not a licensed therapist. At least not for Medrines. I realized what David did, he looked for a qualified human therapist. Since he is dealing with a psychological issue, best to reach out to someone who is a Medrone with experience with human brains. Marina scoffs, wow. That's, well, genius. I agreed with her. So I searched her for in the public records. Few seconds later I found the doctor. I read aloud, Drew Hains. A husband and two kids. Lives in 5th section. Has a background in psychology. Had a long career of neurosurgeon back in Medrine. Currently working as, what. I got surprised.

Marina asks, what. I clear my throat, she's a farmer now. Grows earth fruits that can mix with Kuret. She also works as part time nutritionist for some of the officers. She asks, really. Odd. Why isn't she working in the hospital now. With her skills, she would be more suited there. I scroll down to get more details, oh. I see. It says here the nerves on her joints were effected upon entering earth. She is only 45, but needs to walk with a cane now. So she can't operate on people. Marina replies, that will do it.

I scroll past reading some more her details, David got lucky. A professional therapist with knowledge of both Human and Medrone psychology. Plus she isn't working on a medical capacity, no one would suspect she is helping him. Marina replies, well, you said it your self. David does things very thoroughly. She then faces me, should we contact her then. I wondered if that was the correct thing to do. Marina picked up on my hesitance. She replies, look David allowed M to tell about this. He had to know for sure we would reach out to her. In fact, I bet he wants us to do that exactly. Otherwise why give us that information. He could have just easily kept it hidden.

She did have a point. We need her help. Actually David needs her help. He clearly hasn't gotten over his issues. I said, you are right. We can't do nothing here. David has to fight Charles in a month. We got 30 days to get him better. I would have liked him to drop this match entirely, but. Marina chips in, after hearing David I don't think he is going to back down. I know. We both knew there is no stopping this. Marina turns and looks to the wall on the other side, we should head back now. Need to bring down the barrier. M's hologram went back into the watch hearing her job is done.

Yeah, I said. We both took a once over to David's tank and walked out. We hurried back outside. Once out, all the admins were already on the ground. Reinhart came up to me asking, finally. What happened, is David okay. All the admin leaned on to the two of us. Marina told she would start working on taking down the barrier. I began telling others what happened between Charles and David. I also brought up that David fine, but right now in no condition to move. I kept a lid on many things when I told him the situation.

I knew it wouldn't be good idea to tell them everything now. I didn't tell any info about Charles history or the details of the deal he made with David. Nor that I had carry him out after having a panic attach. I only told him they plan to fight next month with Charles with this overdrive. When I revealed this, everyone got anxious. Anyone would be to know that there is another overdrive user. Reinhart asks me, I can't believe it. We have ourselves a 3rd overdrive user now. And David plans to battle him. Why.

I replied, they made a deal. I could tell, but its better if comes from Charles and Kafar himself. I knew that right now its better not to influence their decision with other details. I need them to conclude this match with David as the winner. Reinhart nods, I see. All right, I will talk to them later. Another admin asks me, so that means its true that Charles surrendered to save his strength then. I think others here told the admins parts of the conversation they heard before I came here.

I reply, yeah. That's right. The admin begin to speak amongst them to sort this development. Some kept asking me for more details, but I was not going to. I told them they should ask Kafar and Charles about that. It was good that Charles was the one who had brought up this deal, it meant they will be ones responsible for handling this chaos. Kafar was the one who kept Charles hidden and made him compete directly on the final match. I am more than happy to let him manage this.

After a rounds of back and forth discussion, Marrina brought the barrier. Once Charles and Kafar emerged from inside, they were bombarded with questions by Reinhart. Kafar still stubborn, kept trying to not declare David winner. But that's not going to happen. Charles had visibly signaled his surrender. No coming from that. Begrudgingly, he caved. When Reinhart asked me about David agreeing to how they plan to handle this, I didn't see any issue. But I couldn't tell if David would have been okay. Its not like he told us anything before passing out. Marina lied about David hoping he would understand. Lets hope so. Reinhart made the announcement and declared David the winner. He is good. He made it look David won, but only in this half event.

Charles didn't stick around long. As he walked away, he gave me look that made me curious. What that meant. Kafar and the admins were next go back inside the building. Other stick around pocking info from me and Marina. I thought I keep it vague, but Marina pretty much told the truth. Well, half truth about him passing out anyways. I was sure others were not fully convinced. But they didn't have any suspicion about his mental state. Tessa asks me, why didn't you tell about the deal between Charles and David.

I told her, that would create a lot of confusion. Especially among the Heraknus house. It would be better if it comes from their alpha's mouth directly. Tessa makes an understanding expression. I continue, plus I don't want to take chance of breaking Citradels trust in their secret champion. All they know that someone has been protecting them. Now that its revealed who it is, a mythical bloodline, they might only listen to them. If Charles comes through with his end of the deal to moving his house here, whether David wins or losses, we would have accomplished our objective.

Nathan says, that was a good call. We don’t know how Heraknus works, from what I heard, Charles word is final. Matt asks, what if others still don't follow them here. That isn't part of the deal right. I reply, yeah. Honestly, we will deal with when we get there. Right now we have to first wait for Charles decision. Cass asks, so suppose they do agree. When do you think they will come here. Derek cuts in, there are only 74 Heraknus. Not all are fighters, but each one is powerful. With such a small crowd, I think they can be easily transported here in secret in 2 days.

Marina says, yeah, but don't they have to pack up all their stuff. That would take time right. Citradel has built with many things catered to particular houses. I would know, since I was the who designed their place. Even if Charles manages to convince others, they won't be ready to move for a while. She pauses a while, best guess, they need about 3 weeks for complete transport. Matt asks, really. They have a lot of stuff. Derek nods, yeah. Unlike you all, we didn't had to move around at all. Heraknus have been given more amenities than others. Most of them can be re-created here, but they have their own armory and weapons. Some even I haven't seen. So yeah, it would take 3 weeks for them.

Catherine asks, I understand all that. But aren't you all forgetting one important thing. David needs to fight a overdrive Heraknus alpha. Charles is already powerful. Overdrive puts him ten times stronger. Whether its for one or ten minutes, that itself is dangerous. I would understand if were Blake or Marina against him. But David can die. All of us were aware of this. Its just all of us were trying not to say it aloud. The odds are not in Davids favor. Derek says, don't be so sure. During the second half, David was back in his feet and actually outsmarting Charles at every turn. With his new anti Kuret abilities, and on top of that that mysterious use of multiple kuret, he also became stronger.

Nathan shrugs, sure. If he gets the time to use it. Didn't you see that it takes him too long to create that kuret storm. Same with that Kuret armor. Charles knows about it now, no way in hell he will give David the chance to use it. I agreed with him, yeah. David had gotten lucky many times. I am not saying that it was only luck that got him the win, but he is not ready to use them in an actual battle. If he was in a war with Echo, he couldn't do any of this. Marina says, then he will just have to level up in the next 30 days.

What she said was the truth, but it was also very difficult. She knows David also has a serious mental issue. Recovering and training in just one month seems very unrealistic. Nathan says, well. That depends entirely on David. He faces me, when can we meet him. There are many things I want to ask him. And looks like others are also eager to know. Everyone waited for me. I thought about for a moment before replying, like Marina said, he passed out. And he will be unconscious for a while. He doesn’t have many injuries, but.

Nathan raises his arm, say no more. I am very well aware how long he takes to recuperate. He snickers, for a guy to be so powerful to go toe to toe against alphas, omegas, and terra, he spends a lot of time in hospital beds. I guess I will have to wait for him to wake up then. Shall we go, he asks Jess who takes his hands and began walking inside. Before he leaves Matt asks, hey. Hold on. You didn't forget about the bet right. You all lost. He points to all the people who had bet Charles winning. I honestly I had forgotten about it. With all the stuff going, only Matt would still care about it.

Nathan stops and just twists his neck with a smile, I didn't forget. The bet is still ongoing. Matt replied what in disbelieve. Didn't you hear, this is was just fist half event. David's a technical winner. He still has to beat Charles in the next event. With that technical loophole he and Jess walks away. Matt looks around us, he can't do that. Right guys. Cass says, well. He isn't wrong you know. He fists his hand, oh come on. I said, whatever. We can wait until then. Also, I like to tell you all one thing. Don't wait up for David. I don't want us to be hovering around his room outside. Marina will let us know when he wakes up. Until then, lets just do our jobs.

Marina raises her wrist to others to show M. Tessa says, I don't see a problem. I explain further, you can visit him anytime. That shouldn't be a problem. But don't stuck around for long. We don't want to create unnecessary worry to others. Especially to Kafar's people. I don't want them to get an impression that him not healing fast can become issue. He can use it to force Charles to back down or something that risks the Heraknus coming over. It’s a delicate situation right now.

Derek says, I hope you don't include Marina and me in those people. We actually want to move here. But you are right. That's a right decision. I actually also wanted to check on him now, but I suppose that can wait. He turns to Marina, let me know he is wakes up. Marina shows a thumbs up, you got it. He nod, okay. I think I should head back and help out Charles. Kafar and admins must be on him all over. I should help smooth things over. See you guys later. He waves us off and leave us next.

That prompts others to also leave. Tessa, Matt and Cass went together saying they are going to get lunch. Marina said she was going back home to rest up. She tells us that all the Kuret use exhausted her and will be skipping lunch. She gave a quick glance at me and then waves to her phone to me. I understood. She was going to reach out to Dr. Drew. I will check with her about it later tonight. Only Catherine was left here now. Wait, I didn't even realize that Vanessa was not here. When did she leave. Catherine saw me looking around, if you are looking for Vanessa, she left us after that announcement. I saw her leaving. Ned followed her also inside.

Hmm, those two were not on good terms right now. But no way am I going to ask them. I turn to Catherine. If I recall, she also has something going on with David. Since we were alone, I thought it was the best time to ask, hey. If you have time, I wanted to talk with you. But only if you are not busy. She took a while before responding, actually I have to go meet with some people at the logistics. I need to discuss about what to do with all the Citradels people staying in the Island. We were supposed to have a banquet for the winner tonight, but I don't think that’s going to happen. So I want to get ahead of this by making a plan to send them back to Citradel in case we cancel the event.

I reply, you know you don't need to do it right. Let the admins figure it out. She shook her head, no. I know many people from Citradel from back I used to spy on them. They have never found about me, so I can handle them much better then Reinhart or anyone else. You know very well that’s why I was given this role. I am the best choice. I understood that much better than anyone. I had assumed she was acting differently due to stress or something to with her job. But it doesn't look like that’s the case. So it really was just David. I replied, okay. I suppose later then.

She responds, I don't know how long I will be busy today, but I can spare some time tonight. Provided the banquet is cancelled. I replied, sounds good. She asks, what will you do now. You didn't go for lunch with others, so you also have some place to go. I nodded, yeah. I gotta also get ahead of this new development and tell our officers we might be getting Heraknus people over to our Island. Which means I have to set aside some land in the island for buildings and whatever else they want. I will wait for Derek to come out from his meeting with admins. If he can tell me more about Heraknus house, I can get the ball rolling. Unless you have any other insights to share about them.

She shook her head, sorry. I got nothing. Its embarrassing, but like I told before, I couldn't find anything about the secret warriors of Citradel. Kafar ran things so quietly and securely, I couldn't infiltrate deep parts of the city. He had rules and contingencies so tough, I would have gotten exposed if I tried. I said, its fine. I was just curious. Catch you latter then. She said bye and went away to the HQ.

Next few days will be busy. Especially for me. I contemplate on our future depending on upcoming days as I walk to the admin towers.

Blake (Chapter 41)

Tuesday, September 9, 2025 17:55

The day went very fast and very busy. I couldn't reach Kafar or the admins. They spent all morning inside the building. This is taking way longer than I imagined. I waited for 3 hours for them to come out. I tried to squeeze in, but Kafar didn't let me. The guards from Citradel told they are in an important discussion and I will be let in only when they want to. I could have forced myself in. But that would only slow things down. I was at least told by one of the admin that they plan to have an press release and broadcasted over the secured network everywhere. So instead I went to the dining building for a late lunch. By that time, almost everyone had left and only a skeleton crew were present.

Seeing me alone eating here, people kept asking what's happening. My answer was always the same. Wait for the admins to have an announcement. One of the dining staff told me they got an huge lunch delivery for the admin building. I realized that they will not be free anytime soon. No point in waiting for them after lunch. In the middle of my lunch, I got call from Marina. Hey, you busy. She was a little annoyed. I replied, just having late lunch. I was hopping to meet Derek, but he is tied up pretty hard. They have basically locked themselves inside. Not allowing anyone from Island. Not even me.

She scoffs, figures. You want me to check it out. I can bug the place. They will never know. To be honest, I was tempted. But I replied, thanks. But leave them be for now. I heard they will hold a press release tonight. So we can wait till then. If they still don't plan to share any information by 9 PM, then I am game.

As shadow operatives, getting intel is key for any situation. Marina replies, hmm. Okay. I took a sip of water and asked, any progress on David. Marina replies, no. He is still unconscious. I just checked 30 minutes back with M, he is recovering without any issues. All though, M mentioned dozens of people have visited him. I asked, anyone we should be worried about. Marina takes a pause, ah, doesn't look like. People from our inner circle, couple of officers from Citradel and some participants. M is monitoring the whole building just in case.

I will have to go over those list of people later. I took a quick glance around me to check no one was listening in and whispered, ask M when we can move David from the infirmary. After a while Marina realized what I was getting at, you think someone will sabotage him. Like how we were? I replied, potentially, yeah. If the match was over, we wouldn't need to worry. But its not. Someone drugged you and tried to drug me. All to influence the outcome of the matches to Citradel.

Marina hesitantly says, and they would have gotten away with it if not for David. Yeah, he needs to be secured. All the admins are only a mile away from the stadium building. Including Citradel people. Someone from Citradel can easily approach him while he is incapacitated. I reply, exactly. I didn't bring this up earlier because our priority was David's injuries and dealing with the matches outcome. Now, they both things are being handled, I think its better to turn our attention to Davids security.

Marina replies, I too didn't want to deal with that until now. I will ask M now if David can be moved. Hold on. Meanwhile I finish my lunch taking the last bite. It took a minute for Marina to unmute, good news. M says he can be moved. That device of his has treated David enough to be ready for transport. Although we should wait until night to move him. Its just in 3 and half hours from now. Dragging him in broad daylight would be risky. I on the other hand didn't want to wait, nah. I want to move him now. It might not be ideal, but waiting that long will be that much be riskier.

Marina asks, ah. Between the two of us, we can move him fast. But not undetectable. The security guards outside will surely know we took David out. Even if we sneak him out, they will know he is missing. I reply, leave that me. Catherine texted me a while ago, tonight's banquet is officially cancelled. So we can't have those guards anymore. I can tell them to help out with Citradel civilians staying in the guest buildings. Catherine needs the help anyways.

Marina replies, okay. Where should we move him then. Into one of homes among our shadow safehouses. I reply, no. If it were someone else than David, that would work. We want a place that is not Islands blueprints. Besides, none of those houses in the Island has the essential things David may need. She then asks, how about his place? I scoff at that, nope. If someone comes after him, that's the first place they would look for. Besides, his place doesn't have sufficient security. I heard Marina smirking a little, I didn't mean his decoy place. I jerked a little sitting on my chair. What. I shrieked. Marina chuckles a little, look. Do you really think he stays in that abysmal place.

This is news to me, how do you know about his actual place then? She replies, I am the best architect he knows. I gave him the designs with all his requests. I am sure he would have added his own personal changes and beefed up the security. And we wouldn't have to worry about security, because no one knows about it. I shook my head a little, why am I hearing about this just now. I swear I could hear Marina's smiling, you know how it is. All of us has their own shared secrets. Like how we both share some secrets, I am sure you share with David too.

I sighed a little. She wasn't wrong. I reply, that’s how we operate, true. But I doubt we have anything secret from David. It wouldn't be a surprise if he knew about. Marina cuts me off and shushes me, not over the phone dummy. M is totally listening. And come on, we can keep a secret, even from David. Don't crush my hope. I wasn't buying it though. Marina and I have been covertly pulling it off during the tournament, but David must have sniffed it out somehow.

I say, anyways, his place is the best option for now. Obviously we have to make sure no one follows us. Where is it and how far from the stadium. At that question Marina felt silent. What happened now. You there, I ask again. She replies, the problem is I don't know where it is now. I snicker, how is that possible. Didn't you say you designed his house. I bet that would mean knowing the topology of the area, coverage, everything. Marina sighs, I know. Actually, when I said his house is on the island, I wasn't being accurate. His place is on the edge of the Island, almost standing on the side like those Human houses in Florida.

I don't understand, I replied. If you know where it is, then why don't you know. She hesitated a little and then explains, well. For a paranoid guy like David, he built his house in such a way that it can't be detected and also be the first to know any threats from the sea. Only one option works. When designing his house, he wanted to be a fortress that can submerge into water, travel inside the sea and relocate itself. I let out a audible scoff from my mouth hearing this. Are you serious, he lives in a submarine?

Marina laughs, no. Its actually a two floor house, 5 rooms, 2 bathrooms, a kitchen, a dining area, hall, gym, open yard and training room. I hope she was joking. But she wasn't done, oh yeah a swimming pool also. I pull up my handing jaw, freaking David. How the hell did he build it? Actually when did he even built it. Marina replies, I have only visited once, after it was finished almost a 5 months from now. As to how he built it, he was vague about it. So I can only assume he used his criminal contacts. I have been itching to visit again and marvel at by beauty. But never got a chance, until now.

I was amazed that David had kept his actual home a secret this long. I had a million more questions, but tabling that for now. I ask, if you don't know where it was, then does M know. Marina pulls out from the call and I hear her muffled question to M. After few seconds she came back on, freaking AI. She won't tell us. I gripped my fist a little frustrated, how the hell are we going to find it. And even if do find it, I doubt we will be just enter without David's authorization.

Marina takes few seconds and says, I have idea. I know of a way we can find the location and allow us to enter. I asked in disbelief, and how will you pull that off. She replies, just trust me. Its better you don't know. You can ask David later, if he wants to. It was a little annoying not being in the know. Then I realize me and David have also kept few things from Marina. Ever since David got his memories, we have started to do things like how we used to back in Medrine. Getting back into all this secrecy and still being friends is a hard balance to keep now.

I relented, how long will that take. Marina replies, I need about an hour. I will text you the location once I get it. I cut in, no message. Lets not keep any digital trail of his location. Even if its only temporary. Instead lets meet back at infirmary in 90 minutes. I will figure out the rest by then. Marina says, got it. See you later. I was about to close the call, but then she spoke again, oh wait. One more thing. I need you to visit the doctors house. I asked curious, what happened.

She explains, after getting some rest I messaged her asking we need her help with a mutual friend. She didn't reply to any of my messages. So I directly went to her house, but she claims to know nothing. I tried to let her know that its was fine since David let us know, but she acted like she didn't have any contact with any of my friends. She said she doesn't trust me. Can you believe it. Me. I get I from Citradel, but come on. I have fought with you all many times now. How can she just close the door saying she can't help me. That explains why she was annoyed in the beginning.

I said, don't take it personally. She is not licensed therapist, she doesn't want to get into trouble. David must have told her not to say anything to anyone. Did you show M to her. Marina replies, I did. She said M only said her name, nothing in detail. Basically accused me of fabricating the whole thing. I chuckle, figures. A patient who loves secrets needs someone who has same inclinations. Let it to me, after we drop off David, I will visit her. She might be more open to me. Marina says, let her know she can trust me too. Before I can speak a word, she closed the call with the same annoyed tone.

I can imagine why she wanted to accepted. With Heraknus relocation, some Citradel people are guaranteed to move here as well. Among their top people, her, Derek, June and the alpha twins must have plans already. We already have plans to make the transitions smoother and less disruptive. But nothings perfect, we will have problems like this from now one. From both side of the cities.

After cleaning up, I head to my officers building. Everyone here is busy with todays work. I heard people talking over the phones discussing about the tournament. Just as I took the stairs on the 3rd flood, Luther approaches me from behind. Hey Blake, where have all this time. He was in a tiff and was carrying an iPad with him. I told him about my successful attempt to meet Derek. Luther's expression hardens up, whoa. Not even you could get in. I asked, yeah. I didn't want to force myself. Not yet anyways. So I believe no has any contact with them as well.

He nods. I reach my office and stepped in. He says, its been such a chaos. I took my chair and pulled to the table, yeah. It certainly is. He continuous, if you were there all this time, then you heard they are going to announce their decision tonight. I open my laptop and it pinged with too many times. I turned my notification off to avoid hearing the dizzying number of messages. Ah, I can't deal with them right now. I turn down he lid immediately. I face him, yeah. I heard. I don't suppose anyone found out more.

Luther takes a seat and opens his iPad screen, actually we got another piece of information after lunch. Color me surprised, what is it. He replies, they will be calling some of the Heraknus people in the admin building. I don't know when. But soon. I lean back to the chair thinking it over. He asks, but you don't look surprised. Of course I knew why they called him. Charles deal with David works only if he can convince them to move here even before the next match. I tell him, I know why. But I don't rummers to spread.

Luther was a little tense. I wanted to ease him a little bit, don't worry though. It's not problem. They are being called for just a discussion. Luther replies, its not that. Its just. He hesitates a little, I can't believe Heraknus are real. I thought they were just myths. They weren't just hiding on Medrine, but on Earth too. And if David wins, they will be living here. Its just, um, overwhelming. He wasn't the only one. Many people approached me since I left the stadium. They all have varying emotions. Some fear, some worship. I bet there are some people who might not even care that much.

I assured him, I am sure everyone is anxious to say the least. But once everyone meets them, it will lessen their worries. Look on the positive side, we will be that much powerful against Echo and Humans. I didn't want to stress him by telling Heraknus are moving immediately. Luther wasn't satisfied, but he didn't pursue it more. He asks, how is David though. You carried him out. Is he okay. I replied almost mechanically given how many times I have been asked, he is fine. Contrary to his composure, he was about to pass out. He should wake up soon. This has been my response to everyone. And so far no one has questioned it considering who he fought for so long.

I continue, since you are here, I want you to pull the stadium security out from their duties. The tournament is over. No matter what decision we get from admins tonight. Luther questions, why. Shouldn't we keep him secure. Especially since there are attempts of sabotage earlier. I reasoned, we don't want to show weakness right now. The longer he remains there, the admins might start to think he suffered too much injuries. What if somehow they decide not to have the next match. We need to achieve our main objective, getting every Medrone move to this Island. I don't know who will win, but we shouldn't give any reason for them to not have the match.

Luther leans back pondering over his thoughts. I waited for him to realize the importance. He finally spoke, it would be bad if they cancel the match all together. And you are right. Keeping David tied to infirmary wouldn't look good on him. I continue, so you understand. Convince everyone who is managing the staffs to redirect people to Citradel guest housing, at least for tonight. He nods and taps the screen, I will talk to them soon. What about David, I talked to someone who visited him. He isn't even awake. Are you planning to wake him up or move the entire tank. I answered, don't worry about that. I got it covered. Just tell everyone he no longer needs security around 4 PM. No need to mention about his condition. Let people believe he woke up and left.

Luther was clearly confused. I didn't want to give him or anyone hints where we are planning to move him. He might have deduced a little that I had a secret plan. So he offered, do you need any help. I shook my head, I already have it. Thanks anyways. He probably thinks that I was going to use some shadow trick. It won't be that complicated. He says, okay. Lets talk about information control. We are getting swamped with calls and people straight up showing here using their kuret and demanding to know what's happening. The overall concern is whether Citradel going to move here or not, you know since David still won.

I knew I would have to deal with this now, what options do we have. He explains, we can say we don't know. No risk, but vague as hell. We say talk to Citradel because their so called champion surrendered. Not vague, but shows less confidence. We can tell the truth that we are waiting for tonight's announcement from the admins. Completely true, but can't explain why they didn't tell people themselves. If we had more details on what happened at the end of the match, we could it handle much better.

I replied, trust me. If I explain what really happened and then later something else is claimed by the admins, it will just create chaos. That’s why I haven't told anyone and waiting to see what they say. I thought about the best course of action. I don't want people to spread rumors based off little pieces of information. But not telling anything is also not an option. I told Marina we would wait till 9 PM. Thats still 6 hours away. Too long to wait without telling people anything.

I wanted to know one thing before we come up with a plan, tell me something. What are the Citradel people who are not in the admin building doing right now. He thinks for a bit and answers, most of them are back in their assigned guest houses. The remaining are roaming around with Island people, probably checking out the place. He then looks back to the hall, a handful of them are here. They are cooperating with us and helping out with some logistics. But if are thinking to ask them, its not going to work. They don't know anything.

I waived my hand, no off course not. I wanted to know if there are more Citradel people out in the streets. I got up from my chair and paced around thinking over it. I really didn't want to reveal any new information to the public. We could tell people there is some sort of deal between David and Charles. But that’s clearly the wrong move here. That would just spark more rumors. Then I had an idea that seems pretty obvious, but still effective. I turned to him, I may have a solution.

He listened in to my explanation and then just remained silent. I wanted his opinion on this plan. After a while he says, that is certainly a way. People don't want to just hear from us, they want to know the truth. If we do this just right, it will help us do actual work and at the same time pressure the admins to hurry up their discussion. It certainly doesn't hurt that none of our representative is there with them. He smiles then, you know, it might actually work. At the very least people will back off from us and instead focus solely on Citradels and Admins.

Glad it made sense to him. This is a good diversion for us to move David out. If everyone's focus is somewhere else, then it will be much easier. With a precise timing, no will know about it. Luther got up from his chair, lets do it. He was enthusiastic about it now. I guess he was stressing it too much. I tell him, lets work out a plan with whoever is here right now. Lets also involve as many as Citradel people we can get.

Luther agreed with it, yeah. I will reach out those who are roaming out. If we can get the top fighters, that would help sell this. He must have made connections with some of them. I tell him, go on ahead. I will be right behind you in a minute. He hurries out to enact the plan. I took out my phone. No messages from Marina. So she isn't ready yet. It was 3:00 right now. Still have a hour till we move David. I decided it would be best to involve them right now. They can help out with the plan. I messaged them with their tasks.

Vanessa (Chapter 42)

Wednesday, September 10, 2025 17:49

When I wanted alone time, I was serious. But people didn't leave me alone. Some congratulated, and some asked it Citradel is going to move here. I am in no mood to explain anything. I kept telling them to talk to the admins for details. One lady asked if I heard what the deal was since I was with them. I got irritated and told her I was just there to help out. She was clearly surprised me reacting like this, but I didn't care. I thought of going back home. But then the neighbors might see me and might bothering me. I wanted a nice quite place.

The only place I could think of was my office. No one would be there right now. At least not for few hours. So I took a trolly ride to the center of the Island. Even in the trolly, some people asked for details. A guy asked me what was David's condition. I didn't answer. Hearing his name was triggering me a lot right now. I didn't want to think about that selfish bastard. Somehow I managed to arrive without loosing it. The door wasn't open, good. No one is here. I scanned my wrist at the door and head to the 2nd floor.

Its eerie to see empty rooms. Its always so busy. I got to my room, locked the door and slumped into my chair. Then finally I let out a loud shout. My fist tighten as I slam it on the table. My kuret leaked out a little and fire came out. It left scorched marks on the table where my fist struck. I am not done yet. I let out another shout filled with Kuret. A gust of wind circled around me and shuffled the stuffs in the room. I am breathing becomes ragged now. This is bad, I thought being alone I what I need right now. I am actually spiraling more. I don't want to leave.

A minute late I finally settle down. I let out air from my mouth to cool down. I pull back my kuret. I close my eyes and lean back. I felt better now. Everything that happened with Ned and David angered me so much. I can't believe I was holding it in this long. I really didn't want to think about them. But I couldn't stop. I spoke aloud, why the hell is Ned behaving like this. Ever since the two week flag capture game, he is active differently. Sometimes he only focuses on me, other times he acts like he doesn't want to do anything with me.

Maybe it's my fault. No, I chided myself. Its both our fault. I am so confused, I couldn't understand what exactly caused us this. I shouldn't have been so much bothered for him betting on Charles. That can't be then. I tried recalling any other bad memories, but I got nothing. None would sour our relationship this much. I got frustrated and kicked the side of the table. I can't believe I am like this. This is not me, I don't get stressed by a thing like a relationship issue. Of all the things I thought I couldn't handle, this wasn't one. Give me dozens of Echo any day to fight over this.

And there's David. Without realizing, I kicked the table legs again. Honestly, without any kuret, it should have stung. I hardly felt. I can't even think about his right now without getting angry. I pleaded him numerous times not to overdo it. But now he is risking his life for fighting alone such a enormous foe. Not only that, I he hiding something about Wagner. Huh. Thinking about him made me realize I still have things about Wagner I didn't know about. He fought Charles before and actually can overdrive. I can't believe he never told me this. We were closer than our parents, and yet he didn't tell me. Why.

I don't know how long I was fiddling around in here. Could have been 5 minutes, or maybe an hour. I heard knocks on my door. My eyes widen on hearing someone is here. I called out, whoever it is, leave me the freak alone. The voice on the other side said, its me Vanessa. It was Siera. What's she doing here. And how did she find me. I stagger a little trying to find an excuse, I am busy right now. Come later. She responds, no you are not. There is no one in the building, and I don't hear you listening to any messages.

I gritted my teeth, I am no mood to talk right now. Just leave me. I didn't want her to see me like this. I thought she would leave if I persisted. But she didn't, would it have to do anything with Ned. My body jerks out a little. When I didn't respond, she says, I got a call from Ned. He sounded worried and told me a little about your fight. I understand you want to be left alone. So I will leave, but not before knowing you are okay.

Dammit. Why did he go and do that. I didn't for a little while. I could just wait it out, but she would just stand there until someone comes in the building. I relented and got up to open the door. As expected she had a concerned look on her. I waved my hand to not come inside. I ask her, how did you find me. She replies, I went to our house. When I didn't see you there, I figured you would come here to be alone. I shook my head at my naivety thinking no would bother me here.

I say, well, now that you have seen that I am okay, you can leave. I hold the door. She slammed the door with her arm instead. I rebuked, what are you doing. She replies, I said I would leave if were okay. That meant mentally too you know. I got angry, I don't have time for this bullshit, okay. I am fine. I forced the door, but she pushed back. She wasn't backing down, that was the very definition of being NOT okay. Let me in and we can talk. I really didn't want to. But what's the alternative, shove her out. I finally caved in and let her in.

I didn't even bother to close the door as I went back to my chair. Siera closes the door and sats on the other side of my table. She just silently sat there. I knew she would be doing this. Every time she and I had a problem, she would just stare in silence until it becomes too awkward. Her interrogation is pretty much natural to me. So I also stayed silent. I just closed my eyes and lead back. A minute went by like this. The probably 5 minutes. I know she has patience, but I have learned from her. So we continue to be like this.

Then it was maybe 20 minutes at which I couldn't take anymore, okay. You win. Lets talk. I swear I could see a small smirk on her. I say, I just had a fight with Ned. She folds her arm and asks, I know its obvious to state, but this is probably the first time I have seen you having a guy problem. And not just any guy, your old crush and then boyfriend. I could feel she was having fun. I let out a sigh, believe me. This is first for me too. She nods, over the years, I have heard all sorts of arguments, how to best ambush Echos, or evade Humans. Even making right decisions in full wars. It was inevitable you would have problems over your boyfriend.

I didn't like how she was expecting this to happen. But to be frank, I was also anticipating it. How I would feel or handle our first big fight. Seeing I was not being open she asks first, so who did what. I answered, obviously its his fault. I blurted out immediately. Without a lack of details after few seconds of silence, she crooks her neck. I was really uncomfortable talking about it to my mother. I hesitantly said, he wasn't siding with me on something. Then treats me like I don't take his side. He also ignored me several times. I had a bunch of other feelings, but I could only manage this much for now.

Siera couldn't hide her surprise, really. I can't picture Ned doing something like this. It felt really good hearing someone else saying it. I reply, yeah, I can't believe it too. He really got a bug up his ass about something. She asks, okay, about what. I screamed, I really don't know. He has been acting little different ever since the capture flag game. Whenever I ask him, he says its nothing big deal. She unfolds her arms and rests her them on the table, that’s hard to believe. He is always so composed.

I know, I responded. I never knew I needed to voice out my insecurities out loud. Siera leans to me a little, shouldn't you confront him about this. It seems you have been wondering this for a while. Of course I wanted to. But then with all the stuff that happened during the match with David, I have been basically avoiding it. I really tell about David as well. His recklessness is eating at me. But I kept my mouth shut about him. It would complicate things with her right now. Siera sighs, avoiding will only make it worse. I know you know what I mean.

I reply, I do. Believe me, I don't want to be like this. Its just, hum, I had to deal with other stuff. It became harder for me to deal with Ned. But I will. I have to. Just not now. There wasn't any meaningful progress, but it felt good to say it out loud. She picked up on me easing a bit, take your time. But do it right. Ned is a good guy. And he is has been good to you. Lately you have been more open and happier. Just a year ago, we would never talk about such things. You are also making efforts to be more social. So give him a chance to explain before you do anything.

I was silent. I knew she meant well. I was a little embarrassed though. Sure, Ned has been good to me. But he wasn't the one who made me open. It was the other freaking guy I was mad at. David and I have become a lot closer since the war. I didn't want to read too much into it so I stopped myself. I tell her, I will. Ah, I am little bit okay now. I guess I just needed to be heard. She nods, trust me. That’s all someone needs. She leans away and relaxes. She continuous, glad I could help out. I replies, thanks.

She raises her hand, come on. I still worry about you know. No matter how powerful you become. I was genuinely glad Siera came first to talk to me, anyone else and I would have just resisted more. She got from her chair, now come on. Lets go for lunch. I am hungry. You must be too. I was. I replied, can we cook and eat something at home. I want to avoid dealing with others right now. I got up and walk with her. She says, whatever you need. We both left my office and headed out.

On the way out of the building she asks, lets walk then. It will take more time, you good with that. I nod, yes. I don't have any stuff after lunch. I do have a meeting later in the evening with Citradel security guys. We were supposed to discuss the banquets security with Derek and his crew. Siera says, didn't you hear, Kafar, Charles and Derek have been in the admins building and not allowing any of us inside. I think its safe to assume plans may have changed.

I didn't know that, I replied. I took out my phone and saw bunch of messages from people. I cleared them and searched for our secure channel network. I tell her, there was no mention of any change of plans yet. But it can change anytime I guess. We passed through people walking on the streets, but now that I was with Siera, none approached me directly. Then I suddenly realized something, how come you didn't ask me anything about the final match. Others have been up my ass.

She laughs, its obvious you don't want to talk about it. So I figures why ask. I was glad she was concerned but I was feeling a lot better now. I reply, only when its from others. I know you are dying to know somethings. Just ask. I scoff a little thinking she must be waiting for me to suggest it first. She glances at me and nods, well, since you asked. How was talking to Charles like. I heard stories about Heraknus, but I never thought they were real. I got way to excited and shoved others beside me.

I chuckle at that image, he seems nice. A normal guy when he isn't using his Kuret. Actually, he was so chill, he starting giving us some advice and answered our questions. Siera head turns suddenly, in the middle of a match. Damn. I would so like to meet the guy. Actually any Heraknus will do. I reply, don't except too much. After talking with him, I get a feeling we have made them a myth. They are ordinary people. Well, aside from the fact they remain hidden for centuries. In fact, they have lot of weaknesses you know. She shrieked, what. He told you his weakness.

I laugh her constant surprised looks, he didn't have a choice. David forced out his weaknesses out of him, using Ruby's kuret of all things. That was the point from which Charles began to pivot to that insane deal. Siera asks, yeah, speaking of which, how in the bloody hell can he use others Kuret. That move basically turned the whole match upside down. I wondered when she was going to ask that, I have no clue. He says he used Human and Medrone knowledge.

What does that mean, she asked. I shook my head, he used math and science to capture Kuret in his anti-Kuret. And then somehow use others Kuret. Don't ask me how because he didn't tell me. He was being careful because others were listening in. She was totally bamboozled, that’s unbelievable. So he can use any Kuret? That’s beyond what Marina could do. I corrected her, not every Kuret. Derek figured it out that David can't control those Kuret, he can only aim and shoot. That’s why he copied some specific kurets. And well some unknown ones.

Wow, she was now completely impressed. She says, no wonder he still wants to fight Charles with his overdrive. Even his kuret took a different form. I thought he was done becoming stronger, but he is nearly on an reaching for omega level. She takes a pause before saying, gosh. As one the few people who known him the longest, I can't believe the same guy who you knocked out by a single punch. He is now fighting omegas and

sigma.

I wish I shared her joy. She didn't know the whole story about the next match. I didn't want to tell her about it, because then we would have to talk about it. I want to avoid that as much as I want to avoid talking about Ned. We talked some more about the match, filling in some details, David and Blake trying to spy on Charles, our bet, the barrier braking and the loophole to save Charles. It was a long walk, but it was good breather. We reached our apartment around 1:30 PM.

Once we stepped inside, she asks me, now I understand what you meant you had deal with so many stuff. This morning was full of chunk full of excitement. I bet everyone watching from outside the Island must find it intriguing to say the least. Do you think that will be enough from them to move to Citradel or here. I shrug, we certainly hope so. I heard the views were more than expected, so at least that's good news. Just then I got a ping on my phone. I read the message aloud, admins are going to give an announcement tonight. Siera asks, that's all it says. I nod. She continuous, at least now we have something to look for now. She walks over to the kitchen, lets table that discussion for now. What are you in the mood for.

I was actually okay with anything. We had to decide on few options from our limited stalk of foods. By the time we were nearly done cooking, an hour went by. Around then I decided to see any new messages on my phone. I peaked on the screen from the counter. Siera asks, any update. I read the message and told her, you called it earlier. Catherine messaged. Tonight's banquet cancelled. She says, what now. You had a meeting with Derek right. That's still on then?

After reading another message from someone in the officers building I tell her, looks like that's also not happening. The admins are still in the building with the Citradel people. Including Derek. One of our people says that they even ordered lunch to their place instead of going out. Pretty sure that means its long to be a long day. She asks, then you free till tonight. I reply, not exactly. Catherine might need my help organizing security around the Citradel guest houses. We had plans for security of the banquet, but now its going to be early night guard shift for the entire night. I will meet up with her later.

With that update, I was at least free for couple of hours. We took our time leisurely eating lunch. We cleaning our dished when I got another message around 3 PM. I read it aloud, few people from Heraknus house are being summed to the admin building. Siera keeps the plate down and asks, huh. That's wired. Why are they being called in. She was expectedly confused. But I knew exactly why. She caught how calm I was about this news. You know something about it, don't you.

When I didn't answer, she got her answer. I understand, she says, its something you can't share right now. I replied, its not that I can't share. But its you. Just for today, promise to not share anything I am about tell you. She nods curiously, of course. I won't. I waved her to sit on the dining chairs knowing it will take some time. Just then I told her everything. All the details of the deal between David and Charles. The risks involved for David with Charles dangerous overdrive.

Siera was visibly shocked to hear this. After finally listening to entire story she scoffs, what the hell David was thinking taking on such dangerous gambit. Being locked in with a uncontrollable overdrive user. Did his new abilities made him arrogant. I clicked my tongue, that's exactly what happened. I told you what happened when the barrier broke, right. Ever since then he has become extremely single minded about winning. I have never seen such a look on him. He was being full of himself and not caring about risks. No matter how much I pleaded to see reason, he wouldn't listening. After a while, I gave up. Maybe I should have kept trying, but then something changed.

She waited for me to continue. I swallowed a little hard, David has some connection to Wagner. She shouts, what. How. I reply, I don't know. I didn't get a chance to ask him. But the second Kafar mentioned that even Wagner couldn't beat Charles, he flipped out. His attitude changed. It looked pale, like he saw a ghost. He immediately accepted the deal once he heard. Siera asked confused, hold on. Wagner fought Charles. He knew that Heraknus were real?

I added, And he lost, even with his own overdrive. Siera couldn't believe, just like I couldn't when I heard it. She asks, his overdrive. Your brother could do it too. I waved my hands in the air, yeah. Add to the list of things he never told me. She was lost of words. She was quietly thinking over it. A while later she spoke, look likes you avoiding to talk to Ned makes sense now. You wanted to time to think over so many things about David and Wagner. I held head on my palms, now you understand what I have been dealing with. Others weren't that much shocked about Wagner, and I don't blame them. But I am a mess. I keep thinking why didn't he tell me.

Siera offers, maybe he couldn't tell you those things. I rebuke, maybe about Heraknus. But why hide he could overdrive. Overdrive users are celebrities. What possible reason he could have that he never told anyone. Siera asks, I have no idea. Wish I knew. I straightened out, I'll tell you what, there is one guy who would know. Its David. If he was close enough to my brother to know about his fighting, he must know more. I'll will get it out of him.

I eased down a bit before I got any angrier. She twitches her mouth, perhaps. Though he is still unconscious for now. I asked, you saw him. She says, not exactly. The guards didn't allow me in. But I spoke to Cass and Matt who did on the way out. You didn't go. I looked away, I didn't want to. I heard he was not in any serious condition. That's enough for now. She says, so you mad at him as well. I rebuked, can you blame me. He kept all those things from me.

Seira didn't have anything to say to me. She just looks at me with pity. We both shared a heavy silence. I dumped a lot of things on her. I felt a little guilty and I finally say, I didn't mean to push all my mess to you. Siera waves, oh no. Don't worry about it Vanessa. You needed to talk to someone about this. She takes a moment to ask, who all knows about what's really happening on the Admins buildings. I told only the people from VIP room. She tells, so you don't want to tell anyone about this until tonight's announcement.

I nod, yeah. Blake must have not been able to meet Derek. And since he or anyone else haven't messaged anything about the deal, it must be to keep from creating confusion. She says, and that's the right decision. If Heraknus really decide to move, then I am sure all the Citradel will move. I got curious on how confident she was, you think so. We were skeptical about it. She chuckles, that's because you were sitting in a room and not outside. Until the half time, every Citradel were fanatic about Heraknus being their secret warriors protecting all this time.

I guess seeing peoples first hand reactions would change your view. She continues, I have no doubt in my mind that Citradel people will be heavily swayed by their decision. Even if people get mad at them to have made decisions on their own, they will still follow them anywhere. David took a completely risky deal, but it was worth it. Seeing me so quite she hesitated, no I meant, it's still reckless. I am not denying that. But… She was trying to back out of her own words. I stopped her though, its not lost on me that those conditions were too tempting. Our only objective was to bring people here. Honestly, if I was in his position, I would have taken it too.

She looks at me strangely, then why are you so mad at him about this. She caught me red handed. Me and my big mouth. I was definitely being hypocritical here. Actually I have known all along, just been avoiding it like everything. I couldn't answer her. Mostly because I didn't know how I could explain. Some of it was unclear to me. The only thing I was sure that I am angry at him. I didn't care about anything else.

With no answer I though she would prod me more she backed down, I hit a nerve. Sorry. I won't ask about it. She is being considerate of me. And yet I didn't know how to a handle such confusing feelings.

Vanessa (Chapter 43)

Thursday, September 11, 2025 21:05

Siera and I decided to go on a run a while later. It was the only thing we could do after the awkward atmosphere we had at the house. A much needed benefit was I needed a distraction and burn off my anxiety. We covered our usual trail along coast. Honestly, it helped me more than I thought. I appreciated Siera's suggestion very much now. We talked more about on the possibility if Citradel people moving here. We already had big plans, but to go over them felt now a reality. We talked about using there technology to improve the Island. We have very little tech help and still rely heavily on manual chores. Using the Citradels Medrine developed infrastructure would help us get back some of our heritage back.

On the way back I spoke to Catherine around 6:00 PM. I hung up after talking with her. Siera asks, they need you. I shook my head, nope. Looks like she got help from Blake. We got some more people from the stadium security team to fill out extra shifts. Still, we are going to use the reserve people, but at least for tonight we are all set. We agreed to meet at 8:00 PM and assign people to guest houses. But what happens tomorrow is yet to be decide.

Seira mentions, the officers building must be in mess right now. We were supposed to take a poll tonight from the losing city on who all wants to move. And the same with all those scattered people around the world. So much planning is now at risk. I also believed we are at a critical point. But then I remembered something Catherine said, actually no one is there in the officers building right now. Its completely empty. Catherine visited a while back and no one was there. Siera looked surprised, really. Why. You still have work after lunch right. I answered, yes. We all had work to finish after 3:00 PM. Mine was cancelled, but others still have jobs. Maybe Blake gave them day off since there is actually nothing to until admins announcement.

Siera questions, unlikely. You didn't get any messages, right. I periodically checked my phone. Nothing new. I didn't even get any update on the Heraknus visit. All I knew for sure that admins are still in discussion. I don't know what's taking them this long. They had all afternoon and still no updates. Its starting to get concerning. I reply, I hope Blake is trying to get in touch with them. He might be only one to force himself inside and actually get to stay. Siera wonders about it a little, he certainly has the right to do. Or maybe something else is keeping them from reaching a decision. It could be other reasons, we have been talking about it little all our run and still couldn't nail anything for sure.

It was becoming dark by the time we reached our house. When we came into its view, there were few people in front of the house. They all wore orange stripped clothes. Citradel people. Three big guys and a women were almost lurking around. They looked almost bodyguards. When we came closer, I was sure they were actually bodyguards for the women. They had her surrounded in a triangle formation. Siera asks me, are we expecting someone. I said, no. I was clueless as her.

Its not uncommon to see people here with bodyguards. That’s usually for someone important. As soon as we were in their view, the nearest guard motioned the women to us. She took step in front of us. She was in her early forties, a dark hair pulled into a pony tail. She smiled and somewhat relieved to see me. Once I saw her clearly, I realized she wasn't anyone I know. I whispered Siera, I have never seen her before. Siera understood and follows me behind as a precaution. The women speaks, Good evening. I am sorry to disturb you. I am Melinda. Nice to meet you. She very polite and her voice had a smoothing tune. Clearly she must be some sort of high echelon of Citradel.

I replied, evening. Are you looking for someone. I directly asked her. She nods, yes. I came to speak to you. Can I take a little bit of your time. She then turns to Siera and says, in private if possible. I told her, this is Siera, my guardian. What's this about. She replies, I am sorry. Its really a private matter. Trust me, I understand how it seems like. Please, I will explain once its just the two of us. I wondered what this could be about. I don't know anyone from Citradel who would want something from me. I looked at Siera for a little help. She was looking at the woman and then the guards. In a calm and relaxed tone, she then turns to me and says, its okay Vanessa. These people are legit Citradels. The dress and those Kuret insignia can't be faked. I will go head to the nearest ship and get something to drink while you guys talk.

I relaxed hearing this and asked her, are you sure. She nods, yes. Let me know when you are done. She waves her phone and walks away. I turn back to Melinda and show her the way in, all right. This way. She replies, thanks. Please, you all can stay outside. The guards keep out and spread out around the apartment walls. I scanned my wrist and door opens. We both step inside and wait at the dining room. I felt she was some higher class lady so I asked, I am sorry I don't have anything in terms of drinks. Is water okay.

She waves her hand, thank you child. I am fine though. She glanced around the house, you have a nice house. Its my first one standing inside a house in this Island. I sighed, its not much. I know. Me and Siera don't need much, we have gotten used to keeping light stuff. But if you want to see really good places, you should visit Nathans place. Out of all the us, he has the most lavish house. I mumbled, a little too ostentatious for my taste. I still can't believe Blake and David let him a house like this. If it were up to me, he should be lucky to have a place with roof.

She didn't see my hidden smirk and says, its still good. With all the stories I heard about you all these years, I could image your house would be like military, functional. She wasn't wrong, but it still stung. At least she is honest. I asked her, please sit. I offered her the dining chairs. She take one and I take the other one. So, I ask, what can I do for you. She clears her throat and takes a serious tone, I want your help with something. It was a little curious she approaching at my home and not at the officers building. She did say earlier it’s a private matter.

She continuous, I have to talk to David. But I can't seem to find him. Do you know where he is. Wait, what. My body tenses up hearing about this. I lean towards her, what do you mean. David's at the infirmary. People have visited him. She shook her neck, no. That was a while ago. I went myself there about 30 minutes ago and he is not there. Then I want to your officers building to talk to Blake, but the place is closed. I am not sure what's going on admins building with the rally, but I can't find anyone there. Its too crowded. And with no options left, I decided to visit you here.

Huh, there's a rally around the admins building. Forget that, David's is not in the infirmary. How that happened. I got from my chair and took my phone. I opened my history of messages. Nothing. No mention of him leaving. Did he wake up and left without telling something. I panicked and ask her, what about the guards outside his room. Did you ask them. She also got up seeing my tensed, there were no guards. I just assumed he left after waking up. This is very concerning, how can no one notice him walking back. I don't think so. And he can't have healed enough to use his Kuret yet. Besides, what would be the point to leave without no one telling. He just won a freaking tournament.

She realized the gravity of the situation. I decided I need to call someone now. Who would know about David. I don't think Ned as left the admins building. Matt and Cass have been managing the block stalls. Catherine is busy with hospitality. Nathan and Tessa should be at the auditorium with the participants gathering. That leaves only one person. I dialed his number and called him. The other end rings several times. Each delaying moment made me more worried. Then finally it opened, Vanessa. What's going on. Blakes voice came.

I almost shout, David's missing. The guards are not at the infirmary. Do you know he is. Blake replies, settle down. He is okay. We moved him to a secure place. I felt my chest unknotting feeling relieved. I told Melinda who was also getting worried seeing me agitated, he is fine. She relaxes and lets out a sigh. She chuckles a little, that was a scare. She takes her seat back. Seeing her I realized I reacted way more than I should. I too calm down but then I was confused, why didn't let anyone know you moved him.

He answered, we wanted to keep in the down low. I was concerned that the Citradel might use his injuries to make a case and stop somehow Charles. Like he is too injured to fight. That sort of made sense, but why hide it. He continuous, more than that. We were worried that someone could sabotage him. Like me and Marina were poisoned. Its still possible since the tournament isn't over. So we decided to be cautious and moved him while no was looking.

That was actually making a lot of sense. Blake made a convincing argument. I ask him, okay. So where is he. He didn't reply immediately. He takes a moment to reply, he is secured and sage I promise. Lets just keep it that. Vague, but okay. Then I heard a girls voice beside him. It was faint but I know who it was. I asked him, you have talking we, as in you and Marina. He replies with a little shaky voice, yeah. Of course it was her. The shadow duo strikes again. He then asks, anyways. We were going to tell everyone that David woke up and left to rest up at his house. Marina is right now drafting the message from his phone making it look like its from him.

After hearing their explanation I sat back down and faced a patiently waiting Melinda. I ask him, okay. I understand. Actually, there is a someone from Citradel asking for David. She wants to talk to him. Blake answers, that’s not going to happen. Last M checked, he hasn't woken up. I am guessing he won't tonight as well. Whoever is there, tell them to try again tomorrow. I relayed the same to Melinda. She looked even more anxious now, that’s not good.

I asked her, what's the matter. Is it urgent. She sighs, it very much is. The admins discussion won't end until I talk to him. I gasped, huh. That certainly was urgent. Wait, who is she. I asked, who are you and what's it got to do with David. She hesitated in answering. Blake heard me over the phone and asked, what's going on. Everything okay. I told him, hold on a minute. I asked Melinda, talk to me Melinda. She finally relents, if David's hasn't woken up yet, I guess you have to make a decision in place of him. I need to hurry and give Charles an answer. But he said to only talk to David.

His name from her was a surprise. If she is in contact with Charles, she must be close to Kafar. I ask her, how do you know Charles. She smiles a little, I am his wife. He contacted me to talk with David about something important. That’s not what I was expecting this. That explains the bodyguards. Does that mean they were also Heraknus. I pushed aside the question and pulled my phone close my cheek. I ask Blake, are you close by.

He replies, ah. We are in section one. Why. I told him, you need to come to my place right now. Charles wife is here and wants to talk something important about the Admins. I heard Blake surprised, seriously. I, then a moment later he corrected, we are coming in 3 minutes. He hung up his phone. I tell Melinda, Blake is coming here. Melinda replies, okay. She was still tensed though. I ask her, what does Charles want with David. I thought everything was done when they made a deal with him. Then a thought occurred to me, don't tell me he wants to change something of the deal.

She lifts her fingers to her lower lips, not exactly. Charles contacted me privately. He wanted ask David two things. I wondered what could be so important that he sent his wife to him. I wanted to ask her what it was. Then I decided its better to wait for Blake to arrive. We waited in tense silence until I hear some hustling outside the door. I got up and moved to the door. As I open it, I see the guards pacing fast and grouping together. They were looking up to the sky at something.

I followed their direction and saw two figures flying. I pulled in some Kuret in my eyes and saw the Kuret colors. I realize they didn't want to wait even a little bit. I told the bodyguards, don't worry. Its Blake and Marina. Their figures becomes more clear as the begin to descend down. The bodyguards relax seeing them. Those two didn't waste any time. A blue kuret ball and red kuret circles land on the road in front of my house. Some people walking nearby looked our way stunned. But this wasn't something new. A moment later they went on their way.

Marina releases her Kuret first and then Blake follows. She looks are the guards and says, whoa. Guys its me. One of the bodyguards told her, next time. Let us know if you are going to do this. Marina scoffs, big deal. Look, we can pretty much free to fly as much we want here. Unlike the Citradel, there are no Humans here. Its true that Citradels are not used to this at all. Blake greeted the guys, hey. Don't mind us. He and Marina walked passed them to my door. He askes me, is she inside.

I let them inside. Melinda was standing and waiting for them. Marina takes one look at her and gasps, wait. You. I asks her, you know her. Before she could answer Melinda says, Marina. I didn't know you would be coming too. She looks at Blake, hello Blake. I am Melinda Heraknus. Blake glances back to her from Marina, hi. Nice to meet you. You caught me a little off guard here. I close the door behind them and all of us take the chairs. Melinda says, I apologize for that. Charles sounded very urgent. He instructed me to only talk to David and be inconspicuous. I told him I didn't any guards with me, but he insisted since I couldn't bring him or any children with me.

Marina asks, you have kids. She was the most confused among us. Its obvious they know each other. Blake asks Marina, how do you two know each other. Marina replies eyeing Melinda, it was not like I knew everyone in Citradel. But I know her. Or at least thought I did. Marina sighs a moment later realizing she never really did know her. Melinda filled in the gaps, we worked together. Or did, before the Echo commander started making waves. I work on matter conversion for the drives using the star dust we mined from the Delago's comet. My family has been involved in mining and processing for generations.

All of were visibly startled to hear that she is the few people who has expertise on inter-stellar travel and our weapons technology. Blake hesitantly asks Marina, this is her. I thought you said it was a guy from some other house. Marina was again surprised to hear this, I thought I knew. Dammit. I can't believe you even lied about your job. I knew her as just a research assistance. I am not one to talk, but you definitely fooled me. Melinda chuckles, Taron is just a figurehead. My area of expertise makes me a valuable to Medrones. I had to lie to everyone, not just you.

Marina is a shadow, so I am sure she would understand. She applauds her, its fine. I get it. But to think you got yourself roped into a Heraknus family. That’s even more surprising. Wait, I remember you were away for about a year on a top secrete mission 6 years ago. She makes air quotes, I always thought why would a research assistance was sent. I understand now. Melinda smirks a little, actually I was pregnant with my twins back then. I was posing as a single women, it would be very weird to see have a baby bump.

Jeez, just how much of a secret was she to the Citradel. Blake cuts in, look I am sure you two have a lot to catch up. Considering there are about a dozen people guarding the place, lets get this over with before someone notices someone important is visiting the chief security of the Island. I shot back a look at him, a dozen people. I saw only 3. He replies staring at Melinda, there are more hiding and posing as Islanders. We spotted them when we circled the place before coming in.

Whoa. I didn't even bother to look for more people. When Siera told me they were okay, I just completely let my guard down. A mistake. Dammit. Melinda doesn't react to Blake much but just smiles and then puts it away a second later, okay. Lets get down to business then. David is not awake, so you all must answer two questions. Marina asks, and this came from Charles directly. She nods, yes. I don't know all the discussion, but the moment Charles explained the deal he made with David, Citradel officials lost their heads.

I could just imagine the faces of people when they heard that Heraknus are going to move here. The panic it would have created is something I wish I saw. She continues, a debate started and people pleaded Charles to reconsider. When he didn't, they began to, well. She pauses ominously. Blake prompts her, they resisted. It's obvious. Your husband word is final for his house, so they must have become desperate. She nods and speaks slowly, Kafar raised a concern saying David cheated during the match with his strange Kuret and was even linked to the sabotages to Marina, and possibly you.

What, I blurted out angered. Blake remained calm, but Marina and I were not going to let it stand. I told her, how the hell that makes sense. Marina shrieks, David was the one who found the bottle I was poisoned with. This is crazy. How can Kafar blame this on David. I tightened my fist uncontrollably. Melinda turned worried and says, afraid I don't know. Charles didn't tell me everything. He said that they wanted David to visit them around lunch and remove such doubts. Derek was very opposed to this. But David wasn't awake, so the discussion kind of went on.

I was speechless at Kafar's shameless actions. Marina got mad and says, he has gone from a sleazebag to a douchebag. I agreed. I also a sneaking suspicion that this wasn't the only thing he did. I asked harshly, what else. I am sure he must be speaking more nonsense. Melinda gulps a little before saying, few hours back, they tried to reach out to David again. But he was not in the infirmary. No guards as well. The discussion somehow pivoted saying he left without mentioning anyone to hide or destroy evidence of his involvement.

Marina spoke aloud, that jackass. I added on, he really is an opportunist you know. Blake for silent a while, but he joins in, settle down you two. This is just all huff and noise. If he really had any evidence or suspicion why not ask us. Blame us. Be angry with us. Or just talk to us. And yet, he didn't even mention a single thing to any Islander. He knows if we heard this, we would ask for evidence. He has nothing. Not even circumstantial evidence. They are just derogatory attempts to have Charles back down the deal. Some may even believe it. But it doesn't matter who said what. If they can't back it, its just bunch of complaints wrapped in hysteria.

Even knowing he is right wasn't enough to make me relax. Marina asks him, but who knows what else must be going on. Charles didn't tell Melinda everything. Blake responds sternly, maybe. No. Most definitely. With David's history, including getting framed by Nathan, human murders or collaborators, and being in top 10 of the most wanted in so many agencies, Kafar has many ammunitions to discredit David. He sighs, I thought when David gave away that 2 billion dollars with his bet, Kafar would leave him be. I guess, that was just wishful thinking.

I rebuked, but he hasn't done anything bad. He has done a tons of good shit. They can't take away those. Blake nods, no one is denying this. Neither can they. Which is why I am sure it’s a sad and desperate attempt to convince Charles to not move here. He asks Melinda, you said you wanted to know two things. Is the first question from Charles about this nonsense. Melinda stares at us for a while and then speaks, yes. So he isn't responsible for these crimes. He didn't cheat during the match or sabotage the tournament.

Before I could answer Marina answers, you know me Melinda. Right. So trust me when I tell you. I have knew David back in Medrine. And having spent enough time with him here, he is a good guy. He is most definitely not a saint, but he wouldn't cheat and risk our lives on the line. I nod, if he wanted do sabotage or cheat, no one would have known. He wouldn't make it complicated by reporting his own crime. Melinda listened to us like she was a reporter, absorbing all the information.

Blake also pitches in, you can tell Charles to ignore such accusations. Even if he is suspicious of his past, David wouldn't cheat in such a crucial match. Like Marina said, its too risky to do that. Just because he did something crazy by pulling out bunch of kurets, doesn't make him a cheater. We waited for Melinda. She glances at us, taking it all in. After what looked like an interrogation eyeing, she opens her mouth, I understand. That’s good. Normally Charles would also ignore such baseless comments. But he was been stuck in that room for hours. No matter how much Derek opposed, Charles still wanted to confirm from David himself.

She looks away to empty air around us, but he isn't here. But hearing from you about him, at least I am convinced. I will tell Charles the same. All of take a little breather hearing this small piece of good news among all this crap. I am still very mad to David, but questioning his integrity is not up for debate. Marina says, thanks. Blake asks, glad to hear that. What's the second thing you wanted to talk about now.

She faces me now, its more like a clarification rather than a question. That's confusing. I asked her, about what. She explains, something about Wagner that made David a little crazy, his words not mine, and he wants to clear somethings.

Blake (Chapter 44)

Friday, September 12, 2025 19:39

Its finally the time. By 4:00 PM, everyone was told what to do. Luther had planned it out around 4:30 PM. I asked him to time it, saying it would give enough people us to work with. Secretly, that would give us the distraction to move David. Me, Luther and four other people were discussing the final orders. I had to come up with an reasonable excuse to explain why I can't be there, but to my surprise Luther didn't want me there anyways. He says, it works in our favor if you are not there. You are our top officer, sure. But you are the leader first. If you were with us from the start, it would definitely be more impactful. But you know what would be even more impactful. You coming in on later.

I was curious where he was going with this. I asked, explain. He shuffles in his chair, we can give an excuse saying you have been sitting inside the admins waiting room. I have people telling me they saw you for hours there in the morning after the match. Who's to say you didn't went there back again and have been there all this time. And then after few hours from now, you come out and show us that you were already inside. I gave this a little more thought. If done right, it would pressure Citradels even more.

One of the other people, Tina asks, but the lobby is also locked. How can we claim Blake has been inside all this time. Luther says, remember the lunch delivery. With that small opening, am I mean literally when they opened the door, that person saw the lobby was empty and the conference room locked. Blake could have been there for hours and even Citradel wouldn't know about it. Looks like he thought of everything. I may have this sleazy idea first, but he made it a politically sleazy plan.

I smiled, I like it. Another person from the group, Forman asks, but can you even get in without anyone noticing. I could hear others sneering at his naivety. Luther says, you do know who we are talking here. His is a freaking shadow. It will be piece of cake. I was pleased to hear such high praises from him. I told them, its not that easy. I am not an trained in that field, but rest assured. I could break into the admins lobby without Citradel or anyone knowing. Everyone laughs with me, I continue, let tell me when I need to come out.

Luther nods and hold up his iPad. I think its best to at least have two hours before we reveal you. So you should be ready anytime after 6:30 PM. That gives me a little over 2 hours. That should be enough to move David. I got up from my chair, that settles it. Lets do it. Everyone looked poised to do this. I went to my dresser to pull out a jacket from my dresser and walked out with them following in tow, I will sneak out from the back. I'll make sure no one sees me. Message me when you are ready for me.
Luther walks beside me as we walked to the 3rd floor deck., got it. I know you don't want any prepared speech or anything like that, but I have some essential points I want you to share. I'll send them later. As I opened the door I told him, make sure it doesn't look desperate. He smiles, yeah. I know. Angry, confused and frustrated. All yes. Pathetic, weak and desperate, big no. I corrected him, hell no. I pulled on my hoodie and grab the railings. Okay, guys. I'll see in few hours. Good luck. They wish me luck as well. I called on my Kuret. It covers my whole body and jump out into air.

I control my landing and then I began running. It was still say, so it was easy to look like I was on a jog with my head covered. I used my Kuret to become faster. I hit the streets and stuck close the buildings or trees as I ran. I kept my Kuret to a minimum, not to reveal others who I was. Soon I was near the stadium. I wasn't going to enter from the entrance. I looked for any entry point from the backside. I saw 3rd floor open window. I looked around me and saw no nearby aura. That’s my cue. With a kuret induced jump, I flew up and suck through the window. I landed softly on the floor and walked slowly to the door. It was an empty room. I remembered this is just a storage room.

It could be locked from outside. And it was. But before I plan to open it, I opened my phone to check on Marina. She hasn't messaged me yet. I didn't want to go out in case someone sees me wandering around. She still had 10 minutes till 4:00. So instead I decided to wait here until she messages. I sat at the corner and decided to pass the time by noting down my own thoughts. I obviously don't want to incite anything so it has to be enough to sound objective.

15 minutes went by and then finally got a message from Marina. She was ready and coming to get us. I messaged to meet around the back garage. I got up and peaked out from the window. I saw a crowd forming near the admin tower on the side. Seems the plan is working. I walked back to the door. I poured out my Kuret into the gaps of the door. My kuret feels resistance from the bolts, I apply more pressure to crush it open. Since this was a empty storage room now, it doesn't matter if I broke the door.

I check for any aura before walking out. The stadium is mostly empty. I only saw few auras on the ground, the clean up crew. With no interference, I jolted across the floor and head to 2nd floor from the stairs. In a minute the infirmary room was visible. The security guards were no longer here. I opened the door and went inside to David's room. I see him in the same place as last time I saw him. The display was showing his recovery to be 70%. Wow, okay. I didn't know it shows this accurately.

I submersing tank is quite big to inconspicuous. I looked around the room. There must be something to cover the device with. I looked in a cabinet, but it was empty. There was a bed, but the sheets weren't big enough to cover. Huh, great, I forgot to realize this issue before. I was more focused with the other plan. I looked around another minute, this time the whole infirmary, but nothing. There wasn't anything I can use to hide the tank. I should have planned more properly.

As I walked back to the tank, I remembered something. When David was explaining to us all those months ago, didn't he mention something about stealth option. I recalled the memories and I vaguely remembered it. I inspected the tank and after a while I saw a symbol of shadow. It would look like just a mark to others, but to us it was a like a big poster. I ran my hands across the cool surface and realized it had a hidden button. I pressed it and heard a rumbling noise. Immediately I took a step back. The device's surface, even the glass, is transforming into a smooth white capsule. Damn David, you got some serious tech. A moment later it looked it was a giant pill.

Somehow this is even more conspicuous. I can't take this out. The shadow mark was still there, so I hit the button again. This time, it transformed into a oversized fridge. What, how in the hell is this a setting. I kept trying hoping get something good. After few tries, I finally got a suitable cover. It's looking like a big box of crate. Perfect for carrying it out in the open. I had noticed it didn't have any wheels, so I guess its all me. I take a deep breathe and poured out my Kuret. I glide my hands motioning the kuret around the tank. Then I pull it up. It was quite heavy. I should be able to manage for a while. Without wasting a second, I walked out the infirmary with a levitating tank.

Soon I reached the garage loading area. Thankfully no was here. But neither was Marina. Where is she. I pushed the tank onto the loading stage. I opened my phone. Marina sent a message saying she is getting delay from people blocking the paths. Shit, another mistake. I didn't think about the people out in the streets. I tried very hard to not look out of place. I was the only person in an empty loading garage so few people did look my way. , They didn't suspect too much. Few minutes later I saw an familiar aura coming from the side.

Marina came in a small jeep. She saw me and turned inside towards the loading area. She was also incognito wearing a ragged jacket with a hat and goggles. She calls out anxious, what the hells going on. What's with all the people gathering around the roads and buildings. We were in a hurry, so I told, I'll explain when we get out of here. I used my Kuret to hold on the disguised tank. Marina looked suspicious me dragging a large box into the back of the jeep. She then realized, wow. Where the hell did you get a big enough crate that fits the tank. Once I put down the tank behind, I hop on the passengers seat. I told her, it’s the tank. David built a stealth option. Marina laughs, sweet. She puts the jeep in a reverse drive and pulls us out of the loading garage.

For a while we only focus on keeping a low profile. We already stand out with a big ass create. I didn't want anyone to give us a second look. People were now coming from everywhere. Filling up the roads and building entrance areas. It took us about 10 minutes to navigate out of the hot zone. Once we crossed the middle sections, Marina picked up the speed. Marina asks, okay. We should be good now. She pulls down her hat and goggles, now explain. What the hell is going on.

Just has a precaution I inspected the tank. We both were on guard, but can't track every person around us. Doesn't look like it was disturbed in anyway. I face the front road pulling my hoody, sorry. I should have warned you about this. I didn't think people would be gathering this fast. I thought it will be taking longer. Luther wasn't kidding when he said how fast he organized it. Marina confused asks, huh. What did you do. I answered, since morning we have been getting calls and people asking us what's happening with the admins and Citradel. We have only rumors and very little actual fact about what's talking them so long to discuss. We were continuously getting approached by people, to a point it was getting in the way of our actual work.

Marina snorts, damn. I didn't realize it was that bad. I reply. Neither did I in the beginning, but just think about it. David was declared winner, but Reinhart mentioned only for the first half event. That was a spur of the moment from them. People don't know what's happening. Is Citradel moving here. Or only half of them. What's with the deal between David and Charles. The longer this goes, the more concerned people will be. And obviously, we can't tell people what really happened. So I had an idea on how to deal with this.

Marina asks, which involves people gathering on the streets. I nod, that just the beginning. My idea is to shut down the officers building, turn off our network and have the officers rally around the admin towers. The people you saw around the stadium were just gathering, I am sure they either have started to move or will do in some time to the admin towers. With all the recognizable officers on the streets, people would naturally be curious. That will eventually leading to a full blown rally once they explain that we also want Citradel to explain what's going on.

Hearing me Marina whistles excited, damn. You don't pull any punches huh. I chortle a little, of course not. Why should we suffer for something Citradel has to explain. Luther perfected the plan by selecting the more well known officers, while the rest would resume work from a secluded location. Once people recognize that few of us are out there, the would assume everyone are also here. We also got some luck in pulling some of the top Island and Citradel fighters. All this in an effort for people to get off our back and instead stuck them on Citradel and admins. It would pressure them to hurry up their discussion.

I continued with worrisome tone, giving admins more time is not good for us. I am personally worried Kafar would do anything to stop Charles. Last I saw him he was still arguing with Charles. I don't want him to have more time to come up with anything that makes Charles back down. Marina left the steering wheels and applauds, hot damn. Now that’s political maneuver to choke them. This is very good plan. I nod, thanks. And as an added benefit, it would also serve as a distraction while we move David.

She laughs more loudly, love when a plan comes together like this. At that I also was mildly impressed by the effectiveness of this crazy plan. I didn't expect it to work this fast. The she asks, wait. Won't it be better if you were also there. I then explained Luther's final trick. At that she giggles, let me guess. You need my help to snuck in. I most definitely was. I answered, its going to be tight, but with you helping me, we can pull this off. She nods, I may of a way. Lets figure that later though. We are almost here.

We had crossed the outer sections and now crossing the forest areas. The road here wasn't proper and it jerked us quite a lot. I ask, whoa. Slow down. The tank is creating dents on the back. Marina scoffs, who cares. This is a very old jeep. Trust me, I got it because no one will look for it. She actually floored the gas and increased the speed. I had to throw my Kuret on to the tank and keep it from falling out. We crossed into rocky forest terrain. I recognized this place. We were close to the northeast coast, the mountains here turns into a large cliff towards the ocean.

I ask Marina, how do you know David's house is here. She didn't reply right away, instead she took us into a unmarked location through the mountain bottom. A moment later she turns the jeep sideways and halts. She turns

off the jeep saying, his house is not here. Well not yet. She got out and I followed a second later. She points to the cliff on the middle of two mountain edges, the house is going to be on that cliff. Puzzled by this I asked, again. How do you know.

She pulls out a device from her pockets. It looked like a small remote with just one button on it. She waved it with her hand, with this. We are not going to where the house is, we are going to summon it. She was purposefully being ominous. She is clearly teasing me with such word play. I shook my head, fine. So we carry David manually from here. She nods, that’s the plan. The path is two rough for us to go in this rusty bolts. So lets go. She offered to take the tank this time, so I gladly let her. She creates mini charms and throws it at the bottom of the tank. It levitates and follows her as we begin climbing through the boulders around us.

A minute later we took a small opening of the path into open cliff. I asked finally, are you really not going to tell me how or why you have a device that can, I really didn't want to say the word. She offers with a laugh, summon the house. Yeah, whatever, I said. She replies, again. Its my secret. Let David tell you. She is enjoying way more than she should. Soon we reach the cliff. She waves her fist to me, stop. This is as far enough. She dispels her charms and the puts the tank of the grass.

She offers the button to me. I said, by all means, your secret. Your button. She smiles gleefully and pushes the button. Nothing happened. It wasn't like I was expecting suddenly, but the device wasn't beeping or making any noise. Marina however was very excited. I ask her, so long will this take. She shrugs, no clue. From what I understand, when David is not inside his moving fortress, it is in a suspended mode somewhere in the sea. But it has to be someplace close by. So I don't know, maybe 5 minutes.

We waited in suspense for minutes. 3 minutes went by. Now even Marina was showing less excitement. I ask her, ah. Just to make sure, that device works right. She gets offended, it works just fine. Its not supposed to make any sound by design. Same with any progress or wait time. I figured it was best not to pester her. Another 3 minutes went by. Its becoming more like nothing goings to happen. Marina looked tense, it will be here. Trust me. She is mumbling under her breath. I was becoming less optimistic about this.

Then a minute later we hear a large surge of water gushing somewhere. We both immediately heard it and run to the edge to gaze over the ocean. Large waves were now coming from a place on the ocean. The water gushed inside and crushed under the rocks. A moment later a small structure came out. Marina beside me laughs excited, yes. It worked. See, I told you. She jumps in joy. I was more fascinated at the rising structure. Slowly the object takes in shape of a rooftop. It looked like it was made of black steel or iron. I couldn't see any aura from it, so there is no medrite is used in the construction. I look in awe as I begin to realize how huge it was. It was as big as a villa.

The house emerges from the ocean and floats towards the shore. I was thinking that at this depth from the cliff, we had to go down. Marina notices me looking at the bottom. She says, no. We don't need to go down. It will come out. That surprised me, what. She smiles, just wait and see. I don't know what to expect. Suddenly the house rose up quickly from the water. Shit, I realize what's happening. The house gathered up momentum and shoot up straight into the air.

My jaw hung with awe. This technology is beyond humans, closer to ours back in Medrine. The bottom of the house had some kind of thrusters that threw large streams of water. I still didn't see any aura, so this was all pure medrite free technology. The house jump straight up, but what now. From my view, it was slowly loosing speed. I turned to Marina, she wasn't worried. This is supposed to happen then. Immediately, large beams of pillars come out from the bottom.

Those think beams stuck to the cliff and break apart. I got nervous for a second, then I saw it wasn't getting destroyed. The beams were actually spitting and spreading around the walls of the cliff like an army of ants. My eyes widen stupefied. I shouted at Marina, isn't that the same as Echos technology. Yeah, it is. I bet I saw this during the war last year. Their vehicles and ships could transfigure like this. More beams comes out and scatter when in contact with the wall.

Marina was also surprised at this, what the hell. I didn't know about this. I have never seen the boarding procedure. The house somehow didn't fall off. I can't believe that those small looking Echo material were this strong. A moment later the house starts to climb up. I point to the house, are you kidding me. Will such a big and heavy house be able to climb. Marina sighs with nervous, it will. We should get back. We take backward steps and get some distance. A moment later, the entire freaking house was able to climb a 400 meters cliff in seconds. Up close I could tell distinctive features like the rooftop, windows and doors.

The ground beneath us shook. The rocks roll on the ground as the house completely emerges from the sides. The tiny moving beams become solid and then froze the house in place. About a dozen of medium sized beams come out from the sides and bottom and lodge itself into the ground. It creates shocks on the ground around us. Then came silence, filled with suspense. Marina then waves her hand excited, Blake. Welcome to Davids home. The building surfaces then change colors, some parts even transform shapes. I could now see outlines of window slits and sliding doors. The roof turns into red color, walls turns light yellow, the windows become transparent.

I spatted, this is where David lives. Freak this. When he showed his ratty place months ago, I thought he didn't care about aesthetics or maybe he was just a minimalist. This is crazy. Marina laughs at my amusement, what this. Its nothing. Wait until you visit inside. I didn't know what we supposed to do now. The door looked closed, maybe they will open for us. Then Marina's arm started to make noise. She lifts her wrist and M pops out, Unauthorized boarding protocol detected. Deploying security measures.

Wait what, Marina shouted. Before we could understand what happens, the house begins to do something. From the side, I heard something like a door opening and three objects shoot out. The objects jump out and fly in the air. I shout in disbelieve, are those freaking robots. Not the echo kind. But it was in the shaped like us from the middle, but on the bottom were two sets of small pillars with propulsions levitating them. Theres a square head with two cameras as eyes. Torse with two arms, an elbow joints, hands, fingers, the whole package. There are guns hoisted all around the robot. They were probably made of same material as the house.

Marina shrieks, what the freak are they. I was nervous now seeing Marina didn't encounter them before. Those robots glide in the air, flying straight at us at speed. I spoke to the watch on Marina's wrist, what's going on. M, tell them to back down. It's your boss for god sakes. M's hologram had gone, and no response came. I asked Marina, any ideas. Marina didn't respond. She had prepared a charm and waving it around us. The robots weren’t the only security. She freaks out, look out below. I sense something.

Just then the ground erupted. I instinctively used my Kuret to block us from the debris. Turns out the robots were also distraction. Five huge spheres made with the same Echo tech were flying around us. They were circling us with mini thrustors on them. Then spheres open a part of it showing a barrel. I still can't see any aura. What the hell David build here.

Blake (Chapter 45)

Saturday, September 13, 2025 21:59

This is nuts. We are being surrounded by flying robots and spheres. Marina asks me exasperated, ah, any idea what should we do. She had tried M several times. But no response had come. I shouted back, are you serious. I thought you said you had this. What did that button do exactly. Marina shook her head, its not my fault. I told you I find a way to locate his house. I had no idea about this. That’s what worries me. She mentioned David would have increased or changed other things. I say that was an understatement.

We both were using kurets to guard us. The robots were positioned at three corners, boxing us in. They had something on their hands pointed to us. It could be only described as a trident shaped gun. I venture a guess its not gunpowder inside it. Marina yells, lets just blast them. We can take them. I waved at her, don't. We don't know what kind of response it will follow next. They are not attacking us. Lets wait for a some more time. Marina says angered, I can't believe David wouldn't have excluded us as hostile threats. Come on, how paranoid is he.

I couldn't agree more. But I had to believe this is just a standard protocol. Few seconds went by, then nothing changed. I told Marina, keep trying M. This has to be due to something she mentioned just after the house came up. Marina kept calling M, but no response came. Then one of the spheres left the group and flew over to the tank behind us. We look at it with anxious eyes. A laser comes out from it and begins scanning it. The next second the two spheres still circling came out and also begins scanning us from the foot.

Marina was fidgety with her charms. I hesitantly tell, don't. The lased completes its scan once it crosses our heads. All the spheres stop moving. They flew towards the tank. The robots that had their weird guns pointed at us, also took flight. Both of us relax seeing they left us. Marina yells at them, oh sure. Yeah. Your boss is there, so we must be not be threats. Your welcome. The robots grab the ends of the tank and lift it up. The spheres hovers around middle and top, like they are guarding David.

The all flew back into the house carrying David. I asked, well that happened. Does that mean we can now go inside. Marina was still a little angry, who the hell knows. You know, David could have mentioned he had some guard dogs here. We started walking to the house. The robot landed on some kind of deck that opened up on their arrival. I was sure this meant that we were also invited now. But that didn't happen. The whole house begins to transform and slowly revert back to the structure we saw as earlier.

Marina shouts realizing what this meant, oh come on. After all this, we aren't even welcomed in. This sucks balls. She stomps on the ground. I sighed seeing the doors and window closing. I tell her, leave it. We got David into a secured place. Let him go. The support beams begins to disassemble and the house begins to move. After some more dismantling, the house begins to climb down. With the same mechanical movements, the house journey down happens in seconds.

Just few meters before reaching the ocean surface, it launched itself horizontally towards the ocean. It creates a giant splash, which create huge waves to the shore. Moments later it starts to swim outwards and then submerges gradually down. Soon it was just the two of us staring at empty ocean. I spoke aloud into the air, David you crazy son of a gun. He had everyone fooled with this. Even us. Marina clears her throat. I corrected grudgingly, okay. Just me. But he didn't tell you everything too.

Marina had to realize that as well. She scoffs, yeah. Can't deny that. Then a moment later she cheers up, wait, that means he upgraded the insides of the house too. I have to see it. I turned my back to the ocean, later. Lets head back. Theres nothing left to do now. Marina stared a little longer and then we both walk back to the jeep. On our way back, Marina's watch starts to beep. M hologram comes out. Marina yells at her, you could warned us about those robots.

M says, updated temporary access. An unauthorized request was sent to bosses house AI. We have isolated me running there. Since the protocol request was valid, but antiquated, it decided to still follow through with the boarding with a potential risk assessment. I looked at Marina curious. She became nervous at my continuous gaze. She asks, what. I replying, I didn't say anything. She retorts, its not my fault. I replied, again. I didn't say anything. After few more staring she blurts out, ah. Okay. Fine. Her voice takes dip in tone, I might have done something David not to do.

I sighed. I knew something was up, David didn't give you that device, did he. Seeing her silent meant I was right. I waited for her to speak up while we continued walking. We reached to our jeep, she finally breaks the suspense, I stole it. I was expecting this. We both take the seats. I ask, how. She explains, last time I was in his house. He was giving me a tour, he showed his control room. There were bunch of these devices lying on a table. She waved the device in her hand. I was a little surprised David didn't notice it. She continues with a little nervous smile, actually it have been from a sperate pile.

That got me curious. I asked her, did that pile was meant defective or maybe even old? I stressed on the last parts. Marina takes a while to respond, yeah. It could be. I let out a scoff that showed my annoyance, there is a reason why you are not trained for stealing stuff. Come on. She reflexes, I had to. The way he was showing me stuff and speaking, it felt he wasn't going to show it again. I yelled, why the hell would you think that. Marina shrugs, I don’t know. But there must be reason why he wanted to keep this a secret don't you.

I thought about it a little. Was it wrong to steal from David. Maybe she was also right for being suspicious. Why hide from us about his house. She says, see. I am telling. I couldn't put my finger on it, but he was very suspicious. So I thought to have a back up. She turns on the jeep and pulls us out of there. I can't tell if what she did was wrong then. I spatted, I will make David give us some answers. Marina smirks, exactly. He owes us a lot of explanations. All about his therapy and then this.

I thought about the reasons for this. But I realized it was pointless, he was trained to be the most secretive among us. I guess after regaining his memories, he reverted to his old self. When we crossed into the forest road Marina asks me, did you see the material the house and robots were made from. I nodded, yeah. It was had to miss. Marina says, I scanned the whole house with a charm and I found no Medrite or Echo signature. And yet the way they transformed and moved…I answered the rest for her, it looked like Echo's ship. I wonder if he salvaged some for himself from the war last year. I thought we kept it locked it away for analysis in our R and D.

Marina says, he must be took some before we moved it here. I can't believe he used it and reproposed it like this. She raised her wrist and asks M, what can you tell us about the house and those killer robots. M pops out and says, information access denied at current authority. However, I am allowed to say that the robots were only part of the protocol for initial risk assessment probs. The actual killer robots weren't deployed. M pops back in. I gasp hearing this. Marina yells, what the freak. I was kidding about killer robots. They were just some sort of resonance probs. Those robots and their weapons looked battle already. What kind of hell machine are the actual ones.

I couldn't stop myself from laughing after I had a thought, he reproposed those Echo tech, knowing how ineffective it was against us in the last battle. So imagine this, with all the resources he has, he may have improved it. He didn't use Medrine or Echo tech, just Earth's tech. I can't even fathom what those killer robots are. Marina is instead smirking. I ask, you want to seem them. Right. She yells, hell yeah. Don't tell me you don't want to. Our defenses are not automated, his is. I could already tell its way advance from what we can make.

I tell her, you know he isn't going to share the secrets. Her eyes becomes sharp, oh. I am going to pull it out from his ass. With the bullshit he made me do, he owes me big time. I didn't argue with her more on this. David knew what he was getting into by telling Marina about his house. I have some understanding of David's view. But I won't lie, I want some answers too.

We were now back on the outer section. It is now 5:30 PM. The rally must be on going strong by now. I still haven't gotten any message from Luther. So I still had some time. I had another thought and I did not want miss this opportunity. I ask, Marina, How far is Dr. Drews home from here. Marina says, you want to go visit her now. You sure. I nod, yes. I don't know if either of us will get time after this. After the tonight's announcement, I don't know happens tomorrow. But right now, I have time and an convenient excuse. You are also here, it could be better if you are with me when we meet her.

Marina thinks about it and says, she lives in section one. Its not that far from here. We can be there in 10 minutes. But what if she is not at home. I answer, then we will have no choice but to try some other day. You said she's now a farmer now, so lets hope she spends time there. Marina agreed with me and she turned towards her house. We won't get much time with her, so Marina and I discussed beforehand what we wanted to talk. We have no idea how much David had revealed to her, so its better we play it safe by keeping our stories straight.

We reach section one a little earlier than expected. We didn't find much traffic here. I guess most of the people would be moving to the admins building. Marina parks the jeep in the lot and we got down. This part of the section was designed primarily for agriculture so population density was low here. I follow Marina to a big house, kind of like ranch, with a shed separate on the side. The backyard extended to a large land. I saw aura's of various plants grown here.

Marina asks me, so you agree we do this my way. I nod, yeah. You are right. I thought about it and there is definitely risky to announce ourselves here. We only want to meet Drew, not her family. We will sneak in without anyone knowing. I didn't like this approach, but I am supposed to be inside the admin buildings lobby. Marina creates a charm and waves over the field. I pull in more Kuret into my eyes and see the auras. I saw 5 aura's people inside the house. The public information on the network says, she lives with her husband, their kids and brother-in-law. Marina confirms no was in the fields. As we walk closed I whisper, okay. Do it.

She opened her phone and sent a prepared message to Drew. It told that Marina has brought me with her and wants to meet at the east of their lands under the cover of trees. We both wait outside her house, avoiding any detection from anyone. Nothing happened immediately. We has to wait patiently until she read it. Marina had used a priority message with my authorization. That means her phone has to be buzzing continuously. Finally, after a minute, I see one aura leaving others and moving around the house.

Marina also sensed it, she motioned to move. Under the cover of the shed and fields, we stealthily dashed to the designated location. We passed through a field of apple orchids that were emitting medrites. Once we gained enough distance from the house I asked her, do you see what I am seeing. Marina also picked what I meant, yeah. Hard not to. Those orchids and now this groves of plums, they shouldn't be able to grow in such proximity, and with such high concentration of Keret inside. She must be making more of the other side. This is actually incredible. We reached the meeting place and glanced over the field.

I answered, yeah. We had a tour on a different farm, but we should have shown this as well. I wonder why she didn't put her name in the list. This would have been a great addition to show others. Marina lips twitches, I know why. The farms you all decided was all Medrine grown crops. Not a hybrid like this. She might have decided this would not help our cause. Think about it, the most selling point we are giving people is that no humans, no interruptions. We can finally be ourselves. That includes, able to grow our food. But this, she waves around the field, can be grown in Citradel also.

She was right. I told her, I can get on with that explanation. Its just I can't believe I never knew someone was growing this. Marina laughs, you have been busy with the tournament. Give yourselves some credit, this isn't like managing during resistance safehouse or wartime. We so many people coming over here now, things will go unnoticed. Even for us shadow agents. I knew this new paradigm shift would be difficult for me. Its just now hitting me how different things will be happening from now on. I tell her, thanks. I guess I was still have to learn things.

Marina pokes me on the shoulder, you got that right. And its not just you, I also have will have adapt. You know David has been pleading me to hire new people and maybe even start teaching some. Can you imagine, me as a teacher. I barely had patience learning during shadow training. I smirk at that thought. Those unfortunate soles will have to face hell, that sounds a lot of hustle huh. But you will do it. Marina reluctantly nods, yeah. I can't take on such massive restructuring without more people. When Citradel moves here, I will have to interview people who have some basic knowledge.

I realized something hearing this, you are already assuming Citradel is moving here. Nothing decided yet. Marina tilts her head a little, I guess I do. When Charles told his reasons for coming here, I think the no one can change his mind about that. I wasn't as optimistic as her. I have been thinking that Kafar might be up to something. I didn't have any proof, not even a rumor, but I bet he is any way to convince Charles. And given David's checkered past, he can use it somehow.

Our discussion was suddenly halted when we head an engine noise. Marina points to the source and we see a mini cart car coming at us. Marina sighs, she's here. Game face on. She pulls out an irritated expression. She is still reeling from their previous exchange. Dr Drew stops the vehicle when she sees us and comes out. She takes out cane from inside and walks to us. She was wearing a stripped shirt and jeans. From the looks of it, they weren't planning to go to the rally.

She waves at us, Prince Blake. What a surprise. And nice to see you too Marina. She was polite, but something about her tone. It was like mechanical, rehearsed. Which was not possibly, we literally just told her 3 minutes ago. I answered, evening doctor. I apologies for calling out like this. But it's important. Marina cuts in, like I told in the morning. You had the gall to make me prove that I was a close friend of Blake. I put my palm at her, let it go. I understand why she was being cautious.

Marina had more to say, but hold her tongue. I already told her earlier on the ride here to not make things worse. I turn to Drew, I don't have much time. So lets not waste time like you did earlier with Marina. What do I to prove I only want your help with David. Drew is silent, analyzing us with her gaze. She says, like I told to Marina. I am not a licensed therapist. I don't have any patients. And certainly not David. Her expression wasn't showing any deceit and she wasn't angered by our presence either. Her aura was calm as well. Only fluctuated when she saw me first.

We anticipating he reluctance. So we knew what to say to make her help us, you are right. You don't have any patients. But we have a friend, someone who certainly didn't tell us about you. Now, I clear my throat, he has unfortunately gotten worse. He got the shakes, panic attack and vomited his guts out. All happened during a critical point during the match. So we were wondering if you have any suggestions. You know, since you have background in this area.

Drew's expression finally broke. I see a slight change in her aura. She glances over to Marina. Marina says, that’s true. I was there. And I would have told you the same, had you listened to me. Drew didn't speak for a while. Her stare became even more intense. I thought I had to reveal some more things without mentioning David's name. But then Drew whispers, how bad was it. Marina tells her, pretty bad. I have seen him interning at my home in Medrine in crutches, fought wars with him. Never seen him so broken before.

She showed guanine concern. I added, I have known him on Earth and seen him at his worst. This is new low for him. One second he was fine, then he is smiling, following loss of strength. I practically carried him out of the match. Drew closes her eyes and leans her head up. She then opens them and faces me, I understand. I get it now. She turns to Marina, I apologies for my rudeness earlier in the morning. Her mood changed all of a sudden. I guess revealing the brutal truth was the best way for her to open up to us. Marina clicks her tongue, yeah. Lets just move on. Faint traces of resentment still remains.

Dr. Drew says, my only condition for treating David was he absolutely not reveal about me to anyone. No matter what happens. I ask her, why is that. She answers, I faced a lot of criticism from other when they realized I enrolled into a PhD course in Havard university. Before coming to live here, my husband and daughters were ridiculed that they got to live easily due to my decisions to later work on human patients in big cities. Living free from Echo. Maybe if I had taken up some work without studying like others, we wouldn't have suffered such stupid things. But as an academic, I wanted to learn first.

Then she shook her head, I admit I was a selfish. Also foolish to think people would understand. People thought I was running away from Medrones. She pauses a little, and maybe I was. Its hard to tell now. So when we moved here, I decided to hide my qualifications. My family has had it much easier now. Her story wasn't uncommon. Since 80% of the us sent to Earth were kids, many had to learn first about Earth and its science. It looks she fell into rough situations with her groups.

Marina says, I am not saying this to patronize you, but you just got unlucky. If you had moved to Citradel, you would have been welcomed. Even become important. Drew says, I appreciate the thought, but as you already know, I can't operate anymore. She stomps the ground with her cane, I thought becoming an advisor of sorts. But that time I was more fascinated by human psychology. The mysteries and studies on Earth is much vast than on Medrine. Because we have evolved with Kuret, illness and diagnosis had been moved from studying our brain to Kuret readings. With such a completely new area open to me, I just couldn't resist studying about it.

After listening to her, I understood her overwhelming sense of caution and reluctance to admit. I spoke to her, you had it rough. So I won't tell ask of you anything you don't want to. But for now consider just helping David. David wouldn't have broken his promise to you if it wasn't important. She sighs loudly, no. I understand. We did agree that he might involve others only if involves matter of life or death. I look over to Marina and we reached the same thought. I tell Drew, the situation is very similar. We are very worried about his state of mind. He has to fight the Heraknus alpha soon. I can't believe he hide his illness so well that no one saw it.

Marina says, trust me. He needs to be a 100% for his next fight. Drew is a little hesitantly with her words, so its true he will have to fight that mythical overdrive guy. We both nod. She shook her head, you know, it's not an easy fix. I can't tell you any specifics about his progress or treatments. I am still wanting to keep that privileged information. Well, her strict priorities are commendable. She continuous, I can tell you we agreed not to have session during the last few rounds of the tournament. Messing or changing with anything new, even by accident, at this juncture would be devasting. What would happen if he froze in the middle of fight. His composition is very human like.

I tell her, I can understand that much. M told vaguely that David had made progress and hadn't had any episode for a while. Marina says, so why now. Does it have something to do with Wagner. At that name Drew faces her with surprised look. She didn't say anything, but that look told us everything. There was definitely a connection. I wonder what kind. How does he know him. Drew says, I can't discuss about it. She tried saving her betrayed expression. But I already caught with her aura and Marina with her sense.

None of us prodded more. After a silence Drew says, I thought he had gotten over it by now. I was certain he would be okay to join the tournament after multiple sessions. She puts palm on her cheek, I guess I was wrong. This is the problem with smart patients. They can lie or skillfully deceit show half truths. She stayed silent. Marina asks, so you will help now. Drew wasn't sure, I don't know. We have been working on his issues for 8 months. It takes could take even longer, but not in a month. She pauses and has a thought, unless. Well, no. Even then its not something easy to deal with.

This isn't good. I was hoping more optimism from David's therapist. She caught my disappointment and says, I know this isn't what you want to you. Sorry. But if its possible, don't let David fight that Heraknus guy. Its too dangerous. I was there today at the stadium. I had a nagging feeling something wasn't right. Its hard to describe, but he felt like he was desperate. You confirmed me by telling this. Unlike this match, the next one could go horribly wrong.

This is bad. I have been worrying so much about Charles backing down from his deal, never thought David would be the one to do it. No, I did think about it. I just didn't want to deal with it. Marina was also perplexed, but we can't. Our future is on the stake, if David doesn't fight Charles, then the deal breaks down. Drew asks, looks like you know what it is. I have my guesses, but nothing for sure. Marina says, oh, believe me. If we could tell you, you would also agree. She then looks at me nervous, should we tell her anyways.

I didn't know what was the right thing to do here. Maybe Drew would agree if she knew everything. Drew made the decision herself, wait. Don't tell me. I rather not get biased. My priority is the patient. If David tells me instead, that’s different. Drew looked at our worried faces and says, sorry guys. But in my professional opinion, he shouldn't be fighting anyone. Then I had a desperate thought, take one session with him. Just one. If you asses that he is can't handle it. Then, I gulped hard, will, we will cross that bridge later.

Drew says, I told you. Getting involved would do more harm than do good. Also, there isn't any time. I cut her off, I know what you said. I also know David. The freaking guy would do it regardless what you say. He was strangely dead on fighting Charles even before his PTSD triggered. You could tell right, something changed halfway the match for him. Marina backs me on this, trust me, he is smart and crazy enough at the same time. We can't do what you can. With your help him, at least there is a chance he gets better. And that means better chances for him surviving the next fight.

Drew was dead silent. We gave a lot for her to chew on. I can't believe we are in a situation where Charles or David, either or both might back down from the deal. If that happens, Charles won't move his house here and we are back to square one. Drew finally speaks up, okay. Just one. She pulls her index finger in the air to us, I understand its very important. At least David himself knows he is a dire situation since he told you about me. What do you know about his condition.

That brought a little ray of hope to our gloomy discussion. Marina raises her wrist, M show us Davids charts. M hologram comes out and shows us the live status. Drew comes closer to inspect and surprises us by saying, M, show me the brain scans during the match. And also show the secondary charts on his dozes. M says, voice recognized. Accessing temporary authority on 2nd level medical status. Welcome Dr. Drew. M then enlarges and shows other stuff we never saw.

Marina shrieks, what is this. I didn't see this before. Did you know, she asks me. I shrug no. Drew took some time to analyze the new images shown. I ask her, you know M. Drew nods, yes. Its been actually quite effective tool in treating David. I also have a device setup in my room that connects to M. All though, it hasn't opened in the last four month. Having David as a patient has some benefits. We gave her some time to study whatever M was showing. After a while Drew tells us, this looks pretty serious. The last time I saw like this was…she stops realizing we were there, well, never mind. I have a general idea on his mental state. I will need time to study these.

She says, M, send me all these data to my access portal. Also, give me all the recordings you have during the match. I don't need to know the details of whatever deal David made, I only need to know what he said, when he said and how he said. Collate the data with that timeline. M says, running analysis and generating requested data. Estimated time, 2 hours. Drew continues, also show me the drugs you are using to treat him right now. I want to know the usage and history as well. M responds, request accepted. Creating a priority protocol for bosses recovery. With that M closes.

I ask, this isn't your first time asking such things. Is it. Drew says, I have gotten pretty used to M now. You think I would be helping David just because he sought me out somehow. In exchange of my help, he agreed loaning M for my own purpose time to time. Some guarantees about my family and this land. Marina laughs, that's makes sense. He can't pay you directly. Drew says, its been beneficial to both of us. I ask her, so what now. Drew says, I will go over this tonight. I should have something by tomorrow morning. Also, I want to talk to him before anyone. Its important for me to know his mental state before he is infused by you.

Jeez. She is very meticulous about her methods. I tell her, its going to be a little difficult. We had to move him to a secure location. And for the time being, we can't let anyone know where he is. At least until he wakes up. Drew didn't know about our situation, but she did her best, I see. How do I contact him then. Marina says, I don't recommend the way we did. I don't know what would happen. Drew is confused at this. Can't blame her. Marina raises her wrist, M, I know you said you can't tell me how to summon his fortress. But can you do it for the doctor.

M pops out, checking. Drew mumbles to herself, summon, fortress. I best ignore this for now. M says, granted access. Give a time, a high priority onboarding protocol can be provided for only Dr. Drew at a place. Marina waves her arms, great. Drew looked a little clueless here, but she nonetheless said, ah, how about you contact me when David wakes up. Even if it was the middle of the night. M says, confirmed. I will message you to your personnel portal. M pops back in setting that reminder.

I thank her, thanks doctor. Marina says, yeah. I almost thought it was over when you said David should quit. Drew says, maybe he should. But, I do agree it's not that easy. Besides, its my job to help him. I don't want to leave him helpless. We each shook her hands showing our appreciation. Drew says, I should head back. I told them I got a message something tripped our sensors. She walks back to mini car and drives off as we waved her bye. I ask Marina, David has to pull through, right. It was more of concern than a question.

Marina scoffs, he has to. He doesn't have a choice. He kept it hidden this long without any trouble. He has to get better. I felt the same. We began walking back to our jeep stashed further away. Once we reached the jeep, I noticed I have been getting a call on my phone for a while. It was on silent during the discussion. I thought it was Luther saying it was time. But it was Vanessa. I opened the call, hey Vanessa. I wondered what she wanted. Marina listened our conversation. Someone came to her asking about David.

Marina says tired, who is it now. You know, it's been a long day. I just want to hit the bed now. Then Vanessa told me Charles wife was there and wanted talk about the admins. I stopped in my tracks. This is very important. I looked at Marina who was jarred from her tiered attitude. I told Vanessa we are coming in. I close the call, Marina. We don't have time to take the jeep. Marina says, exactly what I was about to say. Lets jet.

With zero delay, we called on our Kuret and flew at full speed to Vanessa's house in section 3.

Vanessa (Chapter 46)

Monday, September 15, 2025 18:01

Clear what, I mumbled under my breath. My heart beats a little faster. Melinda turns to me, Charles told me he didn't get to explain everything of his fight with Wagner. And he wants to tell David. Charles told he doesn't want to fight David without telling the whole story. I got impatient and ask her, tell us. What happened with my brother. My voice came out harsher and coarser. Others noticed it also. But I didn't care. Blake clears her throat, she doesn't mean like that. Its just that Wagner didn't tell her about a lot of things. So please, don't held this against her.

Melinda looked little lost. She probably doesn't know of what's going on here. But she nods and continuous, let me first tell you that I didn't knew about this until Charles told me today. Also, Charles didn't want to explicitly tell you Vanessa. Because there are somethings you can't unknow. Especially when it comes to family. You really want to know. She was ominous, but it felt she was preparing me for something. I can't imagine what Charles didn't want me know. With a subtle nod I say, yeah. I need to know, no matter what.

Melinda replies, okay then. She takes a moment, glances to all of us and says, its true Wagner fought Charles. Its also true Wagner couldn't defeat Charles, but neither did Charles. Marina first spoke, what. The heck does that mean. She continuous, just what Charles told me. They were in a stalemate before using their overdrives. After, Charles couldn't fully control himself. Wagner realizing he couldn't defeat him straightforward, he took, ah, Heraknus kids hostage and used them as shield.

I spatted, what. That’s a lie. My brother would not do something like this. He was the freaking crown. He would never stoop so low as to use children like this. I could feel anger whelming in me. Charles is lying. My rage scared Melinda a bit. She shifts uncomfortably on the chair. Blake faces me, Vanessa. Stop it. You need to get a grip. I directed my anger at Blake now, are you serious. You can't believe this lie. Blake looks stern and says, I didn't say anything. I just need you to tone it down. Melinda is only telling us what Charles told.

But I was in no mood to listen to this nonsense. Marina steps beside me and says, maybe you shouldn't hear this. We can leave if you want us to. I can't believe these two. They don't even want to defend Wagner. They were just defending David, why can't they do the same for Wagner. Blake cuts in, yes. You don't need to hear everything. Lets leave. But then I cut in, no. No one is leaving. I want to hear what other lies you are going to say. Melinda looks worried and kept silent.

Blake and Marina looked at each other and to me. Blake sighs, I am going to say this only once. You either listen to what Charles told, or don't. You can't do both. Whether it’s a lie or not, Charles wouldn't risk contacting Melinda without a reason. So choose. He stares at me and waits for an answer. I can't believe I have to listen more lies. But I also can't walk away. Ah, this is so infuriating. After a lot of time, I made up my mind. Fine. I'll listen to her.

Blake nods and faces Melinda, sorry. Its not your fault. You warned her before. Whatever you say its okay. Melinda wasn't relenting this time. She had become even more hesitant. Other two stare at me. No way I am going to apologies to her. Marina shook her head and asks, Melinda, please continue. Melinda finally breaks and says, okay. Hum, those kids were actually Charles children with his first wife, my step-children, Gina, Rory and Tory. Thankfully, they were too young then to realize what was going on. Charles believes Wagner figured out Charles doesn't attack his blood family. He took them and barricaded in a house. Charles was out of his mind in that state, so he kept circling the house with his overdrive continuing to drain. In the end, Charles mother stepped in and stopped Charles completely. In that chaos, Wagner escaped.

I never thought I could get even madder than I was. Such lies. But I had promised to behave. Marina asks in confused voice, it’s a little hard to believe. Maybe he got desperate and had no choice. I shot a death stare to Marina who got nervous, or, you know, Charles is lying. Blake asks, what do you think Melinda. Do you believe your husband is lying. If he is, it doesn't make sense, why he would ask you to tell David. But if it true, that’s also crazy, the crown, everyone knows, would never risk children getting harm. There is a time where he risked his life to save kids instead of adults.

Melinda nods, even I can't believe. I have known Charles for 8 years. I know he won't lie about such a thing. I also can't believe Wagner doing this. I have met Wagner once. He seemed a good guy. When Charles told me this, I almost didn't want to do this. Blake says, setting aside whether its true or not, what did Charles wanted to confirm with David after hearing this. Melinda replies, David only accepted the deal after learning Wagner couldn't defeat Charles. He wants David to know the whole truth. This is nuts. Did Charles wanted David to back off the deal by spewing such lies.

Marina says, it doesn't make sense, why not just say just that. What's the point telling the rest of the story. Blake says, I was thinking the same. Did Charles wanted to show how dangerous his overdrive was by this story. He already told us abundantly before to David. Why bring the fact that Wagner had to use his kids to escape. I finally say, nothing about this makes sense. Melinda understood our confusion, I really don't know why. Marina asks, does he holds a grudge against Wagner or something like that. Melinda says, I really have no clue.

I had a nasty thought, he must be jealous then. If Charles really is this powerful, maybe he didn't like that fact that someone else is crown. It didn't matter to me if it made sense or not, I could only feel it. Blake murmurs, jealously. Is that really it. Marina scoffs, I don't think we will get anywhere without talking to Charles himself. For now, lets focus on this guys. I understood Marina was trying to get back to the task at hand, but my mind is too clouded to think clearly about Wagner and Charles right now.

Blake nods, you are right. He faces Melinda, ideally we should let have David decide himself about this. All I can say is that even if you did tell David that Charles didn't actually defeat Wagner, he would still fight him. I am sure of it. Melinda asks concerned, will he. How can you tell. Before Blake could speak, I cut in, because I talked to him earlier in the match. Two times to be exact. He has his mind set on winning no matter what. You can tell lie or truth to him, it wouldn't matter. Marina adds, yeah. I can vouch for it too. He wouldn't stop just from some story that's in the past, on a lost planet.

Melinda takes this in. A moment later she says, fine. I can at least see David would not back down. She tilts her head and makes up her mind. She stands up and says, I will talk to Charles and tell him about this. The rest is up to him. She walks to me and says, I am so sorry. I don't know if any of its true, but I know hearing something like this hurts. I was also why I chose to reach out to you as a last option. Please understand, I didn't have much choice.

I am aware its not her fault. But I couldn't bring myself to say anything to her about it. She turns to others, thank your time. I will take my leave now. Blake says, we appreciate you coming to us. It actually helps me a now knowing why the admins are taking so long to discuss. Marina also waves, and I haven't forgotten about you hiding your identity and job. I will talk to you later, you can bet on it. Melinda giggles a little, I would like that too. With that she walks through the door and steps out. I saw the 3 bodyguards on the move and they walk away from our view.

Marina whistles, damn. This is a mess. I don't know what's bad, people accusing David, Charles accusing Wagner or Davids condition. The last part made me momentarily forgot about the haze in my mind. I ask her, what do you mean by his condition. Is he not okay. Marina got nervous, which made me anxious. Blake waves his palm to me, she meant he hasn't woken up. Even now. He is fine. Marina nods impulsively, yeah. He is still resting. If he was awake, this would have been easier.

I felt a little relieved it was just that. Blake says, its best we don't say anything about this. About David's cheating or Charles, well, alleged story. We will only tell David when he wakes up. I honestly don't know what he would say. So lets not just blow our heads and create rumors. Okay. Marina says, agreed. They both turn to me. I already didn't want to talk about it, because they are lies. I nod in agreement. Blake says, good. I need to leave now. Luther messaged me when we were on our way here. I am so late, I have to leave now.
Marina says, seriously. That means you need to snuck into the building now. He nods. I was confused. I asked, sneak in where. Marina ignores me, but what about Melinda and those bodyguards. They saw your face. Blake nods, yeah. I was in such a hurry here, I didn't care much. Also, it doesn't matter after speaking with Melinda. Remember, Melinda herself said she didn't want to know anyone where she was or what she was doing. I believe that includes those bodyguards. So they won't tell she met me, well except for Charles. And right now, that’s the only concern now. Whether Charles would agree to us being Davids proxy.

Marina says, I really hope he doesn't back down since he didn't get to reach David. They both walk out through the door. I shouted behind them, hey. Where are you going. Marina says, you will know soon enough. Just turn on your TV. With that, those two used their kuret and flew away. Where the heck are they leaving to in such hurry. I closed the door behind me and slumped into the sofa. I put my arm on my eyes and laid down. I can't keep stop thinking those lies about Wagner. They have be lies. The brother I knew would never, ever do such a thing. Charles is lying. Or maybe he is confused. Maybe it wasn't Wagner. Yes, it has to be it.

But then how did Charles knew something that David also new. It can't be. I couldn't keep my thoughts in check. I obsessed over it continuously. I didn't know how long I was like this. Even when Siera came back, I didn't hear her until she asks for me, Vanessa. What's going on. I didn't answer her. I was in turmoil. Siera become worried, what happened. Did that women say something. Tell me. I finally moved my arms and sat straight up. Siera looks at me with fretting eyes. I told her, I don’t want to talk about it. She told me awful things. All lies. I don't want to talk and get worse. Its all lies anyways.

I tell she was bamboozled. She looked around the house like expecting to find some clue. I realize what she thought, no. We only talked. Nothing physical. Seria sighs, that’s something. If you don't want to talk, that’s fine. Its almost 7:00 now. You said you had a meeting with Catherine at 8:00. So, why don't you clean up a little before that. I didn't realize it was this late. How long was I lying here. I got up and tried to shook off the haze over my mind. I need to just focus on other things for now. I say, yeah. I think I will.

I go to the bathroom to take a bath. With a quick shower I got of my clothes into fresh ones. I am still shaken, but I pressed myself to focus on other things. I spent a little while going over the list of people assigned to the guest houses. With the addition of some reserve and volunteers, we have enough people to cover for tonight. I need to talk to Catherine what's the plan for tomorrow. In the worse case, Citradel people might stay here longer than anticipated. So we need around the call security around those parts of the Island as well.

After finalizing a draft of the roaster, I recorded it in my phone that dictated it. I took my jacket, tied my hair up and walked out of my room. Siera was sitting in sofa and looking at the TV. As soon as she saw me she asks, did you see this. I asked, see what. She points to the TV. I turned around. There were a lot of people in the background and a reporter talking, …going to wait for a decision. That’s the question in everyone mind tonight. We have seen many officers coming in, even after hours since this started. Lets ask one of them.

I recognized this place. Its in the front of the admin tower. I ask Siera, when we went to run, we saw unusual number of people out in the streets. Is that why. Siera nods, looks like it. I have been tracking since I left you earlier. I thought it would die out soon, but its still growing. The reporter come near an officer. Its Tina. She looked agitated. Reporter asks, how long have been here. She replies, I have been here for the same time other officers. Since the beginning. People behind them were now using kuret to draw attention to them. There was one that had drawn answers with a exclamation mark in the air.

The reporters asks, we have been getting reports from the officers. What's your take on this. Tina replies, I have pretty much the same questions as others. Why are they not announcing the result even when David was declared winner. Few hours ago, we saw few Citradel people going in, they were neither officials nor participants. So who and why were they here. I mean, people have been asking me all these questions, and I am beyond frustrated not having any answers. We created this rally to demand answers from them.

Reporter nods, and we all still wait for it. Thanks again officer. Tina leaves the screen. Reporter says, so heard it. The officers also have the same questions as anyone. Now lets switch over to the other side of the building, were now some Citradel participants have joined in. Siera asks, did you know about this. I shook my head, no. I did hear Blake and Marina talking about something like this before, but I didn't think much of it. I sat down beside Siera, I guess this was inevitable.

Siera answers, I am little shocked to see it organized so fast. In just 2 hours, almost a third of the people are over there. The camera now shows zoomed scenes of June and Marina walking into the crowd. I could make out some others too. So that’s why they hurried out of here. They wanted to get in the action. I spotted Matt and Cass near the front of the crowd. I didn't know they are also there. Siera asked, no one asked you to go. I replied, no. But I

wouldn't go even if someone asked. Me being there might cause more confusion when people ask me for details. Also I already know what's going on.

Siera says, that’s probably why Blake is also not there. I have been watching closely and no sign of him. Then I remembered Marina said about breaking in somewhere. Is that where he went. What's Blake doing. I got my answer after 10 minutes. The scene changes to the front of the admin building. Reporter was jubilant saying, we just saw the door opening. He and the camera ran through the crowd and navigated near the top. There was a line of people barricading the crowd. They were the Citradel bodyguards. My mind became focused and both of us leaned towards the TV.

The camera zooms into the person walking out of the building and walking down the steps. It was Blake . That’s where he was, with the admins. The crowd became chaotic, but the Citradel bodyguards kept them back. One of the bodyguards ran up to Blake. It felt like they were talking. Then Blake started walking inside, but the bodyguard followed him and they halted. They were talking more and then a while later they both came down the stairs. Siera asks, what going on. Was he with the admins now.

I don't know, I said. He was here just 30 minutes ago, does that mean he broke into the admin building. That’s bold. Citradel bodyguards part ways a little to allow Blake to leave. People all gather around him in frenzy. So did the reporter. Blake kept waving his arms around and saying something to people. The reporter comes in, Prince Blake. Were you with the admins just now. Can you tell us what's going on. Blake turns to him and shoves around to him.

Blake says, no. I didn’t meet any admins. I was in the waiting area. I have been there since morning except for while when I went for lunch. This caused a stir among the people. On the other hand, my jaw hung low hearing at this blatant lie. He has just here. Why the heck is he lying. The reporter confused asks, wait. You have been there all this time and still haven't meet with the admins. Blake nods, that’s right. I wanted to get answers from them in the morning, but they didn't allow me in. So I have been waiting. I told the officers that I will wait here until I get answers.

Reporter asks, that’s incredible. Why didn't you tell anyone. He replies, well I did. I told the admins that I wanted answers, just like everyone. Initially, they had agreed to let me in. But then the Citradel officials said it was an internal matter and didn't want me there. Fortunately for them, I don't have to listen to them. I do listen to the admins, and they told I could wait outside, and that’s what I have been doing. Trying to pressure them by my presence. Whenever someone comes out and goes in, I am there to remind them I am the leader of this Island. And people have the right to at least know what they have been doing all this time.

He takes a beat. Looks around the crowd who had gone a little quitter as he spoke. I also told the officers not tell others I was here. I didn't want people to get any ideas and barge in like I did. I didn't want anyone but me to take responsibility for whatever happen later. But I didn't know that this would happen. Reporter immediately asks the follow up, you didn't know about this rally. He nods anxious, yeah. No one told me. And the rooms were soundproof. I was actually coming out to get dinner. Next thing I know, there's all these people who are also waiting for answers, like me. I tried to go back in, but it looks like I pushed my luck. Citradel doesn't want me even inside the building now. The people around him shout at the security line. Some begin to cheer for Blake now.

The next question comes in, so you are also clueless as rest of others. He nods, yes. I have tried to play this safe. But they are testing the limits. And now it looks like others are also worried. I am sure they are watching this right now from their conference room. So I ask them now. No, order them. Give me some answers now, or I am about to bust in. You guys are mocking my authority, and that will not go unnoticed. Not while you are here. He was displaying anger now. Not a lot, just enough to make others around him riled up.

He then abruptly waves of, apologies. I am hungry, and a little tired now. He creates path around the people and walks away. The reporter says, you heard it everyone. Our prince is spoken that he is doing whatever he can to get answers. I just hope Citradel listens to him and all these people here. The scene then changes to an arial view of Blake walking around.

I chuckle, now that's a performance. Even though he lied through his teeth, it doesn't look like he is worried one bit. He must have kept hidden himself while he was out moving around. I did remember he telling Marina about no one knowing he was here. Siera asks, what do you mean. I told her, I just meant he basically threatened Citradel now. Seria smirks, sometimes pressure is necessary. Its been almost 8 hours, so I understand how he feels. Imagine being a leader of millions of people, but not able to do anything about this. Anyone would be angered.

I pretty much understood Blake's plan. And I guess Marina's too. They were talking about breaking into the admins waiting area without anyone knowing. He purposely made it look like he was there all this time. And still didn't get any answers. It's a dicey, but a clever plan too. If I remember, there are no cameras outside the rooms in the buildings. So no one could tell he lied. And even if someone did realize that, this public appearance there can't be denied. The best option was for Citradel to come out now. If they delay it further, it would only make him and now the people furious.

I got up and took my bag. I turn to Siera, looks like that was the most highlight of this event. I better go and meet Catherine now. I spotted some of the people that are supposed to be guarding the guest houses. They may be frustrated, but also made my job tougher. I have to pull them out of there. And soon. I'll see you later then. Siera asks, okay. Text me if you want to have dinner at home also later. I nod and walked through the door.

Blake (Chapter 47)

Wednesday, September 17, 2025 18:53

That went well, considering it took Marina and me much longer to find a way without anyone noticing. Luther had texted me more than ten times before I came out. Once I left the crowd he found me, hey, you had me worried. You were late. I replied, only 20 minutes. I am not a magician, you know. I didn't expect this many people. Our ideal way in was gone, so we had to improvise. He asks, we, you mean someone helped you. Was he really going to ask me this. I didn't want to share our shadow tricks. When I didn't reply, he gasps and says, right, the less I know the better. I nod, yeah. Besides, we sent the message to Citradel.

He says, you adlibbed some of the things I wrote, but that’s fine though. I was curious about one thing though, you said to say I wasn't aware of the rally. Why did you want it that way. Won't people now ask why you all never told me. He replies, I know it was idea, but imagine this. What would Citradel think when they heard you knew about this and did nothing. They would think you can't control people hear. That just undermines your authority. We can't have them think that. Its much better to have deniability by having you claim you hade no idea. I have told others to say that if we let you knew about it, you would shut it down. In fact, I will say that you tried to tell me now. And I resisted.

That actually made sense. Then I had another thought, that be just as bad. Won't Citradel think we have no control over people if they can go behind our backs. He shook his head firmly, let them think that. Actually, I want them to think that. That was a surprise. He saw me confused and explains, look Citradels officials have better military infrastructure than us, there's no doubt. But they also have stifled peoples own voices. Their civil infrastructure has holes. Since they hide among humans, people can't openly voice concerns like how we can do here. They instead have to schedule, meet in secret and keep everything under wraps. Only the representatives can make things happen. And the ordinary people would have to hope it gets done from few people. This causes more miscommunications, different intentions, or even different result than anticipated.

He really put this much thought into it. He continuous, actually, it has happens quite often after speaking with some Citradel people I befriended. Obviously, Citradel knows this weakness, but they flaunt their authority by showing how secure and stable they have been for almost a decade. Compared to the other risker groups, they are the most reliable. I figured we can show our strength in this particular area, where they can't. I have explained others to also say that people living here can approach openly. We would focus on the benefits of living here. People will cast aside their doubts of whether this whole thing was right or wrong and reinforce our promise of better life here.

Damn. He planned for everything in just short time. I am impressed by Luther's political aptitude. He exceeded my expectations. I slapped his back in admiration, I think you joining us was the best decision ever. Luther laughs, so that means I can have a raise. I chuckle, aren't you in charge of it. He smiles, deflecting. You are learning. You will have to do this for a while until our cities merge. There is still much to do. He doesn't how true he was. If the announcement goes how I think it will, the following days are going to be completely busy.

My stomach grumbled. I was hungry, that wasn't a lie. I asked him, want to get dinner. He chuckles, so that’s true huh. You go on ahead. I had an early bite. I have to go back and explain what we discussed to the people. I have informed some more reporters to join in. I want to bolster these benefits myself. Better impact, hopefully. I say, okay. Good luck. See you later then. We waved each other off and went our separate ways. On my way to the dining building I passed few people who wanted to express their feelings. Some asked if I knew anything more, some thanked me for my perseverance. I tried to have a good poker face.

I checked my phone which was buzzing with messages from the officers. I scrolled past to see if anything useful was there apart from comments about my performance. Sometime later I reached the building and entered through the officers door. I could tell by the auras from the walls that there were already few people inside. I walked up the stairs and stepped inside the hall. About half the people were here. Most of them were the ones who worked remotely. As I walked to get food, I bumped fist with people who cheered on my apparent sudden appearance.

I pulled up my tray and start organizing my dinner selections. Behind me I saw Catherine coming in with her tray for a refill, so. How was your day. She asks me coyly. I don't know what she heard so I replied, you heard right. Boring and tiring. I am used to be patient, from my training, but man, spending almost 5 hours straight killed my back. Those seats are not comfortable. I should ask you to fix that. Whoever chose that clearly has no taste. She laughs lightly, oh really. You do know that I picked them personally after painstaking time and effort.

Shit. I didn't know that. I just assumed someone else did it. Honestly, I was in such hurry, I didn't even check if they were good or not. But I had to keep going this, well. Ah, then I suppose you have to change it. I didn't know you were had such poor judgement in selecting. Remind me not to ask you for my new office later. She pokes me hard on my side. I had to keep in a laugh and tray from falling. She smirks and whispers, I know what you were doing all day. Vanessa told me. So you can drop it.

I figured Vanessa would tell her since they had a meeting some time ago. Catherine and I finished up picking my food. She points me to the table she was sitting in. It was by the glass windows. I saw Nathan and Jess already there eating. I would have preferred to eat alone with Catherine. I guess I can't choose so freely. With a slight disappointment I pulled up a chair and sat. Jess asks, saw you in the TV. Gotta say, I didn't realize you were trying to get in this whole time. Some people noticed you, but only till lunch. She looked slightly impressed.

I nod and started eating not waiting any longer. Nathan asks, its very curious though. No one knew you were there. Not even Citradel people. Which is quite confusing. I asked him, what makes you say that. I just came out from the admin building. And didn't you hear me telling I saying I saw other people coming in and out. Nathan scoffs, I heard. Funny enough, you didn't say they saw you though. Makes me wonder if you were really there. That guy. He accuses with such conviction. I think he has more definite proof that I was lying. I continue chewing my food, you can believe whatever you want. What matters is what people believe. That’s all I am going to say about it.

He laughs while eating a salad, fair enough. Catherine asks, what happened to David. I tried to visit him a while ago when I had a break, but he wasn't in the infirmary. Did he woke up and left already. I gave some thought on how to answer this. I have been telling others vague answers, but I wanted to tell Catherine the truth. I turn to face Nathan. Then I wasn't sure what to say in front of me. Nathan caught on my hesitation and says, you don't want me to hear. Right. He laughs amused at my suspicions. He glances at others and says, don't worry. I am done with my dinner. I am going back to the auditorium. I have arranged for some fun activities for the participants to engage in. Keep their mind off all the other politics.

I wondered his definition of fun, don't tell me you are having some competitions. Come on. My guess is right when he pulls out a suspicious smile, its nothing too extreme. There is minimal bodily harm. I grunted a little as my food logged in my throat. I coughed a little, what the freak does that mean. He takes his tray and gets up, just kidding. See, I don't you he would believe me. He points to others sitting here and leaves amused at my surprise. Jess shook her head, don't listen to him. I got that now. She says, its just a gathering of top fighters. We have organized few of them before, but not with these many people. He wants to share some stories.

I ask, about what. Catherine replies, about what they did on Earth. We know what Citradel did, but not people. Not individually. He is hoping to gather more information about their technologies and research. That’s actually not a bad idea. Then I ask Jess, you don't want to go with him. She laughs, yeah right. Like I need people judging me with my history. If I went with Nate, we both have to lie about the time in valley, if it came up. She sighs, David has pretty much warned me not to speak about the past. He told me for anything like that, I should let Nate be alone.

That’s strange. I didn't know that. I asked, but Davids okay with Nathan's lying. Why. She shrugs, I don't know. Frankly, I am relieved. I don't want to discuss that devastating part of my life. Catherine says, but also you don't want to set the record straight too. You could tell the truth what really happened. Jess keeps silent. I understood her feeling about it very well. I backed her, leave it alone. She doesn't need to do anything. We all agreed, as long as Nathan behaves now, it doesn't matter now.

Catherine wasn't happy about it but she let it slide. Jess thanks me with a nod, so. Lets hear what you didn't want to Nathan to hear. I glanced around once more with my aura to see anyone listening in. Few people looked are way, but that’s just because they waved at me. It was okay to talk about. I swallowed a bite and explained what I could. Even though I knew it was safe to talk, it was still a public area. So I told the things me and Marina did today, except leaving out my name. I hinted my involvement and they caught now that I didn't want to expose the lie is said in TV. I told them Marina moved David to his actual house. I heighted about the Echo technology, submerging house and robots.

I wished I also told them about Dr. Drew. But David's mental health has to be hidden. At least until her assessment. After I finished that bit of story they both were amazed by it. Catherine shrieks, the hell kind of home is that. Jess laughs, weirdly, it suits him. Virtually unpredictable, hard to detect and easily accessible. It was strange he lived in that normal house. Guess it makes sense now. Catherine then has a thought, is it okay to tell us that. Didn't you said David wanted kept it hidden for some reason. I reply, maybe. I don't know his reasons. But if he really wanted to keep it hidden, he wouldn't have even told Marina about it. So I guess its fine. Even I am little offended he kept such huge place secret.

Jess asks, now I have to see it myself. Next time I see David, I am going to demand him to let me see it. Catherine laughs, me too. Why only you, I mean, Marina got to see it. I nod, I am sure there will be line of people wanting to see. I hear someone coming behind me, line of people for what. Its Matt. And behind him Cassandra. They both walked to us with a dinner tray. I turned around, you guys finally made it. I heard its stalls are still going on late.

They both took a seat facing each other. Cass says, yeah. Our shift finally got over. I can't believe we had to keep it open. Matt sighs, the banquet getting cancelled made the day terribly busy. I am going to get shut eyes as soon I get home. It wasn't just them, it was everyone. Everything that was planned for tomorrow, we had to prepone it today. It couldn't be helped, thankfully we got through the day. Cass says to me, your day was also rough. Saw your surprise appearance in the TV. Matt while eating asks, and oh man. I love how you basically threatened them. I denied, to be clear I didn't. He scoffs, yeah. Fine. A warning then. Whatever, I bet that smoked their ass.

I eyed Catherine without anyone noticing. She immediately understood to keep the lie for now. She then says, it will most definitely will. But listen to this. She and Jess told about David's secret place. It was hilarious seeing their expression when they heard. I laughed while eating my food. Matt slams his fist on the table lightly, echo killer robots. Are you freaking serious. I corrected him, no. Later M told there are actual killer robots. So what Marina faced was just a patrol unit. Cass laughs shaking her head, freak it. How the hell David keep this from us.

All of us began talking what the insides of his house would have. This was a much needed fun topic to decompress. Even when everyone had finished up their dinner, we discussed other things. Matt and Cass talked about their arduous day. There was an incident where Citradel and Island kids fought over something silly as comparing food. Honestly, I have been on edge whole day. Its been a very long day. From finding David's actual home, to finding about his illness and getting Citradel to hurry up. Its nice to distract however much I could, before the impending bombshells, I am certain, heading our way.

After this well needed respite I told others I am going to the deck to check my messages. They all were pretty engrossed in speculating things about future now. I was a little anxious hearing them discuss so I used that excuse to get some air. There were few people on the deck. I took a empty spot on the edge beside the wall. With my back against the wall I leaned on and closed my eyes. Truth was I was now getting worried and didn't them to see it. After gathering my thoughts, I opened my phone to see any messages from Marina.

I told her to let me know when David wakes up. No messages yet. Dammit. How long will David need his beauty sleep. Actually, this is normal for him. He always needed this much time to recover, especially after an hour of intense fight. But we can't afford him to rest too long. He has to himself tell people that he is awake. Marina and I have told people that he has gone home to rest. But I am sure people have visited his decoy home. I wonder how long we can put off this.

My thoughts got interrupted by girls voice, you look tiered. Catherine is in front of me. I stagger a little. I didn't even notice her aura approaching me. I really am tiered now. I nod, can't deny it. Its been a stressful day. I enjoyed speaking to you guys, but reality keeps pulling me away. She nods and leans beside me. She says, I can imagine. I also had to deal with very unpredictable things. Citradel families keep asking about their stay and security. Did

you know the families wanted to open the park again. It wasn't supposed to open until tomorrow, but we had no choice but to open it early. And so many other things to keep them occupied.

It wasn't like my day, but I could image being hard on her. I laugh, you know. I got reminded today that we need to get used to this new life. But let me tell you, its been very tough. All this new responsibilities, I can't even begin to think how crazy it will become later. She laughs, yeah. Sometimes I feel it was way easy earlier. Fighting Echos or waging revolution. It was simple life then. Only she would think it was easy. It was a different kind of crazy for everyone. She caught on, I know what you are thinking. I must be out of my mind. But sometimes I just wish we could have stayed like that.

I saw aura changing slightly. Her mood worsened a little. I realized what she was meant. But I was too anxious to talk about it. I don't want to bring that up right now. We both were silent for a while. The silent was actually worsening my nervousness. I gave up and asked, you mean wanting to stay with Ned. I risked it and asked her finally. She looked somber when I mentioned his name. Actually, this been a thing with her. She said ever since coming here, she has less contact with Ned. It must have strained on their long distance relationship on them. She didn't respond, but I did believe she was talking about him.

I whispered hesitantly, the tournaments over. Regardless whether the next match happens, you can take a little break and visit him. Immediately I wished I hadn't said that. Her aura dipped once again. I didn't know it had became a sour topic for her. I spoke, everything okay. You seemed concerned about it. The way she is behaving, don't tell me they broke up. I couldn't stop from being a little anxious about it. It was like I was expecting it to be true. I soon realize it was a nasty feeling to have.

I quickly reflected on myself and said, forget it. I was just carelessly saying without thinking about it. She finally broke her silence, no. Its fine. Really. Its actually a nice to hear you say it. That nasty feeling just grew more and I wanted to kick myself over it. I don't even know anymore what I was expecting. Did they broke up or not. I definitely can't ask her directly. She says in a somber voice, I have visited Ned few times now. I took your advice and used the routes which no would look. I have been able to go out with the excuse of getting shipments from Citradel. We have been making it work. And its been nice. But..

Something happened. I could tell. I waited for her to say what it was. I don't know what I was expecting. Did they really broke up. But then she sighs, David found out that I have been sneaking out. He found out somehow. I don't know how. Huh. That’s not what I wanted to hear. But then again I didn't want to be jealous like this. I thought I made sure no one would ever find out she has been visiting him. Then it hit me. I asked, you two are at odds ever since your match. Don't tell me its about this. She nods reluctantly, yeah. He caught me before our match. He flipped out when he figured out I lied about breaking up with Ned. I got so mad at him. Did he really think it was easy to do walk away from someone you have been with for 5 years.

So that’s what's going on. I askes, is he really so much against it. She nods vehemently, sometimes he can be such a jackass. I know his previous relationship with a human didn't end well. But that doesn't give him any right to tell me how to live or with whom. She smirks, it got so bad that I told him if I won the match he would back off. That was silly. I lost so miserably. I finally realize the scope of what she has been going through. I told her, it wasn't silly. It just showed how much you wanted to be with Ned. I felt like I was forcing myself to say these things.

She shakes her head, no. I have been giving it a lot of thought for a long time now. It is silly because I thought I was giving myself an out. Like how I could have avoided this conversation if I didn't myself came over to talk to you now. I wanted to blame David and become the reason I had to leave Ned. I'll be honest, I have no idea what she meant. Did she want to break up with Ned or not. She sees my confused face, its nuts right. Believe me, I know. That’s why I have avoided talking about it with anyone. I don't want to leave Ned, and at the same time I know I will have to. I can't stay in a Medrone city and still have a relationship with him.

I wanted to say something that could help her. But I had no clue how. I am not exactly feeling impartial here. I just hope she doesn't ask me what to do. She then asks me, maybe you can tell me. You are the only one who has been supportive of this. Do you think I should leave a doomed relationship or make it work. Dammit. I had no luck here. I really didn't want to say I want to say here. I could tell she was waiting for my undecisive ass to say something. But I didn't.

She understood something and laughs, sorry. Its wrong to ask you this. I have to figure it out myself. I wanted to assure her with something, so inspired from Luther I said, my advice is that you do whatever your hearts tell you. Whatever makes you happy. That's sad. I couldn't come up with anything original or specific. She replies, wow. That’s, well. Okay I guess. I laughed, yeah. I know it's bad. I wish I could tell you what's right. But I am not going to be like David and make you force it. She replies, thanks. I knew you would understand. I should talk to Ned to figure things out.

I nervously asked, wait. Does that mean when you lost your match David asked you not to talk to Ned. Would he really use that silly bet. If she told me this yesterday, I would say no. But after knowing so many secrets Davids hiding today, I can't say for sure. She immediately says, no he didn't. Actually, he said nothing. Whenever we spoke, it would be just about work or something unrelated. He also avoiding talking about it. She then thinks about something for a while. She continuous, can I borrow Marina's device. I think I should talk to David also and clear the air.

I hesitated on this. She asked, is something wrong. I can't use that device. I glanced around and didn't see any one close by. I wanted to tell her about it for a while, but when others came in, I pushed it for later. But now, I think she deserves to know. I whispered, listen to me. You absolutely can't tell this to anyone. You hear me. No one. She was taken a back by my seriousness. She nods. I lean in and say, its best you avoid him for a while. He is not in a stable condition currently. She got worried, what do you mean. You told us he is okay. I revealed to her, physically yes.

Her jaw opens when she realizes, you can't mean. He isn't fine mentally. I nod, yeah. I myself found out today with Marina. He had been suffering from PTSD and other issues. She yelled a little loud, what. How that happened. And what other issue. I told her the symptoms M told us. Then I explained about Dr. Drew and how he has been going to therapy for it. Catherin's reaction was just like us. She didn't even see a hint of that this whole time. I explained how he would have hid it and has been actually getting better.

She scoffs, until today. Is that what happened when you carried him out of the stadium. I nod, yeah. The poor bastard was half passed out by the time I got inside his tank. Imagine the repercussions it would have if the doctor declares him unfit for the next match. It was the thing stressing me out the most. Her eyes widens, wait. Do you think he behaved like that towards me because. I answers, yeah. When you told me, I had a feeling it could be related to it. David's not the type to deal such indelicately on such matters. Considering is own history. Catherin says, you know. I couldn't put my finger on it. But he has changed a little since the war. I thought it was because he got his memories. Now I know its more than that.

She then asks me a difficult question, why did he not tell anyone. People have been getting counselling and therapy for years. Why keep it a secret. I didn't want to tell the truth, that it was because he is also a shadow. I also didn't want to lie. I have already lied to others. I told her, you have to ask David that. Both, me and Marina have a long list of things to ask him. She relents, I see. Must be tough on you both especially. Shadow agents not knowing others secrets. I can imagine.

I am a little conflicted since she really can't imagine. David's true identity. She then asks, who else knows. I tell, no one besides me, you, Marina and Dr. Drew. She realizes the gravity of the situation, seriously. Until today no one knew. How did he manage to keep it a hidden. I knew he has a good poker face, but this is crazy. I offered, like Vanessa says. He is genius, but crazy also. So now you know. And that’s why I am asking you to not talk to him. I don't know how exactly, but he has gotten worse. He might not be in his best mindset to hash out your differences.

After giving it some thoughts she says, after everything I thought that he. Our conversation got interrupted by someone yelling, everyone, there's an announcement from Citradel coming on now. My body jerked up hearing some guy calling out inside. I told Catherine, remember what I told you. Keep some distance from David for a while. She also reacted to hearing that, and I didn't see her agreeing to what I said just now. I was too anxious to worry about it now, so decided I will talk to her again later. I hurried in. This is it. Its finally the time everything is decided.

Blake (Chapter 48)

Thursday, September 18, 2025 17:29

The air had become filled with suspense. Everyone were staring at the big wall screen on the opposite end of the dinning area. Right now it was showing the admins building entrance. Everyone here hurdled near the screen. Some people preferred to sit and see. Catherine and I were on the first floor, so it was the best view anyways. We found others near the glass railings leading to the stairs. Matt waves when he sees us, guys, here. We squeezed into gaps among our friends. I ask them, its not yet started.

Jess replies, no. But the news came telling that the announcement is being broadcasted now directly from the conference room. Matt says, the rally and your speech did the trick. They had to do it soon since you provoked them. I am actually relieved that this crazy plan actually worked. Its been only 45 minutes since I spoke, so I hoped they would not keep me waiting for long. Otherwise I would really do what I said about forcing in. Cass gasps, look. Its starting. All our eyes glue to the screen. The screen changed to show the conference room. There are only two people visible in the screen. Charles and Reinhart. They both were wearing the same dress since I saw them this morning. Charles looked much better now. There were still signs of bruises over his face. Other than that he looked fine. They were seated on the conference chairs and facing us.

Reinhart goes first, good evening everyone. Let me first get out say that I want to apologies to everyone for how long this took. It wasn't our intention to make people worry. The contents of the discussion varied and we had to make sure nothing was overlooked. Citradel officials were put in a difficult decision over what happened during the final match of the tournament. Primarily the deal between David and Charles made. We have come to decision now. I will let the person who proposed it in the first place explain it. Please refrain from asking any questions until the end. He waves towards Charles.

I gulp hard. My nerves were acting up little. What would he decide after talking to his wife. He wanted to talk to David. Will he still go ahead with it. Everything about the deal would be laid out now. Charles leans in and says, hello. Like he said, I do want to apologies my part of the chaos that happened. That said, it was necessary. As some of you heard, I had to talk with people from my house. That took longer than anticipated. And now, we are in agreement. He takes a pause, during my fight, David found something. He found out I can overdrive. But there's a problem, I can, he clears this throat, I could involuntarily hurt others. I don't have complete control. Its also has the same weakness as any other overdrive, burns out my Kuret very fast. In my case, I can't use Kuret for months. While its powerful, its also dangerous. When he figured it out, he was about to make me use it. I couldn't let that happen with a crowd in close proximity. So I temporary asked for a break.

Suddenly there were murmurs and whispers getting passed around in the crowd. Charles continues, like everyone, I am very interested in his multiple kuret trick. I want to fight with my full strength. So I gave David an ultimatum, either we could continue the match without my overdrive or if wait for a month till my kuret recharges enough to use overdrive. And as Reinhart announced in the morning, David choose the deal. And after a little bit of negotiating, we both agreed. And now I want to confirm one crucial part of the deal. I asked for more time, selfishly, so in return I offered a compromise. Something that I had to discuss with my house before telling anyone.

This is it. My heart picks up faster waiting for the highly anticipated decision. So much is riding on this, which only few people knew about it. Charles takes a short breath and smiles, I am delighted to tell you the Heraknus house as decided to leave Citradel and move here. That moment, everyone were silent. The conference room was also silent as here. People were confused, amazed and anxious about it. But I was elated. I put my fist up in air, yeah I whispered loudly. This is what I have been waiting to hear all day. The four people around me saw me excited and took turning looking at the screen and me. I was smiling and laughter escapes my lips. I felt a lot of pressure off my shoulders.

Then people broke the silence and a commotion started. Then he continues, this wasn't just a whim. I had been thinking about it for some time. Ever since seeing the Island in person and its people, the tournament, I found that we can live openly here. We have been hiding our existence on Medrine for 150 years. We had to hide on Earth as well. I am tried living like this. Its time we come out and live free. He makes a stern expression, it will be difficult. I have no doubt our people will find adjusting to a life without anonymity. But its time, after winning the war with Echo we are on the cusp of finally becoming a defiant force. Us hiding would only hinder that effort. So I took this opportunity and offered up the deal to David.

People began speaking in groups loudly now. Would they realize what this means. Charles says, my house also agrees with me. After I explained my vision and hope for the future, they understood. And I hope with time, even those unsure about it will realize it’s for the best for our future generation. I am grateful for all that Citradel did for us, but its time to move on. Now's the time to build up our forces, not just hiding. To all those who have supported in keeping our existence secret here at personal costs, I thank you. Please understand it was a heavy decision after seeing the benefits for my house. Hope you all will understand. Thank you.

He turns to Reinhart, who takes over, regarding the next match. Its going to be a little different. As Charles mentioned, his overdrive is dangerous. We have to add more safeguards. Other particular details will be coming later. For now, I can only tell it will take place a month later in the same stadium. Now, we will open for questions. Give us 2 minutes for Citradel officials and Charles to setup here. From the side, 4 more people came in. One of them was Kafar. During this time, people here began discussing.

Jess is the first to yell, holy shit. I can't believe Heraknus are coming to live with us. That’s huge. Her excitement was showing up with a smile. Matt says, whoa. He actually did it. He convinced them to move here. Catherine says, that’s great and all but don't forgot what Charles said earlier. His overdrive is not only dangerous, its uncontrollable. Convenient he left that part out. I nod, that might be because he didn't want to scare people. But yeah, you are right. He could have shared more. Cass says, doesn't matter. We know. And David knows. That’s what's more important.

She wasn't wrong. Charles might be okay with sharing his overdrive dangers to us, but maybe not to people he is going to live with. He probably wants to ease into this. Catherine asks me, is David seeing this. Is he awake. I shook my head. Matt asks, seriously. Its been close to 10 hours. Is he really fine. At this point even I was a little skeptical. Nothing I could do about it. Cass says, his crazy gamble paid off. With Heraknus moving here, how long until others as well.

That’s now a waiting game. I glanced at my phone which as now constantly getting buzzed with messages over the network. Now that the officers know the whole truth, they must be overjoyed to hear this. I took the opportunity to add this message, just to let you know, Citradel people would now follow Heraknus here. So that means we have won the tournament. I am sure people would eventually realize this, I promptly shared to let everyone know of our victory.

The break was over. Reinhart says, we now going to answers from questions. I looked up to the screen after posting the message. I can't tell how many reporters were inside, one asked, Charles. I have question for you. Since your reveal, there's one question everyone's been asking. Why were the Heraknus kept their existence a secret on Medrine. Charles take a moment to answer. He looks a little concerned, I am sorry. I can't answer that. Its not just me, but the decision of my entire house. I know its pretty selfish of us to not explain. What I can tell you is that it was due to a terrible and worst moment of our history 152 years ago before leaving Medrine. I wish I could explain. Maybe in time I will be able to tell. For now, you have to believe it was for a good reason. A reason no longer having any meaning now that Medrine is gone. One of the officials says, what matters now is that Heraknus are now allies and fighting with us. Our focus should be on this, rather than the past lost on a distant home planet.

That’s strange. Earlier he said he was okay with explaining to David the reasons. I suppose after discussing with his house, they made him not share it. What could have happened that was so bad they went into hiding. Another reporter asks, its sounds incredible that no one knew your existence. Someone must have known about you. Charles nods, yes. That’s true. Few people did know about us. Obviously, the towns and cities in the mountains were we lived. They were our bridge to outside world. We didn't live in complete isolation you know. We just didn't have our presence known. If you think about it, we are like the shadows. They also operate in secrecy sanctioned by nations. Similarly two important bloodlines knew about us. Handful of the Earatius and royal family knew about us. I later learned Marina didn't know about me in Citradel and realized they never told the kids.

Several people around us stare at me. I shrug, don't look at me. I also didn't knew. The faces leave me and focus on the next question, you said your overdrive is dangerous. Can you explain more. Charles turns a little uncomfortable answering this, I have same problems as Blakes. I am can't control it well. And like I told before, it takes months for me to recover, so I don't get enough chances to train. Its very hard to learn under such harsh circumstances. Back in Medrine, the delays only few weeks. But I wasn't the alpha for long there. That's why I want to take precautions. He kept the part of attacking others to himself. Looks like other Heraknus didn't want him revealing too much.

The same reported asked a follow up, you mentioned your lack of control comes from not having opportunities. Are you treating your match with David to learn. He nods, that’s exactly right. I rarely, if not ever, get chance to fight someone in my overdrive. I believe he is up to the task. If not, I would have never suggested it. A follow up question comes in, can we get any details about your overdrive. Charles smirks, apologies. I can't reveal it, for now. You know who my opponent is. He is someone highly intelligent and resourceful. I can't leave any information here that he can use it against me later. I have heard enough stories about him to know that I can't underestimate him.

Its good to see Charles giving David high praise, but internally I am conflicted. With his current condition, his performance has to be impacted. Next reporter asks, there's a rumor going on that David cheated during the match. No one can explain how his anti kuret is able to do the things he did. Does that concern you with the decision to move here. Shit. I can't believe this leaked out. Melinda told this was part of the reason their discussion took long. Charles remained silent, for sure he was also not expecting this. Reinhart took this question, let me answer this. Theres nothing suggesting that there was any foul play. No evidence to suggest this. This is just a baseless rumors. That’s a relief. I guess Kafar's accusations didn't have much impact.

Another reporter asks, no one has seen David since the match. He left the infirmary and hasn't been since then. Is that not a concern. Reinhart replies immediately, not at all. Everyone knows he doesn't heal fast, so he is just resting at home. I don't know how he would know. Did he just guess, or someone told him. The only thing people know for sure he left. No one knows if he is even awake.

A new line of question comes next, now that Citradel is going to lose the Heraknus house, can you tell how it will impact you. This one was directed to the officials. The other 3 people turned to Kafar. This whole time he looked stiff. He didn't show much emotion the whole interview. I think he is defeated and painfully frustrated. He was so confident that Charles would never lose and we would move to Citradel. But all those plans fell apart with this deal. And now, it won't matter who wins. Citradel will have no choice to follow Heraknus here. Lets see how he handles it.

Kafar's clears his throat, obviously this is a great loss to us. They were our most powerful group of team and efficient deterrent that kept Echo leader away from ever invading us for a decade. Even when they knew where we were. People never knew about them, but they are our most treasured warriors. I wish I could have persuaded them to wait until the next match. He looks to Charles for a second, but I also understand their predicaments. Citradel main reason to remain secure this long was because we prioritized developing lost technologies and providing safe place to hide. Things have changed since winning the war against the echo leaders group. Heraknus now have different priorities. That’s just how things go, nothing we can do. He sounded salty and resentful. Even though he says he understood, its just for show. He truly believes moving to Citradel is the right decision for us.

A reporter asks, what about the people of Citradel. Since your most powerful house is moving here, will they also move. This women asked the most important question. Only few us knew about the conditions and their implications. That was until now. Kafar didn't answer. Or rather he didn't want to. I don't think defiance is going to accomplish anything. Realistically, there is only option. One of the other official spoke instead. She's a middle aged women, we haven't decided that. When we planned the tournament, it was to show each cities warriors and their strength. As a way to inform all the other scattered people over the globe. Its true we also made an agreement that we would move to the winners city, but David only won on technicality. Charles still has the opportunity to win the second half match.

I am sure they outright can't say they will also move. There will be resistance to this huge decision. At least they didn't say no directly. This is actually the best answer they can say. Reinhart cuts in, guys we have taken took much of their time. They have been here all day. Especially Charles, he didn't get much rest since his match. I would only just one last questions. Other questions will be answered later. The final question came, can you tell us

when Heraknus are planning to move. Since it was a sudden development, there would have challenges.

Charles answers, I have discussed this. We don't have all of it ready yet. So far, we will be leaving tomorrow morning back to Citradel. I will have to manage everything there in person. Since its our own decision, I don't want to trouble Citradel with helping us. However, I do want Blake to help us organize the travel. We have 74 people in my house. The families have their own stuff, we have our armory and weapons. I would like help on secure ways to transport them here. Meanwhile, I am sure it will take some time to build homes for us. We used to live in mountains in Medrine, but we do live in proper houses. We our own their preference. I hope they can be meet here. Considering all this, we have a tentative plan of about 3 weeks. I am sure I will be here few days before my match.

I was expecting that. Looks like I need to get ready for this as well. Our plans for explains have to be pushed faster. Its unexpected, but welcomed. The faster we can bring them here, the better our chances that they don't go back on their word. Reinhart cuts in, okay. That’s all for now. There are lot to be discussed, but lets table that for now. Thank you everyone for your patience. The people got up from their chairs began walking off screen.

The atmosphere here became full of exhilaration. People were cheering and applauding. It became chaotic, but for a good reason. People were relieved to here this. Actually more than ever. Catherine sighs happily, so I guess I have important work coming on soon. I nod, for everyone. But yeah, you will be travelling a lot I suppose. With her kuret, she has been guiding and managing bringing people from all over the countries. And she been to Citradel the most. She would the secure routes and ways to travel incognito.

Matt howls, hell yeah. We won. I don't care what that lady said, there is no way Citradel would do nothing as they lose Heraknus. Cass smiles, when they see their prized warriors leaving, they would have no choice. I say, it really depends, but I don't see how they can replace the loss. Jess says, imagine how it would be like if to know that secret team is a mythical bloodline. Right now the people might be in shock, once they get over that they will decide whether to stay or not.

Matt says a little excited, I know I am just spit balling here, but just imagine David winning. That would definitely be a decided then, right. Catherine says, if he won. Didn't I tell you earlier, Charles overdrive is dangerous. And David is. She shot me a look of concern. I shook slightly to warn her not to tell others. Matt shook his head, I didn't forget. But come on. This is David we are talking about. You saw him today. He is on fire. I'll admit I was worried earlier, but I think he will be fine now. I mean, think about it. He himself said he has a month time to master his new Kuret form. Cass had the same opinion, and don't forget about his strange new ability to use others Kuret. I also feel he has a good chance of winning.

I didn't have the heart to tell them that he wasn't in the best condition right now. Jess says, Catherine, I know you are worried about him. But don't forget he has knack for getting what he wants. Catherine felt conflicted, just like me. Now I am feeling a little guilty sharing this to her. Maybe I shouldn't have. But I wanted to tell her the most. She and David have been oddly similar in their thinking. And also, their argument could be due to that as well. I just hope it wasn't a mistake.

I made up my mind about something, guys. Lets not get carried away. Not until David wakes up and tell us himself. I am sure its not just you, soon everyone would wonder about this. Weather David wins or not, the most important thing is we got our objective. Okay, maybe not completely. But I bet it will become clear when Heraknus moves here in 3 weeks. Actually, I think with this revelation, it’s a good assumption people all over the world would join us. That what's important. And I want all of you to also mention this to others. I don't want to pressure David more than he already is in.

They all agreed and understood my intentions. Matt says, Cass, lets go celebrate our win. Lets go get a drink. Cass was surprised, really didn't you said you were beat and wanted to go home. Matt scoffs, after this I am wide awake. Come on, lets call in others too. We can have a party at Catherines place. She shot a look a resentment at her name, hell no. The last time you guys came in, you all left a big mess. Go do it some place else. I actually want to sleep now. Matt smiles, oh come on. When Catherine should more reluctance, Cass says, its fine. I also want to have a drink. Lets do it your place Blake.

Now I became the target. I was worried about many things. Maybe a night off is what I needed. I at least deserve this much, yeah. I am down. I was also tiered. But now I too much excited to sleep. I turn to Catherine, you sure you don't want to join. She shook, I need an early head start tomorrow. So I am going back home. Before I can stop her, she already left us. I asked her to wait, but she didn't listen and disappeared in the crowd. I can't really blame her, I did tell her about David's secret.

Matt asks, Jess you in. Jess looks over to me. I say, I have no problem. Matt says, I know I am being rude, but don’t invite Nathan, he would only bring down the mood. Jess smirks, don't worry. I wasn't planning to. He messaged me a while ago, he is staying late with his group of warriors. Matt cheers, great. Lets see if Tessa and Vanessa can also make it. I also messaged Marina to meet us at my place. It didn't even take a minute before she responds she is in.

She also added that she is bringing her special home brewed drinks. I sighed. Great, a drunk shadow is what our predecessors never would have imagined us doing.

David (Chapter 49)

Thursday, September 18, 2025 23:11

I am looking over a corpse. No. a dying one. Then another one. Then others. I have seen them before. Many times. This is a nightmare. I could felt my body was weighed down. Why was it. I didn't need to look far to realize, it was the guilt. This is what happened on the last day on Medrine. They all died, I survived. Somehow I was spared. I felt the blood of others on me as I fall on the debris. Where was this. I know this. Where have I seen it. I felt an explosion behind me.

My body is paralyzed. I couldn't even move an inch. I turn my head, the view changes sideways to a burning ground. The heat felt so hot, it was searing my skin. My vision is distorted from the fire consuming everything around me. I hear someone beside me. They were shouting something, but my ears were ringing too loudly to make out what they were saying. Soon my vision turns blurry to see a two figure moving around me. One of them was big and clearing the debris around us. The smaller one was kneeling down on both legs and doing something. What's going on. Who are they. Like a hammer drilling into my head, I felt a bone chilling pain. I cry out in agony, but no voice came out. Or maybe I couldn't hear it because my ears hadn't stopped ringing.

The taller figure comes closer to me and speaks something inaudible to me. I hear only muffle noises. The tall figure moves over me and begins to moves his arms over me. I didn't understand what it wanted to do. Then I realize it wasn't just gilt weighing me down. I was actually buried in debris from the explosion. The figure is removing it from me. My body gradually begins to feel lighter. Soon I could hear the figures voice better, can you hear me. I am getting you out of here. It's Hanson. His voice is still muffled, but I know its him. I couldn't reply. My body is still paralyzed.

He pulls me out and carries me up with his arms. Like a lifeless doll he carries me out from what looks like a mini crater in the ground. What was it. Slowly I began to remember. We are boarding the ship. I am in the dantlement base in the Tangela empire. I remember an explosion before I boarded. Hansen lays me down at the edge, I need to help others. I am too dazed to remember who were others. Then it came back to me, Brandon and Zakerine. I wanted to help too, but my arms won't budge even a little.

I had no choice but to wait from them. Then I heard a screaming voice. A girls voice, let me go. He is still alive. I can save him. Its Zakerine, she is yelling and crying. I vaguely see Handen carrying her on his arms, listen to me. There's nothing we can do now. He screams over her own. He says, you can still make it. You both can. He comes out of the ground with a kicking and shouting Zakerine on him. She tries to resist and free herself from him, but he persists to carry her away. She yells, let me go. He can heal. He can't die. He promised me we both are leaving together. Her voice is breaking from her cries and wailings.

Hanson says, not from this. You know that. Don't let their death be in vain. John wouldn't want that. He wants you to escape. What. Even with my mind in scrambles, I couldn't believe what I heard. John is dead. How is that possible. I didn't saw him earlier. I don't understand what's going on. What happened to Brandon. Just then I heard the sky creating huge noises in front of us. My head is still not moving, so I roll my eyes instinctively. Two ships were zipping towards us from the edge. A chill went down my throat. They are here, somehow they found us again.

Hanson says with a stern voice, so two made it through the defense line. I expected them reaching here, but not so soon. He grits his teeth as Zakerine took her chance and brake away from Hanson. He shouts behind her as she rans back into the hole in the ground, what the hell are you doing. We have to go now. But she didn't listen, instead she used her kuret to pulverize the large debris. Hansen turns to me look at me. My vision was clean enough to see his bruised and battered face. Blood slipping down his forehead. Then he turns to the sky. The two ships begin firing at our ship.

Their weapons fired blue streams of missiles. Our ship was still grounded, and it couldn't evade it. No. This can't be happening. Our ship wasn't fully active, it was still charging. Those shields will not be up in time. I tried to move, to warn them. A rather useless move since I can't move at all. I closed my eyes to avoid watching the horror about to unfold. I felt a big tug from my shoulder like someone dragged me. Then came a large crushing noise, so loud that pales in comparison to the previous explosion.

My body stopped getting dragged and I stumble inside the hole. I open my eyes in a confusion on what happened. I saw Hansen pulling me back inside. He says confidently, just in time. We got reinforcements. Don't lose hope just yet. Your guys are escaping no matter what. I couldn't see what happened, but I saw many kuret waves in the air. The two Echo ships were still firing, but they were pointed to other targets. Something I can't see from here. Hanson turns to Zakerine, Z, we need to leave. We don't what other reinforcement are on the way.

However, she wasn't going to back down. Now that I was back in the hole, I could see what happened earlier. She is using her Kuret on a body lying on the ground. My heart beats faster while my blood freezes. Its John that's laying on his back covered in blood. His mouth gushed out blood flowing into the ground. My eyes widen when I focus on his eyes. They were open, staring into the sky unblinking. He is dead. Zakerine is trying to revive him by transporting his blood inside. She scooped up his blood with her bare hand from the ground and uses her kuret to open a channel inside his body. I wanted to help her, but what can I do with this useless body I have. I still can't move.

I dart my eyes over to the another body lying beside him. It's Brandon. He is also not moving. My heart sunk down further into despair. His covered in debris and pool of his own blood. His neck cocked to the other side. No. No. Not him. This can't be happening. Even after seeing so many bodies, I still am haunted by another one. Hansen comes over to my view, kneeling down and dragging himself towards a wailing Zakerine. She kept using her kuret fiercely transplanting Johns blood back inside. Hanson says, stop. Save your strength. There is no point. He lost more than just his blood.

I can't see from here, however, I could tell there was a big hole on his stomach. No, I wanted to say. He can be saved. They both have to be alive. I could tell my rational part of the brain was gone. I couldn't think straight anymore. Hanson puts his arms over Zakerine and tries to pull her away. She rebels with fierce intensity. She elbows Hansen in his stomach and gets shoved back. She yells, get out of my way. I will save him. He isn't dying. Hansen stumbles backwards on his back towards me. He spats out, snap out of it. I know you much he meant to you, but you have another one who needs your help. He can't move at all. I have lost too much kuret. I need you to carry him to the ship.

She didn't budge, she continued with her pursuit in reviving John. I wanted to help her, and yet again I am reminded of my uselessness. She cries out, he protected me from that blast. Stupid. He pushed me down before I could react. I am not letting him die. Hansen barks, I know. Brandon saved us too. They were true soldiers. So are you. Don't let their sacrifice be in vain. They didn't save us just to be killed later. So lets leave. She shouts back, I don't care about shadows. I only care about John.

I can't tell what's worse. Zakerine trying to revive a dead body. Hansen unable to pull away her. Or a strange nasty feeling that she didn't even care about. No. I am going crazy. She is just in shock. Seeing her thralling like this jerked me out of statis. I am able to focus a little now. I am still angered with their deaths. However, I also don't want to waste it by staying here. I try to open my mouth, nothing came out. Then I tried moving my hands. I felt a little bit sensations in my fingers. I began tapping on the ground, hopping it would get her attention.

Someone did realize I am trying to reach out. It was Hansen. He turns to me while still lying down on his sides. He saw my hand. He immediately understood and says, Zakerine look. He also wants you two stop. He needs our help. So please stop this. I thought she would listen to his pleas. But both of us where wrong. She didn't even stop for a second. I couldn't tell how much blood she has transported into Johns veins. But their were no signs of life returning in his body. Hansen shouted again, but was cut mid sentence when a ship's noise became louder.

I heard the sound of ground erupting around us. And it was getting closer. Hanson grew desperate in his attempts. He grabbed Zakerine on her waist and pulls her back. She rebukes him and wrangles her arms to get free of him. But Hansen was more determined. With a tighter grip, he drags himself and Zakerine across the debris filled hole. He slithers closed to me and pushes closer towards me. He pulls his body over the two of us. Zakerine yells her lungs out, creaming and waving her hands towards the other side.

The sound of erupting ground became louder. The debris were now flying all over us. I couldn't hear Zakerine scream over the noise approaching us. She kept trying to shove Hansen while pointing to John's body. Which was now riddled with a barrage of attack. I couldn't control myself from feeling nauseous when I see both their bodies being pulverized. My eyes become blurry with tears. I tried to close my eyes, but this time I was too afraid to close them. The countless rounds of attack kept moving, like nothing happened from one end of the hole to the other. I was too much in shock to know if we were also hit.

Once the sound of the attack subsides, Hanson moves a little. Zakerine is now hysterias with madness calling out Johns name. She pushes Hansen away, he grunts and rolls down. She drags her body to where John and Brandons body were seconds ago. A whole new layer of dirt and stones covered us. Hansen shouts, Z, don't. We need to move. As she drags on all fours, kicking and pushing away all the debris in path, she says, shut the hell up. I can still save him.

This is too much for her. She has lost it. I can't see them anywhere, but Their bodies must have been torn into pieces. There were blood stains in their places. I felt I could pass out anytime seeing so much blood and carnage. I pushed myself from getting lost. I have to focus on getting Zakerine out. Even when there is a blood coming from Zakerine as she dragged away, I kept trying to move my hands. Hanson also saw it and shouts, Z, stop. You are bleeding. Why didn't you use your kuret to protect yourself.

Hansen crawls behind her. She spats in anger, I can still save him. I need to save my Kuret for him. She's far too gone. There is no one there anymore, yet she continues to struggle. She was hurt and couldn't move properly. Hansen got up slowly and slid across the ground. He puts his arms on hers and pins her on the ground stomach first, stop this. Focus on healing. You are bleeding too much. She struggles to get free from his grip, let me go. I will use all my kuret to save him.

Her rant is becoming more deranged by the second. Hansen calls her out, he is gone. Theres nothing. But you are still alive, help yourself. Heal. Now. She didn't listen, she didn't use her kuret. More blood pours from her on the ground. A sharp tug pulled in my stomach. At this rate, she will loose too much. I try to tap my fingers more louder. But it wasn't going to reach them. Zakerine had completely lost touch with reality. Hansen yelps, Zakerine. Stop this. Heal your wounds before its too late. Save yourself. We waited for few seconds, but nothing happened. She either wasn't listening or refused him.

Hansen kept trying to convince her to focus on healing. But she never did. The pit in my stomach grew. I kept thrashing my fingers on the ground, thinking she will listen. Then it happened. The moment of complete dread. Her arms and legs struggle less and less. And then, the inevitably they stopped. Hansen looked distraught when she lies still on the ground. He shouts, no. no. Wake the hell up. At that moment, I stopped breathing. My heart left like it was just a rock pulling me down. This can't be happening. Hansen moves her body from below and lays her on her back. Her entire body is covered in streams of blood. From her face to her abdomen. I saw a large wound on the waist. The last attack, she was hit there.

In my utter despair, I tried to move with all the strength left in me. Nothing happened. I cursed myself and kept trying. Hansen shakes a lifeless Zakerine from her shoulders, Z, come on. Heal. You hear me. You can't give up. Her face looked tired and her eyes stared unceasingly disconnected to reality. My effort to move didn't yield any result. I saw the slivers of life draining from her. It felt like it was coming out of me too. No matter how much I shouted from inside my mind, she never heard it.

Hansen kept calling her name and shook her vigorously. Her necks suddenly tilts sideways towards me. The last of her life slipping away. I could only watch in horror as I see her kuret and life leaving her eyes. Blood gushes out from the corners of her mouth when she opens it. She struggles while whispering, I am sorry. I have to tell you something. Hansen shouts over her, no. Save your breath. There is still time. She ignores him and coughs

out more blood, my, our, secret. We should have told you before. Its…

Just then her mouth stops moving. Here eyes becomes vacant. No kuret. No life. Nothing. I can't see anything in them anymore. My heart felt it was literally going to be torn into pieces. I can't let her die. I won't. I have to save her. Hansen kept trying to pound on her chest, don't die. You can't. The continues drumming on her chest does nothing. Hansen slumps on his legs beside her body. I shout at him to keep trying. Don't stop, I kept saying in my mind. He saw me looking their way. He looked defeated.

He speaks to me in a slow somber voice, she's gone. My mind went blank. I couldn't save her. I couldn't save anyone. This is a nightmare. Yes, it is. I just need to wake up from it. Then everyone will be back. I will wake up from this horrible nightmare and be back in my room. I could see Zakerine, John and others in the shadow training grounds. Everyone will be alive and happy again. I kept trying to leave this nightmare, but I wasn't waking up. This can't be real. It has to be fake.

Hansen voice cuts in, lets go. We have no choice now. If I can save you, I could at least do one thing right. I hear Hansen footsteps getting closer to me. Just then a huge noise came from above us. I look up into the sky. One of the ships were directly on top of us. This is it. I could see our end now. There is no way Hansen can get himself or me from out of here now. I wished to wake up from this horror reality. Hansen yells to the sky, you haven't won. Even if I die, you won't be able to kill our future. His voice is trembling with fear. He is scared.

Then came a flash of bright light. That’s it. Yes, finally. I am walking up from this retched reality. But it wasn't what I expected. The ship blew up from the middle. Pieces of burning pieces shoot down from the sky. A figure came down from the Echos ship. It's a person. I couldn't see the persons face. I couldn't tell from the Kuret who it was. This person covered in dirt and lands down slowly between Hansen and me. With his back facing me he turns to Hansen, who was shocked to see this person. He asks, how are you here. I heard you were on the other side of the shore.

The mysteries person says, I was. Then I heard a warning about few encroachment ships crossing the border. I knew this would turn into a bloodbath, but I had. He suddenly pauses. He looks to the ground and sees Zakerine body. He crouches down and puts his arm on her chest. He hesitantly says, she died. I was too late. Another thing I couldn't stop from happening. I didn't understand what's happening. I didn't care anymore. Hansen voice breaks down, I couldn't save her. Her death was completely my fault. Even with Branden and John saving us, she died. His voice filled with regret.

The person stands back up. He speaking in a stern tone, I know you did your best. It was her own decision. Don't blame yourself. Hansen jerks up staring at the person, you saw. No, You knew. But then why didn't. The person cuts him off, I warned her. And I hoped she would make the correct choice. But I can't control someone's destiny. No matter how much I want to. I have tried numerous times. The best I can do is nudge in the path we need to go.

Hansen was silent for a long time. Then he pull himself up, you are right. We haven't lost yet. The person replies, that’s right. This is just the beginning. I am here to make sure that. Hansen walks to me and pulls me up. I didn't have any strength in me to even resist. I didn't want to leave Zakerine. Her lifeless body lying there reminded of my failure. If only I could fight back, only if I was stronger, I could have protected her.

Hansen pulls me up in his arms and asks, are there more of those ships. The person says, not anymore. I destroyed the rest coming here. We should be fine for a while, at least until the ship is fully operational. Hansen carries my in his arms and walks out of the hole. The other person follows us from behind. Hansen asks, is he going to all right. I am worried about him. He has seen too much. The person didn't reply for a while. Then he says, eventually, yes. The scars from today is not something he will be able to overcome soon. But it will happen. Hansen says, what happens to others meanwhile. He will be emotionally damaged, he can't help others in this state.

We reach near the ship now. I felt the silent humming of the engine coming off it. The hanger was still open. The person replies, trust in your successor. And trust in the other kids. They will find their own way. Hansen brings me closer to the entrance of the hanger. Two people come outside to meet us. One says, your made it. Well done. Where's is she. Hansen steps forward, she couldn't make it. Take him instead. The other guy shouts, what. No. But she was just here.

Hansen says, she got caught in the attack from the last two ships. Take him instead. The first person says, but he is not authorized. We have a strict list of kids to take in. We can't take him. The second person says, we even had to replace the Baratheon kid from her brother just now. Is there any relative left that can replace Zakerine. Hansen shouts in anger, she was last of her bloodline. Just a while ago before dying she turned from alpha to omega. There is no one to replace her. So take him.

The two guys were shocked and stayed silent. The mystery guy says, listen to me, you don't have much time. Other Echo ships will be soon here. Check the reserve list. Search for the name David. The first guy pulls out a kuret device from his pocket. It opens to a display and he searches for it. A moment later he says, yes. His name was added as a priority. The second person relieved says, is that right. Then we will take him. Is he okay. He isn't moving.
☐Hansen hands me over to the person. I felt no sensation as he hands me over to that person. I didn't even feel anger being handled like this. I just wanted to leave this nightmare. The mys
details in his directives. Make sure you follow everything it says, no matter how absurd it sounds. Follow it to the end without a single mistake. Do that and I guarantee he will survive this. The person holding me says, I understand. We promise to protect all the kids onboard this ship.

The person then carries me inside. I didn't have even the strength to resist leaving Hansen. Hansen behind me says, don't forget what I told you. Survive, no matter what. You will become stronger. Do it for others, but more importantly, for yourself. And if luck allows us, we will meet again somehow. I didn't understand a word he said. He said with such convictions that made no sense. He probably also lost it like Zakerine. The mystery person steps closer to Hansen and puts his hands on his shoulder, come. Like you said, this isn't over yet. We have work to do. Hansen says, lets go. They both turn and walk away, leaving me like this.

That was my last coherent thoughts of Medrine. I saw the insides of the ship with blurry images. Nothing resisted to me as the man carried me inside to who knows where.

David (Chapter 50)

Monday, September 22, 2025 19:55

All I saw see is darkness. Nothing. My mind is completely disoriented, so is my body. Where am I. Then my eyes open flew open immediately. Bright light encompasses my view, jarring me out from the nothingness. My body jerked around figuring out what's going on. Gradually my eyes adjust to the light. I see something familiar as I stare at the white ceiling. I rack my brain trying to figure out what happened to me. Then I see movement on my side. I turn my head to see the source, which turned out to be something big and dark.

Its familiar, why can't I remember. My vision becomes focused and I see what it was clearly. Its an Echo. My heart went wild uncontrollably. My lazy senses became sharp at the sudden anger swelling inside me. Just on raw instincts I forced myself up. I could vaguely feel I was in a bed. The Echo was twice as large as me, with long arms and a weird head. I don't care who it looked like. They killed everyone I cared. Zakerine, John, Brandon and Hansen. Their names came to me before my own.

I didn't care to check where I was. I got out of my bed and attacked that echo with a fist. The Echo didn't block and instead took it squarely. There was large sound coming from around us. But I am on a rampage. My mind solely targeting it. I punched another time, even kicked barefooted. The pain coming from my hands and foot didn't even register. I continued attacking on my instincts. The Echo didn't fight back. It just stumbles back without falling down.

My anger grew, I shouted at the top of voice, I am going to kill you. And your king. You hear me. My barrage of fists unceasingly pushed the Echo back. There was a voice saying something, but all I am thinking about is killing the Echo. Suddenly I felt something surrounding me by my torso. It felt like straps is covering me slowly around my arms and legs. I yell, don't even try to stop me. I am going to freaking kill you. My mind is laser focused on fighting, I didn't care about the restraints I am about to be in.

The straps becomes tighter and I felt my movement become restraint. I struggled to get out of it. This triggered the memories of Zakerine and how Hansen had to drag her away. That made me even madder and I lashed out like an animal. I felt a small prick hitting me in my neck. I immediately leaned away shouting, get your freaking hands away from me. Suddenly I felt a wave of chill running through my blood. I felt my body becoming colder. No, I can't die. Not before I kill all the Echos. I kept shouting and struggling to get out.

A second later a sharp sting passes through my brain and spine. I close my eyes from that disorientation and jerk my head around to shake it off. A second later I stopped my arms and legs from lashing around. Wait, what happened. Why am I being like this. Gradually I able to think more about me and my surroundings. My thoughts become more cognizant as each moment passes. I rolled my eyes around the room I was in. I know this place, and then I realize its my room. Its my table, bed, windows and fridge. Everything like I recalled.

Like a wave crashing, my memories flood my thoughts. Dammit. I know now what I am doing. This is not Medrine. I had another night terror. I had to relieve my final day on Medrine. Just like during the match, I was able to recall my memories better now. I witnesses their death with more details now. The conversations that eluded me earlier was clear now. I can't believe there was a chance to save Zakerine. Hansen did his best, but her stubbornness got her killed. How did I not remember this. I thought she was hit from the stray attacks and died protecting me. But that’s only half true. She could have healed in time. I recalled Hansens desperate attempts to snap her out of her delusion.

Its strange, but I can't stop feeling confused and anger at her. We were all close friends, but we were also shadow. She was in training for this. And also I can't believe she chose him over me. We were supposed to be together, no matter what. I immediately threw that horrendous thought from my mind. She was distraught about losing John. I was the same. I don't know she experienced before that, she must have been through more than just that moment. But still, it pains to realize she could have lived if she just gave up on John. Branden and John gave their life protecting us three, and somehow only I survived. She could have lived too if I was so helpless back then. My mouth dried a little with this revelation.

And then there was the person who saved us. I can't recall who he was. Maybe the memories are still incomplete, but that doesn't make sense. Why I can't remember only him. I must not focused on him at that moment. Makes sense, I was not in my right mind after witnessing their deaths. So who was he. What did he know about Zakerine and me. The way he said things, like he has been in contact with Hansen and us for a while. I don't understand how anyone outside of shadows would be. Hansen seemed very trusting of him. More than that, he probably knew him. I know all shadow members, present and past. He wasn't in that gathering.

The way he destroyed the ship and landed on the ground, there wasn't any kuret around him. I didn't have the abilities to see them back then, but to destroy a ship singlehandedly so easily, his kuret must be strong enough to seen physically. Yet, nothing. I don't recall any kuret around him. Just who is this person who is this strong and trusting of Hansen. No matter how long I thought, I couldn't figure out. I refused to believe he was a random person helping out. But its also true I can't figure it out right now.

I let out a big sigh, its okay now. ART, you can release me now. The bindings on me begins loosening. My arms free first and then other body parts. I stumble a little as I regain my stance. Number 3, the one I attacked was just waiting in front of me. A hologram comes from the walls to my side. It was M, vitals stabilized. Sedative effective at 88%. Are you feeling better now.

I actually did. I nod at her. I look to my back and see two other Echo bots, Number 1 and 2. I shook my head in distraught. I really thought the last time was final. I haven't had a night scare for long time. I still haven't gotten it out of my system. I turn to the display in front of me that was monitoring my vitals. The time at the corner showed 2:18 AM. Jeez. I have been asleep for about 16 hours. I look down to see a white medical dress on me. Then I look down on my hands. My knuckles were bruised and few drops of blood fell to floor. My toes were also similar condition. I grit my teeth in anger. I totally lost it this time. All the previous times, I am scared. But this time went beyond just shouting. I put my hands down suddenly feeling tired.

M says, boss, you should to lie down. The modified sedatives are very powerful. I had lost all any resistance and just listened to her as I lay back on the bed. M says, one and two, sterilize the floor. Three, bring the prepared electrolytes and medicines. Three runs off on his wheels through the door. The other two prepare to clean up the blood from the floor. I leaned my back on the pillow, what happened. How did I get here. M replies, you were brought here by Blake and Marina.

That’s surprising, since I didn't gave Marina's device the authority to call ART. I ask, how that happened. M says, unclear. ART received an decommissioned onboarding request. Instead of denying it, he decided to follow protocol with a risk assessment protocol. I recalled what that meant. I laugh lightly imagining what those two must have faced, they must have been surprised. M continues, the patrol bots brought you in and we dived back into the ocean. Three hours from now, your tank device cleared your recovery and so we pulled you out and into the bed. We are currently 700 meters below surface sitting on a underwater reef edge.

One and two finished cleaning the floor. Then they took bandages kept at the corner and rolled on each side of the bed. M says, boss, we need to disinfect the scratches on your hands and foot. I understood and spread out my hands and legs. They each take one hand and began cleaning with disinfectors.

Then three returned carrying multiple trays on him. With his four arms he dexterously places them beside me on the side table. Apart from the food and drinks, I don't remember adding other stuff here. I ask M, what's this. Did you add stuff without me knowing. M's hologram walks near the spread on the side tables and waves, these are the usual. And these, pointing to the new stuff, are the recommendation from Dr Drew. I realize something from this. Drew knows about my episode. Shit. I remember now, just before passing out I told Blake and Marina about her. I ask M, tell me everything I missed. I have a feeling a lot of things have happened now.

I listened to M explaining all the conversation recorded from Marina watch during the day. I asked M to cut out any personal logs. Once the bots cleaned up and bandaged my cuts, I grabbed all the food. After settling down my hunger rose up. I drank and chewed on as I listened all the conversations Marina had. I had to endure her complains about my illness and the security of my home. Although I knew she was right. I shouldn't have kept about my therapy a secret. From both of them. They both were rightly angry that I evaded the psychological tests when I entered the tournament. Listening to this discussion was somehow more painful than imagining being there myself.

I felt Marina's frustration over the recording when Drew denied about knowing me or treating me. And seems like she gave Marina a little bit of attitude. Drew told her to leave her house and not bother her family. She made plans with Blake to ask her later in person. I was eager to find out how that would go. I made an agreement with Drew I wouldn't tell anyone unless its life or death. This may qualify or not is entirely up to her to decide. When I heard their plan to move me, I was shocked to learn Marina had a way to get ART out of standby mode. She visited ART just once, way before all the new modifications and security I placed. How is she going to do. I didn't the answer immediately. For more than hour after her call with Blake, I only heard rustling and movement. The GPS showed she visited multiple places inside her home. It sounded like she was searching for something.

I chuckle when Blake explained what he did to pressure the admins and Citradel. That was a genius idea. He also used it as a cover to get me here. I didn't to listen to his side of conversations, but I imagined other officers improved upon it. It was a cruel suspense until Marina told Blake showed something that would summon ART. That’s strange. I couldn't figure out what it could be. All the remotes is accounted for. There is no way she could break any of ART's firewall. Also M would notice if anyone tried to breach. It was both mystery and amusing to hear them shocked when ART onboarded the Island. A smile appear on my face I hear them freak out a little when the petrol bots inspects them. Then my smile vanished when I heard Marina stole the remote from me.

I call out, M, how the hell you not notice her stealing. We have a 135 cameras in this house. M replies, I didn't see any irregularities. A while later she continuous, it seems I have discovered a small flaw. Unfortunately, ART can't detect movement of objects smaller than 20 centimeters that are not tagged before. The disposed pile were tagged together, not individually. I close my eyes irritated a little, your telling me it some dumb luck. That’s crazy. Add it to the ARTs vulnerabilities list. M notes, added 384 item. Looks like ARTs been busy figuring out his own issues. That’s good, but on the other side, the numbers too high.

Then I resume the recordings. I came across a very anxious topic of my health being discussed now. Drew was reluctant to speak at first. Hope she isn't still upset. When Drew said she wanted me not to fight the next match, I become conflicted. I was painfully aware that her reasoning and advices were spot on. Once those two convince her to assess me first, I was too much mortified at my selfishness. I have troubled those two more than I anticipated by telling about Drew.

I felt naked and annoyed at my secrets getting peeled off one by one. I kept doubting my decision to tell them when I was passing out. I didn't consider anyone. Not them, or anyone else. It looked like they didn't tell anyone, but maybe they told people later. My mind began reeling from imagining the aftermath once people realize I hide my condition.

What would Vanessa do. She probably scold me or even get physical. Everyone will. I risked our future. In my defense, Drew and I agreed I was stable enough to enter the tournament. And I trust her more than myself on this matter. My relapse at such a critical junction is a affront to all the progress I made. I can't even begin how to explain this to others. I have to tell others. But I can't think about it. Its too much. So for now I continued on the conversations.

I ask M, did you already notify I woke up to Dr. Drew. M replies, yes. Once you were sedated and stable, which was 10 minutes after you woke up. I remembered something then, when I was zoned out, you mentioned

about modified sedatives. Was that also recommended by her. M replies, correct. Before she closed off her access portal, she recommended that modification when you woke up. I accepted them within the risk parameters and injected the solution.

That women is way to clever than I thought. With just my brain scans and interactions, she predicted how I will come out from my sleep. I didn't realize earlier, but it was strange how clear headed I became seconds after I got injected with that sedative. She must have realized how screwed I would be without it. And that’s when I realized something. This wasn't something anyone could do. Not in the time she had. I reassessed my opinion about her. I will ask about it in person. I ask M, send her an invitation for meeting anytime after 5 AM. I am feeling better now, but I do want to take breather before meeting her. Let me know when she sees it.

M responds, message sent. I should have enough time to prepare myself mentally by then. Its good I woke up so early. With such a kicker waking up, I won't sleep anytime soon. I had finished eating my food and now I craved for open fresh air before listening anything more. I say, M. Scan the surrounding for a secluded spot for an ocean onboarding. I need to get some air. M's holograms turns off and the display in front switches to a view of the ocean topography.

I used the break to clean myself up. The smell of food on me is glimmering the space around me. I was too hungry before, so I brushed and showered properly now. As I changed into a trousers and sweatshirt, I began thinking my next course of actions. I should listen up all the rest of the conversations, but what then. Since M hasn't told me anything alarming from the Island network, nothing major has happened. So I should be okay to stay here until morning.

I walk back in the room where one and two were ready with another set of fresh bandages. ART's intuitive behavior is getting good. He must be learning new models from me. I took a sofa chair at the corner and let them work on my knuckles and foot. This one was made of thinner material, so they should not be constrictive. Once they are done I told them, looks good. Your movements and responses are getting sophisticated. I haven't visited you guys for weeks, so how is your progress. The two bots roll back some space and show a thumps up sign to me. Really. When did they learn that. I didn't design them a voice, so they learning gestures is normal. But showing emotional ques and quips is a big milestone.

They then roll off out of the room to their standby station. M speaks up, boss. I have a place 5 km away from here. There is satellite cover from the clouds and no ships or submarines around the area. However, based on the weather models, the place will be only available for approximately 2 and hours. There is a routine fisher line ship scheduled to cross at the route. I reply, that's fine. We won't stay here for long. ART prepares to lift off the ocean floor and swim to the designated spot. The underwater view outside the window changes slowly. The lights turn dim in this room and the suspension wall activates. M says, ART will reach in 15 minutes, 30 seconds.

Until then I listened to the rest of the recordings. Its a unexpected surprise that Charles wife took the role of messenger from Charles. He must only trust her for this. It was a little uncomfortable to have Vanessa with them. She left the stadium early on. I can only imagine how mad she is at me. I remember her asking me about Wagner, and ignoring her. I am clueless on how to handle this. I can't tell her the truth, but she won't let it go either.

As their conversation progressed, my expression become rigid. I can't be surprised that I was accused of such things. Anyone rational would at least once think if cheated. And my history is always something to be used against me. But I was confused why they Kafar or Citradel would try such thing without any proof. Their tactics to dissuade Charles felt petty and frankly, distasteful. If Blake hadn't rushed them with his rally, I have no doubt they would have gone further to discredit me.

I was grateful to others defending me. My guilt about keeping so many things from them grew even more. Vanessa may not understand my behavior, but I should have been at least straight with Blake and Marina. And then my mood turned to sour hearing the next segment. I crouch down, resting my forehead in my palms. I still have the sedative running through me, so I shouldn't have an episode again anytime soon. But hearing Wagner's skirmish with Heraknus, and Vanessa's insistence on it being a lie was getting on my nerves.

Vanessa kept saying it was a lie, while others kept it together and answered that I would still fight despite Wagner's behavior. I grit my teeth and tighten my hand into fists. I began breathing a little hard from anger. I tried to remain calm as much I could. It wasn't because of others who assumed I was going to fight even if it was a lie. They were right, I had already decided to fight. This wouldn't have made me back down from the deal. I didn't care if Charles actually didn't defeat Wagner. Instead, I am annoyed because it wasn't unexpected Wagner could do something like this. Its entirely possible Charles kept some stuff even from Melinda.

I become even enraged thinking Vanessa thought it was a complete lie, without questioning even a moment. She truly believe her brother was a good person, someone worthy of her devotion. If only she knew half the stuff he was up to. Before I took it too far, I sat back upright and took long breathes to settle down. I shouldn't think about it more. Not now. I haven't decided on how to talk to Vanessa. I table that scary discussion for now. It was a some comfort to not hear rest of Vanessa's voice from the evening. I couldn't handle all the anger she has at me if I heard her.

The next part was easier to listen. Blake and Marina were planning to break into the admins lobby. They both flew to the inner sector. When they land on the ground, Blake asks, okay. We are two blocks away from the building. Tell me you have a plan to get me in. Marina replies, there are 4 ways to get in. The front, which is crowded with people. The side door entrances, we can force it open, but we don't have the time to disable the alarm. The hanger is locked and again, we don't enough time to break open quietly. That’s leaves only one option.

I mulled over the other ways to get in. I never had any real reason to break in, but I do see the obvious way. Fly over to one the decks or windows on higher floors and break in from there. Sure, they still have to avoid the security, but it wouldn't be as difficult than other ways. Blake asks, so we fly in through those decks or windows. Seems he had the same idea as me. Marina scoffs, ah no. Obviously that would be difficult we so many eyes on the building. If I could use my overdrive, we could do that. Instead, I want to sneak in from underground. Specifically the basement.

Huh. What she means. Theres no way to get into the basement from outside. Blake asks, how am I going to do that. Don't you have to be inside to get to the basement. Marina laughs, not if you are me. You think I would not have designs in place that connects underground ways. When you all asked my help to create blueprints for the Island, I purposefully left out a little bit of underground spaces that can be used as tunnels. What the hell. Even I wasn't aware of this. Marina had planned almost 3 years ago.

Blake cries, damn Marina. You are telling we have hidden passages all over the Island all this time. And no one knows. Even from the recording I could imagine Marina smiling ear to ear while explaining, its not just here. There are in Citradel as well. Well, saying they are passages is a stretch. The paths are not tunnel, but can be made into one. The bedrocks of those paths are not load bearing, so drilling a tunnel won't create any issue. I haven't mapped all buildings paths, about 70% do. Fortunately, the admin towers is one of them. Also, the paths exists, but that doesn't mean anyone can take them. You need to have a crew working to open it or a particular person with specific kurets.

I began to realize what she was getting into. So did Blake. A while later he says, you planned this for shadow. But why not tell us about it. Marina replies, I am telling you now. They are just underground paths, not a big deal. I wanted to complete the survey first for the whole Island before Citradel moves. If I told you or David about it before I finished up figuring out all the possible paths, you might use it. I can't have anyone messing with it until I am ready. Besides, who was I hurting by keeping this from you both. Not like it was a bigger secret than David's illness or his Echo house.

That stung me more than I thought it would. She had a point though. Its almost a Shadow policy to reveal things only when its completed. Blake sighs, okay. I get it. So I just have drill a hole to get through. Marina says, yes. This building and the admins one the closest. Thats the entrance, do you see. Blake asks, where does that go. She says, its just a utility closet. Look for a small false wall in the left corner. It should be just huge enough to fit one person at a time. Go through that, you will fall into a small empty underground pit. Theres nothing there, just a hole made of raw earth. From there follow these directions.

I hear a hissing sound in the air. Marina is drawing the paths using her Kuret. Blake asks, can't I just draw it instead of memorizing it. Marina chastises him, hell no. I have taken great pains to keep this hidden. Even I haven't written anywhere. That’s incredible, so she has memorized the entire Islands underground paths. Blake sounding worried, I don't have a perfect recall like you. This has how many, lets see, 7 turns. I have to keep track of the distance and direction as I dig through. Marina says, yeah. So better make sure you don't. And GPS won't help. These paths are possible because of hard rock bed close to the surface, so you can't track yourself.

Blake sighs, so let me get this straight. I have to go in blind and make sure I follow the path perfectly, otherwise I would end up someplace else. Marina says, yeah. Shouldn't be hard. You can still see aura to navigate. Blake retorts, not when I am underground and surrounded by bed rock that can block signals. Marina says, oh grow a pair. Stop complaining and go. You said you were in a hurry. This is the fastest way without anyone knowing. Blake relents, ah. Fine. We are going to have a talk about your management skills. At least let me see this map for few more seconds.

After a minute, Blake got ready and left Marina. She went around the building and joined into the crowed. Later she met June and leisurely strolled around. I am amazed how ridiculous Marina handled this. She could have at least waited or somehow helped Blake in navigating. Maybe she thought it was easy for him. I am being realist, I could also done it. But I am concerned about Blake. Fortunately, this was hours before. So I can easily check what happened next.

I heard Marina saying that Blake is coming out of the building. I looked up and ask M, I am assuming whatever Blake planned to tell everyone was being broadcasted over the network. Do you have the recording of the news. M replies, I do. I also have the recording of the Admin conference from one hour later. So they did reach a decision before the end of day. I looked out through the window, we were still swimming underwater to the spot. I still have enough time then. I tell, show me the news from the evening that are about me, admin, Charles or the deal.

M replies, archiving completed. Showing only 19 of 37 news recordings which I have determined to have any bearing to your request. I nod at the number, okay. Show me.

David (Chapter 51)

Tuesday, September 23, 2025 19:00

Its been almost 2 hours of listening and analyzing the news streams. I am currently sitting in the beach chair on deck staring at the ocean. The waves were high, but the suspension circle around me has kept the floor I am on steady. I had prepared a green smoothie to sooth me. The subtle wind blowing and the noise of the waves was very relaxing. And with no other noise or distraction I could focus on what I wanted. As I gulped down a sip, M alerts me, boss. The fish bots have detected some large aquatic life passing by. Requesting ART to adjust sightly to avoid them. ART gradually glides on the surface as it avoids whatever we were about to encounter.

Its good that M and ART are operating at full capacity, because I had other stuffs on my mind. Blake had done a great job throwing mud at Citradel. Other officers and people had positive things to say about his performances. And it seems people have bought it. I had a few concerns how he would explain the lie about officers not telling Blake about the rally. Or the lie where Blake didn't want to tell people he was inside. Luther explained them in another news. He was quite convincing, and directing the flow of conversation to be on Citradel always. I suspect he and Blake planned much more than he told Marina.

I especially liked it when Luther tells how Island doesn't need to hide their administration and people can openly have conversations. Unlike Citradel, where you have to always have to meet in scheduled hideouts. If this was a debate, Citradel would defend by talking about their safety and technological progress. But he didn't touch on any of those topics. It also doesn't hurt that the Citradel people interviewed in the rally where swept in the chaos to get a chance to speak about it.

The result was Citradel conceding to the deal I made with Charles. I was a little wary when I heard Kafar was trying all kind of bullshit to break this deal. When Charles said he has decided to move, I almost jumped out of my chair in joy. At least my selfish decision has not been a complete disaster. There is still chance people won't move right away. Like that lady from Citradel said, the agreement was for winning the final match. I haven't won completely. This was a very risky gamble. Surprisingly, it turned out to be even ideal than a straightforward win.

I only shared this concern with Blake and Marina earlier. I had doubts that Citradel people would decide to move here even if one of us won. There is no authoritarian law to force them. We have been basically hoping that when they see all warriors strength, they would themselves decide to move here. Many will follow those warriors who have sworn on honoring the agreement. But there was always some doubt not everyone would move here. Kafar's reveal of Citradel secret champion actually played in our favor in the end. People would definitely follow someone who kept Citradel secure for a decade. On top of that they were a mythical bloodline who everyone thought were just a fairy tail.

No one would have known Charles would make a deal and move here. Kafar always touted no one could beat Charles. Turns out, even if I lost to him in the next battle, we still got our objective. I could tell how devasted he appeared in the broadcast. Now everyone knows about our deal. As expected, people had different opinion's about this deal. Some said I was genius, others said I was stupid. I smirk seeing very few people complaining to Charles. It's very coinvent Charles didn't tell it him who offered to move here as part of the deal. In fact many details I thought he would tell everyone didn't come out. Like why they remained a secret on Medrine. Or his arrangement on Citradel with Kafar. Maybe it was Kafar, or his house, discussed with him and allowed to only share those things. I wasn't bothered by it. Rather it didn't matter since it they were inconsequential to the next match anyways.

After that admins news, Marina went to Blake's home to party. I was glad they were at least happy and got time to enjoy our accomplishment. I heard it was Blake, Marina, Jess, Matt, Cass and Tessa. Nathan, Catherine and Vanessa didn't join them. I wished I could hear more about Catherine and Vanessa's day. But that would be too much intrusion. I already have done a lot of snooping on Marina. So I stopped off the recordings of the party. I tell, M. Switch to passive recording from this point. M responds, done.

I lean back on the chair mulling over what I learnt. I understood that this was a very long day for everyone. People have been a lot busy since my match ended. The bottom line is I need to somehow get over my issues fast. Which is what Dr. Drew will help me with. A while back M told Dr. Drew replied to M's message and has agreed to meet at 5 AM. That’s only an hour from now. I was in no mental shape to have an evaluation done immediately after an episode, which is probably the most terrible one I ever experienced. I also knew I had zero chance of fighting Charles, let alone winning in my current state.

I was too exhausted thinking and decided to completely avoid obsessing about it for a while. I got up my chair and sat down cross legged to mediate. I need to center my thoughts and at least be composed enough to think clearly. Then I did Pilates for a light workout. It felt back in control. After about 40 minutes I got back up on the deck. I thought to try testing my new Kuret form. I pull my Kuret out, but suddenly a chill went through my spine. My body tremble slightly at the sight of my own Kuret coming out.

I stumble back and fall down on my back. My breathing suddenly turn ragged and I sweated through the dress. I spatted out, dammit. Number 1 bot came from the other side of the wall and helped me up. I took one of arms to stand up. My legs suddenly felt weak. Its the same feeling when Blake carried me out of the stadium. I can't believe at my own weakness. Just at the sight of my Kuret I am break down. Right now am not even at zero chance of winning. I am at a negative.

Number 1 bot had a syringe on one his other arms. Its probably the same modified sedative as before. I waved my palm at him, no. I am better now. I don't want to be sedated when speaking with the doctor. Its time to get ready, I told M, lets move from here and onboard to shore nearest to her Dr. Drews home. What's the status of the car. Is it operational. M replies, its only at 40% capable. However, its sufficient for a simple pick and drive. I nod, okay. Then once we onboard, send one to Dr. Drews house and let her know about it. M responds, programming decent now.

I turn to Number 1, help me get to my room. I need to take another shower. I smell like the sea now. With the bots help, I walk back inside. ART shifts itself to prepare diving. M responds, surveillance fish bots recalling complete. Preparing to dive now. The windows and doors shift into solid. When I reach my room I tell, ART, prepare a drink for the Doctor. She doesn't prefer coffee or tea, so make a fruit kuret mix from apple, orange and pinnacle. Lets try out the kuret synthesizer now. Make the another one for me. I'll let you decide the correct ratio and tasting. Just don't make it too strong. You can use your desertion to change slightly if you want.

Number 1 drops me off in my room and wheels off to setup the kitchen. ART dives into the ocean, the window shows water filling upwards. M responds, optimal onboarding position located. Preparing the car now. Adding the directives to its OS. With that note I went back to the bathroom to freshen up. 20 minutes later, ART had parked on a cliff in the northwest side of the Island and sent out a car for Dr. Drew. I changed into a shirt and jeans for my meeting. I would usually wear more formal with her, but since its not a real session I decided to be casual. I didn't want to seem overly eager to get her help.

Of course, what I really needed was a miracle from her. I don't have a single clue on how to get back my mojo. What could I do now that 8 months of therapy couldn't achieve. Hope she has some answers for me. I went to the kitchen which number 5 bot operated. He had prepared a drink for me to try. Since I could only taste earth materials, it was kuret free. I took a sip trying it out. I say, its too sour. You added few more lemon squeezes. Take down a notch and we should be good. The bot behind the counter worked on preparing another batch, this time with less squeezes. I made a mental note about this prototype being quite effective.

As I waited in the common area sofa, I explained all the modifications I wanted in the room prepared for the meeting. I wanted the room to shift into something more comfortable. I added 3 large windows, asked the bots to move two sofa chairs into opposite sides and a large table in between. I even went far as to change the color of the walls to a soothing color, like yellow beige. I can't believe I am trying so hard for such a simple thing. I am very aware that my apprehension about this meeting. If she doesn't help me, I am screwed. And then everyone will be screwed. M told me she didn't explain the deal to her last night, but she most definitely know about it now. And I would have to reveal things that neither Charles or anyone has told her.

My legs shook uncontrollably as I waited for her. My fidgeting gets worse thinking the worse case. After 10 minutes of trepidation, the car comes in view. I grit my teeth impatiently as I walk to the door. Its dawn and the sunrise will happen in few minutes. The air had a orange glow right now, but it was completely clear. The car stops in front of ART and the passenger door opens. I take deep breathes and calm my nerves. I pulled the best poker face I had as I greeted her, morning Doctor. Welcome.

She was wearing her usual attire whenever we met. She puts out her cane and M's access tablet. She looks at me strangely, oh, morning to you too. This is where you live. When she closes the car door, it drives off to the shed on the side. She visibly looked surprised walking through the door. I give a slightly nervous laugh, yeah. Apologies I never showed you. For security reasons, I couldn't invite anyone. Her gaze fells on the interiors and takes its in, how long did it take you to build this here. Because I didn't see this in the island plans 2 months ago when I was searching for locations to extend my farm.

I guided her to the room I prepared. I think she hasn't noticed my nervousness as she marveled at my house. I replied, that’s because it wasn't here. She turns to me looking confused. Its expected, no normal person would believe what I meant. Instead of explaining I decided to let her see. I told, you'll see. But before we get started, here's a special drink I prepared for you. I took one from the table and waved at her. She took it with a smile, a smoothie. You think I don't like something like tea or coffee in the morning.

In a small panic I blurted, if you want, I can prepare something more strong. I got an coffee machine. Do you want an expresso. With a slight smile, its fine. I prefer this in the morning anyways. You guessed right. She takes a sip as I clam down. I can't believe how childish I am behaving right now. She gulps it down her throat and says, wow. That really good. I tasted kuret in it. That’s impressive you made this given your affliction. I let out a small laugh, well, just because I can't taste it, doesn't mean I can't make it.

I waved her to the seat, take a seat. We will be moving now. She gave a curious look as she sat down. She puts her cane down and the tablet on the table. I take the other chair and say, ART, prepare this room for suspension isolation. Take us down to only 300 meters. I don't want the doctor to feel uncomfortable. She looks at me shocked, are we going into the ocean. From here. She gripped the chair arms tightly in reflex. I assured her, don't worry. You won't feel a thing. Check it out. I pointed to the windows.

ART shifts and locks all the outside entries. I take a small amusement seeing her slightly anxious expression when ART beginnings to climb down. She soon realizes, how is this happening. We are moving down, but I don't feel us moving at all. I smile explaining, every part of this house can be turned into like a bubble that is isolated from the houses external pressures and movement. I will skip the technical details, but basically this room is magnetically levitated with a 10 cm gap from the rest of the house. So even if the house rotates on his head, we will be on the level.

Her eyes widen as we plunge into the ocean. Explaining and experiencing are two different things. I was sure she could handle the vision reaction over her bodies natural response to such a thing. This actually confirmed the thing I suspected, but I wasn't going to tell her until we start talking. Soon ART begins to dive underwater. The 3 wall window dims the room a little. But the sunrise made shadows dance from the surface waves. After gaining the depth I told, ART seamlessly travels at that level.

She smiles seeing the underwater life and faint see floor visible. She turns to me, I thought I was living in a weird place. Enough distance from others and privacy for my family. But that pales in comparison to this. I nod, that it does. Like I told you earlier, I need a lot of security. Privacy is an added bonus. I was actually happy to make small talks. Seeing it was finally happening, I was becoming too much anxious. I wanted to hide it from her as much as possible.

She gazes at the ocean and laughs a school of fishes pass by, was that you trying to impress me or a normal day for you. I shrug with a smile, I may have asked ART to plot a route that’s easy on the eyes. There are some reefs too dark to see, and well, an average person would freak out seeing up close through just a glass wall. She smiles, that they would. I am assuming that this glass is strong, since you don't seem worried. I reply, this glass is tank proof. Short of a ballistic missile attack, nothing could break it. And besides, there is round the clock surveillance going on. Anything other than a fish appears anywhere in a 500 km range, be it human, Echo or even a Medrone, I would know. So we are completely safe here.

She nods, I can see that. She takes another sip of the drink. Meanwhile, I didn't take sip of mine. I realized that’s not normal, so I finally take a sip. This is a non-kuret version of the same smoothie. It tastes much better than the previous one. She turns to me and places the drink on the table. Then she puts her hands on her crossed legs facing me, as much as I want to know more this submarine, I think we can get started. My nerves started acting up again in anticipation.

I cleared up throat, yeah. I waited for you to compose yourself. She takes a relaxed face, thanks. I am good now. Besides, I am not the one who is a nervous reck. My eyes focuses on that. I became quite for a while. She did too. She caught me. I was fooling myself thinking she didn't notice. Not seeing her glimmer clearly made me unprepared. Then I gave up, you noticed. She nods, just because I was caught by this doesn't mean I didn't notice the signs. When I didn't say anything she continues, you prepared a fresh drink for me, something I never told about my preference. You kept trying to focus my attention on the house, instead on you. And you didn't brought a single line about what happened yesterday. I say calling you a nervous is pretty mild. She was spot on with her observations. She smiles, I bet you even thought of wearing less formal to make this feel less like therapy and more like a chat. My smack my tongue wondering how much she saw.

She then waves her hand around the room, and lets also discuss the biggest clue. You picked a room which is completely opposite to mine we use for your therapy. Chairs instead of longer sofa. Lighter colored walls instead of dark ones. And window walls instead of no windows. Everything here is screaming at me saying its not therapy. I wonder if even noticed that. Ah, not good. I looked around and it hit me that I really did choose subconsciously choose blatantly opposite things.

I couldn't stop a disappointing laugh from my lips. I put one palm on my forehead, freak. I never noticed. She nods, you had to know your worsened condition was going to be discussed in details. So why try such subtle insulations. I reply frozen in place, I heard your conversation with Blake and Marina. Your early instinct was for me to not fight. I put my hands down after saying that. So I guess I have been overly anxious. She takes that for a second, you know about it. But I thought I asked M to tell me as soon you wake up.

I tell, and she did. But you saw it around 4 AM. I have been awake since 2 AM. I heard all of conversation from watch I gave Marina. And went over the news. So I know every little detail I missed yesterday. She stares at me for a while, ah, lets keep the blatant and gross violation of privacy aside. Then her faces perks up, did you bug my place too. I waved her off, no. I didn't. Well, not exactly. M records all communication around the devices I design, but there are privacy protocols. She can't let me hear anything too personal. Its a passive recording. Only important and absolutely necessary to me.

She looks a little uncomfortable saying, I have to believe you, I suppose. We had 18 sessions and I never found any signs of you using any personal knowledge to your advantage. We will talk about that later though. She clears her throat, there you go again avoid to talk by touting your fancy skills and tech. You can stop being evasive now. I wasn't trying to be. Or maybe I am. Its hard to tell if its my brain or body instincts to avoid it. She says, at least this saves time explaining some stuff.

She continues, so you know I went through your brain scans and vitals yesterday. And judging by your need to avoid talking about it, I was right in assuming you will wake up with a night terror. So, did you have one. I close my eyes in resignation. Its finally time to explain my mental state. I gathered my thoughts once again before saying, the worst one I ever had. She asks, this isn't going to be like a normal session, that much is true. Like we agreed, its dangerous to get influenced by anything during a fight. That being said, I will still need to know your thoughts during and after the match. I heard your reactions, and now I want to know from you directly. Based on what happens, I will tell you my recommendation.

I had no choice but to agree, I understand. From When do you want to start. She replies, I noticed an erratic neural activity near the middle of the match. Until then, it was normal. At least normal for a person fighting a Heraknus. She didn't even bat an eye talking about Heraknus. People would ask me how they are in person, but not her. She was down to business with every intention of focusing on me.

Then began my recounting the memories of the last day on Medrine.

David (Chapter 52)

Wednesday, September 24, 2025 18:28

It was completely different than other times. I was so disoriented I didn't know where I was, who I was. Just I needed to kill Hive. It consumed me. With a slight nod at my explanation she turns to look at my vitals of the event in her tablet. Its been around 45 minutes of discussion by now. We exchanged a lot of back and forth with her questions and my answers. I told as much as honestly I could about all my emotional state of the moments leading up to the night terror. It was mortifying and nerve wreaking to hear my voice when I accepted the Charles deal. I could tell how conceited and egotistical I felt saying I could win no matter not. I told her about my memories about the other shadow members without mentioning their names. Fortunately, she also understood not to pry that information. She didn't need it anyways.

Dr. Drew puts down her tablet, honestly. Its almost a miracle you were able to fight in such a state. You were almost like riding a high. Once you discovered a new Kuret abilities, you began taking risk much easily. Even if you had thought of your actions beforehand, you took risks that you normally don't. I know she wasn't pointing out to anything particular, but I know it well myself. I thought I would find a more simpler weakness of Charles. I had no plan to deal with his overdrive at that moment. She continues, you became singularly focused winning. Its actually impressive you still had your wits to negotiate that deal. So its not necessary a high but, in laymen terms, sudden overblown confidence. Clearly your god complex took a part in it.

I wanted to protest getting called out like this. I don't think I have a complex like that. Yet, I kept quite. We are reaching into the crux of our discussion. She smiles, you still could restraint yourself after being called like this. This wasn't the first time she kept poking for a reaction. Often times she would make a quip about something to gauge my reaction. I can't even tell if she was serious about most of the things she says about me. She continues, you believe the person, the one who tormented you as a kid, was the trigger right.

I nod, naturally. I mean, I had a nervous breakdown immediately I found out even he couldn't defeat Charles. She replies, but that’s not actually true, is it. Does knowing the whole truth is why there's no new episode ever since then. I gave it some thought, I don't know. Maybe. Or it could be the sedative you gave me. She says, you only took one. It would have been flushed out of your system by now. So that can't be reason it doesn't trigger you when we talk about him. And I guessing you have thought about him also, many times. But you are still fine.

I replied, that’s not how it happens. Just because I mention his name or think about it, doesn't automatically breaks me. She asks, but it did in the stadium. Did you really had a panic attack just because you got anxious on finally having a chance to get your revenge. Even in such a roundabout manner. I got annoyed at this. I didn't want to talk about him in this context. I kept quite, unable to articulate any response. She notes my silence, let me ask another way, you told me your memories of the last is clearer now. So isn't it possible your feelings about him is the not the complete reason you had a panic attack. Maybe just like your incomplete memories, you PTSD is linked to something more than him.

Rationally, I understood her point. But I couldn't believe anything other than him being the cause. I shook my head, no. I believe its just him. I didn't have clear memories only of the last day on Medrine. But every other day is crystal clear and the truth. It doesn't change what I know about him. She stays quite for a while at my answer. She speaks, if that’s what you believe so confidently, it may be true. But until now, I believed he was definitely linked to triggering your PTSD. After this, I think it might not just be him. Just keep an open mind about it.

I didn't need to rethink my diagnosis after 8 months, but at the very least I keep a note of this. She says, lets switch topics. I became relaxed to know I didn't have to talk more about this. I am a little interested to understand why you became so confident during the match. You say your shadow mentor knew your potential, even when your Kuret was blocked and weak body. Explain it to me how that memory changed you. It may be obvious, but I still want to hear your thoughts about it.

I didn't need to think about it a lot, he must have chosen me for a reason. I have suspicions that he knew I was a project MARS kid from earth. That makes the most sense. She asks, Even if that’s true, why would be believe you become physically stronger. Neither of you have definite evidence of you coming to Earth will save you. I reply, perhaps he know more about that project. Or something else. Whatever the reason, since he picked me as a shadow even with my terminal illness, I owe him my life. Don't ask me how, but I know how difficult it was for him to let a outsider, let alone a terminal kid, join the shadows. So I need to get stronger to honor his sacrifice.

She nods, he is impressive after hearing his story. To carry you over 3 continent and an ocean, especially through the most dangerous place during the war, no ordinary person could do. I don't doubt your intention to become strong for him. But is that what you want though. Whatever knowledge he might knew about him, you were just a kid who were terminal. I replied sternly, I don't have any other goal or ambition. Whatever plans I had, all gone when Echo invaded Medrine and then Earth. She asks, but surely you want more. Didn't you said you wanted be normal. That was the whole point for therapy.

I get her confusion. Its because I didn't have a definite answer. I said, I don't know. Maybe I am conflicted about it. But I know this for sure, I was never planning for a normal life. That wasn't possible. What I need is to be better. I thought it would be enough to support Medrones from shadows. But I also had a life on Earth. One free from constantly being paranoid and scheming. So I just wanted something like a middle ground. That’s my reason for therapy. You know about it. But now, I am not sure about that. She asks in a lighter tone, you want more, isn't that right.

I had to agree on that, yes. Its more than just being a shadow or a stable mind. I need to get strong enough to fight Echo all on my own. I don't care much about humans progress or even Medrones. I'll admit that’s presumptuous and arrogant. But that’s what I need. She leans forward, you said need. Not want. Meaning its much deeper. I shrug at her. She continues, when you joined the tournament, you said that you needed this. The context and reasons are completely different, but I get the same feeling from you as before. When you joined, you weren't aiming for winning, but to eliminate Citradel warriors to increase odds for Blake, Vanessa or Nathan. But now you don't want that, you want to risk your life to win.

I nod slightly at her. She continues, you still have such strong feelings when you are this terrified of my possible negative evaluation. I sorted out my thoughts about it. And I reached an answer, I think of it as two different things. I am worried of being not mentally stable to fight Charles. I also want to win no matter the condition I am in. however, I would like to get over my issues before the match. Two things can be true at the same time. At my blatant response her expression hardens, I don't want to call it optimism. But I also don't want to call it delusion. What a thin line you made it. You know, you have been lucky so far. How long will that last.

I answer, as long I can get. I'll use whatever I have to defeat Charles. She says, and that’s how you repay your mentor. I nod, not just him. Everyone who died saving me that day. I have seen the bodies of so many shadows, dying for me just to get me board a ship. I can't have a life like everyone with such a guilt over me. I have to be better than everyone. She hesitantly asks, better than Wagner. I replied immediately, especially him. I want to be strong without becoming cruel like him. I know how I sound. Me beating Charles doesn't mean I am better than Wagner. But that’s the best I got. She stares at me and thinks for a while. After an agonizing silence she says, you are already strong enough to stand with some of the most powerful people in all of Medrine history. Isn't that enough for you.

I reply, I'd don't think like that, because like you said, I have been lucky. I won against Derek because I caught him by surprise. And Blake lost because he was worn using his overdrive in earlier match. Others may say I am on par with omegas, but I don't think like that. I still have a lot of gap to cover. She laughs lightly at my claim, did you see your own match. You got lucky, but that’s not enough to explain how you fought off a mythical alpha for an hour. You don't believe your new kuret abilities are enough.

I nodded, I know its not. I want to start my training right away. But I am not stupid to ignore my issues. I am terrified you will say I am unstable or delusional or both. Now that I think about it, I also concerned there is nothing I could do to mitigate it in the next 29 days. And that means I would be fighting in my current condition. She leans back on her seat, that’s a problem with smart people as patients. Their blind spots are easily missed and still able to judge objectively themselves. She takes a short breath, I think I have a grasp of yours though. She clears her throat, I have one last question.

I prepare myself. I knew what it was about because she hadn't touched on it yet in all our discussions. She picks up her tablet and turns to show me a frame of the video of me waking up. She asks, among a lot of things, this is most concerning. Everything we discussed till now was about your panic attacks or PTSD. I didn't ask about this one until now because I wanted to know other things first. This nightmare, like you said, it was different. You had recalled a memory of your friend dying. And something different about it. I didn't ask then, but I am asking now. What do you remember.

I fidget in my seat knowing I had to talk about this. My legs began trembling a little. I put my hands on my knees to force them down. She wasn't going to ignore this, what just happened. You showed a physical reaction, something you tried to hide. I closed my eyes trying to calm down. I had noticed it a while ago. Actually, this is what made me worry the most. Every time I think of using my kuret or about Zakerine, my body begins to shake. I gathered my thoughts and said, my body begins to feel irrational fear when I think about it. To be honest, I have been having it few times since I woke up. I thought it was a side effect of the drug you gave M. I knew it was out of my system, but I didn't want to believe it was due to something else.

She asks, its understandable you didn't want to add more problems to your list. What is it about. I sighed and explained what I knew now. All this time I had different physical symptoms going on, shaking legs and arms had become the most common though. Then came the irrational need to ball up and cry. I didn't tell her that though. I was already pathetic enough already. Once finished I took the water from the table and emptied the whole bottle. I was even sweating now.

She waited for me to finish drinking. I lean back was I felt a little calm. She says with concern, I am sorry I made you relieve that. That’s a devastating loss. With a nervous look I reply, it is what is. But this one is pretty obvious to me. She asks, oh. What do you make of it. I clear my throat, I was paralyzed completely due to blood loss for hours before leaving Medrine. I had to suffer through watching 3 people die in front of me. But my friend, who I originally thought died from an injury, could have been saved. Only if was able to move or even talk. I felt so hopeless lay paralyzed and see her die when didn't have to. And now I am experience that same fear whenever I think about her. She nods, yes. That’s the obvious answer.

I sensed she thought of a different one. I ask, so what's not so obvious answer. She answers, you experience the same thing when you use your kuret too. Don't you. That genuinely froze me up. I never told her about that. My face turned pained trying to figure out if M told her about it. She puts her palm to me, I can see you are trying to understand how I know. It was just a lucky guess. I haven't seen you use your Kuret to see any glimmers. So I wondered if you were just scared to observe me, like how you were worried what I my evaluation be. Or maybe you couldn't use it.

Sharp as ever. I click my tongue irritated a little, yeah. You are right. I didn't tell because, well. I couldn't finish my own words. She says it for me, you didn't want to appear even more unstable. Not the same word I would use but close enough. She says, its fine. You don't have to worry me judging. If it were anyone else, they would have been admitted to a psych ward by now. Compared to others I seen in your situation, you are doing great. I didn't share her optimism, its been one thing after one since I got my memories. I just want it to end now. This is tiring, I have so much else to focus on. And I didn't mean just the fight.

She says with a serious face, listen to me. You just hit rock bottom. You can't get worse from here. That's actually good. There is nothing positive about it. Rationally, I knew what it meant. But it felt bleak now. She would almost certainly think I am far too gone to fight Charles. She says, coming back to this fear you mentioned. Its true, you felt angry you couldn't help her. Its also entirely normal if you are angry at her since its also her own fault. I immediately wanted to rebuke her, but I stopped at the last second. I took some deep breathes. I felt trembles all over my body.

She notices me, but ignores it, you most also be angry because if you had your kuret with you then, you could have saved her. With all this built up, made you completely nervous about meeting me. And that's the main reason you feel so much on edge. Everything else we discussed, sure it was also a factor. But this is main reason for your current state. I am sure you realized it as well. I only bring it up now because I know this had to be the main root cause of your issues. I had been bottling it ever since I woke up. But now, hearing this from someone else I finally broke.

I yelled out, why the freak she didn't listen. She kept trying to revive a dead person. I was alive, and needed help. She only cared about him. He was only a friend, I was more. We were in a relationship. I used to feel regret not being able to protect her. I even was able to let it go because I didn't have kuret then. I would never be able protect her no matter what. I accepted that. But now I know that she chose it herself. If it were a regular person, I would understand. Buts he was a shadow in training. She was trained to fight in wars. How could she lose it so much that she died like this. This is so stupid, even pathetic.

I begin heaving at my rant. My trembles worsened. She waited patiently for me to calm down. But I didn't feel it was anytime soon. I shout, this is so messed up, I can't believe it. How can she choose not to heal. She was a freaking omega when she died. Her injuries could have been healed in time. If she wasn't so stubborn, she be alive right now. And I,. I lost my words. No, I didn't want to say this. Saying would mean it could be true. Drew didn't utter a single word, waiting for me patiently. I finally spoke up, if she were alive, I wouldn't have tried to erase my memories. The reason I did it in the first place is because she died. Without it, I might have been someone different. Someone more trusted by others. Someone who would made different decisions I did. I could have had a different life.

My breaths keep me agitated for a long time. I close my eyes and laid back on the seat. I could feel tears wheeling up in my eyes. Even after I already shown my pathetic side, I didn't want to show something worse. Drew probably understood my emotions, because she didn't approach me for a long time. Once I settle down a bit I gather up a slight courage to say, sorry. I got caught up. I open my eyes and wiped any wet surface around my eyes. Drew didn't change her expression much, but she did appear more relaxed. That's was peculiar from her.

She asks, that must have helped. Your earlier talk about getting strong, they were true. But this so was this. You do wish for a different future. I scoff, and different past. That’s not going to happen. I know that. She asks, yes, but have you accepted it. I mean really. I honestly can't her answer her. I thought I could. She continues, I am not going to force to accept it. I sometimes myself can't accept the fact that I am living in an alien planet. Everyone wishes it. You aren't all that different in that regards. So you are not alone.

I knew she was comforting me, but it didn't help. She says, and I also won't ask to accept your friends death. Its not the first time I heard people dying trying to save others. All though, I admit its strange for an omega, but I am sure you would have at least tried rationalizing her actions. Whatever they were, knowing won't change the fact she still died from an attack. I think your subconscious has known about this when you got your memories. It have been also a driving force for many of your actions. You may not even realize it. So just give it time, you will reach an answer yourself.

I couldn't begin to how to deal with this insight. What actions have I been making unconsciously from this. I know I didn't have the answers right now. Drew shrieks a little, oh. Shoot. This isn't a session. I shouldn't have given an advices like this. A thoughtless mistake. She chastises herself. I also didn't realize how easily she slipped back into her therapy mode. She tilts her neck a little, lets focus back. I understand why you had that particular nightmare. You attacked your robot thinking they were Echo because that’s your anger originally directed towards. I knew it was more to it than just simple rage.

As I remained silent, she looks to the glass wall and stares into the ocean. I realize she is going to finish her assessment. I already knew the result though. I had very small hope she would allow me fight knowing my currently worsened condition. It wasn't just self depreciation. I am a mess right now. Drew doesn't know how dangerous the next match is. If I had a panic attack, a moment of hesitation or even as simple as trembles, in the middle of the fighting, I could lose more than just the match. With such incredible stakes, I shouldn't fight. No, I can't fight. And the repercussions of it would be too severe me to bear.

Drew took a long time to decide about me. I didn't want to get sucked into my own mind, so I also turn my chair to view the ocean underwater. She saw me joining, it is a gorgeous view. Especially now that the sun is up. I don't know what this was. Maybe a delaying tactic of small talk. But it eased me since I don't have to talk about my issues anymore. I answers, yeah. When taking test dives, I found many good spots. You are seeing the early fall life. Once winter comes, most aquatic life moves deeper. If you want, I could us to the reefs at some depth. Not even human divers have that far. Its also nice view.

She puts her hand up, maybe some other time. But I'll keep that in mind. This might to be one of your secrets that anyone would forgive you for. Its nice and peaceful here. Oh what I wouldn't give to live like this. She is still going on making me wait. I thought she was only delaying. But she sounds she really wants to just chat. What weird strategy is she doing here. I can't figure it out. Although, I had an opportunity to ask something now. I ask, you know. You have been asking me a lot of questions, so let me ask just one now.

She doesn't look at me answering, oh. I haven't decided yet. I wave my hand, no. I know. Its not that. I think I am not only one good at hiding stuff. She turns to me surprised, what do you mean. Her expression showed nothing new. But I know I am right. I continue, I knew you were smart. That’s why I chose you. But its not just that. Even with M's help, you where able to tell I would have night terror when I wake up in just few hours. I know one can learn a lot from my vitals and medicine history, but what you did was nothing short of brilliance. A smart person would prepare for all eventualities, but a genius would know exactly what would happen and prepare for just that.

She didn't faze at what I am implying. So I blatantly ask her, you are a genius prodigy. Aren't you. I have noticed signs of it earlier in our sessions. Your hot and cold readings are almost always correct. You are can memorize a lot things in very less time. You have PhDs from both Medrine and Earth, and you experiment with growing hybrid crops. So its hard not to believe you lied about your IQ during your Island intake. What is it really. I am curious to know.

She had kept a poker face until now. She turns back to see the ocean from the glass with a smile, it always nice to get praise from others. But you are overestimating me. I am not a genius. I could finally let out a small laugh after such a harrowing time facing my issues, that was a lie. I don't need to see your glimmers to know. Come on, just tell me. What's the big tell. She answers still having the smile, don't you think pestering me like this is not a good idea. I might make a decision you don't like just to spite you.

That’s funny, I say. I am a mess right now, but I can still observe this things clearly. You would never make a crucial decision biased like this. And also, I have pretty much given up convincing you. I am not sure myself I could resolve my issues before the match. So, just give me this. It would make me feel better that even if I can't fight properly right now, my instincts are still good. I'll admit, it was a weak argument. But that’s all I had. I had no solid proof.

After sometime me staring, she sighs. Turns out I didn't need proof. She says, you caught me. Honestly, I was worried you might realize it when I had to meet you so soon. I was quite happy and a little proud that you never figured that out. I knew you would eventually figure it out, I just thought it would be near the end of your therapy. I curled my fist in satisfaction. She chuckles lightly, I have an IQ of 173. I wasn't expecting such a high number. I say, wow. Freak me. You might be in the top 10 smartest people in the Island right now.
She says with a small laugh, I don't know about that. I don't think much about it. You know my situation. I didn't want to work on anything crucial to Islands administration. My decisions has hurt my family. So now, I am just a farmer. Okay, not just any farmer, maybe a more smarter one. I did understand her situation. I agreed I wouldn't tell anyone she used to work as a psychiatrist to humans. Then I had a thought. But maybe I showed it in my expression because she interrupted me, and before you ask, no. I am getting recruited by you for anything else. I am only doing this because you are helping my family.

She perfectly guessed my thoughts, are you sure. The job I have in mind is something you can do from home. You won't have to leave the Island, or even talk to anyone about it. No Medrone or Human. She still refused, thanks, but I must decline. You don't need me, you already have other people working for you. I imagine this house we are in is something you built taking their help. I haven't fought in any wars, but I can tell its Echos technology. So you clearly don't lack people helping you. You don't need me.

She wasn't wrong. But I do need people from her particular background. But we are not in that stage yet. We still have to break through few milestones in the project before we have a brain related problem. I say, it’s a loss, but I got it. All leave you alone, for now. I emphasized the last part. She looked like she would criticize me, but kept her cool. It was still amazing to know another genius Medrine alive.

We both gaze back to the ocean. I don't know if this small talk made her rethink in anyway of her decision. It wasn't my intention to influence anything. But since it happened anyways, I had a hoped she would help me out. After some deliberation she finally says, I honestly can't decide. Its very difficult to know if you have enough time to recover. Also, I still don't want to have sessions until your fight. We can't risking infusing you in any unexpected ways. Buts its just as dangerous not to get help. I understand how important this deal is. You were sleeping all night, but I have seen people enjoying and cheering you on for your fight. So I know the pressure you are in. Anyone would be reeling from it. Genius or not.

It was a good to know she understood me and how grave the situation is as well. She says, I don't know if this is right or not. But there maybe something could help you. Seeing there was even a possibility, I tighten my back, what do you need. She asks, an alternate, actually a radical, treatment which you could undergo. I don't know if it would work, but that’s the only thing I believe even has a chance. That felt almost a miracle to me right now. I ask curious, what is it. She says, I'll reach out about after I have researched a bit more on it. I read about it when I studied in college, but never thought I could apply to a Medrone. Well, you are uniquely different from others. So, who knows, it might just work.

This was the best thing I heard till now. A hope gave me confidence and believing I could make it work. She says, give me a week's time. I'll have done the research by then. Know that its completely experimental. We are going to be in unknown territory. I reply, all take anything right now. But a weeks time is too long, I can't hole up in my home until then. Other things beyond my control will also make it impossible to wait that long. She nods, yes. I understand. Heraknus will be moving here. If you can't fight their alpha, your deal is void with them not moving here. And that’s why I will allow you to start your preparation. You can train, strategies and do whatever you normally do for a fight.

I tried to understand what she was saying, are you saying I should fake it. Convince others that I am okay until your experimental treatment. She replies, no. Its not going to be simple like that. Because of such a time crunch I need assurances that the treatment has any chances of working. Actually, you need it more than I do. So for that, we will have to test you. Specially your mental and emotional state. It made sense, but I ask, and how do we do that. She answers, instead of waiting for a week sitting on our hands. I'll am giving a task, a test if you will. I waited for her to reveal this task. She says nervously, show me that you can control your kuret by end of today. If you can do that, then there is a chance you can recover soon. If you can't do it, we can forget about everything and I will declare you unfit for the fight.

I can't believe she asked me to do the thing I feel impossible right now.

David (Chapter 53)

Friday, September 26, 2025 22:55

We are currently in the dining counter drinking. Drew showed a sudden interest for coffee when the smell of the beans roasting filled the house, so I offered an mochaccino mixed with kuretines. Its been 10 minutes since Drew gave me the herculean task. No, a test to see my resolve. ART began to climb up the same cliff as the one we used climbing down to drop off Drew. I put down my coffee mug on the counter. I had been thinking a lot and ask her, did you conclude that these tremors are a simple psychological response to night terror and could be easily rid in just a day.

She takes a sip and says, of course not. I won't deny that these two are related. But its not a simple one that can be so reductive and solved easily. Normally, it would take weeks for an average person. But you are not an average patient. I gave a short duration because you finally had a sort of relapse, something like hitting rock bottom. Like I said before, any progress from now on, no matter how small, is towards the right direction. You think things very differently, so you feel things differently also. I believe you can show progress differently too. Add on top the pressure you are currently in your situation. In such unpredictability, you might recover unpredictably too.

I scoff, that’s a lot of uncertainty. She nods, yes. A broken compass that wiggles too much can point south just as easily as north. I have seen patients recover in short periods. So its not impossible. Its difficult. That was understatement. I don't even have a plan how to deal with this. Give me a military base to destroy, a prison to infiltrate or a sow chaos in a city. Those I can do in my sleep. But this is way out of my abilities. I need help. The irony is the person I would normally go for help is Dr. Drew herself.

We soon reach the edge and onboard completely. It was completely lit now from the sun. The high waves had begun to recede. The local wildlife had also taken presence with birds in the sky and small animals on the ground around the house. Drew puts her coffee cup down on the counter and stands up, I guess times up. Despite our somewhat dubious conversation, this has been a very unique and pleasant experience. She grabbed the cane from under the seat and begins walking. I follow her behind, I appreciate your discretion. Even if you say you enjoyed the trip, I did ask your help at such an odd hour. And not to forgot the research you are doing on my behalf. Thanks for your helping me out.

We pass through the door into the fresh Island air after an hour and half. ART had already sent out the car from the hanger. The passenger door opened for her. Drew stops before getting on and faces me, don't worry about it. You were right to have Blake and Marina bring me. I don't think someone who is passing out would think of calling for their therapist first. It was good to know you had your priorities right. That helped in making the decision to visit you. So even if you don't feel like it right now, I think you are making progress. Believe in yourself and you will manage your issues.

I flatly said, you didn't even gave me whole day. Just 17 hours. She laughs, consider that extra incentive to figure out, in layman's term, your shit. Even I laughed at her professionalism. I just had a thought, since you didn't mention anything about it, I must have to figure out my shit myself. Is there any suggestion or hint you can give. She nods, I was waiting for you to ask. She stares at me intently, you already know what you need to do. I am sure you learnt one particular thing from our sessions all year, use that.

I was expecting a clue, not a riddle. I scoff, not making it easy even now huh. She replies with a smile, maybe I am just a bit salty you figured something about me. Yeah, that I believe. She gets in the car and give me a parting words, like we discussed, no confirmation over call or video. Only in person by midnight. I nod, I got it. Hopefully, I will see you then. With that, we waved each other off. The car drove off using the same route it took in the morning among the woods. I stood in my place for a while, unsure on how to take the first steps. She said I already knew. I didn't no exactly what it is, but it had to be simple. She wouldn't risk me wasting time stuck with this.

Nothings going to happen stuck here looking stupid. So I walk back to inside. On my way I saw a group of seagulls on the railings supporting the house. Their unceasing noise kept disturbed my thinking. I close the door behind me and say, M, scare the birds away. I don't want them to take a shit on ART. M responds, it’s no use boss. We shoo them off, and then they just come back. When onboarded, we can't maintain the magnetic resonance long enough to keep them away. Its already in the list of vulnerably we have on ART. There are some organic solutions we want you to see.

I didn't have the mental capacity nor do I care right now to deal with this. I take a seat in the living rooms Barcalounger, not now. Just get rid of them for now. M replies, understood. Shall we dive back in the ocean. I decided, no. Lets stay here till lunch. I know it doesn't make sense, but being inside a pressurized container under water is adding to my stress. I laid back on the leather. M replies, all right. Deploying bots to deal with the avian friends. That’s an odd way of saying. Where the hell is M learning this new quip from.

I close my eyes and gather my thoughts. I have to deal with the deadline, that’s my number one priority. That being said, I also have few things to do. I haven't met with anyone since yesterday's match. People have been discussing a lot about my disappearance and absence last night. I need to spare some time and visit the officers building. I have to explain what I have been doing all this time. I am sure people have visited my other home, so I have come up with an excuse to explain that too.

And finally, I think I need to meet with Charles before I leave. I don't know what will happen tonight, but all I can do right now is stay the course. I should let him know I am okay and looking for our next match. I should also talk about my last interaction with him. I ask, M, is there any information in the network when Charles is leaving. M replies, yes. Mr. Charles, few Heraknus people and couple of Citradel officials are set to leave today at 9 AM via a cruise from the south port. So they are taking an early trip. Not waiting for the nights cover means he wants to be in Citradel as soon as possible, even if its less safe during the day.

I have enough time to visit him then. And since I am going there, I should address the officers there itself. That should save me time meeting them later. A sound of the birds came again interrupting my thoughts. I yelled irritated, are you freaking kidding me. I open my eyes and gazed to my side at the window of the deck. A lone seagull was being chased by a number 1 bot around the pool now. I screamed out, for freaks sake. How the hell are you not able to kick it off yet.

M replies, apologies boss. ART is not able to make sense of the abnormal behavior of this one bird. I didn't have time for this cirrus. I got angry now, I need some peace and quite to think. Just shoot the damn bird if you want. I want it off my house, right now. M responds, boss, the wildlife protection protocol stops us from taking extreme measures. Even if you ask, we can't harm a bird for invading its migrating routines. I scoff hearing that ridiculous answer. Then I remembered the protocol. I can't be angry at M, since I wrote that one myself.

I sighed and let my annoyance out. I got up from my seat and walked over to open the glass door. Number 1 bot was still trying to catch the bird. If it had been allowed to use its full strength, it would have grabbed it already. Still, I can't believe one bird is giving it this much trouble. Animals unpredictability is accounted for in their programming. I guess they still have to be tuned more. As soon as I lay my eyes on the bird, it turned it long neck towards me. I wouldn't have given a second thought to that look, but it kept staring at me while making the noise and running around the deck.

Something is weird here. Some animal may not be threatened by cold metal, but a warm bodied one would definitely scare it away. And yet it stares at me for few seconds while running from the bot. I gradually walk back inside closing the glass door. I had a strange instinct about it. I asked M, where are the other birds of the flock. M replies, they already left. Number 1 bot scared it away. Only this one stayed behind. I have seen them enough times to know that they stick together in groups always. No matter the time or place. So why this one is behaving strange.

My mind went many scenarios here. Is someone using this bird to spy on me. I ran down all the kurets in my head that could do it. I knew of people with abilities to control or influence simple minded creatures. But why. And how they know where I live. Has someone been following me. Then it hit me, they could have followed Dr. Drew to me. My mind instantly went to Kafar or the culprits who are trying to mess with the tournament and me. Yesterdays Citradel discussion about me could be a sign they are escalating their approach to get me.

This is not good. If they realize I am meeting with a doctor, before I talk to Charles, I could get exposed. They might use it to finally convince Charles to break the deal. To avoid suspicion further from the bird, I get back to my seat. I need to deal with this now. Should I let the bird go, capture it. Or something I was itching to do since I kept hearing that annoying noise, kill it. I had to use my kuret and see glimmers to see what do next. I bit my teeth hard feeling the discomfort. I didn't want to do it, but I had no other choice. I need to know if there is any kuret in play here.

I closed my eyes and fidgeted a little in the chair. An outsider might think I was relaxing. However, I am conflicted inside. I pull out my kuret. Immediately I felt my head getting hotter. Emotions of seeing Zakerine and Hansen floored my thoughts. My body begins to tremble. This is a terrible plan. I couldn't focus one bit. Forget about focusing kuret in my eyes, I can't control my own mind. I grabbed the side arms of the leather seat in anxiety. My legs begin shaking like the vibrator from the seats were on.

Anger. Despair. Madness. Nausea. It overwhelmed me. Zakerine, what the hell happened to you that day. I should have done more. I let her to die. Thoughts kept coming to me. My breathing became ragged. Shit. Freak this. I stopped my kuret. I can't do it. Its hopeless. My kuret falls back inside me. My thoughts still remained rampant, but I felt them getting dimmer. Small sweat drops from in my forehead. I open my mouth and breath fast like I was drowning. Then gradually I begin to calm down.

I could sense something over my eyes. Just for a split second, I saw strands of thin glimmer in front of me. A familiar color of kuret. After few seconds, I open my eyes in confusion. I know that kuret. How did she find me. This confusion actually distracted me enough from the wave of emotions flooding me from the trembling. I am able to cool down after wiping my forehead. How long has she been following me. And how much did she hear. I guess I have to ask her directly.

I speak aloud, ART, I authorize you to use full capacity in catching that bird. Bring the bird to me now. M responds, are you sure boss. I nod, I am not going to harm it. I am only going to interrogate it. M replies, temporarily authorized to use full capacity. The next moment, number 1 bot uses its impulse propulsion from behind to sped up its pursuit. The bird didn't react fast enough. The bot caught it with its four arms. The seagull squawks even louder with its capture. What a performance, I applauded for the commitment to this bit.

The glass door opens and the bot wheels inside. I tell, ART. Initiate umbrella protocol. The surface of the room shifts and begins to rearrange the sofas, chairs and tables to the side of the room. The glass windows and doors turn tinted black to avoid anyone seeing us. I put my fist under my chin and elbow on my thighs unamused by this trespass, I know its you. The bird struggles to get of the grip. Guess she isn't going to give up like this. I sigh, If you want to be treated like a bird, fine. M, prepare the grill. I am feeling a roasted bird for lunch. Prepare something from menu.

The bird continued to struggle, now, biting one of the bots arms. I didn't know how long this farse would go. Apparently, M didn't think I was joking, how would you like the lunch, boss. Cooked, grilled or baked. ART has 22 current different recipes that works well with a seagull from this region. There stomach are rich in protein and guts have good omega content. It was frightening to think M really thought I was serious. I should check out her context ques programming.

The bird finally gave in. It stops tying to break free. A purple kuret comes out from it and wraps the bird. I say, number 1. You can let go of her. The bot releases its grip on her. The purple kuret unravel round her and grows in size. The body morphs into a person shaped figure and then I saw it talking the shape of the only person who has this kuret. I push the bottom of my Barcalounger to rotate to the other side showing the backside to the intruder.

A second later a surprised voice says, what the hell. Were you really going to cook a random bird. I shook my head ignoring her, what are you doing here Catherine. I could tell from her voice she was anxious and a little freaked after getting caught like this. She says, are you seriously asking me that. What are you doing living in such a gigantic place. I have got a ton of questions for you. She got her composure back and got angry at me. The last time

we spoke, it was around a month back. We parted in not so good terms.

I wasn't expecting this, M, how did you not see her infuriating ARTs defenses. M takes a while before responding, apologies boss. ARTs sensor picked many Medrones since we dived into the ocean. All the signatures detected are labeled as normal since they are part of every day morning routines, fishers, patrols and other activities. Since Miss Catherine was disguised as a bird, ART couldn't account her signature as a Medrone. I sighed realizing the sensors wouldn't can't detect anomalies like Catherine.

M says, adding this flaw to ARTs list of vulnerabilities. Freak, I wasn't here for a week and suddenly so many flaws are popping up in just one day. Catherine shrieks, hey. Don't ignore me. How long are you going to keep me embarrassed and naked here. Hurry up and give me something to cover up. She is being obnoxious now ordering me when she spied on me. I took a second to consider on how to deal with her. I didn't want to speak to her while I am in a terrible shape. On the other hand, I have no idea how long she has been spying me for. And what things she heard about me. I can't let her leave without knowing about it.

With a reluctant voice I ask, dammit. M, get some clothes for her from the axillary closet. On the double. I hear a rumble on the rooms down the end, a bot was dispatched to fetch her clothes. Catherine says a little calm now, thank you. God, what the hell is this place. I reply, how about I ask few questions first. How the hell did you find me. I waited for her to answer. She then smirks, what. You think I would just tell you when you keep so many secrets. I know a lot more about you now. So you owe my answers.

From her reaction I could tell one thing, she is somehow even more angrier at me than before. I didn't utter a single word and instead thought this through. Finding me isn't just a question about a location, its time also. So clearly I was right that she followed Drew to me. How did she found about Drew. And then it's the matter on how she has been spying on me ever since we dove into the ocean. ART didn't warm me any suspicious Medrone near me. That means only one thing. Slowly I begin to uncover how this unexpected guest made her visit.

Number 2 bot came inside the common area with few clothing options in his arms. Catherin shrieks a little, there are more than just one of these robots. What hell David. I ignored her. The bot zips past me and halts near Catherine. I hear clothes rummaging, you always keep woman's clothes here. A while later she says, hey. This is my size. How do you have these. Her voice became a little quite and hesitant. Like she felt creeped out. Before she had any weird thoughts, I answered this time, settle down. I have a spare supply of clothes for everyone. Men, women and children. So don't go accusing me for anything. Also, I know your size, in case you forgot about the incident on capture the flag game. M heard that and picked the ones that fit you.

Catherine coldly says, I was kidding earlier you know. But now I am little freaked out. And make sure you delete the videos that recorded me just now. I won't feel at ease knowing there is a video of me getting caught like this. I felt amused by her panicking a little. I tell, M, you know what to do. M responds, instead of deleting, blurring out parts of the footage as per protocol. Catherine says annoyed, guh. Really. You are the worst. I snicker, you came into my home uninvited. Deal with it.

A while later I hear Catherine finished putting on clothes. I rotate my chair back to her. She took a brown blouse and black jeans from my rack collection. The bot wheels away with the rest of the clothes out of the room. I pull my head up and cross my hands, interlocking the fingers. She finished pulling her hair backwards, you think you have to right to be angry, hell no. Its me. I can't believe you kept your illness a secret this whole time. You shouldn't have entered the tournament, let alone fight Charles. What the hell were you thinking.

Her indignation towards me on my illness proved what I was thinking earlier. I say, just to be on the same page here. You didn't find anything yourself. Someone told you about me, Drew and my home. You didn't wear your morphing clothes, so you were only going to be surveilling me. That meant prepping for it beforehand. You knew about Dr. Drew and followed her here. She takes a stern stance with me, crossing her arms and staring at me angrily. Her expression didn't waiver even a little as I spoke.

But I had figured it out, only two other people knew about the doctor. Either Marina or Blake told you about this. It was a matter of time before people would begin hearing about it, but I didn't think it would happen in just a day. So obviously, one of them told you, despite knowing how much of a stress and pain I had to endure to keep it hidden. Marine feels the first choice, but she is quite reliable in keeping it a secret when she wants to. So it must be Blake. You two have been spending a lot of time together this whole year, so its not a stretch that he told you.

Her expression finally showed cracks of small surprise. I made it look like I was deducing, but already knew for certain. I didn't hear anything about Drew from Marina's recording. Its possible she texted it, but to Catherine of all people. Theres no reason for Marina to share that information. She remained quite despite the angry rant she was on earlier. Though her attitude didn't change. I continued, he must have told you not to butt in to my affairs. And clearly you didn't listen or care. I will have to explain this to Dr. Drew also. She will not be happy to know people are begin to realizing her involvement with me.

Catherine finally speaks up, what is going on. I caught you in therapy, and all you care about is covering your ass. She still harbored annoyance at me. I wasn't being like this just to add flames this situation, I was gauging what else she knows. I say, I know you weren't inside my home. My sensors are flawed, not blind. But I also wasn't warned about your presence in the vicinity. So that means you kept spying on me from outside, even in the ocean. The creatures I saw while we were drifting underwater, you morphed and blended into the crowd. The whole time we were underwater, more than an hour.

If nothing else, I was impressed by her commitment to follow ART underwater for so long. She would have to morph into other fishes, and she kept up her kuret that long. Her abilities as an omega are leagues above her families. Catherine scoffs, you have no idea how hard it was. I lost your trail multiple times. Thank fully, your submarine of a house was circling the same path. Once I figured that out, it was easier to follow. Damn, I should have asked ART to take random paths. Then I realize it can't do that in ocean with limited options to remain hidden.

We state at each other intently now. She followed us underwater, however, that doesn't help her much. She couldn't hear in water, ART is soundproof here. So I suppose she couldn't have heard the conversation. The most she could was, my thoughts froze realizing it. I become vexed at my own mistake for this. I tell her, what did you see from the glass walls. I remember you can lip read, so you must have picked up somethings. My voice turns grim thinking she potentially knows a lot of my secrets. Its probably partly why she is so mad at me. What did she learn.

Her expression finally turns nervous, you figured it out. Even when you have PTSD and bunch of other issues, you are still, well, you. I held my breadth a little as she continues exasperatedly, what makes you think I will tell you. I will just ask Blake or Marina about it. I initially came to find your actual home. But I had to follow you once you all dove underwater. And like you said, I am here to only spy on you. If your wired robots hadn't kept pestering me, I would have left by now.

I gave some thought to her claim and say, that's a lie. If that was all, you could tried to run off as soon as I caught you. Instead you ordered me to get clothes for you and stand here pissed at me. It feels more than just because I kept my therapies hidden. I take a long breath knowing she did read some parts, you picked up some parts of our conversation. And you want to know about them, don't you. I knew I hit the mark when she becomes annoyed, you think you are such a hotshot figuring it all. Aren't you. I wasn't amused by her, I did found you out in the end, didn't I. Let it be a lesson to you, no matter what's going on, I will know the kuret used near me with my eyes.

She makes even angrier face. That boastful provocation was meant to probe her a little more. She didn't know my kuret is on putz right now. So didn't hear anything important from us. I sigh in relief knowing she was only testing me earlier, trying to pull out more information. I lean back in my chair relaxing a bit, I'll commend you for being able to deceive ART completely. But that's all you are getting from me. I have a lot to deal with already. You heard from Drew before, I have to work on myself. So please, leave.

She wasn't going to budge so easily. With a angered voice, she yells, you think I'll leave just because you say. You owe me some explanation. I had enough of her for now. I got up from the chair and move to the center room, I told you. I don't have the time. She follows me from the common room, make time dammit. Don't think this will be like the last time we spoke. I didn't want to do this, but maybe I should force her out with the ART bots. Then she says something that stops my in my tracks, who's Hansen or Zakerine. And how the hell do you know my dad and brother.

Freak this. She heard that. My fists tighten unconsciously. Of all things she could have heard me, she had to stumble on this. What a crappy luck I have. Catherine came to my side and became anxious seeing my expression, so you know them. I thought I imagined it, but I swear I saw you speaking about them. I only have broken pieces, but I was sure you spoke about them. So tell me, why didn't you tell me you knew my family.

I grit my teeth anxiously. I really shouldn't have made the wall transparent. That was the mistake I did trying to distract Drew for some misguided attempt to hide my mental state. Turns out I did a lot more damage than that. You mis read me. I don't know what you are talking about. That was probably the dumbest attempt to hide. Catherine didn't believe a second of it. She points a finger at me not amused, that's a lie. You should look in the mirror. The moment I mentioned them, your pace turned pale. He turns her finger into a fist and says, why are you trying so hard to hide it. It make me more suspicious that it has something to do with me. Blake said there might be some connection with your illness and the fight we had earlier. Is this the reason. Something about my brother you are keeping me out of it.

This is exactly what I don't need right now. Aside from the risk of getting worse, I shouldn't broch this subject willy nilly. But she wouldn't leave me alone now, not after this. She continuous, what the hell is up with you. You have been acting different ever since you got your memories back. Was you life in Medrine so different that you turned out like this. Keeping so much from your friends. I thought I knew you the best, but I was wrong. You are. I couldn't keep it together after he constantly egging me.

I say, you think I want to be like this. Why do you think I put myself in therapy. Just for fun. No. I face her directly now. She stuns at my sudden outburst, you have no idea how much it hurts to keep things from all you guys. But I can't just turn a new leaf after getting my memories. I needed time to sort myself. And that's I have been doing the past year. So don't go judging me just because its coinvent for you to blame on me. You broke the promise when you gave me your word that you and Ned will end your relationship. No, actually, you swore to me that it was over. Turns out, it wasn't. I didn't even force it on you when you lost against me in our match. So you better back the hell off me.

I chewed her out with my rant. She looks completely puzzled listening as I blabbed on. I sighed with my anger subsiding. This won't get us anywhere. Anymore of this line of thinking and I might have another panic attack. I walk to the kitchen, take a glass from the shelf and drink water from the tap. I gulped down 2 cups to calm my nerves. Meanwhile, Catherine just gazed at me nervously now. I closed my eyes and begin taking long breathing. I have no choice. Even if somehow I make her leave, she might do other unnecessary things. She could keep spying on me, or talk to someone else about this. Both options make me feel uneasy. I feel like I am getting exposed, like I am naked right now.

I open my eyes and say to her, fine. Lets talk. That's what I decided. I don't want to drag this out anymore. If I am to get better, I need space. If that means I tell you what you want to know, that's what I'll do. She asks hesitantly, how do I know you will tell me the truth. You have been lying all this time. She is getting on my nerves again. I spat out, you either believe it or not. Take it however you want. But know this, I didn't lie anything. You never asked if I knew from anyone in your family. Theres a big difference.

She scoffs, like that makes it okay. You can't just decide whenever you want to hide things from us. It was hard to stay on topic when she kept pushing me to my limit. I kept reminding myself this is not her fault, it was mine, but she was making me hard to think. What happens when it becomes too much for me to handle. Would it worsen my condition, the one day it shouldn't.

With a heavy restraint I gradually regain my composure, before we talk, do you want anything to eat or drink. Catherine was completely caught off-guard, what, her voice now bamboozled. I answer, you probably stalked Dr. Drew since early morning. You didn't even bother to wear your morphing clothes. So I doubt you ate anything. You have been using your Kuret continuously for more than an hour. You must be exhausted. I don't want you get even more cranky than you already are. This won't be a pretty talk, so yeah, before we talk, I am offering some breakfast.

I point towards the kitchen with the number 3 bot ready to cook, it can make dishes with kuretines. Just don't expect too much. She remained motionless seeing me being so courteous. I wanted her to calm down. She heard few things from us, so she obviously must be imagining a lot of things. I can't talk to her in state where she keeps being mad at me. Also, I needed time to figure out what exactly I should reveal to her. I continue, look, I also need to eat breakfast. So if you don't want it, that’s fine. But I need to eat now. I tried to ease her into this.

She looked suspicious of me at first. Slowly she gives in and nods, fine. I haven't eaten since morning. I used too much kuret. So yeah, you are right, I am exhausted. But don't think I don't know that you are delaying this. I am not leaving without answers.

I sighed at that determination. I could tell this is going to be a harrowing conversation. I have to stay clear of Zakerine or other stuff, while talking about my worse day on Medrine.

David (Chapter 54)

Monday, September 29, 2025 22:58

While we waited for the lunch to be prepared, we both are sitting in the deck basking in cool air. To pass the time I asked her what Blake told her. She is still wary of me, nonetheless she relayed what Blake told her last night. Fortunately, Blake didn't reveal everything. Although I am amazed he was able to link my mental issues to the argument with Catherine. She mentioned Blake did ask to stay clear of me for a while, a correct judgement, but she never promised it. Instead she setup a e-surveillance on Dr. Drew on the network with her own personal codes. Once she got alerted this morning when Dr. Drew left her house around 5:00 AM. She intercepted the car heading out the section and followed me since then.

I sigh at her, we didn't create the that feature in the network to be used for personal reasons. She feels guilt, but the prospect of learning things is not weighing her down, its fine. I have wiped the records now, the only thing anyone will see is a missing log, which no one will find unless looking for it. I am a little worried about the abuse of power she just did. She sees my disappointed face, what's that look for. Like you never do things for personal benefit. It was hard to deny it completely, but I was trained for it. Too bad I tell her why its fine when I do it.

Number 2 and 3 bots dash out from hall. They both carried food trays on their arms. They also brought two glasses with a jug filled with iced juices. The bots laid out the breakfast on the table in front of us. I speak, ART, make us a sheet of cover above us to give us shade. ART shifts the wall from the behind to produce a thin material above us. Catherine looks in awe as it grows horizontally and begins to cover us. The bots leaves us once they setup the table with cutlery. M says, anything else boss. I replied, prepare an emergency sedative for me. I don't know how this will go. M responds, okay, synthesizing a new doze now.

Catherine faces me with now a confused look. I wasn't going to explain that, let her assume anything she wants to. She remained stiff seeing ART modifying my house around us. I dig into my scrambled eggs, not waiting for her finish gawking. She then asks, seriously, what the hell is this place. Blake wasn't joking when he said you used Echo's war remains and technology to build this. What is this ART that you keep talking to. I pondered if it was okay to explain this to her. Maybe revealing a little about it would help with the later topic.

I answer, Autonomous Reconfigurable Technology. Its a system that is a specialized AI clone of M and hardware designed to interface the programmable Echo's material. After the war, I salvaged whatever technology I could from Echos broken ships and weapons. Echo and Medrine tech are not compatible, so instead I used Human science and tech to build this house. With a team of DARPA, NASA and DECA scientists, I build this house. Though, I did use Medrines architecture and design blueprints. This is still just a prototype. She looks at me shocked as I chew on my food. She hasn't yet touched her plate. She says hesitantly, you shared Echo's technology with humans. Isn't that opposite you always wanted.

I reply, I didn't share anything. They work for me. She gasps, say what. You have a team of scientists working for you. I had to reveal this piece of information because no one would I alone built this, especially when there was a tournament going on. I take a sip of lime juice and nod, yes. I couldn't have done this myself. I have them tasked to create weapons and technologies from everywhere, Human, Echo and Medrine. All in preparation for the war we will soon face against Echo. Once she takes in that, I continue, I didn't tell anyone about this because this would create a huge uproar. Medrones are still trying to figure out the Echo machines and techs. If I tell them that I have already figured out a way to use, but it means working with Humans, people may not be thrilled about it.

Catherine fidgets a little, you maybe right about that. Citradel is currently the most advanced technological society, and they prided on being self sufficient. They haven't researched the Echo's weapons we recovered completely. Only just enough to see their effect and how to counter it. They have been delaying the research to use those weapons and instead saying ours will soon be more advance than them. I shrug, and maybe that will happen. But I don't want to rely only on one avenue. Reverse engineering an enemies tech is pretty obvious and important. And I don't particularly care who I have to work with to use it. Maybe once everyone moves here, someone will have the brains to work with humans.

She asks, not you. I shook my head, not me. I already have target on my back, it will worsen if I join the politics. I'll leave that to you guys. She stays a little quite after hearing my explanation. Then, like an internal acceptance she picked up the fork and knife to start eating. She took a bite saying, freak. This is so good. Its better than anything I cook. She enjoys herself as she takes another bite of the fish she ordered earlier. I asked ART to add in kuretines suited to her tastes. Seeing her getting relaxed and eating with such gusto, I was right in making this decision. She didn't show it, but she was exhausted from using her kuret so long. She gulps down half glass of the fruit juice.

I let her eat some more before speaking, lets come back to the topic on hand. She faces me after talking another big bite and nods. I ask, first tell me what you heard. I want to know how big of a mistake I did by using the glass walls. She thinks for moment before replying, I didn't get much. But I think you were talking about your match. I caught Charles and Heraknus name a lot. I picked up some other things like Echo, dreams, and memories. Some things I don't understand, but I did saw you saying my family name. You wouldn't talk about them when referring to just me. So I realized you know them when it came up few times later on. And few names, Wagner, Hanson and Zakerine. I didn't quite read how they are linked to you completely. And yeah, that’s pretty much.

Honestly, it wasn't that bad I was expecting. There was nothing specific and all she heard were dead people names. Its good she didn't pick up on other things I talked, shadows, my issues with Wagner and most importantly, my kuret issues. She continues remembering something, oh. Wait, I also picked up something about your kuret. Like it was blocked or something like it. I am not sure about that one though. My hopes immediately crashed out. Out of all the things she could have heard. My eyes stare at her with such an intensity that she froze while eating. She asks me, what. I didn't reply and kept staring. She understood my intent, that’s all. I don't know anything else. She puts her arms in air resigning.

I so wish I had my kuret to see the glimmers coming off her. I could at least tell if there is any sign of deception. She puts her arms down and says, so its true. You can't use your kuret. I turn my gaze away from her and to the ocean to my side. I felt like I was about get a headache, so I drank a half the jug of water from the table. She looks confused seeing my weird behavior. My throat felt a little cooler now. I open my mouth, I am not going to discuss anything else except about you and your family. That’s the deal, you got it.

She wanted to rebuke, but after thinking about it she nods, yeah. That’s all I care. You can deal with your issues yourself, like you always do. Her harsh tone was a jab at me for being selfish. I was okay with it as long as she doesn't stay mad at me. I clear my throat, so lets talk about your dad first. Brandon was my sponsor in the university. That’s how I know him from. Her eyes become sharp hearing this, but you said you were a scholarship kid. I answer, that’s true. He didn't sponsor me directly, instead he put his own money into the scholarship funds to get me enrolled.

She got curious hearing this act of generosity from her father, why would he do that. I gather my words carefully here, I later found out he wanted to use my thesis on non-kuret applications I published into practice. He let me in the university because he saw potential in that work. I had initially pitched that thesis hoping to get someone attention, and then become my sponsor. It just happened to be your dad. So I agreed to give him my theories and work to be researched in his department. It was an lucrative arrangement for us, I get to live on campus and he get to research on my work.

Catherine jerks a little in her chair, are you kidding me. He wouldn't pay for my summer trip to my favorite place, but he paid for your entire stay and education in one of the costliest university on Medrine. She got annoyed and complained to me about her dad, what the hell kind of theories did you write to give a cheapskate of a father to endorse you. I answered, it doesn't matter. They were just theories I wrote after my own condition not able to interact with Kuret. I don't even know if it even led to any fruition. Brandon never told me the specifics, he just said they are making progress. That was true, I think about it sometimes. He paid such a heavy amount for it, it must have been for something. Otherwise, it was just a pointless endeavor.

I sigh, well, whatever the case, it doesn't matter now that Medrine is gone. With so much of our tech lost, one small research area like mine doesn't matter. Catherine slightly nods, okay. So you met by dad in the university. That can't be the end of it though. She is right, I nodded, we met for purely academic reasons. But he gradually become more of a mentor for me. He showed me to new things I never experienced before in my orphanage. From politics to society to culture. He took me to various work trips, even became an academic advisor of sorts. Once he realized my high intellect, he became more interested in involving me in his department. I had envisioned my life at university to be a quite one, away from others who didn't understand me. But he did. It wasn't long until I began enjoying the work. I became the youngest student to be under his advisory.

They were good times. I recalled what fleeting memories I had of my time there. The time we celebrated the night on completing a project. Or him complaining about his wife or kids to me. I didn't understand why he would unburden his family stuff on a kid. Even if was precocious for my age, you shouldn't talk to kids about that. It was only later I learned the real reason he hand picked me. Catherine saw me reminiscing, you really know him, huh. I can't believe he never mentioned you at home. That pulled me out of my little day dream. I knew why he didn't talk about me to others. But I can't tell her about it.

I continue, I never visited your house, so I am sure he just wanted to keep his work separate. I told her a version of the truth. She asks, and my brother, you knew him too. I reply, not as much as Brandon. He had joined the university two years ahead of me, so we didn't share much in common academically. He was more hands on than us academics, studying in the social department. But we had a mutual friend, so I met him couple of times. She asks, who was this friend. Do I know this person.

This is were it got tricky. I say, she was in the same year as him. We became friends only in my 2nd year, her 4th year. You both never met. And that was all I was going to divulge to her about Zakerine. I hoped it was enough to not dig deeper. Her eyebrows raises and she makes a puzzled look, I don't understand. If you were just good friends with my Dad, why never tell me about it. I was relieved she didn't ask more about Zakerine. But now I do have to tell her something worse, for her at least.

I swallow hard, what I am going to tell you is going to be difficult to hear. So listen to the entire story before judging your dad or me. Got it. My serious gaze met hers and she became tensed. With a suspicious look she nods. I continue, on our last day of Medrine, 1000 kids were chosen to be sent in our fastest spaceship, Galexon. You know that already, and how kids were chosen. What you don't know is that your father had chosen John to be sent instead of you. But he never made it to the ship, so you were taken in instead.

I waited to let her sink this in. She remained stunned for a moment. Then she spoke meekly, so I was the backup. I didn't want to tell her this, I even warned her enough it wasn't pleasant. But maybe she can handle it now after surviving on an alien planet. She nods hesitantly, it hurts, but I get it. John was older, more experienced and was better than me. So it makes sense dad would pick him. Her face betrayed her voice though. It showed disappointment. She knows kids weren't selected based on current physical and mental state. They were picked considering their potential in the future. She asks, did my dad tell you that.

I nod, yes. Couple hours before our departure, I met him at the university HQ that was evacuating in the middle of Echo attack. He explained his reasons to pick John to other parents and guardian. He told. I felt uneasy telling this to Catherine. Seeing my reluctance she spoke, tell me. I want to know. I didn't need to see her glimmer to know she was hurting. Anyone would be upset at this. With a heavy heart I continue, I'll just bottom-line it. He told you weren't mentally strong enough to endure and protect others. I didn't knew much about you back then, but it seems your dad had the opinion that you were more like your mother. It wasn't a bad thing, she was kind, caring and fiercely protective of her children. He believed those qualities passed on to you more than your brother. Qualities not meeting the requirement for sending you in Galexon.

Her silence and blank expression showed her discouraged emotions. But now that I have decided to reveal it to her, I can't stop. I add on, John was there too. And well, he agreed after discussing more. With the father son leading that discussion other people followed suit in making terrible and harsh decisions in choosing which children to send. I didn't agree completely what they did, but I disagree too. It was what it was. If I had known about you back then, maybe I would have been in favor of you. Then I realize it wasn't the truth. It was just a biased view after years of experience with Catherine.

She understood my intention, thanks. You don't have to give excuses for them. I understand it wasn't an easy decision a parent needed to make. With a crestfallen voice she asks, was my mother there. I shook my head. She sighs a little, that’s a little relief. She would have gone ballistic at dad. She would have argued to send both of us. Maybe dad didn't want her there to begin with. After a few seconds of silence her accepting this cruel realization she asks, what else. You wouldn't keep it hidden if that was it. I am sure many people faced cruel decisions to make. Even Vanessa was sent instead of her own brother.

If only she knew the whole truth about that family. But that’s irrelevant to Catherine. I tell, yes. Theres more. I got my memories a year back, but there have been gaps that were still foggy for me. Particularity on the last day of Medrine. A lot happened that day. I have PTSD from that single day alone. My time in therapy helped me make sense of them. With time I began to recall memories much clearly. Things which I had to assume earlier became clearer. One of them was about Bradon and John.

She pulls out another nervous look. I gather my wits and continue, that last day, I was being carried by someone to the ship. The name you read, Hansen. He was another mentor of mine. Not academically like Brandon. But outside my life in campus. I rather not talk about him though. Its complicated. Anyways, when we both crossed the barricade and made it to the ship, I met Brandon there. John wasn't with him. He said John couldn't make it in time and instead sending you in place of him. He was worried about you being alone, so he, um, asked me to look over you. And I promised him. At least that was my actual intention at the time.

Catherine becomes anxious, hold on. He asked you, a skinny kid who didn't have kuret instead of, well anyone on that ship. I understood her confusion and shock. I answer, trust me. It wasn't lost on me he was asking something crazy of me. I don't fully understand his reasoning. Maybe because we kept close over the years made him greatly trust in me. Or maybe something else entirely. I take a short beath, but doesn't matter. I promised something to person who helped me for years and then completely failed at it by loosing my memories arriving on Earth.

Her expression turn downcast hearing about it. I say, there's more. After making that promise, we were attacked by Echos. In the struggle, Bradon gave his life protecting me and Hanson. And recently a new memory resurfaced that John was there during that same attack too. And just like his father, he died protecting a friend. A feel slight tremble passing though my body. I tighten my hand on my knees to calm my nervous. Zakerine is like a landmine for my mental emotional state right now. The memories of their dead bodies come into my mind. This triggered other memories of Zakerine trying to revive John.

I forced myself to not get sucked into another spiral of darkness. I don't know how long I was zoned out. But Catherines voice zapped me out. She asked concerned, David. Are you okay. I look up to he nervous face. I take long breathes and say, yeah. Sorry. But now you see why I am in therapy. A lot of my issues have sprouted from that day. I hid it because I don't want sympathy from people. Everyone has gone through something. My body feels better now. I pour another glass of water from the jug. Even with the winds, I am sweating a little. This is bad, I have no clue on curing this before midnight.

Catherine asks with her softened tone, you saw them die. He eyes feels hazy, like she is trying to see something beyond this view. I nod, yes. I was there when they both died. Someone else also died there. Someone I was close with. The death broke me. So much so that I forgot all about the promises I made with others, including Brandons, and decided to loose my memories. It was cowardly, and complete disrespect to all the people who died saving me. And that’s why after a decade of guilt living, it has impacted me emotionally. When my memories returned, we were in the middle of a war. So I didn't notice it then. But soon after I felt it, the burden of knowing I threw away my responsibilities selfishly.

I began to breath a little fast from my rantings. Shit. I lost some control and spoke too much. I shouldn't be telling this to Catherine just after telling something so awful. She bows her head down, away from me. With a quite tone she asks, so, this is why didn't tell me earlier. She mumbles something to herself a little more. She suddenly faces me back, is that why you kept pushing me to break up with Ned also. She finally understands my reasons, yes. I was guilt driven and trying to look out for you. But it went too far. I added my own personal mess into it. When I found out you and Ned were still together, I went overboard. I felt like I was letting down Brandon all over again. He and John gave their life, and somehow only I made it out among them. You breaking your promise with me was like how I broke mine with Brandon. And I know it doesn't make sense, there is no real connection between the two. But that’s how my screwed up mind process it.

I thought I would feel better telling this to Catherine. But it felt even worse. I could have lied, maybe made something up about how I knew Brandon and John. I could have spared her and my feelings. But I am tired of keeping it from her. Catherine remained silent for a long time. I was worrying every second of her silence. What is she thinking. Does she hate me. Her dad and brother died saving me. Who wouldn't. And then I go butt in her relationship thinking that’s not what Brandon would have wanted.

As I waited patiently for her to speak, I hoped this wasn't a giant mistake. Maybe I should have really kept quite. She finally speaks up, I had no idea you and dad were so close. I don't think you made that part too. He was always got lost in his work. He never once allowed me in his home office or at his work. I actually jealous you saw more sides of him I knew about. I think I am angry about it too. It was a natural response. Knowing some other person was involved with him closely. It must be painful. I wasn't going to add more on by involving shadows here.

She asks me, is my relationship with Robb , something dad would never approve. Or was it just you. He asked me a very difficult question. It was a very complicated one to answer. I answer honestly, both. Like I said, I didn't you well enough back in Medrine. But I knew Brandon very well. He loved you, in spite of the decisions he made. He wouldn't have wanted you to be in a doomed relationship. She fires a question immediately, you think that’s what dad thought about me. She got mad, and perhaps even justified. But I was sure, I am sure. He was very vocal about his bloodline and family. I spent years with him, I know him well enough to know what he would have wanted for you. And I want to believe, I do to.

Her anger simmers down a bit, dammit. How could dad do all of this. Make you responsible for me. This is not fair at all. Treating me like I can't make any good decisions. I rebuked, I didn't say that. I only wanted what was best for you. Brandon played a key role in this, but remember, I told you and Robb years back that one day you both will have to end your relationship. She got frustrated at that, you keep reminding me that. I keep telling you, this isn't like Cristyn. Robb and I have been together for years. We both know about each other.

I raise my hand before we argued further, let me stop you hear. We had this argument last time. Its pointless. That triggered another emotional reaction from Catherine. She probably got even angrier. But I wanted to say my final piece here, look. I can't explain why, but I am not going to interfere with you both anymore. That stopped her from getting mad. Instead confusion washed over her, what. What do you mean. I explained, I always knew this isn't like Cristyn and me. And you both can make your own decisions. Good or bad ones. But it was my mistake to keep pressuring you break up with Robb.

She asks flabbergasted, what's going on. You were so adamant I was making a mistake all this time. I now that I know the whole story, you are going to back off now. I simply nod yes. I will. I made a mistake. So I apologies on how poorly I handled myself. I was guilt ridden and wasn't thinking straight then. It doesn't matter what Brandon would have wanted. He made me promise to watch over you. And if that means if you don't agree with what he would have wanted, I will have to take your side. I misjudged my responsibilities with my emotions.

I had been thinking about it for a while that I didn't handle this correctly. But somehow after learning the entire truth of what happened that day, it changed me a little. Zakerine died because she couldn't give up on John. Regardless of what I believed, I was helpless and couldn't do anything. Something Drew told me had been bothering me. That somehow my actions were subconsciously influenced due to this even when I didn't remember it. Maybe it was also when I argued with Catherine.

Meanwhile, Catherine was dumbstruck at this. She says, I don't believe you. You really would back off me now. I reply, that’s the true. I shouldn't have interfered in the first place. Who am I to judge who you should love. I wasn’t in right mindset back then. I still am not. But I at least I can recognize Brandon wanted you to be happy and safe. Doesn't matter how or with whom. So I promise I won't bother you about it anymore. You were always free to do whatever you want.

I still harbored reservations about their tenuis relationship between an omega Medrone and a human. Maybe that will never change. But I have learnt I was displacing my frustrations of keeping my promise to Brandon for something else. Maybe something to do with Hansens claim I will become strong. Or maybe its about Zakerine. I am not sure about that.

I thought Catherine wouldn't believe me. I wouldn't blame her. Its not something I thought I would come to realize now. But I am glad I did. At least now she knows everything. Well, not everything. But what's really relevant to her. She says, okay. I believe you. I, hum, well I just, she was lost of words. I think I know her hesitations. I say, its fine. It was my fault to being with misinterpreting a promise. And I also hope you don't believe Brandon didn't love you or something like that. He made a decision, not made from malice but a cold, harsh logic. I know it probably doesn't help much, but that’s all I got. You loved you and John. So did your brother. I didn't want to tarnish your memories of them like this. So I decided selfishly not to share this.

With a subtle nod she says, thanks. I know you are right. But I just need some time. I never thought you kept something like this from me all this time. I understand why you did. She fidgets a little, I am sorry how I came at you earlier. I knew you wouldn't have kept something from me if it wasn't for a good reason. But its hard when its about my own family. I say, you don't have to apologies to me. But I do wonder if I made the right call by telling you all this. What do you think. Its an old story and about people long dead. Should I have never told you this. Or is it better to know.

She didn't answer such a emotional question for a while. After some thinking she says, I don't know. I can't decide. Maybe you were right to keep it from me. But that would have meant I would be cross with you all the time. A smile appear at the corner of my mouth, I can make peace with that. Because at least you wouldn't have to worry about things people long gone thought about you. Even if you were mad at me, at least it would spare you the pain.

She looked disheartened. I couldn't imagine the turmoil she would be in. The one I put her in now. I heard a ping from M, boss. I hope your talk with miss Catherine is over. The cruise carrying Citradel officials will be leaving in 30 minutes. I didn't want to intrude earlier, but its time now. Her timing was accurately intuited, yeah. We are pretty much done here. I push my chair back and got up on my feet. I tell Catherine, lets end this now. I know you have a lot to talk. And I don't want to be rude, but I have important things to do.

Catherine also got up, its okay. I understand. You are heading to the port now. I reply, yes. I need to meet Charles before he leaves. I also need to talk to the officers. Actually, everyone. I have been out of touch for a almost 24 hours now. It wouldn't look good to Island people me being sideline for so long. She knows what I meant since she was busy dealing with Citradel guests last night. She asks, I like to tag with you as well. I turned to her with a hesitant look, are you sure.

She sighs, I won't deny I am a little unsure how I feel about you. But at least I understand why you did it. So for now lets table it for later. Like you said, its important to show yourself to everyone. I was relieved to know she isn't angry with me like before. I couldn't think about it now. We both walk inside the room, one more thing. She answered before I asked, yeah. I won't tell anyone about your therapy or about this house. Don't worry about it.

I showed my appreciation to her, thanks. I still didn't feel any better sharing this secret to Catherine. But I learnt something from our discussion. I never figured it out before, but that hint from Drew has made me reevaluate few things. Some decisions and choices I was too afraid to make. Maybe there is something here that I could understand and fix my kuret block.

Blake (Chapter 55)

Thursday, October 2, 2025 23:25

Today has to be a normal day. I wanted it to be. No more excitement or surprises. Okay, maybe some, but not many. I got enough to deal with Heraknus moving. I had to wake up early today, so I asked everyone to leave around 12:30 AM. For Matt and Marina, I had to kick them. They were having way too much fun. Between sharpening a drunk Marina and Cassandra's sudden alter ego bursts, the party became more about blowing some steam rather than enjoying our victory. I didn't mind though, because I enjoyed it more than I excepted. For months, we had been training and managing the tournament. It has been mentally taxing. I even told other officers to the night take time off. Some did. However, sone didn't want off, they kept on working believing its not the time to celebrate. They weren't necessarily wrong, because it wished the moral would be more relaxed this accomplishment.

Fortunately, I had enough sleep last night. The kuret alcohol didn't give me too much hangover. By the time I was ready and finished breakfast, the last effects of the numbness was gone. I messaged on the network that I and some officers will meet the Citradel officers and escort them to the south shore. Everyone responded within minutes, save for one. Catherine didn't respond. I assumed she was just running late. Last night she said she was too tired. So I am sure she had late start.

When I reached the Citradel guest houses, I still didn't hear from her. Now I am getting a little worried. I shared somethings about David to her. Did that have to do something. Other officers arrived near the entrance after few minutes of my arrival. Luther and Jess were the first ones. They both had worn the special uniform we prepared. I myself had worn my royal attire. Luther had messaged last night to everyone that we should wear them to show our authority from David's victory. I wasn't sure if we call it victory, but I got convinced by him that this would make the statement that we are beginning of new sovereignty, a new city.

I was waiting by guest house entrance lobby. Jess says impressed, so that’s your new royal dress. Its exquisite. I smile, thanks. I was just happy it fits. It doesn't look too tight, right. Luther laughs, you look great. Perfect for a royal dignitary. I spat, lets hope Nathan and Freya don't get offended. Jess replies, I already spoke with them. They don’t mind. Truth be told I wasn't worried about it, I just said to let her know I am aware of her family and loyalties. But nevertheless, it was good to know it wasn't an issue. Luther asks, I don't see Catherine here. She is only one still not reported yet. Do you know if she is late.

I say, I have been trying to reach her. But she isn't picking up. Jess says, she messaged me early in the morning that if she couldn't make it, I should step take her role. So should I oversee the Citradel officials transitioning. At that’s good some good news. I look at Luther to confirm our decisions. I nod, yeah, that would be good. Thanks. Luther asks, so you what all you have to do. Jess nods with confidence, its just showing hospitality and managing their exit procedures. And, she pulls out her tablet, I got the roster of those cleared to moving today. Catherine and I had gone through all the checklists yesterday. So I am good.

Luther nods, all right. I will let others know you will be arriving instead of Catherine. Luther walks outside to talk to others. Jess says, all right. See in later. I wave her off as she walks inside past the gate. It was 8:00 AM, so we had an hour before they will leave. It was the time we needed organize and move our officers. I coordinated with Tina and others to confirm the route and keep the rood closed until the Citradel conveys leave. I got a report from Tessa that she and Nathan had arrived at the shore around 8:30 AM. They were setting up the barricade around the pier and should be done in few minutes.

But then we had another officer late. It was Vanessa. All though, she had at least messaged that she is running late. Unlike Catherine, who still hasn't reported in. I asked around few people if they knew if Catherine contacted them. No one had any idea. I can only hope she is late like Vanessa. Soon we got a message from Jess that the first group of officials with their guards will be coming out. We gathered around the entrance gate and had the cars pulled into the lot.

Tina reports to me, that’s all the cars. The last one is for Charles and his family. As you wanted, you and Jess will ride with them. Me and others will be riding with the rest of the officials. I nod, and what about the Heraknus group. Are they still requesting for no one to go with them. She got nervous, yeah. They are insisting they don't need any escorts. I sigh, its not just that simple. We can't have them ride alone. I turn up my tablet and view the convey arrangement. There were 7 Heraknus people. We had them in an 2 SUV. But they kept wanting to take everyone in one alone by not having any officers. I didn't see any issue with them riding on their own, but they are not yet citizens of this city. They were only our guests.

Luther approaches to Tina and me. He looks over my shoulder the contents of the screen. He immediately understood, so they still won't budge huh. Tina nods to him. I say to him, I don't like the idea of having unchaperoned Heraknus people moving in the city. Even if they will become residents soon, they are not yet one. And plus, they are in a very peculiar position. He nods, no need to explain. I agree with you. Personally, I would I have like to be them, but they don't want anyone with them. I stop once I scrolled to a name. Yeah, that could work.

I face Tina, lets make a small change. If they don't want us, fine. Lets have a Citradel official we trust with them instead. If we move Chancellor Reyas, they wouldn't object. And we can put Luther in place of him. Tina says after taking the tablet from me, I have heard about him. Do we trust him. I nod, yes. I have met him few times. He is actually in support of them moving here. He may not openly support it, but he told me in confidence when we met. Luther is in agreement with me, yeah. I know about him too. That’s a good choice. He will make sure no one causes any trouble to either from or to Heraknus.

Tina eyes to the screen, all right. I'll make the changes. She give me the tablet back and leaves to pass the change to others. Luther says, I guess there will some issues with Heraknus once they join. They don't trust us enough. It did look like that. I say, we were expecting it, right. We even prepared for it. But not with a mythical bloodline. Nor them moving here so fast. I think we should expedite our expansion plans immediately. We will soon have to treat them as domestic problems soon. Luther nods, I will take a note of that in our today's meeting.

They were taking some time, then Jess messages that the officials were discussing something and will be getting delayed for a while. I messaged her that Its not a problem since we have planned for a delay of up to an hour before any real issues happen. I wondered what they might be talking just minutes before leaving. A strong hunch was that it was about the Heraknus moving here. Could Kafar be trying to do make a play. But how that work after the conference last night. It has to be about something not to do with him then.

Few minutes later the officials began coming out. Me and Luther begin greeting them. The first one was Geisha. She smiles, good morning prince Blake. You look the part of royals now. I smile in return, morning chancellor. Thanks. I hope you get to see lot of it soon. I flashed a bigger smile hinting the possibility that they all will be moving here. She smirks amused, someone is getting ahead of himself. I don't deny the possibility though. Good chance we will soon be neighbors.

I nod, counting the days. You and your bodyguards can take that car. See you again soon. She replies, thanks Blake. Luther lets them guide to their vehicle. With that, one by one I showed my presence to the officials. When Reyas approached to me, he whispers, you moved me with Heraknus specially didn't you. I nod, apologies for the change. But they wouldn't let any officer with them. I don't want to presume, but is something more going on here than simple not being able to trust us. Reyas thinks for a bit before answering, I am not exactly sure. I knew about their existence in Citradel, but never met them. Kafar had exclusively met them every time. But I spent some time last at dinner. If I had to guess, its just probably that they are wary of others. They didn't expect to more here so unexpectedly. I am sure their attitude will change once they start living here.

It might be like he suggested. But if it were that simple, they wouldn't refuse us to have an officer with them. If Reyas didn't know, then maybe only Kafar would know. But I am not going to poke that bear. I say, thanks for listening to me. I hope its just that. Anyways, thanks for staying with us. I hope your visit was enjoyable. He shakes hands with me smiling, that it was. I loved the open air and freedom here. I will try my best to get others to listen to me and move here as soon as possible. I smiles, that’s very gracious of you. Before he leaves with his guards he says, by the way, you owe me one for this. No, two if the other thing also happens.

I laugh and wave at him. The other officials come and go into their vehicles. The cars in the lot waited to load their luggage's in the trunk. Meanwhile, the last of the Citradel people came out. The first few people were the Heraknus people. I met with 4 men and 3 women. I shook hands with each one, and every time I sensed their aura to be wavering a little. Its like they were intimated by me. I wasn't planning to come out looking like that. But they were polite and enjoying my company. One lady says, first time meeting a Volta royal terra. Another guy says, thanks for having us. I reply, nice to meet you all.

They didn't look any different from rest of Medrones. That goes to show how much the myth has twisted the reality. I took extra caution not to show any sign of treating them any different. Hopefully they can learn to trust me soon. Once they leave, the man of the hour comes in. Charles and his family were accompanied by Jess. I recognized Melinda beside him. The other two must be his children. Only Kafar, Marina and Derek were remaining. They should be with them, but I don't see them anywhere. Regardless, I signal to Luther that we are ready to move out soon.

Charles was wearing a track pants and a v-cut shirt. He spoke first, hey Blake. Looking sharp. I reply, morning to you too. Melinda, who wore a simple dress, beside him says, hello prince Blake. Nice to meet you. We both behave as though this is our first time meeting. Charles says, meet my son and daughter. They both introduce themselves as Rory and Tory. They both chose to wear the traditional Citradel uniforms. I answer, glad to meet you all. Hope you enjoyed the island. Tory was a tad bit more energetic than anyone says, I did. Its an awesome place. Citradel is cool and all, but the vibe here is on another level. But you guys have so much space and yet so little used. Rory interjects, sis, be more respectful. He is the leader of this place.

Seems he is more sensible than her sister. Melinda cuts in, not now you two. I don't want to hear complaining. Not with your first public appearance. I didn't want to be in the middle of this, so I ended by saying, when you come back in a month, we will expand the island's infrastructure. Tory says excited, awesome. I have a request then, I need a big arena for training. Like for a 100 of Heraknus people. And a ground too. We got some equipment and tech that. Rory cuts in, that’s enough. We don't need to discuss that. Tory made an irritating expression. I was glad he himself stop her. Melinda also scolded her daughter a little pulling her to the side. I wasn't sure how to deal with a requests like that. Should I lie or keep it vague.

Charles puts one arm in air, don't take it seriously Blake. She is just excited. We are not going to make any exorbitant demands. With a subtle nod I guided them to their car. The guards with them carried the luggage before us and began placing in the trunk. I turned and waited for Marina and Derek to arrive. Kafar comes out alone next. He had a little scowl as he approached us. I say, morning Kafar. Did you get enough rest. Kafar scoffs, hey Blake. I did as much as I could. Your sneaky stunt last night made some stir, I had to work extra to extinguish that.

I only smiled in response. I better not make any scene here. I made sure to be cordial to him so that he doesn't retaliate in any unexpected way, especially right now. He asks, how is our new champion doing anyway. I haven't heard anything about him since the match. I momentary was amused to hear him say that. He didn't show it, but his aura showed me a little tinge of irritation. I reply, he is fine. I haven't gotten a chance to speak to him, but rest assured, I am told he is just resting. Kafar nods ever so slowly pondering if I was lying. Technically I was, I had to make sure he never picks up on David's actual condition.

Kafar finally gives in, well, that’s good. Is he going to be at the pier. Even Charles perks up hearing that question and eyes me. Honestly, I had no clue. But I can't say that. So instead I say, we will see if he is, won't we. I played it safe, keeping it amusingly ambiguous. Charles laughs, no matter. We got we wanted from him, so its no problem. He is probably mentioning about Melinda approaching us about the questions he had. I didn't know if Kafar was in the know or he just ignoring it, but he says, in any case we have one last business to care of.

Huh, what could he be talking about it now. He says, after some discussion we decided to let Marina remain here and act us our emissary. So she won't be coming with us to Citradel. That was a sudden and strange development. I ask, what. Why is that. Charles answers this time, I proposed it to the officials. She has an extensive knowledge and skills to build our infrastructure here. Of course, it will a joint project with you, not just ours. But since I am making Heraknus move here early, I had to take my peoples consideration. We are used to the setup in Citradel, and we would like a similar one here. Marina didn't know about our existence, but she designed the buildings and infrastructure we lived and used.

That made sense. They were delaying to discuss this then. Actually, this is even a good news for us. I bet Marina is thrilled. She has been ready for this for a long time. Before I get excited I give an anxious look to Kafar, are you sure though. Marina is still your second strongest person. I wouldn't have thought you would let her live here even before Heraknus moved. Kafar nods, I know how it looks. But I had to change my thinking ever since the Charles made the deal. I actually supported this when Charles told us. I know exactly what's going to happen next. When we go back, people will be thrilled to see Heraknus as their secret guardian. And when the time comes, they will have no choice but to move with them. Others may seem hesitant and vague about moving here with Heraknus, but I am not.

Its more weird to seem him given up and accepting this. His attitude has reversed completely. He says, and since that is going to eventually happen, I thought we prepare for it now anyways. Marina could get started integrating the city immediately. We can remotely discuss with your team on what changes and new infrastructure to have in place. We have those initial plans you shared before the start of the tournament. Certain things will be approved immediately for Marina to start working on. Others, we will take some time discussing with you all. Our goal will be to get at least 10 to 15% of the development before Heraknus move. From then the progress will be rapid since people will be coming in soon from Citradel and other small communities.

He is already on top of this. This was probably the best thing I could have heard today. He sees my surprised look, don't look so shocked when you already know it was going to happen. I shook away my confusion, I didn't expect you would be so propellent. I did think we should start discussing it, but not day one. I would have contacted you once you reach Citradel. Kafar replies with a snarky tone, yeah. I know what hand I am delt with. Best to go with what I can control. I turn to Charles who smiles and nods to me.

I smile, Marina must be enjoying. Where is then. Charles says, when Kafar told her she frantically took her stuff from her room to someplace before you came. I couldn't help a laugh when I imagined seeing her rushing. My guess, she dropped her stuff at my place. I gave her the codes to my home, plus she did mention once she was going to use my place for temporary stay. I say, I suppose we should start looking a place for her as well. Kafar says annoyed, that capricious women left without wasting a second. I waited for her to discuss everything, but without me realizing, she had already left the guest houses. She even dragged Derek to help her out. What kind of stuff she has that she couldn't carry herself.

I knew what Marina was keeping with her. She could have carried everything herself, but having Derek with her just speeds things up. I look around the other waiting cars filled with the officials, so I am thinking Derek will meet us on the pier. Charles nods, yes. He told me not to wait and meet at the ship. I reply, okay then. So we can leave then. I signal to Luther and Tina that we are ready. Jess says, everyone and their luggage's are all set. I held the door as Charles and Kafar get in. The guards got in from the back side.

Jess took the driver seat and I went to the passenger seat. A minute later all the 7 cars left the guest house and on route to the pier. I was thrilled to have Marina move here so suddenly. The chances of all Citradel moving here took a big leap now. Jess whispers to me from the side, I heard what you were talking. So its true, Marina is moving here already. I nod. She smiles and cheers with slight gesture of her fist in air. Behind us the Heraknus kids were discussing with their parents about the islands features and places they licked. I get the feeling that Melinda and Charles didn't get much outside exposure. Considering the important work Melinda does, and the squad of people protecting her, she couldn't move around easily.

Neither could Charles. Jess asks Charles, Charles, if can please humor me with a question. Where would you like to live. Charles says, that’s a good question. As you know, didn't got to see much of island. But my kids have. And I heard the eastern parts of section 4 is a good spot. She glances me for a second with a confused look. I understood why she looked at me. I answer, so you prefer to live near the mountains. Charles nods, its not like the one's we had in Medrine. But its quite reminiscent of our lost history. I know it will never be back, but I think we can make it work with what we got.

I understood their sentiments. At this point Rory cuts in, I don't remember much about our homes. Gina, our older sister who stayed back in Citradel with the twins, remembers the most among us. When I showed her some pics few weeks back, she immediately asked us to check if anyone already took the place. Jess asks hesitant about something, she asked about a potential place to live here even before knowing you all will be moving here. That seems, she lost her words. It wasn't just her. It was strange Charles own daughter would think Charles would be loosing.

Rory went silent for some reason, like he thought of something unpleasant. Charles makes a funny expression, Gina is probably the biggest fan of David in whole of Citradel. She will always deny it, but we can tell. She has been tracking all his exploits and accomplishments. Before I left, she told me if I never got to fight you or Vanessa, David is probably the next likely to defeat me. I didn't think much of it, that is, until David came to the finals. She must be going ecstatic seeing David kicking her fathers ass.

I tried so hard to stifle a laugh. This is way too funny. Of all the people who could be supporting David, who would have guessed a mythical alpha's daughter. I saw Jess trying her best not to show her teeth. Tory says, hey that’s not true dad. Gina was just teasing you. Charles scoffs, don't defend her. I am not that stupid. Melinda, didn't Gina say that to you as well. Melinda flashes a smile, I am not going to get between the two of you.

It was complicated, and yet a normal family. No one would believe that they were from a mythical bloodline. Its quite a coincidence though. At the beginning of the final match, Ned had shown the peoples win stats which showed 8% for David. One of the supporters must have been Gina. Charles must be really conflicted to know her daughters prediction came true. David's grow strong during the tournament, but before that, he worked mostly in obscurity. For humans, we was just a criminal. For Medrones, he was a menace who fought for the right reasons. Even though he was framed by Nathan, not many could have supported David from Citradel. I wonder what kind of women Gina was.

We chatted a bit more about the Island development plan. That was the only time Kafar pitched in with his thoughts. After 10 minutes we reached the south shore. A swarm of people had gathered here. Jess had to slow down to be careful avoiding them. The barricade helped people keep at bay, but the kuritine drones with cameras fly over us towards the windows. They must be trying to get glimpses of Charles or any Heraknus. Jess says, guys. Apologies for all this commotion, but we couldn't keep people away far enough. Charles says nervously, the attention is little unsettling, I am not going to lie. Like all Heraknus, I am also not used to such scrutiny.

I advised him, better get used to it. When you come live here, there will be some challenges on both sides. And for a while, you will have to handle little bit of fame. Charles nods anxiously. His kids didn't faze much. I guess, they are now used to it after growing up with others on an alien planet. Melinda says, come on Charles. Don't let this get to you. I am also feeling a little bit of pressure now. But we knew this was going to happen ever since you decided to enter the tournament.

Charles says, knowing and experiencing are different things. Besides, I am not letting it get to me. I am the first Heraknus alpha they get to see in after than a two centuries. Its just a little bit of anxiety. Its understandable he feeling a little bit of pressure. The stadium was a little different, people were cheering for him, not approaching him like this to answer their questions. Some officers came by our side and pulled people a little further away from the road. With their help, we finally reach the shore parking lot.

I say, all right. Lets get you all on that boat. Once Jess parks the SUV, we all climb out. The cheering of the people became louder and the heat was felt from their voices. The guards begin unloading the bags from trunk. Ahead of us, I saw aura of Tessa and Vanessa near the pier entrance. I saw Nathan pacing around the pier, walking and speaking with officials as they climb on the cruisers. Since we were delayed, they got some time to push the barricade further back keeping the reporters from interfering too much.

Kafar says, since we some time until others go ahead, I want to talk to some people here. The pleasant mood turn sour hearing that. Kafar didn't wait for me to say anything and left us. I put my eyes on Jess pointing her to him. She nods, yeah, I'll just go with him. You know, so that he doesn't take too long. I hope she could somehow keep any of his usual antics away as much as possible. Rory approaches me, I don't see David here. So he really didn't come. I was hopping he be here. I didn't answer him and shrug giving him the impression that it is what it is.

Well, I was hoping to avoid this conversation all together. I had a small hope that he would be here. But I am little worried that Catherine is also not here. If was wasn't going to come, she would have at least told us. Both these absent people is making me worrisome.

Vanessa (Chapter 56)

Wednesday, October 1, 2025 17:28

Last night I couldn't get a lot of sleep. I kept thinking about my brother, my idol, my hero. I refuse to believe he would risk harming children. And when I did try to push those thoughts out, I kept thinking why Ned behaved differently to me all of a sudden. I thought we were in a good place in our relationship. I don't know how we got here, the argument we had in the VIP room started it. But it silently grew into a complete mess whenever I see him ignoring me or not talking.

My eyes were still heavy as I lay in my bed. The morning alarm had been snoozed twice already. I didn't want to face others in my current state. The third time it rang, Siera knocked on the door, Vanessa, wake up. You are going to get late. I didn't answer her right away. She knocks a couple more time. I sigh, yeah. I am awake. You know I can get up on my own. Siera says, then stop acting like a kid. You have work to do. I don't like to keep reminding you like this. Even if were late last night, you can't become lazy.

I rebottle at that, I wasn't late out for fun you know. Catherine, Tessa and I had to prepare security for Citradel guests for the night. It took a while to get all the shifts and manage personal. She scoffs behind the door, don't think I know you didn't get sleep because of that. I know you had a lot to deal yesterday. But you need to shake it off. Citradel officials are leaving soon. And your presence is necessary. So hurry up. If she weren't right I would have chided her for being so pushy.

With a laxed movement, I got out my bed, yeah. I got it. I will be out in 30 minutes. I turned towards the mirror and saw my face all flushed and heavy. This is what I get for obsessing so much about boys. Siera is right, I need to focus on today. A quick scroll through the network messages in my phone showed that Citradel officials are going to leave from the south shore 2 hours from now. All the top officers are required to be present by 8:30 AM. I had already assigned the guards for this morning around the south port, but I should still arrive a bit early. There were no new messages. Not from Ned or David.

David has been missing all night. After meeting Catherine last night, she told he is okay as Marina is able to check up on him. So assuming nothing happened, he is just hiding out somewhere. Many people went to his home, but he wasn't there. Blake told is he someplace secure, so maybe he is somewhere out of eyes of Citradel. Maybe there will be more news about him today. I am tiered of telling people I don't where is his or if his is okay. He better show up today to officers building. I have so much to ask him about Wagner.

Another guy I am anger is Ned. Last we spoke, I told him I needed space. I don't know what's going to happen to us. This is our first fight, its odd how long it took to finally happen. It started with him not supporting me when were betting the winner. But slowly it imploded. Even after thinking about most of the night I don't understand why he became so cold. But one thing is sure, I don't want to speak him today also. I want more time to sort out my feelings.

It took me longer to get out of shower today. I thought bathing more would help me relax, it didn't help as much I wanted. I pulled out the officer clothes from my rack and put it on. We were supposed to wear this for when we won the tournament, to show our victory. I don't know if it we really won or not. But Blake messaged last night to wear this anyways. I fashioned my hair into a pony tail. Then I put on my badge on my chest. I thought of applying a little moisturizer to hide any signs of sleep deprivation. I decided not to. It would look excessive effort, like I am trying to hide something.

One I was prepared, I walked out from my room. Siera was already sitting in the dining table and eating her breakfast. She was wearing regular clothes. I ask, you are not going to join us. She turns to me and gazes at my uniform, looks good on you. And no, Blake only wants you top officers there. I will come with you, but I will stay in the back. I took a chair and begin eating the food she prepared. I felt a little guilty for her having to make breakfast alone. I say, you should have woke me a earlier. I even skipped morning workout.

She smiles, its fine. I figured you deserve a day off after yesterday. But don't get complacent. You will have to put in more workout time this evening. And no excuses. You shouldn't let yourself get bothered by your relationship issues so much you can't sleep. You hear me. She was clearly in her soldier mode today. I'll admit that I feel more relaxed now than her mothering attitude. I nod, yes mam. Won't happen again. That was my hope rather than determination. Truth be told, I wasn't sure how I react to Ned. Or David, if he ever shows his face today.

After finishing our breakfast, we got ready to move out. Siera says, you go on ahead. Because of certain someone, we are late. I will follow you in the public trolley. I felt more guilt on my tardy attitude this morning, I can carry you. She scoffs, I rather not get my daughter to fly me like that, especially for a trivial thing like this. I am fine with a ground transport. She looked a little embarrassed about it. I guess anyone would be. I reply, okay then. See you later.

I step into the middle of road. Few of our neighbors are out and walking. Some are probably heading to the south port. Others getting on with their normal routine. I gather my Kuret around me and force the winds to pull me up. The draft begins to pull in more momentum and soon it pushes me up. A moment later I zipped through to the sky and flying in the air. Once I had enough altitude, I turned towards the southern part of the island. I saw more people on the ground converging into the port.

After about 5 minutes I reach my destination. A small crowed had gathered now. The officers had built a small barricade of kuritine border to keep civilians out. I look for a safe spot to land. I found one near the right side of the barricade. I gradually slowed my decent and land on the concrete payment. Around me some officers stepped a little back giving me space to land. I make the winds around me slip away back into the air. I see three officers walking to me. It was my team, Ruther, Deni and Somers.

Deni asks, you are late. She sounded anxious. I figured they were a little worried, even when I messaged them earlier this morning. I wave my hand at her, sorry. I was more tired than I thought. Somers says, I told you she was okay. You were worried for nothing. Deni gasps, I wasn't worried. But she was supposed be here 30 minutes ago. Ruther interrupts, settle down you two. She is here now. And anyways, Citradel people are late too. So there's no harm. Cut her some slack. He is probably the most sensible here. I am grateful to him backing me, no. Its my fault. I shouldn't have been later no matter what happened. I turn me neck around to check out the security lineup.

After inspecting it, I faced them again, I promise it won't happen again. So lets get back to work. Citradel officials will be here anytime. Somers says, we just got a message that the last of Citradel people are finished having their breakfast. They will be here in another 10 minutes. I reply, then that’s all the time we have. I point to the barricade, lets line it further back. I saw more people coming here. We need to create some more space from the shore. Somers says irritated, I should have known. It wasn't enough. Deni replies, hey, I said we will move it back if needed.

We got to work. I ordered the officers to their tasks. The security guys asked people to walk back more. I saw few drones and cameras pointed towards us. They were going to broadcast this over the network. Ruther beside me says, they were here before us. I couldn't ask them to leave, so I kind of had no choice and leave them be. I nod, it will be okay as long as they don't break the line. Have someone ask them to cover from other sides of the barricade, having all those reporters in one place might create some chaos later on. He agrees, will do. He goes to talk to them.

15 minutes go by and we got messages that Citradel officials are on the move. We managed to push back the barricade further away from the shore. I feel better seeing the extra space now. While I worked other top officers who were already here saw me. Tessa and Nathan were the first to walk by me. They were also wearing their uniform and badges. Tessa asks, good. You are here. You have any idea where Catherine is. When I didn't see you both here, I thought you both had some other emergencies I didn't know about.

That’s the first time I heard about this. I reply, no. I am not sure. I thought for sure she was here. I came here 20 minutes ago, when I didn't see her here, I thought she was with the Citradel guests. Nathen says, no. She is not with them. I spoke to Jess a while ago, only she, Blake, Luther and Ned are accompanying them. That’s wired. I opened my phone and checked for any messages from her. She hadn't reached out me. Tessa says, I tried calling her, but it never connected. This is a troubling. I tell them, the last time I saw her was when she left to the dining building. Did something happen after that.

Tessa recalls for a little bit, I can't think of anything. She said she wouldn't be joining us at Blakes place and went back home. I remembered the message from last time. Turns out few people went to party at Blakes house to celebrate the victory. I wasn't in the mood, so I declined. Catherine also didn't go. Nathan interjects, its sad I wasn't invited. I would have loved to join in the party. Tessa smirks, no you don't. You would have brought down the vibes, like Marina said. She was right, Nathen tagging them along would be a disaster to their celebration.

Nathen mocks us with a hurt expression, that’s not true. He smiles then, well. Anyway. I was anyway enjoying the company I was with, so no harm done. I got back to the conversation, don't tell me Catherine is still sleeping off. She looked overworked yesterday. Tessa replies, that’s not likely. No one would miss this out for an excuse like that. Internally, I was hurt by her comment. Siera was right, I shouldn't have been so distracted. Nathan saw me hiding something. I thought for sure he would point it out, but instead he says, its all right. I sent someone to her house. No one responded. I don't think she is there, so she is definitely somewhere. Try not to be worried for no reason.

Its easy for him to say that. I reply, we can't have another person missing. Nathan eyes me for a moment, so David is still missing huh. That’s actually bit more troubling. I hoped he would at least show up here, before Citradel leaves. It wouldn't look good if the Citradel thought he is still resting. Or hiding. He stressed the last part like he was implying something. Does he know something. Before I could ask, two more people came from the side. Matt and Cass wave their hands to us, morning guys. Looks like everyone is here. Cass looks around us seeing anyone else nearby. They both were in their regular officer uniforms.

Cass replies, so, who's still hiding. Tessa replies, hey guys. Its nothing. Nathan just likes to create smokes. Nathan laughs lightly at her jab. I ask them, have either of you heard from Catherine. She is the only one not here. Matt and Cass look at each other confused. Cass says, she isn't here. Maybe she is just late. It was becoming more worrisome that it wasn't just a simple reason as that. Matt says seeing us anxious, is there something we should be worried about. She must be running later, right.

I reply, lets hope so. Matt says, you missed out big time Vanessa. It was a good to let some steam off after so long. You didn't get to see drunk Marina. He starts to laugh recalling the memories of last night, I never knew she couldn't had such a low tolerance. That made me smile. The thought of seeing a drunk Marina was something quite intriguing. Cass clicks her mouth, stop spreading rumors like that. If Marina hears about it, she will get you back at you. Tessa smiling says, I don't know about that. It was hilarious to see Matt and Blake restraining Marina from a drunk casting.

Cass sighs, not you too. Matt laughs becomes louder now, see. It was funny. Besides, she won't care. I didn't agree with him, really. You think a shadow will be okay with that. That made a dent in his joy. His laughter dies down abruptly, shit. I forgot. Dammit. Seeing a normal woman like her made me forgot about that. I must still have a bigger hangover than I thought to forget about that. He then turns a little anxious, you know what. I was joking. I don't remember Marina drunk at all. I might have confused her with, yeah. Cassandra here. Seeing him blame her shamelessly, Cass rebukes, don't drag me into it.

Nathan smiles, thanks for that titbit. Nice to know Marina has such a trivial weakness. The mood suddenly turn downer hearing him say like that. I don't think he was serious, but no can be sure of that. He looked at our

quite expressions and says, lighten up. I am only messing you all. What kind of person you think of me. I reply, you don't want to know that, trust me. Nathen turns to me amused, oh really. I'll admit I am complex. Unlike the simple problem going on between you and your boyfriend.

He is obviously goading me into anger here. I tighten my first annoyed at his attempt to get a raise out of me, you want to try that attitude again. I take one step towards him. He didn't back down, hit a nerve did I. I suppose you were late because of him too, isn't that right. My anger rose quickly at his correct deduction. Ned wasn't the only reason, but yeah, I couldn't get him out of my mind all night. Matt suddenly comes in between us and puts his arms on both of us, okay, lets just take a beat guys.

Cass says in a hushed voice, there are camera here. You don't want to show dissension among us. Do you. Nathan and I didn't budge. I didn't care about people seeing us. I already had to endure so much crap yesterday, and on top of that my lack of sleep is effecting my judgement. Tessa comes in, all the officers are here too. Don't make a fuss here. Do it somewhere else. Finally Nathan sighs, my bad. I got carried away. He takes a step back, you might want to check that temper of yours. So quick to react. He turns his back to us, I am going to check to double check the cruise ships. See you later. Without any more of consideration on goading me so much, he dashes away to the ships arched on the pier.

My anger didn't have an out anymore. I got annoyed being called out like this, especially from him. Cass says, settle down Vanessa. Forgot about him. Matt says, yeah. His is only good at provoking others. I knew Nathan the best, so I understood that. But even after all this time, he can get under my skin so easily. I can't wait to punch him. Tessa sensed my thoughts, leave it alone. Citradel officials are going to be here any second. Get a hold of yourself. She was persuading with enough force that made me shook my annoyance. I answer, sorry. I don't know what's gotten to me today. I am used to Nathans antics.

Matt offers, its all cool. Everyone has bad timings. Though, you could have told you and Ned still haven't patched things up. I remained quite at that. Cass asks, did you even talk to him. All I could do was shook my head slightly. Its embarrassing to show them this side of me. Its discomforting to know people see me like this. I didn't want this to go any further, guys. I appreciate the help, but I don't want to talk about it right now. I have job right now. We all do. So lets just forgot what you saw, all right.

They all no choice but to agree to it. I didn't want them to make big fuss about it. Doesn't matter how I was feeling right now. We are surrounded by people and cameras. Even if I don't care about how I would appear to them, I didn't want others to get dragged into this drama. Tessa says, that’s settles it. Its good, because they are here now. So game face on people. She points to the incoming convoy of vehicles noise coming. Matt and Cass go back to their posts near the barricade.

Tessa and I walk to the middle of the barricade where the officials will be entering. I pass by Ruther and ask him, everything is ready. He responds, yes. We are ready here. Soon the cars begin to arrive in the parking lot. I count 6 cars here. I ask Tessa, is there any change in the personal counts. She pulls out her tablet from her pocket and takes a look. After scrolling she says, no. They are sticking with the 23 people, 11 officials and 12 guards, the same lineup we know. So there's no change needed in our transportation schedule.

The doors open and people began coming out. I saw Blake, Luther and Jess coming out from first car. I peeked at the other cars around them. No sign of Catherine. So she really wasn't with them. This isn't good, she missed her post this morning. What could have hold her up from coming here. The kuret drones with cameras began circling around the people walking towards us. Officers kept guard around people and gave way for the Citradel people to us.

A stream of Citradel people wearing their traditional uniforms walk by us. The guards walked beside them carrying backpacks and luggage's. The first person was the elderly lady, Geisha, the who was in the conference broadcast yesterday. I welcomed her, good morning Geisha. She smiles and we shake hands, morning kid. I ask, hope you are well rested, the ride over the ocean is a little bumpy. She laughs a little, yeah. It was a long day for us. But don't worry about such things. I believe, we are in good hands. She points to all the guards around her.

I nod to the guards around her. She faces Tessa next, and your hospitality was great. We felt safe our two week stay. They both shake hands. Tessa says, that’s good to know. Its too bad you are leaving already. We had planned another 3 day of stay initially. Geisha chuckles, trust me, I was looking forward for it. I guess that’s just life on Earth now. You can't expect everything goes according to how we want. I smile at her. She was referring right now at the deal David and Charles made. I never thought about it too much, but it probably threw a big wrench in their plans.

Behind them, I saw more officials coming at us. So I had to cut short this, lets hope we meet again. Ruther, please escort her to the ships. Ruther nods, please follow the sighs we laid out. He guides her and the guards to their assigned ship. Geisha waves us, see you kids soon. With her departure, officials begin entering the barricade with their guards. Tessa and I make brief exchanges as they walk by us. Deni and Somers fill in the roles whenever Ruther is not here.

Soon half of the Citradel officials boarded their ships. I saw some officials giving interviews with the reports at the edge of the barricade. I look at Tessa asking silently if it was really okay. She nods, its fine. You were right to have them spread out so they don't all cluster around a single person. Even if it delays a bit, its fine. After being assured I agreed to wait for them until they finished giving their interviews. I finally saw Charles at the back. He was surrounded by few people. I recognized Melinda. And there were two young people also. The guards around them were wearing different clothes. They must be the Heraknus people. I found Blake and Luther with them. They were talking. But I didn't see Marina or Derek with them. I didn't see the two of them anywhere. They must be running late.

I didn't want to intrude, so I kept waiting at my post. 10 minutes go by and almost all the Citradels had boarded. The next official was Kafar. He wasn't as excited as others, I would even say he looked distraught. He sees me eyeing him, you don't need to pity me. I know how I look. I hesitantly say, I didn't say anything. He says, you didn't need to. You and your friend's expression says everything. Tessa was also quite, but maybe we both showed too much on our faces.

Tessa says trying to diffuse any possible situation, we didn't mean to be rude. I know you are not happy with this outcome. But I am glad you at least accepted it. He smirks hearing that remark, I didn't think it would turn out like this. I wanted Citradel to win the tournament. I really believe hiding in that city is how we will survive. But now regardless of who wins, we will be moving here. Its wired how he himself has recognized it. I ask, so you already believe everyone will want to live here. He nods, I am not stupid Vanessa. Once I realized Charles had no intention of listening to me anymore, I knew we lost. There is no way we can stay in Citradel anymore without their protection.

Tessa and I share a look of surprise. Neither of us thought Kafar would have accepted it so easily. Tessa faces him again, it’s a little wired to see you say that yourself. But considering you couldn't change this even after taking whole day to decide, I guess you also had to give in. He chuckles, I wanted more continuums, to take another day to hash it more. We hadn't initially confirmed to give our decision last night, even though we said we would. But that rally and Blakes scheming put us in a hard position. Thanks to him, we had to give up. I had to give up.

He sounded defeated now. I don't believe he is faking it too. But I can't say for sure. Quite a bit transformation from his bolstering from yesterday. I smile recalling that, so in the end we won. The bet we made might still be going on, but like you said, the final match doesn't matter. I probably shouldn't have said that. Perhaps I still was riled up from Nathan earlier and seeing Kafar's face made me feel like that again. Kafar stares at me silently with anger. What, is he trying to intimidate me. I wasn't going to back down from this guy. He spewed so much non-sense about David yesterday to discredit him.

Thankfully Tessa was with me. She took a step forward, anyways. Chancellor Kafar, you can go ahead with them. They will show where to board. Tessa points to Deni. Kafar's gaze finally leaves me. Without saying anything more, he walks away with his guards. I thought that would be it, however, he says with his back to us, I haven't see David here. Actually, I haven't seen anywhere since his match. Makes one wonder if he is still resting. Maybe he is hiding because he is too injured to show his face.

Even without his face I could tell he was smiling still throwing bullshit around. Tessa saw my anxiousness, don't go after him. I could tell he still hasn't accepted it completely. He is just trying to throw some dirt around hoping something would stick. I calm down knowing Tessa also didn't buy his attitude. I bark, even after all this, he still believe there is a chance. Tessa says, you are talking about a guy who has been boasting for long about his undefeated his champion. His pride has been hurt too much. But even he can't do make selfish decisions alone.

I reply, I understand all that, but what he said about David missing is true. And now Catherine is also not here. It doesn't look good. I bet he gave interviews with those reporters back there trying to make us believe David can't fight. Tessa becomes anxious, I can't deny that. But we can't do anything about it now. Lets just focus on getting everyone onboard now. I had to push the worrying thoughts aside and greet the remaining officials. Another few minutes went by and only the Heraknus group were remaining.

They finally began moving to us from the parking area. The Heraknus people first came with Melinda and those two young people. I had to act like I never met her before. Melinda says, morning to you all. I am Melinda. She shakes hands with Tessa and me. Tessa smiles saying, morning. So I guess you must be Charles family. Her intuition was right on the money. She nods, yes. Its nice to meet you two as well. And these are my kids, Rory and Tory. These were the kids she mentioned earlier. Charles and his first wife's kids. They both looked our age. The guy had strong features similar to his fathers. The girl was actually quite well built. She was probably strong too.

They both take turns greeting us, hi there, Tory says. She held a strong grip. I had a vague feeling like she is trying to measure me. I wasn't going to let her make this a wired competition, so I took my hands away swiftly. She had a similar interaction with Tessa. Was this a common behavior of her. She felt aggressor than her brother. He was more polite, nice to finally meet you. We were impressed with both of your matches. He felt opposite of her sister, he was probably the older and mature one. Tessa says, thanks. We don't hear enough of this after our matches.

I smiled agreeing with her, yeah. Its nice to hear Citradel people are impressed, especially after my performance. He shook his head, you don't have to feel bad. Marina is quite special. She would even give Dad a run for his money. Tory says, who knows how it might have turned out if dad had entered normally. I would have loved to see him fight you guys too. I couldn't tell if she find it amusing or was serious about it. Melinda cuts in, come on kids. We shouldn't keep them busy. You'll have plenty of time to chat later.

Tory bulges a little, come on. We weren't allowed to talk to other warriors till now. We got to meet them finally just as we are leaving. Melinda chides her daughter, you already got to speak with Blake and Jess. That was already enough, so don't get greedy. She wasn't going to let it go. So Tessa helped out here, let me go with you. I am happy to talk to you while we wait for Charles to board. She smiles happily, thanks a bunch. I have so much to ask. Tessa faces me, I'll take them.

Rory instead asks, let me talk to Vanessa for a minute. You guys go on ahead. Melinda says before leaving, don't keep us waiting too long. With Tory and Tessa chatting up, they left us behind. I signaled Somers to follow behind the guards. Rory says, thanks for sticking with me for a while. I just had a question. He looks around, like he is searching for someone and then asks, I don't see David. Is he not here. I didn't realize he was looking for him. I reply, unfortunately no. He isn't here. He looks a little upset, I really wanted to meet him. I was a little amused to know Charles son was a fan of David.

But then he became serious all of a sudden. He comes closer to me and speaks in a low voice, since you are here, tell me. Did David really cheated when he fought my dad. I was astounded hearing the rumor that was

spreading yesterday from his mouth. I immediately denied it, no matter what Kafar and other officials say, David wouldn't cheat in such an important match. Rory still had the same serious expression, I am not so gullible like my dad. He always has been a little simple minded. Its not that I don't like that positive attitude, but I am protective of him. He believes David wasn't tricking him using those weird kuret attacks. But I am suspicious. I think once David realized he couldn't win, he resorted to cheating. No way my father, an alpha of Heraknus, could be pushed to use his overdrive to defeat a guy like him.

My initial image of him began to disappear. He was only pretending earlier in front of other. I didn't want to make a scene so I calmly responded, what do you mean when you say guy like him. He says, you know what I mean. Its no secret his background is suspicious. The only thing we know he is from the old MARS project. He doesn't even heal, but somehow he is able to defeat alphas and omegas. And even a freaking terra. I don't buy it. Something is going on with him. I hoped he would show up here and explain it.

He had drink Kafar's propaganda about discrediting David. He continuous, and its no surprise he is crafty. I heard stories about him scheming and gullible people getting tricked. It wouldn't be out of the realm that would cheat so brazenly and still get away. The more I heard, the more I tried to not get annoyed. I reply, look. Its easy to speculate from sidelines. He haven't seen my up close. Yes, he uses tricks and other things to win. But he wouldn't try it in a tournament. He answers, then why isn't he here. I keep hearing rumors about him. Like he may be trying to hide evidence of cheating. No one has seen him. Is he really just resting as everyone keeps saying. I don't buy it.

This guy is getting on my last nerves now. The other officers around me didn't see it, but our conversation was one short fuse away from me shouting at him.

Vanessa (Chapter 57)

Wednesday, October 1, 2025 22:59

I didn't have to deal with him for long. Behind us, Blake's group approached us. Charles sees me talking with his son, morning Vanessa. Its good to see you again. His face was all healed up now. I swallowed by emotions about Rory and pulled a weak smile, hey Charles. You are all healed now.

Charles touches a part of his chin, not fully. Just on the surface. His eyes lays on Rory, what are you talking. You looked so serious. He feigns ignorance, nothing much. Just check if she knew if she knows where David is. I am almost impressed how easily he switched back to politeness. Blake, dressed in his full royal dress, comes ahead, it is what it is. I don't know why, I felt that was rushed. Maybe he overheard our discussion. No, Charles didn't hear it.

Charles says, Oh well, I guess the next time I meet is when we move here. Blake steps beside me, hey. All good here. I nod, yes. Deni has confirmed all of them have boarded. The only one left are you guys. I wave towards Charles, his son and the guards around us. And of course Marina and Derek. Blake says, good. I have to tell you something though. There is a slight change in the list of people leaving after all. I just spoke with Charles and Kafar officials about it.

I was expecting a change. Since Heraknus are moving here ahead of plan, there is bound to be changes. Blake says, Marina will staying here permanently. I gasp, what. Isn't she important to the officials. Blake nods, true. But something else came up. They decided that she should overview the construction of expanding and other home requests for Heraknus house. We didn't anticipate any of the Citradel people permanently moving so soon. So they need her help to expedite this and other potential bloodlines moving here. Even with just 4 weeks of additional planning will make the progress fast.

That’s amazing. I was thrilled to know Marina would start living us. Even with all her flimsy attitude, having a powerhouse like here is a serious boast to our moral and strength. Her staying here would help Heraknus move here easily. I had a question, that's great news. But then what about her stuff back in Citradel. Doesn't she need it for a longer stay. Blake becomes a little hesitant at my question. He whispers to me, it seems in an anticipation of our loss, she already had all brought her essential stuff here. Whatever was left in Citradel, Derek can bring it with him. That made me laugh a little. Others saw me confused, sorry. Its just sounds so much like her. Did she really prepared it so early. I mean, she couldn't have known who won in the end.

Blake replies, yeah. In that case, she was going to take all her stuff back with her. Rory asks, you knew about it. Didn't you. You two shadows would do things like that. Blakes smiles, maybe I knew. Melinda says, regardless, Marina was fully prepared when she came here 4 months ago. So its not problem. In fact she was relieved to not travel when they told her this. She and Derek are right now moving her stuff from the guest house to a temporary location. That’s why the two of them are not with us.

Rory says, Derek just messages me a while ago, they both will be here soon. I turn to Ruther, tell others there is one less occupant now. Marina is going to stay with us now. He got excited at that news and walks to the other officers near the ships. I speak to Charles, well. Lets get you seated on the ship at least. He nods. Since his was the last group, I tag along with the group to his designated boat. Blake asks me separately, have seen Catherine. She was supposed to meet us at the guest houses. I whispered back, no clue. I thought for sure you knew where she was.

Blake sounded a little worried. I ask, I am sure she is fine. Just late. He answers, if only that was it. I have tried pinging her phones GPS location, but she has turned it off. That was strange. I didn't think she would do something like that by mistake. I ask, so she is doing her thing. Like espionage or something like that. He shots me a look, where exactly. All the officials are with us. Would she spy among the other Citradel warriors and civilians. And what for. Theres nothing for her to spy on there. He was even more worried than me.

I offered, once we get them boarded, I'll look for her. Blake nods, you and me both. I have a feeling she might be doing something I told her not to. I wondered what it could be. We couldn't chat more once we reach the bridge. The guards carrying the luggage's went abord first. Deni came running behind me, Vanessa. There is something you should know. She looked panicked about something. She tried to hide from Charles and other Heraknus around us. She points to the side shore of the bridge. I see a person walking from the side.

Blake shocked says, Catherine. Speak of the devil. It was her. She finally made it here. Where was she all this time. She was walking fast and hurrying towards us. She was in her officers uniform like me. Once she approached us, others also recognized her. She says, apologies for my tardiness everyone. Especially you Charles. Charles gives a surprised look, its quite all right. I was told I would be meeting you before breakfast. She nods frantically, sorry. I had an emergency that ran far too long than I expected. And by the time it was over, I was already late to meet you. I hope Jess was able to help out in my place. I gave her all the instructions.

That’s why Jess was with others. Charles smiles, yes. She was very helpful. So its fine. I do hope everything is okay with you. She nods, yes. Its been sorted out. Blake steps forwards, we will talk later. But did you ran all the way from the shore. I didn't see you coming from the barricade. Catherine nervously says, I had to use a boat to come here. I was in other part of the island. I'll explain later. Blake and I exchanged looks and understood we shouldn't go in detail here. I turn to Deni and we spoke quietly, how come you just noticed her boat. We are supposed to have a tight security.

Deni looked frantic and anxious, I don't know. We picked up a signature out of nowhere. Soon as someone noticed her in a boat I told you. This is bit disappointing to know our lack of security here. Catherine herself didn't say anything to help explain this. Blake cuts in, anyways. Lets get you two settle in. He points to Charles and Rory. Rory says, yeah. I am worried Tory would be causing trouble to mom and Tessa. Its ironic he would say when he himself was causing me trouble.

They both board inside the cruise ship. Blake followed behind them. I told Deni to inform me once Derek shows up. She agrees with a nervous expression to Catherine. I bet she was wondering how she appeared without anyone knowing. I begin climbing inside the cruise behind others. I get close to Catherine who was looking a little distraught, is everything okay. You look a little out of it. Catherine tried to hide with a poker face. She is usually much better than this, but I could tell she is a little troubled. She replies, something did happen. Its fine though. Nothing you should be concerned with right now. But lets not talk about it now. I reply, its bad enough David is still awol. I didn't want to add you as well.

Catherine chuckles a little, yeah. Sorry. I just caught up in it. She then leans forward and looks a little suspicious, and David is also not missing. You'll see him soon. I got stunned hearing about his reveal. I ask her, you met him. She didn't reply soon immediately. She stayed quite for few seconds. Then says, just wait for it. You'll know soon enough. She wasn't making sense, what's going on with the two of them. I didn't ask her further, we just walked behind the ground navigating the corridor inside the ship. We were walking to the deck on the top where we would take the final gathering of officers before the departure.

I am sure others are already up there. The sky opens up as I cross the stairs to the lower deck. I saw all the officers gathered near the center. Kafar and three other officials were here along with the Heraknus people. Nathan, Tessa were talking with Tory and Melinda. Luther and Jess were chatting with some guards. Everyone scatter around as we approach them. Charles says, looks like everyone is here. Others hadn't met Charles personally, so they were amazed and a little star struck to him. Even Nathan was little formal being near him.

A Heraknus guy came forward to Charles, yes. We are just waiting for Derek. He looked like a regular person. It would be hard to tell he was a Heraknus. I gather a little bit of kuret in my eyes, and yet I couldn't see even a little bit of Kuret from him. I could see some from Charles. But nothing from the other Heraknus. It was a little jarring to see how their bloodline was effected from coming to Earth. I am sure others are also trying to gauge them here. For many of us, this is first time seeing other Heraknus along with Charles in one place.

I got a message in my phone. I put it to my ears. After hearing the message, I relayed it to others, Derek and Marina just arrived to the shore. He will be here in a minute. Blake nods, well. That’s makes everyone. We hoped to get you all leave exactly at 9:00 AM. But I suppose a 20 minutes delay was going to happen no matter what. Charles says, I should have mentioned about Marina earlier. But she wasn't available last night to talk. I hear she was out partying with you.

All eyes feel on Blake. He didn't seem troubled by it, instead, he was a bit amused, yeah well. If you knew her, you would know that she doesn't hold back. She always supporting her stay here. And her wish came unexpectedly like this. Charles smiles, that it did. I can't blame her for supporting David. There are others like her who are happy that they might be moving here soon. So I don't find it wired people are already celebrating your victory. Rory mumbles from my side, if I was participating I would have won. I don't think anyone else heard it. I couldn't help but be amused at his confidence. I don't know how powerful he was, but I don't think it would have been easy. Charles told other Heraknus were effected even worse than him. And judging by the kuret I saw, or rather didn't see, he is not yet at alpha level.

He catches me from the side looking at me. Instead of getting anxious, he pulls out a big smile. This guy, he has an arrogant side bigger than her sister. Catherine from my other side asks, sorry to ask now. But I thought you had other children Charles. They didn't come with you here. I hadn't noticed that at all. I remembered he has 3 other kids. Charles says, my eldest child, Gina is with other two back in Citradel. I wanted them bring them too, but. Melinda cuts in, I didn't want them here. They are only 8. They are very energetic at that age. They would only create more trouble for us and others. Charles looks like he was just scolded and waves his hand to her, well, you heard her. So I had to keep Gina keep an eye on them.

Catherine says, oh that’s fine. I was just wondering. I am sure they will like living here. Charles looks hesitant, hold that thought till you meet the twins. That made us all laugh a little bit. Behind me I hear footsteps from the stairs. Derek popped out from the stairs below and Marina followed suit. Derek had a slightly tensed expression. Marina was excited to be here. What's more interesting that she was now wearing our officers uniform. When the hell she made one for herself. She didn't have a badge though. Marina laughs saying, morning everyone. Sorry we kept you all waiting. Derek says, morning. He looked a bit weary of Marina. I can guess he was because he had to carry her stuff and also wait to let her get dressed or something like that.

Marina walks towards Charles straight head. She must be excited to see him after all this time. Marina says, Charles. Nice to meet you after all this time. Charles and her shook hands. Charles says, same here. Its a little disappointing to know we never got to meet. I hope you understand, it wasn't a decision made lightly. For many reasons, I couldn't tell you about me. She answers, its cool. At least I got to see in person now. She was giddy all the time, but then she turns a little sour noticing Melinda beside him. She says, your wife though is different. In all the time we worked, she conveniently never mentioned she was married, let alone to you.

She is still salty from yesterday. Melinda just let out a little giggle. Charles shares a glance at both of them, you two have a lot to talk about. I am sure. Derek comes to my side now, so you had a busy morning. He sighs, you can say that. I told her she didn't need to wear that uniform now. But she didn't back off. We were late anyway, so I figured another few minutes wouldn't hurt. But man, does that women take time to dress up. Hard to know if she was doing it on purpose or was she planning to make an appearance like this. His was voicing his reluctance, but I figured he didn't mind too much since he offered to help her move her stuff.

Blake asks, when did you get that dress. I didn't issue a badge yet. Marina says, I already had prepared it a while back. And since now that I am officially moved here, I figured I would dress up accordingly. He says, but weren't you told just an hour back. She smiles and shrugs, I was too excited I guess. We should have known since we know how she is. Marina says, forgot about that. But drink in this juicy fact. Finally all 3 overdrive users are in place at the same time.

So that’s what got her excited the most. People laugh around us realizing that fact. Charles enjoys it, true. It is quite surreal to had the 3 of us here. Even Blake was enjoying himself now, its quite a group we got here. I don't I have heard a gathering like this back in Medrine. I am sure they have, but can't put my finger on when. Marina says, it happens rarely. People began chattering amongst about this momentous occasion. Derek sighs, should have known this would happen. We are going to be even more delayed now.

I tell him, its fine. That’s why we planned it ahead of time. Even if you leave by 10:00 its going to fine. You will make to the other ferries and airports well in advance. Derek says, I know. Its just, I want to sleep. I had to be awake till very late last night. The whole day was already tiering from being looked in the conference room. I think I would doze off any second now. So that’s what been bothering him. Its weird that both us security heads are sleep deprived. Though, my reasons are more personal.

Blake says, sorry to call out here everyone. But I think its time. Marina beside him seemed reluctant. He eyes her, we are already late. Maybe if you didn't waste time moving and trying to impress with your uniform, you would have gotten more time with us. But lets not keep them waiting anymore. Marina backed down after being singled out like this. Then suddenly a certain voice came hey now. Spare a little bit of more time for me too. Marina isn't the only one waiting for a chance to meet Charles. It came from the upper deck. That voice. Everyone recognized it immediately. Everyone turn their gazes to the above deck. Soon the footsteps came to the stairs.

David nonchalantly climbs down the stairs. The freak is he doing here. How did he get passed no one knowing. Everyone were too stunned to speak. David walks slowly, making a show of his grand entrance. He was wearing his special officers uniform. His bruises and wounds were stitched. His was smiling ear to ear seeing our stunned faces. I was too shocked to remember that I am crossed with him. He says, what. Did you all think I would miss out this. I was here all this time, hoping someone would find me. No one noticed me. I am a little hurt. The gall of him. I can't believe he was implying he has been here all this time. We did sweep of entire ships, no one saw him.

I turn to Catherine who had a slight smile on her face. She knew. Dammit it. Did the both of them plan this. David walks to us gawking crowd. Marina is the first person to say, Wow. You really made an entrance. David laughs, sorry to steal your thunder like this. I didn't know you were planning to do something similar. Marina laughs, clearly I should have known you would try to one up me. He says, not my intention. As he walks around us glancing around, I found something weird. His is acting very wired. I thought it would be tense between us, but he didn't faze a bit when we locked eyes. In fact, he showed the same expression when meeting others gaze. This all feels too mechanical. Was it just me or did others can also see that.

He halts near Charles, sorry to keep to waiting like this. It embarrassing, but once I had rested enough to move, I left the infirmary, and slept through till the night. I was too tiered than I assumed. I hopped to meet you earlier, but something came up. I sure didn't want to be this late. Charles shakes off his surprise, I am glad to see you here now. You made a lot of buzz though. I heard you weren't in your home. It made your own people worry. David nods, yeah. About that, I didn't want to be bothered by people, so I went someplace I could have more peace.

He is being purposefully vague about things. He seems different than the last time I saw him. He was acting a bit wired then, but this feels a different kind. Like this is too rigid. He is showing emotions, but like its rehearsed. People who didn't know him wouldn't know any difference, but something is off about him. Charles says, I guess that’s one way to do it. So, you all good now. David laughs, I am. I know people were worried about me, but I wanted to surprise you all here first. I am sure I will face some backlash for my poor decisions. But that’s nothing you need to be concerned with. I wanted to show my face once at least to you and tell I will be waiting for our fight.

Charles quietly glances David top to bottom, you do appear better than yesterday. And even without your kuret healing, your wounds don't look too bad. I guess, the rumors of your injuries were greatly exaugurated. He eyes everyone here. But many people stole glances at Kafar, who was most definitely the culprit of spreading those rumors. David smiles, glad I could clear that up. Everyone finally relaxed now after David made his speech. Charles says, I like you to meet my family. He introduces Melinda and his kids to him, my wife Melinda and these are Tory and Rory. He shakes hands with each of them. David peeks at Melinda, pleasure to meet you. Melinda flashes a smile, nice to meet you as well. You know, you gave Charles a lot of trouble yesterday. No one has pushed him so much, not even Echos.

David shrugs in return. He turns to Charles, you probably had some trouble when you got home. Sorry, but not sorry. That quip made everyone snicker. Even Melinda. Jeez, he is still the same arrogant guy I saw yesterday. His behavior might be some suspect, but his intentions are still clear. Everyone here were slowly getting sucked into his blatant swaggering. This must his way to clear the many rumors floating around due to his disappearance.

Rory intervenes here, hey. I have a favor to ask of you. Actually, everyone wants to know this. His enthusiasm caught everyone's attention. He asks, can you show how you were able to create so many kurets. I am sure you know that made a lot of stirs. His face showed excitement, but I knew underneath he was trying to expose David abelites as fraud. That was the first time since he came in that David felt a little troubled. His eyes wonder around everyone here, like he was trying to hide something.

Before David answered, Catherine cuts in, sorry guys. But lets not delay it any longer. You all will have plenty of time to chat once you return back. Then David can show it. Rory kept his smile, come on. It won't take much time. He really is out to get David. Others maybe be seeing something harmless, but I knew what exactly was going on. I turned to David who remained quite and still thinking. I think he doesn't want to show it now. Maybe that’s what I saw him trying to hide.

Others were also excited to see it. Tory asks, I want to see it too. That gave dad so much trouble, he was losing. Charles scoffs, I wouldn't say I was losing. Maybe just a stalemate. Melinda chuckles, no, you were definitely on the short end there. People were whispering now. I could sense everyone wanted to know about it. David was getting pressured now. Blake comes to his defense, everyone, its not the time or the place. If you all remember, David takes a long time to use that ability. And like Catherine said, it would just delay you all that more.

Rory ignored both Blake and Catherine, what you say David. Don't you want show your ultimate trick. Catherine says, Rory, lets not trouble David. Then suddenly David cuts in, its fine Catherine. I am game Rory. I have no issues showing it here. I was taken aback. But Catherine looked shocked even more so than me or Blake. Rory's eyes widen and he gets excited. So were others. But I am sure he was animated for a different reason than others. Rory says, awesome. Then lets pick a kuret, how about.

David puts his hand up, hold on. I don't mind showing my ace here. But I like something a favor in return. Rory's smile disappear halfway, huh. David smiles, I'll begin preparing it now. I'll even take any kuret request, provided I know about it. But while we wait, I want to see your kuret form. That came out of nowhere. What's David's angle here. Rory was puzzled, my kuret form. You want to see it. Why. David shrugs, just curious. Its not like I am asking to tell me about Charles overdrive. I just want to see yours. It may help me give some hints on how to right Charles later.

What is he babbling on about. How are Charles overdrive and Rory's kuret form connected. It would make sense if it was to compare their regular kuret forms. How will he get clues about Charles overdrive from Rory. Everyone here were amused by David's claim. Charles asks, huh. How does that help you. David didn't reply, he just made a menacing smile. Rory, who was until now being pushy, suddenly became hesitant, I don't understand as well. How will you learn hints about dad's overdrive.

David says, don't worry about it. Its just something I read in the university back in Medrine. I thought since I am going to show you my tricks up close, I'll get some clues about Charles overdrive in return. I have no clue what he is talking about. But somehow it changed the air to suspense and mystery. David makes a show of seeing everyone's puzzled looks. He says, okay. Fine. I'll explain. There was a theory written by this famous researcher, Igotus ouker, he did study on how alphas with their overdrive effect the genes passed to their children. This study wasn't that popular than his other works, but I found it interesting. He thinks the RNA passed from same gender parent and child would show characteristics that would be different when the parent cannot overdrive. Since there weren't many overdrive users to study much from, he didn't get funded to research enough. But he postulates his hypothesis is sound.

I wasn't expecting to be hit with such an academic response here. But it’s a very common occurrence with David. Is this what he was thinking a minute ago. Everyone were either amazed or too stunned to speak. David says, I think it would be a great chance for me to use his study and get clues since Charles refuses to share his overdrive to anyone. The only overdrive users with children is Charles, the author must be rolling in his grave having missed this opportunity. Not me though. So, how about it. A favor for favor. Tit for tat.

The ball was thrown to Rory now. The zeal he had was completely vanished. Against David sudden academic curiosity, he remained frozen. After thinking a bit he laughs a little, I give up. I don't know what you were going on about, but if its true, I can't give any advantage for the fight. David smiles suspiciously, you sure. Well, next time maybe. David completely shut down Rory's agenda with his textbook knowledge. David faces Charles, I guess it will remain a surprise until the day of the match. Charles laughs, he got you good Rory. What I tell you, he is clever guy.

Rory nods in quite acceptance. That was a skillful manipulation from David. He got to keep his kuret abilities a secret while also flaunting his knowledge. Blake chips now, well, that was quite something. But seriously, its time. David, I think you have shown everyone here you are all ready for the match, right. So let's not keep them any longer. David replies, yeah. I got it. Charles, the next time we see each other, it will be on the field. Hope you weren't exaggerating the warnings about your overdrive. I am eager to see it.

Charles says showing his teeth, don't you worry. It will be an epic battle. Those two share a look at each other, measuring each others resolve. Marina puts her shoulder on David, come on now. That’s enough. Marina pulls David out of the crowed. Blake turns to the Citradel officials, save travels everyone. I hope we see you all soon. Everyone began shaking hands and seeing each other off. I turn to Derek on my side, see you Derek. Derek nods, back at you. I will contact you with updates on our progress. We can work on travel plan later.

I answer, sure. Derek walks to say bye to other officers here. After some time, everyone begin climbing down the stairs. I followed behind Catherine, waiting for her to finish her byes. I whisper to her, you both planned it together, didn't you. David was lying about being here all this time. Catherine eyes our surrounding and then nods, yeah. We both actually came together from the shoreside. Getting here from the road would take too long, so we took the ocean route.

That actually made me more curious, why were you two together in the first place. I thought he was hiding someplace secure. She looks a bit hesitant, I wanted to talk to him urgently. So I found out where David was. I waited for her explain what she meant. She sighs, it’s a personal matter. So once I heard from Blake about his actual home, I took an early stroll in the morning and miraculously found it. That’s the emergency I was telling earlier. We didn't realize how long it went on. So I just taggled along with him on his house.

There is so much to unpack here. I was so lost I didn't understand much of what she said. But the thing that stuck me the most, what do you mean his actual home. Isn't his house on the outskirts of section 3. She scoffs, trust me, everyone reacted the same as you. But that's just his decoy house. He actually lives in a much more sophisticated house. I am sure others are grilling him about it. I can't believe David would even hid his real home.

Catherine says, that’s right. You weren't eating with us last night. Blake told us about it then. He and Marina moved to his house. That’s the secure place everyone keeps talking about. Even when I have seen it with my own eyes, I can't believe he lives in such a place. From her attitude, I could tell she was very impressed by Davids home. Its crazy, and yet on brand. Only David would be so paranoid to have a secondary home as a smokescreen.

Soon we climb out of the cruise. All the other officers were now gathered near the middle of the pier. Ruther and Somers came to my side, all good to go. I nod, yes. Everyone is counted for, well, except for Marina. But as you have seen, she is now one of us. So go ahead, give the signal for the captains. They both take a quick look at Marina. Ruther says, that was a surprise. Somers says, not as much as David coming off the boat. I am telling you guys, I had people sweep the boats earlier. No one saw him. And nothing came from the continuous scanning we have running. Its like he just appeared out of nowhere from the water.

Their confusion was obvious. They both scatter to give the all green signal to others. I ask Catherine, how exactly did you both hid his presence. Catherine says, I don't know how exactly. He dropped me near the other side of the shore, but its probably that house of his. Its probably undetectable. That didn't any sense, I ask, but you said you came from his place. Catherine replies, I did. She looks at me with a nervous smile, his house is a like a submarine sort of thing, it moves around the island, climb on cliffs or dives underwater.

My jaw drop a little hearing something so outrageous. I almost shout, are you kidding. He lives in a submarine. She shook her head, not like that. Hum, more like his house transform into a submarine. I spat out, that’s nuts. When did he build such a thing. I didn't get to hear her answer because we were now approaching others. Everyone here had now ganged up on David, surrounded him like they were trying to entrap inside. I hear Nathan speaking, anything about it. That’s some bullshit.

I lean in closer to the discussion. David was more nervous than facing the Citradel people, yeah. I get that. Like I have been saying, I will show it later. Its just a prototype. I had remained passive until now since David had appeared. I didn't want to draw attention to me, but now that its just us, I spoke out, so its true. You really do live in a different place. He turns to me with a hesitation. For a second I thought it was about the last time we spoke where I was pleading him to not accept the deal.

But it wasn't about that. No, more like he was avoiding it. He says, Catherine told you. Yeah, I do have a different house. But its not what you think. Marina shrieks, what the hell. So Catherine saw it before me. That's not fair. Of course she would be the one to be most agitated one here. Everyone eyes Catherine. She says, don't look at me. I only got to see some of it. We were in a hurry, so I didn't saw all of it. Blake asks, what where you doing with him. Marina says, forget about that. We want to see it.

The way she said it was amusing. But everyone were stunned to hear that. He can call his house from anywhere. What the hell is this place. David says, listen guys. I promise, I will show it when its ready. Like I keep saying, it's a prototype. And I mean quite literally, it can't handle too many people right now. Its operating system isn't configured completely to manage more than 3 people at a time. Blake asks, what does that mean. Its a house in the end right, why it can't manage couple of people inside.

David says, its not a really a house. That's what I keep telling you. Think of it like those an Echo battle ground vehicles. A very dumb downed grounded version. Sure, its built like a house, but many of its components are not compatible with Medrone DNA. One or two people, it can currently handle. But more than that, it might shut down or miscalculate some of it operations. This one time, it took an extreme response. It treated as the Medrone DNA I introduced as hostile and executed an attack. I was locked in my own room until the system rebooted. I fixed that issue, but there are tons of other problems I have yet fix. For humans and me, its inert, but trust me, its like the Echo tech gets a mind of its own when too many Medrone are introduced inside. And I still haven't found which part is causing this or how to stop this entirely.

He explained all that in one breath. It was hard to believe he was living in such a suspicious looking place. Nathan asks, as unbelieve it may sound, it does make sense. Its possible that Echo ships have been Medrone proofed. I am sure that's one of the reasons why its hard for us to study it. The nano materials don't respond to traditional kuritine approaches. But I never knew it was immune to Humans. I suppose that's how you were able to make it work.

Blake asks, if its about Medrone DNA, how come you are okay. David says, I told you. One or two it can handle. That includes me. Obviously, I had my DNA configured as non hostile from the beginning. And after living for months, the Echo tech considers me as primary user. Like I told you, I may think its a home, but its not there yet. I will sure to invite you guys once I worked out the kinks. Why do you think I never told you all, it would create a panic if people heard I was living in a place where it potentially treats Medrones as enemy. And I didn't want to show it to anyone until its completed.

He made sense. Even Marine was pondering hard, so those sphere drones and killer robots, they were jumped on us because we were Medrone. David says, that's right. For humans, it would had a different response. A more simpler and less threatening. I couldn't keep it in, killer robots. You have those too. David smirks, I do. But what Marina was not them. They were just prototypes I am programmed as an initial line of defense. When I am inside, those are never deployed. I never thought for a second you two would somehow move me there. I would have advice against it, because its not ready for outside exposure, especially when I am not awake.

Marina back down more after being called out like this. David says, I showed you because you helped design it, and I knew you wouldn't let it go until you see it yourself. But I never knew you stole my remote. It was an outdated tech. You both are lucky that somehow it didn't treat you as hostiles. No, that's not true. I am actually the lucky one. Marina asks, what does that mean. David sighs, I don't know to how much extent, but it would have kept attacking you. And in response you both would have no choice but to destroy those bots and my house along with it. I have invested lot of money and time building that prototype tech house not to be destroyed in such a pathetic way.

His arguments made sense. But one thing I couldn't shake, why did you even build it then. If its so dangerous, why do it. David answers, because I could. That's the simple answer. The complicated one is that once its fully operational, it will become an exhibit A for Medrones to use Human knowledge and science. I don't know how advance Citradel is, but I am sure we can't complete with Echo tech right now. We have enough wreckages and stolen Echo tech to reprogram for our use. But its not going to happen fast enough. We need all the available technology, no matter where it comes from. Its not lost on me that its not simple to merge Echo and Human tech. There will be political and social considerations. But first step is getting there before worrying about it.

Nathen says, you got that right. We had a civil war due to opposing views on mixing Human and Medrone DNA. He loves to keep reminding us about it. David scoffs, but that's going to happen again. Nathan smirks, oh really. And why is that. David answers with a straight face, because this time I am the one leading it. Not a half baked plan from a spoiled and attention craving royal. That sharp verbal jab pointed straight at Nathan made his lose his composure. He says, touché.

David nods, and that's why no is to talk about it. At least not until its ready. He singles out Marina and eyes her, you will know when its ready. Trust me, now that its no longer a secret I know how you feel. But think to the first you saw, when I was there. And when I wasn't there. Now think what happens when it gets somehow gets worse during reprogramming. Marina sighs, yeah. I understand. You don't need to keep explaining it to me. I suspected you were just nervous showing me the first time, but I think you were worried it was going to malfunction. I misinterpreted that whole thing. That won't again.

David says, I was worried about that. I didn't want your first impression be about me trying to build something dangerous out of Echo tech. Marina then faces Catherine, if I can't see it yet. At least I can get some scoop from you. Tell me later all about it, okay. He intense pressure caused Catherine to raise her hands, I will. Blake cuts in, well. That's good we settled this. The boats will move out soon. We all fan out and stand in a line facing the ocean.

Blake was whispering something to David. Whatever they spoke, it was short. After few minutes the pier siren filled the air. Soon the boats engine turn on and moments later they left our island. Technically, we are to remain here until they cross the 10 km radius. That's the range we agreed to track them. From there on, the Citradel will be taking care of themselves. After they travel few distance into the ocean, Tessa asks, you know David. People have been asking about you now. The news has spread that you are here.

David says, I am well aware. I plan to talk to the reporters now. Blake asks, you won't give it in the officers building. David says, sorry. I got a start preparing for my fight. I know I was showing confidence, but that doesn't mean I have it all figured out. I have to start my training immediately. Especially today. I am sort on a deadline I can't miss. Something that will help me, well, with my kuret. As always, he was being vague about it. But I am at least glad to see him being careful about it.

He seemed to have simmer down his attitude now that Citradel people aren't watching. Maybe then that strange behavior on the match yesterday was just him getting carried away. No. I am not letting him off easy. He has showed me no indication to explain his behavior back then. He refused all my pleas to not take the deal. Ultimately he abandoned all reasoning when he heard Wagner. He has to explain how he knows Wagner. But I am scared. What if he knows about what Melinda told. I can't handle if David also believed that to be true.

My thoughts gets interrupted by Blake saying, I see. If you have believe that's for the best, then I don't have any issues. Though, before you speak to the people. Lets be sure we are on same page about certain things. I'll like to discuss with you now once the Citradel boats leaves a little farther. David agrees, sure thing. Jess says, before you go, can you explain that overdrive DNA theory to us. That was out of nowhere and I have been wondering about it for some time.

Nathan gets a little giddy, damn. I almost forgot. I would like to hear that as well. I don't know anything about this. What was the name. Catherine says, Igotus ouker. Marina says, what a weird name. I didn't know there was anyone like that. Tessa says, wouldn't anyone researching a subject like overdrive users be obscure because of a very less candidate pool. I can understand why no one heard about this. Nathan asks incredibly, so you know this research. She reacts, no. I never heard about it. Maybe one of our scientists knows about it.

Meanwhile, David was keeping to himself. He was fidgeting with his lips and tongue a bit. What's with that reaction. Blake asks, so. Lets hear it. I am curious about it also. David looks to everyone with a suspicious look. When I met his eyes, something clicks in my head. I sigh realizing what he did. That's so him. He didn't want to show us his ace, so he did it to keep Rory out.

David finally blurts out, sorry guys. I didn't want to reveal that kuret trick to anyone. I felt that Heraknus guy wouldn't leave me alone if I don't come up with something. So I made the whole thing. Its all bullshit. There is no study like that. Actually, names also just something I pulled out on the spot. If you stick the two names together, it spells out I got you sucker.

David (Chapter 58)

Friday, October 3, 2025 22:41

We are seriously late. I just hope we make in time. It didn't hit me that so many people were going to the pier until M told me that going via road will take more time. I didn't want this, but I had ART carry us over the ocean to the southern part of the island. Catherine didn't had her officers uniform with her, so I had to use the clothes synthesizer for her. The badge will be fake though. I just changed into my inform. Applied some gel to my hair and removed bandages wrapped on my hand.

M chimes in, boss, we will be there in 5 minutes. I have located a spot for dropping miss Catherine. I walk out to the window covered deck. Cathrine follows behind me a second later. She fixes the newly printed clothes and puts the badge on her chest. While she fixes her hair she asks, isn't this synthesizer from one in Citradel. Of course she knows about it. I nod, yeah. They had a spare one which was old. I retrieved it a while ago and replaced the kuritine mixer with an artificial compound that resembles human clothes.

She asks, and by retrieved, you mean you stole it. She suspects me the obvious thing, its not stolen if no one reports it. They had enough of them, and this was going to be broken down for parts. I just replaced it with a dummy one before it got destroyed. Catherine smirks, and how did you get it. I don't think you just strolled into Citradel at the exact time it was going to be destroyed. I didn't want to say my source, if your thinking I got it from someone. You are right. But its not Marina or Derek. I do have other contacts. Lets just leave at it. She is still suspicious of me, but doesn't dig deeper.

I sigh, That synthesizer uses too much material. I had kept it for emergency purpose. Never thought I would have to use it for you. Next time, think before you decide spy on me naked. She was a tiny bit embarrassed at her reckless decision. Theres nothing we can do now, so I just l let it go. I tell, what will tell others if they ask why you are late or we were together. She replies, I will I had a emergency and personal matter to discuss with you. Blake told me about this place, so I found it by luck while I took a stroll in the morning.

It was a weak excuse, but we didn't have any time to come up with a better one. Its a little vague, even if it was partially true. I nod, fine. But please try not to make it sound like we were being suspicious. I don't want to explain people if they found out you were naked with me. It was a joke to help with our anxiety, but she shot me a look of disgust. Okay, I didn't think it warranted a reaction like that. She scoffs, yeah right. Like anyone would believe that. Okay, now she is being mean.

M pings after a while, we are here now. Leveling up to the unattended boat I detected. From here, it should just be a minute ride. ART begins to go vertically up underwater. I show Catherine the path to the door of the right glass wall. As soon as the top part of ART comes out of water, the wall splits in two and opens up. A motor boat was lying in wait on the other side. Catherine steps out, see you in a minute. I reply, I will be there on the boat Charles is in. Others will be there two. Do me a favor and don't tell anyone I am there.

She steps out of edge onto the boat. She asks, let me guess. You want to do something like shock and awe. I just smile in response. The glass wall closes immediately and ART dives down back. M says, 3 minutes to the Citradel boat. To avoid detection of ART, we will be traveling at very slow speed. I ask, ART, instead of leveling to the ocean surface, shift the top of the roof into a 10 meter bridge for me to climb out of. M says, obtaining specs from a class 2 submarine model. Reconfiguring now.

I take the stairs to the first floor room. The rumbling and electricity noise fills the upper roof. While I wait, I go to the mirror hanging on the side wall. I stare at my face and begin prepping for the performance of a lifetime. I can't let anyone see how much screwed up I am right now. Catherine knows a lot about my condition, but she agreed to not share. Blake and Marina know a little about my issues, they will suspect me more than others, but they should know not to draw any attention to my behavior. Nathan, Jess and whoever other officers will some odd behavior, but may also attribute to stress or something like that.

The problem is Vanessa. She knows me the longest and the best as well. There is a good chance she will notice my behavior and maybe even call me out. I don't know how or when, but she will. And I don't want that to be in front of others. I had avoided thinking about her too much because I am anxious her about knowing what I am going through. How will she react, will she be empathetic. No, she will be angry. Mad that I kept it from her many things. And she be justified for it. I do want to tell her the truth, but she will hate me for it. I can handle being hated by others, but not from her.

My thoughts suddenly fill with visions of Zakerine. The life we thought we would have, the plans we made together. And how it finally ended. I felt my pulse increasing. Freaking hell. I did a little paced breathing to calm down. Okay, no more thoughts about Vanessa or Zakerine. I don't want to have a panic attack in the middle of high ranking officers and officials. So the new plan is to keep my mind focused on thinking nothing but three goals. Talking to Charles and any other officials to show the rumors about me are wrong. I need to make others believe I don't have any issues. And finally, give an interview with the reporters. There is a good chance I will have emotional triggers on unexpected times. I sure hope Blake, Marina or Catherine help me out when I suddenly become weird.

To reduce the chances of getting exposed, I will use this sudden appearance as a distraction in the beginning. They will be too occupied by my appearance to see anything else. That will last only few minutes. Then I have to talk to others without mentioning anything about the plans for the match, be as vague as possible. The interview will be rockiest. I can already imagine all sorts of questions that I can't answer completely. I have prepared the answer as best I could.

M says, boss. We are here. I have analyzed the signatures on the boat directly above us. There are 3 Citradel officials, 5 bodyguards, 6 officers. And 2 people heading to the boat. I didn't have time to figure out who is who, so I just climbed the ladder ART prepared on the vertical bridge. My body still had few stiches so I carefully made slow movements to avoid opening the wounds. I also needed to make as less sound I could. The other end opens to the upper deck of the boat as planned. So far no had noticed the tall metal tube sticking out of the boat. The tube was just large enough to fit one person, and I had the outside surface change the color to match the cruise. That and the fact that most would be watching the other side of the cruise made it possible to climb on board undetected.

With a very slow and gradual movement, I take a step into the deck. My shoes make a little sneaking noise in contact with the smooth surface around the edges. I grab hold of the railing and cross over without rocking the boat. I signal M to dive off. The metal tube slowly submerges back into the water, using the subtle waves as cover to hide the noise. I tip toe as I make my way to the side stairs and crouch down on one knee. I hear people talking on the below deck. I hear Charles taking about his twins.

I couldn't tell where everyone was standing without using my kuret. But no one had pointed out me boarding the cruise, so either no saw me or were kept it themselves. Either way, infiltration complete. I don't think they are ready to leave just yet. Good, now to wait and see the best time to come down. I listened into their conversation. Everyone seems to be enjoying. He heard Blake and Jess's laugh the closest. A moment later I hear Marina and Derek coming to the stairs. So they were the two people walking outside.

For some reason everyone were surprised. Then I pieced it together, Marina has moved here, officially. That's a complete surprise. I was too busy with Drew and Catherine that I forgot to check in with M about any news on the network. That's a very good news. Sending her here means officials are more than likely going to move here along with Heraknus. Everyone must be enjoying this epic development. They must need Marina here for the developing the islands infrastructure. I can hear from Marina's voice how thrilled she was. Good for her, she wanted to move her all along.

Turns out, she had another agenda, a gathering of the only known and maybe even alive overdrive users. If I wasn't having a mental crisis, I would have been delighted to see Medrones greatest weapons. But with the impeding fight with one of them looming, I couldn't realize the full scope of this. Anyways, I focus back on my first goal. I gather up my wits and prepare to bluff my way. I caught a good moment to drop in when Blake says they are late. This is it. I take a long breadth to compose myself. No matter what happens, I shouldn't panic. Fake my usual composed self.

My entrance was as planned. No one had any idea I was here. Few where very confused on how I circumvented the security and defenses. The bodyguards around the deck looked tensed, but I kept my smile up. There was a little uptick of my heartbeat when I see Vanessa. With all the mental strength, I didn't let her see it. My movements were laxed. I could feel it. I was completely focused, like a machine. After a witty banter with Marina, I walked straight to Charles and made my presence known up close.

My phony smile and attitude seem to do the trick. It was a relief when Charles seemed satisfied about me. I kept my word short and kept reminding him that I am all good for the fight. Inside, I could feel conflicted and a little angrier at myself that I have to lie to everyone about this. I should be feeling guilty, but all I was masking was anxiety and anger. I didn't let any wondered thought come apart from the present moment. Analyze like I am watching them on a screen. Fake my emotions with just enough truth.

Behind him was his wife. I had only heard on Marinas recording earlier. With a face to it, I felt a sense of scientist vibe from here, it wasn't just a guess, she is in charge of Citradels space projects. Their children were quite normal. I don't know why, but I was expecting them to be buffed. Maybe I was stereotyping a little bit after seeing Charles Kuret form. The women Tory was actually beefier than Rory. But physical appearance doesn't mean a thing for Heraknus. Since he was older, his kuret might be stronger. Wish I had my kuret with me to check them all out. No, no thoughts like that.

I was making good progress by being humorous with Charles and his family. Then came my first curve ball. This young Heraknus asked me for a favor, something I am incapable of doing. That momentarily made cracks in my self made composure. Cathrine saw me panicking internally, and attempts to defend me. But Rory isn't backing down. This isn't good. I peak a glance at Kafar, who was eyeing me like a hawk. He has to be waiting to pounce at any chance he sees. If I deny him, they will think I am hiding it selfishly. After my very public display, it doesn't make a good defense to say I am hiding my secrete ace. On the other hand, I obviously can't do it. So I don't want to deny it, but can't agree to it too.

I get some pushy behavior from Rory by much he kept insisting. Initially I thought it was just a curiosity, but his intensity showed something more. I didn't have time to figure what it was. I realized a third option when I raced my thoughts to get out this dilemma. He had asked me as a favor, so I can ask one in return. Trying to come up ways to back him down, I decided to flaunt a little bit of my intelligence. I decided to make a whole shit of academia. When I said I was going to do it, Catherine eyes me confused. I could sense behind me Marina and Blake were also keeping a close look on me. And I could swear Kafar's eyes lit up and sparked. Is he really thinking he could expose me a cheat here.

Then I bluffed my way to get him to back down. Thankfully, it worked. I didn't wait to check if he bought it or not. I focus back on Charles and bring it to a close before anyone else tries to trip me up. I can't really tell if Charles really felt I was okay, but at least he wasn't going to get distracted by my rumors. Blake also felt necessary to break this up. And Marina pulls me out of the group safely. Once I was out of their eyelines, my face melts down. I sigh with relief that I made it without anyone suspecting me. She whispers to me as we cross the corridor, dude, you need to start explaining.

I nod subtly, and I will. Just go with me for now. Thanks for the save. I didn't want to leave myself. She smiles, I didn't do it just for you know. I figured she didn't, but still, I was glad it was over. Behind me Nathan sneaks up, so our brave warrior finally decides to show his face. So, are you all goof after your beauty sleep. I grit my teeth a little nervous when I didn't notice him. Not having Kuret in a group is really making me uncomfortable. I say, yeah. I just woke up this morning.

Nathan whistles, you slept for almost a day. You don't seem to be that injured. I reply, that was my first time in nano chamber tank. It has to calibrate the nano bots with accurate precision, otherwise it will cause even more damage. The first time was going to be a long one. Jess and Tessa join in the conversation as well. I saw Vanessa and Catherine talking at the far end and following us behind were Blake with Luther. Jess asks, how are you now. I lie, its all good now. I have few stiches, but they won't be a problem for much long.

Marina couldn't keep it anymore, so we are not going to talk about the elephant in the room. We cross the cruises door and walk down the bridge to the pier. I felt her frustration, actually everyone was a little curious about it. I don't think they know about my therapy, so she must be talking about ART. But I needed to confirm, about what specifically. At that point she clicks her tongue not amused, jeez, what could I be talking about. I don't know, oh, how about that fact that you live in that Echo tech modified house.

I felt a little relief knowing I was right. I didn't see others being surprised, so I was right thinking Blake must have told others. She didn't say anything about it to others while wearing M's watch. I couldn't help but a smile seeing her being flustered. We come to a stop after walking some distance away from the pier. Everyone gather around me and see me like a specimen. I say, does everyone know about it. They all nod. Nathan says, I was not sure when Jess told me. But now, I have to believe its true. You really are something keeping this for everyone.

He maybe be talking about that. This is not related to that, he knows that, yet he feels cheated. I don't know why he would assume I would tell about ART which has nothing to do with him. I ignore him and face others, I am sorry to keep it a secret, but I had a good reason. And why are you Marina getting so bothered, you knew about it too for months. Everyone gaze now fell upon Marina. She had a look of betrayal for me. Sorry, but I am not going to get accused alone. She gawks a little before say, really. You want to pin this on me.

I tell her, now you know how it feels. And I am not pinning this on you. I am just clearing the air, since you and Blake decided to blab about it to everyone. Marina twitches her mouth a little annoyed. I saw Blake coming towards us. Luther broke off to a different route to other officers. Jess asks, you knew about it. Nathan adds on, and didn't feel the need to share it. Marina wasn't someone who was going to back down so easily, come on guys. This isn't about me, its him. He told me to not talk about it. He was very suspicious about it, but I agreed. Because I am very good friend. Unlike him.

That little minx. She smiles with her teeth out as she emotionally blackmails me. The gaze fell back on me. I remained quite before figuring out what I should revel now. Blake joins in, guys, it’s a little tense here. He takes one look at me and scoffs, see now you know why its not good to keep secrets from friends. He is subtly implying about my therapy. So far Marina was mostly pre-occupied about the tech, but now I have to worry that they don't suddenly reveal anything about it.

I saw Catherine and Vanessa joining in now. I didn't want to keep them surround me for long. But I have to make them believe my intentions weren't malice. I say, its not the time yet. I didn't want to reveal it, because its not ready yet. Its still a prototype. An unstable one currently. To call it a home is not completely accurate. Nathan says, so instead you decided not to say anything about it. That’s some bullshit. I didn't owe him any explanation. Vanessa speaks immediately and accuses me as well.

I tried hard to remain poised. Just having her here is effecting me subtly. No, don't go there. I kept trying them to understand that it wasn't ready. I realized until I calm down Marina, the main instigator, it won't matter how much I explain. So with great reluctance I reveled the dangers of ART. They were slowly realizing why I kept it hidden. Marina who had been looking at me contempt was finally backing down. I made to keep reminding that this is a prototype. And like any potentially dangerous project, you don't reveal it until its safe and completed.

I finally persuaded Marina about why I was nervous showing her the initial model of ART. I made a critical mistake back then by not telling the whole truth back then. But I didn’t think she stole from me and even bring me to ART themselves. Blake backed me up in the end and we resolved this quickly. As we wait for the cruise to sail away he whispers to me, don't think this is over. Me and Marina have got a lot other questions for you. Once you finish talking with the reporters, you owe us answers.

I whisper back, I know. I will explain what I can. Unlike Marina, he was more reasonable. He knew I was being pressured my Marina and didn't push me further. I was grateful for his support. He was right to explain my decisions. I kept a lot from him and others. My only excuse is the reason why I am in therapy. I contemplate on how much I will have to reveal to them. Then Jess's question about the made up research puts in an uncomfortable position. I fidget a bit as I decided its best to be honest with them.

Nathan's the first to voice his shock, you bluffed in front of all those people. All those important people. You sure you didn't hit your head in the fight. He doesn't know how true that was. Jess shook her head. Blake gasps, that's crazy man. Tessa becomes a little betrayed, no doubt cause she almost believed it. I think Vanessa may have caught on because she wasn't reacting to it. Marina yells, dude, the hell kind of lie was that. Catherine was also stunned, but probably the only one who understood why I did it.

I sigh, I don't know what his deal was. And I didn't have time to figure it out. So I choose to show even a bigger arrogance. I wasn't going to give Kafar or him any idea about my Kuret abilities. And especially not Charles. But I couldn't refuse it outright too, that would have been rude. I didn't want to lie this others, but it’s the closest to the truth. I continue, none of us are scientists. But everyone has some impression of me. I used that fact to my advantage. I didn't want to drag it long, otherwise people will be suspicious. And it worked. He backed off immediately.

Vanessa says, you could have done that by not provoking others with that very blatant name word play. What happens when they search for it in their database. I scoff, even if they do, would they believe I was wrong just because its not their limited database. Yeah, I don't see that happening. Everyone one here is interested because we are warriors. They are not. Some will believe it, I eye at Tessa who looked a little mortified falling to my trick, and some won't. Either way, I guarantee they will forget all about it by the time the cross international borders. And if anyone does figure out I tricked them with the name, they won't be angry about it. They just assume I was being evasive and arrogant. That I can handle. What I absolutely cared was not show to my kuret abilities at that moment, when everyone in watching.

Others were gawking at me like I had lost it. But I had no other choice. Having a panic attack of or an episode in trying to bring out my Kuret was going to waste all my efforts. Jess asks, what would have done if Rory kept insisting or even agreed to show his Kuret form. I shrug, I don't know. Maybe stall for more time until it becomes clear I wasn't going to budge and have them decide to leave to avoid being more late. Marina whistles, crazy and clever. Your normal mix of behavior. She smiles, you must be already be feeling back to yourself.

I unconsciously smile at her response. I actually didn't realize before, but I when I was backed in that corner, emotionally speaking, I was in my own element. I wasn't worried about my mental state. I analyzed the situation like I always do. I handled it like I normally do. This was the first time today since I talked to Drew that I was hopeful. I recall the words she said about me, not stable, but not delusional as well. I beginning to believe I could figure it out. I just need to be figure out my shit, like I do if I was doing it for others. Its terrifying thought, I can't be bias. But maybe there is some way.

Blake tells, I hope for your sake no gets offended if they realize this joke. After making so much effort, I don't want it to go to waste all because you had to be clever. His worry was justified, but I wasn't. Kafar who is skeptical of me, wouldn't believe me, but he also won't figure that it out. Rory seemed a little enthused about seeing it, so he might look for it even if its just to satisfy the curiosity. Derek is quite sharp and probably the only who will get is Derek. I reply back, I couldn't help that in front of Rory and Kafar. But I promise, no more of that. With Citradel finally on board with the Heraknus permanent relocation, I also don't want to risk anything.

He nods. Nathan whispers something to Jess, probably saying I am not done yet. If I am being honest, that’s probably true. Not that I will admit that to anyone. But that did make me feel that I didn't others to keep observing me anymore. They might figure out I am not my usual self. So I pulled the card I kept just to open at the right moment. I say, lets forget about that. Instead, lets congratulate Marina on becoming our newest member. I show a gesture of applauding. That made others shook off me and realize they didn't speak to her directly yet.

Marina also becomes her usual self. She laughs, yeah. That’s pretty unexpected. Tessa and Jess take turns congratulating her. Catherine and Vanessa goes next. Vanessa says, you wanted this even when you had Kafar breathing down your neck. You finally got your wish. They both high five each other. Marina says, thanks Vanessa. You are not wrong. I was honestly shocked that the officials agreed. Blake laughs, I am more surprised that you didn't even wait for me to get you your badge and came in with that, pointing to her unform. Marina kept smiling happily at his amused expression.

Soon everyone break into a conversation about her, where she will live, what about her stuff in Citradel. Blake and I know Marina had planned things well in advance. I happily took a step back and relaxed from being freed from the constant attention. Catherine saw me being quite, but remained engaged in others conversation. Blake comes to my side and signals to move some steps away. I gladly left others gaze. He asks in a serious tone, we a lot to talk. But right now, lets get you prepped for the reporters.

I knew the solace was brief and the trickiest part is yet to happen. I nod. He calls to Luther who was some distance away. Luther dashes in, hey David. Good to see you finally. You had some of us worried. I answer, I believe you. And that’s why, I want to talk to people. Right now. Luther eyes became sharp on me, are you sure you want to do it here. Blake nods, yes. What better time when Citradel just left. I think people will be relieved to know he is here with us. That explanation got through to him immediately, that’s true. He turns to me, I am sure you already know, but I still have to ask. Do you know what all has happened.

He was worried that I wasn't aware about what has been going on the city since I have been away. With take a quick glance from the crowd behind him, I say, I have been catching up with the news since I woke up. I know almost everything I need to know. The admins and Citradel long meeting that went whole day. The Heraknus meeting with them. You and Blake organizing the rally. And in the same time allowing people to put pressure on Citradel instead of you all. And I have seen Charles and Admins broadcast from last night.

He smiles, silly question. You wouldn't come here straight after waking up. Great. I actually wanted to have you remain hear while we explain things, but this makes it much simpler. So you will go on live right now. I wasn't showing on my face, but I was a little unformattable. They questions I will be asked will be an emotional land mine. Nonetheless, I have to do this. I nod, that’s right. I am ready to go any minute. He becomes excited, that’s great to hear. The let me go first. I will tell about Citradel leaving with no issues, Marina's becoming the latest member of Citradel joining us. That gotta boast our moral and show we have won. And then I will tell them you are ready to answer peoples questions. You good with this.

I didn't have any issues, sounds good. Blake says, don't let Marina get near a camera yet. Get someone to brief her. I don't want to go and make some statement I can't promise. I have a hunch she will ask a place of her on a very pricy place. I am not denying it, but I can't just let her decide on her own. Luther smiles, good idea. I goes to talk to Marina next. I made an observation, you are getting good at this. Politics I mean. He smiles, nah. That’s just because I know Marina.

He was being modest, but that’s a quality he is slowly developing. He then says, there's more than just what you saw on the network and news. When your were sleeping, we were approached my Melinda. And I need to tell you certain rumors that are floating in the public. You should know about it before speaking. So this is what he wanted to tell me. Before he starts explaining, I raise my hand to him, its fine Blake. I already know all about it. His eyes widen, ah, say what.

I smiled a little, I know all about Charles using her to get my take on certain things before he made his decision. Blake remained skeptical, like he believed I was just guessing. I get into specifics, Citradel, or rather Kafar trying to discredit me using my history. They accused of cheating, sabotaging the tournament by poisoning Marina. I know it all. Yesterday those rumors just among higher ups, and now it might have reached to people ears. You all defended me quite excessively, thanks. But you didn't need to that. Its just rumors.

Blake eyes twitches, how in the world do you know about it. Not even Catherine knows about it. And you two seem to spent some time this morning. Mind telling me what that was about. I say, I know you told her about Dr. Drew. I don't know why you did, but because of that she followed Drew from her home, spied on me and learned few things. He became flabbergasted. He turns behind to see a laughing Catherine speaking to Vanessa something about Marina.

He turns to me a with a softened expression, ah. So its what I feared. She didn't listen to me. Look, I told her to. I stop him and answers, doesn't matter. I had to talk with her, about some private things. Had to even reveal some of my mental issues with her. I hadn't plan to tell anyone about it, and somehow more people are learning about it. The bigger joke is that she knows more about me currently than you both. So best to ask her rather than me about it. I am letting her decide whatever she wants now.

I didn't want to drag this part for long. I already decided I won't interfere with Catherine on personal thing anymore. My promise to Brandon has somehow jeopardized my friendship with her daughter. Blake thinks for a bit and says, I got it. Lets focus back on the topic. If you know about that, then you also know about the other thing. The thing about. I abruptly stop him, don't say his name. I don't know if will have another episode. I am trying very hard to not get sucked into that right now. Lets just say I know. And I don't particularly care what he did.

Blake swallows hard seeing me so jumpy. I could imagine how he must be seeing me. He finally speaks up, you really know everything. How did you. This wasn't the time to bring the fact that I was bugging Marina. So I just eyed him gesturing as if to ask, who is he talking to. He nods, I should have known you are a step ahead already. Well, that’s all I had to tell you. I thought you needed to know that before answering any of their questions. He chuckles realizing how futile this was, you must have bugged me.

He caught that pretty quickly. I have become very predictable. Well, at least he didn't realize its Marina actually. Blake says, in that case, should I be knowing something. You know, in case I have to get in front of the camera too. I had a bunch of things to speak with him. With Marina too. But there's only one important thing he absolutely needs to know. I look around us to see if no was eavesdropping. I wished I was using my Kuret to check this. I say in low tone, for reasons unknown, I can't use my kuret right now. I am tiring to figure that out with Dr. Drew. Catherine knows about it too. So I want you to understand that it will be very bad if I was asked to show my new kuret abilities.

Blake becomes troubled hearing this. I had no choice but to rely on him now. I can't predict what's going to happen. So I need someone reliable if I had another episode. Yesterday, it was on a stadium with few people. Now, I am live on TV. The stakes are higher, even a small weakness will be blown to chaotic proportion. I continue, Also, any questions about, the person, is also bad for me in a crowd. So I if the questions get anywhere near them, pull me out. Doesn't matter how, even you have lie or throw someone to the wolfs. I don't care how, just don't let anyone see if I have a panic attack.

I knew I asking a lot from him. But he is the only one here who is in a position to help me out. Blake doesn't reply immediately. He thinks for long time and says, I got you. I'll take care of it if anything happens. But freak man, you are in worse shape than I ever imagined. That hurt me to my core, but it’s the truth.

David (Chapter 59)

Saturday, October 4, 2025 19:17

I waited with Blake until Luther finished speaking to the reporters. He had spoken to Marina before explaining some ground rules. From the distance it she seems to understood not to prematurely make any claims or statements. She isn't used to it, so I do feel sorry for her. Her greatest quality is to be unburdened from anything weighing her down. Well, she has to learn more than just shadow skills now. Meanwhile, Blake and I talk about appropriate answers to possible questions. We also agreed to some signals to alert him if I crash out. It was weird and embarrassing to talk my insecurities with him. But I had to push the embarrassment and self pity down. I am in this position, because I put myself. I can't wuss out on asking for help, not now in front of everyone.

After we discussed for 5 minutes, he was approached by Luther to speak next. He wanted Blake to tell about the match. So far only Citradel had talked about it. Now, we need to tell our side. Luther asks me in the middle of their discussion, Citradel hasn't told us the specifics of this overdrive match. Since you both were there, what can we reveal about it without causing any issues with Citradel. I ask Blake, do we tell everyone about the whole dangers of Charles overdrive.

Blake thinks about it for a second, no. We wait. It was his decision, but I wanted to know his reasons. He explains, it won't look good if we tell without Charles. I know its an important detail, and people should know about it. But if I alone say it, it might come across demeaning or even derogatory to Charles. No matter what the truth, its best to leave it alone. We have yet to set a specific time or talk about the security. I nod after understanding his reasoning. Personally, I would have told people some more if not more. But its his decision. He says to Luther, lets tell people the match is warrants more caution. Luther was curious about what we were talking, but ignores it, that’s fine then. Try to bring the conversation to compare with your match with Marina. Overdrive power is too much to be contained and we will make do everything to make it safer.

Blake nods, that’s good. I am also in agreement. Its good idea to bring their attention to previous matches to show the severity of clashes. They resume discussing amongst themselves. Marina was almost done speaking. She was having the time of her life speaking about moving her. While I was conflicted and preparing myself for a hurdle. Someone sneaks up from behind. Hey, you have a second. When I heard the voice unexpected, it broke my concentration and I shook my shoulders away.

Vanessa looks at me with a stare that got me swallow hard. I can't believe I am such a mess, I can't behave normally around her. She says, what was that. I pull out a nervous smile at the corner of my mouth, sorry. I was just preparing for the interview. I guess I was so engrossed I didn't notice you. She looks suspicious of me. This isn't good. Earlier, I was thinking how much I was in my element on the boat. But all that confidence is lost. She says, ah. Okay. I need to talk to you about something. Where are others. I recall they all scattered sometime ago and went back to work. I thought Vanessa had also left. She came to talk alone, so it had to be about one thing only.

Freak this. She is the last person I should talk to. I felt my brain getting hotter. I probably sweating all over as well. She didn't notice that, but I know she sensed something off. I nervously say, yeah. Sure. I kicked myself mentally, I shouldn't have agreed. I know what's she going to ask me. She asks me, before you left the stadium yesterday. You said something about. I took over from her, your brother right. I pushed ahead. I was too eager, she saw it too. But I wanted to take over the conversation and end it fast before I get worse.

I pull out a apologetic smile, yeah. That would seem an odd behavior. No, to you it most definitely was. Vanessa remains silent, probably weirded out by my overeagerness to share. But I was on a roll, since the middle of the match, I had been carried away after seeing the effectiveness of my new Kuret abilities. I think I just became overzealous when I heard even the previous crown couldn't beat Charles. I know powerful crowns are, so I agreed to the deal immediately thinking I have a shot too.

Vanessa asks, that’s what I thought too. But before that you asked Charles somethings about my brother. How do you know that. I knew I had to lie here. I even had thought of a solution before. But seeing her in person had made me judging if its alright to lie. But I didn't have a choice. I can't tell her the truth. I say, he used to visit the university frequently and gave a speech to us in our classroom. He was a idol to many of us, so someone asked what's his favorite fighting style. He wasn't going to reveal his tricks to a bunch of kids, so instead he told us his quirk. Something he likes during a fight. I was there too, so I remember what Charles mentioned and that when I realized he was telling the truth.

Vanessa stare intensifies. I can't tell if she bought that. The truth is he did gave speeches, but he never talked about that. No one here is either alive or remembers about it. So neither should Vanessa know. She says, you remember a conversation from that long ago when you were a child. And even after forgetting your life for a decade. Her skepticism was going to a different direction. That’s a little relief. I answer, I do. My memories returning, also filled up some the memory place I built. You know that’s the.

She cuts in, I know what it is. You have told me enough times. Its just so random to memorize it. I make a fake gesture of being offended, he was popular you know. I remember all the important bits. I was hampered by my brittle body back then, so learning was all I could do. Vanessa subtly nods. I think I am getting through to her. I wave of relief washes over to me. She says, I think I understand now. I nervously smiled relaxing the tension in my face, I didn't think it was a big deal. So I didn't think to tell you.

Vanessa says, its fine. And so, that whole Kuret overflowing thing and getting exhausted suddenly. I blurt out, I was trying to look not exhausted, but in really I had dead tiered. And that last hyped emotion got me passing out. Its little unsettling that I thought I could fight in that condition. Clearly, I wasn't thinking straight. I was too emotional. This was actually the truth. I never intend to show her or anyone that side of me. Vanessa says with a small smile, you admit it yourself huh. That’s good to know you realize it.

I think we are good now. Her suspicions are getting cleared. She doesn't seem to be that agitated. Compared to her voice I heard when she and Melinda were talking, she seems calmer. Wait. She is too calm. Then a nagging feeling came, why didn't she say anything about the whole truth Melinda told her. She doesn't know that I know, so she should tell me. Right when I realized something was not right. Her smile broke away. Then came a glare that was complete opposite to what was now. Freak.

She says, everything you said is a complete lie. I know it is. I gave you a chance to come clean to me. But you lied. It was a mistake to think that I would get a straight answer from you. Shit. She didn't believe any of it. My stress level jumps to a whole new level instantly. She says, whenever I talk about my brother, you weirdly become silent. Like you are hiding something. No, I am now sure. I tried to gather some wit, what are you saying. I told you. She cuts me off, I know how you operate. You say truth and cleverly add lies to it. I don't know which is which. But I know you didn't tell me anything useful.

She saw through me so thoroughly. The last thing on my mind was being impressed. My sweats begin forming again. Vanessa looks upset now, I thought you trusted me. But you don't. All the time we spent together in the capture flag game. I thought we becoming close enough that you didn't need to hide things from me. But you not only did that, but kept important things from me. About my brother. And for what, because you don't trust me. Don't you. Shit. Shit. She looked distraught now. I try to form words, no. That’s not true.

She shook her head, no you don't. And I understand. I have betrayed you many times. And I thought you forgave me for the whole fiasco in the valley. I thought searching you for months gave me some reprieve. It was dumb of me thinking you forgave me. I spat out, that’s not true Vanessa. She wasn't budging, how can I believe you. I remained silent trying to figure out how to get out of the hole I just dig. But Vanessa was done listening to me. She raises her hand, I am done. I don't want to talk to you. Do what you want with you match with Charles. You seem eager to prove you are stronger than my brother. You'll even risk your life. So have at it. I am no longer going to stop you from it.

And just like that, her outraged tone stops. She turns back suddenly into her stoic expression she had in the beginning. Her look of disappointment at me was so obvious, that I felt anger at myself for choosing to lie. But I had no choice. And that reasoning has to led to this. She says in monotone voice, good luck with your interview. Hope you show people how strong you really are. With that parting jab at me, she turned her back to me and walks away. I wanted to stop her. I even slightly moved my arms in air to stop her. But I froze over. This isn't good. I could feel a panic attack coming.

My body begins to become heavy. Shit. Freak. Not this again. I saw images of dead people. Shadows. Wagner's corpse flashed over my eyes. Then Zakerine. I keep making the mistakes. I am still helpless as before. All the normal emotions I had, was now turned upside down. I felt I was about to fall down. This is worst place to have a nervous breakdown. My vision was getting blurry. I hear someone's voice, David. What's going on. You look pale. It was Catherine. No, not her. Anyone else, but not her. Images of Brandon and John came to me. Zakerine crying.

Catherine puts her arm on my shoulder. My head was crouch down, leaning away from her. I didn't respond to her. But she leans and whispers, Blake messaged me what you discussed a while ago. I was keeping an eye on you when I saw Vanessa talking to you. Come on Blake, why do you keep telling her about things I don't want others to know. Using her arm, I take support. She becomes worried seeing my weak body, what the hell happened. I had no choice, I blurt outed out, panic attack. She leans away little in shock. Then leans forward, what. Now. Why, you were okay just a second ago.

My breathing becomes ragged. With trembling hands I open the button around my neck of the uniform. It didn't help. I was sweating feverishly now. I couldn't answer her. My mouth was gasping for air uncontrollably. My other hand covers my pounding chest. It felt I was about to burst any second. Catherine says whispers loudly freaked out, pull it together David. You have to give an interview in just few minutes. I blurt out, I lied to Vanessa. She found out. I can't do it.

With no coherent thoughts, I was sharing her things. Catherine turns to look away at the direction Vanessa left. She looks back, seriously. You lied to her too. You got a serious problem. I don't need that now. I manage to say, I know that. Do you think I enjoy being like this. I almost shouted at her. My anger made my vein pop in my forehead. It was already visible from my heating brain. That made Catherine become less angry at me. She says, this is messed up. I didn't need to hear from her. With trembling finger, I point to the pocket on my right leg. She looks down and after a second realizes what I meant.

She slips her free hand to the pocket and pulls out a syringe. She asks, is this what I think it is. I managed a furious nod. That the modified sedative from Drew. I kept one on me for an emergency, just like this. She didn't wait a second, just jams the needle into my thigh. I felt a sharp sting when I am pricked. She pushed down the liquid into my body. Then with swift movement pulls it out, once its emptied. Another sharp pain surges through me. She puts the syringe her own pocket. She asks, tell me if its working.

I was still breathing hard. But the cold drug spreads fast all over my body. I felt chills and tingles all over my body. My body stops trembling. My breathing becomes stable. After a minute I felt my strength back. Catherine had a tensed expression all the time she waited for the sedative to work. Another minute goes by and my mind becomes clearer. She lets go of my shoulder once I got my balance back. She says, that was fast. What the hell was that. I sighed, a special doze from Drew. Made just for me.

Finally, I was able to think clearly again. I wiped off the sweat on my head. I looked around us to check if anyone saw my meltdown. She says, no one saw. I made sure it looked like we were just talking. I reply, you saved me. Thanks a lot. I felt like myself soon. And now I could tell how worried she really was. She says, you have been dealing with this for a year. I reply, not as much as before. I made good progress. I thought I did. Turns out I have just been bottling it. To quote Drew, I have hit rock bottom.

She says, you got that right. You almost collapsed in the middle of this pier with everyone watching. She didn't need to point the obvious and make me feel even more shit. She asks, what do you say to Vanessa. She looked cold and angry at the same time. That was probably the right mix of emotion she was going through. I close my eyes trying to figure out a way to explain to Vanessa. But nothing came. She completely believes I don't trust her and lied to her. I can't deny that. There are things I don't trust her with, like having information about Wagner. But that doesn't mean I don't trust her.

I open my eyes, same shit as you. I know somethings about her brother. She was taken aback. It was weird joke that I kept things about their family to both of them. I wasn't going to get for sympathy from either of them. She asks nervously, is this just a coincidence. Or a pattern with you. She was thinking the same as me. She asks, what happened then. I answer, she realized somehow I was lying. Then she accused me of, stuff. I couldn't take that. She looks at me with pity. I don't know if she really felt that, considering I put her through something similar. She asks, so what will you do now.

I answer, about Vanessa. Nothing. Not until I can speak to her without having a meltdown. I'll focus on the interview now. I keep wiping the sweat off my head. I was so worried about the questions I would be getting, never thought I had an attack before I even answered the first question. Catherine says, that's good. Because you are up now. I see Luther is ready for you now. I turn following her eyeline and see him signaling an index finger. One minute. I tell, thanks again. I'll be fine now.

Catherine looks hesitant to leave me alone. I assure her, the sedative you gave me is pretty hardcore. It hardens my emotions, I won't have another one again anytime soon. She nods understanding, okay. Good luck. I appreciated her concern, however, I can't dwell on it longer. I approach to a make shift interview setup with 4 reporters sitting on a chairs with kuritine drones flying in the air. Blake was siting in a single chair opposite to them. Luther and Marina stood beside them a little steps away, enough to be out of the camera.

Marina had a concerned face when she asks, you good. Saw you discussing something with Catherine. Looked important. Blake must have filled her on few things about it. With Luther beside, I didn't have much choice. I waved my hand in air, its nothing. Just talking about what to do with the remaining Citradel people. Whether they will be leaving as scheduled or is that changed now. We decided, its something Blake has to decide. Luther bought it completely since I know Blake was talking about it to the reporters now.

He says, she isn't alone wondering about it. Blake just told people that nothings changed for that. Citradel citizens will be travelling back just as planned. What happens after, is entirely up to the Citradel officials. I nod half-heartedly. My thoughts were still a little clouded from the nervous break I just experienced. Without anyone noticing, I took deep breathes. Luther was concentrating on the questions being asked to Blake. He didn't pay any attention to me. I was vaguely hearing conversation between Blake and with them. I was making all effort to not get distracted by anything. This is the final hurdle and probably the first step in preparing to bring people here. If I can't show confidence to our own people, Citradel and other communities won't believe it either.

Marina whispers to me, Blake told me. Don't worry about it now. I got you. Just focus on this, nothing else. Did she and Blake saw my meltdown earlier. No, Catherine hide it well. I think she is just backing me up. I felt a bit of hope hearing her, thanks Marina. I will need it. But promise me you or Blake won't do anything unless absolutely necessary. She nods, I will.

My mental preparedness comes to a close when Blake steps out of the hot seat. Blake walks to me and his smile vanishes halfway when he sees me. Luther says, that was good. We got to cover most of what we could tell. Blake turns his gaze to him, they didn't ask some of the question we thought they ask. I think they were eager to get it directly from the horses mouth. He was implying I will have to take over the majority of the stuff. I nod, I got this. I'm not sure if I'm reaffirming it to him or myself. Blake waves his hand to the chair, all yours.

As soon as I get in the view of the camera, the people behind the barricade started to shout in excitement. I put a forced smile for everyone, waving them and took my seat. The kuritine drones glide near me for a close up. I tuned everything out of my mind and laser focused on the interview now. In the first row was the primary reporter, Sasha. She had been covering news all about her. Beside her was Keith, he was from Citradel. The two beside them, Geina and Terry were representing the other communities.

I preemptively started the conversation, good morning everyone. Nice to meet you all. I kept a mechanical smile all the while talking. Sasha says, hello David. Thanks you for joining us. Have your injuries healed. Its been almost whole day since we saw you. I cross my legs and interlock my fingers, getting comfortable with them. I reply, they have. I apologies for worrying everyone, its wasn't my intention to be away for such long suddenly. Vance asks, I have to ask, where were you all the time. You left the stadium without letting anyone know. And you weren't at your home also.

We had prepared for this obvious question, as you all know. I can't heal like others. But I do have nano bot chamber designed for superficial and small surgeries. That's the one I was in after the match. Its a prototype, and its not at fully optimized. It was my first time using actually. It was slow and time taking procedure since it had to calibrate for me the first time. When I woke up yesterday after the match, I still needed to get back inside to complete tending my injuries. With Blakes discretion, I moved to safehouse in section 4 and I have been there all this time. I just woke up early this morning. And came straight here hoping to surprise Citradel officials before they left.

Sasha says, its still an impressive recovery. You seem back to your usual self. I laugh amused, mostly because they don't have a clue. They however would see me as someone being modest. Geina asks, people want to know about your fight with Heraknus alpha. You have fought before with alphas and omegas. Tell us how you felt when you saw your opponent the first time. I reply, I was shocked, like everyone. I never imagined in my wildest dreams that Citradels secret warrior and champion would be a mythical bloodline. Whatever battle plans I had, were all crushed. How does one fight when you don't know about their kuret. Once he introduced himself, the real challenge begin. And as you saw, it was one tough battle from the very first clash.

Vance asks, during the fight, was there ever a time you thought about giving up. I chuckle, oh man. You have no idea. Every time I came this close to resigning. The first half was brutal, none of my attacks were working on Charles. I was lucky he was slow, because of that I could run around to stall for time. And even after I got my bearing and fought head on, I couldn't budge that Heraknus guy. Each time I thought I figured out something about him, he switches his attack style. No was has made me think this hard in the tournament. I am actually very lucky Charles humanization backlash happed when they did, otherwise the outcome of the match would have been different.

Geina asks, I am sure it was not just luck. You woke just in the nick of time when you were knocked unconscious. And as you said, the game changed around the middle of the match. Your kuret armer, the barrier braking and lastly, variety of kuret attacks. You were slowly beginning to dominate the match. How much was it part of your strategy. I answer, first of all. Thanks for the compliment. Keep them coming. I laugh and so does other 4 amused by my ego. I continue, it didn't go entirely how I wanted. But the important bits, that went as I wanted it. I had no intention in scaring any of the audiences in the stadium. Chalk that overzealous moment to adrenaline rush. Thankfully, no was hurt. Then my smile grew acting suspiciously, but in my defense, I didn't think that Charles would be blown away. He should have been able to stop it. Don't you all think. Does that size was only for show.

I took shots at Charles to show a little bit of hubris. That made the them feel delighted at my attitude towards Charles. Sasha asks with light giggle, this comes to my next question. Do you have any protest over the prolonged Charles countdown. Everyone had almost believed you won then. That was almost a 10 minute break for Charles to get back up. I reply simply, no, I don't have any objection. No rules were broken. If fact, in retrospect, that gave me the opportunity to lunch a bigger attach. Sure, I do feel a little discontent, knowing I could have won the match. But because of that, I got to chance to show my full kuret. So I can't complain.

Terry asks, throughout the tournament, you have shown brilliant strategies. You went from the underdog to potential contender for the finals. And yet, you shocked everyone again with your kuret abilities. People want to know how your anti-kuret could do such a thing. I flighted slightly knowing this is one of the trickiest question. I purposely made it look like I was thinking about it for a moment. Then I say, sorry. I can't reveal it. Not just yet. You heard Charles yesterday, right. He also doesn't want to give my any advantage. Neither do I. All I want to say is that it was something I developed during the tournament. I grew stronger seeing other warriors participants.

Vance asks, have you heard about the allegations against you about you fight. Allegedly, you employed deception and trick to use that mind blowing ability. What do you have to say about it. I had long known how I was going to respond to this. Blake insisted that I deny it. But I had other ideas. I say, they are just rumors. I haven't been accused of anything. I don't feel any need to worry about it. I chose to remain neutral about it. Vance looked a little bit perplexed, are you denying it. I reply, I am saying, admins didn't find any proof to make them believe I did anything wrong. Until someone officially asks me to give justify my actions, there are no problem. My objectivity didn't budge even at his insistence.

Geina asks a bit confused, just for clarification, you aren't denying it. I just give my smile as response. I wasn't going to let them continue this line of questioning, like I said, I am not worried. They are just rumors. That shut down any further talk of this. Sasha smiling asks, creating suspense and being mysteries. Just the brand adore portraying others. Her candor made me feel better. Terry asks, okay. Lets talk about the deal you made with Charles. What prompted it exactly.

I cleared my throat replying, as you saw. Once I had Charles bound by his own kuret, I was able to pull out some information from him. The quickest way to overcome his tremendous kuret endurance was to make him use his overdrive. I wasn't thrilled to know I had to fight him in his overdrive state. But I wasn't going to back down also. I was prepared to compel him and use it forcefully. Once he realized what I plan to do, he stopped me. The rest you all know, we talked for it. He proposed me a condition for allowing to fight him in his overdrive. And I accepted it.

Sasha asks, but not before adding in the condition to move Heraknus here. What made you make this, a genius move if I say so, a part of it. Because Charles didn't mention that he himself made it, I realized Kafar had to make him say that. He didn't want to show that Charles was the one who came up. But that doesn't mean I should claim it myself. Blake agreed with me that we shouldn't call out who proposed it. I answer, both me and Charles felt this would be fair. He was going to give us both a month to prepare. He needs to regain his kuret, but I could also train in this time. While it looked fair, it wasn't. Since we did agree to allow him as a wild entry at the finals. Using the final match like this isn't fair. To make up the difference, we decided it was crucial to treat this as my win. And that resulted in his promise to relocate his family here.

With careful wording, I asserted that it wasn't a sole decision. Vance says, that was a big win for you all. Citradel lost their most important warriors, well apart from the recently gained Marina Ozarek. But we are curious though. It's such a big risk. Charles has told his overdrive is unstable and he can't control it well. He said it will be very dangerous for you. Its a very perilous situation. What made you decide you it was worth the risk. I swallowed hard here. I had to think long on what I was going to say to this. Blake wanted me to just say this, and I agreed, I am under no delusion that this isn't dangerous. But after weighing the benefits, it's clear I want to secure our future. Me, Blake and everyone here have always stated its important that we come together in this Island. Not in Citradel, in then middle of human society. I had no choice but to accept the risk.

I lied through my teeth. Only few people know the real reason I did. But no way in hell was I ever going to admit that I did it because of a selfish and unstable emotions packed reason. Vance continues, that's admirable. Risking your life on the line. I thought this line of questions were done. I showed how serious I was. He says, however, there are now new information from one of the Citradel officials, that you were influenced by someone. A person we all know.

My smile broke in half. No. no. Don't you say it. Don't freaking mention that guy to me. He generates a small suspense and says, Wagner, the previous crown was mentioned in you talk with the alpha. And it seems even he couldn't defeat Charles. A slight tremor suddenly appears in my toes and arms. This can't be happening.

Blake (Chapter 60)

Monday, October 6, 2025 21:26

I had been a little worried about David and Catherine missing. But then she finally showed up just when were boarding the cruise. Vanessa and other officers were a little disturbed on how she came undetected. I assumed she had assumed she just morphed into a bird or something to fly here. I wanted to immediately ask her what she was doing. And if my fears were true. But I stayed focused on seeing off the Citradel officials. They were getting delayed. And later, Marina and Derek shows up. Seeing her so excited to talk to Charles made me almost forgive her for delaying us further with such an ostensions show of her uniform.

When David showed up, I was amazed to see him so lively and being his usual self. But then I saw how Vanessa was shocked he was also avoided detection. I peeked at Catherine who was amused slightly. I saw her aura to confirm. She wasn't wavering like others. I internally sighed. What I feared did came true, she went to look for him. She was late because they both came together. That's the only reason why she isn't surprised to see him. But what could have kept both of them this long. I don't think I would get an answer now.

I knew from the moment he spoke that he is straight up bluffing. His body language, behavior and speech, all seem like his is just flowing through the motions. The last time I saw was him was in his nano chamber getting carried into his house by those robots. He was having a panic attack before, but, you can't tell he had a nervous breakdown. When Rory asked to show his kuret, I saw David eyeing for help. That was the first time he showed a hint of panicking. It broke the mirage he had me in that he was really fine. No way he would be fine after that crash from yesterday. Catherin spoke in his defense before I could. She also saw he didn't want to show his kuret.

It was odd how he asked for Rory to show his Kuret. Obviously, he didn't want to share his tricks without something in return. But throwing that study at us. What was he trying to accomplish by that. Thankfully nothing came of it and I secretly signaled to Marina. She understood and pulled away from others. I had a hunch she was more interested to ask him other things, like his house, than hide his mental condition. It was okay, as long as we get him clear of the eyes of Charles and officials.

Once we cross the bridge and step into the pier, I tell Luther, I need to talk to David for a bit. He nods, I get it. He needs to be filled in a lot of stuff. We have some time until Citradel boats leave. Do me a favor and ask David to come to the officers building. He needs to be in front of a camera pronto. People will be coming for our heads asking about him. Yesterday it was all a mess, I don't want a repeat for that here. I reply, boy do I know. I will let him know. He takes off to meet some officers.

I can't really tell if he is okay to talk in his condition. When I came to others, it was a one sided crusade to get to the truth out of David. He should have expected people are going to demand answers why he hide his Echo tech house a secrete. I was more concerned about his mental state, but, I can't deny I was interested to know about it. After hearing his explanation, I felt satisfied. It wasn't because he wanted to keep the tech all to himself, he didn't want a potential dangerous tech to harm anyone.

Then he revealed his bluff to Rory. I am shocked to know how he choose to lie so boldly. I agree with Marina that he feels like himself, crazy and clever. No one aside from Marina and I could ever guessed he was in the middle of a phycological crisis. Is he really going to therapy. I think I understand how he was able to fool everyone for long so good. He is quite excellent in manipulating and deceiving. I didn't think he would be like this after yesterday. I did reprimand him a little and asked to not make any more trouble for us. He has to know how tenuous the situation is. Until Heraknus move here, no matter how many Citradel citizens move here, nothing is certain.

But even David had limit, he made everyone's attention to Marina. I used the chance to talk to him. Luther and I wanted to get him up to speed before he speaks to anyone. However, I should have known better. This guy already knew everything. Detail only me and Marina knew. Maybe Vanessa know some of it. But he didn't speak much to her. He correctly deduced I talked to Catherine about his therapy. I should have better to ask how a shadow strategist knows so much while he was unconscious. The only logical guess was he bugged us. He didn't confirm it exactly, but he didn't need to.

He told me that Catherine found about him. Dammit, she actually followed Drew. She even spied on David. I could tell David wasn't happy about it. He didn't want to be exposed by her so suddenly. I felt a pang of guilt. Maybe I really shouldn't have told Catherine. But she was angry with Daivd. I thought it was the right thing to tell her about it. I really think there is some connection to his behavior on opposing her and Robb like this. Though, it does look like they talked and settled their argument. I want to ask Catherine about it, but this isn't the time or the place.

When he told me his condition is actually worse, I almost yelled out. Poor guy, somehow he is even in a stranger mental state. Can't use his kuret for unknown reasons. What the hell does that mean. Since he asked me to help in case anything happens, I was glad he is cognizant about his current condition. It gave me confidence he was still able to operate normally at some level. We discussed what he will say to others, making especially sure we don't say anything to offend anyone.

After some time, I left him alone to give my interview. Marina just came out from her seat, that was not satisfying. I wanted to say much more. They mostly just asked me about Heraknus moving and Davids match. Then they asked about my thoughts on who will win. I avoided taking sides in front of people. I just said no matter who wins, they both are strong. Then they asked if I could beat Charles. I am going to be honest, I was not sure what to say here. I too was amused by this. I didn't her interview, so I waited for her to talk. She sighs, I wish I could say what I really wanted to. But I remained impartial and said who knows.

She made the right call. Better not to provoke by saying anything. I had a thought, do you think you can take Charles. She smiles, everyone thinks so. You too. They said we both might have better chance. Honestly, I think that also. I am not being conceited, but I think we could take him. Sure, maybe we would have some trouble in beginning. Like David had. But we also have a chance. Don't you think. I reply, you know what. I feel the same. I don't want to kick down David, but I would be more happy if you or I were fighting Charles. I may not have admitted this before. But after learning about David's condition, I also believe we could take on Charles.

She says, yeah. But I know we can't say something so vain. But I so told them I am excited to be the city's newest infrastructure designer. I wanted to talk so much about my job, but weren't interested in knowing that. Her enthusiasm about this wasn't appreciated here, wait for at least a day. We will get it sorted out soon. Once people understand, you will have a lot to talk about. And I feel people She nods slightly disappointed, yeah, I got that. Well, its fine. Important thing is that I am staying here from now on. Nothing keeps her down. She leans in and whispers, what about David. Is he going to be okay. I seems a different. She also caught on. She looks a little offended sensing my realization, hey. I noticed it. But I wasn't going to say anything. So I just asked him the next most important thing I wanted to know.

I smile, no need to explain. I know you also want to help him. But for now, lets not make it obvious by talking about it. I don't want to know what would happen if had another panic attack here. She says, he sometimes behaves his usual self, but some times he just, becomes blank. You know what I am talking about it. I reply, I do. I just hope others didn't pay much attention to it. She asks, is he going to be okay with the interview. Shouldn't we wait for some more time.

I say, he decided it himself. And so far he hasn't shown any signs of issues. Its actually important he speaks to people now. I was okay with it being later, but now that he has shown here, we can't delay. It won't look good on us. She says, I guess. Her fears weren't satisfied. To be honest, neither was mine. Marina says, Dr. Drew made it pretty clear he shouldn't be doing this. But maybe its fine now. Did they both already spoke. I had the same thought sometime before, they have. David mentioned they met. She did say she wanted to talk to him first when he wakes up. Lets hope she assessed him that he was good enough. She says, they did. That's good. She thinks a moment before asking, so I take it you both agreed on what to tell people. I saw you both talking for a while before.

I answer, I did. I will answer some question before him. To ease into it. I turn sideways to see David talking to Vanessa. He looks a little flustered talking to her. And her aura. What's that about. Maybe she is asking about Wagner and if he knows him. I was curious about that too, but I didn't think much about it. Marina sees me eyeing him, you worried about something. I wasn't sure why, but Vanessa aura was flickering like crazy. She appears calm on the outside, but her body speaks differently.

I was a beginning to get worried. He is too open and if he gets a panic attack now, everyone will see it. I saw Catherine moving around the edge talking to some officers. I get an idea. I open my phone and type in a message. Marina asks, what are you got there. You have an interview in a minute. I say, making a backup plan. I am telling Catherine to keep an eye on David. She looks puzzled. She didn't know that Catherine knows. So I explained it to her. She sighs, come on dude. Even I know when to keep a big secret like this.

What was worse than David frustration at me was Marina being right. She knows when and what to keep something from others for right reasons. I felt again the weird feeling about sharing it with Catherine. I say, I know I screwed up a little. But it had to say something to her. She shook her head, that's why they both were late together. She must have gone to talk to him earlier. She figured out the rest. I nod, yes. But since she also knows about it, maybe even more than us, she can help. The more people can keep an eye on him, that much better.

Marina reluctantly says, well, now that she knows and hasn't revealed it to anyone, I guess its fine. I finished my message and sent it to her. I saw Catherine grabbing her phone from her pocket. After a while she turns to me and slightly nods agreeing to it. With that settled, I felt more secured. I say, that's done. Marina says, I'll also help keep an eye on him. He seems fine though. I say, don't be fooled by his appearance. He is good at hiding it. He told me he can't use his kuret for some reason. She freaks out, say what. That's terrible. Did he explain why. I shrug, take a pick. Drew said he was suffering from multiple things. One of them might be causing it. All I we can do right now is keep anyone knowing about it.

She sighs, that's why he pulled that stunt with Rory. I thought he was just being secretive. I say, I had the same thought. We both look at David, who was still talking to Vanessa. Marina says, that poor bastard's got it rough at the worst possible time. Maybe I shouldn't have gone at him like that earlier about his house. She felt guilty knowing the whole truth. I say, I don't know it would make any difference. David is somehow keeping up his usual appearance. She makes a pity expression.

A while later Luther calls me. Its time to talk to the people. Marina and Luther stayed on the sidelines as I walk to the interview chair next. Sasha and Vanse asks me few questions about what's are plan next and will more Citradel people will be joining like Marina. Most of my answers were centered around expediting our infrastructure for Heraknus arrival. We didn't have any indication that any other people are going to come. Terry asked about the other communities and how we plan to bring them. I told him they should decide for themselves, but I did highlight that when Heraknus moves here, its for their sake to relocate here. We can provide protection much better with Heraknus here.

I didn't want to speculate on anything else. Giana asks questions about their role and contributions. I told as much as I could. More will be revealed when we start talking to Heraknus once they are back in Citradel. Few more questions came around the topic of David. I deferred those to have them ask David directly. They didn't ask me few things, like the rumors floating about David's supposedly cheating. Or the part about Charles overdrive dangers. They must want to talk to David about it.

Soon my time was up and David was next. The reporters thanked me and I left the hot seat. David, Marina and Luther were watching me. And after a small exchange from David, he took the seat. I now stand beside Marina whispering, anything I need to be worried about. She shrugs, I can't say for sure. He and Catherine were talking for some time. They looked suspicious. He said it wasn't anything. I saw them before, hopefully it didn't escalate to anything. I looked around, Catherine was no where around us. She must be busy with Tessa and Vanessa managing security from the barricade. Few people had also begin to leave. Officers are going to be soon back into their normal routine.

The reports asked David pretty basic questions. And he didn't waste any opportunity to make jokes and show his cocky attitude. I got a say, for a guy with mental issues, he has hide it very well. The best poker face I have ever seen. The topic then switched to the rumors about him cheating. Luther turns confused hearing David's answer, wait. Why isn't he denying it. I shook my head dismayed, I told him to deny it unequivocally. I don't know why he would confirm it or deny it. Marina offers, maybe he doesn't want to share any clues by talking about it. I couldn't understand that logic, what good will it be if he doesn't outright say he didn't cheat. He must have a good reason. But no one here knows it.

Thankfully the reports didn't pursue this topic for long. Then they asked about Heraknus moving as part of the deal. David stuck to the script this time by not mentioning who came up with that condition. Marina asks, you don't want them to Charles brought this offer himself. Luther says, it's the right call though. If we say Charles did it, Citradel will not like it. Their prized bloodline making unilateral decisions like that may cause some unintended issues. Its best if everyone believes either David made him do it or they both did. Citradel probably wants the same since Charles also didn't mention it. As always, his political savvy mind picked up the same reasons we were thinking.

When Vance asked him the question why David accepted such a risky deal. I hoped he wouldn't go off script. Its important they he conveys our ideology to all the communities. I relaxed when he responded as we wanted. When we talked about it, he was little distracted. I know what was going on his head. His reasons weren't as noble as the words he spoke. Since I was there physically, I could tell he accepted for different reasons. Perhaps reckless and selfish reasons. Who knows, something else entirely. But the next question tripped all of us. Vance revealed about Wagner being mentioned during the deal.

Marina says hesitantly, hey, is it just me or did his mood suddenly change. I answer, you aren't alone. Luther asks, what happened. What's Wagner got to do with this. Luther was bamboozled at this question. But I had other things in my mind. Like how David image was cracking. His eyes were twitching slightly. His smile was melting away and he was fidgeting. Marina saw it too, this doesn't look good. I know I promised him, but should we barge in stop the interview.

Anything, but that. Not in the middle of the questions. From their aura's I can see the reporters also felt Davids subtle change in attitude. David remained silent for few seconds. Luther asks hesitant, hey what's going on. Did something happen to him. I couldn't answer him. Marina says impatiently, 10 more seconds and I am going in. Marina had up her mind. I wanted to stop her, but should I. What if he having another episode right now on live TV, in front of all Medrone population. That's a disaster. If that's the case, we should just risk it and pull the plug now.

Marina takes a step ahead. But then David clears his throat. He regains his smile and eyes Marina for a moment. Marina understood and steps back. David says, apologies. That caught me of guard. His mouth spoke words normally, but he was now clutching his fingers more tightly. I think I see a bit of blood. Did he just dig his nails into the back of his hands to snap out of it. Is he that desperate to stay in control. David continues, I wasn't sure how to answer this, and needed a moment to think.

Vance asks, I hope it was okay to ask this. Neither Charles or any Citradel officials have any comments about it. We just want to know if that's true. David chuckles, this was definitely a nervous one, I think I understand. I was wondering how this got out. You have a good source to get such an information, even when Citradel themselves haven't shared it. Vanse looked smug about it. No one from our side must have told him. That leaves Marina, Derek and Kafar. No, really its just Kafar. Is he willing to leak details of things he asked Citradel to hide himself. That guy is incorrigible.

Marina girts her teeth beside me, that rat bastard. There is nothing he wouldn't try to stop this, huh. Apparently, she seemed to arrive in the same conclusion. Sasha asks, so its really true that Wagner Wecker, the last crown, fought Charles. Giana asks, can you tell us how and why. Terry asks, if even the crown couldn't defeat Charles, do you think you can do what he couldn't. I swear I saw David digging his fingers deeper in his skin with each question thrown at him.

The last time someone spoke about Wagner, he had a panic attack. What's going to happen now. I doubt he would recover enough in a day. I could hear David breathing quietly to calm down. Even with such self control, he is showing signs of a nervous breakdown. David kept up his outward composure in all this, let me be assure everyone. I don't know the reasons. Charles didn't talk about it. He only confirmed that he once fought the crown for some reason. He laughs, no, more like a halfway between a whimper and laugh. He says, you should ask your source the how or why. Because I was shocked to know he knew about Heraknus existence. I don't have a clue how he knew or why he fought Charles.

Sasha asks, I do think that it pretty strange no one ever mentioned it after the match. Can you at least tell us why. David answers, I can't say for sure why Citradel didn't. However, I can tell why we didn't. Talking about it without any evidence wouldn't make sense. I mean, apart from Charles testimony, where's the actual evidence. I am not saying they lied, but anyone can say they fought the crown. And then claiming he couldn't defeat them is even a bigger one. So we thought its best not to reveal it, at least until we confirm it.

Vance asks, did Wagner's sister reveal any details about it. She must have some information. David struggles a little to answer this, Vanessa was too young back then. She doesn't know about it. I suspect the crown didn't mention this to anyone. Before there was another question, he added, I want to be clear about this. We didn't want people to get discouraged by such a unverified statement. Regardless of whether Charles fought or not, won or not, I would still taken the deal. If anything, it probably fired me up and gave me another reason to accept it. The thought of fighting at the level the crown was too enticing. I may have been selfish, but I hope people can understand that it wasn't a decision I made lightly. I weighed the pros and cons of taking the deal before accepting it. It was always the future of Medrones and our fight with Echo on my mind, not about the crown.

David's little ranting ran out as he begins to breath a little faster. I think he was overcompensating his selfish desire by reaffirming our goals. Thankfully, the Sasha and Giana interpreted the way David wanted. Sasha says, that was well said. I am sure anyone in your position would have been also tempted to fight someone the crown couldn't defeat. Giana says, absolutely, a warrior has to be confident in himself to take on a Heraknus overdrive. Looks like David made the right impression on them. He manipulated them, using this to his advantage.

Vance switches the question, as impressive your resolve is, do you have plan on how to fight Charle's overdrive. He hasn't reveled anything about it. But he has seen your kuret abilities. David chuckles menacingly, I was hoping you ask that. What you all saw was me not at 100%. But once I am, overdrive or not, Charles will feel what its like to taste dirt. Whatever I plan is irrelevant, because his first defeat on Earth will be my hands. You can quote me on that. Jeez, I know he is being cocky to hide his mental state, but instead of weaning off slowly, the guy is doubling down on his arrogance. He said it with zero hesitation. I can't tell if people will think he is delusional or just ego talking. Either way, the impression he was making was too strong and it resonated among the reporters. Their aura even showed slight admiration.

David handled it nicely. But it wasn't going to last for much. His hands were bleeding visibly now. The reporters can't see from their seats, but we could see it. I want to get him out of here soon. Marina had been wavering for a little while, she kept taking a step in front and back. But with Luther beside us, we weren't going to take any chance showing this side of David. David finally said, and I am afraid that's all the time I have guys. I have a lots to prepare. While I am sure I will win, that doesn't mean I don't need to work for it. I have to start planning strategies immediately.

David had the good sense to back off now, before he becomes worse. The reporters seem not fully satisfied. I am sure they had other tons of information. But David has done his bit. Theres nothing more I or Luther want him to say. Shasa says, Thanks for being here. Good luck David. Other give their appreciation as well. David stands up, covering his bleeding left hand with his right one on top. He shakes his head to the reporters and to the crowd behind him. With no expression of any discomfort, he walks to us.

Luther asks, that was great David. You showed how confident you are with your victory. I am a little worried it was a bit too much, but that's okay. This should raise our morale, and pressure Citradel at the same time. David smile was gone now. He seemed exhausted, yet he keeps a pleasant attitude, thanks Luther. I could have handled it better, I know now. Well, anyways. This was just to show I am okay and not going to back down. Other things were just me getting a big head. Luther waves his hand to him, I told you. Its fine. The important thing was like you said, your presence.

David replies, great. So we are done here right. Because I wasn't exaggerating that I had work to do for my fight with Charles. Luther says, all right. Unless you have anything to discuss Blake, we are good here. I immediately reply, no. I think we got everything we need. Let me talk to him for a sec. I will be just behind you. Luther walks away after that. David suddenly leans towards and grabs Marina by her arm whispering loudly, get my the freak out of here.

We both were ready for this. With a quick look around us in our vicinity, I signaled Marina to walk with us towards the far east end of the shore. I don't see any aura nearby there. She nods and grabs on Davids arm supporting him. Few officers turn their gaze at us as we walk briskly, but we both spoke to David like we were in deep discussion. We make random remarks about David being too confident and ask his plans. David meanwhile remained silent, the guy even closed his eyes.

It feels déjà vu, carrying him like this again. Thankfully, he wasn't passing out. He was walking properly. As soon as we arrive at the isolated part of the shore, David began gasping for air, like he was holding his breath. He opens the buttons around his neck. He crouches down on one knee and pants heavily. He places his beading hand on the wooden planks to support his body. Marina puts her hand on his shoulder, are you okay, David.

David didn't reply. His face was flushed with blood and red appeared on the skin. I could see sweat shining from the sun behind his neck. He did nod his head after a while signaling he is recovering slowly. I look to Marina and we both shared a relief signs on our face. I ask, man. When I said you have problems, it was understatement, you are a real mess. Marina puts on a scowl expression towards me. I shrug, what. She remains silent, like she was telling me not to say the obvious. Maybe she was right, I shouldn't kick him down when he is quite literally on the ground.

David moves finally. He turns and sits on the wooden floor with his back against the railing. He looks much better than a minute ago. He sighs, its fine Marina. What he said was just a fact. Marina shape gaze cuts me deeper. Maybe I really shouldn't have said it. Marina crouches down on her legs, are you really okay. Do you need water. He says, no. I got it under control now. His ragged breathing was slowing down. I had to ask, I know I shouldn't say this. But this the second time we had to carry you out in two days. This is not a good sign.

Marina was giving me a warning expression to shut it. But I had to ask him, I hate to ask this. But I need to know. Its important. What did Dr. Drew say. Marina realizing what I am getting at faces him again. David glances at both of us. He grits his teeth, shit. This is so embarrassing. I never wanted you both to be worried about me like this. I know I made the right call telling you both about my therapy, but it still so hard for me to see you guys like this. Marina scoffs, you are worried about us. Dude, you need to take a look in the mirror. I was a little angry in the beginning, but after sleeping on it, I get how it must have been suffering through it. You should have told at least me. I would have kept it a secret.

I didn't like her implying that I couldn't. Well, hard to argue since I did share it with Catherine. David smiles a little, I really thought I had it under control. I hadn't relapsed for months. I was sure that all of it was behind me. I was planning to tell you all, after the tournament. I didn't want to you or me to get distracted. And Drew also made me promise not to tell about this. Her condition was not to reveal her involvement, but she knew that if it got out I was in therapy, eventually she would be found out as well. It made sense for various reasons to not tell you. I am really sorry about it.

His expression was not at all what it was during the interview. His confidence and arrogance had been stripped down, replaced with pity and humiliation. Just how much was he bluffing back then. Whatever I felt about him went up in smoke. I say, it must have been a struggle. But I understand your reasons. If I had known you had so much going on, I would have not pushed you to win our match. He scoffs, only I need to take responsibility for it. Not you. When I entered the tournament, I accepted the risks. Besides, even if you did let me win in the end, I could have backed off anytime during our own match. I didn't. We both knew with your overdrive had taken a

major hit from Marina, I was the best chance for the finals.

Just because it made sense, doesn't mean it was the right. I say, honestly, me and Marina were just talking about how we might have better chances than you right now. Marina gets flustered, no. I mean, yeah. But listen, we were just joking around. I didn't mean to say you couldn't win. She was trying to console him. David snorts, no. That’s true. You guys might have better chances. At least, the way I am right now. There a slight hope still in him. That’s good, he hasn't given up completely.

Marina asks, right now. So does that mean you still intend to win. David remained silent, but that gave us the answer anyways. I ask, so you still believe that. Did talking to Drew helped out. Because I am concerned more than ever about your mental health. He replies, she agreed to waive her decision until midnight. The deadline I was talking about earlier was that. She told she has a way to help me, but there's a condition. I need get my kuret under control without loosing my mind. Marina asks, how does that makes sense.

He then explains how Drew believed that if David couldn't do it, it would mean he will not recover fast enough for the fight. Drew was testing him and only if he could use his Kuret, would she even administer this treatment. I ask incredulously, is she really a psychiatrist. Isn't she supposed to remove your stress, not add more. Marina says, this sounds a little crazy David. He says, I question it too. But she is my doctor. She knows the best. Maybe she is right to question my ability to recover. All I know is that if I don't figure it out before midnight, I will get no help from Drew. And I would be fighting like this. Which would end in most likely my defeat. Or worse, my life.

Marina and I remained quite learning of this ridiculous deadline. David slowly beings to stand up. Marina gives offers her hand to him, which he gladly accepts. She pulls him up. David pulls out his hand and wipes the drops of the blood tricking down. He asks us, did anyone see this. I made sure to hide it well. But I felt as maybe some officers saw it. I don't know. I was too focused on getting him out of there. Marina says, I don't think so. Even I didn't see it until it you moved it in the end. He nods, okay. If anyone does ask, just say one of my stiches opened up.

I say, is that something you do whenever you feel having an attack. He shook his head, no. I never had so intense in front of anyone before. I took a sedative just minutes before, I can't believe I had another one so soon. My body must be building up immunity to it. Drew told me this trick for situation like this. I never thought it would work, since I have been hurt much worse before. But my head felt like it was about to explode. I desperately thought for anything to keep me from breaking down in front of the whole world. I tried my best to salvage my image near the end. I wasn't planning to be so conceited. But I had to hide it by using a stronger emotion.

Marina says, boy did it work. Your ego felt it had no limit. She nervously smiles. I didn't it that amusing, only you would be fine to be vain enough just to hide your illness. There will be some people who will question your big head. He nods, I know. Can't deny it. I didn't want it to take it too far. I felt like I was back in the middle of the match with Charles. The situation was different, but it felt, well. Forget it. I wasn't in my right mind then or now. But what[s done is done. I have achieved all I wanted coming here. Even with so many unexpected and harrowing things along the way. The damage I caused to others, I can't undo it.

What damage is he talking about. Me and Marina look each other confused. But neither one of us were going to ask him to explain. He might be thinking of Catherine or his interview. David then turns to the center of the pier where officers were mobilizing to clear the place. He says, I should go back now. Tell anyone who asks that I am busy preparing or something at my home inside the city. Marina asks, wait. You are already leaving. You sure that’s a good idea. I was with her on this, I don't think its okay to leave you alone for today. What if you have another episode.

David turns to us, that’s why I should leave. I have a less chance of triggering if I am alone. And I have asked a lot from you two already. Marina, you just relocated here today. You will be busy settling down, permanently this time, I don't want to became a burden for you. And Blake, you are soon going to be swamped with work. With so much going on, other officers need you. So trust me, right now I need time and space. He argued about the situation, which was hard to dismiss. He was right, both us don't have the time to keep an eye on him.

I ask, what about Catherine. She could help out. She already knows about you now. Most of her work is done with the officials gone. The only people left in the guest houses are the Citradel regular citizen and warriors. Jess could take over her. David becomes sullen at that suggestion. He closes his eyes and shaking his head like he was trying to forgot a memory. A moment later he opens them back, yeah. That’s not going to happen. We maybe talking now, but things aren't resolved between us. I already shared too much today. Things I still believe I shouldn't have. And she helped out already. I can't ask her more.

I didn't know what he meant. I recall they were talking before his interview. Did something happen. Marina says, then we will get someone. Hell, maybe you go to your doctors house. David sighs, that’s not happening. I don't want to be analyzed or scrutinized like a patient right now. I feel it might do the opposite of helping. Trust me, its best if I figure out this alone for sometime. I was conflicted here. Can't we get anyone to watch over him. Marina says, I don't know if this would work. But what if we told Vanessa about your condition. She is also freed up now. And I am sure once she understand, she would help you.

David vehemently shakes his head, absolutely not. The ferocity of his rejection was hard not to notice. He sighs realizing his rection, sorry. It just that she is little mad at me for not explaining how I know Wagner. I kind of lied and she somehow knows I lied. So she is a bit cross at me. I stare at him trying best to understand this absurdity. Marina mocks him, is every women mat at you. David grunts, I know. I don't want you to be the latest one. So, you know how much I am messing things. Guys, the bottle line is that I will cause trouble for anyone around me right now. Whether they know about my illness or not. Its best for everyone that I get out of everyone's way. Figure it out without having to worry about a panic attack when I talk to anyone.

At this point we had no choice but to trust him. Theres only so much help we can give him without anyone knowing. With reluctance I said, okay. I get it. Lets trust him Marina. Marina wasn't satisfied with this, are we really not going to do anything. I shrug, if you have any idea, I am all ears. What else can we do, but trust him to be okay. Marina faces him. After a brief stare she says, fine. This isn't over though David. You hear me. You got still a lot to explain. The secret to be able to use multiple kurets. How you know Wagner. What's the deal with Catherine. And now Vanessa.

I agreed with her, yeah. We got a lot questions you need to answer. He nods, and I will. Just not today. His shoulders slump down, like he lost all his strength. He walks between us towards the forest, I will be taking the long way to my place. I need to clear my head anyways. So I need the walk. I ask nervously, seriously. If don't want to ride with anyone, at least take the trolley from the nearest stop. Marina backs me up, its almost 12 miles from here. That’s too much for you. It will take around 4 hours. David doesn't budge, he says, that’s good. It will give me some workout to release my stress.

He walked towards the forest line near the shore. Once he was away from us, Marina asks me, he is going to be okay, Right. I had no words of encouragement.

Vanessa (Chapter 61)

Wednesday, October 8, 2025 18:29

This was my chance for an answer. When I saw Blake leaving David for a moment, I knew this was the only time I might get to talk to him. I approached him from behind, Hey, you have a second. I didn't expect him to be on such edge. Was giving the interview making him anxious. I have seen him fought off worse things than this. I can't believe he would be lost in thoughts so much that he wouldn't notice me. He is clearly hot himself right now. But I set it aside and got to the real matter in hand.

He surprised me again with how eager and forth going he was revealing how he knows my brother. I listened to him justifying his actions to me. I was glad that he understood how pompously he was behaving yesterday during the match. Maybe he really is telling me the truth. It made sense how he knows about it. Derek did say David's university is Wagner's also. But why would he not tell this before. I never once told he met Wagner before. He had enough chances to tell, yet he chose not to.

I noticed him slowly getting calmer as we spoke. Its almost like he was panicking when we spoke. I don't know how, but I had a nagging feeling he isn't telling the truth. He has the same expression I have seen countless times. When is lying. Maybe I am wrong. Its not like I can be certain of it. He maybe just stressed right now. I shook away the thoughts. That's what is going on. This guy is manipulating me. I was slowly getting more certain of it. This realization crushed me. Why can't he tell just me the truth. I wanted him to tell me what Melinda told me was a lie. But I couldn't even utter a single word about it. Because I knew he would twist it, like everything he does.

I blurted out and accused him of lying the whole time. He tried to rebuke it, but deep down I know he was lying. He always does it so effortlessly. After getting close this year, I really thought he didn't need to behave this way with me. I thought he trust me completely. I thought he has forgiven me for the things I did in the past. But I was wrong. He hasn't changed. Its the opposite, he has been keeping a lot more. He just let me believe there was nothing. My anger was getting out of hand. I recalled Siera methods to cope and pushed it down. I usually do this only when I am in an argument or fighting. But I couldn't take it. I slowly push away the distracting thoughts, centering my senses.

The half hearted smile was not needed anymore. I could tell David saw my attitude changing. I say, I am done. I don't want to talk to you. I basically told him to freak off. I don't care about his match anymore. Whether he wins or not, is not going to change anything for me. He will always be like this. He didn't even try to stop me from leaving. Actually, I was grateful for that. He is nothing but efficient, sparing us both any further pain. I didn't even once looked back to him.

With a stoic expression I approached the small shed where we setup our surveillance equipment's and satellite link. Inside few officers were talking over the phone and monitoring the situation. I found Ruther seating in front of a monitor that showed a satellite view, everything all right with the Citradel boats. Everything on schedule. Ruther looks at me strange, like something was weird on my face. I was making painful attempts to hide my emotions. He says, ah. Yeah. They just crossed the international borders. I nod satisfied. I take a seat beside him and watch the monitors that showed 7 boats crossing a border line.

Ruther asks, you don't need to keep watch here. We got it covered. I reply, I don't have anything else for now. I spoke to other officers to begin removing the barricades and get back to their posts. I will keep an eye on these boats, in case of any emergencies. Ruthers asks hesitantly, okay. You are the boss. He takes the side beside me. I whisper to him, let me know if there is any issue with the words or number on the screen. I don't want to guess if anything goes wrong. Ruthers nods in agreement, I got you.

We stare at the 3 monitors in silence. Others were talking and coordinating resuming the security of the island. I wasn't listening to them. I wasn't listening to anything. I didn't want my emotions to waver even a little. Otherwise I might either shout in anger or cry. That's what I am feeling right now. After a while, I heard a voice I couldn't ignore. Deni says, hey guys. Davids on the TV. Others gather around her enthusiastically. I remained motionless. In the corner of my eye I saw Ruther tilting his head towards the screen.

He asks, you don't want to check it out. I wave him off, I don't. Besides, why don't you all see him in person. You all should just go and watch yourselves. He is just 200 meters away. Somers, who came in a while ago, says, Luther told us not to interfere. Otherwise we would have gone. Deni says, besides, this is much better. With all the people shouting, you wouldn't hear much anyways. She wasn't wrong about the crowd going wild. David's presence lit an even more fire after Marina and Blakes interview.

I, on the other hand, didn't want to hear his voice. A voice filled with deception and lies. I wanted to leave, but where would I even go. Right now, the entire Medrone community is watching this. Even the Citradel people on the boats are getting this. Wherever I go, his voice will be looming. Reminding me that I am untrustworthy by him. I try to tune out the discussion. But it was so hard to be composed. I kept forcing my thoughts not to listen to his laughter. The nerve of the guy to behave like thing happened just now. He was so casual in his answers, like he wasn't bothered a bit about Charles overdrive.

My fist tighten when he evasively skipped over any details of how dangerous the match was in reality. Is no one going to talk about it. Neither Charles or him said even a word about it. They both are crazy to conveniently leave it out. Then came a I expected the least. I couldn't keep myself in check now, I rotate the chair and view the screen. David was sitting in the middle of a platform in front of 4 reports with their back to us. David became silent for several seconds.

Everyone here were confused but this. Ruthers asks, hey. Any idea why David became so quite. I didn't offer any explanation. In fact, I was going to see what lies he would spew to get of this. People were slowly becoming nervous about his odd behavior. Then he finally spoke, bringing back his usual attitude. The answer was carefully crafted. In fact, I don't he lied about anything. Just that he never mentioned about knowing Wagner. Other perceived his behavior like he was caught off guard. But I knew something more was going on. He was rushing things, being more egotistical to a point I wonder if he is faking it. But people were eating it all up. The officers here cheered him as he left his chair.

Deni says smiling, damn that confidence. I got say, that's hot. Seriously, what was she even thinking. Is she talking about the same guy here. Somers says, calm down women. He is just getting cocky knowing he gets to be stronger than the crown. I couldn't listen to them, guys. If it all the same to you, get back to work. The interview is over. I took a strict stance here. Others gave a confused look, nonetheless, complied. Everyone got back to their work. Ruther who was also enjoying the show went back to his work mode with me and asks, hey, about your brother. Did you know.

I cut him off, did I know he fought Charles. No. I didn't. Didn't you hear David. He nods tensed, yeah. But. Its just a little crazy. Wagner knew about Heraknus existence and never told anyone. Don't you think that's very strange. I gave a disgruntled look. He immediately backed off whatever else he was going to ask of me. I turned back to stare at the boats. There was nothing new, just the boat crossing on endless water. Ruther didn't spoke to me after that. He got the hint I gave him, loud and clear that I was done talking about it.

Things went monotonously then. I kept up ignoring the issue with David and instead just went through the work. After an hour, the Citradel boats had gone beyond our surveillance. From now on, we will only be communicating through the network sporadically. We begin wrapping up our stuff from the pier. Everyone got a message from Blake that there will a long meeting today at 12:00 and we should all get an early lunch. His message mentioned meetings and plans for city expansion. Everyone knew that this was coming. Since last night, we knew today was going to be full of discussion. Now that the officials have left, we need set aside the tournament stuff for a while and focus on the city.

We had an hour and half till we meet. Ruther and others offered me to join them to grab something to eat. I declined saying I wasn't hungry. I know I should eat properly. But I didn't want to relax. Because then I think about David. So instead I choose to go the officers building alone. After talking to few officers, I left. I had some time to kill, so I looked for Siera. She must have stayed behind. But I couldn't find her. She must have left for the school already. She said the morning was off due this, but I guess she already left.

I wished she was here to talk. She doesn't judge me or lies to me when I speak my mind. But then I chided myself. Didn't I just talk to her yesterday. I can't keep running back to her, whenever things doesn't go my way. I need to show her that I can take care of my feelings all on my own. When those thoughts in mind, I took the trolley ride to the officers building. There were hardly any people riding it now. Most people already left the shore and must be back into their normal day routine.

In another 15 minutes I arrived at the officer building. I saw few people also here, maybe they too wanted to have a jump start on things. I was thinking where to go. Maybe my office, but then being alone would make me go crazy a little. I already experienced it yesterday. That neither helped nor was it productive. So instead I walked to the 4th floor to the big conference room. I hoped someone would be here like me. I didn't know if anyone would be here an hour early, but I heard few hustling noises coming from inside.

When the door opened as I walk closer, the voices becomes clear. They were a group of officers already inside. I recognize most of them. They were the regular administration department. People had hurdled together and discussing various topics. I didn't have to listen to close to know what it was. They were commenting about David's interview. I wanted to talk to people, but not about him. So I took a seat at the far end from the stage. I put my tablet on the desk and started the message board over the network.

There wasn't anything new here. Blake said this was going to be a long discussion, so I am guessing everyone went to eat before spending hours here. After passing some time I heard familiar voices from the door, Matt and Cassandra. Cass says, see. I told you there will people here. Matt sighs, you were right. I just didn't want to be here so early. Can't we just get that parfait before it begins. Cass says, you saw the line. Its going to be a long one. I don't to be late again and make a scene. You know people expect us to be here always. Matt rebukes, I say this again, just because we know those the top ranking officers, it doesn't mean they expect too much from us.

Seems that's been going on for a while. Matt then notices me sitting alone, Vanessa, so you got here early too. They begin walking towards me. Cass makes a big smile, see. Like minds. Best to take this seriously. I didn't want to correct her with my actual reasoning. The tournament is over, we can't flaunt our broken ass ranking anymore. I smile at that, don't worry. No one is saying that.

Matt clicks her tongue, you think that, but that's also bad. Last week, we made loads of impression. But since the semis, and now the Heraknus reveal. All that fame is gone up in smoke. I was happy and enjoying for all of us yesterday, but after a while it becomes apparent we need to step up our game. We need to get stronger. Otherwise we become irrelevant.

Its probably not just him who is feeling this. After the final match and celebration from yesterday, people will gradually become inspired to get stronger. Cass scoffs, yeah. We get it. You don't need to remind me of that. You were at least were in top 1000. I lost even before the capture flag round. Matt smirks, that's just dumb luck. We both got beat by Citradel people in the end. They both take seats around me. Matt asks, back me up here Vanessa. How much do you think we have a chance of getting promoted.

I laugh at the nice change of scenery. I didn't have to worry about the problems I had with them. I answer, you really want me to be honest. I don't think he wanted me to be this honest. His eyes widen and then says, see Cass. Even she doesn't want to say it. Cass snorts, yeah well. Did you honestly think she say it outright. We both are at the low end of the raking in our group. Just accept it and don't keep whining about it. Her eyes were lighting up with her Kuret.

Matt and I got anxious over Cass's alter ego taking over. So Matt diffused the situation, okay. Calm down. We will talk about it later. Don't lose control here. That relaxed Cass before she used her Kuret. I offered my opinion, look. I may not be the best person to look for advice, given my history. But don't get discouraged. The tournament was just the beginning. Once everything settles down with Citradel and everyone moving here, you both will have chances to train now.

Matt sighs, we know. Its just everyone keeps looking at us with such expectation. With people also gather and stay for a long time, they begin to realize how odd our presence is. He looks around us to check if no one was listening in. He whispers, truth be told. I have been a little tensed about it since yesterday's match. That's why I offered to party at Blakes place. I wanted to feel how we used to be. Just us. Or well, at least us doing our own thing. But now, we got so many responsibilities. Stuff we never had to care about. And I know it's a good thing, but I miss it.

I could tell he had been wrestling with this for a while. I recalled he was hesitant to jump into the stadium yesterday. He was acting brave, offering to help out. But he was feeling the pressure. I understood his view, I felt it too. David becoming so strong and Charles being so strong, it changed my view about myself a lot. Cass comforts him by placing her hand on his, you aren't alone you know. Just because I don't say it much, doesn't mean I don't feel it too. Imagine me, who has known David on Earth the longest, being compared to. Just thinking how far he has gone, its slowly gnawing at me too.

It was weird that she felt exactly like me about it. She knew him longer than me on Earth, and had to see him rise up so far, to become on same levels as omegas, and now overdrive users. She must have her own insecurities she doesn't show us. Matt nods somberly knowing he isn't alone. Its not their fault though. It be friends with us, makes it difficult to be in a proper society now. I didn't have any other way to encourage them. Especially, when I feel the same as them.

Matt shakes his head, ah, leave this depressing topic. Lets talk about you Vanessa. He turns away their attention to me. He asks, did you really not know about Wagner and Heraknus. We didn't get to ask that yesterday. Cass asks, or why they fought. I wished it was about something else. But I should have known it will come up more often now. Thankfully, after spending some time away from others, I had calmed down enough to talk about it. I say, yeah, I have no clue. My brother wasn't going to tell me something that even royals were secretive about. You remember what Charles said, very select group of people know about him. So I figure he was made to keep quite too. My lips were going to be sealed about the slander against him. I still get angered thinking about it sometimes.

Matt chuckles, yeah. That's probably it. But man, that was surprise. Even David chocked up a little when asked. How did that guy from Citradel found about it. Cass says, who else. Kafar's the only one who would do something like this. I agreed with her. Matt remains unconvinced, I thought too. But it doesn't make sense. I heard him talking to the reporters before leaving, he almost given up trying to convince Charles or try anything to break the deal. He was more looking forward to joining us now. He mentioned it multiple times he was a little disappointed that Charles gave up such a way. But how he looking forward to live here now. I can't think of a reason why he would try to leak something like this. What would he even gain by doing it. Heraknus already decided to move here.

His suspicion made me reexamine Kafar's motives. Its true he doesn't have any other moves left. But I can't believe his last provocation to me was just a vain attempt to rile me up. Cass says, who cares. If not him, someone from Citradel did. No one here would benefit from leaking it. The morale would go down here. David save it being so recklessly overconfident. I mean, did you saw him getting so fired up. Only he wouldn't be cornered by this. Matt smirks, I know. Me and Vanessa has seen this side of him before anyone.

He was referring to the time we caught him after the barrier broke. I got curious about something, did you get a chance to talk to him. Cass sighs, no. I wanted to, but after the interview, I was told he already left. Matt says annoyed, only we both didn't get to meet him. That's not fair you know. I was surprised he crashed the party, but then again he likes to do this sort of thing. He didn't even explain to us about his secret house. Always being mysterious and stuff. He makes an gesture with his hands in air to show spookiness. Cass says, I asked Tessa. She said he went back to his home.

I just wanted to know he spoke about me to anyone. That's the only reason I even cared to bring it up. Blake might be only person he probably talk to later. But that's the extent of my curiosity. I wasn't going to ask him now. Matt asks, do you mean the secret one or his usual home. Cass chuckles, she said he went to section 2. I guess, If he goes missing again, people will become more agitated and concerned. I could have revealed about why he kept his house a secret. But I want to stay clear of David.

I had other things in my mind. I wasn't going to talk to anyone about it. But right now its just us. And these two can help me out in ways Siera can't. I hesitantly switch the topic, guys, I have something I want to ask the both of you. Its a kind of personal, so I appreciate it if you keep this between us. That got their attention. The two of them eye me waiting. I nervously blurted, do you guys ever fight. That bamboozled them with a blank stare for few seconds. Cass finally breaks the silence with a whisper, is this about you and Ned. I didn't want to say that, but what other excuse I could make here. I already embarrassed myself by asking this, might as well go through with it. I slowly nod. Matt asks, you guys are still arguing. I thought for sure it was just a disagreement.

I was too flustered to comment on this, I just want to know how to fix it. I thought I get some tips from you two. You two don't argue a lot, so you must be good enough to avoid any fights. Matt scoffs, don't get fooled. We fight over everything. Just a week ago, I got two different kinds of tart, because Cass and Mel like different ones. I thought it was the right gesture. You know, an thoughtful boyfriend. But hell nah. Cass got angry why I thought it was okay to bring one for Mel. Then I had to physically fight Mel when I told why I got for Cass. Can you imagine we fought for such a ridiculous reason. She didn't talk to me for that whole day. I still don't understand what I did wrong.

Cass flinched away from Matt, are you still hung up on that. You know why I am mad. Matt yells quietly, no I don't. I don't give me that crap about not being considerate of your feelings. I did that because of it. They both glare at each other. I can't tell if this was normal for them, or are they projecting out because I am here. Cass sighs, whatever. It isn't about us. Matt snorts, yeah fine. But we will circle back to it. He turns to me, Vanessa, is it about the bet in the VIP room. I nod in response.

Cass asks, did you guys not talk later. Its painfully humiliating to talk about this. I never had to deal with this, probably because I wasn't in a proper relationship before. I meekly reply, no. He has had ignoring me several times yesterday, so I got so mad that I didn't want to speak to him. He did try to talk before I left the stadium, but I was too angry with him then. Somewhere back in mind I know he tried again by texting Siera. But I was furious at him to mention that indirect attempt. Matt asks, so, you two didn't spoke not today too. I shook my head, I noticed the admins are busy. So I assumed he was too. Probably why he didn't even bother to show up at the pier this morning.

They both look to each other for a moment, then to me. Cass asks, you do know that you won't get anywhere without talking. I answer, I know that. But every time I think of talking, I get angry. Its not just that he didn't back me, he got angry at me. You heard him. He is usually keeps a pleasant demeanor. That's what I like about him. But he got mad just because I wouldn't take his side. That's preposterous. Cass says, look, because we were there, I know what happened. But didn't you also expect the same from him. You wanted his unconditional agreement. So I believe you both are arguing about not taking each others side. Right.

I say, no. He should have taken my side. We supported for David, so he should agree with me. But he got mad at me for choosing something I thought was completely idiotic. In my exasperation, I said out the stuff I wasn't thinking too deeply. They both quietly stare at me. The realization hit me immediately once I understood what I just said. This is the first time I said it out aloud. My anger dissipated suddenly by a somber thoughts. Matt says, don't you think that's a little bit unfair. To Ned I mean. I told us why he thought David was going to lose, right. I mean, I wasn't happy with his explanation, but was just harmless bet.

My thoughts became dismayed wondering what I just said. Was I really so arrogant, wanting him to agree with me always. Regardless of the issue. Cass adds, yeah. I think that's a little harsh. I'll admit, Ned might have been a little out of line. He told why he chose Charles, because of those stats. I didn't like that too. Still, he explained his reasons. Not like it was any intent to discourage or persuade you. I don't think your boyfriend has to agree with you all the time. Like Matt said, it was just a bet to pass the time.

I can't believe I never thought of this. They were making sense. I have been judging him too harshly. Siera also said similar things, he doesn't do things without good reason. Was I really hung up due to this. Matt says, cut the guy some slack, will you. He was a little dramatic, but that shouldn't lead to you not talking for so long. Cass agreed, yeah. Just talk to him. Tell him what you really felt, let him apologies to you and be done with this. Matt scoffs, hold on. Why should he be apologizing. Obviously Vanessa should do it first. Cass snaps at him, ah. No. Ned was too angry when he talked to Vanessa like that. Its obviously his fault. The boyfriend should apologies always.

Matt gets annoyed, says who. If the girlfriend is being unreasonable, she should do it. Cass leans forward, she isn't being unreasonable. The guy didn't understand how she felt. Matt says, how in the hell is going to understand that. He just did what felt right. That's what we always try to do. Cass got infuriated, is this still about that stupid tart. Matt says, tarts, as in two. And its not stupid. It was a nice gesture. She didn't believe that, oh you still think that, don't you. Listen here you.

I zoned out from their conversation. Honestly, I don't think they even realize I asked for their help anymore. They kept arguing about things I wasn't paying attention to anymore. There is obviously still tension about that between them. But then I started to wonder about my feelings. How could I not see this. I was so engrossed with blaming him, I didn't realize I was being unreasonable too. Like Cass said, he was way more angry than me at the moment, but I made it him that way by being unreasonable myself. Uh, god. How can we both mess this up so badly. Is this why he doesn't talk to me. No, its not just about talking. He ignores me.

I think I understand I was in the wrong too. But his attitude on how he handled was heavy handed. Getting mad and then giving me the cold shoulder. Thanks to talking to both of them, I got somewhere. Then I got depressed realizing that something so simple I couldn't see before. All because I couldn't talk to Siera like this before. It really is best to talk to friends about this. I thought I thank them, but they were still arguing. So instead I mentally thanked them.

After few minutes people began to pour into the conference room. After getting some gaze from others, Matt and Cass finally stop arguing. They settle down in their seats with angry silence. I couldn't tell who conceded, or if it was even resolved. A moment later Cass whispers to me, sorry you had to witness that. We kind of got distracted. I smile, its fine. Now I see why Matt said not to get fooled. I was fooled, I thought you both had a steady relationship. She get a little offended, we do. We just know how to navigate it better. Trust me, in the beginning it was worse. David used to help out back then, like mediating for my sake. But he also soon gave up. She chuckles remembering something.

She then says, besides, its probably your first fight. I don't know about others, but I think its always about something silly. I felt a little better hearing that. Because I was mentally kicking myself for not seeing it. She continuous, a tip though. If things gets messy for whatever reason, its not about that. Its about something else. Trust me on that. I was angry about many things at Matt, that was actually towards Mel. So who knows, it might be good to talk about that too with Ned.

This advice turned me upside down. I was just accepting the fact that I was being too judgmental. Now I got to figure out if it had any other reasons. Ah, this is so infuriating. Cass read my expression, you got angry about something, didn't you. Well, before you use it against Ned, just talk to him. Be honest when talking to him, like you did with us. And then, if there is still a need, get angry at him. Do whatever you need to just get it out of your system. I know its not that simple, but its what helps. Don't keep it in for long, otherwise things will spiral of out of control.

She was right. Rationally, that was the right thing to do. But I couldn't do it. Not yet. I nod, thanks Cass. And thank Matt too. I should have talked to someone sooner. She says, don't worry. That kind of thing happens. If you want, you can talk to me whenever you want. She was being generous. I might take up her on that offer. Maybe I ask about David as well. Would she know why David doesn't think I should know about Wagner or why he still doesn't trust me. No, I should stop now. I already shamed myself by asking their help on Ned. I can't ask for more.

I gazed around the room to distract myself. Its half full now. Even though we have over 30 minutes left, people came in early. I guess everyone is anxious to get started. Ruthers, Deni and Somers come in. They notice me and waved siting beside us. Ruther says, hey. Did you have anything to eat, or did you just came over here. He greets Matt and Cass sitting in the front. I sigh, I wasn't hungry. I thought to get some work done here. That wasn't a complete lie, but I am not going to explain the real reason to him. He doesn't dig further, okay. Since you are here, I wanted to give you some reports.

We discussed some minor details about the securities of Citradel guest houses. Without the officials there now, we could lower the number of people assigned. Went over the assigned groups and their shifts. We talked just long enough to hit 12:00. During that time, the seats began filling. Nathan and Jess came in next. Then 10 minutes before, Tessa and Catherine. Then I caught a person coming alone. It was Ned. As we he walked, our gaze met. I thought I should approach him.

What about the meeting. Theres is no time. But he wasn't fazed even a little. The same cold look he gave me yesterday was on him. I thought he would be at least cordial since the last time we talked, he wanted to try talking. But he remained silent, no expression, no gestures. Just an empty stare. Then he walks to the literal opposite side of the room and takes a seat, like it was nothing.

This pissed me off. Screw him. I had thought of asking him to meet later. I was even going to make amends for my part. But he was being cold again. What the hell is wrong with him. He doesn't even want to sit with me. Did he gave up. Does he want me to go begging to him. No, that’s not happening. You and David should just freak off. I didn't want to get angry here, with everyone around me. But I was too distracted. But I can't leave either, that would be just rude. What if someone notices that I left because of him. No, I am not going to him that satisfaction. So I controlled the anger in me and pushed it way down.

5 minutes before Blake, Luther and Marina in tow crossed the doors. With him entering, people stopped their discussion. Luther takes his usual seat near the edge of the podium, managing the conference rooms systems. Marina sits in the front between few officers. They shook hands her congratulating on becoming the latest citizen. Blake takes the center stage after talking for a while with Luther. The room dims and lights focus on Blake. The room system boots up and turns on the mini lights around us. The 3D wire systems turns on with our logo in levitating in the middle of the room. Blake walks in front of it and says, is this everyone. Luther says, I count all 84 are here. Blake nods and faces us.

He says, thanks everyone for waiting. I am sure you know what discussion we need to have today. Its the first day in a soon long days to come. And I not understating it when I say, it’s a beginning of a new era.

Blake (Chapter 62)

Thursday, October 9, 2025 21:51

After leaving David, I had messaged everyone about the meeting. I am worried about David, but there's very little help I can offer him. So instead, I should focus on what I can do. I didn't want to waste any time getting to work. Me, Marina and Luther went to grab some bite from the dining building. Its too early to have lunch, but they had few snacks still left from morning. Usually they don't serve people at this time, but I got a pass. Plus I think the crew understood how busy I was.

Marina was still a little nervous about leaving David alone. She tried to broach the subject few more times, but with Luther around she didn't get far. I understood it was hard not to think about it. But I didn't want her to dwell on it for long. So instead I distracted her by asking what her demands are. Instantly she perks up, really. You will listen to it now. I sigh, yeah, of course. I just didn't want you to talk anyone before me. Her somber expression turn bright and excited.

Luther interjects, just don't ask too much. I know you are very important, but it would show very bad precedent. She nods frantically, yeah I know that. I am not that unreasonable. We both laugh at that. She asks, what. That’s true. Luther says, if that were really true, you would have waited to get our own badge before putting on that uniform. I appreciate your initiative, but you could have waited a day at least. She shook her head, that was an impromptu move. I got excited. Didn't want to waste the opportunity and rub it on Kafar. Or even Melinda.

Luther gives me a curious look, don't ask. Its a long story. Luther heard Marina talking to Melinda on the boat, but he probably didn't understood everything. I say, we will get it issued soon. I already left a message to Tina. You will get it tonight or tomorrow. After you are sworn in as our new citizen. She smiles with stuffing a sandwich in her mouth, nice. She chews fast and says, okay. So here's what I need. I already selected a place in section 1. Near the river. The same line your house is in.

I figured she would want that area. After thinking about it I say, okay. I will have to ask to see if anyone contends to it, or if anyone already claimed it. She says, don't worry about that. No one would have picked it. The ground around the place isn't level. So I bet with what you have already have around the area, it would be difficult to go digging, leveling the foundation and build a house. Luther asks, but you don't have a problem. She says, nope. With the designs I have, and the help we are going from Citradel, those ground inconsistencies are easy to rectify.

I say, that’s all well and good. But we will still ask, just in case. Luther says, even if someone did issue an order to occupy it, I am sure they will back off once they see Marina on the list. Marina smiles gleefully. I scoff, don't encourage her please. I know she may look impressive, but you will soon realize how impulsive she is. Marina tried to say something, but stops herself realizing I was telling the truth. Luther smiles, probably already realizing that too. I ask, what else. She says, I will need a office room in your building. I don't mind getting any floor there. But it would be good if it was on 3rd floor.

It was becoming a trend of her to basically leach of anywhere I work or stay. Its not bad though, being closer meant we could work better. Even if its for our shadow activities. I nod, there is an south wing we planed to open. You can pick a room there. She replies, north wing. That one opens to the city view. I am an architect you know. Need inspiration and work space. She wasn't being unreasonable, so I let it slide. She says, oh, who should I talk to get some home appliances. The ones I have are all Medrone tech based and they don't run properly without consistent kuretines. I think its best to have a backup of your Earth influenced techs.

Luther says, I will share you the contact of team that handles it. Prepare a list of things you want and I will setup a meeting with them. I ask, if there is something very specific, you go to David. He handles all the unique and experimental stuff. She becomes a little nervous when I mentioned him, yeah, I do have some specific things. But he is busy right now, so I will just stick with some basic stuff. We both were worried about David's current state. He probably won't be able to take any new work for a while.

Marina shakes off the quite tone, and finally I want to be enlisted as the high ranking officer. Luther and I already knew that she was going to join us directly at that level. I say, don't worry about it. We already discussed and agreed its best you, Derek, June and the alpha twins join as high ranking officers. They may have not yet officially been matriculated in our city, but when they do, the role is theirs. Marina says a little shocked, wow. I thought there will be some pushbacks, making Citradel people high ranking officers immediately.

Luther scoffs, who said immediately. We agreed those people are best suited to the high roles. But not straight away. To make your and our transition smother, there will be adjustment period. You know, sort of like an intern learning the ropes. You will have conditional authorities. You can make the decisions, but someone else will supervise you and have the final say. Its unreasonable to ask you all to immediately do your jobs here, which is a lot different than Citradel.

Marina takes that in for a moment. She then says, yeah, that makes sense. Then, who is going to be my training supervisor. I answer, that burden falls to me. I would have preferred David to do it, since he also knows you well, but he is occupied right now. Maybe he will take over me later. But for the time being, you and me work together for a while. She nods, sounds good. Then she smiles, boss. I liked the sound of that, but I know she was just teasing. I ask, anything else. She thinks for a long time before saying, I am good. These were my immediate concerns.

I nod, I am sure there will be more. She didn't deny that. After that discussion, me and Luther spent some time discussing about the topics we want to highlight today. After an hour and half we decided to leave for the meeting. Along the way, people were congratulating Marina. She was basking in all this glory. She isn't the only one from Citradel who will move in, but she is the first one. And she knows this, enjoying peoples praises while it lasts.

With 5 minutes to go, we arrived at the conference room. Everyone were here now. I clocked all the essential personals aura. I wanted to check on Catherine and Vanessa. But I can't do it now. So I decided to wait out the meeting first. After Luther setup the rooms system. We got down to business as I take the center stage, first order of business. Give an applaud for Marina, our latest citizen and officer from Citradel. Everyone cheers and claps excited.

Marina got up on her seat, smiling and waving around, thanks everyone. Its finally good to be here, with you all finally. After she settles back down I say, I know everyone is delighted to have her here. In fact everyone in the island is. However, don't forget this is just the start. So we will immediately starting our integration process. There are other candidates for the same job as Marina, so like we discussed, there will be temporary supervisors. Right now, I am going work with Marina. Once other Citradel people join, we will decide who gets them.

People were quite, but I am sure they were wondering who will be picked along with me. I wasn't going to share that right now. So I moved to next topic, lets now talk about the big changes. I think all of us know to some degree what's going to happen. But let me be clear to everyone. I signal to Luther, he changes the 3D hologram to shape of Charles and 9 other Heraknus. I waited for the rendering to complete and say, you know Charles. But we have now confirmed other Heraknus. I point to the holograms, 7 of them, we don't know much about them. No, actually, we don't know anything about them. But these two, I point to Rory and Tory, are his kids.

Some of you saw them this morning, others didn't realize who they are. And apart from this two, Charles has 3 other kids back in Citradel. And other 62 or so Heraknus. Take a note of them, they will be coming here soon. And we don’t want to give them even a single reason of doubt or problem when they arrive. They are vital to get all of Citradel and other communities here. Everyone's been asking if Heraknus coming here also means everyone else are also coming or not. The answer is not that simple.

I let a pause so that it sinks in everyone. Then say, personally, I am 99% sure they would follow. That elicit a range of whispers among the people. I continued, some have talked to the officials. I talked to almost all the officials. They may say they will wait until the next match with David and Charles. Or may show doubt. But I believe its inevitable. Soon enough they are going to realize that deal was the best thing happening to us. The Heraknus alpha was supposed to their undefeated champion. But they couldn't have imagined David's resilience. The alpha even admitted himself. So yeah, with the trust they kept on Heraknus for this long, I don't doubt they will move here. Its just a matter of time.

I see people nodding in agreement. Some were still not sure. Their auras show doubt. But that’s okay. Its to be expected. I continue, I don't want you all to celebrate achieving our goals just yet. Because here comes the crucial part. We had made plans to bring people in course of 4 to 6 months, but not in a month. I can't say for sure if Citradel will send other people or bloodlines by then. But at least some will. So we need to expedite the expansion plan we had. Its not going to be easy. But it is necessary and we have to do it.

I signal Luther to step in now. He walks up beside me and says, take a look here. He pulls out a remote and changes the hologram. The scene changes to the birds eye view of the island. The island was shaded in 3 colors. He say pointing the green one, this where the habitable zone is. We occupy around 30% of it. He then points to orange parts, these are the agricultural lands, water and air treatment with kuretines and other essential factories. Only 15 % operational of this is operational. And finally, he points to the red parts, these are all forest around the edges of the island. We have only developed 2% of this. Considering most of the security lies here, its still manual. We want to make it automated with our tech.

With that explained, Luther leaves and goes back to his chair. I take over, its not realistically possible to develop all these colored regions within a month or so. But we have to make progress in all areas. However, we will focus on each of them differently. We will prioritizing the green zone where we can live. I say about 70 % of our efforts should be on that. Then we will focus on expanding our orange zone, I say roughly 25% and the rest efforts on the red zone.

At that point, someone asked me, shouldn't our efforts be on the red zone be more. More people coming in means we need to increase our defenses. I nodded the guys, that is true. I like to double down here too. But there are two reasons, we can't. Our defense system is not yet operational. We have the tech, but its slow going. If we want it to develop faster, we need new assets. Not just the science and tech, but people too. Citradel is full of more scientists. They joining us will make our progress fast.

After learning about Melinda, I am sure many people we don't even know are going to pop out from Citradel. Some of them should have the means to accelerate our defenses. I wasn't sure about it yet, so that part I kept to myself. I continue, second reason. Right now, the Echo invasion on Earth is in a little bit of scattered. They lost their commander. Either they are waiting for backup, or hiding or both. But in any case, their activity is low if not none. Even Citradel agrees. This was why the tournament was possible in the first place. So what it means is that we have a breathing room. We can hunker down, get ourselves sorted out first before worrying about Echo.

A women asks, that could change any moment. They might arrive before we can detect them. Luther answers this one, if something like that happens, the problem we will face is the same for all others. If we were the ones moving to Citradel, they would also take time to expand their defenses. Just like us. So there's no real solution to that problem, we just have to believe if that happens, we face it together. I nod, exactly. Look, the threat is always there. There is no doubt about it. But its also true for almost a year, we hadn't fought Echos in the scale as the war we just did. The reality is that they are not as active they used to. Is it risk to assume that, yes. But we will take it anyways, because this opportunity is important too.

That may not ease the doubts of everyone, but at least no one asked further about it. I say, instead of worrying about it, lets focus on developing our city. So I was saying before about focusing our efforts, we will prioritize our living zones first. Now, a month time is not enough. But we will start just for Heraknus. Until Citradel tell us, we are confirming only they are coming. So I want them to have a place to live, regardless if any one else comes along and don't have a place.

I clear my throat, now, its just my opinion, but I talked to Charles family and they might want to live in the mountains of section 4. Now, that's not really confirmed. It was just a causal talk. But lets start there. We got Marina now, as you know, she isn't just a warrior, she is an architect. So Citradel sent her to help us fast track the development. In coming days, Citradel will contact us and give us more resources. I heard from a official that they might send a crew to us soon. Once they arrive, we can immediately get down to construction and revamping our infrastructure.

Luther says, simultaneously, we will develop other areas in preparation of other arrivals. But that is a secondary goal, so we will not work on it until we complete Heraknus houses or bloodlines from Citradel come here. I add on, so we are going to split into 3 groups of development team. One focusing on Heraknus housing and one working on the secondary goal. The last team will be working on the revamping of the existing city infrastructure. Before the start of the tournament, Citradel had shared their plans to improve the society. The last team will start working on it immediately. Luther says, we will assign the team soon. But if anyone wants to put up their names, you let me know.

After a few seconds of pause I continue, moving on to the orange and red zones. Like I told earlier, they are not going to be our top priority. We will start working on them after 3 weeks. Once we build up enough of the city's habitable zone, we will expand our manufacturing industry. This team will work on preparing, analysis and procuring assets or resources until then. We may not have any meaningful changes in our defenses. One guy says, not that it matters. With two overdrive users and bunch of omegas here now, we can secure the additional people arriving.

That cheered up many people. Marina laughs too on that comment. I couldn't stop one myself. Luther says, he has a point. Back in Medrine, an existence of an overdrive user is like having a personal army for your country. Hardly there was ever a time in our history where two existed in same country at the same time. And don't forget Charles is coming too. He may not be able to use his overdrive, but his other bloodline members are powerful enough to keep Echo away for a decade. So we decided not to focus on our defenses just yet. And I am sure Citradel will agree with us too.

That encouraged few people here and probably helped understand our reasons. This must be enough to convince others of this course of plan. I continue, after we conclude this meeting, we will immediate start our preparation. Before the end of day, I want teams assigned, ideas outlined and plans listed. We will take suggestions from anyone to advance our goals. I expect it will be a challenge, but it is necessary. Many people nod after hearing my resolve.

I clear my throat, now. There is one last thing I want to discuss. We have talked about Heraknus, Citradel and our city development. But there is one more thing we have to be aware of. Its about the match between David and Charles. Few people get a bit excited to hear about this. I wasn't sharing the same enthusiasm. Because no one knows the true dangers of this. And unfortunately, I can't reveal it to them too. I explain, after talking to the admins a while ago, we concluded that we are not going to treat as part of the tournament. The actual tournament is over with David as the winner. That is undeniable, no matter how much Citradel spin it.

The suspense fills the air in the room, from now on, whoever we talk to, we say we won the tournament when Charles gave up. There will be fight. Now, while Citradel considers David to be a technical winner, its just what they claim. However, I never agreed to it. Did I. For us, David is the true winner. People shout in agreement. I add, The admins have changed the second half of the final match to an exhibition fight. Making it separate from the actual tournament. Reinhart didn't have the entire details when he made the announcement yesterday. But after spending the whole day with Citradel, he understands it better now.

Luther adds, the rally we formed yesterday pushed Citradel to make a decision, but it also pressured admins to not hear our side of it. And after spending the morning discussing, they come to proper resolution. A women asks, won't that just contradict what Citradel said. I answer, a little bit, yeah. That's why admins won't be making that announcement to people until Citradel agrees to it. Honestly, I wanted to tell the reporters this too, but they never asked me about it and I didn't bring it up. I am telling about it now, because it doesn't matter if Citradel argue over it or not. The fact is Heraknus are moving here. They have already lost the tournament. The exhibition match is now really just about David and Charles. That's the undeniable reality.

Luther says, even if David loses, it doesn't change anything. The course we are on remains the same. This deal between the two of them, has effectively ended the tournaments goal to decide which city will be moving where. So there's no point in calling it a tournament match. I say, and this is what I want everyone to say to others once admin announces it. Whether is to other communities, our people or even if they are Citradel citizens. We want to bolster the idea that David already won, and this is just an exhibition match now. There are some things Charles didn't tell anyone yet. So I personally know its more than just a simple fight. I want Charles to explain them once he arrives here.

People began whispering amongst them. I won't share the actual danger to other people not just David. That I leave it to Charles handle it. I say, take some time, think over this and what we talked before. If anyone has question or doubts about this, I'll hear it after the meeting. Does everyone understand this. I didn't see any aura showing any big confusion. So I guess that its time to end it. I say, all right. That's all we had to say. We are get down to work immediately. We will take a break around 4:00 to 4:45, and work until we finalize the points I highlighted earlier. All right, thanks everyone.

I got off the stage while the 3d wire hologram turns off and lights turn on. Luther gets up from his chair, that went well. Not many had issues with this. I answer, yeah. I look towards the officers exiting the conference room. I saw Catherine and Vanessa leaving too. Dang it, I missed talking to them again. I sigh a little. Well, I can't be hypocritical here when I just told everyone we will have busy days ahead. Luther goes to talk to Marina. He got someone to show her the north wing.

I went to my office downstairs and began working on the team goals and requirements. Once Luther and Tina came by to my office, we talked on forming several team options. We had a challenge to make sure we don't make teams bigger than we need. Or making the team too small for the secondary projects. We then began planning the targets and deadlines. Hours flew by on the clock like seconds the more we talked. Around 3:30 PM, Marina dropped by my office. Luther and Tina were typing up the teams on the board at the end, so I signaled her to take the couch on the opposite side. I heard she went to my place to get some stuff after taking a look around the building.

Marina and me sat down. She asks, busy work huh. I scoff, don't worry. From tomorrow, you will be too. She laughs nervously, yeah. I gather. Since the tournament, this building hadn't been buzzing with so many people. But today I got to see everyone working. I knew you guys were working here, but seeing it with my own eyes is different. Decisions are made by high ranked people and others follow. Everything goes fast, but no larger discussion like we have to ensure everything is smooth. You know, make sure no unintended consequences happen. Its almost like you are a company workers.

I laugh at that, you are not that far off. Unlike Citradel, we don't have experience in proper policy making of a actual city council. So we make it work the way can for now. All that changes when Citradel comes on. We will finally have a proper civil infrastructure. She nods in agreement, that it will. I am sure it will be changes and hopefully for the better. I say, yeah. So, you got your office setup. She nods, not completely. Just enough to get started. I wanted to make sure no one takes it, so I added my name to the wall outside. I laugh, of course you did. You had prepared for that too already.

She chuckles, anyways. I know you are busy, so I won't take too much of your time. I do have one thing to pass on. She pulls out her phone and hands it to me. The screen was displaying some list of items. I read them aloud, concrete, crushed stone, slag,, alloys - iron, nickel, aluminum, Fiber - Reinforced Polymers, Hempcrete, Geosynthetics. Is this what I think it is. There were more things written after I scroll down. Each item had the amount needed to next of them.

She answers, yeah. Its the list of things I know we need immediately to get started with Heraknus houses on the mountains. I read few other items that I read with my eyes widening, huh, Platinum 0.5k ton, Palladium 1k ton, Carbon fiber 20k ton, Titanium 2k ton. Aren't these insane amount and very costly. She says, that they are. We need those for enriching them with kuretines. Lower grade elements don't have stability to combine with kuritine. We need some of it for direct applications, some for catalyst.

I put down the phone confused, how did you get this. You are just an architect, right. She smiles, I can pick up other things also. Mom taught me about designing things, but after coming to Earth I had learn other things too. I don't know everything about the process or the tech used, but I know these are some the raw things we need to get started before Citradel sends those specialists people arrive to help us. I am sure they will demand a similar list if not everything. Since you kept saying we need to hurry up, I made this list in anticipation of the things to come.

I was impressed with her, wow. Seems you are already getting down to work. She leans back on the sofa, what do you take me for. I know how important this is. I chuckle, but these things are very hard to come by. We maybe have what, barely any of it. She says, why do I think I came to you instead of anyone else. Theres only one person who can get these in short amount of time from humans without causing too much suspicion. I sigh, realizing she was right. David, he has connections everywhere. To corporations and criminal world. I don't think anyone else has enough pull with Humans to get these things in such bulk quantities.

I say, so we need to talk to him. She shrugs, considering the beaten state he was this morning, I didn't want to add this on top of it. I shared the same concern. She says, he is the only one I know who can get these, but that's still very difficult to procure in short time. I ask, is there anything we can cut down. She nods, I already thought of that. Some things we maybe push it for a later time, but not the ones I listed at the end. They are essential to the kuritine enrichment. This is a problem. I can't find a way around it. I didn't have any clue in this domain. I can talk to the team we have, but if Marina says even David will have hard time, they might not have any luck too. I ask, how soon do you need these.

She says, depends when Citradel sends those people. I nod, okay. I have to assume Citradel wants to fast track that, similar to us. So we can expect people arriving in what a week. She says, maybe less than that. The officials don't need to in Citradel to decide this. I am sure they are already discussing it on the travel. The boats might have reached the mainland by now, but they had hours to talk through. She had a point. There is a good possibility we need this stuff in less than 4 or 5 days.

I sigh realizing there is only thing we can do in such a short time. I say, if we had more time, we could have had our team get it. Maybe they would have to steal from some ore deposit. David's the only one I know who could buy it legally or at least without much detection. I also don't want him distracted. He has already enough to deal this. She nods, I had the same thought. If you also think the same, then maybe its time do it ourselves. I stare at her for a moment. Then I figured out what she said. I take a quick glance at Luther and Tina talking. They weren't listening us, engrossed in their own discussion.

I shook my head slightly whispering, no. Its too early for that. You know as well. We are not ready for an outside excursion. She quietly says, we don't have a choice, do we. I know its still early. But I don't see any other way. I understood the problem here, but this is not the solution. Things are not so dire enough to risk getting exposed. I say, even if we do it. There is no way that no one notices how we were able to get so much materials in short time. I mean, I have no idea how to explain that. Do you.

Her silence told me she also didn't know how. I sigh, we have no choice. We need to ask David. She leans forward, I don't want to. I nod, trust me. Neither do I. We got no choice. Knowing him, he must have a way to pull it off. He build a whole Echo fortress for himself, he has the resources to do it. She wasn't agreeing, but I know she knows it's the only way. I got up from the couch, listen, if there is any other way, we will do it. But for now, David's the only option right now. I don't want to add more troubles to the guy, but he should know how desperate we are.

Marina remained silent. I didn't want her to get distraught more by convincing her, so I left and went to Tina interrupting up their work. I ask, Tina, I need your help with something. She turns to me, sure. What's up. I hand over Marinas phone to her and showed her the list of raw materials on it. I explained her the problem and conclude, we need David's help. I need someone to go over his house and give it to him. Tina takes a moment to go over the list and the last items invoke a similar reaction as I did earlier.

Holy shit. Is this right. Luther looks over her shoulder, are they something difficult to get. She scoffs, try impossible. Getting these things in a month, no, less than a week is simply not possible. I don't know if even David can get it. I know Palladium and Platinum are highly regulated by Humans. There aren't any such mineral deposits lying freely around we can steal from. Hearing from her on the difficultly added to my guilt on taking David's help. Luther says, I didn't know Citradel had access to such resources. Won't they have it, we can ask them to had over.

I shrug, maybe. But I doubt they have everything or the amount we need, otherwise Marina would have mentioned it. Tina gives back the phone to me with a conflicted expression, this is just nuts. Is kuritine enrichment that difficult with materials. Luther says thinking hard, well, we are only doing to the ground, water and air. Logically, it makes sense its hard on things we can't do. Tina says, so we have to have David get these. But won't that make it difficult on him to focus on preparing his fight.

I nod with a somber expression, I know. But we have no choice. Like I said earlier, it will be a challenge. This is the first one. She nods ever so slightly, okay. I guess. Luther asks me, why don't you just send this to David on the network. The reason was not obvious to him. I am very sure he won't be checking his messages or anything else. He must be home by now, but has to be working on getting his kuret to work. I say, I want to make sure he gets it. He must be busy with his, ah, preparation. He might miss out the message. And I know him. Even sending a priority alert may not work, he may turn off the communications on the network. Any other day, I wouldn't worry, but today is a bit different. So trust me, I want to be sure he gets it and see its importance.

They didn't ask for details, probably assumed it was something to do with his dedication to win. Tine says, okay. Ask Marina to send me that list. I will have someone go to his place. I answer, thanks. I turn back to Marina still trying hard to find another way. She looks up to me, I can't think of any way. The team we have in Citradel wouldn't get it either in time. Plus, it wouldn't look good on us if we ask for their help already even before they offer. She is already acting like one of us now.

I gave her phone, I see. Well, there's no options left. Send this to Tina, I have explained her everything. Someone will get in touch with David. She gets up from the couch and says, shouldn't I take it to him. I answer, no. You need to visit the site around the mountain immediately. Survey the land and get some rudimentary blueprints started. Besides, either of us visiting him will stress him out even more. She thinks about it for a moment and says, you maybe to right. Okay. I will send it to her. I say, thanks for taking the initiative so early, getting hit with this later would have been bad. She nods with a small smile and heads out. don't know how David will take this. He might even refuse it. Its possible even he couldn't do it.

I can't think about it now. We resume our work on planning the teams and outlining objectives. Soon the brake came, but I decided to remain in the office. I did tell Luther to get somethings for me to eat later. I spent the entire day toiling in my office and others whenever I needed to. Few issues pops out ever so often. Like we didn't have enough people with some skills. Or people not having enough time to get it done. Some gave suggestion to streamline it. Some worked, some didn't. Wherever we could, I told others to put a pin on it. I didn't want peoples enthusiasm get hampered for too long. We pressed through the discussions, despite some obvious challenges and some not so obvious ones.

However, we were making good progress. By 6:30 PM, we already had confirmed teams with their objectives. Some even offered to join based on their expertise or their kuret effectiveness. In middle of all this, my thoughts kept drifting off to David. I was concerned about the deadline initially, but after Marina told about that issue, I am more agitated now. Around 7:00 PM, Luther comes in to my office. I was working on my laptop, drafting up the team assignment details. He takes the seat in front of me, how's it going. I answer, its slow. I don't know we can do it by tonight. Luther nods, I feel the same. You can never tell the issues that pops out until you see it.

I sigh, we still have some time. Lets try to finish it. I don't want people to leave just yet. We can ease a little bit from tomorrow. He says, that’s what I also been saying to others. We need to get our objectives and timeline set today. He then says, by the way. I got a message earlier about David. That made me stop typing. I close my laptop and focused all my attention on him. He says, apparently Matt and Cass somehow heard we needed to get David a message and they volunteered. They were quite eager, even when it took time from their break. They got back a while ago, but we didn't hear because you and me were both busy in a meeting.

I smile a little knowing the two of them were the only one not talking to him in the morning. I say, I should have told people to let me know immediately. Anyways, what was David take on this. Luther says with a half smile, I am not sure how, but he said he will get it done. He told it will be very difficult, but he can get it in 6 days, counting from tomorrow. He didn't explain how, and they didn't ask. Honestly, neither do I. My tensed body relaxes after hearing that. I slump back into my chair, that’s a relief. I don't know what miracle he will pull off, but lets trust it to him for now.

Then I became even more worried. He already has a more pressing deadline tonight. How does David plan to do it in his current condition. I ask, did Matt and Cass talk anything about how he was doing. He was being cocky in the morning for peoples sake, but I know he is stressed out. Luther says, I don't think they mentioned anything concerning. So I guess David is okay. Is there something else going on with him. I wave my hand, no. Just curious. Either David figured it out his kuret. Or he hid it from them. Well, either way I can't do much about it. I can only hope he recovers from his hang ups.

I didn't even leave for dinner, had it delivered to me instead. I didn't want to relax until I got everything done. After three more hours of grueling work, we finally got everything sorted out. I stretch my body in the conference room. I was in a discussion with Luther, Tina and 8 other officers we selected to be in charge of managing the teams. I take the seat on the front row and straighten out my legs, its finally done. Luther says exhausted, well, not completely, but its enough for now. Tina says, thanks guys. You now know your teams and assignments. We will meet tomorrow again for a short briefing. Everyone were tiered, but they all agreed. One guy asks, we made some good progress today, didn't we.

I answer with a smile, yeah. We did. Its going to a rough start for few days, but it will get easier. Even I can't keep up like this for long. Tina chuckles, no one can. I nod cracking my neck and shoulders, have others left the building. Luther nods, yeah. The last group of people left around 20 minutes ago. I nod, okay. I guess that about does it. Thanks everyone for being here. I will see you all tomorrow. With a quick back and forth byes, only I remain in the conference alone. I hoped to meet at least Catherine before leaving. But I guess its not in the cards.

I couldn't meet Vanessa as well. She was called for something an hour ago. Some people had a brawl in section 3. She was called because one was an alpha. This is not what I needed to hear. More problems, something not even related to Citradel, Heraknus or David. I turned on my phone. As soon as I opened it, I saw bunch of miscalls. I sat up straight and unmuted my phone. There were dozens of messages and voice messages from Vanessa and Tessa. I got concerned. I quickly dialed up Vanessa on speaker.

After few ringing tones, it connects. I ask, Vanessa, I just saw your calls. I had to keep my phone muted. She sounded a little bit distracted, you still in the officers building. I answer, yeah. I just finished my work. There were hustling in the background. I heard people talking and lot of noises. She says, I figured that was the case. I was waiting for you to call me. Since you are done with your work, we need you for some time. I got curious, for a brawl. I heard there was some alpha involved, but is it really important. Can't we do it tomorrow. Everyone is exhausted.

She was exasperated for some reason, believe me, I also didn't want to involve you. But it escalated more than just a brawl. I ask puzzled, what the hell happened in just an hour. She says, it didn't happen now. The patrols initially reported noises and kurets sparks in section 3's water treatment plant. They thought it was just a brawl with an alpha they assumed from the kuret levels. But by the time I arrived there, it wasn't just that. We have dozens of people lying unconscious in the basement. Among them are 2 alphas and one dual kuret user. All 3 were warriors from the tournament.

I jump out from my chair, what. I can't believe this happened tonight. She adds, and I got to know from Tessa some time ago, there appears to be some sort of smuggling also involved now. Freaking shit. The hell is going on.

Blake (Chapter 63)

Saturday, October 11, 2025 01:05

A thin line of people were surrounding the kuritine barrier around the plant building. People have already heard about it. I should have been here earlier. Hopefully, others have taken appropriate measures. I can't believe such a thing happened just a day after the tournament ended. The only good news was that the Citradel officials left this morning. We can't have any sort of domestic problems involving warriors now. And based on the very little details I heard from Vanessa, this also involves smuggling. I girt my teeth, we did have some reports about things sneaked in the island, but this is the first time so many people are hurt because of it.

I glide in the air to the entrance where couple of officers were guarding the doors. With a swift decent, I land in front of my and dispel my kuret. I hurry and cross the thin barrier separating the people and the door. Two officers were in front of the door. They were patrol officers in their uniform. One of the them says, Thanks for coming, Blake. He points to the door, Tessa and Roland are inside. Adam, take him to the basement. I nod while going inside, thanks. Adam takes the lead in front of me and we walk inside.

We both walk to the right end of the ground floor and take the stairs. As we walked, I saw signs of struggle, broken crates, crack on walls and the floor. The destruction wasn't severe, but I could tell that people fought aggressively. It wasn't a small fight. I ask, tell me what happened. I only got a very brief report. Adam replies, all I know that there were 13 people lying unconscious when we arrived. All of them in the basement. Apart from 3 warriors, rest everyone were regular citizens. Additionally, there was a small kid was the one who alerted us. I saw a broken railings as we cross the lower basement stairs exit doors. The room opens to a big subbasement with machineries places all around the area. The damages were more severe here. Shattered glassed across on the floor, some walls were broken with holes in it.

The scene was chaotic here. This was a whole gang figh. We cross the first room and entered the second one that was humming with noise and vibrations. He says, I don't know who they are. But I did hear on the secure network that everyone have been taken to the detention center. We have been asked to secure the place until the security team finishes analyzing the main area.

This wasn't the place where it started. Just how big of a fight was this. I had so many questions, but I had to wait until I arrive where others are. A while later we reached the origin of the chaos, a large empty room with a hanger on the other side. There weren't any machines here, just a underground hanger and a driveway. This room is probably where we carried and installed machines from outside. There are several kuritine drones in the air flying and throwing a scanner light on large room. Several officers were moving and using their kuret all over the place.

The fight clearly started here, because the place is destroyed. The side pillars were broken, debris all over the place. I stepped around the debris and blood stains on the ground. The floor had cracks spreading out from a corner. People had surrounded it with some equipment stands that were throwing lights over it. I finally approach to Tessa, who was talking to some officers. She notices me and dismisses others, Blake. Thanks for coming. I know you are already tiered from all those meetings. I wave my hand a little frustrated, never mind that. Fill me in.

She nods and points me to 3 crates standing near the hanger driveway. She says, I assume you already heard about the unconscious people we found. We suspect that they all came with this. We walk over the opened crates. I peek inside them. All three have the same items stacked inside. I ask incredulously after seeing the contents, are you telling me this all was caused because of this. Boxes of smuggled booze. This must be a joke. I hurriedly inspected the other ones. They also have bottles of alcohols inside filled with hay to protect it.

A mans voice looms, its not what you think. I turn to the guy walking to us. Tessa says, Blake, meet Roland. He is the primary on this. We both shake hands, thanks Roland for taking point. He smiles a little, its not everyday I get to see this. This might the biggest incident we have seen ever in the past year. I ask, this is madness. I still am confused on how this could cause a fight. You said something earlier, what is it. He picks one of the bottle and gives it me. From the scotch label and year model 1850, I made a guess, is this some expensive bottle or something.

He says, or something. Do you see anything. I don't know what he means. I took a closer look, even used aura to search for any kuret influence. But there were none. Its a plain human scotch bottle. Roland says, we also didn't see anything wired about it. Then we tested the contents from the broken bottle there. He points to a wet pillar that had broken pieces of bottle lying on the bottom. He explains, its not just alcohol. It has a bunch of drugs dissolved in gel.

My eyes sharpen at that. I take glances on the wet surface and then to the bottle. I ask, what kind of drugs. Tessa answers, the human kind, Methamphetamines. They are can be used to make variety of drugs. I got curious, but what's the point smuggling this inside. This doesn't produce the same effect on us like it does on Humans. Tessa nods, most drugs just has a temporary numbness before out bodies dissolve it. Roland says, we don't know the reasons. But seeing the quantity, its probably the reason why people fought. I ask, are all the bottles filled with it. I place the one in my hand back inside the crate.

Roland says, we haven't checked, but a cursory glance shows that some are actually genuine. One of the officer used his kuret to enhance his smelling sense and found a couple of bottle on the top row with no drugs. So I believe they smuggled the drug, using the actual bottles as cover. No bottle shows any abnormality when scanned with our usual kuret detection, they carefully added to this fool in case of actual liquid inspection. I take a quick look at the size of the crate, how much drugs are here. Tessa says, we have to check the boxes, but if we assume 2/3rd are actual drug bottles, and in all 3 boxes, its probably around 130 pounds.

I shook my head in distraught, all this for a bunch of drugs. I never imagined there be what, a drug war here. Roland says, that’s not the case. What kind of war ends with the merchandise being left behind and everyone knocked lying on the ground. When you came from the front door, you saw all the destruction along the way, right. The fight long the exit path, not the kind you see in a gang war. Most likely people were trying to escape, but they were dragged inside. We found drag marks on the floors nearby.

I say, maybe something else was stolen then. Did you check the entire place. Tessa says, we did. We have been scanning the entire plant, all the rooms, the control center, the machinery room, everywhere. Nothing is stolen. And these crates are filled to brim with bottles, there is no space to hide anything. Rolands adds, we did x-ray of the box and found no any evidence of disturbance to the lower parts. I ask, so nothing was else hidden or stolen from the create. Nothings missing from the plant too.

This doesn't make any sense. I look around the place seeing the debris, and yet there was a big fight here. This is a mess. Tessa says, we don't know who were fighting whom. This area is not under any camera surveillance. Besides the people we know, we can't tell how many were here. Roland says, we found the kuret signatures of all the 13 people all over the plant. But that’s it. We didn't find anyone else. I ask confused, does that mean those people fought among themselves.

Tessa nervously smiles, the evidence seems to say that. I ask, what about the kid. Could he have done this. Roland shook his head, he is 13. He isn't even a alpha. There were two alphas and one dual kuret user. He couldn't have done it. I didn't want to tell him there were exceptions. A shadow at his age could do it. Tessa says, he was the one who reported it. When the first patrols got here, we was saying to save her sister. He wasn't injured, but his sister had a major one. He and his sister are also in the detention center until we figure out how they are involved here.

Nothing makes sense. Roland says, I do have a theory. We both look to him. He says, its possible a sudden internal conflict happened. The kid was worried about her sister, so we didn't get much out of him. But he said few things like deals and breaking. I think a group within the people rebelled for some reason. And I think some escaped. Somehow they hid their kuret imprints. His theory had some ground, those people fought 3 warriors. All decently powerful people.

I pondered on this. Some powerful Medrones were involved in a strange drug smuggling gone wrong. Its more likely than a gang war. I ask Tessa, I am sure you have the videos of the scene from the patrol officers. Show it to me. Tessa pulls out her tablet from her pocket and hands it to me, they entered through the same way you did. I hit the start button. The video begins with officers running in the front door. The kid was also with them, the other officer was carrying him. They followed the exact same path I took. The kid was telling them the direction, hurry. She is bleeding out, he wails.

The officers rush to the scene. One says, shit. What happened here. Quick, report in. We need get others here immediately. All around people in jackets and hoodies were lying on the ground. The place I am standing now was littered with unconscious people on the ground. The kid breaks away from the officer and drags himself down to a bloodied body. He cries out, Elina. Wake up. Come on. I brought help. The other goes to inspect the area, check her. I will look around for any other person.

The officer crouches down and moves around on the women lying on the ground. There was a big cut on her left shoulder, where she bled all over herself. The officer says, what happened Ryan. How did your sister get injured. But the kid ignored him and kept trying to push Elina's unconscious body, no. no. Please. Wake up. Come on, do something. The officer begins inspecting her body. The camera views changes to her entire body. Then he pulls out the dress from the shoulder wound. The stained cloth was sticking to her body, but he slowly cleared that part. The camera catches a large wound, scaring from her collar bone to her neck. The women wasn't moving, however, the wound wasn't pouring out blood now.

The officer says, thank the kuret. This is good. Ryan, your sister will be fine. She is already healing. The would is not healed, but she isn't bleeding. Your sister is just sleeping. Ryan cries louder now hugging her sisters neck, Elina, you are going to be okay. You are going to be okay. The kid remained hugging her sister. The officer stands up and takes a look around. He walks around, shining a kuret light on the ground. The people lying on the ground were scattered everywhere. He looked around the entire room, but no one else was awake.

☐Soon the other officer comes in. He asks him, did you find anything. The other officer says, I checked the entire plant, there's no one else. Is she okay. He answers, yes. Thankfully her heal steady. The other one says, what in the hell happened here. Did the kid say anything. He says, he didn't. He isn't leaving her sister. We might have to wait for a while before he tells us. Suddenly the other officer says, hey. Isn't this cory, the alpha. What is he doing here. The camera points to a body. They roll him on his back and clear the dirt on his face.

It is him. I also vaguely recognized him. He says, holy shit. Yeah. It is him. They checked his pulse, just unconscious. What is going on here. The other says, no clue man. Quick, check the others. They both began checking the other unconscious people. Their big breaths were filling the muffled Ryans sobbing noises in the background. Some were lying in uncomfortable positions, they didn't move them much, just their heads. The camera points to another familiar faces. The officers bellows, I know this one too. He is Quinten, he is an alpha from Citradel.

After a while, the third person is also identified by the other officer, freaking shit. I know this lady. Polly, the dual kuret user. What is she doing mixed up in this. I recalled her too. She is someone who came from outside community. They continues checking the other identities. But like them, I didn't recognize anyone else. Nor there were any other alphas here. Just those 3 people among everyone were warriors. I stopped the video here. I ask, nothing changes since then.

Roland says, yes. We closed off the plant. No non-essential person has been in or not. And like I said, nothing missed either. This just gets crazier. I say, that alpha Cory. Isn't he the one that can manipulate light. Tessa says, yes. And the other one, Quinten, he is from a bloodline that can rot anything with kuret. Polly can control temperature around a place, make it lava hot or ice cold. All of them were in the tournament, in top 1000. So not so easy people to knock out.

Roland says, as you saw, their faces and bodies have physical altercations. So whoever was fighting them were not using any metaphysical kuret. I ask, and no other Kuret signature on them. He says, we moved them to the hospital immediately, so we can't definitely say. But a preliminary kuret scans showed only kuret signatures of the other people involved. That’s why I believe they fought each other. Tessa says, I still can't believe those 3 were knocked out, even if they were fighting 9 normal people. And what about the women, she was hurt badly. How is she or her brother mixed up in this. Roland says, we will know more when those guys wake up.

I have a proper understanding of the situation now. I hand over the tablet to Tessa, you said we don't have surveillance here. What about the area outside. Tessa says, still canvasing. So far we haven't found anything. IDF are reviewing the recordings as we speak. We should have something in some time. I take a look around the place. The people lying on the ground from the video left body prints all around us. I ask, since no one saying it, let me say it. Do we think people were stopping a drug gang or they were one themselves.

They both remained quite. Tessa says in a low tone, only the these people can tell us. I am here just taking control of the scene. You should head to IDF if you want to talk to them. Some of them may be awake by now. I nod, that's probably the only thing we can do right now. I turn to Roland, tell me what your plan to do next. He clears his throat, we scan the entire plant, leave no room unchecked. Look for any other kuret signatures. Then I will take these crates to the IDF and have them analyzed. We are going to find out if its one drug or others also mixed in. Then we will be expanding our search area. This part of the section 3 is a little remote from population. We will check the roads leading here, see if can figure out where these crates came from and who brought it.

He then turns a little hesitant. He looks to Tessa who stares with a question in mind. I ask, what. He says, I need your permission to search their homes of these 13 people. It may be a little presumptuous, but either these people smuggled drugged in or at least knew about it. That's a big ask. I understood why Tessa and Vanessa wanted me to come here first. They wanted me to see this myself. I gave this a long thought. I arrived at a decision, okay. But only question their family or the neighbors. No intrusive search. I will allow for only questioning. I don't want this to blow up until we know more.

Roland nods, that's fair. We have noted all the 6 bloodlines the people belong to. Their home addresses and their jobs, we will hit all those places. Most of the places would be closed. Can we at least search them. I thought about it. Then say, only if you find evidence. Like a surveillance camera, DNA or their exact kuret signature. Otherwise, just close it off for the night. He agrees with me, we can do that. I turn to Tessa, anything else you want to tell me. She says, that's all we got for now. I will keep you and IDF updated on anything we find.

I okay, thanks. Send me the names, kurets, and their jobs to me. I want to know exactly who the other guys are. She says, done. I moment later, a message pops in my phone. I check to confirm. All 14 identities are listed here. I push it back in my pocket, I will go to IDF and see if anyone is awake. I leave them both here and head out. While I climb up the stairs I try to figure out how to deal with this mess. One silver thing is that most people are in their home right now. So we have time before this news spreads to the entire island. We need to resolve this before sun comes up.

I step out of the plants door and immediately took off. I felt a little bit of my kuret wavering. My mind and body was tiered from working all day. Personally, I was so ready to sleep. But the rush is pushing me on. This complicated situation has to be resolved immediately, maybe even before Citradel hears about it. There are still many Citradel people here, they can easily report it to them. I sigh thinking of the issues we will have to face if they use this incident to stop Heraknus from moving here. Since both the communities were involved, the chances of that is not exactly low.

In 10 minutes I reach the IDF building. From above I could see many auras moving around the building. I land near the road. The people outside see me and give way. I climb up the stairs to the main building. I recognized one officer, Somers. He comes rushing in, Blake. I heard from Tessa you were on your way here. I will take you to others. I nod and follow his way. We crossed rooms where people were walking around and working on their desks. I asked, I am up to speed with the situation. So is anyone awake.

He answers, yes. We forced the 3 main people to wake up. They are being questioned for some time now. I was a little relieved and anxious at the same time. I ask, what are they saying. He says nervously, we have them in sperate rooms because they refuse to explain. I shout back, seriously. A depressed thoughts loomed on me. Are they really involved in those smuggled drugs. He says, they only said they don't know anything. I yell, what the hell. Did they loose memories or something.

He shrugs, I am not exactly sure. Vanessa and Ruthers would know more. This is spiraling out of hand. A while later we reached the detention center. Somers says, they are inside the room. Just head straight in. I nod. He begins to leave, but I stop him, wait a second. Sorry, but I need a favor. He turns to me. I ask, I had a very long day. I need something to drink to keep me focused. Bring me some coffee kuritine or something if you have here. He frantically says, absolutely. I got you. There is one in the cafeteria. I'll get it for you. I appreciated that, thanks. Sorry for the trouble. He waves off saying, not a problem.

I head inside the room. I haven't been here from quite some time. Stuff have been changed around, new offices and desks have been pulled inside. There are less people here compared to outer rooms. I guess only higher ranked officers are allowed here now. I caught sight of Vanessa standing in front of a kuritine blue barrier. I hurried to her. She notices me approaching, removes her crossed arms, Blake. Glad you are here. I scoff, trust me, I would rather be sleeping. She nods, you and me both. We had a long day already. She turns to the barrier, but we can't ignore this.

I follow her gaze and see the person sitting inside. Its Quinten. He was sitting in a single chair with her arms bound on top of the table in front. His arms were bound by kuritine cuffs. I immediately yell, why is he detained. She says, believe me, I had no choice. There was an incident before you came. Cory woke up and was being uncooperative. He actually tried to escape. The guy actually had the gall to attack the nurses and guards In his room. Sommers tried to him, but there's was a brief struggle. So I had to step in and rough him up.

I shouted, freak, this escalated too quickly. Vanessa says nervously, I didn't wanted to do this, but I can't have a rouge alpha running out of here. So I ordered to tie him down. I clutch my hands to my head. The drowsiness I was feeling was completely gone. This can't be happening. I ask her, and that's why Quinten is locked up too. She nods, they also weren't being cooperative, but since Cory tried to escape, I didn't want another incident. So I have them tied all up.

I pull out hands and shook my head. This is bad. No, its worse now. The small hope I had to resolve this peacefully was gone. I ask, did you try talking to him. She sighs, I tried. None of them is talking. And since they are warriors, I am not letting anyone else inside with them. Right now, only me, Ruther or you can handle them. I sigh, this isn't what I was hoping to hear. We both silently stare at the imprisoned Quinten. If they aren't going to talk, then there is someone else we can talk to.

I ask, what about the kid Ryan. His sister should be okay now. Is he talking. Vanessa says, we tried. But he isn't leaving her until she wakes up. He is refusing to explain too, saying he doesn't know anything. I cursed internally, look. I know its not ideal, but we need to talk to him. She nods, I know. I also tried, but he wasn't listening. She then thinks for a bit, maybe you'll have a better luck. I nod, yeah. I will do take anything I get right now. We need clarity.

She leads me to the adjoining room where the siblings were resting. The women, Elina was now in a kuritine gown which was stimulating her healing. Ryan was sitting beside her in a chair. Deni was also sitting in a corner chair. She stood up at our entrance. I ask her, any update. She says, nothing. She is just unconscious. Her wound is almost healed now. We didn't want to force her up, so for now we are just waiting. I gave a subtle nod and walk to Ryan. He was still wearing the same dress I saw him in the video. He looks up to me, gets a look of surprise. But doesn't say anything.

I say, Hi Ryan. I am Blake, but you already know that. Don't you. I tried a gentle prob, but he didn't respond. He turns back his gaze to his sister. I take a seat beside him, your sister will be fine. You know right. The doctors say she just sleeping. He doesn't reply to me. I make a tense look at Vanessa and Deni. They both had their own trepidation about this. I sigh, look Ryan. We just want to know what happened. That's all. People are anxious here, but you can help. So why don't you help me out here.

He remained silent yet. This isn't going anywhere. I stood back up and went to others. I signal Vanessa to follow me outside. Deni stays inside. Vanessa says, he is in a shock. Its not his fault. I reply, I know. I am not saying it is. But we can't just wait. Soon this will spread all over the island. We can't have people carelessly spreading rumors about a drug gang war. She asks, I am open to any suggestion. I take a peek inside the room to the woman unconscious.

I say, the 3 people we woke up are not cooperating. Neither is the kid. But what about her. Considering she was the only one injured, she must have some idea. She looks at Elina, you want to force her awake. I nod hesitantly, yes. If I wasn't desperate, I wouldn't ask this. But you all have been at this for almost 2 hours and still no clue. I can't let it delay like this much longer. Vanessa asks, I understand. Honestly, I wanted to this also. But I just felt concerned for the kid. He might resist us doing anything. He was struggling to remain outside when we carried her in. He isn't going to leave her side.

I nod, I saw the video of the scene. I can understand the shock he is in. But I am not going to wait this out more. His sister is fine, he is fine. His aura was already feeling exhausted. Lets make him asleep. You must have someone here who can do it without the kid knowing. Vanessa looks a little bit anxious about this. I felt her aura flicker a little. I wait for her to choose this too. I don't what she was concerned about. The talk of Wagner could be making her sentimental. A moment later she says, fine. I don't know what else we can do. The guy who can wake people up and also make them asleep.

I recalled this particular kuret, he is from that Zeld bloodline then. She says, yeah. I will get him. I saw him checking on the other unconscious people earlier. I reply, great. Thanks for understanding. She nods and leaves me to find the person. I decided to check the other two imprisoned people. They both were held in similar fashion. Polly was actually beaten the most. She had cuts and wounds all over her body. He clothes bloodied and torn. She was in the top 124. For her to be soundly beaten, they must have ganged up on her.

But that's what puzzling. Its not just her, Cory and Quintin were also roughed up pretty bad. Roland and Tessa didn't find any other people in the area, and the other people were also knocked out along with them. How did those group of people defeat them and remain undetected. How small of a group were they to do this to them. And a group who just left 3 boxes crate worth of drugs. My thoughts gets cut in when Somers approaches me with a cup in his hand, here you go.

I gladly took it from him, thanks a lot Somers. He waves, no sweat man. I didn't wait to see if it was hot or cold. Or even what it was. I just gulped it down my throat. It was a coffee at just the right temperature. The caffeine mixed with kuritine soothed my throat. The scent also helped me focus out a little. Somer says, hits the spot doesn't it. I laugh wiping off my lip, that it does. Suddenly, the door opens. Two people walk in. Its good that I just had a coffee to keep me awake, because the one of the two people who walked in were actually banned from this place.

Everyone here were curiously looking at the two of them. I dash in front of the person, Nathan, you are not allowed in here. His answer was just a smile.

Vanessa (Chapter 64)

Sunday, October 12, 2025 00:54

I was so ready to get back home. Spending whole day in the officers building was draining. Blake had given us orders for the day. I couldn't disobey his order when he himself was working till late. I didn't want to skimp out just because I had a rough day. Though I spent the whole day here, Ned and I somehow managed not speak a single word to each other. My anger towards him had never went down ever since he walked in the room. He kept giving me the cold shoulder. I can't believe he didn't even care to even try to approach me after the meeting was over. He just walked out with the same expression he came with this morning. I kept a small hope that we would talk it out, like Cass and Matt had suggested. But that never happened. I was about to loose it in the officers building when I stepped out the conference room.

Fortunately, work kept me going. I poured all my focus into assigning the teams and giving tasks to the IDF crew. I don't know what I would have done if wasn't keeping myself busy. When break came, I went with Tessa and Catherine to get some snacks in the dining building. I didn't even bother to seek out Ned or wait for him. I initially thought to decline Tessa's offer to join them. But then I thought it would be better to stay with people instead of being alone with my thoughts. Even if I didn't resolve my issues with Ned, talking to Matt and Cass helped me sort out some of my feelings. Honestly, I am still embarrassed that I had to talk about my relationship issues to others. But despite that uncomfortable feeling, it did help me.

Thankfully, those two didn't broach the subject of Ned or David with me. I was more than happy to discuss about the upcoming plans and the work that’s soon coming to pile up in our future. Tessa sighs after we finished eating, we were preparing for this for a long time, but its still all so sudden. Its surreal that we are already preparing to lunch a full scale expansion the day after the tournament is over. I am sure everyone was feeling the same as her. I say, but you know what, its actually good we are doing it without wasting any time. I was always skeptical how the this transition would be. Whether we were moving to Citradel or they were coming here. It would have been slow and long.

Tessa says, you say that, but I feel the same what the guy in the meeting called out, I am not sure how safe it will be without our security upgrades. We are going to let people in when our defenses are not yet fully operational. I understand the stakes and what Blake explained. But I am not sold on it. Echo might use this opportunity to attack us. We had been talking about it for a while now. Its not like I don't understand the risks, but I do feel it’s the correct move. I answer, we are taking a risk by rushing, I won't deny that. But we got strong people now. Like Luther said, we can protect the island ourselves.

Tessa remained unconvinced. She slumped back into her seat. Beside me, Catherine just silently looked at us, and didn't utter a word. She had been not participating in our discussion as her usual self. Something is going on with her. I tried to prod her, what do you think Catherine. You might know the situation much clearer than most. She looks up to me in a strange look. Like she was herself not sure. She answers, I am not sure. I leave it up to others to decide. I'll just follow Blakes lead here. He knows what he is doing.

That was probably the most impartial view she can have on this. I am sure something is bother her for some time. She and David spent time this morning, that I am sure of. Something must have happened then. She seems a little off, like she is just going with the flow. I am not going to question it though, since I am almost doing the same. Tessa says, don't get me wrong. I also will support whatever everyone decides. Its just my opinion. I nodded, its fine. I am sure many have the same concerns. All we can hope that nothing happens during this transition. I feel we deserve some break after dealing with so much crap from Echo and humans.

Tessa smiles and agrees. After talking a little bit more, Tessa got a call, it seems I have some stuff to get to before our break is over. I will see you all in a bit. We both see her off while we decide to head back to the officers building. There was an awkward silence between the two of us now. Tessa might have invited me, but I get the feeling Catherine didn't want to be here too. I decided to check up on her now since we were walking a bit away from anyone that could hear us.

I ask, Catherine. I didn't want to ask this before, but are you all right. You seem off the whole day. She didn't turn to me, just answered snarly, I could say the same for you. I can tell you wanted to be alone too. I wasn't expecting her to hit back like this. I felt a little prong in my throat. I shouldn't have asked her this. Of course she would also realize my sour mood. We both walk in silence now. A while later she speaks up, sorry. That didn't came out harsh. She felt a little guilt, but honestly, she was not wrong. Who am I to intrude on others when I don't want people to do it to me.

I shook my head, no its fine. Everyone has bad days. I hesitantly added, I just thought to ask since you and David met this morning. You did say yesterday during the match you were a little angry with David. Did he said anything to you to make you upset again. Honestly, I was hoping for it. I know that makes me a bad friend, but I wanted to commiserate in our shared anger at that bastard. She pulls a small smile, I'll tell you if you tell me what he said to you that made you mad at him just before his interview.

She got me. I wasn't paying attention to others when I was catching David lying to me. I might have made a scene in front of others without realizing. Now I was the one who shut down. I have zero mental capacity to talk about David and his constant need for secrets and distrust. She picked up on that, just like you, I don't want to talk about it. She pauses for a bit, at least not yet. I completely understand her emotions. It was a weird situation that both of us have issues going on with the same person.

She then spoke up, but I will at least tell this. She turns to face me with a serious expression and says, I am not mad at David anymore. We did talk yes, he told me things maybe I shouldn't have known. I was surprised she opened up a little. But what does that mean. I ask curious, I don't understand. She doesn't clarify it, I am just saying he doesn't hide things from others for no reason. I am not justifying the way he did it, but I at least understand it now that he was being considerate. I am clueless now. I thought she was still angry at David like me. But instead she says it’s the opposite, she is defending him for whatever r believe a word he says. He lies so cleverly that you never realize he is manipulating you. He just said what you wanted to hear. Catherine makes a exhausted laugh, I would have actually preferred that to be true. She closes her eyes for a second and then opens them to me, I don’t think he lied. I get you what you mean, he does that often. So its like the boy who cried wolf. I think he didn't tell me everything. She ponders hard for a second, no. I know he was still holding back some things from me. But after mulling over it for some time now, I think its better to not know. I don't know how I might feel if he told me everything.

This made me angry. David got to her. I shook my head, don't just forgive him. He doesn't deserve that. I spat out that without hesitation. She look a little shocked seeing me this vile. She says in a quite tone, I am not completely sure what's going on between you two, but all I can say is give him a chance. I shook my head, I already did. He never learns. And its not just about me and him. You know the whole truth about the deal between David and Charles. He didn't listen to me or Blake before deciding to take it. He didn't ask anyone else's opinion. As soon as he heard my brothers name, it flipped a switch in him. And then I hear ridiculous lies about my brother, which I am sure David knows about it.

I realized I went on a rant and disclosed something I shouldn't have. Catherine eyebrows raises at me, what about your brother ?. I stop myself from saying anything more. I don't want to dishonor my brother's memories. I quickly added, its something personal. Lets just leave it at that. She must have understood my feeling because she didn't ask about it. I continue, what I mean is David has changed. He thinks its okay to lie if its for good reason. That’s just crazy. You might have forgiven him. I will not. I am sure he is keeping stuff from us we don't even know about. He hid his house, his reasons for accepting the deal, and keeping things from both of us. That’s beyond kindness. He doesn't trust us one bit.

Catherine remained stunned by my claim. She didn't refute it, but she didn't defend him too. I blabbed too much again. Without talking to Siera, I have been using others as an outlet to blow off some steam. I should be a little guilty, but I don't feel it. I need to warn her David doesn't trust her with truth also. She didn't spoke up again. She was probably too shocked to see me so agitated. I also remained silent, not wanting to embarrass myself further showing her my pitiful state. In a way she was being considerate by not taking anyone's side anymore. We both never spoke again all the way back to the officers building. I thought she would say something encouraging to me, instead we just waved bye without saying anything.

I don't know what I feel about her silence, but at least I was grateful she didn't say anything to stir my emotions again. Once I came back into my office, my focus shifted to my work, which was the distraction I needed to remain functional. Tessa joined us after a while. I had to push my emotions away to make sure she or others don't see my pitiful state. The last thing IDF crew needs is to see their chief going through a personal issue. I continued discussing with Somers and others about the new changes we will be implementing in the IDF for the city. Without progress in our defense capabilities, we need add more patrols and continuous shifts. Everyone knew that meant more working hours, but it can't be helped. All of us signed up for this.

Our discussing and planning went on late till 7:30 PM. That’s when Somers got a alert from some patrol officers about a fight near the plant. I sigh, really. Are people so stupid that they would start causing problems on the first day. I just can't. Somers smirks, I feel you. I still gotta check it out though. It might just be some drunk people enjoying and got carried away. We did get some reports from bars and clubs. Tessa scoffs, but at a treatment plant. What kind of drunk people would choose that location to cause disturbance.
☐Somers shrugs his shoulders, like Vanessa said. Stupid people. I'll take a small team and check it out. Its probably nothing serious. I nod, thanks. And you know what, why don't you all head close to dinner time. And we have pretty much covered all the topics for today. Somers smiles, well, I will take up on that offer. Thanks. Tessa laughs, I was waiting for you to say that. Let me join you Somers. Can't believe today was getting to Tessa too. Well, there was a lot to work today for her too. I agreed seeing I didn't have any issues, sure. Send me the report. Detain those people to the detention center. We will sort that out tomorrow.

With that concluded, Tessa and Somers took 3 people with them and head to the site. Meanwhile I was wrapping up the discussion with the other crew here. Deni comes up to me after a while, hey. Did you hear from Tessa ?. I am not able to reach to her or Somers for a while. I checked the time, huh, its already been an hour. Time flew when all of us were busy. I quickly took out my phone and search for any messages from him. I say, nothing. That’s weird, just how many much time it would take to detain few people.

Deni shook her head, I don't know. I had a report for Somers. I wanted to catch him before he left home, but he or his team hasn't even come to the detention center. This is strange, I thought for sure they already went back home by now. What could have happened at the site that they haven't come back yet. I quickly rang up Somers. He didn't pick up. Then I tried Tessa. After a few rings the line connects, Tessa, what happened. Are you guys still at the treatment plant.

The other side of the line had a lot of hushed noise in the background, the hum of the machines. Tessa says, there's been a development. It wasn't a simple fight like the alert we got. Its much worse. Her serious tone jarred me out of my seat. I shout, what. What's going on. Other's nearby me were surprised to see me react this way. Deni also came closer. Tessa says, I didn't want to contact you until I got some more clarity on the situation. But I guess its best to tell you now.

Then she explained everything to me. My jaw shook loose as I heard about a dozen people lying unconscious and among them were 3 warriors. This is nuts. Tessa says, I called up IDF to send someone here to help investigate. There is signs of damages and struggle all around the place. It wasn't one or two people fighting, there are multiple Kuret signatures all over the place. There are no camera's or any witnesses apart from the people here. We got no clue, so we are going to move all the people involved to IDF. Somers is with them. I suggest you also head over there too.

I click my tongue in frustration. So much for a peaceful sleep. I respond, I'll head there now. I disconnect the call and turn to others, guys, there's been an incident. Everyone had their eyes on me already since I had been so vocal. One women asks, is it about the alert we got. I sigh, yes. Its not looking good. I need everyone to delay their dinner plans for a while and head to IDF. People were whispering and some were cursing. But I couldn't appease them. It was an emergency, we had to handle it.

I already started to walk to the deck. Deni comes behind me, yeah, you go ahead. I am going to gather all the people on the shifts to IDF. I answer back, see if you can send some people to the treatment plant too. She nods,

will do. See you there. I pushed the window door open and immediately gather wind on my feet with my Kuret. In few seconds I took off to the cold night sky and head to IDF. I was mulling over the scattered details I got from Tessa in my mind on the way. We can't let people know about this incident, because it involves both Citradel and Island people. This could effect the Heraknus transition.

Its actually the worst possible time this could happen. Could Kafar be behind it. He did seem like he hadn't given up on his agenda. But why involve his own people then. Best not to jump to conclusion about this right now. Few minutes later I arrive at IDF. I land near the entrance, which was had 4 trucks in front now. Ruther saw me coming, and came from the IDF building, great timing. We just got all the people to the clinic and detention center.

I nod as we walk inside. I ask, is anyone injured. He hesitantly says, well, everyone are hurt, expect for a kid. My eyes widen at that, what. There's a kid mixed up in this too. He sighs, he is. I don't know how though. He did call for help. This just kept getting worse. He then hands me a pad with a video paused, this is the footage of the patrol officers arriving on the scene. I played the whole video from the start. My shock continues to add on as I see so many people lying unconscious. Then finally I learned the names of the 3 warriors.

I spat out incredulously, is this a joke. Two alpha warriors and a dual kuret user. All in or around top 100 ranking of the tournament. How did they all get knocked out. Who attacked them. He says, we have no clue. But Somers says they have Kuret signature of each other on their wounds, so as ridiculous as it sounds, they fought each other. I scoff at that idea, what possible reason could they have. Ruther then pulls out his phone and shows me a picture of the scene, its possible its about this.

It was a image of some creates lying in the middle of the concrete floor. One of them was opened and showed liquor bottles stacked inside. That just added more confusion to the scene. He then says, its not what you think. He proceeded to explain about the drugs mixed in with actual bottles. At this point I put my hand on my chin and close my eyes exasperated. Are we really dealing with a drug smuggling in the middle of an important Medrone society formation.

At that point I had no choice but to call Blake. I pulled up my phone and called him. But he didn't pick up. I tried again, Ruther says, if you are calling Blake or Luther, forget it. They all still in a meeting. We checked. We wanted to first loop you in before them. Well, that’s probably the right call. As I walked into the inner room of IDF I hear a commotion from inside. There was a lot of noise and loud pounding noise. Ruther and me almost sprinted towards the source. He shouts, what the hell.

Just then I caught strands of Kurets coming from the wall. The door opens with loud bang and two people come out. It was Somers and Cory . I scream, what is, but my voice cuts off when I see both of them fighting. Cory was using his Kuret on Sommers. The air between them was turning grey and dull. Wait, that’s his Kuret that rots. Somers in return uses his Kuret to harden himself to avoid the rot hurting him. I rush to them with my Kuret ready. I shout out, what the hell is going on here.

My loud voice caught both their attention. Cory was injured. Did Somers to that. No, I just saw the video recording. He had injured when he was unconscious. Is he for real. He is trying to fight in his state. He takes one look at me and says, shit. He immediately changes his posture and turns his back to me. Somers seeing this dashed ahead, he is trying to escape. Stop him. I understood what happened. This crazy guy woke up and trying to escape.

Sommers puts his arm on Cory's shoulder, but he got an elbow shoved on his face. Somers staggers back shouting. Shit. I saw Sommers face bleeding from the side. Even with his Kuret strengthening his skin, Cory hurt him. This alpha is still so strong despite his injuries. I decided its not safe for anyone else to try and stop Cory . I need to do it myself. I rushed in with a blast of wind on my back. Cory knew he was cornered when he saw me. He stopped fighting and instead was trying to run away.

I wasn't going to let him. I halt in front of him blocking his escape through the door. He looked visibly troubled. I shout, you got no where to go Cory . He got agitated, shut up bitch. He suddenly got mad and make a reckless attack on me. He coated both his hands with his rot Kuret and tried to grab me by the arms. I saw it coming, so I discharged a short blast of lightening at his arms. He shrieks when the lightening hits his arm. However, his rotting Kuret was still there.

Damn. He is still this strong. I recalled his fight with June. Whatever his reasons are trying to escape, he is still one of the top warriors. Even injured he can probably do some damage. I took a peak around the room. People were rushing out from the inside room. Others came after hearing us. I can't let this drag on. A thought came to my mind. If he is really serious and desperate, he might take someone hostage and try to escape. No one here is powerful enough to avoid getting hurt from his rotting Kuret.

I decided to finish this fast. Cory shook off my attack and then charged again. His Kuret now covering his whole arm. I prepared a layer of ice on my left arm and block his punches. I could have avoided it entirely, but I chose to make a close combat. I let out a shout and force my Kuret on my arm to grow. The ice begins to grow on Cory's right fist. He shouts in pain, but he doesn't relent. He instead increases the rot and tried to slow down the ice growing on his arm.

I knew this wasn't enough to stop him. I wanted him to focus on that for a moment. With my other arm I prepare a fist of fire and throw a fireball point blank on his face. Quintin saw in horror as a ball of fire, a size of fist struck his left face. I felt my attack connect physically. But he had somehow brought his rot Kuret to his face too. I felt a small sting on my knuckles on the contact. He got knocked back and smashed straight to the wall behind him.

I wriggle my right hand a little to shake off the pain. Dammit. Just how persistent he was to get away. I thought that was enough to stop him. But instead he was doubling down on escaping. He was letting his Kuret flow into the wall behind him. I saw that and rushed ahead. He won't be able to break the wall in time, but just in case I should avoid any more damage. At this point he probably had given up on fighting me because he was focused on spreading his rot.

I am done holding back. If he isn't going to stop, I need to ramp up the pressure. I began to prepare a wind assisted fire on my right hand. The fire begins to glow brighter and hotter. Cory begins to panic seeing me come at him with full force. But he is too slow to react. I land a huge blow to his abdomen and knock the wind out of him. Cory tried to grab on with his Kuret on my shoulders as he let out a big painful shout. I could feel more sharp pain surging on my skin at the contact. I stifled a small shout from the pain.

Damn him. He is still this strong. Its good I was here. Otherwise someone would have been hurt. I didn't stop my attack. The pain wasn't so strong that I need to back off. I let out a big wave of electricity from my elbow and struck him on face. This discharge was on the level I used when I fought Marina. No way he would walk away from this. And I was right. His face cracked in pain with the electricity penetrating his skin and bone. He lets out another shout as his clothes and skin begin to singe from the burn marks.

A moment later I see his Kuret subsiding. I back off from him. His eyes were rolled up and without any resistance he falls front in me to the ground. I wasn't going to take any chance. I bend down and grab on his unconscious body. I shove his arms back and then I lock them with a thick layer of ice. I kept continuing adding ice up to his elbow for good measure. He is an alpha, he will soon wake up and heal. I can't have him use his Kuret rot on others.

Once I was satisfied he can't easily break off I back from him. Behind me Somers comes in, is he down. I nod, yeah. Somers was bleeding and had a big swelling on his left eye, but he too was slowly healing. I shook his head in anger, freak this. What the hell was that. He just attacked a nurse and tried to ran off. I turn back to look the body lying down. I ask, he was so desperate to escape. I didn't want to involve others so I had to attack with some serious Kuret.

Behind us other came and were inspecting Cory. Ruther also rushes and says, what a mess. Was he really going to escape IDF. Someone take him to a prisoner cell this time. Others agreed and picked him up, carrying to the cells we have installed. We never had a use for it, until now. I say, its not enough. Add two guards around the box. Chain his hands and don't treat his wounds. He was even giving me trough despite the injuries he had. I looked around my arms and shoulder spots he touched. The unform I was wearing showed a little bit of my bare dark skin. It wasn't that bad because it was already healing. Thank god he wasn't at full capacity, I would have been more injured otherwise.

Somers on the other hand wasn't doing well. He was hurt all over and that last elbow to the face scarred him bad. I say, I got this. You should rest and focus on getting healing your wound. Somers was too agitated, no. I am good. It looks worse than it is. Ruther chips in, no dude. I can feel pain just by looking at you. You should rest. Somers wasn't backing down. I guess his alpha ego was hurting. I tell, just rest for a moment Somers. You were taken by surprise. Ruther nods, yeah. And the dude was on something. He was desperately trying to escape, no matter what. Somers looked like he was going to back down. I gave him a glare making him understand that it was order.

He closes one eye and sighs, fine. I will at least heal up face. It wouldn't look good if people saw me this hurt inside IDF. He then sighs exasperated as he begins to walk away. Ruther says, its not his fault. I say, I didn't say it was. It was lucky that I was here. He clicks his tongue, what made Cory behave like this. Is it really about the drugs we found. I ponder hard about it. I don't have a clue what could make him do this. His desperate attempts to lash out and escape suggests something else.

I realized something. I turn to Ruther, have other two warriors also move to prisoner cells. I don't know what happened, but something big must have happened. I can't let have another incident happen with Quintin and Polly. We just saw that even injured, these guys are strong. Even I won't be able to stop them if they all 3 band together while escaping. Ruther thinks about it for a moment. He then turns to others inside, are you sure. Maybe it was just Cory.

I shook my head, I am not sure. But I rather not risk it. And make sure no one talk to the warriors. Not until we will question the other people involved.

Blake (Chapter 65)

Sunday, January 4, 2026 21:56

Nathen was amused by my serious face. I wasn't. He says, calm down. I am here to help. I snicker, no. You don't. You and your companion should immediately leave this building. You will cause a lot of stir. If he was alone, I might listen to why he would offer to help. But he brought a troublesome women with her. She laughs, don't be like that Blake. I am here only to offer my assistance. I hear you have uncooperative people under locked up. You know I can question them.

I grit my teeth at her, we already have people from your bloodline here Rose. You aren't needed. She smiles at me with a slight annoyed look. She was wearing casual clothes. Actually, when I think about it, she was wearing her hospitality dress. She must have come directly from work. She raises her hand to me, please. I am an alpha, you need me to interrogate other alpha. My bloodline people can't do what I can. I don't know how she knows we got alphas in our holding. I turn to Nathan and glare at him.

He shrugs at me innocently. Damn him. I guess he still has people in IDF that inform him things. He says, don't look at me like that Blake. You know you need Rose and her Kuret. You are holding alpha and a dual kuret user. They are powerful warriors. Only rose can pry out information out of them. It's alarming he even knows who they are. At this point people all around us became aware of their presence. People were whispering and some gave strange gazes towards us.

This isn't the right place to discuss. But I can't just let them inside. I take a stand, it doesn't matter. We will try to do it our way first. If that doesn't work, then I might, think of asking Rose. But not you. Your presence will cause more problems we don't need. Nathan's smiles wears off and takes a look around the stares he has been getting. He then says to me, I don't mind the attention, if that's what you are worried about. The nerve of this guy. Before I force him out of here he continues, also. I can help too. If you recall, Cory was one of my guys back in the Valley. I know him and can help get information out of him. □ I scoff, that's a lie. If he was close to you, we would have kept an eye on him. He wasn't in your inner circle, like Rose here. I point to her. She makes a offended gesture. I ignore it and say, and even if that were true, it won't help much. We can interrogate him ourselves. Nathan replies, I don't doubt that. But its about not wasting time. I rushed here because I too want to resolve this faster. He then sighs a little, sure, Cory wasn't really my guy, but he was close enough. He has been beside me enough times to know his quirks, habits. Tells that he is lying or telling the truth.

I say, that goes both way. He knows you too then. So he will be more cautious and clamp up. He nods, that's also true. But I got another ace. I can read his aura. Better than you. I bet you are tired and handling multiple things. Are you sure you won't miss anything. A single misread and you might waste a lot of time going with a different line of questioning. You know me and Rose's Kuer combination of interrogation is very efficient. So why can't you make an exception just this once for us.

I grit my teeth a little. Not because of anger, but due to annoyance that he was right. I was just telling Vanessa that we don't have time to waste. Using these two would drastically make things go faster. I was thinking hard on what to do. Initially I wasn't going to let them in, but after hearing their reason, I am perplexed. In the corner of my I notice Vanessa and a guy coming. I shook my head knowing this is going to cause even more stir. I say to Nathan, since you both are so adamant. I will leave this decision to the chief. I waved to Vanessa. I have just dumped it on Vanessa just because I didn't want to force this.

Nathan and Rose instead were not happy. They became a little tense, like they know Vanessa will be a tough sell. Vanessa and the guy she brought to wake Elena walk to us. Vanessa says angered, what the hell are these two doing here. Someone get them out of here. The guy from Zeld bloodline looked around in confusion. I didn't want him to be delayed so I say, you should go to the sleeping women back there and wake her up. We will be behind you in a moment. He looks at Vanessa for a second for confirmation. She was staring hard at Nathan, yeah. Peter, you go on ahead. He nods and moves away from the tense looking people.

Nathan speaks first, listen to us before kicking us out. But she wasn't having it. She walks closer to him saying, I don't need another problem. There is a reason you are banned from this place. No one can trust you. She gives a quick glare to Rose, same goes to her too. Nathan replies, hate all you want, but you need us. You need us to interrogate your prisoners. We can help make it go faster. I am sure you would get truth out of them eventually, but how much time will that time.

Vanessa wasn't buying any of it, I don't care. We do it as long as it takes. We do it properly, without any interference from a nuisance duo. Rose cuts in, come on Vanessa. You are being unreasonable here. I sigh, she shouldn't have said that. The comment made Vanessa burst out a vein in her forehead. She yells at her, am I now. I think I need remind you the pain you caused me back in Valley. I saw her preparing her Kuret on her hand. Rose saw it too and became slightly terrified. Nathan also downed a very serious expression seeing the possibility of a getting blown away.

This escalated far too much. I cut in, stop. All of you. This is not productive, we can't waste time on this. The IDF crew around us also took a step back thinking a fight might break out. I don't think Vanessa wants that, she is getting way too angry. I asked Nathan, will you both agree to some conditions while you are inside this building. Vanessa looks at me with shock, Blake, you are joking right. These two are just looking for an angle, you can't trust them one bit.

I nod, yeah I also was ready to kick them out. But don't you think we should use them. Its not about trust, its about getting the truth and resolving this situation fast. We need only their Kurets, not them. So let me propose the rules and if you don't like it, feel free to kick them out. Vanessa glares at me with anger. Okay, that was unnecessary. She might really be a little unreasonable. I brought kuret to my eyes and made her feel like it was an order rather than a request. She finally backs down after a moment, fine. Lets listen to the conditions.

I take a small gulp relieved she didn't push me further. I turn to other two, you both will be monitored every second you are inside. Everything you do will be monitored, your actions, your Kuret, hell, you so much as sneeze, it will be seen. Second, no use of Kuret outside the cell. You use your Kuret outside anywhere, even for a second, and I will personally shove you both out. I turn to Rose to single out this condition just for her, especially you. If you are caught using your Kuret on anyone else, I won't just kick you out, I will penalize you. You will be suspended from your job or even fired.

Rose makes a annoyed look. But she doesn't say anything when Nathan waves at her. I continue, finally. Whatever you learn here, will remain inside. If you reveal it to anyone else and we found out about it later, there will be severe consequences. I am talking something between house arrest to even exile in extreme case. Agree to these conditions and I will allow you inside. My last harsh condition made them both flinch. Rose couldn't hold back anymore, hey now. That's too much. The details about this would be released to public eventually, so why ask to hide it.

I shook my head, we might not share it to the public. Or we just tell a water down version to avoid panic. Regardless of our choice you both will not share it to anyone. I mean it. Nathan had a relaxed expression until now. He was dead silent, no doubt contemplating if its better to avoid this. I won't deny their assistant will help us out greatly. But so is the risk. Vanessa actually smiles a little hearing these conditions, I like it. Gives me an public excuse when I have to kick them out.

Okay, what's up with her. She is taking way to much anger out on both of them. Nathan says to me, isn't this abuse of power. I scoff hard, I don't want to hear from a guy who ruled Valley like a dictatorship. I am not you. I will not unilaterally make decisions for you both. But rest assured, I will make sure you both don't escape the consequences of your selfish actions. Nathan asks, only if we break your conditions though. I answers, goes without saying. If you really only want to help, that's well and good.

Nathan then relaxes a bit, in that case I accept. My only objective is to help here. Nothing else. I don't think Vanessa and me believed it even for a second. We turn to Rose for her response. She looks nervously to Nathan, who just nods at her to help her decide. She takes a moment to think and says, fine. This is still unfair thought, but I guess I can't complain it. Now I am sure she is here not really to help but because Nathan called her. She must be still following Nathans lead on some level.

I ask Vanessa, so you good with this. Vanessa had a small smile in the corner of her mouth, I guess I have to. I don't like them here, but I can't deny their kurets are efficient. Nathan cocks his head, great. Since its decided, lets get setup right away. Vanessa puts her hand up in front of him, hold up. Not so fast. Ruther, she waves to Ruther from the side. She says, escort these people for a checkup before we have them meet anyone. Check for any Kuret device, or anything they have on them. Do a complete inspection. Once that's done, assign two people for each to watch over them. Ruther comes forward and looks around to the two alphas in front of him. He was a little out of place, but kept his face composed.

He speaks out, got it. Follow me. They both follow him obediently, thankfully. Vanessa says, on second thought, let me watch over the two of them for a while. I don't trust Rose to leave her alone with any guys. She follows behind them. Rose makes a mocking face, I am hurt that you think so little of me. Vanessa brushes her off, oh please. Like you haven't thought of it. Rose shook her head, No. I meant that you think I cannot influence women. Please, after that humiliation from all those years back, I have been improving my skills. I bet I can make you do stuff too now.

She makes a teasing wink at Vanessa. God, this women must have a screw loose to test Vanessa like this. Especially today. Vanessa was surprisingly calm about it, but her tone wasn't, try it bitch. I'll make you regret it. Nathan cuts in before it escalates, settle down ladies, keep it professional. They all walk through the door leading to secure rooms. I am starting to think this could be a mistake. But I can't think too much about it now. I need to get answers. Others finally free from the drama get back to work.

Behind me Deni comes up and says, is everything all right then? Good question, I wasn't sure how to answer. I say, lets hope so. I turn to face her, is Elena awake. Deni nods, yes. She is. I just thought to gave her a moment to settle down before we begin asking her questions. Peter says her mind is clear and the doctor says her injuries are not threatening. We can begin questioning her. That's good, I said. We both walk back to the room Elena was resting. Peter was beside Ryan with his hand on his head. Ryan was slumped back on a chair opposite to Elena, eyes closed and neck resting on the side.

I step inside the room and take a look at Elina. She had cuts and wounds around her neck. There was a big cut on her chest. I could see her aura flickering with some pain. Considering the extent of her wounds, it was probably not a good idea to wake her up like this. The doctor comes up to me and says, Blake. I understand the situation and I object to this in spite of it. She needs to recover first. Her concerns were valid, I get it. I only need few minutes. You can stand by in case anything happens. She wasn't convinced but, nonetheless she wasn't going to object my direct orders. She nods slightly and walks out of the room.

At the same time Somers comes in, hey Blake. Glad you are here too. I head from Vanessa before he was in scuffle with Quintin. She was putting it mildly. I could still see his cracked bruises on his face. Deni says, you good. He touches the bruises on his face, I am. It still stings, but I can't just sit on my ass just because of this. His aura wasn't flickering too much, so I guess he has recovered enough. I ask, I heard Quintin gave you and Vanessa trouble, thanks for handling it.

He smiles with a little embarrassment, I barely slowed him. The guy was not in his right mind. If Vanessa hadn't shown up when she did, I am not sure if we could have stopped him. I can only imagine. Even with his injuries, he would have been tough to handle. I turn to my side as Peter stands up finishing using his Kuret on Ryan. He says, its done. He is fully asleep. Deni says, that took a while. He nods, kids usually have less resistance to my Kuret. But he was too terrified and anxious. I needed to exert some more Kuret to make him sleep. Though I suspect it won't last long, he will wake up in just few hours.

I say, that's plenty. Thanks. Then I thought about others lying in the infirmary, since you are here. Can you tell me anything about the other dozen people unconscious. Were you able to wake anyone up. Peter expression turns a little sour, not much progress there. They are not hurt badly, but they are still in bad shape. I am waiting for their wounds to heal enough before I attempt to wake them. Somers ask, what happens if you wake them now. He answers, doing so will have some risk. They will be dizzy and may even have trouble remembering some stuff. Some may not be effected, but its not a good idea to do on regular people. Now if they were warriors, that would

be different.

I turn to a see a tense Elina silently gazing at us from her bed. I ask, what does that mean for her then. I didn't know there could be a side effect like this. Will she be okay. He answers after thinking for a second, she should be fine. Unlike others, she wasn't beaten down. She had only a single wound. Granted that it was severe, but now that its been treated, she shouldn't reel from the side effect very much. Considering her initial condition, it's a quite impressive she recovered. I was confused. I remembered from the her video that she was stable back then. I ask, what do you mean. I thought her injuries weren't life threatening.

He turns to Deni with look like he wasn't sure what he wanted to say. She then peeks to Elina behind me and whispers quietly, the doctor who was just here. She told me she was actually very badly hurt. Maybe, Ryan was not exaggerating when he making it look like Elina was in worse shape. Somers asks, huh. You mean should could have died. Deni gulphs hard and nods, the doctor didn't confirm that, but she subtly implied that. I turn to face Elina. With my full focus on her now, she averts her eyes. I saw a slight change in her aura.

I say, she is definitely hiding something. I don't know about what though. Somers says, thanks Peter. We will take it from here. Keep me apprised about other others. He says, will do and leaves us. Finally, time to get some answers. I ask, I assume its okay to proceed without Vanessa here. Somers replies, no worries. Everything is recording here, so shouldn't be a problem. I walk to Elina's bed and stand beside her. Somers and Deni take the other side of the bed.

Elina was intimated by my presence and kept averting my eyes. Clearly she is trying to avoid having a conversation. But is it because of guilt or something else. I ask, Elina. How are you feeling. I open with a harmless question to ease into first. I thought being direct at first, but I decided to be neutral initially and change my tone based on her being a victim or part of the smuggling gang. She finally looks up to me with her eyes. She's a little hazy, but shakes her head slightly.

I answer, good. First of all, I assure you Ryan is fine. He was very protective of you, so we just had to make him sleep before we could talk. He will remain beside you, so don't worry about him. She looks at her sleeping kid brother with eyes filled with anxiety. But her aura relaxes a little. I ask next, but you should know its not looking good. We found in the middle of what looks like a drug smuggling gone wrong. We got people beaten and unconscious, from Citradel and Island. Among them some strong warriors. And in the middle of this mess, only you appear to the victim. I am looking for answers.

She remain frozen at my prodding. She was terrified now, clearing showing in her aura. Somers asks, help us. We can help you then. What are those crates and what do you know about them. Deni piles on, and who attacked you all. Elina closes her eyes trying to avoid us. I was loosing patience here. We finally got a witness but she is being incorporative. She hasn't spoken a single word. Would a victim really feel this much fear. Especially when I am in her presence now.

I decided to approach more directly now. I take a step forward and ask her, if you are not going to talk. We will have to detain you. I don't want to do this, because I don't think a kid would be involved in such a thing. But you might are. I can't guarantee Ryan would be safe from the consequences. I threatened just slightly to aggravate her. She suddenly blurts out, no don't. I am all the family he has right now. That opened her up. Somers asks confused, what do you mean. You got an older brother. We haven't been able to find him though.

Elina shuts down again. Deni asks, you need to tell use what happened. Like Blake said, it's a mess our there right now. Elina turns to face me suddenly. Her aura brightens a little, promise me Ryan will not be arrested. This isn't good. She asking for this means somehow he is also involved in this. I looked at Somers to answer that question. He would know best what to say to this. He answers, we will do our best. But we can't promise though. Its very unlikely he did anything in the presence of 3 warriors. Still, we won't make any decisions until we hear the whole story. Until then, he remains with you and us.

Elina didn't like this answer. But he wasn't wrong also. After giving it a lot of thought she relents. Her tense expression falls into resignation, its all my fault. I shouldn't have been so gullible when I went with Paul's ridiculous plan. I asked, who. Somers answers, their older brother. He is involved in this too. Where is he then. Elina looks even more somber now, he isn't here. Now this isn't a good sign. I ask, you are telling me your bother was with you.

She nods. I sigh, Somers, what do you know of this. Somers and Deni were both just as shocked, first time I am hearing. We had people scour the scene, we didn't find any other Kuret signature. After a moment Deni says, if all three siblings were there, isn't it possible his Kuret signature would have been hidden among the other two ? She was right. Somers clicks his tongue, you got a point. We missed it. Call Tessa now and ask her to investigate their Kuret again. Deni pulls out her phone and walks out immediately.

We might have a suspect now, I assume he is on the run. Elina says, I don't know. I must have blacked out before he left. I ask, is he the only who attacked everyone and ran off. Elina shook her head vigorously, no way. Our Kuret is a not suited for battle. We can just change our Kuret color. She demonstrated by gathering her kuret on her palm. The Kuret swirl around her fingers and begins to radiate different colors, like almost a rainbow. She disperses it, I can make it strong enough to be visible to others. Same as Peter. Its not even enough to be used as a distraction. Peter can't fight, let alone 3 warriors.

I already knew about her Kuret before, when I got information from Tessa. I knew he couldn't be capable. But I still thought to ask. My expression harden. If he isn't responsible then, why is he on the run. Or his is missing. I tell Sommers, there is detective with Tessa on the site. He is looking into the families and work places of the people involved. Tell him to check if Peter is hiding in any of them. Somers nods, yeah. Good idea. Now he also leaves the room with his phone in hand. Now just me and Elina remained in the room. I ask, tell me then what happened. Elina looks a little apprehensive about revealing the story, but she knows she had no choice.

She clears her throat, I work in a bar. I don't make much, but its much better than being hiding among Humans. I have a health condition after arriving on Earth. I need constant medication. She sighs before saying, I have very less hemoglobin count in my blood. So even small cuts takes longer time to heal. The doctor told me it was a miracle I survived with my condition. That's why the doctor told me Deni about how lucky she was. As much as I sympathize with her about her condition, its not just her. So many people have medical condition that needs constant supervision.

I ask, I can only imagine the challenges you face. But how is this related to the smuggling or the fight. I had a guess the drugs were part of it, but I want to know if she knows about it. She says, it started due from this. Peter approached me and told me he is building a network in the island that will supply stuff legally inside. I ask, stuff like. She gulps hard before answering, you saw the crates then. I nod, I did. I want to know if you know about it. She takes a long breath, I knew I shouldn't have done it. But I was desperate and thought it was safe.

She looks at Ryan for a bit and then to me, there are different type of drugs shipped. Sometimes it is controlled human substances, sometimes more extra legal stuff. I don't know the whole details. Only Peter knows about it. I heard from them and pieced it together. I was confused about something, you said legally. How in the hell did you think smuggled goods were legal. She immediately shook her head, I had no idea they were shipping drugs, or being carried inside the liquor bottles I order. I never imagined they were using my using my shipments to carry drugs like this.

Slowly I was able to understand her involvement in this. I say, you were a patsy? She gets frustrated, I can't believe Peter was using me like this. He told me that in order to get me my medicines, it would be best to get it with my usual orders of the particular type of alcohols that we mix Kuret with. He said it would be efficient since it reduces the commission charges. I thought it was a good idea. I was there with him for the first shipment in the crate. It was all legal and shipped through proper channel, security guys inspected it and approved it. Since then I always place my medicines with the bulk order of the alcohols. I always sign the shipment under my name.

She leans back and grits her teeth, stupid. I should have inspected the bottles myself. Peter handles the inventory in out shop, so I never realized the number of bottles I ordered is more than the number of bottles shipped in. I have been blindly signing off on larger shipments without realizing all this time. She closed her eyes and tears rolls off her eyes. He aura didn't seem to flicker too much, instead it showed regret and anger. Something one would expect of a victim rather than a co-conspirator.

I ask, you say you didn't know. But you clearly know about the creates and drugs now. When did you find out and what were you doing there. It was probably rude of me to continue asking when she is crying, but I want to get the crux of this mess. She takes a moment to wipe her tears from her cheeks. She regains her composure a little before saying, Peter never told me the specifics of how he was creating his supply chain. I assumed it was done all through proper channels. Today, around 7, he came to our shop and was in a hurry. He told me that there is a problem with the last shipment and needed my help.

Her voice breaks, I was confused at the time how I was involved since I never worked with him on this. The picture was beginning to get clearer now on how she was involved. But then I turn to Ryan, why take him with you. She answers, I didn't want to. He should have stayed with our neighbors, but Peter insisted he came along too. He was being evasive on why, but at that time I just followed him without questioning. She turns to her brother with teary eyes, I shouldn't have brought him. He was so terrified. He was only a baby when we left Medrine, never saw the horrors or the violence. Even on Earth, we never saw a single Echo. We were in hiding, but at least safe from violence. I failed to protect him.

More tears roll down from her eyes. I turned around to pick up tissues from the side and offer some to her. She quietly accepts them and wipes some off her face. As she was speaking, I didn't see her aura being deceitful. So most of it must be the truth. At least, I am very sure that her guilt is real. After she settles down she continues, Peter brought me the treatment plant. I was getting terrified how Peter was behaving and the remote place he was taking us. When we arrived, those people were waiting for us inside. The creates I have for my shipment were also there. I kept asking Peter to explain, but he never did. Instead, he kept saying to just answer all the questions they have for me and Ryan.

I ask, did they think you had something to do with the drugs. She hesitantly nods, I was being questioned by a guy named Wyan. He seemed like he was the boss. I recalled the names from the unconscious people, one of them was named Wyan. Its a good sign we at least have the boss in custody. She says, he asked stuff about missing bottles from my shipment. I said I didn't know anything about. I was expecting it to come 2 days later, not today. They ignored my questions on how they intercepted my shipment and kept asking Ryan and me about missing products.

I had no clue what they were talking. But they were almost interrogating me after some time. I wanted to leave. Begged Peter to let me and Ryan go because we didn't have anything to do with this, but he didn't. No one did. They were certain I stole something from them. Then she shouts with anger, but I didn't. Her small outburst was consistent with her aura. I ask, they were accusing you of stealing their drugs. There are drugs missing too now. This is worse now. We need to track missing drugs.

She settles down a bit, I don't know. Maybe. The way they were talking, it sounded more like they cared about who stole it rather than what was stolen. I can't be sure about it though. Peter was trying to defend us that we didn't know anything and by bring us there should prove our innocence. I tilt my head a little trying to make more sense of this. She continues, that guy, Wyan. He didn't believe us. He was sure I stole it. Given my medical condition, he thought I had something to do with it. I tried to explain that I get my stuff separately, but that freakier doesn't understand. I can't use heroine or cocaine for my hemoglobin platelet treatment. I don't know if was purposefully being dumber or just plain cruel. Her anger recalling the incident was clearly shown on her face.

I ask, what happened then. How did it get physical. Did the warriors do something ?. She shook her head, those people weren't in the room. They were outside the room, I saw them when coming inside the building. They were guarding the people. I almost choke at that. Those people hired top ranking warriors as their bodyguards. Seriously. Who were they thinking they need protection from. I ask, do you think they know they were protecting illegal drugs. She answers, I don't know. Maybe. People inside the room were shouting and screaming. Sometimes at me or each other. I doubt those three didn't hear us.

If I assume they were part of this, then it makes sense why Quintin was trying so desperately to flee. He knows he is screwed when others wake up. I put my hand on my chin, so they were hired muscles. How much would they be paying to such powerful people to work for them. Did they say anything about them. She answers, no. I don't think even cared who was on the other side. They weren't discrete at all when they kept shouting at me or Peter. I felt a little despair, its almost looking like they were really part of it. That's bad. I had kept some hope that they were unknowingly being used or at least not completely complicit. Now we need to treat them as smugglers too.

Seeing my expression change she asks with her voice broken, please you have got to help me. I was being used, I had no idea this whole operation was going on. She begins to sob slowly now. I don't know if I can help her. Her brother is directly involved. If Peter isn't found it could be bad for her. Her name is on all the shipments. I didn't answer her but instead ask, how did you get injured. At this point they were just questioning you. Her tears were slow, but still there. She becomes grim when recalling.

She says, there was this another guy. Don't know his name. He was getting impatient more than others. He thought I was just acting and purposefully playing dumb. He tried to become more physical with me. But before he could, Peter tried to shake him off me. The guy pushed him away. Ryan was so terrified and confused about what was going on. He suddenly just went and kicked the guy. No one was expecting it from him. The guy got angry and I saw him preparing his Kuret. I don’t know what it was. All I know I he was about to hurt a my baby brother. So I rushed in front, pushed Ryan away and got hit. Whatever that Kuret did, it tore a hole in my chest. I blacked out from the pain and woke up here.

She finishes recounting her story while gazing with watery eyes at Ryan. I am almost certain she wasn't lying to me. So I assume this turn of events, something happened after she was cut down. I ask, you don't remember the in fighting or how they all were knocked out ? She shook her head in a panic, I have no idea how that happened. Next thing I know, I woke up here. I only got to know about other when that officer Deni told me.

This got a whole lot crazier. I just hope we can find this Peter guy to shed more light on how this happened. I tell her, I understand. Get some rest now. I will send the doctor in now. I know you are worrying about Ryan, but first rest up. We will decide what happens to you both later. She couldn't do anything but accept this for now. I turn my back on her and walk about. Just before I step out, I ask her, before I go, tell me one thing. You siblings are very close, I can tell that. Are you by any chance protecting Peter by not telling where he is.

She shook her head adamantly, I wouldn't do that. He needs to make this right. I want him found. She says that, but the only time her aura had flickered a tiny bit was when he heard Peter is missing. She felt relieved. I could have misread it. Maybe it was about being safe from him. I guess Nathan was right. He can read aura much better than me. I nod, I see. Well, we will find him no matter what. Thanks.

I walked out from the room letting her rest. I told someone to tell the doctor I am done. Well, at least with her. We got to find Peter. Maybe I should ask Vanessa to send more crew to Tessa. Just as I was thinking about the next action, Ruther rushed towards me with a anxious face, hey Blake. A guy just came back to the treatment plant and asked to be turned in. He says he was involved in the incident. His name is Peter, guess what. He is the brother of the injured lady.

A small smile came to my mouth and then a chuckle that made Ruther confused.

Vanessa (Chapter 66)

Monday, January 5, 2026 19:39

My eyes never left them, even for a second. I was doubly cautious of Rose. Her Kuret is invisible and can effect even with just scent. I could tell she wasn't using her Kuret. But I won't be taking any chance. I watched like a hawk when they were searched thoroughly for anything suspicious item. Fortunately they were clean. Rose was fidgety about being searched, deal with it, I said. She makes a scorn expression to me. I didn't care if this make her uncomfortable. Actually, I slightly enjoyed it.

Rose snaps, you are staring at me so hard. Did you accidently get a whiff of my Kuret. You know it might leak out accidently. I scoff at her. She has been just messing with me all the time. She kept goading me as we escort them to Cory. Nathan says, come on ladies. Focus. I am so annoyed at Nathan, acting like he is managing me. Like we are back in Valley. Before they walk inside the prison cell, I put an arm at the door. I sneer at him, you know the ground rules. Break it and I will be kicking you out of here. So please, I lean in closer to say, do break it. I am just waiting to get my hands on you both.

I basically threatened them. Nathan giggles a little and raises his arm surrendering, I promise I will behave. You need to relax a little Vanessa. We are in this together. I was still mad at him from this morning a little. Earlier when Blake forced me to listen, I realized I have been venting out my anger on others all day. Some may deserve it, but most don't. But its hard to feel any guilt or embarrassment with Rose here. She was getting on my nerves. I waited for her response.

She snickers saying, yeah fine. I will play along with you guys for a while. I drop my arm and allowed them inside. Nathan and his guard Dan first go in. I tell Dan, do not stop your Kuret on him, no matter what. Tell me immediately if he is using his Kuret other than reading auras. He replies, I got it covered. Won't let him do anything suspicious. His Kuret sensitivity is high, so he can pick up Kuret being used by anyone much better than others. Before Rose walks in, she asks me, tell me something. Why haven't you called David. I thought he would be here.

I got curious, why, you want to give it a shot and try controlling him again. Don't bother. He is beyond anyone's control now. I spat out angrily without meaning to. I thought how these days he can manipulate others, even without her Kuret. She mocks, wow. Someone's salty. He is my greatest adversary and an enigma at the same time. To this day, he is the only guy to ever resist me. I still don't know how he did it. I don't believe in that strong mind bullshit he told back then.

I was slightly amused by her irritation. I didn't offer her any answer. Actually, I myself don't know how he did it. He never told me how he did it. She grumbles a little, anyways, I saw him using my Kuret yesterday. I am not kidding when I say that I was horrified to see my Kuret used in the match. That Kuret was definitely like mine, but what a slopy control. Still, it would have worked. Why did Nathan brought me instead of him.

So that's what she meant. I wasn't going to give any an answer that would give hints about my issues with David, so I reply with a answer she will eat it without questioning, he can't control other Kurets. He can only direct and throw. Finner control is beyond him. Like you said, when he used your bloodline Kuret, it wasn't focused. Using him wouldn't be nearly as efficient as the original Medrones. That cleared her doubt, oh. Gotch ya. Makes sense now. Well, I suppose I should solace in the fact that I am still better at this than him.

I didn't pursue this topic any further. She sighs, but I did want to try my Kuret on him once again. You know, just to see how much I have leveled up. I yell at her, enough. Get inside, I say while grabbing her arm and shoving her inside, hey that's rude. The guard assigned to her walks behind her. I tell Errika, do not let her touch anyone except Cory. Not even you. She needs only a second to induce a thought control. She nods, I will box her in with my shield Kuret if she does anything.

I carefully chose these to be their guards because they would have the best chance of thwarting anything Nathan and Rose do. I closed the door and walk to the front of the transparent one sided wall. I whished I was inside with them, but I decided its best not to be in the vicinity of Rose while her Kuret is active. Nathan was already in discussion with Cory, disappoint me. You were always showed initiative, but not like this. He was sitting opposite to Cory, who had his hands tied behind on the chair.

Cory didn't speak, only snarled at Nathan. Nathen laughs, you sure did become more confident. You wouldn't dare do this sort of thing back in the Valley. I guess coming in the top ranking of the tournament gave you a ego boast, yeah. Then Rose came in and stood beside Cory. Seeing her appear with him made Cory agitated. He had to know what was coming. Rose says, hey Cory. Long time no see. She walked around him like a predator on hunt. She still hadn't used her Kuret. The two guards were now on the opposite side of the walls with their eyes and Kuret glued on the two interrogating.

Nathan asks, tell me how you became involved his smuggling drugs. Normally, I would have been impressed you had the guts to do this. But not now. We are in a middle of an important Medrone milestone. You screwed up big time. I bet you guys have been doing this for a while. And then you go and mess up somehow. And even get caught. That's just pathetic. Did you learn nothing from me. Cory had been trying to remain composed all this time. But Nathan was making him angry little by little. I might not like it, but Nathan was right. He knew which buttons would push for Cory.

Rose finally halts in front of Cory, you just didn't get caught. You got pretty beat up. I don't like it when strong guys get beaten, that's a turn off you know. I don't know what her angle was here. Did she thought that would make a rise out of him. Nathan slides his arm on the chair and turns to me, in case you are wondering, Cory here had a massive crush on Rose here. That clears it. Jealousy and shame, that's her angle. Cory's composure was slowly crumbling. I don't know why Rose isn't using her Kuret immediately.

Rose turns to Nathan, really. I didn't know. Well, she lights taps Cory's shoulder who jerked away in reflex, there are always people who are perusing me. I can't remember every one of them. She laughs. Cory veins starts to pop up. He glares at Rose with eyes that look like he was about to hit her. Rose says, wow. Just look at that stare. Don't tempt me Cory. I might accidently use too much Kuret and turn you into a drooling puppet. I sigh at this ridiculous performance. So far Nathan's asked only one obvious question. I know there are different interrogation ways, but this is seems like they are just insulting him where it hurts.

I knock at the wall a couple of times to signal them. Nathan shifts on his chair, whoops. Our chief is getting a little impatient. Rose smiles, don't worry Vanessa. We are professionals. Dealing something like this was like eating breakfast back in the Valley. I did not participate much in the internal Valleys businesses, so I admit I don't know their routines. But still, they should move on with the questioning. Nathan says, but you are in hospitality now. Your skills might have rusted for this. Rose touches Corys shoulders again. He shakes them off but Rose was more forceful this time and kept her grip.

She says, on the contrary, I get to perfect my craft on people even more now. A short breath escapes my mouth hearing that comment. The hell is she on about. She clarifies, my work in Valley was very focused, getting truth out of someone or just straightaway control their actions. But now I get to diversify my Kuret applications. She slides her tip of the fingers on his arms and necks. Its a pity I don't get to do big stuff, but I am happy focused on small stuff you know. Especially in this tournament, where I had various jobs, keeping angry people from going overboard, shutting down any in fighting. Some were alphas or omegas, so I had to level up my game.

Nathan smiles, I see. So that's where the confidence comes from. Cory was jerking around trying avoid contact from Rose, who still hadn't used her Kuret on him. Is this some kind of slow anticipation tactic, make him so nervous just by touching him like this. Nathan smiles, so you are stronger than when you were in Valley. Rosy finally beings to use her Kuret. She gathers some on her hands first. Erika on the other end takes one step ahead, keeping a much closer eye on her now.

She makes a teasing gesture by running her running her fingers on Cory's neck and cheeks. She grins saying, you bet I am. I have been training on my own way. She then grazes her hand on his hair. Corys composure was breaking down now. We had blocked his Kuret access, so he shouldn't be able to resist much longer. Then she comes face to face to him, even this is a training. I will not be satisfied until I tame him. I shook my head in disgust. Just how much obsessed is she with David.

Nathan snickers, you don't think Cory here is good enough for you. I mean, sure he got beat up, but he was still in upper echelon of warriors. Rose kept her eyes focused on a struggling Cory, I told earlier didn't I. I don't like strong guys who get beaten so easily. Cory's face became red, flushed with uncontrollable anger. At this point Rose lets loose a wave of her Kuret from her entire body and envelopes Cory's head. Erika takes two more steps towards Rose. Rose ignored her presence, puts her hands on Corys shoulders and says, you are nothing without me. Become stronger with me.

I step closer to the wall slightly anxiously. Rose's Kuret had actually become more potent. She wasn't kidding when she said she was training. The level of her Kuret spreading around the room was dangerous. Maybe this was a mistake, what if she infects Dan or Erika. What I get hit by it too. I was thinking of barging in, but then her Kuret suddenly stops spreading. Instead it was contained around her. I turn to Nathan who was using a bit of his Kuret to box in Rose's Kuret. This guy, he is already breaking the rules.

Dan was already a step ahead of me and walks to Nathan, stop this immediately. You are not allowed to use your Kuret here. Nathan now raised his palm towards Rose, really, you should thank me instead. If I hadn't done this Rose's Kuret would have effected everyone here. Dan makes a stern expression, we don't need your help, just because you are high ranking officers doesn't mean you get to do whatever inside IDF. I'll give you one last warning. Nathan smirks seeing Dan hovering him from the side. Nathan dispels his Kuret, all right. But happens when you become her slave.

Dan relaxes a little, and so did I when I see what happened on the other side of the room. Dan signals to look over there. Erika was already on the move, she had already used her Kuret to create a thin Kuret walls around Rose. She had her arms extended towards Rose from same position she was a second ago. Dan asks, you good. Erika didn't looked pressured, she nods, piece of cake. Nathan actually looked surprised to see that, impressive. I didn't even catch the speed of your reflexes. He then turns to Dan, apologies for my hasty behavior. I don't know you both, so I didn't know what your Kurets could do.

Nathan actually seemed shocked. Maybe he was really caught off guard. I turn to Rose and Cory. They both were still locked in what could only described as a mental battle. My eyes widen when I saw Cory with a pained expression. Huh, all the times I have seen her Kuret, wasn't it based on seduction and pleasure. What kind of BDSM tactic was this. Nathan cuts in, since I broke the rules, does that mean I have to leave. It was just a innocent mistake on my part though.

Dan turns towards me through the wall. I did threaten him that if he used his Kuret, I would kick him out. But seeing him and Rose halfway there already, it wouldn't make sense to kick him out now. Plus he only used his Kuret on Rose. I sigh and knocked the glass wall once. Dan got the message and says to Nathan, I guess you get one more chance. I suggest you don't waste it. He walks back to the same spot and resumes observing him from a distance. Nathan turns to face me, thanks Vanessa. And my word, you seem to have reliable people around you. He then chortles, I am happy at least someone learned from me.

My fist tighten unconsciously. Even when praising others he can't help but include himself. His narcissism knows no bound. Behind him Rose finally disperses her Kuret and let goes of Cory. She was visibly heaving. Did she just went for a brute approach rather than her usual ways. The Kuret around her begins to disappear and Errika removes her Kuret barrier. She yells, whoo. What a workout. Cory's stubborn face was gone, it was now replacing with a bright glow. He was staring at Rose, but not with hate, with admiration now.

He says, Rose, please, be my strength. He was completely love sick. I was confused seeing this complete opposite behavior from a second ago. He was in pain, but now he is in euphoria. What did she do to him. Rose walks and takes the seat beside Nathan, he was a challenge, I am not going to lie. I guess he really did become stronger than the last time I saw him. His internal Kuret was pushing back. I didn't expect him to resist so strongly, and so I had to go all out on him. She looks around the people in the room, sorry guys if I put you under my spell. She wasn't being apologetic, she was enjoying herself.

Nathan says, I suspected that was the case when you suddenly went berserker. But you know, if this lady wasn't here to stop it, we all would probably had been infected. What do you think Vanessa would have done then. Rose turns to me and says, I don't know. Maybe she would have knocked me out, or maybe she would have been my next target. I grit my teeth with annoyance. This bitch is not really afraid of me at all. I need to correct that. Nathan

says, playing with fire is fine, but you need to watch out, because this fire will burn you in more ways than one.

Rose got the message loud and clear because she backed off, just kidding. I would have stopped. She turns her back to me, but I could swear see her mouthing, probably. Nathan says, well, that was fun and all, but lets focus on our task. Cory was now swaying her head like he was high and kept his eyes glued to Rose. Nathan asks, I assume when he was hurting, he was actually enjoying it. And that turned him like this so quickly.

She says, just think of it as the fine line between pleasure and pain. The stronger the Kuret resistance, the more pain they feel. I just redirect that pain into pleasure. Doesn't work on all people. There are some weirdos with high tolerance for it. But most people are unexperienced and would succumb to it soon.

Even if she explains it like that, that's basically just a BDSM thing. Nathan says, you have are trying out various forms of seduction now. You went from an sweet angel to demon style dominatrix. She laughs, I can still do it like I used to. Its just on Cory I decided jealously would be much better emotion. Okay, now they are just enjoying themselves. This isn't a freaking torture chamber. I slam my fist on the glass hard. Rose says, okay. Okay. No need to get so feisty. I was just making small talk. Jeez, don't you know I work in hospitality now. This is how you make people like you. She had the nerve to question my authority here like this.

Nathan clears his throat, lets not make her more angry. He waves his hand to Cory, by all means Rose. She leans in forward to Cory and asks, what happened Cory. Tell me why you were involved in smuggling drugs. Cory hazy eyes didn't blink one answering, will that make you happy my love. Rose replies, very much. Cory nods like a dog wagging his tail, it was 4 months ago. I was approached my a guy named Wyan. He said he had plan to supply goods into the island. Wyan, huh, he is one of the people lying unconscious here.

Nathan asks, and what were these goods. Cory suddenly barks at Nathan, shut up you mongrel. You aren't worthy of seating beside Aphrodite reincarnated. He tries to wriggle out of his chair and shows his teeth to him. Nathan slumps back, what the hell. I had the same reaction. Its like a switch flipped from drunk to menacing. Rose says, I should mentioned before, because he is decently strong, his Kuret was inverted turned too much by mine. He will listen to me alone. Nathan shook his head but still smiled, I suppose will only be gesturing each other then.

Rose asks, tell me the whole story Cory. I would love to how a strong man such as yourself became a drug smuggler. Cory immediately settles down and answers, Wyan talked about how he wants to take control of the shipments channels and bring in stuff mixed with others. Rose asks, so this Wyan, he was using other people's shipment to get his own drugs delivered inside. Cory shook his head, it wasn't only drugs. The gets all kinds of things like, stolen artifacts that Medrones prefer, animals, things like that. Anything that people want and is possible for Wyna to get.

I see, so he is importing stuff we don't want. We banned these stuff on the island because we don't want to mix in with Medrone culture and instead promote on relearning our lost heritage. We have allowed simple harmless possession, like we definitely borrowed human technology, but not these things that impact Medrone culture. I didn't realize that there are people desperate enough to smuggle stuff here. Nathan signals something to Rose, she asks, do you also get something for your corporation Cory. You don't strike me as man in it for money.

Cory makes a gleeful smile, of course, I am not like the other two who were just in it for the money. I protect his shipments whenever it comes, from the security gate to the time its delivered to the client, in exchange I get the treatment for my condition. I see, that makes sense, If I remember correctly, coming to earth has burnt his taste buds. Back in Valley I vaguely remember him taking some sort of injections for a temporary sensation. Rose asks, I suppose it was difficult for you to live here with more Medrone cuisine culture coming back, but not able to taste it.

Cory replies, but don't worry. I don't give a crap about it, as long as I am with you, I don't want to taste anything, only you. My face distorts in disgust. She has turned him into a slobbering love sick freak. He is obsessed with her now. But Rose didn't mind at all. In fact she was enjoying the attention, oh my poor pet. You need to be spanked properly. Cory brights up with lust in his eyes. Nathan clears his throat and Rose asks, right, so who are these clients. He says, don't know. I never know their identities. I just keep guard at a certain drop points and when its picked up, my work is done. I never get to see who they were.

She asks, who has the information. Does you boss Wyan has. Cory immediately scoffs, that guy is careful, even he didn't want to know who the clients are. The only one who keeps a record is Jade. She keeps a digital file locked in somewhere, arranges for the communication between Wyan and clients. Only she knows their identities. Just like Wyna, Jade is also here in the detention center. That's good. With both of them in custody, we will get all the information about their smuggling network.

Seeing how undetectable they have been all this time, this incident actually helped us uncover a big smuggling operation like this. This is bad, but also good. Even if the timing is not ideal, we still got everything we need to dismantle their operation now. Nathan leans in closer whisper something to Rose. Cory becomes enraged as he got closer to Rose and begins to shout at him. I tuned out most it because it was same thing over an over again. Instead I mulled over the actions I will need to do with this information.

Rose then asks, what happened today. With such a carefully crafted organization, its so strange that so many would gather in one place. Cory nods, I never met so many people working with Wyan before today. But it was an emergency. I don't know what it was initially, they just wanted the 3 of us to guard them and some crates we had brought a week ago. Later I pieced it together that someone is steeling from the smuggled goods. We don't guarantee complete order to our clients, because there are always some risks, unforeseen accidents or issues in transport. But we still maintain a minimum. Lately, the drugs we smuggle were under the acceptable margin loss.

Someone was steeling from them. That must be enough of a reason to have them congregate together like this. Rose asks, someone was a tad bit greedy huh. Did you find out who it was. Cory shrug his shoulders, I don't know. I was only guarding the place, they all were talking inside. All though, I kept hearing people shouting or accusing someone time to time. So I guess they were still trying to figure it out. Nathan signals something to Rose. She asks, if they were trying to root out the traitor, does that mean that women Elina, the who was hurt was the culprit. Did they decide to eliminate her.

I gulp a little hearing this question. Nathan is basically asking if they would be bold enough to straight up murder the culprit. Cory replies, I don't know if she stole from us. But I could tell she wasn't a part of us. Rose asks, then what was she and her brother doing there. Cory says, I saw one of the guys, Peter, I think his name, left the treatment plant and brought back those two. I was hesitant to let outsiders in, but Quintin said Wyan summoned them.

Hold on, I took out the list of people we are holding and there is no one named Peter. Was this an alias. It could be. I don't like where this is heading though. Rose asks, why were they called. Cory answers, I didn't know initially. I was little anxious that a kid was brought here. So I stood a little closer to the window from the 1st floor and listened in. Turns out Peter brought his siblings to them. They were accusing them of steeling the drugs. That women kept denying, but everyone was sure it was one of them two for some reason.

This makes it even more confusing, we know Elina had a older brother, but he is not among the unconscious people we found. I quickly messaged Dan to confirm this. Rose was in middle of question to know if Cory had seen them before. Dan reads the message and says to Rose, chief wants to show him the list of the unconscious people faces and see if he recognized Peter among them. Cory immediately yells, get that hell away from her you freak. I will gut you and feed you to dogs. This a goddess and you are an eyesore.

Dan glared at Cory. He ignored him a second later, but I could tell he wanted to punch him. Cory says, oh, you want to go. Let me out and I will finish you in a second. Only I get to talk to my lady. Rose laughs hysterically, oh Cory. You are just too much. If I didn't find her voice to be useful to her Kuret, I would have just gagged her mouth. Nathan takes the tab from Dan and keeps it on the table in front of Cory. Rose says, Cory, be a dear and point out Peter among these.

Cory immediately yells, why. Am I enough. You don't need that rat. He is just a bottom feeder, I am more of use to you. She says, of course you are. I just want to know if he is an eyesore too. Cory was giddy by her comment and takes a look at the 11 people photos. A moment later he says, he isn't here. That rat must have escaped during the chaos. He is good at that. My suspicion was correct, he might be even responsible for Elina getting hurt. But would he hurt her own sister.

Nathan turns to me and says, Vanessa, if this guy isn't here. He might know what really happened. Cory was just a guard dog, but this one might have all the answers. I agreed with him. He then waves his hand to Rose. She asks, did he hurt Elina and ran ? Her own sister. Cory scoffs, the guy is nothing. He hasn't seen much fighting, let alone be violent. I couldn't see who actually hurt the women, but I ran inside when I heard her scream. The kid brother was bawling his eyes out beside her sister on the floor and I saw Peter covering at a corner.

Now we are getting to the real mystery of all they were knocked out. Rose asks, what happened then. Cory turns grim, its not important Rose. You shouldn't worry about stuff like this. Is he for real. I thought Rose would remain amused, but she wasn't. Her smile dropped and turn a little serious, you are resisting it. I must reassess my Kuret concentration. Nathan looks curiously at her. She answers, I could feel him pushing my Kuret a little, it could be because its getting weaker, but I suspect he is resisting about telling what happened to him. Its impressive he resisted this much even when I went all out.

Cory was a little subdued since he didn't shout at Nathan for speaking to Rose. Nathan asks, is that right. So I guess I also have to re examine him. What does mean for the interrogation though. Rose leans forward with her Kuret on her hand, not to worry. I just need to override his emotions again. She puts her palm on his jaws in an effort to make him love sick again. While it makes me happy that even Rose is struggling a little, it reminds me again that both he and Quintin are strong.

A while later Rose takes her hand off him, what. I could feel him fighting desperately. What a guy. He must really not want to tell us how he was beaten. She clicks her tongue in frustration. Nathan asks, no dice huh. She says, up until this point he didn't care too much about reveling about his organization. But I guess his warrior pride and ego is making him less suspectable to my Kuret. Seriously, he is clamping up about the real details. I waited for a little longer for Rose to try and get Cory talking.

But he kept resisting. I could tell even Rose was gradually becoming irritated. Nathen turns to me, looks like this might go longer. What should we do now Chief. I wonder about this. I messaged Dan and Errika with the next course of action. They both read the message and walk closer to them. Errika says, if we can't get answer from him right now. We can try to pry it from Quintin or Polly. Nathan says surprised, I thought for sure I would only get to talk to Cory. She is allowing to interrogate others too.

Dan says, that's right. Personally, I don't want to see this ridiculous performance, but I can't deny the results. Nathan nods while thinking. I didn't decide this lightly. I really didn't want him in IDF, but we already made an exception. While they both are annoying as hell, like Dan said, they were useful. Rose complains, yeah. No, I agreed for Cory. But not others. Errika says, why. You have somewhere more important need to be. Rose smiles, this place is depressing, kills my vibe.

She was being frivolous here. Nathan then says, it's a good opportunity to get some favors from them Rose. We were not allowed inside, but now we can open a line of communication. I was afraid he would think this way, but I guess I can't help it. Rose understood what it meant, really, like I might get to do this more often. That would be sweet. These two are getting ahead of themselves. Like hell I would make this a recurring thing. Dan cuts in, anyways. If we can't get more out of him, we will try with other two.

Nathan nods, sounds like a plan. This is good. I am so happy I got this opportunity to show our skills to you IDF people. I shook my head hopping I didn't do a mistake. After waiting for a while, someone steps into my viewing room. It was Somers. His face was still not fully healed, but he definitely looked better. He asks, any progress. I nod, yes. He was surprised, really. When I heard you allowed those two in, I thought it was a mistake. I raise my eyebrow at him.

He becomes defensive, no I just meant them being her caused a bit of stir. I understood his intention. I sigh, with Blake here I didn't want to seem petty. I felt a little guilty throwing the boss card, but I wasn't going to give any other excuse. Somers smiles, anyways. I wanted to tell what Elina just told us. I face him with anticipation. He briefly explained her story and how Peter was missing. I listened intently to him, aligning with the information I got

from Cory.

Then I told him about the smuggling operation they have been. He was shocked like me earlier, damn. So it wasn't just drugs. Elina must of heard or remembered only about the drugs. I say, this tracks with what I heard from Cory. We need to find Peter immediately. He says, Deni and I made the calls. We missed his Kuret earlier. But now I am sure Tessa must be on his trail. I answers, that’s good. But still we don't know how they were all knocked out.

We both waited as we listened to Rose grumbling when Cory would mumbles something to her questions, but nothing noteworthy. Then the door opens and Deni comes out, guys, I just got a call from Tessa that some guy named Peter just walked to the treatment site and wants to turn himself in. That made me and Somers anxious, but also hopeful. He says to me with a small smile, we got him.

Blake (Chapter 67)

Tuesday, January 6, 2026 21:53

I was very tiered, but the latest news about Peter kept me agitated. I sat on the lobby sofa waiting for Tessa to bring him in. I had another cup of coffee Kuritine to keep me going. Its 11:00 now. I didn't have much spare thoughts other than this chaos. But I took some time to think about the deadline David was talking about. I am very certain he was talking about something his discussion with Dr. Drew. Its going to be midnight soon. As much I want to go and check on David, I am needed here more. Besides, I can't do anything to help out David.

The door opens with Vanessa and Somers walking in. I get up from the couch anxious, is he here? Vanessa says, not yet. Tessa can't fly like us you know. Of course I know that, but I was too much agitated. I say, you heard about Elina's brother then. She nods while they both take a seat on the other couch. Vanessa then told me what she learned from Cory. I figured the scope of the organization may not be limited to just drugs.

I hesitantly ask, I am going to regret asking this, but did he say anything about weapons or anything close to fire power. She shook her head nervously, no. My expression became somber, so we can't rule that out. Somers says, but that doesn't mean they smuggled it. I mean why would you even want human weapons when we have Kuret. Vanessa answers for me, that's only if you talk about officers or warriors. Regular Medrones still would benefit from using guns.

I slump back on the couch thinking about the report Vanessa gave few months back. She probably recalled that as well, Blake, do you think the stash of weapons we found was given by Wyan too. That's exactly why I asked her. Somers says, wait I remember that now. Oh shit. Yeah, its possible. We found the weapons, but no Kuret signature, no one tying to it. I say, that's what worrying me. We need to get search Jades place and find that data and their clients.

Vanessa says, I just sent a team to Wyan and Jades home. We will find it soon. No matter how long it takes. I sigh, the silver lining of all this mess is that we uncovered a criminal gang. With the boss in custody and their very physical presence with a smuggled goods, they are caught red handed. They won't get away with this. Vanessa says, you got that right. We already have their Kuret signature all over the place, soon we will get forensic evidence with exact Kuret match too.

But it won't be so simple. I get a small headache thinking of all the backlash I would get from Citradel and other communities. We have to disclose this to public, no way I can keep a lid on this. If we can get all the clients and the smuggled goods, it will mitigate the uproar it would cause. Vanessa says, this is good Blake. We have a win here. I don't know how she was so optimistic here. But she did have a point. Its not a total loss. We caught this before Heraknus moved. Before Citradel or any other community moved.

I nod, yeah. I know. I was just thinking what I tell people. I don't want people to think we had no clue about this. Somers says, but we were all busy with the tournament. I shook my head, doesn't matter. There will always be things that keeps us busy. Echo attack, humans spy or whatever. We should always project strength for our Island city. Otherwise people will not come here. Vanessa says in low tone looking suddenly depressed, I didn't think that. Yeah, it would effect people morals too.

The mood was getting depressing. I jerk my body straight, its fine Vanessa. I wasn't accusing you or the IDF. Its just politics. People just need one flaw to assume the worst. But let me worry about it. You guys just focus on getting catching everyone involved. Vanessa aura flickered with a little guilt. I would tell her not to worry so much, but she is the chief of IDF, and would also share a little bit of burden. I don't want to make any promises to her so for now I just let her handle this on her own.

The door opens again. I jerked up again. Somers says, not yet Blake. I just asked for dinner. I had a chance to eat earlier while I was resting. So have most of the other crews. I am sure you both haven't eaten anything since our break. Two people come and place wrapped boxed on the table in front. I wasn't in any mood to eat, but I need to keep up my energy. Vanessa says, thanks guys. The people leave us to our dinner. I might not have been feeling hungry, but the first bite make me realize I was indeed hungry.

While we ate, I asked couple of things about Cory's interrogation. Then I realized Vanessa allowed Nathan and Rose to interrogate others. That momentarily made me amused, must have been tough to keep them both here. Vanessa makes a pouting face while she ate, you have no idea. I was never part of this back in Valley, so I never saw them in action before. But sheesh, they both were basically just hurling insults at him to rile him up. I thought it only works in theory, but they somehow made it work.

I could imagine. Its not just about riling up. Its getting to a point slowly where they will slip up the most. I ask, are you okay with them without your supervision then. She says, I left Dan and Errika to keep an eye on them. They are quite effective and because those two are behaving for now. Somers laughs, you were just annoyed with them and didn't want to deal with them more. She shot a look at him. Somers gets his smile cut down from her glare. That's probably true.

Vanessa sighs, I am worried about one thing though. They both going to cash in this favor for something. I don't know what though. And that terrifies me. I help her out, don't worry about that. Since I asked you to let them in, I will take care of it. Vanessa snickers, I was thinking about letting you handle them anyways. She really didn't want to manage Nathan or Rose. Its not her fault though, I am sure she must not want to recall her time with them in Valley.

About 10 minutes later Somers gets a ping his phone. This was it, finally. Somers check it and faces us, Tessa is here. They just arrived in a car outside. All of us wasted no time and prepared ourselves to get real answers. Vaness leads us into a separate interrogation room she asked earlier. This cell is similar to the one the warriors were put in, but was less secure. Didn't matter though, with me and Vanessa present inside and desperate for answers, there is nothing he could do.

Vanessa asked Somers to keep everyone out. She says, they are free to view from the window wall, but make sure no one disturb us while we talk to peter. Only in case of any emergency, Somers will come inside. Somers agrees with her and coordinates the crowd growing outside. I took the seat on the left and waiting for Peter to come in. Behind us I could see Nathan's aura coming from the other side. He was there too. I don't see Rose's Kuret though. Vanessa saw me looking at the wall.

She asks, you looking for something. I ask, Nathan's here. Can't see Rose. She is like prepping Peter or something like that. I don't think we need to do that since Peter came in willingly. She took a seat next to me, no. Rose got tiered and asked to take a break. She is resting in some room. Her expression becomes sour, I allowed one specific waiting room, but my god. Guys were gooning hard on her. They have been offering to help her, moving the couch or getting her food.

I know this was tense situation, but it was a little funny. I ask, I assume you have her surveilled though. She waves her hand, I wouldn't be here if I hadn't taken care of it. I was very cautious of them in the beginning. Setting aside their attitude, they are not causing problems. So I think its fine for now. The conditions you gave still apply though. They both are not allowed to use their Kuret. I guess they have garnered enough trust for this much from her.

With that out of the way, I gathered my thoughts about the task in hand. A minute later Peter was brought in. He was wearing casual jeans a T shirt. His hair was a mess,, face was covered in some light bruises, dirt on his clothes, but no wounds. I was expecting him to be more injured. He is not an alpha, so he wouldn't have healed already. So it means he wasn't injured to begin with. Did he really escape from a situation where 3 warriors were beaten.

Tessa was bringing him in. She had his arm grabbed as she brought her to the chair in front of us. Up close I could see his eyes agitated. His aura was completely drenched with guilt and fear. A little bit of shame too. Vanessa asks, any problem bringing him here. Tessa says, no. He never spoke a word on the ride here. Never gave a response to any questions I asked. He looks to the both of us with fear. Vanessa glared at him more closely than me. Tessa says, though he did ask about Elina and Ryan once we stepped inside the building. I didn't tell him anything, I didn't have the updates on her condition.

I nod, thanks Tessa. We will take it from here. She takes a final look at the fidgeting Peter and leaves us. Vanessa was still trying to figure him out. I say, Elina is fine. Ryan too. They both are resting in the infirmary. That made his aura less worried. He was visibly less tense too hearing about his sibling. Vanessa asks, you shouldn't have involved them. You knew your sisters has a medical condition. Yet you risked her. The doctor said she got lucky we got her in time.

His mouth twitches as he heard that. He says with a meek voice, I want to see her. Vanessa shook her head, she is sleeping right now. Besides, I have a feeling she doesn't want to see to you. His eyes avert us and he slouches her head a little. I ask, if you are so worried about her, why did you ran ? You should have stayed with your siblings. Your sister nearly died and you let your brother fending for himself. He didn't respond or made any movement, but his aura showed more shame.

Vanessa asks, we know all about the smuggling organization you are part of. Your criminal friends, including your boss Wyan is in our custody. Soon we get the records of all the things you illegally brought into the island and for whom. There is nothing you all can do now that we have caught you all literally five feet away from a smuggled drugs. Staying silent doesn't help you at all. Just tell us what happened and you might be able to some lighter punishment.

Our judicial system isn't really impartial right now, its more like a tribunal. We don't have lawyers or advocates for people to defend or make a case. I had hoped we be ready with a defined administration before we run into things like this. We have to consult with Citradel on how they handle this since their people are also mixed in this. Regardless, their crimes are now apparent. The only question is how much offense they did. Peter suddenly becomes grim. I see his aura changing.

He snaps quietly, It's easy for you all to judge me a coward. But what could I done then. His demeanor changes to anger and slams his fist on the table in front. I prepared a little bit of Kuret in my palm just he in case he got agitated and needed to be restrained. Vanessa saw me and raised her hand to me, no need. I release my Kuret realizing he was just frustrated not mad. He continues, you all have seen battle. Fought wars, seen people die. I have only heard stories. What could a normal person do in a situation like this. I ran because I didn't want to die.

I read his records. He and his siblings came from community that had remained hidden and safe for decades until coming here. I can imagine that it would be a normal reaction for civilians. But that's not the case. I say, don't give a weak excuse like that. I would understand if it were outside the island, where you had no one to help you. But here, you could have called for help. Alert some officer. Instead you ran, leaving your sisters in pool of her blood. Your brother Ryan, let me tell you, was even more terrified than you right now. But he did what you didn't. So don't sit here and give an excuse saying you are weak.

That shut his unreasonable anger down. Vanessa adds on, you ran because you didn't want to get caught. Plain and simple. He didn't have any counter to this. I sensed his aura shifting to more shame. At least he sees himself now. She asks, but lets leave your reasons for others to decide. We only want to know what happened tonight. I lean in closer, and why you turned yourself in. You had a headstart, we didn't know about you. So you could have

ran, though for how long that would have been is questionable.

He remained silent. We waited for few seconds, but the only thing filling up this room was his ragged breathing. I break the silence, your problems are not going away by being silent. Vanessa went with a different tactic, you know, its not just you that is in trouble. You sister is also in trouble. While she is a victim, it was her shipments that was used to smuggle products. Now, she didn't know, but she should have. Because she didn't inspect her own items carefully. No matter how much she defends, she will suffer some consequence of your actions.

She was purposefully singling Elina out. Its debatable whether Elina would be punished, but there no doubt that even if she was completely innocent, there will be some problems. Her brother is a criminal, and this is a relatively small society for people to forget that. Peter becomes anxious listening to her, she has nothing to do with this. Neither does Ryan. Vanessa says with stern voice, unfortunately its guilt by association. People can argue you both were in on it. Especially with the in fighting about the solen products.

He snarls, she was hurt. Shis is clearly the victim here. How can you going to blame this on her. Vanessa answers, you care for your siblings, however little it may be. I suggest you use that feeling to take the blame for everything. That’s the only way she remains safe. Vanessa was pushing him hard to take responsibility. I thought she was going a little to far, but she was just trying to get him to open up using his sister as a threat. Could have done a different way, but it works either way.

He grits his teeth hard thinking. I say, this is simple. You confess that it was your own idea to use Elina. She was just a patsy. You tell us everything what you know and what happened tonight. Leave nothing. Only then she will remain safe. He asks, can you promise. I turn to Vanessa. She says, no. But we can help reduce the damage. We have your boss, so you will not charged for the entire criminal operation. Maybe some, but not whole. That will also help lessen any punishment on Elina.

He thinks about it for long time. I was confused about something, isn't this why you turned yourself. To take responsibility. Or was it for something else. He closes his eyes like he was trying to hide away. But there is no place to hide. He just has cold feat, I can see it clearly from his aura. Soon his emotions crumble and becomes defeated. His eyes had lost the last hints of hope and says, did you talk to Wyan. Vanessa looks at me and gives a nod signaling he was done holding back.

She says, tell us your story. Forget what Wyan might have said. Its the right call to not tell him anything and here his version first. He shook his head, I thought I would make something of myself by joining him. I don't know how it came to this. He takes a deep breadth, 7 months ago he came to me in our shop. He heard from somewhere that I used to be a smuggler when we were staying in Alaska. He wanted my skills. I didn't believe him at first. I only did it because it was necessary for survival. We were living here, not just surviving. He told his vision and I believed, he chokes a little, no, I wanted to be more than what I was.

I got curious, was your life so unsatisfied that you wanted more, even if it was risky and unnecessary. He says, you don't understand. I was respected in my community. I made things happen. People would barter things in exchange of my skills. Things that I can do for Elina and Rory. He scoffs, all that changed when we came here. Suddenly we weren't alone. So many people, so many communities. Soon my own name was forgotten by the people who I came with.

I was realizing his motivation for this. Its sad that it was as basic as respect and power. I guess he was missing the life he used to have. Vanessa asks, so you joined Wyan. And came with a way to use Elina's shipment. He doesn't deny it, it was the best plan. She was always good with people and trusting. I didn't like lying to her. But she wasn't getting hurt. It didn't impact our business. No was getting hurt. His hands turns to first, must have realized that was not true anymore.

Vanessa asks, so for months you used Elina shipments to smuggle goods. Everything was running without anyone noticing. I am embarrassed to say even we didn't know about this. She pauses a little to hide the frustration she felt. I didn't want her to feel more of it so I help out, what changed. Why did someone steal from the smuggled goods. He turns slowly to me with a curious look. I answers, we know about that too. We know everyone was accusing Elina of steeling. That's how she got hurt.

He closed his eyes in anger, like trying to avoid taking about it. But there's no point in stopping now. A moment later he opens his eyes and says, I don't know. Wyan made sure everyone knew the risk of stealing from ourselves. No one would dare steal things that would spell doom. Vanessa scoffs, be honest. You stole it, didn't you. You used your family as a cover to hide it. And they paid it for your greed. The thought did cross my mind too. Several times. He just said that he ample experience with smuggling, won't be a stretch to find he has experience in steeling too.

That made him defensive, no. He puts his palm on the table to make a point, I might be a thief, but won't risk Elina and Ryan like that. I didn't steal anything. They all just zeroing to me always because I knew of the shipment time and place. But they were convinced I used Elina or Ryan to steal from them. They were very angry and so I had no choice but to bring her to them. I was trying to protect my family, who knows what they would have done I didn't do that. They could have sent Cory, Quintin or Polly to them. And not just to talk. I wasn't going to let that happen. So I had to make a tough decision.

Vanessa was half right then. He did use his siblings as cover, just not to lie but as truth. She looks at me to get a confirmation. His aura was clear, he was telling the truth. I nod in response. She asks him, then who stole it. He puts his hands on his temple, I have no freaking clue. Everyone kept accusing me, Elina, each other, but no one knows who stole it, and how they stole it. I ask, how can you be so sure it wasn't someone in your group. He answers, maybe. But what's the point in stealing drugs from us. We could always smuggle in more. Why risk it.

Honestly, he made a point. We also discussed about the reasons for this. I was hopping Peter would know more. But he is also doesn't know. Vanessa asks, fine. Lets table on who stole it. Lets revisit tonight's event. Explain what happened. And don't leave anything, for your and Elina's sake. She was right to move on from this topic. He becomes anxious when recalling the event, I tried to explain it wasn't Elina or Ryan. I wanted to clear that suspicion and let them go.

He grits his teeth, I didn't even care at that point on how I would make Elina explain this and not report us. I just didn't want them to hurt the two of them. I thought they would just scare her and once they saw she knew nothing, they would release her and Ryan. Then it went all wrong. The freakier Grover got angry after Ryan kicked him and used his Kuret on Elina. His Kuret isn't that powerful, but he was close enough to injure with his thread Kuret.

He slams his fist on the table in anger, the bastard. Not only he ignored the rules about not using Kuret and leave evidence. He also hurt someone not part of the operation. Everyone were panicking seeing Elina bleeding, Ryan crying over beside her. I was in shock, frozen, unable to do anything. He puts both his arm on top of his head as he slouches forward, people were shouting, confused, accusing Grover of messing up. All I could hear was Ryan crying in the background.

He dugs his finger into his hair and grabs it in anger, like trying to rip out the pain of the memory. He continues, that’s when all hell broke loose.

Vanessa (Chapter 68)

Wednesday, January 7, 2026 20:08

I should have remained calm when I heard Peter reasons to join Wyan. What he did was nothing short of arrogance and power hungry move. I felt betrayed thinking how I failed to make the city safe. I have been trying to protect people for more than a decade. And when we do finally achieve some semblance of stability, there still are people who aren't satisfied with this place. Before I get sucked into frustration, I pull myself together. Its only people like him, not everyone. There are many people who are happy that they are here now.

Then we got to know that Elina hurting was a rash and reckless move by this Grover character with no real meaning. We still don't know who stole from them. But I decided to instead focus on learning what happened next. I ask after listening to his somber voice, what do you mean by that. He takes a moment to answer, It became pitch black, like the light went out. And I started to hear people screaming and struggling. I slid to behind a pillar at the corner scared to hear someone was fighting.

I make a quick glance at Blake. He was also eager to this part. Peter says, I heard people crying out in pain and shouting. I even heard people dropping to the ground. He visibly shakes as he tugs on his hair. I ask, someone was fighting you guys? He raises his head back to us, no. It wasn't a fight, it was a slaughter. I couldn't see anything in the dark, even when I unconsciously used Kuret in my eyes, I didn't understand what was going on. I saw people attacking. Some begin to use their Kuret to protect, some used to fight, but one by one everyone we were getting cut down.

Blake asks with stern expression, how many people did you see. Peter says, I don't know man. It was crazy. I don't even know if we were attacked by others. It could have been 5 or 50. I could only see the Kurets of people I work with. This is not what I wanted to hear. I ask, then they were fighting each other. Peter gulps hard with confusion on his face, hell if I know. I just knew one thing, people were fighting with their Kuret and still getting knocked out.

Then I saw a Jade falling near me. She was close enough to see her wounded. It was too much, so I ran. I become enraged hearing that, you mean you left your sister and brother in the middle of a fight. He shows his teeth to me, I told you. I don't do violence. At the moment I just wanted to run away. I would have gotten her help once I was away.

I don’t know about that. But he did turn himself in, so maybe he wasn't a total wimp. Blake asks, I am still confused. Were people fighting each other or not. Did someone attack you all. Peter replies, like I told you, it was chaos. He looks away from us, but now that I think about it. Its possible some was double crossing us. Maybe seeing Elina hurt made them angry. My eyes sharpen at that and yell out, someone grew a consciousness after berating a defend less women. Ha, I don't think so. Stop lying.

He jerks at me, I am not. Some people were not happy how Wyan was handing this situation. Making me bring Elina and Ryan to them and exposing our operation. I know that the Citradel guy Tod wasn’t happy and kept accusing Wyan of not keeping his promise of no internal conflict. I told you right, people were accusing each other. So I don’t know, maybe some people lost it when Elina got hurt and they attacked others. Blake says, a dissention among the criminals. Not entirely impossible.

I shook my head, but how come everyone was knocked out then. Someone would have escaped. No way they would all knock each other out in a mutual destruction. Blake nods, that is also true. Somethings not adding up here then. I ask Peter, what about the 3 warriors then. They were supposed to be guarding you all. Even if no one come from outside, they would have stepped in and stop the fight. Peter somehow becomes even more somber. He says meekly, as I was crawling back to the exit I heard them rushing in and shouting something to us. I don’t know what they were saying, someone had started fighting with a Kuret that made lot of noise. But then.

He croaks a little now. I prod him, what. What happened to them. He says, I am not sure why, but they were also attacking each other. My head starts to hurt now. I lean back on my chair trying to understand what he just said. Blake shrieks, are you kidding me. You are saying not only you all, but the 3 warriors were fighting each other. Peter became frustrated, yes. I am telling the truth. I can't even begin to understand what I saw. Their kurets were clashing in the dark.

This is crazy, the warriors also turned on each other. Blake leans to me and whispers, do you think those 3 saw everyone fighting and started a brawl amongst themselves thinking a double cross was going on. As ridiculous as that sounds, it makes sense. Blake didn't mention that Peter was lying, so our sole witness did see people fighting amongst themselves. I shook my head and ask Peter still confused, again, how in the hell all 3 were lying unconscious in the end. It might be possible for all of you to knock each other out, however unlikely, its not impossible. But the same for the 3 high ranking warriors. Now that’s not incomprehensible. Someone must have attacked.

Peter didn't give an answer. He was silent and trembling slightly, likely recalling the fear he felt from hours ago. Blakes says, I can't believe that too. Someone must have intervened. That’s the only explanation. Peter answers, I don't know. I have no freaking clue who was fighting who. I got impatient, so let me get this straight. You don't know who attacked, or why or how. I don't like your chances in the tribunal. Peter gets angry, that’s the truth. What more do you want from me. Ask others when they wake up. Ask those 3 crazy warriors. Why do you keep asking me like I attacked them. I did nothing, I just ran.

His outburst ended him in heaving heavily. He even started to get sweat on his forehead. I turn to Blake. He was analyzing Peter for a long time. Then he turns to me and nods at me. Dammit. So he is telling the truth. Nothing about this makes sense. I ask Blake, we still didn't find any evidence anyone else involved. The only people we can account for here in this building. So someone attacked and still no one attacked. That's crazy. Blake ask, are there more members of your gang. It can't be only these many people.

Peter steadies himself a little, there are some more. But they don't know much about us. They are hired for intermediate work, getting supplies, choosing locations for drop offs, stuff like that. I ask, what about other warriors. Were there more than just 3. Peter stares hard at the table for a while, Wyan had called everyone important. He got all us, the main people in one place. He wouldn't risk our security in case something goes wrong. He trails off, I didn't think about it till now, but yeah. Its possible he had some more people he never told anyone. As an insurance. He does that sort thing, have backup plans.

He then immediately jerks to me, does that mean those freaks attacked us. I didn't know for sure. But seeing so much distrust amongst them, it would make sense their boss would also keep things. We will only get the truth from Wyan about this then. But then I had a thought, even if that’s true. Why they leave Wyan and others like this. Leave the drugs in the crates lying for us to find. At least they should have taken Jade, she was the one who keep tracks of all your criminal activities. Blake offers a theory, I don't know if this makes sense, but Ryan had called for help during all this chaos. Maybe realizing officers will be arriving, they left in a hurry.

He made a plausible argument. I say with a confused tone, so a group of people attacked them, without leaving a trace and left in hurry not caring about Wyan or drugs. Blake says, or maybe leaving it for us to find. Can't be sure of anything right now. The only thing we know for sure is fighting started when Elina got hurt and ended when all of them were unconscious. Maybe they took something else from them. Maybe something incriminating, like wiping off their identities.

I recalled the personal artifacts we got from the people here, more specifically what wasn't there. I say, they don't have phones on them. So yeah, its possible it was taken. Especially Wyans. His might have contact or at least give us clues about their identities. I turn to Peter, did they have phones with them when you met them. Peter thinks for a moment and then nods, yeah. We all had to shut it down and keep our phones in a sealed box. I say, we didn't find any box or phones on the scene Blake. It must be taken then.

Blake thinks for a moment, I thought they just didn't bring it with them for security reasons. But its more likely they were taken. He then turns to Peter, what else. They hid there presence so well. They either fought everyone or caused everyone to fight each other. They could have some other goals too. Peter shook his head, I can't think of anything that would be tied to us. The phones are encrypted. Wyan bragged a long time ago that even if it gets stolen, no one be able to crack the encryption. We brought nothing important with us in the end. He then takes a moment, except for the drugs.

And that’s the item still lying in that treatment plant. I ask Blake, does this make any sense. He makes a defeating laugh. He then stands up and walks to the other side of the wall, I can't make heads or tails of this. We are now suspecting someone attacked, but have zero evidence of anyone else. Peter says everything was dark, so I doubt others would say anything different when we wake them up. The warriors might enlighten us more, unless they also say that 3 of them fought each other. He then looks to others on the other side of the glass. Do you think that’s why Cory was refusing telling how he got beat. They fought each other.

I pushed my chair a little back and clasp my hands on one knee, maybe. Rose did say she that Cory might have hurt his pride and that makes it strong enough to resist her. If I got in a fight with 2 other warriors that somehow resulted in all of us knocking each other out, or someone intervened to take advantage of a wounded people, I would be pissed too. Blake rests on the wall on his back, true enough. Since the phones are disappeared, someone was definitely there. But that’s it. Nothing else.

I add, it could have been also taken before or after the fight. It was kept in a sealed box, so stealing it would be easy. Blake shrugs, could have happen anytime. He sighs, but it doesn't matter. Once they see that its encrypted, two things will happen. They will try to erase their names and anything incriminating after breaking into it. Or they just destroy it. We lose information either way. I shook my head, so it’s a dead end then. He says, unless we uncover who are these people. Lets hope someone can remember and tell us who they are.

He didn't seem confident. Actually, neither was I. Everyone were fighting each other and someone took advantage of it. We don't know if it were part of the criminal gang or not. I say, lets wake up Wyan and interrogate him. If he really hired others, we will make him tell us. Blake says, that’s well and good, but without them tying to the scene its just a blame game. No evidence, not a video of them outside, no eye witness. No way to prove they were ever in the fight. Whoever they are, they are really good at covering their tracks.

I had the same thoughts. I turn to check on Peter. He wasn't even listening to us. Just gazing down at the table, looking tense. Well, we aren't going to answer about that right now. I say, lets set aside that. I just have one last thing to ask you. You escaped successfully from the treatment plant. You weren't being chased or hunted by anyone. Why did you come back to the place you ran from, after hours. Peter looks at me with heavy eyes. He was so tiered, mentally, I could guess the reason before he said it. He says, guilt. I ran and hid at a construction site. I was there for long time. My thoughts gnawing at me. I knew it wouldn't be long until you come looking for me.

I kept seeing Elina on that dark floor. Ryan beside her. I didn't even know if she was made it alive from there. I thought of running so may times, but where would I even go. Even if I somehow scape the patrol borders in the sea, the island is far from any mainland. Fleeing wasn't an option. Hiding wasn't an option. I had nothing. I gave up in the end. If I was going to be caught, I at least make sure Elina and Ryan are safe. I don't know he was trying to get sympathy from us. But he did seem exhausted. And he wasn't wrong about no other option. Turning himself was the only non lethal option. He doesn't look like the suicidal type, not with family.

I glance at Blake. It didn't take much time for him to say, looks like the truth. It must have been eating at him until he couldn't bear it. I nod, a simple answer for this at least. I ask, so we still don't know who stole from them and who intervened. Is it possible they are the same people? Blakes laughs mockingly, wouldn't that make it much simpler for all of us. That was indeed wishful thinking on my part. Blake says, anyways. We made a lot of assumptions and theories. Lets not make it worse. We will wait for others to wake up and first confirm what Peter was said was the truth.

That’s was reasonable. Peter cuts in, what happens to me now. I answer, you go to a holding cell with others. We will move you all into individual cells. If they all were really fighting each other, its best to keep you all separated. He didn't resist or complain. He says, before I go, I want to see Elina and Ryan. I want to see for myself that they are okay. I turn to Blake. I didn't want to make any decision for this. Because my answer was already decided, he shouldn't be even near them.

Blake says, not tonight. Maybe tomorrow. I will ask Elina once she has recovered enough to make a decision. If she agrees, it will be under strict supervision and for few minutes only. You have traumatized your sister and brother enough for tonight, I don't want to hurt them further by showing your pitiful state. Best you also gather yourself before showing up in front of them. Blake was really being considerate of their feelings. I agreed to this as well.

Peter had no choice but to accept whatever Blake offered. He slouches back on his chair and relents, I can't believe all this happened because someone stole from us. He scorns, only if they left it alone, nothing like this would have ever happened. He was being delusional here, if it wasn't this incident, then something else would have happened. Be thankful that no one died. You say you haven't seen any fighting on the outside. This was quaint compared to real hell we some of us have been through. So don't think for a second this was not your fault.

He shook his head, our operation was air tight. You said it yourself didn't you, we went undetected for months. If the drugs weren't stolen this wouldn't have happened. I almost got up from my chair in anger, but I controlled myself. Because he was right. It hurt and he was just saying to spite us. But its clear we weren't paying enough attention. They used the perfect moment to do this, when all of us were busy with the tournament. He then faces me, I still can't believe some freakier had the balls to steal from us. I can't understand why. I don't even understand why steal these drugs. We could have just been hired to bring more of it. He grits his teeth, instead they go and steal some drugs that are not even that important. Just some weird drugs MCTL and Hetrox. I don't even know what they can be used for.

His anger was clear on his face and directly on the person who stole from them. I think we are done with him. I stand up from the chair, Blake, I think we are done with Peter now. Should we. I was interrupted by Blake, hold on. His voice was grim. I turn to him. His face had became suddenly serious. He asks, what was stolen. I was confused. What happened. Did he know something. Peter also confused says, I told you. Some other client had ordered these two drugs, MCTL and Hetrox. We were preparing for a scheduled drop off. But it went missing about 3 weeks from before. We only got to know now due a backlog. Nothing else was stolen, only.

Suddenly the table in front of me flew off. What the hell. Blake's demeanor changed a whole 180. He just used his Kuret to throw the table to the side. I took a few steps back from him when I saw how mad he got. His eyes fueled with Kuret and anger. The other person who was more shocked than me was Peter. He stumbles down along the chair and hits the ground. Before I asked Blake what happened he extended his arms and threw his Kuret around Peter. He picked up a terrified Peter and levitated him towards him.

I shout, Blake, what the hell are you doing. He ignored me. He had a murderous look on him. Peter struggling in the air flies straight into Blakes arms. Blakes catches Peter from the neck and slams him to the wall. Peter struggles under Blakes grip. I ran to him, what are you doing. Blake yells, tell me who that client was. Blakes grip tighten on Peter. What just happened. What's going on, I scream at him. Peter had wrapped his hand on Blakes arm, trying to push it away.

Its pointless. Blake was using his Kuret, at this rate Blake was going to crush him. I shout, let him go Blake. What's gotten into you. Blake turns to me with an angry expression, don't tell me you forgot. I ask, I don't understand. Forgot what. He turns to a now red flushed Peter, those two drugs were found in the poisoned drinks I and Marina got in our semi final matches. Its because of this guy that Marina almost died. If David hadn't warned her, the poison might have reached her heart.

It then hit me. I recalled the meeting we had with others when David said he found poison in their drinks. We were all confused as to how such sophisticated designer drug was created inside the island. Now I realized what really, happened. It wasn't created here, it was smuggled here. This made me mad. I shout, you. Because of you Marina had to use her overdrive. If it weren't for that poison, then. I don't know what I was going to say. I still lost to Marina. But what devasted me was learning that she only used her overdrive because she was poisoned. I might have still lost against her, but I wanted her to user overdrive to defeat me, not because she had no other choice.

Blake grips tightens on Peters neck. His skin was not getting bruised under the pressure Blake was putting him on, because of your selfish desire for making a name, someone used you to sabotage the tournament. They almost succeeded. One of my closest friend suffered from that poison. The one you gave. Peter begins to choke. Blake spats out, I was also almost poisoned with it. I somehow avoided it, Marina didn't. All because of you. I could just feel Blakes anger from his voice.

I was furious too. I should stop Blake before Peter gets hurt. But I couldn't do it. I wanted to him to show Peter some more terror. But then the door opens and people flood in. Blake, get off of him. It was Tessa who barged in. She came rushing with Somers behind her. Blake was not about to let him go, not before he tells me who that client is. Tessa says panicked, he doesn't know. Only Jade has that information. You know that already. He doesn't know anything.

Blake did know. He just didn't care. It was personal for him. It was for me too. Finally Blake listens to reason and let goes Peter. Peter slumps down and gasps for air. He hits the ground and tries to crawl away from the murderous look Blake was giving him. Somers comes from the side and grabs Peter, come on. Get up. Peter was choking on his own neck and trying to get away from Blake. So much so that he practically ran into Somers arms. Somers says firmly, settle down. You will be fine. Peter had teary eyes and horrified expression. Somers says to us, its not a good idea to have him here. I will take him to his cell.

I wish I also had the chance to wring his neck too. But I shouldn't. I managed a nod in my frustration. Somers carrying a whimpering Peter out of the room. Blake was pacing a little bit around the room with his hands turned to a fist, trying to calm down. Tessa says to me, are you good. I wasn't sure how to answer that. I was angry and irritated at this mess. But we all have a job to do. I centered myself and say, yeah. Sorry. I should have stopped Blake. But when I heard about the drugs, I got mad.

Tessa hesitantly looks at Blake who was trying to calm himself down. She says, its personal. I imagine it was hard not to blame him. I am surprised she was understanding instead of reprimanding our behavior. I am glad she didn't judge us. I say, I guess we aren't that different from Cory. We lost our mind when someone interferes with our fights. If it weren't for Peter, Marina wouldn't have been poisoned. She wouldn't have risked getting injured. My match would have been different. Same for Blake.

Tessa says, like I said. I understand why its personal. People like us can't forgive something like this. Blake takes the chair that was fallen and sits on it. We both approach him. Tessa asks, I know its not fair to ask, but lets not have another burst like this in front of entire IDF. Blake had visibly calmed down now. He turns towards the glass wall. I am sure many wouldn't have mind seeing more of it. But in the end, it's not good image for Blake. He sighs, I just lost it. We investigated the incident weeks ago, but when nothing came up and with the upcoming final match, I just sort of put it aside. Now realizing that these bunch of criminals were responsible for so many thing, I couldn't let it slide again.

Like me, he was frustrated with the outcome of the matches. Tessa says, no need to explain to me Blake. Like I told Vanessa here, when its personal for us, its not something we can control. He says, Marina almost died due that poison. Under my watch. Of course I am taking it personal. A moment later he says, though maybe I shouldn't shown my petty side in front of an audience. Especially when Nathan is among them. I totally forgot he was here too. Dammit, he would be having a laugh from this.

Tessa says, look guys. Its late. You all had long day, obviously tiered. Go home and rest. I will stay back and take control of the situation. I shook my head, no. I can't leave now. We still have so much to do. Talk to Wyan. Blake stood up now, and Jade. I need to find who was that client. Tessa raises her hand, and I will. But not when you are rearing to kill. You need rest. Both of you. Just then Nathan comes in. Great, another annoying guy just walked in. Behind him Dan walked.

Dan says worried, apologies chief. I tried to stop him, but he just barged in. I tried, but. Nathan says, don't blame the poor guy. He is good but not good enough to stop me. Besides, I only left your watchful eyes into a group of even more cautious looking people. So I traded into a more restrictive group of people. I didn't have the patience to talk to him, leave us Nathan. He says, not yet. I have something to say to you. Actually, all of you. He turns to Blake, it might be worth your while.

Blakes looks around us. Then he faces him back, is it so important that you would risk your temporary privilege. Nathan smiles, of course. Blake says, fine. Its not like you are causing issue to others. We are used to your antics anyways. He shook his head at me. I reluctantly agreed, yeah fine. Dan you can leave us. He can't do much here anyways. Dan looks a little nervous leaving but he does anyways. Nathan cuts in, also ask others to leave. Only for a few minutes. It weird he wants to keep it private. It didn't matter much though. Dan waited for me agree. I waved my hand signaling its fine. Dan leaves the three of us.

A minute later he says, that was the last person to leave. Now I can talk. Tessa asks, why not ask us in a officers room. Why here. Nathan says, I don't like those rooms. I laugh, you what. Why. Afraid of the décor. Nathan smiles, I don't. But that’s not the point, someone could hear us. Blake says, what, like some bugged the officers room. Paranoid much. Nathan says, you said it not me. I shook my head. We do routine sweeps of the place. There are no bugs.

Nathan says, lets leave it at that. I just want to salute your rare show of anger Blake. That even made me surprised. You keep you cool most the time, I get to see you like this after months. Blake didn't appreciate called out like this, do you have something actual to say or just want to me to throw you out. Nathan mocks, very touchy. Though I guess anyone would be. Tessa says, then get to the point. Nathans says, all right. Since none you seem to have realized, I want share my thoughts.

I ask, about what. He says, you both were not able to see what's right there in front of you. Huh. I got impatient, look. Its been a long day. I am tried, I don't have time to play your stupid games. Just tell us what you mean. I can other were also feeling the same. Nathan looks at with strange looks, really. Not one of you thought who was behind tonight's drama. Blake asks, what. You mean the client who ordered those drug. You know who it could be.

Nathan shook his head, not about that. I got no clue who it is. But I know for certain that the its not same as who stole the phones or made a mockery of criminals or the warriors. Teesa says, how can you be so sure. We have no evidence, no witness. Nothing. He must be just making things up. Or maybe he has some insider knowledge. Nathan clicks his tongue, the lack of evidence is the evidence itself. Come on, do I need to spell it out myself who was the orchestrator of tonight's fight.

Blake steps forward, don't tell me its you. I am in no mood for a joke. I had a strange feeling he was building up so much suspense to reveal himself as the culprit. He laughs, I am honored you think so highly of me. But no. It couldn't be me. Even I would really struggle to fight those 3. And even if I wasn't alone, no way I can avoid erasing any Kuret. At least not in short time I had. But since you asked, who do you think could do it. I am puzzled what does he mean.

Tessa asks, it would have to be a group of strong people. I don't know maybe. She looks to Blake, maybe shadows. I think they would have the skills and training to pull this off. She was right. They are a bunch of covert squad capable of pulling such a thing. I say, that’s not possible though. Only Marina and Blake remain. And we know they didn't do it. Nathan says, of course. My first suspect would have been them too. But they don't exist anymore. Sadly. He looks at Blake, who was now thinking deeply about something.

Nathan says, I am sure its not a group of people. He pulls out his index finger to us, one person. I suspect one person did this. I scoff, really now. That’s ridiculous. Nathan nods, normally yeah. Short of Marina or Blake, who are overdrive users, no one can orchestrate downfall of 3 top fighters. But even they can't do it undetected. So we are looking for someone else. Just then Blake says, shit. Why didn't I think of it earlier. Tessa and I turn to him. Did that really made him convinced it was one guy.

I ask, what. You also believe it now. Blake didn't respond. He just stared at Nathan who was now smiling, look who caught up. Don't worry cousin, you had a lot of things to deal with. I am sure eventually you would also realized it. Just what Nathan said that made sense. I ask, stop speaking in riddles. Just tell us why you think its one person and who it is. Nathan says, where's the fun in that. Just think what I said, lack of evidence was the biggest clue.

Someone with history to do something as bold as this. Someone who could make everyone believe they are fighting each other. And most of all, someone who is strong.

Just then it clicked for me. Holy shit. Tessa says, no way. But how. Why. Nathan laughs louder, I don't have a clue how or why. I know only its him. This guy has showed how he can manipulate a whole crowd, making a fool out of all of us, pitting us all against each other during the flag capture game, while securing own objective. He has fought all sorts of crazy strong people. And the cherry on top, he very recently showed he can duplicate others Kuret, even those of alphas. A master manipulator and an expert in warfare. Do you all deny he isn't capable of this.

No, he is right. I grit my teeth, its David. Only he is capable of this. I can't believe I didn't see it before. Like Nathan said, it was right in our face. Tessa say, hold on. Why would David do this and not tell us. Why hide from us. I ignored her. Because I couldn't believe I so distracted by Ned and by David himself that I never thought it about this. He has fought alphas, omegas, twin alphas. And won. He could take down Cory, Quintin and Polly all together. Nathan says, I don't have a darn clue. But isn't this exciting.

I can't believe what he was saying. Blake asks, what does you mean. He says, we have no to prove it. If its really him and he didn't tell us, then it means he doesn't want anyone to know. Whatever the reason it is, he would leave no trace, and remove any evidence of his involvement. You were worried about their identities being erased, you were right on the mark. We won't be able to prove it. He laughs, that’s what makes it interesting, what could he be thinking. Anyone wants to take a gander. No one had an answer. We were confused. I was more so.

Just then 4 pings sound in the room. It was our phones. We all got messages at the same time. Everyone took out their phone, I didn't. I was still trying to process this. Nathan whistles reading the message, freak. This guy. I thought I got one over him, but he is already two steps ahead of me. That jarred me out of my thoughts. I ask, what happened. Blake sighs, the theatrics with him. Listen to your message.

I open my phone and listen the voice transcribed, took you long enough to figure it out, sorry of the mess. The client who ordered those drugs, also stole it to cover their tracks. Leave that person to me, because I am on the hunt. After I listen the message disappears from my phone, leaving no trace that it was ever there.

David (Chapter 69)

Friday, January 9, 2026 12:27

I don't know what I am doing. Quite literally. I am currently sitting in my room with a digital board staring in front of me. I had written names of all people related my PTSD. Wagner, Zakerine, Hansan, Branden, John. I even wrote names of people who are less likely the cause of my condition, Istra and the last shadow whose identity I still don't know. Its not surprising they are all the shadow members. Because I was hanging with them the most. Even on the last day. It's a little morbid to say, but only these people death would make me so broken.

I connected each of their names with their relationship and mine, trying to understand the root cause. Why I am doing this. I have been questioning this ridiculous method of laying out dead people names like this. And the answer was always the same. I can't figure out just by thinking. I had whole 4 hours of walking, and yet in all that time I was only circling on same thing over and over. I blamed Wagner, then I blamed Zakerine. I even blamed Hansen for dumping me on that ship.

Even if I could somehow forgive Zakerine for dying the way she did, I can't bring myself to forgive or forget about Wagner. His corpse keeps hunting me like a bad smell. Refusing to leave completely from my mind. Once I reached my secondary house, I had exhausted my thinking and decided to just work through it by writing it on a visual board. Its pretty pathetic I need to write all my feelings and possible causes of PTSD below peoples name. But I don't have time. Half of the day is already gone. And I am no closer to figuring this out.

Then came frustration about how unproductive this has been. I keep gazing at the people's name and their relationship to me. How its connected to my panic attacks. Drew said I knew what I need to do. I even got some hint after with Catherine. My actions have been unconsciously being driving from memories I don't know. And now that I have recalled almost all my memory, I have been tracking all the missing memory and trying to figure which event had the most profound impact on me.

I toss the 3D digital pointer to the table and slump on my chair with eyes closed. This is driving me mad. Self therapy is hard. I had been making progress and having breakthroughs before because Drew was guiding me. But now she gave it to me figure it on my own. I thought of doing this thinking that's would therapists also do, make notes. I already knew that my own bias thoughts will not be impartial. Having to look at oneself impartially is not easy. At least not for me.

Some time later, while I was in the middle of my thoughts, M holograms comes from the wall projector, boss, Its 3:00. You haven't eaten since morning. Your energy levels are way down. I didn't realize it was this late. I can't let my health get worse by skipping meal, so I need to eat, begrudgingly. I don't have ART in this house, so I had to make lunch on my own. Surprisingly it was a little relaxing now that I distracted myself a little. I am a mess, because I was dragging out the cooking hoping to avoid the useless task of self reflection.

I finished eating around 4. I was a deadline, and no close to figuring out my block. I even tried numerous time to call on my Kuret. Every time I felt my body rejecting it. Its so damn frustrating. I don't know when, but I somehow dozed off a while I was siting on the sofa chair. No doubt due to my mental fatigue. Around 5 I head a ping from M. With lazy eyes I lean from my chair to M's hologram. What is it, I was annoyed. Mostly at my self, I slept when I had things to do. M says, boss, you visitors. Cass and Matt will be on your doorstep in few minutes.

What. They didn't tell call me before coming. I ask, what happened. Everything all right at the officers building. M says, nothing of importance. People have been busy all day with meetings and discussion. All though they have break right now. I couldn't meet the two of them this morning, so they must have come personally to meet. To be frank, I didn't want to talk to Cass right now. She might figure out I something wrong with me. With how was appearing to the public, I don't know if I can do it again. Not after what happened with Vanessa. That guilt has never left me. I could have handled it better. No. It would end the same way no matter what I said. She would stubbornly see through everything.

But I can't just send them away too. Reluctantly I changed the digital board to show a 3D view of the coliseum. Specifically when Charles and I were fighting. I had prepared this in case someone did visit me. I looked around the house that would gave me away. I didn't see anything that would reflect my mental state. After I cleaned myself a little, I waited for them. A minute later the door rings. I take a deep breath and open the door, hey guys. How is it. Matt interrupts me, dude. What the hell.

His annoyance was expected. Not just his though, Cass had a scowl too. She says, you couldn't have waited for us this morning. Their impatience in not letting me explain was apparent. I first tell them, come on inside first. Give me a chance to explain though. They both give me a sharp look, but still came in. I saw they didn't have anything with them, so they must be here to just talk. I close the door and then suddenly Matt looks around the house. Why is he searching, I answer, no ones here. Its just me.

Matt says, yeah duh. We know. I was looking for your hidden entrance to your actual house. I made a smile, I am sure you heard from others, its not here. Its. He waves his hand, I know, I know. Its somewhere in the ocean, but knowing how you think, I bet there is hidden door or escalator that goes underground to where its right now. I laugh amused at the thought, that's a little too much. Even for me. Cass scoffs, is it though. I haven't been able to talk to you since the match yesterday. But you have meet everyone else, do I you know how it feels that only two of us have been left out.

I could tell she was annoyed at my behavior. I nod, its not like I did it on purpose. I needed rest, and if Heraknus hadn't rushed moving back so suddenly, I would have stayed in my home all day. Matt shouts from the room inside, which home by the way. This one or your super secret one. Because you wouldn't even let anyone know where you were. I guess I will be in their dog house for a while. I reply, look, that's not my intention. Then I give them the same explanation I gave others in the morning.

After hearing it, Matt finally gives up searching for hidden passages under the bed or in the wall. Cass asks, that's crazy. It could attack us. I nod. Matt shook his head, only you would live in such a dangerous place. I had to agree a little with him, its safe for 1 or 2 people. Excluding myself. I want to get it fixed before showing anyone. My team is working on it, so wait until they fix it. They had no choice but to trust on my judgement on this. Cass asks, and this team of yours, you trust them with this technology.

Her concern was valid, I nod at her. I say, I carefully handpicked them. But its not like I am blindly trusting them. I am using standard protocol of information modulation. No one person knows everything, so its fine. I also have M tracking their activity as a safeguard, with their consent of course. So you don't need to worry about that. That makes her satisfied. She asks, okay. What about that multiple Kuret blasts, care to explain that as well. She and Matt glare with intent. But I wasn't going to disclose that. Not yet.

I smile, you heard what I said yesterday right. I want to keep that one secret until my match with Charles. Matt shrieks, really dude. We are in your house, you must have sound proof walls here. I reply, its not just here. I don't want to risk telling you and Kafar spies hear about it. Cass's eyes widen, spies. What do you mean. I answer, come on. You think we are the only ones who sent Catherine to spy on them. They must have too. Its not about trust, but more about recon and intel gathering. Though with the tournament finished, I doubt they are active now. But I rather not risk it.

Cass says, do you think we would just blab about it to anyone. Why keep it from us too. Matt says, come on. Spit it out. We won't leave until you do. I should have know that this would happen. Outside arena, my usual excuse fells apart. I ponder about it for a moment. Obviously I can't tell everything. I decided the part I can tell. I say, fine. Now try to keep an open mind about this, because it's a little wonky. They both got excited to hear me. I say, you know how light is split into a spectrum of colors when it goes through a prism, or through a stream a water. It works very similar to that.

They both looked confused. Matt asks, what does that mean. It would have been easier to show them, but I can't do that. So instead I continued this analogy, the pure Kuret I store inside my Kuret storm, I split a little piece of that into a Kuret I want. Cass asks, I don't understand a thing. How can you do that. I raised my palm, my hands works a prism. Actually, any part of my body would do, but its easier with my hand. If you recall my match, I pointed to the 3D view of the match behind me, you will see my hands always inside my Kuret storm. That's how I am doing it. In a normal scenario, Kuret coming in contact to my hand would just disperse, but in the right condition, like this, the pure kuret splits.

There dumbfounded looks were quite amusing. I continued, it was an arduous task. Trying to make use of the randomness of this Kuret splits into the Kuret I want. But after many trial and errors, I found a trick. But it renders my hand useless because I have to dip my hand to the Kuret storm to make it work. I could tell from their expression that this was too vague. And I agreed. But this all I could tell. I say, it would be easier to show you, but you can't actually see inside my Kuret storm. I can instead could show a mathematical simulation of how it works internally. M, open file S and run it.

Matt cuts in, wait. No, leave it dude. I only understood about half of what you said. I get a feeling you were going to show us some complicated science. I wasn't actually going to show it. I shouldn't make my friends feel like this, but I was just flaunting science in their face so that they believe its so complicated that its best to just ignore it.

He says, I am not even going to try to understand that with just my knowledge of medicine. I thought you had a Kuret related trick. This is, well, impressive, but. He couldn't find the response. Cass helps out, boring. I might not have told them the whole thing, but this caught me off guard. After spending whole afternoon in mental torture, I finally let out a hearty laugh, did you say it was boring. Do you any idea how complicated it is.

Matt elbow Cass to chide her. Cass says, what. I am not saying it's not incredible, but its just not related to Kuret. You said it's a mix of Earth and Medrone science. I expected it have a Kuret science. I understood her confusion. It could have been easier if I told the whole thing on how I am able to split the Kuret. I say, my biology. That the Kuret science. Math and Science of Earth. Its a combination of all if it. Cass shook her head, I think it was better when I didn't know. I am more confused now. Why didn't you want to reveal it to anyone. I doubt anyone can stop you from doing something non Kuret thing.

But its not. That's the part I can't tell. I gave a safe answer, right now the biggest weakness of this is the time it takes to prepare it. You saw that, nearly 3 to 5 minutes. That's just not practical. I got lucky to have be able to use twice in a same match. Only because Charles was relatively slower. But now he knows that. To remove this weakness I will have to work on making it work in seconds. Once that's done, my other weakness will be revealed. Matt asks, you mean somehow Charles can stop that kuret prism refract thing.
□Not exact, but he was close enough I nod, I got away this time because it was the first time. Everyone will focus on the biggest weakness, but the real strategists from Citradel will focus on a
That means not telling anyone how I can do it, not even you guys. Cass sighs, I kind of understand, but I don't even understand this. Forget telling anyone about it. Matt nods, same. But anyways, we are not going to tell anyone this.

At least they understood my reasons, even if they didn't the whole truth. Matt walks to the 3D hologram projected view of the battle, you are already planning for your next match. Dude, you should chill for at least a day. I laugh a little thinking if he knew what I was actually doing. Cass walks beside me, yeah. And your interview was quite something. You were so arrogant, it was quite a performance. My eye twitch at that word. What did she mean by that. Did she knew my mental condition. Someone already gave my condition away to her. No, she was smirking right now.

But I have to confirm, by the way. You both barged in demanding for explanation, but neither of you asked if my injuries ae healed. Gives friends you are. Matt gives a blank stare, I mean you don't have any wounds. Others said you were all right. So I just thought nothing of it. Cass laughs, are you embarrassed about passing out even though you were talking big about defeating Charles yesterday. I was right, you may not have physical wounds, but you were just showing off. You still haven't recovered, right.

That's clears it. For the time being only 4 people know about my therapy. Well, its still bad considering it was only one till yesterday. But the information leak didn't happen as of now. It looks like Cass thought I was hiding my

injuries, well she was right in a way. I nod, you caught me. I may not show it, but Charles still managed to leave my body sore. It wasn't a lie, but the acupuncture I got from ART removed the almost all of the soreness. Cass nods, I knew it. She gazes at Charles hologram that was currently of him jumping in mid air and me standing below.

She says, Charles is really strong, isn’t he. I take the sofa chair and turn to face them, extremely. I got lucky with Blake, he hadn't recovered from fighting Marina and his overdrive was not stable. But Charles is different. He has been alpha much longer and has finer control on his vast Kuret. And while he says his overdrive is also unstable, it still feels dangerous. Its going to be really tough match. Matt asks, I am still not sure why you agreed to take the deal. We were listening in to your discussion, and everyone's been talking about it. But isn't it too risky. Charles himself said he could kill you accidentally.

I need to tread carefully here. Obviously they saw me crash out when Wagners name was mentioned. Cass walks to me, I get it was a very tempting deal. You weren't sure you would win, and he was basically offering his house as a bargain. But its too dangerous. I didn't want to lie about my reason, but I can't just open that can of worms right now. I decided to say some truth. I close my eyes in resignation, it was my ego. Matt asks, say what. I clarify, when I heard even the crown couldn't defeat Charles, I got worked up. I have not been strong always, so I carried away and thought I could become stronger than the crown.

This was really the truth, I just didn't explain it in this word to anyone before. Not to Blake or Marina. Not to Catherine or Vanessa. Cass scoffs, you, the guy who is so careful that its almost a sickness, suddenly did a what, an emotional selfish decision. Matt says, that’s kind of hard to imagine. I open my eyes, mortified, I did. And you really think I don't have moments of selfishness. All I can say is that I was having a rush of excitement. Being able to push Charles to use his overdrive, and getting a time to master my Kuret. It may not be logical, but that’s what I did.

This is really what I feel. Having a panic attack was another factor, but I can tell this from objectively reflecting after spending hours on that PTSD board. Cass remains wide eyed. Matt clicks his tongue, damn. So I guess even you can be goaded into, huh. Cass nods, It's definitely strange behavior from you, but you are still a person. Flaws and all. She had no idea how true she was. I retorted, you say like I wasn't before. Cass fidgets a little, being hit like that. Matt smiles, yeah, what did you mean by that Cass. He was obviously teasing her.

Cass stares at the two of us, one at a time, no. that’s what I mean. I just. She was lost on words a little. She bits her lips, you know, I thought you didn't have flaws. This whole year, you been very different, more calculating. Thought you changed a little. I smile a little. I was right to believe she would notice my subtle change in behavior. I answers, I have told his before. Everyone has weaknesses. I am no exception, I just hide it well. But its not going to stay hidden much longer, I thought. My secrets are unravelling. One by one they are being revealed. First was my ability to see radiations, truth about my condition from Medrine and now my therapy.

It won't be surprise if somehow my shadow history will also get revealed. Either from me or someone else. Matt cuts in my thoughts, you can say that again. That over confidence you showed in your interview was so blatantly obvious. Was there a secret meaning behind it. Cass asks, that’s pretty obvious. You always have an angle. They knew my tactics well enough to claim this. I lied here because they don't know I was overcompensating for my panic attack.

I say, if you had met Kafar today you would know he wasn't done scheming. And there's the rumors about me cheating. There is still so many things that can go wrong before Heraknus arrive, showing a strong front was important, but I was also challenging him in a way. Trying to force him to do a mistake that I can use against him. Matt was confused, wait what. How does that make sense. I continue, he may or may not be the one who tried to sabotage Marina and Blake. And interrupting the my match with Charles. I didn't care about him earlier, but now he is unpredictable. And that’s dangerous. So I figured if that would make him pressured and make a mistake that I can show publicly.

This was a blatant lie, but it could still happen. I thought about this a little on my way over here. I was wondering if there was any positive side of my show. The chances of this coming to any fruition was almost zero, but who knows. Miracles happen. This was good enough reason for them to believe. Cass laughs, damn you. You really can't help scheming huh. Matt puts his hand on his jaw, yup. Classic. Its a little weak though. You didn't even mention Kafar in your interview. It was a weak lie to begin with.

I shrug, hey, my ideas can't be always diabolical. I just went ahead to kill two birds in one stone, show my resolve to everyone here and put pressure on Citradel. That was in part true and Luther was the one who suggested it. Matt wasn't fully convinced, but in the end nods, yeah I guess. I mean, if it really worked, you are a god damn genius. I am glad he thought of it, because I felt a complete sham. Tricking my friends like this. Cass walks around the hologram, ha, that was always true.

She faces me, can you imagine how far you have become. I mean, just years ago I used to visit in your hospital and later your guardians home. Even then you weren't strong enough to fight other humans, let alone alphas or overdrive users. I feel embarrassed knowing I fallen behind. I points to Matt, and he was even depressed this morning. Matt suddenly jerks and gets appalled, hey. I was not depressed. I was just feeling down a little. Cass scoffs, that’s the same thing.

This wasn't my intention to make them feel this way. Its completely normal to be even jealous. Its in the nature of people in a group. I say, its fine. You don't have to worried about it. I know very much how much a strange existence I am. Being a MARS child has its own way of making it very different. But trust me, you don’t need be so down. This is just the beginning. Once our cities merge things will change, everyone's real trainings will start. And depending on you, your ranking will change.

Cass asks, wait, training and ranking change. How. I nod, ask Blake or Luther or Tina. They have proposed a way. Me and some other were consulted about its feasibility. I agreed to it. I hope others also do it. Matt got excited, tell us more dude. He was more enthusiastic to improve. I answers, nah. This one is not my secret to give. Ask them. We don't want people to get wrong idea and influence the officers to change it. I like the idea. In fact I am looking forward to it. I think this had been looming on the two of them for a while, because they seem to welcome this idea very much.

Matt cheers, yes. I thought tournament was the only time we get to train seriously. Cass nods, but we can change our raking's that means we still have opportunity to grow. I just added in something to curb their expectation so that it doesn't lean in a single way, I'll just say this, it wouldn't be a tournament, so don't think it will have same rules. Matt glees, you mean there's no time limit. Cass runs her hand on her hair, what about weapons, we can use them too.

I was done telling anything else. I just smiled at them telling I am not going to tell what exactly. They both got excited. I was glad this seem to alleviate some hidden tension they been carrying since their defeats. I checked the time and say, I know you guys probably want to talk more, but aren't you on the clock. Your break ends in another 20 minutes. Matt says, oh shit. Yeah. I totally forgot. Wait, how did you know. I was hurt he had to ask that. I just raised my eyebrow gesturing that it wasn't worth asking how I know.

Cass says, duh. He probably has M keeping tab on everyone. We should go back soon. We both totally forgot what we came for. Matt nods and pulls out his tab. Oh, so they did have something for me. He gives me his tab. It showed a list of things, materials, minerals and compounds. And against them the amounts. I quickly did a cursory glance at it. When my eyes landed on the few of the items at bottom I became a concerned, what is this. Cass then explains that this list came from Marina. She prepared a list of things in preparation for a team to arrive from Citradel. She is concerned that without these materials, the Kuret enrichment will be slowed down and cause more delays in the infrastructure expansion.

I sigh, I had a rough guess of what Citradel used to make their buildings and infrastructure. I never imagined it was this expensive. Platinum and Titanium I knew, but I didn't know about Palladium. And she says we need it in a week. Matt nods, Actually, 5 or 6 days. My god, does Marina believe I am a magician that I can pull out this from a hat. This is something not even some countries can buy in one go. If I had more time, I could get it. But less than a week. I doubt anyone could. Cass says not everyone understands how difficult this is. When Tine told us, some clueless people who didn't study about human or Earth thought it wasn't an issue.

I bet they were people who hid in secluded places to avoid fighting Echo. Its not that uncommon that people will lack Earth knowledge with a growing crowd now. Matt asks, to be honest, even I didn't know some of it until Cass told me how rare or difficult some of it was to get. I got some vague idea when Tina explained its almost impossible. But hey, impossible for you is a daily snack right. Cass smack her palm to back of Matts head, knock it out. Don't just assume he can perform miracles.

I wished he wouldn't put me in such high pedestal. I answers, Cass is right. This, I raise the pad to him, is nearly impossible for me. Matt gives a angry stare at Cass and turns to me, you said nearly. So its not impossible right. Damn him, its just a phrase. I never say anything hundred percent. But that doesn't mean I can actually do it. Cass says, what about getting it illegally. I scoff, with this amount, nothing can be procured legally in a short time anyway. I do have some of these in bulk quantities prepared. But definitely not everything.

I ask, M, check this list against our inventory. Run a brief overview of how much we have right now. M says, running the list, boss. Matt asks, should I share this list to you on the network. I shook, no. As a precaution, any device in the vicinity of his place is hacked. Matt's jaw open in shock, huh. Dude, you are way too paranoid. Cass laughs, you should know its nothing new Matt. She closes his jaw with her hand. Matt gulps and whispers something to her. Her eyes immediately widens and then she glares at me.

I make a mischievous smile. Talking to them has been good for me, because I get to laugh rather than be gloomy and frustrated. I say, don't worry, flashing them my teeth. They both remain silent, whatever private things you have on your phone, its yours. M has a privacy screening. Only in extreme cases I can ask her to show it to me. So all your dirty stuff is safe. That didn't exactly lessen the glare they were throwing at me. Jeez, I shudder to think what kind of messages, photos, or maybe even videos they have on their phone.

I say, trust me. I am not interested in seeing anything you both kids do in your private time. But seriously, if you don't want things to leak, keep it in separate phones, unlinked to the network and encrypted. Cass says in a quite anxious voice, it is unlinked and encrypted. I nod, that’s good. Then you don't need to worry. Matt eyes me, dude. Not cool. You can still hack in it right. I didn't say anything just smiled. It was kind of a revenge for making me reveal so much of my secrets.

I left them both in a panicking state and turn to the result M showed in the wall screen on my right. M says, boss, we have about thirty percent of the total items with their required quantities. And an average of seventeen percent of the other items, ranging from eleven to twenty three percent. Honestly, I was expecting to be much lower. When did my contact in the east accumulate the additional supplies. Must be during the tournament when I wasn't looking. This is still not enough.

I began raking my brain for a solution. There are two things we must do get this done. One requires me to visit my European friend, its been long and we are due for a meet. And the other, well, I have to talk to Blake and Marina. If both things work out, I might get up to 80 to 90 percent of this list. That will have to do for now. I can get the rest next week, while they begin processing with the materials in hand. I say, it's going to be a rush, but it will be done. Cass looks at me doubtful at my claim, are you sure. I nod, tell others I will have it imported in 6 days. I will make it so that it in comes in multiple shipments for security. I will share the details of the shipments in a day or two.

Matt says, see. He got this. He probably had a little too much faith in my abilities. That only made me feel more like a sham. Cass was less confident, but a moment later nods, if you say so. Lets head back then. I followed them through the door as they step out. Cass says, don't go missing today again. Had dinner with us. I bet everyone wants meet you. Matt waves, yeah. Spare some time for us also dude. I wave them with a smile, not sure how tonight will turn out.

I resumed my analysis of my mental condition. Talking to them had alleviated some of the anxiety I had. I hopped it will look with fresh eyes. After two hours I threw the digital pointer into wall in anger, nothing. A damn waste of time. I thought I had to just accept Zakerine death as something I couldn't stop. I forced myself to believe it wasn't my fault, even mediated on it. But its still the same, my panic attacks are still coming when I use my Kuret. Just

what am I missing here. What about Wagners death, I wasn't even there though. And as much as I hate him, how can his death make me feel guilty.

My spiraling thoughts were driving me crazy. It was 7 now. Only 5 hours before I can show I have my panic attacks under control when I use my Kuret. My anger and frustration left my body after I drink a glass of water. I sigh realizing its no use. I won't make it in time. I had a dangerous thought then. What if can trick Drew into believing it I can use my Kuret. Immediately I dismiss the thought next moment. Setting aside the moral betrayal, she won't be fooled so easily.

I yell, dammit. I give up. At this point I had exhausted all the phycological avenues. I surrender myself to luck. I went to my bedroom and pull out a shirt and jacket I use for disguise. I say to M, begin protocol D. Give me all possible locations I go visit. M interjects from the wall monitor, boss, are you sure you want to leave now. The deadline with Dr. Drew is in 4 hours 53 minutes. As I put on my dress I say, just do it. I am mentally done. I need to get out and stay with people. Otherwise my own mind will drive me crazy.

M says, understood. Running the protocol. Scanning for suitable destinations. I went to the bathroom and pulled out the face net from the cabinet. Its been a while since I put it on. I last used it just after the flag capture game. As I prepare to set it on the skin, M says, found 4 locations with a balanced crowd. What is your preference, boss. A fast dining, central market, a bar or the recreation center. I thought for a moment. I wasn't in the mood for a drink, but I was interested in chatting with certain person.

I ask, what about my usual spot. Is that not suitable. M says, there is a little more crowd than usual. I pick up 37 GPS phones, and possibly a dozen more with switched off phones. I suggest to find a less crowded place if you really want to go there again. Once the face mask was done, I put on the blond hair wig. I say, its fine. As long I don't have to deal too much of riled up crowd I am good with it. Set a course and obscure all the available cameras in the path. Also, have ART send the car nearby the location as a backup. But keep it hidden. After a moment M says, all set boss.

I last touch to my disguise, I take my wide black spectacles and put it on. I look into the mirror checking if everything was okay. M says, facial recognizability, 12%. A little higher than usual. But its fine. No one would think I was crazy enough to walk in the city disguised. I smile at that thought, little did they know that I had been doing it for quite some time.

David (Chapter 70)

Sunday, January 11, 2026 14:20

I took the public trolley and in about 20 minutes, I arrive at my destination. It was almost dark now. Sun had already set down, and along with my brooding was growing. I am literally depending on my luck. Hoping that someone says or does something that will trigger something in me. Guh, its just crazy to think it come to this. But in the wise words of James, you get drunk when you don't know what to do. I was standing a little away from the new haunt bar. I can see a lot of people talking inside. I just hope that I can get a seat on the counter. My usual spot.

When I step in, the natural brew of booze fill my throat. Of course its mixed with Kuritines, but I can't smell it. Or see its glimmer. I saw about 50 people here, many in groups sitting around the table. The musician playing his tunes with his Kuret on the side. He remember him, he was here the last time also. So did he get hired permanently. I look for my seat, but unfortunately someone was already there. And the person I wanted to meet was here too, well, she is always here, its her family bar.

The guy I don't recognize sitting was an officer. He was happily talking to his other buddy beside him. Hmm, I could take the empty seats at the corner, but that's too cramped. I guess I just have to remove them from my place. I walk to them, hey guys, you mind if I take this seat. I am a regular here. I tried the carrot approach first. Their laughter died down and then turns to me, just take one in the corner man. You don't monopolize this place. Well, that's true. I stuck my hand in the coat pocket and pull out some cash. This is the stick approach. I put it on the counter in front of them. Their eyes widen at the amount of notes stacked, how about I get you both five more rounds of whatever you are having.

They obviously didn't think I was this adamant about this particular seat. The left guy says, someone is having a nice day. Well, I don't mind. But are you sure, we are celebrating tonight on our victory. We got special kuret drinks. The guy was getting cheeky with me. I smile in response, is that right. Well, in that case I guess there's nothing I can do, I put more cash on the counter from my pocket, expect recommend the 1970 Irish whiskey, more expensive, but tastes much better. You won't forget this night. The two were a little bit speechless at my ostentatious conduct. The guy on right laughs, we will take up on that offer. He knocks on the counter and the lady behind zooms into the view.

The guy said, this dude is buying is couple of rounds of drinks for us. 1970 Irish whiskey and keep them coming. He slides the money on the counter to her. She flashes a smile seeing me, is he now. Well it's a good choice. She turns to a kid behind her, I need 3 bottles of it. The kid disappears in the back room and the guys leave their seats enjoying much more of their unexpected delight. I gladly take the empty seat left behind. The women says to me laughing, you didn't need to do that. That is 3 times than the ones they were drinking.

I wave her gesturing its no big deal. I rest my hands on the counter, the usual. She raises her eyebrows to me standing still, that's all I get. I don't see you in 3 weeks and just like that. Jeez, you must think I am just a waitress huh. She was playing at me. I smile, oh please. You were just worried that if I don't come often enough, you won't get to buy that Kuretine bracelet you had your eye on. That caught her off guard. I remembered she said about it one of the times before. Just then someone called for her and she motioned me wait for a minute.

While I waited, I looked around the bar. There were more people today. I touch the end of my shades and boot up the interface. From the ends, a beep sound comes, which only I can hear. A moment later, the eye glass begins to scan all the people in the room. M says to my inner ear, all clear boss. No one important or anyone who could recognize you. The interface goes away and I turn back to the counter. Just then the kid comes out rushing with 3 bottles in his arms, careful Ryan. You don't want to drop them again.

He sneers at me, just forget about that will you. I did a mistake once. I say, yeah. And I covered for it. You want me tell your sister. That removed his scowl with a little annoyance as he carried more carefully now to guys at the corner. He then walks back to me, let me guess. You will have the same, your usual human scotch. That's so boring. Try this one. I raise my hand, I am not making the mistake of one having your made up drink. I'll stick with the ones I know.

He twitches his mouth, come on. This is better. Just try it. Its free. But the next one is going to cost you. He brings a deviant smile. I shook my head, I had made the mistake of buying expensive things twice from him that turned out to be shit. I remain unconvinced that this time would be any better. He then jumps up and leans on the counter bending towards me. He whispers, I am saving up money for buying something and surprise Peter and Elina. Ah, I see. His real intension was now apparent. I wouldn't mind buying it, but I can't just give it him. That would send wrong message about me to him.

I look around the place and whisper back, a bet then. If you can get just one person to buy your drink while I am here, I will buy a dozen of your new inventions. How about it. That made his eyes lit up. I interrupted his bliss, not counting the free drink. You get someone to buy after their first drink. Like how you just did it for me now. Do that, I am game. That put a stop to his chipper. Thought he would get one up on me. But he wasn't too much discouraged. In fact, he was little fired up. He nods, don't go back on your word Mack. And don't tell Elina about this.

I nod and we both briefly shook hands. He settles back on his feet and begins searching for his next victim. He is a good kid, and even a better brother. Much better than Peter, who is nowhere to be seen again. I guess his side hustle of imports is keeping him busy. Don't know if he is making any money out of it to balance out his absence here. Elina zips back to me after handing out drinks to others, what was that. Did he ask for your money again. I raise my hand surrendering, nope. I didn't give him anything.

She glares at me, you know what I mean. He offered his mix of cocktail again right. I didn't deny or confirm it. She clicks her tongue to her brother now going around and looking for gullible people. She sighs, you are a bad influence on him. Don't take more of his ridiculous Kuret drinks. She pulls out the scotch from underneath the counter and begins pouring it on a ice filled glass. She says, I don't need people to think this is an experimental bar like the one in sector 3.

I smile remembering her rivalry with that family. Honestly, I don't mind the experimental bar they have. I have visited them couple of times too. But they run out of the stuff I can drink very quickly, so its not always feasible for me. I grab the cold glass and say, its fine. He is the poster kid of your bar. She shook her head, you mean a bad sister who allows a minor to be here. I answer, you need the help. Without Peter, you either hire more staff or trust Ryan. She puts her elbows in front of me and sighs, yeah I guess.

I take my first sip of this in a month. The liquid warms my throat and chest with the familiar sensation. I put down the glass basking in the much needed bliss from this terrible day. I tell her, besides, your company more than makes up for it. Those sector 3 guys are just buffs from Citradel. You got the skills. She turns to me with an amused smile, just one sip and you are already drunk. I chuckle, I don't need to be drunk to say it. I didn't just think because hers was more profitable, she was very attractive too. A quality one needs to run a bar.

I didn't expect her to be good conversationalist when I was searching for good places to spend in my downtime. Obviously, she has to be good to fit her role in a bar. But she and I just clicked on many things. I liked that about us. I used to feel guilty about being a fake though, but after a while it just went away. I thought she was being the same with me and other customers. But I gradually helped open up more of her. And we became real friends. All though I only get to meet her in her here always. I kept it this way intentionally to keep her out of my life, separate from the drama and repercussions if she knew who I really was. It was nice to talk to someone without them knowing my sordid history.

She puts her head on the counter, hair black pony tail swaying on the side, these two days have been draining. Good for business though. I even hired 3 more temps. An hour ago it was damn crazy. You came in a good time. I take another sip. Of course I knew that. I had M run a prediction algorithm on finding the best time when she would have a little less customers. I look around the place. I had kept my eye on Ryan, who was just shot down the second time. I am very sure no one will buy his drink. At least he will get a good lesson from it.

She raises her head to me, so. What kept you all this time. I put the glass down, you know how it was. With the tournaments end approaching, they kept me on double time to use my software for the broadcast. I barely had 5 hours of sleep everyday. Even on off days. I think I told you last time too about it. She looks to the scaffolding trying to recall, oh right. You said that. I totally forgot. I thought you swore off drinking when you didn't swing by the 2nd week. I chuckle at that, ah, so you missed me. I didn't know you were thinking about me that much.

She says coly, please. I was just wondering where my usual drinker go. The amount of money you have spend all this time, and even paying for others. I sometimes feel you are not my customer, but my employer. I raise the glass to her, I am hurt. I thought I was your friend. She whispers, true. But you know, friends with benefits. That was too corny. I spilled a little while drinking. She laughs seeing me little agitated at that comment. I scoff, you know. If someone heard you, they be jealous. I get to hog all of your valuable time when I am here.

She makes a disapproving smile, come on. Don't say that. She looks around to see if anyone was watching them. No was doing it, I was just teasing her. She says, you still don't have a girlfriend, that's why you hang out with me, borrowing your sorrows in the same scotch, in the same place with just me. I smile, oh, who knows. I might have one and I still come here to watch you work. Its strangely satisfying to see you work your magic on other clueless people. And you do look good in that outfit. She laughs, you just a tease, no guts. You never made a move on me. I bet you still haven't asked out any of the girls you have a crush on.

Okay, that weirdly took a turn. I never told about this to her. She caught on when I didn't immediately say anything back, I knew it. You never asked me out, so there is a girl. You keep asking if I have a boyfriend, but you don't talk much about yourself. I say this as someone who can read people, you are a total wimp. Just ask her out. You got money and decent looks. And a big brain is a plus too. What's stopping you. I didn't like the fact that my brain was less important than money. She was just goading me by saying that. I scoff, calling me a coward huh. What would you say if I really asked you out.

She didn't waste a second to reply, hell no. I was expecting that, I don't need someone who has this much time and money to spend on just drinking. She mocks me by thinking for a second, now, if you weren't a customer. Then maybe. She shrugs like she was open to it. I too didn't hesitate to say, all right. That makes this simple. I will not be your customer anymore. That made her a little tense. Even if was only messing with her, I could tell she was blushing a little. Then she shook her head and says, yeah, no. Pass. I need us to be friends with benefits. At least for a little while longer. The last words were more hushed.

I take a slip laughing all the while noticing didn't hate the idea. Honestly, if my life wasn't mess right now, I would want like to try. Things with Vanessa is, well, complicated. I don't even have an inkling on how to fix that relationship, let alone think what's next for us. Plus she is with Ned. I shook my head and take another slip before I get distracted by how much my life sucks now. Elina says, by the way, did you watch todays interview of David. I try to stay clear of any conversation about myself for obvious reasons.

It was inevitable we would talk about people I know. The tournament went for months, it's going to be on peoples mind majority of the time. Like a sport event people bet on, enjoy on someone victory and curse on others loss. But whenever I spoke with Elina about this, I kept it general, without pointing out anyone. Otherwise it would be awkward, like it was now. I have especially avoided talking about me, because that will shatter my own persona of Mack and I begin speaking in third person. I also don't know how I will react when Elina says what she thinks about me. But today I was different, I was slightly drunk and feeling resentment and anger on myself. Not the best moment for self pity me, but I went with it anyways.

I say flatly, that guy has a bug up his ass. I get he is fighting that Heraknus guy, but he is being too cocky. A couple beside me were startled to hear me suddenly rant. I thought they would ignore me, but no, they joined in. The guy says, you are talking about David right. I don't know these two, but looks like Elina does, Dos, keep out of it. Don't anger my friend. I found it interesting she was defending me, or maybe Mack. Then she says to me with smile, he hasn't even finished his first drink. Wait until it's had bought for at least his 3rd or 4th.

I couldn't help but laugh. She knew me well enough to know I wasn't bothered by her blatant honestly. He says, you got it wrong Elina. I agree with him. That made me smile even more, when I should be pissed instead. His girlfriend says, he is being delusional if he thinks he will win so easily. Its not like I was expecting people to be on my side. I even heard it on news that some people's reaction. But its interesting to know what they think when not in front of a camera.

The women says, he was lucky to get a draw. But now he is just pushing it. I had to comment on this, I think he should not have taken the deal. The guy jumps in, yeah. Exactly, I was just telling earlier that he should have just continued the match. Instead they go and make an exhibition match out of it. I was weirdly having fun chatting shit about me. I have been blamed for many human crimes, knowing full well it was all fudged up to build my criminal reputation. But now I am blaming on my real self.

I mentally had a kick when thinking about my real self. Do I even know what it was. I have been thinking so much about this today when searching the answer for my condition, and yet no luck figuring it out. Elina says, don't start agitating people. I don't want to deal with this again like yesterday. So it wasn't the first time huh. Dos asks, what do you think Elina. You said yesterday he was a twerp for disappearing after the match. But what now, you saw his interview.

I could my heart beating slightly slowly in anticipation. Elina leans and says in low tone, you didn't hear from me, but I heard from an officer that he broke into the Citadel's boat and caused some problems when they were leaving. The guy thinks himself a hot shot. If I wasn't drunk a little, I would have either yelled at her or went to a corner to hide in shame. The girl says, jeez. I didn't hear about that. Guess he really does break rules and thinks he can get away with it.

Funny thing is she wasn't wrong. I do think I can break or at least skirt around the rules and still get away with this. I ask, what do guys think will happen. Elina leans away and shrugs, hard to say. He may be even cheating, maybe not. Still, he made it through the finals. I don’t know if he really as arrogant as he appears in the TV.

This is terrible. I don’t care what the other two think, but Elina is annoyed with me. She says, I don't care who wins, I just want more stability in our city. I guess normal people have their own priorities. Dos says, so true. This tournament was well and good, but I don't want to keep driving and giving tours to outsiders.

His girlfriend says, pays is good though. He nods, can't deny that. I finally bought a joint house for my family due to this. Elina adds, yeah, no matter who wins, we will soon have new residents. I am much more looking forward to meeting Heraknus. The women says, oh my god. You too. Some people are afraid, but I feel much safer with them here. Dos says, hey now, our officers are strong too. They were talking about Heraknus. I don't know when, but I tuned out the discussion because I finally learned what Elina thinks of me. I hurriedly finished the drink and asked for another.

I shouldn't have made the unreasonable hope that she was on my side. Its not like she is outright against me. And based on how I appear on a screen, its not her fault. But still, just because I understand it, doesn't mean it doesn't hurt of what she feels about me. This is exactly why I never wanted to talk about me. I just wanted to keep our conversations simple. I was on my third glass when Elina came back again serving another couple of guys, I think more officers will be coming in now. I heard they were stuck with work whole day.

I ask, dang it. That means I can't keep you to myself any longer. She opens her jaw like she was repulsed, but I know she liked it. She replies, come now, I can't be exclusive to anyone. This is prime time baby. I think I should hire more temp for tomorrow again. Its a good bet. The next few days it will be busier, so people won't have time to go back and instead come here or other places to eat. I didn't get to talk to her much today, M's prediction is just a probability in the end. I saw more people coming in.

I can't stay here any longer. I caught a few people whom I spent some time. They might recognize me. I shook my head, so this is all the time I get today huh. I should have came in earlier. I wished I stayed here much more. The company here is much more better to look instead of what I have been staring at whole day. I thought I was saying this in my mind, but turns out I was mumbling to myself. And Elina was close enough to hear it. She cocks her eyes at me, wow. That’s a compliment I never heard from you. Please tell me which other girl you were ogling today. And you gotta tell me how much prettier I am from her.

I was bursting out laugh from that. I have been staring at a digital board filled with dead people names. What kind of reaction will she have if I reveal that. She was waiting for my answer. I say, you are a 9 compared to 0's I have been seeing. She makes a disapproving face, I don't know what to say. Be angry that you don't think I am a 10 or that you are a natural enemy of women. She reminds me of Marina, but less whimsical. I scuffle in my pocket and pull put some cash on table.

I was moderately drunk, but not enough to lose my faculty. However, at this point I might just get loose lipped and say something I shouldn't. Elina says looking at the stack, Mack. I know I joke around, but this a little too much. I added a little extra than usual, actually I gave the remaining 5000 MDR I had with me. I finally got to know what she thinks of me. Not that its going to change anything. I guess even she feels guilty using me like this. Though I have used her more. So it’s a fair trade. I say, take it. It was a celebration for me too today. Buy that Kuritine bracelet you wanted.

She looks at me with a little guilt while talking the money, I really appreciate it. And you still remember that, I told you that months ago on a whim. I nod, whims can be sometimes good. You struggled a little opening this place. And I want to keep it going. So I can have you for even longer. I said it too seriously. Dammit, I was really getting too light headed. She laughs, you are just too much. Only you would get drunk from simple human drink. Your Kuret immunity is still impressively low.

One of the drawbacks of this was I couldn't get fully drunk. Because no ever does with normal human drink. This is pretty much the tolerance I have to stay sober without outing that I am really drunk. She sighs, I should seriously consider making you an investor, but what's the point. Funny enough is that you are almost already like one. I say, I'll take that action. How about 20 percent. She smiles, sorry. I rather have you as a friend than a partner. I don't want to mix business between us. I answer, I thought we were friends with benefit.

She scoffs, aren't you the clever one. She says after thinking about it, I just don't want to change anything between us. That makes two of us. This is what Dr. Drew had suggested months ago. She said to open up and talk to people outside my circle of friends. Having conversation with her helped my therapy. Its not just her, but talking to anyone without the burden of my history is what helped me. However, what Drew didn't know was that I am doing it incognito. I don't know if Drew knows doesn't know that I hid my identity like this.

We may keep flirting each other like this, but that’s all this will ever be. I wish it wasn't about money, but that’s the best way to not make it personal. Because once I step out, its done. We will never meet outside her bar. No, its more like I purposefully keep our lives separate. I have been lying to her big time. The money I give her is also a little incentive to keep her for asking more out of us. I know her family will be her priority always.

I say to her, well I tried. She then says, wait, that’s it. You won't even try to ask me out and convince me more. I look at her with a strange look. That came out of nowhere. I curse that today's the day when I can't see her glimmer to know if she was just flirting or for real. I played it safe, I don't want to take advantage of you. Not when you keep saying I pay you too much, but then you take it anyways. That made her laugh, such a cowards answer. See, this is why you always come in alone. You need to grab the opportunity when its coming, no matter where it comes from.

I still can't tell if she was for real. I laughed it off pushing myself out of the chair, message received. Will be on the lookout for more opportunity. I turn around to look for Ryan. But he was nowhere to be seen. Elina says, he went back inside. In the end no one tried his drink. I smile and pull out a little from my other pocket the separate cash I was keeping for him. It was just in case he actually got someone to drink it. Elina saw me trying to add more money on the table. She says, stop it Mack. You shouldn't spoil him. I reply, he is like you. He wants to get something for you and Peter. And he was trying hard to sell his product to people. It was quite impressive for kid his age.

Elina remained stunned, really. I didn't even see him among the crowd. You got some sharp eyes dude. It was out of habit to keep aware of my surrounding. Even when I don't have glimmers to see. Instead of putting this cash on the table, I grab her hand. It was warm and felt good. For a moment she was stunned. Damn, I was being rude to her. This is why I don't stay here when I am this drunk. I slide her the cash in her hand and take it away, I didn't want people to see me giving you more money. Didn't want to give trouble to you from others. Though, do me a favor and give it to Ryan.

She looked a little shocked, perhaps I really screwed up when I just grabbed her like that. She shook it off though and puts the money in her own pocket, I don't know how to thank you Mac. I feel I am using you too much. You sure you won't bankrupt. I hate to think I don't get to see you because of this. She shouldn't have said that, it just pains me knowing the reverse was going on. I just say, don't worry about it. I had a rough month, that’s why I didn't visit you. I'll be back next week.

Her smiles returns, well, that’s great to hear. I shouldn't toy with her emotions like this. Or maybe she was doing it to me. But I waved her bye and walked out. It was 7:30. I spent only about 45 minute with Elina, but it always feels longer and shorter at the same time. I wish I could talk to her outside of work. But that’s not fair to her. I would just create more troubles for her. As I walked to the next block, I saw a familiar jeep. It was Peters. He was racing through the streets recklessly. Beyond the normal limit. As he wooshes past me, I turn back and check him out for a moment. He didn't even park his jeep to the shed, he jumped out of jeep with its engine running and rushed inside the bar.

He was lucky there weren't wasn't a single officer in sight. They would scold him for driving like a mad man. I don't know what got him so worked up. I turn back and walked away, knowing nothing I could do. I won't get into their affairs once I am outside the bar. I have my own personal shit to figure out. After walking another block I stopped. I shook my head, no. Don't get involved. I mutter to myself. Peter is like this, brash and reckless. Maybe he came to just pick something. Or talk to Elina.

Then I recalled how suspicious the guy is. He used to manage the bar with Elina, but when he got some part time job he basically left everything to her. I mean everything. Elina said he was contributing to the family, so I just figured he wasn't interested in a bar job. What could make him rush into the bar like this at night. I shook my head, no. Stop it. Don't look for trouble. I thought I made up my mind. Then a moment later I started walking back to the bar.

Dammit. This is why I shouldn't be drunk. My sober mind is telling to just leave it. I somehow convinced myself that I just wanted to check on Peter for a second. I seriously need to find a better reason than just bad intuition. And that’s when I was frustrated that my suspicion actually come true. I saw hoards of people coming out from the bar. Huh, its not closing time. More like it’s the beginning. What happened. I found the two couple I was talking to before and ask, hey guys. What happened. Why is everyone leaving.

Dos says, don't know dude. Elina's brother came in asked everyone to leave. Elina almost kicked him out, but he was way to amped up. The girl interlocked on his arm says, Peter said something about some emergency and asked us all to leave. I didn't even get to finish my bowl of chips. I ask, there are some officers inside, did they just sat while Peter made a ruckus. Dos nodded, yeah. They were mad too. But then Elina apologized and asked us to leave. I guess you can't choose your family. Even if they are so rude like him.

That he was. I observed from a distance as people left the bar. I pulled my hoodie when I recognized some officers coming my way. I continued to watch from a street corner from the opposite. This is too much, I should leave. They might have some real emergency. Nothing suspicious except for Peter. Elina also agreed to this, so everything fine. I sigh, what am I even doing. I am already hiding my identity from them, now I am stalking them too. This is crazy.

I forced myself to wake and move on. There are other ways to keep an eye on them. I hit the button on my specs. I say, M, keep an eye on Peters jeep GPS. I don't want to know where its going, only if it is an outlier from his

usual places. Strictly passive observation. I turn my back and walked away. M says, will do boss. Isolating the GPS and running passive surveillance. I felt much better now. I should have done this from beginning instead of suspecting anything wrong here. My senses are inhibited.

A moment later M gives a warning sound, boss. There is something wrong. I can't find the GPS on the car. Its not just switched off, I don't find any signal of it. My legs stop when I heard that. I take in a big breath when I knew I landed myself into trouble.

David (Chapter 71)

Sunday, January 11, 2026 21:50

I positioned myself at a better spot in the alley to check what was happening inside the bar. With my specs I had zoomed in through the window. Dos was right, Peter was behavior very odd. He was anxious as hell. Elina and Ryan were now beside him and they were talking. No, more like a heated discussion. My earlier intuition was correct. When people become blind, there other senses gets stronger. Without my glimmer, I had a bad feeling. At least that's the excuse I was giving. Simpler answer was I was being nosy and didn't want to go back home. I already gave up on finding me a way to fix my panic attack. I could at least be more useful here since i have already broken my rule.

Every vehicle on the island needs a GPS tracker. Its a mandatory. Tampering or removing it was, well, a crime. A minor one, but it was still a crime nonetheless. Why would he need to remove it. I also don't have a GPS on my car, but that's because mine is ART and I used my own team to build it. What is he trying to hide. Isn't his work just some sort of supply chain for importing stuff from outside. A nasty thought came to my mind, but I didn't want to presume anything yet. I continued to watch them without hearing what they were talking about.

I could tell Elina was upset. Something is wrong here. And after a while all 3 of them came out. Elina turns off the lights and closes the bar. She is actually closing the bar early. It was really some sort of emergency. Soon everyone got into Peter's jeep. I took a step back hiding beside the alley wall. What's my game plan though. I could tail them, but the city streets are have too many corners and turns. Its a maze structure so that its easier to travel, but it also means you could spot a tail that much easier.

And without my Kuret, I can't exactly run behind them. I did have an idea. I come out of my hiding spot and cross the street. I tell M, bring the car at my current location. Also, turn on the GPS on this specs. M says, done. I take it off and fold it in my left hand. I hear the jeep's engine roaring. Before it starts moving, I stealthily throw it in the back of the jeep. Ryan was sitting behind, he didn't hear it dropping to the floor. He was very still and anxious. I didn't want them to know it was me walking, so I didn't turn to check on the front row seat.

Peter drives the car a second later out of the view. I opened my wrist watch and ask, we good. M mini hologram comes out, tracking signal acquired. ART's drove the car to my spot and I didn't waste time to take the driver seat. I tell M, keep the standard distance from them. The car takes me out of the crowded street and we began tailing them. M shows the map of the city on the window display.

He is going outside the city. ART drives the car exactly 200 meters away from them. I didn't want to push it any more since I am tracking them anyways. Soon we cross the sector 3 border. I ask M, anything important here I should know. M says, nothing out of the ordinary. There are mostly factories in this side of the sector. There are zero results on any high alert area watch list. Its possible they were just passing though this place. But then the GPS stops moving.

ART also parks beside the road. I saw the GPS marker close to a water treatment plant. Not at all suspicious, I say. Why did Peter bring them here. I ask M, is there any surveillance in the area. M says, very minimal boss. This area isn't high profile enough to warrant such need. City plans shows they have enough camera's to check the in and out from the street, but not in the plant it self. That's no surprise, the plant runs all the time, but there no crew in the night.

I ask, what about patrols. M responds, I see 5 patrols near this section. But none have this area in their path for the next few hours. Right, nothing suspicious about this too. This is officially now a secret hideout. This carefully chosen place doesn't have any other purpose. What has Peter gotten himself into. I really didn't want my earlier suspicion to be true. What's my next step. Alert the officers on patrol. But what exactly do I say, hey, I was just stalking someone while incognito. I could leave it anonymous, but what if it wasn't anything truly nefarious.

I already put my nose in their business, lets do it properly then. M, how many surveillance bots I got right now. M says, we have 3. ART has confirmed its operational capability is at 100 %. I thought about for a second and say, fine. Release them. But no engaging the target. This is a recon, map the area, look for any people. Nothing more. M says, deploying them now. I hear some gear turning behind the car. 3 spear bots are thrown into the air straight up. They glide in the air with mini propulsion.

All of them has camera, so M links them to the window display. M says, entering stealth mode. The speed decreases, so does the noise it was creating. With slow and hidden movements, it flew in different directions of the plant. One bot came closer to the empty jeep parked beside the plant. It was completely hidden from the street. If this was really some sort of secret meeting, is Elina mixed up in this. No, she can't be. Ryan is with them too. While I don't believe Elina is hiding something, bringing Ryan was very strange. Maybe that what she was upset about while pointing to Ryan back in the bar.

Few minutes later of surveillance revealed nothing. There is nothing disturbed or suspicious. No vehicles or presence. M says, scanning complete. Nothing visible on the outside. Should I proceed to check the inside too. I stop her, no. Don't. I have a bad feeling. Peter can't have brought them to an empty plant in the night. Are you positive, no one is visible. M says, its all clear boss. If there are people, all are inside the building. I decided what to do. I open the small compartment and take out the small bag inside.

It had some battle ready items like medications and surveillance equipment's. I usually don't need it, but I have no choice. I order M, do heavy heat signature detection. If there are people inside, I want to know how many and where they are. From this point on, everything is on stealth mode. I put the micro transmitter on my right ear. M turns my watch into a minimal black screen to reduce the light. M says, shall I bring the bots from ART as backup. I nod, yeah. Good idea. Keep them hidden, but ready. I don't know whats going to happen. I like to avoid any combat if all possible.

Actually, I should leave if the situation escalates. Without my Kuret, I am too easy of a target. But I should prepare for the worst case. I get out of the car and ART camouflages the outside to match the grassy land. With my backpack in tow, I stealthily walk in the land. Using the cover of trees and landscape, I close the distance to the plant's backside. A minute later I hear a vibration on my watch. M has an alert about the surveillance. I crawl down and take a look at the small hologram my watch shows.

Its an arial birds eye view of the plan first. My lean curiously as I see 10 people inside, hurdled in one spot. Dammit, I was right. There are other people inside. Aside from the 3 that entered a while ago, there are 7 close. Then I see 3 more separated from the large cluster. They were spread out in the building. Bodyguards came to mind. It had to be. All 3 were moving around, but not leaving far from their spot. I tap my watch to view the side view of the scanning.

I can see one was in the 1st floor, along side the glass railing. One in the basement and one was very close to the people grouped inside. I think they are guarding the entrance door to hanger area where people are present. I see a lot of movement from this angle in that group. There are something large also that the scanner picked up. What is going on here. Peter brought them to meet this people? What did he get mixed up in. Without ears inside, all these questions would keep piling up. But I know, whatever this is, it is very distressing. A secret meeting in a empty place with no surveillance camera and patrols nearby. This whole thing screams a criminal gang.

Now I should really alert the officers now. I was about to do it, but then I get another alert. The 3 sphere drones had snuck in close by to capture their faces. The watch changes the hologram to show me a view of a highly pixelated camera of their identities. My jaw became loose from the shock. Cory, Quintin and Polly. These are top tier warriors from the tournament. I remember Cory was one of Nathan's lackey in the Valley. Is he also mixed up in this. No, I have kept very close tabs on him. And he knows with me, Blake, Marina and Vanessa here, he be screwed if he pisses off any one of us.

Are these people really hired guns. It's good I didn't call the patrol officers, because they can't handle all these 3 people together. Just what kind of game these people are playing to hire these people as protection. I should call Blake and Marina. I whisper, call Blake, to my watch. While the line connects, I move a little closer to the back entrance. I hid behind a tree and pull out a spare shades I had from the bag. This was designed for tactical purpose. I wore it and turn on the night vision.

From this angle I could zoom in and see Cory walking alongside the railings. I zoom in to him. He doesn't appear to have any weapons. He is strong without it anyways. I lean away and look at my watch. I didn't get an answer from Blake. Was he busy with some meeting? Then I tried Marina hoping she would be available. But she was also not responding. This is not good. I didn't want to do this, but I tried calling Vanessa. She also had turned her phone off.

I slam my fist on the tree, what is going on. I can't reach any of them when I need them the most. What am I going to do now. I can't exactly storm into the place without my Kuret. The bots I have brought will be turned to scrap by the 3 people guarding this place. So the only logical thing is to get ears on inside. I should decide what to do after knowing more. I speak to my watch, M, use one drone to launch a listening bug inside the hanger area. Use the wall in the east side, the one which opens to the inner room beside the loading area. The wall must be thick, so shoot a very small and precise laser and drill the hole.

M says through the transmitter in my ear, boss, a much more optimal location is through the window from the west side. The glass will be easier to shoot through with no noise. I reply, no. Polly is guarding the room not 30 feet from that window. She can sense the changes in temperature around her. She won't hear the sound, but she will most definitely sense the laser heat in such a cold room. Look at her position, she is purposefully standing away from all the machinery that generates the heat. Use the east side, machines running nearby will mask the laser heat enough that she can't sense it.

I remember her fight in the tournament, she was hyper aware of her surrounding. Her dual Kuret skill is very good for detection in such situations. M says, adjustment made. I will also base scenario predictions using their Kuret as a risk factor. That's good, because we will need it. Using the shades I track two of the drones flying stealthily towards the east side. One soars to a minimum height without alerting Cory and other one takes a mid ground level height to drill the hole.

A minute later the drones position themselves and fire. I anxiously looked at the feed from the third drone to monitor the guards position. I don't see any rapid movement, so they must not have heard anything. Instead of becoming less anxious, I was more now. Eager to know what this is all about. The bug was probably stuck into some inner wall of the hanger room, hopefully it can pick up the sound from there. Nothing came for next seconds, I ask, is there a frequency jammer. I can't hear anything.

M says, the bug is active boss. I don't detect any other high signals to cause disturbance. I suspect someone is using a Kuretine inside to block the sounds from leaving the room. M was right, I can't see the glimmers right now, so there's a good chance someone is using a kuritine or they themselves are using a Kuret. They probably didn't even want those 3 to listen what's going inside. I was getting impatient now. This was a bust. I am getting worried about Elina and Ryan much more now.

After scanning their heat signature this long and using Ryans height, M was able to find the identities of the two of them. They and Peter were standing on one side, while rest on the other. Its not just that they are simply surrounding them, they got them cornered. I don't like this one bit. Their body posture seems to have implication of being interrogated. Peter has gotten his siblings into something sinister. I shouldn't interfere directly like this. What if she learns of me because I storm inside. Just an hour ago she said she wasn't a fan of me. This would completely break our friendship. I don't know if can take ruining another person after Catherine and Vanessa.

I grit my teeth in anger. What am I thinking. When did I get so bothered by receiving people's scorn that it would prevent me from doing the right thing. Whatever repercussions happens, its not worth them getting hurt. I take a deep breath to clam my thinking and resolve for a possible close encounter with this group. I have very limited options without my Kuret. But its not like I not done things like this before. I must not forget that I could do these sorts of things on Earth, without relying on my Kuret.

Just because my Kurets gotten stronger, I shouldn't be completely relying on it. My ego has gotten fat with pride and that's one of the reason I have been miserable without my Kuret. I knew that since morning, but I couldn't move past it then. That has changed now. Seeing Elina in a hostile group like this is driving me. I don't believe Peter would let them get hurt, but he did got them involved for some reason. And if anything happens to them, it wouldn't be just on him, but on me too.

I tell M, prepare for infiltration. M responds, not advisable boss. You have not fully recovered from your fight with Charles. And without access to Kuret, you can't fight them. I make small laugh, tell me something I don't know. There is no backup coming, at least not in time. I have to do something. With the level of their security, I don't want to wait anymore. So override any concern setting for me and help me instead. M takes a moment to process and replies, switching to infiltration mode. Retrieving the blueprints and running algorithm for best point of entry undetected.

I began crawling around the field. Whenever Cory comes to the southeast side, I lie down still and avoid making any sound. With painful patience, I cross the land and hide behind the steel fence at the corner of the hanger entrance. M

hasn't response with an optimal entry point, so I sit tight and look for possible place to break into. Not many options. The hanger garage door is wide, but will make too much noise to cut through. The basement door is an option, but Quintin is patrolling below. His light controlling Kuret makes him able to detect light. Like Polly, he also chose the best place that gives the most advantage. Basement rooms and paths that are dark.

What's more, he can go invisible. If he suspects something when I break in, I might not be able to see him. Even with my night vision shades, the machinery around the basements generates heat. Its dark in the basement, but its hot as well. I am not fully equipped with any weapons too. I could get cornered if I am not careful there. So that's not an option too. As I crossed off other entry points, M says, I found a way to get inside boss. Through the water input pipe in the southwest. The pipe is large enough to fit a person in it. The pipe has a hatch outside and another one that opens inside the building. The outside hatch is easy to open and enter. Then you can cut through the other hatch from the inside with a laser and gain entry into the water treatment room number 5. It's one of the stations where Kuret treatment happens.

I ask, what about the water in the pipe. I don't have my underwater breathing apparatus. M answers, at night, few selected pipe are shut down. The water is closed off from the river side as well, so it will remain empty. It will be however, be terribly damp due to constant river water being fed through it. I can't worry about that. This looks like a viable option. I ruffle inside the bag and confirm I had the laser cutter. I ask, any idea how thick the iron is around the hatch. M says, unknown. The laser will cut through all of the material listed from the blueprint. with 97 percent probability. I will take that as a good sign.

Then I ask, this could work. How do I gain access to the hanger area room then. There is only two entry point, the garage door and inside door where Polly is guarding it. M answers, you navigate on this path from the control room. M shows a path in a hologram of the building. It leads to a operating room in the first floor that has window facing to the hanger room. I should be able to pry a small window open and listen in. I nod, all right, start showing me the path in my eye piece display.

I approach carefully to the outside hatch as M directs me. I was coming much closer to Cory's view now. While he may not be able to see me, he could hear me opening it. I have to time it properly when he is farthest away from this side. I have been observing his strides a while ago when I was waiting at the fence. He is moving in a predictable pace, so I have exactly 1 minute and 18 seconds before he laps this side. I hid behind a tree preparing myself to run when Cory leaves this side.

M started a countdown in my shades screen. As soon as he was out of view I dashed as deftly I could without making a sound. I saw the hatch door coming into view. I hope its not rusted. M told me earlier its used for regular maintenance inside, so I really hope its loose and quite enough. A moment later I skid down and grab the large handle The cold metal comes in contact and I anxiously start to rotate the hatch. This hatch is supposed to be a two person job. Its very heavy and refusing to budge. I put all the force into my wrists to get it moving.

A few seconds went by and I all managed to do was a little superficial movement. Shit. M failed to tell I it was this heavy. This probably isn't a problem for the workers, with their Kuret. Honestly, this should have been nothing for me. I grit my teeth in frustration as I kept pushing. Then I saw the countdown on my eye glass. I wasted a minute, this is bad. I let go of the handle and crawled back to the nearest tree I had marked for hiding in case I couldn't do it. Just few seconds before Cory came into the view, I hid behind the tree from his angle.

My fist tighten agitated. I can't fumble like this. Its pathetic. I get a flashback of the fight with Charles. I felt the same as back then. I was loathing myself when made mistakes and hid behind a boulder and pit. I thought I had moved passed such emotions. But it came back. No, I have been feeling it whole day in its own way. I have become over reliant on my Kuret. Since the war last year, I have become physically stronger, but my mental states been affected. So much so that I become weak without my Kuret. M begins a new countdown as Cory makes his next lap. But I didn't move. I took a deep breath to clear my thoughts.

I recalled Hansens and James words. Two mentors from two different planet, but same one lesson for me. Learn from mistakes. Even when I couldn't remember Hansen, I was unconsciously following his teaching. Drew also mentioned about repressed memories guiding my decisions unconsciously. But did I learn from the fight. No, I didn't. Not really. I had to fight the yips back then, and I will fight this mental block. With or without my Kuret. I resolved myself again. If I can't do it with strength, I will find a different way.

I opened my eyes and turned to see Cory leaving this side. I crawled back to hatch and sat in front of it. I was too agitated earlier, but I calmed myself to breathe slowly. Analyze the situation, like how I been doing all my life. The hatch is big and heavy, I didn't feel it was rusted, so its just about the correct force and angle. There is no strong stick to use as leaver and no gloves or cloth to get better friction with hands. I got an idea, instead of continues force, short burst of momentum could work.

I position myself on my back and angle my right leg towards the round edge of the hatch. And then I kicked with all my power I could muster. My kick make a low thump sound, and the hatch moved ever so slowly. I corrected the angle a little bit and kicked again. The hatch was turning with this position now. I felt a rush of adrenaline and continued to kick at the corner. It was definitely loosening now. But the time was running out. I hid again behind the tree once more. Even though this was a small insignificant obstacle, I felt some mental pressure I had all day getting lighter. It felt strange that a water pipe hatch did the trick for me that nothing else worked. Luck and coincidences, powerful things in the correct situation.

Once he left, I went back to work. With a bunch of more kicks at the correct angle, the hatch become loose enough for me to move it with my arms. The hatch was making small sound from the metal turning, but from the surveillance drone I saw Cory not reacting. I didn't want to waste another chance so I pushed a little faster and got it open. Now I have to open this heavy hatch, not just with brute force again. I crouched myself in a position where I bend my back and knees to use my entire body as a leaver.

This is the same concept used in tug of war, using the entire whole body weight. The result is how I expected, the hatch was heavy, but gravity was much stronger on myside. My grip tightens as I lunge backwards to the opening hatch. And soon it opened completely. Only 20 seconds remaining before Cory came in view. I swivel on the ground and jump in feet first. M was right, the pipe was big enough for a person to fit. The splash of the puddle in the bottom made an echoing sound in the hollow pipe. I sure hope no one heard that, because this was unavoidable.

I turn up and jump to grab the bottom inside handle of the hatch. I can't let it remain open for Cory to accidently see it. I was risking making a large sound when it closed. When the metal clashed, it made a low pitched sound. It reverberated in this pipe. I looked anxiously at the Cory from the surveillance camera, the thermal view showed no change. I exhale a long breadth. I dodged a bullet here. Maybe the sound didn't travel far like it did here. I confirmed Quintin and Polly also weren't moving far from their spot.

I didn't want to take more risk, so I began walking inside with slow and careful steps. It was getting damp and hot as I reach the building. My shoes were getting dragged in moss and a bit of mud. This is not how I imagined my infiltration would look like without my Kuret. I remembered how I was able to use the Kuret that reduces friction when I was crawling in the passage while looking for Charles in the coliseum. I smiled at that, compared that elegant and skillful work, this is brutish and ineffective.

I shake myself out of the negative feeling. It doesn't matter how I do it, as long as the job gets done the way I want. A few minutes later, M shows me the hatch distance in 50 meters. It comes into my view and it was the same as the one I used to enter. However, this was on the side, not on the top. At least M had chosen the correct pipe. It was on the top, I don't know how I would have opened it from the inside, even with my laser cutter. Actually, I wouldn't let that stop me. I would definitely find a way even if that had happened.

Once I reach to the spot I whisper, M, start scanning this area use the blueprints to find the approximate location of the lock I need to cut. I pull out the laser cutter from my bag. M begins to scan from my shades and begins to perform analysis. A minute later M says, analysis complete. The eye glass shows me the spot on the pipe wall that had the lock. I get to work and fire the cutter. M had shown me a rectangular area, so I was cutting though the metal in a unform way. This would have been a sinch with my glimmers. No, don't go there again. Doing it differently, doesn't mean its wrong.

Soon I fished the breaking the lock. I heard a small metal creaking. I have to carefully push it out and make sure it doesn't fall down. Otherwise there will be big noise for the whole building to hear. Using M's help I locate the best place and angle to push the hatch so that it doesn't fall. I took my time this time as I wasn't in a real rush. And gradually, the hatch opens with a whooshing noise. With one eye I was staring at the widening gap, with other I was monitoring the feed from the surveillance drones.

Finally, the gap was large enough for me to get out. With meticulous movements, I climb out of the pipe and push the hatch back into the pipe. I looked around the room with my night vision. It was like M said, it was a control room. There were machines and controls all around the room. I located the door and walked towards it. I was very close to Quintin this side of the building. However, I had the advantage here. I have an eye on them from the outside and inside.

I realized my shoes were wet and the sole was covered it dirt. He might see my dirty footprint as I move around the place. I removed them from my foot and threw it in a corner. I removed the socks too, since it was soaking wet. I thought the concrete floor would be cold, but the heat generated from the machines makes it warm. I then wait for Quintin to be farthest away from this door. Once M confirms it, I crack open the door and move out. I walk sideways, hugging the wall on my backside. This was the best way to avoid making any sounds.

M had turned on a virtual route though my shade glasses and I continue to walk through that route. I passed through a machinery room and took the stairs and back down again. I had studied the blueprint earlier too, so I know I was heading in the right direction, just talking the long route. Soon I was near the hanger area. I still couldn't hear anyone talking. I tried to list down all the Kurets I could recall that makes this effect. The obvious one is the sound absorbing Kuret I used in the match with Charles. But there are couple more that can have the same effect. If there is an alpha with them, it could prove troublesome. Their range will be far more than normal.

I was now getting closer to Polly. She was 50 meters to my left, while I was crawling in a room parallel to her. I held my breadth and made sure to turn off my watch and shade before approaching her vicinity. I won't let her detect any electrical heat coming from any of the devices I have. I was a little worried about the body heat, but M had accounted for that too. I was walking beside a small turbine, its speed was reduced at night, but it was generating enough heat to mask my presence to her.

At long last, I reach the hanger control room. With arduous and anxious steps, I open the door and slithering. I am crouching down as I enter to avoid being seen from the windows in front. I didn't dare to look up and see who or what people were doing until I find a good spot. I found one at the corner. Based on the thermal vision, they are standing at an angle from where they can't see this corner. I take the corner and stood up hugging the wall. I was worried that I wouldn't be able to hear them even from this distance, but I could definitely hear muffled noises. I am relieved that I am inside the Kuret range.

The windows are drilled into the wall, so I can't pry it open. But fortunately, I had the device for this type of task now. I fished out my listening device from the bag and stuck the dish end to the window. This one had a vacuum suction feature that can listen to sounds from thin walls and windows. M syncs it to my transmitter in the ear. I begin to hear static noise initially as it calibrates gradually.

Now's the time I can figure out with Peter has his new friends are mixed up in.

David (Chapter 72)

Tuesday, January 13, 2026 20:37

I begin to hear muffled noise. Still not clear enough to understand. M was running analysis and adjusting the device's configuration. I bet there is interference due to the sound blocking Kuret. It will definitely have some physical jamming property. M says, boss, the signals I am getting are distorted, but I am analyzing the waveform to adjust for this room. Give me one minute to recalibrate. While I waited I decided to risk it and take a peek from the corner at them through the window.

This room was dark, but the hanger area wasn't. The low illumination yellow light came from Kuritines glow sticks on the walls. They were not using electricity of the building, avoid even being detected by the islands electric grid. They really don't want anyone knowing they are here. After a long waited moment, I finally get to see the people involved in all this. The first people my eyes laid on were Peter, Elina and Ryan. All 3 are looking scared and tense. But not hurt. I sigh of relief left my lips.

Ryan was clutching Elina from behind. No, Elina was keeping him behind her. Peter was beside the two, but positioned himself in between them and other groups. Like a mediator. I was right, the others were cornering those 3 for some reason. Unfortunately, I couldn't see any of their faces from this side, only partial faces. M was already running analysis on facial recognition on the people through my shades. There was one guy was behaving more agitated and vocal. And Peter kept waves his arms around as to rebuke in response.

A moment later M says, boss, audio signal reconstruction complete. There is a delay of about 0.2 seconds due to the signal reconstruction, so please prepare yourself for the visual and audio misalignment. It would have been worse. At least I can hear them now. The first voice came of the agitated man, easier for you and give up. I got all night and nothing to do until I catch the person. We will get to the truth eventually. I hear others grumbling as the voice laughs.

I whisper to M, it’s a long shot, but run voice recognition of all of them against the network social media, any online video and officers database. We may get a hit. M says, on it. I recognized Peters voice, why do you think you will get a different answer. I will keep denying it whole night if I have to. I can't believe how stupid you are thinking I have anything to gain from this. Looks like he has been defending some accusation from others. And somehow that also includes Elina and Ryan. I hope they weren't involved.

The angry voice says, Wyan, lets beat some sense to him. My body freeze for a second reacting to this. Are things escalated to physical altercations now. The guy named Wyan replies, I told you many times now. No violence, we are civilized business men. Besides, I am still not sure if she is cleared of suspicion. I ask you again Elina, tell me you did it. You will a world if pain. Elina, visibly shaken and scared, shrieks, you keep asking me things I don't understand. Please Peter, you promised us it wasn't dangerous. Let us go.

Peter replies, not before they realize we got nothing to do with this. Wyan, just trust me, Elina had no idea this was going on. You already confirmed she wasn't near this shipment ever before, so she has nothing to do with this. Neither do I. my eyes turn towards the crate lying in the middle of the hanger. This is linked to his part time job. I began forming a hypothesis, actually, it was almost certain now. They are illegally importing stuff from outside. A smuggling ring. I lean back to the wall in shock. Such a criminal activity was happening under our noses and no one knew. Everyone were busy with the tournament, and these guys must have exploited that as well.

I see M running analysis on the crate too. I couldn't see what was inside it, but it was large. Whatever it was, it was too large to be smuggled in without detection. So there must be something hidden inside. Elina cries, Peter, please. At least take Ryan away from here. You all have to believe he is not involved in this. Another guy steps forward, no ones leaving until we get answers. I don't care if he is a kid. Everyone here is an equal suspect. Huh, what's going on. I thought everyone were ganging up on the 3 of them since beginning.

The angry guy says, not this again. Everyone's been vetted. Nothing was stolen from this shipment and the previous one. The guy replies, but not the one from 3 weeks ago. That’s why we all are here right, it happened once, so no reason to believe it didn't happen again. We got to check again. Suddenly people argue over that. I hear frustrated shouts of voices, waste of time, nowhere close to the truth and stuff like that. M still hadn't identified any of the voices. This Wyan name could be an alias too.

Wyan raises his hand, shut up. All of you. This is serious, stop behaving like animals. We will get to the truth eventually. Yes, every been tested. But that doesn't mean anything, any of us could hire someone to steal it. I don't care how many times we do this, we need to find the culprit. I am getting a more accurate reading of them now. Seems like someone has stolen something and they are grouped here to find the culprit. I guess thievery is a common side effect of criminal behavior. Even if your in a group. So how Peter, Elina and Ryan fit into it.

Peter turned to be a criminal after all. His laxed attitude in the bar should have been apparent that it would lead to him doing this. I am not that surprised he actually became a criminal. But Elina, I can't picture it. Sure she struggled financially, but she is stable now. I don't think I mis judged her to be greedy enough to commit crimes with her brother. So far I still haven't heard what's her involvement in this. Peter says, tell me what we can do more to prove it. You already questioned us, tested our Kuret prints on the crate and continue to hound my family. What more could you want.

Wyan says, I have been saying this. I have handpicked all of you, so I know your ambitions and the lengths you would go. She is the unknown variable here. I want her to admit it. I know a guilty person when I see. Ryan behind her shouts, leave us alone. We told you, we have not stolen anything. Elina grabs Ryan and pulls her behind her to shush him. The angry guy says, the kids got a mouth. Don't know about the girl though, but my money's on the kid. He small hands are perfect for grabbing stuff from small places.

People begin arguing over it. Wyan, apparently the boss of this gang was not yelling at people to shut up. They are kind of disorganized, but they do seem to be listening to him. M says, boss. I have identified the crates. Its registered under Elina. She has ordered it for shipments of various kinds of liquor. Her last shipment was for whiskeys. My heart drop hearing that. Was Elina also mixed up in this. I recalled all the conversation I had with her. She claims she can read people, well, so can I. And she was honest about being profitable the right way. I didn't feel anything from her that screamed she was being deceitful. She is a hard worker, until Peter. Would she really risk her family and reputation by joining Peter with this.

I refuse to believe that. But then I realized I was also lying to her. Could it be she was too. Is she scared because she is caught stealing or is a genuine fear. But all this for a bootlegging theft. No, that doesn't explain the severity of this issue. Regardless of whether Elina is involved, her shipment must be a cover to smuggle in the actual goods. Wyan turns to Peter, I have one final wat to figure out if she is lying. Peter says, great. Lets get this over with and prove our innocence.

The angry guy says, really now. Why did you wait until now to say it. Wyan says, I wanted to avoid it. Its not reliable, but they are not cooperating with us. Even when I am so graciously keeping everyone from you all. Elina cries for help, please, believe me. I know nothing of this. Peter hid this from us. I don't know about missing drugs. My eyes widen at that information. She didn't know. Whatever inkling I had, was being washed away with relief. I shouldn't have doubted her, but I couldn't exactly rule it out until now. Then my gut tighten on the new information too. Drugs were being smuggled in. What kind, something that would useful for Medrones.

The angry guy says, not missing women. Stolen. MCTL, Hetrox and Pesphinate. It was your shipment, you found out and stole from us to report us, Didn't you. A small shiver goes through my spine. My heart beats faster when I heard the drug names. I know them. All the high ranking officers know it. Elina shouts, I didn't take whatever the hell it is. I didn't know my crates were used for it. And no one reported it, because we didn't know. Please, let us go. I was hearing them, but my mind was racing on different thoughts.

The poison used on Marina and almost on Blake. They were the once who did it. Wait, somethings not right here. I only found residue for MCTL and Hetrox. I didn't know about the third one. Besides that, why would this group try to sabotage the tournament. I am missing something here. Wyan says, I don't believe you. You have a look of someone caught in a trap. I can tell. Your brothers are clueless, but I am not sold on you. Elina yells, I am scared Peter. You promised we would be safe if we were honest. I have told the truth all this time.

Peter says, she is right, Wyan. You don't have a shred of proof. Don't just blame her or me with just wild intuition. Will you promise to let them leave once you know they didn't steal the drugs. Wyan laughs, you don't make demands here. I will not let anyone go until we find the culprit, even if she turns out innocent. Elina makes whimpering noise. I could feel she has been crying. Ryan behind her was grabbing on Elina's waist as she steps a little back from others.

She was really scared now. And I can't blame her. This is less of an interrogation, and more of baseless accusation. I so wish I could just jump in and stop these people. Even if I had my Kuret, I couldn't risk it without knowing their identities. M hasn't been able to identify anyone with their voice. It had a low success probability anyways without a dedicated voice database. The facial recognition was also not happening from this angle and no clear lighting.

Wyan walks and whispers something to the one of the people. One thing I don't understand, why did they reveal their faces to Elina and Ryan. I have listened enough to understand that they made Peter bring Elina and Ryan because they had access to their shipments. Peter was in a rush because of others. They must have threated him or his siblings. And Peter was right to be scared, they got some pretty powerful warriors with them. Still, none of it explained why they didn't kept their identities hidden from those two. They can't be this foolish after doing this much consideration in their security. My throat becomes hard thinking a possible reason.

Wyan said he won't anyone leave, even if Elina was innocent. Lets assume it did turn out to be someone else, what will happen to Elina then. This might not be a real hideout, but she has seen their faces. They can't risk her exposing them. I gulp hard realizing they don't intend to leave her. I don't know what this Wyan guy is capable of. He might blackmail her with something or worse, eliminate her all together. Shit. Why didn't I think of this earlier.

I whisper to M, I don't care what you have to do. Get some backup. Send priority network message to all the officers and patrols in the vicinity. I don't care who it is. M says, boss, there is a problem. My link is broken with ART, unfortunately the facial and audio recognition have not been working since beginning. I had assumed the IP requests were sent and taking time to respond, but on further analysis, its been running on a continuous loop. I believe along with a sound blocking Kuretine, they have some sort of electrical disrupter as well. What the hell.

M says, I have been running with limited capability and most of my processing is focused correcting the audio signals and surveillance feeds from the drones. The thermal image is also receiving static noises. Shit, I was focused too much on these guys that I didn't notice the glitches on the frames at the corner of my eye glasses. I put my hand on my temple frustrated. I ask, how did you not detect this before. M says, suspecting the disturbance is from a Kuritine similar to a EMP field, very stable, but very small too. This looped field was allowing infrared thermal signals, but not the frequency of island network or the ART.

This is worse than I thought. No way he don't plan to do something to Elina and Ryan after making sure such level of secrecy. I should have told M to send an alert to others if I couldn't from inside. Too late now. The only other way is for me to go back the way I came. But I couldn't leave after seeing Elina crying and Ryan scared out of his mind. I don't know what Wyan has been discussing with others, but it can't be good. Curse this, of all the day I have mental issues, this had to be worst one.

The angry guys shouts, what's this kid. I saw you looking at the door. Don't you dare. Elina shields Ryan form the guy who was walking towards him. She yells, don't come closer. Peter steps in front of them, he, leave it alone, he is not going anywhere. But the guy shoves him away, buzz off. Wyan told you, you are not in charge here. Peter gets pushed away and falls on his ass shouting, you bastard. You will regret this. The guy laughs hysterically,

pathetic, you are a bottom feeder. We are using you, not the other way around. Don't you forget that.

Before I could understand what he means by that I saw Ryan coming out escaping Elinas arm and runs towards him. Oh no, don't do it Ryan. My eyes twitches in despair as he kicks the guy in the nuts. The guy wasn't expecting it and he shrieks in pain. He bends over a little stumbling a few steps behind. Ryan says, stay away from him. Elina frantically runs behind him shouting, Ryan. No. Don't. The guy stand up still in pain and coughing, freak this kid. Behind him Wyan says, stop this Grover.

He yells, like hell I will. The guy gets his balance and shouts at Ryan, you little freak. You will pay for this. Peter screams, no don't. I was frozen, in the dark when I see the guy use his Kuret. I couldn't tell what it was in beginning, but then I saw it. It was a light yellow Kuret that was turning into a rope. I don't know this Kuret, but I have seen it somewhere. But I couldn't focus at all. Because of what happened next. The guy throws his Kuret on the Ryan, but Elina manages to push him out of way.

No. no. She wasn't fast enough to dodge it herself. I slammed my hands on the glass unconsciously without caring if was spotted. Elina cries fill the air around the empty room as she falls bleeding on the floor. I got angry seeing the face I was seeing an hour ago so happy, and now covered in blood. She falls on her back on the ground and remains still. No, she can't be. This is wrong. Ryan crouches down beside Elina shouting, Elina. Peter screams from the floor, what the hell did you do.

Wyan and others came rushing towards them. Wyan yells as he grabs the man, freak Grover. He disperse his Kuret, he made me do it. My eyes were glued to Elina's motionless body. My whole body went limp and fall back to the wall. I didn't care if they saw me now. This is my fault, I let her die. What the hell was all this for. I couldn't help her, I didn't bring help. I was useless. Ryan was wailing over Elina's body. My heart begins to race and sweats pour down. I began shaking.

I saw it then. History repeating itself. I saw Zakerine over Johns dead body. She was crying and trying to revive his corpse. My vision gets blurry. I only saw Zakerine in place of Ryan. John's body where Elina's bleeding. My body feels like its about to burst anytime. I am having a full blown panic attack. But I couldn't feel it. All I felt was despair. Nothing changed. I let her die. Ryans going to die too. Just like the pile of dead bodies hunting me. I was deluding myself, thinking I could save them.

My body felt so heavy that I got dragged down and hit the floor. My hands are trembling as I grab my chest. My teeth is shivering, I could taste the fear in my mouth. My ears are filled with the cries of Ryan. Then I hear Zakerine voice. Her cries mixed in with Ryan. What's going on. I am loosing my grip on reality. Am I stuck in the past, or in the future. I grab my hands on my throbbing head. I want it to stop. My heads about to burst open. Its too much. How I am letting this happen again despite getting strong.

A voice looms in my mind, did you really become strong. You are still that scared little kid inside. I recognize this voice. Its him. My worst enemy. I said aloud not caring about others, get out. The voice says, I can't stupid. I am dead. You soon that kid will be too. And then you. Just imagine this, you survived so much, only to be killed by a couple of common criminals. I shout out, leave me alone. The voice now comes back with his face in front of me, its so pathetic. So many people died. And you wasted their efforts. You should have just stayed on Medrine to die. Let someone better take your place.

I covered my ears to stop the phantom voice, shut up. I closed my eyes, but his face becomes more closer to me laughing manically. He says, just die already. You couldn't save Zakerine then, and you can't now. She will die again. I shook my head. No, she won't die. He says, she will always die. Zakerine made her choice to die. Now its your turn. My anger was souring such height that I could actually feel my blood boil. Is this it, am I really going to let her die again.

I saw Zakerine now. She was happy and we were laughing. We were enjoying on our missions, then she was annoying me when we wrote the book. Our training sessions together. I was going to loose all of it. Again. The voice says, yes. You will. You are still so weak. My sister see's your true self now, something I have known since beginning. I grit my teeth in fury. My heart was about to burst any moment. I want this to end. I want Zakerine back. In the middle of all the voices in my head, I heard Elina's name from Ryan.

My mind suddenly singularity focused on that one cry. What am I doing. Elina is still alive. I can still save her. I couldn't save Zakerine. But she isn't Elina. The voice rejects it, you can't. You are the same. I ignored it. I was only listening to Ryan. I could hear only his voice. My voice. The same kind I had when Zakerine was dying. I saw myself then. I looked pathetic, weak and most of all, terrified. Is this all I am in the end. With all my intelligence and strength, my will is this weak.

The voice kept trying to drag me down to the abys. But the cries kept me strangely together. This can't be all I am. I have changed since then. It can't be only what I am seeing. Slowly, but gradually the voices fade. I focused only the cries, mine and Ryan's. Then I heard the cries of others, Branden, Hansen. They were there too. But that didn't stop them from fighting back. If they can do it, so can I. My teary eyes open with sudden burst of energy. I was back in the dark room.

My body was still shaking beyond my control. And yet somehow I was able to make a fist and hit my thigh. My heart felt like its racing out of my body. I shout out, I going to save them. Let me do it. Move dammit. My voice was loud, so was my anger. The anger finally brought my Kuret out. I felt my whole body tingle with familiar power. My bones that felt so brittle, felt alive again. My Kuret burst open from my body like a exploding bomb. Flowing out in all directions, across the walls and rooms.

This was the trigger I needed. My Kurets back. All the voices filling my head were gone. No. I could still feel them. They only gotten quitter for now. That didn't matter. I was back. My body slowly calms down, so does my heart. I got up from the floor and stood on my feet. I turned to the window to understand what I had just done. My Kuret had seeped into the entire space in the hanger area. The Kuretine glow sticks were flickering under my Kuret presence.

I gaze down at my hands trying to understand what just happened. I overcame it. The realization finally hit me like a thunder. I am agitated as hell, but I can control my Kuret without crashing out. This is unmistakenly the same feeling I have relied on for years. I tighten my fist and thrust myself throw the window. I came crashing through it on the other side. I hear everyone shouting at each other confused. I could see them now, their glimmers. Its back as well. Its like my whole world lit up. This was different than my yips during the match. It was stronger, more deeper.

I land on the shatters glasses on the ground. I should be hurt, but the Kuret covered in my feet protected me. This is my Kuret dome. I was almost passing out a moment ago, what a complete reversal. I saw everyone's glimmers around me. They were all panicking, running around in confusion. Some had red glimmers, some blue and others orange. I could see it all. I turn towards Elina, the glimmers of her blood was potent.

But before I rushed towards her, I saw the person beside her. The one who attacked her beside her. I focused all my rage on him. With my Kuret thrust, I rushed ahead straight at him. He was shouting, what hell is going on. I respond to him with a straight punch to his face. My fist was covered in dense Kuret as I struck him. He bellows as I crush his nose under my fist and throw him away back into the pillar wall. It was good I let my anger at him. That burst of anger helped me calm down even more.

I look down to Elina's body. I could see glimmers flickering on her skin. My heart beats easier realizing I wasn't late. She is still alive. I can save her. I turn to others around me, you all are freaked.

David (Chapter 73)

Thursday, January 15, 2026 12:09

Its a chaotic now. Some of the people have cleared out from the hanger area. They are moving beside the wall or towards the exit. My Kuret has filled the entire place, making it pitch dark. I myself have been wrapped in my Kuret, probably making me blend in with the Kuret around and hiding my presence. As I calm myself from the panic attack I just had, I start to strategize. The first priority is to save Elina. She told me about her medical condition and I don't think that was made up. Her healing abilities are severely affected and I could confirm it when her bleeding weren't slowing, even for regular Medrones.

I don’t think I will make it in time to take her to a hospital or bring medical attention to her. Then the only option is for me to a healing Kuret on her. That means I have to setup my Kuret storm. And I need to dispel my Kuret dome in order to do that. But before I do that I realize one thing, I shouldn't let anyone see me. I realized the best course of action for this and waved my Kuret around to destroy the Kuritine glow sticks on the walls and pillars. One by one, the light dims in the hanger.

My eyes fell towards the center of the room. There was a briefcase with two large Kuritine put on a stand. One was purple and other radiated maroon. Those are the Kuretines that block sound and communication. I need to destroy the one that jams the signal, and keep the sound barrier, at least for now. But I can't tell which is it. The two Kuretines were kept too close and I was a little farther away to see the glimmer and its property. I could destroy both, but I don't want all the 3 bodyguards to hear people screaming. I had no choice but to leave it for now.

I hear someone grunting. There was a person who was still standing near me, what the hell is going on. Who's here. It's the boss, he had crouched down on his knees, but he wasn't frantic like others. I needed him to get out of my way. I grab his body with my hands on his collar. He was shouting, get off me. He tried to wriggle out in the darkness, trying to fight me off. But my arms, strengthened with Kuret, didn't let him go. I slam my knees straight into his face. He winces in pain from his broken jaw. I wasn't going to waste any more time on this trash, so I just threw a kick to his guts. He flies off to a corner and knocks out on the impact.

I begin to gather my Kuret in my hands and focus on making the inner sphere. I need to hurry, the 3 problematic people will be here soon. I don't know if that will be enough, but at least I will get one shot of Kuret. I will the Kuret around my hands to move in circular motion. My Kuret dome begins to shrink into a ball in my hand. I poured all my will into making the Kuret vibrate faster and gather the ambient Kuret inside it. People were still shouting around me, some cursing while others were asking where is Wyan.

I ignored them as much as I could. My hands were trembling, still reeling from the effects from the nervous breakdown. I focused on saving Elina and nothing else. My Kuret sphere suddenly turned into a wild exploding ball. I could feel it, its similar to what I did in the match. But its erratic, much less controllable. I figured it was beginner luck the first time. Doesn't matter the efficiency for now. As long as I can get one Kuret blast. Then I hear the glass shattering above me.

From the glimmers I saw Cory jumping throw the windows the first floor. Shit. The sound is cancelled in this area, but not the vision. I need to hurry up before Cory comes down here. My fist tighten and a small yell comes out as I kept pushing to make the Kuret storm forming into a smaller size. I felt it then, the pressure in my hands. Yes, its working. Just few more seconds. At the corner of my eye, I saw Elina's glimmer flickering slower. Oh shit. Ryan wasn't even paying attention to what was going around. He had his hands clutched on Elina's shirt and buried his face on floor, like he is trying to stop the bleeding by covering her shirt.

He was unknowingly hurting Elina. Its not his fault, but he was making it worse. I tell him, let go of her Ryan, you are hurting her. He didn't let go of her. Either he ignored me, or didn't hear me. He is in shock, his glimmer showed yellow. I see a similar glimmer coming from the person hiding in a corner. Peter, who was now cowering and scared shitless, hiding in the corner behind the crate. Damit, both brothers are too damn rattled. I had no choice but to do it. Its not done, but I can't risk anymore time.

I prepared the Kuret storm and throw the healing Kuret on Elina. This was nothing short of a gamble, unlike Janathan, I can't adjust this Kuret compatibility to the targets body and Kuret. All I can hope a large overdose of alpha level healing Kuret would be enough. But the Kuret I showered Elina wasn't at alpha level, hell it was even less than the average. I didn't have enough time to prepare it. I grit my teeth in frustration. I kneel down and focus on the largest part of the wound on her chest. If I can't heal her injuries, at least I can slow it down.

Few more seconds and I saw her glimmers stops fading. Her heartbeats is slower, but at least it isn't going down. That’s a good sign. I let out a sigh just as the healing Kuret ends. I still had my Kuret storm held together, but it was a just hollow now. I had no choice but to disperse it. I felt sweat tricking down my face from that sudden arduous task. But my work is not over. Elina's is hanging on, barely, for now. She needs help. But now I can focus on others.

I move towards Ryan and tell him, get help. You need to go and alert any officer you can find. Ryan wasn't letting go of Elina. He cries out, I am not leaving her. She is hurt. I knew I was asking too much of him, but right now, we are in middle of a mess. Having him here is problematic for what I am going to do. Using my Kuret I yank him away. His grip on Elina's clothes were tight, but I wasn't going to make it easy on him. He stumbles on his legs and falls down.

Even if I was not using my night vision shades, I would have seen he was crying hard. Tears filled his eyes and face. I tell him, you are hurting your sister. I'll keep her safe, so go and get help. He was too scared to be doing anything when he couldn't even see me. He frantically looks around, tapping his hands on the ground searching for Elina, where is She. Elina. Dammit. I was expecting too much of him. He isn't like me. I am putting unreasonable expectation on him.

I saw Cory coming out of the stairs and looking around the place. I don't have time to deal with Ryan. I prepare to fight him and raise my arms. It won't be easy and the other two will be here soon. I turn to Elina, then to Ryan, then to Peter. I saw people trying to leave, some already did. I figured out what I need to do. I put him arms back down. I need to be smart about this. I ran to the room I was hiding earlier and jumped through the broken windows. The remaining glass shatters into pieces, but I didn't care.

I went to grab the bad I had left behind and pulled out the voice changer. I slap in on my neck and whisper, M, listen to carefully. I need you to do exactly what I say. M says, understood boss. I begin to gather my Kuret into another sphere. Now that Elina was not in mortal danger, I was more calm and could focus better on building my Kuret storm properly. As I prepared my Kuret I gave instructions to M, once I destroy that EMP Kuret, get all the bots you got as backup here. Have them close the entire building. Bolt the doors, cover the windows, I don't care how, just keep anyone from escaping.

M says, what about the warriors boss, the bots can't stop them. I say, leave them to me. I will stop them. You just make sure others don't leaves this building. If somehow anyone escape, tell me. I will drag them back inside. M says, understood. They will be here in 45 seconds once the link is restored to ART. I take another breath while making the Kuret storm more stable. The wild exploding kuret was still not like how I used it during the match. But as long what I plan works, it doesn't matter if Kuret produced isn't on alpha level.

I peaked out through the window. Cory is navigating though the place, I saw him talking to someone. He must be trying to understand the situation. I need another minute. I just need 5 decent shots of Kurets, that should be enough. Then I see Ryan crawling around the ground helplessly. Peter had curled up in a corner. I explain the next order to M, get one bot inside and carry Ryan out of here. Get him to the road, take the northwest road, I think there is a patrol path coming soon. M responds, preparing instructions for the bot. Wouldn't it be better to send the message myself.

I say, just let Ryan get help. We need to keep our presence hidden. Don't let anyone see any bot too. M complies, adjusting the battle protocols. And then I explained the 2 remaining orders to M. Once done I turned around again. Cory had found his way in the dark towards Ryan and Elina. He must have heard Ryans cries. I don't know what he might do with them. So I got up and braced myself. My Kuret storm was making whooshing sound, so staying hidden wouldn't matter. My position was a good enough vantage point to attack.

I built this one better than the previous one. The exploding Kuret was still not showing the same level of energy from the coliseum. But for a makeshift one, it wasn't bad. M says, the voice configuration is 80% complete. So I can't attack Cory yet. Fine, I can finish off others as much as I can. I throw a sound wave Kuret to the 2 Kuritines in the stand. I had recognized one of the people's Kuret glimmer earlier. They are from the same bloodline from that alpha who could amplify sounds using Kuret. The one I used against Charles.

Cory and few others back away when they hear the Kuritine breaking from the sound pressure. I kept throwing the soundwave to the entire room, dragging it across to anyone close by. One guy tried to defend himself with his Kuret. I couldn't recall this glimmer Kuret. He didn't have a strong Kuret though, because he was hurled into the air and thrown back to the pillar up side down. One more unlucky person was not able to dodge it. It hit him in his legs and his knees broke, twisting it around. Red glimmers erupted as he slumps down and shouts in pain.

I stop this Kuret realizing its good enough and prepare for the next victim. Cory yells preparing his rotting Kuret on his arms, who the hell was that. A women screams, Lance. What are you doing. A different guy from some far corner shouts, what are you talking about. I wasn't going to give them time to talk though. M says, link established boss. Deploying the bots. I also have the results for the facial scans from earlier. I smile at that, tell me what Kuret does that guy who attacked Elina has. Show his Kuret marker if you have it.

M shows the face on my shades. His name is Grover and his bloodline Kuret is to create Kuret ropes. They are not that strong, but its sharp. The actual good news was that I did have his bloodline marker. M shows the marker pattern in my screen and use it to prepare my next Kuret attack. Meanwhile people were shouting at Lance. Lance was shouting back, I don't what you are taking about. I didn't attack anyone. Then someone used a Kuret to start a fire and light up the place.

Oh, no you don't. I can't let people see each other. I don't how good I would be able to replicate Grovers Kuret without testing it. But I didn't have any choice but to use it whatever it may be. My Kuret storm shakes and a long raggedy Kuret rope comes out. It was barely shaped like a rope, more like brown threads crumbled together. But it had speed and power. I had aimed at the women near the fire and it struck her back. She stumbles down while wriggling, freak. Grover, stop this. Its me god dammit.

She hits the floor beside the bricks she had lit on fire. The Kuret rope I throw cuts off in the middle. I guess that’s all I can manage without controlling it. However, the Kuret attack was still coming out from my Kuret storm, so I aim it towards the bricks and knock them out from their place. The rope's force was dense enough to blast them far and fast enough to put off the fires. The little embers still remains, but it was significantly dimmer now. Like water I continue to spray the Kuret rope all over the place.

People were trying to defend from it. I saw Kuret clashing all over the place. Some where caught by the attack and cut themselves. Cory wasn't much fazed by it though. His rot Kuret was very strong and could easily disintegrate the Kuret rope as it came in contact. With two attacks in a row, he had pinpointed the origin and was running at me shouting, Grover, what the hell. Stop this madness. Just on cue, M says, voice configuration completed boss. I shout out, Wyan, he is the traitor, get him. Cory's glimmer flicker in confusion. Because it wasn't my voice, it was Grover.

He shouts as he ran at me, what did you say. I stop Grovers Kuret useless attack on Cory. He will reach me too fast, I need a little more time for my next Kuret attack. I tell M, switch voice. A moment later I shout, I knew you were a scumbag. Never should have trusted someone who was once a lackey of Nathan. Cory abruptly halts his one man dash at some distance. He shouts, Quintin, what are you doing. I wasn't going to say anything more, let him sweat on that.

This was enough of a stall to prepare for an attack. I aim my Kuret storm at Cory and fire the yellow beam of Kuret at Cory. I had used his Kuret before, so it was much stronger. Hopefully it will fool him enough to think it was really from Quintin. Cory couldn't dodge a light speed attack. The Kuret hits him square in the chest and he was dragged away. He grunts while shouting Quintin to stop. He had enveloped his whole body with his Kuret to lessen the impact. If I had Kuret to spare, I would have continued. But I need to save 2 more attacks.

I drag the beam away from Cory and aim it towards the top steel stairs. I cut through one edge and then the next, the pieces break apart and fall on top of Cory. The steel makes loud noises as it crushes Cory in a rubble. However, this is no where near enough to stop him. His rot Kuret is highly effective on steel. All I wanted to stall him more. I halt Quintin's Kuret once I had added few more rubble on top of Cory. Then I kick the outer door open and walk outside.

I could see Polly's gimmer coming from the door. I ran towards the door with while preparing my next Kuret. There are people breaking the locked doors and trying to escape through other exit paths. Good work M. The bots were able to lock the steel doors and reinforce the windows. If people had worked together, they could have broken out, but these guys were organized only in crime. M says, boss, I have a ART bot carrying Ryan now. I will take him to the nearest patrol route. As I ran, I quickly turn my neck for a second. An ART bot had managed to sneak inside somehow. It was picking up Rory with its four arms. If it found a way to get in without being noticed, it will get Ryan out too.

I bring my attention back at the door where Polly emerged. She shouts, Wyan, what's going on. Someone tell me. I whisper to M, switch voice. A second later I yell at her, Wyan, I got her. She is also working with them. Polly had already prepared her Kuret around her, Cory is that you. Keeping them confused as much as possible, that’s the only way to completely trick them. I throw Cory's attack, the rotting Kuret was now coming at her confused face. But she wasn't about to take it head on. She sucks the moisture from the air around her.

The rotting effect of Cory's Kuret is a physical effect. Polly must have already prepared in advance in case Cory ever attacked her. The rot needed air gasses and particles to travel, and without it, its effect goes away. She was making good use of her dual Kuret. But I knew this already. I just wanted her to be distracted for a moment, I aimed the rot on the ground where was standing. This is the hanger area, but there is another level below, the basement. She must have realized my goal too when her glimmer became agitated.

I came running towards the door because I wanted to stop her and keep her in that exact position. A place above the basement floor, where there is a large water tank spinner below. The floor crumbles to rust and she falls through before she could jump off. She falls into the water, making a large splash as she and other blocks of concrete beings to get dragged away in the circular current. Like Cory, this was just temporary, she would soon vaporize or freeze the water. And then finally, my last target came into the room from the basement door on the left of the room, what was that just now. Who is attacking us.

I made sure I was farther away this time, because Quintin may clock a mans silhouette in the dark speaking a woman's voice. I scream at him, Wyan, Quintin is working with the traitors. We have to eliminate him too. Quintin looked around in the dark rushing toward Polly's voice. He asks, huh. What. Wyan, what's going on. Where is everyone. I had switched to Polly Kuret now. Hers was tricker, like Vanessa's, I have no control over what may come out. It didn't matter though, because Quintin would believe it's Polly.

The Kuret that came out was freezing out the moisture in the air. Quintin protects himself the cold using his Kuret light heat. He yells, what the freak Polly. You gone mad. He goes invisible in defense and starts to run at me from a different position. Him going invisible would be a problem, for others, but its wasted on me. His glimmer was clear as day for me. I aimed at the place he was running towards. He is shocked that his position was found so fast. He builds up enough Kuret around himself to fend off the freezing moisture around him.

This isn't enough to corner him though. With the last sparks of Kuret that was left in my storm, I threw all the remaining at him. This time, the Kuret turns the air to molting hot around him. A large amount of steam comes out from the collision with the icy moist around him. His Kuret can't protect from this. The scorching heat turns his skin to red. He shrieks in pain, what the hell are you doing. Get away you bitch. He ran off and plan to attack from a safe distance, but Polly Kuret has much more range.

His blisters on his body from the heat was still growing as he tried to dodge it. Quintin decided he needs to get away first. He crashed through a door into a room and ran farther away from the attacks range. That’s it, I used all the Kuret. A moment later the attack subsides. I break down my Kuret storm and kneel down for a moment. I didn't realize, but I was heaving. My sweat covered all around my face and body. I wasn't planning on such a close combat fight again so soon. M was right, my body is already so sore from just doing this much. M says, boss, your heart rate is spiking too hard. You should back away for a moment.

No. This isn't enough. Not even close. Cory is digging his way out of the steel rubbles. Pollys blazing heat could be felt all the way up here. And Quintin will heal soon from that heat wave. I stand up and dug my hands into my pant pocket to out the other thing I took earlier from my bag. An adrenaline syringe. M says, boss, I recommend to use only half. You will risk reopening your wounds if your body takes the full doze. I concurred with M on this. I rotate the dial and set it to inject only half the doze. I felt a sharp pain when I inject it on neck. Ideally, I should do it in my heart for maximum effect. But I am way too amped up right now and my heart will hurt.

I grunt a little from the prick as I pull it out. I could feel the effects slowly taking over. I focused on bringing my breathing down and analyze the room. I checked on Elina first. Her glimmer was still flickering, but wasn't weaker. So her healing is countering her condition. I wished I could get her out, but I am in a very precarious situation right now. Others will most definitely get in my way. If she was in a much more dire condition, I would definitely abandon my plan and get her out myself.

M says, boss, I am monitoring Elina's condition. Her bleeding has slowed and gradually healing. I have an ART bot standing by that will take her away to a hospital in case anything happens to her. I turn up and see a surveillance bot in the air with a small beam pointed at Elina. say, good. Actually, keep two more bots on her. I don't know if someone might get in your way, but do it anyways. M says, requesting backup bots for Elina. Now that I have confirmed Elina is not in danger, I focus on others. Apart from the ones I took down earlier, there are still 6 people standing.

Apparently, two have managed to break open the barricaded door and are somewhere inside the building. One has somehow even managed to break out of the building from the basement floor. And remaining three are still inside the hanger area. I need to finish mopping them up first. I bring out my Kuret and throw a line at the nearest person, who was hiding behind the pillar near the garage door. The guy was not a fighter, I could tell because he panicked and stumbles down as he heard me approaching him.

Now that I was close enough, M could use the facial recognition on him. His name was Wiz and he had a puppeteering Kuret. I didn't wait for him to use it. I kicked him in his face. His jaw and nose break as he yells in pain. I grab his leg and using my Kurets force, I threw him over the room into the air. His body hits one of the hanger pillar and he slumps down out cold from the impact. I threw my Kuret line at the next person who was running towards the broken exit Quintin left behind.

Her name was Jade. She can create a Kuret glitter, probably useful for distraction and, maybe entertainment. It wasn't going to help her out when she threw it at the dark figure looming at her. I don't know if her Kuret had any other effect, but my Kuret disintegrated hers on contact and I grab her neck in one arm. She yells writhing to get away, please I beg you. Let me go. She winces in pain under the pressure. Her legs dangle in the air. She even tried to kick me with it. I effortlessly grabbed that leg with my other arm.

She yells, I won't say a thing. I don't care if you are the one who stole from us. Just let me go and I will remove your name from the records. Please. My grip tighten. What does she mean by that. I didn't know what those records were. I will check her out later. I turn to the last person, hiding behind the crate. He is still curled up and frozen in fear. I can't let him remain like this. I need to get him moving for my plan to work. I need to nudge him. I throw a Kuret line and drag Jade along with me. She was now panicking seeing that she was being carried somewhere.

Once I reach closer to Peter, I drop Jade a little closer to him so he would be able see her. Jade thought I was letting her go, thank you. I don't care why you did this, I am not going to tell anyone. My plan was working, she really thought I was someone from her criminal group. I smile a little knowing my half baked plan was working. She turns her back to me and begins to run. Sorry, I wasn't going to let you get away. I just needed you to run towards Peter direction.

Once she was beside him, I sprinted and thrust my foot, sweeping her legs off. She halls hard on the ground face first and grunts in agony. Peter finally woke up from his fear when Jade falls beside him. Jades bruised face rises and looks up to him. She says angered and confused, help. Whoops, I wasn't planning on letting her see him. I crouch down and jab her neck with my palm. The Kuret assisted force was enough to slam her face to the floor. I saw her glimmer dwindle down as she looses consciousness.

I was being too hasteful here. I didn't want anyone to see each other. Otherwise they could clear them of suspicion later. I thought that seeing another person fall in front of him would jar him open. I don't know if he could see my face. Though he might be able to see hint of green light of my shades night vision. It doesn't matter though. He is so scared, I doubt he be able to differentiate between my shades light from a person's eyes glowing from Kuret. This got the job done, seeing her cut down in front of him, made him rattled enough that he crawls back and begins to run away.

Good, he is leaving now. I tell M, you know what to do. Make sure he gets out of here without him realizing it. M says, already deploying the countermeasures as per your last order. I sure hope it pans out the way I hoped. I hear a angry voice now, come out Quintin. I am going to make you regret this. He got out much faster than I thought. I still have 3 people to capture. I threw a Kuret line to the 1st floor railings and fly up.

Once I cross the railing on the floor, I ran towards the outer balcony space where Cory was patrolling earlier. I kicked the door open and face towards the lone escapee. There was a drone tracking him from up, he isn't getting away from me. I threw a line towards his direction and flew in the air after jumping off the ledge. I sour through the air, the wind against my face when I land on the ground. He was running towards the main road, maybe he thought he could find someone to help him. Otherwise he would try to escape in the grass land on the other side of the building.

It wasn't as dark as outside, so I need to finish him much cleanly. I tell M, distract him. Throw flood lights at him when I say. M brings the drone down towards him. The guy heard something coming from the air and looks up while running. I say, now. The drone throws a small, but blinding light right at his face. The guy closes looks away and brings his hands up in reflex. I had closed my eyes before since I was still having night vision mode on. I saw his glimmer becoming agitated.

He was off balance, I threw a single punch to his gut. He falls on his back, clutching his stomach in pain. He even threw up a bit of blood and spit out of his mouth. Did I punch him so hard. I must have used my Kuret to strengthen it unconsciously. He writhes in pain as he tries to crawl away. Suddenly, he digs his fingers into the road, leaving scratch marks trying to run away in all fours. M shows his identity, Puttan. He has Kuret to make his nails into claws. So maybe that’s how he was able to escape, cutting away the lock hinges or something like that.

I was in a hurry though, so I ran behind him, on two legs unlike him. I jump into the air with my Kuret and land a kick on the back of his head. He didn't even get a chance to defend and knocks down hard face first into the road. I turn back and throw a Kuret line into the air, extending it back to the edge where I jumped off. As I fly back to the balcony, I tell M, have a bot carry him and throw somewhere in the hanger area. M says, boss, I believed our objective was not to involve any bots in the fight. They might be recognized later and your involvement will be exposed.

I let out a small sigh from a exhaustion as I land on the 1st floor. I begin running towards the other side where the 2 remaining people hiding. I say, even if he could recall what happened to him, he will say a light attacked him. People will naturally assume Quintin attacked him. Its all good. I was imagining it, but my god, I swear I could hear M laughing. Maybe it was just the adrenaline. M says, ordered bot number 3 to carry him. Shall I dump him in

west side of the building.

I say, yeah. Now where are the other two exactly. I halt when I reach the end and gaze over the roof. I could tell from the glimmers their position, but I needed another pair of eyes to know their precise location and where to land safety. M displays the camera feed in my left eye shade. One guy was hiding in the basement, maybe some machine room. The other woman was moving slowly in another room that connects to a water pipe. I should have known I wasn't the only who would use the pipes to enter or exist.

The women, Kiera, with a exploding Kuret was a little farther. But if she used her Kuret to break into a pipe, it would be difficult to capture her without damaging the pipe. Her exploding Kuret might even collapse the pipe on top of us. I decided to grab her first. I threw the Kuret line in the air and swing down towards that section. With my glimmers and the position M told me, I was able to pin point her position accurately. I decided to rush in through the window. I threw a Kuret line from my back to angle my decent.

I bring my arms in front of my eyes as I crash through the control room's window. Kiera was on the left side of the room, and steps away when she hears me land inside. She yells with her arms raised, don't come any closer. Wyan isn't going to forgive you. Neither will I. I shouldn't have, but I chuckled knowing she too believed I was one of them. Her Kuret was aimed at me, I don't know what it was aimed at, but I got out of its path. Behind me, a broken window frame exploded.

I roll away safety and hid behind a small turbine machine. I wasn't so much scared by her Kuret, but the window I crashed through was seeping more light than I hoped. I positioned myself so she couldn't see me. She yells angrily, yeah, that’s right. Get away you freak. She mistook my demeanor as a precaution from her attack. I didn't know she could explode things away from her. I know of the other bloodline members, they need to touch things to explode stuff. She isn't an alpha, so I thought she couldn't do it.

Best guess is that she is directly related to their current alpha. But her range and the target size must not be at that level. There are some unexpectedly good people in this gang. She must have been in the tournament. I didn't bother to check her rank though. I had already formed a plan. I grab a fist will of the broken pieces from the frame she exploded. I whisper to M, bring a bot that has a retrofitted a fire gun to the room behind the wall she is standing in. Then on my mark, spray it on the wall.

M says, I got what your cooking boss. I am brining an ART bot in 30 seconds. There was a small chuckle again from M. Okay, I am not hallucinating. What's with this setting of hers. When did I upgrade her humor model. Ah, forget about it. I waited as the bot positions itself. Kiera, shouts, I am getting out of here. You hear me. If you don't want to get blown to pieces, leave the freak alone. She slowly moves towards the hatch on the water pipe. Hurry M, I will get only one chance.

I held my breath for while until M says, its positioned boss. I say, do it now. Kiera had her arms raised on my direction all the time. She might have an impressive Kuret strength and control. But she lacks any combat experience. She didn't hear the bot that wheeled inside the room behind her. The wall begins to get warm, then hot and then crazy hot. A few seconds later even a novice like Kiera realized what's happening. The wall begins to peel off, like the blaze was melting it.

She shrieks, what. Wait, is this, Polly. No, stay away from me. She turns her back to me and left it unguarded. I jump off behind and threw the broken frame pieces to her. Those pieces begin to explode when they come near her vicinity. I was right to be wary of her. I close my eyes to not get blinded by those mini exploding pieces. She was too late to know what hit her. I jump and thrust my knee into her mid back. She cries out and gets crushed between me and the melting wall.

Her skin burns a bit on contact while her screams fills the air. Before she could around, I take my left hand and thrust a jab at her throat. She jerks sideways to the walls clutching her hands on the burning skin on her neck. Then I finished her with a punch to her head. He eyes rolls up in pain before she could see me. She wriggles a little when she hits the floor and gets knocked out. I back away from the wall, since the heat was a little too much for me too. I clear out the debris I collected from my arms.

She most definitely is close relative of the alpha. She was clever enough to try and trick me into thinking she had to aim her Kuret to explode things. When it fact, it was an area attack around her, like a bubble in all directions. Anything around her can be exploded. But she has a limit, I threw those pieces knowing it will give me the cover to get in close.

After taking a moment to settle myself down I tell M, lets go. One more left. I sprinted off searching for the last one.

David (Chapter 74)

Thursday, January 15, 2026 18:19

This guy is probably even tricker than Kiera. M showed his identity as I navigate my way towards Max. His Kuret can create distorting vertigo on people around him. He could confuse my sense of direction from a pretty far range, even before I could throw my Kuret at him. He is decently skilled too. He chose to hide out in a section that has long hallways, numerous control rooms and corners. He is clever enough to take advantage of the confusing surrounding to infect others with his Kuret. This Wyan character is mildly impressive to recruit such people into his criminal gang.

I had to be careful here. He wasn't much of a threat, but I needed him to believe I could be anyone while I attack him. That’s why I have been beating down everyone physically. No one can read my Kuret signature as evidence later and no can see my Kuret in the dark. I halt when I reach about 50 meters from him. I don't know much about his bloodlines alpha's capability. But this distance is a safe bet. He is hiding in the closet room, fear coming from his glimmers. However, he was constantly using his Kuret around him. I could see his Kuret clustered around him.

I could throw my Kuret at him, but its too far. Its effect will lessen and I won't be able to eliminate all his Kuret. His physical effect on me would work even if a tiny bit of it hit me. That’s only one way though. Since he was doing me the favor of hiding in one place, I could just bury him in that closet. I tell M, get a bot in the basement and make it fire propulsion blasts at the ceiling. Make it look like its going to crumble away. M says, one bot on its way boss. You are on a roll boss with the attacks.

M's puns are too amusing for her core programming. I didn't expect her recent upgrade now had some personality. Regardless, it was reassuring that the ART bots are working synchronously with M. I didn't realize before, but this is the first time I am using them in the field. I should view their action post mission report. My thoughts are interrupted when M says, ART is in position boss. I ran to the basement and position myself to the place he will fall.

I see the ART bot M brought. It had four gas powered air propulsion cannons. Ordinarily, it would be used for flying only. I suppose if a bot focuses it on one point, it becomes lethal. I signal the ART bot and it fires the cannon at the ceiling. The compressed air dugs large creator in the wall. I couldn't tell from this distance, but it was definitely getting bigger with each blast. The impact vibrates the whole building. I look around for the 3 glimmers, that are still a little far away.

But that’s not going to stay the same for long. I have made many noises, with Kiera and now this. One of them is bound to reach here soon. I prepare a plan of attack for each of them. Meanwhile, the walls becomes thinner on another blast and derbies begins to falls down. I see Max's glimmer running around the closet. He was trying to reach for the door and leave. Unfortunately for him, I already instructed another bot to block the door. His Kuret doesn't effect inorganic beings.

I could even hear his faint shouts as he pounds the door, trying to break it open. Another blast did the job and broke the ceiling. Large debris fall down, and in middle of it was Max helplessly getting crushed in between. It wasn't going to kill him though, but he won't be able to move with broken bones now. I see his Kuret disappearing around the area, he was knocked out. Damn, I didn't even need to physically get my hands on him. I ordered the bots to leave this place, its going to get messier.

With this, all 9 people are taken care off. I quickly checked on the situation, give me the sitrep. M says, I have just dropped off Ryan to the nearest road. I have covered his head with a cloth, to hide who was carrying him. Ryan was out of it when the bot left him, but now is running off to the direction where a patrol will soon be there. Based on daily routine patrol logs, they will find him in approximately 8 to 11 minutes. That means I need to neutralize the 3 of them in that same time. Its a damn difficult task.

M continues, Peter has evacuated the premise as planned and I have kept a surveillance on him from the air. I sure hope he goes where I hope I want him to. M says, Elina's condition has improved gradually. The bleeding has stopped and her healing has kicked in time to fix her cut on the lower right liver. Her life isn't in any danger now. This is working as I planned. Now I just need to finish off 3 very strong people in about 10 minutes. I mockingly say to myself, easy right.

I had hoped to use more of the Kuret storm to trick them more. Maybe even get them attack each other without me directly. But the attacks I did earlier weren't alpha level ones. I had managed to caught each one of them by surprise. They are now wary each other. They have spend time beyond the tournament, so they have decent knowledge about each other too. They would figure out that their attacks are too weak to be an alphas. And besides, I don't have the time to create my Kuret storm anyways.

Its the hard way then. I look for a good spot around the rubbles for launching an attack. I found a room with some machines not running. Its about 10 meters away from Max's unconscious body and I could easily attack through the thinner walls here. I went through this rooms door and walk towards the opposite wall. I tell M, its now a danger close combat. I need you to intuitively organize the ART bots in case I need backup. M says, calibrating for auto mode.

When few deep breathes, I gather my Kuret around me. Recalling the memories and sensation from my fight with Charles, I begin to vibrate and rotate my Kuret on my body. My Kuret control was weakened, I can tell. I may not be able to get the last Kuret form I used later in the match. After a while I feel this is enough. Otherwise they will recognize me, even in the darkness. As I focus on downing that Kuret armor, M says, boss, I have lost visual on Quintin. He is somewhere in the basement, along the hot environment of the machines and heading to your direction. He will be reaching you first.

So he is my first target. He thinks Polly attacked him, I can't let him see me in the light. My Kuret begins to gradually soften and I cover my arms, torso and legs. I will my Kuret to became stable around my joints as well. This will have to do. It was a very shoddy work. Even when I had time to concentrate, I couldn't reach the same level as before. It really was the first time intuition thing that drove me to such high level. However, if its even half as powerful, its enough to taken them down.

Now I have to be very careful here, I have to taken them on one by one. Or somehow force them to fight each other. I am not confident I can take all of them down in my current condition. So I plan to whittle them down individually and then throw them to others to finish themselves. Once my Kuret form was done, I remained still and focus on seeing the glimmers. Quintin is invisible, and he is walking along a path that even I won't be able to detect his glimmer instantly.

There is debris outside, I just have to make sure he is facing opposite to me when I attack. As I listened silently, felt a long time by the way, a sound came of a very light footstep. I immediately turn to that direction and saw his glimmer. He is here. I position myself and brace myself for a surprise attack. His slow and cautious approach made him difficult to listen, but he was tense enough that his glimmer was just enough to sense him. Once he was in the defenseless position, I forced my Kuret to thrust me ahead.

I bring my arms in front of me and break through the wall behind Quintin. The force of the thrust was reminiscent. It was still powerful enough for me to break through the wall completely. He was also on his toes and had prepared a bunch of Kuret lights around instantly to attack. Before he understood what hit him, I grab him by his neck and slam him to the wall. The light Kuret he threw hits me from all direction. But it did nothing. These are light attacks, protons. Sure it was dense enough to physically cut though my Kuret, but its still lighter than others. My Kuret, which caused Charles body to falter, was cancelling out his attack and leaving me with minor pricks.

I raise my elbow and land a powerful blow to back of his head. He grunts out in pain and removes his invisibility. M was making decisions for me with the voices. I say, I know its you. I am taking you to Wyan. He grumbles, bitch. I didn't like the way he said that to me, or Polly. So I land a Kuret kick on his lower abdomen. Had tried to protect himself with his light Kuret, but it cracks under my Kuret and my knee lands on the target. The wind gets knocked out of him again.

I land another punch on his upper back, hopping to impact his lungs. He bursts coughing from the pain and closes his eyes. This is it, I grab his head from the back with both my hands. He has never fought me before, so no way he would feel my Kuret on him. But I need to get away before his pain subside and he thinks clearly. Good thing my whole plan was to keep him distracted. I drag him with his face across the wall all the way as I force the Kuret on my back to push me ahead.

Quintin was desperately trying to get away from my grip. He had been continuously attacking me with his light Kuret. His battle senses is impressive, even when his face is getting crushed against a wall, he is not stopping. And that’s exactly why I can't beat with in this situation. I made turn to the hall where the wall ends. His face finally open for a brief moment, Polly, you are dead. He shouldn't waste his energy cursing, because I just pushed him to the other wall and continue dragging him.

He was getting more desperate, blasting me with his light Kuret at point blank behind his head. I will my Kuret in the torse to cover my head. And just like how I remember, it breaks into tiny little threads of sparks, running around my neck and skin, to finally converge in my face. I was protected before he could fire his Kuret. I was right to cover my face, because he fired it at light speed. He could have fired it anywhere, but his intent gave away the attack.

I could feel the force of this one. It even brought me to a halt in the hall. It felt I hit my head on the ocean surface. This attack a lot of weight to it. If I didn't have my Kuret, he would have burned through my skins and bones. He went in for the kill. But I was resisting it. I still had my hands on his neck and smushed his head to the wall. While his attack kept happening, I saw at the corner a glimmer approaching. I was dragged Cory to her. She must have heard the commotion and got here first.

I can't let them meet yet. Quintin is primed now. He won't listen to any reason and attack her. But she isn't pushed far enough. I need to keep Quintin here for a moment. His light Kuret was not backing down. His determination to kill is quite strong and fueling him. Well, I just have to pour more gasoline on it. As I was stuck, under his Kuret light pressure, I raise my right foot and stomp his foot. With the added pressure from my Kuret, his foot got crushed under mine.

This created enough distraction to slow down his Kuret attack and he winces in agony. I used opportunity to pull him closer and grab his head with my elbows. With a swift sumo move using my Kuret to thrust him up, I slam his entire body on his back into the floor. His face was cut and bruised all over. His eyes were squinting and he most definitely couldn't see me. I land a another blow on his chest with my Kuret covered elbow. He chocks and spits out blood as I take a step back.

He was writhing on the floor and cursing something. Must be for Polly. I didn't waste time and thrust myself towards Polly. Quintin was tough, he kept me occupied far too long, because Polly was right at the corner. I used my Kuret on the back to kick into a higher gear. The force of my propulsion is something I am still not used to. I nearly hit the wall as I turned at the corner. Polly wasn't surprised, she was anticipating me. She was charging at me mad, Cory, I am going to melt your bones for that dirty trick earlier.

There was no light from the windows here, so its great she thinks I am Cory. But now the problem is I can't get near her. As she was approaching, she was leaving being a melted floor and wall surfaces. She had raised the temperature around her to blazing hot. Even with my Kuret protecting me, my skin will burn off. Plus I have exposed skin, physically attacking her is not a good idea. I wish I could throw my Kuret on her to stop her producing the heat.

But unfortunately I have to go to her. She knows Cory rotting doesn't work on her, so me staying at a distance will be suspicious to her. I can't let her think even for a second that I won't do what Cory could do. I grit my teeth knowing I heading to a furnace. As I fly in the air, I will my Kuret to spread out and cover as much of my body I could. I could feel the hair on my body burning from the heat. I just hope my Kuret vibrations are strong enough to cancel the heat.

Polly was going to attack with her fist. Her glimmer was coming off it more. I crouch down and land an uppercut aimed at her chin. She dodges it before it hits her and throws her other fist. I flick it away my arm, countering with a kick. She jumps avoiding it and brings her knee, which was burning the air around, in front of me. I forced my Kuret to pull me away back and narrowly escape my head from getting burned. I take some distance away from her and gather my footing.

She is good at close combat. With the type of Kuret she has, she had to be proficient enough in hand to hand close combat. She charges at me again with another punch. She is able to see in the dark quite well with her Kuret. I counter it with my elbow and throw a punch at her chest. She blocks it her other arm. The contact was brutal, she already had wrapped her arm with a heat wave that burnt me. I grunt and back away again. This is going nowhere. She has the upper hand, while I am handicapped.

She grins saying, come on. Bring it on you little freakier. If you think hiding in the dark will help you forget it. I can sense your body heat. No point in running. I knew that already. It would have been much simpler if could use my Kuret on her. She was trying to goad me to attack her. Cory is definitely the type to be rage baited. I decided to change my plan, I can't fight her like this for long. If can't make her mad enough to confuse her more about Quintin, I will have to redirect her to the person she will attack without hesitation.

I dashed in front of her. She laughs manically, yeah. That’s more like it. She was preparing to release huge amount of heat around her. My eyes widen at that, oh shit. I jump and let my Kuret thrust me with as much speed I can. This is going to hurt a lot. I clench my teeth as I slammed head on into a burning furnace. Polly brought her arms to catch me and keep me pinned down. I was momentarily stuck in a mini sun as I continue to push Polly backwards.

The arms she had grabbed me felt like it was burning my skin off me. I can't stay like this. I shouted, hoping M understood my reasoning of the voice, you are a slut. I always knew that. It came with Cory's voice. It worked, it was slightly distorted due to the heat, but that just gave more credibility to the voice. Polly got even mad and raised up the heat. It was a move to distract her footing as she grabbed me harder. I used that opportunity to push myself up in the air.

While Polly grabbed on me, I willed my Kuret to burst out. I envisioned the spikes on my arms. The same I had conjured when Charles kicked be before I was knocked out. I don't know how much was successful, but it was enough to hurt her. Her grip loosens and with a spike filled fist, I pushed ahead for a punch to her face. The force was enough to knock her vertically into the ceiling. I was on timer, so I bailed from there. With another boost of my Kuret, I was propelled into the air again.

I ran fast as I could without looking back. I hear Polly falling back flat on the ground and yelling in pain. I too was in pain. Few more seconds and she would have probably boiled my blood. Even my bones feel the pain as I rush head, creating more distance from her. Once I was out of her range, I could feel the cold air of the abandoned building air. That relieved some of the pain, but I am very sure I got burn marks all around me. I wasn't just running away, I was heading to a certain place.

I wanted to take a break, but its important to challenge him again. I spotted Cory's glimmer. He wasn't even trying to hide or be stealthy like the other two. Instead he was using his rot Kuret around like a wave and disintegrating floor. I guess when you have a strong metaphysical attack, its more beneficial to remain open. Once I reached the staircase where he was heading down from, I shouted call, hey. But then I immediately stopped. It was my own voice.

Dammit, the voice changer must have short-circuited earlier when I tussled with Polly. What do I do now. I need him rattled enough to believe that I was Quintin. It wasn't just the device on my neck, my shades, watch and transmitter were also burned and broken. I immediately stop in tracks, near the end of the staircase. This is bad. These people can't be tricked easily. I have been building up the illusion meticulously and precise actions. Take away the vision and Kuret, only voice is left that will overwhelm their senses.

I was running out of options, but then I saw a glimmer of something. My eyes widen at drone arriving beside me. I realized that M understood my predicament. The drone creates the voice, found you again freakier. You won't get away this time. It was Quintin voice. I smile and jump into the air with my Kuret pushed me straight up. Cory was using is rot all over the staircase. Maybe he has been thinking Quintin would be invisible and using his rot kuret around would prevent a surprise attack.

Cory shouts in response, bring it on you scumbag. I will turn you into dust. Just then I thrust my body through the stairs he was rotting and come out bursting through the concrete. He was already prepared for this though. He was ready to grab on to me, I pulled away before he came in contact. His fingers grab on to a rock which instantly turns to dust. His Kuret is dangerous, I am able to cancel his Kuret in the air with my own. But even I would get infected if he touched my body.

I jump backwards as he tries to grab me again. With the dust I just kicked up in the air, his vision is even more blocked with the dark. I prepare for a close encounter. I pour all the Kuret on my body on my arms, making it denser and stronger. Its a risky move, my entire body is exposed. But I have no choice now. Because at the corner I could both Polly and Quintin moving. I don't know if they encountered each other yet. But I am sure Polly will be here before Quintin.

With a burst of momentum from the Kuret on my arms, I lunged straight to Cory. He was prepared with a strong, dense Kuret on his arms to block me. But my Kuret was significantly stronger than his. I crashed straight into him and pushed him back where he came off. The acceleration I had on my arm felt like I was tugging on a jet ski. The I rushed ahead with Cory yelping in pain when I broke the door and came bursting out the room. I don't stop here. I continue to push him backward and force him backwards.

He yells, stop this you freak. What would, his voice cuts off when I rang his head like a bell on a steal door. He was already using a crazy amount of Kuret around him. The doors were almost like a sandpaper at the point of contact. I just hope my arms are still intact on his chest. We break through more doors and walls, pushing him as much as possible from others. The pain is hitting me hard now. I am very sure its from the burns I got earlier and now from my skin peeling off.

I need to fish this quickly. My plan is simple, to get two people isolated first. Initially I wanted Polly and Quintin to fight, but these guys are way too tough. So now its Polly and Cory first. I was never going to beat them handicapped this much. Case in point, even as Cory was being dragged across by me around the rooms, he grabbed my arms and poured his Kuret on me. I couldn't focus on whether it was effective or not. I just had to get him away. I finally reached an open room. It was another water control station.

I concentrated to make another spike. But I couldn't do it. I am at my limit right now. So instead I just went with a brute force Kuret blow. With such a dense Kuret on my arms, it almost exploded likely a bomb and physically hits Cory in the upper body. He yells out in pain with this close proximity attack. His grip leaves me and I waste no time to fly into the air. I purposely went to this spot, closer to the Hanger area so I can jump to the nearest point in the first floor. I grab on to the railing and crossed over it. I slump down and hid behind the railing wall.

The adrenaline I took earlier was wearing off. I felt it for a few seconds ago. My sore body was paining all over. The control over my Kuret wavers and the armor cracks out. My Kuret goes back inside me leaving me all vulnerable again. But its not a mental block anymore. Its just pure exhaustion. I saw myself bleeding on my arms and chest. Then I felt it trickle on side of my jaws. I couldn't tell if it was because of Quintin's relentless barrage, Polly's nightmare furnace or Cory's zombie grip.

I was wincing in pain. A second later I realize it’s a good thing. That means everything is still intact. I crawl a little away from the railing and sat at the corner. Below me, Cory yells, where the freak did you run off too now. He chuckles a little, that was impressive. You dragged me all the way here. He was walking around the place trying to find me. And he would have eventually noticed the staircase that leads up here from below. But I had stalled him long enough that Polly came rushing into the room from the broken door.

I saw glimmers of red on her neck. She was bleeding a little there. Though I doubt it will for much longer. She took her fist and slammed it into the wall. Apparently, she had changed her Kuret to her other one. A layer of thin ice spreads across the wall and it cracks near the impact. She shouts at him, finally. Let me get a good at you before I turn you into an icicle. This is it. All the planning I did was for this. Will Cory take the bait. They both should be way too angry and frustrated to be thinking clearly.

Cory was mad, and now visibly puzzled. He says, Polly. What the hell happened to you. Wait, no. buzz off. I need to finish off that bloody Quintin first. He tried to leave her side and exit this place, but Polly wasn't going to let him. She threw a kick at him that was so cold, I could see ice in the air. Cory blocked it with his hands and pushed her away. The both back away and keep a distance, freak this. She scoffs, you think you can just ignore me. For him. Not a chance. I am putting you down.

Cory didn't had a clue what just happened. He glares at her. Then something makes him to cover his arms with his Kuret again, do that again and I will crush you. He spats off a bloody spit and says, where is Wyan. What did you do to him. She says, now you care about him. She takes a step closer, the air chilling around her. She yells, after I popsicle you, I will bring you to him. Cory was so confused, he probably knew something was off. But with all commotion and the hints of traitor I laid out. He must have pieced it together.

He glares at her, you think Wyan will take your side. Hell no. Not after what you have done. I am bring you to him. Polly brings her fist in front of him, shut it. I am going to kill you. Cory charges in, bring it on bitch. They both clash with their Kuret. This is so much better than I predicted. I thought they would accuse each other of traitor out in the open. I wasn't sure what would have happened then, would cooler heads prevail or become hot headed.

I planned it very carefully to not give them enough time to think about what's going on. The first step was the surprise ambush, keep them separated and off balance. Then there were frantically searching for me, or rather each other. And I further pushed them over, by baiting them and beating each of them. The conclusion was this. They will not listen to each other no matter what. They are a bunch of hot headed pissed off people. If Wyan was here, I bet he would have been level headed enough to stop them. But his was already knocked out.

I was grinner like a madmen when I saw them duking themselves in the most severe case of confusion and manipulation.

David (Chapter 75)

Thursday, January 15, 2026 22:38

If I wasn't in pain, I would have laughed much harder than I am. But even this simple movement was now aching my neck. Cory's attack didn't hurt me badly, but it was quite a strong blow. I am sure he broke one or two ribs. My hands were trembling a little. The heat and rotting Kuret was stilling reeling on it, even when I had protected myself with my Kuret. But I am not injured too severely. Just have a sore body aching everywhere. I think I have overworked my body and I am certain I can't use either my new Kuret or the Kuret storm.

I peek down to the two people still locked in battle. They had been going at each other for quite some time now. Cory had to be way more confused than Polly. But he was not backing down. He kept trying to grab Polly and infect his Kuret on her. She deftly moves around to dodge it and counter with her punches. Its impressive Cory was able to sustain himself in Polly's vicinity. A while ago, she had switched to her heat Kuret again and blazing up the place.

Cory was apparently, rotting away the heat. I didn't knew he could do that. How does that make sense scientifically. It's quite a spectacle, so I have to believe he is targeting the Kuret around her that lets her control the adjust the temperature. When I mimicked and threw Cory's Kuret at her back in the hanger, I couldn't control the rot like Cory can do. He is proficient enough to selectively rust off the Kuret before it generates heat around him.

Polly was also cancelling his Kurets. Just like how she did it with me, she is removing the moisture. So basically, they are engaged in a fist fight. Whoever lower their guards first, will get hit. They both were jumping around the place, locked in deadly combat. Polly charges with her whole body burning now. In response, Cory enveloped in a Kuret so dense, I could see the air particles turning to dust. He charges in straight too. I tighten my grip in anticipation, who will prevail in such a compatibility.

Turns out, no one. Their Kuret clashed, hurting each other. Some of the rot managed to hit Polly in the face and abdomen. Corry was punched in the inner thigh with Pollys fist. They both stumble away in pain. So it’s a draw then? Polly yells, you freakier. She had part of her face peeled off from the rot. However, that didn't stop her from rushing in with a new kick. Cory couldn't dodge it because his leg was immobilized, so instead he poured his Kuret on the floor where Polly was running on.

Polly jumps out of way seeing the floor crumble and goes for a high kick. Cory yells, take this bitch. He showers her with another blast of his Kuret at her mid air. They both clashed again for the 9th time. Surely, there will be only one left now. The clash resulted in debris and walls around them disintegrating and bursting to flames. The heat flames even reach high up that I had to slouch my head down to avoid my hair catching on fire. Once the dust settles, I raise my head.

Both of them were down. I don't believe it. Did they really go for a mutual knockout. I can't be this lucky. Turns out, I actually wasn't. The debris clear out and Polly picks herself up. Cory was lying on his back, writhing with the pain of huge blisters on his body. Even if he could heal himself, he won't be able to move for some time. Polly wasn't fearing any better. She was bleeding all over her body with cuts and disfigured skin patches. I think Cory's rot Kuret couldn't protect himself from the Polly's heat entirely. While Polly was able to shrug off a lot more of Cory's Rot.

So I guess the winner of this round is clear. She was in the top 100 not for nothing. She limps and drags herself to a bleeding Cory. She picks grabs his collar with her one arm and pulls him up a little bit. She spits on his face. Oh, damn. That’s got to hurt his pride. Cory's boiled face somehow became even redder, as did his glimmer. She grabs him by his hair, I told you I am going to kill you. Cory tried to move away, but his body was too broken down.

She slams his down on the floor. He couldn't defend much with his own Kuret now. She still had some left in her tank though. I see ice forming in her fist, ready to smash a punch in his face to end him. Just then, the final contender comes rushing in. Quintin face was still bruised, but he was healed enough to come back up. He saw one look at Polly hovering over a beaten Cory and longes at her, you bitch. Get away from him. I couldn't have manipulated the situation better than how it happened right now.

Polly won against Cory, but she wasn't exactly in the best condition for another right. It was now Polly's turn to be confused and yells, what the hell Quintin. He ignored her. He was already mad from his face getting plastered along the walls earlier. He lets out a barrage of Kuret light on her. Polly couldn't muster enough Kuret and strength to dodge it. She slides away on the ground and hides behind a pillar. Corys head falls down and I see his slimmer flickering away.

Marvelous, one down. But that means I need to enter the fray soon. I gather myself slowly and prepare to enter this three way battle. Quintin continues to hurl his light Kuret at Polly. He was so angry, that his Kuret was lasering through the rooms everywhere. Even where I was. Thankfully, it didn't hit me. Polly wasn't so lucky. Most of the directed attacks drilled inside the pillar and hit Polly. She winced in pain trying to find more cover. But she was way too battered to fight back. Quintin threw another round of Kuret and one pierced through her shoulders.

That was the critical blow. Quintin goes invisible and circles around the pillar to catch Polly. She is on her last breath. Her glimmers is filled with pain and anger. She will be knocked out cold any second, even before Quintin reaches her. In one last desperation she lets out a scream and blasts a wave of icy wind around her. The wave covers everything in thin layer of ice. The floor, the walls and the debris from the destruction. She must have done this to catch Quintin, wherever he was.

Quintin wasn't expecting this sudden attack. He was caught in it. A side of his body was covered with freezing cold wave. That last attack finally did in for Polly. Her head rolls away in exhaustion and pain. Two down, one to go. Quintin becomes visible again. He grunts as he picks one of his arm with his other. When Polly blasted her Kuret, Quintin uses his Kuret to protect himself. But unlike his Kuret, he doesn't react in light speed. He couldn't fully save his left arm and part of it was covered frozen. I couldn't help but giggle realizing that he has frost bites on his arm.

He yells, bitch. This hurts dammit. I am sure it does. He will probably recover soon anyways. I wasn't going to let him though. I don't know how much I can when I am still in pain. But Polly gave me a gift I wasn't expecting. I need to use it now. While he was distracted by the mess I created for them, I took the long way around down. I crawl away slowly and slither inside the room. As luck would have it, M had prepared an ART bot for me.

The bot wheels at with one its arm extended at me. I was in pain, but still laughed as I grab that metal arm and it helps me stand up. The bot helps me from stumbling down. My right foot gave me a sharp pain. I think I must have twisted it. The bot throws a light at me and scans from head to toe. M's voice comes, boss. You need to be bandaged. You have few broken ribs, burned skin and sprained ankle. I nod, I know. I can't ignore it anymore. But Quintin is the only one left, and mildly hurt. Before he heals, I need to finish him off.

Using the bot as help, I dash to the other door and head the nearest stairs. I ask, what is he doing. M says, he is checking their pulses. I have detected their vitals. They are only unconscious for now. I was a little worried about Cory, but I guess he is a tough bustard too. If Quintin hadn't shown up then, he might have been killed. With every step hurting my leg, we somehow climb down the stairs. This made me realize that I was in no condition to dodge or rush at Quintin.

Maybe if he is immobilized, I could attack him. I need to rely on the bots now. As we come closer to the room from behind, I try to figure out a way to retrain him. I thought of one. Its quite a strange one. I ask, do we have any bots that can throw a rope or net laced with poison. M says, we don't it boss. Figures, this was a very out of the box idea and I would never configure such a weapon in any situation. M says, however, we got carbon wires that we run electric current through.

I remember that weapon, I designed it for capturing Kuret animals. It could work. Its dark there, his arm is frozen and he is in pain. It wouldn't make it difficult to him believe a certain someone his attacking him. I say, prepare that. Grab all the bots you have that can do that. Surround the room and then blast through the walls, we will go all in one attack. Restrain him to the pillar while electrifying his ass. He would most definitely be using his Kuret to cut through the rope. So keep adding it on top of him, empty everything you got.

M says, understood boss. Deploying the ART bots. Ready in one minute. That was probably how long it would take for me reach the room. Once we arrive, so did the bots. I can see 5 glimmers around the room. Quintin couldn't sense the light from them because of the walls and machines that had caught fire earlier from Cory and Pollys battle. Once everyone were in position, I signal them to attack. All 5 bots break through the 3 walls surrounding Quintin.

He was probably less alert since both warriors were down. He didn't react enough in time. He did threw his Kuret around, but the bots had prepared in consideration and had some sacrificial bots guarding them. The dust thrown in the air hindered what little vision Quintin had from the fire. The bots throw the electrified carbon net around him. He shrieks in pain as get hit with massive amount of current on the ropes. The bots aimed at him in angle that made him push towards the pillar.

He threw his Kuret out in defense, but more bots rushed in to defend the 5 bots. I raised my over my eyes, covering the glare from the light. More and more carbon nets entangle on him. Soon, he was stuck to the pillar. His screams fill the empty air. His left arm was no longer in frost bite, but it had to hurt even more now. Still this wasn't enough to take him down. His barrage of Kuret attack didn't stop as he yells out angrily, face me Grover. You coward.

It worked, it actually worked. I was sure it wasn't going to work this good. However, he was too furious and irrational to actually believe the ropes with the electric cuts he is feeling is from Grovers rope Kuret. I have primed his mind to perfection. Its not over though. The ropes were piling up on him, but he wasn't slowing down his attacks. If anything, it was growing in number. At this rate, we won't have enough bots to protect the 5 bots keeping him restrained.

I tell M, stop the current. Just keep him restrained and throw me at him. M says, that’s too reckless boss. I yell, just do it. I gather all the Kuret I could pull out and prepare for a final knockout. The bot carried me to the entrance. Oh boy, this is going to be crazy. The bot rushed inside while carrying me by the torso. Like a baseball, it hurls me straight towards him. I gathered all the Kuret on my arms and throw my Kuret on his face. He yells, what the hell.

He probably didn't understand why he went blind. He throws his Kuret at me. Just like earlier, even without looking, he had got blinding accuracy. Thankfully, as I was thrown up in the air, he missed most of it. But one was heading straight at my face. I can't change my direction, so I blasted a wave of Kuret from my body to cancel it out. The Kuret light disperses before it could hit me, but the force was enough to hit he on my neck. I grunted in pain, yet continued on my pull.

I sped up the pull on my Kuret line and clashed straight into his abdomen with both my fists. The impact was devastating for him at this point blank range. My hands tremble at the pressure, but I didn't stop yet. His Kuret looses its strength, pinning him to the pillar even more tighter. Blood trickles down from his mouth. His Kuret attack was still up, but it had lost its power. I was able to cancel it out with just this much minimal Kuret. With one last pull I crush him further back.

That's when the pillar couldn't hold it together anymore and broke. I lost my balance as I stumble down on my side covering my face for the impact. After I roll away, I look at Quintin. He was still tied to the fallen pillar. And yet the guy wasn't completely down yet. Jeez, just how much longer can he go. I yell out, Grover get him. M understand my intention and ran the current on the wire again. With a much weaker Quintin, it worked even more

effectively. He was able to cut through some of the ropes with his Kuret. But the damage was done.

He had scars from the cuts all over his body. He slides down from the pillar into a motionless body. Holy shit. My body that was tensed up till now, finally relaxes. I yell out with a bit of pain, bloody hell. I did it. I took down two alphas and a dual Kuret user under 10 minutes. A bot comes closer to me. M makes a sound like she was clearing her throat. I laughed, really. The bot helps to stand up, fine. Yeah, we did it. But I am taking the credit for everything.

M says, of course boss. I did all the work, and you take the credit. She was being purposefully being facetious with me. I can't deny it though. I couldn't have pulled all this alone. I ask, how much time do we have. Did Ryan find the patrols. M says, they are on the way boss. I estimate we have around 3 more minutes. I grit my teeth. I made it just in time. But there are way too many evidence here. I ask M, please tell me you have some bots cleaning my DNA evidence. I have been bleeding and sweating all over the place.

I waited for M to respond, keeping me in suspense for a while, already working the scene. Your extreme stealth activity was evident enough for me to initiate the cleanup protocol. I sigh in relief. Earlier I asked M to made intuitive decisions. Glade it worked out. I see the bots picking up the broken pieces of the ART bots wheeling away. Behind them, a different sphere drones hovering in air that were spraying acetone liquid and blowing off tire marks. The protocol is in full effect.

I tell M, take these 3 to the hanger area. With the bots help, I rush towards the hanger area with 3 unconscious, beaten down, warriors. Each of believing that they were fighting each other, from start to finish. Two minutes left. The hanger was now filled with unconscious bodies. Even Patton, Kiera and Max were brought here. All in one place, with a smuggled goods with their Kuret prints all over them. No matter who they blame, who they point, no one is going to get away from this.

M says, boss while scanning the everyone earlier, I found they don't have any phones on them. I turn towards Wyan. He seems like a cautious guy. It wouldn't be a surprise if he ordered no one to bring anything here that could have a GPS or bugged. Then I remembered something from earlier. I look around the briefcase I blasted at the beginning. I remember seeing something else as well. I saw a glimmer coming off the broken wall lying on ground. I say, pick that up and check. The bot uses his 3 free arms and pushes it away. The bottom revealed a small iron box. Its quite thick, so I don't know what's inside. But it has to be their phones inside. This is a good, now I can figure out who hired them to smuggle in those drugs.

The bot picks up the box and carries it. M says, boss, sanitizing is at 95 percent completion for the building. Unfortunately, we have run out of time. The patrol officers arrived much earlier than anticipated. Luck runs out eventually. I answer, lets leave. Keep one cleaner bot and one surveillance bot behind. I doubt the whole cavalry is coming here immediately. Let it finish its work, even its slow. M says, assigning the stealth task. My leg hurts as I run towards the front exit. Its too late to go though the pipe now always.

I was too tried to keep track of the path. This basement and ground level has too many rooms and machines. Many of them were kept as redundant for emergencies, so the paths looks the same. Finally we cross the stairs and exit from the front. At this point I was too exhausted to even use Kuret in my eyes and saw no glimmers. M had called in the car beforehand and was waiting. Before I got in, wait, you swept the whole building clean, but did you pick my specs from Peter's jeep. M says, good catch boss. We almost blew it, leaving behind a big evidence.

Speak for yourself, you, strange AI. The bot helps me get inside the car and then sped off towards the jeep hidden in the trees. I thought Peter would take the car when he escaped, but just he ran on foot, scared out of his mind. He didn't even realize he could get away much faster on his jeep. Well. Doesn't matter now. The bot comes back with the specs and puts it on passenger seat with the iron box. ART opens the back trunk and the bot slithers inside.

Just then I hear the sound a car coming from the road. I say, M, take us through the grass and hide us until they go inside. M responds, hold on boss. ART takes us off road and accelerates into the uneven terrain. The car jerks up and down as it travels inside the land. After gaining some distance, it stops to hide. I could feel ART was shifting the outer color to darker green to match this region. I wait here in silence as two officers step out of the vehicle with Ryan and run inside.

We barely made it. I take big sigh. M, take us out of here. We couldn't drive on the road, not if we want to be caught on cameras. So M plotted a course for ART to the neatest safe point that we can use to entire into the city. I wasn't too thrilled, because it meant more turbulent journey. I took for the bag that M had collected from the room I was hiding in the hanger room. It was siting on the leg area. I pulled it out and opened up a small box from it. It had a spray made of antibiotic cocktail so that my wounds don’t get infected.

I took my time applying it on my entire body. Meanwhile I watched through the surveillance drone hidden in the hanger room. The officers were shining lights around the place. Ryan head straight to the Elina lying on the floor. I was even more relieved when they also confirmed she is fine. Not that I didn't trust M, but it just bolstered the fact that she will be fine. Soon they started inspecting my handiwork. All gathered in a place, at the scene of a crime. Their and mine.

Won't be long until they call the IDF. Vanessa might be called here soon. Or maybe it would be Somers. Either way, I ended up making a lot of mess for them in a short time. I wish I could have stayed and explained. But I had a plan. I can't go change it now. I ask M, where is Peter. M opens up a different camera that showed him hiding in some construction site a mile from here. My eyes twitch in disbelieve, what is he doing there. Is he for real. Is there anyway that he is contacting someone from there.

M says, unlikely boss. I don't see detect device on his person. I slam my fist on the dashboard. He is just hiding in fear. Dammit. I was really hoping he would lead me to other members or to the person he stole the drugs for. I am almost very certain that he stole the drugs and brought Elina and Ryan as a cover. By using his family, he would gain whatever little sympathy from others and be free from blame. That’s my theory and that’s why I let him escape. The plan wasn't perfect, but I had hoped to get something out of him.

I guess I have to go pick him up and interrogate myself. Though, I decided to wait for some more time. Let him feel the guilt and maybe he would run off somewhere more useful. ART got us on the road after a while. I ordered to head straight to the house. I haven't forgotten about the tonight's deadline, but I need some first aid pronto. Its around 8 right now, so I have enough time treat my wounds before I go to Drew's place. I tell M to send a message to Drew saying I will meet at her in her field around midnight.

Soon I arrive at the cliff on the outer edge of sector 5. I say, M, keep monitoring the IDF and the network. We need to be sure, our hands are clean from this. Even if things doesn't work out with Peter, we want don't want to be involved in this. M says, I am monitoring the feeds, boss. Sommers and Tessa are on the way to the water treatment plant. So its them first. I assume Vaness and Blake were held up in the officer building due to work. But soon they will move out too.

ART was already ready to dive into the ocean when the car drives inside the garage. I waited inside the car until we were underwater. With the more dexterous house bots, I limp my way to the infirmary room to treat my wounds. M had already calibrated for the medicines and bandages based on the scans earlier. M says, shall I prepare the nano bot chamber. I raise my hands, not yet. The nano chamber is not effective for a short time. I will use it later. For now just do the disinfection and wound dressing.

I ordered the bots to leave for a while to clean myself up. The hot water helped me clean off all the dirt and blood on my head and body. Now that things have calmed down completely, I felt my chest and leg ache. After a checkup from the x ray and body inspection, I was bandaged up with a cast around my chest and leg. My foot burned in agony when the bot moved it and locked in the correct position before applying the cast. I had multiple burn marks too, curtesy of Polly.

I ask M to adjust the composition of the burn paste to be applied for my neck and face without the bandage. I can't be looking hurt, again so soon. The bandage dressing on the other burnt skins is good enough for now. The nano bot chamber was slower, but it was less painful. This manual process was faster, however, painful. I forget the times I jerked in pain when the gel was applied or a cut was stitched. I wished I was unconscious for this, but I need to be wide awake for this manual processes. M herself is not confident on the bots following careful instructions and not mess it up.

The entire process took several hours. It was grueling time, but this was on me. I knew I shouldn't have tried to fight all of them when I wasn't fully recovered. Both physically and mentally. Speaking of which, I could feel my panic attacks are not an issue now. I tested it few more times now by bringing out my Kuret. I felt the exhaustion, but not the gut retching full blown nervous breakdown I had been struggling all day. This is not I how imagined I would overcome it. I don't know if this helped my PTSD or other symptoms.

I do feel a lot lighter, like a burden I had been carrying for years has been lifted. I might have internally rationalized saving Elina as saving Zakerine. Not sure how I feel about this. But at least I got past through the trauma. I sigh recalling that moment. I heard that guys voice back then. Obviously that was my own subconscious talking to me. But even when I know I he was an imagination, it made me feel so mad at him. What kind of hang up do I have with him, even after all these years.

M says, boss. I found a message from the IDF that Elina has woken up. That pulled me out of my own thoughts. I was siting in the bed room sofa chair and eating my dinner. I put down my fork and ask, that’s great news. How is Ryan. I regret a lot of things I could have done better tonight. One of it was him. I basically pulled him away from her dying sister and left him helpless on the side of the road. That was at least from his perspective. I don't know what I could have done differently, but I wouldn't have make the kid more miserable than he is right now.

M says, unknown. I only intercepted a message from the doctor about Elinas condition. I can confirm all the people involved are in custody in IDF. I nod as I continue eating. I am sure that they all are being treated as person of interest right now. Then I asked the important question, please tell me Peter has finally got out of hiding and is somewhere in the city. M opens a camera view from a drone of Peter in the wall display. He was walking down the road now. I was relieved he finally snapped out of it and moving.

I couldn't see his face from this high angle, but his posture is raggedy and slouching. But something else is weird, where is he going. The road feels familiar to the one we just came from. I ask, what place is this. M says, boss, he is 0.3 miles away from the water treatment plant and walking back in that direction. I freeze up for a second. I take a sip of water from the glass before putting my hand on my forehead. This behavior from him was not what I expected.

I close my eyes trying to sort this out. Does he have an ulterior motive. Could he going back to retrieve something. That can't be true, he is not panicking or running. It doesn't look like someone wanting to evade capture walking so openly in the road. I waited for him to do something unexpected at the last moment. But it never happened. There was a crowd near the plant, people and reporters hovering around the barricade officers put up. He simply walks into the crowd and gives himself up to the officers.

After interacting with them for a while, Tessa comes out and grabs him away by the arm into an officers car. He actually turned himself in. So I was wrong. He wasn't the thief. He is not bold or daring enough person to surrender himself and make his innocence with such a tactic. More like a guilty person who got his siblings involved in something he shouldn't have and guilt had eaten away at him. I tighten my fist, I made a wrong assumption back then. Oh if I had known back then, I would have pounded him too like others.

M says, shall I continue to have surveillance on him. I wave my hand, no. Leave it alone. He isn't going to escape from IDF when he just walked in himself. Pull the drone back. Pull of them back. I take another sip of water to

calm my nerves a little. I was so close to figuring out who was sabotaging us in the tournament. Or I thought I was. I ask M, you have saved the recording of their conversation from earlier, right? M says, yes. Before the watch was destroyed from the battle, I was able to upload a backup to ART. Shall I play it for you.

I say, not right now. Just analyze the discussion and isolate any indication of deception or lies from the others. I don't know how effective it will be with partial videos and reconstructed voices. But do whatever you can. Its still possible the culprit was someone else in the group. M says, creating an objective of analyzing the recording. Wyan was very eclectic group of people involved in this. I admit I don't the guy well. But the operation he was going on was very impressive. If he wasn't doing it in this island, I would have recruited him for my human operations.

Would he make a mistake of not exploring the option that it was really an outsider. He said he handpicked everyone and he was very sure none of them did it. Setting aside personal bias he might have towards his people, he was oddly focused on Elina and Ryan. But that can't be. He was very sure of himself. Going by your intuition is a very risky gamble. I would very much like to hear his statement when he wakes up. But I could be making the same mistake by personal intuition. I want Elina to be not guilty because I know her. But its not impossible she or Ryan found about Peters little scheme and got greedy for some reason.

Ah, I wanted to talk to them. But its way to risky. If by a terrible chance they did stole it for the person, they would know I am on to them and cover their tracks. I made the painstaking decision to hide my involvement so that the person behind this would think the group imploded on its own, unaware that I did it and on their trail. M cuts in my thinking, boss. I have two different reports for you. For the time being I pushed aside Elina or Ryan's possible involvement.

M says, I intercepted a message that mentions Cory tried to escape IDF about 2 hours ago. He almost did, but Vanessa stopped him. I scoff hearing that ridiculous escape attempt, why are you getting this report now. M says, it seems Vanessa has put a lid on the entire IDF communications. I assume it’s a preventive measure to avoid anyone knowing that they have detained so many people at the IDF. That does sound plausible. I ask, anyone hurt. Cory was soundly beaten up by Polly. Well, little by me too. But I had to learn the hard way that there are still alphas that I didn't get to fight in the tournament who are very resilient.

M responds, unknown. If Vanessa was there, then I don't doubt she would have stopped him without letting him hurt others. That was pretty reckless move from Cory. I get he didn't want to get entangled again with us, given his history of the Valley. Still, breaking out of IDF? Where does he think he will escape. Even Peter knew there is no place to run and accepted his fate. For a brief moment I entertained the thought if he was the culprit and was running to guy he stole it for.

No, it doesn't make sense. He was way more concerned about Polly being the traitor and fought her till the end. In that sense I can rule out the other two as well. They were the muscles of the operation, not the brains. I ask, what's the other thing. When M told me about it, I cock my head gazing into the ocean in the window. This is bad, very bad. My assumption what who was behind the sabotage was wrong. Its good that the suspect pool has dropped to fewer people, but it leaned to a different group entirely.

I couldn't dwell on it too long because it was time to visit Drew. I changed into a casual dress to hid the bandaged underneath it. Hopefully, she won't suspect my involvement. Around 11:30 ART brought us back up in section 3 and I took the car to her place. On the way M says, boss, Peter is being interrogated questioned by Vanessa and Blake. This could be interesting, let me hear it. M activates the bug in that room and I listen in to the conversation. Peter actually felt guilty and wanted to see Elina and Ryan. I don't think he was lying, so its almost certain he doesn't have anything to do with the actual culprit.

As Peter recounted his perspective of what happened, I was smiling. He was there in the hanger the longest, so if really believed people were fighting each other, it’s a good bet everyone thought the same. Then I realize he missed out or told some events out of order. Well, he was scared out of his mind. He being able to tell this much is good enough. They both were able to pry out information from him. Enough details to correctly guess that someone else was definitely involved.

For the time being their prevailing theory was that it was some hidden bodyguard of Wyan. Not a bad guess. Honestly, I have outdone myself. I manipulated the whole flag capture game, but actually, doing it on few people is much harder. They still don't know that it was me. I know that I have to reveal it to at least Blake later. I can't let him waste manpower on a hunt for me. Best to focus on getting them convicted in the tribunal. When Blake allowed Peter to meet with Elina, I became little concerned. Not for Peter, but his siblings appear to be completely rattled. What does this mean for the Elina. Too early to say.

Then Peter revealed the information about the drugs. I didn't expect Blake to go full ballistic on him. But he wasn't alone. I felt the same when I heard it few minutes ago. I was so mad, but I had other things to worry about. I don't even want to know what Marina would do when she hears about it. Fortunately, Tessa intervened and stops Blake from making a punching bag out of Peter. I guess that would be it, but I was able to hear the next conversation even after Peter left the room.

I ask, what is this. M replies, I suspect the bug was dislodged in that short altercation. To think Blake used so much force. I hear Nathans voice now. What the hell is he doing there. How did Vanessa allow him inside. Before I could figure that out, he was already on to me. Of course the guy who was obsessed for a time with me last year would figure out first. As he laid out the breadcrumbs to others, they all realize my involvement. I was hoping to tell only Blake first.

Oh well. Its not a very big issue. I am hundred percent sure, the four them are not suspects. But I can't let Nathan have so much fun, not after he ruined the epic reveal I was thinking of doing. Wait, I can still mess with him. I say, M, send this message to their phones and delete it after 30 seconds.

Blake (Chapter 76)

Friday, January 16, 2026 19:59

There is only one thing I want to do. Find David, and then kick the shit out of him. What kind of a shadow strategist is he, not telling me about any of the stuff he was up to. As I fly in the cold sky towards Dr. Drews house, I began thinking of slurs I was sure to say to him. Once we got the message I told others to put a lid on it before I get confirmation. Nathan was the only who seem to enjoy the situation. I had to make sure he wouldn't tell anyone. He just laughed and said there is no point. There is no evidence and besides that, there no reason to betray David. He was right about that. He was allowed on the island based on various conditions.

Tessa remained neutral, saying even if David was the behind this incident, its not a problem. Though she wants to know why David remained anonymous. On the other hand, Vanessa didn't agree with anything. She was already mad at David and didn't promise that she would be quiet about him. I was concerned about her the most. Even if its not personal, which she claims its not, I know she can't hide this from her crew without good reason. And I did agree with her.

And that’s why I am approaching to Dr. Drews place. I assumed he would meet her there since its easier to go to her rather than bringing her to him. I spot her house and descend down to the field. I caught some aura's nearby and land there. As I came closer I realized Drew and two another person were already outside, standing at a corner in field. She was with Marina and Catherine. Damn, Catherine also figured it out then. I scoff thinking they also couldn't stay away from this huh. They saw me coming down and pause their discussion.

As my feet land on the field, Marina asks, you came. I thought things were very crazy at work. I shook my head, you have no idea. All of them had changed to their casual dress, save me. I was so busy after the meetings, I didn't get time to go change into the spare clothes in my office. I walk to Drew, sorry to intrude on this. I wasn't expecting people to be here. Marina says, come on. You think I would stay away from this. Catherine agreed with her, David had been unreasonable to me, but doesn't mean I have to be too.

If Catherine is also here, then she must have explained how she found about Drew. He look at her with my intense gaze. She shot a look back of zero qualms about intruding like this. She asks, what. I say, I asked you to leave alone David yesterday. But what did you do instead, you not only stalked Drew but spied on her. I don't know if I can let that slide. I didn't get time to talk to her the entire day. So I wanted an answer from her now. Now she felt a little cornered.

Drew defends her, its fine Blake. She already apologized. I wasn't happy about it, buts there no harm done. I can't believe she wasn't bothered by this. But I wasn't letting it go this easily. It possible I was still agitated a little after my little tussle with Peter. I say, even if Drew is fine with it, I am not Catherine. I can tell she wasn't proud of her actions. She must have understood that it wasn't just about tailing Drew. She rarely does things so impulsive, so it might be also why I couldn't let it go.

She says with a apologetic expression, I couldn't help it Blake. You know how he is. Unless I force things out of him, he won't tell me. I can imagine that, but you could have waited. You being late this morning isn't a big deal. But I can't have friends going rouge on critical times. There are so many things me and Marina wanted to know. But do you see us hounding him. You need to be patient. I might be taking it more personal than I thought. Marina steps to me, whoa, Blake. Look, she said she was sorry. It was a just a small judgment miss. No need to make this bigger than it actually is.

I was ready to rebuke her too. But then I stop myself, because she was right. I was making it way too out of proportion. Turns out I was talking my anger about the whole ordeal on her. I sigh thinking how rude I might have been to her. But Catherine didn't see it that way. She says, you don't need to cover for me Marina. She turns to me, I know what I did was impulsive. I just wanted answers from David. We had been in an argument lately, so I couldn't take it anymore when you told about his condition.

She then becomes a bit somber, if it makes you feel any better. I am regretting it now. David told me things I shouldn't have known. She said something like this earlier. I calmed my nerves before asking, what do you mean by that. She turns to Drew, you know about it too. Don't you. As his therapist, she knew things about him the most. But she wasn't going to indulge in revealing anything. She says, like I told you earlier, it’s a privileged. She was a very good at being impartial, her aura remained consistent. I can't tell if she knew about it or not.

Marina asks curious, he told you things. What things. Catherine faces her, stuff about me in Medrine. That surprised both of us. David said he never met most of us. I ask, he met you back when you were kids. How. I am very certain David didn't have many friends outside Shadows. Catherine shook her head, not me. I meant my family. Now I get what she meant. Marina ask, you didn't like what he said about your family. He didn't like, trash talk about them. Did he? Because he did mine few times. I mean, he isn't completely wrong, but. She stops her herself before going on a monologue, forget that. What did he say to you.

Catherine seemed reluctant to share that. I say, lets not force her, Marina. I apologies Catherine. I wasn't accusing of anything. Its been a long day for me, and with the recent mess, I wasn't thinking clearly. I sigh a little, I know we are all adjusting the new life here now. I wasn't even sure until now if Drew would make a complaint against you, if she ever found about you spying. Catherine nods at me, you aren't wrong. I was also afraid of that, so I came here to explain my myself. She looks at a stoic Drew, who turns out she is a very understanding person. She probably knows what David told me and what other things he didn't.

Drew didn't even flinch for a second, not giving even a small change in aura. Damn, she is really good. She says, I don't know what he said to you. That’s between you two. I just hope you both can work things out. Marina says, hey, wait. Does that mean he has revealed everything to you. She got a little anxious for a moment. I realized what she was going on about. We both assumed Drew knows David's shadow past, but we aren't certain of it. Not surprising, Drew's poker expression didn't change. She locks gazes between me and Marina. After thinking for a while she says, don't worry. I am not going to share his past or his secrets to anyone. And even if I wanted, David has put counter measures.

Marina looks at me a tense expression. We both knew at that moment that she knows. She could have said nothing, but she reassured us not to worry. I can't believe David, so overly cautious, would entrust her with so many secrets. Catherine asks, is it something bad. Should I be worried too. I clear my thought, its nothing. No, not nothing. You don't need to worry about it. Just that Marina and I can't believe you got David to open up. Drew finally shows an expression of a light chuckle, therapy can't work without honesty and transparency. He is smart enough to know this is the only true and efficient way to mitigate his symptoms. I just didn't realize that would involve you high profile people.

Marina says, we are just worried about him. She says, I understand Marina. Like I told earlier, David already warned me about people founding about our arrangement. I would have preferred it remain hidden, but I can't deny its good that he opening up at least to some people. Bottling it up inside is not healthy, no matter how good you are, it takes a toll. Quite a change in perspective, considering she refused to hear Marina yesterday. She turns to me, I wasn't expecting you though. I heard some sort of fight broke out involving some warriors. My whole family was on edge when we saw the news. Aren't you busy with that.

Since the topic shits to that, Marina asks, I heard Citradel people were involved. I don't know what to say here. David basically broadcasted his message to us after hiding his involvement in this matter. Its a little confusing what his intent is. What I know is that I can't tell to Marina or Catherine in front of Drew. Drew caught me staring at her for a moment. That was enough for her to make her realize my intension, you don't want to say in front of me. I got it, its not my business.

She was quick to understand my dilemma. Marina looks at Catherine who shrugs. I reply, thanks for understanding. Its just too early to tell. We need time. The investigation just started, and there are things we can't share until all the facts are known. Drew nods, I completely understand. Once I confirm David's condition, you guys are free to discuss. Catherin says to me, how sure are you of David condition improving. Isn't it a little too much to have him resolve his issues in a day ?

Marina become a little forlorn about it, he was very depressed in the morning. She turns to Drew, that interview he gave was a performance. Drew takes that information like she was reading us. She nods, I figured that was the case. A form of self defense mechanism. Personally, I am ninety nine percent sure he won't overcome it in a day. I haven't talked to Drew much, but I come to understand she is good at her job. Her low expectation was considering that she could judge him the best.

Other two became very nervous hearing such a claim from the said person's therapist. But I knew more than them in this matter. I scoff, don't worry guys. I am very certain that he got over his issues, at least the panic attacks he was getting today. Drew inspects me trying to figure out how I can be so confident. Catherine asks, you spoke to him? Marina says, weren't you in the officers building whole day. Did David visit you at work. I could tell them how I know. But I wasn't completely sure about it. Would it be possible for him to beat down those warriors without using his Kuret. Seems incredibly unlikely. But now I have seen his robots and security, he could have used them instead.

My moneys on him using his Kuret. Peter said he saw people fighting each other. He must have done that trick where I could use others Kuret. I reply, I didn't seem him since morning. Its just a hunch. Marina nods, yeah. Well, that’s all good. But doesn't he has only 5 minutes left. You said he messaged you a while ago, why is he so late. Drew says, can't imagine what's keeping him if he actually controlled his Kuret. That’s also why I think he couldn't do it within the time limit.

Catherine asks, what if he did overcome it, but like hours from now, or tomorrow. Would you still help him? Marina says, yeah, how does few more yours makes a difference. Drew thinks about it for a moment and then shook her head, its not just about the time. I am testing other things too. I can't say what without giving up some things about him. He did ask me the same thing when I didn't even give him whole day. If it weren't for those things, I would have been okay to wait till tomorrow or a week. And besides that, there's the match with Charles in the future. I can't deny that external factors wasn't part of the reason. All I can hope is that he makes it here regardless of the situation.

She made sense, as her therapist. But we were all having mixed feeling about this. Time past by and two minute remained. All of us here becoming frantic. Marina, I am just going to call him. Catherine says, don't bother. He isn't picking up. I tried it a while ago. He might be on his way here. I put down my own phone that I was myself going to use. Now even Drew couldn't remain calm. She was rolling her eyes around the field towards the in road.

Then one minute remained. I ask, did he really bailed. Did something happen after leaving the water treatment. Suddenly Marina says, what's that. I thought she finally found him on the road, but she was pointing to the sky. Everyone's eyes gaze up to the sky. I didn't see anything in the dark, but I could also see a figure coming in. Catherine says, I don't see anything. Is that him. In the next moment a large beam of dark Kuret hits the ground in front of us. The Kuret was pouring in like a burst of large water, pushing the grass sideways an away from the air its pushing out.

Marina says, wow. Look at this entry. Like stepping out of an elevator, David comes out of his Kuret that begins to thin out behind him. I am not going to lie, he looked beat up. He had bandages wrapped around his chest and few stiches on the side his face. This is what he gets when he recklessly attacks a group of warriors all alone. He was a little out of breath, what are you all doing here. Wait, before that, tell me if I made it in time. He was huffing and restless as he approached us.

Marina asks confused, what the hell happened to you. Were you in a fight again. David turns to all of us and then to Drew, I'll explain in a moment guys. I need to finish my business with Drew first. I wanted to ask so many things, but he had his own priorities. A while ago I would have just smacked him, but I have calmed down since. We turn to Drew. For the first time, she was genuinely surprised. He aura showed her momentarily shocked expression.

Drew says, you actually did it. I don't believe this. She then smiles and chuckles. David feels a little relieved then, that was close. I thought I was late. Why was he so late, he should have left the plant hours ago. Was he getting his injuries treated. He turns to us, I wasn't expecting a welcoming committee here. He then singularly focuses on Catherine. They both just have a staring contest trying to figure out something. Then he finally turns to me, I know you are in a rush to talk about incident. Just give me few minutes with Drew. Okay.

At least he knows why I am here. I nod, yeah, I can wait. Marina clicks her tongue and slaps on David's back, you had us worried dude. David chokes a little on that and coughs slightly with pain. He winces while saying, easy there. Marina got anxious, hold on. You look worse than yesterday. What happened. David answers, would you believe if I say injuries look worse on the second day. Marina and Catherine both say in unison, no. David straightens himself, well, things happened tonight. But first.

Drew says to him, no need for keep on the theatrics. You did this on purpose didn't you. You got your Kuret back several hours ago, didn't you. All eyes fell on David. David asks with an innocent look, why do you think that. Drew smiles, I'll be honest. I thought you were going to ask for an extension when you sent your message earlier. But you have made me wait in anticipation this long and make a show like this. You were just messing with me, didn't you.

David can be petty sometimes unexpectedly. He just went out of his way to one up Nathan a while ago too. David smiles, all right. You caught me. No matter how calm you appear, you must have been worried at least a little, right. He wasn't even going to deny it and accepted so fast. That’s probably even more surprising than his antics to keep us in suspense. Drew didn't say anything, but I know she was worried for a moment there. She remained silent to not give David that satisfaction.

Marina asks, jeez dude. Don't antagonize your own therapist. David scoffs, don't worry. This isn't even close enough to rattle her. Drew breaks her silence, its quite all right Marina. He is feeling smug that he did it in time. David says, and justifiably so. Drew replies, maybe. But what if this was a trick you have just shown. I am sure you must have thought about it at least once whole day. David chuckles being called out like this. Catherine asks, ah, you can't believe that wasn't his Kuret.

Drew says, who knows. He is extremely skilled in deception. I won't rule out anything. Did she really thought this a trick from David. Maybe she hasn't seen his Kuret up close enough to know its real. All of us were sure of it though. David says, that’s fair. So how about I prove it to you. Lets. Marina cuts him off, I'll prove it Doctor. Even David was surprised by her sudden enthusiasm. Marina prepares a bunch of her Kuret charms and prepares to launch on David.

My eyes widen at that sudden outburst from her. David yells with his palm raised at her, wait. This is not what I meant. Marina already threw her Kuret on him. She threw couple of circuit charms that do a little bit of physical damage. Not good, she doesn't know how David is hurt. He must be weak right now. With my quick reflexes, I pull out my own Kuret and block two of them in the air. But one went around it my Kuret. David stumbles down on the ground not able to maintain his balance when trying to dodge it. Just before the last Kuret charm could hit him, David pulls out his Kuret in front of him and cancels it out before it physically hits him.

The impact still had force that he got dragged away a distance though. Marina had her jaw open seeing David couldn't defend himself. I immediately wrap my Kuret on her extended arm to ensure she doesn't attack him again. David grunts in pain, what the hell Marina. Catherine shrieks while running to him, what did you do that for. Marina yells shocked, what was that David. You could have easily cancelled it with your Kuret. I remove my Kuret from her arm once she backs down, didn't you saw his injuries.

With Catherine's help David stands back up. He was already panting hard. He is even in worse shape that I imagined. Marina was the most surprised among us, I saw. But this is nothing for him. Didn't you see the amount of Kuret he used when he came here. Why didn't you block it. David was glaring at her, woman, I get you are annoyed at me for keeping stuff from you, but this is not how you get even with me. Catherine holds him tightly he almost slipped out from her grip.

Marina broke into a sweat, no. That’s not. Dammit. Sorry David. She steps to him. David was reeling a little from it waves his palm at her, believing she might attack her again. He sighs, just. Give me a second. He raises his watch, any stiches open M. Hi watch opens with the hologram, a small stitch opened in your chest, boss. Its underneath the cast, we will need to cut it open to handle it. David grits his teeth, I felt that one. Well, next stop is the nano bot tank.

Catherine asks, wait, are you wearing a cast underneath. Marina turns panicked hearing that with anxious eyes all over his body. David nods, yeah. I have on in my left foot too. Marina asks, what the hell happened to you. He sighs, price of getting my Kuret back. Two of them didn't really get what he meant. Daivd says, I am fine Catherine. Thanks. She lets go of her and walks towards Drew, who was a little puzzled by Marina's rash behavior. She says, you know, you might also benefit with a bit of therapy for that explosive impulsivity.

Marina ignores her after a mocking expression, what about that Kuret you showed a minute ago. David says, I was late because it took time to build up that. I wasn't totally faking being late, I didn't realize it took so long to pull that off. That little show was the limit. Its funny to see David flustered enough that he didn't even try to hide the pain. David turns to Marina, I was going to propose just a talk with Drew alone for a minute. She knows how to prove I can use my Kuret without triggering a panic attack.

Marina turns to Drew who nods in agreement. With a scorn look from David, he and Drew went a little farther for a brief private discussion. I poke Marina's arm who was in a daze, its fine Marina. He will be fine. He just took a beating from couple of tough people. That pulled her out of her thoughts, what do you know. Catherine also joins in, he definitely looks worse than morning. I guess I could tell them now that Drew was not listening in. But David kept a lid on his involvement. There must be a reason. So I want him to tell us.

I say, all I know he was involved in the fight that broke out in the treatment plant tonight. Marina shrieks, what. Involved how. Catherine turns to David's back, he got beat up there? But no one mentioned him. Did he escape from there. I laugh, more like the mastermind. I am not sure completely myself. The bastard didn't tell anyone about until 20 minutes ago, and, it was with a two line message. No explanation. I rushed here immediately to get details for him. And that’s how I knew he probably resolved his mental block.

Marina tilts her head confused, hold on. I heard Quintin was involved too. Did they fought. I shrug, no clue. We will have to hear it from him. Catherine scoffs, no wonder he is so banged up. Its not just Quintin, Marina, you remember the dual Kuret user Polly, she was there too. I added, and Cory too. Marina eyes widen, I remember those people. They are pretty strong too. Did he fought them there. Who was with him. I shrug not knowing the whole picture.

We waited for their discussion to end. We couldn't hear them, but from their body postures its pretty clear she was asking him bunch of questions. After being is suspense for a while, they finally walk back to us. Drew spoke first, I confirmed it, she eyes at Marina, with words. Sounds almost ridiculous that he actually pushed through in a bizarre manner. Catherine asks, so your symptoms are gone. David replies, it doesn't work like that. Drew answers for him, its not a switch that will turn off in on go. But he took a very big step in recovery. I am a little conflicted about it though. Because that means I have to held up my side the deal.

David nods, yeah. To quote you, a radical experimental treatment. She nods, exactly. She takes a moment to think about it, maybe I was exaggerating the radical part to maybe scare you from actually being able to do this. I can't believe she would do mind games like this on her patient. But then I look at him nod at her. No, actually she is perfect for him. She says, I can't back down now. Its not everyday I get to observe a case like you. So I'll help you.

David replies excited, thanks Drew. She says, as I told earlier, give me a week. When I am ready, I will contact you. She then looks around to us, I suppose that’s all I can do now. I am sure you all are eagerly waiting to hear an explanation for this current injuries. So I will you all some time to discuss. But please do me a favor and do it somewhere else. I don't have too many neighbors, but someone might see you all here. I understood her concern, thank you Drew. We will get out of your hair.

She waves good night to us and leaves us. I proposed, David, can you move. He says, I will manage. Lets move to my place for a while. I'll explain what I can. I can't wait to hear that explanation. Marina hesitantly asks, do we move to your. David shots her down, no. Not ART. I told you, it can't handle all of us. My place. Its the closest. We all agreed to that and started walking towards the road. A car runs down the road towards us. I ask, is that for us.

David nods, yes. I hadn't seen this car before. What's more that it was a driverless car. This must be part of the underwater house. We all get in and it drove us to his house. While we drove, David asks me, what did you tell them. I replied, not much. Just what I know. He leans back on the driver seat, well then. Before I explain what happened I want to confirm something. He turns to Catherine seating with me in the behind, I know I am being rude, but I am not in favor of telling you.

That’s shocked everyone. I face a irritated Catherine. She asks, what do you mean by that. Why. David replies, I found out things. Things about who tried to poison Marina and Blake. Marina yells, what. You know who it is. Give me their name right now. She was a down with guilty from pushing David earlier, but now she was distracted by the prospect of finding the people who poisoned her. David says, I will tell you. However, Catherine. You are in a position where being in charge of managing the social affairs of the island makes you a target.

Now I was flabbergasted, hold on. Target for whom. You mean the people we have in custody. He shook his head, they are nothing but criminals. They don't pose a threat. But there is someone pulling strings behind them. My worry is that if I share this to you Catherine, you might act or do stuff that will attract their attention. That’s what I mean by becoming a target. Its safer for you to not know this. I got a little annoyed, that’s not fair to her man. You can't held what she did in the morning against her.

As soon as that left my mouth, I felt hypocritical. Didn't I just chewed her a little about it minutes ago. David didn't rebuke that. Catherine become quite, her aura showing bit of confusion and anger. But their were hints of resentment too. Marina asks, is it that dangerous for her. David nods, it is. More than us. I was coming up a way to defend her. But I couldn't. If David was being so concerned, he must have a good reason. Catherine asks, is it because of what you told me in the morning.

David closes his eyes, like it pained him for some reason. He replies, maybe. Maybe not. I don't want to lie by saying its not. So instead I'll say this, I trust you. I just don't trust the people around you at work. And after today, anyone around me will be in target. I don't know how, but it’s a very strong possibility. Marina and Blake are shadows, they know how to be covert. He then thinks for a moment, no. Actually you are even better than them. And that’s why this is dangerous for you. They already have a target on them. Can you handle one on you as well ?

He was being very cryptic, but he made sense. We were targeted in the tournament. No one else. It might not be fair to Catherine, but I was beginning to think she should stay out of it too. Catherine turns to me, I don't understand what he is saying. You seem to know the most. Tell me honestly, am I a liability here. I didn't like her being so dejected. I answer, you aren't a liability Catherine. Don't think like that. I am at a loss of words to comfort her. I understood both their concerns, but it was hard to weigh which one is more important.

David says, Catherine, how about this as a compromise. You can do what you excel at without me stopping you. Figure things out for yourself. You are excellent at it. Catherine turns to him, what's that supposed to mean. He answers, I know its not fair to keep in the dark. So how about instead of me asking you to stay out of it, you do your own investigation. Follow the trail and if that somehow leads back to us, I will gladly show our cards. David was meeting her half way here.

This cheered up Catherine a little, you mean I can figure out how or why you were involved today, and keep perusing it on my own. He nods, exactly. I shook my head, I don't like this David. You are using her as a bait. Aren't you. Marina slaps David on his shoulder who grunts in pain, the hell David. You are the worst. David shots Marina with another glare and then back to me, to be clear, she is only a target if she is helping me. But if she investigates it on her own, she won't have to worry about it. The entire IDF is doing it as well.

He didn't deny it. But apparently, that was the jolt Catherine needed to get out her sour mood, you sure. I may not be good at deceiving like you, but I am damn good at spying and gathering intel. What if I found about things that you don't know. I might not share that to you. That brought a smile to his face, that’s fine. That just means I will ask your help in that case. Besides, this is the perfect chance to prove certain people wrong about you. I turn to her with a confused look. She finally grins, hmm. Really, you think I have to prove myself. No thanks, I may not be happy with them, but I don't need justify myself to them too.

Earlier Catherine said David told things about her family. They must be talking about someone of her relatives. David says, I knew that. Just wanted to know if you know that too. Catherine clicks her tongue, you think you are so clever, don't you. You still lied. David says, I didn't. So lets just leave it at that. Whatever conversation they had, it made sense only to them. I ask her, are you really okay with this. Being out of the loop. She nods, yeah. I don't know what this is all about, but I will figure it out.

She was resolved to do, so I guess I didn't have to make a decision for her. Marina asks, Blake is right, Catherine. David might want be using you as bait despite all what he said. David smiles now not denying the accusation. Catherine says, its fine. I might use him as well. Just you know, to keep things fair. Okay, she is beginning to be her usual self. David says, thanks for understanding. Because I programmed M to drop you at your house first. I didn't realize we were going through section 1.

Catherine says, damn you. Apparently, David already knew how this conversation would turn out. In a minute we were at her house's driveway. Catherine gets out of the car and says, I see you all tomorrow. Then she sneers at David, I will see you real soon. David waves her, looking forward to it. We say our byes and the car drives us to Davids place next. Marina ask, so what's with all the sudden dangerous mission.

Once we were on the road again, David says, the one behind the sabotages and behind tonight's event is someone close to us, an officer from the island.

Blake (Chapter 77)

Sunday, January 18, 2026 17:11

It took another 15 minutes to David's house. He kept us in suspense and didn't explain why he thought one of the officers was behind the scenes. Marina and I kept asking him why he believes that. To make sense of this, he started from beginning. He was a little hesitant to explain how he came to be at the treatment plant. He wanted us to focus more on the criminals than how he found them. But after continuous pestering from Marina, he relented. He pushes a chair, taking a sofa seat, fine. Fine. I'll tell you everything. So far he told us bits about his day.

Me and Marina each take the couch. I opened my unforms jacket and laid it on the back to get comfortable. David offered us some coffee explaining it will be a long night. Honestly, I needed it. Marina sits on the couch with on knee crossed in her seat, this is so good. Much better than what we have in our office. I didn't like that tone, what do you mean. We have good stuff too. Marina says, nope. This is much better. Honestly, you should install same machines there too. She blows off the steam and takes a sip.

I was annoyed at her blatant disregard for the office coffee. Then I tasted it myself. My throat tasted so good that I actually grinned while drinking. Marina smiles with a light foam on her lips, told you. David laughs too. I ask, dude. What the hell. I thought you said you added the latest machines in our cafeteria. You are keeping the good stuff to yourself. David answers, its my own concoction. I have been experimenting with some imported south Columbian beans. I don't have a large enough supply. So unfortunately, you will have to stick with your usual stuff.

Both of us groaned at him hogging it the good stuff. After setting down, I break the ice, as much I want to chat our life styles, lets get down to business. David agrees, are you fine though. Its been a very long day for you. I scoff, I could say the same of you. I wasn't the one who had to fight off 3 warriors. David leans back on his sofa and stares at the ceiling, like something ominous is about to come next. He says, M, begin the umbrella protocol. Lock down the house.

We hear a little mechanical noise and I hear the shades down on the windows and doors locking. M's voice looms, all done boss. Whatever you say will not leave this room. David says, you too M. Unfortunately, I can't have you listen on this too. Manual shutdown for an hour, bypass authorization with voice authentication. A moment later M says, authentication completed. I will be in my lowest passive monitoring mode. Then all the displays in his house goes dark.

Marina asks, you really are serious now. David turn to face us, I am going to reveal everything to you both now. Not just about tonight, but about shadows and my PTSD. I wasn't expecting complete transparency from him. Did he really got over his issues now. Marina asks, look, I know I have been the most vocal about you not sharing, but seriously. If you don't want to, then. David stops hers, appreciate it Marina. I think its time to come clean. Even if you did broke my ribs again.

She jerks, that was an accident. David laughs, yeah, yeah. I know. Just promise you won't do it again now. Marina nods without hesitation, trust me, if you are okay with sharing with us, I promise not to hurt you. Then she murmurs, only if you deserve it. I think only I heard that. I ask, what changed that made you decide this. David says, honestly, I have been grappling about this is for some time now. You remember our talk yesterday morning, just before the match. I told you were going to be the first person who I will explain my changes in behavior.

He did say that back then. Somehow he is honoring that deal. David says, so much to tell. Where to start. He looked unsure where to start. We both remained patient while drinking our coffee while David prepares himself. He says, lets talk about my PTSD. Its not a typical one, you might have heard it from Drew or known about it yourself. If it were normal, I would be cripped with nervous breakdown for years. Instead I have been slowly effected just few years ago, when I was out for revenge against Nathan.

I could feel the pain in his voice. I recalled that year. He was struggling with his guilt over his first human murder and his obsession with getting justice for Sophies father. So it started from then huh. Marina, who wasn't there, asks, but what about the war with Echo last year. You didn't struggle then. Isn't like PTSD worsens in a war. David nods, you could say I avoided then because I was lucky. My memories was only beginning to resurface. What I told you all last year was the truth, at least what I remembered until then.

I ask, you remember more since then. He says, that’s right. Repressed memories is not like a door, not everything comes back immediately. I was already feeling the effects when we were back in the island after the war. That first night terror. His face contorts with slight pain, was excruciating. I thought it was just a one time thing. Then it happened thrice in the next week. I knew then I was screwed up mentally. I tried to fix it myself. Then came the panic attacks. My conditioned had worsened much more than I thought.

Marina ask, why did you hide from us. David answers, I wanted to tell you all. But I was embarrassed and didn't want to be seen weak. Call it arrogance, or egotistical or just plain being a jerk. I wanted to fix myself without people knowing about me. Not a whole lot of people trusted me back then. Giving them an excuse that I had such a base human problems would be like giving them an ammo. Hiding my condition, even to you all seemed the best course of action.

I don't like it that he was giving a mildly rational explanation. I ask, we could have found a way to help you. He asks, how exactly. Its not like there are people here who are skilled in helping complex things related to mind. If it was a physical, mental or medical issue, there could have been ways. But not a phycological case like mine. I needed help from knowledgeable therapist who can understand my unique situation. A human one. Marina asks, so you sought out Drew instead. David nods, luckily I found her a while later. 2 weeks living with the symptoms made me realize I can't do it myself. I needed to get treatment from human professionals. I may be vain about hiding my condition, but I wasn't stupid. Seeking therapy for my mental healthcare was paramount to get better.

I recalled something about this, several months ago, right after we came back. You were asking about going on a long assignment outside. He says, that was the first plan. But luckily I found about Drew. She was the perfect person to help me. She had the right skills, experience and knowledge of both Human and Medrones. Finding her was nothing short of miracle. Since you talk to her, you already know she had to face difficulties due to her choices while living among humans. It took a while to convince her. In the end she agreed and we started doing sessions every week for 8 whole months.

Marina says, David, I can't believe you had to struggle so much. Seriously, you could have told us, at least for moral support. I agreed with her. We have been through so many things together. David says, you aren't wrong. I was probably jealous that I was the only shadow alive who is struggling to get past the horrors of Medrine. You both already went through your trauma alone while growing up in a foreign planet. He turns to me, Oriana died, but that didn't stop you. He turns to Marina, you built Citradel on all your own, despite not knowing anything about Earth.

Oriana's name brought bitter memories. He may think I lost her recently, but we both know I lost her way before when she decided to betray us for Nathan. He continues, I guess I wanted to prove to myself that I could get through the trauma's on my own too. If that makes sense. Marina and I were silent hearing his reasons. He must have felt pressured. Especially when he was part of the shadows, who were chose to have strong mental fortitude. I say, look, I can't imagine the duress you were in, so I understand the need to hide it. I think I can understand that part at least, if not everything.

Marina keeps her cup on the side table, ditto. I may look like this, but I was a mess too in the beginning. I added, yeah, same. David pulls a weak smile, I know, but I was too late in the game. And the worse part is that its my own fault to be in this position. His mood becomes anxious, I told you before that I lost my memories when I came to Earth due to an accident. He takes a long breadth, that’s not true. My memories were fumbled back then, but I remember them now.

I leaned in a bit closer to him. He claps his hands on his knees, I did that to myself. I repressed my own memories. I didn't fully know what he meant, you mean from the trauma. He says with a grim tone, I mean a serum that erases memories. My jaw shook loose hearing that. Marina puts her hand on her mouth shocked. He continues, the last day on Medrine broke me completely. You know that I wanted to leave Medrine and live on Earth believing it that will save me. It had another side to it. Erasing my own memories so that I get live a normal life.

I shout, you are kidding right. You wanted to live here without your memories. This was before Echo attacked Medrine. That’s the most ridiculous plan I have heard from you. Marina says, why would you do something so extreme. David puts his hand on his head. His face screamed guilt and resentment. He says, I don't know how to explain. Unlike most, I didn't have anyone. I was on my own for a time before joining the university. Struggling to eat, breathe, even a basic live. Every day was a struggle, no one could help me or understand me. Maybe things would have been different I knew about the MARS project when I was a child.

He shakes head, regardless. When I learned of Earth, it was a dream and salvation for me. And it became a reality once I got into Shadows. I had a plan then, once I found a way to get off the planet, I would quit Shadows and leave Medrine. I can't believe this. I ask, are you for real. You thought of escaping to Earth without your memories. Marina shook her head, you think Shadows would even allow it. David sighs, it was a crazy and desperate plan. I don't deny it. But it was what all I had that time. I just wanted to live a different life.

He then laughs mockingly, you knows what's even crazier. It was never going to work. I told you before that I was suffering through malnutrition. I later found out on here on Earth, that I wasn't going to make it till even my 20s. Once I hit puberty, my body wouldn't developed, nor my brain. It would eventually lead to some terminal illness. I am not sure what it could have been, it could have been simple as allergies, or something severe like cancer. And most likely, I would be dead before even I could amass resources to leave Medrine.

I never imagined he was going through of all this as a child. I knew he lived a harsh life, but this made it impossible to even fathom how worse it was. Marina asks, was there really no cure. He replies, the only cure came with the destruction of Medrine. One of the things I was struggling in therapy was the survivals guilt. No, actually there is not even a phycological term to describe a situation where I not just survived, but got to live beyond the time I thought I had. All at the expense of everyone and everything dying.

I could only offer some solace now, but that’s not your fault. He makes a weak smile, don't I know that. Just because its true, didn't make it easier for me to accept it. Like I said, one the challenges I had to accept. Marina says, gosh. David. I can't believe it. I can imagine now why you didn't want to tell anyone about it. David says, the story is not over. When I arrived on Earth, I didn't know at that time that I was spared and got to live. I was consumed by the horrors I saw that last day.

He put downs his cup on the side table. His mood becomes serious again, to understand what led me to erase my memories, I need to tell you about someone. A girl I was very close with. She was the who actually came up this crazy plan of erasing memories and was going to come with me to Earth. What the freak, someone else also part of this. Marina asks, that’s nuts. I can understand if its you, but why would someone normal would chose to do it. David says, depends on what people believe is normal.

He leans forward, I am going to reveal things about Shadows as well, so do not disclose this to anyone under any circumstances. I ask, huh. Ah, okay. Marina nods with hesitation too. He continues, I was close with our generations Shadow retrievalist. Her name was, Zakerine, the next in line in alpha to the Utabine bloodline. Do you know who they are. I gulp hard finally learning of another Shadow member. But I had a hard time recalling this bloodline. Marina jerks a bit on her couch.

She shrieks, no way in hell. Someone from their bloodline joined us. Freak. I ask, you know who they are. Because I don't. Marina waited for David, but he waves his arm for her to explain, by my guest. She explains, they are super

powerful bloodline Blake. They can physically teleport. I hands tremble a little hearing that, say that again. She scoffs, I didn't believe when mom told me about them. Buts its true, there is a Kuret that allows space to fold, and make it possible to open, something like a gate ? She asks David. He says, yeah. A mini wormhole. I don't know if you heard about spooky action theory by Einstein. Its basically instantaneous teleportation in a limited space.

My god, I say, that's some ridiculous ability. Having such a ability makes it perfect for a Shadow retrievalist. But how come I never heard of them. Marina says, that's probably because they rarely ever get to use this ability. I was confused why that was the case. David clarifies, unlike most bloodline, only five or six people could do it. And that includes the alpha, so in reality, its even less. Their Kuret has such a massive physical attribute, but most of their house people can't open a wormhole.

I say, jeez. You know, once I learned of Heraknus, I thought I wasn't going to be surprised anymore. But Medrine is the gift that keeps coming. Marina says, yeah. But where Heraknus hid, Utabine ran. They are impossible to find, mom had a theory that royals were protecting them. But I guess not. I shrug, maybe I just wasn't told about them. David adds, no. Not even the royals didn't know. Zakerine told me she was bounced around with her mother, the current alpha of that time. Marina is right, they are sought after. But not to join their house via marriage or team up. They wanted to study and create Kuritines with their DNA. So even if they didn't have he ability to teleport, they can be studied.

Now I understood why Marina was freaked out we had someone like that in Shadows. Its a sad, but predictable tale, when you mean studied, you mean. He sighs, yeah. In a lab, as a controlled subject. Getting your hands on one was like finding a holy grail. Getting an alpha would be divine miracle. The applications are endless, even humans are searching for ways beyond lightspeed. Imagine what Medrones can do with such technology. The potential are boundless, he was right about that.

Marina says, how did she came to join us. We may not abuse or mishandle powers, but still, we do use it. David says, I don't know. She never shared the details on how. I only know why, she, like me wanted to run away to Earth. Her mother left her at the university under the alias of some other bloodline. Some Shadow recruiter found about her true heritage and gave her the choice. After passing the trails, she became our member. She said she was just hiding, biding time in Shadows until her mother came. But after joining a year, she got her bloodline marker and became an alpha. She didn't receive it normally, so their was only one way it would have happened.

We have come to know about this all too familiar, her mother died. David says, that's when she formed that plan. I wasn't aware of it, but once I knew who she was, I found about it accidently one day. Normally she wouldn't have let it slip, but it was her mothers death anniversary, was depressed and I happen to be nearby as she was speaking to herself in her room. She was initially denying it, saying its not possible to create a potion. But I revealed that I was also in Shadow, and we can find a way if we worked together. She took several days to consider, but then she agreed. From then on, I perfected our plan. With my network of people with access growing in time, we were able to make the serum.

I was enthralled listing to this. Not in a good way. I ask, this is when you were both nine or ten. What kind of children think of a plan like this. Marina says, only you could come up with such a dangerous thing. David says, I know that now. But back then, I wasn't aware of the repercussions. No, I did know but didn't care. I was dying, thinking I won't get to become even an adult. And she was being hunted. She didn't care about her bloodline, she just didn't want to die like her mother. Both of had different reasons, but same goal. To live. Something to strive for. My brains and her ability were the best combination to break into any place.

He leans back and takes a moment to himself, like he is reliving those days. After a long silence, he says, she wasn't like me. But I never met anyone who was dedicated to achieve something. Other kids, no offence, were boring compared to her. I can imagine that. When you are born genius, especially on Medrine, you don't mix well with kid of your caliber. He continuous, as we studied and worked together, over time. I found her to be my only true friend. A guide.

He then croaks a little, and eventually I became infatuated with her. Ah, I see now. I can already begin to understand what happened now. Marina was less tact and said, you fell in love with her. When you were kids. David felt uneasy taking about it. I silently signal Marina to not push it. I am very certain this is very sore topic for him. David says, I did. Yeah. Sounds ridiculous, I know. Marina completely ignores my plea and asks, and her, did she also felt the same.

I wished she wouldn't be so inconsiderate of David. David saw me eyeing Marina, its fine Blake. I want to tell. Its just hard to tell reveal this to you. Not even Drew knows the whole story. He then turns to Marina, I think so. Though I always wondered if I pressured her in some way. I can't be sure that I didn't manipulate her. I did that a lot when I didn't care about anything back then. But I was happy. And she was happy. I never told her this, but I was beginning to want to not erase our memories when we go to Earth. At least I didn't want to. I thought I could be with her, even if she lost her memories.

I have seen him rarely this vulnerable, he was even talking without his usual demeanor. Opening up to us like this must be too much for him. Now even Marina understood and patiently waited for him to speak when he got the courage. He takes a moment and says, but that didn't happen. Echo's attacked. She died. And the serum I almost discarded, I used it on myself. Unable to process my grief and unable to forget the memories all the people dying. I couldn't take it anymore. That's also one of my issues I had to grapple with in therapy. I erased my memories for selfish reasons, and lost time when Medrones were hiding or dying, when I could have helped them.

This is painful to just hear, I can't imagine what he must have been going through. He says, I never once imagined Echo would be following us to Earth. In my own selfish way, wanted to keep the plain a live, thinking she would want me to do it too. He had teary eyes now. But before he could shed any tear, he wipes his eyes and closes them. He smiles, damn, I didn't know telling the truth would be this hard. It was much earlier with Drew. It was hard for him, no doubt.

We all have troubled history, each have to bear the burden however they can. David wasn't different, just was really unlucky. Marina asks, you don't have explain to us. I shouldn't have pressured you all this time. David laughs, chocking a little, thanks. But I told you all, I am about to clear the air. That's doesn't mean just the happy stuff. But the gritty stuff too. As he tries to calm down, I went to fetch him a glass of water. He thanks me while drinking it all in one sip.

He then says, but just last night, I unlocked the very last moment of my time on Medrine. I ask, you still hadn't recovered all your memories. He nods, I thought I did. I thought Zakerine died from a bombardment from Echo ships just before we were about to board the ship. But turns that it was the whole story. He then explained to us how she survived that initial attack, but people died to save them, including Branden and John. This is how he knew about Catherines family. But then Zakerine died anyway trying to save John.

This is getting worse by the minute. I am in shock David was able to go on with the day, come to the pier to meet Charles and give the interview. I was depressed for days when Oriana died. This freaking guy had to tough it out and come to accept it in a day. Marina asks, I can't believe she died like that. Why she go this far for John. David replies, a million dollar question. I have no idea. All day I have been trying to figure that out, thinking it was key to resolve my mental block. The best I can think is she didn't want to lose anyone, like she did her mother.

With the messy history he telling, I almost forgot why I came to him. I was curious what made him get past his trauma. But for now, I wanted him to lead his story that way he wants to. Marina says in a muffled tone, I can't believe Utabine bloodline ended like this. I am not trying to disregard her effort, but it was so. She couldn't find the words. Neither could I. David offers, needless. I didn't expect him to be this callous about it. Its not like I wasn't thinking that. I just didn't want to say it.

He says, there's no need to sugarcoat it. It was a pointless death. He sad expression turns to an angry one, Drew told me that I might have always remembered this memory, and influenced my emotions subconsciously. By how much is anyone's guess. But this completely broke me. My lowest point, as Drew calls it, rock bottom. What if could have stopped her, made her see reason. What if I was able to use my Kuret then. All these questions, and no way to answer them.

I gulp hard before asking, she made her choice. I know its easy to but, it really wasn't your fault. He says, I couldn't accept that. Not until tonight. Saving Elina, felt like I was redeeming myself. Marina asks, who is that. I tell her, the victim last night. She was gravely wounded. Marina says, that's her. I nodded. I was very curious how he knew her, but I had to wait for him to tell me that in his own time. I felt it I need to switch topic so David doesn't feel pressured into explain his issues with us. I had a question for him that was good way to turn things a bit, how did you know John and why was he and Branden with you both there.

David puts his palm on his face for some reason, like he didn't want to tell us that. A while later he says, I guess I have come clean about that too. He turns to us, what do you know about the last member, Shadow spy. I looked at Marina who shook her head, same as me. David says, its John. He was also in our generation. Holy shit. I ask, Catherine's brother was in the shadows. Marina says, no way. You know, now that I think about it, its perfect for them. Their Kuret is basically made for this.

I was still stuck at that reveal. I ask, does she know. David says, what do you think? His question gave me the answer. Marina asks, that's so bizarre. Normally you expect Shadows to have distinct people, but we have many so many people for famous and strong bloodline in the same generation. She had a point. Aside from David and Zakerine, all three of us are chosen from powerful bloodline. David chuckles hearing that. Marina asks, what. Am I wrong. David waves his hand, not at all. Just amused how close you are.

I ask, close to what. David says, me and Zakerine learned about something crazy about Shadows. Its probably not so crazy, just a propaganda they spread. I was so confused by this. David says, it's a sham. Well, not a total one. But they still lied big time. Shadows aren't recruited from a very big pool of candidates. Three of roles are almost always filled predetermined from certain bloodlines. Only one or two, maybe three in extreme case, are actually selected from the rest of general population. Marina waves both her hand around David, what does that mean.

Hold on, does he mean what I think he means. David says, Shadows was originally created by your three ancestors. Yours and Catherines. Naturally they would want to keep their power and have their bloodline member in the shadows each generation. Its being going on for centuries. David wasn't just revealing his secrets now, he was telling all of ours. I ask, is this for real. Marina yells nervously, someone from my family was a Shadow too. I ask, but why wouldn't they tell us.

David says, for many reasons I am sure. Like if they told you, it might make you feel undeserved. Because of how they sell the idea that Shadows are selected based on skills and morals. You all would feel cheated and maybe even feel too much privileged. But don't worry, they definitely chose you all for the right reasons. I said earlier the candidates for your roles is less, not gone. You still had to beat your other bloodline members. I don't know if you realized this, but Nathan was a candidate too. He lost in the trials to you, Blake.

I immediately jerked in my seat, who in their right mind would try to induct him. David smiles, its not based on personality, but their skills and judgement. I had to learn the hard way about this in the Shadows. I can't believe I faced off Nathan when were child. We were given individual trails, so its obvious I didn't knew. Marina asks excited, hey what about me. Did I also fought get to fought someone I knew. David thinks for a bit, Ozarek is a little mystery to me, even now. Zakerine said your older sister have been a candidate one time, but we didn't know for sure. But I personally always believed your 4 cousins were candidates too.

She slams her fist on the side of the couch, I should have known. They were so obnoxiously proud of being my aunts children. Those girls in Shadows would have been a disaster. David says, like I said, that just my assumption. Marina says, still. Its amazing though. Shadows kept us always in dark about this. I say, probably didn't want us to know our history and be influenced in any way. David nods, most likely the truth, I believe it too. I ask, but how in the hell did you figure this out. Even if you knew about us, you couldn't conclude about our history with just that alone.

David smirks, every year, there is a summit. All past generations Shadows come together, at least all the ones who are alive. The location is so well guarded, you probably have a better luck searching for pitta Kuretine in the

ocean. I will spare you the arduous details on how we got their location. After failed attempts three times in row, two years before Echo attacked, we finally found their summit location. We successfully infiltrated it too. Never in entire Shadows history they ever recruited people like me and Zakerine. My presence can't be detected by Kuretine devices. And she could basically wrap into anywhere. Even if they had managed to stop Zakerine, I was a different story.

I smile thinking how two kids were able to do it. Marina says, hold on. Are you telling me you know the previous generation Shadows were. I was eager to know too. David says, are you sure you want to know. Some of these are people you know intimately, outside your training. Knowing them will most definitely change your perspective of them. They trained you from a small age, while you didn't know them. I didn't tell Catherine for this very reason. Once you know, you can't go back. So, do you still me to tell you. His concern was legitimate. I don't know how would I feel about them. Marina wasn't grappling with the same as me.

She says, oh come on. I am dying to know. I might not like it, but its always better to know. David says, not always. Even Marina had to agree that. She says, can't deny that. But I'll think I still want to know. Even if its changes my opinion about them. David laughs, that’s so you. Well, maybe you won't have a problem. But I didn't want to find out that out with Catherine. So I never told her. I ask, then why was she upset then. David thinks for a moment, you have to talk to Catherine about that. I'll leave it up to her if she wants to share it.

Probably for the best. At least it helped me make my decision too, I want to know too. Whatever happens, it already has happened. Besides, like you said. It might not be as bad as you think. David tilts his head a bit, that's what everyone says before regretting it. He then sighs, well, since you both have made up your mind, I might as well tell you then. The previous generation of shadows were Brandon, Wagner, Istra, Hansen and a women whose identity I don't know.

As soon as I heard those names, my mind went racing into all directions. Some good, and some very bad.

David (Chapter 78)

Monday, January 19, 2026 19:47

This is so embarrassing. One by one I am telling them my deepest and darkest secrets. Some that I not even told Drew. I had been wavering back and forth about telling them about many things. But I ended up spilling all the beans. I felt someone plunged a cold abyss in my guts when I told about my biggest regret. The most selfish decision to erase my memories. Even when I told my relationship with Zakerine, I couldn't bring out everything. I wanted to tell them so many things. The things we both did, places we visited, and the missions.

I knew I was being cold and detached when I told them her death was pointless. Because I still can't myself to forgive Zakerine. I can accept to some extent, but never forgive her and myself. She might have lost her mind back then, but I didn't help her. The regret hasn't gone, only dimmed by the acceptance of her death. I was glad when Blake asked me something else to not pressure me into telling them everything. I apricate that very much, because I wanted somethings to be just between Zakerine and me.

I decided that it was time to reveal things about Shadows I had learnt over the years on Medrine. Their family being in the Shadows was no doubt a shock to them. I just hope it doesn't dishonor their memories in any way. There was only person that I was reluctant to name in the previous Shadows. But I am tired of hiding his identity now. The two of them were stunned to hear the four people I named. Marina is bewildered, mom was shadow member. What, no way. I think I would recognize my own mom when she was training me in our headquarters.

Her reluctance to believe that was expected. I answer, she was there in the summit. There's no mistaking it. Marina leans back in the couch, damn mom. She was so different when she trained me as Shadow keeper. To think she coddled me so much at home, while was a strict instructor in Shadow. I never imagine it was her. I nod, its perfectly fine. If you think about it, each Shadow generation of your 3 bloodlines go through similar transition. Only once you turn from an apprentice to full fledged member, you learn the truth. I never saw your grandmother in the summit. But if you think about it.

Marina understood my thinking, she was the alone sibling of her generation and her cousins were all male. She was the Shadow before my mom. I nod, most likely. Blake asks, Wagner and Branden were one too. I guess that makes sense for Catherine's father. Marina ask, who is Hansen. I don't recall the name. Before I could answer, Blake says, I think I know, he was the chief advisor to the council right. I nod, you know your politics. Its him. He was a very intelligent. To this day, I haven't met anyone smarter than him. Maybe that’s just how I remember him, but he was certainly very cunning. The quality you need to be strategist.

Blake says, high praise from you means he was a great person. But I can't believe Wagner was one too. I can't believe the crown was a member too. My expression harden a little bit. I know I have tell him, but I was still harboring doubts. He asks, I am guessing you didn't tell Vanessa also. He raised an eyebrow, maybe already knowing the answer.

I sigh, no. She doesn't. To her, her brother is very important, so much so that she blindly idolizes her unconditionally. She will not accept anyone bad mouthing him. You saw yourself when Melinda told that story about him endangering the kids. Blake asks, wait, so that’s actually true. He infiltrated the Heraknus home and causes problems. Its hard to believe that. I shrug, I don't the slightest clue if he did that or not. But honestly, I don't find his actions surprising.

That even brought Marina from her daze, why do you say that. He might have made a mistake that time. He was the golden boy. I immediately make a scowl, he was a menace to the society and should have died way before the Echo killed him. I couldn't hold back now. I used to control myself and holding back, but my veins were popping on my head now. My venomous derogatory comment about him left them both stunned. I need to explain it properly, Blake. Didn't you notice something weird about the lineup of the previous Shadows.

He had already noticed it, you didn't mention anyone from my family. Maybe it was the women you don't know. I shook my head dismissing that. He turns nervous realizing the cruel truth, no. That wasn't Wagner, tell me it wasn't him. I scoff, who else would it be if not him. He was the previous Shadow attacker, there's no doubt. When I laid it out, Blake runs his hands on his hair trying to calm down. Marina was confused, is he like secretly bad. Blake looks at her anxiously, if David's right, then he was a nightmare. This is bizarre, no one should have him as a mentor. Its like Jekel and Hyde, his personality is flipped from a cool and dependable to someone with no qualms brutalizing me.

I am glad at least someone else beside me is able to understand Wagners true nature now. It felt like a big rock lifted from my shoulder hearing that. It was burden I didn't know would release me so much from that guys grip. I smirk, glad you believe that too. Ever since I got my memories, whenever I heard praises of him from Vanessa, I would almost lose it. I could never reveal this to her, without telling them what I know and how I know. Blake shook his head, still in denial, freak this. No wonder you hate Wagner so much. I am so bloody confused right now.

Marina asks hesitantly, really. But why is he like this. I have seen few times personally. She pauses a little before saying in a hushed tone, he was so handsome and charming. I had a massive crush on him. As soon I heard that, my breathing cuts off and I began chocking on myself. I raised my hand to her to stop saying anything more. I could just throw up listening to this utter nonsense. Blake asks me, dude. You good. I nod while I settle down, please Marina. I can handle other women talking about him like this, but not you. Please, never say that in my presence again. I didn't have a panic attack, but I felt even worse than that.

Marina was stunned by my adverse reaction and says, ah, okay. Clearly she was conflicted about it too. I go and grab another glass of water to calm my enraged nervous. I know how Vanessa talks about Wagner, but I know why she believes that. I had gulp down two more glasses to cool myself. Blake says, Marina, he was bad. I mean, there is a strict teacher and then there's him, completely unreasonable. I used to believe that it was a mistake to bring him into Shadows. That guy was deranged. He would beat me up every time I mess up. He didn't even bother to teach me anything. Out sessions were nothing but me getting hurt. I had to rely on David to learn.

I am sure by now Marina now understand what Wagner was truly like. I add, I have no idea why he was like this, Marina. Once I saw their real identities, me and Zakerine spent months digging into everyone's history and tried to understand some weird inconsistences. But even after all that research, I couldn't find his background other than what's public knowledge. But I do one thing, he wasn't like this when he joined. I take sat back on the sofa chair as Blake asks, what makes you say that.

I answer, because he was chosen by the previous Shadow member, Slater. Yours dad Blake. Blake stops rummaging on his hair and looks straight at me, holy shit. My dad was one too. Marina chuckles amused, of course he was. My mom, Catherine's Dad and now yours. Dude, our parents were master in deception. For the love of. She trails off mumbling to herself. Blake clasps his hand and rests his head on it, deep in thoughts. I offered them some advice, look. They had their reasons. I am sure their relatives made them go through the same. If Echo hadn't attacked, I am sure you all be doing the same. I know it’s a lot, but like I said before, don't let this change your perception of them. Its important you don't forget that.

I was really afraid of that they would be angry with them. They should not blame them their families for any reason. Blakes says, I am not angry. Just, hum. I need some time to process this. Marina puts her hand on her cheeks, Its a lot. I nod, it is. But that’s why I know Slater wouldn't have picked Wagner if he was like this from the beginning. You dad gave up alpha power to his brother, just to marry your mother. So I really don't think a selfless guy like him would chose such a poor successor.

Blake nods, that’s true. Dad was very careful about everything he does. But then what happened to Wagner. Something went really bad while he was in Shadows. Marina asks, maybe a mission gone wrong. I say, probably. But its futile to even think about it. No matter what happened, or what his reasons were to change so much. Nothing justifies brutalizing me or Blake like this. Blake asks me, I know what he did to me. But what did he do to you. I close my eyes recalling all times of our encounters. I shook my head, I rather not say. Just trust me, it was bad.

Marina says, jeez. What the hell he did to you. Unfortunately, I had maxed out my quota of terrible memories of Wagner and didn't offer any answer. Instead she asks, okay. You don't have to. You said something about inconsistency among Shadow members. What did you mean by that. I gave it some thought, me and Zakerine found something strange when you compare the ages and lineup of the previous Shadows. Blake caught on what I said, yeah. You are right. There wasn't anyone from the my bloodline, instead Wagner came in as an attacker. Marina says, hold on. I just realized, my mom's even older than Slater. So why would still be in the shadow when younger people were in her generation.

I said, we had the same question. We spent a lot of time trying to figure that out. We have some theories, but no evidence. All I could say is that like any organization, Shadows has politics involved at some level. It had to be. Hansen was older than others too, but I know that the guy before me was killed in a mission. So he had to remain in Shadow even longer until I was recruited. I didn't find any evidence that Istra tried to find any candidate before Marina. Why she wait so long to find a successor. Meanwhile, Slater chose not to include someone from the royal bloodline and instead brought in Wagner. This reeks of politics maneuvers rather than just not finding the right people for the job.

Blake says, that is so weird. I thought Shadows were free from it. Guess that was just wishful thinking. Marina says, I never imagined it was like this. I never gave this so much thought to it except for the training. I am still confused that Slater would choose someone outside from royal bloodline, something going for centuries like you said. I say, I wish I knew. I didn't I know everything even after finding their identities. They were very good at keeping secrets. I myself would love to know why Wagner was brought in. He was nothing but a walking disaster.

Marina asks, is he the reason for your PTSD ? Is that why you had a panic attack yesterday in the match. I knew this would eventually come up. I had unconsciously I grip the sides of the chair tightly. My PTSD is not completely gone. I never know I might regress to some of my previous symptoms. I take few deep breathes before explaining this, before my mentor, Hansen, brought me to the ship. I was in the other side of the continent the previous day. I don't know I got from there to the ship. Anyways, I was helping out with issuing command in place of Hansen, who left with other Shadows to defend against the hive king and his army from crossing the ocean.

They both lean in closer to me. I continue, we were in the middle of the city when we were attacked by Echo ships. I somehow was able to take the underground train and escape with few people. But Echo kept pursuing us and I told we had to split up. I gave them directions on how to remain safe and find the second ship. I and two other people took a different route though. I wanted to check on the Shadows, with whom we lost contact. Hansen didn't want me to come, but I wanted to find him.

I tremble a little recalling that horrid journey. Air filled with dust and bloodied bodies everywhere. I continue to take deep breathe to keep myself calm. Marina asks concerned, are you okay. I nod frantically, just trying to forget that part of the day. It was horrifying and scary. It was a tough decision for me. I don't know how many actually made to the ship or to my two companions. Once we reached close to the battlefront, we got separated. Most likely they died when we ran from the ground troops.

I shook my head, I shouldn't have gone there. I thought I could be of help. I still can't believe the sheer arrogance of thinking that I was better than Hansen. I often think about what would have changed if was there. Maybe I would have just died, or maybe saved someone. Or maybe nothing would change. The shear carnage of being surrounded by the dead soldiers. All alone, its when my mind started to break down. The beginning of my psyche breaking that eventually lead to so many other paths, ending with my erasing my memories.

Blake asks anxious, what did you find. My breathing was hard, I think I was sweating a little too. But I pushed through the irrational fear gripping me, I found the dead bodies of your parents. I saw Istra dead first. She was beside the river. Marina turns horrified, but doesn't interrupt me, then I found your dad and mom, Blake. I don't know why your mother was with him. Blake turns slightly pale next. I could still see their corpses, all bloodied and mangled. I say, I looked around to find anyone alive. But I didn't find anyone. Then I found Wagner and the last shadow women dead too.

My heart beats faster and heavy. I don't know if this a precursor to a panic attack. It could just be my nerves acting up. I managed to bring up some more courage, Wagner was dead with a Kuretine dagger in his heart. This past year, I have been having nightmares of him, more than anyone else. I keep wondering why he died like that, Echo didn't like to use our weapons. Actually, they couldn't use it back then. I have run multiple scenarios, someone betrayed him, or some Echo broke it off from a bigger weapon, or he just freaking killed himself.

My hand turns into a fist, but his death hits me harder than anyone else. I don't know why. Even with so much time in therapy, I can't get him out of my mind. I had once foolishly promised myself that I will kill him, no one else. I know it makes no sense and its completely bonkers, but it feels like my one real purpose was stolen from me. How could he have died like this, not by my hands. Its the regret and anger over my own strange desire, that is one of the core issues for my PTSD. Drew agrees with me. Its just that we haven't broken through the crux of it. Not yet.

As I explained the whole thing, it was dead silent in the room. It was just our breathings in the room. No, actually it was just mine alone. They both stopped a while ago and didn't need the air. What felt a long time in painful silence, Marina broke it, mom died fighting huh. She was one tough lady. I always wondered how it happened. She grabs her arm and stares to the floor. Blakes says, I knew my father was fighting the hive kings army. But mother was there too?

I nod. Blake shook his head dishearten, dammit mom. You couldn't stay away from the fight too, could you. After more silence of mourning I say, I am sorry. I should have told you both this earlier. I thought I was just sparing you unnecessary pain, but I was just hiding stuff for selfish reason. I didn't even told Drew about any of the identities of the Shadow members. Just aliases using their bloodline family name for enough context for the sessions. But it became a bad habit of mine to keep stuff from people, just because I judged it selfishly.

Marina says, don't be. I am glad you told me now. It was a relief to hear that from her. After a while Blake says, I am not sure if its better to know or not. Weirdly I understand what Catherine said about maybe not knowing was better. He sighs, time will tell I suppose. But I apricate you for telling the truth. I may find some closure in it. I was hoping that would happen for them. Marina asks, damn. Its so messed up. Sheesh. I need to think about something else, otherwise I might cry.

I know the feeling. She hurriedly closed her red eyes before any tears formed and opened them in a furry, distract me with something else. Anything. Blakes asks, I got one. Why not tell Vanessa the truth about Wagner. You are keeping way too much from her. I think this is why she was mad at you this morning. This can't be just about breaking her heart about Wagner, is it? He was right on the money. I had take a moment to be sure I was making the right call. I say, I haven't told this to anyone. Not Drew, not Vanessa and not even Siera. You both also are not going to say a word about it to anyone.

I have had them promise not to tell so many times. I just hope they wouldn't be annoyed by it. Thankfully they agree to it. I continue, I have a strong suspicion that Vanessa has been displacing her brothers memories with something else. I said it aloud, for the first time ever. It feels weird and guilty talking about this. Marina sat up, what. You mean she is faking it. I answer, something like that, yeah. But on subconscious level. I have tried talking to her about it few times before. Gently prodding and trying to find a way to tell her. But every time, I was shot down by her.

Blake says, same thing happened a while ago too. I asked her if the tournament winner would be the new crown. She glared at me like I was stealing it from Wagner and said no one can replace him. I didn't think much of it at that time. Marina says, oh yeah. Now that I think about it, she has been weirdly obsessive about him. She got angry with Melinda too when she told that story. But how do you conclude it from just this. I say, over the few months. I have been researching a lot more about memories and psyche. How they break during traumas and its side effects. I was doing it for me, but I could relate it with Vanessa.

They were listening intently as I continue, memory displacement disorder. Its a term when a person in trauma replaces or fabricates an entirely new memories of a person. Now, I don't think she fabricated memories of Wagner, but instead replaced happy memories from, like their parents, or friends or someone else and put Wagner face into them. This is just a theory, but I suspect this really happened. Marina, you said she was obsessive. That’s a classic symptom. I can understand if Vanessa was trying to preserve his memories, or maybe even just admiring his good qualities. But she has blind devotion and finds no flaws in him. That’s not natural, nor realistic. That’s beyond obsession or being starstruck.

I was terrified of what I was saying since I never said this out aloud. Maybe they say I was insane or would be skeptical about this. Blake asks, you really believe this. I nod, think it this way. Imagine how he treated you, and then try to imagine how he would treat others. Do you really think it was only you or me and not be at least rude to her, not even once. I don't buy that. Blake couldn't rebuke that. Because he knew I made sense. Marina says, dude. You cannot tell this to her. She will rip your head off.

I didn't have to think to reply, why do I think I never bring his name in front her anymore. I have my own issues with him, and I am pissed that can't tell any of this to her. I asked Siera a little bit about it, but I got the impression from her that there was nothing wrong with Vanessa. So I have stayed quiet. Trusting that in time Vanessa either begins to accept Wagner isn't a god or at least try to leave the past. Blake says, you have been keeping too much from people. Drew was right earlier, its talking a toll on you.

I can hardly deny it now. We stayed silent a bit contemplating so many things coming out. Blake says, I don't know if its true or not. But I understand why didn't tell anyone about any of this. But she is mad at you. What are you going to do about it. Honestly, I have no clue. So much has been happening that I can't even spare any thoughts on how to mend that relationship. I say, I don't know. For now, I can't keep being depressed about it. We got a lot of work to do in the meantime.

That jarred them both out of the heavy atmosphere we had for a while. I had calmed my nerves now that I revealed all that I had to say. Marina says, I sure hope you don't lie again to her. Because that would suck a lot. Yeah, that would be really bad. I say, lets keep this on the down low. I know I keep repeating myself, but do not reveal the identities of the Shadows or anything else we talked now. There are still many people who hold grudges on us. Adding these names to that list, even if they are gone, will break moral and sow distrust among people.

Blake nods, true enough. I don't know how people will react if they ever found about 3 bloodlines forming the shadows. Marina adds, or how their crown wasn't the person they thought he was. I nod, I would also appreciate if no one finds out that I erased my own memories. People wouldn't have cared about it before. But now I am getting the attention from the entire world. It will eventually get out, but I hope it happened after our city is united. I am glad that they expressed agreement for that request.

I got up and walk to the wall display, lets stop this depressing topic. As much as you all want to know more, lets table it for later. I tap the bottom screen and punch in the code to reactive M, we need to discuss about the mess I made tonight. Blake comes out of his brooding mood, agreed. Marina says, I guess. But I want to know more about my mom, okay. I nod, and I will. For now, I finish the code and M boots back up, M resume your system directives.

M's hologram shines in the display back, resuming all paused tasks. I get to my chair and face them, let me first tell that I didn't want to do the way it happened tonight. I tried calling you multiple times tonight. You both never picked up your phone. That made them agitated and pulled their phones out. Blake says first, seriously, but I don't see. He pauses as he scrolls down all the way down. Marina taps her phone to her temple, shit. I switched it off when I was surveying the land in section 4. I had some of the officers with me, so I must have turned it off to not be disturbed.

I scoff, just want kind of shadows are you both. At least you could have called me back later. I shook my head unimpressed by their lack of sense of alert. They both look guilty as hell. Blake was even more so, I can't believe this. I didn't even see your missed call among the ones from Vanessa and Tessa. Shit, I missed it completely. I figured they both were very busy, but at least they should pick up when one of calls the other. I say to M, install your alert software on their devices. I can't have us be not available when in deep shit.

Marina says, hey. Wait, what is this. She becomes confused when her phone begins to run something on the screen. I wave my hand, its fine. Just a patch that will bypass your phone setting, weather its turned off or silent. It will also reserve some battery for an emergency priority alert from any one of us. Blake keeps his phone on the table until the program completes, shit. I can't believe I was so careless. I should have asked something like this from the beginning.

Marina followed suit and kept hers on the table, but you could have reached out to someone else. I scoff, the patrol officers wouldn't be able to handle those 3 people. I even tried Vanessa. Hoping she or Tessa or some of the IDF crews would stand a chance. But she didn't pick up too. There is a small chance she basically ignored my call. I had wasted enough time for any backup. So I had to forget about calling anyone else and so I just went on my own. It was a reckless move when I couldn't use my Kuret, but I am glad I did that. If had waited for backup, Elina would have died. I barely made it in time myself.

I am sure they understood now that I did it because I had no other option. Blake shook his head, you know I was a furious with you for not telling me about this. But now I am mad at myself. Marina helps him out, don't take it yourself alone Blake. I was reckless too. I never imagined an emergency like this would have happened. We should really had someone keep on eye on David, like we talked about in the morning. That didn't help out the frustration Blake was feeling.

I sigh, lets not dwell on this. We just have to be more prepared. Blake makes a subtle nod, yeah. Sorry man. We should have been there to help you out. I raise my head at him, yeah. It would have made things easier. But anyways, it wasn't all bad. I somehow got over the mental block. Marina whistles, only you would use any situation to your benefit. But how in the hell did you get mixed up in this. Does danger comes to you naturally or you keep looking for it.

I laugh towards Marina's irritated expression, I have asked that myself so many times. Let me start from beginning. After a day spending time alone, I was tired and decided to visit a place I usually go to relax.

David (Chapter 79)

Tuesday, January 20, 2026 12:57

I explained how I have been disguising myself and been visiting public places all over the city at night. And lately, that place was frequently Elina's bar. I was not going to actually tell them that I was there for Elina. So instead I tell them half truth. Marina says shocked, scotch. You visit her because she sells the best scotch in the entire place. Don't you have your own stock at your house. And even if you don't, you can get it for yourself. Why go to her.

I could tell my weak accuse was not going to fly under a woman's intuition. I answered the half truth version, I also like talking to people there. You know, inebriated people, who are drunk with loose lips and open up easily to me. They are normal people, who aren't going to be intimated or bothered by my history. Blake chuckles, you sure that’s the reason. He was thinking the same. I shrug, I won't deny Elina was a friend, but yeah. Nothing ever happened between us. I was just a frequent customer of her. You can ask her yourself about a guy name Mack who was an IT guy.

Marina laughs, that’s what you went with. And she never figured you were a fake. I say, I can be very convincing when I want to. That made her dismiss any thoughts of my ulterior motive. To make sure they really don't get any more ideas I explained it was a process and Drew encouraged to do it. I only chose to do it under a different identity. After making sure they understood that we were just friends, I told them how Peter barged in and took off with them.

From here, I told them exactly what I did. I found his actions suspicious, no GPS on his car hinted at something very criminal. As I explained, they questioned me like I was witness to the event. Which I was, in a way. Then M played the recording from the conversation. Blake had a serious expression downed, probably trying to see if the events match from the interrogations he did with others. Marina looks at me suspiciously when the recording begins to show my intervention.

I think she just was skeptical about its authenticity. I don't blame her. Thankfully, from her on out, M had probably starting taking video too. M had a surveillance camera on me all the time once I smashed the EMF Kuritine. They both kept questioning my decisions and fighting style, for the time being I told them I had a reason. They eyes widen at my reckless assault on the three people. I actually hadn't seen this myself yet. I was amused at my own struggles. I kept making mental notes about the fight itself. My Kuret control was shoddy and inefficient. I was critiquing my own mistakes.

The little show ends when I see myself come out of the building, half carrying by the ART bot and drove off. I say, that’s enough M. I turn to face the two of them, they expression was a little nervous, like they saw some like of movie. Blake puts his hand on his chin, you tricked the hell out of them. Is this the whole video. I was confused, this is everything man. What's the point in hiding anything now. Marina laughs, this is even crazier when you manipulated the entire flag capture game.

I say, I won't deny nor confirm that. But, sure. I'll accept the praise from both if you want. Marina pouts at me for teasing. Blake says, Nathan was right. Only you be pull something like this. You know Cory was reluctant to talk to us. Even when Rose infected her with her Kuret. Now I can see why he was so emotional about this. This is first time hearing of this, you are talking about the same woman who tried to control us years back. I moment later something clicked, I see. Nathan and Rose were both there. They were assisting you with the questioning. That’s a good idea. But I am surprised you allowed them.

Blake sneers, I had no choice. I was desperate for some answers. I didn't invite them though, they barged in. Vanessa was ready to throw them out. I managed to make them agree to some terms and allowed them in. Marina asks, is she the one who can seduce men and control them with her Kuret. Blake and I both had a scowl now. I answer, to be clear, she can influence peoples actions. Not control. Blake answers, and not just men. Everyone. She just has better effect on men. Marina backs down by our sudden clarification. She knows little of our history with the Valley.

She says, I was just asking. Calm down guys. I didn't mean like that. Blake scoffs, anyways. Yeah, we got Cory talking. He pretty much told us what you showed. But shouldn't you already know all this. Seeing as you bugged IDF. Marina jerks up, you did what. Not cool man. And you think why Vanessa is mad at you. I cut in, hold on. Don't just assume things. I didn't bug IDF. What's the point when I can get the details from our own officers in IDF. Blake asks, don't lie dude. You sent a message to us exactly when Nathan called you out.

I nod, I said I didn't bug IDF. I bugged Peter. That made him back off. I say, I told you. I made a plan. I decided to tag Peter and let him go. I thought he would go somewhere, maybe to other members of the criminal smugglers, or maybe the people responsible for stealing the drug. I was certain he stole it at that time. His behaviors made sense, using his siblings as a cover. I put a GPS tracker on the bug too. I was constantly monitoring his every movement. But that plan went to shit when he just surrendered himself.

Blake was in deep thoughts and then speaks up, that was, he thinks for a moment, clever. Marina smiles, gosh. I wished if really led anywhere. I just want to kill the person who poison me. You sure he didn't contact anyone before he got arrested. I shook my, I was monitoring his every move. He just hid in a construction site all the time, not even the slightest hint of contact or any kind of message. It was a good plan, but I am annoyed that I didn't get the result I wanted.

Blake says, I interrogated Elina and Peter myself. I am very sure they are have nothing to do. I was interested in this and I asked him to tell what he learned from Elina and Cory. He told the two of us about Elina's injuries and the accounts of the story from her perspective. Turns out before I arrived the scene, they had been arguing the same thing repeatedly. I clench my teeth a little when he told she was crying at her guilt by not protecting Ryan. It wasn't her fault. I poorly handled the situation with Ryan. Blake believes she is innocent in this. And want I to believe that too. But I had a nagging feeling I couldn't put it behind me. Why was Wyan so sure she stole it from them.

Once he finished explaining Cory's interrogation I say, I also believe they were not behind the theft. They were just hired muscles. Marina becomes mad, let me have a go with them. They might not be behind it, but they must know who did it. Blake thinks for moment, I don't know if it’s a good idea. Marina stomps her fist on the couch, come on. I have been keeping it in for while, but I haven't forgotten about it when David told me in the car. One of them must have seen this client.

I say, you aren't wrong. While I have a strong believe none of them stole it for themselves, they might know something about the person who made them smuggle in the drugs. Marina nods, yeah. Exactly. You allowed Catherine to do her own investigation. Let me in too. Blake pulls a weak smile, I knew you would say that. He sighs, I couldn't stop her. Definitely don't have any right to stop you too. Just give me a day. Okay. I will bring you in once we get everyone's story straight.

I ask M, did anyone wake up in the detention center M. M says, 3 people have been woken up boss. Lance, Wyan and Jade had the least injuries had woke up ten minutes ago. I don't have the latest update on them however. Blake grabs his phone, which was done updating with the software patch. After a minute checking the network messages he says, they all are being interrogated now. And looks like Rose and Nathan are back at it again with Cory.

Marina asks, I am guessing you can't speed up the investigation by telling the whole story we just saw. Blake smiles at me, unfortunately no. As much as it pains for me to let us go through unnecessary witness questioning, we have to make it happens properly. Especially once we bring in Citradel in the loop. I think I know what you are trying to achieve my hiding your involvement. I got curious, lets hear it then. Marina and I listen to his theory, I bet you want to make it look like they had an internal struggle and basically self destructed. All the people, including the warriors, believe they were fighting each other. So even the people who brought the drugs would think that. Not realizing that we are on to them, following their trail.

He hit the mark. Marina asks, so is that it. I nod, yup. Its simple in theory, but it was pain in the ass to actually do it. You saw it yourself, I couldn't fight normally against them. All 3 were very strong. I remained skeptical about the plan until you just told what Cory thought happened. Blake laughs, I believe you. Talking on all three of them was definitely reckless. Marina nods, you got lucky dude. Don't get a big head just because you took the down. She was trying to make it look it wasn't a big deal, but I saw hesitation from her. I smile, thanks for your consideration. I know I was lucky.

Blake asks, anyways. What else you planned. It can't be just this, right. He was right again. I answer, you already know I took their phones. But I will return it to you. Once I have hacked into them and copied their contents, I will drop them someplace outside, inside a water pipe. The same pipe I broke the hatch from inside. Hopefully your team thinks it was the rouge bodyguard of Wyan that took it away, but had to leave behind for some reason. I will make it look like he had no choice but to leave it.

Blake scoffs, covering your own tracks in the process huh. Seems doable to make them believe it. I shook my head, no. Keep your hands clear of it. Don't steer the investigation in anyway that is not based on the facts. Marina snaps her finger, right, we don't want the people behind to know we know about this too. I say, exactly. You need to handle this like the mess it was earlier, before Nathan rudely opened his mouth. Blake giggles, he got you good huh. I wished Nathan would think before calling me out openly. I guess that’s the risk I have to take when dealing with him.

Blake says, I won't cause unnecessary intervention. I understand everything now, but you need to tell why you think the client who used them to smuggle the drugs, are the ones who stole it from them too. I say, M, open the information you found about the drugs. All eyes turn to the hologram forming in the middle of the table. M says, hers are the 3 drugs stolen, MCTL, Hetrox and Pesphinate. M showed the drug compound and its effects for them to read.

Blake says, Pesphinate was also one. But Peter didn't mention that one. I nod, I know. I heard your questioning. I think he just forgot about the last one. He was scared out of his mind in the hanger when I attacked them. Its best to think he is an unrealizable witness for anything related to the fight. Blake says, that lines up. His story didn't align perfectly with what really happened. Guess he was in shock. They both resume reading the details of the third compound.

Marina ask, Low boiling point. Would evaporate on contact to air. Is that why we didn't find this in the residue of the poison. I reply, exactly. We missed it. But read the rest. See for yourself something contradictory. She gets anxious reading the rest of it. Once they read, they caught on the subtle difference of the effectiveness of the drug. Blake says, this makes no sense. If this is correct, Pesphinate would have a positive effect on a Medrone. A mix of steroids, adrenaline and some other stuff that promotes energy consumption. Isn't this the opposite of what it did to Marina.

I point my index finger at him, that’s the contradictory part. Why would it cause a negative reaction to you Marina. Maybe a basic biological compatibility issue, could be. But a more realistic explanation is. I waited for her to come to that conclusion, the poison I got didn't have this. What does that mean. I explained, M had a digital sample of both your poisons. So she was able to find a find very faint traces of Pesphinate on the second poison. The one meant for Blake.

Blake looks to me, the poison for me was different. I nod, yes it was. Its virtually undetectable, unless you look for Pesphinate specifically. Actually, calling it a poison is wrong. This specific compound when mixed in the correct combination will produce a reaction that promotes Kuret production in Medrones cells. Of course, there will some damage by forcing your body to go beyond your natural Kuret limit. But it isn't life threating, at least not to you. So Isn't this strange. Poisoning Marina to make her lose, but forcing to max out your Kuret reserve to make you win. What's the objective from this weird outcomes.

They both are completely baffled now. Marin tugs on her hair ends, what's the point in doing this. I thought they wanted just take out me and Blake from the finals. But now it looks like they wanted to keep Vanessa and Blake in and me out. Blake realizes something, no. That can't be. He made the connection. Marina asks, what. I answer, it makes sense if the people behind this is not Citradel, but someone from the island. Its the only thing that makes

sense. They should believe that too now.

I laid it out to them in simple terms, I never told this before, but I had initially hypothesized that they didn't want the Citradel champion to fight at all in the finals. And that means, taking out strong contenders. Marina, you were a wild card. Since you were outspoken about joining us here, its very possible they thought you would switch side any time. So to make sure that never happened, they poisoned you for extra measure. Blake was a real threat to them, so he was targeted. Me and Vanessa were apparently not deemed a threat, so they us left us alone. Derek was connected to Kafar and couldn't switch sides. This is what I thought had happened. Until today.

Marina says, that’s rude. I wouldn't do that. I scoff, didn't you do something similar this morning. Marina rebukes, that's different. I didn't think it was that different. Blake says, but that’s not true anymore. If Citradel was behind this, they wouldn't want me to beat you and instead fight Charles. I nod, yeah. So that means Citradel can't be behind this. Someone carefully crafted the narrative that looked like we were being targeted and wanted Citradel to win. They almost got away too. If I hadn't heard about the drugs myself, I would still be looking into Kafar or Citradel.

Marina waves her hand, but even if that’s true. Why do you think its one of the officers who stole the drugs. It could be literally anyone. Blake answers, it could be anyone. But more than likely, its one of us. If you think about it, covering up crimes at this scale is impossible without help from the inside. Marina says, you mean they are hiding evidence. He nods, we recovered a stash of hidden weapons few months back. We still have no clue who got it. Now I don't know if it was bought from the same people, but something feels wrong here. How come no one saw anything suspicious. Not a single report. Marina says, when you put it like that it does makes sense that someone is inside. Do you think the boss works with him.

I say, doubt it. Otherwise they would be there too. And even if he has someone among us, why keep questioning Peter and his siblings about the stolen drugs. Its more plausible that they are not together. I didn't make the connection from the weapons found months ago. It may or may not be related. But I agree that someone should have seen something. They were giving smuggled stuff to their clients in public spots. And besides that, the water treatment plant wasn't just a perfect location. They held the meeting exactly when the patrols would be away. A literal blind spot in the city.

Marina says, I learned today that officers shits and patrols are scheduled and predictable. Couldn't they have just observed and figured it out from that. Blake answers, that’s what even more suspicious. The routes are scheduled. But we have a set of officers blended in the crowed, regular clothes and cars. You haven't been told about them yet. So to avoid even them, it means they know who they are and where they are at all times. Marina scoffs, you guys don't mess around with the security here. Whose idea was this ? She turns to me.

I wave my hand, I had no idea about this. Blake raises his eyebrows to me, I really didn't know. I left a lot of the internal mechanics of the city to others. Its a good idea though. He smiles, it was Vanessa's idea. She wanted make this place more secure than the Valley. If even you didn't know about it, that means it works. But then his smile drops, or maybe not since it got leaked to those smugglers. Marina asks, it still doesn't mean one of the officers is behind it. Blake answers, it still doesn't mean its impossible.

I add, either way, I believe that someone used Wyan to deliver them the drugs, but didn't want to pay or keep a trail. So they stole it from them to cover their involvement. We have their phones and the records will soon be in our hands, but that only gets us the people who smuggled in other stuff. Not the one we want our hands on. Blake says, so you think we won't find them on that data. I says, maybe something will be there. Who knows. Maybe even Wyan knows something. But someone went great lengths to remain hidden while poisoning Marina, juicing you, and using a secret criminal group as a patsy. I don't think they leave behind obvious evidence.

Marina asks, jeez. Sounds like it could be you when you say it like this. I smirk noticing the similarities. Wyan was good at this. But I can't believe he is good enough to do all of this. She asks, so what's the game plan now. They both turn to me for this. I shrug, I don't have one. Remember, I was banking on Peter to lead me somewhere. That was a bust. It was a spur of the moment decision, but I was betting on something to pan out from it. Blake says, what about the people we are holding then. They could be in danger. If someone knows something, they could be poisoned. We know they have the ways to make it happen.

That is real possibility, I concurred. Marina makes a depressing expression, so we need to guard these people. I rather see them dead. Her aversion this action was evident because it was personal for her. I added, best you get as much as information from them as soon as possible. The longer this drags on, the more danger it is for anyone. Those people behind this might retaliate in unexpected ways. Blake nods, that’s troubling to even think about. He looks to the floor thinking about his next moves.

Marina asks me, what about getting help from others. Surely we can trust some people to help us. I thought about her suggestion. It wasn't a bad one. If we were free to act on our own, we would be out there searching ourselves. However, we all have others work to do. We have responsibility and can't exactly move freely enough to do our Shadow work. And like Marina said, I did put Catherine as a distraction and bait. I said I won't stop her, didn't mean I wasn't going to keep an eye on her moves from afar.

I answer, we do need help. I can't deny it. If I didn't have a massive match coming up, I would have time to this myself. None of us are really available to undertake a untangling an internal conspiracy right now. Blake says, we should have people who we trust. I gave a better suggestion, better to find people who have zero benefit in sabotaging the tournament. Trust is a fickle thing, being on the receiving end from many people, I can assure you of that. Blake thinks for a moment, you mean getting someone from the Citradel. I nod, yes. If an officer is behind it, the safest bet is to look in other communities for help. Naturally, Citradel is good ally for this. They are merging with us soon, no reason to betray us now.

Marina says, if that’s who you want. You can leave that me. I know some decent people who we can actually trust. But what if they have people in Citradel too. She made another good point. Blake asks, we just have to pick people we really can count on then. Have very limited people involve in this. I add, just don't tell anyone of my involvement. I want to keep it hidden at all cost. Blake asks, seriously. Didn't you just talk about trust. I countered, didn't I tell Catherine that anyone beside us, more specifically me, might be a big target. I wasn't talking about just trust, I am worried to involve people who aren't trained like us. You involved Catherine, so I had no choice but to take her help, but asking others to get involved with me isn't exactly fair. I am always someone's target. Better me than others.

I hope this was good enough to make them believe my intention. Marina says, yeah. He is right, Blake. We are trained for this, and we can take care of our own. We both are already outed as Shadows, keeping David acting separately works in our favor. Blake wasn't convinced. I could the conflicting thoughts in his face. Speaking of people to trust, I think its time I tell them. I sigh, if you want some trustworthy people, why don't you have involve your new Shadow recruits. They seem to be skilled enough to work as a team.

Marina nods, yeah. Blake, we should use them. I have been thinking about it too. They are. She pauses and turns to me immediately with her jaw slightly opened. They both freeze up, their faces blank with utter confusion. Blake's hand slipped from his position. That made me laugh, what. Did I say something wrong. Blake asks, you knew? I say, that you both were already formed a new Shadow team behind my back. Yeah, I figured it out a while ago. Marina a gulps hard, what. Why didn't you tell us. I reply, I didn't want to interfere in it. I trusted you both were good enough to train them in our Shadow ways.

Blake asks, for real. Do you not know anything. I smile, if you are asking if I know who they are. Then I do. If I could infiltrate a Shadow summit as a kid, I can find their identities too. Marina shook her head, I should have known. We didn't tell you because you said you wanted time. I thought it was just because you just got your memories, but now I know it was more than that. I don't want you to feel like we excluded you or anything like that. She was panicking a little.

Blake supports her, with the past you did tell us about, I thought you didn't want to be involved in Shadows anymore. Neither of them were wrong. I say, appreciate it guys. Honestly, I do needed some time to figure things out. You know what's funny, since I always planned to quit, I never panned to groom a next Shadow. And I am the worst kind of teacher one could hope for. I am not oblivious to my own thinking. I know that I would demand high standards from someone I want to replace me. Plus you two must been shaping them for quite some time. I wasn't going to change that in any way. But I don't know how long you have been training them.

Marina answers, its been about two years now. Once I met Blake in Citradel, he proposed this to me then. Blakes says, I just didn't want our tradition to end like this. So we started to look for people during the year you were missing. In a perfect world, we would have recruited kids, but situation has changed. It's much better to recruit experienced adults instead. Marina leans back, you should have told us you knew dude. It would have helped with their training. Blake agrees with the her sentiment.

I say, I will now. I wasn't in the stable enough mindset before. I am still not completely. But once my match with Charles is over, I will help out in anyway I can. Blake asks, does that mean you will look for your successor too. I smile, that I will put on hold. I don't think I am ready for that yet. He says, fair enough. It took us a while too. Marina then gets excited, so. You know who they are. What do you think of them. I gave her my honest opinion, since you didn't know our Shadow history, you did what you thought was right. And I gotta say, they aren't your typical Shadow candidates. There is still room for improvement in their individual capabilities, but they do form a pretty good team.

They both sat up straight, they were proud of it. Marina asks curious, how do you know they are good though. I say, how else. I tested them during the tournament. If I were the mastermind behind that event, I would also see how good they work as a team. Marina scoffs, give it a rest will you. Everyone knows that was all you. I smile while Blake says, leave it. Its like a sickness with him. Just how long will he keep denying that.

I ignore their gazes, I observed their matches. Two of them have moves that were definitely straight from Shadow manual. It must have been tough to train in disciplines you aren't an expert in. Blake sighs, more like impossible. We know the theory, but not the actual practical training. We only guided them, the rest was on their own effort. I nod, they are good. I can help out them out too from now on. I have pretty good grasp on all different Shadow training. Hansen used to show me the sessions with all Shadows.

I turn to Marina, your successor. You pretty much chose someone whose Kuret was similar to yours. She nods, yeah. Funny how without knowing, I still stuck to the same tradition. Blake says, its obvious it would happen. If our family trained us, we would naturally gravitate towards Kuret that behave like ours. I nod, that did happen in a way. I don't have any qualms with your choice, Marina. He is skilled and adaptable. He does lack the power though, but its not his fault. Its not a fair comparison since very few can compete with you.

Marina flashes her teeth with a smug face, I am so relieved you said that. You know Blake has had doubts since beginning. Blake cuts in, hey. Don't say that. I was just concerned. He might be skilled, but he seems even more unpredictable than you. She replies, he is perfect for me to train. Blake denies it, oh come on. Not that again. You are unleashing another one of you. She says, excuse me. That’s is hella rude. I am guessing its not first time they debated like this. I say, must have been hard to do this on all your own huh.

Blake turns to me, it has been rough. Hopefully your involvement will make it easier. I say, but I am not sold on your successor, Blake. Marina slaps her hand on his shoulder, See, I told you. He wouldn't be fine with yours. Blake shoves her hand, of course you have an opinion on my decision. I ask, did you really thought I wouldn't say anything. Blake sighs, no, I guess not. It wasn't a something I did lightly. I needed someone who has the potential to have what it takes to be Shadow attacker. Means raw strength. You saw for yourself. Do you deny it.

I answer, skill wise, I don't have any issues. I am concerned is loyalty. You know who is constantly around us. What happens when there is a choice between Shadow mission and personal affairs. What will be prioritized more. Blake says, believe me, I had the same anxiety. But didn't you said yourself, Shadows need people with correct skills and judgement. Not their personality and ties to people. He got me there. I couldn't refute that reasoning. I sigh, I am not asking you to choose someone else. I just don't want history to repeat yourself. Even if you didn't know, your dad picked Wagner. Whatever his intensions were, it caused internal strife among us. I hope you know what you are doing.

He remained silent, trying to contemplate his actions with this new information. Marina says, since everything is the open now. Shall we bring them into the fold. I nod, I know their skills and effectiveness as a team. But not personally. But if you trust them, then I don't have a problem. They would be a valuable asset. Marina raises her fist and cheers. Blake was little bit excited too. I guess this is their first official mission now. Weird how in just one year I remember being a Shadow to training new generation of Shadow. Its a little strange to think about it. But it wasn't like I was doing nothing last few years. I might not have known I as a Shadow, but I was certainly behaving like one. However, the prospect of teaching someone is not in my forte. Don't know how good I can be.

I looked at the time and decided this is enough. I say, I think its enough for one night. I turn to the side, M, are the tickets booked. M says, I got you the first flight at 8 AM from Beijing. I say, that gives me around 6 hours of sleep. Well, I'll take what I can get. Blake asks, what was that. Marina asks, you going somewhere. I say, we are involving others because we are busy. You think I wasn't. I need to go and contact people to gather the construction materials Marina asked for. She becomes anxious, shit. I totally forgot about that. Do you have to leave today for that.

I lean back into the chair, its not as easy as you think. I need to meet my contacts and get help from them in person. Blake says, can't you do it from here? I shook my head, if it weren't for those bulk amounts, I could have managed. But getting everything in time means in need to move them fast myself. I don't like leaving things like this on you both, but I have to priorities this first. Blake says, can't complain since I had to dump this one on you first. I will authorize your travel for tomorrow morning. When will you be back.

I had a rough estimate, give me two days. I need to make 3 stops in 2 continents. I turn to Marina, I will get around 95 % of the total stuff you want. Is that be enough to get you started for a few days until the remaining comes in. Marina thinks about it for a moment, if you can get all of Platinum, then yeah. We get started while we wait for rest of the other materials. I say to M, adjust the quantities to priorities for Platinum first. M says, adjusting the algorithm. I turn to Blake, if you need anything from me, contact M on your phone. The software patch installed just now can also connect to her server. Blake picks his phone from the table and puts it in his pocket, got it. I will handle the investigation my side.

There was one last thing I wanted to ask them, before we call it a night, one more thing. I got from the chair and they both did the same from the couch, its more like a favor. Once I return, I will have to start my focus on my training. The last fight showed me that I am lacking severely in Kuret control and techniques. Marina asks, isn't that because you haven't recovered. I answer, that’s true, but its not just that. I have relied on physical techniques assisted by my Kuret. But now, I have hit the limit I can improve in this aspect.

Blake says, I think I get what you mean. You want to now learn Kuret techniques assisted by physical strength. The normal way Medrones train. He caught on pretty quick, I was able to turn my Kuret nature a little bit. When I fought Charles, it was the pressure of the match that made me unconsciously pull out new techniques. Tonight I tried them again, and I barely attained the Kuret form. It was a fluke during my fight with Charles. To get to that state again, I need to train like you guys from now on.

Blake turns confused, you want me to train you. I nod. Marina laughs, really? But isn't Shadow techniques are not based on Kuret. I say, I am not asking to learn Shadow tricks. I am asking for a sparring partner. I have always learned from others how to use Kuret. That hasn't changed. I think if you help me out, I can improve a lot faster than on my own. Blake takes a second to answer, this is unexpected. I can understand how it may seem to him, but I have roughly 28 days only. I have to get help to reach the level I need to fight an overdrive user.

I turn to Marina, I need your help too. Marina shocked shook her head, me? What can I do to help you. I say, I can use others Kuret because of you. I analyzed your overdrive from your matches. Using your charms, the markers of the Kuret bloodline I know, as a basis, I was able to pull off both gathering and firing off different Kurets. Marin eye widened and scoffs, you are joking right. That is not possible. I nod, normally it shouldn't be. But did made it work.

Blake turns to Marina, please tell me he is joking. Or did you help him cheat by using some Kuretine. Marina is bamboozled at this, I didn't do anything. Certainly did not him cheat. She faces me, show me. I smile, I would like to. But right now Kuret is burnt out. You saw earlier how weak I am right now. I will show it when I come back. Marina says, all right fine. But what help do you need from me if you already can do this. I say, I need to figure out a way to reduce the time to prepare it. I will explain everything later, but I know that once I show you how I do it, you can help me to optimize it.

Marina puts her index finer on her chin and scratches it thinking about it. I asked something ridiculous of her. No, both of them. They take few seconds to think about it. Blake asks, you want both of us to train you. In less than a month. Are you sure you will be able to handle such arduous regimen? Marina adds, we are talking about two different school of training. I answer, this is a lot. I can understand, but I need to improve on both fronts. I need to learn my new Kuret form, from you Blake. And from you Marina, how to improve my Kuret storm. So, how about it. While I am asking for your help, you might benefit too.

Blake chuckles, that’s actually enticing. I always wondered what it looks like to be, well you and train. Marina says, that is not good enough for me. I was one time a total naïve and beaten down many times when I was with James. She needed more incentive to join in, you know about your mom's charms book. I can. Marina cuts in realizing my intention, yeah, that’s already done deal. I used my Averna charm during the match. You will help me unlock those restricted pages, no matter what. Her piercing gaze is sharp and points to me, you can't offer that again. I smirk, let me finish. I will help you unlock those pages. But did you know there are hidden pages too. That caught her off guard. She closes in towards me and becomes grim, what do you know about it.

That’s a surprise, I didn't know she already had found them. Based on her reaction, she knows about it, not actually found them. I grab her shoulders and lightly push her back, chill. I know there are few forbidden pages. I don't know how many. Marina locks her eyes on me with ferocious intent. She blurts out, how do you know about them. I say, how do you think. Istra told me herself. I remembered a memory of her few months back. I was just a semi temporary apprentice at your home, but for some reason she told me about it.

Marina gasps, she showed it you. Why. I shook my head, she only talked about it. I have no clue why she shared it with me. Maybe she thought I would forget it. Or she was just messing with me. I didn't know at that point that she was in Shadows, but she knew who I was. That’s the best guess I can think of why she tell me about it. Marina punches me in the arm, why in the hell is she sharing family secrets you. I say, I know, right. I have no freaking clue. Marina face contorts in anger, first authorizing you to be in the ship. Now this. She crooks her head to the ceiling, Mom. You better have a good reason for doing this, otherwise I am going to tear that book in half.

I wish I knew why Istra did all of this. I can't think of any reason other than me being a Shadow strategist. Marina faces me back, huh. You win again. You are the worst. Taking advantage of me only when it suits you. You could have told me anytime during the match, but no. You waited this long instead. I wasn't going to let this one slide, hold on. I would have told you, eventually. But part of the challenge is for you to figure it out yourself. That in it self your training. Didn't you said so yourself. You wanted to do the challenge yourself. I was always going to be a guide.

That calmed her down a little. She then says, you think that makes it okay. I can't help it. I feel cheated by own mother. She sighs, so I guess you will only give me hints then. I nod, you guess right. Even though she told me about the 2 pages hidden, all I know is the location. She scoffs, that is already a big clue. Blake had been quite for a while, letting us hash it out. He asks, ah, just asking, how big is this book. Marina says, 1024 pages. And each page has a 10 sections.

Since Blake never saw it himself, he couldn't understand what this all really meant. But he still could understand that if Marina couldn't figure it out all this time, it was well hidden. He asks, is it safe though. The forbidden seems pretty dangerous. Marina waves her hand to him, that’s just a silly term to scare of my other members. I am very certain she has seen it herself. Though, it's probably only for people in my family who can overdrive. Isn't that right.

I shrug, don't know about that. She mocks, of course you don't. I ask her to confirm, so, can I count on you. She laughs, I guess so. You are just taking advantage of me though. She teases me about it, but I know she was very happy inside. I turn to Blake. He sighs, like I will back down now. I am in too.

This is good, I am sure I can figure out way to defeat Charles in his overdrive form now.

Vanessa (Chapter 80)

Wednesday, January 21, 2026 15:07

This is the latest reports of the latest interrogation, I have sent a recording to you as well, a few page note drops on the table in front of me. Ruther says, we got 5 statements now. I stared at it as it was added to the rest of the pile. Deni asks, let me guess, they claim to the same thing. He nods, same as others. Nothing new. I remained silent and looked away through my office window. The sun is setting down already. But the day is not over yet. Not until we mope up the mess that David as left us.

Last night, Blake asked us to keep his involvement a secret. Others were in agreement with him, but I wasn't. Blake was also frustrated that David didn't tell any of us. But then this morning, he told me and Tessa to forget about it. Obviously I couldn't accept this. I rebelled a little against his order because I was done with Davids' antics. He really is the worst kind of person. Knows everything about others, but keeps his own things private. I am not going to help him lie anymore.

My stance on this had made Blake uneasy, so he personally told me the situation. David had no choice when he raided the plant. I never once realized until Blake told me, but David actually had tried to reach out us. I confirmed it when I saw his miss call on my phone when I was busy. Turns out he wanted our backup before his one man army assault. He hadn't recovered fully, but since there were warriors involved and the patrol officers couldn't fight them, he had go in alone. I was too angry and so I just told Blake I will need time to think. As the day went on, I realized I was being childish. David is apparently hunting the guys who poisoned Marina and attempted on Blake.

With heavy reluctance, I decided this plan, to make the real culprits behind think they self destructed, was actually very clever. As much I hate David right now, he wasn't wrong. I was mad at myself, at Blake and Marina who got manipulated again by David. What's worse is that I know that David didn't lie, but I can't feel it this way. He can't keep getting away with this, lying when it suits him. Not trusting me when it suits him. After seeing Wyan's interrogation, all the little objections I had was gone.

Wyan tried to plead he was not involved and tried to blame on Grover who attacked him. At the same time, Grover blamed the entire thing on Wyan trying to cover his ass. We had enough evidence once others woke up. Their Kuret signature was all over the smuggled goods. Wyan had to knew he was going to cop to this sooner or later. It took a while, but he broke under Tessa's interrogation few hours back. He admitted to being the leader of their smuggling operation. But he is trying to get out from harsher punishment by making a deal by giving us access to the data. He was sure that no one can get to it, apart from him. Jade has the data, but he claims only he can access it.

No way we were going to play ball with him. So I had confined to his prison cell while we get to the records holding all the clients information. The reports I got from all the people say different views, but the same story. They were attacked by traitors amongst them. Few people claim that they were attacked by the warriors. But the most ridiculous part is that no one saw their faces. They are so scared and confused that they believed the Kuret attacking them were from them.

Nathan and Rose have been working on Cory this morning. They somehow broke through his mental resistance and fessed up everything. He told us how he and Polly were in close combat. I didn't believe him until then, but now. fully infected by Rose, he confirmed he was in fact fighting Polly. In the end Polly took him out. Until his confession, rumors going around some outsider involvement died down slowly. They are current working on Polly now to corroborate the story. Rose said she was today much more prepared and assured me she will crack Polly much faster.

I didn't even care about her ego, but I didn't stop her. The faster she works, the better for us. Now most of us focusing our effort on gathering evidence and catching everyone involved in this. This all his doing all right. That freaking guy made everyone believe people were fighting each other. Not just that, but if Polly and Quintin say the same story, people will slowly begin to think it was a internal struggle that resulted in mutual destruction. I had no choice after listening to people blaming each other and messaged Blake that I agreed to the ridiculous plan of theirs.

I thought nothing would make me madder when I had to accept David getting away with this. But then my mood turned even worse. Ned finally contacted me after lunch, with a voice message on the phone. I immediately deleted it. If has something to say, he better come to me and say it to my face. I didn't want others to see me distracted with personal things, so I have been focusing on this case. I don't know if I am making it worse by doing ignoring it, all I know is that Ned is too stubborn by keeping his distance. I am trying hard to see his side, but I just can't think why he is behaving this way. I know I was in the wrong first, but he is not blameless too.

Somers asks me, are you listening Vanessa? This pulled me out of my mind. I ask, sorry. What. Sommer was standing with Denu and Ruther behind the table. Sommers asks, I was asking if you listened to the reports I sent about the searches we did of their houses and their work places. I pushed those meddling thoughts and got my game face back on, yeah. I listened to them. We recovered nothing that lies to any other smuggled stuff. But Jades apartment was booby trapped, is that right.

He nods, clearly she thought it would be destroyed if it was anyone but her, but we got to the floor safe before it activated the trap and disintegrated the whole floor. Ruther says, these guys are very resourceful. They used and electrical jamming Kuritines earlier, and now its Corys rotting Kuretine. They have some serious backing from if they are able to create such unregulated Kuritines. I lean back on the chair, they are no doubt the biggest group of criminals we caught. Deni asks, did we though. I know I have been asking this many times, but are you sure we shouldn't have a team looking into who beat them all up.

Since I promised not to mention David here, I have to switch everyone's focus instead. I didn't want to lie to them, so I been telling them that Blake and Marina have been looking into it. I say, do you doubt the Shadow team can't figure it out. She clamps up, no. I don't mean that. I am sure they are good. But they are busy themselves. I just wanted to end this thing quickly. Even during my lunch, my friends keep asking about this. She wasn't alone, the entire IDF has been swarming with reporters and concerned citizens.

Blake had addressed them all in front of a camera in the morning. Explaining the facts, and ensuring that this is an isolated event which is already contained. People don't have to be worried about it since we have everyone already in custody. He didn't give any specifics, like what they were smuggling, or why were they found unconscious. I proposed Peter as the fall guy. Blake said no since we can't exactly say how Peter remained unscraped when warriors were gravely injured.

It wouldn't be difficult to frame him. No, actually. He is really the root cause of all this mayhem. He may not have stolen the drugs, but he got his siblings involved. I am very sure David had to step in to save their lives. I tell her, I know its frustrating. But we have no proof that anyone was involved. Yesterday, that was me and Blake just guessing as we got info from Peter. Once we found the mini safe with their phones in the site, I decided it wasn't worth the effort to look into it now.

David must have took it with him, copied then contents and then dumped in the water pipe in the middle of the night. He meticulously placed it inside a water pipe part of an elaborate escape attempt. Roland told us how he found it. There was some destruction in one of the control rooms. It looked like someone tried to escape, which we know now, it was Kiera. She was fighting Polly at the time, or so she claims. Roland thought that like her, people might be using similar escape routes and investigates all the water pipes. That’s how they recovered all the phones.

Somers says, true. But its very suspicious. Roland team found the broken hatch, signs of a struggle and the safe box inside. But seriously, why would anyone leave it there. Isn't it important. Ruther says, someone tried to leave with it and failed. We have a guy saying he broke open the door and got dragged back in by Quintin. It wouldn't surprise if those three initially beat all the people and then fought each other. Deni cuts in, I don't believe that. Cory says he didn't attack any other person.

Somers says, I don't think he is reliable. He lied about Wyan ordering him to hunt the traitors. Wyan says he didn't. All I know its very strange about the inconsistences in the story. I sigh. David really created a big mess by confusing everyone, not just those criminals. People have been speculating now that we have listened to many of the people in custody. What's incredible is how he wiped his fingerprints off this completely. Even I come out and explain this, how am I going to refute that Cory and Polly fought for real.

While they were arguing over a little, I cut in, that’s enough guys. They all stop their chattering and face me. I got up from my chair and say, the bottle line is, until we get some evidence or at least some kind of clue that someone else is involved, I don't want to waste time on this. So, is there any shred of evidence apart from the circumstance itself. I knew there was none, but I laid it out so that they leave it alone. Three heads shaking confirmed it.

Honestly, I really want to find one. So that once I prove it that it was David, I will publicly lash him out. I know it goes against David's plan, but if he left evidence for me to find, then his plan was never going to work. Plus, I only agreed to not reveal David's involvement, I didn't agree to suppressing or hindering the investigation itself. That might teach David to not mess with me again. I ask, all right then. Lets get to cracking their phones and the records. Where are we on that.

Ruther says, everyone's phones are heavily encrypted. Its taking time to get in without triggering any failsafe. We are requesting for some additional servers from the other departments. With additional computing power, I have got an estimate of 12 to 18 hours. I rest my hands on my waist, its going to take that long huh. I guess it’s a waiting game for now. And what about the hard drive we recovered. Sommers says, that is even worse. X rays shows that there is physical traps, like an acid kill box inside it. We make a wrong move and it will destroy everything.

I click my tongue, so that’s why Wyan is so smug about this and making it look like he is holding all the cards. Deni says, we can't take any deals from him. I agreed, and no one will. What are the options. Sommers says, we are exploring none Kuret options for now. By using human tech, he has made sure we have very slim chance with any Kuret being effective. But still, I have asked everyone here to look for any personal who knows any Kuritines or a Kuret user that can do this.

I ask, are you searching for any civilians too ? Somers says, I wanted to ask for your permission first. Right now I am looking only for officers and others in the administration. I began to weigh the options and say, do it. But don't approach anyone if you think someone can help. Just tell me first. I will talk to Luther and then involve others. Sommers pulls out his tablet and types in the order to his team. I turn to Deni, where are we in finding others who are involved.

Deni opens her tablet and says, apart from the 11 people involved, we are suspecting 8 more. We got 3 of them and brought them in an hour ago. I scoff, let me guess, the five others are in the wind. She says, for now. We know their names and checking with their friends and families. They got nowhere to run. I am sure we will find them tomorrow. I say, we shouldn't take any chances though. Inform our border team to have double shifts. Some are guaranteed to try and break though the barrier we setup.

Ruther chuckles, good luck with that. No ones ever escaped through it. 14 people have tried in the past 9 months, and all of them failed. I say, I know. But we never know. I am not going to take any chance. Just pull in more people for few more days until we catch all of them. Deni taps her tablet, all right. I will inform the team. Sommers says, you know, this is no doubt very bad for our reputation. Not knowing about such a smuggling operation going on. But I think we will turn it around soon, seeing as we caught every single person involved in one swoop. We can turn this into a very good win and make Citradel see our worth.

I smile. Blake is planning to do this exactly. Our effort to rush this faster before people start coming let to possible advantage. Ruther says, yeah. That’s good. But don't forget we still have a lose end. One the client used the

drugs to poison Marina. And someone stole it too. Deni says, I bet one them did It are still hiding it. Why don't we have Rose interrogate them. I stop her, hell no. I am going to use her only on the warriors. No one else. Her presence is already bad enough and I am tolerating it for now. She and Nathan may be good at this, but they completely unpredictable.

They couldn't deny that. They have only heard stories about the Valley, but if they had seen what I had, they wouldn't want them here too. Sommers says, I figure you wanted to keep it that way. Nathan had asked earlier to Dan about the same thing and I to not allow him. I answer, keep it that way. If one of them did it, they will soon give up. We still have 4 more people unconscious, lets see what they say first. Sommers says, I think its Elina who stole it. Wyan is still claiming she stole from them. I don't see a reason for him to lie when he is already caught.

Elina and Ryan have also been detained. Blake said they are victims, but we couldn't let them go. He think David theory is very convincing, but its possible Elina is still involved and maybe even working with the people who stole the drugs. I didn't find anything strange about her or her story. Regardless, they both are still associated with Peter, so we can't let them go. I ask, what's Elina's condition now. Sommers says, her injuries are healed completely once we called Janathan. She has minor internal sourness, but we have confined both her and Ryan to a safe room. Are you going to question them.

I have been thinking for a while now. But because I had a different agenda. Blake said David tailed the criminals because he was following Peter. I didn't believe it when he told he knows Elina and has been visiting her all this time incognito. Just what kind of bizarre coincidence it that he happens to know the sister of a smuggler. I don't know if this was just a coincidence or David is playing at some angle. So I have waiting for an opportunity to visit her. I have finished most of my work, so this is the best time to ask her some questions.

I nod, yeah. I want to be alone with her a some time. She might respond better if I am talking to her alone. He nods, all right. I'll set it up. You want to go in now. I tell him, in 30 minutes. I have an meeting with Luther right now. So go head and inform her I am coming. He asks, just her or Ryna too. I gave it some thoughts, is he responding to us. He shook his head, he is barely talking to Elina. He refuses to leave her side. Ruther says, poor kid is terrified out of his mind.

I say, okay. Lets not agitate him. I will talk to him too. Sommers nods and we all disperse from my office. They all head back to the IDF, while I takes the stairs to the 3rd floor to Luther's office. As I reached his door I hear voices from inside. I knock on the door, he calls me in. Tessa and Roland were here also sitting in the couch. Luther stand up from his seat, thanks for coming in Vanessa. I wave at others and take the space beside Tessa, sorry if I am late.

Luther slides his chairs to us, not to worry. They were giving me a report before our meeting. Tessa asks, any luck with the hard drive you guys recovered. I say, like everyone suspected, it his not only encrypted, but also has fail safe with acid. So, its going to take a lot of time. Rolan puts his hand on his head, damn. That’s hard core. Luther asks, are you sure you don't want to even entertain the idea of using Rose and Nathan on Wyan or Jade. So this what they probably called me for.

I refuse it, I already told I am not going to allow it. I already hate it that I owe them for doing this much. I don't want their help. If I did take it, and it somehow worked, they would just mean I owe them more. That’s infinitely worse. Luther makes a slight scowl, you too huh. I was hoping you would help change Blake mind too. He also doesn't want to involve them more. Just what kind of history you all have that makes them so untrustworthy. I say, trust me, if I went on, it would take hours.

Tessa backs me, she is not kidding. I was with them only for a little time before coming her, but they barely were a team. I say we are lucky Nathan is on the island, let alone inside the building. Her impartiality make Luther even less confident and raise his hands in defeat, fine. I had to try once. We will try with Rose's other bloodline members. I was okay with that. Roland says, could you send some of them my way too. I am finding hard to get information from two people in particular.

Tessa asks, let me guess, you are still stuck with Grover and Perry. He nods, yeah. We got details about the fight, but I know they know more about the people who are on the run. It would help if I could them to reveal it. Luther turns to me for confirmation. I say, yeah, no issues here. Luther nods, all right. I will ask for some volunteers. Tessa says, Roland, lend them too me too. I'll take a stab at Wyan too and try to get him to open the hard drive. He makes an okay gesture with his fingers.

Luther asks, lets move on to the next topic, tomorrow we are going to have conference call with Citradel at 10 AM. They know some of the details of this incident, but we haven't officially told them anything. Vanessa, can you get all the reports Blake asked before then. I was expecting this to happen, yeah. I can get it done by then. Luther asks, what is left on your plate. I answer, we already discussed about the people on the run and the hard disk. If you guys can handle it before morning, then that’s taken care of.

Tessa says, I will try my best. Roland says, I will catch them, I promise. I say, then the only thing is left getting statement from the 4 people still unconscious. I have asked to wake up the one woman from the Citradel first, so that we will have her involvement confirmed. Luther says, good idea. Citradel can't remain blameless for this miss too, he forms a small smirk saying that. I figured we want to make sure they don't blame us solely for this. Well, they can't exactly do that since Quintin is directly involved in this. But this just hammers in the nail on the entire criminals from Citradel.

I say, next, about the warriors. We are haven't Quintin to also admit his role in this. I believe Nathan and Rose are on Polly, but they should be finished soon. I am allowing them both to remain in IDF the entire night. Tessa says, they are okay with it. I shrug, they also know its important we get the warriors talking before we talk to Citradel. Nathan said he liked the challenge and Rose, well, she just wants to show off. I'll have two people watch them all night. I don’t care there reasons, as long as they keep Quintin talking.

Luther nods, all right. We need those 3’s complete testaments. Its essential to prove they were doing this for their own gains and not someone else. I continue, and for the last report. Unfortunately, we are nowhere close to finding who ordered those drugs involved in poisoning Marina. I know that’s very important, but aside from the hard disk with the records, we have no other lead. No one in their gang knows the identities of their client. Luther says, damn. I was hoping there was something else by now. Marina was this close to breaking into the prison cell and beating the crap out of them. She was so mad, that I thought she punch me when I told her to give me some more time.

I smile, best to her meet them. I start with Peter. Roland shook his head with a small laugh, don't. The guy almost pissed his pants when Blake grabbed him. If Marina gets his her hands on him too, he might jut shit himself. Tessa says, I say let her. Wyan too. That would get them talking. I was so glad that they were on board and pressured Luther. He says with a smirk, thankfully I am not going to decide that. She is a spit fire, and I am going to let Blake make the decision.

He made the right call. Keeping her away from this when its so personal to her would be a mistake. She and Blake are Shadows, both together in same room would scare every one of them. I ask, what about the request Sommers made a while ago. Luther says, oh. Right. He pulls out his laptop from the desk and opens it. He types on the keys while reading on the display. A while later he says, done. We are going to get all the servers we can to IDF right now. Hopefully that will speed up the hacking the devices.

Tessa says to me, I want to take a stab at Elina again. I say, actually, I am going to see her soon. I have some question of my own. Let me know what you want to ask her. She says, that’s great. I can focus back on Wyan again then. She then clears her throat, I got the list of all her shipments and their dimensions. I need to how much of them is really hers. If we can't get the smuggled items from the hard disk, at least we will get some clues on the size and amounts of the smuggled goods. Who knows, we might lucky with some item that stands out and cross reference with other people owning them.

This was actually a very good strategy. She says, admittedly, it’s a long shot. But its better to try this than just wait. I want to use this as a leverage at Wyan. If I get even one of the smuggled items, we will make him believe we hacked into the hard disk and his corporation is not needed. That will shut that smug face of his he has kept all day. I smile. Tessa doesn't get worked up often, but even she was hitting that limit when dealing with Wyan. I nod, all right. I will have Elina look at the list.

Tessa offers me some advice, I already showed her the list before to confirm the shipments, but have her view it differently this time. Also, see if you can keep Ryan away from her. I feel for the kid, but he keeps interrupting Elina. I answer, I heard he isn't talking. She sighs, he has not. Roland says, I would like to know how he got out of there. Peter said he found a door broken open to escape, but how did Ryan get out. I am very sure he is suspecting something so I ask, you think something happened.

He nods, not just me. Tessa here also thinks someone helped him. Peter didn't help him, Elina was bleeding out and everyone were fighting each other. No one said they tried to help Elina or him. He is in complete shock now, but I bet he was too when back then too. I know you said that we didn't find any evidence someone else is involvement. I am guessing he knows more. Luther asks, you still believe a group of people went in attacked the place. He says, I refuse to believe it was internal conflict ending in mutual destruction. Its too neat and tidy.

I am a little conflicted here. Blake didn't tell me everything, but it’s a good guess that David was the one who helped Ryan get out of there. If that’s true, then Ryan might know it was him. I wanted to avoid taking to the kid, because then it will be official that someone was really involved. Despite that, I made a decision after thinking a bit more. If he calls out David, fine. Let him. I don't care if this messes up David's plan. He doesn't trust me, well touché. I don't trust you too.

I say, want to tag along with me then. You can try to talk to Ryan while I speak to Elina. Roland became interested in this. He looks at Tessa who says, sure. But try to be gentle with him. He says, yeah all right. But you know, we have tried the carrot for long enough. We need try stick now. Don't worry, I am not going to force him. But its bloody time he understands the situation he is in if he doesn't talk. I add, just don't accuse him of anything. We all might suspect Elina, but I hardly believe he is involved too.

Luther says, I agree. Don't push the kid. It would be bad we cause any distress on him and Elina stops cooperating. She has complained us enough times to leave Ryan alone. Roland nods, I am only going to ask the hard questions everyone else are resisting to ask him. He was right. Its one thing to sympathizes with him, but at a certain point that has to end and answers are needed. I don't know if I made the right call. Maybe Blake will get angry with me on this. But I am already prepared if this somehow leads me to piss on David's plan if he gets outed now.

I say, if that’s all. I will get ready to meet Elina. I got up from the couch, Roland follows me. Luther says, just one last thing. Blake is giving you a deadline with the hard disk. If we can't get it open by tonight, we need to hand it over to him. I asked confused, what. Why. Tessa stands beside me saying, I am guessing he wants to open it before talking to Citradel. He tells with a defeated look, that’s right. We really can't go in without knowing who all the people are involved in this. We don't know if there are 100 people or only 10 people who have used this smuggling service.

I understood the impatience. But I was a little confused what would Blake do with it. Then I realized something I really don't like, does he plan to give it to David. My teeth grit a little with a sudden anger. I am not giving this to him in a silver patter. We do the hard work he gets to swoop in like he is so great. Did he not get it himself because he knew we would ask for his help. I won't give him the satisfaction of this. Luther says, not David. He wants try opening it with Marina.

My anger left as fast it came in. I am relieved to hear that. Tessa says, how would they get it open if we can't. Luther says, how else. They are freaking Shadows. If they can't do it, then who will. Luther has always been a little infatuated with Shadows. Its not like they are magicians. But they do have the best chance, okay. That’s fair. So we have about 6 hours then. I get some more people to help out. Roland says, hey now. This isn't a competition. I rebuke him, I know. But it wouldn't look good on us if we weren't able to do it, but they somehow did it.

Even Tessa understood that, you know what, I kind of agree with her. We should not be complacent just because they are here. Now even Roland could see the bigger picture, that would suck. All right, we better hustle then. Luther says, honestly, I did want David also helping us. But he left this morning. I turn to him in confusion, huh. He isn't in the city. Where he run off too. My retort made him pause for a second before saying, he has gone to collect the materials for the expansion. Apparently, the Citradel requirement is quite high and we don't have much of it here. He is the only one among us who has a vast human network. I guess this task is difficult for him too, so he had to go himself.

I murmur to myself, so he bailed on us while letting us handle his mess. Luther asks, what was that. I says, nothing. Just wondering if he took anyone with him. Luther says, we authorized his sole travel. Are you by any chance worried about his safety? Because I was. He may look fine, but I bet he hasn't recovered fully. I opposed him leaving alone, but Blake said David didn't want anyone. I wished he would take someone with him for some extra protection. A lot is riding on him with his match with Charles.

Tessa says, its fine. He is more in his element out their than here. He can take care of himself. Tessa knew he was involved yesterday. Did she think that if he can take out 3 warriors all on his own, he is fine. I wasn't sold on it. No way he remained untouched from that. Even he would have struggled a lot. Luther says, lets hope so. He is supposed to come back day after tomorrow. I ask mocking him, and what about the materials. He is going to carry them.

Luther says, no idea. I am supposed to get some sort of import schedule from him by tonight. I have asked Tina to handle that. I know its not fair, but I was hoping he stayed away for more days. It felt good knowing he isn't here. Like everything I do now is somehow not under the palm of his hands. After that we all go our separate ways. Roland says he will join me a while later after he prepares a little. While I takes the stairs back to my office, Tessa comes behind me.

She says, don't think I don't know what you are doing. I ask her blatantly, what do you mean. She scoffs, you want to expose David's involvement. Don't you. She guesses right. But I wasn't going to show that on my face, what do you mean. I am doing what Blake said. She shook her head, you know. Being mad at him won't do you any good. You want Roland to question Ryan hoping to get him reveal it. I say without any hesitation, I did that because we want to what happened to Ryan during the time.

She shook her head, fine. Lets go with that excuse. What's the point in keeping a lid on this, if you let others do it. I got a little irritated, I agreed not to tell others about him. But I am not going to hinder the investigation just because of Davids name. If Ryan says his name, so be it. Not like anyone would believe him, right. I was blatantly mocking David now. She sighs, I was wrong earlier. You are way too emotional about this. Maybe you should take a break. I laugh, please. Now that David is not here, I feel a more relaxed. I was worried that he might leave us with another mess. Not anymore.

I know I was being totally unfair and ridiculous. But I didn't care. I was now going to openly state my thoughts a bit, he always has some convenient excuse and gets away with this. He just left after creating so much chaos. I understand the plan is to find out who is behind the curtains, but he decides everything by himself. I am not going to do anything to hinder the plan, but I sure as hell won't trust David to handle this alone. Tessa doesn't say much more and just leaves to her office.

Was I being too harsh. Maybe. Was I wrong though, not even a bit.

Vanessa (Chapter 81)

Wednesday, January 21, 2026 21:42

I knew I shouldn't have made Tessa tense when I said the things on my mind. Because she most definitely warned Blake, who was coming to IDF now. Me and Rolan were waiting for him before entering the safe room. Roland says, do you know why he is coming to observe me. I thought he had other work going on, you know with the Citradel meeting tomorrow. I didn't have answer for him. What can I tell him, he is probably going to convince us not to pressure Ryan into revealing David.

I know I scared Blake, and he probably is going to reprimand here. But I was enjoying a little. If he is coming personally, that means Ryan definitely knows something. I tell him, maybe he wants to see if Ryan lies or hides anything. He is kid after all. I gave him a plausible answer which he mulled over it. We waited for few more minutes and then he walks in through the door. Beside him came Ruther, shall I get you a coffee too. Same kind. I thought he would looked panicked, but he seemed calm. Must be just giving us a poker face.

He laughs, thanks. But no. I recently got a taste of something earlier, and can't get enough of it. Ruther says, I knew it. You have a different machine in your floor, right. Can we also get it. He says, that's not what I meant. He turns to us now, hey Roland. Vanessa. Thanks for waiting. Ruther looks a little sad he didn't get his answer, but he left us alone anyways, let me know if you guys need anything. And Roland, don't pressure the kid too much. He sometimes makes a tantrum until Elina calms his down.

Roland says, yeah. Yeah. I know. Jeez, he has made everyone so on edge. He taps his palm on face, gotta get into a character now. Blake says something that makes me remove my cross arms, good luck. Hope you get some valuable information from him. Roland takes a moment, oh. I thought you were for Ryan. Blake raises his eyebrow, must be a mistake. I came to observe Elina. I got a good read on Ryan before. Sorry if you thought it was him. I am more interested if Elina can help locate any client with a smuggled stuff.

Roland smiles, yeah. Makes more sense. That's actually a relief, I was under a little pressure thinking you wanted to find out who was involved. I couldn't believe what I was hearing. Is he really going to not stop or obstruct Roland from this. Blake nods, really. Am I that intimidating. Roland says, dude. You got aura man. I am not talking the Kuret kind. They both chuckle like there was no tension. Blake says, we have no evidence that someone was involved. If you can get Ryan talking, it will be great.

Roland becomes relaxed knowing Blake wasn't here for him. He says, I got some tips from a friend on to approach him. With that he leaves to the room first and to get Ryan out. I look at Blake with a confused look. Blake eye twitches, why are you looking at me like that. Did I say something wrong to him. I ask, what did she tell you. He behaves clueless, who told me what. I don't believe this. Is he behaving like this on purpose. I ask, aren't you worried that Ryan might identify David.

Blake understands something, oh. You mean that. Don't worry about it. Ryan doesn't know anything. Did you really think David would go to such lengths to hide his presence and forget about Ryan. There's nothing to worry. I am speechless. My rebellious and anger emotions gets replaced with something even more. Embarrassment. I was so sure about this and acting so haughty with Tessa. I ask him, um, how sure are you. He looks around the empty hallway and whispers to me, pretty damn sure. David had the whole thing recorded. So me and Marina got to see everything. Honestly, it was quite a show.

All my hopes were crushed in an instant. Then came even more shame. I was looking for some revenge against David that never existed. I want to kick myself now. I ask, then why you came here. He answers, I was always going to come here. I thought Tessa wanted to question Elina, but she later she message me you are coming instead. This is so not a good reflection of me. Here I was enjoying showing my personal rebellion. I don't think Tessa even warned I brought Rolland to try and get David exposed. What was I even trying to achieve here.

He asks, what did you want to ask her though. I let out a sigh to clear out my messed up emotion. I shouldn't let him see my petty nature. I wasn't expecting this, so I didn't have any clever lie. I had to tell him the truth, honestly. I was going to ask about David to her. That put a damper on his face, you what. I say, not as David. But as a poser. I want to make sure if it was really a coincidence if David happened to at her bar, and at the right time. He asks, as opposed to what. You suspect David has ulterior motives with her.

I wasn't really expecting Blake to be here. I couldn't just say that I was just scratching a curiosity. He sighs, Vanessa, I know you aren't happy with him. But it wasn't his fault. It was a freak coincidence. He told he visits other places as well. You can blame his bad luck that danger follows him around. I say, But don't you want to know why he keeps coming here. Maybe he already had suspicion about the place. Maybe he was onto Peter from the beginning and hide it because he was ashamed he didn't do anything about it until now.

I blurted out some excuse from the top of my head. I hope Blake would be convinced enough with this. He then looks at me for a moment. Like he was observing me. It then went for a lot longer. It was my turn to ask, what is it. He finally says, this may sound weird. But are you feeling all right. That was a strange question out of nowhere. Did he caught on to my rambling. Or did he saw something in my aura. I played clueless, just tired. You and Marina agreeing with David is making me worried a bit.

He says, so it has nothing to do with your brother and David's reasons to accept Charles deal? I ask him immediately, what did he say about my brother. Tell me now. My sudden switch in voice caught him off guard. He clears his throat, sorry. I was just curious. He didn't tell me much about his reasons about that. I just thought to ask If you knew more and that's why you are mad at him. I reigned back my eagerness and back down. I say, nothing useful. That's what makes it me furious. He doesn't trust me at all. Not like how he does you all.

He remained silent. I think I have made the atmosphere awkward. But he was the one who broached the topic about Wagner. Blake says, I am not going to make excuse for him. But just do me a favor and keep an open mind when he does tell you about it. I feel like he is defending him. I sigh thinking David got to him real good. Just want kind of trick he did to make Blake understand his actions. I ask, you still haven't told me what all David said. I bet he told you more than just yesterday attack.

He asks, what makes you say that. I say, you and Marina seem a little different. You seem fine now, but in the morning you and Marina had a face that was like it was burdened. You were distracted for while. I am sure others did too a little. Blake simply says, we were tried and slept late. Try grilling David for answers and you will feel the same. That's all. I ask, really. Even Marina was behaving strange. He asks, she is always like that. It was hard to point out. It was Marina, her mood is very hard to say. I shrug, that's all.

He smiles, I think she is just trying to contain herself. Imagine if I could lose control on Peter, how hard it is for her to keep her hands away from him. I am just glad you allowed it finally. I am going next to her and try to make sure she doesn't kill Peter accidently. I thought that was the case. But maybe something was bothering her too. I set it aside for now. I say, I guess. Well, lets forget about that and focus on Elina. He says, all right. Though how are you going to ask about David, while not asking about him. I say, let me handle that. He nods.

We waited for Roland to message me that he took Ryan to the adjoining room. After I got the message I say, you coming in too. He says, I already questioned her. Best not to pressure her. I will listen in from the monitor here. There was still some part of me that thought he would try and stop me exposing David from Elina. But he wasn't fazed at all. I am really making a fool out of myself now. I enter the room and see Elina siting on the chair.

She was fearing much better since the last time I saw her this morning. She had a jacket on her. We got their clothes from home a while ago. Thought that would help them feel more comfortable. She stands on her feet seeing me, Vanessa. I reply, hey Elina. Don't push yourself. Stay seated. She says, I am good. I promise. Jonathan helped more than enough. I feel fine now. She did seem in good health. All things considered she is better, even though she almost died yesterday.

I nod while checking out the bed with a bad with her clothes in it. I say, I know its not ideal, I hope you know we have to be thorough. We will have to keep you here more longer. I thought she would argue over it. But seems like after hours of interrogation, she has understood the gravity of the situation. She says with a sad face, I know. Your officer, Ruther, kept saying its procedure. Honestly, I was furious before. But I had time to think. I guess I was being over protective of Ryan.

I say, glad you understand. There's nothing more I want than to end this investigation. We are still in the middle of it all. So just bear us some more time. She sits on the bed looking tired, Peter really freaked us. Didn't he. I was seeing a different side to her now. I ask her, how is Ryan. I take it's a good sign that he went with Rolland. She says, barely. He is still terrified. I have tried best to calm him down. Are you sure you can't send him to my neighbors. They have babysit him before and I am sure they can help out again.

She is still persistent. I am a little reminiscent of their bond. Wagner would get worried about me too. I say, I wish we could. But him not talking has made it difficult. She asks, its not his fault. I reply, I never said it was. But like Ruther told you, its procedure. Besides, even if we did send him. He would just throw a fit being separated from you. She sighs, I don't want him to see my pathetic side. So that's also a reason for her. I guess its not all that unrealistic.

I ask, has he told anything to you. She turn forlorn, he has asked a bit about Peter. I didn't know what to do, so I just told him that Peter is fine. She looks to me, he is fine, not that I care. I nod, for now. Have you decided if you want to see him yet. She grabs her arms like she is guarding herself, I don't know. I think it would just mess me up more. And confuse Ryan. I say, he did surrender himself. She spats out, only because he knew he screwed up big time and has no where to go. No love lost for her older sibling here. Her anger was justified. I didn't want to agitate her more, so I got straight into the task at hand.

I ask, Elina, I have to ask some questions. She was in a slightly better mood than I thought. She unfolds her arms and lets them rests on the bed, I know its important. So fire away. I gave her my tablet that had the list of her shipments on the display. She took it and gazes at it, I know this list. This is all the times I ordered my liquors. I nod, that's true. But now I am asking you to go through it again. This time try and remember if there is any shipment that is bigger than it actually was. Maybe we can track that to the smuggled goods and hopefully to the people who bought it.

Elina says, I see. That's smart. Get something that more than necessary volume. Give me a minute to check. She is eager to help out. She must really want to help us get her and Ryan out of her. She went through the list multiple times. But it didn't look she was getting anywhere. I ask, is there a problem. She says, no. I don't remember all of my orders, just trying to figure out which one Peter could have forged. I ask, we tried to match Peter's forged hand righting with yours, but he got it pretty good.

She hesitates a little saying, I should be able to tell which one was my own, but he copied mine well. I am having time figuring out my own handwriting. I say, take your time. Its a long shot anyway. You might not remember all your orders. I hear a small laugh from her, believe me. I am trying to recall all of them. I am meticulous about it. And being here has just amped me up more. That's why its me making mad that I still can't figure it out. She is taking this a little harder. I offer some advice, look. I have some experience in being betrayed by people I know. Its not your fault.

First Nathan and now I am trusting less and less David every day. I don't know if its fair to say he betrayed me, but I feel like it was. He puts her tablet down in frustration, damn him. Its not just betrayal. I wasn't keeping on eye on my own business. He was bringing in profit, so I feel like a turned a blind eye to everything because of that. I feel such a fool. I wanted to assure her she wasn't wrong, it's just men are devious. They do whatever you can to manipulate you.

I was laying a little bit thick now. Hope no one picks my own bias in this matter. She says, its still unreal that this happened. I hate Peter for roping us in to that group of people. Just what was he thinking bring us to a dangerous place like that. I was almost killed and Ryan could have been hurt. And the coward just ran off, leaving him alone. I am glad he is fine, because he want to kill him myself. Her anger was boiling more now.

I turn towards the camera and signal not to note that remark. She panicking seeing me gesture, wait, that was just me being mad. I wasn't being serious. I don't know why she would think we serious about her casual remark. I say, don't worry. Everyone knows you would be justified to feel like this towards him. Actually, many people are waiting in line to get their chance with him. That was just so that they scrub off some of the remark before we send the transcripts it to Citradel. She looks confused, so I explain, there are Citradel people involved. So want to have complete transparency about this situation. That means handing over all our investigation and reports.

She was still nervous, don't worry. It was just a precaution. I am sure they won't held you accountable for your brother's actions. She relaxes a bit and settles down. She says, let me take a look again. He resumes her search. Few minutes went by and then she shrieks, wait. This one. I remember now. It was just before the semi's started. I ask, you got something. She nods excited, this one. I think I only ordered 3 dozen bottles, but I think I saw more than that. Peter has marked it as 5 dozen to cover it, but I know feel their was one more crate.

I can't believe this actually worked. I ask, you sure that’s Peter's and not yours hand righting. She nods, I remember it now. I definitely wrote 3 dozen in 2 crates. I would never go overboard on that that day. I remember that. She pauses for a moment and stares at me. I ask, what. She says, ahm. She was fidgeting a little bit before coming clean, it was the day you and others lost in the tournament. I remember serving only 3 dozens of those particular brand on that day.

I smiled a little bit, though there was a little sting, don't worry about it. It was a match. Someone had to lose. She says, sorry. I remember it clearly that I anticipated a lot of people coming in that day and prepare it with this amount specifically. She seems confident, so did we really catch a break here. She says, look here, it clearly says 5 dozen. She brough the screen to my view. But I look away, great, just mark the date and crate details for me. She pulls it back to her, shit. Sorry. You are dyslexic, aren't you. I totally forget.

I turn back to her, don't worry about it. I am used to it by now. You are struggling much more than me medically. She pulls out a weak smile as she taps the screen, I still can't believe I am alive. Even a paper cut causes me a lot of trouble. While she scribbles on the tablet. Then she looks at me for a second, you know. I was rooting for you to win. You gave a tough time to Marina. If only she didn't use that overdrive, you would have own. She was clearing trying to cover her previous blunder. But regardless if what she thought was really true, I say, thanks. But I was outclassed by her. Everyone saw it. That makes her smile a bit and releases the tension she had.

I thought asking something. I know Blake is looming at me, but I had to know. I ask, do you remember anything when you blacked out. With her eyes glued to the screen says, sorry. I have don't recall anything. I remember Ryan voice near me, but nothing else. She finished marking it and hands over the tablet to me, here you go. Sorry, I only found this one. I am not sure about others.

I say, this is good enough. We have a lead. But in case you remember anything else, let Ruther know immediately. She replies, I will definitely try to recall more. I continue, great. If this helps us catch a break, it would help to you get of out of here. A wave of relief washes over her. She had been waiting for long to hear this. I ask, coming back to my question. Doctors were amazed you survived. Do you know if anyone helped you. I was poking the bear lightly. I can't believe I am prodding for something myself so blatantly. She was already prepared, likely due to beings asked about it already.

She says, I heard about it. Honestly, it’s a miracle. I was surprised myself. If Ryan hadn't gotten me help in time, I would be dead right now. There wasn't any sign of hesitation or lie. Not like I can be sure by seeing her aura. But it doesn't feel like she is hiding it. I had to let this one go. I say, you were lucky no doubt. You got help, just in time. Just not from the person you think, I said internally. She smiles weakly, I try not to think to much about it. I have never been in a fight. It is sucks hard that the first one was so terrifying. For Ryan as well.

Everyone first time is bad. She was really unlucky to have almost died. She then says, I got some checkup from the doctor this morning about my psych eval. I didn't hear the results. Am I showing any severe symptoms. Its amazing she is cognizant of being aware of her own state. I ask, for someone who hasn't seen much violence, you seem more together. I have seen people crumble under the trauma. She says, trust me. I will have a major freakout later. I am just toughing it out for Ryans sake.

That is actually commendable from her. I answer, I think the doctor just forgot about it. I'll let them know to tell you later. She says, thanks. Also, you don't need to tip toe around me. I know you are just trying to keep me calm. I told you, I am good. I can answer any other question you have. Her attitude is also good. I guess a days worth of rest helped her. I say, just a second. I walk to the door and open it. Blake turns to me and I hand him the tablet, mind giving it to Tessa. Best we get on this immediately.

He takes it from me, sure. Also, try be a little inconspicuous when you ask about him. I rather not ruin the plan on the first day itself. I still can't tell what his angle is here. Does he make me to expose David or not. Did he really thought David is untouchable even without his help. I was even more determined to squeeze out truth from Elina. I say, I got this. I don't know if he believe that, but he walks to the other door. I have a few minutes before he comes back. With him gone, I won't be pressured to not ask things I want to ask.

I head back in to her patiently waiting. I ask her, I am sure people have asked you. But has any suspicious person approached you. She says, if you are asking about Peter's criminal friends, then no. I was shown their photos earlier. I never seen them before. I ask, okay. Does no one else pops out. She was shaking her head. I prodded a little more, maybe some customer who was keeping on eye you. She asks, why would they do that. I answer, maybe to make sure their orders don't go missing.

She says, but if that were the case Peter wouldn't have brought me to them. They would know I didn't steal from them. Damn, she is quick to grasp things. I feel like a fool making such excuses. I say, true. But covering my basis here. Could be that whoever keeps an eye on you is one of the people on the run and didn't vouch for you in time. I made a better and plausible argument now. She understood this one, I see. Yeah. That makes a lot of sense. I guess its possible. Lot of people come in and go. I don't have camera in my bar. I never thought this would happen.

Its probably why David chose her place. No surveillance. She thought my silence meant I was suspecting her. She anxiously says, I know I should I have gotten one. A couple of my friends of mine insisted it many times. I should have listened to them. Stupid of me. She blamed herself. But I saw an opening now. I ask, yeah. It could be one of your friends also. Do you suspect anyone. No matter how innocent they seem, they could be one of them. She thinks hard at this question.

She answers, I don't think they would be involved in this. I am a very good judge of character. Her eyes drop a little, I guess that’s not true anymore. I couldn't tell my own brother was a smuggler. I was getting a little impatient, focus Elina. Dig deep and search for the guy who is still lying to you. My intense glare cause her to be nervous, you really think one of my friends were faking it. It could be. Good, she is getting closer. She asks, but aren't you looking into everyone I talk to.

She is good. She had enough wits about her. I say, we are. But you have a lot of customers. It's not going to be easy track all of them down. I dropped even a bigger hint to her now. She picked up on that, one of them. Nah, I don't think so. How would they know about my orders. I say, maybe not directly. But they could have bugged you or something like that. She becomes even more nervous now. I need to stop gaslighting her. I am only terrifying the poor woman even more and making her paranoid.

What the hell was I trying to do to her. I grit my teeth in anger. At myself. How much longer will I do this farse. She mistook my anger as impatience, Vanessa, I am sorry. But I really can't think of anyone. I wish I could. That was my limit now. I say, don't apologies. I was just looking for something suspicious. I didn't want to rattle you. This is my fault. I can't believe I let go this for just for being curious. She sighs, I can't believe how my life turned like this. I have to wonder who I shouldn't have trusted.

I decided to just leave now. I am only stressing her out by my pestering. I say, don't think like that. You are not being treated like a suspect right now. She nods, some of all must be wondering it. And I don't blame you. I was so blinded by the cash Peter was bringing in. I should have just took my friends offer and made him an investor in my bar. He would have found out my mistake for sure. This was unexpected opportunity. Do I dare push ahead. My curiosity got better of me, you wanted someone to be your partner.

She looks at me confused, oh no. That's nothing. Its just something we both joke about. He is my friend, from before Peter told me about his side business. He isn't involved in this, I can guarantee. Oh, is she now talking about him. If so, how is she so confident when he is lying to her. I ask, I see. So he might not be involved, but its best not to overlook anything. What's your friend name. She becomes a nervous for some reason. Now this is suspicious, what is it. You said he isn't involved, right.

She bits her lip, I don't to get trouble him into any trouble. He is a really good guy. I was almost beginning to think she must be taking about someone else. She says hesitantly, I like him a lot. I don't think he would be involved in this. What is this, did she have a crush on this guy. Is it David or not. I curse at him. He didn't tell Blake his name he was using. So even I don't know if she is talking about him. I ask, I can see you care about him. I am not going to accuse him without any proof. You are not going to get him into trouble.

She was still concerned. I tried a different approach, you said he wanted to invest into your bar. So he as money right. Maybe he made if off the smuggling. Maybe he is guilty for using you and giving some back to you. I gave her enough reason to doubt. She would definitely have some sort of doubt in her mind. I hope Blake is not back already, because I am definitely goading her towards David. This accusation puts her at even more uneasiness. She finally says, not him. I know him. We flirt around and tease each other all the time. I know how he makes his money, and he definitely doesn't spend for guilt. He just uses it as an excuse to be around me.

I am so confused now. Is she talking about David or not. She says, sorry. I am just rambling. You don't want to hear my personal life. I swear I could see her embarrassed now. Its killing me not being to not openly ask if its him. I ask, just give his name. We won't even question him. We will go through his profile and see if anything is suspicious. I didn't want to dangle this in front of her, but I was becoming desperate.

I point to the other room, if you can help us out, we can get you and Ryan out of here much faster. That dirty emotional push made her give up. She nods, okay. Anything for Ryan. But you will see, he is a really decent guy. His name is Mack. Don't know his bloodline family. He works in the tech support. All I heard was Mack. It is him. I am know it for sure it now. David said to me during the flag capture game that if had an option to change his name, he would pick Mack.

I finally got him. But then my heart dropped. What the hell did he say to her to make her so faithful to him. I wish I had my tablet with to me to do a search. I will do that later. First I need to learn what they are to each other. Am I really going to expose David here? When I just promised Blake that I won't. I didn't care about it now. I ask, thanks. We will do a background search on him. Hopefully he turns to be how you say his is. She responds, he is. I have no doubt.

This is sad. He has wrapped her on his finger. I ask, you seem too much attached to him. I am not saying that’s suspicious, but what if he turns out to be someone he is not. I am border lining this question so that people don't assume I am hard pressing her. She unexpectedly smiles, oh I know he is keeping stuff from me. It wouldn't be surprising if it turns out if his name isn't Mack. This bamboozled me. What. I don't understand this. I ask, are you serious. You trust such a dubious guy. She smiles, I know. Its weird. I told you before, I have decent grasp on people's character. He told he is private person and may be using an alias. I chewed him out for being so cautious, but I learned he doesn't do it because he was to hiding something out of ill will.

I waited for her to explain. She says, but why do you want to know. I am telling you, he wouldn't betray me like this. He might lie and laugh, but he is good at heart. He always has a reason for whatever he says. A new raw pure emotion evoke from within me. Jealously and hatred. On David. And on her. What he hell is going on here. What kind of wool has he put over her. I had to control myself from shouting out her. She is being manipulated by him.

He is toying with her.

But how exactly. She herself admits he is lying to her. How in the bloody hell is she okay with this. I had a nagging feeling how. Should I ask her. But that’s not appropriate. I will definitely be crossing a line, if I ask her this. I can't be ask her about her private life so suddenly. I am so conflicted that I might my fists tighten in frustration. I ask, you seem so close. You sure he isn't your boyfriend. I asked this instead. She looks at me with strange look. I bet she must be thinking I was being too forceful.

She opened her mouth to say something. Then suddenly the door opens. I turn behind and Ruther rushes in, hey. Sorry to barge in. Blake just pulled me in, saying you wanted me to run background on some guy. He came with a tablet in hand. Damit. Blake was here. He read my aura and figured I was going too far with this. I nod, yeah. Search for a Mack from tech. Ruther looks to me and then to Elina, that’s it. No family name? Elina says, he said he doesn't know his bloodline and doesn't want to. He has a condition that makes him unable to use Kuret. I kept asking him to at least get his Kuret tested, but he didn't want to. Said it doesn't matter, as long as he gets the job done.

You know what frustrating, he didn't lie anything about this to her. He mislead her big time, not a blatant lie. She really has a crush on him. Or Mack. Its hard to figure out if David was playing a character. Ruther says, whoa. Not able to use Kuret, guys got issues no doubt. Lets see. He begins to look for him the database. After a while he says, that’s weird, no Mack here. Are you sure his name is Mack. For the first time there was crack in that confidence. I knew it. She was blind to Peter, and now she was being blinded by David.

She shook her head, I told you. He might not be using his real name. Can you search again please. I nod to Ruther and he tried once more. As more time passed by, Elina became more anxious. To the point her palm turned to a fist and grab the cloth over the bed in anticipation. Hold on. Is this right. I might expose David, but I would also make her even more miserable. She is already suffering due to Peter. Am I so vain that I am going to break her, just to prove a point. And for what.

Just then Ruther says, got it him. Turns out Mack was a nickname. I turn to him shocked, you found him. It had be a fake identity. Nothing else makes sense. Ruther says, yeah I did a broader search and got a hit on Macklerington. Says he joined the island around a year and half ago. So he has been here among the first citizens. No criminal actions. Single, lives in section 5. Works in software, building his own apps sealing it to people. Nothing wrong with his income too. He smiles, the dude is not in debt, but he isn't raking in too much money too. I don't see any recent suspicious transactions, not like we found with others.

David crafted this whole fake identity. Elina says, wow. I see now why he wouldn't tell me his full name. It’s a mouthful. This is not happening. She is falling for someone fake. I grab the tablet from Ruther and raise it in front of Elina, is this him? Elina leans in closer and says, yeah. That’s him. I put a bit of pressure, you sure. She says, we are friends for months now. I think I can recognize him well. She was being witty with me. I think even she is getting irritated my continuous pestering.

I gave the tablet to Ruther, call him. He asks, excuse me. What. Elina stands up, wait. You promised you wouldn't accuse him. He just said there is nothing suspicious. Can't we keep him out of this. I really don't want to get him tangled in my mess. I was painfully aware my own selfish behavior. But I have gone to far to back down now. I say, I know what I said. But he sounds too suspicious for some reason. I turn to Ruther, just call him and but don't tell him you are from IDF.

He was caught in the middle of something. He looks flustered and asks, ah, fine. But what should I say. I ask, say anything. Say you are a friend of Elina and asking to see if he has seen her. Ruther was so confused by my rush. I was doing it purposefully, because any second Blake is going to barge in and shut this down. Elina was beginning to me a annoyed look. I deserved her enraged eyes, I am not denying it. Ruther sighs, fine. I guess no harm in checking him out.

He opens his phone and types in the contact number. Two things will happen, either it goes to David, or the line is dead. I tell him, on speaker phone. Ruther puts he phone in front of me as it rings. Every ring was like my heart beat. But then it connects. It has to be David then. Ruther asks, hey, is this Mack. A very familiar voice speaks, yeah. Its not David. The voice was different, but very similar to David. I am so lost right now. Ruther says, hey man. I am one of the temps Elin hired few days back. I was just wondering if you know where Elina is.

He says, Elina? Why. Is something wrong. Elina slumps back into her bed. Ruther says, oh man. You know. She didn't open the bar today. She and Peter went somewhere in a hurry, and feel he is involved in some shady stuff. So I am beginning to get worried about her. Apparently Mack is angry, you mean they are still not back. I knew her brother was no good. I should have warned Elina. I haven't heard from either of them. Okay, this had to be fake. Or David hired someone to pretend to be him.

At this point I wasn't going to rule out anything. I gesture Ruther to say something. He understood my intent, where are you now. I feel we should go to some officer and report it. Mack says, for sure. I like visiting her bar, be shame if something happened to her. Where do you want to meet. I just thought to have dinner at section 2. We can meet there. This had be a decoy. David must have someone pretend to be Mack now. Ruther was little clueless since I was speechless.

Then another person enters. It was Blake. I had taken it far enough. He whispers something to Ruther. Then he says, thanks man. Just let me try to get out of this shift. I will try to contact you. He says, you sure. Okay. Hit me up whenever you can. He ends the call. Blake asks, is this Mack. Elina nods, he sounds a little different, but yeah. Ruther says, his phone GPS says he is at home. Everything checks out Vanessa. I don't see any connection to Peter or anyone.

I am so quiet, I could cut myself with it. Blake takes over me, we can eliminate one potential suspect now. Elina, thanks for the your help today. I am going to try to get you and Ryan out of here soon. Elina says, thanks Blake. I promise if I remember anything, I will tell you all. He nods and signals us to leave. I follow him out with a lump in my throat. This is nuts, did he really hire an actor with a real job. Once we got out Ruther asks, do we bring in him for questioning.

Blake says, good question. What do you think Vanessa. He was obviously calling me out here. I am so damn confused and angry. I managed to say, just send officers to his place. Do a routine check on him, nothing too intrusive. I can't help but think this guy is hiding something. Ruther says, really. This guy. He looks at his photo in the screen, I don't see it. Looks like a regular guy. Just because he is friends with Elina, doesn't means he is involved is he ? We have talked to the rest of her friends. Blake corrects him, he is more of a customer.

Ruther says, right. But still, what is it that you don't feel right about him. I had no answer. No justification. No reason. Just petty revenge. Blake says, just do it. And quietly. Maybe she isn't sure herself. Ruther scratches her checks, ahm. Okay. Then I guess I will go myself with some patrol officers. You want me look for something specific. I shook my head. He says, all right. I might as well have dinner there too. With that he walks away. As soon as he left, Blake grabs me by the arm.

What the hell is wrong with you. I get you don't want to lie for us, but this, you didn't have to do this. He was angry. He was every right to be. I couldn't even shake off his hand off me. I am so mortified by my actions. He says, you know. I wasn't going to say this. But you are messed up. Angry at David, at me, at Elina. You are angry at Ned too. Don't think I haven't noticed that. I was now feeling more guilt. He let goes of me, what exactly was your plan. Keeping digging until you prove that Mack is fake? That David is using her ? Or you wanted to hurt Elina ? Tell me.

I managed to blurt out, sorry. I got carried away. He spats, damn right you did. He sighs, you don’t trust us. Well, now I can't trust you. I look at his furious eyes. He was being impartial earlier. But now he was berating me. He continues, you know what. Just finish the reports for tomorrow and take tomorrow off. I'll others that you are exhausted too much or something like that. Take a break to get your shit together and then come back. I couldn't believe he was asking me this, are you benching me. Really. When things are so dire.

He says, you leave me no choice. I didn't think you would try to use Ryan like a leverage to use her. It was harmless, but I shutter to think what you might do next. I close my eyes in shame. He says, besides, your work is almost done. After tomorrow, it will be mostly cleanup. Might as well take some time to cool off. Between Wagner's rumor and your behavior now, you might just go ballistic on the next person. I open my eyes trying hard to not let them get moist. He was right. I am thinking clearly, not when I am can't let go of things.

I didn't give him any answer as I walked away to the door.

Blake (Chapter 82)

Thursday, January 22, 2026 12:18

I am sitting in the conference room, my legs shaking anxiously. This has to gone as plan. We have prepared as much as we could to handle any accusation or demand Citradel makes of us. I take sip of my second cup of coffee and talk a look at tablet nots I made. The door opens and Luther walks in, you got in pretty quick. I says, I have been here since 6 AM. He laughs, you need to relax. We got this. I scoff, I will relax once this whole ordeal is over. He has a snack on his hand and takes a bite of it as he takes the seat beside me.

I glances over my notes. I push it to him for his opinion. After long through it, he says, this one. You sure about this. He see the line he was pointing. I say, don't you think its better this way. Citradel hasn't join us, I rather not give with our people. Let them focus on only theirs. Luther nods, I suppose. But I would at least have them the transcripts and reports. I thought about this compromise. After mulling over it I say, okay. I scribble it on the screen, if they push for it, I will offer them this. But not before.

He agreed, that works. He then says, I don't see any issue with the other things. But have to ask, were you able to hack into the hard disk. Sommers was very reluctant to hand it over last night. You know, between Marina and him, I am getting cornered by you warriors. That made me chuckle, don't worry. It's just a little bit of ego. He says, tell that to them. But anyways, what's the latest on that. Yesterday I had given a deadline for the IDF to work on it. Even with the extra resources, they couldn't open it. They did have an option, but it was way too dangerous to try it out.

Others may believe me and Marina are working on it. But the truth, we gave it to our Shadow apprentices. I don't feel good about it, I basically pawned it off to them. But I told them in all honestly what I was asking and why. Thankfully, they understood the situation. In fact, they were glad to be finally active now. It helped a lot when Marina jumped the gun and told them that our Shadow strategist is ready to address them now. So far they only know he existed. That lit a fire under them.

I say, me and Marina working on it still. We have something going on in the background. Lets hope it pans out. Luther looks at the time, any idea if that happens in the next 2 and half hours. I wish I know. My hesitation got him an answer, understood. Well, in case it doesn't, you okay to go head with that response. I nod, yeah. I don't like it, makes us look weak, but I rather say this instead of lying. The idea was to say that since Citradel people are also involvement, it has caused us to be more careful. Arguably, that's a pretty weak defense, but it's not a lie.

I say, we will handle it when the time comes. Lets go to the next action item. He says, all right. David got in touch with Deni around 4 in the morning. That me made alert, and? He smiles, he did it. I was skeptical about this. But dudes a bloody magician. He says he got everything we wanted. He gave me his export schedule and a plan to get it into the island. I tilt my head in joy, that's awesome. At last, some good news. Now we don't have cover anything on this front. Luther says, you said it. I was a little uneasy on how to handle this if it David hadn't pull through with this one.

I still can't believe him. Even when so much going on with him, he managed to priorities this. Me and Marina are still feeling a bit of all the massive truth bombs he threw at us. Even now my thoughts keeps drifting sometime to our discussion. David being messed up yet again due to a woman. My dad and her mom in the Shadows. Our history intertwined with Shadows. The real Wagner. Him knowing everything about the new Shadow recruits. I still can't believe so many things remained secret for years, for decades.

We were at least in the comfort of our homes while processing it. But he was on the move constantly. He might actually be more at ease outside the island too. People are gunning for him everywhere. But at least he has more resources the out. Luther says, one thing though, he can't make to the meeting. I know you wanted him here. Tina said it was unavoidable. He had issues on his side and it delayed his return. I don't know when he will be back, but its not today.

I say, if that's a compromise we have to make, its not that bad. Luther shook his head, I don't like it. He is out there, all alone. Aren't you worried about that. People did ask me yesterday why I let him leave alone. I didn't have a good enough reason for them. David was very cautious of any officer right now. And so was I. I tell, you have to ask him. He just put it off saying that if he needs protection, he is not worthy to be fighting Charles. That's pretty much what I have been telling others.

He smirks, I understand that sentiment. I guess there's nothing I can do now. But its not all bad, I got him to agree to join in the call. He said he will figure out a way to join. With that settled we moved on to discuss other topics. After going through some political stuff, we arrive to the nitty gritty ones. He says, Vanessa handed me all of her reports. I was very anxious about her. I may have been too harsh on her. No, I chided myself. She was out of line. She was not talking to Elina, she was making her miserable. Regardless of what Elina thought of David, I had asked Vanessa not to force David's name. I don't know what exactly she wanted from Elina.

And oh boy, I can't believe I never noticed that behavior from her when I mentioned Wagner. Its like one of those things when someone doesn't notice it unless they are aware of it. David might be actually right about her. And on top of it, she and Ned are still fighting. Catherine told she still hasn't met with Ned. Not even once. Far from me butting in their relationship, but hasn't it gone long enough. Catherine said she was going something similar, so she sympathizes with her. I couldn't muster to ask what's up with Rob and her. I thought she would be happy now that David would stop meddling between them. At times like this, I am glad I am not in a relationship. Its not like don't want one, but its not the right time.

I ask, all in order. He says, yeah. We got all the statements from everyone now. Including all Citradel people. I ask, and Quintin. He taps his tablet, all ready to be shared. You sure you won't to go through them again. Its quite an interesting read. I say, I am sure it is. Nathan has been talking to everyone nonstop on how he got them talking and what they said. I feel I already heard it multiple times. He says, that is that right, with a light chuckle. He says, I didn't hear about it. I guess it must be just recent.

It was a little white lie. I already know what happened, saw it from the horses mouth. But just to cover my bases I did a quick glance at the reports now. Luther says, honestly, its nuts they all fought each other, believing each other to be the traitor. And since Wyan is not talking, we got to assume each of them have their own agendas now. David's plan was working. He caused so much confusion and made a narrative for people to guess themselves, its turned everyone into an unreliable witness. Some of them blame each other and some blame Wyan. Since they all were arguing themselves before David stepped in, its became even more chaos as everyone wants to save their own ass.

There are people, like Roland, who still believe someone else is involved. But no has any proof. So they aren't willing to force their opinion on others. After going through this, I ask, and how about Elina and Ryan. Did you find any connection with them. Luther scratches his head, none. As you know, Roland finally got Ryan talking. And we thought, he doesn't know anything. He doesn't even remember how he got out. Just said he was cold and everything was black.

I think he might be referring to the bots cold metal and David's Kuret. But there's nothing tying to him. I knew there was nothing to be worried about it. That's why I was more interested checking on Elina. Aside from the lead that Tessa is trying to follow, Vanessa may have agitated her a bit too much. She was a little different ever since Vanessa talked to her. She is little more annoyed at her being questioned, again and again. Somers send a message this morning that she was little incorporate too initially with another round of questioning.

I shook my head. I should have stepped in much earlier. I didn't realize Vanessa was prepared to expose David's fake identity this far. Even more surprising is that David somehow already had a real guy, with a real job, house, the whole package. I was sure he was a decoy, but then I along with Sommers report, I saw Ruthers. He said Mack was at home when he came by and nothing looked out of place. I am still confused about it. Did he take an identity of a real guy as his disguise. Bue the real Mack spoke about Elina. I don't know everything, but Mack has no apparent connection to David. Just what kind of illusion is this.

Its amazing and I wanted to know desperately how he managed this. I just have to patient until David returns. Luther interrupts my thoughts, Elina has grown tired of us, I think. I figured he would notice it too, she is still cooperating right. He hesitates, on paper. But I guess the shock of her almost dying is wearing off. I won't be surprised if she demands to be released today. And she would be right to ask us. She mentioned to Somers in their last discussion that they have not found any evidence on her. She has been transparent about everything. Its been 3 days now. I am also beginning to think she is innocent.

Vanessa rattled her a little too much. I say, what did Vanessa suggest. He says, not much. She went home early last night. Said something about taking an early dinner. I am waiting to talk to her today. Yeah, good luck with that. I basically ordered her to cool off. Even if she comes in today, I will force her out. I can't predict what she might do next when I am not looking. Soon others started to arrive. When Tina arrived she told me the latest updates on David's travel. He will be in a private Jet when he joins in the call. He travelled in public to avoid suspicion, but apparently, he was in Saudi Arabia, where travelling in Jet is more normal for a wanted criminal.

With the clock hits 9 AM, all most everyone arrive. I was now anxious. Marina is with the other Shadows, so if they are able to crack it, she was supposed to bring it to me. I don't know if they will make it in time. I familiar presence comes from behind, morning Blake. I turned to see Catherin, in her work clothes. I say, hey. How are you today. She pouts at me, you know, you don't have too keep asking me that. I smirk, I will keep asking until I am sure you actually are.

She clicks her tongue, I am fine. I know I said yesterday I didn't like not knowing what you all talked about with David, but that's just me venting. Her aura told something else. She caught me noticing, well, not completely. But don't worry. I am not going to push for an answer. I talked to Marina and she gave me hints about it. I raise my eyebrow. Now what did she reveal to her. Catherine laughs at my stern face, I am kidding. She didn't say anything I could understand. She doesn't have a good poker face, but she can confuse the hell out of anyone. Classic Marina defense mechanism. I don't know if Marina wanted to tell about her family, but I wanted to know what was the other thing that Catherine didn't like about them.

I didn't get a chance to ask her, this was too personal for her. Also our work as kept us busy. Catherine had also begin her own spying to uncover the people behind the stolen drugs. I whisper to her, so any progress in your hunt. She teases me, really now. You think I am that easy. I am not going to show what I found so soon. I doubt she found anything in just two days. I say, just be careful. Those people don't mess around. She smiles, yeah, well, neither do I. I got this. At least she was confident and not depressed about her family.

Then she pulls out tablet, enough about that. You have a job to do for now. She has become more of her usual self now. I say, yes mam. I took from her and go through the list I asked her to bring. As I go through it, I get familiar with the contents. She asks, you don't think this is a bit too much. You are basically going to insult them. I replied, its not that. It about leveling the field. I have no doubt they will try to blame us and use this to discourage Citradel people from joining us.

She asks, but there are their own people involved in this. They are already partially responsible. I say, it happened in our city, that makes it more our responsibility. Don't worry about it, I am preparing it just in case they start causing a ruckus. I am not going to do it if all of us remain level headed. She was little relieved to hear me and looks at me with pushing her lips, you are too good at this. Must be yours dad's influence coming out of you now. I made stiffed laugh. If only she knew how close me and dad were really.

At the end of the list, I saw one strange entry. I ask her, this one is strange. She puts her hand on my arm, trust me. I got this one straight from an unexpected source. Her devious smile was vexing, but I guess its not a big concern if its true. After checking everything I was satisfied. She then says, one more thing. David called me an hour ago. I gave her the tablet back. She had a confused look. She says, he wanted to know I know where Citradel

get their materials. That’s not that strange, he had some troubles getting last few. I bet he was looking at all possible places to find it. I did ask him to check if we can get it from the same source as Citradel, but he said he won't be able to get all the materials within a week from their sources.

She says, I assumed as much. That maybe he had to buy or steal from their usual suppliers. The actual weird thing is the time. I just met Tina and she told David contacted her early in the morning. So if had everything already by then, why call me. This is mildly unsettling, did he tell you why he wanted that information. She says, he said he was in a hurry, so I just assumed he was still trying to gather all the stuff. I don't know why he wanted it now. Should we be worried.

I was a little anxious too, maybe. But lets trust him. Maybe there was an emergency and had to search for alternate sources. She says, he did say he was delayed. So I guess that could be why. I just thought to tell you this. Don't want to be blinded by him, again. We both have a good laugh at David. After chatting with others a bit more, I take the center stage around 9:30. Everyone looks at me, all right people. We are all good to go. Luther says, nothing on the hard disk. Many eyes fall on me, I says, apologies, but I guess we fell short for that.

I see a lot of disappointed face. A voice comes out, you guys are thinking too much. Its still a win that we got all the people involved in this. It was Nathan, I saw him coming in earlier with Jess. She was a bit more tiered than him. That was expected. But Nathan was too eager to call this out. Tessa says, don't start Nathan. I know you helped out this time, but that data was important. The people who bought the smuggled stuff were just as guilty as the people we have.

People were murmuring in agreement. This wasn't going to damper his chipper mood, true. They are the buyers of the smuggled stuff. And they knew all the risks buying them. But isn't it better to look at the win rather than what we couldn't. Also, its not like all is lost. We can still crack the data, it just might take more time. He was trying to elevate the slightly depressed atmosphere. I didn't like the way he went about it, but its not a bad thing. I bring the attention back to me, anyways. We still got everyone involved in the actual smuggling, like he said, we should focus.

A moment later the conference door opens and my eyes dart to the person hoping it to be Marina. But it was Vanessa. Shit, she didn't listen to me. She hurries inside with a calm demeanor, sorry everyone. I had a late night. I pause a little while I try to figure our her aura. She was much calm and determined today. But like yesterday, it could change any second. She stands beside Tessa. Nathan says, such tardiness Vanessa. Twice in a week. Are you sure everything is fine.

This was really the worst time to prod her. But her aura remained intact, yeah I know. Work's been crazy at IDF, but you all know about it. You and Rose were able to pull out information from the three people, but a lot of it is just them simping on Rose. Obviously I have that in the report. I spend extra time redacting that. This caused a laugh among the people. I can't tell if she really did that or not. Even Nathan giggles at her. The only guy who was unaffected by her was Ned, who had a slightly sullen face.

Please don't tell me they had another fight. For now I have to trust Vanessa isn't going to cause another scene. I says, anyways, as I way saying. I grabbed the attention back, our focus is on ensuring them that we had a fast and swift resolution to this. If they start saying unreasonable things about our negligence, don't panic. We are going to expect some blowback. But trust me, if they go overboard I am not going to stay quite. Just let me handle it. People remain steadfast at my confidence.

Luther takes over, all right guys. Lets clear the room, except for the top officers, please go to the next room. One by one people start leaving. I was setting up my place in the conference table when an unexpected person approached me. He asks, Blake. Do you have a second. I turn to Ned. Oh god, what did Vanessa do. I hide my nervousness, what's up Ned. I haven't seen much of you around the office, you know. The corner of his mouth twists, don't I know. While you are busy helping this gigantic mess, someone still had to focus on the upcoming matches.

His team was still working with Citradel side and coming up with the plan about the match. I say, sorry Ned. I have been a little too busy to focus on that. I know we were supposed to go over it by now. He says, understandable. Given the mess those guys made, I knew it wasn't the priority. But I like to setup some time once this over. I nod, for sure. When I told everything that this week was going to be a crucial, I didn't know it would also a wild one. He laughs, no one could have predict that.

I take a quick peek at Vanessa talking to Sommers. Then I turn back to him, so. What's up. He says, I was just wondering if you know when David is coming back. I thought he would be here by now. I talked to Tina, and she doesn't know. I thought you would have some idea. I respond, no clue. Did you checked with Vanessa. I tried to test the waters of their relationship. He sighs, she and I are in a fight. I think everyone knows by now. We haven't talk much lately. So she didn't cause any more issues last night. At least not with Ned.

I wasn't going to comment anything about their fight, what do you need from him. You can still contact him, you know. He says, I wanted a face to face conversation about the ideas we have for the match. I didn't want them to be shared over remotely. I say, you will have to wait for sometime then. He looks around, I suppose that’s unavoidable. His travel is very unexpected, I understand he had to priorities, but this is important too. I understood his concerns, don't worry. He will join in the call.

That somehow relieves his tense expression, is that so. That’s great then. I was being concerned for no reason then. With that he leaves us and follows others to the next room. Soon it was just the high ranking officers in the room. I am in discussion with Luther when Marina rushed in the room. He hair was messed up, likely she came flying at top speed. He had a bag with her, oh thank the Kuret. I made it in time. She hurries to me and drops the bag on the table. Luther asks, are you all right Marina.

She was breathing heavily and is now tidying up her crumbled clothes, I just came here at a sonic speed. Give me a second. People gather around her hearing that ridiculous lie. But I was more interested at her bag. I hastily open it and saw the hard disk inside it. It was connected to another device through a connector. The device had a lights flashing on the side. I got excited seeing this, I shriek, is this what I think it is. She fixes her hair, yeah. Special delivery of all stupid guys who bought the smuggled goods.

The room now was filled with excited aura. Luther says to Marina, I knew it. Shadows are the goat. She was smiling ear to ear. I don't know why she is so smug about it. We didn't crack this, we are just taking the credit. Nathan walks near me, well, damn. I lost the bet. Jess elbows him in his stomach, not now. I will pretend I didn't hear that. Catherine helps out Marina, girl, you are messing your hair even more. Let me. Marina turns her back to her, thanks. I didn't get time to fix it before I left.

Somers had a wide eye staring at the hard disk, what the hell did you guys do. There were 3 fail safes in this device. He incredulously looks at both of us. I stayed silent, letting Marina handle this. She laughs, sorry. Trade secret. I don't think we had any better excuse than this. Luther was in glee, while Sommers eyes was twitching. She says, that device is connected to the network and decrypting the data on the hard disk. Tessa asks, so you got all the names of the people.

She sighs, unfortunately no. We got through the safeguards and firewalls, but the data is itself 512 AS encryption with a rotating algorithm. Suffice to say its quite advance. We don't have the names and the smuggled goods right now, but this is the best we can do for now. I hand over the hard disk to Vanessa, I am giving this to you. Tell the Citradel IDF cracked this. This caught her and everyone else off guard. Marina flared her nostril, but I already told her I was going to do this.

She asks nervously, why. I say, its not going to be fair if I tell them me and Marina personally cracked it. IDF is going to have a little bit of backlash because of this incident, but at least you can show you guys are still reliable. Sommers, you want us to lie. I shrug, this doesn't have it be so bad. I am sure you would have done it if you all more time. I wanted give you more time, but Citradel didn't budge and wanted to meet now. He was not convinced, probably not happy with me or Marina that we cracked it less than the time they had it for.

Marina pleads, hey, you know. Its best not you lie, you know. There were so many layers of emotions to her voice. But her aura was clear. She wanted to enjoy the attention. She is being way too petty, considering we didn't actually do it in the first place. I say, I told you. Shadows don't care about stuff like that. She got the hint and gets annoyed. How would it look to our recruits if we can't do what they just did. She says, fine. Yeah. Whatever. She grumbles while Catherine finishes her hair, there. Isn't it so much better.

She was more presentable now. Vanessa takes the disk from me, I don't like this one bit. I gave a intense look that said deal with it without making a scene. She relents, but yeah. This will help regain some of the trust we lost. Somers mumbles something while Ruther puts his hand on his shoulder calming him down. I don't have the time for people to be worried about things like this, it’s a win guys. That’s all what matters. Isn't that right, Nathan. He smirks but doesn't say anything back.

Jess asks, what if there are names of recently moved Citradel people in it. She had a good question. Luther says, it’s a fine line, but its still our jurisdiction. Anyone who moves here are now under our purview. She asks, I get that, but what I mean is that how do people know about these people. Its not like they are advertising right. Its basically something like a reference and word of mouth. So I was just thinking if there are only island people or from other communities in this disk.

Deni says, we had similar questions during our investigation. Unfortunately, there is no way to know until we get one name. I say, its fine. We will figure out what to do once we get the names. Lets not assume anything right now. Nathan turns to Tessa, I hear you got a lead. Tessa scoffs, it’s a very thin one. I feel like this disk will crack before I do. So that didn't pan out much huh. I say, it was a good idea. Luther asks, did Elina offered any other shipment. She says, nope. I wasn't even sure we will get one. Getting more from just Elina is a bit unrealistic.

Vanessa says, so we have only this to rely on. She turns to Marina, I don't want to give a vague time frame. How long before we get the names. You must have some approximate time in mind. Crap, she doesn't know. She eyes to me, what, neither do I. Marina plays it off, its not an exact Math. It could take a 3 hours or even 3 days. Nathan asks, really. I assumed you can at least predict how long the decryption will take. Fortunately, I got an answer from the hidden person in the room. I step in the conversation, what she said was just the lowest and highest limits. It will around 14 hours to get each names.

Somers says, what. Seriously, you are saying we have to wait that long. How many names are in there. I looked for help again before anyone could recognize them. I say, its between 60 to 70. That’s the best guess. I have no idea how they arrived at this number. I am just the messenger here. Ruther says, holy shit. So many. I was expecting there are maybe less than 30. Elina had made only 30 orders in total. Vanessa says, either some people were purchasing same thing or there were multiple smuggled items. Ruther says, I get that. But the crates don't have enough space to hold big stuff.

Marina adds, small things can be valuable too. Speculations were running rampant with the new information. I say, okay guys. That’s enough. This isn't the time for this. Vanessa, this much should be enough for now. She the bad on the table and puts the hard disk inside it, its much better than being clueless. Jess says, it would be really bad if the first name turns out to be someone important. Nathan says, that’s entirely possible. I sure hope that doesn't happen, because we would have a lot problem. People trust would waiver around unpredictability.

While everyone got ready for the meeting I spoke to Vanessa briefly, I told you to take the day off. Vanessa expression contorts a little now that its just me. She answers, I was out of line yesterday. I know that. It won't happen

again. I didn't believe her, because she herself didn't believe it. She says, and besides, regardless how I acted, if I am not present here, then it would look bad. She raises the bag, we are trying to show Citradel and any other community that we can handle our own shit. I am the head of security of this place. Do you believe it will show strength if I am missing.

I retort, before you handle the entire islands shit, can you handle yours. I was not holding back right now. Because I need to decide is she would not get carried away again, like she said yesterday. This got her to think hard, but she didn't say anything. I ask, David is going to join the call. How am I going to believe that you won't try to accuse him of hiding his involvement again. We got bigger things to worry than your trust issues. I had being harsh, but asking the questing I had to.

She answers, I will be fine. I am going to be fine. Trust me. You can ask Tessa to keep an I am me, you really don't think I can handle it. I say, I was already going to do that. If you don't mind it, then maybe nothing will go wrong. Vanessa says, don't worry about me. You got other things to worry about.

I was about to leave, but turn to her, what does that mean. Vanessa says, nothing, just saying things to myself. I really hope this turn into a mess.

Blake (Chapter 83)

Thursday, January 22, 2026 21:04

In another 15 minutes, the meeting started. We had setup a video conferencing setup with all of us here. There is feed going to the other room and to all the rest of the officers in the building. Once the screen opens, the first person we see is, Kafar, sitting in the middle. To his left is Geisha and on the right a younger guy I didn't know. Though facial recognition system runs on the screen and it shows his name, Winden. I think that's Ryes son. Huh, what happened to Ryes. And finally we see Derek in the far left.

Just these four people. I guess others council people are busy dealing with Heraknus movement. I open first, good morning everyone. They all greet to all of us next. Kafar says, this is quite unfortunate Blake. To think this happened this week. I say, I know. And here we thought Heraknus was the biggest highlight of the week. That even made Kafar smirk. Geisha says, everyone here is shocked and can't believe so many were involved in this. I answer, the shock came to us too.

Derek says, I know we got a lot of things to ask. But first I have to ask, where is Quintin. I turn to Vanessa. She says, we have him in a prison cell. There was an escape attempt by one of them, so we have them on lockdown. Winden speaks up, I don't understand this. He is one our best warrior. I refuse to believe that he is involved in such a thing. Vanessa says, no one saw it coming. Not about him, or Polly or Cory. It took us a lot of time, but we have their confessions recorded and the physical evidence of their involvement. So as much as we like to believe it was a mistake, its not.

Winden shook his head in disbelieve. Derek says, when are you going to share it to us. Vanessa signals Sommers and he taps his display. He says, I have just sent it to you in your IP address you sent us earlier. Kafar says, you already have everything ready. I answer, of course. We had a couple of really busy days. Somethings even ran till this morning. So apologies for not sending it before. But our team has everyone in custody now. Geisha asks, Derek, please have you team look at their evidence.

Derek says, will do mam. But I like to interrogate him personally. I say, you are free to do it. But let me tell you, he has been really uncooperative. We got him to open up only after grueling work and effort. Nathan says, these guys have strong Kuret resistance. So we had push them harder. Derek asks, let me worry about that. But you are right about one thing, he won't answer my questions when I am not around. Ideally I would want him to hand over him to us, but.

I interject him, you guess right. Our mess, our prisoner. If you want, feel free to come here yourself and talk to him. Derek smiles turning to Kafar, thought so. Kafar says, you won't budge that request huh. I say, its nothing personal, but we caught him red handed where people are injured and one almost died. Do you would hand over one of us he they had gone to Citradel and caused trouble there. Geisha says, I guess we won't. Winden asks, I know you won't try to hide anything, especially when Heraknus are going to move your city. But how can we believe anything you say.

This guy seriously thinks we are fabricating the whole thing. He seems to be more hot headed than his father. I look around the confused faces in the room and then I turn to screen, I should have asked earlier, but why is he here. Kafar says, that's rude Winden. Don't try to make a mess. Winden backs down like he was on a leash, sorry Blake. I should messaged earlier. Ryes is stepping down from his position. Instead we have his son taking over. Don't mind him, please. He is still new to this.

This is the first time hearing about this. I turn to Catherine quickly who shook her head slightly. She also didn't hear from her contacts then. I ask, is that so. Did something happen. Geisha says, nothing to worry dear. He just wants the younger people to take the reins. You know, like you all. He was just appointed last night. Winden says, apologies. I didn't mean to accuse you. I just, I have known Quintin for a long time. We weren't close, but he wasn't into hurting people.

Derek says, or being bodyguards to smuggler. I too find it hard to believe. But, he turns to him, since they are openly sharing evidence like this, its hard to ignore the facts. This put a lid on Winders anger, for now. Kafar asks, speaking of hurt people. How is the young women, Elina is it. I hear she is fine. Vanessa says, how did you find her name. We haven't told anyone but the officers. Kafar just smirks, please, don't underestimate our influence. It is necessary to be updated on situations like this.

Vanessa was about to say something, I cut in, that's fine. Its not like we were hiding her, it was just so that she could help us. Derek says, so she is not involved in this. Tessa says, not that we can see. Her brother, on the hand is one of the main smugglers. Derek says, using your own sister as a mule, that is either clever or pretty damn disgusting. Kafar says, I say both. No wonder no one suspected this was going on for months. This is where he begins his campaign to blame us.

Geisha asks, how come they all remained hidden. I get that there was a tournament going on, but this is quite disturbing. I say, they are pretty good. That's how. The boss, Wyan, he has quite a impressive operation going. I signal Luther who shares another set of document. I continue, take a look over these guys. One of them is, Kiera. She is the daughter of the alpha from Citradel. Technically, she participated in the tournament, but got unlucky and got eliminated when facing an omega in the first round.

They all take some time looking over a separate screens with the profiles involved, excluding Elina and Ryan. Kafar says, when Reish heard, he went mad. Said it was a mistake and wanted to get her back himself. They are still waiting for her. I say, we haven't harmed anyone of them. I will be sending you a live feed of them, you can share it her family. Not just her, all the 5 Citradel people involved. But I suggest you prepare all their families for a hard truth. No matter what they say, we have them dead to right next to bunch of smuggled drugs.

Whatever Kafar would try, I would have a counter for it. He asks, I see. Its quite fortunate for you that all of these people were found together with the evidence. This all seems very, Derek adds, suspicious. Lets not mince words Kafar. Derek seems to not care about bring subtle. I guess he was being impatient and cutting to the chase. Vanessa says, there is nothing suspicious about this. Oh no, hear we go. I sure hope she doesn't botch this.

Winden asks, how do you mean. She says, we got everyone claiming they fought each other because they were accusing of being traitor. If you look at the their statements, you see they all attacked each other. Its a whole lot of mess, but not that hard to imagine what happened. Kafar says, but don't you think its highly unlikely everyone self destructed like this. She answers, that's what happens when you have a mele with three strong warriors. Kiera said she was attacked by Polly, while Polly is trying to cover her ass by denying it. But she is claiming she fought both Cory and Quintin.

She was laying it pretty good to them. She continues, the boss is not talking, and trying to strong arm us with information. His lackeys are all blaming each other as traitor, and we have a guy for attempted murder. Are they all unreliable witness, a hundred percent. We have people saying they are not involved, but their Kuret signature and DNA are all over this. They are all involved in illegal activates. Not even you can deny that. So however the circumstances may look like, it is what it is.

She was getting angry a little, but that helps her case. Geisha asks, I am not questioning you dear, its just hard to accept. I think Vanessa did her part so I jump in, it was harder for us to accept this. We welcome you to inspect everything yourself. The scene is under lock, all evidence is prepared and tagged. All the people involved, even the ones on the bottom ladder are in custody. They are not going anywhere. Kafar says, but you are not going to hand over any of them to us.

I just shrug in response. I wasn't going to repeat myself over this again. Derek says, I guess we have no choice but to go ourselves and check it out. Winden says, and what about the exhibition match and Heraknus. We are not in position to do our own investigation. Kafar says, both you make good points. Lets table that discussion for later. He pauses for second and asks, lets talk about the people involved, as you say. Last I heard, you have only the smugglers in custody, but not the people who used them to buy stuff. And Wyan has not been cooperating, right ?

I say, that's just old news that you heard. We will soon have all the names and the smuggled goods. Geisha is surprises, that's new. Who are they. I gestured Vanessa. She says, they were using a hard disk to store the data. We recovered it and its being decrypted. We will soon have all the names of all 60 clients. Kafar says, my word. So many were involved. Derek asks, and what exactly did they smuggle. She answers, its talking time. The encryption is heavy.

Kafar says, lets not waste more time. How about you share it us. We have own tech team that can crack it. Vanessa says, I don't doubt you can crack it faster. This is pretty advance stuff. But besides that, there is evidence that Citradel tech was used when we took the internal x-rays. I will share that to you all as well. I am sure your team will recognize the designs. Geisha says, that's not good. Just how did Wyan get access to it. Kafar says, lets say it is really ours, then it makes sense we are best to crack it.

I take this request, sorry Kafar. Like I said, our mess, your mess, still our responsibility. I see his annoyed face, so I add, you are right about not wasting time though. But we only just cracked it this morning. I am sure we will find a way to get the data faster. You can't expect us to get it done in a day. Even you will have a fairly longer time. Unless of course, you can explain to our tech team what resources you have that we don't. This put a stop to this pursuit of this. Beacon they will not reveal their hand like this.
Derek says, you guys are pretty sure you of it.

Vanessa says, of course. We are all over it. I swear I could see Kafar glaring me for the corner of his eyes. I just pull a small smirk to him. If he thought I was going to cower to their advance tech capability, they are wrong. I add, once we get the names, I will share it with you. Though only if any of the Citradel people is involved. Kafar says, naturally. You don't want to disclose your own people. I say, not before we catch them and recover the smuggled goods.

Geisha says, you seem quite reluctant Blake. Is there any reason you don't want our help. I was waiting for this question, I am not happy with this situation. We never realized such a dangerous group running their operations. If I can't show you all that we can handle it, what's the point in bringing more people in. We don't have the long stability like yours, but we are getting there. And with Heraknus house coming, its even more important that we can improve our administration. This was a disaster, but's also an opportunity for us to grow. Isn't that how communities grow. We make a mistake, we learn from it, we get better.

This was a prepared speech from Luther. I liked so much that I didn't change anything and said it word to word. Luther smiles and shows a small thumbs up. Even Kafar had a hard time refuting this. He says, quite a bold statement. I nod, it is indeed. Geisha says, all right. I suppose we will continue to trust that you can handle this. Derek says, Vanessa, is it possible I can talk to Wyan, I am okay with you guys observing it. If he really used our technology, I would like to know he got it for himself.

Vanessa says, I can do that. Ruther, setup some time later for this. Ruther notes this down on his tablet. Derek says, thanks. Since you are no decrypting the data, what happens to Wyan now. He was withholding information from you all, what now. She says, to put it simply, he is screwed. Since his own people are blaming him, he will now want to save his himself as much as possible. We are very certain he will spill the bean on the entire thing. Where is the money from his operation going, how is he getting his clients and who his contacts are outside. He will squeeze everything out him.

Derek says, okay then. I would like to sit on that interrogation as well. She nods, gladly. I think we are making good progress. It was good that we weren't not going to acquiesce to any of their request. They will get only what we give them. Kafar says, this is all well and good. But let me ask this now. Your point to show your city's strength is commendable. But we don't have time for that. We never know when Hive will attack. And we are still in hostile planet. We can't have more problems like this for Heraknus. What if Heraknus were the victims in this, when they don't have their Kuret, they would be in grave danger.

It was bound to happen. Kafar is very predictable. No, actually it was obvious he would try to stop them moving here. I didn't want to open that can of worms, not yet, so I went with a diplomatic answer, I know all the concern people have. But the hard truth is, no one died. That’s a big win in my book. Sure, people were hurt, but that’s the price of being living on in a community trying to survive. If you expect that there won't be conflicts and problems, you are not being realistic. There will always be danger to people, not because they are in the wrong city, but because they are in the wrong plant.

My confident attitude made them stun for a second. I wasn't going to lie and sugar coat the hard truth saying we are going to protect everything. That's not possible. That's what the different between our ideologies. I thought this would be enough for Kafar, but he wasn't backing down from my strong sentiments. He says, you are right. This whole situation is a problem caused by something bigger than us. There are no good solutions. However, people still have to think which place is best for them. If you are going to be always in danger, best to stay in a place where it is less.

I guess I don't need to hold back now, are we talking about dangers to Heraknus or to everyone. He says, everyone who comes to your city. Be it an alpha or a regular person. How can they live in a community that is still not stable and dangers lurk everywhere. Is he even trying to hide his blatant accusation now. Gisha even tried to lean and tried to whisper something to him, but he didn't listen. Just how desperate is he for this. I could tell people here were also becoming annoyed at him now.

I turn to Catherine. She nods her head, all though she was reluctant about it. He leave me no choice but to reveal it then, if you are now talking which city is best place for Heraknus, why don't you explain about the fires to your harvest 3 years ago. I hear 3 people died and numerous people were hurt. This shocked everyone here, but even a bigger shock appeared on him. His eyes widen and he became frozen solid, did you find the culprit, or are they still in the wind. Didn't that create a shortage of your yield and you had to supplement with human replacement for few months.

Geisha says, someone is well informed. I nod, of course we are. Quoting what Kafar said in the beginning, don't underestimate us. We may not have your technology or skills, but we have one thing you don't have. Winden asks, what's that. I answer, it should be evident already. Our experience. We have lost many people. Many have struggled hard to survive. Its a powerful motivator to adapt and get stronger. Kafar says, one incident doesn't negate our advantages. We already know you have skills we lack. That why we want you here instead.

Guess he won't make it easy for himself, does strong people in your city really makes it better. Then how about you explain the robbery of a your weapons cache 6 years ago. An alpha died stopping the robbers, what was his name. Catherine says, Eren, I snap my fingers, yeah. Him. Seems like even with the current stability and security of that time, you had a severe causality. This made him nervous finally. He now knows that it was a fluke that we know about that one incident.

Derek says, how did you know about that. Not even some of the council members know about it. I say, I told you, we are good at adapting. I am curious though, did you catch the culprits. Derek turns a little grim as he turns to others behind him and then says, not all. Some escaped. Though we know who they are. I say, if you want, we can help you. We got a good track record of locating people. Though we use it to offer them a choice to relocate to one the large communities.

Derek says in low tone, I will think about it. I answer, good shall I continue. Because I even know the thefts of your Kuret cloth synthesizers. Winden says, synthesizers. Huh? He turns to both of them who were clueless, but not Derek. He asks, you know about that too ? He turns to Kafar, we had some devices stollen few months back. Kafar asks, stolen devices. Derek says, actually they were defunct, and we were going to use them for scrap parts. Geisha asks, stolen defective devices ? Why didn't you inform. Derek says, they were about to be destroyed, the theft itself was useless. I ask, really now, how is it I know about this incident, when you yourself don't know.

Their reactions is even more priceless. How the table has turned. I was ready with 2 more incidents. But I think Kafar had a fill of it, you made you point. Catherine, you has been very busy. You managed to get hold of our most guarded secrets. Catherine says, just doing my job. You should have better security. I didn't ask her to add more salt to their wounds, but I guess that put an end to this. Kafar had no more ammos to fire. There was an awkward pause among us.

Derek says, lets take a step back. Kafar, if you allow me I will ask next questions. Kafar could only wave to procced. Everyone relaxes now. The heavy mood was still there, we had to sit it aside for now. Derek says, what about your leads on who poisoned you, Marina. He had to ask the hardest question right after this. Marina had been very quite until now. But now she gets the chance to speaks up, I questioned Wyan myself. He doesn't know who stole the drugs. He has been cagy about his clients, but he didn't hold back being angry about the theft itself. You should hurry up and question him now, because I will get another round with him now that we don't need his cooperation.

He asks, you seem too fired up. I should prioritize that first then. Marina smiles like she was enjoying the thoughts of beating up Wyan. He asks, so your working theory is that whoever stole the drugs are the same clients who used Wyan. Vanessa answers, that's very certain. We are not giving up, but there's no lead, except this. She raises the hard disk from the able. She says, I know its unlikely, but maybe we get lucky and get the name of client in this.

Derek nods, yeah. But what if the people escape fearing the capture. Vanessa says, no one has every escaped this place in two years. And no one will ever. I say, besides, even if they do escape by some miracle, its good riddance. We will be safe from any further dangers from them. Then I would be than happy to let Marina pursue them outside to her hearts content. I pity those who made an enemy of Marina. She laughs hearing I was okay giving her free reign when that happens.

Even Derek mood lightens at that, I can personally attest to that. Seems like there is some funny history there. He continues, I suppose that’s all we can do is wait for the name to pop up. Geisha says, I must say. You have things running very tightly. Even I can tell it must have been tough getting this done so fast. I wish I could take the credit. We all have worked hard on this. But the main person who actually made it happen it is yet to join us. Geisha says, we have take some time to go over the data you have sent.

Vanessa says, I will open a channel with Derek later for any questions you have. She nods, thank you. That will help make things easier. Kafar says, I guess that settles that. Just one last thing. I answer, is it about the construction materials for Kuret enrichment. Thankfully Marina has already given us the list before. He says, did she. That makes things easier. How quickly can you gather it. We are preparing to send a team tomorrow. They will reach you in the next 36 hours.

Marina says, we got it covered. We will have everything on this list by the time the come. She taps her tablet and shares the list to them. Winden says, hold on. This is a little more than we thought. Kafar cuts him, no this better. Have a surplus amount. You were right to assume we needed some redundant materials. Derek asks, but did you really get them all. Marina says, I made the list the day you all went. So we had enough time to work through it.

This is the second time they were speechless. Winden asks, in 3 days. How did David manage that. I say, oh, so know about him. He says, yeah. He left some your city a while ago. But we don't know where he went. I was hoping they didn't know that. But its fine. I say, we have him on call. Shall I let him in. Kafar smiles, of course. Luther begins to type in the keys on the laptop. After a while a new screen on our connects and opens a view.

David is siting inside a plane with camera in front of him. He said he was in a jet, it does look like he is alone inside. The window behind him showed night time. Then is still quite far from here. He says, hey guys in grim voice. Something was wrong. He is forcing a smile. This is different than when he was putting up a performance. Something is up with him. Some of us clocked it too. Catherine, Vanessa, Marina, and Nathan aura changes. Derek says, hey David. You look tense, everything all right.

He shakes off the expression, just the lag. I haven't slept in 32 hours. Marina made quite a ridiculous demand. Marina says, not my fault. David laughs with some tension on him. He says, anyways. It was quite a challenge. Though I am happy to announce I got everything you would want. Even the equipment's. Widen says, that’s awesome. Did you find the industrial laser carbine cutter. We can send it over if you need it. There are very difficult to get by. David says, that is true. I only got one. If you can to send it, that will speed up the construction.

Widen says, great. Kafar, I will authorize to be sent with the team. Geisha asks, dare I ask how you got it. Because we had to steal ours. I didn't know that it was so difficult to obtain this equipment. David says, given the time frame, I bought it from the owner. Stealing leaves quite a trail for this type of equipment. She smiles, that’s one way to avoid troubles. Derek asks, how are you going to ship it to the island. He says, I shared the details to Tina.

Tinas turn comes up, we have a simple strategy. David is loading up ships with the materials and equipment's in the port of China. They are on course to the US. We will intercept them in the ocean, swap in the entire contents of the ship with different materials and it carries that to the US. David is going to hack the manifest so that what China is sending items which US will not be aware about. Instead they get what we swap in to the ships. They are simple alloys that China frequently exports.

Kafar says, this is simple in theory. But its not practical. What happens an inspection happens on. David cuts in, I have taken care of it. I have bribed the customs to turn a blind eye. They will approve our modified manifest. Kafar says, what about the water border patrols. They do regular checks on that routes. David nonchalantly says, bribed them too. I don't know what exactly is going on here. Is Kafar trying to trip up David for a mistake or testing him.

Kafar says, and what about. David jumps the gun, the port masters are also in. I had a chat with Patrick Drognerwind just few hours ago. He was more than happy to take a bribe. Turns out his son needs a start up money for a new business venture. Why did David explain so much more for this one specifically. The reason was because this caused Kafar's with an astonished face. I ask, any problem. Geisha says, ah, its quite a coincidence, we also use him for our transports.

David says, seriously, what are the chances of that. David says, I guess everyone would also use the same routes. Derek says, its the one with least suspicion to us. Was it really a coincidence. I am don't feel so good about this. Tina continues, the ships will pass through us about 480 miles away. We are going to intercept the ships tonight. Most of the humans will be asleep, the rest will be forces to be asleep for few minutes. In that time we will swap in our stuff. The crew won't even know we robbed them.

Derek says, okay. Sounds easy enough. How many ships will there be. Tina says, David only shared for tonight, around 5. David says, make that possibly 8. I just acquired a supply from the South Africa mines in the Ewaka region. So instead of waiting till tomorrow night, I will try to get them tonight. That’s actually why I am delayed. It was an unexpected opportunity I didn't want to let it go to waste. Winden says, you work fast. David says thanks, it was actually a really good luck that.

Kafar cuts in, hold on. Did you say Ewaka. By any chance are you talking about the Titanium mine in the village. David says, you know about that. Don't tell me you also use that and the routes. What is David doing now. Derek says, yeah. We have a contract with the local government. David shifts uneasily on his seat, really. Since when. He says, its been years. We couldn't steal Titanium in large quantities, so we had no choice but to buy these materials from them. Very less human know about it. We deliberately kept it this way so that less people monopolies it.

David says, ah. This is a little awkward then. What is going on. Behind me Catherines aura shine with a lot of confusion. Didn't she say David contacted her a while ago. He says, I bought the mineral rights of that mine. So, he makes a face that looks guilty, I guess your contracts are with me now. Derek jaw flew open, you did what. David shrugs, I thought the same as you. I wanted to capitalize on the entire mine. Great minds think alike I guess. I have never seen Kafar this nervous before. If we weren't in this situation, I would laugh at him being so speechless.

I grip my hands tightly as I turn to face others. None of us knew what David was doing. Catherine whispers to me, I told him that this morning. What the hell is David thinking. Geisha says, is this really a coincidence. David says raising his hand, what else could it be. I mean, it would be really a freaky coincidence if you also exclusively use the small platinum deposit from Germany. But that not possible. Its just a small vein that opened in the mountain 7 years ago. Funny thing, that mountain is not registered as an actual mine, so I had to buy the whole freaking land from the government.

They were hit with another shock. Geisha whispers something to a panicking Kafar. Derek was now staring hard at David. On stark contrast, all of us nervous at David blatant disregard for what he is trying to do. Why is he intentionally provoking them like this too. David sees them and laughs, no way. Okay, now I am sure something is very weird. How did this happen. Did you use the same guy, Orlove Koskov, to make the deals. Because I don't fully trust this shady guy.

That was the final straw from them. Kafar snarls at David and then says something to Geisha. Geisha says, ahm. Blake, sorry. We need to cut short this call now. We have to, hum, check on few things. Before I could say anything to them, she and Kafar both got up and left from the view. Winden was confused and didn't know what just happened, so he also left following them behind. Only Derek sat there with a grim face. He clears his throat, you got us good David. David behaves clueless, maybe we can made some sort of deal. I didn't know you guys were also being supplied from there.

He says mockingly, of course you don't. Well played. I assume this is retaliation for what Ryes did. I hit the limit of my patience, I ask, what the hell is going on. Am I missing something here. Derek says, you haven't heard, that’s a relief. Well, I can't explain it right now. But before I leave, I want to apologies to you, David. I tried to stop Ryes. But it was too late. Believe me. David had a very serious face now. No, he was pissed off. He didn't say anything and kept quite now.

Derek scratches his head, anyone would be angry at that, but only you have the means to do something about that. Just let me handle this. Okay. Blake, you don't have to worry about Citradel not coming now. They might call for Davids head, but this was our own fault for allowing Ryes to go after David like this. I will see you all later. Before I could get any more words in, their videos turns off. Now it was just us worried officers and a pissed off David. Nathan asks, ah, someone's explain what just happened. I stand up, what did you do David.

David takes a glass from his side table. I don't think it was water. He takes a sip and says, what I had to. Marina asks, what does that mean. He sighs, do you what happens when a dog keeps barking at you. You smack it down and remind who has the leash. I just reminded them of that. Marina gets nervous at his demeanor, what happened. What did Ryes do. After contemplating a lot, he says, first, take me off the video call from other officers. I will tell only to you all. Luther says, it something sensitive. He nods, very. Luther turns to me. I had to trust David had a reason. I nod. Luther goes back and starts typing on his laptop. After few heavy silence of seconds he says, done.

David says, I don't know how this happened. But 8 hours ago, one of my sources told me Ryes gave an their interview in Citradel. It was broadcasted to other communities, excluding us. The whole time he was defaming me and involve other's along with it. I ask, what. Ryes would never do anything like that. David says, I don't know how it happened. I heard only pieces of that interview, but it was clear what is goal was. Throw all the possible dirt on me to create doubt people from moving to our city. Catherine says, hold on. This is the first time I am hearing of this. He says, Kafar has somehow able put a lid on it. Or Reys planed it this way.

Luther asks, what was Ryes saying. David says, he has dig up my past on Earth. Not just any, but all the worst parts of my life and twisted them to absurd lies. I knew I was about to garner a lot of negative attention due my sudden fame from the finals. But I never imagined this. He was dead set on making Heraknus change their decision. I yell, no. That can't be, he has been a supporter of moving here. David says, then Kafar or someone else got to him. Because he had sudden change of heart and began a complete smearing campaign.

This is unbelievable. I can't believe Rayes would do this. Is they why his son was here instead. Marina asks, what did he say exactly. David was a reluctant a little. Then he says, Ryes said I hid for years in Greenville, living a ignorant and blissful life while everyone else was trying to stay alive. I was somehow the reason why half the people were mascaraed 5 years ago when Hive attacked the compound. He began lying and giving fake evidence that I somehow led people to their deaths. That’s why I always remained behind the scenes, to cover up for my failures. I gasp, what the shit. Vanessa says, what a load of crap. Because of you, half of them made out alive.

David says, if it was directed at me, I wouldn't have retaliated like this. But then he somehow found about our tussle in the Valley. Shows photographs and eye witness claims that I released the poison gas to kill the other MARs children, like a mercy murder since they were dying anyway. I use the panic I caused myself to become a hero when I risked my life from it killing anyone else. Catherine says, holy mother of. Then all our eyes to go to Nathan. He was just as clueless as us, I swear I didn't tell anyone about this. David says, I know you didn't. Because you are painfully aware not what would happen if you ever said a word about it.

Nathan was put under pressure from David's glare. Only David can him so nervous. I ask, what kind of fabricated proof he showed. He turns to me and says, don't know. All I know is that it was so convincing that more than few people believed it. They also know that I killed, someone, to take over his criminal empire. Twisting the truth was not enough for him. He said I was tried to kill Nathan because he was against human experimentation, while I wanted to do it. Freak. This one must hurts us the most now.

Nathan snarls, what the hell was Ryes thinking revealing that. David says, that’s not the end of it. He says I somehow used Oriana with a cold and calculating manipulation, made her to save Blake life even at the cost of her own. I don't even know how he could make anyone believe I did that. My confusion turn to anger. Did he really drag Orina into this nonsense too. Catherine says, that’s complete bullshit. David says, tell that to him. I have know historical real life dictators with less notoriety than what he kept painting on me with.

Luther shouts, has he lost his mind. David says, he might have. The last thing I learned was how I roped Marina in and got her to betray Citradel. For years. Then I used her, poisoned her and Blake once they cleared in enough people and I cheated my way through the finals. I had to sit down now. My head was throbbing and aching now. Marina shouts in anger, bloody freak. He said that. David says, there were other minor things, but these were the major highlights.

I shook my head wrapping around this. Did Ryes betray us or was he blackmailed. But either way, Citradel allowing this to happen in the first place is completely unacceptable. Tessa says, how did this happen. Even I don't know much about these thing before I met you all. I says, he knew enough truth to twist them into convenient lies. My Kuret bursts out of my hand and table edge crack under the pressure of my anger. Luther takes a step back. I never imagined Oriana death be used like this.

Viens pop in my head, you let them off easy. I heard people gasping behind me from my sudden anger. David says, I know. There is only so much I can do without completely shattering the deal I made with Charles. This was the only choice I had left. Luther says, they purposefully left us out in that broadcast. Did they think we weren't going to find out about this. Nathan asks, are you sure all this happened. Maybe you were fed wrong intel. I have people in other communities, no one told me this happened.

David makes a scowl, you think I would do this without absolutely making sure the authenticity of my information. Go check with your people if you still think this was a lie. David's anger put Nathan doubts away, no, you wouldn't do something so drastic if it wasn't true. Vanessa asks, how did he found about all of this. David didn't answer. Only select people know that someone is betraying us big time. It was only Marina and me that were targeted before. But now its David too. David was right to not involve others, he foresaw him getting targeted next.

Catherine says, the timing of this is also suspicious. You left the city and then Ryes goes live with this crap. She was right. This had to be deliberate. David says, I agree. He knew I would retaliate, so he did it when I was away or on the travel. Once I realized what had happened I had to make my moves immediately. If I wait and give them time to anticipate my move, I don't know what else they would have done. Once I made up my mind, I got the details from Catherine about their recourses and went to monopolize it for myself.

He says, now, no matter what kind of dirt they throw at me, destroy my reputation, they are at my mercy if they want to expand their infrastructure. They no longer have the resources do it themselves. You all heard Derek, he understood how it impacted them. I am sure they will try and resist this. But its futile in the end. I am awe in the swift and ruthless action. Just in one move, he has completely destroyed Citadel's potential to move people in.

Marina says, holy shit. Damn David, you got them by the balls now. Luther says, we need to mitigate the fallout. He turns to Tina, contact others. Send out teams to other communities and explain them this is a lie and not to believe anything Ryes said. Before Tina could say anything, David says, no. Don't do that. Luther asks confused, what. He answers, denying it so excessively will not solve anything. The more you deny it, the more people will believe its true. Like the rumors about me cheating. Do you really believe if I had denied, people would accept it. No. Even if I explain how I did it, their doubts will never be gone.

Vanessa says, so you are not going to do anything about it. David scoffs, do anything? Didn't I just say I took their toys away from them. What more do you want me to do. Its already more than appropriate response for this. Luther says, its not just about you David. All of us are being dragged through the mud. David sighs, I had time to think over it. Take some time for yourself too. Even if Citradel now makes an apology for Ryes actions, my reputation has gone to shit. This isn't court and there is no government to uphold our actions. Word of mouth has lot of weight right now. You make a wrong move, you will get dragged down with me.

Vanessa says, we can make it right. We will tell everyone the truth. David says, to what end. The events itself wasn't lies. Just lied about my involvements and intentions. No matter how much truth we tell, there will always be a nagging feeling that I am at the very least not reliable. Whether I lose to Charles, or win or just surrender. The doubt will never go away. And that by extension means you all. They might not show it, but they will think you are complicit in some, if not all of my actions in the past.

I slam another fist on the table and stand up. My Kuret settles down a little, so what exactly are you saying we do here. David says, I only offered my opinion on not making a rash move. I'll leave it to you decide how to handle this. I did what I could to counter the effect of this smearing. Ryes wanted to stop Heraknus from moving, I made a move that forced the Citradel to move. I won't do anything more. If you want to deny or tell the truth, fine. I won't stop you. I never plan to order you. Just voicing my opinion. I have my own troubles right now.

I say, Citradel won't let this go so easily. They will fight, try to get back the resources you stole. David says, let them try. This was just the start, I will soon monopolies all the mines and deposits they use. Even if they look for someplace else, I will be ready to snatch it away from them. All the purchases are not under my name, but they are done by my people, who have the major government support. So the local government can't side with Citradel. Unless they make bigger waves and attract attention of more humans, they are screwed.

Nathan says, just how much loaded are you right now. Didn't you just gave away a large amount of money in a bet. I ignore him and ask. Okay, but what if they forget about getting it legally and steal it. David laughs at me, I already planned for that eventuality. You think I am just buying the mines and deposits. No, I am going to empty it immediately. Citradel don't have the resources like I have to extract the ores and minerals. Pretty soon they will be dry and Citradel won't be able to steal anything, because there will be nothing. Tina says, what the. That’s why you are sending more ships tonight.

David has everything all ready planned out. He did say that he had time to figure out a plan. He has completely outsmarted Citradel. I couldn't help but enjoy that they are all panicking right now. Luther says, that’s a genius move David. But still, I don't think I can keep quite about this. Soon everyone in the city will hear of this. You might have forced Citradel to move, but what about you. And the people Ryes involved along side you in this lie. David says, I am not saying not to do anything. I am only cautioning against what not to do.

After a tense silence he says, I have to go now. The deals I made are not completely finalized. I got the ball rolling, but I am on my way right now to finalize it. I am about to enter into a monitored air space. Look guys, the bottom line is, I made a decision that I am fine with. Whatever repercussions happens due to this, I am fine as long as its just me. I strongly urge you to stall for some time before people learn this. He then turns his neck to something off screen, all right. I will see you all tomorrow. The connection turns off.

I turn to angry and confused faces. Everyone where in utter disbelief. I say, I don’t know about you all, but I am not planning to just let this slide.

Vanessa (Chapter 84)

Friday, January 23, 2026 12:54

I had a little cry last night. It was embarrassing. But I needed to get it out of my system. When I went back home, I shut myself inside the room and stayed in for few hours. I was immersed in self doubt and shameful behavior in front of Elina and Blake. I couldn't believe I was so angry at David and Ned that I would be looking for petty revenge. But I had learned by my lesson from last time. Being cooped with frustrating thoughts just don't do any good for me. I went to the gym later after dinner and poured all my anger out on a spontaneous workout.

I must have destroyed the kuret filled boxing bag before I left. Thankfully Siera was busy and came late last night. I managed to avoid yet another embarrassing encounter with her. I couldn't handle her being disappointed in me. Letting out my anger was good, because I became so tiered that I dozed off immediately. I felt much better than yesterday, and honestly, I could see how spiteful I was acting yesterday.

I couldn't believe how gullible Elina was with David lies. No, she knows he had lied about few things. Yet she even has a crush on him. I still couldn't wrap my head around it. I was projecting my own insecurities on to her. How can she trust a person who lies like he breathes. What would she do if she knew what David as been doing.

But what's even crazier is that Mack is real person. Its so confusing that I continue to waver if David using Mack's identity or if it was someone else. There was nothing to go apart from the name to link to David. David isn't paying him to use his identity. So what's up with that. I had to shake those thoughts because I had work to do and I promised myself that I won't let my emotions get the better of me.

I had to make Blake believe I was fine today. I half expected that he would force me out. The case I made him believe I was thinking clearly now. It was a relief that he allowed me to stay. Things were going smoothly at first. There was some back and forth, but we assured them we can handle this mess on our own. Like most, I knew Kafar would use this to try and make this meeting about our shot capabilities. What I didn't consider how Blake was ready to counter this. His merciless rebuttal against each their verbal attack was very precise. Catherine must have found out about those incidents.

Everyone knew there will be issues in any community. But Citradel had hidden them well, claiming the title of the most safest place for us on Earth. That illusion was shattered and they backed down before Blake broke more of that illusion. I thought it was over then. Jeez, I was so wrong. I don't know why, but whenever David is involved with Kafar, there is always a danger looming in the corner. I thought Blake was bring ruthless, but David trumps that. David was so condescending, I thought it was simply just because he could. But then reason come out. David doesn't like to talk about the past, for many reasons. He told me many times he made lot of mistakes and doesn't want them to be define him.

Its just him that thinks that. Its true I am having trust issues with David, but that doesn't mean he is a bad guy. He is a terrible person, but not how Ryes kept slandering him. They thought with David busy, they would get away with it. This is what happens when you piss off David. Ryes had betrayed us or he was never in our side. This is all Kafar, he used Ryes to lower our guard around us or threatened him. With the unexpected power of money and opportunity, David gave a devastating blow to Citradel.

The aftereffects of the meeting still continued to lunch. Blake issued few orders. Its not been ever done before, but he asked to close off communication with other communities for several hours. Luther played it clever, under the guise of a system upgrade, the network has been down since morning. This may not prevent the news from spreading, since few people have their own separate communication system. But this will buy us some time. The next order was to send a team to Citradel incognito.

Many volunteered, even Marina and Catherine. But he denied them, saying Citradel will be already on high alert for these two people. After a lengthy conversation, Blake decided to form a team on his own. Without anyone knowing so that no one can leak it to Citradel. We didn't understand who would be good enough to break into Citradel, if not the two Shadows. But he later says there is a team he has in mind. In the end, we left that to him. The final order was for specifically to me, Marina and Catherine, he wanted us to meet him after lunch.

I could imaging what Blake wanted to talk to me about. During my lunch with Tessa and Sommers, many officers wanted to know from us why David did that. Tessa helped cover it by revealing portion of it to the rest of IDF crew. That Citradel made a desperate attempt to keep Heraknus from moving. We never explained how to anyone, just that it so bad that David fought back. Sommers says, David does not mess around. He absolutely crushed them in the most brutal way possible.

Most of high ranking officers knew that David was being framed of crimes, even without us clearing those accusation. Deni was the vocal about it. They weren't for many the stuff before we came to the island, but she had enough trusted him a lot. If this happened yesterday, I would have been more conflicted. But after sleeping on it I wasn't bothered by David's actions. Tessa smiles, just how much money did he spend for this massive endeavor. Citradels only chance is to try and get it back from him before David empties the mines.

I have seen a little bit of his criminal network, but this had to be one of most impressive feat yet ever. Sommers says, you think they will try to stop him for purchasing it. She nods, David told himself, if those mines becomes his, he will not sell it back. They would have no legal option left, no way they will go to human courts or civil administration. They can't risk opening a fraud case when they themselves don't want to be caught in it. So they have to stop him from taking over.

I say, or steal from him later. She nods, that's more easier. I say, David must know that already. He probably will hire an small army to protect the places. He had done something similar to this before. Sommers smiles, dude's hardcore. He is has been glazing him a lot, but it' true. Tessa says, I heard he was in Germany now. So he is working down the list somehow. Do you know who his allies are? They must be quite powerful put these things together so fast.

They both turn to face me. I shrug, no clue. Since David is posing as a wanted human criminal, he wants to keep us and that world different. And I am very happy about it. But, I try to recall a conversation few months back, I have some suspicion though, he has visited Europe several times. So I am guessing someone very powerful is backing him. Somers ask, the prime minister? Tessa asks, someone higher perhaps. Maybe the queen of England herself. I laugh, maybe. I wouldn't be surprised if it were both. I get an alert on my message. Its Blake, he is ready for me now.

I got up with my empty lunch tray, I am going to meet Blake. See you in a while. After cleaning up and I head back to the officers building. Just like yesterday, Ned had left me a voice mail today too. I would have deleted it again, but I decided to listen to it now. He says, Vanessa. I really hope you get this message. I know you have been busy past few days. But I never wanted this to drag it this long. I know we can find a way to talk through our issues. Give me a chance to make it up to you. I may not look like it, but I miss you. Please, meet me at my place tonight. Like yesterday, I will keep waiting until you agree to meet.

This is like the first time I am getting some sort of apology from him. I am seriously having mixed type of emotions. I want to do both, talk to him and not. It's just messing me up even more. I sigh as I enter the building, deciding to think about it later. A while later I enter Blakes office. I assumed Luther was with him, but he wasn't in. Marina and Catherine were here already. And couple of unexpected people. June and the alpha twins, Frank and Chealse. This a very odd group of gathered here.

Blake says, close the door will you. I lock it behind me and take a place beside Catherine, so, what is this about. June asks, is this everyone you wanted. He says, not quite. Just waiting for Derek to join in also. I notice there was a Kuretine device flaring on the corner of the table. I wave to the 3 Citradel warriors, hey guys. Its been some time since I saw all of you. June fleshes a smile and waves me hi. Chealse says, yeah, I think last time was the flag capture game we saw you. Frank says, hey Vanessa. Its been long too. The tournament was just ended, but it feels so long ago.

I felt the same way. June says, any idea what this is about though. I shrug. Marina says, let me tell Vanessa and Catherine first. These 3 have decided to join us here, in the city. I was a little surprised, but also glad. Catherine says, that’s awesome. Welcome. I say excited, this is the best thing I have heard all day today. June says, I know. I was wavering a lot, but yesterday I told Citradel I moving here. Frank says, there are actually few of us.

Marina tells, around 26 Citradel warriors are going moving here. Catherine says, that’s a whole lot of them. Did you decide as group. June nods, we did. Honestly, I would have liked to join along with Marina, but she jumped the gun. Marina stand proud at her impromptu switch. I ask, that’s wonderful. So I am guess you all were chosen to be high ranking officers too. Chelsea says, we do. Frank says, I would have been happy either way. June says, I actually didn't want to be one.

I ask why, you were in the top 8. She shrugs, same reason I didn't want to join you in that VIP group. I don't like to stand out too much or have too many responsibilities. But Marina changed my mind after learning of the benefits. Blake sighs, please know she would have exaugurated it a bit. June says, oh I know. But if she is fine being one, I guess its not that bad, huh? Marina says, exactly. I don't think she realized June was mocking her. Blake says, well, Luther should have briefed you all yesterday, and you since haven't changed your minds, I am guessing you all no issues.

They all didn't seem to have apparent problems. I ask, which department are you all planning to join. June says, these two haven't decided. I am planning yours. I smile at her. She says, you guys were very efficient in handling the smuggling gang. And its impressive you got caught all the people involved so fast. We had issues in Citradel before, but not like this. I ask incuriously, really. I turn to Blake hinting at the Citradels supposed hidden incidents. Blake got the message, listen guys. Since you are all joining, there are few things we will have to tell, things Citradel hid from general public.

Frank asks, like Heraknus, because we didn't know. People have asked us so many times, its pretty embarrassing. Chealse says, honestly, that gave me panic too. How the hell Kafar kept them a secret for so long. Marina says, that too. But other stuff too. Because we were hiding among Human, Kafar was very easily able to hide many things. I still mad at Melinda being Charles wife. She fooled me completely. Her Shadow pride was hurt a little. June says, so what else is there.

Blake says, a lot more. But lets table that for later. I have gathered you all here to discuss very urgent matter. His expression becomes serious. Catherine asks, its about Ryes right. He nods. Just then the Kuretine device flares up and a hologram of a certain figure comes in view. Its Derek. He says, is this everyone Blake. Blake says, yes. Thanks for joining. David must have thrown you into a frenzy. Derek says in a stern voice, its chaos here. I don't suppose you can tell where David is ? I am supposed to send a team to stop him.

Blake mood had improved, but not so much that he would agree to his earnest request, sorry. At the moment, I am not going to help Citradel in any way. He nods, I understand. It was worth a try. Frank asks, what's going on guys. I thought we were holding a meeting with just us. Derek says, hey now. Just because you left, doesn't mean you forget I am still your friend. Frank snickers, then prove it. Everyone has pleaded to leave Citradel and come with us.

Seems there is some friction between them. Marina adds, I know. I tried to get to change his mind too, Frank. The guys too stubborn. Chealse asks, you know, some of are haven't forgotten you lied about Charles. Derek sighs, this again. Chealse, this isn't the place to bring that again. Besides, you think I wanted to lie. I have told you, I need to be on Kafar's side. At least for now. You think this is bad, if I am not there to handle him, it would be worse. Marina asks, worse than Ryes spewing lies on TV.

June asks, Ryes. You mean chancellor Ryes. What's he got to with this. Blake says, before I explain that, let me tell you all why I have gathered you all here. He turns to Derek, this might take some time, can you spare an hour. Derek says, I assumed as much. Yeah, I asked for some time alone. We should be good. Then Blake explained his reasons. With four newcomers, he had to explain from the beginning, I am going to tell you talk about some

details the investigation of the smugglers and how they link to the sabotages.

I thought he was going to reveal David's role. But he told them nothing about him. Instead about the details not released to the public. About the drugs stolen, and then used on Marina. And then he explained new stuff even I didn't know about. Turns out there was another drug involved, which Peter continently forgot about. That coward. We have questioned him so many times, how the hell did he forgot something so important. He said he learned it from Wyan, but I know we haven't gotten that information from him yet. Since the client list is not decrypted, he has remained silent, trying to keep his leverage which is sinking.

I assume then it was David who told them about it. Even Catherine didn't knew about this. Then he explained how its possible one of our officers were involved too. Its something I dismissed early on as a possibility, since we didn't have any proof of it. But there is a strong possibility now. If Blake believes it, then David believes it too. Then he told how they initially suspected Citradel to be the culprits, but now its one of us. And after today, its high chance of it. Now that Marina, Blake and David are being targeted, its likely from the same people.

June asks, how does that make sense. If someone is betraying you all, what's the point going after him and try to dissuade Citradel to move here. Marina says, that’s what confusing. No one knows why create such chaos like this. But didn't you hear about the rumors of him cheating. Chelsea says, yeah. That was the day after the tournament. I thought it was the admins who started it. Blake says, not them. It was Kafar.

Then he explained how Melinda had visited us 3 in the night. He didn't talk about the second portion of the talk, likely knowing that it didn't directly effect David, but it would to me. He wasn't wrong. He even made a slight eye contact at me to make sure I don't talk about it. I got the message and didn't dare. Marina also caught that and remained away from that topic. June says, Kafar really has bug up his ass, huh. He would go so far to question Davids history and try to stop Heraknus.

Frank says, its not that hard to believe. Derek, you said you didn't want to leave Kafar. Did you meant for this? Derek says, not just this. Back in Citradel too. But I can't tell about it. I just can't go against Kafar. Not until we all move to the island. I need to remain on his side. Frank nods like he somewhat accepting it. Chealse asks, so you think because of that rumor, David would be targeted too. But didn't you said it wasn't Kafar, and someone from this island.

Blake says, they maybe working with Kafar. Or maybe using him. Derek shook his head, no way. I know the guy better than himself, he would never work with others. Catherine asks, how sure are you. Because you didn't believe Quintin would be involved in this. But he had another side hidden. This made Derek anxious. She made a good point. June says, I didn't know Quintin well, but even I was devasted to know he was involved in that mess. The two twins also were frustrated with him.

Blake says, be that as may, the point is, you don't know Kafar's every move. Do you? So keep an open mind about it. Derek remained silent, lost in his thoughts. Blake continues, that little rumor was enough to make David believe he was next. It turns out, David was right. It was even done so publicly. June asks, what happened. Seems like something big happened. Frank asks, you spoke earlier about David leaving a mess in Citradel. Blake then revealed what happened today.

After listing this, all three had to sit down with anxious looks as he talked about Ryes interview. Blake was visibly getting angrier when he talked about Oriana. Catherine and me helped him out in between the explanation so that he calm downs. They all had bewildered expressions. Marina asks, that’s not you expected your first day here to look like, right. Hope you don't regret it now. June says, this is very different from Citradel. That’s for sure. Chealse says, now I know why the network is down. This would definitely cause a major distrust on David.

Frank tugs on his hair, Ryes is a level headed guy. To think he would do something so underhanded. Are you sure he would with be working with someone. Chealse says, do you think these guys would be so angry if it was a lie. Derek says, allow me to explain a little. All eyes feel on him. He says, last night, Kafar agreed to let Ryes take an interview. I was told it was going to be shown to all the communities, including yours. Everyone thought it was going to be a debate on why we should all move to the island.

His eyes widen, little did I know it was the complete opposite. Everyone panicked and I rushed to stop him. But the most crazy thing was that Ryes was hijacking his interview to look like it was from his home. I broke inside his house where only his wife and son where there. He was never there. We searched everywhere for him in Citradel. By the time we found where the interview crew was taken, it was too late. I didn't hide my rude voice as I ask, please don't say he is missing.

Derek sighs, he is not in Citradel. We found a footage of him leaving Citradel. Don't know where he went. Blake asks, you lost him. That’s pretty convenient. Derek replies, I know how it looks like. But believe me, none of us know why he did that. Or where he is now. I got an idea, that’s actually good news. We can go look for that bastard. Blake takes a moment to think, are you searching for him. He says, of course. He made the biggest blunder of his life. We have sent a team after him, searching every safe house, and every place he ever visited. Catherine asks, you know, he could have been blackmailed and then kidnapped.

I didn't think that was the case. Few of us believed he was just cozying us up, trying to get people on his side and throw a big mess at us. Derek says, I can't be sure of that. But regardless, he went for David's past, dredging up painful memories for him and twisting the truths. I am very certain that David is hunting him too. Marina asks, does he know Ryes escaped.

Derek shrieks, really Marina. You think a guy, who was able to find this out, even after we did everything we could do to suppress it, doesn't know Ryes left. Nah, he knows. Regardless of whether Ryes is innocent, or complicit, David is going to hunt him relentlessly. And when he gets his hands on Ryes, there will be hell to pay.

He was right. David said he wasn't going to do anything more, but I doubt he will leave this matter alone. Blake says, after you left the meeting, he was very mad. I don't know what he might do. He turns to me, how quickly you can form a team to look for Ryes. I lean forwards, I can have people ready in an hour. Many officers were confused earlier about David's actions, but now they have some idea on what happened. I bet they will be ready to back us. Blake says, good. Form your team, tell them what really happened and Ryes is in the wind.

He turns to Derek, I know this is very rude, but unfortunately, if we find Ryes, we are not going to hand him over to you. He nods, right back at you. He then looks around the room, if you wanted to talk just about this, you wouldn't have explained so much. So what's the ask. Derek must be wanting to finish this a little faster now. Blake says, right. Now that you all know the situation, I need all of your help in finding out who is behind this. I can see what Blake was planning with us now. Frank asks, how. And why us.

Marina answers, simple. You guys are in the clear, there is no point for any of you to go after us. I recommended you all to Blake to help out. Chelsea asks, but we are new. Blake nods, exactly. Meaning you will be impartial and see things we won't. June asks, you want us to investigate this matter. Its not exactly our forte. She was right. They are fighters, not detectives. Blake says, what I need from all you is eyes and ears. Nothing more. Since you all recently joined, any strange behavior will be chalked as curiosity. Making it less suspicious to the people behind this.

They begin to finally understand their roles. June says, that is something I can help with. If its just about observing, I am very good at it. Chealse got weirdly excited, a spy. I know its serious thing, but I kind of feel we would be good at it. Frank makes a scowl, speak for yourself, I am bad at hiding. Marina says, don't worry about that. You being nervous is completely fine. And if you play it correctly, it will even help you to blend in much better. He wasn't exactly thrilled by her support.

Blake says, she is right. I am not asking you to do anything you don't want to. This is strictly observe and report. But in case you do want to do some more digging if you find anything, take help of your supervisor. They will also be made aware of you. At that June says, okay. But how can you be sure its not someone from the high ranking officers. No offense, but isn't Nathan a prime suspect. He has known David for long. He could have supplied Ryes with the information. Catherine says, normally yes. But he is living in this island with under a careful scrutiny. If he did anything like this, we would have found out.

Chealse asks, but still. He is good at hiding stuff. He could planed this long before the tournament. I join in, IDF is tracking his every move. If you want, I can check and tell you what he ate for todays breakfast. Every communication to outside the city is monitored. I then take a sigh, besides. Even if he wanted to do this, he can't. He knows he will be snuffed out. Frank asks, and by that you mean ? Blake says flatly, David will straight up kill him. He was already close to doing it 2 years back. The only reason he lives is because of Jess and Freya. Nathan may not never show it, but he is more scared of David out of any of us. So yeah, if he even is partially involved in this, it’s a death sentence for him.

June asks surprised, seriously. He is a royal alpha. I say, doesn't matter to us. As long is Freya is alive, its fine. I don't think they were expecting us to be frivolous with his life. Derek says, lets not assume anything. I also like to believe no one from you all could do this. I am sure one of you would notice it right away. Blake says, true. That’s why there is benefit of doubt. Frank asks, so why aren't everyone here then. Why only us. Marina answers, two reasons. One, just because they are not involved, doesn't mean someone close to them is innocent. They could have stuck close by and gathered information. That made sense, otherwise how can anyone know so many of our past.

Blake says, second reason. The people here I have here will not, in any circumstances, talk about our past. We have been with David longer than others, and all of us want want to keep it private. There is actually one more person more closer to David than us, but I didn't involve her. June asks, and who is that. I answer, Cassandra. She used to meet David and his human guardians for years. She knows things even I don't know. Derek asks, and why don’t you want to involve her.

Blake hesitate to answer. Marina answers for him, because she is the most likely source. I didn't know we were suspecting this. Catherine asks, are you serious. But why. She wouldn't tell anyone. I say, not necessarily directly. But she could have been hacked, or spied on. I hate to think, but yeah. She may not have realized it. Derek asks, isn't that a wild guess. Its too week of a reason. Blake says, there is another reason. He sighs, among the things David told me about Ryes accusation, he said Greenville.

June says, so? I see, I never caught that before. Catherine says, shit. David never told where he used to live. Derek says, seriously. He never told you guys? Blake remains quite. Marina asks, yeah, why not tell us that. I know why, I answer, This is the first time I heard about too. But he didn't want to tell anyone about his foster parents. He has human enemies, so if it ever got out he lived, then they could find a trail and try to catch them. Marina says, wait, so is he like protecting them?

Catherine recalls something, hold on. Yeah. I remember this. They are with Home, aren't they. I mean before Echo forced them to run. I nod, yes. To this day, only Cassandra knows about them. Since she is in the city, even if she talks about them, Medrones won't care. But outside this city, some communities have beefs with Humans, Echo, Home or just normal humans. So being called out where they used to live is a big deal for David. Chelsea, holy shit. Doesn't that mean she is literally the leak. Does she know about this.

Blake says, its not for certain. Just like Ryes, I am highly suspect of this. And she doesn't know about it. Not yet at least. But I want you all to leave her alone. That’s because I will personally keep an eye on her. I say, David would do something familiar. He must have also thought what we suspect. He nods, most definitely. A rather long pause remains in the air. Then Derek says, seems you made up your mind on how to handle this. But you are telling quite a lot about this. Why trust us to tell us so much.

Blake says, take a look around us. I didn't chose you all just because you all are new. All of us were in tournament. And we fought someone involved in this. It took a second, but it clicked. Derek says, quite the clever team you formed. June and others understand too. Marina says sighs, I see. Now I understand why wanted Derek too. All of you have fought David. June scoffs, more like smoked. The twins become a little irritated being reminded of

that. Blake says, I wanted people that have seen him up close. This all started with his rumors of cheating. Setting aside the abilities he showed in finals, do you think he would cheat?

That question made them recall the tournament and their matches. David had joined the tournament initially to systematically defeat as many Citradel warriors as possible. I still don't know how he twiddled through games and rounds to get matched with so many Citradel warriors. Save for me and Marina, everyone here had fought him in the top 500. June says, it does sound a little absurd. He never used those things against me. He didn't need to struggle so much with me or Derek if he had that option.

Frank says, hey, I don't like that tone. You think he went easy on us. Chealse nostrils frails, yeah. We gave him a tough time too. While that is true, David wasn't serious about defeating them. He was just using them to gain attention. But the two of them also didn't believe he needed to cheat. Cathrine says, is that good enough for you Derek. He smiles, I didn't think you of all people would rub it in. But yeah, I do feel this just enough to give David the benefit of doubt and get our help. But why me. I am still with Citradel.

Blake says, I wanted you in for another reason. You see my thinking is that whoever is behind is, they are naturally wary of the new people. They would be much harder to snuff out. He says, you think I can help from outside. Blake says, exactly. I am not asking you to do something kafar doesn't want you to do. Instead I want to warn in advance and prepare for what I have planned. This was news to everyone, even Marina. Derek says, so generous. I can't tell if it’s a threat or not when you say it so ominously.

Blake says, its strange. I know, but I am going to tell you what Luther and I decided to do to avoid people from believing these lies. He says, I am guessing its not denying right. Because as much as I want to tell the truth about it, I don't think people will easily accept it. Marina says, you sound like David. He also didn't want to outright deny it. Derek says, it’s the most obvious, and a hard play. Ryes has given solid proofs. Even if they doctored, he said it first. People have already formed their opinion about it. It will be very hard to refute that, especially when none you seem to eager to share your past.

He was right. As much as I wanted to immediately tell everyone the truth, after spending just few hours with other officers, I begin to feel the slight pressure of how to make them believe us. Blake says, its not that. No matter how much I want to set the record straight, it won't help us in the long term. So we are going to do something else. And for that I needed you to understand our situation first. He says with conviction, you can't betray Kafar, I gather that much. But you can hinder his efforts, even if it goes against Citradel. There is a very fine, but clear distinction.

Derek smirks but doesn't say anything, likely signaling that Blake is right. Blake says, I am going to publicly blame this whole smuggling operations on Citradel.

David (Chapter 85)

Sunday, January 25, 2026 18:26

Are you listening to me kid. I answer lazily, yeah, yeah. No need to be loud. The voice on the other end of the phone says, no you are not. I can hear you thinking something else. I looked at the sunrise through the window my speed boat. The sun has just begin rising from far end of the ocean line. I answer, I can multi task. He grumbles, them multi task and tell me what you are going to do about it. I had so many things to worry about. For now I focus on him, because soon I will cross the city barrier and this call ends.

I answer, don't you think I know how it impacts us. He gets annoyed, then why did you do it. Your impulsive decision has cost of billions of dollar. I reply, 1.14 billon dollars. Not actually enough to make it a plural. He says, save your witty answers for others. I thought you would return the materials we got as a sort of trade for this, but no. You had the gall to take everything. I say, I need it for my other project. You know which one. I could hear him getting angrier now.

He spats, that was supposed to be done in slow perpetuity. Not in this bulk. You only met with the our guys and the local government officials. I am handling the real players. How do you think they will respond when I tell their investment is all gone in go. His anger is justified. But that doesn't mean I what I did was wrong. I had a major crashout when I heard about Ryes. If wasn't so tired and worn from the journey, I would have destroyed the whole apartment in anger, and not just the room I was in. That room is littered with broken pieces of the table and sofas. I had to pay the people I was staying with for the damages.

I answer, let me be clear. Its your job to handle the politics and money. Like you wanted. And I keep my end of the deal by keeping Echo, Home or Hive out from your operation. Now, could I have done things differently. Probably. But I couldn't wait for the other options. I had to settle this very quickly. I could hear him breathing hard. I continue, I also know it put a very big hole in our pockets. Its not lost on me that without them bank rolling us, we are in real trouble.

He barks, if you know all this. Then why haven't you traded from the materials. Lets sell it off and rake in the profits now. I answer, really now. When have you been so bothered by taking money and clear the debts so soon. He says, because this time I am trying to poach them into becoming our clients. Having them to invest in us will benefit us immensely. But we can't show our worth, if I can't show the fruits of their investment. Finally the truth comes out. I was waiting for the real reason. I knew it had to be something not related to money.

I laugh, I knew it. You greedy bastard. You used this opportunity to look for gullible wealthy people who are also unpredictable. You don't want to loose their interest in us. So thats why you are hurrying for this one. He stays quite a second, hold on. His voice lowering, you kept dodging my calls, just to make me reveal this. Didn't you. I smirk, I had enough time to prepare something for you. And I was going to tell you about it, but you were uncharacteristically too pushy about trading off something for the money. I wanted to know why.

He makes audible snarl and says, you freaker kid. You think you are so clever. I say, I am clever. Enough to know I anticipated this would happen, though I didn't knew you used money from prospects. I need to who these new groups are. He stayed silent, don't worry. I only care about their alliances. Since you approached them, they must be just dirty enough to met your requirement. I just want to check it for myself. If you don't want to tell me about them just yet, that's also fine. I am already busy right now. So I will check them out later. For now, at least tell me if how rich they are and what's their age.

He asks, their age. Does that matter. I say, of course it does. I want to show them something, something worth investing in us. But what if they are bunch of old people, almost ready to retire and just looking for fun. They might only find it amusing and not be serious about if. He asks, what exactly do you want to show them. I tell him about ART. Not too much, just the highlights. His voice finally becomes normal. He says, that project already progressed so ahead. I thought we wouldn't see it full potential for at least an year.

I answers, sometimes you get unexpected breakthroughs. Its still a prototype, but its functional and ready for a demonstration. I am not going to hand over anything, but these clients, if they are young, they would invest in it more seriously than old people looking who are in for just amusement. He finally gets what my intension is, they are mostly middle-age guys. And they have young families. And enormous connections rather than wealth. So yeah, they would have a more reasonable interest in us.

He then finally laughs, kid, you were just messing with me huh. I replied, I have a lot of things on my mind, I don't have to mess with you. Instead of going the longer approach of me going your back, as usual, I wanted to hear from you directly. He says, jeez. Just what made you mad so much. I sigh, it doesn't concern you. Someone has just openly threaten me and few others. Someone very dangerous. He says, you mean the guy you sent my men after. You didn't even tell the guys name, just a photo of him in a train. I have never seen you so nervous. I just found a while ago that you put a million dollar bounty on him.

I snarl, I would have preferred if you didn't know about it. Not so soon. He doesn't concern you. Just focus on getting us those clients of yours. My beef with that guy is just between the two of us. He finally backs down, all right. Messaged received. That guys has screwed the wrong person. And just because you have given such a nice gift, I will add another of my million on the bounty. I shout, don't but in. I just said stay out of it. He says, I am helping you out. More bounty hunters means you find this guy faster.

I say, he is not your typical person. He has alien technology you can't fathom. I put a observe request, its already difficult to do that. You putting more money would make people suspicious. He laughs, don't worry about that. You placed the bounty on the dark web. I got my own guys. And they are aware who he is, a Medrone. I really didn't want to involve him. But its true I need the help. Ryes may most definitely know who put him up to this.

M says, boss. We are going to be crossing the border in 2 minutes. I say to him, fine. If you trust those guys and they are aware of the danger, I will up the bounty to three mil. Add your two as well. He roars in laughter, so demanding. Just now you didn't want my help, but now you want to increase my share. Well, this is what I like about you. You know how to adapt to changing situations. I'll get it done. This guy has pissed you so much. We will find him, even if he is living inside a cave in the Himalayas.

I had to believe this much bounty haul will make people even more incentive to find him. I say, I am nearly here, so lets finish this up. I'll tell you later where and how the demonstration will happen. To keep them interested, I will share a video. Its your job to make them believe its not fake. I can't send ART in parts, it has to go all together. Also I can't do it very soon, maybe a time-frame of 2 weeks. He says, I can work my magic until then, keep them hooked for this long. But I need a location for this.

I think about it a little, somewhere in the ocean. He says, seriously. That’s it. I say, yeah. You said to keep him in anticipation. Isn't that good enough. He laughs, I guess so. You know, one of these days I am going to figure out where your island is. I smile, do you have a team of hackers trying to trace this phone. He chuckles not confirming this. I didn't want to give any hints, I am dropping the call. He says, such a poor sport. Fine, lets talk soon. The line disconnects as I get up from the seat.

I take the mini stair to the deck and feel the wind on my hairs. I speak loud into my watch, transmit transponders codes. After a while M says, codes accepted. I could see the tiny island coming into the far end of the view. The island is tiny, but the problems I am about to face is large. Now that I can focus on this, I needed to put my emotions aside. I was in complete disarray yesterday. I had hoped I would get rest in the flights. But the locals were not really happy when I plan to buy their properties. Not just that, I had to buy off local militias or government contractors for security.

And then yesterday was supposed a relaxing day. Get my body and mind recharged. But my capacious luck keeps butting in. Ryes had me going full on rampage in the room. Every lie coming out was a dagger thrusted deeper to my heart. I think at one point I was so mad, my eyes became wet with tear. My whole persona of a mysteries but dependable reputation has gone dog shit. The only solemn I have is that there was a deal with Heraknus. If that wasn’t already in place, this ploy to sabotage Citradel would be not truly efficient.

Citradel would fight much harder to get their resources back if Heraknus weren't moving. Most people had already given up and were going to follow Heraknus. But with Ryes ranting my entire past to people, there was a very good chance Charles would break the deal himself. He was already suspecting me earlier and had to send Melinda to confirm I wasn't cheating in the final. I don't know if it would be him or other pressuring him to break the deal. If that had happened, this whole tournament would have gone to waste. I couldn't let that happen. So instead of waiting or convincing Charles that these are lies, I went with the plan I never wanted to execute.

I never had such intension take away Citadel's resources. If it weren't for the circumstances, this plan would have forever remained in last resort section. I made this plan, if we had lost the tournament. That was before I saw decently strong people in Citradel. I could have imagined doing this in a future where we had truly lost. I had scraped that plan and decided to leave it up to fate later. And that ended with me in the finals. I never thought I would actually do this. Thank the heavens my contact told me about Ryes in time. I ask M, any news from our friend in Citradel.

M says, none boss. I suspect they have broken the interface too, since I am not getting a ping. That’s probably the right decision. Finding my source in Citradel is right now low on their list, but better to remain cautious since I have declared war on Citradel. I could see this go two ways, first one, they fight me. It would be long protracted political war demanding I give them their property back. The only viable threat they have is Heraknus. But I highly doubt they can stop Charles. If Citradel had that ability to that, they would have never acquiesced to Charles accepting the deal in the first place.

The other way, the difficult but also easy one, is for them to surrender. Our city is going to get a massive infrastructure boost. They would be stupid to overlook that. Their goal is also to make one big community we ever want a real stable society. I am very sure they are still trying to figure out which is best. The third way, which is highly unlikely, is they do nothing and wait for the dust to settle. They allow Heraknus to move here, but keep others in Citradel with their stagnated resources. I don't think it would happen, but its still a possibility I have to prepare.

I said earlier to others that I won't do more than this, that is still true. All these are eventualities that I am only being aware of. I'll follow Blakes lead. M says, boss connection to the network reestablished. Scanning through the news and message boards. It will take some time for M to analyze through it. So I manually scroll through the news orderly in the timeline. I began reading about the arrests of all the people. They didn’t mention Elina's name, but they said the victim has recovered completely.

Then I read all the people have been confirmed in their involvement and are going to wait for the tribal until Citradel arrives. Makes sense they postpone it since there is one confused and pissed off Citradel warrior in jail. So far no one has any proof of a third party involvement. Some people still believe it but there are no evidence. So those concerns are loosing its effect. People are more interested about punishing the guys, rather than knowing who did them in. Blake and Vanessa have done a good job keeping IDF and people focusing the criminals itself.

There were lot of theories floating around this. One article says they think Peter took advantage of the weakened warriors and finished them off with some of their own smuggled in weapons. Not a bad theory. Only people who didn't know Peter would think this. So far my plan had gone without a hitch. So much confusion has been caused, people don't believe one thing, they believe either nothing or everything. This is good, whoever is behind the scenes doesn't know I am onto them.

I would need to manipulate the situation even more now. People were confused about this situation. But now the confusion has shifted about my past. There is nothing worse for a Shadow to get his secrets revealed. Not just that, using them as weapons and against me. I still have no idea who the freak is it. I really wanted to suspect the small circle of people beside me. But this could be a double bluff strategy to keep me looking in wrong place. Its not impossible someone got to one us. Someone like Cassandra, who knew I lived in Greenville before. But its strange though, they could have just fabricated total lies. If the intention is to create doubt among the public mass, creating completely believable lies would still get the job done.

Instead they deliberately left out specifics. Just the events and added lies. That’s what made it even frustratingly mad. They had to know I killed Sophies dad, Rick. Saying that would make the lie even harder for me to refute, since that is actually true and theres a public record of this death. But they only talked about a cliché criminal beginning. The same about MARs subjects. They already know so much what happened in the Valley, they must know about Liz. So why not name her too, the people from Valley will know her. Adding such details would make it much harder to prove all this wrong.

Its possible they don't have complete information, and I was overthinking it. But I can't help the nagging feeling that someone is playing a game within a game. No doubt that denying any of this is infinitely harder now, since there are truth mixed in it. If it wasn't directed at me, I would be impressed. This is something I would have done too, but not at such a platform. To have phony but believable evidence, is something I don't prefer to do. Someone really clever is behind this.

I have been racking my brain all night on how to tackle this. People are going to go for my neck. Everyone loves to drag people down on from their high pedestal. Its a question of how to salvage my image. I thought about completely being neutral about it, like I was last time. But it won't fly with many people again. In a week, I am center of rumor twice. I could play it as coincidence and blame jealous people. Maybe even say a dirty tactic from Citradel to keep Heraknus.

But its not really enough to make them believe I am reliable. I had realized the way of this mess is to prove I am reliable, regardless of my actions, my decision or even personality. A person can be the worst kind, like Nathan, but still be called reliable. Its about general public perspective, not individual. I don't know when, but last night I recalled my time with Sophie. How she deals with things like this. Its funny, since she is not really the best person to learn this skill.

It was really interesting to think how she would approach this. She would say people are all selfish in the end. They don't care about the truth, just want excuse. She wasn't wrong about it. But she never really cared about others and what they thought. She could manipulate others into doing anything she wanted. I something wish I could do the cold logic like her. Like how I was really portrayed by Ryes. She doesn't have emotions like regret or fear, so doesn't feel pressured. I have crippled by both right now. I don't want to play on people's emotion.

I shook my head, frustrated at my naivete. I don't have much choice. I have to imagine she is here and embody her mindset. That’s the only I can get out this mess. I don't know what Blake has done to keep people the from panicking about me. I ask M, delay analyze on everything, just get me the partials on what happened yesterday. M says, scanning past 24 hours partials. A moment later she says, here are the results. I look at the news. Wow. I wasn't expecting this. Blake has gone nuclear. He is blaming the whole criminal operation on Citradel.

I didn't anticipate this move. This is bold, ridiculous and pure genius. After a half day of so called network shutdown for upgrade, the fist news flooding the network is about Blake officially accusing Citradel of the entire thing. Apparently Wyan has finally been cracked by IDF, he is saying he was hired by Ryes, got the tech from him and even had Quintin join him. This has to a big lie, no way Ryes is connected to the smugglers. Wait, the actual reports from IDF says he is suspecting its Ryes, but not sure if it is him. But a suspicion at a recently escaped person is believable. Wow, this a dangerous play from Blake. I see what he is trying to achieve here. They must have made a deal with Wyan, if he agree to point at Ryes, he gets a lighter sentence.

He is doing the same thing Ryes did, except to the people in the city. Throw a suspicious blame at Citradel, before everyone learns of Ryes interview. Its an risky plan, but its good. Ryes is on the run, either betraying Citradel or kidnapped, and Citradel can't refute this without Ryes. Blake is creating a smokescreen of the truth in all these lies. Now no one knows what to believe. If this narrative is done correctly, then it would look like Ryes tried to discredit me after he was about to be found it.

Ryes is being used as scapegoats from everyone. I am little worried about the people behind this and they plan to do with Ryes now. I am very mad at him, but its still possible he was blackmailed. That’s why I want him alive. But now, he will not be easy to find. Two communities gunning for him. If he was forced into this, I feel pity on him. However, this is good for me. I am a little more confident I can get out of this mess. I will still have a whole lot of scrutiny on my character, but if I play this correct, I can make everyone believe I am an asset to them.

I have to gain people's trust here. I recall Sophie saying once that she can imitate the emotion of the person in front of her and make them trust her just by her body language. I can't do that at her level. So I have to reveal a little bit truth here so that people will be satisfied. Its going to be a hard challenge. These are my one of the most gut retching experiences of my life. And I still have PTSD, I may be much better mentally, but anything could trigger me again. I have to be careful in what I say and how I say.

I ask M, is the analysis completed on the news. M says, 80 % completed boss. I see the island becoming larger, I have 40 minutes before I reach. This has to be enough to get understanding of the people opinions. I say, run the prediction algorithm on my choices based on the feeds and comments about Ryes slandering. M says, isolating the comments and running sentiment analysis. After about 10 minutes M says, I have the results boss. I ask, what is the successes probability if I deny everything about Ryes. M says, close to 38% satisfaction. I thought it would be worse, but clearly its not viable. I ask, what about staying quite.

M takes some more time this time for a prediction. Few minutes go by and she says, approximately 11 to 14 % satisfaction. Yeah, that makes sense. I can't have an indifferent opinion like how I was accused of cheating. Then I ask, how about me correcting those lies with the actual truth. I never want to do this because then it implicates others for those things. And that it will just create unnecessary distrust for the high ranking officers among the mass. M takes some time to crunch this new prediction. And then comes the response, around 46 to 53 %. Damn, this is brutal. I thought it would be a bit more higher. But just half the people will believe the actual truth. Even if this just a mathematical prediction, its still disheartening to see its so low, just one of two people.

Then I ask for the final prediction. This one takes the most time for M to process. I wait in anticipation as this is the only hope I have. M finally says after 5 minutes, its in the range of 80 to 95 %. Shit. I knew it this is only option that would work. And such a large gap, possibility because M has to take into account the various unknown variables. And M just proven in math what I believed true in psychology. After then I check with M with different prepared responses for the people. Some were good, others were still bad. Using her model prediction as a basis, I adjusted the details of the responses.

Just before I reach the island, I get a numerous texts and emails. M says, boss you are being flooded with huge number of messages. 22 % of them are spiteful and hate categories. I sigh at such a high number. I tell, hold all the these, don't delete them. There is a very low chance, but maybe the one behind everything has also messaged me. Analyze all suspicious messages and give me a report later. M says, running ancillary analysis. I say, also, tell me if any of the messages that mention anything about the real truth of the events. I would assume some people know they are lies and cross check any connection to the officers. If any names comes up, add it to the suspect list.

M says, objectives updated. Shall I recommend another task. Using the past days timeline and the spread of messages, I can formulate clusters of rumor origins in all the officers. This may reveal outliers that are potential suspects. I nod, yeah, do that too. M says, done. Also, you have many calls that I have blocked for you. I say, did anyone important call me. M shows me the list of people. I have many calls from the general public, so just swiped them away.

Then I notice Vanessa's name. I am a little vexed about her. We spoke 4 days ago and it ended badly. She did talk to me yesterday, but it was only because we were in a group. Knowing how stubborn she can be, she hasn't forgiven me. I say, call Vanessa. I don't know if the person on the other end is going to get angry for leaving her to deal with the mess with the smugglers or be the chief of IDF. After few tense rings, the line connects. Even though she picked up, she doesn't say anything. For a few seconds neither do I.

But this no time to be nervous. I ask, Vanessa. You there. She finally answers, I was just. Her tone wasn't angry, so may be its not that bad. She continues, no nothing. Before I get to the main stuff, I want to get somethings straight. I listen carefully, she says, I am not going to apologies for any of my behavior. I am sure you must have heard about it already. I was just carried away a bit. It won't happen again. What was she talking about. Is she still talking about how she responded when she caught me in a lie. Why is she feeling guilty about it. I was clearly in the wrong there.

I didn't have time to worry about her right now, so I say, I understand. You don't have to say anything more and I will not bring it up. We can still be professionals, despite our personal differences. I bluffed hoping that would ease her. She says, we can. Yes, that’s better. Besides, you have lot to worry about right now that broken trusts. She still jabs me with hurtful words. I muster myself and say, you got that right. You got Wyan to lie and put blame on Ryes.

She says, it was easier than I thought. Once we hacked the hard disk and got the first name, he was done. He no longer had any leverage. But then Blake got this crazy idea to use him. I don't like lying, but I subtly gave him hints about our situation and he caught on. To save his ass, he started making up stories about Ryes. He is nothing but an opportunistic snake. He was very convincing in coming up with a story that it neither lie nor far fetched. The result is a flurry of blame going on everywhere.

I say, I saw few of them on my way here. You guys might have just saved my ass. I wasn't very confident about getting out of this mess. Thanks. It was my sincere appreciation. She says, save it for later. You still have to deal with people demanding for answers. I asked all the officers to defer all the questions to you, so you better have a plan. I say, I do. She asks, and what is it. I say, before I explain that. Tell me I need to ask two things. First, are there reporters at the dock.

She says, unfortunately yes. We tried to hide your presence once you entered. But people found about it 5 minutes ago. They are all swarming in the pier, and we are trying to barricade them. I say, okay. Second thing, where is Cassandra. She pauses for a second, she is here too. I ask, anyway to get her out of here. She says with a exasperated tone, we tried. But she insists to be here. When she found about this, she went livid. She doesn't remember if she ever told anyone about where you used to live. Despite that, she thinks she somehow is the leak and is very guilty.

I can imagine her to be blaming herself. I hesitantly ask, is she the leak. Vanessa was somewhat reluctant to answer, no one is sure. Blake did ask not to pursue her. He himself is keeping an eye on her. I think he must have assigned a Shadow apprentice on her. I ask, I wanted to talk with her, but not under public view. She asks, what are you going do then. Are you going to deny it. I say, no. As infuriating it is for me, denying will not help. I will have to tell a version of the events which people will believe.

She says, you mean more lies. I can detect slight disapproving tone. I wasn't going to just take this from her, if these things were directed at you, how would you handle it? I ask her for her opinion. I was being defensive about my choice. She was the last person I should have to explain why lying is best for me right now. And yet I feel she is also the right person to explain my reasoning, would you tell the truth? You were there with me for better part of the years when I became active. Those vile things people are saying of me, do you think I can set it right and everything goes away.

She was quiet, the only sound was coming from my side of the water slashing beside the boat. After few seconds she says, I don't know what I would have done. I got an confused answer from her. I was wrong to put my frustration on her, but I needed to make her understand this. I say, I know its difficult. Imagine how I feel. You think its easy for me to lie to others. I was making it personal now. But I had to vent out a little bit of my anger on her.

She was somehow talking my ranting without rebutting. But I can't push it. She is still hurt by our last conversation. I back down and say, sorry. The stress of it is getting to me. I wasn't trying to put this on you. This whole situation is new territory for me. I rather fight the Charles than deal with this. I think that broke a little bit of tension there. She says, I don't like it, but I get it. Marina was defending you against some officers at dinner. But they were making it hard. I think I realize some situations cannot be handled the right way.

Is she saying its okay to lie then. A small hope builds up in me. But then she stomps it, don't think this changes anything between us. You can't manipulate me. I sigh, that wasn't my intension. I wish she stops thinking everything I do is lie. But I don't want to get into this with her, lets not waste more time. You must have called for something. What is it. She says in a grim voice, we want you to tell the people truth about you undermining Citradel. I ask confused, say what. You want me to publicly tell everyone that I sabotaged Citradel because Ryes came after me.

She says, Its non negotiable. You said yesterday you are okay to take the responsibility for you decision. You have made peace with whatever happens. So prove it. We want people to know it your personal decision, we weren't part of it. People haven't heard about your behind the scenes monopoly on the Citradel resources. We all discussed about it and decided its best for us if you tell it first. Before Citradel makes any move. I am not happy with this. I wanted to let Citradel come to the decision, on their own.

I ask, if I do this, won't it back fire. I haven't heard any major moves from Citradel. I know they have sent people and trying to stop from me acquiring their resources. But I have confidence that they won't get it. Even if they plan to steal it now, I have extracted 24 % of the deposits. By the time they actually decide to do anything about it, it will all over. Why should I poke them and influence their decision in any way. She says, its not about them. You keep thinking about Citradel, but you underestimate the panic in the city.

I ask, what do you mean. I have read the news, are you saying there is something else brewing amongst people. She says, there is no new issue going on. That’s not what I mean. Its the officers. They are giving off a vibe of confusion. Their subtle nervousness and silent judgement. Many officers are questioning Blake. Since none of us are explaining the Ryes lies, their faith is us has taken a hit. I know this is not your fault, and you might have saved us from a potential disaster by sabotaging Citradel. But while you saved our future, Its not enough to just assure people in the present.

I took few seconds to think about this. Maybe I was focusing a little much on the bigger picture and not enough to the officers. I assumed they would have same mentality as the general public. But it seems Ryes lies has done more damage than I previously anticipated. I ask, you think if I reveal that, the officers will get be reassured. She says, not exactly. Its not the ideal solution we are looking for. But if everyone hears you doing something so drastic, most people will question you, instead of us. Your past, your decision to fight back.

I answer, in short, you want to save your own ass while I take the heat. She didn't respond to my accusation. It must be it. I shake my head, is that why you offered to call me first. Kick me down when I am already at my low. She hastily replies, that’s not true. I didn't believe her. A part of her definitely wants me to be punished for lying to her. Breaking her trust. I girt my teeth in annoyance. I say, this is freaked up. Just because you guys can't handle the bad attention, you want me to take it. Just who came up with this idea.

There was a long pause. I sigh realizing, of course, it was you. Makes sense. I hurt you, now you want to take it on me. She rebukes, I told you its not like that. I just. She couldn't form the words. I ask, since you are asking me, even before I step on the island, you want me to tell people now. Isn't that right. Another long silence gave me an answer. I yell, freaking Ryes. I don't know if he is innocent or not. But the people using him as pawn are making it personal now. I know I have enemies, but what did I did to incur such animosity.

After a long moment of lingering tension in the wind she asks, what are you going to do then. I don't have time to think. The pier is beginning to appear now. With a heavy heart I say, fine. I did say I will take any repercussion from this. I can't go back on my word. She doesn't give her appreciation nor she consoles me. I don't think she wanted this, but she must be enjoying seeing me suffer. I can't do anything to fix our relationship right now. Then I had a thought and decided to add a condition. I add, tell Blake I will do it. I need a favor from you instead.

She asks confused, favor. What kind. Because if you want me to forgive you. You are crazy. I reply, I know that. That’s not what I mean. You have a compliant Wyan with you right now. Let me talk to him once, alone. No recording. I need to ask him something. She says, why. I answer, its about him accusing Elina and Ryan of stealing. She asks surprised, you think they did it. But didn't you tell Blake its not them. I say, I know they are most likely innocent. But I was there when Wyan was accusing them. I want to understand why he believed that when others weren't convinced.

She says, we have interrogated him days. He says it was just his intuition. Nothing else, no hard evidence. Why do you want to question him again. Do you not trust your friend, who has such unshakable faith in your fake self. I lean in forward, you talked to her about me. She says, I asked her about Mack. My arm slips from the railing of the boat. Freaking shit. I panicked hearing this from her. Why did she ask her about me, and as Mack. This sent me into a whole range of flurry of emotions. What did they both talk about.

Did Vanessa told Elina what I did and who I was. Shit. I underestimated how mad she is with me. I thought should would at least not involve me in any way with that. I had to calm down. I can still save it. I need to talk to Elina too and ask her not to tell anyone. But not right now. I say a little angry, well shit. I can't believe that after all I did to keep my involvement hidden, you go and tell the one person you shouldn't have. She immediately responds, what are you talking about. I didn't tell Elina about you.

I clench my jaw, of course you didn't. I am highly suspicious of her. I doubt Blake would have not done anything about it. Unless Vanessa spoke with Elina without him realizing. I say, forget it. Just tell me if you can allow for me to talk to Wyan. She thinks for a moment and tells, fine. But I need to be in room. Whatever you have to ask him, I need to know. Bloody girl is making me more harder to remain calm. I say, fine. Just you, no one else. She says, okay. Tell me when and I arrange for it. After a moment she asks, but why ask for permission. Why didn't you just do it without asking me.

I spat out, because I am trying hard to regain your trust. But you are making it even harder for me now. She pauses while talking in my sudden anger. I continue, whatever. I am reaching the pier. The next time you see me is in front of a camera, talking about the worst moments of my past, trying to get sympathy out of the lies. She didn't responds to me anymore. So I end the call and grab the railings in anger. This is so jarring. I kind of understand the position everyone is due to this. But now I have figure out a way to make it all about me, even the things I don't want to.

I slam the railings hard with my hands. It slightly hurt under the palm. I lead forward and stare at the ocean water zipping fast me. This is bad, I thought I had gotten my bearing back from yesterday, but clearly my emotions are not in control. I could literally have a nervous breakdown. I can't risk another on again in front of a camera.

Whoever is behind this. I am going to get you and I am going to freaking kill you.

Blake (Chapter 86)

Monday, January 26, 2026 23:31

A whole crowd of people were gathered around us. I think more than the last time when we were sending off Kafar and Charles. They were several reporters along the line talking about the current situation. I should have know it was fruitless to try and put a lid on this. Yesterday evening, we planned and accused Ryes backing the smugglers. I thought it would make things less crazy. But then Nathan told us about a new problem. The officers were not happy with us and some even were complaining to us whole day. I never thought it would become so bad.

Marina was this close to getting into a fight when an officer told she was probably faking being poisoned. I thought I had to worry about people, but now I had to worry about the moral among the officers too. Then we held a late night discussion, when resulted in a outrageous suggestion by Vanessa. She basically wants to focus everything on David, since he is already in a bad spotlight. Many were against it. But then Nathan smooth talked us into this. We have 3 new high ranking officers, I didn't want them to feel pressured since I already asked their help before.

And with great reluctance we decided to let David handle this. But when we asked who talk him into it, the last person in the city offered her assistance. I immediately told her not to, I offered to do it, even though I don't like it. But its better than using Vanessa into what, guilt trapping David into agreeing to it. She claims she only offered since she gave the idea. Since everyone just decided to leave it to her, I had to let it go. But then after the meeting, I spoke to her privately.

I ask, what is it you are trying to achieve here. She shrugs, nothing. I told you. I gave the idea, its only fair I tell him. I shake my head, no. You want to punish him. Don't you. You have been trying it for some time now. She makes a hard expression, that was a mistake. I am not trying to do get revenge on him. I say, it sounds like you are. Why not let me talk to him. She says, because I know if David talks to anyone, he will talk his way out. He will either say something to cover up or give a different solution. Only I will not back down from this.

I am surprised at the sheer distrust she has for him. How deep is her connection to freaking Wagner, that anyone who lies about him, she is so emotional that all reasons are thrown out the window. I say, if you know half the things about him, you wouldn't be like this. She snaps at me, there you go. He got you to trust him. Marina was always supporting him. But I thought you would see through it. I don't care what his reasons are, he keeps justifying his actions. I just can't take it.

I didn't want to make a scene with her again. I so wish I can tell her about Wagner. But the way she is behaving, that will only drive her further. I take a deep breath and say, fine. But don't antagonize him. The guy has already enough on his plate with the Ryes lies. She nods, I know. I am not heartless. I didn't say it to her, but I wasn't sure if it’s the right call. And now I am waiting for to finish her call with David. In the windy pier, a person comes beside me. Luther asks, there is too much wind in the air today. This is not the ideal location to allow David to talk to the reporters.

He was right, the wind had picked up more. There is no storm nearby, but there are some white clouds in the sky. I say, any suggestions. Behind her Tina says, well, we could take David to the officers building. Have him take the questions from his office. Would make it look more authoritative. Luther says, that is good idea. I rebuttal, no. All the officers are there, don't forget that. He would be surrounding by curious eyes. After what we discussed yesterday, I don't want anyone near him when he talks.

They both nod realizing my concern is valid. Luther says, that’s possible. We can't clear the entire building, not even the floor for him without making a scene. I thought a good place, his place. Isn't that better. Luther says, yeah. That is good. Familiar, more comfy and less space for people to hover on him. Tina says, and you get to talk to him also while on the way. Luther says, lets get a car for him. We will immediately get into one from the pier and take him to his place.

Tina asks, and what about the people here. I say, don't tell them anything for now. Pretty soon they are going to realize where we are taking him. Let them follow us behind. The more time we get with David, the better. They both get to work and talk to the officers about the change of plan. I stare at Vanessa's back and wait in anticipation. I can tell her aura is flickering quite fast. She may have a poker face, but inside she is feeling too many things. After the call ends, she comes to me with a confused look on her face.

Oh no. I felt a small despair. Did David decline for that unreasonable request. We really shouldn't have asked him to take the burden alone. She stops in front of me and says, he is in. I am shocked at the strange expression of hers. I asks, that's good. But why are so nervous. She hesitantly replies, he got angry. I ask, on whom. She says, I think at everyone. No, more towards me. This is a bad sign. I ask, but he agreed to do it. She nods, he also wants to talk to Wyan privately.

I am guessing he wants to know something about the stolen drugs. I ask, and did you. She says, I want to be there when he questions. I nod, a little relieved. We asking a lot of David. But she is still nervous about something. I ask, what is it. She says, I think this is getting to David more than I thought. I scratch my temple in reflex, how do you mean. She says, he didn't want to reveal about his plot to sabotage Citradel. I thought he would not like it, but agree to it. But he just snapped at me. I think the stress of his past being used against him is more than I thought.

I yell, shit. Did he actually say that. She says, I didn't expect him to be so down. I think I may have unintentionally provoked him by talking about Elina. I yell at her, Vanessa. What the hell are you trying to do. I keep asking you to lay off him, but you ignore it every time. She rebukes, but I didn't do anything. David just assumed things on his own. I grab my forehead, frustrated. Not on her, but myself. Why did I let to talk to David. I should have done it. This is bad, what if David has another PTSD trigger right in the middle of this.

Vanessa was even more nervous than me. We can't let this continue like this. I have tell Vanessa so she forgives David. Just as I made up my mind, Ruther comes running to us, David is here guys. I look turn my back and see the speed boat approaching. I can't tell David's expression from here. But it can't be good. In the strong windy air I shout, Tina. Get the car right now. I ran to the dock, with Vanessa behind me. David parks the boat and he steps on the wooden planks.

I could visibly see dark circles under his eyes. He has hair all messy and even few bandages under his arms. He carry's a rucksack bag on him. Ruther says, hey David. Let me get that for you. David tried to wave it off, but after Ruther not leaving his side, he relented and gave it. Thanks, he says. I walk to him, David. You look awful. David didn't have any humor left him in, that’s because I am. I had to endure so much crap, from Ryes, from Citradel, from the people bankrolling me. And now this. I wish you let me at least sleep for a while. I am so jet lagged I can sleep all day.

He was nervous. I could tell. He is rattled for some time now. It was unreasonable to assume he would be okay. He didn't even take a look at Vanessa and passed her by as he walks. I walk beside him, are you okay. I mean, for the reporters. I don't want add more pressure to you, but they are sure to ask you hard questions. He snaps, I freaking know. Ryes has royally screwed me. Ruther says, dude, we know. But you have a plan right. David seems too much in anger to response immediately.

And it doesn't help when a army of people watch from the sidelines. Some with curiosity, others questioning him. Luther brings in a car and says, get in. David asks, are we going somewhere. I answer while Ruther puts his bag in the backseat, this place is not good right now. So instead we are going to talk you home. You can clean up a little bit before talking to anyone. He says, good idea. I will feel more comfortable there. He gets in the passenger seat, while I go back with Vanessa.

But David calls out, not you Vanessa. Vanessa says, what. Why not. I have not been so anxious in a while about David getting pissed. David says, you used to not have a problem with how I normally do things. But since you don’t trust me anymore, I can't have you judging me as I lie. I need to have a clear head. I am too tired to argue and make any other excuse. Since you want honesty, this is me being that. David openly glares at her while Luther and Ruther look at me with tense expression.

Holy shit. She did it. I had warned her not to antagonize the guy, but she completely ignored me. I say, its fine Vanessa. You can help by having some officers around David's place so citizens don't bother us. Vanessa just stares at David, who already has his turned back on us and sitting in the car. I drag her out of her daze, did you hear me. Vanessa shuts the door saying in quite tone, fine. She wasn't really angry, she was just shocked at David being so straight with her.

I ask, Ruther, you get in instead. Ruther had no idea what drama was going on. He looks anxiously at Vanessa, who nods at him. With her approval, he gets in with me and Luther drives off. As we pass through the crowd, the people try hard to question David. The Kuret drones around the interviewers try to get glimpse of David through the window. Luther kept asking people to clear the way and they did after some officers helped. Soon we got of the shore and inside the city.

The four if us were in heavy anticipation in the car. I was focused on David, but not like them. I ask, seriously, are you fine. I was subtly questing his mental state. David says, obviously not. You saw me just now. You guys didn't make it easier by asking me to reveal about me sabotaging Citradel. Yesterday, I only wanted to tell you all this, not everyone. Luther says, I am very sorry David. I know this is bad. But we had no choice. No one is happy with this. David murmurs, I bet one person is.

Ruther asks, what was that. David says, I am saying I understand the problem you are facing. But this is exactly what the people behind Ryes wants. Cornering me for god knows what reason. I offer him some support, we don't know why. But you have a plan, yeah. David sighs, I do. But don't ask me about it. I am in terrible mood right now. He is really not talking this well. Even someone like him as a tolerance limit for this. Luther turns back to look at me with nervous eyes.

I couldn't reassure him of anything. Soon we reach his house. Somehow there were already few people gathered here. Ruther gets out of the car and asks them to clear. Once we park in the driveway front of his place, David says, give about 20 minutes. I'll get cleaned up. You can have all the reporters inside. And one you inside, no one else. I ask Luther, mind if I am the one inside with him. Luther was already ready to back off, its all you Blake. Try to calm him down.

I take his bag and we both rush inside his house. David says, M, did you prepare everything. M says, as per your request. He turns to me, take the reporters to the porch. There is enough space for six people. Do not allow anyone other than the reporters. I nod, I got this. He disappears into his room and shuts the door. Meanwhile I clear out the chair and tables on his porch and make space. With Luther coordinating outside, I ask Ruther to only let the reporters inside.

Soon people began to surround the house. Vaneesa and Tessa came in next, following a group of reporters in cars. Tessa rushes towards me, I have asked the reporters to wait for some time. I reply, let them setup in the porch. One by one each person comes in and setups their Kuretine instruments. Tessa ask, Ruther said something about David being weird. I am a little worried about him. I answer, I think we have may have underestimated his tolerance for bullshit.

She shakes her head, I have never seem him like this before. I don't know why, but I always thought him as a cool headed guy. Always in control of himself. She is beginning to see another side of him. Pretty soon everyone will. This is what they wanted, to cause mental agony on David. They probably knew they can't face him head on. That’s why they are sticking with such sneaky back stabbing. I say, you only knew him just recently. But some of us have seen him at his low. Honestly, for a while too I thought nothing would rattle him. But even he is not immune to conflicts.

She gives off a tense atmosphere while peaking at the side, towards Vanessa. She says, I might understand about David. What about her. She is also acting very strange, like she has a serious grudge against David. I can't explain the situation, its personal. Best for us to leave her alone. She says, I agree. The level of animosity she has towards David or anyone who sides with him so clear. Just what happened to her. I didn't have an words of assurance. We all resumed our jobs while David prepares himself. Some time later I later hear his room door opening.

David steps out with a fresh change of clothes and a cleaned face. He was hastily fixing his hair with a comb and walking towards me. He seemed to have relaxed, is everything ready. I reply, they are. He throws his comb over to the table and faces a mirror in the living room. He then catches the hoard of people surrounding his place. He grumbles, god damn. So many angry people. Just how much they distrust me. I say, forget about people's opinion. Don't let it bother you. He turns back to me, I know that. But its not easy. I have been gained this much attention before. At least not on my real self. And such a negative one. I can feel being a wanted human criminal is far easier to deal than this.

He closes his eyes and begins to take deep breaths. His face begins to calm down a little more. I whisper, you have to be honest here. Are you going to have a panic attack now. He opens his eyes in dreary heaviness, I want to she no. But I am not sure. PTSD is not something that goes away in a week. He seems to be more aware of himself now. He says, I just took a bunch of sedatives and pills. Right now I wasn't confident of handling this all on my own. I say, that's the right call. He looks around to the porch. He says, about my behavior, I don't want to make silly excuses. I was out of line. I have a million things going on in my brain.

I wave him, don't worry about it. I don't think anyone would be taking this better than you. I'll have already told to Luther and Ruther a while ago to cut you some slack. They also understand the burden we made you carry. His breathing becomes a little slow, good. Because I was unreasonably rude to Vanessa. She already hates me right now, I might have just made it worse. I say, I didn't want to butt in, but she is not thinking right when it comes to you. I bet she also knows this can't go on.

He asks, is it true she talked to Elina about me. I grit my teeth and gaze outside to Vanessa's back. She really wants to hurt David. I say, yeah. But she didn't reveal your identity. Elina never doubted you, saying that she believed you were lying to her. He asks with a narrow eyes, about what. I shrug, like your name and some other stuff. I shook his head in anger. He says, I shouldn't have involved Elina from the beginning. I should have just gone to anonymous trauma meeting like others. His guilt was now on his face.

I reply, don't doubt yourself. Not now. You did what you thought was right. Besides, think it this way. If you hadn't met her, we wouldn't have known about the smuggling operation and Elina may have died. You may think you involved her, but she involved you. For the first time his lips from a smile, that is different way to view this. I say, it is what it is. And if we hadn't found about them, we wouldn't have used them against Citradel. He chuckles now, seemingly back to his regular self, that was struck of genius and very ruthless.

I say, thanks. I wasn't about to let Citradel get away with this. They could have warned us what Ryes did. But instead they tried to hide it, while letting other communities judge our past. I am very certain Citradel would have played clueless if this had surfaced later. And by then even our people would begin to question us. He says, you mean me. Ryes motioned other names, but you don't have to treat this as everyone problem. Its a me problem now. I sigh, you are right. That the problem with rumors and fabricated accusations, you never know how they turn into.

He tells, I got the gist from Vanessa earlier. I don't like it. But I have no choice now. I did say I will accept any consequence for my actions. So I will try and shift the narrative. I ask, how exactly. You said you were going to lie. Isn't that dangerous. He replies, if not done correctly. But I am not going to just simply lie. I asked confused, then what is your plan. He says, I am going to use Ryes lies and make them the truth. As he walks away I remain momentarily frozen. Wait, what. What the hell does that mean.

But we didn't have time to talk. The reports sitting on the chairs in the porch begin preparing the Kuretine drones with camera. David waves to them, while the reporters start shouting questions at him. Besides the four usual people, Sasha, Vance, Giana and Terry, two more new reporters were here. I have not seem them before. Their name tags says, Barry and Lena. They must be new people. Each of them kept asking David as he takes his seat opposite to them.

Vance says, David, how much do know about Ryes and his accusations. Sasha says, do you plan to deny them today. Others were asking things like, how did Ryes learn about his past, is he involved in his disappearance. David had somehow brought out his serious face now. He wasn't putting on a performance like last time. I think he is about to get emotional this time. I step closer just enough to be away from the cameras and angle to his face. If it ever felt like he was about to crash out, I would shut this whole thing down.

At first David remains composed, letting all the reports finish the ranting. Vance says, David, aren't you going to say anything. He says, how can I do that when you all are not asking me questions. Instead you are demanding all at once. You will have to give me a chance to speak. I had a terrible time yesterday and have been flying across 4 continents. So you will have to forgive me if I am not as vibrant as usual. Gone was his cool and calm demeanor he has shown to the public. He was not going to take anyone shit anymore. I can't tell if this is intentional or not.

Barry says, apologies David. It wasn't our intent to cause you more trouble. Its just Chancellor Ryes has accused of many things. People want to know if they are true or not. Or if this is Citadel's last attempt to stop Heraknus from moving here. David says, and I am here to set the records straight. So I would advice a bit of your patience and more restraint. I will answer your every questions. Just go one by one. He was showing annoyance on him. Maybe deliberately.

Terry asks, are you involved in Chancellor Ryes disappearance after his interview. David says in a flat tone, I am not. I don't know where he is. But its not surprising he left. He left before Citradel could stop him. Vance asks, so you think Citradel is lying about that and is instead helping him. David says, I don't know anything about that. You will have to ask the Citradel council. I was halfway across the world when this happened, how would I be involved with him. Lena asks, you have human criminal friends. You could have abducted him.

At this David smiles, you think I had humans abduct Ryes, who has a decently powerful Kuret ability of controlling metals. And on top of that, have them break into and kidnap Ryes from a highly secure city. Do tell me, just who are these suicidal humans who would agree to it. Citradel has one of the toughest security on the planet, apart from ours. No Medrone can break in, let alone Humans with their rudimentary tech. Let me clear on this. I have am not in anyway involved in Ryes or his escape. Or why he would suddenly slander my past to everyone before leaving.

Vance asks, if you are not involved, why did Ryes tried to do this. David waves his hand, once someone catches him, he answer it himself. He made many ridiculous claims against me. I am here only to set the stories straight. Giana asks, so you are denying what he said about you. David becomes uncomfortable, like he doesn't want to be here. He then says, he found out things about my past but conveniently left out parts from it. And even twisting the things that happened to me.

Barry asks, sorry. Just to be clear, you are not denying them. You are saying they are the truth. David says, I am saying that Ryes told half truths. He made me turn into a villain by just revealing partial stuff about me. All the reporters were shocked to hear this. I saw their aura change in utter confusion. So did the people outside who where seeing the interview in their phones. My jaw hung loose at David's big fat lie. This is he what he meant, he isn't going to deny them. Instead he will stretch it out, like complete into more believe lies.

He is playing a very dangerous strategy. It will back fire at him very easily. Sasha says, I am sorry. Are you saying you poisoned Marina and cheated through the tournament. David says, no. That one is a blatant lie and completely outrageous. Don't you find it strange he gave proofs for other things, but he only accused me for this with no reason. That is completely false, just rambling of a misguided person. You think I can cheat so brazenly by poisoning Marina. Who apparently, won despite being poisoned and almost dying. You think she, who is a Shadow, would be so easy to catch off guard. I can't believe think people would think so little of me and my friend. She is a freaking overdrive user for bloody sake.

He takes a breath, if people still think I cheated, I ask them to meet all the strong people I fought. I doubt anyone would believe such crazy lie. You are only hurting them by believing Ryes lies that I could trick them. These people have fought Hive in real battle. You only tarnish their reputation by believing in Ryes empty words. Wow. He is going hard on the people. He is deftly defends himself and other warriors to his advantages. He is being visibly emotional about it as well. He says, so I ask people to consider this, just because I don't explain my abilities, doesn't make me a liar or a cheat. It makes me cautious and alive.

So far he hadn't lied about anything. I guess he wants to first make a passionate repones in the beginning. This even momentarily made the reports think for a second for their next question. Barry asks, so if this was a lie, are the rest the truth. David says, yes. The best way to make believe something, add the best lies to truth. Ask me about them and I will tell what really happened. Lena asks, then lets start it chronologically. Can you tell why you hid in Greenville for so long.

David doesn't respond immediately, instead he pulls out a small needle from his jacket pocket. My eyes squint when he stabs his palm with it and begins to bleed. What the hell is this about. Everyone here were stunned to see him self harm for suddenly. He winces in a little pain and then raises his arm to the cameras, what do you see. The reporters weren't sure so they remained quite. He continues and points to his bleeding palm, I can't heal. Even when I do this, he wraps his Kuret around his palm. But the blood still drips from his hands to his knees.

He continues, you all know I was one of subjects of MARs project. What it means is that my body can't assimilate Kuret. What it also means is that I don't have even a speck of Kuret immunity. After barely living on Medrine and I came to Earth. Suddenly being thrusted into a new environment, with pathogens, bacteria and virus crippled me to the hospital 90% of the time. My Earth guardians had to hide me while also help with my recovery. For years, I suffered through countless diseases. Typhoid, Malaria, Syphilis, TB and bunch of extinct diseases that haven't been on Earth for decades. Ryes conveniently skips out this part.

Holy mother. I didn't knew that. I knew he said he was sick a lot of time. But this the first time I am hearing the specifics about it. Vance asks, but he has photos of you living out in the open. David says, and I have other photos of me being in and out of hospitals. My guardians took photos to commensurate every time I get cured from a disease. With his uninjured hand, he pulls out a drive and tosses it to Vance. He caught it in surprise and holds it in front of everyone.

David says, I never talk about this part of my life because its frankly quite embarrassing. What kind of Medrone can be trusted when he has same weakness as Humans. Even something as simple as a common cold would be ridiculous. But since Ryes is calling me a coward, I rather be called weak and selfish. That drive contains a copy of all the photos of my hospital and medical data. I haven't seen the photos Ryes showed, he never shared it to anyone, but I am giving you the physical photos. Check their authenticity. See if they are fake. If someone people still believe it's a lie, I would ask them to meet Yana.

Terry asks, who? David says, she is the younger sister of the famous alpha Loid. Many people remember him. After arriving to earth she was supposed to be the next alpha, but couldn't become one because Earth has caused to have a vascular blood vessel disease. She needs constant blood transfusion. For many years, she to remain out of the fight, bide her time until she could find a way to mitigate her illness. Now she is an alpha who was in top 100. Her efforts are widely recognized and people praise her skills, despite her condition. I too had to struggle and just like her, I was only able to overcome my weakness only recently. There are so many stories like her. Ryes singled me out just because I made it to the top.

He already searched someone like him to relate. He is angry, but he is making it look like he is justified about it. The reporters were trained to remain impartial, but I see some speck of understanding in them. If David can bring them to their side, they would pull in other people too. Sasha, asks, so you needed time to adjust to Earth. David nods while pulling out a small cloth from his other jacket pocket and wraps his bleeding hand, lets move along, next question. Giana goes next, Ryes said you were responsible for the people who died five years ago in that horrific massacre. He has named several eye witnesses who saw you there. What happened there.

David suddenly turns somber, his eyes droopy, like they were in guilt. He says, what happened was I made a mistake. A terrible mistake of underestimating that Hive leader. I didn't get in time to the backup he had when he blew

up the building filled with people inside. He closes his eyes saying, those people wouldn't have died if I had figured out his plan sooner. I know you all have different account of that incident. I am not refuting anyone, because it was chaotic then. Ryes only told his side, I am telling my side.

Shit, he has taking it all on himself. I met David for the first time back then, but I know what really happened. He figured out the plan while me and Vanessa kept the Hive leader back. It wasn't his mistake, but ours. He triggered the bomb early noticing we were trying to stall him. David actually saved half the people. This is crazy, he is letting the lie continue for our sake. He says, with others kept him busy, I was supposed to disable the bombs. But I made a mistake. I didn't notice the trip circuit and 83 people died. I nearly died. If only I had more time, maybe I could have done things differently.

He opens his eyes and they become teary. His voice cracks a little with guilt now, that was one of the worst mistakes of my life. I should have been smarter. There was no one there that had any knowledge on how to diffuse the Hive tech. And I certainly didn't have the Kuret skills I have now back then. So it was a hasty decision that resulted in disaster. The guilt of that failure has haunted me very long. He shakes his head suddenly, but I learnt from it. I decided to never make the same mistake ever. I have to carry those people death all the time now.

Then suddenly he becomes angrier, Ryes has no right to criticize me or the people who were there. He wasn't in the war, he doesn't know what kind of split decisions a soldier, a warrior, has to make in the middle of a war. Where was Citradel in this, they could have sent reinforcement, maybe that would have changed the outcome. Instead they only arrive at the end, rescuing people with a small team. I am not going to let him slander me. I will instead take the blame from the families who lost then and the people who fought with us. But he has no right in judging me. And if anyone has anything to say to me, I ask them to consider what would they have done in a situation like this. If they say that they would have saved everyone, well, they are much better person than me.

What the freak. This is his plan. To go along with all the Ryes lies. I know we asked to take away the focus from us, but this is too much. But I can't stop him now. If I do, all this effort to will go in vain. David had moist eyes, I can't tell from anger or frustration of the lie. But he settle down a bit, any more questions. Barry asks, I am sorry to ask this David. If this was a honest mistake, why is Ryes claiming you responsible. David says, isn't it obvious. Discredit me. If I am defined by mistakes, then no amount of redemption that remove that stain. He wants Charles to know my past is loitered with bad decisions. If I may be responsible in that massacre, then everyone is. We were all fighting Hive, and we all lost. He just wants to exploit that loss and make it an example of our failures. But honestly, that’s bullshit. I would like to hear from him why he is making an enemy out of all of us.

His words are powerful. He most likely prepared them in advance. He is almost making be believe this to be true. He is strategically using us as shields and defends us at other times. This is a level of manipulation I have never seen from him before. Vance says, you are right about one things. One persons view is different than others. We need to definitely question Ryes motives here. Its working, a small hope blooms in this mess. Terry says, what about the accusation that you killed the MARs subject and then tried to stop it yourself.

David makes a show of taking a deep breath and calms down, what Ryes didn't tell was that those MARs subject, unlike me, had terminal ill. Many of them couldn't handle the Earth's atmosphere and had cancer. One of my friend, Liz, she had glioblastoma. Brain tumor. Which causes hallucinations and lapses in judgement. Near the end, she tried to do kill herself and everyone along with her. I stopped her, but then she persuaded me to help her die. I blink my eyes hard at this. Just what kind of story is he going to tell now.

Sasha asks, I am sorry. Did you say she wanted to die. He nods, yes. What they had was hardly called living. Ask the people who used to live in Valley. They will tell you that truth how those people were living. Separate from others, not even allowed to see because of their horrendous conditions. They were dying and offered their lives as a sacrifice if it helped Medrones to eliminate the weakness we have from Earth. No one from Valley talks about them, because people either didn't believe it to be true or refuse to be part of that sad story.

Mother of god. Its terrifying how he lied here. MAR's kids were experimented in secret, only scant few knew about them. He is using the Valley people's ignorance as a distraction of his lie. He says, when I saw how bad it had gotten, I relented and give them a painless death. The poison gas Ryes said I released, it was poison only to us. It reacted differently to them and they died without even feeling a thing. Barry says shocked, you admit you killed them. David leans back on his chair, I took their pain away. I told you, MAR's subject had negative reaction to Kuret. Everyone knows that. Nathan was even trying to help them, but there are sometimes no cure of things beyond your control.

I clench my teeth. Nathan didn't help them, he was only making it worse for them. Freak, I can see David bloody fist tightening up in anger as he had lie and cover for Nathan. Lena says, but they were important. Weren't they, don't you think it was wrong to give up. They could have helped so many others. David snarls, at what cost. They were in constant pain, they wanted to free from it. As a scientist, you may say it was a irrational move. But when you face a crying friend, begging to die and would do anything, take her own life, I like to see you choose what to do. I took most humane choice and helped them die peacefully. That is something not many get on Earth nowadays. I ask this to Ryes. What would he have done.

David is completely twisting the truth and looking for ways to get sympathies from people. And you know what, its very possible he may get it. Vance says, if that’s the case, why did you try to stop it. David says, Ryes showed you evidence me stopping the poison. What he didn't show you that there was a leak. The gas spread escaped through the vents. I wasn't going to let anyone else die, so I risked my own life to stop something I started. Everyone there would have seen me rushing to close the valve before it reached the Valley Kuretine groves. No one died during that incident. I wasn't going to make another mistake like before. This wasn't to impress others, this was about responsibility.

The way he speaks, his body posture, his timed voice trembles and his anger at untrue things. This all makes it incredibly true and easy to accept. I don’t know what's going through his mind, but making the lie even bigger is something only he can do. And people were eating it up. I can't tell how much, but the people outside were silently listening and have stopped being angry on him. David says, but Ryes is completely making be responsible for everything. He should not but in things he doesn't understand. No one from Citradel was there with us. So just listening to one sided story from disgruntled people is hardly the source of all truth. With careful weaving of the stories, David is making it look like he is the victim now.

Giana asks, such a terrible story. It seems Ryes didn't have the whole truth. David says, or he only told the parts that made me look bad. She nods. Barry asks, if you were against the experiments on MAR's subjects. Why did you tried to resist Nathan. I could see him clenching his fist even tighter. So much that more drops of blood was falling down on the floor. This was the time when he was out for revenge. David calmy answers, I told you, I had a friend Liz. She sacrificed her life. I wanted it to mean something. Using the research Nathan acquired I looked for Human subjects to test.

He then leans forward, to be very clear. I didn't harm any human, or any child. I only took their blood samples. I did not kidnap or kill any Humans in the name of experimentation as Ryes claims. He doesn't have any proof of this too. Just baseless accusation. But I have proof. I looked around children with the same diseases many of the Medrones have. I took tissue and other sample from kids who were cured from those terminal illness and tried to find a similar cure for Medrones.

Before anyone could ask for clarification, he asks, do any of you have kids. The reporter turn a little anxious being called out. Lena says, I have a daughter. David asks, how old is she. Lena says, she is 8. David says, that's great. She also had the check done like all the children come in. Would you mind telling us anything the doctors told you about her. Lena is confused. So were many wondering where is David going with this. Lean says, she is a healthy child. There is nothing wrong with her, if that’s what you are asking.

David nods, that’s good to hear. But there should be something else. Something specifically we tell to each parent when they step in the island. Something clicks in her mind, yeah. Now that I am reminded of it. I was told to give her a Kuretine drink for few days. It was something to boast her Kuret immunity, something called. David steps in, its called Repesomnal terial. I will spare you the jargon, basically it replenishes the missing Kuret in the children born in Earth now.

Huh, is that right. I did hear Nathan saying something about it a long time ago. I know we give supplements to children so they acclimatize to the sudden introduction to Kuret environment. But did Nathan did that. I realize what he plan to say for this specific issue. He says, this is the fruit of that labor. After years and months, we couldn’t find a cure for us, but at least we found a way to supplement what the kids born on Earth lack. This is same thing that Citradel does, we shared the formulae to them. So that every child will be not develop any earth born diseases like us.

Majority of the people didn't know the history behind this. People only care about saving their children, not learn history lesson on it developed. But it was Nathan who found this after his experiments on human children. He must have realized he can't actually dismiss every lies just by himself. He is stealing Nathan's discovery. Why is David doing it, wouldn't this enrage Nathan. Lena says, my word. I never realized that was the case. Barry says, but its been said that Nathan was the one who came up with this.

David nods, I helped him. Nathan was grateful enough to leave my name out of the public, because of what happened between us. Vance asks, what did happen between the two of you then. He says, as everyone knows. We kind of went through a tough time fighting each other. Ryes was right about us at each other throats. Nathan didn't want help from Humans. He didn't like Medrones being dependent on Humans. Anyone who knows Nathan would know that to be true. He refused to even let me work on my own, believing we Medrones should figure things out on our own.

What a wholesome lie. David continues, I don't completely disagree with that. But what Nathan failed to understand is that I wanted to use the knowledge of Humans for our benefit. A royal alpha like him didn't want to admit out weakness. And maybe I was being too hard on him. I really can't say which of us where right at that time. And so, with diverging ideology, we both fought. Anyone who was there would know that we both only wanted what was best of all Medrones. Once we settled our difference, we agreed to a compromise. Rather than using Humans as lab experiments, we stick to a slow but steady gene and Kuret research. Its not fast, but its better than us fighting over it.

I wouldn't have mind it if David had thrown more blame on Nathan. I suppose since he was basically stealing his achievement like this, he wanted give back some of his fake good reputation. Barry asks, so this how it happened. Did Ryes not know about this. David says, if he did and purposefully hid it to create another rift between me and Nathan, then he is worse than us. David supports Nathan and then uses him as a shield. I bet even Nathan wouldn't be minding such attention on him from now on.

Sasha asks, we will have talk to Nathan and ask if Ryes lied. David nods, you can't judge us when you don't know the whole story. Vance asks, he also mentioned about you killing a human to take over his criminal business. What do you have to say for that. David nostrils flare. Oh shit, that hit a sore spot on him. He says, I have nothing to add more. It just what he said, I killed someone and took over him. He was a bad guy who was doing inhuman stuff. And that’s all I am going to say about him.

Barry asks, you can't tell us why. David says, no. And it shouldn't matter. This is my business. That involve humans. As long as it doesn't effect Medrones, it doesn’t matter who I killed and why, does it. I doubt even Ryes knows about it, since he only say to turn me into a murderer. Well, here is a news flash. We all killers. Hive are also people, they have society and culture. And sure, they are a race of war mongrel hell bent on only on destruction and domination. But you wouldn't take a moment to hesitate and kill a defenseless Hive all alone. So I ask Ryes to cast aside his small things and leave that to the people like us. Our warriors, our officers.

Lena says, you might be right. Humans have hunted us, and they have killed some of us too. I doubt one less criminal human will make any difference. David really didn't want to talk about Sophie or her family. It makes sense, they are still alive, unlike Liz. Vance then says, please tell us about Oriana. We already have asked few people involved in the war last year and saw you taking to her.

My crossed arms fell down and I lean in closer. At the same time David looks at me with guilty eyes. Almost like he is apologizing in advance. The realization hits me after thinking over it a bit. He did the same thing earlier with Liz. I bit my lip in anger. This is not David's fault. I shouldn't be mad at him. I need to remain composed. This is about our future, not our past.

David has been dodging the blames by either accepting it or taking responsibility for it. He would also blame it on someone. He was going to put it all on Oriana, because dead people don't talk.

Vanessa (Chapter 87)

Tuesday, January 27, 2026 16:54

Peoples eyes never left the screen of their phones. Some of us were close enough to listen David from the front lawn, others were far and had to see the broadcast. But one thing was everyone, complete silence. David had everyone wrapped around his finger. The way he planned to get out of this was not to deny or tell the real truth. But make the lie into a reality. Freaking shit. No wonder he snapped at me earlier and didn't want me with him. I am sure my presence would cause him to flinch and second guess himself.

But what a lie. Every accusation Ryes threw at him, he took it head on. Not denying anything, but instead filling in the missing gaps. He even went as far so hype up Nathan. I never imagined he would go this far. Its vile to see how seamlessly he is able to wrap our perception of him. I know this was a desperate gamble, and I would never do it myself. But he wasn't wrong either. Many people behind me where not angry anymore. On the other hand, some felt sympathy for him.

I don't think he was even trying to hide his emotion. It was all over him. His anger, frustration and guilt. He was channeling it into his stories. This is by far the most complex, hardest, but the only way to reclaim his reputation. And after I while even I begin to believe those lies could easily be the truth. At least from others perspective. I could sense pain in his voice. He isn't acting that. Did I cause him that much pain. But he doesn't trust me. Why make me feel guilty about what he did.

I don't understand why he became so angry with me. I was so shocked earlier, that my own anger subsided. He didn’t even care if other officers heard him. I had to tell Ruther it was a misunderstanding between David and me for him to back off. I thought I would be making him only guilty, but his sudden anger at me makes me very suspicious about Elina. He clearly didn't want Elina to know about him. Just what kind of relationship these two have. But he wants to talk to Wyan. Did he not trust Elina, when she trusts him so much. I don't think Elina was complicit in anything.

I couldn't give it enough thought once David's interview started. And we are at a very sensitive topic about Oriana. Vance asks, David. Are you all right. I angle my self a little to see David's face. He turned away from Blake and says, yeah I heard. I was just wondering if any of you had to make a sacrifice. That question tripped the reporters. Davids voice angers, what am I saying. Of course you have. Everyone has done something to protect people they love. I am asking, if you know anyone who would die for you.

What is his angle now. David says, let me clear this up. Oriana was one of those people. I didn't manipulate Orina into doing anything. I only asked her to do the right thing. She betrayed is in our misguided war with Nathan. Did you know her parents were sick and needed help. Help that comes with a cost. That cost was us nearly dying. I won't tell how or why. I won't give this satisfaction to Ryes by mocking Oriana's death. What I will say is that I wanted her to repent her actions. I wanted her to believe that her actions were cruel, but not unforgivable.

His anger then turned to fury, was I wrong to ask of her. In retrospect, maybe. I didn't know she consumed with so much guilt she would completely forfeit her life for Blake. I am going to repeat myself, those who were not in the war have no right to judge me or Oriana. Especially not Ryes or Citradel. Who like always called in the cavalry too freaking late. Everyone deserves second chance, so did she. I am more mad at her than myself that she didn't get a chance to make things right with us.

What the freak. He is putting the blame on Blakes dead girlfriend. Just how far is he willing to go to save his lie. Lena asks, so you didn't ask her to die. David yells, freak no. I wanted her to live. To help us fight. Ryes believe I am so cold hearted and manipulative. Where is he now. He was only supposed to be only giving a debate, not go live and spew nonsense about people's death. He is the one who is using a people sacrifice to make everyone against me. He collected so much information on me, and yet he only tells one sided story. How is that any fair.

He is riling up the scene too much. I don't believe for a second this is a performance. He really is mad. He no longer cares about portraying a level headed guy. David says, Orina made a mistake, but I didn't held it against her so much that I would need to punish her. How could I when I myself am responsible for many deaths. That was the final straw for him. He stood up, I have read what people think about me. I am not angry at them, I just pity them because they believed Ryes so easily.

His body tenses and waves an index towards us, if anyone has any problem with me, say tell it to my face. Don’t be a coward like Ryes who tainted my past with half truths and just ran off. Lena says, but what about. David cuts her off, by now you must at least believe there is another side to anything Ryes has said. And I will be ready to explain it. But I want Ryes first. If he has so many things to say about me, why doesn’t come out and face me directly. It all started with a debate. So lets do that exactly. What's with his disappearing act without a trace, and how come no one from Citradel knows where he is. Not even his family.

Sasha says, you think Citradel is lying about him. David says, if they didn't know that Ryes might be involved with the smugglers, what else they might not know. I find it very suspicious they do all this just when they lost the tournament. It can't be just me who thinks the timing of this is just coincidence. Many of the Citradel warriors are joining us, full aware Citradel is not the right place for them anymore. Barry asks, but there is no proof of their involvement. He says, that means we just have to find it.

David is on a mission to bring down Citradel. Ah, I see. This is how plans to reveal what he did to them yesterday. Giana asks, they might not be related to any of this incident. David says, maybe not. But honestly, do you not find it even a bit suspicious. They tried to hide Ryes disappearance. Did you know that. They appointed his son, Winden, as the chief of staff. They didn't even wait a day to replace him. Sowing seeds of distrust on people. The same thing Ryes did to everyone. He continues, Blaming us for Marina's poisoning. Then almost a week ago it was rumors of cheating and now this. I don't trust Citradel anymore.

He continues, they used to be the safest place for Medrones on the planet. Maybe that’s still true. But is that the best place for your children. They might live in safety, but surrounded by people who only think about making enemy of me or our people. That’s no way to live. Our real enemy is the Hive. Something many have forgotten since they haven't attacked for long. He then takes a pause, and because I don't trust Citradel anymore, I don't believe they are going to honor the agreement between Charles and me. They are already doing whatever it takes to hurt me, hurt my friends. So in response, I have retaliated.

This is it. Sasha asks, what do you mean by that. He answers, I have bought all of the Citradels resources. Since they don't want to play fair, neither will I. I am going to ship all of their resources to our city. Citradel no longer has the resources to expand and let more people in. Meanwhile we have the space and the opportunity to make a far better city. This news causes a lost of murmurs and whispers behind us. He stuck to his promise and told everyone about it. Even giving a justifiable personal reason.

Giana asks, is that really true. You went behind Citadel's back. David says, I did. Yes. I don't believe for a second they thought about us. They didn't even tell me about it, I had to find it own my own. I have to face slander in front of the whole world. Drag me and my friends along our regretful past. While they says, oops, we totally forgot to tell you about it. He shakes his head, I want Ryes here. Unless he is brought and explain to me what made him go after me, I am not going to give back the resources.

This is incredible, he is making a show of using those resources as a bargaining chip to flush out Ryes. Damn you crazy genius, I have to give it to him. He knows how to play on the changing situation. Barry asks, what happens when Ryes is not caught. David scoffs, they you all a choice. He turns to the look straight at the camera, you decide if you want to go to Citradel, the safest place on Earth. Or to our city, the place where we fight back. At that last line he turns his back to the reports, that’s all for today. If you want to question me more, bring me Ryes first.

He passes Blake near the door, while the reporters try to follow him in. This was a chaos, David just left the scene so angry that it felt justified. Blake stops the people with his arm. He had a fowl expression on him, that’s enough people. You asked and he answered. I suggest you give him some time to rest. And if he agrees to it, you can all question him again later.

The reporters were clearly not satisfied. But its not they could force their way in, not when their prince is giving them a hard glare. They back off and apologies to him. Lena says, we didn't mean to upset him so much. His is all right. Blake says, don't worry about him. He had a rough week. This wasn't a lie. His word were lies, but not his intent. And I feel even more guilty now. I thought I wasn't fazed by my cold behavior. But clearly, it wasn't all of it. He was just better at hiding it.

One by one reporters leave David's house. People gathered here had mixed reactions. But if I had to say which was more, it was anger and confusion. Most of them wanted to believe David, others at least doubted his reckless decisions. But at least no was angry at him. I tell Ruther, lets get the people out of here. Ruther nods, all right people. The show is over. The officers follow his suit and make people leave the property. Soon Blake comes out of the door.

As soon as he left, the door shuts hard behind him. All the window turn to tint black. Blake looks at the house, I guess we won't seem him again today. I answer, did you know he was planning for this. Blake responds, no. He just gave me vague answer just before doing it. I honestly, can't believe David did that. I answer, he said he was going to lie, I just assumed it would be things about Ryes. To discredit him. I didn't expect this. Blake says, I am sure no one expected this.

He then hesitantly says, and yet I hate to say it. But he. I gave him a subtle nod, he was believable. So much so that I would have preferred some of those lies to be true. I was talking about our mistake which David took it upon himself. We didn't stop the Hive leader from blowing up the building. David saved us, not the other way around. Tessa comes beside me with a forlorn face, that was not how I expected this would go down. I am assuming by the look on your faces while David spoke, that it wasn't the truth.

Blake says, far from it. Tessa nods, I assumed so. I don't want to put pressure on you, but the reporters asking for you. Blake says, to confirm what David said. Tessa shrugs, and not just you. Most of the high ranking officers. I am in no mood to talk about any of this mess. Seems Blake was on the same page, tell them no. And especially Nathan. I need to talk to him immediately. He turns to me, pass on the message that no one is going to talk to reporters for anything related to David or Ryes. If they want to talk about Citradel or the smugglers though, that’s fine.

I agree with a nod. He then walks a bit away from us. Then his brings his Kuret to envelope himself and take off into the sky. At this time Nathan would must be at the officers building. Tessa and me coordinate the officers to handle the press. There were very persistent, but we had enough of a drama today. Luther comes to us, where did Blake go. Tessa says, to Nathan. Only he is the unpredictable guy who might screw up David's story. Luther scoffs, you know, I wasn't really confident about this. David was freaking out earlier. I wasn't sure he would be able to pull it off. But that was something else. He sold his story so good, I couldn't believe it. Even now I am terrified how angry he became.

Others notices it too. It was genuine reaction from David that really makes every people believe him. Tessa asks, so whats the plan now. David did what we asked of him. Probably even more so. Luther says, I know it feels sudden, but we have to focus on our work for our infrastructure expansion. Last night Tina led a team to get the materials from the ships they intercepted. They are talking a longer approach to avoid detection. But we will soon have all the construction materials to enrich Kuret. We had a unpredictable few days. Dealing with the smugglers and now this. But David's effort will all go to waste if we don't start making progress.

I ask, what if Citradel doesn't send those team. We don't have the skills or the tech to do enrich them with Kuret. Luther says, yeah, about that. Turns out they send them anyways yesterday night. I gasp, what. Why would Citradel do that. Luther says, I asked the same to Blake. He said something about Derek helping us without Kafar knowing. I realize what happened. Yesterday, when we were in our secret meeting. He told Derek subtly that he can help us. That’s why he warned him beforehand. Derek knew a shit storm is about to them, so he must have rushed for the teams departure.

Tessa asks, that’s incredible. So they are on they way. I ask, won't they turn back if Citradel calls them back. Luther says, they have a lot of tech and machines with them. Their route is planned and scheduled by the hour. Going back now with that much stuff is going to be very difficult. Still, its possible. So we already sent a team to them. I asked them to use force if they try to escape. But these people are architects, designers and scientists. They are care about their work, and not about politics. The people guarding them may pose a problem. But not much.

I understood his thinking. He says, best they can do is stall. We have very lucrative incentive for them to come work for us now. We are getting the raw materials instead of Citradel. They will soon realize its best to stick with the plan and come to us. That made sense. Blake and Derek planned this very well. Tessa says, what about Citradel then. They haven't contacted us, but soon they will. I say, let them. We have them by their balls. They screwed up with Ryes and made an enemy of us.

Luther corrects me, of David. I wasn't certain how serious David was until I saw the pics of 8 ships he sent last night. The guy actually made it happen. Tina says, based on the estimate of Titanium he sent, its already about 10% of the total deposit. Citradel has been slowly mining it, but he did 3 months of mining in 3 days without humans noticing it. Dude's got some seriously powerful friends. Did he really took over someone's criminal organization. He immediately backs down when I glare at him.

Tessa says, don't even joke about it right now. Luther panics saying, sorry. I get it, it’s a very sensitive topic among you guys. I won't press for any details. David lied big time to save our asses by taking too much of a blame. I turn to the closed house, unsure of what happened to David. Luther says, anyways. That’s the plan for now. We finally have some breathing space to begin working on our expansion plans. If Citradel contacts us, we will handle it then. Until then, lets just get back on track.

He was right to keep our focus on the goal. There are so many things to worry about, but its not the right time right now. The rest of the day we spent back in our offices. The officers attitude wasn't changed too much. It was highly unlikely that they would immediately back off. But I could definitely sense less wariness from them before by lunch. I was able to get some work done. The hot topic all morning was about David's interview. His passionate filled words resonated very strongly with people. Its too early to say what impact it would make. But suffice to say, it feels a slightly different scene from yesterday.

Even during our lunch, we had people asking us about David, and if he is doing okay. There was a growing concern about his current state. Most people have not seen this side of him, so its not surprising. I went to IDF after lunch. At the entrance I see June waiting to me. I ask, did you wait too long. She shakes her head, not much. I didn't want to be late on the first day. Blake has assigned her to me. I didn't object because she was definitely a great addition to our team.

As we both walk around the place to let her get a feel for the place. Surprisingly she didn't ask about David's interview. She instead talked about the different jobs and sections we have. After the tour was over I finally asked, why didn't you ask about David. She smiles, I figured it wasn't my business to ask. I saw his interview. And I don't know what is true and what isn't, but I know it was personal. I don't understand much of politics, but I know people don't want to talk about their personal business.
☐I chuckle, you will definitely fit in this pace. She says, lets hope so. Then I let her meet our fellow high ranking officers in IDF. Sommers says, welcome to IDF. What do you think. She says, different than Citradels place. Junes thinks for a second, I would say this is much better. We have bigger building, but its filled with humans. So we have to be very careful of that. Also, I saw you have prison cells in the next building. That is much better arrangement what we have.

I remember a little when I visited Citradel last time, it’s the same as the county jail with a secret inner basement section. She nods, yup. Its a pain every time we have to capture an escapee. Ruther says, you have escapees. She nods, of course. The cells we have are advance, but past that we don’t have any Medrones stationed. But don't worry, they would be caught immediately. We have humans not only for cover, we can use them to track their movement too.

So that’s the trade off they have. Seems difficult for us to comprehend how they would work so seamlessly, but that’s just because we haven't lived there long enough. Sommers tells, you don't want to worry about that anymore. Here you can use your Kuret freely. I remember you can fly right, our own chief does that very often. She smiles, it would be a little awkward for me. I don't like to stand out unnecessary. Besides, I can't really fly. Its just levitating against gravity. Not really convenient for travel.

Deni says, that still cool. Come on, let us show you your desk. June says, I already have one in the officers building. Sommers says, of course. We all have one there. But we have one here too when we are working here. June got excited to know about her second work place. I guess this is something Citradel can't do. While they help her sort out her new place and job. I get to work on mine. I had a bunch of tasks I hadn't looked at for last 4 days. Since the expansion plan didn't involved much security upgrades and IDF, my work was more business as usual.

I reviewed the plans again and reassigned the team we formed the day after the tournament. With so much disturbance for past few days, it was actually good to do resume our mundane activities. It was around 8 that I got a message from David. He wants to come in after dinner to IDF and talk to Wyan today. I thought he would take the day off. What is so urgent about this. Since I had no idea when he would arrive, I decided to stay for dinner inside IDF. I had some officer grab some dinner for me on his way back.

I waited in anticipation at my desk as I eat my food. What do I do when he arrives. He was in a fowl mood with me this morning. Would he still be angry. But why am I stressing about that. I should be the one who is mad at him. I haven't forgotten that he lied about Wagner. I can't let it go, no matter how much I want to. I was too lost in thought as I ate completely distracted from my surrounding. A voice comes, are you done with that. You don't have any food left in that box.

It was David. I jerk and push back my chair. He was standing in front of me and observing me stare at my empty food box. I dust of my hands and stood back up, when did you arrive. I think he slept off the whole day, because his eyes were much brighter than before. He also changed out of his clothes. He answers, I didn't want anyone to see me. I look behind him, even though we have skeleton crew at night. How did no one saw him. I got annoyed at him, did you just break into IDF without anyone noticing.

He didn't respond and instead says, lets not waste time. You promised to let me talk to Wyan. Or did you change your mind about it. I stare at his flat face. He was not going to make any small talk. Actually, I preferred it this way too. It would just turn into messy argument otherwise. I wave my hand, follow me. He tags behind me as we walk to prison cell we were holding Wyan in. David looks around the outside of the prison cell. It was just the two of right now. He asks, did you clear the crew.

I nod, I asked them to take a break. I planned to be her till around 11, so a bunch of locked up criminals are no threat when I am here. He says, good. Then lets get on with it. He raised his arm and speaks to his watch, M, loop the camera for next 15 minutes. And let me know if anyone approaches us. M says, done boss. I get annoyed, don't just hack our security. He scoffs, I didn't hack anything. I have the access codes that works when you haven't used yours.

He just nonchalantly tells me this now. He didn't even explain more and just goes towards the window of the Wyans prison cell. He was in his usual posture of sitting cross legged on the bed. He used to be so much reluctant to use it for sitting, saying it was dirty or beneath him. But we have cracked three names by now from his encrypted device, he has lost all sense of superiority. He knows he is screwed now. I thought David would enter now, but instead he stays still.

I ask, what. Don't tell me you don't want me to go in. Because that’s the only way I will allow you in. He turns to me with an annoyed look. Was he really being angry with me. Before I could ask to change his attitude towards me, he says, its not that. I am just preparing a little. I ask, for what. He turns to me, for this. I didn't see from this angle, but he was actually using his Kuret. More accurately, he was making his Kuret storm. I ask, what are you doing. I didn't say you can hurt him.

He snaps, stop judging me. Its fine if you don't trust me right now, but don't just assume stuff. I am not going to hurt him. I don't want him to know I was questioning him. So I am preparing a Kuret that will confuse him and also make him compliant. That’s what he meant earlier. He didn't have to be so rude to me, I set it aside for now. I take a step back when he pulled more Kuret around him. The last time I had seen him use it this close was during the tournament when me and Matt were helping him from being thrown away to the barrier.

Two minutes goes by and his wild Kuret stabilizes into a storm. Even after seeing it so close for the second time, I can't understand how he is is able to change Kuret. He walks to the door and pushes it open with his foot. He points his mini Kuret storm to the door and fires a Kuret. This was a yellow Kuret. I think I have seen it somewhere before. He said he wanted Wyan dulled, maybe he copied one of the tournament warrior Kuret. Wyan notices the Kuret and shrieks, what the hell. What is this. Help.

He tried to shout, but he reacted took late. The yellow Kuret blast had filled up the entire space inside. He got off the bed and tried to run, but he slumps back on the bed as fast he got up. David says, he is cooked. Lets go in now. I follow him instead. I prepared a little bit of my own Kuret around me to keep the yellow Kuret away. David says, no need for that. His black Kuret runs around the air wildly and cleans up the excess Kuret. This Kuret of his was far stronger than I have seen it before. I had almost forgotten that he fought Charles with this Kuret, he had to gain enough power to do that.

After few more seconds of Wyan breathing in that yellow Kuret, he becomes completely inebriated. He makes weird expression on his face. I ask, is he drunk. David says, close enough to that. He switches to a different Kuret next. This one expands from his Kuret storm and envelopes the whole room in a thin invisible barrier. I see small glints of Kuret at the edges. I ask, what is this. David says, a sound barrier. I can't have make a sudden loud noise. Damn. Just what kind of ability is this.

I doubt he would explain how he can do this. So I just let him do his work. Once the sound bubble is stable around us, he switches into another Kuret. This one was familiar, it was Rose's Kuret. But he didn't keep that for long. It was probably for just three seconds and he dispels his Kuret storm. I ask, why did you stop at just this much Kuret. I have seen Rose use it many times now. She uses more than this. He responds, a Medrone mind can only sustain so much of Kuret effects. I already have dulled his senses, if I use too much of Rose Kuret it might work against it and he would wake up. I have never tried this before, so don't know what kind of tolerance people have. But he doesn't have a strong Kuret, so this much should be enough.

That made sense. Its incredible to see him use his Kuret outside of the coliseum. I ask, is this how you fooled Cory and others too. Use different Kuret on them. He turns to me and doesn't answer. Instead tries to observe me, like he was trying to figure out something. I say, what. He says, lets just focus on the him. So that’s how we wants to be. Fine by me. David says, Wyan. Can you hear me. Wyan body was slumped with his back on the wall and his neck tilting down sideways. With his eyes closed and jaw loose, he looked exactly someone who is drunk off his ass.

Wyan grumbles a little but didn't respond. David leans and snaps his fingers around his ears, wake up Wyan. I need to talk to you. Wyan grumbles, shut up Sara. Go away. David leans back, who's she. Before I could answer, M says, its his girlfriend boss. Actually ex now. David smiles, well. I guess now I now how much Rose's Kuret worked on him. He already has M with him who has all the data on Wyan. He came prepared, that not surprising. He says, Wyan. Its Sara. I need you help me out with something.

I can't tell if he is serious about roleplaying like this. But Wyan grumbles, go away. I am busy with Irina right now. David says, two timing bastard. Well, its both of us. Sara and Irina. We have questions for you. Wyan chokes up a little, you two are together here. Lets forget about talking baby, come on. Lets use our mouths for something else. The hell he is, I was about to smack his face. But David grabs me my arm and signals me to back off. I shove him off and raise my hands. Fine, I'll let him handle this looser.

David says, that’s why we are here. But you know, we heard something awful. You are interested in another girl. Wyan cries, what. Who told you that. David says, Grover. He said he saw you with someone girl named Elina. Jeez,

its like seeing a more hyper focused Rose working. I should have used David instead of Rose. She'd danced around them far more than needed. Wyan says, he lies. That bitch is a two face liar. David faces turns grim. I was curious about this now. Wyan has always been adamant about this. But now maybe I will get to know more why he believed that.

David asks, why do think that. She seems so innocent. Didn't even knew her own brother was a smuggler. Wyan laughs, of course she didn't. She is dumb bitch. Lets forget about her though. Come on, ladies. He raises his arm, he is trying to grab them. David raises his arm like he was about to punch him, but then he puts his fist away. He says, not before you tell explain why you are so sure she is lying. Wyan snarls at us. David says, if you tell us, we both will do the thing you like.

Wyan perks up, even though his eyes are closed. He says excited, you mean that. David says, yeah. What is this type of interrogation going on. So different than Rose, yet so familiar. Wyan says, don't break your promise. Okay, you know I don't like girls who lie. We both patiently wait for him to spill more details. He says, that freaker Peter was using her sister good. She has a good body and nice tits, but is not so bright in here. He taps his head with his palm, I wasn't even buying one second of her weak little act. I know she stole the drugs.

David asks, I don't understand. She doesn't know about Peter's real job, why do you believe so much she stole it. Wyan says, she is opportunistic women. It takes one to see one. She must have figured out sometime ago and thought to sell of our stuff to get more money. Bitch thought we wouldn't notice. But I keep track of everything. David says, you have no proof of that, you only assumed that since others were clean. It could have been someone else who stole.

Wyan waves his index finger and signals no to us, task, you both are dumb too. I know it was her. I have kept tabs on her. The only thing besides her looks is her need for money. Peter was giving her enough dough to keep her ignorant, but she is just as greedy as me. Their youngest one, Rotan. She noticed same symptoms on him as hers and believes soon it will develop into the same problem as her. She wanted to save up enough money to get the Kuretines that can cure him early. So she will looking for anywhere to get money from. Even if that meant stealing from me. Dumb bitch thinks she can steal for me. I need to teach her a lesson.

I couldn't keep it together, call her a bitch one more time. I dare you. Wyan yells, who is there. David faces me and grabs me by the arm. I try to get off, but he was too frustrated at me and held his grip tight. He looks at Wyan and then at me. He then says, Wyan. You need to help us. Its Elina, she is here. Wyan barks, what. I should have recognized that voice. Give me my drugs bitch. Did he really confuse me with Elina. Because I have been talking to him so often, he must vaguely recall me. David let goes of my arm and motions me to be silent. He says, she isn't leaving. She says that you are liar.

Wyan snaps, you bitch. Let me get my hands on you. He waves his arms around the empty air. David says, she isn't budging Wyan. I think she wants to know why you keep suspecting her. She knows nothing. He says, trust me ladies, she is lying. I know it. This isn't going anywhere. He is really just assuming its her without any actual proof. I knew it, he was just throwing hot air. David says, you told us last time there was a way to prove it. Maybe you tell us now so that it make Elina run away.

What is he talking about. Wait, he was there. He might have heard something Wyan hasn't told us. Wyan says, huh? Oh that. Yeah. Nice one Sara. I knew you had a something better than that tiny ass. He makes slapping motion in the air. Just how much are we going to make him make a fool of himself. David says, please tell us. Wyan says, I was going to ask Peter to bring out our ledger. I got anxious, what do you mean by that. Wyan says, I won't let you go away again. He arms fails around the air again.

David didn't interrupt me this time. Probably thinking it was for the best for me question him now. I say, what do you mean by Peter has a ledger. He says he doesn't have anything. Wyan laughs, I am not talking about his ledger. I said I was going to ask him to get it. Your brother is coward, but he is still smarter than you. He said to keep a backup record of every order you make. Make it easier to track and tamper your records with just enough so you never find about it.

A backup records. That will exactly tell what were her actual shipments, and not the doctored one. Tessa had a tough time following this lead because it was difficult to figure out what was tampered. But if we have the original, it becomes simple. I ask, Peter didn't say anything about. Wyan laughs, because he never has seen it. Like hell I will let your brother get his grubby hands on it. He would change the records himself and no one know about it. I have sealed it an Kuretine lock and gave it to him.

David says, Sara here. Why would you keep the book with Peter. Wyan says, Sara babe, don't you know I am very cautious. I am never going to keep something such dangerous with me. Its better to keep it with her brother, he is basically a patsy. He can't open it, or lay his eyes on it. Its genius isn't it. David clicks his tongue, it is. You are so clever. I think he really is impressed with this trash. David says, where is this book now. Wyan mood turns sour, she stole it. Peter said it was stolen along with the drugs.

I push my lips in anger, you are kidding me. That was stolen too. Wyan barks, don't play the victim. I know you stole it. You live in the same place as Peter. That's why I am know you stole the drugs. Is that all he was basing it on. I say, you dumbass. If someone was good enough to steal drugs from you, they can easily break into her house and steal it. Wyan says, its you bitch. Don't lie. You stole the drugs. Give it back to me. You screwed up everything. Everything was fine until you came in.

David shook his head, that's all. Irina and I don't believe it. Even after the security you have in place, you think Elina can just steal it under your nose. Wyan says, that's why I kept asking her, who helped her. She must have hired someone to do her dirty job. David says, so now she is hiring people to steal from you. Wyan shrieks, yes. Exactly. Nothing else makes sense. They must have saved her in that hanger. David says, but I thought someone betrayed you. He wails, I am telling you bitch, everyone is in on it. Elina, Grover and even Peter. They are framing me.

David had enough of this. He walks away from him seemingly given up. Wyan says, don't go away Sara and Irina. I telling you. They all are just using me. Even that bitch Vanessa. She has got a even smaller brain than Elina. Making me use as a weapon against Citradel for such ridiculous things. I don't care about Citradel. I care about me. Oh no he didn't. David didn't even raise a finger to stop me. I punch him straight in his cheek. I think I broke his jaw as he winces his face in pain. His loud yell dies down immediately when he slumps down sideways to the bed.

It finally felt good to shut him up. David remains quite, seemed like he was enjoying it. I ask, will he remember any of this. David shrugs, don't know. Maybe he would assume this was a dream. Or a nightmare. He walks to him and grabs his arm and pulls on him. I ask, what are you doing. He says, can't leave him with a broken bones. It won't heal by tomorrow morning. I can't have him claim IDF brutality even if he deserves it. Its good he is here, because no way I was going to help this trash.

David prepares another Kuret storm. This one he prepares pretty quickly. He throws Johnathan's healing Kuret on Wyan's face. Soon his jaws sets back and he bruises go away. He then looks are the drops of blood trickling to his shirt. He says, I can't do anything about that. I say, leave it. Let him think he has a nosebleed or something like that. You already healed his face. He says, fair enough. I didn't realize but the sound barrier was gone. That was enough time.

I ask, so this all for nothing. David says, perhaps. But at least you know about the other records they keep. I say, what's the point. We have searched everyone's places. We didn't find anything like it. Whoever stole the drugs, also stole the book. He says thinking, it does look like that. But. He is lost in his thoughts. I ask, what. You believe Elina stole the drugs and the book. He says, I didn't say that. I am only confused why steal the book. What could be in it that is so important to risk breaking into their home.

He wouldn't be suspicious about it for no reason. I ask, you think that book contains some damaging info. Perhaps they didn't want us to know Elina's order and actual shipment discrepancy. He suddenly turns to me, what did say. I say, what. I am asking what kind of information would be there be just from bunch of shipment orders. It have been useful to us before we had cracked the hard disk, but now its not really important. He says, right. Not important to you guys. But maybe, its important for someone else. He was staring into the wall, deep in thoughts.

Did he figure out something. I ask, do you know something. He shakes his head, no. Nothing. I thought I made a connection, but it doesn't add up. I had a thought that maybe they stole other things too. That's probably the only thing that makes even sense to steal the book. I ask, stole something else. Like what. He says, don't know. I am just spit balling here. It could be just nothing and maybe a misdirection to throw us off. After yesterday, I am not dismissing any possibility.

He is weirdly making sense. There could be something else in the book that could give us some clue. David says, anyways. I'll leave that to you. I was only here to know why he kept terrorizing Elina. Turns out it was all a hunch and nothing else. He walks out though the door like nothing happened. I rush behind him, hey. Wait. That's it. You are done. You won't even see Elina. He stops in his track and turns to me, why. I answers, oh I don't know, Guilt? You have lied to her. And she still trusts you so much. She deserves to know the truth.

I guess he picked up my real intent as he walks up to me, what I tell her has nothing to do with you. You and I have our own issues. Don't involve her in it. He kept a straight face while he spoke. The nerve of him, I don't believe it. You won't even see her. He says, I already saw her. While you were staring at your food. I checked on both of them. If you are suggesting I come clean to her about me. Think again. Right now I am subject of everyone's scrutiny. And anyone beside me is a target. Ryes declared a war on me. So don't think I am being cold to her just because I am being a coward.

Something has changed. He never used to be so direct with me. But now, its like he has nothing holding him back. He continues, don't start talking about trust. Because I already know how you feel. All I am saying is leave Elina out of it. She is suffered enough. I came here just to know for sure about her involvement. Nothing more. I already took the blame for things I didn't do. It may be weird to say this, but its better when I am blamed for correct reasons. I know I am using Elina. But not in the way you think. I ask, what. How do you mean.

He clicks her mouth, forget it. I mean it. You are usually so rational about so many things, but when it comes to certain someone, you lose all reasoning. I got angry, what are you implying. He says, I am not saying anything. Just leave Elina alone. He turns his back to me, since this pretty much shows Elina is innocent. I hope you can clear her and let her go. I yell, I don't orders from you. He replies, it wasn't an order. It was a request. I just don't want to see her cry to sleep every night.

He knows about that too. I might have jumped the gun thinking he didn't care about her. He has been keeping an eye on her. I saw his back disappearing from the corner. I pull myself out of my thoughts and run after him. He can't leave from that side. The late night shift starts soon. They will see him. I turned around the corner to stop him, but I stop immediately. He was nowhere to be seen. How the hell did he do that. I didn't see any doors he walked through.

An officer comes and ask me, Vanessa. Are you looking for someone. I ask him, did you see any guy walking here. He looks around the place, a guy. No. I just came in. Didn't see anyone.

David (Chapter 88)

Wednesday, January 28, 2026 11:01

Things have been going normal for the past two days. After my epic emotional nervous breakdown in front of everyone, I stayed in my house the whole day. The exhaustion had hit me so much I didn't realize that I slept all the way till night. I wanted to stay hidden the house, away from people. I don't know if I can handle any more of their stares or gossiping behind my back. This sort of stuff never used to bother me. But Ryes had changed it. He exposed me in front of the whole world. This is the downside of have fame. I always knew there would be people not happy with me, but I thought it would happen later. I never imagined it to be so soon.

I had to shake off that duress, because I had an opportunity to talk to Wyan. Its still bothers me that he would make Elina suffer through much on just a hunch. After an awkward talk with Vanessa, I got the real reason he was so adamant about her involvement. Certainly, from his perspective Elina would be a prime suspect. If both the drugs and the book had been stolen, his behavior made sense. But all other things like Elina hiring someone to steal the drugs is just a wild conjecture. IDF has gone through everyone financials with fine comb tooth. Elina doesn't have any other thing to trade off in exchange of hiring people.

But something Vanessa said made me come up with a theory. A totally unfounded one that doesn't make sense. But then again, I couldn't really dismiss it too. I need to see the recording of their interrogation. Wyans and Grovers. And Elina's too. I don't want to come to any conclusion right now.

I was heavily jet lagged and once I had my dinner I slept again. The sedatives I took helped me have a peaceful sleep. I half imagined being haunted by the nightmares or hearing his voice again. But when I woke up, I was fine. No, I was feeling much better. I had a continues stress inducing days. Having to sleep and wake up normally felt like a bliss. I was lazy yesterday morning, reviewing the progress of the material shipments. I had to make some calls also to coordinate some hurdles in the village in Ewaka.

Citradel had sent few of their council members to negotiate their contracts. I had a good laugh when the local chief said they were exchanging other things like tech to purify their local river. Citradel were underestimating me. My small misdirection worked. I have been telling everyone that I was buying the land, like giving them cash. But that’s not completely true. These are rural towns. Sending them cash wouldn't help them if they don't know how to efficiently use them. So instead of sending hard cash, I sent money to a organization that helps in building better infrastructure.

I already negotiated a deal to build roads, better homes, electricity, fertilize their farm land, water purification plants and an aqueduct. I knew Citradel would think I made a mistake and waste valuable time sending their higher ups first. The chief said they couldn't offer anything else valuable to them and they left after failing to persuade them. They would have a better response if they weren't thinned out from so many things. Searching for Ryes, planning for Heraknus travel and dealing the pressure from Blakes blame on them. But still, I am very sure that Citradel have a backup plan to steal the money should this fail.

So stalling for time was important. M showed that the ores and mineral extraction had been only 25%. I need to be at least double of this much to make a significant blow to Citradel. I made calls all morning warning the security people and government about possible interventions. I was reassured by them that they are guarding the machines and mining people all the time. But its not enough. Based on the latest projections, its going to take another week or so.

I was dancing around with different strategies to stall for more time. Because I know that no matter what security these people have, if Citradel sends even one warriors, they stand zero chance. The security was a layer of protection from other humans interference. And that’s when I figured out a very risky plan. It would be attracting a lot of eyes, from everyone. But I can handle the other side of this, Citradel can't. I checked with him if had any news stations as our clients.

He gave a very long list. I smile at the sheer amount of information control this guy posses. But for now I need only few. I arranged for the news station heads to meet with the organization in charge of building the infrastructure of the town. I had them talk about a collaboration and making a documentary of the town. This gives a spotlight on the organization and the people in the city. It took whole day of me talking and making this collaboration as fast as possible. This couldn't happen in a day or two. They needed more time to finalize the scheduling, travel and other various things. I put pressure on the station head using our mutual friends name, he agreed to send out few crews to the city ahead to start filming the progress of the town immediately.

I told the lady that she wouldn't be able to get good footage and the viewership if she waits long. I promised her that the construction is going be fast paced and all over the town. She would get lot of viewers if the filming crew would record it from the start. And the charity organization would benefit from the exposure as well. Its a win a win if they agree to start the ground work immediately while they hash out all other corporate stuff. And they agreed. In the next 10 hours, a big crew with camera's and recording equipment's were on their to that small town in Africa. I told the village chief of this, he wasn't happy about it. But he understood that while the mine would dry up and I would leave, their town would continue to benefit from this.

After a grueling day of work, I ask M to end the hundredth call. I was exhausted by making other arrangements similar to this, under a different organization and buyer in other towns and city. Some were semi urban areas, so they already knew how to invest in the cash. I received a message that Citradel had sent people to Germany as well. They offered them double the money to buy the land back from me. But that’s not even legally possible. They seemed to even trying bribing them.

Unfortunately Citradel came up short on that front too. If bribing would have worked on the people governing there, I would have already done it. That’s why I went with the expensive route to just the mountain and its land for a private resort. I don't know what exactly to do with the land once the ores are extracted from the veins. I hope the client who paid for it would think of something. So far none of Citradel direct approach would work. What would have been a guarantee was Blake sending some of our people to protect the mining team. But that’s never going to happen.

I ask M, any suspicious activity from Citradel. M says, nothing out of the ordinary boss. I can't track their locations in any cameras or satellite surveillance. Well, they weren't going to be so easy to find. They are incredibly skilled in travelling without detection. I ask, and anything from our contact in Citradel. M says, still no response. Should we be worried. I reply, no. This is just a precaution. Otherwise we would have gotten an urgent extraction request. Lets wait a bit longer. I am only worried about any people Citradel sends to sabotage the mining crew or their equipment's.

They should have a very tough time making any noise with so many scrutiny on the towns I could get media attention from Humans. That should stall them, hopefully long enough that its extracted. The next move they could make is intercepting the mined materials while it is on the move. Hijacking it during road transportation is possible, but unlikely due to risk of involving police for the theft of such precious materials. Then the logical move is during the ship transport. The ocean is so large and not everything is tracked by satellite. They could steal it much more safety there.

In anticipation of this, I had asked the transport crews to split the ores into smaller containers and transport it via different routes. Now Citradel people won't be able to recover all it once. Its very possible they might intercept few of them, but not all. The materials transportation cost and time will increase due to this, but its far more reliable. I let M decide the best routes and different check points, like switching trucks, cargo, ships and crews to add layers of deception to Citradel.

When I finished my dinner, M gave a modified itinerary plan. After some minor modifications I sent to the team in charge of transport. I gave them an excuse that there was threat from some environmental extremist group and needed extra caution while transporting. They complied since they already suspected something was strange about the hastiness and amount of materials they had. I gave them extra bonuses to let their mind be at ease. Even if Citradel pirates them, they are not going to harm the Humans.

I was completely exhausted now. I lay on my bed. I wish I could sleep in my actual house. I don't feel enough secure right now. But I had to send ART away to our R & D team. Seems they had some breakthrough with interface and they might have a way to fix the defense mechanism system. That’s actually good timing. Because many people know about it now. And I can't have a dangerous weapon with me. They said it could take another 2 weeks to test out the new changes. I gave them a deadline since I also have to send ART for a demonstration to the new clients.

M says, boss. Would you like to read the news articles about you. I have complied them for you. I reply, no. I don't think I am ready to read them. I have been purposefully avoiding them since yesterday. I had a lot of trepidation about my public display of anger and self pity. I rather not know what people think. At least not tonight. I had already stretched my mental capacity to block Citradel from any encroachment.

Yesterday, Blake and Marina had messaged me that our training would begin from tomorrow. They needed some time to come with a plan. That actually made me happy knowing they were taking it seriously too. I took a quick shower and dozed off immediately to get all the rest I could for tomorrow. I thought I would have night terror or maybe just a nightmare. But nothing, I woke up fine. I did sweat a little hard last night, but that’s nothing compared to the time I was suffering in the first month.

They both could only spare an hour today morning. They need to head back after 8 AM. Since this is the first day, I know it would be mostly preparing. I'll take any help I get from them. I put a lightweight track pants and jacket and head out to the spot in Section 4 they asked me to meet. I took my normal car to the rocky shore GPS location he sent. When I step out of the car, I smelt the salt from the ocean waves hitting the sandy beach. This is actually a busy place later in the morning.

I thought we would be in a secluded place. But its possible they both wanted to be open, in public view. I don't want people to see me training my Kuret abilities. Not until the match with Charles is done. I hear a sound of wind in the sky. I lean away from the car hood and take a few steps as Blake lands on the sandy ground. Blake was dressed in causal clothes like me. He says, dude. What did you do. This is not boding already. He had sense of surprise in his voice.

I ask, what happened now. I gave a slight smile trying to think if I screwed up anything. He says, Citradel is furious with you man. Oh, that’s what he meant. I shrug, what's new. I bet they aren't happy with the both of us. He says, I can't deny that. But I got a call from Derek around 3 AM in the morning. He says you have screwed up their plans and Citradel are livid. I says, and by their plans, you mean? He says, they sent out two teams to the cities they get their materials from. One was a diplomatic team to try and negotiate a deal. And another team sabotage the mining equipment's, stop them from extracting the materials.

I answer, I already know about that. I spent the entire yesterday to undermine Citradel. I wasn't sure how effective it was, since I didn't see anything suspicious in the news. But from your reaction. He nods, Derek said the team almost destroyed the machines, but had to back away since there were filming the entire town. Tell me you didn't just use a filming crew to stop them. I chuckle, what Citradel values more than anything is their discretion. They might be able to destroy the machines, even under the filming crew's eyes. But that will involve the police then. The best they would achieve is stalling for time.

Blake then laughs mockingly, I can't believe this. Derek and I weren't sure until now if this was really you. Because it's a risky plan. There are so many eyes on those cities now. I say, true. But I rather see those materials be confiscated by the governments than Citradel getting it. They know that too. I am sure they will have take some time for their next move. Blake says, Derek was conflicted, he wanted to praise you and curse you at the same time. Just imagining that made me proud of my decisions.

I say, and what the technical team they sent. Pretty sure they were called back after yesterday. Blake says, just as we predicted. They are stuck with a hard choice. They had travelled two thirds of the distance before Citradel asked them to bunker down at a checkpoint. We have team there trying to negotiate. I sent both Luther and Tina, because it needed more personal touch. I nod, so for the time being they are at a statement. Blake says, it would have been better if they had reached us a little early. But, he shrugs, I guess this is not bad too.

It was best of the most chaotic situation. Blake asks, hold on. You didn't know about that Luther and Tina. I thought for sure you would already know about it. I wave my hand at him, past two days I have shut myself in the house. I didn't see anyone nor did I look up anything happening in the city. I was getting a much deserved rest. And like I said, I was completely focused on stopping Citradel yesterday. Blake shocked says, that long huh. Well, you did take an very difficult task.

Since he brought it up, I had to apologize to him. My voice becomes low, listen. About Oriana. I am sorry. I was pressed for time and I had no good option. Blake fortunately understood the plight I was stuck in, thanks man. I know you didn't want to do it. I could see you slightly trembling near the end. He did caught that moment I had slight tremors on my hands had to grab the seat to hide it. I sigh, I really didn't want to use Oriana like that. He nods, its not your fault. You did what I couldn't, and it was needed. It was Ryes who brought it up and lied. We asked to take the heat for us too. It would be unfair of me to be angry with you about it.

I was glad he wasn't mad about it. The small linger doubt vanished from me. He says, you do seem a little better since then. I crack my neck, the pressure had gotten to me. I have no excuse. He smiles, I would be more worried if you hadn't. You shouldn't have needed to do it if it weren't for someone who is betraying us. I ask, I couldn't do much investigation on that. Did you have any luck. He says, not much. But I do have something in motion, with some people. He explained about the Citradel warriors he included to spy on the officers.

I say, It's good idea. I think I saw June in IDF when I talked to Wyan, where did the twins go. Blake says, Frank went to Nathans team. I had to warn him about being very cautious about that. But he said it would be fine, so I assigned Nathan to the R & D department. I say, did Nathan agree to this. Because I basically stole his achievements. Blake says, I had a talk with him. He didn't mind since you put his name under a positive light. Most of the people in Valley would not be contradicting your stories, since they didn't know everything. But some do know the truth, Nathan said he would keep them quiet. No one wants to be involved in that mess anymore.

I says, that’s a surprise. I was sure to believe Nathan would resist or ask for something in response. Blake says, he knows asking more would just aggravate us. He should be happy with this much. I had no choice but to trust Nathan right now. He continues, Chealse went Tina's department with logistics. She thinks she can fit better with accounting work. I say, I don't know why, but I thought the twins would be in same department. Blake says, I know right. I was surprised too. Frank said it was just a gimmick in Citradel about having same interest. They wanted to explore different things here.

As long they are excited to belong here, it should be okay. Blake asks, I heard from Vanessa about your chat with Wyan. She thinks there must be something with the missing ledger. I needed to be careful in my words here. I don't want to make trouble for Elina, possibly. That’s just a wild guess. I might have mistakenly led her to read too much into this theory. Blake says, maybe. Because while she released Elina and Ryan, she has them in surveillance and scheduled check ins.

I say, she did huh. I hoped Vanessa would release them after the final missing piece. I ask, what do you plan to do with the two of them. He says, for now I asked Elina to remain insider her house all the time and not to talk to people. Especially about Peter or his smuggling operation. I ask, and her job. He scratches his chin, Vanessa asked about that too. Unfortunately, I can't let her open her bar. Even if she is innocent, I can't. Its a consensus among the officers that her bar has to be closed off for a little longer. Besides, people are suspecting her involvement. So I doubt that even if she reopen it, anyone will go to her. Elina wasn't happy about it too, but I think she was smart enough to know that lying low is better for her.

Considering the situation, that’s the best decision. Fortunately, she has enough money right now to sustain her self for weeks. But that’s only materialistic things. She has no moral support right now. Blake sees me a little disappointed, sorry dude. I know she is your friend. I couldn't veto others. I says, its not that. I was just wondering what it would take to let her get back on her feet. Blake says, honestly. Its difficult to say. Maybe just give her some time. People might start suspecting her less, and maybe get back the public trust.

I say, the IDF and officers need to also be able to trust her, right. He nods, the constant check-ins definitely makes Elina less trustworthy. I am not in a position to help her right now. Getting involved with her will make only make things more complicated. I say, thanks for the update. I just wanted to be aware of it. Not like I can do anything about it. He says, yeah. Its best if she first settles herself and Ryan before worrying about the future. As much as you and me want to help her out, we have other things to prioritize first. I guess I have to put the matter of Elina for another day.

He looks around the beach, Marina's late as usual. I shouldn't have asked her for late night reports on her blueprints. She stayed up late last night going over her designs for Heraknus community. I says, did Heraknus contact her. Even with the state Citradel is in right now. He smiles, you should have read the news. Well, I'll let her tell you about it. He seems to be excited about it, so it must be good news then. He then asks, since I have you here. I want to ask you something.

I say, sure. His pushes his mouth together and makes a confused face, I have been thinking about my Dad yesterday. You told there were some strange things in Shadow history. Like Dad choosing someone outside family. I cross my arms to his confusion, did you figure something out. He says, I am not sure. I wanted to ask you if know if have heard about Kinsley. I try to recall this name for a moment, no. I don't think I know anyone by that. He says, shucks, I thought maybe you would know if she was a Shadow before Wagner.

I say, before Wagner. What do you mean. I only saw Slater and Wagner in that summit. He says, but its possible that she was one too, but not present there. I says, you mean she died. He shakes his head, not died, but clinically brain dead. I had to take a step back, who is Kinsley. He clarifies, my older cousin. She is around 8 years older than me and would have been around the same age as Wagner. She was a talented girl in our house. Even when she couldn't receive the alpha powers, she displayed unique ability to imbued Kuret into things.

That’s impressive, Blake can also do it, but only using hid mothers bloodline ability. She could do it without it. I say, that takes some serious skill. He says, exactly. She couldn't maintain it for long, but it was a feat almost no one could do. I remember Dad saying she was very popular. I see what he is getting at, you think your Dad chose her before Wagner. He says, I have been trying to recall. Even talked to Nathan to confirm when she was injured. It was around the time Wagner would have joined the shadow.

I ask, hold on. What are you implying. He says, I don't know. But ever since you told the truth about Wagner, I have been thinking what lengths he to go. We already know is not beyond threaten children as a diversion. So maybe. I stop him, I am not the right person to ask this. Do I believe he would kill people for personal reasons, I wouldn't put past him. And if he did that, my fist tighten in sudden anger, he is even worse than I ever believed. He says, so there is a possibility.

I could tell he was too much conflicted by this. I don't have an answer that can reassure him. Honestly, if someone else asked me if Wagner killed a royal bloodline member for their spot in Shadows. I wouldn't hesitate for a second to its possibility. But this is Blake and his family we are talking about. While I was thinking what to say, I hear a whooshing sound in the air. I turn up and saw Marina approaching us from the sky. I turn to Blake, I don't have a definite answer for you Blake. The only thing I could suggest is to leave the past. I know its pretty ironic coming from a guy stuck with PTSD from past, but that’s why I implore you. Whatever happened, it doesn't change our present.

He says, I am trying to do that. Its just I have been wondering a lot about Dad's choices. I guess I was just thinking what I can do better. Is he having doubts about his shadow recruit. Its not something for me to intrude. Let him decide how to proceed. Marina lands on the beach with a bag on one shoulder. She was wearing jogging shorts and a top. She was hyper agitated, dammit. I am late aren't I. This is bad, people will thing I am tardy. I say, what people. Blake says, people already think that.

She makes a pouting expression to us. She then walks to me, before we start, I want to know if you are okay. Her concern was evident on the sudden change in demeanor, thanks Marina. I am better than yesterday. That much I can say for sure. She nods, thank the Kuret. You had me worried when you just stormed off in anger from the interview. I wanted to be there, but Blake here said too many people would only stress you out more. I smile, nah. Never. If you there, I would have been more relaxed. She gets excited, see. I told you. Blake answers, Don't twist my words. I was talking about you putting other officers in duress.

She clicks her tongue, tsk, whatever. I thought about checking up on you, but I figured you needed the rest. I say, appreciate that. I haven't had rest for a while. I needed to cool off. She says, but not your brain. She chuckles, I heard about Citradel pissed off at you. Blake says, who told you. She says, please. You think Derek is the only there. I got friends too. Blake says unsure, really. A friends you didn't recommend along with Derek. She says, I didn't want to involve in something risky. Isn't it better to have some allies there too. Blake says, that makes sense.

I had a thought. I ask her, how much do you trust this person. She asks, why. I explain, I have a friend in Citradel too. He pretty risked a lot to send the message about Ryes. Without him, we would have been pretty much screwed. And we haven't been in contact since last three days. Its obvious that he has gone silent to protect himself. But since I couldn’t do anything from here, I am a little concerned. Can you ask your friend to check on him, or at lease give any indication that he is trouble.

Marina says without hesitation, I can ask. He is eager to help us out in any way possible. I nod, my contact's name is Jack. He is the head of the communication department of Citradel. He had access to the secure lines of Citradel network setup, that's how he got me the info. Blake says, that’s a very sensitive department to have connection to. How did you pull him in to your side. I say, I didn't. I recruited him 3 years ago and asked him to spy for me in Citradel. Both gazes fell upon me surprised.

Marina says, freak. Now that’s some serious dedication from him. Blake says, he has been with them for years, without them realizing it. I say, he is from the same bloodline as the guy Nathan has than can camouflage into his surrounding. He wanted to join us during our campaign against Blake, saying he has beef with his relative. I don't know what it was, but he couldn't approach him while Nathan was with him. So instead I made him a deal, he if agreed to this, I would instead take his relative down along with Nathan. We only agreed it partially since I hadn't stopped Nathan. I told him zero contact for the first year. But due to my accident, that stretched out to two years. But he still remained in Citradel because I kept my word to him.

Marina says impressed, what a guy. For him, you disappeared during that time. Yet he still played his part. Blake says, we have to get him out of there. He saved all our asses. I say, that he did. I have a way to extract him in case things go wrong. I don't want to pull that trigger until I know if is in trouble. Marina puts the bad down and pulls out her phone from her jacker, I am on it. She begins typing her phone with the message. Blake asks, he was in high position in Citradel and still didn't know about Heraknus.

I shrugs, I know, right. I contacted him during the tournament and he tried his best. But its not easy with Humans everywhere. He couldn't freely move around without causing a lot of suspicion. Blake says, jeez. Kafar went great lengths to keep Heraknus hidden. Marina says, done. I'll let you know if he has any information. I say, thanks. Then I look at the bag, what's in that. She gets excited, don't tell me you forgot. He opens the bag and brings out a large old book.

When my eyes fell on it I immediately flash backed to the time I was with Istra. Her office table in Marina's house. Its the same. The brittle binding ends, the various Kuretine locks on it. A green Kuretine embedded at the edge of the book. Marina grabs the book with both hands says, I am not waiting any longer. You need to show me the way to open the restricted pages and where the hidden ones are. I ask, right now. I asked for your help. She slams the book with one palm, payment up front.

I chuckle and turn to Blake. He says, hey man, you have been stringing her long enough. I guess that’s true. Marina was super hyped about this. I couldn't just deny her child like enthusiasm. I say, I have been keeping you waiting for long, that’s true. She says, like ages. Come on. Chop, chop. She didn't want to miss the chance. I look around to a good spot and asked her to come to a large rock near the beach. All three us walk towards it and Marina lays the book on it.

I tell her, hear me out. I promised to assist you to unlock the pages. Unfortunately I don't remember all the pattern of the charm Istra used to open it. She shouts, what. You lied. You freaker. I raise my voice, hold on. I said I don't

remember everything. I took a broken tree stick and started to draw the partial pattern I do remember on the sand. After I was done, Marina was staring at it, is this right. I reply, this is about one third of the charm Istra used to open. I don't have total recall like you, be glad I was able to memorize even this much after all this time.

Marina was already lost in thought inspecting the charm I drew on the sand. She was murmuring things to herself. Blake asks her, can you figure out the rest with this. Marina then immediately jerks up, shit. I was looking in the wrong direction all this time. What is this. Its completely different than what Mom said it would be like. Are you sure this right. I say, I vaguely remember knowing more, but I am not sure of that. But his much, I point with the stick, is hundred percent correct.

My confidence gave her assurance, then I can work with this. It might take some time to figure out the right charm. She then points her index to me, you gotta help too. I say, how about I help in a different way. If you remove the complicated stuff of Kuret, its just a pattern prediction and recognition right. You can use the computing knowledge of a powerful AI. Marina says, of course. That’s right, using M would makes things go faster. I was relieved she took that suggestion. Because I didn't have time to do manual puzzle solving.

She gets excited, tell me about the hidden pages. I lean in forward to the touch the book. She jerks, don't touch it. Anyone other than me who touches it will instantly be zapped with a Kuret blast. But I ignored her and put my hands on the large page. I nonchalantly begin flipping that large heavy pages with my fingers. Marina bends her neck eyeing me and the book, what the hell. I laugh, don't worry. I have my Kuret resistance working for me. Istra was dumbstruck too when I accidently touched it. Maybe that’s why she found me interesting and showed me things.

Marina was still in shock, this is unbelievable. You know this book is our sacred treasure. Only our bloodline alpha's can open it. Blake says, you were carrying your sacred treasure in a satchel. Marina rebukes, it’s a very nice satchel. I think about this books history. This book has gone through much in centuries, so I doubt it would mind that. One I recalled the position of the page I stopped. This one, I point, I remember this page. I can't understand any of this language. But yeah, this part here. I point to the familiar written language I remembered, I am very certain its in here.

Marina shoves me aside, rude, and inspects the page. She chuckles, ha. Seriously. The irony. The is about charms that unlocking Kuret binding. I didn't find this content useful. Which section. I say, no idea. I think she was expecting me to hand over everything on a silver platter. She gives a annoyed look. I say, what do you want me to do about it. I don't even know how many sections there are. I just remember the page. She sighs, you did say you only know the page location. Fine, I guess this is still better than searching blindly. Where's the next.

She is borderline being impertinent with me. But I let it slide because she was so excited I found it funny. I flipped around the pages. Somethings strange. I flipped the pages again from the back. But I couldn't find the page. She asks, what's wrong. I ask, it may be a bad joke, but are there any pages missing. She elbows me in the guts, stop messing around. This pages look like they are normal, but they are insanely strong. Its easier to burn or destroy the book rather than ripping off pages.

I assumed so too. I flipped the pages faster, this is weird. I can't find that page. She got worried, seriously. You didn't forget about it. I scoff, please. If I wasn't so sure about it, I wouldn't have even mentioned about the other one. After a while Blake asks, I don't know if it makes sense, but our place had some sensitive Kuretine books that sometimes have pages that shuffles its position in the book. I was surprised, seriously. I have never heard about it. Marina immediately grabs the book and starts flipping the pages, holy shit. I never realized that. Yeah, your royal books were also old and used to have similar tricks like ours. She flips the pages around, but I couldn't see the page anywhere.

She kicks her legs on the ground, I thought maybe it would open up to me. Dammit. Her pride was hurt. I say, for now let me draw you the language script I know. Maybe that will help you find it. She nods, good idea. She pulls out her phone from her pocket opens a notepad. I draw the partial scripts I remember. Once done, she looks at it trying to figure out what it means. She says, something to do with Kuret purification. I ask, what the hell does that mean. She says, no idea. Never heard anything like this before.

She puts her phone back inside, anyways. It looks like I still have some work cut out for me. I ask hesitantly, so we good. She says, are we good seriously. You tricked me into using an Averna charm and all I get is hints. She was purposefully making me wait in anticipation. She suddenly chuckles, I was just messing with you. I let out a sigh. You never can tell her when her mood changes. Blake says, that’s great. Because we have wasted 10 minutes already. We should focus on you now David. I reply, yeah.

I say, my game plan is simple. Like I told earlier, I want to improve on two fronts. My new Kuret techniques and the Kuret sphere. They both get into this with excited expressions. I continue, before I show you what I can do, I need to explain what I my thought process was during my battle with Charles.

David (Chapter 89)

Wednesday, January 28, 2026 16:43

It took another 15 minutes to explain the tribulation I went through during the match. I had my Kuret around my hand and just waving around them as I told them. Blake says, so vibration? Really. I snuff out my Kuret and says, I mean from a science point of view, yeah. I saw thin amount of Kuret on Charles constantly moving around. Unlike other Medrones, he made his Kuret was so dense it became extension of his body. I imagined for a similar result. Admittedly it was a shot in the dark, but it worked. I have looked at the footage of my own battle, and unconsciously I did the same thing with my Kuret before I even realized.

Marina says, I remember. During the initial confrontation, you were evading Charles and your Kuret around you rotated on you. I say, that's right. It must have been instinct, like my brain registered Charles Kuret even before I realized it myself. Blake says, that's unbelievable. I have known people learning new stuff in the heat of the battle, but this is first for me where you figured out something so subtle from your opponent. Marina chuckles, your battle instincts is top notch. She makes a okay gesture to me praising my efforts.

I would have felt more pride in it but its not the same right now. I say, but I haven't been able to pull that final form again. The wild exploding Kuret is the best I can do right now. Blake says, so I assume its not about your recovery, right. I nod, I have checked my vitals this morning. I have a little bit of soreness in my lower back, but that shouldn't stop me. Marina snaps her fingers, you need to remember your rhythm. Its obvious, isn't it. This happens so many times. You were locked in during the battle where every second counted. You went beyond your limit and can't recall that same condition again.

I says, that's right. I believe the same. Its not mental, or physical. Its conditional. Blake says, what did you do back then. I say, I can't say for sure. Like Marina said, I was completely zoned in and flying of my instincts. He says, you basically got lucky. I had to agree to this, yeah. Marina says, beginners luck, as they say. Blake thinks for a second, okay. So our ultimate goal is to help you achieve that state. I ask, how do we do that. He says, first things first. I need to show you something. A demonstration of sorts.

He takes us to a nearby large rock and says, I have seen your battle too. And I have leaned a lot of things. I listen in close. He point his hand to the rock and throws his Kuret at it. The Kuret wasn't powerful, it just blew some dusts of it, this is what you could do normally. Your Kuret didn't have any weight or power. Then he pulls out a lot of Kuret around and expands it, like I do with my dome. The space around him is filled with Kuret and then he attacks again. This time it creates a large crack on the rock.

I say, and that's what my Kuret dome can do. He disperses the Kuret, correct. You have power, but it doesn't last long. And then you learned to do this. He walks to the rock and wraps his arm in Kuret, watch this. He punches the rock while wrapped in Kuret it cuts a piece of the edge. The broken debris falls on the sand creating a mini dust storm. He says, this is what you did with Charles. Now you need to learn this, he kept both his arms down and instead attacks the boulder just with his Kuret. The force of the impact was the same, but without physical action. Another piece of the rock chips off and falls to the ground.

I ask, you want me to do this, with just my Kuret. He nods, you have already done it before. You created a shield on you when Charles attacked, you even created a spikes on it when he kicked you. I recall I was able to do it against Polly too. I say, but that's just for a split moment. I can't control it beyond a second. He nods, that's what you have to learn first. You were running around with your Kuret controlling you, instead of you controlling it. I understand it was your first time using it. But it doesn't change the fact that you don't have control over your new Kuret. When you run, your legs are out of sync and uncoordinated.

He correctly observed the same thing I did. My Kuret assisted physical coordination is out of balance. He continues, there was a moment just before you got knocked out that looked like you let your Kuret control you like a puppet. That is the overly extreme and excessive control of your Kuret. You were incredibly lucky you didn't break your joint during that movement. That confirmed for me that even if you could use that Kuret form, I wouldn't want you to. Because you will be wasting your energy and stamina in superfluous movements.

I nod, that is absolutely right. A lot of the time I was letting my body get dragged by Kuret. He says, you drove a plane before learning a car. So that's why we have to first you need to learn to controls your Kuret without physical movement. I ask, but how does this help me. My fighting style is all about being having physical combat. He says, until now. There is a limit to it with just physical movements. There is two step to this. First was creating your stronger Kuret. And once you learn that. You get this. He asked us to gave some space and prepared another punch. This time he made a physical jab but the same Kuret power he showed earlier.

The result was not simple addition. The force was multiplied, his arm dug into the rock and giant web cracks grow from the impact point. Soon the entire rock crumbles. He takes a small breath, this is what you get when you have total control of you physical and Kuret strength. I realized his point, I think I get it. You switch between different type of attacks, a plain physical Kuret boasted attack, a pure Kuret attack and then a combination of both. He says, that's a good way to think about it. You learn these types individually first. Maybe you will learn it fast. But the real trick comes when you have to combine your skills.

I say, I has a similar type of idea during the match. Incorporate what I learnt into my existence techniques. He says, not bad. You had the right idea. But your execution order was not correct. It probably worked with Charles because, like Marina said, you were in a zone. But you can't rely on that. You need to consciously learn to do these things before. I say, man. If you were in your top form when you fought me, I would have a lot of trouble. He smiles, maybe. I shake my head, nah. I know. That's why I never fought you head on, never once tried to block a full punch from you.

He laughs, that was the right call, not going to hide that. You did the same with Charles, but you either got carried away or couldn't dodge some of his attacks. Normally, you only take a hit if you can prepare a counter for it. I add, or you attack with same force. He says, that's also a way. You did that by flying up in the air and using the momentum of the drop to even out Charles blow. Quite a reckless move though. I had to agree with him. That was a little terrifying. Marina asks, have you tried flying. It would be so awesome if you could do it.

He make nervous laugh, hell no. The most I can do is jump high and slowly decent. Like the entrance I made with Drew. You called it earlier, I wasn't thinking about the dangers and just winged it. Marina says, that was wild. You made a powerful blow on Charles, but don't think you can do it every time. I say, agreed. That's why I haven't tried it once. Even though I sometimes badly want to soar through the air. I don't know if you guys know, but I envy you, him and Vanessa to be able to fly.

Blake slaps me on the back, if things go well. Maybe you could do it too. Just imagining that gives me goosebumps. He then says, one more thing. While we train, we will use Charles fighting style so that you get used to him. That means every attack is physical but covered with strong Kuret. Marina says, that's a good idea. I say, maybe initially. But I rather not get used to his bulky body. Blake asks, wait what. What do you mean. I say, that was his normal Kuret. Now picture what it could be during overdrive.

They both think about it for a moment. Marina says, if its anything like ours, his transformation happen from inside the body. Right. Blake says, yeah. I imagine his body turns into a real Kuret body. I say, but you are imaging him to be bulkier. But what if he becomes slimmer, more leaner instead. Like a Chettah. Then would his entire style be flipped to speed type. If I only learn heavy punches and blocks, I will be freaked if I don't cover other possibilities. Blake says, I never imagined that. Marina says confused, he could have even more tails. Or no tails.

I say, that's also possible. You guys have variety of abilities in your arsenal to tackle anything thrown at you in real time. But my true strength comes before the fight begins. Blake says, yeah. I was trained for power. Marina says, I was training for versatility. I say, I was trained to see all possibilities. Never I imagined I would ever reach to a point where I need to learn different abilities. And I get your point Blake. I was jumping the gun by asking to learn the physically boasted attacked directly. I need to take a step back to that as well.

He says, its going to a lot of work. I have a basic outline to get you a feel for using your Kuret psychically. But your Kuret vibrating thing is not really something I can understand. He pulls his Kuret around his hands and forms a small ball, eventually everyone learns to use their Kuret without thinking so much. We don't have to really understand how it functions. I mean we can, but we do it subconsciously. Marina says, he is right. Its like breathing. You don't consciously put effort into breathing do you.

They made the observations I was painfully aware I lacked. But it is what it is. I have used my Kuret my own way. Marina says, doesn't matter though. Every person is different. We may say it nonchalantly because we have alpha level Kuret control. I know many struggle through it differently. You are basically an anomaly. She flashes her teeth, enjoying the fact saying I was very unique. Blake says, speaking of that. I think its time you explain how you can use different Kurets.

Marina grabs me by the shoulders excited, yes. I am dying to know that. Ever since you told me you copied me I have been racking my brain every night. I put my hands on her elbows, all right. Settle down. I laugh and she let goes of me. I say, you heard earlier how I am able to gather the ambient Kuret in the air. They both nod. Then I next explain about my prism light refracting analogy. Marina shrieks, seriously. That is not how Kuret works. I say, well, it works for me. I don't know how else to tell you.

Marina says, the pure Kuret have all the properties of every type of Kuret. But you can't split it. That's like saying you want to pull green from white. I say, I know. Its confusing. Let me show you what I do. I take few steps back and ask her, hurl a blast of pure Kuret towards me. She exclaims, huh. Ahm, okay. She pulls out her Kuret and I prepare mine. I figured since Blake is here, I should convert to his Kuret so that he can see it for himself. I raise my right arm and flow my Kuret in my palm.

Just like I have done numerous time, I wrap my palm in Kuret, shaping it in the form of Blakes bloodline sigil. They both look a little confused at this. I imagined anyone would be. Marina had a charm ready to fire a blast. I say, throw it. She extends her arms and it flies straight at me. I will the Kuret on my palm to get stronger and then as soon as the pure Kuret ball comes it contact, it splatters into different directions as small fireworks. Most of the Kuret scattered were pure, but there were sparks of blue mixed in.

They stare hard at my palm. Marina rushes over in an instant and takes my palm in both her hand like she was checking my nerves. She yells, what the freak was that. I tell, the secret of my technique. Blake follows her behind, you mean to tell me that was real. I make a face, seriously. Did you actually thought I cheated. Blake says, no. I mean, you can't tell me this is bonkers. What did you do. I say, I did nothing. Marina uses a charm on my hand, but it doesn't reveal anything.

She says, what kind of sorcery is this. Ironic, coming from a bloodline that are basically witches. I say, people keep asking me how I do it. The reason I keep saying is because I didn't others to know my weakness. The other reason is because this is completely accidental and I have no clue why it works. Marina let goes of my wrist, what the hell. I explain, last year, when we battled. You sent an attack at that Hive leader and he deflected it. Well, a part of it fell on me. I was kind of distracted by someone and I couldn't make a Kuret wall in time. It came out all web shaped. I saved myself from getting pummel by it. But at the edge of my hand were I had wrapped my Kuret, I saw sparks of different glimmers. Like colored glimmer.

She tries to recall that moment, I remember that. But I didn't sense different Kuret coming of from that. I say, there were many Medrones beside us. You probably missed it. Besides, it was for fraction of a second and just Infront of my eyes. That was the first clue I had something was strange. I didn't make much of it because, well, you know, I was going through therapy. Then tournament started and I was somewhat mentally ready. So I started to investigate from then. First it was very difficult to reproduce, because I didn't have a source of pure Kuret. And I started to buy Kuritines we use in our medical department.

Blake says, you mean the Kuritine crystals that used for backup in generating electricity. I say, that's the one. Once I found suitable source, I began testing. After few days I realized one common thing. The Kuret change happens only on contact. I turn to Marina, you can produce different Kuret in your overdrive by making charms. But they don't have to be physically on you. That's different for me. She says, so you need to be contact with the Kuret. But doesn't your Kuret breaks down Kuret bindings.

I says, that’s the subtle difference in what I showed just now and what I actually do. Once I was tested it repeatedly, I formed a hypothesis. Something in my unique biology allows the Kuret on my skin to cause minor fluctuations to pure Kuret. Call it science, call it chemistry. I have even used a microscope to understand this. The best I can say is that being a MAR's subject and my lineage has created a very unique DNA. Its like asking how Marina can sense Kuret. She can naturally just do it.

Marina says, what, like a physical ability. I say, could be. Blake says, what the hell dude. Just how did you get from there to now. I continue, I knew there was potential here. So I explored it. In between the matches I tried various things. But it wasn't working. But then I saw a match between Marina some guy, I don't remember him. Marina used a charm that resembled the Kuret web I had thrown last year. I tried to copy you. And it worked. I realized different pattern lead to different Kuret.

Marina breathes loudly, this is crazy. You used my charms as a reference. I say, I did. But I wasn't getting any real connection. The Kuret changes were happening not really uniformly, some mixed with multiple. Some weak. I didn't realize until later that I was missing one important detail. Blake says, you need to make the bloodline sigil. Marina says, the same way I do when I create my charms. I raise my hand and pour Kuret in it. I form sigil markers of different bloodlines.

I show them the changes I make to the design, making it exactly as theirs. I say, I don't really have a good grasp of Kuret convergence and its correlation to sigil markers. I never can see Kuret, so I don't have a complete idea. Marina says, that’s because you need to know a lot of Kuret mechanics to know that. Sigils of a bloodline isn't just random design. Think of them as DNA for Kuret building. All of us have sigils engraved inside our hearts. Its where our Kuret spreads from. Our bodies absorb Kuret and turn into out bloodline Kuret because of this divergence.

Blake says, that’s common knowledge. What isn't is how David is able to do it. I say, like I said. I can't understand working of others Kurets. I only have science and trial and error to understand. She sighs, many people have their own view of understand things. What one believes it to be true, doesn't make the other one wrong. Looks like it’s the same in your case. Your unique way of looking at things is what made this possible. I say, I guess so. Now you get how I was able to use different Kurets.

Blake says, not really. You couldn't focus it nor control it. I nod, that came after. While this was cool, it didn't have any way to use it in actual combat. That’s when I started to look for ways to gather pure Kuret with just my Kuret. I have told this earlier. My anti Kuret works like opposite sides of a magnet. That’s how I can throw Kuret and run along it being dragged towards the cluster of Kuret in the air. Using that same principle, I began experimenting trapping Kuret. It took a crazy amount of time and effort to finally find a viable solution.

Marina says, your Kuret sphere. Or Kuret storm. Whatever you call it. I say, its actually a sphere. I purposefully wrap it in a mini storm for stability and also physically hide what happens inside. Blake asks, so you learned how to trap Kuret in the air and condense it. I say, not immediately. First step was making my Kuret dense. And that I learnt from you. When you battled against Ned, I saw your technique of filling the air with Kuret. I copied it. Blake says, wow. So your Kuret dome was actually a by product of your actual goal.

I say, you can say that. When I fought Catherine, Jess and June, I used my Kuret sphere. It wasn't really stable, but I was able to catch them off guard with it. Marina eyes widen, that’s why you waited to be either hidden or not in view from anyone. I say, of course. I knew there were really tough people waiting in the finals. I wasn't going to reveal it then. But then Derek happened. He was far stronger than I imagined. I revealed the Kuret dome. And almost revealed the pure Kuret blast back then.

Blake says, that’s what caused those burn marks on him. Derek thought it was from the friction caused by his own Kuret. You were using it already back then. I nod, yeah. At that point in time, I was able to explode the trapped Kuret, like a bomb. Then the real game changer thing happened. I point to Marina, I don't want to make light of you almost dying, but your overdrive battle with Vanessa gave me a lot of clues. She points to herself, you couldn't leave my overdrive too.

I shrug, I saw you using different Kurets. The very thing I wanted to learn. Using your battle, I found out a way. In your overdrive, you gather Kuret and change it instantly around you. I couldn't understand it, let alone do that. But I studied the science behind it. You pass the ambient Kuret through the charms and then gather them. Changing the Kuret first. I figured if you do it this way, and then with an anti Kuret properties, I can do it in reverse. I first gather pure kuret and then change it. I already knew how to this before. And that’s how I was able to make the first of my Kuret spheres.

Marina looks genuinely shocked and impressed at me, so basically you used me as a muse. Blake says, by learning from both of us. I smile, more or less. And when you two fought, I studied more of your Kuret science, the way I can understand. Once I have Kuret condensed, I create a small instability. Very minor. Enough that a piece of the Kuret breaks from the center and then bounces around the sphere. With the sigil marker I form in my hand, that piece strikes my palm and slowly create sparks of the new Kuret nature. Those transformed Kuret then creates the other pieces into same nature. And with this chain reaction, a few seconds later I open a tiny gap though which the Kuret flows out and naturally gains the properties of the bloodline.

Blake says, that slight vibration we see just before you throw an attack, that’s what it really does. I say, I perfected the Kuret technique over time. Well, calling it perfect is a bit too much. More like functional. Marina puts her hand on her waist, mother of Kuret. I thought I our family were prodigies. No wonder mom took so much interest in you. I wouldn't be surprised if she was one of the people who voted for your selection. A chuckle slips past my mouth, maybe you are right. Anyways, I explained things by oversimplifying the inner mechanics. I turn to Marina, I can tell you more in depth later.

She says, I really need to know the details. She then turns to the book in her satchel, I guess I should also start looking into trying out things differently too. Blake says, for real. You understood that, because I didn't get everything. Marina says, don't let anyone hear you say that. Otherwise they will think royal education is not as good as Ozareks. Blake face turn a bit scornful. Marina laughs at him. I ask, so. I guess you understood the general idea. Is there a way you can help improve this technique.

Marina thinks about it for a long time. I thought best to give her some time, because I had another question for the time being to Blake. I ask him, I noticed it a while ago. There are many people gathering around us. I turn around the beach and people were gradually growing in numbers. A couple of officers for their routine water patrols. Few were heading out to the ocean to work on the security upgrades around the island. Some were fishermen.

I thought Blake picked this spot because we would be secluded and the only people who would come are regular people. This beach isn't so big that people can come to relax and play. But the majority of them are normal citizens. I saw a couple in their workout cloths, few teenagers and people in their work clothes. I thought they would be passing by. But they were hovering around us. I swear I could see glimmers of their phones pointed at us. Blake smirks at me, you really should see the news.

I sigh, what's the point. I basically admitted to mistakes and decisions that led to many people dying. I rather not be seen with you guys. They might think something is up. He says, something is up. I gave him a confused look. He says, you have turned into an overnight celebrity. I should have known I was getting bad press. But the way he has been talking, somethings strange. I look around the crowd looking at our direction. I couldn't see the glimmers from this far, but I saw majority being surprised and enjoyment. Huh, wait what. Blake says, there was a discussion yesterday about your actions. I don't know if you follow the Cranston show, but he goes around and puts spotlights on people.

I know that guy. I ask, he is the one Marina talked to few days back when she joined us. He replies, that’s right. He is quite an influencer in our city. A lot of people follow him. Turns out he was impressive by you and decided to do a video about you. He went to you, but I had stationed officers near your place to not disturb you. That didn't stop him. So instead he went talking to folks and began a agenda to create more positive awareness on you. My jaw hung loose, huh. Did you put him up to it.

He raised his hands, I didn't. I promise. That was all him. Your interview got to him. And as it turns out, to many. They just didn't went out of their way like Cranston did. In just one night, he got most viewership than he ever got. So he isn't just doing it completely for you. But he did champion you for thwarting Ryes slander. I didn't feel even a single bit happy hearing this, but I lied to everyone. People have wrong impression of me. He scoffs, Ryes lied first. And besides, your story makes you more relatable. They only seen you winning. But now they have seen you at your low. Its not a surprise when people see you struggle that they feel connected to you.

This is nuts. I wasn't expecting this. Did someone plan this. But what would be point in first smearing my reputation and then making me look good. After realizing that the people were here for me, I noticed something. I say, you planned this. You knew coming here would make noise. Didn't you. He didn't responds, just drops his shoulder with his hands in his pocket. This guy, he wanted me in public with them. Most likely to give team vibes and hints about them helping me train.

Marina steps forward, you spoiled the surprise Blake. I wanted to tell him that. He says, you snooze, you loose. She flares her nostril. She turns to me, so, you enjoying your fame. Honestly, I am more uncomfortable right now. It was one thing to take the blame, but now, to be appreciated for it. Feels the trade off is suspicious. She says, don't look so gloom. Think of it this way, you were never in the wrong. You did what you thought was right. And so you are getting the credits you are due.

I guess that made sense. But weirdly, I didn't feel good about this. I should be happy that people don't hate me. But it’s a strange feeling. I say, its going to take a minute to process this. But lets set that aside. Did you figure out something. She smiles, I did. At first glance it seems what you do is efficient, but its not really. I ask eagerly, how so ? She explains, first. You take a long time to prepare that technique. While the trade off balance it out, its not practical. She is right about that. The first time I used in the field against Cory and others made that even more aware.

She says, since we can't really change the process. We can cut short the time be using a different configuration. She draws a circle with her hand, you use sphere, but that’s not really the best. A circle or elliptical is far better. I am confused, but how do I gather Kuret without trapping it. She says, I got an idea when you spoke of magnets. In that final Kuret form of yours. The Kuret was circulating on you and very dense. I think we can use that when you gather Kuret also. Instead of you trapping the ambient Kuret, you suck them into the space inside the circle.

That sparked so many confusing thoughts in my mind. But I asked the important one, is this something to do with Kuert physics. She says, give that man a prize. Yeah. Its no wonder you didn't think of that before. You need to see and feel it for yourself. My mind in thousand directions on this new avenue. She isn't wrong, I have treating Kuret like a scientific energy. But certain laws apply different to it. She continues, you gather Kuret like you are gathering balls in the air in your hands, on by one. But a much faster way is to like suck all the balls in one go.

If I can do that, then I can speed up the time it takes to prepare. But then I had a thought, hold on. I get that I overlooked many things. But even if I could do this, the Kuret I gather isn't stable. It will be highly volatile, since its no longer covered completely in all directions with my Kuret. Or do you have a way to stabilize that. She says, if you were like me, then you had a shot to do that. But that’s not possible. So I propose something else. She raises her arm and pulls out her Kuret over her arm.

She was purposefully making her charm mimic my Kuret form. She then says, you are right about it being unstable. You might have just one or two seconds before the pure Kuret breaks down and dissipates. But before it happens. She creates the sigil of royal bloodline on her hand. The pure Kuret she has slightly changes into Blakes and vanishes. She sighs, I can't do this without my overdrive. But you get the idea. I got excited at this demonstration, because I got what she meant, you want me to make a smaller Kuret ball and use that immediately.

She nods, exactly. There is no guarantee you will get enough time in a battle field to prepare it. Instead of trying to fire 8 or 9 Kuret blasts. Just do single Kuret nature change attack. Gather it again for the next. Blake asks, I may

be wrong, but won't it effect the output. The attacks David threw on Charles were on alpha or omega level. She nods, nice catch. That will happen. I don't have a solution for that. He turns to me, there is a trade off. Your attacks will be faster, but they won't be as strong.

I think I get the whole picture now. I say, its like a quick and dirty Kuret attack. She smooches one eye with her cheeks, something like that. But I was okay with this, its actually better. If you seen my match with Charles, you would know that I was wasting a lot of the Kuret. I had the option to do that because I had a bigger reserve of pure Kuret. But not all Kuret need to be powerful. She says, I also believe variety is better here. Besides, this was just me giving an idea. Give me some more time. I can some up with something more proper. I will check with type of Kuret configuration works the best for you. Who knows, if we do this right, you might be able to even control the output of your attacks.

Blake whistles, seriously. That will be sick. I was now smiling ear to ear. I don't have any idea if I could manage it in 3 weeks. But with Marina here, I have a chance. I say, thanks a lot Marina. I am glad you are here. She smiles, anytime. Then she turns a little hesitant. I ask, what. She says, nothing. Just. She turns to Blake, if he help this become stronger, his stocks will go even higher. We might be unleashing a monster, even bigger than Charles. She knows I am here right.

Blake giggles, you should have thought before you accepted the payment. She snickers peeking at the bag beside her legs. She says, true. Do you not have a problem. Blake turns to me with a sly smile, I will be lying if I am not slightly envious. But hey, I am here to pick on his brain too. You already said his thinking is very different. I am sure that will benefit me also in someway too. I think those two are here for themselves just as much for me. I was more than happy to reciprocate that help. I say, I will do what I can. But don't expect too much, even after getting my memories, Kuret science is a difficult for me to comprehend.

They both get a good laugh from it. They support was honestly more reassuring that I ever thought. Marina looks around, by the way. Seems a lot of people have gathered around. Seems kind of waste. Don't you think. I looked at my wrist watch, you have only 10 minutes left. Don't think we can do any actual training today. Not that I planned for any from the beginning. Marina smiles, why not give people something to see. She starts to give poses to the people, arching her waist and raising her elbows to her hairs.

I burst out laughing, what are you doing. Is that a swimsuit model pose. She gives another pose, hey, I need to get some attention too. And not just for my fighting skills. Its not fair you are hogging everything. I am giving you a lot of my precious time. Be glad. She has just committed to this bit on a whim. I turn to Blake who was stifling a laugh. He sees me and says, I am not joining that. That’s all her. I reply, not what I was thinking. Marina is giving more poses now. Does she really have no embarrassment while she goes on her knees and gives a more erotic pose.

I need to stop her. I don't know about Blake, but I am getting embarrassed from people watching me just gawking at her. Before I could approach her, Blake says, Marina. I got a better idea. Oh, no. Not him too. Marina stands up excited, what. He points to the a group of large rocks, you are just hogging the attention, like him. We are here to train him. So lets just show the people what they came here for. I can't believe he was suggesting this to her. Marina got excited, I love it. Oh yeah. I shake my thoughts and decided to play along, why not. If I am going to be under people's scrutiny, I might as put on a show. Marina fists my shoulder, that’s the spirit.

Its been a very time since I wanted to do something that didn't have any hidden agenda. Just something fun. Blake says, we each will pick similar sized rocks and throw an attack once all together. Whoever pulverizes the rock wins. Marina says, and the loser buys our lunch for the week. I yell, wait a minute, I will definite loose. This isn't fair. Blake shrugs snickering, who said about being fair. Suck it up. I guess even Blake is salty like Marina a little bit about the media. I says, well, in that case let me prepare my Kuret storm. I will turn all the rocks into dust. How's that for being fair.

Marina dips out, freak no. Blake lets not wait for him to do that. All attack now. Huh, what. Marina was already producing multiple charms around her arms. Then on my right Blake was to gathering his Kuret. Freak you guys, I yell. I make a yell and bring out my wild Kuret. I already know I was going to lose though.

Vanessa (Chapter 90)

Thursday, January 29, 2026 13:40

Things in a small island can change very easily. One day you are at the receiving end of wary eyes. And then suddenly you are respectable again. That's what happened last few days. David wasn't seen anywhere in public since his outrage accusing Ryes and then Citradel. And then Cranston made a live stream about the officers and David. While people were skeptical of David, majority of officers were backing David now. And from there he had managed to garner sympathies from people. No, not just that. Admiration. Its like people are gradually believing that Ryes had a person grudge on David since he made Charles give up. Cranston had a live talk with Reinhart and showed that it was a mutual decision. No one was forced.

Cranston sparked a lot of controversy among people. Many remain unconvinced, but they can't do anything about it. And then last night Marina send out a group message to us. Charles had contacted her and confirmed their deal hasn't changed. They will be coming to us as promised. They even shared their requirements and preferences on where to live. Blake had called for a discussion today with Marina and some other developers. Though we can't really start any construction. Not when Luther and Tina are still trying to convince the tech team stuck in Italy to move to our city.

I haven't heard the latest updates from them, but Blake was quite confident after getting the news from Marina. Slowly things were turning in our favor. The smuggling operation is running full steam ahead. We had arrested around 19 people by today morning. Most of them were normal people, who didn't like that they had to give up things before coming here. Its a very strange behavior, if they didn't want to give up those things, try to convince us before resorting to illegal imports. We are not asking them to forget everything about Earth, just remember our own heritage.

One client had even imported a stolen artifact from some place called Lurve. I don't know where that this, but few officers knew and were outraged. They wanted it to return immediately. Deni said it was a very important cultural item from Human history. Keeping it here was a heinous crime. Others like Tessa just wanted to return it so that no one traces it to them. We had seized various things from the people in IDF. But they are just under lock and key for the time being. We have a team ready who will plan to take it to back to the government, or their owners.

There were so many things like that, a painting called Rembrandt I didn't understand, illegal human drugs for recreational pleasures, even some weapons I am not familiar with. That last one made everyone hesitate. Why even need it, but Sommers said they were just low level weapons that were mostly for self defense. Still, we couldn't let them keep it. Some people had harmless things, but it didn't change the fact that we can't have it in the city. I am leaving it to the tribunal to decide how what type of punishment they will get.

Speaking of punishment, there is talk amongst the officers about the warriors in prison. Having such powerful people in cells is bad. Many hold a popular opinion to stipe their alpha powers and give it to their relatives. That did felt justified. But with Polly, we didn't have an option. So rehabilitation is possible. No one died, so all three have some chances of getting lighter sentence. If Elina had died, they would be held accountable much extreme. Like exile or permanent presentment. That headache was for others to decide. My job was to keep catching the people the hard disk spits out.

After lunch, I am reviewing some of the footage of Elina and Wyan currently in IDF at my desk. Ever since David pointed out something about the book, I have been suspicious. At what, I don't know. David said he was looking for some physical proof on Elina and since there were none, he seemingly gave up. Maybe he was right. Though I held back some reservation. Behind me June approaches, still watching the tapes. I saw you watching yesterday too. If still something is strange why release Elina.

I pivot my chair towards her, don't mind me. I just want to cover my base. June says, no doubt. You guys seem pretty chill on the outside, but inside you are all about work. I smile, that's because everyone wants to finish up work and leave early. No one wants to work more than necessary. June asks, I am beginning to see that. I thought it was because this is hard work. I say, no. its because there is always more work. June laughs, which apparently you are taking a lot of it. I have seen you working till late. Don't you want to go home before dinner.

I could have told that's its just work. I feel guilty lying to so many people. The actual reason is that I have been avoiding going back home in case Ned shows up. He messaged me about meeting at his place. I haven't done that. So he might just come to my place instead. June says, don't you have a boyfriend though. I would assume you want to spend more time now that things have settle down. I make a somber expression. She says, oh wait. So you two are on the outs. Really, I thought that was just a rumor.

I ask, a rumor. June plays dumb, but I prod a bit, what are people saying. June says, well, I am spying on others as you know. I do hear gossip as the new person. On one hand I found it reassuring that she is mixing in well with the people, but the flip side is she will know what others think of me. I sigh, me and him are just having a spat. No big deal. I straight up lied, hopping she doesn't pick up more. She eyes me a little bit leaves it alone, all right. Just asking. I respond, Blake told we all will have busy days. There are things that only I can do. So, I do have to stay back for a little while.

She nods, I guess. I don't know if that was good enough reason for her. I ask, how about you. Did you find a place to live. She smiles, I did. Got a nice little house in section 2. Me and Sam needed some lawn area for our pets, so that place worked. It is a little expensive, but I rather live there than the other place I saw in section 4. I ask, and Sam is your? She shrieks, oh shit. I didn't tell you. Sorry, I thought I told you. He is my partner. We have been together for three years now.

I ask, then he is also from Citradel. I don't think he arrived with you, did he. I would have known about him. She becomes disappointed, he didn't. He is vet, so he wanted to stay with the animals patients. He said he would be here for my match near the end of tournament, but he had an emergency and couldn't leave. I was so mad at him before, but honestly, I am also glad he wasn't here. I didn't want him to see me so down after I lost. I got a little anxious, does he loves animals so much he rather not see support his girlfriend in the first ever Medrone tournament on Earth.

June leans, exactly right. Boys are so dumb. He watched all my matches at least. I wasn't going to let him off the hook. But to be fair, he was very busy with treating and training animals. He had wanted to leave, but some council member wanted him to there longer and couldn't make it here. I had to forgive in the end because it wasn't really his fault. I say, still. Its bad he wasn't here. You might have gotten a great support and beaten David.

She laughs hysterically. But then she saw my serious face and her laughter died, you are serious. She shakes her head, you don't think I didn't give it my all. Girl, you are giving me way too much credit. I was in it for the win no matter what. But now that I have seen the matches after mine, I had no chance.

I suppose it would be unreasonable to think she would falter just because he wasn't here. I smile, as long as you don't regret. She nods, no regrets and I gave it my all. Unlike me she is satisfied with her match. I got curious, you haven't told anyone about Sam. I bet all the guys are hitting on you would back away knowing you are taken. She smiles, let him get jealous. Serves him right for not bring with me. I chuckle, bring Sam in sometime, I like to meet the guy. Talk some sense into him about leaving you alone.

She says, I would honestly love that. But he isn't in the city right now. I realized something, hold on, he is still in Citradel. Seriously, you moved here, even brought a place for the two of you. She shrugs, this one I know isn't his fault. Citradel council have banned anyone from entering or leaving. Ryes escaping has hurt their reputation in more ways than one. And ever since both Blake and David have shaken them, they are trying whatever they can to keep people from leaving.

I am horrified that Citradel is keeping people against their will, did you talk to him. She nods, yeah. Not for long, just enough to know he is fine. Citradel is basically keeping people in the name of finding co-conspirators of Ryes. A clever plan to stop people from leaving. Sam already quit his job once he got a new replacement. She snickers, just last night the replacement also quit. I feel bad he has to leave the animals unintended, but he promised me to not delay any longer. So the moment Citradel opens their border, he will leave.

I lean back in the chair, does Blake know about this. She replies, yup. He already knew it before me. I wanted to get his take on this and see if there is anything he can do. Unfortunately, I have to wait. I know I wasn't expecting Blake to just demand people over, but I had to try. If this is happening to one person, then it maybe happening to others too. Has it gone this bad or was I just exaggerating it from just one instance. June says, he is fine. I keep in contact with him daily. She sighs, I just miss him. Its been months since I saw him. And I like his help to setup our place, because no way I am doing it alone.

I tell, if you need anything let me know. She says, thanks. She then thought of something. I thought she was about to ask a favor. But instead she goes, when he does meet you, could you maybe bring Ned with you also. I ask confused, why. He becomes a little nervous, he has a thing for you. Nothing serious, just a harmless crush. But I don't want him to meet you alone, the guy may look decent, but, he is guy in the end. I had a genuine laugh, are you for real. And he told you that.

She is really a nervous, yeah. And then imagine the shock when I told him I am working with you. No, rather you are my boss. He said he was seriously going to hop over a fence. Like there is an actual fence in Citradel. The nerve of the guy. I can't believe I still have admirers. I thought many would have lost interest in me after I also lost. She says, hey. You look a little bit more happy than you should. I fidget a little. She smiles, just kidding. But seriously, he is intimidated by you as well, so keep your usual self and that will scare him away.

I get offended a little, hey. I am not scary. June makes a unconvinced face. Wait, seriously. I hesitantly ask, I am not, though. Right. She sighs, I don't know if you heard, but have a intimidation aura on you. I mean, when was the last time you had something fun. I say, I have tons of fun times. She waited me to explain. I nearly brought David's name in reflex and shut my mouth. I can't believe I almost said his name instead of Ned. She says, see. You need to live more. Just fix things with your boyfriend.

I can't deny that I haven't been able to enjoy much these days. She says, and you know what. We can. Suddenly I hear a loud commotion. Then someone yells, guys we got a runner. I sigh and stand up muttering, not again. June looks around the place confused and says, what happened. I gesture her to follow me and we walk to side window. There was a women running with hand cuffs on her away from IDF entrance screaming, I still love you, even if you are in prison. June shouts, did that happen again.

This was the third time someone tried to escape. Props to this women, she was the first to try out in the open. I saw Sommers at the entrance with two other guys, both in cuffs. June says, shouldn't we help. I decline, lets just see for now. They aren't going to get far. Sommers sprints into action and leaps into the air towards the running women. The women cuffs should have dampen her Kuret. But somehow she broke through it. I see her skin radiating Kuret in thin slashes thought the air

Oh boy, did she just cut the cuff even with so much Kuret dampening her. Sommers lands a few meters beside her tried to grab her. She cries towards me, leave me alone or I will shred you into pieces. Sommers barks, give it your best shot. That caught her off guard and Sommers side steps towards her. She threw a flurry of slashes towards him. I don't think he was keen on dodging, because he ran straight ahead. The girl screams nervously as the slashes cuts on him, but he just brushes them off with his bare hands.

She throw more at him at this distance. He wasn't getting hurt, but he had to guard his face with his arms. June says, shouldn't we help him. I say, no need. He has been in a fowl mood ever since Cory almost escaped under his watch. When he gets like this, better to just let him do it on his own. And on that cue Sommers leaps towards her again. The girls Kuret slashes were weakened so he rushes in close and grabs her arms from the behind. She screams, let go of me you freak.

She struggles under his tight arm lock. She must have tried to throw more of those slashes, but before she could manifest them completely, Sommers tackles her down face first and plants his on knee on her back. She screams under her face. I tell, looks like attempt number third failed. When are people going to learn. June says, I don't think ever. Because those two guys are already running. I turn to the other side and see the two guys running. One guy

shouts, I already forgot about you. They both also got out of their cuffs also.

One guys grabs the other by the shoulder and they both start to fly up in the air. I smile, not bad. A Kuret was forming in one guys legs and was using it like a staking board in the air. I have seen this Kuret somewhere before. Sommers saw them surfing away in the air and leapt up to stop them. But they were out of his reach. The guy who was being carried by the arms, laughs, get lost sucker. My brother has a warrior friend from the top 100. Better not mess with me again. One word and he will kill you.

Seriously, that threat felt a little bit weak. I open the window and raised my foot to cross outside. June pats my knees, wait. Let me. I saw her getting a little bit excited. This was her first job as an officer. I let her, they are all yours. Just try not to kill them. June activates her Kuret and levitates out through the window. Once out she raised her hand and creates her gravity Kuret ball aimed at the fleeing guys. A few seconds later they get immobilized suspended in the air.

I hear them shouting, what the freak. Other guy yells, why are you stopping. He replies, I can't move. Somethings pulling me back. June levitated closer to them and they began to fall backwards towards her. Their panic reach a new level when they see her approaching from back. They guy yells, freak. Get away women. You don't want to mess with my friends. I got connection to Citradel warriors too. June ask who is it. I might know them. The guy panics, that's the gravity women. Lets go dammit. He shouts, I can't.

June gradually settles down on the ground and then yanks them both down hard. The two guys fall straight to the ground and get plumed in the lawn grass. They writhe in pain lying flat on the ground. I think one guy got a broken arm and other got a broken leg. June says, shit. I messed up a little. She walks to the guy who was threatening earlier, I wanted to cripple just your legs. The guy while in pain tried to crawl away in fear. Sommers rushes in, thanks June. These are some slippery bastards.

June releases her Kuret, no problem. But how did they get out of the cuffs. Sommers turns one of the guy in pain on his back, we used old one I think. They must have gotten weaker with repeated uses. I need to ask the R & D to fix that issue. Other officers came and picked the three people from the ground. I turn around the gawking people from this side. I yell, shows over people. Unfortunately, no one escaping today to.

People scatter away realizing the attempt failed. Ruther comes to me, they are getting even more desperate now. I nod, these clients aren't snitching how they get in contact with Wyan. So it's a pain to go after them one at a time. Gives them a chance to run. Ruther says, a team caught them near the shore this time. I think we should triple the patrols in the barrier. I say, we have no other choice. Even one escaping just to the water itself is not good enough for IDF.

Ruther pulls out his phone and makes a not of it. He then gets excited, speaking of shores. Did you see the viral video going from this morning. I ask, huh. Is it about Cranston. Did he post today again. He says, I knew it. You were either in office all day. I pull my phone and view the social site. There were a lot of messages floating in the network. But then I saw a short video. At first I didn't understand what I was seeing. I saw Blake use his Kuret, then Marina. And David was there too. They all seemed in deep conversation. I ask, are they working on something.

Then the video cuts to a different scene. A shock appear in my face. Is this Marina doing a photoshoot in her jogging shorts. She was in multiple poses, like for a beach commercial. The other two were in the corner staring at her. The sound of the people cheering came from the video. I ask, what is this. Ruther laughs, right. Marina's got style and confidence. You can see it right, it made the guys nervous. How hilarious is this. What the hell is going on. Are these guys having fun in the beach. I ask, when was this. He shrugs, don't know. It happened this morning though. But that's not all. Check out the rest.

Suddenly the video cuts to them all standing in a line up and reading their Kuret to attack on a rocks. Blake uses his Kuret kick from a jump into the air and pulverizes the rock. Marina's charms creates a crack on the rocks they blast into pieces. David had dawned his wild Kuret and landed a punch which did the least damage among them. He broke the rock from the middle into only few pieces. They had a competition in which Blake won and David lost. Daivd slumps down on his knees, like he was devasted from the loss. Marina beside her points to the people victory pose with her fingers.

I laughed at this amusing scene. I say, what were they doing there. I put my phone down. Ruther says, I heard they were training David. My leg almost slipped, say that again. He says, imagine the surprise. I haven't gotten to talk to any of them. So we aren't sure. But a friend told me they were talking over an hour. So I think this is some sort of special session. Two Shadows helping out David. That's going to seriously make even Charles nervous. I didn't expect this. Its true David hadn't gotten the chance to begin his training for the match. And now that Heraknus are confirmed to move, its high time he resumed the original goal.

What are they helping David with. That question lingered all the way till night. Around 8 I got a message from Blake that all high ranking officers are mandatory at the dining building. What is this about then. All four of us left from IDF 15 minutes before that time. Sommers says, probably to welcome Marina, June and the alpha twins. We didn't have official one and not everyone has spoken to them. I say, probably. Any news about Luther and Tina. Deni says, I got a incoming request from the barrier control. They are heading back now. I ask, with others?

Deni says a little desponded, empty handed. I ask, what happened. Something went wrong in the negotiation. Ruther says, didn't hear about that yet. We might know might now. June says, its not all bad right. No news doesn't mean bad news. I hope that's the case. When we reach the dining building, I found a officers table and saw Blake, Marina, Nathan, Jess and Catherine already seated. They all seem in better mood than us. I slight tension vanishing seeing Blake in good spirits. It doesn't look like any issue happened.

Blake notices us and says, welcome guys. Take a seat. I take the seat beside Jess, hey. So what's this about. Jess says, something about Citradel. Must be good because Blake called all of us, outside the office. Blake says, we are waiting on others to arrive too. Just few minutes. Sommers ask, is this about Luther and Tine. I hear they are back. Blake says, yeah. They just arrived an hour back. I ask, then about the negotiations with the tech team. I thought they won't return without them.

Blake says, that wasn't the actual goal. We told them our proposal, and now its up to them to choose. Ideally I wanted to let them discuss more, but apparently Citradel has been issuing a sort of clamp down. Not letting people leave or even talk to other communities. So the Citradel guards with them stonewalled us since this morning. Luther wasn't able force himself in to their rooms. I wasn't expecting them to send 5 warriors. He turns to Marina, do you know any one of them, Lorance, Uni, Wade, Esin, Piper. They had participated in the tournament too and went back after they lost.

Marina says confused, Wade's was with them. She shook her head. June says, I know Piper too. I hope they didn't antagonize these two people. I ask, are they trouble. Marina wiggles her palm to us, while June shrugs, in a way. They both are alphas, but their bark is more stronger than their bite. They are decent fighters. More then relying on Kuret, they use weapons. If the tournament didn't allow for weapons, they would have gotten farther than others. I hope they didn't hurt anyone.

Blake says, no they didn't. Nathan says, so couple of alphas relying on weapons. I can relate with that. Catherine asks, so what happens now. You just let them leave without doing anything more. Blake says, believe me. I didn't have much choice. With strong guards, they couldn't do much. So I just called them back. But its not all bad. I ask, they are still in Italy then. He says, they won't come with us, but they aren't going back as well. Not when Citradel is in lock down. So for the time being they are stuck.

Then its still the same situation right now. I ask, but then our expansion gets delayed. Doesn't it. Blake's shoulder drops down in a slight disappointment. Marina says, that can't be helped. Ruther asks, you have any expertise in the Kuret enrichment Marina. Marina says, some. But not like them. We can try it our own, but that means its slow and also error prone. Nathan says, not a good idea when we don't want to waste our materials. Marina nods, that's right. We might have it in surplus, but its not good to let it to go to waste. I ask, but isn't this bad then. The longer this drags, we more our plans get delayed.

Nathan smirks, Citradel council knows this. Those cunning people are not giving up the fight yet. If they can't stop David from robbing them blind, they can stop their tech teams. Which is very actually very weird. Why send it in the first place. Could it be some internal discord. He was close enough, only 5 people knew how that happened. Blake says, in any case, Citradel blocking them is putting us behind schedule. Marina has laid out the foundational plans and blueprints are nearly done. But those people are absolutely necessary.

Citradel isn't going to back down so easily huh. Blake continues, I have two things to discuss today. One is to welcome our new Citradel officers into our ranks. The other is to get any idea on how to break the stalemate. June says, you didn't have to do this you know. Blake says, nonsense. I wanted to this much earlier, but we were in a critical time. Things are much better right now. He turns to me, where is Tessa. I though she was in IDF. I answer, she went back home early. She will join in a minute.

Blake says, something wrong. I reply, no. She has been non stop hunting for the people on the run. I asked her to take the latter day off. Marina says, that reminds me. You had another escape attempt today, didn't you. Sommers replies, please don't remind me. I can't deal with more people. He turns Nathan, your Kuret suppressors gets worn off pretty fast. Nathan says, what can you expect from those silly things. I have been asking Vanessa to other alternatives.

I reply, I am telling you those are too harsh. They are for actual dangerous criminals. Not regular people. Nathan clicks his tongue, keep having that softer restraint and you will have to deal more of that. He turns to Sommers, Frank is saying he wants try out something that Citradel does. So maybe that will help you out. Sommers nods, that would be great. Blake asks, is that why he is also late. He replies, the kid's taking initiative. I thought he take another day to settle in, but he jumped straight in. I might has well use him well then.

I say, but you left him alone. Nathan scoffs, wrong, he left me alone here. I told him to take a break and join us. But he was in a zone. He should be here soon. Blake says, okay. Chealse is at the office wrapping up some work too. These alpha twins might really have a physic connection. That made everyone giggle. People broke into their discussion for a while. I joined in the conversation between Catherine and Marina. Catherine says, Marina, I saw your video from morning. That's was so funny I almost dropped my drink.

Marina gleams profusely, yes. Its going well then. Jess beside me asks, you planned that, didn't you. Marina says, of course. I just feel Blake and David have been talking the spotlight a little too much. I can't be the only shadow left behind. That's a weird way to do that. I say, so you pose like a model. Seriously. I laugh remembering that ridiculous images. Marina puts her tongue out amused my by reaction. Catherine says, you have gotten attention from all the boys for sure.

Marina says, that's the idea. People only talk to me about my Kuret or fighting style. I gotta show my feminine side too. Otherwise I am not going to get a decent boyfriend. Jess asks surprised, you playing the field then. Marina thinks for a moment, I mean, not right now. Too busy. But sure, I am just dropping out some hints. I say, and what way to do that. I clap to her. She laughs, thanks. It was just a whim. I thought it wouldn't work. But honestly, the guys reaction made it even better. Catherine peeks at Blake and back to her with a smile, I think Blake was worried you were going to ask them to join in.

Jess laughs, that would have been even funnier. Marina says, nah. They were just intimidated by me. I say, more like frozen in shock and awe. Catherine asks, that's so true. David looked the most panicked. I think being in the limelight has him nervous. Jess says, I have seen him less nervous during battle. That's right. He felt out of his element. I ask, so is true you were there to train. Marina says, yeah. We discussed on how to improve his Kuret skills. I ask, I have been wondering about that for a while. How exactly.

Marina smirks, listen to this. He has studied my and Blake Kuret very closely. And using the, she makes air quotes, science behind it, to use that technique to generate multiple Kurets. I lean in closer, did he reveal it to you. She nods. Everyone gets excited at this. Jess asks, well. Don't just keep us in suspense. Tell us. Marina makes a hesitant face. I ask, what. She replies, sorry you guys. I rather not tell. I scoff, really. Did David ask you not to tell. Because that's just crap. She says, no. He said its fine I want to reveal it now. But I agreed its better to keep it under wraps.

I don't believe it, why. She says, the whole things is a little complicated. Catherine says, hey, you calling us stupid. Marina gets a little anxious, not like that. But lets just say he told me something completely ridiculous and unheard

of. I like to study more about it and help him first before telling anyone. This is suspicious. Even Marina doesn't want to share it with us. Jess asks, you mean its unique to just him. Marina says, exactly. Once I heard about it, I couldn't believe it. His way of thinking is very different than yours or mine. The way he copied me is nothing short of brilliance. Suffice to say its not something people will accept easily.

Just what did David tell her. But if even Marina is not ready to explain it, its something really serious. I point to Blake, if I ask him. Marina says, try him. Poor guy tried to act like he understood, but I know his brain fried and later said to me he rather forget about it. Jess says, jeez. You know, the way you talk about David. Why not ask him out. You two are close anyways. I turn to Jess with a sharp glare. Jess leans away a little with a smile, what. Just saying. Marina laughs, nah. He is more like a brother to me. I rather not think him of like that.

Catherine smirks with a sinister smile, really. And why is that. Marina says thinking and searching for words, well, he. Jess asks, different? Catherine asks, too brainy? I ask, keeps too many secrets? She looks at us with flustered face, no. I don't have problem with that. But, she becomes even more flustered, he knows more about me than anyone. I rather keep some things simple between us. Besides, he is not my type. And I am not his. Catherine asks, I see. Interesting, what does he know about you. Like your childhood. Marina nervously smiles, not going to talk about it.

Maybe Marina has things even she is embarrassed or want to keep private. I ask, so wait. What is your type then. She says, if I had to say one thing in particular, someone who can keep up with me. All three of us lean away and look away from her. She cries, hey. Rude. I know I am high maintenance, but come on. How hard is it to find a guy. I have no idea if there is anyone that can be in tune with her. But who knows, maybe someone is perfect match for her. But the thought of two of them makes me anxious. Jess asks, you know David's type then. I should have known it would eventually come to this. I wished we didn't talk about David's dating life.

Marina smirks, really. Is there trouble with Nathan? Jess flairs her nostrils, no way. David is too scheming for my taste. She wasn't really wrong, people who haven't seen what he was like in the beginning tend to think that. She says, few of the girls were asking to me about him. Catherine remained impartial, but I wanted pay back a favor to her. This is a good time if any to ask about it. I ask, other girls are interested him. Catherine says, of course they are. He has been raking up quite a bit of name for himself. And now he went on live broadcast and said deeply emotional things. You do know that girls are attracted to that right?

Can't say I feel the same, he lied about everything though. Jess nods, that’s true. Its a tricky thing, that’s why I didn't want to intrude on him. Marina says, but that’s not really a problem, is it. Sure, he lied. But the reality is he was never guilty of any of those things. So what's the problem. Her logic made me even mad, not because I didn't know it he was innocent of it, but because this made me envious. He gets to lie, keep secrets, and doesn't trust people. And yet people admire him. I am angered thinking why I am not able to reconcile with the other facets of him.

Jess says, you known him longer than us right. So you must have some good idea about his type. What kind of girls has he dated. I was being cornered by three curious and excited gazes on me. I can't say what he likes and doesn't. His past girlfriends is either dead or trying to catch him. I say, its hard for me to say. You know how he is. But maybe he. The gods heard my silent plea and got me off this topic. Because there was huge commotion downstairs. I heard many people cheering and clapping.

Everyone here got up and walked to the edge of our floor. Below us people had gotten up and surrounding a figure crossing them in the middle. It was him. Dammit, did he bug us and planted to make an entrance just to mess with us. Blake says, finally. I thought he wouldn't show up. I wanted to do this during lunch, but he was busy then. I ask, you called him too. He replies, I did. He needs to get out of his house, thought this could help him out. Nathan says, look at him struggling. This is a rare treat.

I thought he was just being salty from the attention David is getting. However, it turns out David is not really acting like himself. He has wary eyes with unsure expression. He nervously chuckles as people give him fist bumps and waves to him. Even when shaking hands with him, he takes a delay to contemplate about it. Marina laughs, he is like a small fish trapped in the sea of piranhas. Catherine says, he needs to shake it off. Blake says, that he does. We can't have him act awkwardly all the time. First few times people will just shrug it off saying he was probably taken by surprise. I should talk to him about it later.

If someone had said few days before that David is going to be a celebrity like this, I would have just flipped them off. But seeing it in front of me, I just pissed me off even more.

Blake (Chapter 91)

Friday, January 30, 2026 15:27

We took our seats back once David approached out table. He had a nervous smile plastered on him. He waves at everyone as he passes around us and takes the chair I left open for him on my left. I say, you are way to troubled. He reply, no shit. I am really not comfortable with this level of reaction from people. Nathan says, you surprise me. You show a cavalier attitude when they be cautious or be suspicious of you. David makes a disappointed face, I can't help it. I have gone from being called a cheat and manipulator to this. This is way too fast and unpredictable. Every smile I see, I am either overthinking or not believing them.

I assumed as much. A paranoid guy like him is at ease when adapting in bad or difficult situations. He obviously never had received praised for his actions like this. He shifts uneasily on his seat, lets not make it a big deal. I will try to not be so awkward around people next time. People gave him encouraging smile. At least he is aware how is appearing to others. Then I shouldn't butt in and ask him to adjust his attitude. He turns to June, welcome June. You were Marina's top candidates, and its good to have you. June replies, thanks David. Its been a wild ride these months for me. Its help me realize this place is better for us in long term.

He says, glad you came to believe that as well. If only all of Citradel came to that conclusion. She says, they will. Especially when you are making their lives so miserable. That invoked a laughter from us. David smirks, funny you should say that. He turns to me, I couldn't make it during lunch because I had to deal with another pushback from Citradel. I ask curious, what did they do now. He replies, lets wait for others. I think I saw Tessa behind me. I agreed, so I filled him the current situation with Luther and Tina.

After the report he says, so Citradel is not playing ball on that front too, huh? Seems about right. Nathan asks nonchalantly, can't you do something about it. He snaps, I am already struggling to keep the materials away from Citradels grasp. Anymore than that and I might as well just declare war on them. Jess says, lets try for a diplomatic solution for them instead. Nathan says, that’s too slow. Blake, you said it right. We are loosing time. How much delay can we take.

I say, I need ideas, not complaints. Just then we see Tessa joining us, hey guys. Sorry for being late. I say, hey Tessa. No worries, we waiting for everyone. She takes her seat beside Vanessa, are the twins not coming. I reply, they will be here soon. Then I spotted Luther and Tine near the entrance. Their defeated aura showed their tired state. A few minutes later they walk sluggishly to our table. I say, you both look awful. Tina says annoyed, I hadn't had a shower until now. 39 hours. This is the worst. She takes a seat beside Luther. He was more collected, but visibly stressed, it was a bust on top of that. We only got to discuss some time in the night two days ago and since then we were blocked from even seeing anyone.

I say, thanks for trying though. Tina says, wait. David's already here. Oh shoot. I was supposed to make you the schedule of the next shipments. David says, don't worry about it Tina. I have made one for you already. Take a look at it in the morning. It can wait until then. She relaxes, oh jeez. Thanks. You seem much better than last time we saw you. Luther says, you have become quite a celebrity too. I saw Cranston's video on the way back. Marina says, though he is too shy. Its really not a good look on you.

David gives an short annoyed look at Marina. Luther says, really. I thought you wouldn't mind it. People are loving you and it makes also look good. David sighs, just stop it. I know this is good, but I rather not be praised about lying to people. Vanessa says, when has that ever stopped you. I was waiting for her to snap. I know she and David spoke recently, but she is still so hostile to him. He didn't hesitate to reply, the difference is it was about my past. There are people I don't want to bring into peoples conversation.

I ask, you mean about your guardians. I don't think you have to be worried about that. No one here can or will do anything to them. David wasn't convinced even after I all the times I tried to assure him. He might be also worried about Sophie. Its true that if Echo learns of this, they all will be jeopardized. Luther says, I understand the concern. But if keep that aside, it’s a matter of perspective. You did nothing wrong, don't forget that. David stayed silent, probably wondering on how to adjust to this new situation.

I say, regardless. This is pressuring Citradel even more. Did you hear about the latest Citradel policy. Luther nods, a rather typical response I would say. Nathan says, I find it very counter productive. People must be anxious there right now. Luther says, they were already before. If you think about it, with Heraknus being revealed and their sudden departure announcement, they were in turmoil way before this. Marina says, that’s true. My friend in Citradel said she say people were desperately trying to convince Heraknus to stay.

Luther says, that was the beginning. They are in worse situation right now. The first thing they gotta do is to hunker down and sort their houses. Because its crumbing down. Stopping Heraknus, finding Ryes and his possible co-conspirators, and holding on to their resources. Its no wonder they have closed the border. Next few days, maybe even a week will be tough for them. Nathan says, I get all that. But it feels this response was a little excessive. I feel something else is brewing there.

Marina asks, like what. He shrugs. I am beginning to feel the same, I wondered about it too. But Derek's not responding to me, so I have no new information. Marina says, my friend didn't mention anything. June says, same with my boyfriend. I turn to Catherine who shrugs saying, my contacts have either left Citradel before or not responding. So I got nothing. Then I turn to the silent David. He was worried about his contact, so I doubt if he also knew anything.

But turns out his contact is much better than anyone's. He says, Nathan, you might be right. I may know something. But I need all the Citradel people here to confirm something, because I don't understand it completely myself. Tessa says, in that case wait no more, here they come. All eyes turn to stair case and they both were climbing to us. Chealse says, shit. We are the last ones. Frank says, doesn't look good for us, right. I says, hey guys. Thanks for joining. But I thought I said to take it easy for first few days.

They both greet us all. Chealse sits beside Tina, I know. But Tina wasn't here, I thought to take some slack before she came back. Tina sighs, sorry for dropping things on you. Did you run into any trouble. She says, I would be lying if I said none. Lets just say I didn't know I was given my own person desk. Tina asks suspicious, what did you do. She says, you can see tomorrow. They both sigh. Nathan asks, so, you make any progress. Franks says, I got that component working half way. Nathan gets confused, half way. How the hell that makes sense. He shrugs, I know right.

I stand up, all right enough of that. Lets raise a toast for the four new officers. I took my drink from the table and others followed suit. David took one out of politeness. I walk to the edge of the railings and shout, guys. Just a minute of you time. People below stop gathering and turn their eyes above. I clear my throat and say, Everyone knows this already, but I wanted to formally welcome some new people from Citradel joining us. Everyone who just joined us, could you stand up and everyone gave a round of applause for them.

Around 35 Citradel officers stood up from various seats. Everyone applauses for them and cheers them on. I had made sure everyone of them were here tonight. I then wave to the four here, and here we have new additions our high ranking officers. You all already met Marina. She is joining our city admin team. And before anyone asks me, yes, that’s me in that video. But if anyone asks her what I was doing there, do not believe her. The hall bursts into sounds of laughs and Marina mocks at me smiling. I continue, June has accepted to join at IDF. If anyone wants to see her in action, I take a pause, don't. She is not be messed around.

People snicker and whistle at my joke. June made a flustered face at me, and took one step back in shy. Vanessa grabs her arm helping her stay. She really doesn't like to stand out, like David. I say, and you know these famous twins. They are one omega together, but double the strength of alpha's. So do not mess with them either. They both in proper gimmick raise their arms in unison and even turn their neck around in sync. People were eating up their performance like crazy.

I say, Chealse is in logistics team and Frank has joined our R&D team. Thankfully, they choose different department, because I didn't have the heart to separate them myself. The two of them laugh at my honest thoughts. I really was a little worried for a while. I raise my glass, so here's a toast to our newest team of recruits. You made a decision, and you choose right. Welcome to our city. A thunder of claps seers through the hall and people cheered. It would have been if everyone were happy, but many had trepidation. Its to be expected. They were from Citradel initially. Given time those worry will go away.

After a minute of celebration we come back to our seats and took our drinks. I asked the chef to prepare a special one today. All glasses were empty in few minutes while people congregates the 3 of them. Marina says, hey, no one said anything to me. Vanessa says, that’s was for others benefit. You are already a part of us. Don't forget about viral video. Maina remains still left out. She still is enjoying herself, I think. I wanted to dive right in, but I thought to at least have out dinner we get to our agenda. Everyone began to get tray from the buffet and started eating, well except for one person.

David remained behind reading something from his watch's hologram. I felt a little bad calling him here at the actual dinner time. He said he didn't mind it. June asks him, are you skipping dinner. He says, I had it before. She looks at him trying to understand why he do that. He replies, you haven't heard about me. June is confused, huh. About what? She really didn't know. I guess the details of this condition are not yet known to everyone. I tell her, he can't consume Kuret food or drinks. She puts her drink back on the table astonished, what. Since when. David replies, since birth. June jaw looses, is that because of MAR's.

David nods, yup. Other subjects had the same symptoms. June asks, I thought you just couldn't heal. But not able to eat is worse. What did you do on Medrine. He says, I didn't have much choice. Kuret free extracted foods. Which was basically chemically filtered goo. It was edible and nutrient sufficient. But barely. I was malnourished. The part about my medical condition after arriving on earth was actually true. June says, Jesus. I can't believe it. Marina sits beside her now, don't pity him though. He figured various ways to supplement his intake. I remember this one time at the university chemistry lab where was growing pure organic vegies inside a glass box in a cupboard.

June laughs. David turns a little embarrassed recalling that, you remember that. Please forget it. Marina smiles, no way. That was so damn funny. Who was the prof that had to bail you out. David quickly peeks at Catherine, who realized also who it was. He says, lets not talk about ancient past. Marina chuckles seeing a cornered David. She doesn't get a audience like this often. She was flaunting in front of everyone about knowing him back on Medrine. Well, beyond the Shadows that is.9

She looked like was going to share more embarrassing stories of David. I was actually looking for it. But David is not having it. He says, Marina, if you are going to revisit the past, I might also share things about you as a child. So lets not. Marina says, I am an open book. I got nothing to hide. But her aura showed some hesitation. David made it look like a challenge. I smile seeing something interesting. He says, courtyard of your house, evening on your 11th birthday. Shall I go on. As he was saying Marina was getting a little pale with each word. That instantly shut her up. She gets back to eating quietly. She whispers in very low tone to Catherine, see, I told you. What was that about.

Everyone had a nice laugh seeing someone was capable of making Marina awkward. This is where his skills shines the most, knowing people's secret. Marina shouldn't have tested David when its about his real past. Deni and Vanessa prodded her for details, but she just shrugs off. Nathan says, that’s not nice David. You shouldn't use shouldn't personal information like this. David titled his head to him, do you hear the words coming off your mouth. A second later he backs off him with a chuckle. Nathan's the one here that’s used it against David the most.

We all broke into more laughter and people began talking in small groups. I wanted us to finish our dinner first before moving to the main discussion. I was enjoying the little break too. After some light chit chats, Deni asks, hey Vanessa. Shouldn't we ask for their opinion about the thing we were discussing this morning. Vanessa says, lets not talk about that right now. She says, I get that. But it’s better to ask them now. We need help. I ask, its fine Vanessa. We are here to help out each other. Is there a problem?

Vanessa gave a disapproving look at Deni but then sighs to me, well, I didn't want to talk about work. Tonight is about these 3 people. June shakes her head, I don't mind. Its not lost on me we are in a middle of crisis. Besides, I really don't want to explain to Catherine why Sam loves his pets more than me. I gave a questionable look to Catherine, who felt she was betrayed. She panics with a nervous smile, that's not what I asked. Chealse says, don't mind us too. Frank nods along with her.

Vanessa says, if you are okay, then I guess its fine. We are having a problem with the cache of smuggled merchandise we recovered from the peoples homes. Sommers adds, we do? I didn't hear about it. Tessa asks, is it about the our contact team's refusal to take these items with then. Vanessa says, that's right. They are claiming the pieces are too dangerous to take them back and think to either destroy it or keep it with us. I ask, hold on. I saw reports of harmless stuff mentioned in there, paintings, artifacts and other human cultural significant items.

Luther says, are you saying that they have what, like some sort of tamper proof failsafe. Marina says, that seems overkill, don't you think. They paid so much money for it. Why risk that. Vanessa says, hold on guys. That's not what I meant. They didn't mean dangerous like that. They mean by their value and significance to Humans. Jess asks, you mean like Humans know they are stolen. Deni replies, we don't know that. But suffice to say that sending it back without explaining how we had in the first place could ring major alarms. They said that Humans might trace it back to us.

I ask, seriously. Did Wyan had such a wide network outside among humans. I turn to David, what do you know about it. He says, practically nothing. I mean I tried to find about him, but unlike our small population, there are far too many organizations out there. Though, if I know what kind of stuff we are talking about it could provide some hints. Deni says, they are old relics, that what we can make out. I don't know what's the fuss is about though. Vanessa says, agreed. I mean, we saw have painting this one paining a single women in it. I get that it was drawn by early humans, but I can't figure out why its so important.

Ruther asks, a painting of a women. Deni nods, yeah. You haven't seen it. We kept it in a storage room with others. Sommers says, yeah I saw it. A smiling dark haired women with some mountains in the back. I thought it was decent painting, considering it looked old. Ruther says, I think I have heard about it before. Now where did I remember it from. Jess chocks a little while eating and coughs. She asks, are you kidding me. Are you telling me there is a painting of Mona Lisa sitting in IDF right now.

This causes visible panic among few people. David besides me jerks, Nathan scoffs. Tina shrieks out a little, Catherine puts her glass away in haste and Frank puts his hands on his jaws. Ruther snaps his finger, yeah that one. Wait, holy shit. I didn't know what happened that made them this worried. I ask, who is she. Some famous painter. Tina ignores me, is that true. You have a painting from da Vinci collecting dust in storage. Vanessa was nervous just like me, I mean, we the team asked to lock in a safe place. But what's with the weird reaction.

Nathan says laughing, do you seriously not know what you have there with you. Deni turns pale, does this mean its really important. David says, just wait. He extended his arm and says, M show image of Mona Lisa. His watch throws a hologram in the middle of the table of a paining I saw in Vanessa's reports. He asks with a gulp, is this what you have. Vanessa says, yeah. David lets goes of the hologram and slaps his palm on his forehead, freaking shit. Wyan is far more of over achiever than I thought.

Tessa says, come on guys. You are exaggerating. Franks says, no we are not. This is a very big deal. Its an important part of human history. Catherine says exasperated, its around 500 years old. Its got a long history. Tina says, I can't believe I have a chance to see it in person. Seems only half of us knew what its real worth is. I ask, so I am guessing if we were to simply it back it would cause a problem. David says, a major one. The Italian government will search high and low to figure out how it was stolen and why they have forgery instead.

Tina asks, why do think there is a forgery in Lurve. He replies, Mona Lisa being stolen for the second time would be a big news. There are many legal reproductions out there, but none is currently hanged in Lurve. Either they are hiding that fact it was stolen or it's a forgery. Tina says, yeah, that's makes a lot of sense. Luther asks, this is really bad for us then, right. Marina says, can someone explain how its so valuable. David says, I don't know how to explain it so you can understand it. Someone please help me out here. Catherine says, I got this David. Guys, have you all must heard about the famous Kuritine sculpture made by Jenfroya Payalia.

Of course everyone knows about it. Its one the things very Medrone kid learns about our history. Vanessa says, isn't that the one in the Dorena city. Tessa says, the 5 meter tall statue. I have seen it too. Nathan says, that's the one. Catherine continues, imagine that, but even older and suddenly stolen from the Dorena elders. You think they would sit quiet after learning someone stole it and returned it later. I begin to realize the seriousness of the situation. David says, now you get it. Then something makes him jerk again, wait. If Wyan is able to smuggle that into the city, what else he got in.

The people with Human cultural history knowledge turn to Vanessa and Tina with horrified expressions. Vanessa says, hum, yeah there could be more. We have a painting called Rembrandt. Frank says, freaking shit. Chealse says, hey why do you know that. He says, better question is why you don't know about it. We took Earth cultural classes for a while together. She gets lost in thoughts trying to remember that. Nathan asks, which one is it. Jess says, please say its one of the famous missing ones. That would be incredible. Tina voice goes low, ah, I don't have a clue. David says, this is crazy. Did people really not care about keeping it for themselves here.

Marina ask, I didn't think you were into this so much. David says, I am not. But I am not so callous to not know their importance to Humans. Things may evolve, but not their place in history. Tina says, he is right. Catherine says, maybe its just a coincidence. Lets not make it panic before we know for sure. She turns to Vanessa, do you have something called Goya as well. Vanessa hesitates a bit not responding. Catherine scoffs, I was only kidding. Okay, we can now panic a little. Ruther says, I think I have heard that one too. Damn these people. They were using Wyan to steal these so brazenly.

Nathan says, what's next, the Shrik. Jess says, I doubt anyone has a taste like that among Medrones. Marina asks, what's that. Sounds so strange. Deni says, I don't think we have anything like that. Catherine says , that's the Norwegian name. Its English name is Scream. Deni shakes her head. Nathan says, dang it, I thought it would be here. David asks, do you have something that looks like it was made by a kid and someone is posing and screaming. Tina looks at Vanessa at that description. Their anxious expression gave it away. Jess smiles, I stand corrected. Apparently there is someone who likes it enough to steal it.

People began murmuring and whimpering about this stolen artifacts. Luther asks, lets try to think this through. What if don't give it back, just keep it with us. Even if humans know they are missing, the last thing they will suspect is aliens among them. Tina says, its not just that Luther. Keeping it here longer in dangerous, what if it gets destroyed. I know we lost a lot of our culture, I rather not see Human loose theirs too. A few shared similar sentiment as her. Catherine says, I am with her. We need a way to get it out of the city. Frank says, I rather we keep it with us. Wyan has already stolen it without alerting anyone. But if you guys think its better, I won't get in the way.

Nathan says, it's a waste to give it back. But I know the safer this way. Jess nods along with Nathan. The general census was best to give it back immediately. I say, If you all believe so strongly about it, I guess we need to figure out a way to get rid of it. A few moments of thinking and everyone's eyes fell on one particular person. David scoffs, right. I guess I am the only option huh. I ask, can you return it back without raising any suspicion back to us. He thinks for a moment, easier said than done. We recovered only partial items from people. I am guessing there are more people in the list yet to be decrypted.

Vanessa says, yeah, we are not even halfway done. He replies, so we can expect even more ridicules paintings, or even something else. I won't find it surprising if someone asked Wyan for a dinosaur fossils now. I wanted to believe that was joke, but I can't be sure of it. He continues, I can't give precious items back to government all together. Someone might link the thefts and involve the Interpol. That's especially bad for me. I am not charged for art crimes. Not yet at least.

Marina says, you worried about adding those charges on your name. He says, I am. Having more crimes pinned on me will make it difficult for my other businesses. He then cocks his head to the ceiling for a moment and then back to us, that being said, its not a bad thing if I do this correctly. Luther says, dude, only you would be okay with more crimes pinned on you. Maybe fame has messed you a little bit. David smiles, perhaps. Anyways, I am thinking for selling it to people, instead of giving it back to the owners and museum.

Vaness says with a snark, you dog. You want to make a profit from this. David defends himself, hey, its not me who stole it. Blame Wyan for this mess too. I am just explaining the reality here. I can't just courier Mona Lisa in a box to Lurve. It will cause a massive international manhunt. A trail that not even I can hide us as the source. Maybe I can return some items back to smaller museums or personal owners. But what if they report the unexplainable theft and even ridiculousness of its anonymous return.

He had a point. David turns to Tina, I know you want to give it back to their rightful place. But its very risky to do it ourselves. Tina replies with a somber face, I get what you mean. It may not be the right move for us. David nods, and I can't just sell it for free to other people. That's even more suspicious. So I gotta sell it off quickly and silently. I think I can find a way that they remain undetected for long enough that trail goes cold for anyone to find out about us. It may take months, or even years. By then the original source of the theft will go unsolved. That's the best option right now.

I consider this for a moment, if you believe that, then I leave it to you. David nods, great. It will take some time though. He then smiles, actually, it's serendipitous. I have burned a lot of cash fighting against Citradel. This might help in making me whole again. I know one person who would be ecstatic and back off me. He turns to Vanessa, keep it safe in IDF right now. Once everything is cataloged, I will take it off you. People had mixed feelings about it, especially Tina. Her aura showed a lot of regret. Nothing can't be done about it though.

But Vaness remained a bit unconvinced. I ask, something else the matter? She gives us a big smile, like she just thought of something sneaky. She says, if you are going to sell it for money, tell me why I should be giving it you for free. Marina whistles, that's cold, Vanessa. She ignores that snide comments, if you are going to get benefit from this, why shouldn't we. Everyone were stunned by Vanessa's sudden reluctance. I thought things had cooled down for her. But maybe that was just wishful thinking. Does she still carries so much petty anger towards David.

David was even caught off guard with this. He says, a few minute ago, Deni was telling us how you guys were thinking of destroying it. And now you are using it as leverage against me. He smirks at Vanessa's change in demeanor. She laughs, a minute ago you weren't going to sell stolen things too. David scoffs, so you want me to buy it from you. Vanessa shrugs suggesting it was the only way. Beside her Sommers, Deni and Ruther gave nervous look to watch other. Tessa and June were also confused.

Nathan says chuckling, bold move. I kind of like it though. David gives slight glare towards Vanessa. Oh boy, he is not going to let this go easily. He tells, you do know that if I want, I can just break into IDF and take it for myself. Vanessa remains skeptical for this, if you could, you wouldn't be so bothered by it. I am guess you don't want to make an enemy of IDF by doing this. Don't you? And by that she meant herself. She was intentionally provoking him in front of everyone one. I sigh realizing she still has enough grudge against David to rebuttal this.

Others from IDF didn't share the same confidence as her. Ruther whispers to Deni, ah, is she going to make an enemy of David instead. David pulled back some of his annoyance back while observing others. He snickers, all right. It does seem unfair to you. So lets make a deal. What do you need. A bigger budget for IDF ? Because I got the bank with me, he slaps Luther on the shoulder. Luther says, hey now. That's not how economics work here dude. He replies, I know, but you can make exception right.

Luther says, no way. He then turns to me, how about I get the coffee machines, like mine, for the officers building, seems a good compromise then. I didn't even hesitate, Luther maybe we can make an exception just this time. Luther turns to me incredulously, coffee, really. Marina spats, say that again after you tried it once. I have been dying to grab another one for few days now. Others were not sure what happened. I think I might have been influenced by David's seriousness. But honestly, I do believe if Vanessa needs a bigger budget, we can give it to her.

Luther was caught between him and me now. I remained silent wondering in Vanessa really wanted money. She says, really now. You think I am so shallow to ask money for this. Sommers, actually we already sent a request for

that a few hours ago. We got a lot of new officers joining our department than any of others. So its fair, right. I turned to Luther, who says, I was about to discuss it for tomorrow. Vanessa says, that’s not what I want. David sighs, thank god. Because I was not ready to be extorted like this. Looks like no coffee for you guys. Marina and I made a slightly disappointed look.

This made the mood a lighter amongst us. I think David wanted to take away some of the awkwardness Vanessa was causing everyone. Vanessa says, we are not in shortage of people, and yet our security is not enough. We have had increasing attempts to escape recently, things are becoming gradually becoming difficult for us to guard all the edges around the island. Tessa says, she makes a point. On top of that, the expansion plan doesn't include our security as high priority.

Vanessa adds, right. Its fine for outside threat, but the inside threat is a growing concern. Blake, I know you wanted people to keep their faith in IDF. I just think finishing up the smuggling criminal case is not enough. We got lucky no died. But I can't let it happen again. Seems she has been thinking about it for a while. I nod, I get your concerns. But what is David going to do for you that we can't.

She says, glad you said it that way. I heard about those autonomous bots David has. I want him to give it to us. Even the killer robots Marina told about us a while back.

David (Chapter 92)

Saturday, January 31, 2026 14:23

What a little minx. She is definitely gunning for me because of my behavior last time we met. I was out of line, I get that. But in my defense I had to lie to every Medrone about my past that day. I was also on edge since I heard she tried to reveal my identity to Elina. The issue was between us, why bring Elina into it. Once I noticed she wasn't going to hide her resentment, I decided to distract everyone and make some jokes. I managed to diffuse the situation before she escalated any further. There was no way that Luther would bank roll me. But its was funny that Blake almost did it when I bribed him with coffee.

The heavy air seemed to less and for now at least Vanessa didn't push it further. But then she asked something completely unexpected, my ART bots. You want those. She nods, is that what its called. Then yeah. Its clear she is not letting go of the grudge. She is cleverly blanketing with something reasonable. Frank asks puzzled, you have robots with you. He gets excited about it. Marina says, oh he got lot more than that. Let me tell you new joiners. She began tattling about my ART house.

But my mind is hooked on Vanessa. She seems to enjoy putting me on the spot like this. I do know she is thinking about IDF and its reputation. But she could have made it less mischievous or asked for it separately later. I turn to Blake who was probably thinking the same. Did he or Marina told Vanessa about them from the video I showed them earlier. No, they wouldn't have. Vanessa hasn't seen them. She probably just heard about it from them. Or maybe from Catherine. So what should I do now. This deviates from the plan I had for the bots a little. After thinking over it, I decided on a negotiation plan.

I needed to confirm few things so I waited for Marina to finish her story. Nathan turns to me, I didn't know you were looking into this avenue. You are holding out a lot from us. Aren't you. He is involved in one major research mission with me, so I am sure he suspects there are other too. Frank says, I need to see this man. You have successfully integrated Hive tech into Medrine tech. I correct him, not Medrine. Earth technology. And its not completed. Marina is so up my ass about finishing it up quickly. She scoffs at me, because I only got to see it from outside. Catherine got a inside tour. Catherine sighs, again, I didn't see much of anything.

Vanessa asks, so how about it. You can give it to us, can't you. I am sure you other security measure available. The island needs it more. I could feel the pressure from few people now. But I had already made up my mind and just smiled, sure. I got no problem. Vanessa smirk slightly wavered, probably wondering I am giving it up so easily. I add, they are not combat ready. Any person with strong Kuret or a decent weapon can destroy it easily. Vanessa remains silent at my acquiesce behavior. Sommers says, that’s perfectly fine. We only need it for surveillance and minor scuffles. Deni says, we can come up with a response based actions then.

Tessa asks, I have a suggestion in that case. We can rearrange our crews to be more spread inside the city rather than out. Avoid another situation like this. Can these bots can go underwater ? That will save a lot of effort and time in manual patrolling around the border. I say, sure. I designed them for underwater operations. They can even shift into marine life, like fishes, sharks, whales, or seafloor faunas. And they can mimic the biological signals of the creatures they shift into, so unless someone is at close proximity, they are virtually undetectable.

People are impressed by the tech. June asks, and it has no Kuritine or Medrone tech. I shake my head, none. So not even Echo know about it. But I am not sure about Hive. Its their tech, I haven't been able to field test that. Luther says, that's plenty stealthy already. But why have such advance tech. I sigh, because the house I am living is much more important. I needed max security for it. I don't think its time to reveal my ultimate goal with it. I let that sink in and let others believe whatever they wanted.

Tessa asks, what about arial surveillance. Marina said they were flying. I reply, unfortunately there is limit there. It doesn't have a sufficient power source to sustain itself for a perpetual flight. The last test I did showed around 1 hour of aerial time at a max height of 0.7 miles. But you can send it in separate batch for continuity. Ruther says, that’s awesome. We are lacking in surveillance from above. I add, the cameras on them go to about 400 optical zoom. I have been playing around the idea of a satellite system with this. Though its just an idea for now.

This made many excited. Blake says, seriously. We needed an interface like that. Nathan, we were planning for it right. What was the progress for it. He says, its just at the design stage. We were more focused on reinforcing ground infrastructure first. Which type of interface are you using for it. I say, lets not get into technicals now. Just know its the same software as what SpaceX is using. Its not integrated into a single interface, but maybe you can look into it. He nods, that I can do.

Marina asks with excitement, what about those killer bots. I laugh at her excitement with others. I answer, they are functional too. But a word of caution for them. I face Vanessa who was no longer enjoying anymore. She really thought I would cause a scene by getting angry at her for such a demand. She asks, what's the catch. I say, they are not people friendly. I programmed them for operational efficiency and combat flexibility. I haven't focused tested about their appearance with people. Their tech doesn't allow for much shift in exterior form, but only on weapons. I am very certain its going to scare people instead of making them feel safe. Kids will most definitely be wary of it.

Blake asks, the one Marina and I saw weren't that scary. I say, those aren't combat bots. They weren't present in the video I showed them earlier too. I turn to Vanessa, I tried to change the design but it was interfering with other operations. So I didn't pursue it. Luther asks, its actually better for us if its intimidating. But on the other hand. Blake completes his words, if this makes people unformattable it could be difficult. Marina says, we can just dress them with a designer metal frame.

I say, maybe. Like I said, I wasn't going for aesthetics right now. Try to upgrade them without restricting any of their core designs. Have at it. Nathan smiles, I feel you are just dumping things to me. I nod, that’s right. Since Vanessa is haggling for it, I might as well let you guys finish the tech. Tessa says, that’s all fine. But what's the power source. If its not Kuritine, then I don't think its simple as a battery. I look around people and say, I wanted to confirm this. Are you all okay with keeping that a secret. Vanessa says, you don't us to tell anyone about it. Why.

I was intentionally making a show to her. She was slightly annoyed with me. But I had to make her believe this is me not playing any tricks on her. Otherwise she might sense my intention. I say, people might try to steal the tech or study it then. Blake says, all right. Anyone has any problem with keeping it just between us. Vanessa slightly hesitated, but others agreed to it without an issue. I waited for a verbal confirmation from Vanessa. She finally says, sure. That’s all I needed. I say, I got my hands on a the designs of the tech Citradel uses to power majority of their other techs. My science team found a way to alternate the Kuritine supply with a cold fusion drive.

As expected not many people understood the concept. Save Nathan, who shrieks, holy shit. Cold fusion reactors. They are real. I thought it was a just a theoretical concept Human scientist have. I say, well, its not exactly that, but its close enough. We reversed engineered that tech from Echo's war ships. They have far advance power source, and we only were able to achieve 30 % of their energy output. At least, for now. But we if you guys can figure out a way, you can reinforce it with Kuritines source. I haven't researched that. Its another development you guys can look into it.

Nathan asks, if its fission, then it means nuclear materials. We aren't exactly a big supply for it. And it will take time to modify the tech of our purposes I reply, I got you covered. I will provide enough cesium to last for another two years. That must be enough to come with an alternate source. Nathan says, you just have that much lying around with you. I say, be thankful to the actual team who are in charge of it. I design, give directives and provide the science, but they have much higher IQ than me.

He asks, just who are they. I want to meet them. I reply, dream on. They are people who I am trusting with these tech. I have to think about their safety. Nathan clicks his tongue at my rejection. Catherine says, I didn't understood the science, but I am still stuck on the fact that you stole the designs from Citradel. Do they know about this leak. I shrug, I don't know. I have been asking them for years. I didn't realize they would be so stingy with at least the designs. But they didn't comply. I didn't like the fact that they were hoarding it for themselves. I told you that I have contact earlier, he got it for me around 18 months ago. It took a lot of time and effort in this development. But I am quite happy with the result.

Blake asks, you had the designs this long. Why not share it with us. I reply, I was about to share it. But then they went ahead with the idea of tournament. And everyone accepted it. Do you think it would be wise to reveal it back then. They had their spies everywhere. It would jeopardies many things. So I figured to just keep it hidden a while longer. Besides, didn't I say already back on the pier that its still a prototype. I didn't want to give unfinished products, not the house or the bots. Franks says, but you said its functional. I reply, functional, but not flawless. There is a 33 % chance of it overheating and exploding. Imagine if it was in middle of crowd or a bot is flying over in the sky.

That made them wary of it. Actually it was a lie, it had only 10% percent chance of malfunctioning. But I was over estimating it so that Vanessa doesn't pick up what I was doing here. She already takes whatever I say with a grain of salt. I didn't want to make it look I was hiding it for something else. Vanessa says, I think I understand now. We are right now pressuring Citradel. We already blamed them and Ryes for Wyan. So we can't let them know this and make it worse. I nod. I think she is accepting it for now. Blake asks, that would be bad. But on the other hand, when they do join, won't they figure it out eventually.

I say, if you want to use my tech, you are going to have compromise something. Luther says, Blake, we can keep it under wraps and then make it look like we got their designs after they joined us. Right. He gesture to confirm it with Nathan. He says, well, sure. I mean, if we want to use our own tech in it, we need their help. So I suppose it wouldn't be hard to make it seem like they shared with us. I am glad they were quick on deciding this. I turn to Vanessa, you cool with this. If you are then I am ready to hand it over to you.

The ball was in her court now. People were waiting for her response. She looked at Tessa who also convinced it was good enough. She then replies, fine. Since its for our protection, a little white lie won't be a problem. I swear I could hear her grinding her teeth as she said that. But others were more glad about the tech being introduced to the island to notice that. Blake says, that’s settled then. But are you sure you are okay to give it away. I say, its fine. Vanessa makes a hard bargain. But she is right, IDF took a hit and they need to do more to assure people. Not just the people in the city right now, but others also who will join.

The IDF team got excited and even praised Vanessa for it. She had lingering doubts, I am sure. But she was smiling nonetheless with them. I add, however. I need one more help. Or rather two of them. Vanessa smiles instantly drops. I smile thinking she was panicking a little. I say, don't worry. Its more like a favor. Loan me your boyfriend and Sommers for time to time. Sommers raises his eyebrows, wait what. I explain, Heraknus are coming, no matter what Citradel do. So I need to fight Charles. And I need all the help I can get to prepare for it. I would like you to help with spars a couple of times in the next 3 weeks.

Sommers was caught off guard, but then he understood it, oh, I get it now. You want my help to prepare for Charles strength focused attacks. I am game. He turns to Vanessa who was still thinking about it. I added, Ned can copy Charles Kuret and help me with real sparing. Even if its not the real deal, it would be a lot of help. She asks, why not ask for Matt? I nod, I will. Even Cassandra too if she agrees. I rather not ask other of their people. Sommers alpha Kuret strength should be a good enough. And since we don't know where Matt and Neds alpha's is, I'll take both their help.

She thinks for a moment, you talked to Ned. I reply, not yet. But I will. I am just letting you know now. I might have hit a nerve. So I guess something is really going on between Ned and Vanessa. I haven't looked into this, but Blake said something about it in the morning. That could be a reasons why she is so angry with me. Its possibly she is redirecting at me. I was being rude to her now. But I didn't care. She wanted to put me in a bind in front of everyone. I can't let her think I am so easy.

She relents after a while, if he agrees to it. I got no problem. So a roundabout way to say she won't ask him. I guess that shows they did have a fight. I turn to Catherine and waited for her next. She shrieks, me too. I nod, it would help with visual training when others are busy. She replies after a second, okay. Sure. But it would be just a hollow Kuret body. I say, don't worry about it. I was talking to these two in the morning about it. Charles overdrive form might not be same. So it would be better to prepare for different possible forms he might take.

That impresses her, that’s a really good idea. In that case, I am in. The next time in contact with him, I can copy his Kuret appearance. Then I turn to alpha twins, I like your help too. But only its not awkward. You know, since you

just transferred here. Chealse says, I don't mind, but our Kuret isn't a strength type. Frank understood before her sister, I get it. You want to prepare for the endurance challenge. Charles may be fighting for 10 minutes, but it will be very intense. You want to prepare for continuous barrage of attack.

He is smatter than he looks. I say, your both can switch your attacks without exhausting individually. Chealse, oh that makes sense. Damn David. You have given it a lot of thought. I nod, I had some time to prepare for it. So how about it. They both look to each other and continuing with their gimmick, they give okay gesture to me with a smile. This was an unexpected opportunity to get people's corporation. I had just given up something to the island, so I didn't want to waste this opportunity to get some favors in. I could have done this later, but somehow it was satisfying to do it in front of Vanessa. I am very sure she thinks I was planning for this. But actually it was cover so that she doesn't notice the other thing.

I put that thought aside for now, thanks guys. Appreciate it. I turn to Deni, can you get me access to the stollen items then. I like to catalog it as soon as possible. Deni says, yeah. Sure. Ruther asks, how many of the bots do you have. I take a moment to recall, I have 250 of the small drones for both flying and underwater expeditions. 36 ground bots with different weapon configuration. And about 12 of the actual killer bots. Marina spats out, what. That’s not security, that’s a personal army. What the hell. I shot her a look, the number doesn't make lick of difference against strong Medrones. It may be crude to say, but anyone from the top 500 warriors from the tournament could crush dozens of them.

Blake says, when you said they aren't combat ready, you meant it would be only useful against regular people. I nod. Luther says, still, its good enough for the island. With those numbers we can cover every sector in the island. Marina says, its more than that. I say its almost enough to cover the island and the extended ocean border. I held my tongue here, hoping no one catches how close Marina guess was. Thankfully no one paid attention to it. People were enjoying that fact I had such impressive tech.

Vanessa asks, when can you send it over. I answer, I need around a week or so to configure it. Once its done, I will explain to your IDF tech team on how to operate it. She says, seems like a good plan. How will you sell the artifacts, out team said they would but difficult to deal with. I say, let me worry about it. Its the business I do with Humans. I figure you rather not know about it. She sighs, that’s true. Blake asks, Luther, where does this makes us with the expansion plan for security.

He thinks for a second, I like to say about a third of our plan. Why do you ask. He smiles, because this helped me find a solution for current dilemma with Citradel tech team stuck in Italy. I had an inkling what he was thinking about.. Blake says, why don't we show this technology to them. So far they thought we were behind Citradel in terms of technology. And we are in many domains. But this one is far more advance than Citradel.

Nathan jerks, genius. He turns to me, no offense. I shrug putting it off. He continues, since we don't want to force them or abduct them. We give them something they can't no to. Those nerds would no way be intrigued by this. He is right, those Medrones might believe siding with us gives us the best chance for tech development. Tina asks, but aren't those team more specialized for Kuret enrichment. Would they have the expertise to even understand this.

Luther says, even if they don't, its fine. They will relay it back to Citradel to others. I guarantee this would make them reconsider even more. Either way, if we show them the thing we lacked, the council members would be even more pressured. This could work Blake. Blake says, lets hope so. I was hoping to hear ideas from others to help me out here. I didn't expect something actually promising already. We should try it immediately.

I had a little concern and ask, why the hurry. You can wait them out. Blake shakes his nod, its like you told us before. Better to not give them time to think and retaliate. I get what he was trying to do. But he didn't have the information I got this morning. I say, just hold that thought. He is puzzled like others. I say, lets set aside the ART tech for a moment. Everyone prepared for it. Let me tell you something. I waited for Vanessa to give me the go ahead.

Then I tell, who hear know who is Selene, an alpha from house Reton in Citradel. People turned to the Citradel folks. June says, sounds familiar. Marina says, me too. I know I have seen her somewhere. Ah, geez its been so long I can't believe I would forget people. Chealse says, seriously guys. You should have visited the church more often. She is the priest there. That made them recall her. Marina says, yeah. That’s right. Catherine says, hold on. There is only one church Medrones visit and Selene isn't the priest.

Chealse says, she just recently became one after replacing the old one. Now the message Jack sent made sense. Ruther says, Citradel has a church? What religion are they from. Marina says, sort of all combined one. It took a lot of cultural stigma's and hurdles, but the previous priest made it under one convent. Hoping to make a new religion people can follow on Earth. Frank says, I think I have met her when she was studying under the priest.

I ask, how much sway does the church has in Citradel affairs. June says, I don't really know. I know that the priest in the council. So at least they have a vote on things. Marina says, why are you asking about it. I reveal the info now, I heard something concerning from my contact. There is a reason for Citradel sudden clamp down on closing the border. I don't know why, but Selene, using the Church name and is preaching hard to everyone that Blake, Marina and Charles are our hope. Chosen by gods due to their overdrives. So they should move here.

Blake says, she said that? Marina says, chosen by gods. What a load of crap. I say, I didn't know she was the priest. But now I know why her name came up. Council think she or someone in church might be in league with Ryes. And there is some friction due to this. Marina leans her head on the back of her hands on the able, never mix politics and religion. Always a bad combo. It was a very simplistic way of thinking, but she wasn't wrong. Vaneesa asks, is she working with Ryes. I say, no clue. I have seen the church before, but I didn't thought much of it back then. But this is the first time they are voicing their opinion this hard.

June asks, but Sam didn't tell me about it. I say, if you talked to him yesterday, then he wouldn't know about it. Selene wasn't making those claims until this morning. That’s why I couldn't come by during lunch. Blake says, what happened today exactly. I say, I don't know the whole story. Selene is gathering people to leave Citradel. I don't know if its mutually agreed or if she is forcing people. My contact said one of his friend was approached and it almost seemed like they weren't giving him much of choice. But then another friend joined on his own volition.

Luther says, this is not good. We don't want to have a internal conflict within Citradel. That will only divide them further. Blake says, it’s a problem. But we can't do anything about it, can we. I say, true. That’s why I rather not kick the hornets nest even more. You really want to go to Italy with this tech, fine. But you have to be careful what you say to them. Like Marina said, politics and religion is a dicey combination. Blake says, that does make things a little difficult. Tessa tells, there has to be a way to make convince Citradel, with or without this tech.

I guess I made things complicated for them even more. But its better they know it now, than later. Blake, Luther and Nathan were in deep discussion about this. I let them decide the best course of action. I am glad I don't have to take any decision with this. Marina asks, so your friend made contact with you. I nod, he did. Thank your friend for me. Turns out he was unsure what to do next. When your friend contacted him, he decided its time for him to leave.

Catherine asks, isn't Citradel on lockdown right now. I lean in closer, he still wants out. He said things are spiraling out of control there. He wasn't in trouble, but he didn't want to risk it. And I agreed. Vanessa asks, you are going to break him out of there. How? I say, we have a plan and a way out. I am sure they notice him missing. But it will be too late to do anything about it. Jess asks, is he coming here. I say, yeah. I am going to ask Blake to hide them here under different identity. I am not about to make them an enemy of Citradel.

Marina says, them. You have more people. I say, when arranging their transport, he told me he got married and has a one year old son. He kept it hidden for me all this time. He was probably thinking I would question his loyalties. Vanessa asks, and do you? I scoff, of course I do. He would naturally priorities his family now. I don't want him to live in constant doubt. Raising kids is already stressful enough, him spying would be just cruel. Marina asks, what did he tell his wife for leaving Citradel.

I say, I am not sure. Either he told her everything, or she is just following him. I didn't waste time asking about it. He doesn't feel safe for his family. That was enough for me to extract them out. Marina asks, how exactly? We had escapees before, but the security's gotten better later. I smile, I have visited Citradel exactly three times. By the last visit, I found a way to break in or break out. Its a way that is not secure. But once its used, the council will know about it and close it.

Marina asks, sewer systems. That’s the only place I can think of. I say, not quite. Lets not discuss about that, I rather not tell anyone about it until I get him and his family out of there. Marina says, I got it. But I would really like to know where me and Derek missed. I sensed her to be a little defensive about this. I will tell her about it after the meeting privately. June the asks nervously, ah, David. Is it possible for you to get another person out of Citradel. I turn to her puzzled. Then I remember she has boyfriend. I ask, Sam?

She nods hesitantly, I wasn't worried about him until now. But now Selene is causing a ruckus. So much that your friend is risking to leave Citradel. I don't think I want leave behind Sam. I get her concern but its not same. I tell, look. My friend is spying for me. He is worried about being caught. So I am getting him out of there. But I don't think you have to worry about Sam. Marina adds, Citradel council will not let harm anyone. No matter what happens. June says, I get that. But what happens that changes. Selene is a far more progressive priest if she is forcing people to join her side. Sam isn't religious, but what if he is roped into it.

Chealse says, you are making me worried about my girlfriend too. Frank says, don’t forget about our foster parents. Catherine says, guys. I get you all are worried. But its not so dire that they need to be pulled out. Vanessa says, she is right. We can't just irresponsibly extract people from Citradel. It would make things worse for us. June says, I know what I am asking. But you can't guarantee their safety there, can you? Tessa asks, if you are so worried, how about asking for help. Maybe some friends or someone can to protect them.

June says, I don't have many friends left in Citradel, certainly not close enough to ask them this. Frank says, I know some people who can help, but I can't just involve them like this. Not until there is direct threat. Chealse says, a lot of the warriors have moved here, so we don't have many dependable people left back in Citradel. Jenna isn't a fighter. She is a simple fashion designer. She has no one to protect her too. As I listen to them I was thinking a way to help them ease their concern.

Vanessa was right about the repercussions. I can't just pull these people out of Citradel without a clear threat. But on the other hand they won't be able to completely let go their worries. At least not without some sort of back up plan. I say to them, guys. Listen. I don't want to make a real enemy of Citradel. So lets do this instead. The plan for him to leave is going to take some time. 5 days. That’s how long he has left in Citradel. His absence would be noticed, but no one will no he was a spy. There are many loose ends to tie.

Vanessa says, so they have the same time to decide. I nod, like I told earlier, the escape route is a one time thing. Even if you ask me to help them out, my first priority is to get 3 people out. So the original plan will not change. That being said, I may be able to allow others to join them. June gets anxious, you are going to help. I say, hold on. You are skipping a lot steps before that. First talk to your people. Ask them if they are really okay to leave Citradel like this.

Tessa says, they will need some time to think about it anyways. Catherine sympathizes, its not easy to leave the place you lived for so long suddenly. June and other didn't thought about that until we pointed it out. I say, at the very least tell them to be wary of the situation. Their consent is paramount for me to trust that they are serious. Vanessa says, if possible, ask them to first contact the council. They are not allowing people to leave, but it would be better to know if Citradel is seriously complying or not. Makes it easier for us to believe Citradel is using any excuse to keep people. And easy for us to help you out.

She brought up a good idea. Chealse says, yeah. I guess we should try the correct way first. I say, there are no wrong ways. Its just about knowing which way will have less consequences. My words resonated with them now. I think

this was the right call. Give them time to think about it. Vanessa says, I want to help you all too. If can convince Blake and Luther about the real dangers, we will support you guys. June says to me, thanks. I know I am making an unreasonable request. I should talk to Sam first. I'll call him immediately. She got up and walks to the corner of the room.

Chealse follows suit, might as well confirm with our people too. Frank nods and they both find a separate corner of the room. Marina gets up as well, I don't think my friend will go for this, but no harm in checking. She joins the others on their phones. I turn to Blake and Luther who were listening to us. I turn my eyes to him. He says, yeah, I heard. Luther says, if there is a legitimate reason, we will get them out. But until then we aren't going to provoke Citradel in such direct manner.

I say, I am just the middle guy here. What about your negotiation tactics. Nathan tells, we will use your tech as a incentive. Despite the obvious dangers, its still the best play. Blake says, its true this will make Citradel more angry, but it’s a risk we have to take. Besides, he smiles, they are focused on you more than me right now. I only blamed them on a probable suspicion, but you are openly attacking them. These bastards. They are banking on the hope that the council is going to be focus with my external efforts to undermine them, rather than the internal conflicts. I turn to others who were probably on the same page as him.

I sigh, you are going to use my sudden popularity as part of your game. Nathan says, of course. Why else we asked you to tell others. He isn't even making an effort to look guilty about it. Catherine says, don't worry David. We got your back if anything happens. Vanessa smiles, you have to know you are our city's favorite poster boy right now. I bet even the other communities would soon be on your side. Tina says, they are beginning to. We send teams to them earlier to asses the damage, and its being slowly replaced in your favor.

I was unconfirmable before, but now feel the weight of it even more. Others make a light banter seeing me so cornered. I think I heard Deni saying I am being shy about it. Someone said I am pussy. And I heard one particular girl whispering I faking this whole embarrassment attitude. I need to do something about her. Ruther asks, hey David. I got to know something. You said you had a way to get in and out of Citradel undetected. Does that mean you have something for this island too. Sommers says, no way man. Unlike Citradel, we don't have to worry about Humans. We got Kuritine barriers and maned patrols.

I gave them a slick smile, not confirming anything. Sommers chokes a little, nah, you are bluffing. I shrug. Deni gets excited, so you don't know how to do it. I didn't respond. Ruther says, you do know. Tell us. Now I gave them a wicked smile, wanting to exact a small revenge for messing with me. Vanessa tells, he is just messing with us. This place is secure, no one will ever escape or break in. I respond, its good to have such confidence. She glares at me, trying to figure me out.

Tessa says, I am not sure about it. We are soon going to use his tech. So even if he didn't have a way, he might have one now. She ogling me with a smile, but I didn't take the bait. I tell, maybe you are right. But who knows, one day we might get to see if its true or not. People gave me questionable looks, and I am enjoying each of them.

David (Chapter 93)

Friday, February 6, 2026 13:11

I yell, this is not working, Blake. He answers, then we do this until we get it working. Its been already 30 minutes me hanging upside down from a tree. The ropes on my legs and arms strapped on me were stopping me from balancing from the swaying. Blake launches another Kuret attack, I could vaguely see glimmers of the Kuret behind my back. But this position makes it impossible for me to predict the moment of impact. I will my Kuret towards the back, hoping it will shield me this time. But I misjudged the timing and could only protect my upper back.

Pain surges through me from my tail bone and I grunt aloud. Blake says, its still not strong enough. Stop trying to predict it and focus on gathering your Kuret. Easier said than done. I sway in the air while focusing on strengthening my wild Kuret. This is what Blake planned to train me this morning. We first sparred on the ground. But I was using my hands to block Blakes Kuret blasts every time. Then we decided to tie my hands behind my back. But turns out my brain is hard wired to predict his attack from the glimmers, I was making Kuret shields on my body before he even threw his Kuret. After an hour he realized I needed to be in even more unpredictable situation.

And that's where I am right now. Hanging from the top of the tree with a rope tied to my legs. Initial few attacks I could parry, but then he started to swing me around the tree, up and down, side to side. This makes it impossible for me to plan anything ahead. Many a times I relexify tried to free my arms to block the attacks. Its hard to change my habit of using physical movements and rely on just Kuret alone. Blake approaches me from the ground, any changes to your Kuret.

My sweat flows backwards to my hair while I gasp for some air, not really. Its really frustrating. I feel like it's just there, but the moment I think I get it, it slips away. My arms are sore, falling above my head. I have been trying for more than an hour, the most I achieved was to keep my wild Kuret around my body. But stabilizing it instinctively is proving to be really difficult. Blake says, we won't see any improvements in the first day. It will take a lot of practice. We will keep at it in the first few days. You should soon begin to control your Kuret whenever needed and save your stamina for physical movement.

That's the new goal. I focus my Kuret to cut the rope around my legs. But it didn't break. I sigh when I forget it was carbon steel. If it were a normal rope I would have broken free already. I say, a little help. Blake says, you done? I reply, not really. But its 8:30 now. You have to get back to work. He pulls out his phone from his jacket pocket, its time already huh. Didn't realize we have been at it this long. He then fly's over to top of the tree to unknot the rope. Once it loosens, I fall to ground. But my Kuret cushions the fall with a burst of impulse thrusting me up and land softly on my feet.

My breathing is ragged and the sudden blood rush away from my head makes slightly woozy. But by now I had gotten used to this many times, so I wait for Blake to return and untie my arms. He lands behind me and works on the rope. I ask, you are going to send some people to Italy. He nods, last night we discussed our options. Its not my first preference, but sending Nathan and Frank seems the logical choice. They can speak their language and they both can handle the Citradel warriors.

I didn't like it either. We have many eyes on him inside the city. Sending Nathan alone and unsupervised makes me anxious. But we can't afford to send more people and antagonize them. This is a scientific discussion now, instead of a diplomatic effort. Blake says, I would have liked someone from IDF to tag along him. I says, but they are needed to find all the people who have smuggled items. I understand. Just make sure to educate Nathan what will happen if he causes any trouble for us.

He smirks while releasing the restraints. My arms ache a little from being bounded for so long. He says, I will. Jess asked if she could go with him, hoping she could reign him in. I smile at that thought. He continues, but I want to know if Nathan can be trusted enough for this. He was more or less well behaved during the interrogations. So I need to know if he is really on board with this. I sense a little more to this than just caution. I ask, you don't think that he is the one behind Ryes and the stolen drugs. Because that's.

He says, I know. Its impossible. That's why I trust him enough to send alone. The worst case would be picking someone who is backstabbing us. That's not I am worrying about. Its just that Frank is with him. I just hope he doesn't cause a scene by making use of Frank. I can imagine Nathan trying to win them over by explaining the recent transfers of Citradel warriors. I answer, he is smart. He knows what cards to show and how. He won't use that card unless needed.

Blake says, lets hope so because I can't clean up his mess out there. I already knew what he wanted as a backup, you plan to send a shadow to keep an eye on him. Aren't you. He says, don't read my mind dude. Not cool. But he chuckles at me, yeah I will. I have asked to not reveal themselves under any circumstances, unless someone is in mortal danger. We have a lot riding on this, can't have Nathan screwing up in any way. I add, it's a good idea. I like to see their individual capability too.

After then we started to walk out of the forest, back to Blakes car. I pull out the towel from the seat and rub my face. I had a workout this morning, and with this sort of training, I was drenched in sweat from head to toe. Blake asks, I haven't asked this before because I didn't want to stress you out. But tonight's your meeting with Drew, isn't it. I nod, it is. We spoke yesterday and made plans to meet at my place at 8. He asks, did she tell what this treatment is. Because I can't wrap my head around it.

I say, I don't think its anything surgical, but she said its radical and experimental. Not much to go on from there. Blake asks, will there be risks. I didn't want to sugarcoat the truth, perhaps. Its experimental and so its not tested. But I have faith in Drew. You heard her last time, she just warned me ahead so that I can prepare myself better. Blake says, you know, you may not need it to do this. You said you haven't had a panic attack in days. Maybe your symptoms are subsiding.

I smile at that optimism. Its true I haven't had an episode for a while now, but it doesn't mean I am in the clear. I answer, it's not a physical trauma that can be healed visibly. I am psychically better now. But I am not there yet. I can feel it. Its not something I can put into words. He makes an anxious face trying to understand my plight. He says, I suppose if Drew said it would be dangerous to leave you untreated, then its really needed. I toss the towel back inside to the seat. I add, you saw me crashing out during the interview, and how I am behaving towards Vanessa. This something I need to do make sure I don't loose it again.

He raises his eyebrows, speaking of her. Vanessa is furious with you. I lean towards the car with a droopy shoulder. Ever since the tournament I have wondered how I can make her understand. I thought I have been sparing her feelings by not talking about Wagner. But now its gotten to a point where whenever I talk to her, we are confronting each other for any reason. I regret my decision by keeping her in the dark, but it was for her own good. Or so I believed since it is now costing our relationship.

I sigh, I know its gotten bad. Yesterday she tried to put the screws in me. I thought she was being salty, but she is trying anything to get back at me. I finally got the chance to see her questioning Elina. Blake says, it was more like a mission to expose you. She never liked the plan to hiding your involvement. But even I never thought she would go that far. We can't keep her making waves like this. He sighs, not at this critical time. I felt the same. I don't blame Vanessa for her actions, but she is isn't going to stop. She will keep pushing me until I break with another episode.

I say, I don't plan to do nothing. Blake crosses his arms, so you will tell her about Wagner. My instincts kicked in before I even a rational thought, no. I mean, yes. Maybe. I was confusing myself now. I can't sort out my thoughts about that. I ask, what if she doesn't believe me. She already hates me, imagine how worse it might get if I tell her the truth. Blake says, few days back I casually mentioned Wagner, and she looked like she was about to punch me. Getting through to her will not be easy. She is too stubborn. And like you said, maybe she has replaced her memories with Wagner. I can't think of a way to break this to her.

After thinking about it for a moment I say, Its my mess. I will tell Vanessa what she needs to know. He leans in closer nervously, what does that entail. I say, not sure. But I need to start being honest with her now. Its not fair to her. I am being angry at her when she retaliates due to my lies. I have been postponing it for a while. But it can't keep going on like this. Blake nods, okay then. Lets at least tell her together then. I raise my hand, no. I alone to tell her. She would just get mad at you too for no reason. He asks, but I can help you. Aside from you, only I personally know about Wagner's hidden side. She will believe it more when we both explain it.

I answer, maybe. But I rather it come from me. I am okay with taking the blame of hiding things from her. You would just get caught up in it in for no reason. He replies, are you sure. I answer, I am. I may not know how much I will tell her, but I am sure I want to do this alone. After a tense silence he says, all right. But at least me be there tonight when Drew comes to your home. I wasn't in favor of it, I really didn't want to be distracted with my well being. But he was giving a stare that said he wasn't going to back down from this. I ask, I am guessing Marina will be there too.

He nods, she will be. She started her work today early so she can finish early. Same reason why she didn't show up now. She is surveying the sector 2 middle zone. She said she will be off by 7. I wished they wouldn't be bothered by this so much. But that's the reason I was in a situation with Catherine and now with Vanessa. I can't keep pushing people away from my private stuff anymore. I pull the door, fine. You guys already know so much about me now. Doesn't make any sense to keep things separate. He nods will taking the driver seat, good. You are learning about sharing stuff now.

Maybe. He turns on the engine and we head back inside the city. We chat a few things about the Citradel current affairs. No new development about the search for Ryes or the stirs of conflict from the church. Blake said he doesn't like being involved in their religion. Overdrive is purely based on luck, not a sign from some higher power. But who are we to stop people from believing anything. I kept assuring Blake to not be worried about it. Selene might be just using their names as a way to gather people and pressure the council.

He relented in the end since there is nothing we can do about it. Though, its curious that even though Blake blamed Ryes, and in extension Citradel, and yet there are people backing us there. I used to believe Citradel people are united very strongly. Blake says, it's bound to happen. People there are slowly realizing the benefits of moving here. Heraknus will be here, many of their warriors are already here. I reply, that would be the obvious thing. He asks, then what's not the obvious thing.

I reply, not really sure. I mean, we wanted this kind of thing to happen. Force Citradel and make them move here. However, the religion getting involved so blatantly is suspicious. Blake says, you mean the timing of it all. I say, they could have done this before Ryes accused me. And yet the schism is happening when we are gunning for them from multiple fronts. A second later Blake hits the brake in front of my house. He asks, I also find it pretty convenient. I got a message from Derek early in the morning that the council are trying to appease the priest and their followers.

I ask, how's that working for them. He shrugs, no idea. I get out of the car, let me ask Jack to dig around. He still has some time left. He thinks about for a moment then says, about their new identities. I have asked Catherine to create them. She said it will be done by the time they arrive. I should thank her later for this. I close the door, thanks. This will make him less apprehensive about leaving Citradel. He nods, they deserve it. I grab my stuff from the back, see you later tonight. He waves and drives off.

I get back inside and take a shower to clean up the sweat and dirt I was covered in. After that, I reviewed todays training session. I have been trying to stabilize my Kuret since yesterday. I spent hours, before the dinner meeting and after that last night till 2 AM. I have exhausted all my mental efforts, and yet I couldn't do achieve that same form during the match with Charles. I don't know what's stopping me. What condition's has to be met to get that form.

I continued my workout trying my Kuret form again. I decided best not to focus on the that and work on honing my Kuret control instead. Morning's restrictive training helped me a bit to gather Kuret without physical

movement. I did different Kuret techniques Blake taught me this morning. Best to cement the basics down when I remember them clearly. Its hard to understand what Blake said about gathering Kuret, so instead of teaching me the process, he showed me the end results of the Kuret techniques. I had to figure out on how to make them myself.

I sat down drenched in sweat in my home gym room. M says, boss, your calories levels are too low. I said, I already had meal hours ago. M replies, the mental exertion has burned away calories from lunch. I lean to the wall with a sigh. I have never done a workout like this, using Kuret without using any muscles. I have been replenishing with electrolytes all day, and yet I am so exhausted. I expected this type of training to be different, but I didn't realize it would be this arduous. I say, M, create a new nutrition plan based on today's workout. Focus more on replenishing blood flow and sleep for brain restoration.

M says, calculating the changes. Increasing glucose consumption. Done. My body doesn't ache, and yet repeating making my Kuret gather around my skin makes it feel its aching. This is new territory for me now. Instead of my body effecting Kuret, its Kuret effecting my body. But I still laugh in spite of this hurdle. This just means when I control this Kuret nature, I will be strong enough to handle whatever Charles throws at me. M says, boss, this is a reminder for your meeting.

I close my eyes and my emotion that was elevated takes massive dip down. I have been distracting myself from this. I didn't want to face certain people. Drew was right to call out saying I was not showing kindness by keeping things from people. I can't keep them in the dark anymore. I don't know if it will help me untie this knot in my heart, but I know I can't keep it in anymore. Whatever happens, I can't chicken out now. I thought my resolve wouldn't waver again. But as I cleaned up to visit them, my body felt heavy. Like my own Kuret was resisting it.

What will Vanessa think of me. What will they all. I wished I could go back to training like I did the whole today, focus on what I can control. That’s much easier than what I am about to do. M says, boss. Its time. Shall I send the message. Its 6 right now, I suppose there is no backing away from this. My heart feels like is about to come out from my throat. I just gave a slight nod, hoping I don't have to say it. M says, message sent. You should leave now to avoid being late when returning.

It must be nice to have decision running purely on logic and probabilities. No guilt, no remorse. I take the car out of the driveway and head to Vanessa's house. In 15 minutes I was standing at her doorstop. Even though I messaged ahead, I couldn't ring the doorbell. I kept pacing a little, thinking of excuses to get out of this. Every time I muster up with determination, I fell back in the last moment. Its so pathetic that its almost comical. I just hope the neighbors don't see me stumbling like this.

A few minutes later the door opens on its own. My heart beats a little louder. Siera comes out, just how long were you planning to stay out. She was alone in the house right now. I immediately felt embarrassed knowing she saw me hesitating for so long, sorry. She opens the door for me to enter. I say, thanks for making time. She closes the door behind me and we walk into her living room. She was in a workout clothes, its all right. I just came back from a run. I look around the house, it's been a while since I have been here. They have moved around some furniture's and stuff.

She says, what's this meeting about David. Its a little suspicious. I give her a nervous smile, does it feel that way to you. She says, your messaged said to meet me and Vanessa at our home. You are a celebrity now, so yeah. Its a little odd you coming to us at an odd time. I don't know what Vanessa has told her. She wasn't here when Melinda talked about Wagner. Vanessa could have told her everything. But it doesn't matter. Since I came here to hash out everything.

I reveal, Its been a week since the tournament, I owe people answers. That’s why I am here. She raises her eyebrows, answers, huh. I see. But why tell me. Why not just Vanessa. I answer, I will explain once everyone are here. She takes a second to think, you called someone else too? I nod while we both take our seats. She puts on a jacket and offers me a water. I decline, thanks but I just drank like 5 liters whole day. I feel like I might burst any second.

She smiles, is that right. So this is really true, Blake and Marina are training you. I nod, it was just Blake today. But yeah. She says, incredible. I had to agree with her, they are key to mastering my Kuret. I need all the advantage I need right now. She says, Vanessa told me you enlisted others too. Since she brought it herself, I hesitantly ask, what else she told you. She turns a little confused, honestly, she's been working late this week. I don't get enough time with her to chat. Its probably going to stay that for a while until the mess with Citradel blows over.

So its pretty good guess that Vanessa hasn't told her about us. I don't know how to feel, should I be glad or be more nervous. I say, its my fault. I selfishly decided to attack Citradel. She waves her hand, no, its not. I don't know everything, but Vanessa said what you did was justified. She suddenly chuckles, only you could go after them like this. Let me ask since you are here, are you really stealing from them.

I smile, as of today, I have extracted 23 percent of their mineral deposits all over world. She shakes her head amused, its amazing. But they must be retaliating. I reply, they are. I have made contingencies and for the most part its been working. She asks, they must be stealing them back from you. I nod, I have lost around 5 percent, so yeah. However, I am not losing here. Not really. She thinks for a moment, so I let her. She snaps her fingers with a smirk, I get it. I heard from some officers that we will have more than necessary resources. Anything you steal now, it’s a bonus. But its their loss. You must be giving those away so that no one gets it.

She got it right, I clap my hand to applaud her. I say, you guessed right. I have split of the shipment of the mined ores and minerals. Each of them taking different routes. But more importantly, I added a failsafe. In case the shipment gets compromised, only one of two things will happen. Either I report the stolen items at the borders and customs will seize it. Well, at least those that get caught. Or more easily, just blow it up. She jerks at my nonchalant comment. She scoffs, you blow up the shipment.

I shrug, the blown up shipment attracts enough attention from the agencies to cause panic for Citradel council. Sure, its not a fool proof solution. If there is some decent Kuret users, they could abscond with the stuff no matter what I do to stop them. In fact, I suspect they already were able to secretly steal back around 3 of 10 shipments daily. Its an acceptable loss. She says, damn David. You are playing a very dangerous game. She was equally impressed and horrified. I reply, I know. But they didn't tell me about Ryes and probably never wanted me to find about it ever. I needed to teach some sense into them. Not to mess with me again.

I got back some of my confidence when I re affirm my ideals. Enough that made Siera look at me in admiration. She says, you have changed. You are you, but still different. She has no idea how much of that was so true. She says, the old you would have at least attempted to deny Ryes claims. Instead you just lied on top of it. I shift a little uneasy in my sofa. Siera wasn't there for most of the things that went down. Or she was there, but wouldn't know the truth. She figured out my confusion, Vanessa told me. And even before that I sort of figured out your plan.

Its strange. Vanessa told her this, but not about our fight. I ask, did you tell anyone. She replies, don't worry. Few people asked me about it, but I since I wasn't there I didn't have to hide much. She then becomes a little tense, however, based on what Vanessa has told me, seems you weren't planning for this though. I sigh, I was hoping to just create doubt and stall until Ryes was found. Not this. This isn't how I imagined I get famous. Its all lies. And even when I am innocent, I feel its undeserved.

She takes a suspenseful silence trying to come with words. I don't think I will be okay with any excuse or reasoning. No matter how true they are. I say, I am so much conflicted about it. I don't make public appearances alone right now, because then I would just feel guilty. She nods, I can only imagine what you are going through. I can't say anything to comfort you. But if there's anything you need, let me know. I am so glad she was not trying to convince me. I reply, in that case. I want a small favor. I am going to reveal things that will make Vanessa mad. I might be unfair to ask this, but try to remain impartial until the end.

She is clearly confused at my strange request. Nonetheless, she regains her composure, all right. I can do that. I feel a little better in preparing her beforehand. We talk for few minutes about mundane activities. Since we couldn't really talk about my stuff, I asked hers. She was enjoying the more quite life now with just teaching kids about self defense. Then the door bell rang. So its time. I grab my collar and loose it a little, hoping to catch more air. Siera opens up the door to Cassandra and Vanessa. They must have met up before coming together. My throat felt dry with anticipation.

Cassandra asks, hey Siera. Long time no see. Siera asks surprised, Cass. You were invited too. I haven't seen Cass almost a week. And I have been avoiding her the most right now. Last I heard she was laying low because she thought she was the leak. Vanessa steps in, I met her in the trolley. So what's this about. Why did he. She stops when she catches me sitting in her living room. Like a clueless guy, I wave my hand, thanks for meeting with me guys. I didn't know what Vanessa would have done when I sent her the message. She could have just easily blown it off.

Vanessa remained quiet, maybe trying to rien in her frustration on being ambushed like this. Cass says, David. You are already here. I say, yeah. I didn't think Vanessa would open the doors for me if she was already here. I came in earlier a little while to avoid that. I wasn't holding back anymore. I didn't want to beat around the bush and be delicate about it anymore. Otherwise I would just waver my resolve. Others were confused by my attitude. Vanessa just crosses her arms not giving me any rebuttal.

Cass looks around us, what is going on. I say, not many people know this. But Vanessa's has been mad at me for a while. I am here to clear it up for once and for all. I blurted out before I get embarrassed or cower in fear. This made even Vanessa puzzled. Siera asks Vanessa, you had a fight. With David too. I guess she was talking about Ned now. So that means she is taking a lot of anger at me. Cass is so confused and asks, why. And why did you call me here then.

I say, lets take a seat before I explain. Its going to take a little bit of time. Vanessa is suspicious of my intension. I guess its nothing new for her. Cass and Siera leave her behind and take the chairs beside me. Vanessa was alone standing and with our eyes staring hard. She finally relented and sat opposite to me, throwing daggers at me with her eyes. In the middle of our silent confrontation, Cass interjects. She says, David. I need to tell you something first. I turn my gaze to her. She was puzzled earlier but now I see guilt. She says, you have been avoiding me. And I know why. Why did you ask to me here now.

I answer, it wasn't how I wanted to play it out. But its what had to happen. Siera asks, what do you mean by this, Cass? Cass responds, didn't Vanessa tell you about that. Someone used me to get to David. Siera didn't the whole story. Vanessa breaks her heavy expression and says, only Cass knew where they lived before meeting us. Siera than clicks her tongue putting it together, ah right. That’s true. But then how. Cass butts in, because I have blabbed about it. She tucks in her hair behind her ears, I never thought someone would dig up our past. I have been asking around people I talked to ever since Ryes mentioned it. But its been so long that I can't remember everyone.

Its was the right time to quell her guilt. I tell her, you don't have to take this on yourself. She rebukes, but I messed up. We agreed not to talk to people about our past. I say, its fine. Really. She says, how are you calm about it. Ryes found about. I cut her off, they are safe. You don't have to worry about them anymore. She blinks at me confused, but I hear he has pictures of them too. Surely he knows about them. I reply, I don't know if knows about them or not. I sent them a message a while ago to relocate just as a precaution.

She is surprised to realize I was in contact with them. She asks, wait. You know where they are. I say, no. I had a single one time emergency way to contact them. And since I didn't know what Ryes or whoever is behind this would do with this information, I wanted to avoid contacting you. At least until I was assured they were safe. She asks bewildered. I explain, I can't say for sure how he found out about other stuff, but I am hundred percent sure the Greenfield info came from you. This makes her anxious.

☐Vanessa tried to speak something, but my sharp gaze stop her. I continue, I haven't told anyone about it. So it had to be you. By extension, someone around you blabbed to Ryes. So I had to wai
before I approached you. I apologies for not coming to you sooner. I didn't want to risk their safety in any way. Not even a text message was safe. She shakes her head, don't be. I was a little frustrated for a little while, but then Matt made the same argument as you. We figured you were trying to find out who it was without us. I am glad she understood my intent.

Siera asks, since you are talking to her now, I assume your human parents are fine. I say, they are. I got a message last night. I could have told you this morning, Cass. But I wanted another day before I tell you. The arrangement I made for them was in haste and needed some more time as a precaution. By now, their new identities should be setup properly. So no matter how it was leaked, its safe for me to talk to you about them. This relieved a lot of the tension she was carrying on her. She says, thank god. I have been worrying so much about them. You know, Matt and I have been combing our house and office for bugs every night.

I smile a little picturing them looking for signs of sabotage. I say, sorry for the trouble. I didn't want to influence you in anyway in case someone was still watching you. She grabs her hair back her head with both hands, I am so relieved. I have been a mess thinking I got them in trouble. She leans in back to her couch. A big weight lifted off from her shoulder. Siera says, where are they right now. I reply, someplace safe. But this time I am keeping that information close to me. Cass raise her arms to me, I rather not know about it. Safer for everyone.

Vanessa didn't feel the same, shocker. You hiding things from us. Well, at least you are being open about it. This garner two pairs of confused eyes at her. I guess Vanessa is also not hiding her displeasure with me anymore. Siera asks, just what is going on with you. I thought it was about Ned. But what did David do to you. Cass also joined in, David, what is going on with you two. Vanessa seemed like she wasn't going to offer any help. Its not surprising since I came to her in person.

I lean in back and close my eyes. This is it, no more stalling. I clutch the chair ends tightly with my fingers. Cass asks, what's happening. You are acting very strange. I nervous smile appears in the corner of my mouth, that’s because I have been in therapy for months. Then followed few seconds of silence. I open my eyes to see confused faces gawking at me. Vanessa uncrosses her arms and gives a suspicious look. My grip on the sofa tightens as I continue, I have been diagnosed with PTSD and currently undergoing treatment for it.

Cass asks bamboozled, are you serious right now. I answer, ever since I got my memories, the floodgates were opened to all the horrors of Medrine. Its been causing me a lot of mental issues. Siera asks, that was almost a year ago. You had PTSD since then ? I thought it was scary to reveal this to Blake and Marina. But its so much worse with them right now. Vanessa asks with wide eyes, that can't be true. You have been fighting in the tournament for four months.

I shake my head a little depressed about it, I have been hiding it. Or more accurately, I thought I had moved on. Drew and I thought I was mentally stable to participate in it. And I was okay, all the way till the end of tournament. But then everything came crashing down from then. Siera asks, Drew. That is your therapist? Vanessa scoffs, stop messing around. There is no doctor named Drew in the trauma counselling department. Her skepticism was expected. I answer, she isn't your typical doctor. She isn't listed as a doctor. She was trained in human psychology, stuff not related to Kuret. Things I needed from her can't be gotten from regular doctors.

Cass leans forward shocked, I don't understand. What caused you PTSD. And why the hell did you not tell us about it. Vanessa asks, this is hard to believe. Are you just making excuses for your behavior. Siera reprimands her, Vanessa, stop it. Vanessa gets mad, don't tell me you are buying into this. I cut her off, don't just assume I am lying. Few people already know about it. She turns to me, what. Who. I had to start from the beginning, you saw me passing out while I was carried out of the coliseum. It wasn’t from exhaustion. I was having a panic attack.

Vanessa recalls the moment from a week ago. Her expression changes to confusion, what do you mean you had a panic attack. I thought I was over it, but I still felt a sting from the weakness of that moment. I sigh, it's exactly what I said. Blake and Marrina carried me out before people saw me in a much more pathetic state. I had to tell them to get me help from Drew. They got in contact with her later. And the next day Catherine spied on me meeting with Drew and found out as well.

Cass jerks, Catherine knows about this too. My god. David, what the hell. Her outburst was mixed with anger and concern. Vanessa exclaims in anger, they knew and yet told know one about it. At least she didn't think I was lying. I could keep my hands on my knees to stop my legs from shaking too much. I tell them, its already bad enough that I am suffering from such a weird PTSD. I didn't want people see me like this. I look away for a second, no that’s not totally true. I didn't want you all to see me at this ridiculous state.

I know it’s the right thing to tell them the truth, but its so damn frustrating. The mortification I felt was unlike anything before. Siera asks, David. I am sorry you were going through so much. I had no idea. Cass says, I can't believe it. He turns to Vanessa, you didn't know about this. Vanessa shakes her head quietly, this is the first time hearing. She turns to me, if this is true, why keep it a secret. We have so many people going through traumas. I myself had to adjust a little bit after the incident with the Valley war.

I tilt my back to stare at the ceiling, if only it were so easy. I face them again, I have been trying to change. Get better. But its not easy to change certain habits. Especially with my memories coming back. I get a little annoyed at myself, it wasn't easy to keep this from you. I turn to Cass, I should have told you before. You were there for me in the beginning. I owe you that. But its was way more complicated. Cass is visibly concerned for me, why did you feel hiding from it from me. I sigh revealing my biggest shame, same reason I asked not tell anyone about my situation in Greenville. You visited me mostly in the hospital rooms. I didn't want you think even less of me, again after all this time.

Cass becomes enraged, come on, David. Do you really believed I would held that against you. I had no words to make her believe it wasn't the case. I really didn't want my oldest friends to know about my issues. Siera asks, I have seen you make some rash moves and even behave strangely at times during the tournament. Is it because of. Her words trail off. I reluctantly nod, I am not making any excuse of my behavior, but yeah. It was a big part of it. Vanessa has been silently taking all of it in. I am sure she must have been trying to recall all the times I was being cagy about things. Particularly about one person.

Cass becomes despondent, I don't like this David. You shouldn't have kept it from us. Not from me at least. I wouldn't have judged you. She eyes towards Vanessa, not like others. Vanessa asks, what does that mean. She replies, nothing. I am just saying it wasn't something he needed to be ashamed off. She turns to me, I could have helped you. This is what I was avoiding all this time, the pity and judging from others. I reply, I told you. I wanted to get better. Therapy was the only option.

Siera asks, I get it would attract some doubt from others. But still, you risked an awful lot during the tournament. Cass chips in, yeah. You said you had a panic attack. How many times did you get one. I wasn't going to divulge my weakest moments, a few times. I had it under control. I would have never joined if there was an issue. Drew made sure of it. Vanessa says, you said you got one when we were with Charles and Kafar. But why would that. She halts when she pieces it together.

I didn't want to reveal the next part of my redemption plea. This is the most personal stuff sworn not to be revealed. I say, there are certain things or names that triggers me. If I am careful about it, I can manage it. But I was caught off guard when I heard Wagners name from the last person I thought possible. Vanessa eyes sharpen at me. Cass asks, ah, yeah. You sounded different after that. Siera says, you said it in the interview that you got carried away in the moment. I grit my teeth, it was half truth.

Vanessa blurts out in anger, you lied about knowing Wagner. Didn't you ? She gets a little agitated, you asked about his fighting style to Charles. Tell me how you know him. I knew it was just time until she becomes hot headed. Like me, she also gets triggered in a different way whenever its about him. Cass asks, wait. Why does mentioning him caused a panic attack. Siera asks, how did you know him. My arms felt it weighed ton when I rummage in my jacket pocket and pull out an item.

I say, I know him. I know a lot of influential people back in Medrine. Because, I toss the item straight at Vanessa. She reflexes catches it with one hand and opens it confused, what is this. Her palm opens and reveals my shadow ring.

Vanessa (Chapter 94)

Saturday, February 14, 2026 15:30

I was annoyed that David backed down so easily yesterday. I have never been this petty in my life before. I could have asked him outside the dinner meeting. But I wanted to see David struggle in front of others when I asked for his bots. I never anticipated he gave it up so easily. He even went as far to explain the tech. It had to be a trick. But I couldn't understand what it was. Even if it was in exchange of those stolen artifacts, the tech must have been something he worked on for quite some time. And it concluded in what I wanted.

It felt strange, but I had to move on to other things. I had work to do today. I didn't want to face David again, because even though I got what I wanted from him, it feels I lost somehow. Then he messages me out of the blue around 5 and asked to meet him at my home. I wanted to ignore it, like I have been ignoring Ned. But this is first time he wanted to meet me somewhere not work related. I thought I had resolved myself to not listen to any of his manipulation tactics. No matter what has happened, he has lied to me about Wagner. He can't be trusted.

But curiosity got the better of me. I took off early from the officers building and head back home. On route I met Cass who was also coming to my place. This made me very nervous, what did he want with the two of us. I went in home early to first make sure Siera doesn't let him without giving us the reason. But he beat me to it. It seems he gave me a time, but arrive much earlier. When he confirmed it so openly, I was so shocked that my mind went blank for a few second.

He wasn't hiding it anymore. I felt pressured by others gazes, but I maintained my composure. Whatever David's game was, I wasn't going to be manipulated so easily again. I knew he didn't trust me, so I shouldn't believe anything he said. Then he drops them bombshell about his therapy. I can't believe he hid something so big this long. I reminded myself he is good at making convenient excuses. Maybe it was just some causal consultancies he had. But as he talked, my emotions turn to turmoil.

I wanted to believe he was lying his ass off. But he was visibly troubled by this. At times it felt he was so ashamed of himself that I almost pitied him. But then I would mentally slap myself. No, this is another justifications for his actions. If he trusted me, if he cared for me, he wouldn't kept it from me. I was battling myself, trying to figure out what to do with this information. But one thing was sure, I couldn't bring myself to forgive him. He said lying was his habit and wanted to change it. But I can't believe it.

There is nothing that can convince me of this. Then he threw a small object towards me. I caught it mid air and open my palm. It was a ring with a small engravings on it. It had a small gem rock in the center. I didn't understand how this explained all the secrecy. David didn't offer any explanation to it too. I just stared at the ring. Then suddenly I remember vagally seeing this small rock somewhere too. As I tried to recall it, Siera beside me snaps in confusion, David. Where did you find this. He voice shrouded in ominous shock.

He answers, I didn't find it. Its mine. Just like others have their own. Then it clicked. I yell, this can't be. You are. Cass beside be shrieks, what the hell. She also realized what this meant. I turn to face a nervous ridden David. He makes a nervous smile, saying, you are looking at the 342th Shadow strategist. A cold shiver went through my brain. There is a moment of complete shock. Until Cass breaks it, the freak. This is not funny David. David says, its not a joke. I never told anyone last year when my memories returned. That ring is part of the same insignia as Blake's dagger and Marina's neckless. If you check, you see my blood on the rock.

I hastily check the sides of the rock, it had red stains on its sides. Its exactly like the other two. I get angry, you. Are you one of them? This is unbelievable. Another surviving shadow, and of all the people its him. Siera asks, I don't believe it. Wait does that mean Blake and Marina. He cuts her off, know about me. They do. I told them a year back. Cass's jaw opens in shock, they know and never told anyone. The freak David. David clenches his mouth, trust me, its wasn't easy for me. I took an oath when I joined Shadows. I couldn't just tell anyone about this.

I shout out, why not. My anger rose, they both have told the whole world the truth long ago. He replies immediately, they had years before told anyone about it. My memories came back just recently. Try to imagine my situation. I learned an entirely new persona and identity suddenly. At that time, my mind was so screwed up that I instinctively only trusted the two people I knew the most. He makes a scowl, Marina is the only alive person who knew me before Medrine and I met Blake in Shadows. All the others I ever interacted before were dead. So trust me when I say that I was a mess. Revealing such an intimate and personal wasn't possible for me. At least not yet.

He looks so defeated right now that my anger subsided a little. Its true that he didn't have the same situation as others. I didn't like it, but it made sense why needed time to sort himself out first. And on top of the PTSD, it seems more and more that he was telling me the truth. Cass says with a somber voice, David. She couldn't say all her words at this shocking revelation. Siera picks the ring from my hand and inspects it. After a second she says, never did I imagine you were a Shadow. He suddenly drops her hand and faces him, no wait. It actually makes. When we met, you were displaying unusual skills and uncanny abilities. Your physical strength didn't match your intellect, but it wasn't something you expect someone to have without any training.

He says in a low tone, without me realizing, I was subconsciously using my Shadow training. This is ridiculously confusing. How the hell I never thought of this before. I ask, Blake and Marina said all other Shadows were dead. He leans in forward, I wasn't with them when they boarded the ship. Shadow strategist are given special privilege. Something only the other shadows know about it. He takes a small breath, I know the identities of all shadows. My palm curl into a fist, what. Cass cuts in, are telling me you knew Marina and Blake were in shadows. Like before they told.

He nods, I do. That’s how I know they were safe when they boarded the ship first. I stayed behind to coordinate an platoon section to buy time for the two ships. This is hard to believe when he was just a kid back then. He was commanding a whole darn army. Siera asks, damn. I heard rumors of this, a shadow strategist, even an apprentice could command a entire force alone. Cass clicks her tongue, seriously. I don't remember much about them. Holy shit. You kept Hive off of the ships. David seemed reluctant to tell this. He makes a disapproving face, don't be impressed by it. Those rumors about us are greatly exaugurated. Part of the whole lore, as you know.

I ask, what does that mean. He replies, was I coordinating our defenses. Sort of. But was I alone. No. I was still an apprentice. I was only taking the reins which my predecessor gave me. He did most of the heavy lifting. I almost died several times after he left to command other troops. It was the most horrifying thing I ever did. I had taken missions before, but not at this scale. He closes his eyes and shakes his head. Its like he is trying to forget those memories. When he didn't answer for some time Cass asks, David. You okay.

He opens his eyes, no. I am not. That’s why I am in therapy. He turns to me, I didn't tell anyone about my PTSD because I am different than others. And its not about being arrogant or confident. I was chosen and then trained to be one the most important pillar of Shadows. And later for the every Medrones left alive earth. And I squashed it all away when I lost my memories. The guilt and regrets I carry is nothing compared to any perceived accomplished I have had since then.

This is not what I expected from him. I couldn't be angry at him any longer. I have seen him hurt and depressed many times. Even when he had been guilty of things he shouldn't be. But this is something I can't wrap my head around. Everything about his screams he has been suffering for a while. A small thoughts come in between trying to continence me that he was lying. Or manipulating us. But the sincerity behind his eyes and his broken voice made it difficult for me to believe that.

Siera asks, you take on too much. It wasn't your fault. Being a Shadow doesn't mean you are impervious to feelings. David leans back on his chair. There is a long silence and then he says, its my fault. Because this could have all been avoid if I hadn't taken my own memories. A moment later his words sink in. I yell, what did you just say. After then he revealed his most horrifying experience. He told about the dead bodies of the solders he saw at the front lines. Then about deaths of the few important people. He didn't tell us their names, but he saw other Shadows death in front of him.

The horror was too much for him to bear. So he took the serum he always planned to take. The serum which he made before Hive ever attacked, since he was dying on Medrine. 10 minutes later we all sat in utter silence. His horrifying retelling had made David asking for water numerous times. Siera even asked him if was having panic attack. But he just waved it off saying it was just nerves. But no one believed him. Cass asks, holy shit. You went through so much as a kid. No wonder you are. She eats her own words before saying them.

David scoffs, don't need to hide. I know I am a mess. I haven't told this to anyone. Only 3 people know about it. Now it includes you all too. Its was a messed up discission by a kid who just wanted to get it over with it. Not be haunted by the memories. Cass says, no. That’s what I meant. She tries to hide her intension from before, but it was clear everyone were thinking it. I ask, you told us you were slowly getting malnourished on Medrine before. But you were dying? He says, in a way. I would have died much earlier than I predicted.

He makes a depressed laugh, try to rationalize this. Hive attacked us, billions were killed, and that somehow paved a miracle for me to survive. I arrived on Earth, which not only cured me, it made me stronger. This was beyond any type of survivor guilt. I never ever wanted to tell people about this because its totally insane if you think about it. Siera assures, you can't think like that. He replies, but its what happened, didn't it. No matter how many times I am told it wasn't my fault, it isn't easier for me to let it go. If I could have, I wouldn't have PTSD or needed therapy.

Cass says, David. How in the world does that makes sense. You don't know that would have happened. He waves, it doesn't change how I feel though. We can keep arguing about it but I would always feel like shit. At the very least I shouldn't have been so scared and took that serum. I am a shadow for freaking sake. We are supposed to have strong mental fortitude. He sighs and takes another sip of the water. This is really causing him mental strain. He says, imagine if people know a Shadow strategist turned out like this. Hansen must be berating from his grave.

I ask, Hansen? David looks up to me in confusion. I think it was a slipup because he corrects himself saying, forget it. Just someone I used to know. He just told us he didn't know many people outside Shadow. Then this person was probably someone from Shadow. Siera consoles him, let's not keep pressuring him on this. Seems something that is meant for therapy. She had a point. Cass says, but that’s not right. David says, doesn't matter Cass. I am telling this to you now, but I have been struggling for a year now. It may not look like it, but unless I am actively talking about it I can manage my emotions well enough.

This is very strange type of coping mechanism. Bottling it up is never good. I should know, but I was like him. I can see myself in him, trying to handle it all alone. Cass asks, jeez David. This is lot to take. He nods, for me too. He then takes a pause, but I am getting better. At least much better than a week ago. I hit a low point that I couldn't use my Kuret for a while. Not unless I had a panic attack. I spat, hold on. When did that happen. He says, right after the tournament. I talked to Drew about it. I needed help desperately. That day was the longest for me. I had a panic attack when we talked on the pier, then later I almost slipped up during the interview.

I recalled the events of the day. He was suspiciously jumpy when I was talking to him. Its so damn frustrating to think about it. At time he acts like he is fine, but other times so different. It makes sense now why his emotions were all scrambled up. Siera asks, but you got over it. He nervously nods, I did. Wasn't easy. I had to accept certain people's death. Death that could have been avoided. He stares to his right, like seeing something beyond this room. The turns to me, not just theirs. Being a Shadow strategist kept me in a very precarious position. He then places his hand on the side of his temple, I have seen, people dead. People close to ones I care about.

My heart immediately beats faster. My gut was telling it was about Wagner. I wanted to know, but I was too afraid. I was in too much of a shock to even speak about it. Siera asks, what do you mean. Who did you see. Cass says, you said about visiting the front lines. David jerks of head, trying to not recall those faces. He then takes another sip of water, I was searching of survivors. Anyone I could help before I went back. But the dead bodies were everywhere. Those who were barely alive, I tried helping them. I don't know how many survived in the end. However, I found many people who I recognized. They were relatives of yours.

All of us held our breathing as he clears his throat. Cass asks, whom did you see. David was stalling. No, he was reluctant to say them. Siera asks, girls. Lets not ask so much of him. He is too much troubled by this. This is probably

why he doesn't talk much about your families. This made me a cold shiver. Is this why he never spoke of Wagner. Because he was there when. I couldn't finish my own thought. It was too complicated to untangle of mix of emotions I had. David says, I want to Siera. What's the point of going to therapy. Or coming here. They are the reason for my PTSD. It triggers me in strange ways whenever I talk about them. So I avoid them actively. But I am much better now.

We wait until he gets ready to tell in his own time. He then opens his mouth, out of respect of the dead, I won't talk about others. If you want to know, then ask Blake and Marina. I told them who all I found. Because I want them to tell you, if they want. Its not my place anymore to tell. He gave us a version of it that met us in the middle. If its two of them, its possible its their families. He turns to Cass, how much do you remember of your great aunt. Cass immediately arches her shoulder, you know Terrisa. He continues, she was a shadow two generations before.

Cass adjusts in her seat a little ahead completely amazed, no freaking way. I ask, hold on. How do you know that. He says, I just do. Lets leave it at that. I should have asked more, but his heavy eyes made me realize he doesn't want to dredge up that past. Cass says, she was my grandfathers sister. She becomes a little curious, she wasn't an alpha though. David says, you don't have to necessarily need to be an alpha to be in Shadows. Blake wasn't one, neither was I. What we need is talent. And Terrisa was special.

Siera says, I think I remember her. When I was little I heard about a women from your house. Cass says, yeah. She was had a physical gift. Her Kuret abilities could in certain conditions exceed our alphas. That’s incredible. I ask, how come you never talked about her before. Cass says, honestly, she was remarkable person. But not very sociable. And she had a big temper. My dad didn't like her much, so I kind of don't talk about her. I turn to David, she was in Shadows despite that.

He scoffs, one is not judged on personality to be in shadow. If that were a problem, Marina wouldn't be one. He made a strong argument. He says, I don't know all the shadows personally. But lets just say many have distinct personalities. But what binds us is talent and skill. Its crazy that I am having a conversation about Shadows from David. Blake and Marina only know a facet of the organization. But it looks like David knows a hell lot of more. Siera asks, interesting. What was she.

David face contorts, I rather not say. These people are gone, but their decedents are alive. Even mentioning Terrisa is breaking a lot of the oaths I made. He sighs, but I wanted you to know, Cass. He faces her with sudden seriousness, I found her near a building. She was an elderly lady, but she was still hot blooded and fighting even at her age. Cass sat back up, my god. He nods, she must have fought off Hives while people escaped, because she was all alone outside an empty building. I don't know about your parents, but I hope you know your family was strong. Be proud of them. Cass shakes her head with a little smile, she died like how she lived, huh.

He says, that she did. I ask, who else was there. I must have sounded insensitive to Cass. But I am impatient. David faces with such seriousness that I wondered if I pissed him off. But I didn't care about that. I just wanted to know. Eventually he gave up, yes. I found Wagner too. My heart beats faster. I have talked to countless people till now and no one was able to tell me about Wagner. Its strange that the person who did know was with me this whole time. He grits his teeth, I don't have any words of comfort. I found him dead with his own dagger in his heart.

I jumped out of the couch in anger, what the hell does that mean. He tilts he head to me, I don't know what happened. Maybe some Hive decided to kill him with his own weapon. Or maybe. He trails off. I ask in hast, what. What happened. He says, I don't know. I wasn't there. He makes it clear he was only there after he died. My fist tighten in such blaze of anger that I couldn't control. I blurt out, my brother wouldn't have died like this. He was the strongest. Tell me what happened.

I was asking something unreasonable. But I didn't care. I had to know. David looks over to others and then to me, my answer is not going to change. I found him with other soldiers. I can only assume he was fighting of some of the key Hive commanders. I don't know what killed him. I can only tell you how he died. I take a step towards him, towering him and ask, tell me the truth. David nostrils flair a little. Siera says, Vanessa. Behave yourself. I wasn't going to, I say to her, not this time. I want answers. Siera says, what kind of answer are you looking for. He was a kid back then.

I was too emotional to think clearly now. Not when I was so close to knowing about Wagner. I turn to him, you knew him. Didn't you. You could have helped him. He would have been saved. I finally said out aloud what I was thinking. What was I even saying. Cass says, Vanessa, that is. David cuts her off, this is not possible. I was barely able to help myself back then. How do could I have helped him. I got angry at him. I spat out, how do you know him. Was he also. David buts in, I know him because some of my previous missions clashed with him. He was the crown, he was involved in a lot of sensitive matters to the country. I met him several times.

He explained how he knew my brother. But I wasn't satisfied. I ask him point blank, was he in Shadows too. David gives me a blank stare silently. Siera asks, is that true David. He thinks for a moment, what does it matter if he was one or not. I ask, that is not an answer. He closes takes another sip of water from the glass and this takes gulps it down all in one go. I take another step towards him demanding an answer. He puts the glass down and says, if I say he was one, would you believe me. Or would you prefer he wasn't one.

I wasn't going to play any games right now, just tell me. He then suddenly takes a stance, no. What is this. What the hell is he thinking. Is he really going to provoke me right now. He stands up in front of me, if I say he was one, you would blame me and the shadows for leaving him to die. And if he wasn't one, you would still blame us for not saving him. Siera says, that doesn't make any sense. He says, that’s right. It doesn't. Yet its true. Right now Vanessa truly believes that we are responsible. No, rather I am. I clench my jaws in anger. The sheer arrogance of him to be so haughty.

But what's worse is that he is absolutely right. I couldn't form those words, yet I was thinking the exact thing. He read me like an open book. Cass says confused, Vanessa, do you really think that. I couldn't answer her. My attention was squarely on the person in front of me. I ask him, he was the strongest Medrone alive. He wouldn't have died if you had helped him early. David's eye squint, strange. If he was the strongest, how the hell did he die then. I couldn't take it anymore, I pull my arm and slap him on his cheeks.

David slouches a little from the hit. The other two stood up behind me and Siera grabs my arm, Vanessa. Stop this right now. I shove her back as David straightens back up, did that feel good. He didn't look even one bit apologetic. It only ticked me off more. He grabs his jaw where I hit. He says, I have been waiting for you to let out this anger. Because I am tired of tip toeing around you. I yell, what do you mean by that. He replies, I know Wagner is a sour topic for you. This past year I have tried to tell you. But you never try to listen to reason. So I sort of hoped you would leave it alone. But I can't anymore.

Siera asks, what exactly happened with you and Wagner. He turns to Siera, I have tried many times to talk to Vanessa about Wagner. But every time she shots me down. I am sick of it. He faces me, your brother had a dark side to him. You only remember one thing about him. But I have seen a whole lot of him. I say, lies. He was the most decent person I knew. David's demeanor had changed completely now. He wasn't nervous at all anymore. He says, if that’s true, then why is Charles claiming he made a ruckus at his village.

I take a step forward, he was just making things up. Cass asks beside me, what about Charles. But neither one of us explain it. David says, Vanessa, you make him out to be a god. But he was a person, just like us. Flaws and all. He had a darker side to him. I am not at all surprised he did something that endangered children. I had enough of this lies. I went for another slap. But he grabbed my wrist before I made contact. He nonchalantly says, you only get one. I tried to pull back my arm, but his grip was so tight it hurt me.

He continues, having admiration for him is fine. But having blind devotion, that’s dangerous. I angrily yell, you think you are so hot shot being a Shadow. You think you him better than me. His own sister. Then he does something out character, he laughs maniacally. He says, you know what. I do know him better than you. He was the strongest, there is no doubt about that. But he was also harboring anger. Anger and hate that you don't seem to know about.

I wriggled under his grip. I aimed for a punch with my other hand. But before I could, I let goes of my arm and I stumble back a step. Siera catches my arm and I regain my balance. I shout, you are just spouting nonsense. He was the most decent person. He sighs, and that’s why I never wanted to talk about him. You have romanticized your childhood memories to an absurd level. Everyone naturally would want to believe their sibling were good and kind. But they at least recognize some of their faults. You on the other hand are too stubborn and never once believe that to be true.

I am so much mad I might punch him again. I say, I never said anything like this. He says, try to recall. I tried to broach the subject about the next crown during the flag capture game. You straight up said no will ever be as strong as Wagner. And everyone should try to be like him. He then shakes his head, I am sorry to say. But we already have multiple people here who have surpassed him. Or at the very least at his level. My veins start to pop up, I get it now. You are jealous of him. That’s why you are even willing to risk your life fighting with an overdrive Heraknus. You want to become stronger than him.

He gives a flat response, you are right. Not about being jealous. But I want to be better than him. Let me be clear about something though. I am perfectly okay with you believing Wagner was good person. What I don't understand is why you can't stand anyone talking anything less about him. I get its important to hold on to memories, I know more about it than anyone. But you are holding it like its your life. You don't even want to entertain any flaws about him. There is no such person who is all good always. They are just delusions of kids.

Those words made me so mad I felt I was boiling. Wagner is the strongest. He was the most decent Medrone ever. But why can't I remember anything other than that. We had so much fun and he was always caring for me. And yet I can't remember anything bad about him. This made me even more furious. This the same thing Cass was talking few days back. I am did the same thing to Ned, put my own selfish desires on him. I am so confused now, why am I even thinking this. Wagner was a good person. I know it be absolutely true.

But then why can't I convince David of it. In a wrapped sense, he was making sense. I don't like anyone putting Wagner down. Even if its about something so silly as the title of crown. No, its not silly, Wagner was the crown. But then David voices echo's to me, so were others before him. I grab my burning head trying to break out of this turmoil. David says, I don't want to argue this with you. But I care about you. And I needed to tell you what my feelings are about this. I even called in Cass and Siera because I wasn't brave enough to do this alone.

I look up to him. He wasn't angry anymore, he was very said. He continues, I have tried different subtle ways to make you understand this. But you are strangely adamant about your own believes. All I want is for you to acknowledge that I will not have the same believes as you. He earnest request was making me angrier by the second. Am I really being petty with this. But its Wagner we are talking about. My brother. The strongest Medrone. My eyes swell in tears. Why am I getting like this. Why can't David believe in my brother.

David sighs, but if you can't even do that. Then you are in need of therapy too. He words cut me deep. Why can't I let it go. Cass says, that’s enough. You should stop David. You are hurting her feelings. He says, I wasn't planning on doing this. But even I have a limit on my patience. She was demanding me to accept something about Wagner which I didn't agree. I am not giving an excuse for my behavior. I am only telling what I feel. Why am I not even allowed that, while she is not being fair. This is my way of making amends.

Cass says, how is this. He says, my mistake was not about lying or hiding the truth. It was being dishonest about it. I should have been honest about knowing Wagner from the beginning. But I am still not going to tell what I know, and how I know. Because I truly believe its best to leave it in the past. That’s why I didn't about Terrisa to you, Cass. Why should I open wounds from the past that can't affect our present. Cass remains silent. I couldn't open my mouth even a little anymore. I was a bag of angry and confusion. He says, same thing happened with Catherine.

Cass asks, what do you mean. He shakes his head, ask her. Ask her if its better to know about your family in a long lost planet. He takes a short breath, this is my problem. I wanted to reconcile my past self on Medrine with my current self. Knowing so many secrets suddenly about so many people took an unexpected effect on me. That’s why I ended up in therapy. And I am trying hard to change. I am trying very hard to accept my reality. Blake and

Marina had years to adjust this new life. And while I was technically living on Earth like everyone, I am basically having an identity crisis recently. I am trying to make it right with everyone. I don't want my Shadow past to define my behavior anymore.

He faces me, I regret how I handled things with you. Its that I didn't trusted you, I didn't trust myself enough. I thought you would just hate me always about this. Instead of explaining my reasons, I hide the reasons it self. That was the mistake. But I am trying not to be like this anymore. Its taken me months, but I have been gradually confiding in people about things. I told everyone about my eyes healing on Earth. I told you about my life in the university. Maybe not everything, but I was opening up. Just like how I am telling everything now.

He intense gaze pierces me so hard I feel dizzy. I can't seem to let of my anger at all. What's wrong with me. David is rambling and pouring his heart out, and yet all I feel is anger at him. He walks back and takes the jug of water to his mouth. He drinks it halfway empty and then wipes his mouth, sorry. My nerves were acting up. Needed to cool down. Siera asks concerned, are you really okay. You are way to riled up. He sighs, I might have taken it too far. Because after this, I am meeting with Drew with some sort of special treatment.

Cass asks, what. Now. He nods, yes. I wanted to clear up things with you and Vanessa before that. Because it seems there is some risk to this. My anger subsides with complete confusion. Siera asks, what kind of risk. He shrugs, don't know. It could be anything from a hypnotic congenital exposure or a straight up hard core medication. Cass asks, why so sudden. He sighs, because I still have PTSD. I may have gotten over some of my issues. Not all. And its dangerous to leave it untreated any longer.

Cass says, you going to fight Charles despite your condition. He says, I have no choice. I made a deal with him. That deal secured our future. And I have been painstakingly making efforts to make sure Heraknus follow through it. Even if that meant raging a political war against Citradel. Siera asks, and that somehow equates to you taking a risky treatment. He says, I can't deny I am worried about it. But I trust my therapist. I recently learned she is much smarter and skilled than me. Objectively speaking, that says a lot about her. She predicted a nervous breakdown even before it happened and prepared a sedative in advance. I have complete faith in her abilities.

This is absolutely bonkers. What kind of person Drew is that made David trust her this much. Cass says, David. This is too risky. You are not in right mind right now. She peeks at me from the side as I remained silent all the while. Siera says, she is right. You need to settle down. Maybe delay it for tomorrow. David says, there is no point to delay it. I have been dealing with this for months. I am ready to be done with it. This week has been tough on me. But I rather face my demons.

His determination was strong now. His lost vigor had returned. While mine was dwindling away. It had has been ever since he called me out so openly. I looks at his watch and turns to us, its time. I need to go back home in another 45 minutes. I wasn't planning on arguing with anyone so I didn't thought I needed a lot of time. I should have come earlier, but I know you all are busy. I squeezed out a lot of time without meaning to. Siera says, forget about us. Are you really not going to postpone it now.

He says, I am not. I might look like I am unstable, but trust me. This has been going on for a week. Therapy has helped me a lot to handle my emotions. Actually, its not been much help recently, but I do feel it would have been worse without it. And that’s why don't care about the timing right now. In fact, this maybe the best time. I know its strange to say out aloud, but I am feeling much better now that I said my piece. Especially about Wagner. I will say it again. I wasn't planning to be so confrontational about it. Still, its made me feel better. Even if I hate myself for putting this on you, Vanessa.

I don't know how he can be so considerate of me right now. He basically said I am delusional about Wagner. The person I admire the most. Gah, my head hurts now from the internal conflict. He then turns to Cass, I know its not fair. But I would like you to be there too. Cass takes a second to respond, if you are going to be stubborn about doing it. I might as well see it through till the end. He nods and turns to me, I don't want to cause more duress on to you. So I leave it up to you to. But I would prefer if you are there too. Both of you. He turns to Siera.

She looks at my quiet demeanor and says, ah, we are going to need a minute to think about it. He nods. He prepares to leaves the room. But before he leaves, he says, one more thing. I would really prefer it if you don't tell anyone what you heard today. At least until the match with Charles. I am not asking you to lie, just don't mention it to anyone. Something this personal could be used against me. I am worried about people targeting me. This sort of stuff is exactly the thing that would create a chaos that I can't cover it again.

I couldn't give it any thoughts. I was a mess inside right now. Siera says, of course. Be assured that I won't be telling this anyone. Cass didn't make the same promise, she just gives a slight nod. He says, you all have been there for me in the beginning. You saved me many times back then, so I owe you the truth about me. Sorry it took so long. I just needed time. Cass says, its all right David. I don't like it, but at least I understand it better now.

He says, thanks. He turns his back t us, see you all later. He abruptly steps out of the door. The three of us where standing in my living room like couple of confused people gawking at the retreating figure of David. Cass turns to me, Vanessa. I don't exactly know what really happened with you, David and Wagner. I don't want take sides. I am only sorry this happened. Between this and Ned, I don't know what's going on with you. But all I know is that I want to trust David. Even when he was ranting like crazy few minutes ago.

She was clearly taking his side, despite what she said. I can't blame her though. And yet I couldn't utter a single word. I was lost in my own thoughts. Siera covers for me, you'll have forgive her. She is shaken up by this ordeal. Can't say I am faring any differently. That was a lot. Cass says, that I get it. Are you going to go to his place then? Siera says, I am not sure. But you go ahead. If we do leave, it will be later. She says, I need to talk to Matt too before I go to his pace. Siera asks, hey now. Didn’t David tell not to tell this to anyone.

She scoffs, I am not like David. I can't just keep such a massive thing from Matt. I didn't verbally agree to it, did I. David can be mad at me later. I need Matt with me right now. She already had her phone open while walking out of the house. Siera sighs, maybe David had a point to keep this hidden from people. No matter how much you try to hide it, the truth always comes out. She looks at me, you have been quiet for too long. I am getting worried about you. Say something.

I lost strength in my legs and I slump down in the couch. With a meek voice I say, I don't know what to think. I can't believe David said so many wiles things about my brother. We have argued so many times. But never like this. Never something so personal. She sits beside me, you know I am always here for you. I am on your side, but I can't dismiss him too. You love your brother a little too much. I face her angrily, sounds like you are taking his side. How is that right. I can't understand my own emotions anymore. Why is everyone siding with him on such things. I hate this.

She reaffirms me, Vanessa. You are stronger than this. She reprimands me like she always does. The familiarity of her commanding voice makes me feel a little better. She says, I don't know what David knows about Wagner. Its honestly unbelievable that the clueless kid we met all those years ago is actually someone important. You him much better than me. Do you think he is sort of a person accusing people for no reason. I spat out, don't tell me you believe him.

She says, its like he said. It doesn't matter what we believe. Its all in the past now. It was on a different planet. I am only agreeing with David on this point. You should try to leave it alone. People can have different views about the same people. It doesn't have to mean one is wrong or right. I have noticed it for some time, but I didn't realize it was this deep. I ask, what are you saying. I know my brother was a good person. She says, I am not denying that. But you don't have to this angry with David for not agreeing with you. I have many issues of how he spoke to you. Maybe its because he is in therapy, or something else. But at least he has a good excuse. What's yours.

She was making me question things I didn't want to ask myself. I had an unshakable faith on Wagner. Even after all this I refuse to believe it. And yet I know how unreasonable I am being with this. David himself said he was okay with me, it was me who wasn't okay with him. It just pissed me more that he was somehow having the moral ground right now. Siera then says, listening to David make me wonder about Wagner myself. I ask, how do you mean. She says, I am not sure if its related. But I have always found it weird. You once told me a story about your brother. I thought I remembered it wrong. But something David said makes me curious.

I didn't like where this was heading. I can't handle if Siera begins to lean towards David now. She then begins to tell me story that makes me leaves speechless once again.

Blake (Chapter 95)

Sunday, February 15, 2026 09:25

Where are they? She asks me again for the fifth time. My answer hadn't change again, calm down, Marina. We are early. We both were waiting in front of David's house. His car wasn't in the driveway, so we know he was somewhere else. We were waiting beside my car and pacing around for the time being. She says exasperated, I can't. I have been avoiding talking about it because I didn't want David to feel pressured. But now that its now, I am freaking out a little.

I can understand her worry. I am worried as well, however, David had made up his mind about this. I tell her, its going to be fine. We need to trust Drew with him. Marina clicks her tongue, we still don't how she plans to treat him. I can't help but imagine its something like a lobotomy. I scoff, that's not true. I think David once mentioned its non surgical. She says, then it could be a non invasive lobotomy. I don't even understand what that meant. Don't think Marina knows it herself. We chatted about the different possibilities for a while. Then 30 minutes before we saw he car approaching.

Marina yells, finally. I was worried he might have bailed for some reason. I don't think David would do that, but anything's possible right now. We parks his car and gets out. The moment we saw his face, Marina and I immediately knew he was upset about something. His eyes were droopy and his posture looked lopsided. Marina asks, David. What happened. David turns to us walking to him. He says, hey guys. Ah, he sighs heavily, nothing serious happened. That didn't exactly make us less anxious.

I ask, you look exhausted. Don't tell me you in a fight again. He smiles, not exactly. Marina crosses her arm demanding answers. He relents, I just met with Vanessa, Cass and Siera. This garnered an immediate anxious reaction from us. He says, I told them about my PTSD and I was in Shadows. Marina blurts, holy shit. You did what. I bit my lips, you told them everything. He replies, not everything. I didn't tell them who the other shadows were. Well, expect for Terrisa.

I turn to Marina who shrugs at me. She asks David, and who is she? He replies, a Shadow from Cass's family. She was the retrievalist from two generations ago. I am surprised by this new addition to our mysterious Shadow history. Marina asks shocked, someone from Cass's house were also part of Shadows. He nods, like me, Zakerine and Wagner, she was an outsider. I ask, and you told Cass about it. He says, I figured I come clean to her now. I don't know if people targeting us would use it against me. I rather tell them myself first rather than hear from someone else.

So this is what he decided to do in the end. In the morning he wasn't sure what to do with Vanessa. Seems he found something to say not just to her, but also others. He says, ever since I told you guys about our Shadow history, I have been thinking about telling both Cass and Catherine. I need to clear my conscious. Anything that will help me get over my PTSD. His desperation to get over his issue is apparent. Can't say if it's the right call though. Marina says, so does that mean you told Vanessa about Wagner.

He makes a irritated face, I couldn't. I only told few vague details to her that Wagner wasn't a good person like she thought. I ask, that's all. You didn't tell her he was a Shadow. He says, I couldn't. Vanessa was at my throat, believing I was wrong unquestionably. And based on how our conversation went, I realized she wouldn't be okay with either way. If lied about him, I would have only made it worse. And if told her the truth, she would undoubtably blame us for not saving him.

I ask, that can't be. She can't blaming us for that. He says, she didn't put it in so many words, but I know she was thinking about it. Marina says, that's freaked up. He says, she couldn't reconcile Wagner dying a ordinary death. She has told us numerous times how he must have died heroically. He probably might have. But reality and perception are different things. Marina asks, I feel sorry for her a little now. And what about your theory about her trauma replacing memories. He clicks his tongue, I already broke her heart and basically made her hate me even more. I had nothing left in me anymore. I kind of rushed out of there in a hurry not wanting to have a panic attack.

I take a nervous step, did you have one. He cracks his neck and puts his hand behind his neck, not really. I thought I had one coming. But it was just my nerves acting up. I thought for sure talking about Wagner would cause him to have a panic attack. He already had it several times before. But he is in much better shape than I thought he would be. I ask, so you are okay. He scoffs, relatively speaking. Though, I feel much better now that I have come clean to them.

Marina says, damn dude. How can you say that when you look like you are beaten down. He gives a nervous smile, I don't doubt it. Maybe I am just exhausted from training entire day. Or its something else. Its strange, isn't it. Who knows why. That's why I am in therapy. He wasn't making any sense, but that's exactly what he himself acknowledges. It feels like he is coming to terms with himself right now. I ask, you wanted to tell them just before a treatment. Seems kind of unfair to them.

Marina says, yeah. That does seem strange behavior from you. He says, I have been stalling entire day struggling with this. I know its not right, but I don't exactly know what this treatment entails. I know I said its not dangerous, but I don't want to risk it. I should have told them earlier, that I admit. I can't make all the right decisions, now can I. I can't tell if he using his PTSD as an excuse or its really making him do strange things. Regardless, I know he didn't mean to hurt anyone.

Marina sighs, all right. You get a pass since you are not well. But try not to anymore rash things. That's my thing. She lightly taps his one arm. He gives a little smirks, that won't be the last one. But I will sure tell you beforehand. That makes Marina punch his arm again. He says, ouch. Marina scoffs, don't get snippy with me. Its difficult to grasp him. He seems stable, but also not at the same time. This is a completely new avenue. But I shake it off and ask, I am guessing you also tell them about you are meeting Drew now.

He says, I did. Cass will be here soon. Don't know about Siera and Vanessa. I reply, okay. So we better get out stories straight. Marina says, yeah. What did you not tell them? He gave us a rundown on what he said. He didn't tell about our family, nor Catherines. He didn't leave hide much about his PTSD, so that's a good. Because I don't have to hide it anymore from others. He even told about them his guilt about taking the serum. Marina whistles, jeez David. You didn't hold back did you.

He says, I didn't see the point in it. I didn't want to make another mistake, like I did with Vanessa. So that's everything I told them. I scratch my head thinking about it. Its good he freed himself from keeping so many secrets, but at the same time I feel anxious. What will they think of me and Marina who kept his secret. My nervousness was read by David, don't look so down, Blake. You both did what I asked of you. Just tell others it was my decision. You don't have to feel guilty.

I smile at how he read me so easily, did I look worried about that. Marina says, you kind of. I ask her, you don't have a problem. She chuckles, dude, I am freaking out a little inside. But come on, we all decided it was for the best to hide his identity. I am glad I wasn't the who had to tell anyone though. That would be too awkward. This is so like her. I am a little envious of her. She has a much better positive attitude than me right now. David says, you both don't have to be worried. Then we hear a car coming from the side. David says, I am the one who should be on edge right now.

This is it. It was Drew's car. She parks it beside my car. I saw a lot of stuff in the back seat. She is wearing a large coat as she septs out from the car, good evening everyone. I figured there would be an audience. David walks to her first, evening doctor. They both shake hands. She says, you look tired. Busy day. He says, busy week. As you know. She chuckles, quite the celebrity you have become. David makes a scowl, it's a phase. It will die out soon.

She scoffs, I don't think so. Your passionate speech convinced everyone. I would love to hear sometime how much of it was true. David snarls, don't mess around. I may not have told you everything of my time on Earth, but you must might have pieced enough stories about me. She says, maybe. I have some suspicions for few events. I know you are not really responsible for those people dying in the warehouse. But I can't be sure of it. That stung me a little. It was mine and Vanessa's fault. She correctly guessed it was a lie.

David says, doesn't matter. Its the official truth right now. I hope you are not telling anyone about it. Especially your family. She says, of course. I know that. You are creating huge waves against Citradel. My opinions are just that, nothing more. Though. She turns a little quieter, my daughter is smitten by you. And I don't like that. That made me and Marina laugh a little. David however played it slyly, really. That's good to know. He gives a wicked smile. I can't believe he had the nerve to make jokes to her right now. Drew immediately straightens her back, I can easily mix poison in your sedatives. You won't even know about it.

David chuckles, didn't she broke up with her boyfriend recently, this makes Drew even more anxious. Marina cuts in, dude. Stop antagonizing the person who is going to poke around your brain. David smiles. Drew shakes her head, lets not get into it right now. She then meets us, Blake. Marina. We both take turns to greet her as well. I ask, so this it huh, I point to the bags in the back. She says, yes. Marina asks, and what is it. Drew says, some equipment's, pharmaceuticals, and all kinds of fun stuff. He peeks at David like she wanted to scare him, maybe get a little revenge for earlier.

I don't think I have seen any doctor like her. She doesn't know what's been going on, but its refreshing to see she has a sense of humor. Marina scoffs, you won't tell us. She says, not right now. I am in the presence of very high profile people. I don't want to give false promises until it works. I say, you don't have to be worried about that right now. She smiles, I cannot be not worried. I am guessing more people know about this than a week ago. Right. She looks around our apprehensive face.

She ends up staring at David. He says, like Blake said. Lets not be concern ourselves with it. Drew scoffs, so others know about me as well. She shakes her head a little, I guess its fine. Thankfully no one has approached my house demanding answers. Though, I expect some discretion. Please leave my family separate from this. Can I at least count on that?

I want to assure her privacy, I will make sure no one disturbs you. Marina says, we will not allow anyone to interfere with your daily life. That we can promise. She takes a second to take it in, thanks. She turns to David, you have good friends. You have caused a lot of problem for them. He smirks, don't try to make me feel even worse then I feel. Not right now. She analyses him for a second, you seem different. And the earlier banter too seemed off. Did something happen. She picked up on his behavior. He waves at her, I had a rough week. I was entangled in a big criminal business and then blindsided from Ryes. Me being strange is actually not that strange.

Her eyebrows furrows in a little, hum, that's true. Well, in any case, if you are able to look at yourself this objectively, that's makes me feel better at the odds of this working. David says, great. Then lets get started. We all help her get our stuff out from her car. Marina offered to carry all with her Kuret, but Drew said they are all delicate equipment's. So we chose to carry them in hand. In few minutes we set her stuff in David's living room. He had earlier cleared up all the furniture and made space there.

Drew says, thank you all. But from this point on words, its just me and David. I ask, we can help you setup your equipment's. She says, thanks. But its better if I handle it myself. Among us, only she was only medically trained so I can't really argue with her. She needed some space from us to work. David says, I will help her however I can. So its fine. Then came a heavy atmosphere because its time. The highly anticipated stuff we have anxious about is finally here. Marina says, you better not wake up a zombie okay. She gives a tight hug to David. She pats his back, if I do, just smack me around to wake me up. She smacks his back of his head after pulling away, don't think I wouldn't do that.

Then me and David lock in our arms, do whatever you need to do. And don't forget we are here for you. He smiles, thanks. I need to hear that. We let go of our arms. I add, we will outside the whole time. Give us a shout if anything goes wrong. Marina shots me a look, don't say that. Everything is going to be fine, right? She turns to Drew. She says, I am here. M is here too. He points to a hologram of her from a side display. She continues, have faith in us. I promised David to help him, and don't plan to break it now.

David is the most anxious. I know he is putting up a strong front, but anyone in his place would be terrified. Especially since he also doesn't know what this radical untested experimental treatment is. David says, don't worry

guys. I need this. And everything is going to be fine. We didn't have any choice but to have faith in his wavering confidence. Marina says, Drew, please take care of him. She nods, I will. I give a subtle nod to David. After that tense exchange, me and Marina step out of the house.

We both remained silent as we sat on the lawn chairs. David kept few out since we weren't going to leave his house. There were some additional kept out too, in case others visit here. Marina becomes very nervous and begins shaking her leg in quite suspense. The house begins to make a noise. This was familiar. The same thing happened few days ago. All the doors and window close. Windows turn to black tint. And the faint noises of stuff moving inside stops.

Marina waves her charm in the air and focus around the house. After a minute she disperses it, can't get any read. Whatever they are doing, its not related to Kuret. I ask, what do you think it is then. She says, no idea. I read up a little about behavior modification and correction. Some treatments are mild, while others are drastic. But they are all for a human physiology. I ask, for a Medrone it has to different, right. She didn't have an answer. All we can do is wait.

We chatted about our Shadows recruits. The tail we set on Nathan and Frank reported no problem so far. And she tells that she hasn't heard any new news about the culprits amongst us. It was going to be difficult, but we gradually we were crossing off officers who were completely innocent. We aren't completely sure if it was an officer who stole the drugs, but at least they seemed to be some connection with the smuggling operations. After around 10 minutes, Marina says, I sense someone. She turns towards the road where a car is approaching.

I follow her gaze and check the area. I could see a familiar Kuret aura coming off someone. It was Catherine. She parks her car beside Drews and runs off in our direction. She halts when she sees us sitting alone in the lawn, shit. I missed him, didn't I. I reply, yeah. They already begin about 15 minutes ago. She shakes her head, I should have just given the work to Jess. She turns to the house in lockdown, I assume those black windows mean I can't just knock and see him right now.

Marina pats to the seat beside her. Catherine gives a little frustrated scoff and took the seat. I ask, its fine Catherine. We all are busy. David knows that. She says, you guys got here fast. Marina says, I finished my work early to meet him before. I add, ditto. She lays her hand on her chin, I wanted to done the same. But some kids made a mess in the guest houses and I had to deal with it personally. I ask, anything important. She waves her other hand, nothing serious. They just were making a scene about Citradel.

I have been getting reports like this for past few days. Not everyone is happy what David and I did to Citradel. But they can't really side with Citradel officially. So they create feuds just to vent their frustration. Marina asks, you called in the IDF then? She sighs, I didn't. I have been calling them numerous times, and besides, they are busy with catching people on run. I stayed back to deal with it myself. She turns back to the house, enough about me. What about David. Will he be okay.

I give a nervous smile, we hope so. We still don't know what kind of non Kuret treatment is she administering. Marina says, based on her bags, I can't even tell what kind of non surgical way it is. Catherine leans back on her chair, resting her head. She says, I suppose we are going to just wait then. Marina and I gave a silent agreement. We passed the time the discussing about the exhibition match. Since things have settled down a little bit, Ned had been asking me to start focusing on that.

He has sort of became a liaison with the admins. Citradel isn't helping us with this right now, so we have to start preparing it ourselves. This week has been all sorts of chaos, but next couple weeks it would be about our expansion and the match. Just 3 weeks left, but it will fly by soon. Marina is already done around 80% of designs and geographical plans for out city. We can begin our work as soon as the tech team arrive. In another few minutes, next group of people arrived.

It's now Cass's car. I spot her and Matt coming to us now. I turn to Marina who was a little apprehensive too. David said he only told Cass, but what are the chances Matt just came here to just talk with us. She looks around us and asks, is he already inside. I nod, yeah. Matt looks like a clueless person and gives me and Marina and thorough stare. I sigh, she told her. She had to. Matt gulps a little, ah, hum, so its true. I wasn't sure exactly what he meant. I ask, what do you know.

He looks nervously at us and then to the house. He seemed so confused I felt a little pity for him. Did Cass drag him without telling the whole truth. Cass sits on the chair beside me, I thought they take more time. Should have arrived a bit earlier. She then looks at me with curious eyes. Marina sighs, Matt. Take a seat. David is not going to come out anytime soon. He looks around us and takes the seat beside Catherine. Catherine was also confused about these two. She asks, you know about David.

Cass didn't have words to answer her. Matt leans forward, you knew then. Catherine scoffs, when did you find about it. Matt slaps his temple, like just now. Cass told me. Catherine turns to Cass, who told you. Cass replies, David told me, Vanessa and Siera, like 2 hours ago. Catherine scoffs, so he just came clean about his PTSD right before this. What was he thinking. Matt looks to her, I don't believe it. He has been hiding his PTSD from everyone. He then faces me, who else knows about this.

I says, apart from people here, only Siera and Vanessa. Marina says, unless David went around telling someone else too and just didn't tell us. Its not entirely impossible. Matt says, you guys should have told us before. Marina says, it was David's decision. Don't blame us. Catherine says, I did the same. Cass asks, then you know everything too. Me and Marina remained impartial here, because we don't know who knows what exactly. But the situation so confusing, its about to come to a head.

Catherine says, I don't know the whole deal, but I know enough. Matt says, jeez. And you two, you have known about David for almost a year. I can't believe this. Its clear now Cass told him everything. Catherine jerks, what do you mean a year. She turns to me, you said he told you after the final match. I don't want to be the one to explain things to her. Neither did Marina, because she just shakes her head. Cass says, nah. They know. Once David memories return he told them he was a Shadow too.

Well, cats out of the bag now. Catherine jaw hung loose and then looks around the confuse faces. She yells, what the freak did you just say. I lean my head back on the chair. Matt shrieks, you said you knew everything. Cass shouts, about his therapy. What do you mean David's a Shadow. Matt turns to Cass confused. Marina puts her hand on Catherine's shoulder, Catherine. David conveniently left out things. Though we knew about it too. A completely bamboozled Catherine looks at her, you are not joking. Are you?

Cass says, you really didn't know. Catherine shakes her head, what the hell. David's a freaking Shadow. At this point I had enough. I need to step in, lets clear this up for everyone. Yes, he is really our Shadow strategist. For years I believed I was the only survivor of Shadows. I am sure Marina felt the same. I bring out a chuckle, but turns out we always had another one among us all this a long time. Imagine the surprise. Catherine makes a scowl, holy shit. A strategist. That is, ah.

Matt helps her out, perfect for him. Don't you think. I just heard it from Cass and I almost crashed my car while I was driving. Catherine turns to Marina, how in the hell you kept this from us. I didn't like the fact that she automatically assumed I was never going to tell her this. I have already told her many things before. Marina says, hey. Don't make this about me. I can keep secrets when I want to. I wasn't in Shadows for just my pretty face. She didn't had it say it like that.

Catherine asks, I can't believe this. I knew he didn't telling me everything. But I never imagined this. She turns to me, how come you didn't figure it out before ? Didn't you train together on Medrine. I sigh, he was very different in Medrine. Even his voice, the way he spoke and body frame has changed since then. Marina gets a little guilty, maybe I should have figured it out. But David knew our identities, so he sort of took extra care around me. I had no idea it was him all this time.

Catherine says, wait. He knew about you, but you didn't know him. The hell does that make sense. This is going to take a while. I let Marina explain the internal mechanics of Shadows. Matt listened in closely, while Cass filled in stuff she learned from David. After a long discussion Matt asks, he knows all the Shadows identities. Holy mother of Kuret. Cass says, he didn't really tell us how he knows that. Many eyes feel on Marina and me. Marina says, sorry. But that’s Shadow business. I explain before she makes everyone angry, what she means is that Shadows has long bloody history. Disclosing those names would be dangerous.

Catherine asks, why is that. Are there more still alive? I stayed silent because I had no intention of giving any more of our history. Thankfully Marina agreed with me and didn't tell anything. Cass says, you guys are making me my head hurt. And now David's part of this too. Matt asks, lets keep aside the Shadow for now. Why didn't he tell us about his therapy. This I can help understand them. I answer, you do know how does therapy works, right? Matts gives a strange look and thinks about it for a second. A second later he snaps his fingers, oh damn. I get it.

Others realized it too. Catherine says, for this to work, he had to tell Drew about his past. Didn't he. Then Drew knows about him being a Shadow. I say, she has never said it, but we kind of figured it out the first time me and Marina met her. Marina says annoyed, that’s actually second time for me. She didn't believe me the first time, don't forget that. I wave at her to be not petty about it now. I continue, anyways. I can understand why David didn't tell anyone. Since Drew knows more than anybody, even than us two, if people knew it would be bad.

They had to know how dangerous that knowledge would have been. Cass says, you mean what Ryes said. Marina says, yeah. Thankfully that didn't happen. If he did, it would have been much damaging. Matt asks, I suppose that makes sense. But then why tell any of us. He turns to Cass, I mean I am kind of glad to know one of the most important people survived Medrine. But now we know. And people are trying to expose him. Isn't it a risk telling people. He had a point. I didn't think David would do this. Expose himself, right after nearly dodging a public attack.

I shrug, you should ask him. I thought he was only going to tell about his PTSD. Cass adds, he said he wanted to clear his conscience. Marina asks, he said that? Cass nods, yeah. He seemed weirdly forthcoming about stuff. Going on about something like a identity crisis. I recalled Drew something similar earlier. Cass sighs, I hate to say it, but it that kind of make sense. Having lived such a wild like he had and then forget about it. That’s going to take a toll. Cass says, yeah. But you know, even without his memories, he has acted like a Shadow stagiest. You remember how he tricked Nathan 3 years ago. She chuckles, that was a mega brain move.

The discussion then went on about stuff his was up to on Earth. Me and Marina already went through this phase before. But it was amusing to see others going through it. Its different than us, since they were normal kids. Marina joined to share her Shadow experience, and I had to steer the conversation in between whenever she ventured about talking about our parents. I don't think its right to tell Catherine about her family's role in Shadow. I don’t like keeping her dad's and brothers death from her. She has only recently became her self again. I don't want to hurt her again.

I thought it was only going to be us, but then another car rolled into Davids driveway. Its already been 40 minutes since David and Drew went in. It was Vanessa car and then both her and Siera came out it. Marina says , I didn't think she would come. Cass, didn't you say she and David kind of fought. Cass says, more like a screaming match. It was crazy. I still don't know what David knows about Wagner. Cass told about the heated exchange earlier. Only me and Marina knew the truth about this. There was no point in telling them and cause more mess. So me and Marina stayed out of that matter. We assumed they weren't going to show up. But here they are.

Siera says, evening everyone. She looks at our tense faces. Vanessa is looking like hell. I think she was crying hard too. Her distraught and pain were visible on her face. The vibe here immediately shakes up and becomes suspenseful. Vanessa didn't say anything to us. She just stared at the house for a moment. Siera says, I am sorry to intrude on you all like this. I say, its no problem. But you should know he is already indisposed right now. She nods, I understand. We still like to stay though.

I take a quick peek to the other concerned faces. Obviously no one really had any reason to deny them, yeah. Sure. Take a seat. We had one seat less now, so I got up and offered mine. Siera says, I am fine with sitting on the

stairs. I say, come on. No need to be formal with us. We are off clock right now. Cass says, there is a garden chair in the garage. David showed me some time ago, I can get it. Siera says, thanks. She takes my seat. Vanessa finally unfreezes and walks to Marina.

She bends down whisper to her ear. After a moment, Marina nervously says, ah, yeah. Sure. She gets up and they both walk away. Everyone eyes glued to their retreating figure. Knowing what David told Vanessa, it could be only about one things. Her brother. Others figured it out too. Catherine asks, ah, Siera, is Vanessa okay. Siera says, no. Not right now. She looks around us, so I assume everyone here knows why they are here and what happened. Matt says, yeah. Cass told me. And we sort of told Catherine.

She turns to Cass approaching with a smaller chair. I thank her and take the chair from her. Siera says, you shouldn't have told Matt. Cass takes her seat back and scoffs, come on. You think I could keep such a big thing from him. I am not good at keeping secrets. And even I am, Mel is sure as hell not. Siera sighs, this is not good though. More people are going to find about him now. Cathrine says, so its that bad, huh. Siera says, you were just kids on Medrine. But us older people know how influential Shadows were.

She turns to me, maybe you and Marina also know. But all you were still only apprentices. Being a Shadow strategist is one of the most difficult jobs there is. I have heard many rumors about them. This is a little interesting. I ask, you mean how they are ruthless and dangerous. She smiles, you heard them too then. I say, of course. Even amongst us, there are many stories about them.

Catherine asks, stories? Siera says, I am sure not everything is true. Cass asks, are they really powerful? Siera says, all Shadows are crazy powerful. As you already know. But strategist wield different kind of power. She knows her Shadow lore. I know people now are more aware of us due to me and Marina. But Shadows were an enigma back in Medrine.

Siera lays it out, their knowledge and secrets are their weapons. Some so powerful entire nations and army can be toppled just like this, she snaps her finger.

Vanessa (Chapter 96)

Monday, February 16, 2026 20:35

I didn't want to be here. Not after what went down. Its too embarrassing people seeing my pitiful self. But after listening to Siera and crying, I settle down a bit. I still don't believe any of it to be true. But I am not going to stay cooped up in my room right now. I don't want to repeat the same mistake I did with Ned. I need to confront this instead letting it consume me. When I got here, 5 people were already here. I knew already that we were too late. David was in his house with his therapist doing god knows what.

I wanted to know more about Wagner. David said he knows Wagner due his Shadow mission. Then it means apart from him, Marina and Blake could also know the truth. I decided to ask each of them one by one. I grabbed Marina first because I thought she would tell me the truth. Blake already knows I am being unreasonable. But Marina wouldn't held anything against me. Once we were a distance away from her on the other side of the house, I ask, thanks for coming with me.

Marina says, I know what you are going to ask me. I make a confused expression. Then I noticed Cass coming out of the garage door. I ask, she told you. Marina says, yeah. Sorry. I know its private. But she was there and wanted to know more. I didn't waste my energy on being mortified so I ask, and. Is it true. Did you know Wagner too. She nervously answers, I'll be honest. I don't know. I have only Wagner twice, and it was a social events. I ask, so there were no missions that involved Wagner.

Marina says, I didn't say that. I ask in haste, what do you know then. She answers, look. Shadows work in pairs. There are at most two working at any given time. Kind of important to keep low profile so we can't really move in groups. So if David met Wagner, he could have done with others. I get annoyed, who then. She says, no idea. We keep secrets within ourselves too. Us apprentices don't even know each other identities until we become graduates.

I ask, does Blake knows then. Marina becomes suspiciously quiet then. My heart beats faster and I remain in heavy anticipation. She says, I don't think he knows too. I mean, if he knows Wagner, he would have told you. Wouldn't he. And from what I saw a week ago, when we were with David, he didn't know this about Wagner. My fist tighten up. This is just great. Just how screwed up is this. I get angry knowing they both don't know Wagner. I ask, are you lying to me. Did David put you up to this.

She sighs, look. I get you are angry at David. So I am not going to make things worse. Would I lie to you. Yeah, sometimes. Mostly about Shadows though. But if I know more about Wagner, I would tell you. I promise that. I couldn't tell if she was lying or covering for David. However something tells me she was telling me the truth. I ask, then do you believe him. That my brother wasn't a good person. Tell me he lied about that. Marina bit her lip and pauses for a moment.

She was probably being considerate of me. I say, please. Just tell me he was lying to you. She says, I don't know. That’s the truth. He didn't tell us anything specific. But, she makes a quick peek behind the group of people, I think there is something not right. My heart plunge into despair and anger, how can you say that. My brother was the most powerful Medrone. He was the role model for everyone. I grabbed Marina's arm in frustration. She lightly pushes me off, jeez. You need to calm down Vanessa.

I was being rude to her. But I didn't care. She says, I don't want to be in this position. But if am going to pick someone to trust, I am going to trust David. He has kept many things, sure. But that’s just because we are Shadows. And his job is all about using knowledge. I don't think he would lie about this. I mean, what would be the point. I answer, jealously. What else. He wants to be like my brother. Marina says, yeah, I don't think so. I get even angrier. I know many people who envy my brother. I say, David took the deal because Charles couldn't defeat my brother. He wants to prove he is stronger than him.

Marina thinks about it for a moment. Then she says, I don't want to seem insensitive to you. But, how is that wrong. Anyone at his position would be tempted to try and beat someone who gave the crown a challenge. I know I would. I couldn't believe what I am hearing. I need to make her understand, he is lying to everyone about Wagner. That’s what wrong. Marina asks, so you think even Charles was lying. I nod vigorously. She sighs, I really don't like being in middle of this. But I mean, do you honestly have no doubt. Not even a second about your brother.

I shake my head with resolve. Marina was getting impatient with me. She then mutters, god. It was right in front of me all this time, how in the hell did I never notice this. I get furious, what does that mean. She says, I think you should talk to Blake. He is better at this stuff than me. And you already know my answer. I am not blinding trusting David, but I am at least giving him the benefit of doubt. I hope you can do that to. I'll send Blake to you, so wait a second. After giving me this advice, she left me alone for a while.

My heart is in turmoil. Marina has bought into this nonsense too. This is so ridiculous its almost funny. Not many know Wagner personally since most of those who know him are dead or were too young. And the ones who do seem to be close to him say he wasn't a good person. I am so mad at them. Its infuriating that I can't let this go either. Siera has been trying to convince me that it shouldn't matter anymore. But it does to me. I have looked up to him all this time. Trying to fill the hole he left by staying back in Medrine. I idolized him, trying to be like him. What would say it about me if this was true.

In the middle of my anger thoughts, I hear Blake approaching me. He seems concerned about me. He asks, Vanessa. Maybe you should go back home. Take some rest. I ignored his plea, tell me about Wagner. Marina said you all have missions separately. So did you have one with David. He says, so that's what Marina called me here. He takes a moment to himself and says, I have met Wagner few times publicly. Like I told you some years ago. But I don't know him well enough to become acquaintance. I don't know if this makes sense, but even though I didn't know him personally, I finally learned truth about him.

I take a step towards him in frustration, tell me they are all lies. Wagner didn't kidnap children then. He says, I don't know anything about that thing. That was all Wagner. I get annoyed, you said you weren't sure of that. But now you do. What lies did David said to you. Blake gets a little louder with me, just stop this Vanessa. He gives me a intimidating expression. He says, you need to stop assuming David is lying all the time. That’s not true. What he has is knowledge that he keeps from us. Most of them for good reasons.

I yell, you believe him then. My brother, who has been always good to me and others. He was lying all this time. I don't believe it. He says, you don't have to convince others of it. Don't you get it. Cass told me what David said. Your problem isn't about Wagner. You keep making about him, but its about you. He might have been good, or maybe bad. Or maybe he just a person. Who can do mistakes. Just like anybody. I am so mad at this because I know he was right. But every fiber in my brain is telling me they are all wrong. What's going on here. I am so conflicted that it is giving me a headache.

Blake says, I don't like how David handled things with you. But I agree with him saying that past is the past. We should learn from it, not obsess over it. And he is currently the last to person to say that. His PTSD stems from the past. You need to learn to let it go. I say, I can't. I just can't. He won't even tell me how he knows Wagner. Was he in the Shadows. Is that you all know him. He asks, what did David tell you. I answer, he didn't confirm or deny it. He sighs, typical. But even if he was one, how would that help you. Hypothetically, if he was one, that means he didn't tell you about it. How does that makes you feel about him. You precious brother, who already kept his overdrive a secrete from you.

That stung me. My throat get stuck and I couldn't form any words. I never thought about it like this. This creates a whole new mix of emotions in me. Blake says, you heard it from David, Marina and me. You know where we all stand in this matter. I don't to us to keep arguing about this. And I know it looks like we all are being against you, but its not true. Whatever Wagner was like, he was still your brother. Its natural your feeling be different from us. We can agree to disagree and move on. Or you can keep wanting to make us villains.

His word cut me even deeper. All 3 of them said it differently, but their intention were the same. I should move on. But I can't let it go. I can't tolerate anyone speaking ill of Wagner. But its almost like a sickness now. Blake says, this isn't your fault. Its natural that you love your brother. But understand this, this isn't our fault either. Sure as hell its not Davids. He turns his back to me and leaves me consumed with confusion and guilt. I came here hoping to they back me. But it didn't happen. Blake seems even more sure about Wagner's so called hidden side more than Marina. Wagner definitely has same connection to them.

I stayed alone for a long time, hoping I could calm myself down. But when that didn't really help I thought of going back home. I would only make others uncomfortable by others. But I also didn't want to be alone, without Siera right now. I would only spiral down even more. So I made a painful decision of sitting with them. When I approached them, their discussion stops abruptly and stare at me. Their eyes showed pity towards me. I felt so ashamed at my behavior. These are my friends and the people I work with daily. I just hope they don't ask me things.

I take the empty chair beside Siera. She gives a consoling look and then faces back others, as I was saying, these are the stories I heard. Matt says, damn. How much are they true. Marina scoffs, not telling. He makes a snarl, come on. At least tell us you weren't involve in the incident in Lititana. I vaguely remember about the city's government disbandment. It had to be you guys. The place became a ghost city in two days. Blake says, you should ask David. Because we are not going to disclose anything. Cass says, oh we will. Trust me, he ran off before I could ask anything. I have about a hundred questions for him. Catherine scoffs, try a million of them. I still find it unbelievable that you two never realized it. She eyes Marina more than Blake.

Marina gives a depressing laugh, I told you before, he was more careful with me. Whenever he came by our house, he acted clueless about our Kuret around me and my family. But during our Shadow training, he helped me with my charms construction, despite not being having knowledge of Kuret. That kind of makes it difficult for anyone to think it was him. Catherine asks, and you guys never tried to find each others identities. This made Marina and Blake more nervous than anybody thought. Even in my emotional state I could tell they were hiding it.

Blake says, so here's the deal with our generations Shadows. We didn't know who they were, but David told us about them. Siera says, but you won't tell us. Blake nods, if I believed that knowing that would help anyone, even like finding peace, I would tell. I rather not create more problems. Marina says, I feel the same. Though, I think its okay to tell one of our fellow Shadow's whole bloodline is gone, along with them. That stings me a lot.

Siera says, that is sad news. Blake says, it is. And David confirmed their deaths in person. So, he turns to Matt, no new Shadows will pop up unfortunately. A disappointed Matt looks to the sky. Catherine asks, but about older generation's Shadow. You said David knows them too. So you know too right. Maybe someone survived as well and have been in hiding. Marina says, it’s a wishful thinking. If they were someone, they would surely approach us by now. But none have. Blake says, all the previous generation are gone at least. Siera asks, David?

He nods without giving any further explanation. The air becomes thick with suspense. I wasn't paying attention to much of their discussion from here on. How could I. They were all now talking about different possibilities. What happens to David's after this PTSD treatment, the Shadow's boast in ranks and his fight with Charles. I zoned out for most of their discussion. I still heard them, but I was non responsive. I am grateful to others not bothering to check on me. I am painfully aware of their wary eyes on me.

Cass question pulls me out of my funk, isn't it getting late. Its already been more than hour. Didn't his doctor tell how long will it take. Blake says, no idea. Marina says, I don't think it will take whole night. Matt says, I know this is terrible timing, but I am getting hungry. Cass pulled me in on my way to dinner. Catherine asks, yeah. Me too. Shall we take a break and come back later? Blake says, you all can leave if you want to. Me and Marina will stay behind. I felt a little better knowing we are possibly leaving. I am not in a shape to worry about David right now. Though, I am now a little concerned after listening to others.

All the time I have been mad at David, but he undergoing some weird treatment. I didn't have much spare thoughts to worry about that. Most of it were frustration towards him. Cass says, I'll stay back too. I don't want to leave. At least not until I get some news. Matt looks at the time, I guess we can wait a little longer. Siera says, lets give it about another 20 minutes. And so they decided stay longer. I am so mentally exhausted and wanted to

leave. But I had no courage to voice my sole opinion.

And there was another brief discussion about different topics. 10 minutes went by and we still didn't have any news. But that’s when we all heard a explosion. That shock made us jar and stood up. My mind which had become numb come alive again. Marina screams, what the hell. She already produces a Kuret charm towards the source of the blast. David's house. Matt shouts, shit. Blake already brought his Kuret around and dashed towards the broken deck.

I tell Siera, stay back. She nods and gestures me to go ahead. I ran fast behind the others. The explosion was big, but there was no fire. Once I came close I saw the wall broken and from the debris a lone figure standing. Blake shouts from ahead, David is that you. It had to be him. I heard Drew yelling out, restrain him quickly. A cold shiver ran though my body. What just happened. Did the treatment went sideways. There was strange laugh coming from around us. It took a second to realize it was David.

Marina shouts, what's the hell is going on. Suddenly David's Kuret surrounds us. It instantly fills up the air around the ground. I bring out my Kuret on my arms and defend myself with wind. Blake shouts, David what are you doing. Then the black mass of Kuret from the middle shoots straight up in the sky. I gasp when I realize David just fly off into the sky dead straight. Marina shouts, the freak is going on. Drew comes rushing out coughing up, thank god you are all still here.

Blake screams, what happened. Where is he going. Drews cuts him off, just get him back immediately. She pulls out a small injection device from her coat pocket, quickly before there is any permanent damage. I shout out, what do you mean. Drew shouts back, no time to explain. She hurries back inside the room. Blake says, shit. Marina, go after him. I yell, I am faster. But Marina didn't wait to listen. She already had made a bunch of Kurets charms and blasted off in pursuit.

Catherine comes beside, help her. I saw his faced covered with blood. I didn't wait any longer. I gather wind around my feet and fly into the dark night. I add bursts of fire to my tail and accelerate faster. David and Marina weren't far. In fact I could see David is slowing. I catch up to Marina quickly as the wind around me glides me faster. Marina throws a charm towards David and it turns into a massive web around David.

I hear David saying something, but I couldn't make out what in this speed. But David's Kuret was different than normal. The charm web Marina threw disintegrates before it could wrap around him. Marina throws a bunch of her charms. I realize she isn't close enough for her charms to physically reach him. There is no other choice. I had to be use force. I prepare a fireball in my right hand. It slowed my ascend, but I launched it anyways. Marina saw me throwing it and threw her own Kuret into my fire.

The fire immediately picked up speed hits David. The fire explodes into a blast and it envelopes him inside. I can't believe Marina made it this lethal. But my concern was not needed. The fire dissipates and I see David falling back down unharmed. Now that I see him closer, I saw his form. He was covered from head to toe in his Kuret armor. It was dense and up close I could feel its moving around him like how my electricity moves on my skin. But the explosion broke his Kuret armer and exposed parts of his body. Marina grabs on David with a restraint charm and starts to descend back down.

I stop my own climb and follow them behind from above. As we gradually go back down my eyes fall on his face. It was covered in blood. I felt shivers in my gut. What the freak did this therapist to do David. But what's even strange is that I could hear him laughing. He didn't appear to be in pain, but that bleeding coming from his face didn't match his voice. He was laughing hysterically. I hear Marina shouting at him to wake up. Soon we were close to the ground. Then David decides to act up again and creates a Kuret blast around us. This Kuret attack was so strong it physically hit us. Marina's Kuret broke and her charms on her legs disappear. David gets away from her grips and launched himself straight into the ground.

I wanted to dive and get him, but Marina was momentarily not without her Kuret and we were dangerously close to ground. I decided to head towards Marina first since she was closer. She was flailing a little in the air, regaining her balance with another charm. I grabbed one of her arm and she levels straight up. She creates a large Kuret charms around us, cushioning our fall. We both land softly on the ground. I look towards David, but he falls faster from the force of his own Kuret. The impact unearths a grass and dirt around the place.

Once Marina and I stand on out feet again, I ask, you good. I let go her arm. She nods frantically, thanks. David momentarily broke my Kuret access. I have never seen him do this before. Others gather around the small crater where David fall. He was still lying on the ground. But his own Kuret acted as a physically broke his fall and he didn't appear to be hurt. But what's crazier is that he was laughing like a maniac. Catherine rushes to us, David. What the hell is wrong with you.

David raises his one arms to us and gives a thumbs up saying, that was awesome. I give it a ten. Lets do it again. Matt shrieks, dudes' lost it. Cass shouts back to the house, Drew. What the hell did you to him. David slowly picks himself up. But his movements are sluggish. His Kuret has formed into rings and spirals over his body. This is the same form he had when he was fighting Charles. This if my first time seeing up close, but I can felt his Kuret is humming with power.

Cass shouts, David. What happened to you. David faces us properly now. But then we finally saw the damage Drew was talking. It wasn't just his face was covered in blood. He was bleeding from his eyes, noes, mouth and ears. I shout, you are hurt. Let us get you help. He scoffs waving his hand around us. He suddenly stumbles a little to his side, hell no. Why should I leave now. You all are here, so it’s a party now. He is gone mad and spouting nonsense. Marina slaps her head, freak. Drew messed up his head.

Behind me Blake came running. He shouts, you are bleeding too much. Stop this. He raises his palm, showing the same injection device Drew just had. He walks gradually to David, but David just unleashes a blast of Kuret with his palm raised to us. I immediately ducked to my side, escaping the barrage of physical Kuret over my head. I was right to dodge it, because this wasn't just meta physical. His Kuret was physical in nature now. Cass guards Matt with her own Kuret body.

Blake grabbed Catherine and Siera out of the way. Marina created a charm to defend herself. It cracks a little but she managed to keep it intact despite the pressure. I shout, someone grab him quickly. Cass runs jumps towards him, you freaker. You finally lost your mind. Mel had taken over now. She ran with an arm extended for a punch. David glees like a child shouting, hell yeah. That’s more like it. Mel lands a blow from below. David didn't even try to dodge it. His Kuret gather around his leg and he blocks her with his knee. The impact makes a large sound.

Mel didn't hold back, but somehow David wasn't blown away. Mel shouts, you little shit. Mel went for another punch. But David lost his footing on his one leg and falls on his ass on the ground. Mel fist passes in the air. David chuckles, that was a good punch. I call it a solid seven. I should return one though. He joins his hands and throws a Kuret blast. Mel brings her arms around her arm. Normally she should have been able to tank it. But something was wrong. The black Kuret shove her backwards into the air.

I saw Cass's face. I immediately ran behind her and catch her before she falls on the ground. I grab Cass's back and ask worried, are you all right. Just like with Marina, David's attack broke Cass's Kuret connection. She was back to her self now. She blinks hard, what happened. How did he do that. I grit my teeth. This is bad. David's kuret attacks have gotten stranger. Matt saw Cass with me and was relieved to see her okay. He shouts, Cass, is it you. She nods in confusion.

Matt then sprints off to David. Marina runs behind him, wait. Matt don't. Matt yells, you need to wake up. David stands back again, hey Matt. Great, is it your turn now. I see Matt using Cass's Kuret. He must have copied hers just now. Matt went jumps up in the air and goes for a high kick. David nonchalantly grabs his ankle on contact with his Kuret covered hands. He was pushed back slightly. But it wasn't enough to topple him. He pushes back Matt and he lands on his feet. David laughs, that’s was a six. You can do better though. Marina joins Matt from the side screaming, Blake hurry.

I saw Blake running from the side. I decided to join him. Blake says, restrain him. David raises his arms enjoying the chaos, yes. This is more like it. Lets see who is the strongest now. He wasn't moving all the entire time. But he finally makes his move. He rans straight at Matt and Marina. Marina waves her hand around to create a bunch of Charms. David crouches down while running and then speeds up suddenly. It was the same speed he showed in the match. He zips past Marina, breaking her charms before they are created completely.

He then stand up in front of a terrified Matt. He shows his bloody teeth, hey Matt. Want to know a secret. Matt throws a punch in response. David catches his arm by the elbows and restrains him. David says, I am a Shadow. Always have been. How crazy is that. Matt cries, yeah, no shit man. David then twists around with roundhouse kick straight at Matt's chest. Matt's Kuret protected him, but he went flying straight into the air. Marina jumps to the air behind him to catch him before he hits the ground. She also realized his Kuret connection is broken.

Ahead me Blake halts his approach and signals me to do the same. I ask, what. He yells, everyone. Stay back. Only me, Marina or Vanessa will go near him. Its too dangerous for others. David makes disapproving voice, tsk. Blake, no one likes a party pooper. Then suddenly he coughs, and more drops of blood comes out it. I can't believe he is not even acknowledging his own condition. He shows his teeth, what's this. He laughs. I shout, you are bleeding dammit. You need help.

He barks, nah. This is not blood. This is proof of my power. He raises his fist like it was some victory. Blake whispers to me, you go in front, I will go from behind. I nod and we both rush ahead. David wasn't even paying attention to us. He was in his zone. When I came close, I gather electricity on my hands. He finally saw our approach. Blake levitates straight at him with his Kuret grabbing David. David's Kuret flair in response and he tries to break out of the restraints. Unlike others, Blake was putting in more dense Kuret. David couldn't break it off completely.

I used this opportunity to get in closer with my palm raised to him. If I just come in contact with him, I can produce a small jolt current to knock him out. But before I could, David yells out aloud and his Kuret armor expands outwards. Shit. It was his dome. The dense Kuret comes in between me and him. And the pressure from the force made me stop my assault. David chuckles while stumbling a little. But unlike me, Blake thrusted forward and pushed David from behind.

He drags him from away from me and pushes him into the ground. I thought this would finally wake him up. But David wasn't even fazed by this. He says, finally. That’s was a crisp nine. Blakes puts a knee on his back and keeps him restraint, sorry David. But you are making it hard for us. David yells, I don't mind. But I prefer being stomped by her. What do you think, Vanessa. He has the gall to be sadistic while eyeing me. Blake then frantically pats himself on his jacket pocket, where the hell is it.

I realized he dropped the injector somewhere. I look around the place, but David's Kuret was blocking a lot of the vision. David laughs, I knew you were trying to kill my buzz. I knocked it out from your hand earlier. Good luck finding it now. This insane person. Even inhibited he was himself. I shout, guys. Find that injector. David clicks his tongue, nah. I am still enjoying this. You can't take away my fun. He raises his arms from the ground and snaps his fingers. It took a moment to understand what he did. But I was too late to do anything. I hear something being crushed.

Blake grabs David's head and pins him on the ground, what did you do. Even with his face mushed into the ground, I can hear his laughs. Suddenly the dense Kuret around him sucks back into David. The Kuret grabs Blake from behind and tried to pull him away. But Blake wasn't going to give in. He fueled his own Kuret to stop from being pushed back. He yells to others, someone get Drew. She must have another on of it. I rush towards Blake and gather ice around my palm.

David couldn't stop me from covering his back with my ice. The cool chill creates vapors on his body. Blake says, yeah. We will keep him immobilized like this. I nod and shout, where is she. Catherine shouts, I see her. Marina is running with Drew from the house. But that’s not all coming from the house. Two large figures appear behind Drew. They were 10 feet tall and slim. A moment later I realize they were robots. They had six arms on its torso and

a cubical shaped head. The bots were running on four legs like a spider. What the hell are they. The robots rush in ahead and began spraying a gas around us.

I didn't feel any Kuret mixed in the gas, so I think this is some sort of knockout gas. David felt it too. His voice rises, but he was not going anywhere when me and Blake are pinning him down. I thought it was finally over, but David wasn't done. He moves his Kuret around like a storm, creating a small hurricane. I let go of my icy grip and tried to counter my own wind tornado to stop his Kuret. But I didn't have time to build it strong enough. His Kuret slowly clears the gas around us.

I yell, Blake, just knock his ass out. He isn't going to stop. Blake was covers his Kuret on his arm for a blow to David's head. But Drew loud voices reaches us, don't hurt his head. You will do irreversible damage to him. Blake halts before he had a chance to throw down his hand. He yells, then what I do. Before Drew could answer, David found the opportunity when we are distracted. He gathers enough Kuret around him and drags away from below us. Blake grabs him with his Kuret. David threw a wave of Kuret at Blake and me. We both held our ground, but David used the force to propel himself away and creates some distance from us.

He uses his Kuret to support himself and stands up. His face is covered in dirt and blood. I think his nose was broken. He should be in pain, but he was having the time of his life. He was raised his arms in joy, yeah. This is great. I am finally enjoying the thrill of a fight. Don't you just love it. There is no reason to him anymore. Blake steps beside me. I ask him, any ideas. He shouts back at Drew, why can't we just knock him out. Drew wasn't listening to him though. She was speaking something to her tablet.

The bots behind her take a stand. All twelve arms pointed at David. Blake gestures me to clear out of the way. I step aside and let the robots do whatever they are doing. Marina had a charm running and pointed at David, make it fast, Drew. I sense he his loosing too much blood. Drew shouts, do it now M. The robots had some sort of dart guns attacked on their mechanical arms. David says, bring it on. The robots fire some small projectiles. But they never came in contact with David. His small Kuret dome was protecting him like a cocoon. The darts suspends in the air. David makes a show of plucking them from the air and says, this is a mediocre three.

Blake yells, Drew. She shrieks, I know, I know. The bots fired another round of darts at David. But none where doing anything. David begins to wobble a little. Like a drunk person. But he was still not going down. He says, woops. More blood pours from his eyes now. My fist tightens harder. This is no good. I can't just wait for him to bled out. I ran at him. Blake says, wait Vanessa. I didn't care. As much I am odds David right now, I don’t want him to die on me. I thought he would focus on me. But he turns his back and gazes into the ground.

The ground shook and a huge snake appeared from below. But before it could wrap itself around David, David already jumped into the air. He throws his Kuret around the snake and it gets pinned in the ground. David lands on top of the snack and gives a pose like he was climbing a mountain. He says, I give it a seven for ingenuity. The snake begins to transform back to Catherine. She had tried a sneak attack on David, but he saw her coming. Just how cognizant is he right now.

I rush faster with a fire ball ready. Instead of throwing a multiple smaller shot, I prepare to throw it like a flamethrower. It was a little extreme, but I need to stop him before he breaks down. David was focused on defending against the darts and pinning Catherine. He can't stop this. I throw my fire and it hits dead center in his Kuret dome. He was strong, but his focus was divided. The force was enough to push him away and he was flung into the air.

I shout, this is our chance. Blake was already on the move. So was Marina. They both flew to the robots and yanked their dart guns from their arms. They then flew back to us. David was now lying on the ground with his Kuret dome much smaller now. This fire was strong enough to burn him. But he was still laughing. He says, that’s was a twenty. Awesome. Its a shame we never fought in the tournament. He uses his Kuret to get up. I went into check on a coughing Catherine. I slouch down and help her up.

She was half naked since she had to ditch her clothes to transform. She had covered herself in violet fur to hide her skin. I ask, you good. She gives me a subtle nod, forget about me. Just stop him. David walks towards with slow steps. He was gathering his Kuret behind him, like a raging fire in wind. I can't believe he is this reckless. Marina just said he is loosing blood. But the currently insane David was enjoying the battle. He says, bring it on guys. I am loving this.

He gathered more of his Kuret around him and it becomes the armer we wore earlier. Blake and Marina zip past us through the air and in a synchronous attack push through his defense. David had no chance of stopping this. They both easily broke through his Kuret defense and grab him. Blake went low to grab his legs and Marina went for his waist. Together they drag David backwards, straight towards were are cars were parked. They crash into the nearest one and it gets crushed under the pressure. I feared a gas tank explosion so I ran behind them.

I immediately prepare ice in my hand and wave it behind them. I shower the cars with my icy wind as I wave my palm around. I didn't see any fuel leaking. But I still kept showering my ice around as a precaution. Blake stabs David on his thing with a dart and Marina stabs another on his neck. David eyes were covered in so much blood he had closed it. Yet he was grinning. He says, that was a hundred. You guys rock. He then winces in pain, I will get you next time.

They both let him go as he slumps on the distorted metal car frames. Marina slaps his cheeks lightly, there is no next time you crazy jerk. David finally stops his movement and his Kuret retreats back into him. His voice comes out like a whisper, this feels great. Blake says, you are out of your mind. He replies, pain is good. Means I am alive. Just what happened to him. Finally his Kuret goes away completely. He was barely clinging to his consciousness now. He mumbles, I told you Wagner, I will be better than you.

What is he dreaming about. I know its inappropriate time, but I needed to know. I ask, what do you mean. Wagner? He says, that guy sucks. I prefer her sister. What is he even saying. But I couldn't get anything more from him. He is finally succumbs to the sedative and is unconscious now. Marina yells, we should get to him to the hospital. Blake says, how are they going to help him. This seems completely different kind of problem. Marina yells, we can't just let him bleed. Behind us Drew runs. She struggles while running. Did she hurt during the explosion.

Siera came from the side and helped her. She approaches us, give me second. We give her space to check on David. She waves a device around David's face. She asks, M. Hurry. M says, scanning complete. He has a concussion. The sedative is working, its coagulating his blood vessels. I didn't understand the meaning, however Drew lets out a relieved sigh. She then lightly pats a sleeping David chest. She the continues waving the scanner around his neck and other body parts.

Blake asks, mind telling us what the freak just happened. I ask, he wasn't even himself anymore. Marina add, I have never seen anyone enjoy himself while bleeding from every orifice in his face. Others finally catches up to us. Catherine collected her clothes and walks with Matt and Cass. Cass asks worried, what did you to him. Drew was more focused on completing her inspection. M says, boss has 3 cracked ribs, a hairline fracture in left arm and a cracked femur bone. No internal bleeding.

I ask, what about his bleeding outside? Just look at his face. Drew says, he is going to be fine. We made it in time. She stand up slowly. Blake grabs David slowly from the crushed car. He uses his Kuret to make sure David doesn't fall. I ask, careful. Blake says, I got him. But what do I do with him now. Drew says, take him to the basement. He has a nano bot tank there. I grab the other side of David around my shoulder. We both carry him back to his house. Marina asks, what went wrong with the treatment. He behaved like he was high on some drugs.

Now that the David's rampage is over, she finally tells us, he was actually high. This was a side effect I didn't anticipate. I know it looks like a disaster. But it wasn't a failure. It was a success.

David (Chapter 97)

Wednesday, February 18, 2026 11:11

This is your brilliant idea. I thought she was just messing with me. But her stern face told she was not messing with me. My jaw hangs loose, you want me to do acid. And this, I point to another beaker kept on the table, this looks like shrooms. This is your radical and experimental treatment. Sorry to break your bubble, but this is sort of thing many humans already do. Sometimes more than a few times in a day. She sighs, you really think it that's simple. I face down on the other vials. They were giving different glimmers and few are probably chemical compounds that are harmful to humans.

She says, I didn't say it was ingenuous. I said it was untested because this brew of psychedelics don't work on Medrones and Humans will definitely die after an OD. You are in rare thin zone where we might have a possibility of unlocking your subconscious. I gulp a little trying to wrap my head around it. I grab a beaker and analyze the blue gel, and what is this. Doesn't seem like a typical consumable drug. She answers, a formulae that will lit up your amygdala, the part of the brain that. I answer, controls emotions and responses. She nods, that's right. But more importantly, processes fear too.

I put it back on the table. I felt a little anxious facing my own fears. She picks up her tablet, the drugs will lower your mental guard. The subconscious prevents you to look at your self objectively. We are going to break through that and I will guide you in REM sleep through the maze, which is your mind. I hesitantly ask, so technically this is a deep hypnosis visual memory therapy, but for a Medrone. She is a little impressed by my insight, looks like some has been doing their homework. She points me to the display screens we setup around us, it's called a deep trance. Ideally, it is aided with just vision, sound and sense. But you are different.

I say, because of my Medrone nature. She says, that's a part of it sure. But I am talking about your brain ability's to process thoughts. I say, you can just its because I am a genius. She smirks, I was talking in terms of biology and physiology, but sure. Yeah, your neurons faster than average Medrones. And as you already guessed it, it also means your subconscious will not make it easy to uncover the crux of your memories. I get what is happening now. I answers, those drugs are going to inebriate me enough that I my brain will not wake me up. She says, exactly. We need your neural activity to get low, but not too low.

I look around the bunch of injections she setup earlier from the vials. I say, I am guessing the risk is this massive amount of drugs. She picks up one injector device, I had to work up a balance of psychedelics and make it safe for you to consume. However, as I have been saying. Its completely unprecedented. I am good at this stuff, but not that good to anticipate what kind of side effects it will have. In worst case you will OD and suffer a brain stroke. I take the couch prepared for me and sat in it nervously.

I look around the equipment she had with her, an EKG, a neural activity scanning using a modified live MRI and a blood dialysis machine. The last one is to probably to regulate the amount of drugs in my system. I finally grasp the severity of this situation. This is not a novel treatment, but a different process. Drew designed it specifically for me. I sigh, you know, I told everyone I had faith in you. But I am a little terrified now. She says, its perfectly natural. I would be worried if you aren't scared. You should be wary of the risks.

It took a few minutes for me to think this through, but I had no choice. I already decided to see through whatever this was. I say, lets get started then. She takes a seat beside me, you sure. Once we start, there is no turning back. We only got one shot to do this. Dozing such heavy synthesized into your bloodstream more than once will negatively effect your heart and kidney. The damage from this one session can be reversed in time, but only once. Suffice to say there will be no do over. She made sure I understand the risks. My confidence is waring like a needle in a campus that has lost its directions. I gave her weak nod regardless of my hesitance.

She says, I got the patients consent. She grabs the blue gloves and puts it on. With dexterous movements she begins to mix in the compounds into a single beaker. While she did that I hooked up myself with bunch of wired sensors around my head where she had marked my skin. M says the nano sensors inside my body will not be able to accurately function with copious amount of drugs in my veins. So need to attach physical sensors. A majority of them are on my face and temple. I removed my shirt and place few on my chest and abdomen. Drew says, keep that here. She points me at the exact position. I say, but that's not my heart. That's probably.

She answers, your lungs. Unlike Humans, your lungs functions differently. I need to monitor that much closely. I don't know if its possible, but your brain might forget how to breathe. If that ever happens, I will manually inflate with air. Besides, we need to monitor your heart more closely. She pulls out a long, thin needle with a device attached at the other end. I make a scowl, don't tell that is going where I think it is. She nods, unfortunately yes. I need more than just your heartbeats. I will stick this through one of your valve. I never imagined it had to be this invasive.

And now it makes sense why she brought straps with her. She was going to restrain me in the recliner chair so that I don't jerk around and tear an artery or a vein in my heart. I sigh, do me a favor. Stick that after I am buzzed. I don't want to see it sticking it out of my chest. She smiles, don't worry. I can't do this while you are awake anyways. It will hurt. My stomach feels colder imagining it piercing my heart. But I had to tough it out. She rubs a gel around me and puts some more sensors on my torso.

She says, all done. She brings up a beaker and holds it in front of me. This isn't what she was mixing. I ask, what is this green liquid. She says, a rejection suppression booster. You have a transplanted heart, don't you. Doing hardcore pharmaceuticals is already risky, but doing this is on a transplanted patient is dangerous. This will help with maintaining your heart. I am curious though, its been years since the operation. And I been through much worse than doing drugs. Why do think it will cause an issue.

She takes a moment to her herself. She then says, honestly. You are right. Your heart is yours now. But I found some irregularities in your x-rays this week. I lean my head back up, seriously, like what. I have been taking care of my health this whole year. And M never said anything about it. She says, I don't know what it is. But the cardiomyocytes have unnaturally high fibroblasts. Now, its entirely possible it was necessary during that operation. I says, I know I am not a heart surgeon, but I read up later that its not really a bad thing. She says, neither am I one. And yeah, it shouldn't cause a problem. In fact, I say your doner had a strong and healthy heart.

I recalled memories of Liz. I told Drew about her and she knows about the contrasting nature of her physiology. A weak body, but a strong heart. She says, still, a strong heart doesn't equate to strong resistance to drugs. This is a harmless precaution. I am only raising your tolerance with this. I lean back on my seat. I know she is covering all the bases, but this wasn't the best time to remind me of Liz. I ask, what were the chances if it was my actual heart. Less than ideal? She says, don't think like that. Not right now. We make hypothesis, not second guess ourselves. The one thing I learned from running and hiding on Earth. You can't control everything. You do what you are dealt with.

I take her advice and the beaker. I raise it to her, well, here's to taking control to what I can. I drank it without thinking about the taste, which was horrible. I chugged it all the way before any gag reflex kicks in. I cough a little putting the empty glass away, you couldn't inject me this instead. She chuckles, I could have. But its better for your body to not absorb it immediately. She speaks to her tab, M, you are on. M says, starting the timer. I am guess they are going to time it so that the effectiveness is at its peak.

She finishes her final preparations with the drugs, I say, you know. This is my first time doing acid or weed. I make a nervous laugh seeing her fit a small vial into a injector. She places it beside the table. She then setups the monitoring devices. While booting them she says, really? That's surprising. Given your long stretched history of hospitalization, it wouldn't be unreasonable to think you got hooked on it. I answer, I never enjoyed the numbness. I tried as much less morphine I could have. Around the second year, I began researching the same statistics you summarized. I had no intension of becoming a junkie.

She laughs, bold move from a small kid. I reply, I didn't have my memories, but I was still trained tactically. She says, that makes sense. The rumors of shadow training are intriguing. I know where she was going with this. I say, I hope you are not drugging me to get info out of me. She gives me a sly smile, the thought did occur to me once. She places a metallic ring around my forehead, the one to monitor my neural activity. She says, but don't worry. The whole goal of this is to make you cognizant enough to talk through the memory. And even though you want to change your habit of keeping secrets, we aren't talking about sharing private thoughts.

She was implying something else too. I think she meant about the people I still haven't told her about. I told her about Wagner, Brandon and Zakerine. But not about John, Hansen, Istra, Slater or the other Shadow personals. Maybe even about my feelings towards a certain angry girl. She caught me looking worried. She says, I know its uncomfortable. I will try not to intrude too much. However. I nod, there is good possibility I will slip up and tell you things. She lays her arms on her knees, I won't deny that. But we are way past that point. I hope I have enough of your trust from spending these months together.

I sigh, not like I have a choice. And I am sorry for making you complicit. When I say the wrong thing, I don't want you to be responsible for it in anyway. She puts her arm on my elbows, I appreciate your concerns for me. But I completely aware of what I signed up for. I know the risks, so don't have to worry about me. She pauses for a second, I used to believe that you would definitely cause problems for me. But thanks to you, I have recognized that I can't really change myself. I like being a doctor. I hesitantly ask, and is that a good thing? She nods, it is. But enough about me. You focus on just yourself now. I can't deny she has been invaluable to me.

She takes my arm and wraps a hard rubber band around my biceps. Near the joint she finds a vein. She taps my skin few times. With a slow movement, a needle gets pricked in that spot and blood starts to pour out into the tube. She says, you barely reacted to it. I answer, I have a lot of experience with needles, unfortunately. She turns towards the display, M, start us off with the phase one. M says, need confirmation from boss. She picks up the injector from the table and waits for my call.

I close my eyes and settle my thoughts. I have tried to suppress all the different kind of emotions I have been going. The argument with Vanessa and the guilt of lying to her. I have been purposefully keeping it aside, but I can feel it consuming me again. I focus on my breathing. I can't tell how long I took to settle, but Drew was patient with me. She was sitting beside me, not moving a muscle and letting me do my thing. I was grateful for that. I get my courage back, do it.

M says, phase one initiated. The lights go off around me and it turns dark for a second. Drew puts on her goggles which had a display in it to track my vitals and share any readings. Drew says, this is your last chance. She places the injector near my neck. She waits till I assure her of this. I start breathing hard with my mouth and I gave a nod to her. She takes that sign and pushes the needle to my skin. Upon contact a warm and strange shiver went down my spine. I can't tell if its from the cocktail of drugs or just nerves acting up.

She pulls it away, its going to be administered in intervals. We can't risk introducing foreign substances in large quantities. She uncorks the empty vial and replaces the empty one with a new one. I didn't feel any difference, but that's because it hasn't travelled everywhere. She says, we are going to start with slow biaural sounds to relax. She picks up a different injector, this is a mild melatonin. It will help you sleep better with the drugs in your system. She doesn't delays it and injects it on my other neck.

This one I was familiar with and begin feeling the effects immediately. In few minutes my eyes becomes heavy. The sound of sea and other natural earth elements makes my drowsy. Few seconds in, I didn't even realize my eyes were close. I was only hearing and imagining the slow hums of whales or the rain drops in a forest. Soon I was drifting off. I was nowhere now. Everything around me was pitch black, but I didn't feel scared. There was lingering doubts, but I was more relaxed.

Then I hear a voice. A muffled voice that I didn't pay any attention to. But then it grew louder. Its calling a name out in the abys. I couldn't ignore it. Who was it. The voice becomes much clear after a second, David. Can you hear me. The voice jarred me out the trance. I floating body formed a shape and also a voice. Who, I grumble. She says something about phase two. Then my surrounding changes from black to bright. Shades of red and orange. The peaceful noise I was hearing slowly turns into something different. I wanted to go back, but the voice telling me to move ahead. I didn't want to go anywhere, but then I hear sound of fire. Then came noises of things crumbling.

No. Not this. I had on idea where I am, but I could feel myself resisting. The voice says, don't resist. I mumble, I don't want to go there. The voice says, you have nothing to worry about. Just follow my voice. I am here to help. The calm voice help me feel less agitated. And suddenly I am thrusted into a open air. My body feels heavy, like I falling down. I couldn't feel the wind, but I felt the heat. My surroundings take shape and I see blurry things. Like a thin veil around me is obstructing my view. The air is so thick, I feel like I could just grab it.

The voice says, where are you. Describe it to me. My environment is smoldering hot and fire everywhere. The voice says, follow that glow. See where you are. I vaguely felt having a body. But I needed my legs to move. Instantly I felt my legs moving. I suspiciously move around to inspect my surrounding. I saw blue sky, red sky and then dust clouds. Where is this place. A mouth appears on me, I ask, where on Earth am I. Then comes noises of strange animals. Their blurry visions appear in front of me.

Those noises, I heard them before. The voice says, yes. You know where you are. Just say it. A moment later I spoke aloud, Medrine. Everything comes crashing down on me. The blurry image becomes clear and I see streets on fire and trees destroyed. My close my eyes to avert from the destruction. The voice says, don't avoid them. You have to go somewhere. Where is it. Find it. I am so confused, where am I supposed to go. I look around the abandoned street. I recall this road, this city, this planet.

Another wave hits me and I fall down. But I was still standing. This doesn't makes sense. And then everything does, Drew? Her voice comes, yes. David, I am here. I stumble around my shaky surrounding, like I was being dragged in different directions. She says, focus on one thing. Don't get distracted by anything else. I put all my will into one thing, the place I need to go to. Then another wave hits me and pushes me down. But I am standing again, like it never fell down. What is going on.

I say, this is dream. I am dreaming right now. Drew says, good, I thought I lost you for a second. You took a lot of time to remember me. That made me recall everything happening. I mumble, I am not in Medrine. I am on Earth, my house. She says, you are in both place at once. That's not possible. But everything is real around me. Like the fire in that alley, I think I might get burned if I walk past it. Drew says, don't go there. That's your subconscious fighting back. Using your memories to scare you. Don't give in. Just look for the place.

I ask, what place. She replies, the place where it all began. You know where. I tried hard to recall. But I couldn't. She says, that's fine then. Look around you, you will have clues. Clues, huh. This is a dream. Yeah, it makes sense. Actually, no. It really doesn't. But I had no choice. I began lazily walking around the empty road. The debris were all around me, trying to block my path. I had to zig zag my way through it. Drew says, good, you are slow but fast learner. Don't let anything stop you.

I felt encouraged and pushed through. But then a huge tsunami was coming for me. What the hell, I am not anyplace near the shore. Drew didn't advice me on anything. Did she left me alone. I decided to run into a building nearby and take cover beside a pillar. An insane amount of water gushes out into the street and begins to slips inside the building too. I panic and ran inside further. I don't know what this building is. I couldn't even focus on it, but I could vaguely sense the direction. I ran straight ahead until I saw a staircase. I jump on it and began climbing up. The water races behind me, trying to catch me and sweep me away.

Drew was still not with me. But I no longer cared now. I just focused on climbing up. Soon I exited through the top door. I rush out into the open sky and look around. The water tried to seep out, but I pushed the door close before it escapes. I ran around the place looking for any escape, but I couldn't focus on anything. It felt it the scene in front of me is breaking. What's happening. A muted voice looms in the air. I cry out, Drew? Her suppressed voice comes, can you hear me.

I felt relieved to know she was still with me. Want happened, why did she leave. Drew says, your subconscious is pretty stubborn. Its not allowing you to even move freely. I had to adjust the dosage. I recalled what was going on. I recalled that I was being drugged. But for what. Drew says, don't focus on it. Focus on going ahead. But I am stuck on the terrace. There is water everywhere. Hold on. If this is my dream, then I should be able to control everything. Just like that the air around me fixes and the image becomes clear.

Suddenly I am standing on the road again, but there is no flood. The tsunami is gone. Drew says, how do you feel now. I say, darn frustrated. I can't believe I did ran up a building for nothing. She replies, not nothing. You are fighting back, taking control. That's good. I continue walking the debris covered road. I don't have to find a way around it. I just will it and all the broken building parts just vanishes. With nothing to bother me anymore, I cut through the path much easier.

Another obstacle came, a rain of glass shard showers from the above. I try to make it go poof, but it doesn't do anything. The pieces of glass becomes bigger. I needed my Kuret. Wait, why did I say that. What's that. The haze in my head, it feels important. But my immediate problem were the glasses. Then I had an idea, if I can't remove the glass. I can visualize other things. I raise my hands, which became more real to me and I create an umbrella.

It was a weird looking umbrella, it was made purely of black substance. It feels familiar, but I didn't know what it was. The shards fall on me, but I remain unhurt from it. Drew says, well done. Only you would be testing out the defenses of your dream. But a piece of advise. The more you try to control, the harder the fight will be. So look for a middle ground. I felt more of myself now. I continued walking while the pieces of glasses continue to rain on me. But where I am going. The place I need to be. What if I am too far from it. Drew says, this is you dream. Distance means irrelevant. You have looked around, now visualize where you need to be.

I focus on the escaping memories. I can feel I am close. But where. Then a large object approaches in the sky. It makes a big shadow on the ground. Its flying in the sky. The rain stops and my black umbrella vanishes. But now I am facing a grey ship. Its so familiar that I almost can tell what it was. A sense of dread swells up in me. Its them. Drew says, did you find them. I say, it's the Hive. I ran without thinking. I forget all about the sense of direction. The only thing what matters is to get away from here.

But this wasn't a dream. It was a nightmare. Turns out any direction I choose, I am heading straight towards the ship. The ship descends down and few people jump onto the ground. They were wearing some grey metal suit with a gun on each arm. Oh shit. The five people began firing at me. Duck down and cover my head with my arms. The terror grips me hard and I am immobilized. I can't move anymore. Drew says, David. They aren't real. You don't need to fight this. No way I they aren't real. I don't know what to do.

She says, then fight them. You have been fighting them for years. You know their weakness. I have no idea where she is getting her information. I have never fought them. I crouch down even deeper now, like the ground is burying me alive. I can't to this. I am too afraid. Drew was trying to encourage me. But her voice was getting buried with me. This is it. I am going to die. But then suddenly I am thrown back into the air. The next second I am hugging the ground like a caterpillar. I hear a barrage of noise piercing the air above me.

What the hell is going on. I cover my own ears. But my ears were not covered, my hand just goes through it. The noise becomes clear by the second. Its a sound of a machine gun. I peek my head up and see the Hive being pushed back from the hail of bullets. They were firing their own pulse guns at something at my side. The white smoke covers the ground above. As a lone figures appear from it. The long barrel of the machine gun was creating the white smoke.

The person appears in front of me. A completely new emotion comes from me. Confusion of the highest level. The person grins at me, are you going to lie there whole day. Come on. Get up. Its him, its James. He gives extends an arm to me. I was hesitant to take it. He says, hurry up. I don't have enough bullets and you don't have enough lives. I shake off the haziness keeping me down and take his arm. He pulls me up. His face becomes clear. The same stub beard, the same scar on his neck. Eyes that had such hate for aliens. What the hell is going on.

He says, who the hell knows. I am just glad I finally get to kill aliens again. And with so many around, I think I am going to enjoy this. I say, you are dead. He says, tsk, why does that matter. This is nuts. I called for Drew. But there was no response. What the hell happened. Where is she. He says, no one's going to rescue you if we stand here in open. Come on, lets move. He ditches the machine gun and grabs me by my collar. I didn't know I had a collar. I turn down and look at my dress. Its the same as that day. The blood stain on my jacket was there too.

He says, yeah, you remember now. He drags me out of the road we somehow end up in an abandoned half broken building. He leaves my collar and I stumble back to a wall. He smiles as he sees a crate in the middle of them room. He opens the tarp and inside was large cache of weapons. He begins to grab whatever he could. He then finds his favorite shotgun and begins loading the shells. I am bamboozled at this scene. He says, sweet. We got everything now. I couldn't stay silent now, you are dead. I watched you die. He suddenly aims that weapon at me, you mean how you killed me.

I get angry, I didn't kill you. He laughs, that's right. You like specifics. He lowers his weapon and resumes packing up his weapon in his pockets. He says, you didn't save me. Instead you saved the other people. I says, the people you almost blow up. You couldn't let go your revenge. He raises a bazooka on his shoulders, psst. That's ancient history. Besides, I am here now. Ready to whoop some alien ass. This is nuts. I realized something. My dream, my memories and my imagination.

He laughs, correct. You called me to help you. Be happy, I get to save you sorry ass again. I can't believe he was my choice. What was I thinking. He picks up a grenade belt, look at you being choosy. What a hot shot you have grown into. But to me you are still that clueless kid. I grit my teeth, speak for yourself. My freaked up brain decided to take his help. There must be a reason. I walked to the weapon create and begin looking for guns. I found the grenade launcher and the tactical rifle gun. Its the same, the exact same I used when I went raiding with James in that Hive hideout.

He says, this brings back memories. You remember those days. You and me, going around, kicking doors and killing Hives. I remember them now. Its weird how clear those memories are now. Its feels like it were just yesterday when we were bombing the bridge to stop the Hive in the helicopter. James laughs, now that was a good one. That the was moment when I believed our team is going to clean up the city. But then I recalled what happened next. I grab a pistol, if only you weren't consumed by blind rage. You could have saved a lot of people that week.

He loads up his bazooka with a large shell, you know me. I wasn't going to ever help you once I realized you were one of the aliens. I picked up some grenades, then why help me now. I have grown farther away from a Homo Sapiens as possible. You words, if you remember. He chuckles, don't I know it. He stuffs a box of bullets in his belt buckle. He replies, I don't know, maybe I want to try a different way. My hands freeze. I spat, seriously. It took dying for you to try this way. He smiles saying, don't think I am getting soft on you. I don't like any alien. But, he hands me a box of bullet, you are probably the least irritating and tolerable alien.

This is surreal. I know he is just a figment of my imagination. But still, it gives me some twisted sense of empowerment. Besides, I know the real James would never say this stuff. He says, it doesn't matter what he do. The guy died and now is reborn. Wow, my subconscious has morbid sense of humor. He says, but that doesn't mean you can't wish for it. He made some sense. I know what kind of person he was. If it weren't for him, I would have died back then. He shakes his head, never thought I would have to save you again. Can't a guy remain dead in peace.

For the first this thing started, I had a laugh. I say, for you, peace is overrated. I unlock the rifles safety. He grins and give me big smile. He slams his hand on his shotgun, damn straight. Now you are like yourself. Perhaps that's why he is here. To remind me of that and also give me the support. When he was alive he was rude, obnoxious, and held dangerous ideologies. But he was also dedicated, focused and fueled by unshakable determination. The quality I need to need remember.

He pulls a bag out of nowhere and says, stop it. You are being way too sappy. So, are we doing this or not. I replied, freak yeah. I imagined a bag on my shoulders and it appeared. I hug my rifle on the shoulder and grab the grenade launcher. We both instantly transport to a front door. He kicks it open and a fire breaks out. I shout, what's the play. He says, there is a battalion coming from the south and east. We are going to west. You are going to be on my six. And cover the tail. Got it.

It felt good to have him here. We ventured out in a hailstorm of bullets. We both began firing at our targets. A Hive in grey suit and a knives was coming at me. I aimed the launcher at his face and blasted him off. The Hive vaporizes on impact. There were a whole army behind it. But I wasn't scared anymore. I began firing on the crowd while dodging the return fires. The heat from their blasts grazes my body. It should have hurt, but it felt nothing. Its a dream, nothing can hurt me. With that unshakable truth me and James made a run to the west.

We threw grenades, and even reloaded our guns as our assault grew over time. It was crazy that I was reminiscing this feeling. A Hive suddenly came out of nowhere. James grabs me by the arms and drags me down before the blasts hits me. He says, don't just stand looking pretty. Get you head in the game. One wrong move and you are dead. I smile and nod, while also realizing the ridiculousness of the situation. He levels his bazooka on the ground, aimed towards a low level flying cruiser. The missile hits the target and it crashes down in ball of fire.

He removes his pistol and open fires on the Hives coming at from the side. He waves his arm around yelling, hell yeah. This is what I wanted. I am glad you brought me to your planet. Its a open buffet and the main menu are these freaker. He aims his shotgun at two Hives approaching us. His passion is infectious and I begin to feel the allure of it. The strength and the power. I pull out a machine gun from the bag and open fire on another troops of Hive coming with a daggers. James yells, that’s it. Now you get it. You seem to have become complacent and forgotten your killer instinct.

It finally clicks together. This is why he is here. To remind of that. We continue firing on the squad and crushing them. Our approach was steady but gradual. We were heading somewhere, but I can't tell where. He scoffs, get a grip man. We don't have infinite bullets. Where are we heading. I look around the place. I remember this area. Its familiar. Then another invisible wave goes through me. And I remembered. I say, we need to go towards the shore. There are some people I need to see.

He laughs, awesome. You are taking me to more aliens to kill. But that’s when I realized the futility of this particular mission. As I take down another batch of Hive I say, James, I am grateful for you help. But. He cuts him off, I know. Me being there with you will be make it difficult for you. It was frustrating that I couldn't take him with me. But there's no point, he would get in my way. Even as my imagination, he will always be an alien killer. I don't want to change that about him. He laughs laughing when launching another missile at a cruiser.

He cries, damn right. I won't change. I don't need to. But you have still some soul searching to do. So here's what I will do, he points to the corner, I am going to the opposite way and you head in. I say, but that place is miles away. I still need backup. He slaps me on the back and pushes me ahead, you don't need me anymore. I have done my job. And besides, you are damping my moment by being so damn emotional. He was right I was feeling sad and depressed. He pulls out his grande buckle and chucks it towards a group of Hive.

He runs away to a white smoke again. His laugher carries in the air, I am coming for you all. Get ready. It was a funny yet sentimental scene. James was dying in life and always had a death wish. But he wanted to do this always. Even if all this was imaginary, he was providing cover for me. I didn't waste this opportunity and ran to the corner. Hives were popping up from everywhere, but I was gunning them down with my riffle. Even though I know that these are ineffective in real life, it was enough here. It was a homage to James, the fearless guy who was there when I needed him.

As soon as in turns around the corner, my scene changed and fell flat on the ground. My bag and guns were gone. So were my clothes. I was wearing something different that I can't recall from where. I get back up and inspect my surrounding. This is the place, yeah. I saw this countless times in my nightmares. The place were they all died. A voice zaps through me, David. Can you hear me. I ask, Drew. She makes a relieved sound, what happened. I lost you there.

This is really a dream. I say, I got lost. But a friend reminded me how to fight back. Drew says, James got through to you. That’s a relief. I didn't think you recognized his photo. I ask confused, what photo. She says, don't worry about it. Are you there yet? I look around the place. I say, yeah. I am here. She asks, and who are there with you? I know whom she is referencing, but there something really strange going on. I run around the plaza, but I can't believe what I am seeing. Or rather not seeing.

Drew asks, what's going. The air feels heavy and feel like I am drowning in confusion. I answer, I don't see anyone here. There are no bodies.

David (Chapter 98)

Wednesday, February 18, 2026 16:53

I probably ran around the place twice and found no one. Its strange, I know I have seen them here hundreds of time. How did they leave. Drew says, are you sure you don't see them. Maybe you can't focus on them yet. I yell, they aren't here. And I know this is dream, or a nightmare. Or something in between. So what exactly am I missing here. I looked under the bridge, inside the burning buildings, and even under water in the beach. But they have just vanished. It left I have spend days searching for any clues. But my stupid consciousness wasn't giving me any.

There were no blood trails, or any drag marks. How in the freak the bodies moved. Drew says, your subconscious is you. Its clever. You didn't want to find the bodies and relieve those traumatic moment. So you moved the bodies. How the hell does that makes sense. I am trying to find something I don't want to find. That makes this whole thing a big joke. Drew says, there has to be something. Some way to find them. Your ego can't just do something you can't. You must have a way.

I wave my arm around in anger. I can't believe how much mad I am at myself. That actually makes sense if I think about it. If Drew said what is true, then I think the effectiveness of this trance is weakening. I am being more aware of myself. Drew says, that is true. That last detour burned through a bit of the haziness. Its probably why the bodies I was sure of was here were moved and there are no clues. I have been at this for hours, or at least feels like its been hours.

Then another wave hits me, toppling me on my back, but somehow I fall on my stomach. And the same time I was standing. The air becomes hazy again. Drew says, how do you feel now. I couldn't recall what happened. I was brought here with James, but then, What did I do. Drew says, you are exactly where you need to be. Find the people. There have to be clues. I followed the voice and looked for the missing people. I don't know why, but I feel I have already searched everywhere.

Then I step on something. A small piece of cloth I didn't notice before. It had a strange insignia. Feels important all of a sudden. Drew said about clues, is this it. She says, yes. That’s it. Remember where you have seen it. Go there. I try to pick up the cloth, but my hands pass though it. What's going on. I try to grab it again, but it feels like it wasn't real. Like this is a dream. Wait, it is really a dream. Then I can just imagine it. As I did, the cloth begins to fly into the air. I chase after it, its leading me somewhere. Drew says, follow it.

It felt like I have been chasing the cloth for hours, maybe even days. But I couldn't catch it. And I think its leading me in circles. This makes no sense. Where am I. I realize I am back again where I started. Its so damn frustrating. The cloth was flying just out of my reach and its been mocking me. Suddenly the cloth wraps me by the neck and try's to strangle me. What the hell, I couldn't breathe and struggle trying to remove the cloth from my neck. Drew says, its not real. Its not chocking you.

The hell it isn't real. Its on my neck. Then it was around my heart suddenly, crushing me from inside. I felt like I was dying. Just what kind of cloth is this, first making it chase me around and then suddenly trying to kill me. My hearts about to be crushed. I need help. But Drew's voice was again softening, becoming muted. That’s just great, I lost her again. The cloth of death kept trying to chock my neck and heart. Someone help me. I then hear a clack of metal and my chest tore open.

I thought I was done for, but the cloth torn itself into pieces and someone stands in front of me. A women was standing with a crutches on her left arm. I gasp for air trying to breathe. The woman says, come on David. You are not losing oxygen. That just your fear. That voice. I know that. It was unmistakable. It was her, Liz. I sigh and stand up, so its you now, huh. Great, I look up at the sky and scream out, freak you. You are one twisted guy. Liz pats me on the shoulder, you know you are talking to yourself.

I turn to her, doesn't mean I am wrong. She was wearing the same dress the day she died in. Her right arm had black skin, the poison that killed her. Her hair, still messy the way it was earlier. She smiles, I thought I told you stop being reckless with your life. And here you are almost dying again. I say, this time I am not trying to self destruct. She scoffs, oh I know. She points her crutches end to the torn clothe pieces, that was killing you. I couldn't deny that. What the hell I do want with myself. She says, that’s a great question. But why I am here though, I thought I was done saving your life.

I look down to my shirt and it had a whole in it. I am missing my heart. Liz says, ah yeah, I am here aren't I? That’s my heart that you just tried to crush. I gave it to you so can live. And you just tried to kill yourself, again. So I think I'll keep it away for the time being. I smile. I missed her. Even though I remember her, its been long and I have sort of forgotten her face. It makes me feel guilty. She puts her hand on my chin, don't be. Its natural you want would want to forget. You went to war for me. That was more than enough to honor my memories.

I felt even more guiltier. I didn't kill Nathan because of her. And yet I felt I was led astray by her too. She says, hey. You already forgave yourself. So don't revert back to that moody person looking for revenge. You saw James now, didn't you. It wasn't just a reminder you to keep fighting. It was a warning. To fight for the right reasons. I guess that’s why she is here now. To remind of that again. She pulls her hand back, maybe. She looks around the empty plaza. She gets suddenly excited, so this is the famous Medrine, huh.

She has only seen pictures before. But this in this fantasy, she is with me, here. I grab her hand and point her to the bridge, remember that. She says, oh. Yeah. That was the engineering marvel people were talking about. Said to be 300 years old. I say, 290. And it stood tall until the end. She says, that’s incredible. The next moment, we were instantly teleported in the middle of the bridge, standing at the railing. There should have been wind, but all I felt was woozy. Liz grabs my hand tightly, easy there. We can't have you tripping out yet. Too late, I am tripping on acid. She laughs at my joke.

This is reminiscent of the time I visited her in her room. Telling stories to each other. Her being in my head again is weird. But this time, she wasn't appearing as a hallucination. I am in one. She says, rude. You saying I am not real. I grip her hands tighter, hoping she wouldn't care regardless. She says, I don't. She grabs my arm and enjoys the view. We were now walk around the bridge, and it felt good. It felt like we were on a date. She scoffs, date. Jeez, you are being way too needy right now. I haven't been with anyone since she died.

She stops to laugh at me. This is incredibly weird and inappropriate. I am basically laughing at myself. She says, you know that’s sad right. You are a celebrity now. What's stopping you now. I am sure there are many girls crushing on you now. I say, yeah. Well, I am looking at only one special girl. She turns to me, please don't say its that Sophie girl again. You need to move on. How long are you going to hung up on her. Yeah, I don't think I have any shot with her. I killed her dad and she is actively hunting me. She feels nothing, and yet she has enough emotion to have a grudge. I think that’s a pretty big hint and that ship has sailed away.

She says, good. You deserve better. I don't know about that. I can't remember her name, but I know someone I have hurt terribly. She says, wow, look at you. You already moved on. She is enjoying watching me squirm. But that’s how she was. Living her life to the fullest, all the till her last breadth. She then says, guh. Enough about this depressing thoughts. I am actually envious that you lived on Medrine. I am a little mad too. It feels like you betrayed me. I thought we commiserate over our shared past as MAR's subject. But turns out that while I was frozen and sleeping on Earth for a century, you were living here.

I scoff, living here? I would have preferred to live on Earth with you all. This planet might be were my parents lived, but I was born on Earth. That’s my home. She sighs, home, huh. Its a difficult to say what home is really. She becomes forlorn, remember I used to believe the Valley could be a home. Then when you promised to take me away. If her plan was to make me feel guilty and resentment, mission accomplished. She says, its fine. Its all in the past. I am just reminiscing. I looked at her other arm. I don't understand why she has crutches. If this my imagination, why keep her in pain.

She chuckles, always so considerate of me. Even now. But don't need to be. You are the only successful MAR's kid. You should be proud of it. I lean on the railing. Be proud of something so messed up. I don't think so. The most I can be is grateful that I am living. She leans her head on my shoulders, that’s good enough too. We stay here for hours, days. It feels like eternity and at the same time it was brief. In my confused thoughts I looked at the city which was burning. I tried to forget about it. But Liz says, don't. Ignoring it will not do any good.

I say, not ignoring it. Just delaying it. She lightly pokes at my chest, that’s also bad. Stop procrastinating and get a move on. She brings the piece of torn cloth from her palm. Was she carrying it with her this whole time. Its funny, it was trying to get away, and now its showing up in front of me. She says, we got a job to do. I ask, there is no we. I know I was being rude, but I know she isn't here. She flicks my forehead, that old thing again. Its been years you needed my help, but you are still the same.

She puts her hand on my empty hole in my chest, I, we or something else. Doesn't matter. We both are always here, she places her palm on my bare chest. The sad part of this nightmare is that I can't feel her touch. I am just imagining the warmth. She smiles, ghosh. You are being too sentimental. You need to relax and learn to be more trusting of yourself. She then turns to ocean and the city view, letting it soak it in one last time. She says, its not the last time. I am with you always, that means I can see this place all the time. There was no literal sense to this, just a poetic one.

She turns back to me, its time I guess. I can't be a good role model if I keep delaying things like you. She steps a little closer to me and whispers, I hate to see you waste your life on just fighting. Try to get laid, will you. At least for me. What the freak kind of advice is that. She then reaches her fist straight into my chest. I get one last message, but don't ever forget your first. The scene in front my eyes changes I am now standing in the plaza again. I pat my chest for a hole. My hearts back in my body. What's more, the piece of cloth that was trying to kill me is in my fist now. Its not torn anymore, its back to its original form.

She had to make things weird for me. But maybe that’s what I am telling myself. I hear a voice now, David. Are you back. Its Drew. I guess this is going to be thing now. She says, did Liz help you out. I chuckle, she did more than that. Made me realize I have not been living to my fullest. Drew says, that’s good. Do you have the clue now. I look at the cloth. Seeing it up close I remember what it is now. Its the Shadow insignia. A wave of thin air and haziness sweep me. It consumed me.

The drowsiness hits me and fall straight down on ground. I felt the ground was hot and dirty. I look up and see the entrance to my old university's gates. My memories of it flow into me, I know where I have to go. Drew asks, can you reach there. I already began walking through the gate the next second. I say, those people weren't taken away. They moved back to the one place which was their home. Or at least the closest to it. That’s what Liz, or me, was talking about. Questioning what home is for a person.

Drew says, that’s where you will find others. It probably makes sense now why I chose this place. I am now roaming around the courtyard, garden and lecture halls. Then I reached my department. If I am right, Brandon should be here. I look into the chemistry lab, but I see no one. That’s strange. This where I spent so many time with him. I look around my old lab desk. But my things are gone. No, I have forgotten about them. Just have some vague memories of it.

Suddenly the building shakes and there is a loud explosion. I fall down on the floor and gets transported outside to the hallway. I see the ground was cracking open like an egg. I look up and see dozens of Hive approaching us. This is just what I needed, a hallucination of them trampling the university grounds. I run in a different way, but the cracks were following me behind. I jumped around the building, from stairs to corridors. Then from classroom to bathrooms. But the earthquake followed me like a snake.

I ran to the most logical place now, the headmasters office. Don't know why, but I felt safe there. I ran inside and shut the door. Thankfully nothing followed me behind. No quake, no Hive. I laid back on the door. I immediately jerk when I hear someone clearing their throat. It was Hansen and Branden. They both were sitting on the chair like nothing was happening. I am so confused, why are you here. Branden scoffs, you know this is our university too. I used to be a student here before a teacher. Hansen raises his hand, same here. I even had a brief stint has the headmaster.

With anxious steps I look around the place. Their gazes never left me as I peek outside the window. The university is on fire, literally. The building are breaking and the garden is torn apart. I turn back to the two people chilling nonchalantly. I blurt out, what the freaks going on. But I couldn't hear Drew's voice now. Great, she is offline again. Hansen says, I always knew therapy would do wonders for you. Great, a witty banter from my dead mentor. This had to be the worst kind of twist here.

Brandon says, since we have time to talk. Can I just say, I don't like you told my daughter about me and John. It paints me like a villain. Ah, I slump down on the corner tile. I say, really. There is a freaking war going on outside. And you want to talk like there is nothing going on right now. Hansen says, there is a war somewhere always. Didn't I taught you to savor the peaceful times in between. I wave my arm in reluctance, look. Its great to see you guys. But I am in pinch right now. There is a quake after me, chasing me like a freaking magnet. I need to get to the entrance of our HQ.

Brandon says, why the hurry. This is not real anyways. Breaking the forth wall already I see. I say, yeah well, I don't have full control. So pardon my urgency. Hanson says, interesting. I like your therapist. She has a good understanding of your state. I didn't need to be psychoanalyzed right now. Especially from a Hansen me. He laughs, that’s true. Its way too meta. Brandon says, that’s rude you know. We are fellow fallen Shadows, have some respect for us. I blurt out, I didn't say I didn't acknowledge you guys. I am just in a hurry to leave.

Branden says, you think its that easy to get rid of us. I say, look. I am sorry I told Catherine. Happy? I didn't tell her everything, did I. Besides, in time she would understand everything. Branden sighs, only when she has a child of her own. But even then I hope she never has to choose her children. She is mad at me, isn't she. I don't know why I am asking this myself. Of course she is mad at both him and me. I basically told her she was a backup and not the first choice. Kind of hard for anyone to forgive.

Branden says, I know. Its not your fault. But now I can't feel anything, but the shame. If he felt this, I did too. But there's nothing I can do about it now. That promise was creating a wedge between us. I was pressuring her stay away from Robb, which basically makes me just as guilty as Branden. Maybe even more. Brandon says, will she ever forgive us. I hope she does. Even though we are on speaking terms, I think she still resents me a little bit. I can't recall, but I kind of excluded her from something. And now she is doing something about it.

Branden laughs, that’s my girl. She has grown up to be a very beautiful and independent woman. I wish I get to meet her now. Tell her how much I am proud of her. How much I miss her. He faces me, will you tell her this. This had to be one most freaked up thing since I arrived here. My subconscious is asking me to convey a message from myself on behalf of her dead father. I think I just broke my own mind. Branden says, yeah. That really doesn't make sense does it. He gets up from his chair, at least tell her to be careful with her human boyfriend. She is my precious daughter. If he hurts her, you kill him, okay.

This is getting out of hand. He walks to me, I would have preferred she be with you. You are far better choice. Now its definitely weird and embarrassing. What am I saying to myself. Branden says, anyways. Make a different promise now. You won't interfere with her life again. I was more than happy to agree to it. He says, set her up with Blake if you she ever breaks up with her boyfriend. He will protect her in ways you can't. I think I am being rude to Catherine, Blake and Brandon, all three of them by having this conversation. Branden says, nah. Its all good. This is all, in your head in the end.

Just like that he steps out from the door. But before he leaves he says, I will stall the Hive a little longer. Best you find the entrance yourself. With that cryptic message he left. I turn to Hansen, what did he mean find the entrance. Isn't it near the. I forgot my words. This is strange. Where is the entrance. It was in this university. I am sure of that much. But I can't remember where. Hansen says, I guess we need find it. Don't we. Figures its his turn now. He stand up and helps me get up. Instead of taking the main door, we take the back door.

I don't remember this office room having a back door. The outside is a bright place instead of a room. We were now in front of a club building. He gestures me inside, ah, this is no time to play games. He says, why not. Its a good place to hide from Hive. They wouldn't dare to disturb our game. I turn back and group of Hive was running at us with weapons aimed at us. I didn't understand the logic, but I followed Hansen inside. I close the door behind us and the game room light turns up.

This is the room I spent some time alone. Whenever I wanted to get away from other kids, I would come here on off hours and just take my mind off by playing games. Hansen says, that’s right. You could bypass the Kuretine locks and come and go as you please. I always knew you had a place like this to go to. I scoff, no you don't. You are just seeing my own memories. He smiles, who knows. Maybe I knew about it but never told you. I could actually imagine this to be true. We walk around to different areas, strength, intellect and strategy type games. There were all different kinds of it to nurture the students here.

The next second me and Hansen are sitting across each other and facing a game of chess in between us. I had the white faced towards me. Hansen says, your move first. I am confused, chess was never on Medrine. Why not play the 5d version of chess here. Hansen says, I am tried of playing the same game so many times. Chess might be simple, but its fun because its simple. I always wondered how good Hansen would be in a game of chess. I played my usual move of pawn. He moved his knight instead. Its interesting he would do that.

The chess board instantly changes around the pieces and suddenly we are at a critical conjecture. It feels like I played with him for hours in less than a second. Coming at each other with unpredictable moves, keeping each others pieces in check. Even sacrificing my queen or his bishop to gain any advantage. And right now its anybody's game. Wait, does that mean I am playing myself. Doesn't that mean I am the loser and the winner at the same time. Hansen smiles, quite the predicament you are in. Do you want your subconscious to win, or your awareness to win. I don't understand what I want here. What is the point of this game then. Hansens says, you are asking the right question now.

He leans away, your fight with Charles. You were in predicament, much like this one. Weren't you. Out of moves and out of chances. Then I recall the memories of the match. I blurt out, you. You were there. You said something crazy, like I was going to get stronger and I would face challenges that I couldn't find a way out of. The same is represented in this chess game right now. He says, but with a little bit of luck and will, you made it though. Nothing makes me prouder than that. I stomp my hands at the edge of the chess board. I yell, I need to know. Why did you have so much faith in me. You are optimistic, but you were even more pragmatic.

I was a kid with a short life ahead of me. No Kuret, no family. And yet he made claims that turned out to be true. That is not probability. He says, that is only for me to know. I gave you the push you needed. I was a little worried since you basically forgot about me for more than a decade. But I am glad you remembered my advice when you needed it. I don't believe this, he isn't giving me a straight answer. He says, much like you don't want to answer your friend. Don't you think its little bit hypocritical.

I am confused, who is he talking about. Am I keeping something from someone. Hansen says, I am not here to accuse you. Only to assure you that my reasons are mine. I may have known you were a MAR's kid, or I had a way to save you. Or maybe I knew about your family. You can keep guessing things. But it doesn't matter. Because the truth is I placed my trust and faith in you. I gave you the skills you need to take down any advisory in your path. Whether it’s the Medrones, Humans or the Hives. I say, its not enough. I want to know the reason why you believed in me so much.

Hansen replies, I believe it, because you believe in yourself. I am tired of going around in circles. What kind of meta mind game are we playing here besides chess. Its abundantly clear I might never know the truth. Does he want me to be at peace with it. I might never know how anyone can put so much trust on me back then. Hansen says, its like this game. We can keep playing at each other infinitely, but eventually we have to stop. The question is, can you make peace with your decision. Sometimes giving in is better than being stuck.

Everything with him is a lesson. I get what he is trying to make me understand. But its hard to let go. Hansen says, of course its hard. If everyone could do it, they be no one with any regret. He is asking me to choose, either to keep playing or end it. Ah, this is such a head scratcher. My mind is telling me one thing, but my heart is telling something else. How can I end this. I pray for someone to help. Maybe someone would help me here again. I waited, and then some more. But no one came. It felt eternity went by and no one came to help me choose.

Hansen extends his arm, what do you say. Call it a draw? I can't focus on the chess board, and all I know is that its anybody's game. Maybe I can win. But what exactly am I winning or losing here. I sigh, the real enemy is someone else. I don't know if I am ever going to be satisfied with this. Not knowing the truth. But I don't want to be stuck. I want to move on. This whole thing is to find a way for me to change. Hansen says, you will do that. You don't have to know how. You can only trust that you will get to a state where you are your best self.

I suppose this had to be enough. I can't keep getting stumbled at every obstacle, looking for answers or reason. I grab his hand, good game. The chess pieces all tumble down one after another until all it vanishes from the board. Hansen says, its good that you want to let it go. I hope you do the same with her. Again, who is he talking about. He pulls his hand back and begins to fold the chess board by each column, like it was a cloth. He says, and by the way. I would have won. Huh, what. Was he teasing with me. Or am I myself that petty. Guess we will never know. Suddenly the room goes dark and I find myself in front of a big black door. It had the shadow insignia on it.

No goodbyes from him, typical in this nightmare. I look around the place, it was just a dark room I can't recall and a single door. But this is not the entrance to our HQ. I don't know where it is, or how it looks like, but this is too open and simple. I just know this wasn't the real entrance. I still can't hear Drew, so I don't have any choice. I grab the door handle, twist it and open it. The dark room is instantly shined with a green light and I am sucked in. I hit face first into a strange wall. It didn't hurt, but it felt like it was pricking me.

I gently push away from the wall with my hands. I looked around some weird room, seems very familiar. Then the next second my senses distort and I realize I wasn't on the side wall, I was on the ceiling. I scream as I fall backwards on the actual ground. But my fall was broken by a couch. I am relieved it was a soft landing, not that I felt any pain. The couch was covered in a lavish styled material. It was glimmering with different kind of gems. I know what these colorful gems are. I have seen then many times. What are they. They are so beautiful.

A woman says, I always know you liked them. You said it was too gaudy the last time you saw it. I jerk to see an elderly women standing opposite to me. She was wearing a dress that radiating colors, like a rainbow. Her sleeves were only to her elbow, but it revealed a long insignia all over her arm. Its a tattoo that was glowing green. I have seen and that green color before. She scoffs, you are staring too much. Don't be so rude. You are still a child. That snarky but teasing comment triggered a memory.

I say, Istra. It was her. The next second there is someone beside my couch, it was Istra too. But this was the dead body of hers. She was lying in the same position as the day I found her on Medrine. The terror grips me and I stumble away down, trying to get away from it. The alive Istra says, apologies. That’s not I wanted you to see me. I tried hard to hide, but you kept searching so earnestly. I had to be found, like how you found me back then. I couldn't take me eye of the dead body. I feel like someone's hand has gone through my throat and pulling me out from inside out.

She says, what a terrible imagination you got there. She walks slowly to her dead body and covers it with the same material of the couch. She says, its better now, isn't it. I don't think hiding her is accomplishing anything. I can still her dead. She says, of course. Nothing can change that. But I don't want to see myself like this. Its too disturbing. I rather you remember me like this. She sits in front of the couch, blocking the view of her other body behind her. Was this some sort of representation to remember her by this and not by the dead one.

She smirks, you are clever. I made the right choice by entrusting stuff to you. Guess its time to face her now. I gather enough determination and get up. The next moment me and Istra are sitting on the couch, her dead body was no were to be seen. She says, its still here. You just can't see it. I look around, but I don't know where it went or why did I hide it. But I feel much better now. She says, you must have a lot things to ask me. I reply, yeah, well, Hansen beat you to the punch. I am sure you won't answer why you helped me so much.

She smiles, you learn quickly. I say, besides, I am sure you were just trusting me to help your daughter later. You told me about your family secrete book when you didn't need to. My best guess is that you didn't want to burden Marina. Maybe keep me indebted to you for allowing me in the ship too. She says, is that what you believe. I say, maybe. Or something else. Doesn't matter. I am grateful you helped me. I don't think anyone else referenced me

on that ship. Must be a painful decision to choose both me and Marina when you were supposed to send only one.

She says, you shouldn't worry about such things. I would do anything for Marina. But you, she chuckles, you were always going on the ship. Like Hansen, she is being cryptic. I ask, Hansen? He already sent his grandson. Braden sent Catherine, and so did the other shadows. They all chose their families or loved ones. She says, you are trying hard to justify your survival. I get knowing the truth matters. But its not like its end of the world. You being on that ship, was a blessing. You went to save countless people.

I say, I lost people. I couldn't save everyone. I felt like the embraided cloth was slowly climbing my body, trying to cover me, the same way it did with the dead Istra. She says, you are not a god, son. No matter what you do, sacrifices will always be there. She turns to see a side wall. The wall immediately filles up photos of the Ozarek family portraits. I saw photos of her, with her husband, Olander. Their three kids, Marina's older twin siblings, Sam and Violet. She says, I sacrificed my family for others. For a future where the people who could leave Medrine and save others. Even if one of them would be able to help Marina, in any way, that would be worth all the this.

Her fierce determination was apparent. When she was alive, she was known for her indomitable spirit. She was perfectly able to make choice and not look back. Very few, like me, knew she had a warmer side to her. Like Marina said, she cherished her kids lot more than she let on. She shoos me, you are going to make me sentimental. Not a good look on me. I prefer you always see me as someone who would do anything for my family. A new type of guilt swells in me. The embroiled cloth climbs even more and covers my torso now. She says, why are you sad. Its not your fault I died.

I blurt out, but you could have chosen someone else. Why send me of all people. I wasn't powerful, I was barely a Medrone. The only thing I had was my intellect. Which I have wasted it for years. You could have send someone better, an alpha or even an omega. They could have changed the tide of the war. Able to do things I couldn't do. I was stuck in a place without memories and bound to a hospital. She didn't give an answer. Figures, whatever she says, its just me talking back in the end. The cloth begins to tighten and it covers my neck now. I feel like I am stuck in the sheets, slowly dragged inside.

Istra says, do you believe you aren't the right choice. I say, all the time. I have many regrets. I chose to forget about your sacrifices. I chose to be a nobody because I didn't want to remember this. Its was too painful. She sighs, I can't deny that. It was a very selfish decision. The grip tightens around my neck, almost cutting off my air. She says, but do you think anyone else would fare any better. Is she really saying that others would fail. That is completely egotistical and hubris. Having pride is okay, but being conceited that others were the wrong the choices. I can't believe that.

She says, I am not saying that others would fail. I am saying to give yourself the credit you deserve. The cloth looses a little before it reached my mouth. She continues, did you know when Marina was a five, she used to cry all the time when she got hurt. So much so that she said she would never wanted to be warrior. Never wanted to be an alpha, let alone an omega. This momentarily made me left bamboozled. Is this a made up story from a hallucination. She says, come on. Don't tell me you forgot about that. I was discussing this in the shadow HQ one day. Don't you remember.

What is she on about. She says, try to remember. You didn't know who I was back then. And I was feeling down that day, because others were pressuring me to choose my successor. My predecessor, my grandmother wasn't allowing me to choose other children. I remember it now, something so long ago and insignificant, that I had forgotten about it. She was talking to Hansen and I happen to listen in. I remember I was with someone else. Who was that. That person was someone I was close with.

Istra says, you remember now. Yes, I was speaking with Hansen. I was telling how my family wasn't letting my other kids to be next Shadow. But I wasn't going to let Marina be one. I am confused why she didn't want that. Marina is very strong and capable. She smiles, of she is. But at the time I was being selfish. Marina was born because Violet couldn't be my successor. She wasn't capable, like Marina. But Marina, she was so full of heart. You know her best, don't you. Do you remember what I told Hansen. What she said when wanted to become grow up. I rack my memories, trying to find those particular words. I say, an artist. She wanted to create things so that you wouldn't have to. To make your life better.

She nods and looks away with pride, imagine my small child saying such big imagination. I wanted to protect her dreams. She has born with a gift I didn't want her to be forced to be something she didn't want to become. Not like how I was forced to be one by my grandmother. What happened then, why she change her mind and recruit Marina. Istra says, I wasn't the one who changed. Huh? If Istra remained firm on her decision, then it could be only one thing. It was Marina who changed.

The haze appears in my memories and I begin clearing them. I think I am onto some thing here. I remember Marina saying something about changing her mind a long time ago. Istra says, let me help you out. It was you who changed Marina. What. That’s impossible. The cloth around my neck unwraps and falls below my chest now. Istra says, don't you know what you said to her to in our house. You told her she could do both the things. She could be a warrior and an artist. I recall a vaguely something like that. I was visiting her home and once I saw a Kuret structure. I was impressed by the engineering attempt, but she was afraid to show it to others. Her mother was hounding her to be a warrior like her and she didn't want that.

Istra says, no need to be impudent. I was also being pressured by my family. Is this how Istra really was, or am I just picturing her the way I want her to be. But it makes sense if she was really asking advice from Hansen back then. She was concerned for Marina's decision and didn't want to force on her. Istra says, but you had a positive influence on her. You made her question that she could do both. I am sure she was inspired by you. And because of that she chose to become something she was hesitant initially.

I did that? How in the freak did I never realize that. Just how lucid I am in these dream memories. Istra says, you were blinded by your own insecurities. You never realized you had positive effect on her. I don't know how I feel about Marina following in my footsteps, but you helped her become the woman she is now. Strong and still valuing her freedom. I can't ask for anything more. The cloth slips past my waste now. Its like my guilt is slowly slipping away too.

Istra says, just like her, you had positive effect on others. You lost many people, but you not only saved people, but helped them grow. You helped stopped a epidemic attack on Humans. And singlehandedly stopped a misguided royal. You saved Blake, because of which a freaking terra is alive right now. Do you believe someone else would have done the same as you. Maybe things would be different, but do you honestly believed you should have stayed back on Medrine. There are many reasons for you to feel guilty, but you only need one reason to be alive. Because you are worthy.

Those words were something I never knew I needed to hear from her. No, from anyone who died on that day. The clothe vanishes, freeing me from the terror and guilt. I know I did a lot to balance out my selfish decision. But I never once believed it was enough. But even hearing it from a fake Istra was enough to give me some hope. Istra puts her hand on my cheek, you don't have to stop feeling the guilt, the frustration. But you can however stop doubting yourself. For whatever reason, you were chosen. And whatever you do with it, its your choices that will effect the future, not the past. We did our part, you do however you can.

This is probably the first time I could feel some warmth in this dream. Istra says, I thought you believed this was a nightmare. I say, ha, maybe it’s a good nightmare. She laughs so hard that I was sure it was a just a product of my imagination. She pulls her hand away, and it felt she took away all the confusion I was feeling with it. I felt re invigorated. Maybe this whole story was bullshit and I made it up to feel good. Or maybe it was real. Regardless, it felt good to realize that I should value myself more.

At that moment, the couch begins to glow. The different colors were blinding, but it was very familiar. The dark room was enveloped with kaleidoscope of glimmers. The couch I was in vanishes and I fall on my ass, but I somehow was also standing. This is dream is just getting weirder. Istra says, well, its your dream. You are definitely weird. The glow flows out from the gems stitched into the cloths. No, they are not gems. They are Kuritines. The room changes and instantly I am transported to the basement under the library.

I look around the place, the memories are so strong here I could see everything clearly here. Istra says, this the door to the HQ. You made it here. I turn towards the hidden entrance behind this door. It looked like a ordinary door leading to the adjoining room outside. But there is switch mechanism that changes the destination. I place my palm around the side which triggers the secrete door. I need something to open it. Istra ruffles something in her hands and produces a ring in her palm.

That’s my Shadow ring. I pick it up and new memories of it flows in me. All the hardships I had to suffer, but also the good stuff. Istra says, you are ready. Well, as anyone could be. I understand what she means. Behind this door, there lies a person I had a bone to pick with. Someone who I have been ignoring for a long time. Istra says, I can't say it will go the way you want. Things rarely go the way we want. She sighs, even though Marina changed her mind about becoming a warrior, I would have been okay with her being a normal person.

I ask, but then she wouldn't have been there during the war with Hive. She saved countless lives there. And help defeat the Hive commander. She nods, look who has recently started to appreciate things. She chuckles, a mother can still dream. Even in someone else's dream. That joke was making my head hurt. She points to the door, go on ahead. I nod and place my ring on the wall. The door makes a noise and the ground beneath us shake a little. The leavers and gears were moving behind the door. It felt like eternity as it opens, but it takes a second for the door to open.

Istra says, I won't ask you to look after Marina. She is perfectly able to protect herself. Though, she leans a little, she is a little too unpredictable. I hope you will keep reining her like you always do. Once again I am in a very awkward and baffling position. Just how much twisted is my subconsciousness. That being said, its all make believe, but not the emotions I am feeling. I say, you say I inspire her. Well, she inspire me too time and again. Istra gives me the biggest smile she had to offer.

Suddenly a hand comes from the open door and pulled me inside to who knows where.

David (Chapter 99)

Thursday, February 19, 2026 16:03

I thought nothing would surprise me anymore. But when a strange guy pulls me in and then drags me to hell, I had to reconsider how much messy my emotions are in this place. I can tell this is Shadows HQ, but its on fire. There walls are torn open from blasts, the floor have been ripped apart and numerous broken equipment's. Stuff were exploding from the assault of weapons. What I was thrusted into now. I was being dragged by a smaller kid now. He feels familiar. But I couldn't put my finger on. I know he was a Shadow, but I can't recognize him.

He pulled me my the arm and dragging me across the burning rooms. We finally take a cover beside a wall and crouch down, seriously dude. I know we weren't the best of friends, but come on. How can you forget me. He knows who I am. Then he back fists me in my chest, duh, its your nightmare. That voice, I remember now. John? He gives me the Shadow greet with the hand gesture. It was him. He says, of course dude. You have kept me on the sidelines a lot more than I thought you would.

He wasn't wrong to complain, I had more or less a strictly Shadow connection with him. Its sad truth, but we haven't spend enough time together outside the Shadows. He was friends with so many people. Even someone mutual. Ah, I still feel I am missing someone. He was a polar opposite of me. I was gloomy and serious, while he was cheerful and easygoing. If I had to put in words, I'd say I envied him. He smiles, really. I never knew that. He is being facetious, just like this father. I ask, I thought you be more angry. Even though you were the oldest Shadow to join in our generation, I haven't been mourning you.

He says, no worries. Our relationship was different than others. I preferred to keep it that way. That was my choice, do you not recall what I said that day. He did say that once. Maybe I am just drawing this from that reference memory. He says, I am not too much mad about it. I figured I keep this life separate. I didn't have to keep contact with Blake and Marina too. But I did my part in the missions. Remember the time you had me investigate the thefts in the city. You said it would take a lot of time, but we got it done in just three days.

I remember it now. I say, you almost got caught that time. You were cocky and made a blunder. He scorns, how was I supposed to know the person I took the identity was the guards son. I say, that's the first person I told you to not take the identity of. He replies, no you told not to take his daughters face. Said nothing about his son. I can't believe he is nit picking such small detail with me. He says, I thought you loved being technical. I am just saying what you ordered me to. I smirk at his witty response. He was always a wild card, different from Marina. He chuckles, I wasn't that bad, was I.

I smile, no. You were someone I believed had a proper balance in life. Didn't let your Shadow work interfere with you private life. Unlike mine, your world was bigger on Medrine. He replies, you say that but I can't believe dad was sponsoring you the entire time. Just how did you to manipulate him to do that. Mom once asked if he was cheating on her when she noticed his account draining so suddenly. Now I realize you were the reason. I had forgotten this memory. Branden once said it to me and played it off like a joke. He then asked reduce the budget for our department next semester. I don't know if that was a joke or a real thing.

Regardless I laughed aloud. He scoffs, real funny man. I say, sorry. I don't know he was like that at home. Your sister told me about this a while ago too. I guess even Shadows can't get away with everything. He asks, speaking of my sister, I have a beef with you. Ah, not him too. He gets annoyed, did you thought I wasn't going to say anything. I had enough of the scrutiny from their dad about this. He says, I got my own stuff to say. Its my baby sister and you caused her pain. I sigh, okay lets skip to the part where you tell what you need to tell her. I am guessing we are on a clock since you pulled me in here and hiding.

He says, we got time. Why, you in a hurry? There's someone I need to meet. Someone I had been avoiding for a long time. I only had the urgent feeling. But not their name. its frustrating. That's why I need to hurry up. He sighs, fine. I get it, you have become a big deal. I am now envious of you now. He looks round the place and faces me, since dad covered pretty I glaze over the details. I want you to tell Catherine about me. I ask, that you were a Shadow? I don't think. He shakes his head, not that. She was only eight when I died. She barely remembers me. I was most of the time in the university or participating in Shadow related stuff. I barely got any time for her. To her I was just a name and sibling.

That is true. She doesn't remember much about him. Though she remembers Branden. He says, yeah, well dad had a much better work life balance than me. Did he not. I have been so careless, doing my own thing, that I never got to be a big brother. Forget about being good or bad like a certain someone. Who is he talking about. He says, you will met him soon enough. So my ask is to tell her about me. As strange as it sound, you are the only person left who knows me. I want to be remembered. If possible not just by her, by others too. You could have told Blake and Marina a little more about me. Did you thought I wasn't interesting enough.

I didn't have a good enough reason for him. At that time I was telling them my worst mistakes and guilty secrets. I didn't tell them everything. Because I didn't want to talk about dead people's life. I thought I was sparing them unnecessary hurt. But now I see John asking for it. His annoyance is a directed at me, so its actually at myself. I have told people a lot of things, helping me unburned myself, but all I gave them were the cliff note versions. Not the real, the actual important moments and conversations. When did I decide its okay to forget why people mattered.

He says, now you get it. Its okay to leave the past and move on. But no one is asking them to forget us. People matter. No matter how little they impacted ones life. We want to be remembered, our own unique stories. That's how we stay alive. For someone to truly let go of the past, you have to know why its okay to leave them behind. He places his hand on my shoulder, I know you don't want to cause pain. But pain is how we live. How we grow. You can't heal without knowing that pain.

Its different when are you told something, rather than just knowing something to be true. I always knew its never better to lie, but I never corrected my behavior. Because I was scared. Fear of getting hurt, being scorned by others or even blamed for things just because I survived. Hering it from a face like Johns, I realize I don't have to sideline people. I need to let them in instead. Its not easy though. He scoffs, doing the right thing is never easy. Especially the ones that really matter, they are the hardest. I don't expect you to just flip a switch and start revealing everything immediately. That's nuts.

He puts a finger on his lips, we are Shadows. We have responsibilities and some secrets that should remain as it is. But we are people too. So when the time is right, help remember people about us. I ask, how will when it's the right time. He says, you will know it. Don't you worry about it. Just promise me you will not try to hide us anymore. And you will tell some non Shadow related stories about me to Catherine. I know I should be used to this by now, but every time someone asks me for something, I feel all different kind of awkwardness. I am yet again asking myself to promise for something.
☐John says, that is pretty weird. Not going to lie. He acknowledges the ridiculousness of the situation, and yet he waits for me. I sigh, yeah, yeah. I promise. The goal is to change and be a be
take it one step a time. See you later. What does that even mean here. A loud explosion occurs beside us and a white flash blinds me. I felt we were transported someplace again. The air around me changed to a little cooler, did I enter deeper into the HQ.

I raise my imaginary arm to block the imaginary light. A girls voice says, you'll go crazy if you think too much about this. The light goes away. I am in different room. I recall this is the training room. And in place of John, a girl is sitting ahead of me. Her hair was tied into a ponytail and she had blood stains on her abdomen. Do I know her ? She scoffs, jeez. Well, freak you too. She slaps me out of nowhere. That slap actually resonated to my core, like my entire being was shaken from inside out. Those vibrations evokes new memories. The ones about her. Zakerine. She smiles, I don't like the fact that I had to make you remember me, unlike others.

I didn't care if this was fake. I went in for hug. I held her tight, believing that if I let her go, she will vanish again. She snickers at my sudden emotional outburst. She says, its good to see you too. My arms wrap around her tiny body even more. That made her irritated and shoves me back, you could have done it without calling me tiny. You are just gotten older. I am forever young, you know, because I died. She even had that sense of humor. She says, you know me the best, so here I am. Apparently she was the most clearest memory of mine.

She says, I am honored you keep me so close. She then becomes annoyed, but I never thought you would do something so crazy. Shall I list all your greatest hits. Oh boy, this is going to hurt me a lot. She says, so I died and you spiral out in depression and decide to erase your memories. Which turns out you were starting to not want it. What a douche move, by the way. Then when, a Zakerine less David scums around with different girls. First one friend zones you and dates your human friend. Then you go meet a terminal women and decide to lose your virginity to her. Gross by the way, you are one nasty dude. All the while screwing around with a Human psychopath. Am I getting this right.

The embarrassment was enough that I felt like I was sinking into the ground. She grabs me up my by neck and pulls me out. Turns out I was actually sinking in the ground. She is really angry at me, and then you go crazy after losing both women. Spend years planning for a revenge and then don't go through it because the said women stopped you. And now you spent this year flirting with two women again. I ask, what. Who? She says, agh, forget it. Its a pain for me to talk about them. I can't believe you grew up to be a complete player.

I rebuttal, I think you are just salty. If had stayed alive instead of stupidly dying like that, we could have stayed together. If you think about it, everything started because you died. So, its not really my fault. She gives a stink eye, so I am to be blamed. I shrug, am I wrong? After a tense moment she relents, guess I should own up to that. Besides, I know you weren't fooling around with those girls. But Sophie, really? What the hell do you even see in her. I should be more embarrassed and confused about it. Talking about my alive ex to a dead ex. But I gathered enough of my wits with me. I say, you don't get to decide about me anymore. I will choose whom I like. She crosses her arm, is that right.

I nod, I don't know how exactly, but I have dealt with your death. Its sad and disappointing. But I had some time to process it. You made a choice, nothing I could do about it. The best I can make sense of that avoidable death is that you didn't want to lose anyone. Not after loosing so many others. She asks, what if there was a different reason. I say, my answer would be the same. It was your choice. Do I regret not able to stop you then. Hell yeah. But I can't obsesses over what I can't control. Some reminded me of it recently.

She smiles, you have some clever friends. Or at least you used to have. I say, I still have them. Everyone. John helped me remember that. She becomes depressed when I mention him, when I saw him dying. I didn't want to lose another friend. I lost already everyone I cared about, even before then. But that day, I didn't want anyone else to die. Not if I could help it. I know I made my peace with it, but it still stings me that she went so insane and didn't even heal herself while trying to revive John. She says, you don't need to remind me of that. It was, what did you tell others, a pointless death.

I try to come up with a excuse for my behavior. But she puts her finger to my lips, don't bother denying it. You were there, I was there. Its true. Not all death are due to noble reasons. Right. I had to agree with her. She sighs, I have so many reasons to explain what I did, or why I did. But none that will ever make you see the logic in it. She knew me well. Aside from the obvious reason of her being me. She pouts at me, not everything had to be rational. Like you thinking that saving Ryan and Elina would save me too.

She got me there. When she mentioned their names the memories of that instantly fills me up with a whole lot of emotions. It doesn't makes sense who the two different seem the same to me. She says, it doesn't have to. You see what you want to. And sometimes that's okay. I need to hear that from her. I feel a lot of my burden being lifted from me. Like I had been carrying the weight of the entire world. And each passing time, they were peeling off. She dusts off a little dirt from my shoulders, whoa, that's quite literally. You seem to be shedding your worries.

I guess she really did have a purpose to be here, other than to criticize me about my choice of women. She punches me in the chest. I chuckle, faking to be hurt. She says, you know you were a mess a while ago. All because you loved me. I say, yeah, well, chalk one that to suppressed anger and fears. Its not been pleasant regaining memories one bit at a time. She says, you are much better now. I nod, yeah. More than better. I realized I was making this all about me, but like John said, I need to share. She says, oh, you are going to tell the girl you have a crush on about me. Isn't that a turn off, to talk about ex.

I ask, Elina? I don't think she mind. Zakerine makes a heavy sigh, not that one. The other one. I ask, there is another girl? She looks to the celling, damn. You are lost cause aren't you. You need to fix things with her, like pronto. I don't like her much, especially not her brother, but you like her. That's all I care about. Who is she talking about. I feel someone very important to me. Someone more than Zakerine? She punches me again, hey, I am still here.

Well, not here. But you know what I mean. Actually I have no clue what she, or I, mean. This the only constant in this dream or nightmare. It confuses the shit out of me.

She laughs, I guess my jobs is almost done. She stands up. Wait, what. I stand up, don't leave. I have so much talk to you about. She gives me a disgusted smile, you clinging to me is even worse. You have already moved on, don't go back. I say, I am not. But I don't know if I ever will get a chance like this again. She says, and what was this anyway. You are only hearing what you need to. I blurt out, I will take what I can get. I grab her face my hand and come closer, I miss you. She joins her head together, I know. I miss you too. And its okay to feel this way. I am not going anywhere. But Liz is right, you should start living your life the way you want. With whom you want.

She pulls back, I am always ever going to be kid. Its not fair to keep me bounded. Others are alive and I am just a memory now. There is literally no completion. And so I am doing something I don't really like. She pulls her face away. she says, I am letting you go. This is weird, I should be the one to let her go. She says, I know, right. This is a little messed up. She continues, you should be free to do what you like, what you love. No more hiding from your true feelings. I ask, you aren't just talking just talking about love, are you. She says, you are holding back a lot of yourself. You don't have to stifle those feelings. Let yourself feel whatever you want to.

I don't really get what she meant by that. She says, you know about it soon. She slowly begins to walk backwards. I want to follow her, but my legs are stuck. She says, don't. Its fine. I am done holding you back. But do me a favor, when you tell others about me, tell them I made a mistake, not some foolish girl who died pathetically. If possible, make it look like I was heroic. You will have a tough time to sell, but I hear you are good at manipulation. She begins to fade. I try to move, but I am stuck like this. She is pushing me away. She mouths to me something inaudible. I realize what it was, me too. That’s all I could say before she vanishes in front of my eyes.

The next moment I am standing in the middle of the training room now. I can move again now. The Kuretine crystals were glowing in the walls. This is really the same room where I and others trained. I look around for others, hoping to find them. But I was all alone. Where is everyone. I desperately looked for Zakerine. Maybe she will be here again. I looked for her everyone, but there is no place to hide. Its like everything is out in the open. Then I hear a guys voice, what kind of a man are you. You need your imaginary friends to help you.

That voice, that coarse pitch, gravelly timbre. It felt like a train hit me and all the memories return to me. It made me so angry literal hell fires erupted from the corners of the room. I turn to face the source of my anger. And there he is, standing with a knife wound over his chest. That same face that makes me want to shove my hand into his chest, pull out his heart and feed it to him. He claps at me mockingly, what an active imagination. You know, in this place, you might actually get that wish. Want to try it out. Everything about him is making me nauseous. Of course he is the person I have been avoiding this whole time. I rather face a hundred Hive than see that smug face.

He walks closer to me, you got a mouth on you, you little shit. Don't think you have changed because you got stronger. All you have done is achieved a little bit of fake fame. He is goading me. Of course it’s the first thing he does. He says, actually, I am not doing anything. Its you who is doing everything. I am just the messenger. Someone needs to whoop your ass and beat some sense into you. Its official, I am my own worst enemy. My own subconscious conjured him physically to torment me.

He smirks, yeah. Its fun to see you squirm by our own mind. Tell me, how does it feel. It feels like I want to kill you. Too bad you are already dead. We walk around each other, circling in mirror opposite. Stop, I said. He shrugs, you are not me. Just some dark twisted part of me. A wrapped sense of humor. He says, I see we no longer playing along the roles given to us. I reply, what's the point. You know what I am going to do, before I even think about it. He clicks his tongue, that is partially true. The drugs are quiet potent, so much that it can bifurcate your conscious. Ever that of that.

I laugh, yeah. No. I know my own tactics. Trying to get inside my mind, trying to make me believe some plausible expiations. Too bad its not going to work. He stops, oh, are you sure. I say, enough of the games. Why are we here. All the peoples I have met had a purpose for me. What is yours. He says, you really have no respect for me. You need to learn some you punk. I bark, educate me. I want to know what a child abuser can teach me. He lunges at my throat, I dunk away before he could grab me.

He goes for a sweep kick, but I crawl away to get a distance. He says, look at you. You think just because you enough meat in you, it has changed you. I get back up and raise my arms to guard, no, I think experience has changed me. He smirks, you think you take on the crown. Don't delude yourself. You are nothing. My anger boils hotter now. The fire spreads around the room, enclosing us inside. I gesture him to come to me. He dashes at me with a right fist hook, I block it my arm and go for an elbow shove to the wound on his chest. He backs away a little from the impact. He snarls, you freaker.

My mouth turns to a big smile, what's wrong. You thought it would be like the last time. You thought wrong. He came at me again, this time with more vigor. I dodged it and knee him. He blocks it with an arm and goes for another punch. I block it and get pushed back a little. We kept attacking and blocking each other. I didn't feel any pain, but I was getting frustrated. While he remained the same jackass. He continued taunting me cursing any chance he got. I was fighting him for hours nonstop. Neither he nor the fires stop.

If anything, the longer this went the more angry I was. I should be stronger than him now. But why can't I finish him off. He aims a kick to my face. I block it with my elbow and jabbed his knees with me leg. He side steps from the impact and we take a few steps back. He laughs, I'll give this much to you. You have become a little bold now. All you had earlier was your mouth, but now you can at least move. I shriek, shut it. I will kill you. He snarls at me, and what will that achieve.

I reply, I will eliminate the part of me that causes me my PTSD. He chuckle surprised, you think I am the cause of your issues. You give me far too credit. I say, deny all you want. But once I cut you of my mind, I will finally be free. He says, you think you can get rid of me that easily. I don't think it will be easy. But I didn't care. Everything I did, it lead me to this moment. I gone through a transformative experience. And the only obstacle left is him. Once I prove that I am better than him, I will be free of him. Forever.

He says, didn't you hear John. The past lives in our memories. Even your pathetic brain believes that removing me is not the solution. I ask, I don't care what you think. There is a tense moment between us. I thought he would attack me. But we just stood there, like he was waiting for something. He says, your hate is even bigger than me. Letting it blind you. You been holding onto a grudge for more than 20 years. I am not the one with issues, you are the one. The fires burns hotter around us. Is he trying to teach me something just wanted to torment me while spouting nonsenses. I guess all he knows is to torment.

He says, nonsense. Look at you. Playing make believe in your mind here. Tell me what is more ridiculous than this. He extends his arm and circles around himself, this is all you. The fire, the floor, the air you think you are breathing. Even the both of us. We are all representation of you. You attacking me is you fighting you. He stops and faces me directly, you cooked this all up because you are sad little boy, who still thinking he is strong. Every word he spouted fueled more anger at me.

I tighten my fist in pure anger. I need to end this and get out of here. If I can't beat him in a brawl, I need something else. I am stronger, but what exactly did make me stronger. I felt like I was missing something, a core component of my abilities. What was it, a secret strategy or a weakness of his. How have I beaten other after him. He says, seriously. How freaked up are you, kid. I feel sorry that you are one of the Medrones left alive. There are so many others who could have replaced you. Many people who died sending you to Earth. If they saw you so weak, so helpless, they would have never sent you.

That does it. I don't care what I am missing. I rush ahead with my fist raised up in the air. He didn't try to dodge it, instead blocks it and grabs on tight to me, not letting me attacking him. He barks, so that’s all you got. A measly half punch. Jeez, you are so pathetic. You dying here would actually save a lot of trouble in the future. I am disappointed that I am dead. Because I could never see you epic your downfall would be. The fire reach smoldering hot around me. This heat is so strong, I think the heat is melting the air around me.

I need to find what I am missing. There should be something I know than can defeat him. Suddenly a muffled voice echo's in the room. He shoves me away and we book around the burning room. I don't see anyone, but I can hear a faint voice saying a word. I listen in closely and heard a voice. Drew says, Kuret. The ground shakes and I topple over. The room begins to vibrate crazy. Its an earthquake. But why is that. I topple down again while I was already on the ground. Its like I was stuck on a loop, the ground shakes and kept getting knocked down. What is freak is going on.

Wagner says, looks like this your real nightmare. You have no one to help you. All alone and powerless. His taunt made me infuriated, but not like these constant quakes. It looks like he wasn't being effected by this. What does this mean. Drew said something. A word, something that struck me to my core. But she isn't saying anything anymore. He laughs, that was me. You won't hear her voice anymore. I didn't want anyone to interrupt us. This is between you and me. What does that mean. How can he control this, I am one in charge here.

He says, you sad little boy. You are the one who kept getting knocked down. Not me. Ah, every time I try to get up or try to crawl away, I am forced to fall back on the ground. What's even strange is I can't recall what Drew said. She said something, feels very important. He walks closer to me, forget it. You are too weak. A little bit of power is not enough to beat me. If I had my real teeth, I would have cracked them from the pressure of my anger. This is so damn frustrating. I had enough of this quakes. I decided that I am going to first destroy it.

Instead of jumping out, I decided to give in. I face down and fall straight into the ground. The floor immediately breaks apart. Huge cracks starts to form around me. I was falling into it, but then the next second I was standing in the middle of it. I was standing at the epicenter of this quake. Hold on, from here I can see something I didn't before. This quake, it was chasing me earlier when I entered the university. Yeah, it’s the same one. Did it follow me all the way from there. I thought it was trying to kill me. But maybe.

I crouch down and lay my land inside the cracks. The vibration stops and a dark veil erupts from those cracks. It surround me. I was terrified for a second, but then I felt a familiar sensation. Something I had forgotten. Yes, this is my power. My Kuret. It flows into me and so did the memories. The next second I am back in the room with Wagner. The fire is still burning at the edge of the room. But the cracks in the floor are gone. I raise my palm and bring out my Kuret. That made me chuckle, this is what I was missing.

I wave my Kuret to Wagner who wasn't fazed by this. He scoffs, so you remembered your Kuret. Big deal. He pulls out his own Kuret. He aims his arm at the fires and some it gets pulled into his hand, you gained yours, so did mine. You actually did me a favor. Now I can kill you. I spat out, try it. He throws a fireball at me, I dodge it and throw my Kuret. He gathers wind on his feet and flies up. I throw a Kuret line to the air and get pulled into the air. He prepares for a gust of wind towards me.

I change my direction in the last second and summersaulted in air to land a kick to his face. He narrowly dodges it and return fires a hail of icy bullets. I throw a Kuret line from my back to the ground and get pulled down before they catch me. My feet skid a little as I land back on the floor. He throws a lightening bolt at me. I yell and create a Kuret dome. I fill the space around me with my Kuret to block that bolt. Then I grab him using his Kuret. He tried to fly off away from the Kuret. But I had prepared a Kuret wall to cut his escape. He instead decides to create a huge wall of ice around him. The ice too think for my Kuret to break. If he thinks this will stop me, if was dead wrong.

I gather Kuret around my arm and thrust myself towards the ice barrier. I crash throw it. Turns out he was preparing another thunder bolt inside, I wrap the Kuret around my like an armor and we both clash straight into each other. The resulting force knocks both of us away in opposite directions. I gather the Kuret behind me to break my fall. He does the same with wind. A strange emotion emerges deep within me. Excitement. I am finally fighting him. This is the opportunity was waiting for ages. I can finish him off with this.

Then begin a very long fight. Sometimes it felt we fought for a second, other times felt decades. I realize I am fighting the grudge I have been holding all this time. Then it means I just have to keep this up that long. Only then will be satisfied. Our Kuret clashes a hundredth time. He threw everything at me, electricity, wind, fire and ice. But I countered all with my physical Kuret. I even downed on the wild exploding Kuret to keep this battle engaging at his level. I know I am stronger than him. But he had a sadistic smile plastered on him all this time. Like he is enjoying this. I get frustrated and ask, what's do damn funny.

He backs away and we both take a breather. He says, this is awesome. That weak little child has all grown up. And yet its so disappointing. He says that, but that relaxed smile never shows any changes. He says, that’s because I know you are holding back. You do better, can't you. Show me that form of yours. The one that pushed Charles so much. I smile, I don't need that to beat you. You couldn't beat Charles, even with your overdrive. That lead you to

endanger innocent children. All because you were weak.

He smirks, such a weak ass approach. Trying to make be doubt myself. I am you, so I know you can't use that form. Your lies don't work on me. I spat out, why don't you show me your overdrive and make me use that form. Once I beat you in your peak, I will have finally gotten rid of you. I tried a little bit of goading myself. Hoping he takes the bait. He suddenly bursts out laughing, look at that. You say you don't want to be like me. But you are exactly doing that. I immediately throw my Kuret at him.

But something weird happens. My Kuret vanishes and leaves me all alone with Wagner. But so did his own Kuret. What the hell happened. He says, do you have a brain damage. This isn't a real fight. You are just a child throwing a tantrum. Not knowing why you were fighting. He raises his arm and snaps his fingers. Immediately I get strapped down to the floor, like an invisible force is pulling me down. What the freak is happening. I can't move from this spot and fell down on my knees. He walks slowly to me, I grew tiered of fighting. So I decided to just end this.

I wriggle out of the invisible shackles. It makes no sense, I was winning. He crouches down, how deluded are you. There are no winners. Only losers here. Only you. I don't get it, what was the fight about then. I bark, you said you wanted to teach me lesson. I haven't learnt enough. Lets continue learning. He sighs, what a kid. I am asking you again, he flicks my forehead, you can't get rid of me. I am a part of you. I yell, never. You are a bad memory, that needs to be removed. He flicks my forehead, wrong answer. Didn't you learn anything. I thought Hansen choose at least a good student. But you are nothing but a disappointment.

I lash out, trying break free. But the bonds get tighter and I get sunk even lower to the ground. Why can't I fight back. He says, because you are too weak. Too afraid to admit it. I ask, admit what. Suddenly, he punches me hard. For the first time I felt pain. It shook my entire being. He says, did you feel that. I am getting stronger. As you continue to hide behind weak reasons, I take more control. I receive another punch on my other cheek. I felt blood trickling out of my nose now.

This is not happening. I can't let this be the end of it. I got my Kuret and beating him. This isn't fair. He grabs my hair and yanks me up, life isn't fair. You of all people know that. You suck it up and move on. But you don't want to. You are too afraid. I yell, I am not afraid of you. He gets closer to me and barks, You are. There is no hiding here. I am you, remember. I know all your deepest desires and the delusions you make for yourself. He drags my head and thrusts me into the floor.

My head shoots up so much pain that it sends shockwaves all to my core. He yanks me by the hair. This is so damn frustrating. I can't believe I am being manhandled like this. This is so embarrassing. He laughs, it is. The great David. You have defeated so many people, but you are still so afraid. That’s why you can never beat me. He let goes of my hair and I crouch down. The blood trickles from my head to the floor. Each drops brings even more emotions. Anger, hate and beyond all, confusion. Why am I so pathetic.

He says, don't ask me. I am you in the end. He then raises his arm to the fire. Is he going to kill me. He says, I am. You will die here, and all that remain will be me. The fire comes closer to engulf me, I felt my skin singeing from the heat. He says, I will be take over you and defeat the Hives. You are too weak. You have created a fantasy to help you recover, but all it did was unleash me. The air becomes thinner and I start breathing from my mouth. This can't be happening. I can't die here. Not like this. All the lives lost would be wasted if I do so pathetically.

I kept pushing myself to break from the shackles. But I just can't. I am too weak. He says, and nothing will change. You refuse to learn the thing I was teaching you. So you will remain weak. He is spouting about things I don't understand. What I am not learning. What I am not admitting. The air becomes so thin, I feel my lungs is on fire. He laughs, you feel that. That’s your brain not having oxygen. Huh? He continues, you moron. You are going to OD. Those many drugs in your blood, did you thought nothing would happen.

The freak. I shakes becomes so tight that I begin to feel the despair. No, this is a trick. He is lying to me. He says, you don't believe. Why don't you see it for yourself. He waves his arm and I begin seeing visions. Something was bright and I saw some screens ahead of me. It was red and dark, like this room. But the terrifying thing was the sound of Drew yelling, M, stabilize him quickly. His heart is defibbing. He is going into shock. Another voice says, oxygen level critical in boss's brain. Drew says, give me his sodium levels. I need to synthesis a sedative.

I am pulled back into the room, chained to the floor. He smiles, see. You are going to die from your own stupidity.

David (Chapter 100)

Friday, February 20, 2026 21:33

All I feel is the pull of a dark void. From within me. I feel its tug so strong I think I am going to topple inside any second. Wagner was laughing out so loud that he was tearing my ears off. Is this it? My final moments are of an imaginary person enjoying at my death. The air is thinning out that makes my body hollow. I think my legs are also disappearing. Wagner says, give up. Its better if you don't struggle anymore. I can't understand him anymore. No, I don't know myself what I want here.

He says, you finally ask the tough question. What do you think you want. To defeat you. He says, that's obvious. But how will you do that when you never learn. So make it easier for both of us. Just die and let me take over. Let me take the wheel. What the freak is he saying. If I die, so will he. He says, I guess that is confusing. Well, your therapist is good doctor. I am sure she will keep you alive a little bit longer. A second there is minutes here. Don't you know about the basic dream rules. He chuckles, or a nightmare. Whatever you believe this is.

I realize what his plan is. He wants me to die and then he wakes up, as me. He says, ding, ding. And once I am out, I will do what you are too weak to do. This is all kinds of wrong. Is he talking about a personality takeover. Is that even possible. He says, who knows. I am willing to gamble on that chance. I will get much stronger than you were ever. Because I have no qualms about myself. I know who I am. I can't believe him. I can't let a freak like him go out. He would only terrorize people.

He says, what I do doesn't matter. I will be born again. This was the plan from the beginning. Letting you go through the hoops of your trauma was a bonus. The freak is he talking about. This is not his dream. He says, not at the beginning. But don't you see how much control I gained since then. I don't even need Kuret to kill you. You are killing yourself. All I have to do is wait. No, no. This is not happening. I rather die with him than let him out. He smiles, just how much do you hate me, kid.

There are not enough words to show much I do. He is deluding himself if he thinks he is a better than me. He says, oh really. Tell me why. I am the most powerful Medrone. There is no one better than me. Just because you are strong, it doesn't make you better. Look at me, I am the prime example. He comes closer to me and kicks me in the head. The pain stings so much its hurting me all over. He says, just die already. I don't have to prove anything to you. A better person will wake up then.

The air is hardly there anymore. The oxygen is not reaching to my brain causing me start hyperventilating. How much longer will I last now. Seconds? Minutes? I refuse to give into the despair. The dark abys within me so strong I feel the moment I give up, I am gone. He says, don't struggle. There is no point. This is not how I die. I need to figure something out. I have been in hopeless situation so many times. There is always a way. He says, there is none.

I raise my eyes at him. He was truly enjoying this. The anger and hate I feel towards him is literally going to kill me. Why would my subconscious even bring him to me. Do I have a death wish. I need to do something. He has been lecturing about me not realizing something. He said it many times. I have been so furious at him that I never thought to think about it. What does he mean I am not accepting something. What is there to admit. I already want to be better than him. He had so much power, but he wastes it on being a trash. I would never be like him. Ever. Does he want me to admit that I am afraid I will become like him. Despite how much I detest him.

He chuckles, such delusions. Its actually funny to see you trying to figure this out. The time is ticking, I suggest you rather say goodbye to your imaginary friends. No, that's can't be true. Its something else. I may use his knowledge, but never be like him. I refuse to believe any part of me admires him this much. Then what is it. He suddenly grabs me by the collar, you are one stubborn bastard. Just how long are you going to keep this farse up. Give up and die. You will be doing the world a favor.

He starts to relentlessly punch and kick me. The pain slowly spreads. There is hardly any air left that I beginning to fade out. The dark void is pulling me in. I can't keep my thoughts straight. The singular moments when he pauses in between his attacks feels getting shorter and shorter. I hate him. But I hate myself more. I can't let go any of this hate. How insane it is that I refuse to let it go. So many people helped get where I am now, guiding me and pushing me ahead. Their faces pop in my head.

I saw James grinning at me. Liz holding my hand. Branden helping me. Hansen guiding me. Istra assuring me. John reminding me. Zakerine loving me. Wagner killing me. Is this my life flashing before me. No, I am missing so many others. People are depending on me. But what can I do. I am getting beaten down in my own nightmare. In fleeting glances I saw Wagner gleaming with bright eyes as he continues to inflict mind numbing pain. How sadistic he is. I don't even remember him being this much in the real life.

Real life? I was about to lose hope, but it burned a little longer now. That question triggered a chain reaction. Wagner stops hitting me and pauses, you have nothing. Just die. He grabs me by my neck and starts to squeeze the life out of me. My body feels so light, deprived of air and hope. I might disappear any second. I gather every ounce of hope I can gather to fight back. I feel like I am the cusp of grasping something. And Wagner is afraid of it. That's why he is getting desperate.

His grip tightens further proving my point. What is it he is afraid of. Something about him being different in real life. But that was just a thought. Its not really possible. Is it? He was a menace and abusive. Just like he is now. But I feel like someone close to me thought he was decent. Who was it. How could anyone believe that lie. He was a monster. Then an image of a women pops up. Who is she. Why is she so familiar. Something about her makes me feel stronger. I need to remember her, she is my only hope right now.

Wagner yells, she has nothing to do with this. That throws me a spiral of emotions. He knows her. And then before I could even realize I say, Vanessa. I can't believe I had forgotten her. Wagner yells, she can't help you. Not here. His fist feels like it dug deep into my throat. She claims she saw a different side to him. But I know what he was like. She was little child back then. She would hardly remember what he was like. But why do I keep circling back to this feeling. I saw what happened, the atrocities he did. He wasn't a good person. She is wrong about him.

And yet I can't let it go of that suspicion. Is he really the villain I am making him out to be. Wagner yells, there is nothing to understand. You hate me. There is nothing else. What he said was even more strange. He said I was deluding myself earlier. Perhaps he did have some lingering goodness of him. Just then he begins to choke me harder. I barely had any essence of my being left. The void is beckoning me. I can feel it. The only thing keeping me sane right now is the hope I just got from Vanessa.

What am I missing here. Come on, think. Think. He is just as bad as I remember him. He had the same smile when he fought me earlier. The same menacing smile, enjoying the fight. He was completely immersed in the thrill of the fight. A chill ran through my body. What. The. Freak. In here, he is me. Then what I saw was myself. My own reflection. I finally realized something. Something insane. Wagner gets mad, just die already. You are weak, you are no one. This is simply not possible. It can't be. But I felt it so strongly.

Wagner says, just few more seconds. Then I would be finally be born. This isn't Wagner. That's what Vanessa came to show me. He never enjoyed when he was being abusive. That's what I made up about him. All this time. I thought I was trying not be like him. But I am him. I get it now. Wagner screams, you get nothing. But his words had lost its effect on me. I need to say it. I feel that once I say it, I will be free. Free from this chains. Free from this delusion.

Wagner tried to shut my mouth. But I don't need mouth to this. This is my dream. I am terrified to say it aloud. Everything will change once I say it. I will start believing this. The fear is so damn chilling that I can feel it swallowing me up. But I had to say it. Will all my resolve I blurt out, I like my power. One of the chains snap and I get my strength back. Wagner tries hard to put me down. But I continue, I want to become the strongest Medrone ever. Another shackles brake. Wagner's grips on becomes weak. He yell, no you don't. You are afraid of becoming like me.

I reply, that's what kept me from realizing the truth. You said you were teaching me something. I get it now. You were showing what I really wanted. The thrill of a deadly fight. Another shake broke. Wagner is forces back and stumbles back on his ass. The force pulling me down had gotten weakened that I was finally able to stand up. This is my deepest desire. I have been refusing to admit this. All the time on Medrine, I envied people with strong Kuret. I was literally the weakest Medrone to have ever lived on Medrine.

But that has changed now. I have gotten power to rival many of the strongest Medrines now. I say, I want to beat Charles and become the strongest Medrone in history. The shackle are so weak now that I can almost feel I am free from it. Wagner is confused and anxious. As he should be. Because I am admitting the stuff I never knew I had. He says, you are being arrogant. And conceited. I reply, I am. There is no denying it. I began to feel this way back when I was fighting Charles. I experienced something I never felt before. Many people have asked me about this, but I just put it off. Giving vague excuses or refusing to admit it.

He says, what's that got to do with you hating me. I explain, I was feared myself and I made that fear into you. Because you were the easiest person for me to blame everything. The final shackle broke, releasing all the restraints on me. I felt like the weight of an my entire existence has been lifted from me. It feels so good to finally admit how I truly felt. I say, I wasn't afraid of becoming you, I was afraid of what I will become. What will I be when I am so selfish. And you were my scapegoat. A coinvent villain. I blamed you so much that I distorted how I saw you.

I walk to him, just like Vanessa replaced your memories, I did the same about my feelings towards you. I was just a child back then. And one with a rough life. I am sure you had one too that made you like this. I sigh, you are not a decent person. But you aren't what I am making you out to be. Ever since I saw your corpse, it created a domino effect. Hating you, then hating myself because it terrifies me. My body gradually starts to materialize.

The fires around me also gets dimmer. They were representing my anger. Now that I am accepting that part of myself, I am no longer angry. I have been bottling it too much, it was eating me from the inside. The air was back too. Wagner stands up and faces me, but you still hate me. I says, yeah. But not for the right reasons. I was fixated on you for many reasons. You had strength, abelites and reputation. I am envious of that. I want that too. Maybe not the way you had. I want my own thing. He says, you want more than what you already have. That's just greedy.

He wasn't wrong. I am guess I feel like universe needs to give me some kind of reward for all the crap I went through in life. But its not that simple. I know that. And yet I like being powerful. I want to beat Charles in his overdrive. I want to kill the Hive king myself. I want to live the life I want to without feeling guilty anymore. He asks, didn't you say having power doesn't mean you are better than me. I smile, I was wrong. Power only corrupts if you don't value it. It can make me a better person when I use it correctly. And believe me, you will be my biggest reminder to not screw up.

I step forward. He thought I was trying to attack him and raise his arm to defend himself. I think he loosing his sense of identity. Maybe I am realizing mine and he is crumbling away. I say, you can stop playing the tricks on me. Don't you think we had enough of it now. Wagner says, I don't get what you mean. I say, really. I thought you knew what I am thinking. Stop this and show yourself. The scene changes in front of me and we are now standing outside on the plaza. The same place were all I found everyone on Medrine.

But this time, all the bodies were back in their place. I saw everyone here, the people I didn't recognize and the ones I do. Slater, Istra and Wagner. I finally found them and brought them back here. A voice behind me says, this place has haunted me for so long. I thought hiding them would have made it better. I turn around and see the person I wanted to see. It was me, but the child me. Its me when I saw this the first time. He says, you really think it will be all right.

I shrug, no idea. It scares the hell out of me. But it feels me with excitement too. He asks, what if he turn out to worse than Wagner. I say, that will never happen. Unlike him, we have friends. He says, that’s true. I also had few good ones in Medrine. But almost all of them are gone. I answer, I made new friends. People I can trust. Who can trust me too. He asks, even after all the lying. I answer, well, its going to be hard to change. But its not impossible. I prefer to think this a new beginning for me. For us.

He looks around the dead people. He says, I want one. The plan I had for my future is gone. But maybe. I help me out, we can make a different one. And it starts by embracing the truth. He sighs, I never thought I would ever like this life. The constant fighting and scheming. I say, neither did I. I had a simple life for a while. Like how you wanted. But things change. And its not all bad. We can finally enjoy what I have been denying. I want to get better, not only for others, but for myself. I want to see how much far I can go. How much we can achieve. Don't you think that sounds awesome.

He smiles, sounds, he pauses a little and says, interesting. I say, you made me jump through all the hoops for this. Didn't you. He says, not everything. We are not always in control. You know how it is, some pieces of memories, some liberties and few theories. You know, the usual. That made me giggle. He says, sorry about Wagner though. You were too stubborn to admit what you wanted. And nothing makes me more angrier than him. I had to use that to pry open your emotions. Sometimes you don't need a pen. I answer for him, you need a sword. He nods, I hoped Wagner would invoke all kinds of emotions out of you.

I say, only I can be so diabolical. We both laugh at that thought. I ask, and what about me dying and him getting out. He says, creative liberties. Needed to push you to your limits. I can't believe my subconscious was so scheming. I guess I should be impressed by myself. I outdid myself. Which is all already very confusing. He says, lets not think about it too much. Otherwise you will go insane. I say, by admitting the truth, I am already a little insane. He says, maybe you have to be to live in such a crazy world.

That is true. The world I live is messed up. I have to be a little crazy. He says, but a good kind. I answer, the best kind. Having such a strange existential conversion with myself had been enlightening. I am having a feeling that its time. I ask, how much will remember of this when I wake up. He says, no idea. But I hope you remember the important things. I want that too. The warm glow beings to wrap me even more. Before I get swept by it I say, you coming. He smiles and walks to me to join in the embracing light.

I feel my emotions are heightened right now. I feel great. Acceptance is such a powerful thing. My body shakes a little as I begin stirring and wake up. I couldn't move yet, but I felt something strange. Something new. My Kuret was flowing into me. What's going on. I see pieces of my vision. I am back in my house, sitting in the couch. I can see the glimmer of my Kuret flowing in me from my surrounding. This has happened to me few times before. The first time during the fight with Hive commander six years ago. Then when I got my new heart. When I almost drowned in the sea water. Last year when I was in the war with Hive. Just like then, I can sense that the new black Kuret is flowing inside me.

Its probably the drugs making me feel woozy. But I swear this is happening. Every time I had a break through of some kind, my Kuret grew stronger. If this happened again, does this mean what I think. The Kuret is so much present in the air, it feels overwhelming. I couldn't feel everything, but I know it is flowing into me. I don't think Drew this. She is siting beside me like nothing was going on. Then maybe I was still hallucinating this.

My eyes lazily open. The first thing I could recognize was the multiple screens in front of me. It should different images, some were shades of colors, some themes and others were places. Something gets stuck in my throat. I cough a little. I hear a faint voice of Drew moving around me. I feel her cold hands behind my neck and she puts a pillow behind it. My lungs feels like it is on fire. My skin feels so itchy that I could just scratch my entire skin. Drew comes closer to my eyes and says something inaudible.

What's going on. What happened. It took a long time for the disorientation to leave. Drew kept asking me something. Her voice was slowly getting louder. She throws a light at my eyes and inspects my condition. I know the light is thin, but it felt like floodlights to me and blinds me. Few minutes go by and begin to hear Drew, can you hear me now. My throat is so heavy and sour, it pricks a little as I move. I managed a blink to let her know. She says, good. Her voice shows relief. She says, where does it hurt right now. She places her hand on my chest. She says, tell me when. I blink twice when it was near my throat. She nods, okay. That’s what I expected. She turns around and picks up a beaker.

She lifts my head up and brings it closer to my mouth, drink this. This will clear the blockage. She pushes it against my lips and try it hard to swallow the hot liquid. The warm liquid soothes me a little. But then I immediately feel nauseous. The hell she gave me. I felt like throwing up. She knew I was going to have this reaction and brings a garbage bucket. I tilt my head and lean towards it. I cough up the liquid and a little bit of blood. That was disgusting and brutal.

I lean away when I empty my throat. I lean back on the pillow. But I felt infinitely much better, like my lungs were cleaned out. I open my mouth and ask, what happened. She says, a lot. Take a minute to gather yourself first. She was right, the weird sensation was slowly going away. My skin begins to feel my own. She brings her tablet, M, run a complete diagnostics on him. Do a full workup of his blood and tissue. I need to know if there was any adverse negative side effects. M says, running diagnostics.

Another minute went by and I could feel my body getting better. I look around the room. She had dragged more table around me with her stuff on it. I look down on my chest and see a small bleeding coming from the spot. She says, that was from the needle in your heart. You will feel a little prick from inside. So move very slowly. I pull myself slowly and try to sit upright. The pain in me chest stung me sharply. She wasn't kidding about the pain. But I muster through it as Drew helps pull the recliner into a sitting position.

I turn to see the dialysis machine running and cleaning my blood with the two needles on me. The metal ring is still on my head. Drew brings out a scanner device and begins waving it around my neck and chest. When its done, she says, all clear. You don't have any other blocked passages. I think that was just a small tear in your esophagus. The drug from your blood spilled out and hardened a little from your spit. You should be okay now. My feel shaky, did I die a little bit?

She becomes curious, you remember that. I nod. She has a nervous smile, you were in a such deep trance. I lost you for majority of the time near the end. I try to recall what happened, but it’s all a blur. Actually, it gave me a headache when I try to think too much. She says, take it easy, David. You went through something completely untested. We don't know the side effects of this yet. Don't strain yourself. Just relax for now. Deep breathing. With me now. She takes deep breath, it helps to mirror her actions.

Another minute goes by. It helped me calm down a lot. M says, boss's blood work are done. He still some drugs left in his system. But the sedatives you administered are flushing them out. Drew says, what about this neural activity. M says, boss suffered through near cardiac arrest, and the drugs are still burning him up. I can't get an effective scan until it cools down. I ask, cardiac arrest. You don't mean. She says, you went into a shock 10 minutes ago. Your was body shut down, and your heart stopped. Freaking hell. I ask, how long. She hesitantly says, 62 seconds.

Bloody hell. I spat out, I was dead for a minute. She says, clinically dead. But yeah. I had to a use the defibrator to restart your heart. Thankfully, you made it out before you suffered permanent damage to you brain. It was deprived of oxygen for few seconds. I get a little confused and angry, I thought you had the dosage right Drew. What the hell happened. She puts her hands on her knees, I told you this before. This was experimental. Things could go wrong at any moment. I recall about the risks. I sigh, I remember now. Sorry. She says, don't worry about it. Just focus on you breathing. Besides, I didn't anticipate it would turn this bad myself.

I say, I feel parched. Is it okay to drink water. She grabs me a jug, more than okay. Keep yourself hydrated. I gulp down the entire jug of water. Water spills around my mouth on my skin, I still have a slight headache. She says, perfectly normal. I am not turning on the lights because your nervous system is short circuited. Your nerves are hyper active. I say, I have numbness on my hands and legs. She says, I sedated you with a nerve relaxant. Its more effective in your limbs right now.

I suppose she is covering all her basis. I say, thanks for saving my life. She says, you are welcome. But don't overthink it. You are my responsibility. She bites her lips. Its unsettling that this happened despite when I took every precaution possible. The worst I believed was you going into a shock. But your nervous system refused to corporate with any of the sedatives. I ask, what does that means. She says, not sure yet. I will do that analysis later, once M runs all tests. I lean back my head back on the pillow. My headache is getting better for a while. I am strangely not panicking, even though I nearly died.

I ask her, how long was I out. She turns to one of the displays which had a clock, its been 97 minutes. So about 92 minutes. I scoff, that’s all. I feel like I just spend days stuck in a dream. She grabs her tablet from the table with a digital pen. She begin taking some notes. She says, I have been documenting each step. She scribbles down while I flex my wrist a little. After she is done, she puts the tablet down and faces me, how does it feel. Any soreness. I say, not really. Just feels a little heavy. She says, lets test your motor skills. I want to see if we damaged any of your nerve endings. She begins physical checkup of my joints in my arms and legs. Then we inspect my senses. I let her check my iris reflexes to see any signs of visual feedback damage.

She performs the same for my hearing and my tongue. Apart from the bitter after taste of few pills she just gave, I didn't feel anything wrong with my taste. She says, I didn't find anything wrong. You show signs of dehydration and a little bit of shingles, but that’s normal under the influence of the drugs. How's your head. Any particular area you feel pain. I point to one part of my skull that was still throbbing. She asks, M, what is going there. M says, boss's neurons are still hyper active. His pain receptors are still active. She asks, even after so much time has passed. I ask, is that bad. She thinks for a second, I mean I thought it would dissipate in few minutes.

I look over to the table beside her, maybe give me a sedative for a pain killer. She turns to the injector and then back to me, sorry. I know you are in discomfort, but I rather not risking inflaming your tissues. Instead, drink this. She brings out a different bottle. This one had a very familiar scent, she says, its just electrolytes mixed with some mints. It might help with the pain. I gladly drink it. She was right about be dehydrated. I swallowed the whole thing in one breath. She then places an ice pack on my head where I felt pain. The cool contact immediately soothes me. She says, I was afraid you would go into a withdrawal.

I say, I am guessing I got lucky. She says, not just that. Your medical history boasted your white blood cells. Your immunity. He scoffs, what a delightful coincidence. I don't know what would have happened if you never went through that cycle of treatments. At least there was some upside of being hospitalized for years. She asks, M, turn on half the lights. I think his disorientation is gone. The side profile lights turn on and I squint my eyes a little. For a brief moment my eyes strain under the light. However, like she said, I adjusted to it quickly.

She says, you okay. I nod, just shaking off nerves. I look down to my body and I realized I had been sweating like crazy. My pant is drenched in sweat. God, I hope I didn't peed myself. She then pulls her tablet, you show remarkable resistance to the drugs. Are you sure you feel okay. I crack my neck a little from the sourness of my position I was stuck in. With slow movements I stand up. She puts her arm on my shoulder, what are you doing. Don't get up. Too late, I immediately stumble back on the chair from the heaviness of my body.

She rebukes me, there are still lot of drugs coursing in your system. I turn look at the dialysis machine that was filtering my blood. I ask, you gave me a sedative right, can I at least get this off me. She takes a moment to think about it. She made up her mind, I guess its fine. Few minutes later I have gausses and bandages where the needles were. It felt better. I couldn't exactly explain the feeling. She says, how does it feel. Better. She says, I see. That must be also causing you pain in your nerves. Good call there. She picks up her tablet and taps something.

She asks, I know you need rest, but I need to do a physiological test. I am confused, now? She nods, it is imperative. You just went through a visual therapy. Your experience is still fresh in your mind. This will help me check if your mind experienced any phycological trauma. She made sense, though I felt a little concerned. My memories are still woozy about the dream. But I honestly don't feel anything wrong. There is no harm in checking. She first gives me an IQ test for 5 minutes. After that she says, 158. Huh? I scored 2 points lower. She saw my confused state and smile, its all right. You didn't get dumber, there is a margin of error I anticipated from the drugs.

I hope she is right. My IQ is my biggest tool. She then gives a simple color coding question to judge my emotional state. She says, that’s good. You seem to be responding well. She then points to the screen, next is the word association test. You know the drill, just tell me the first thing comes to your mind. I had a few reservations about this. What I say something wrong. She say my worry on my face, relax. I rigged the images that could cause issues out of this. I am only checking for positive reactions, not negative right now.

That made me feel less anxious. She says, lets begin. The first image is of Medrine. I say, lost. Then its Earth, home. A picture of puppy, pet. A spider, creature. Kuret, power. Fire, destroy. Forest, nature. Weapons, tool. Sky, vast. And mundane things like that continues. I kept answering with the thing that comes first in my mind. She looks over her tablet down, excellent. You don't show any physiological degradation. That’s good. Turns out, I was being nervous for no reason. She asks, how you feel if I give you another round. A little harder one.

I ask, like the stuff that is a minefield for me. She answers, in a way, yes. I like to see how you respond to something contentious. I don't know about it. She gives a moment to think about it. I have a mild headache, but that’s all I feel right now. I am beginning to be more aware of myself with a clear thoughts. With a slight nervous expression, I give her a nod. She says, at any if you feel anything wrong. Just raise your hand, you don't even have to say it. I will stop this immediately. I nod appreciating her concern.

She starts new images. The first is about a burning city, sad. Alien ships in the sky, flee. Bodies of some blurred out dead people, disaster. A group of Hive solders walking on a street, run. Destroyed buildings and roads, devastated. Medrones fighting Hive, revenge. Hive attacking Humans, helpless. Image of a war from last year, avenged. I gave my answers all related to our current struggles and war. Drew asks, are you sure you don't feel any discomfort. I ask, yeah. Something wrong? She makes confused face, not sure. You gave all normal responses. I say, I think I would have given the same answers before this.

She says, its not that. You are inebriated right now. Your first impulse and reaction would be what you say. Your answers could be the same, but your minor physical reactions are different now. They are in the normal range. She is talking about things like micro expressions, breathing changes and heart beats. Stuff like that. I am actually very happy with this result, isn't that good. She faces me, it is. Its just I was anticipating a bit higher number. Logically this only makes sense if your consciously making an effort to hide your reactions.

I didn't know if this was really a cause to be concerned. I say, the deep trance worked then. She scoffs, this improvement is suspicious. Didn't you feel anxious about you almost dying. Wouldn't that make you even more scared after see these images. I gave her my honest feeling, its not like I don't feel sad or depressed about risking my life. But I signed up for this. She asks, you don't have any regrets to have risked so much for this. PTSD can be resolved normally. I answer, it was a calculated risk. I don't feel like I should make a big deal out it.

She inspects me like I am a rat. She even comes closer to check my pupils, they are slightly dilated. You don't seem to be lying too. She scoffs, if this is really how you feel. Then this is incredible. With just one session you seem to have overcome few core issues. I say, you said it was all or nothing. She says, I wasn't expecting this to give results immediately thought. I had a thought. If Drew was saying this was beyond expectation, could I really be okay with the actual stuff. I ask, lets try with the core issue ones. The usual suspects of my triggers.

She says, absolutely not. We don't know if the drugs or you got lucky or the instruments are misreading. We can try it once you get more rest. I insisted, think about it. You are saying I am recovering. I was apprehensive about it a minute ago, but I think I can take it now. She says, there is too much risk. At least wait for some more time. I say, didn't you say its best time to check. I am being brutally honest right now. So is my body. Shouldn't we confirm it now. She has a hard time to accept my proposal. She turns to the screen, M, show up his neural activity. M brings up my brain activity. There were spots of red and yellow. The middle was mostly red.

She says, its very curious. You just had a stoke, and all you have is a some abrasions on your brain. M asks, there is a substantial increase in with the atropine levels in boss's cranial epidural tissues. Drew says, that is because his brain is trying to stay awake and aware from the effects of the drugs. She turns to me with a hard stare. After a tense moment weighing out all the options, she shakes her head. She says, fine. Lets try it. But this time I will use my own desecration to stop this whenever I feel like it. I say, that’s fair. I felt a mix of anxious and excitement.

She says, relax back. She picks up an injector, I will use this to knock you out cold if I see any hint of an adverse reaction. I nod in anticipation. She sighs, god. Why did I listen to you. He gestures me to the screen. She asks, ready. I nod. The first image is of me as a child bloody and hurt. I immediately say, struggle. Drew looks over the screen beside her. She didn't flip over the next image. She glanced over the screen and to me. She says, that’s all. Honestly, it was a disappointment. I ask, why did you think this would be a trigger for me. That’s just me miraculously surviving Medrine.

Drew's eyes widen. She stares at me so intensely that I felt uncomfortable under her scrutiny. She says, all right. Lets try the next one. Its just a word saying Zakerine, tragedy. She pauses to read my readings. She asks, you don't feel guilty or anger. I answer, of course I do. I feel responsible for it too. She could have saved herself. Or maybe I could have saved her. That being said, it was her decision. I can be angry at her, but it wasn't truly my fault. She ask, you have forgiven yourself. I think about it for a second, more like I have accepted that her death was a tragedy and something I couldn't control.

She clears her throat, you remember how you were obsessing over it a week ago. How does that feel. I say, confused. And embarrassing. I understand the emotional trauma I was going through. I remember the frustration too. But mostly I feel pity on myself. I took a lot of unnecessary burden. She says, unbelievable. Those are some. She mumbles a little. I ask, am I being too callous. Because I am trying not be. She says, no. These are normal response. Someone who has grieved over loved one's loss and moved on. I am glad that she understood my intent.

She flips the next images. Blake, friend. Marina, funny. Catherine, hot. She gives me curious look. I nervously smiled and blurted out immediately, ah, I mean that objectively. But why are you showing them. She answers, I need a baseline to measure. I want to see it there is a new trigger instead. That’s a terrifying thought. But I wasn't too concerned about it. Next is Nathan, problematic. Jess, potential. Tessa, dependable. Matt, good. Cassandra, sis. Vanessa, love. I started coughing a little. What the freak did I just say. I nervously bit my lip and peek at Drew. She is more composed then me. I sneakily turn away and wait for the next image.

This is so mortifying. I basically outed something very personal. I am so confused about it. I have never been so forthcoming about this before. Thankfully Drew didn't ask for details and we move on. Next was a word. Hansen, respect. Shadow keeper, strong. Shadow retrievalist, mystery. Shadow spy, guidance. John, regret. She pauses for a second. She turns to me, be prepared for the final one. I already knew who it was. An image of Wagner appears. I thought this one would stir up a lot of emotions. But the only one I felt relevant was, jackass.

There is utter silence in the room. The only sound was some from the machines. Drew had the injection placed near my shoulder, that’s all you got. I am a little taken aback from this too. I say, I got more. She waits for me. I says, a pain in the ass. Worst person I have ever met. Regret that I never fought him. She stares at me and then to the screens. Even I felt weirded out by my clam demeanor. It seems so childish that I used to get so much angry at him unnecessary. She says, M, what's the verdict. M says, no adverse reaction beyond the acceptable range. All vitals with normal range. There is no increase in emotion center of boss's brain. She asks, deviation? M answers, ten percent.

I get a little anxious, hold on. Deviation of what. I didn't lie anything. I was honest. She says, its not that. Deviation is the difference between what you said and how your body reflexes reacted. Ten percent is. She trails off with a serious look. I gulp a little, I thought I did good. But maybe I was being too optimistic. She says, its natural. I am so glad she said that, then its normal. She says with a deep thought, it is. A sudden realization came to me, hold on. I didn't have any adverse reaction. Doesn't that mean I didn't get triggered ? What about my PTSD then.

She nervously swipes her lips with tongue. She didn't say it, but her nervous and obvious shock said it all. I don't believe this, this freaking actually did it. I stood up in excitement. Drew didn't even stop me. She just stared at me and the vitals back and forth. I raise my fist in air and shouted, lets freaking go. I did it. No, we did it. I grabbed her hands and clasp it together with mine. She was bewildered to the point she was stunned. All she gave me was a curious look. I understand her shock. We both didn't know how effective this would be. I say, thanks Drew. You the best doctor I could have gotten in the whole god damn world. This is awesome.

It turn to look at the screen where Wagner's image still remained. I didn't feel angry anymore. I didn't have the need to gauge his eyes out or break that jaw. Just a normal mix of hate and pity. She stands up with a jacket for me in her hand, I have never seen this before in my entire career. I happily take the jacket and put it on. She says, you don't have a panic attack, or at least an outburst. She pulls out the metal ring from my head, I feel some lingering anxiousness. But not enough that would make me nervous.

She puts her hand on her temple, this makes no sense. There is no magical cure of PTSD. You don't just wake up and suddenly its gone. I get she is worried, but unlike her I am thrilled with this outcome. She asks, what happened in the dream. I ask, what do you mean. Didn't you guide me through the trance. I heard your voice. She says, initially. But then I lost you after a while. I try to recall the moment, but the memory is till fuzzy. I say, its all a blur at the moment. I know I died, but that’s probably just because it was the most recent memory. I gave it some more thought, I think I met people. She says, beside James and Liz?

Their names makes me recall flashes of visions and faint memories. I say, weird. Shouldn't I know more about it. You were there with me. She says, clearly the drugs effects are still there. You will remember soon. I really want to know what really happened. I turn to the door, I remember Marina and Blake are outside. I think I should let them know I woke up. I take a step forward towards the door, but my lazy leg hits at the corner of the couch. Drew says, you really shouldn't move around so much.

I says, sorry. I'll be careful. I just got. I couldn't speak another word. Something strange happens and hunch over. I grab the side the table for support. Drew rushes and grabs my arms, what happened. I couldn't explain this. My body is suddenly hot. I look down at my knees and saw that I unconsciously called on my Kuret the sport where it hurt. It begins to pour out of me without my command. What's going on. Suddenly my brain is on fire. There is loud alert coming from M. M sounds, Dr. Drew. Sedate boss immediately. My vision gets hazy unsure what was going on in the screen. But I felt no pain. Actually, I was feeling awesome. A bliss that I never felt before.

Drew screams over the sound of the alarm, what happened. His vitals were fine a second ago. M says, unclear. There is massive hemorrhaging from bosses entire nervous system. What is she saying, I feel no plain. I feel awesome. My Kuret soothes my agitated skin. Even without asking for it, I was wrapped in my Kuret. I stand back up and suddenly I felt a rush of adrenaline. My thoughts became lazy, but it was the best feeling. Drew backs away from my Kurets rampage. I topped over a table and few glass and its content spill on the ground. Few beakers broke as well.

But I didn't care. I am having the time of my life. Even why I felt metal taste in my mouth I didn't care. Nor when I saw red blurriness near the end of my vision. Drew yells, stop it David. You are sick. I yell, nah doctor. Its the opposite. I feel like the world is mine now. I tighten my fist and expel all my emotions towards the deck door. I didn't even feel commandeering my Kuret. It acted on impulse and I tore through the wall instantly. Drew backs away in the corner to safety. I hear M also saying something. But I no longer cared. I was free and I wanted to enjoy my freedom.

I walk out through the broken wall and doors. My Kuret wraps around me so intensely that I feel invincible. With this power, I can do anything. And to prove that, I thrust myself into the sky.

David (Chapter 101)

Saturday, February 21, 2026 19:22

I stir from the sound of a low music. What happened to me. My eyes open lazily and it takes a few seconds to clear the haze above me. Ah, my body feels sore. I try to move, but I couldn't. I felt my arms and legs were restrained. What the hell. I blink hard and focus on myself. I look around and realize this is my bedroom. I look down to see a strap around my chest that goes around the bed. I had shackles around my wrist and ankles. I wriggle out in frustration. Why I am chained up here. My voice hurts a little for a second. I yell, who did this to me.

The music stops and a soothing chime rings around the room. M says, good afternoon boss. Your vitals have improved considerably. But please don't force yourself. You will break your needles. I say, what is going. M says, what do you remember last. I lean back on to the pillow and try to recall how I got here. The memories become clear after a while. I was with Drew, then my Kuret started acted kind of funky. What happened then. I have vague memories of me doing something. I think I saw people outside my house. Then I jerk suddenly when the memories become clearer, did I fight others?

M replies, you did. You were under the influence of heavy narcotics. We didn't anticipate such a severe reaction to your body after the treatment. You went on a rampage and attacked others. Bloody freaking shit. I recalled glimpses of it. I was mercilessly plundering through others. I didn't have any control over myself. I spat out, I was tripping on acid. M says, a reductive but accurate assessment. Oh shit. I yell, did I hurt anyone. M says, rest assured boss, with Blake and others there, you were got man handled. Though, I get nervous, you totaled your car.

I sigh a relief in response. My car being the only collateral damage was fine with me. Based on how crazy I was acting, I got off easy. I move my arm a bit, what's with the prisoner treatment. M says, yesterday you suddenly woke up in the middle of night and hit your head while trying to walk without seeing. This was done to stop hurting yourself. I click my tongue, I don't remember that one at all. M says, that was the last vestige of the effects of the drug. You were heavily sedated and barely conscious.

Jeez, what a mess. I ask, what happened to me. I was okay, you said so yourself. M says, you were boss. There was no problem with you. Aside from an irregular neural activity, you were recovering. But the moment you used your Kuret, your vitals changed. And for reasons unknown, the drugs that were inactive in you system suddenly interacted. Resulting in a brain hemorrhaging. I recalled the taste of blood in my mouth. And I think I was bleeding through my eyes too. I asked shocked, I was bleeding from inside out. What the hell. Please tell me that is no longer happening.

M turns on a display of my brain activity. I have seen enough times to understand that its normal now. M says, the neural chip embedded behind your neck had short circuited and we had replace it. I ask, how that happened. M says, your brain activity generated so much heat that it broke it. My jaw hung loose, my brain fried the chip. All because I was high on drugs. That is ridiculous. M says, please wait for Dr. Drew to arrive. I saw your neural activity spiking and messaged her. She will be arriving shortly.

That’s good. I nervously look around my body. I was wearing a thin white cloth. But then I focused my eyes on something small. I ask, you said something about needles. Is this. M says, acupuncture needles. You have 87 pressure needles from all over your head, your face to your scalp. This is to stimulate your nerves. Please be mindful of that. She should have led with this. I take a deep breath and relax myself. I ask, I think am okay right now. Get me out of the straps. M says, Dr. Drew gave strict instructions for you to not move.

I sigh, I won't leave the bed. I just want to sit for comfortably. M says, all right boss. However, please restraint yourself from using your Kuret. We don't know what other side effects there will be. I nod. The next second I hear a mechanical noise. Then a combat bot in its compact mode approaches me. I ask, its been reactivated. Since when? M says, Drew asked for assistance for delivering the sedatives. My objectives allowed to wake them up in case of emergency. I ask, did others saw it too. M says, they did. I sigh, I was hoping they didn't. I was going to give them to IDF, but I needed to explain its function first.

The combat bot had shifted to two legs and three arms. With meticulous movements, it removes my restraints. I am finally able to move again. The bot leaves the room as I slither back and take rest on the pillows. There was a bottle kept on the side labeled, drink me. It was from Drew. I uncorked it drank it without checking what it was. My throat was so dry that I didn't care. It tasted like electrolytes. I could a little as I wipe my lips. I ask, how long was I out. M says, you have been unconscious for 39 hours. The shock jerks me a little, two days. Seriously. M says, another consequence we failed to anticipate.

I lost more days due to this. I lie back trying to sort out my memories. Few minutes went by and I began recollecting everything after I started the hypnosis deep trance. I smile when I realized what had just happened. I got over my PTSD. The joy surged though me like electricity. The dream I was having is also somewhat clear to me now. Did I really talk to myself disguised as dead people. I think I made promises to certain people too. This is so weird. But I was curious of something. I ask, M, run protocol for evaluating PTSD triggers. M says, boss, I strongly advice that.

I say, just do it. I want to check it if really happened or was that because I was high. M turns on the display on the other wall. M says, advising caution. The she starts to play photos of all the Shadow members. One by one they go by in different scenarios. Alive, then dead. They were all generated variations to test my emotions. It ended with Wagners photo. I quint my eyes, blink hard. Even tilt my head sideways. But I felt normal. If I wasn't covered in needles, I would slap my own cheeks to confirm. Nothing. All I feel are normal emotions. This is really happening. My PTSD is gone. I haven't had a panic attack, or a night terror. Does it mean I have gotten over my issues.

I raise my fists in the air overjoyed and started laughing. Then I felt a little sting in my chest. M says, careful boss. The nano bots didn't have time to completely heal your ribs. I stung a little, but it still felt good. I decided to view the recording when I woke up that night. After seeing how crazy my behavior was, I hear a car approaching. M says, Dr. Drew is here. A minute later she walks in. She wore hear usual jacket and jeans. Drew says, David. Glad to see you up. She puts her crane and bag to the chair and walks to my bedside. I say, its good to see you too. I made a lot of mess, didn't I. She asks, did M tell you or you remembered.

I say, both. I just saw the video recording of me absolutely humiliating myself in front of others. She smiles at me. I can't believe how I was cruelly rating everyone's attack. I was being especially rude to Vanessa. She says, they understood it wasn't you. You were, I offered, high on drugs. Wasn't I. She nods, there wasn't much left in your system. I say, we should have just kept the dialysis machine running a little longer. Could have avoid all the mess. I don't know how I thought it was okay to take it off. That’s my bad.

She says, you were awake and aware, but you couldn't process complex thoughts. Its my fault too. I didn't realize sooner what just happened. I ask, does that means you figured it out what really happened. She sighs, I spent the whole day yesterday and this morning to understand what went wrong. At first it didn't make sense. You just woke up and displaying extraordinarily ordinary responses. The same stuff that would trigger various complex and intense emotions few weeks ago. I add, and FYI, I just tested myself again now. I had the same response.

She asks, seriously. You could have just waited for me. I shrug, the curiosity was eating at me. She chuckles, its fine. I found out something last night and knew you were going to be fine. These restraints were just a precaution. I ask confused, so how is it am already cured. She says, like I was saying. It was strange, and then something even stranger happened. The moment you used your Kuret, your brain started to do act up. A completely unprecedented chain reaction happened. I nervously ask, what kind of reaction are we talking about.

She pulls out her tablet from her chair and gives it to me. The display was split into two halves. One said before and the other after. It was a snapshot of a few seconds of my neural activity. She says, this one is before we started our therapy. And this one is from this morning. Notice any differences. I didn't understand her. This wasn't a typical MRI scan. It was showing a 3D grid of neural pathways and activity. What difference will this show? Regardless, I analyze the data. If we are talking just about visual difference, I can easily spot it.

I point to a section at the corner, this one. It's a little different. I see a new fork in the path. Then I notice a difference where the fork is now a new path. I didn't understand the meaning behind it. Considering Drew should me it to me personally, I am missing something here. She says, the difference you are seeing is the cause of that sudden hemorrhaging. I realize something and asked horrified, you said this is my neural pathways. I am guessing it doesn't change naturally.

She says, unless you have an accident or loose cognitive ability, this type of restructuring doesn't happen. At least not without severe consequences. I am lost here. I ask, what are you saying to me. She says, your brain rewired itself. I drop my tablet in utter shock. I bit my lip confused, how did that happen. She picks up the tablet, it doesn't happen naturally in Humans. But this happens to Medrones. I ask, seriously. When does that happen. She asks, how much do you know about Ketriya.

The name sounds familiar, I try to recollect that info. She cocks her head, you do? How. I couldn't tell her how, its not like I know everything. I say, I read about it once. But I don’t recall everything. She says, its a hormonal growth in young Medrones. Typically between the ages of 4 and 6. It used to be common knowledge back on Medrine. But now with so less people, only few knowledgeable know about it. Mostly those trained medically.

I gathered the rest from this information, children born on earth don't go through it anymore. Isn't that right. They go through it during puberty now. Very less percentage of our current young population are teenagers, around 40% will through it in two years. She says, you know your stuff. I say, it’s was a fascinating statistics. But what is that got to do with me. She says, children go through Ketriya when they awaken their Kurets. Its a natural and normal growth for kids. Since you heard about it, then do you know how it work.

I didn't know the details, refresh my memories. She says, until kids use their Kuret, our brain is very identical to Humans. But as you grow, it changes bit by bit. It normal for both species. Except there is one critical difference. Medrone kids brain goes through a metamorphosis. Speaking your language, it recodes itself. Changes the neural paths to adjust for the new conscious control of their Kuret. Every kid goes through it, with no exception. It happens slowly over a period of weeks. And its completely harmless and painless. Almost no one realizes it since its become such a norm. A natural growth for kids

I finally understand what she is telling me. It only made me puzzled, are you saying I went through Ketriya. But I am already an adult. Besides, you said the brain develops for Kuret control. I already have it. She says, like I said, there are no exceptions to this. That is, until two days ago. You became the sole exception in entire history of Medrone to go through Ketriya as an adult. The most extreme case I heard back on Medrine was of age 8. You broke the record by three times. I am bamboozled from being such an aberration.

I shake my head, no. That can't be. I have never gone through any sort of Kuret puberty. She says, you did now. I confirmed it last night with multiple tests.. Ketriya is a phase where Kuret grows along with restructuring of the brain during the weeks in brief phases. You, she points her index finger to me, have been going through it for the past 20 twenty years. This is an unpreceded case in which you are an extremely late bloomer. I sigh, I have become a more unique outlier in all of Medrone.

Freaking hell. I finally experienced something that normal Medrone have. This made me strangely happy too. Like I belonged to Medrones and not just due to biology. I ask, so the bleeding from my brain. It was because Ketriya happened to an adult brain. She nods, young children's brain's are plastic, able to handle modifications much easier than adults. Your brain experienced a massive growth that night. Such a long Ketriya had bound to cause a lot of scaring and abrasions. I suspect if you were normal Medrone, you wouldn't have survived such a brutal evolution.

I can't wrap my head around this startling revelation. There had to be reason for this. I ask, is it because was a MAR's subject? She nods, most likely. She nervously shifts in her chair, I have a wild theory. Would you like to hear it. I say, you know people like us love theories. Lay it on me. She says, back on Medrine. I had a chance to see MAR's research dossiers. The agencies wanted to understand their extremist ideology. Me and many others people were consulted. And it was pretty much what everyone knows. They were experimenting on infants to make them live on Earth with access to Kuret. I had forget about a term I saw in that research, Ketriya deficiency disorder.

I understood what it means from the name. But I haven't come across this from our secret project research. She says, it doesn't exist. I am confused, so it’s a made up disease. She says, not quite. MARs claims this is real, but no

one could study it to prove its existence. A moment later I realize why, you think MAR's were kidnapping pregnant women and children before anyone knew. She says, we can't prove something exists when we can't test it. I vaguely remembered the details outlined in that research. So here's my theory, MAR's were either targeting people with this disease or maybe even causing it to susceptible people. I can't comment why or how, but they might have chosen people with this genetic mutation for their research.

This is the first time since Nathan that I heard a theory like this. I ask, any evidence? She says, the research might have mentioned something about prolonging KDD. Stretching it out over years, rather than years. That way, even without your Kuret access, the rest of your brain could develop uninterrupted. At the time it was completely ludicrous. Delaying Ketriya will result in Medrone kid's death in a few years. Everyone dismissed this outright and called them pseudo mad scientist. But now its possible we have found a case. You. Your growth doesn't matched exactly like how they detailed. But this is actual, nature influenced, evolution and that was a theory on a paper.

I took a moment to take this in. I ask, so they modified our genetics to adjust Ketriya period. Something that would be lethal to normal kids. Assuming if we had KDD at birth and diagnosed to die soon since we wouldn't survive without it. Does that mean MAR's were trying to saving us? This made my thoughts upside down. All this time everyone, including me, have assumed MAR's were crazy scientists and lofty agendas. Drew says, maybe. They could have found a way to cause it artificially. We can't rule it out. She is right, there are still suspicious. But this opens a new discussion about them.

I say, there is a lot of maybes. She says, it’s a theory. I couldn't really fact check this. There are few trained professionals in the Island, but none know about their research. But I believe few people from Citradel could know about it. They have more scientists and research data. Another reason for me to bring them here. KDD is an intriguing research subject. I ask, can you share what you know about it. She says, sure. I have been making notes from memories. Why do you need it. I couldn't tell it was for my project. I answer, I have my own private genetics labs with my team. If your theory is right, I like to find prove of this. She nods, that could be important. It might be helpful in the future for our kids in case this KDD is real.

She made a good point. MAR's experiments were on Earth. So are every surviving Medrone. The chances of KDD happening naturally might be low, but its still possible. Once again I am reminded of how my value as a test subject. I sigh, I wish at least one MAR's scientist had survived. There are so many questions to be asked. Why people were left on Earth cryogenically frozen and tool some of us back to Medrone. Drew says, perhaps they were failed subjects while the kids with you in the orphanage were successful. I didn't like the thought of labeling Liz as a failure. But I get Drew is only viewing this from a scientist point of view.

It can't really deny completely though. Nathan once suspected the same thing before. She says, anyways. That’s just my speculation. From this point on, its hard facts. I ask, there is more? She smiles, there is. I haven't explain why this happened to you so suddenly. She takes the tablets and taps on the screen. A minute she says, M, run the program from my tablet. A hologram shows in the middle of the room. It first showed a map of neural pathways. She says, this is your brain after you arrived on Earth. You had taken many MRI's and CT scans, I was able to make a model from the data.

M says, its accurate with only 63% confidence. Drew says, it’s a good enough approximation. Then another neural map forms beside it, this one is when you had your heart transplant. Then three more appear, this from 8 months ago, 2 days ago and this morning. Laying my brain scans juxtaposed in a timeline, the differences in the pathways becomes much apparent. Drew explains, this is how I know your Ketriya been active for years. I don't any data for your time on Medrone. So I don't want to assume anything. But there is clear changes since arriving on Earth. Actually there is trend, first 8 years, the changes were very minimal.

She points to the fast three scans, its been progressing much rapidly. Culminating with the highest 28 percent change 2 days ago. When you accidently used your Kuret, it triggered the final phase of Ketriya. My eyes dart around the timeline. Specifically the time she recorded the data. She didn't have all the data. I think there is even more evidence to support this. I say, I have experienced my Kuret evolving differently than others for few years. I didn't tell her about how I imagined seeing Kuret from the surrounding flowing into me.

She says, so you felt it too. In fact, in your match with Charles, a few pathways tried to change, but it reverted very quickly. Your body had resisted Ketriya. But for that brief time, your Kuret control skyrocketed. Damn, that was my physical Kuret breakthrough. That's why I haven't been able to use it since then. Freaking balls. I scoffs, are you telling me that it wasn't due to how I learned from Charles about his Kuret. It was a freaky coincidence? She says, who says it can't be both. Fueled by the intense pressure, your Kuret control and Ketriya both augmented each other. If it you hadn't resisted the transition, you would sustain brain bleed there itself.

In hindsight, that was actually a good thing. People didn't know about Drew and Drew wasn't remotely prepared to treat me. I say, between your theory and my Kuret awakening, I have a lot to think about it. She nods, take your time. I only explained what I know how your Kuret is different. I ask, so what happens to it. Did I magically gained the complete form. Maybe I will go though Kizaton like how others go through during puberty. She says, I had the same questions. Hard to say. Maybe you already went through it while recovering on Earth. Your optic nerves healing could be part of it. Or maybe its yet to happen. Its hard to predict with your physiology.

I sigh, I am going to need a stiffer drink. She puts the tablet down, save it for later. Because I haven't even told the really fun part. I was ready to be done with this much. What other revelations of my strange existence can be there. She points to the neural maps, look at the timeline. Then think about this past year. And then two days ago. I glances my eyes over it again. I didn't know what I am missing. She says, a hint. See the correlation with your psyche. Her cryptic clue didn't really help. What's so important of the timeline.

Then it hit me. She has been explaining all this for a simple question I asked her. How am I suddenly not having PTSD anymore. If what she is implying is true then. I couldn't finish my thoughts. She realized I caught on, you didn't undergo a lot of drastic changes in your brain for years on Earth. Even after accessing your Kuret, it wasn't significant. But then things took a turn 2 years ago. You started to gain back your memories. We all, including me, assumed that the serum you took lost its effect due to time. But that’s not the complete reason.

I close my eyes, my brain had recoded enough time that the memories came back flooding in. Didn't it? Just like how the drugs that were in my blood started to effect me suddenly. She says, yes. That’s correct. Did you clock the rest too. I gave a subtle nod, between the start of therapy and now, the percentage difference have been substantial. And along with that my PTSD worsened. Dammit. My PTSD was linked to Ketriya. I open my eyes to her, was that even a PTSD? Or deranged physiological issue manifesting as PTSD. She says, there was many component of PTSD, I am sure of that. Because the therapy was working for you. However, the evidence is compelling.

I get a little annoyed, this is nuts. Not even a million years would I have ever guess I was suffering trauma from both, a physical and phycological issues. That has to be one of the most freaked up thing I have experienced. I am angry, to whom I don't know. Maybe the universe. Maybe myself. She says, I know its tough to swallow. I know you suffered a lot, but you come out strong. And I don't mean figuratively. I am only telling you this because you are like me. Soon you would have driven yourself crazy trying to make sense of how you are magically cured. I couldn't let it go until I found the answer. Scientifically or Kuret related.

I take sip of water from the jug beside me. I feel like my brain would explode. I smirk knowing it actually did. I say, thanks. For everything. And I mean it. You are right. Getting to the truth is important to me. Don't know how I feel about it though. I am going to revisit all the various decisions, all the therapy work we did. Try to make sense of this sense. She leans forward, I understand. But know this, whatever happened, only reasons changed. You still had to do the work, learn more about yourself and get better. You were still sick. I know she was trying to assure me this wasn't a waste. But I wonder now, would I have still had PTSD if I had gone through Ketriya a tad bit earlier.

I scratch my back since I couldn't do to my face with the needles still on my skin. I take a deep breath, is there anymore more. Because if there is, I had my fill of fun, as you so amusing put it. She smiles, that’s all I got. I hope you don't take this the wrong way, but you are a much interesting research subject than I ever imagined. I laugh at her serious but nervous tone. She looked tiered, so I assume has spent nights working on figuring me out. She says, I if its not too much trouble, I would like to keep this particular treatment under wraps. I want to go through the whole thing again with different perspective.

I smile, you sound excited. What happened to sticking with just therapy. Don't tell me you miss the science. She becomes a little hesitant at my teasing. She remains a little quiet after realizing she was doing more than needed. I say, its fine if you miss this work. And don't worry, I am not going to recruit you. But the door is open for you. She scoffs, please don't. I won't deny I am getting a little ahead of myself. But that’s a lingering feeling for a long buried past. I reply, so that’s what denial looks on you. She shots me a look. I say, trust me. I know what it feels to hold on your past with guilt. My brain was physically stuck in the past.

I could tell she wants to avoid talking more about it. I didn't want to push it. Its her decision to pursue whatever she wanted. She says, look at you mister I know it all. Your brain only rerouted new paths, it didn't effect your personality. Mind telling me happened after you stepped into your university. I say, that’s where I lost you? She nods, yes. You gone mute and only mumbling few words. I didn't want to administer another dose since I already gave you once before. So I had to let you go unguided. It was unsettling for me to leave you alone in your own exposed mind. I had no other choice to wait. I only got through to you later when you were screaming for missing something and I mentioned your Kuret to you.

I remember it now. It was when I was fighting Wagner. I think I was stuck and needed to remind of my Kuret. I smile, sorry. Its deeply person with Shadows. It involves people other than Zakerine and Wagner. She glares at me a little but doesn't make a frustrated expression. She understood it was my private thoughts. I continue, I will tell that many people showed up and helped with certain perspectives. Of course I knew at the time it was talking back to myself, but it changed me little by little. The screaming you mentioned, that was my final fight with Wagner. I thought I was meant to defeat him, to finally get some piece. But it was all a distraction to the real truth.

She asks, which was? I replied, like you don't know. Tell me, when did you realize I was unreasonably hating Wagner. She remains unfazed trying to play dumb. But she has been poking at my thoughts for months. No way she didn't know about it. After a few moments of silence she finally broke, I wasn't sure, but I noticed clear signs of deflection on the second month. I chuckle at being so transparent. I say, and you didn't say anything. She replies, that’s not how therapy works. Not at least with you. I had a strong suspicion. Last week you blamed Zakerine too. I realized you hide your reasons behind them. Its a classic coping mechanism. I am surprised you never noticed it.

Great, she is turning it on me now. I sigh, touché. You wanted to let me figure it out myself. She nods, if couldn't accept it yourself, there would be no point in me revealing it. So, she nods at me, seeing how Ketriya came though, you finally accepted everything about yourself. Its hard to know if noticed she knew about me before or not. I gave a sly smile and came out, yeah. I had a very hard time to accept my selfish and arrogant side. But I don't want to give any excuses anymore. I had to show her my clear intent. She learned enough about me from this. She says, good to hear. Having modesty and humility is fine, but times like this, in war, you need more. You need to have enough confidence in yourself.

I ask, even when its borderline narcissism. She replies, in wars, soldiers need to be in a particular mindset. You can't expect you all to have rational feelings. She has never been in battle, I am sure she has treatment many people with familiar stories. She gives a serious tone, but reign in some moderation time to time. I say, don't worry Drew. I feel a hundred times much mentally ready now. She nods, glad to hear. She stands up, I need to get back home soon. But I want to test one last thing before I leave. I ask, you just got here though. She says, no. I have been spending a lot of time yesterday. I can't keep making excuses for my absence to Parry and the kids.

She already did a lot for me, I can't keep her occupied with this any more than necessary now. She works on pulling out all the acupuncture needles from my head. Then we walk to the destroyed deck. There was a makeshift wooden planks nailed to the wall, with a tarp wrapped around it. The combat bots must have sealed it shut and tried to hide the damage from the outside. We take the other door and step into the lawn. There were few patches that were covered with soil and no grass. I asked, do you know how this was covered.

She explains that Blake made an excuse that this was a training session and things got out of hand. The only really damage was to my car, which got destroyed and sitting inside the garage. That is easy enough to convince others. Drew says, I checked for any physical issues last night. Nothing alarming. But there is a slight increase in your ATP generation of your brain and spine. You might have not noticed it yet, but your oxygen intake by the tissues is increased by 15 percent. Damn. I had a thought just now, so will I expend more energy. She says, it’s the equivalent or normal people burning more ambient Kuret in their body. You just do it with oxygen instead.

Burning oxygen means more output calories. I suspect she wants to test my Kuret, I saw the footage of my Kuret. You want to know if there is any adverse reaction to using my Kuret. She says, physically you have recovered. But I couldn't test anything with your Kuret. So as much I don't want to risk this, its more risky to not check it out. Your Kuret also evolved along with you. And based on what others told me the night, you displayed radical abilities. I want to make sure they aren't going to negatively impact you. You are sure to resume training soon enough.

I am thankful she also anticipated my plans for the future. I know the reasons for my sudden change in Kuret, but that doesn't change the fact that I need to train and master it. I ask, what do you want me to do. She bring out a single injector, I want you to bring out your Kuret. But only for 10 seconds. M will monitor your brain from the modified chip I implanted yesterday. And if anything goes wrong. She waves the injector to me. I got the message. I

ask, I think its overkill, but maybe we should bring a combat bot too. She says, I have asked M to have one in standby. Besides, 10 seconds won't be enough for you to go fully berserk.

I didn't want to leave it to chance, if don't stop, just use it regardless. She takes a step away from me as I prepare myself. The feeling anxious and a hint of excitement. I take a whole minute of deep breathing to lock in. I give a signal to Drew and bring out my Kuret. I felts nothing different for half a second. But then it felt like the dam broke open. My Kuret comes out from my whole body even when I wanted only on my hands. The Kuret was vibrating so chaotically I didn't realize it initially. I waited for five seconds, but I didn't feel any pain. I started to enjoy this incredible feeling of tingles coming off my bones.

But then I started to glimmer and raised my palm over my eyes in reflex. There were so many different spectrum of colors and so intense. I closed my eyes and it caused me more disorientation from the sudden influx of glimmers. I felt down on one knee breathless a little. Drew came rushing yelling, what happened. I could see the glimmers of the injector closer to me. She is going to inject me. But before she could push it against by neck, I intuitively guarded myself with my Kuret. I didn't command it to vibrate faster, it already turned into the wild Kuret and stops the injector. Not just that, I accidently blew it away from Drew's hand. She jerks a little and stumbles back with her cane.

I raise my palm to her, just wait a second. I will my Kuret to settle down. I already crossed the 10 seconds mark, but I had gained enough control to pull it back in. The glimmers in my eyes lessen and I could see normally again. She hesitantly asks, David, is everything all right. I sigh as I get back on my feet, sorry for scaring you. I acted on impulse. She turns to the crushed injector on the ground, its okay. You didn't hurt me. But I felt your Kuret. She raised her palm, very interesting. Your friend, Cassandra said something like you cutting off their access to Kuret. She puts her hand away and smiles, that is quite the troublesome power you have.

I inspected her hand. I feel relieved that I didn't bruise her. Then I wished I could see with my glimmers to know what happened. She says, I am fine. Trust me. Lets hope she wasn't putting up a front for my sake. I say, the glimmers were too much for me. I couldn't see anything. She leans in, you were blinded from it. I nod, this was too much. I don't think only my Kuret has improved. Did you happen to see any changes in my optic nerves. She says, I did. As you suspect, it is linked to your frontal cortex. So naturally it has changed too. I reply, I had a very similar problem long time ago. I think I need to relearn this again. Its like there is a massive reset.

She nods, you may be right. Your eyes might have become much more sensitive now. I know I had to relearn my control, but this only excited me more. And Kuret feels on whole new level. Maybe this my Kuret was supposed to be from the beginning. She says, you will need a diet plan to compensate for your new changes. M showed me your latest nutrient strategy. It wasn't half bad, but I have recommended changes to incorporate new changes. I reply, thanks a lot. That will help a lot.

I turn my hand into a fist feeling jubilant. I have only shown false confidence to others until now, but with this new ability, I can now match against an overdrive Heraknus.

Blake (Chapter 102)

Tuesday, February 24, 2026 14:16

The officers building is empty right now except for few people. Me, Luther and Tina stayed back to finish up objectives from our latest success. Few hours back we got a message from Nathan that he was able to get through the science team in Italy. Despite the obvious obstacle from Citradel warriors, three days of relentless efforts paid off. The warriors couldn't stop Nathan or Frank from meeting them. Frank mentioned in his message that they didn't want to escalate by fighting two warriors. That was the outcome we were hoping.

Luther gives me the action items. I take a look at it and hand it back after confirming the details. I say, this is good enough. Just go over with Tessa over assigned personal people for them. Luther says, I have a meeting with her tomorrow. After the admin meeting, of course. Tina asks, anything we need to prepare for it in advance. I waved my hand, I don't think there is anything we can do any more. Heraknus didn't say much who they are sending. We will prepare the usual place for their brief stay.

Tina says, you know, I didn't think Heraknus would agree to our meeting request. Citradel is still in lockdown, aren't they. Luther says, same. I can't imagine their council is very happy about this. Means the Heraknus are really serious about moving here. I say, Charles has publicly agreed to corporate with us. That means they no longer are tied to Citradel. A little chuckle passed through my lips at the thought of them breaking out of Citradel. Tina says, council must have tried to stop them. Luther scoffs, it would create a bigger chaos. They already have their hands full with other stuff.

David's human organization has been continuously hijacking and stealing their precious resources in broad daylight. Tina did mention in her report this morning that the shipments are getting smaller. But we have a surplus of martials to work with now. So much so that she requested for additional land to store them. Citradel is not only bleeding dry from this, they got their own internal strife. Their priest Selena hasn't stopped her blatant campaign of convincing others to move. We heard a rumor that its escalated to the point of protests. I don't know how much that is true because its not covered by the human news stations in Citradel.

I say, it doesn't matter if Citradel supported Heraknus or not. They are coming tomorrow. Lets focus on that. Tina sighs, it would help we know how many individuals are coming. Luther shrugs, I tried asking. But they didn't want to leak any particular information in case other communities got wind of it. I don't know why they couldn't at least tell us. We are going to be neighbors soon. I partially agreed with them. Its a little suspicious they only told they are coming. I say, who knows. Maybe Charles is with them. Tina replies, I don't think so. Luther asks, you know something. Tina says, not really. Just a hunch. Would he be busy with his house members in Citradel.

Few officers also believed he would be arrive. I honestly don't know. It would be better if he arrives, since its his match we are going to discuss tomorrow. But its not totally necessary for him be here. Luther says, I am more excited to know more Heraknus people. I know they are normal people, but they will become famous soon. He wasn't alone. Everyone on the island have been waiting to meet other Heraknus. The public only know about Charles for now. Tina says, speaking of famous people. What's our recent celebrity doing. We messaged him this morning, and he hasn't responded to us.

David's sudden absence had people nervous. I couldn't exactly tell them the truth. So far we covered with saying me and Marina spared with him and it got out of hand. But it wouldn't hold up for much longer. I say, I am going to meet him for dinner. The guy has been holed up is house coming with different strategies. Luther asks, I get that. But he can at least see his messages. I have been thinking of sending him a priority alert message many time today. Tina scoffs, I hear he had been getting too many calls and messages from people. Even those from outside. Just a life of celebrity, I guess.

I need to defended him for now, he might be very busy with blocking Citadel's efforts to steal back their stuff. I imagine its very time consuming coordinating stuff remotely. I gave a white lie hoping they will buy it. I have been telling versions of it all day. Tina says, yeah. The shipments have started to become less bulky. Luther remained unconvinced. But I am meeting him directly, so there is no problem. He asks, I guess that is very challenging. Anyways, be sure to tell him to show his face in public. We can't keep placing officers around his house to stop reporters and kids. Tina smirks, don't forget the group of girls that tried to sneak in. Do they think they will see him from outside.

If only they knew the whole story with David. I say, I will tell him. I eye to Tina, maybe not about that. I don't want to stroke his ego. We had laugh to relieve some tension. I look at the time, I should get going on. See you guys. We all parted for the night. I decided to not take my car and instead fly there. Last time my car was nearly destroyed. If it weren't for his car blocking mine, I would be mine that be totaled. I get a message from Drew around 3 that David had woken up and was back to normal. I messaged others about his condition. But I still cautioned them to keep a little distance. For their safely just in case David looses his mind again.

Matt and Cass took some convincing, but they agreed to wait for David to meet them. Catherine said she is coming. I didn't have any good reason to stop her. Siera and Vanessa said they just wanted latest update. I am guessing Vanessa didn't want to face him again so soon and Siera is just backing her. In about ten minutes I reach his house and descend down. Once I landed on his driveway, I heard people talking inside. I look up their aura. Marina and Catherine are both inside. I guess its my time to be late. I dispersed my Kuret and rang the bell. M voice responds, Blake, you can head through to the basements. Boss and others are in lab down.

What are they doing there. The door opens and I takes the stairs down. Besides their voice, I heard a machine buzzing. Are they working on something. I open the door and peak inside. The table in middle of the room is covered in sophisticated chemistry setup. There are different chemicals being passed though the beakers and long glass tubes. In the corner, a large 3D printing machine was running. Beside it, others were sitting. I see David among them. He looked much better than yesterday, when we visited. He had down a workshop apron. He also had some sort of big cloth around his neck. Did he get hurt again.

David waves at me, hey Blake. Its good to see you. Marina pouts, you are late. I ignored her cheap jab. Catherine and I wave hi to each other. I walk closer to David who stood up to meet me. He had a little serious expression, let me just apologies for my actions. I scared a lot of you unnecessarily. He really is much better now. He raises his fist to me. I nervously fist bump him not really sure how is so chipper. Catherine says, look at your face. You weren't expecting this, huh? Honestly, I don't know what I was expecting. Its not just he is better, he is relaxed.

I ask, so no more tantrum like that. He smiles, yeah. That's the last time I am ever going to do any king of psychedelics. More than being mortified by my actions, I am more horrified what a disaster I become. I take an empty seat beside Catherine. I ask, as long as you are better, its all good. But you scared us a lot. You weren't just high, you showed crazy strength before. I turned to Catherine, did he explain how this happened. She waves, no. He wanted to wait for you first. That's a good call. She says, besides. I had a lot to say to him before. That's right, she found about his true identity.

Marina says, you missed a lot. Catherine laid him out pretty good. I smile imagining that. Catherine scoffs, I should have seen the signs. You three are so close. She eyes me like it was my fault too. I can't exactly say I am blameless. David says, since you are here. Settle us a bet. Who was the one who told Catherine about me. I can't believe the atmosphere had become so cavalier. David wasn't even bothered by the slightest. I say, it was Cass I think. He clicks tongue, damn. Marina says, ha. I told you the truth. But you kept believing Matt would bring it up immediately. What kind of game were they even playing. I am so confused.

I turn to Catherine who was also enjoying this. She asks, what. I ask, I thought you be more angry at him. She says, I was initially. But he explained his reasons. While I didn't like that he kept something so huge from us, from me. I understand his reasons. David says, besides, I think she is more impressed with me than be angry. Whoa, what happened to him. He sounds far more easygoing for someone who went something harrowing. Marina says to me, even he noticed it. Can you imagine what he said to us when Catherine and I showed up. I am hesitant to ask what he did. Normally I wouldn't be bothered by it, but I have a suspicion its something aberrant.

David gives coy smile with a little awkwardness, it was nothing. I just welcomed the ladies. Lets not make a big deal out of that. Marina scoffs loudly, you think we can just forget it. I turn to Catherine with a curious look for answer. She sighs not amused, he subtly insulated about a threesome or something like that. My eyes widen with utter shock. I turn to David, who was not being enough guilty about it. He chuckles, it was clearly a joke. What do you think people will say if two beauties visit me in the night. I turn to others wondering who would even believe this. Marina says, please. I got standards. Catherine gave Marina a look asking if she meant Catherine doesn't. David says, I admit it was in a poor taste. It was a harmless joke. Don't you think?

He was asking me to bail him out. But the surprise of cheerful attitude hadn't left me yet. I ask, you are really feeling okay. He says, never better. Didn't Drew said so herself. I blurt out, then what the hell happened. You acting very different. He smiles, that's because I am. And I am not being glib about it. Before I ask what he meant, he then raises his palm, hold on. I think the solution is done. Give me a second. He walks to the platform and puts on a goggle from the counter. He then takes a dropper and begins to perform some chemistry.

I turn to Marina, has he been acting like this all the time. Marina smiles, kind of. It surprised the hell out of me too. But to be honest, I kind of like it. Catherine says, he does seem to be less burdened. I whisper, is he like. I point my finger to my head. David behind me says, I saw that. I thought he was engrossed by his work. Marina says, he says he isn't forcing himself to be like this. But who knows. Catherine says, I thought he was a little crazy in the beginning. David puts his goggle down, that's fair. Don't worry though. Just thought its time to improve my social skills a little. He then pours a liquid, and I haven't lost my touch too. The liquid sizzles a little from the beaker.

I turn towards him, what are you doing there anyways. Marina says, he is making a coating of boron lining on a pair of shades. Marina says, maybe he wants to style up his life. Based on how he is acting, its wasn't far fetched. He says, I wish it was just a fashion statement. Its less interesting. He picks up two lenses with tongs and dips them into a petri dish filled with a black liquid. We all hurdle around him as he pours another liquid on top of the lens. He then repeats it again with another petri dish and another set of lenses.

Once down he sets his goggle down, this should set in about few hours. I ask, are you ready to tell us what is going on now. He faces to us, leaning against the table. He says, let me just clear one thing first. I can't talk about my treatment. Drew put a gag order explaining it was untested and technically unethical. And I agreed. So unfortunately I will not disclose the methods. Marina whines a little, you are going to hang us dry like this. He cuts her off, I know its frustrating. But those are my doctors order. And I am going to respect her decision. If you have a problem with it, I suggest you ask her.

He makes it very clear he wasn't going to go against her on this. Catherine says, I can understand Drews concern. But we were there, you know. We know some stuff already. I nod, yeah. She said you were high, and you said it yourself about using drugs. Marina says, can you tell us what kind of drugs were used. He smiles at her, trying to score some drugs from me. Too bad. Your going to have to ask the dealer directly. He was clearly enjoying keeping up the suspense. Marina knew he was deliberately goading her, but she was giving David the evil eyes.

I didn't know how this new dynamic would explode, so I get us back on track, what can you tell us. He turns a little hesitant. Catherine says, at least tell us how your Kuret got stronger. I am still so embarrassed I couldn't do anything back then. She is referring to her failed attempt to catch David off guard. David says, I not trying to hide anything. I am just thinking how to explain it. We wait for him to tell what he was having hard time to say. He says, I guess I'll do how Drew explained it to me. What do you know about Ketriya.

Now that's a word I haven't heard in long time. But other two didn't seem to know about it. Marina says, no idea. Catherine says, I think I have heard it back on Medrine. But I can't remember what it is. I say, really. You guys don't know what it is. I am disappointed. Catherine asks, what is it. Some sort of Kuritine. Its not that. Though I can't imagine how it is related to him. David gestures me to explain. I say, it's a phenomena that happens to us as when we are small children. When we first get the first taste of our Kuret. Marina says, there is specific term for such an obvious thing ? Catherine says, all I remembered that was something related to children.

I say, its an old terminology. But still, its pretty damn important if you ask me. David says, I am guessing royals consider it to be special. He guessed right, some of our family members still celebrate it. Its not a custom, but I remember attending a ritual of passage to a cousin once. Catherine asks, whoa. You guys are so lavish about it. I shrug, dad told me he did it for me too. I was too young to remember that. Marina asks, I didn't know people would be considerate of this. I don't know if mom did it for me.

I say, I guess not everyone cares about it much. David says, that’s actually normal. Even I didn't know about it. When Kuret biology is common in Medrone society, you don't put significance to every little thing. Drew did say it’s a piece of lost medical knowledge. Not many would know about it. And even if they did know, they wouldn't put any real significance to it. With our current state of things, that’s actually the most probable effect. Marina says, fine lets chalk that to list of things we should learn. What its got to with you.

He raises his eyebrows to us waiting to get the hint he seems to be giving on his face. What is he implying. He says, I thought you would guess it. But its pretty far out. So let me just say it. I just had my Ketriya. As in, when I am an adult. That makes no sense. He already has uses Kuret. Marina giggles, be serious. David says, I am. Then he told us all about Drews insights and conclusion. After 10 minutes of full surprise and shock, he ends up saying, so yeah. That’s how I cured my PTSD. He makes air quotes on the last word.

I was stroking my chin, because I was just dumped such unbelievable explanation. Catherine says shocked, so to summarize. Your Ketriya ran for years, unlike ours. That saved your from a genetic disorder. And it also made your Kuret change over the years, the same we do but in weeks. Marina says, and it's also responsible for your PTSD. I continued on, your head was bleeding because your brain finally adapted to Kuret control. I am flabbergasted to hear such a incredibly convoluted medical history.

The only who wasn't shocked was David, who was now preparing our dinner. He had ditched his neck comforter, which was actually a neck massager. I couldn't believe he was so chill about this. He laid out the plates in front of us on the table of his dinning room, bon appetite. I couldn't really focus on the steak and salad he had prepared for us. Marina cries out, how are you okay. He says, I had a day to sort through this. After a while I just sort accepted this absurdity. At least he is honest how he himself feels about it. I ask, then your Kuret is complete now? He takes a sip of wine from the glass, unclear. Drew said Ketriya is 99 percent over. But no one knows, just like no one knows when Medrone kids go through it. Its up to biology and nature.

Catherine, which nature. Earths or Medrines. Because you are more closer to Ketriya in teenagers growing on Earth. He says, take your pick. I am sure there are arguments for both side. He swirls his glass amused by our confusion. Now it is making a little sense how he was able to use suddenly such a strong Kuret. He says, in any case, now that I have gone through it. I have undergone a bit of metamorphous. Just like how children behaviors changes, so has mine. But in my case it’s a little severe. I ask, because it happened to you late in life. He points the wine glass to me, yeah. You think you are shocked, imagine my surprise when I noticed more changes.

I ask, like what. He says, let start drinking first. Its been a strange long day for me. Among us, only him and Marina were drinking. Marina was puzzled, like us, but unlike us, she didn't hide her thirst. After few more insistence from him, me and Catherine took our glass. I had to praise his selection, this was very delicious wine. I could taste a hint of bitter fruitiness. This must be from his old collection. When I check out the bottle label, I think I have seen it before. But I couldn't recall from where. Catherine was the most enjoying from it, nice. Its been so long I had a wine like this. I miss outside food a lot of times.

She needed to change her pallet to Kuret nutrients food after coming here. She takes couple of more sips savoring the taste. Marina was already pouring next glass but then abruptly stops, is this an attempt to get us drunk. She gives nervous smile to David. He cocks his head, please. I wouldn't do that. She resumes pouring her glass. He says, at least not with this. I got another bottle that will make you so drunk that not even your Kuret immunity will be able to metabolize it. I would love to try that one out. But it would be a chore, there is only one bed and I am not sleeping on the couch.

Marina almost spilled wine from David causal retort. Marina starts laughing, you sleaze bag. I get you are trying to turn over a leaf, but you need to work on your timings and the people. He turns to Catherine, is that right. Catherine nods, you are trying too hard. He takes a drink and makes a expression like he is contemplating his approach. I ask, please don't come up with something else. I already feel strange you acting this way. He laughs, just making mental notes. I am terribly behind my social life. Its not like I am seeing a completely new side of him, but he isn't hiding his thoughts anymore.

Marina says, stops stalling. Explain what you meant when you said there are changes. He puts his glass down, right. See neural pathways in brain is just neurons firing messages and instructions. Having a different route shouldn't really shouldn't change anything. But that’s true for a Medrone children, wholes brains aren't developed. As an adult and a denser brain, there are regions of my brain are already had hardwired. So there are certain aspects parts of my neural makeup that corresponds to years of habits, preferences and actions. And two days ago, those pathways suddenly changed. And that will result in various aspects of my life.

I ask, Kuret being the main one. He nods, of course. That’s the most prevailing one. The Kuret control. I have been doing social tests all day. There is divergence of about 24%. That is way to abnormal for anyone. Marina asks, what kind of deviations are we talking about. Catherine stares at the drink, like drinking wine at dinner. Because I have only seen you do it few times. He says, good catch. Yeah, tastes is just electrical impulses to the brain. I didn't care for wines. But now its like a new pallet option is opened up. Meanwhile a particular fish I used to like, doesn't taste good anymore

Catherine says, but that’s normal. You can't take that as sign of change. He says, it could be a placebo effect from the treatment. But there are other subtle things. Like my favorite mathematical equation in physics was hooks law, but now my pick is Bernoulli's equation. I didn't understand how math is involved here. However our resident mathematician spoke up, that’s not big deal. My favorite equations change every month. He reply's, shocker. But that sort of thing doesn't happen for me. Even I set aside my personal preferences, you can't deny I am trying to be more proactive. Would you ever imagined me making jokes about women like this.

That is suspicious for sure. He could be playing around intentionally, but seems he is just telling the truth. Marina says, I don't really buy it. David thinks for a second, then let me ask you about happened when you went through it. Marina says, you mean when I went through Ketriya. I don't even remember it. He says, since you are an over achiever, I bet you got it early on. Think back when you were a kid, you may not remember when Ketriya happened, but you have total recall. You must remember when you gained your Kuret. Marina thinks about it for a moment. David adds, I vaguely remember around the time you were building something with Kuretine.

That jolted Marina's memories, my first successful master piece. I remember it now. Oh, whoa. That takes me back. She starts to reminisce about that time. She smiles, how cute you remember that. He says, its hard to forget a 6 feet tall structure that wasn't really shaped like any building I know of. I chuckle, that does sound an over achiever to me. Catherine scoffs, what were you even doing with it. Marina says, I was just trying to build something for my parents. Back then I wanted to. Now, what was it. After a few seconds of wait, she says, don't remember. But yeah, now that I think of it, it took me months to do finish that, and then I decided to begin my training next summer.

David clears his through, any particular reason you decided to change a career path ? You already had an older sister to inherit the alpha Kuret. She thinks hard as she bites her lips. She sighs, can't remember. I guess it just a push from the family. For some reason David becomes a little sour, like he didn't like her answer. He shakes it off the next second, see. That was around the time you changed too. I bet that was a big change in habits. She says, kind of. Yeah. I didn't know what engineering, but I wanted to build things with my charms. And then later made an effort to join shadows.

I didn't exactly understand the purpose of asking Marina this. Children go through this all the time. Even Humans children changes. How does this prove anything. David says, if you had remembered the feeling, then you would know what I am going through. Its possible I am just fooling myself by overdoing stuff. But I feel a lot calmer, more in control and aware of myself. It could be because I was lacking it for so long. Only time will tell though. I guess I was suspecting him a little too much. He just wanted to know about others experience. Since Marina is possibly the only one who could remember that phase in her life.

Catherine says, I think I understand. Its not that you have completely turn over a new personality, you are not unburdened anymore. I raises his glass to her, I like that. I might use it to explain it to others. I can't deny I used to feel chained down, thinking that people died on Medrine and I wasted their sacrifices. The guilt had been eating me up for years. More so this past year. I ask, and now you don't. He says, that’s not something that I leave behind ever. But at least I won't drag me down. I ask, I don't know if that’s a healthy attitude or you are faking it. He smiles, don't forget being delusional. Just how much changes are we going to witness. He usually acknowledges weakness or self pity with us. But we have Catherine among us right now.

Marina says, yeah. Definitely the last one. Especially after how he has been treating me and Catherine. He scoffs while cutting up the stake. We talked a little more, try to pry out more about his secret treatment. He never divulged anything apart from some vague details. He only told us about Ketriya. When I asked if there were more details about why it happened, he said everything else was still speculation about his biology. He was especially evasive when Catherine asked if it was due to MAR's testing. That is the only logical reason for all the mess he is caught up in.

After finishing up our dinner he says, I heard on the network about our scientific conference is successful. They are coming. I nod, yeah. They finally acquiesced today morning. Catherine says, Nathan took his sweet time. Do you think he was playing some angle. Why take so long. I reply, I am expecting the transcripts of their conversation tomorrow. We will know more what he promised them. Marina asks, they want something in return. I say, I am sure they do. David says, if he didn't ask for your permission, if they did want something, Nathan can handle it own.

That’s what we believed it too. I say, Luther wasn't really happy not keeping us in the loop. We will soon know about it. Marina says, before tomorrows meeting. I nod, they will arrive tomorrow morning. David says, what meeting. I scoff, you don't know. I though you were tapped into everything going on in the city. He says, I have been a little busy today if you recall. I haven't been checking my messages. I only heard about the science team from Drew. What's happening tomorrow.

He really has been living under a rock today. I guess I was unreasonably expecting him to know things. His casual demeanor made me forget he spend almost two days unconscious. Marina says, the Heraknus are sending few representatives to discuss about the relocation. She turns to me, I am assuming they want me to tell them about their living situations. I reply, most definitely. You done with the checklist? She pulls out her phone and scrolls through the list. After checking she says, all done. The tunneling, foundations and blueprints are all done. But I do have questions about some things for them.

I ask, anything important. She says, not really. Just need to hash out some logistics. David says, weird. I asked M to notify any movement from Heraknus. How come she didn't caught this. He peeks to the side display for a moment, I'll check that later. Anyways, who all are coming. Catherine says, don't know. What make my job a little harder. She teases me for not able to figure it out. If I thought I wanted to know, I could have dug deeper. David says, okay. Did they mention if Charles is with them. I shrug him no. He scoffs, so keeping it under wraps huh.

I ask, but they did ask for you specifically to be there. He asks, the exhibition match will be discussed as well. I say, most likely. He says, guess I need to put on my game face on. Marina scoffs, I am dying to see what that entails. We all laugh, even David himself. We chatted few things about tomorrows meeting. We have been dealing with so many other issues that we never noticed how close we are getting to the match day. Catherine asks, you barely trained this past week right. Isn't that bad.

He says, you don't have to remind me of that. I didn't have much physical training, but I had a mental training done. So from now I will be more diligent. No more distractions. I ask, if that brief brawl we had with you is any indication, you are no where close to handling your Kuret. He says, you had to say it like that. He leans back and folds his arms, I know my current limits. But don't think I am just recuperating. Today, recuperating was my training. Drew said the more I let my body adjust to my brain, the better. I have another issue with my Kuret right now.

Marina asks, is that something to with your lab setup in the basement. He says, yeah. My optic nerves have reset, so I am sensitive to glimmers. I got completed blinded when I tried to look with my Kuret. I used that glass coated boron material to help me learn to control it few years back. I need too keep it on temporarily, even when I am not using my Kuret. I chuckle, it’s a coincidence. Dad said his brother once said he went through a similar phase. The aura was too much to see when he was a kid. I say, nice to know it has happened to someone else too. I don't have much reference on how to handle Ketriya. Do you guys know anyone who can help me?

After a lot of silent thinking, no one came up with any suggestion. He sighs, I guess its up to biology and luck then. Marina says, how long till you get adjusted. He says, a week at least. I wanted to give tomorrow day for relearning it. But now I need to pick a more fashionable shades. I hate to be so gaudy as to wear black shades inside. But I can still rock the look. His makes a crooked but confident smirk. Marina will be getting her wish for David to put a show tomorrow.

Marina says, someone feels cocky. We will see. And about your training with Kuret copy techniques. He asks, I can manage that at least. She nods, I didn't want to mention it until I was confident you were okay. But you seem better now. Maybe more than that. Think its time we work on it. He gets excited, awesome. I can't believe you found time for it after being slaved to work so much. He peeks at me a quickly, blaming me for that. I took offensive, I told her to delegate task. But she is not just over achiever, but a perfectionist too. Blame her.

She gives me a smile, we both are to blame for the work you are putting on me. I sigh and face a giggling Catherine. Marina says, it took some time. I may have few solutions for your particular problem. We can go through it tomorrow. He says, that’s excellent news. I am sure you have made some sort of schematics and designs. Send to me tonight. Marinas gives him a thumbs up. Then he pauses for a second, but lets not do it tomorrow. You might be a little busy tomorrow in case you are called by Heraknus for some ground survey.

She says, oh right. They will ask for a tour of the city. Then let me spare some time for Thursday. I am glad they agreed to let be free tomorrow. Catherine whispers to me, is he talking about that Kuret storm thingy. I nod. She scoffs, isn't it too much. He just recovered from a major brain trauma. David caught her murmuring to me, don't worry about me Catherine. I got everything under control. Trust me. And I will be asking you soon to help out with the training.

A devious smiles forms on her, I know I said I'll help. But I was caught up in the group flow back then. I am also very too busy you know. She remains silent and nods ever so slightly to Marina. David caught it too. I say, let me guess. Marina told she isn't helping David for free. And now you don't either. She shrugs playing innocent. She is enjoying herself a little from having an insider information. I didn't think she had anything to extort David. He didn't mind though, what do you have in mind. Whatever she wanted, she wasn't hesitating sharing with us. David laughs, whoa. I didn't think you were going to ask me out for this favor. Bold move Catherine. I am sorry though, I got hands full at the moment. How about after the tournament.

Catherine repudiates him, you wish. I already have a boyfriend. We only made it look like we broke up. Marina was stifling a laugh while I was uncomfortable. I didn't want to be in a conversation about Catherines relationship. David says, don't look so appalled Blake. I just messing with her. Did I showed it on my face. I quickly shake it off. He turns to Catherine, how about you tell me after the meeting tomorrow. She thinks for a second, I can work with that. I am sure I can come up with an equal compensation.

He grins, it’s a date then. I don’t think he is going to stop his weird flirting anytime soon.

Vanessa (Chapter 103)

Friday, February 27, 2026 11:47

The cruise ship was now visible in the horizon. Sommers yells to others, stay sharp people. The Heraknus are here. All the officers gathered in the pier is a circle. As usual, dozens of people and reporters are waiting to see them. I message Blake that they will be arriving in 10 minutes. He responds saying he will be here in another a few minutes. Everyone here is anxious to meet the Heraknus people. Some officers met one or two Heraknus before, but majority of the people haven't seen anyone.

Tessa and June approach me. We discuss about the occupants of the ship. There can't be more than two dozen people in that small boat. So we prepare for the cars accordingly. June asks, aren't going to let them rest first? Why take them to the admin building immediately. Tessa says, they messaged saying they want to finish up discussing about the match before retiring for the day. I say, they are in quite the hurry though. I thought they would wait another week. June says, maybe they decided to leave Citradel as soon as possible.

That was the popular reason everyone were thinking. Even though we called for them to meet, we expected them to delay it. Let the stuff going in Citradel settle down first. Tessa says, It was sudden, but its not a bad thing. This weeks been going much easier than the last one. I say, that's for IDF. Other departments are bring crunched by the expansion phase. The construction was in full force for past couple of days. Other officers are pressed to finish tasks before deadlines. June says, its not we have it easy though. We are only just halfway through the list people from the smugglers data records. Tessa says, that's is there. But I heard Ruther is going to be briefed by David with his tech. She turns to me, are they meeting today?

She opened that can of worms. David's not been seen in public past two days. And we have been covering for him. Drew sent a message to us updating us on his condition. On one hand I am glad he is recovering. I am so confused on what I am going to do with him. We didn't part at the best of terms before. He basically told me to screw off and left angry. I had a lot of time to think on how to confront him. But each time I think of something, I remember Wagner. I was resolved to never forgive him. But is that okay. He has apologized and even came clean about many thing to us. I wanted to know more how he knows Wagner. But I couldn't ask anyone without getting frustrated.

The only solace was Siera was there for me. Her support helped me to not get broken down again. I honestly don't know what I would have done without her. June asks, you okay? I didn't realize I was silent with my rambling thoughts. I say, just thinking about it. He reached out to us last night. He plans to send a batch of surveillance bots tonight. But he said he is busy today, so we come by another day. Tessa says, its not surprising. I hear he is doing some sort of special training alone for few days.

They began discussing about different possibilities. I didn't want to lie, so I just stayed quiet. I hope he has recovered enough to come to the meeting. As they discussed how he would prepare from his home, I drifted to think about the Shadow. Even now I am having trouble accepting he was a freaking shadow. Matt was boasting how he is perfect for the job. And I couldn't deny he was right. But I was more troubles by how an important person like him was in hiding all this time. He lost, no, erased his memories due to trauma. And that single choice has rippled out to a lot of mess.

Honestly, I could accept him being a Shadow. But hiding his therapy from us. That's what hurts me the most. I didn't believe any of his excuses about him sharing his Shadow past to his doctor. When I think about how he was targeted, it was good he took precaution. But still, he could have told someone. He went through the tournament in such a state. My brother was a trigger for him and yet he never once hinted about it. All he did ever was be quiet about it whenever I would mention his name. And if I am being completely honestly, that's what infuriates me the most. What kind of relationship did they have.

I didn't realize it was too late when I blurted out, what kind of Shadow is David? He has a such ridiculous issues. I immediately jerked when I realize I said it aloud. Even though it was a lower tone, their discussion halted and they face me surprised. I immediately broke in sweat. What is wrong with me. I was praying they didn't hear me. June says, what you mean. Tessa eyes raise curiously, David. Shadows? Bloody hell. Just how lost was I in my thoughts that I let it slip out. Their face showed confusion and shocked. I nervously say, nothing. Just rambling. Just saying that Marina and Blake might be training him at his house.

Tessa says, that's not what you said. June leans in closer, did you imply that David is. I cut her off, I misspoke. Nothing else. They were not buying it when my composure is breaking apart. I desperately looked for an excuse. Thankfully it came in a form a car. I turn my back, Blake's here. Lets break for now. I took few steps away from them and called to Ruther. I actually didn't have anything to say to him, but I wanted to get away from two bamboozled expressions. I just ask him for confirming of people in the admin building. He was confused since they we just went through it a minute ago. I just hope he doesn't pick up the strange vibe behind me.

Me and Siera have been talking about it so much, that I slipped it out to others. Cass has been blaming herself about leaking information, and now I am doing the same. This is so embarrassing. How could I let it happen. I need to distract myself. I saw Blake, Tina and Marina approaching from the car. They were norming uniforms like the rest of us. A minute later, they joins me. He asks, are we all set. I nod. ETA 5 minutes. Marina says, we got delayed at the admin building. Blake says, a lot more people are gathered than here.

We expected that to happen. Everyone got into place and wait for the cruise to arrive. But before they did, I had to know something. Once Tina left them to check on the transports. I ask, how is David. I heard you met him last night. I was expecting them to be concerned. But their different reaction made me even concerned. Blake sighs shaking his head. Marina just shows her teeth with a snarky smile. I ask, what happened. Is he okay. He says, sorry. He is fine. A lot saner than the last time you saw him. Marina chuckles, but boy did the treatment did wonders for him. Even I am get uncomfortable sometimes around him. But I kind of like this new David.

Blake says, that's because you encourage him a lot. She pulls her tongue out, now you are going to deal with him too now. He didn't like the prospect, but he also chuckles a little. What is going on. The last time I saw him, he was out of his mind, bleeding from his eyes and fighting us. Blake says, sorry for the confusion, Vanessa. Its just a lot has changed about him. I ask, like what. He says, you will know when you meet him. I don't understand the unnecessary suspense. Marina says, yeah. Its hard to explain ourselves. Blake says, there is a lot to talk about. But for now, just know that he no longer has unresolved trauma. Its hard to believe, but he has been cured of it.

I didn't understand how he can be cured from a trauma. I have seen so many people struggling to adjust even not traumatized from the past. I ask, are you seriously saying the treatment fixed his PTSD. In one night? How does that make sense. He scoffs, trust me. This was hard for me to take it in too. Marina says, I know its strange coming from me, but he is even more effusive than me. Blake nods, that is true. I can't believe what I am hearing. Blake saw my utter confusion and says, lets just say there was more going than just PTSD with him. And the treatment, which by the way Drew told not to tell anyone, has been miracles effective.

I am so lost here. When the doctor said the treatment was a success, I thought she was just trying to cover her mistake with some false hope. And from their words it seems it actually wasn't a failure. Blake says, lets save the rest for later. I see they are docking now. I wasn't satisfied by their strange reactions. But for now we had a job to do. Soon everyone gathers at the dock. Catherine and Jess joined us as well. Rest others will meet us at the admin building. Blake asks me, you still don't know who all are coming. I shake my head. Marina says, lucky for us, I found out. Remember my friend, she was able to check who all left the Heraknus house.

All the officers gathered here lean to her. She says, sadly Charles didn't came. And I know Melina is one of them. She smirks, guess she wants to meet the tech team that arrived this morning. Blake says, damn. I was hoping he was here too. Catherine says, are they sending her to represent him. That's what we had to believe. June and Tessa were peeking at me time to time. But I remained stoic, determined to not let them see me nervous. I hope they forget we ever had that conversation.

Soon the boat docks at the pier. After few minutes, a group of people disembark. The first one was Rory. He was carrying a rucksack bag on his shoulders and another bag in his arm. Behind him was Melinda. I didn't recognize anyone else in this group. Blake steps forward, welcome back everyone. Rory puts extends his free hand shake with Blakes, glad to be back Blake. Blake says, Melinda. How are you. She gives us a warm smile, I am good. Though I am tired from the journey. We took a different route last time, and this one was considerably shorter.

I saw their route. They crossed over the Atlantic on the flight this time. So I think they spent cramped with humans much longer this time. Few officers come to help pick their luggage's. Three people came beside Rory. A guy that looks like his fifty's with a bold head. He was a thin guy with a patterned beard. But his posture and demeanor said he was someone important. Beside him stood a younger guy. He was lean and tall with a studier build. Beside him was a elderly women with grey strands of hair. Her wrinkles showed she was an elderly lady.

Rory puts his bag down after he greets us. He says, everyone. I want you to meet few people. He gestures to the elderly women first, this is my grandmothers sister, Reina. Her son, Barnard and this is his son Eric. We finally meet other Heraknus. Blake shakes hands with all three expressing gratitude. Reina says, so you are the terra, prince Blake. Blake says, just Blake is fine. I didn't exactly inherit any royal title. That distinction is for Nathan. She says, oh. That's right. Where is he by the way. Your family helped us in the evacuation from Medrine. I wanted to thank everyone of you. You all sacrificed to save us.

That's news to us. Blake becomes anxious, I didn't know that. She says, oh yes. Charles told me he shared with you few things about the royal house supporting us. He didn't tell you everything. Blake nods, that's. He seemed to lost for few words. Then he gains back his composure, you don't have to thank me. It was all my family who helped you. But if you get time later, I would like to hear about it. She says, of course. Barnard steps in, I want to show my gratitude too. If it weren't for their help, Eric and me wouldn't be here. It looks like Charles hadn't told us everything about their connection to the royal family.

Did they priorities Heraknus to board the second ship. Blake says, its great to hear my family was there for you. Barnard says, I know its probably self serving to say this. But we hoped they would also make it out with us. If they had tried to save themselves too, they would be here too. Blake says, I am not sure what happened with Heraknus. But I recently learned where my dad and mom where in the last day. So I assure you, they had other plans. They were on the other side of continent fighting off the Hives. They made a stand, and I am proud of that.

This is also I never heard from Blake before. But then I realized that David said he saw many people while escaping from the city. He must have told Blake about it. Riena says, is that right. I met Slater few times with my sister. Guess we have a lot to talk about. Blake smiles, we do. Lets have you get rested first. Eric who has been quiet this time speaks up, Blake. Its a pleasure to meet you. He had a brisk voice, and showed a little tiredness from it. Blake shakes hand with him. He says, Rory and Gina told me a lot about the island. I am excited to see it.

Blake gestures to the people behind, and so are the people behind us. Rory whistles, we made quiet an appearance showing up so suddenly. Few drone were up along the barrier taking pics of them. We had instructed them not to cross the barrier. But their zoom lens and Kuretine microphones could probably pickup some conversation. Catherine comes up forward, morning everyone. I am Catherine. I am help you settle in our guest houses. She meets few other Heraknus behind them. From there everyone mingles a little. I thought I would meet Melinda, but Rory comes between us, hey Vanessa. How are you. I smile, I am good. Did you come alone. Tory?

He sighs, she wanted to come. But dad wants her help organizing and packing up our stuff. After years of living in one place, she has accumulated a lot of junk things. She is taking too long to sort which things she wants to bring here. Honestly, how long does a women need to choose which makeup set to bring. I laugh, if she is anything like me. A lot. He sighs, and don't get me started with Gina. She had so many clothes she doesn't want to discard. Our home is right now a dump. Behind him Melinda appears, I heard something about a dump. You must be talking about our room.

He says, don't deny it. She says, its less organized. She didn't want to give wrong impression to us. He sighs, lets not say too much. What would they think if they knew so many slobs live in our place. I couldn't resist a smile. Siera is a drill instructor when it comes to keeping things neat and tidy. Melina agrees with him and moves to meet June behind me. Taking this opportunity with us alone he asks, and where our celebrity. Don't tell me he is

going to make another entrance. I say, not this time. He is going to meet us at the admin building. He says, great. I hesitantly poked him, you still not giving up your theory he cheated? His response was just a smile to me.

He didn't say anything and moves on to meet other officers. A few minutes later Blake raises his arm, guys. I am sure we want to talk more. But let them rest first. He turns to Melinda, I am assuming you are going to represent your husband. He is probably thinking the time she visited me to discuss maters Charles wanted to say. She gestures, I am here for the tech team. I know some of them and would like to extend my help. Besides, I am here primarily to scout some homes for us. She gestures to Rory. He says, dad allowed me to take over any negotiations for him.

I can't tell if that's the right decision or not. So far only I have seen his petty side. Blake says, all right. Catherine says, you all mentioned in your message that most of you are for looking at suitable prospects of houses and not participating in the meeting now. So anyone who wants to take rest, please follow us. She and Jess breaks into smaller Heraknus groups. I ask to the women still contemplating, how about you Reina. She turns to me, Charles said to take it easy and leave it to Barnard and Rory. But I can help along with the discussion. Eric says, grandma, you couldn't sleep much in the flight. I suggest you go with Melinda. She says, I should, right.

A moment later she makes up her mind, actually, if I can get a cup of tea Tory was telling me about. I can attend the meeting. Barnard asks, are you sure. She nods, yes. You know we will talk about Charles. And I think I need to judge David myself. Looks she has a lot on her mind. They all agreed and everyone split into different groups now. 8 people were coming to the meeting, while rest 15 opted to go to the guest house. In an orderly fashion everyone got into their vehicles we prepared for them. The people who are coming with us had their luggage's sent along with the rest.

Rory, Barnard and Riena took a car with Blake and Marina. I took the a group with Sommers. And the rest were with June and Tessa. I felt a little guilty rearranging the order so that I don't seat with either June or Tessa. But thankfully they either didn't notice or didn't care enough to object. I was with Eric. All the ride away, the other Heraknus were chatting with us about the city. Me and Sommers explained the city layout and the current infrastructure. A Heraknus girl says, this is so awesome. I can't wait to live separately now. I had enough of us grouping together all the time. She becomes excited. I think they finally realize that they no longer have to hide.

They can now live openly and choose their homes. A luxury they didn't have in Citradel. I say, we will be handing you a digital guide of the city soon. Their faces showed their happiness. But some, like Eric showed a little nervousness. I ask, something wrong. He turns to slowly. It takes a moment to gather his words, I saw the people and reporters back then. Its a little annoying. Judging by his face, it meant he didn't care about being popular. Sommers says, we are sorry about that. Its just people are curious to see Heraknus after all this time.

A guy says, I share a little bit of Eric's concern. Same thing happened in Citradel too after Charles introduction in the coliseum. The girl says, I get what you are saying. Initially people were glad to know about us. But that died down pretty quickly. Many are criticizing us for not showing up before. So it happened in Citradel too. Jess told me a while ago how few people are now raising concerns on Heraknus decision. Charles explained why they couldn't help before. But that didn't alleviate the frustrations people felt. Especially from the people who lost their families in all the wars since coming to Earth.

I turns to face the four Heraknus in our car, I don't want to cause any more concerns for you all. While you won't face a lot of resistance from your presence, but there will be some friction. Even among the officers, some concerns are spreading. I hope you can ignore it. Eric says, I don't blame them. Many of us had requested Charles numerous time to let us fight. He would either refused for us to act independently or we would be too late. The other Heraknus gave silent agreement. I ask, I am sure he had reasons. He says, he did. And yet we shouldn't have been restrained like this. Kafar's agreement with us protected us, but it also alienated us.

Its natural different Heraknus will have their own opinions. Eric seems to be more respectable guy than Rory. At least for now. I ask, Charles said many weren't happy being revealed about your existence though. The girl scoffs, yeah. Many didn't want to leave their safety zone. My father didn't want me fighting out in the open. The guy who hadn't spoken said, its not really their fault. They were just far too used to living without scrutiny. Sommers asks, sounds a lot of problems stirred within your house.

Eric says, too many to count. The girl says, you know, all of us in Citradel were in a disarray for a while. Once Charles came back, there were arguments flying around. The guy laughs, and then Citradel made a big mistake. That made everyone supporting Citradel lose hope. I ask, you mean about Ryes. He nods, I never met him. But I heard he was a pretty nice guy. I never expected him to start accusing David. Eric sighs, then Blake blamed your criminal problem to Ryes and Citradel. That put the nail on the coffin. The girl says, yeah. People began to lose hope in Citradel councils. The guy says, I still think someone else stole the tech from us. But that's just me.

David's continues assault on Citradel probably put them more on edge. Eric says, I don't want to say ill of the place we lived for so long. But the situation has only worsened since David is stealing their resources. The quiet guy says, I still can't believe how continues to dry them. The girl says, Kafar is losing is hairs trying to contain this. I thought about a question, I hear your priest is also being vocal. Can you tell us anything about that. I don't mean to pry thought if its personal. The guy says, nah. Its all good. Ever since we decided to move, we sort of cut off from Citradel. Though we can still see what is going on there.

The girl says, they church is on missionary complain like never before. The guy says, I thought that priest was just hot chick. But turns out she was spicy one. I heard before we left she is planning another protest. This time in front of the council. Sommers ask, and they are allowing them? Eric says, they all are regular people. Nothing wrong with a harmless protest. I heard Blake did something similar after the tournament. I recall that long and tumultuous day. I was not around much that day, but I saw the aftermath on the news.

The girl says, only when they are not causing trouble. I still think that broad is interrupting the will of gods too deeply. So the situation hasn't improved on the ground. If their fears are correct, they are not stopping anytime soon. The quiet guys says, lets not talk about things that don't concern us anymore. Eric rebukes him, just because you don't want to weigh in this, doesn't stop others. Everyone here wants to be aware of Citradel and their issues. The guy backs down after being reprimanding from Eric. Looks like Eric is even bigger deal than I thought. The other two also pull back their concerns.

The guy says, dude chill. Lets switch it up always. We saw your matches. And it was awesome. The mood improves dramatically. It was still nice to be appreciated. Sommers also got few praises for his efforts to be in top 100. But he still hadn't let go off his brawl with Cory. He says, I still need to get my act together if I need reach for higher ranks. At least he isn't being a downer. Eric says, that's a good attitude to have. He turns to me, I was impressed by your match with Marina. I didn't know which way it would go in the beginning.

Everyone assumes that it was a fair fight. But people know Marina was poisoned and still beat me. I didn't think I deserved too much appreciation for it. I say, I tried my best. The girl says, you did. Marina is, well a Shadow. So she had an edge. Its been painfully made ever to me now that how much stronger shadows are. Now that I know David is one too, his feats makes even more sense. The girl says, speaking of Shadows, Blake was so close to reach the finals. I heard from Charles that he too has trouble controlling his overdrive. Is that true.

I nod, yeah. He will deny it, but everyone knows the match could have gone more his way if had control. Eric says, that was surprise for many of us. The guy says, we were hoping for Charles to fight off against a terra. How crazy that match would have been. The quiet guy says, my mother thinks their overdrive clash would be too destructive and could have destroyed the coliseum. I smile imagining that fight. I don't know how that would have gone. Eric says, even I can't deny I wanted to see that. But Charles overdrive is dangerous.

So they their bloodline know about it. The guy says, true. There is a debate among whose overdrive is more crazier. But you what even more surprising. David's kuret. The guy showed some crazier stuff pushing back Charles. The girl asks, you have to tell how does it. How can he copy others Kuret. This was bound to happen. Sommers says, sorry guys. None of us have any clue. He wants to keep it an ace until the exhibition match. The girl clicks her tongue, I was looking forward to know it. The quiet guys says, you can ask him when he meet him. I didn't think they would get any other answer.

Eric asks, I am very intrigued to meet him too. The way he appeared on the interview was, at the very least moving. Has been getting time to train though. I heard he told Charles about getting stronger. I couldn't answer him without explaining so many crazy stuff. I played it safe, he is preparing the best he can. But I can't deny he has been busy. Sommers says, but soon he will kick it up a notch. I heard from Tina that he requested for using the coliseum training center to train.

I turn to him surprised, when was this. He says, heard it over the breakfast. I don't the whole details, but I think he is starting tomorrow. Eric says, you mean the obstacles of the preliminary rounds. He nods, that's the one. Its one of the best training center of our island. So it makes sense he go there. The guy says, I love to see that too. They looked wicked in the broadcast. I didn't think David would be already ready to begin training. Didn't he spend two days unconscious.

Eric asks me, tell me one thing though. Is he really strong as people say. Because people say he got lucky. After witnessing his Kuret from the other day I had no qualm saying this, I don't want to presume anything. But he is on whole other level than many alphas. My specific words convinced them of something. Maybe they didn't think David had a chance to survive Charles overdrive. But I knew things many people didn't. Him being the shadow strategist was the biggest reason. Too bad I couldn't tell anyone about it. I think I finally seen a smile on Eric, awesome. Can't wait to meet him.

Few minutes go by chatting about other things happening for the tournament and we reach the admin building. Like Marina said earlier, there a lot of people on the street now. Many were gawking and trying to break through the line of officers to take a peek at the Heraknus. I say, I know it's a lot. But please don't worry about the people. We will make sure they don't bother you. Eric says, much appreciate it. The girl says, we had to prepare this sort of response. I just hope they soon realize we are normal people. One kid in Citradel asked me if I turn into a tortoise. I didn't know how to deal with that. I wish she ask about me about my Kuret endurance instead.

I grin without realizing. If I remember Kafar said Heraknus have different forms. Somers asks, are you all warriors then. The quiet guys says, except for the Reina and Brener. Yes. I did guess a while back from their toned bodies. Eric says, we are what you might call a swat team. There are half of us back in Citradel. I ask, so you guys are the top of your house. The guy makes a prideful voice, you got that right. Trained by Charles and Berner themselves. I wished we could have participated in the tournament. He murmurs, damn that Kafar and his ultimate surprise.

Sommers drive us through the sea of people, navigating and finally crossing the boundary we set up. The people ease a little up after seeing the people leave behind. The three cars stops at the entrance. Sommers says, it got here a little late. I say, its okay. The meeting will start in an hour anyways. I turn to others, you guys can freshen up in the admin houses here. I point to the independent houses we had prepared for them. We come out of the car and everyone congregates near the entrance. Blake comes to the middle, we have setup a little breakfast bar in the main building. Once you ready, please meet us there. Few people still had their bags with them. I think it contains something pertinent to the meeting.

Heraknus begin to disperse into smaller groups. The officers we stationed guarded their rooms. Eric says, see you later. I nod and wave our new friends. Deni walks to me, there are way too many people. Sure it won't cause any problem. I say, its fine. Once the meeting starts, they will go away. I turn to the large crowd. Many people were trying hard to see the Heraknus. The drones were zipping around the air. Unlike the shore, we allowed them to hover above us. But they will be asked to leave once the meeting starts.

Blake approaches near me and asks her, is everyone in. She says, almost. All the admins are here. And the necessary personals for the exhibition match. It meant Ned was here too. But I doubt we will get any time to talk privately. Not like I am willing to meet him. Blake says, who is missing then. She sighs, take a wild guess. She gave an obvious look. I sigh, you told him the time right. He says, I did. The meeting is at 10. I told I need him to arrive at 9. Deni says, he isn't late though. Blake says, for now. Wonder why he is taking his sweet time. We waited for 5 more minutes. And just before it was 9, there is a large commotion among the crowd.

I face the direction of people cheering. I say, guess he just made it in time. We see a lone person being escorted with officers among the crowd. Blake asks, is he walking. Why is he on foot. I reply, his car is a wreck, from this training accident. Remember. He scoffs, that doesn't mean he needed to come without a car. If I knew he was planning on taking the trolley, I would have giving him my car. The drones were now hovering more closer in the air towards him. I think I see few reports tagging in the crowd.

Soon he appears through the crowd. He wore officers uniform, but he was wearing a black shades and gelled up his hair outward. I ask, what's with this sudden interest in showing up like a tortured artist. He wasn't just cutting through the people, he was also shaking hands, fist bumping and taking photos with people. He looked like a fish out of water last time. But now he is swimming and enjoying himself. I swear I could hear his laugh from all the way here. He was not used to this, because he kept making mistake with peoples greeting. But its far cry from the awkwardness he was during the dinner that day.

Blake says, Deni, help him out of that. We can't have him getting hogged by the people like this. She laughs, on it. She leaves us to help him out the officers. Blake says, see that. That’s the new David me and Marina were talking about. I ask, how do you mean. Isn't he just used to the fame now. Blake says, that’s part of it. But be prepared to see a new side of him. Then leans in closer, try not antagonize him today. I don't know what kind of response he will have today. I don't understand this warning. His wasn't serious, yet he was anxious.

I ask, is this some sort of side effect from the treatment. He leans away, in a way. But this effect will be lasting. What happened to David for others to be acting this strange. With Deni's coordination, David finally made out of the crowd. Blake says, I am heading back in ahead. You guys can come when you get over the shock. He left leaving me stunned. I hear Deni laughing loudly now. David says, its true. You saved me. One girl was asking for me to sigh on her chest. I wasn’t ready for that. Deni says chuckling, stop it. I saw you. The most that girl was ask a photo. He says, yeah, with me beside her chest. You saved me from becoming a terrible meme. What the hell are they talking about.

His laughs slimmer down seeing me in their path. He says, Deni, can you give me and Vanessa a moment. Deni says, sure. And now its just the two of us. He pulls out his shades, underneath which revealed a black left eye. I ask concerned, what happened. He says, its part of the cover you guys gave me. Upon closer inspection, I think he applied make up to create the wound. I look at the shade in his hand and then back to him. He says, oh this. I am having trouble seeing with my Kuret. Need this to help me keep in control. Otherwise I might accidently see what people eat for their breakfast. I can't have me getting dizzy right now.

He puts on the shades back. How is so composed talking to me. I thought he would be either very serious or angry with me. But seems he is just so unbothered by the argument. He says, I want to apologies my rude behavior earlier. I said few things during the fight. I didn't mean to scare you. Chalk that to a drug riddled brain. He gives a big smile, and yet still guilty of those crazed comments. He says, I understand the confusion. I don't think others told you what happened to me. I say, they said you changed. He says, an over simplification. In a nut shell I am trying to be a different person. So bear with me.

I blurt out, what does that mean. The last time we spoke, you told me to get help for my issues. Ironic coming from you. He says, and I was justified. You did say some unreasonable things. Before another argument broke out, he cuts in, but so was I. I wish I didn't took it on you. I thought Wagner pulled over a wool over you. And I was desperate to fix that. I kept a lot from you. And truth is, its wasn't just you. So many people. He sighs, no more though. You want to know about Wagner. I will tell you. He says this with such a straight face that I remained speechless. I say, I don't trust you. You said you won't tell me about him.

He says, I know what I said. Feels like I was different person back then. I was thinking that shielding from truth is kindness. But that’s a convenient excuse. Like I said before, my mistake was hiding the reasons. And when you hear them, and you still want to know everything. I will tell you. Something's strange with him. He was so adamant about keeping things secret. But now he just ready to share them. I don't trust that. He says, I can guess what you think. I am being manipulative, trying to lie. But I am done with that. Its not like I am ready to divulge everything. Some things need to remain buried. Its not because of you. Its because of other reasons.

He walks closer to me. My heart take a beat faster seeing his serious face. He says, but know this. You won't like everything you hear. You say you want to know truth about him, but don't want to hear anything you don't like. You don't get to have that luxury to pick and choose. Let me know when you ready, we will talk then. I couldn't form any response. He is warning me about my brother. I feel annoyed and the emotions I have been suppressing come up, I don't believe you. You will lie to suit your needs. He nods while leaning away, that’s fair. I need to work on gaining your trust back. You got any ideas. Because I am lost here.

I am frozen how he is not holding back his thoughts. Openly asking for my suggestion. He says, well. If you do think of anything. Let me know. Maybe then I can make you see things you don't like. He then looks around the area, looks like I was the last person. I knew I shouldn't have taken the trolly. But I was envious of the couple I saw ahead me and asked tips for effective communication. A mistake, they gave me stuff not really relatable to us. Should have known I can't really crowd source solutions.

I ask him confused, you asked advice from strangers. He raises his arms, trust me, I didn't say your name. All I said I was in a dog house from a gorgeous and terrifyingly intimidating friend of mine. So don't be mad. Is he messing with me. But the that relaxed smile is way to real to be fake. He says, fine. I added the intimidating part. Just trying to score brownie points. I didn't like how you were getting angry with me. Hope it puts at least a smile on you. See you later.

He walks away, always like he is fleeing after messing up something. I don't know what just happened. First he warns me and then he compliments me. What is his deal. I followed behind him. But he was already inside the building. I saw Blake talking to Reinhart at the corner wall. He excuses himself and approaches me, what do you think.

I say dazed from the conversation, that was David. Wasn't it. Because I can't tell anymore.

David (Chapter 104)

Friday, February 27, 2026 20:36

I think I am making good progress. Especially with Vanessa. I was scared for a second how I might offend her. But I am okay with how it turned out. Direct but also cautious. I really hoped the couple would give me some ideas. But they were far too excited by the fact that some girl was angry with me. We laughed about it when they said any angry with me wouldn't be for much longer. They clearly haven't met Vanessa. It wasn't even half as nerve racking when I was greeting the people outside as I was with Vanessa. I just hope I didn't made her more angry. The most she would be right now is confused. I am okay with that.

I met with the admin crews I haven't seen for some time. Many were asking about the shades and seems they all believed my story about the accident. Technically, it wasn't a lie. So we should be good. I heard from Sommers that the Heraknus will join us soon. I ask him, anyone you find interesting. He scratches his neck, you should meet Eric. He seems very dependable guy. He then told me about the special team within Heraknus. I can imagine this squad is probably the very strongest within Citradel. I say, more than dozen alpha level in one team. And all sharing same Kuret and weakness. They would make a very balanced and powerful team.

He says, absolutely. Though, I couldn't see much of their Kurets. Charles wasn't kidding when he said Heraknus are effected coming to Earth. I was talking to a guy in our car, he said he needs at least 3 minutes to build his Kuret body. And another one said he can maintain his form for 4 hours, but gets interrupted at least 50 times. To cover each other weakness they fight in groups. That is the most logical way to overcome drawbacks. I am curious about one thing, they told you their weakness. Are you sure they told the truth. He says, I get what you mean. I don't think they be trusting us so much already. But I didn't feel like they were lying.

Maybe I am reading too much into this. But why tell anyone about your problems in their first meeting. He says, maybe they are trying to be friendly with us. You know, try to look more normal. That could be one of the reasons. I ask, I also don't know why send so many warriors. Even if others aren't really fighters, they are still Heraknus. They are stronger than your average Medrones. He says, don't know about that. I heard from Tessa that their access to Kuret is really inconsistent. They can't control when they loose out their Kuret reserve. The warriors are trained to counter their problems.

All that sounds logical, and yet I can't shake the feeling. They didn't need to send half their team here. We have strong warriors of our own to protect them. I say, why do you think the warriors came to the meeting. They are here to guard others. He thinks for a moment, that’s actually a good point. None of the warriors with the others in the guest house. What do you think that’s about. I had a theory, but for now I wasn't sure of it. I say, we will soon know about it. I didn't want to feel suspicious of our guests right at the beginning.

A person approaches beside me. Its Ned and he is carrying a tablet with him. He says, can I talk to you for a minute David. I turn to him while Sommers excuses himself. I say, long time no see Ned. You been busy. He says, a little too much. I have been trying to reach you many times over the week. But something or the other kept that from happening. I smile, apologies. If only he knew the whole truth about the stuff I went through. But I can't just tell him. He might tip accidently tip off the people or officers targeting us. He says, I understand. I am not holding that it against you. Not for that at least.

That tone suggests he is wanting to blame me for something else. There is only thing that he probably wants to talk about. But I let him breach that first. He put downs his tablet and asks, this isn't about the match. Its personal and I need to ask you something. I prepared myself to keep my composure. I pull out my shades and look at him squarely. He reacts to my fake black eye a little but ignores it. He continues, I heard you and Vanessa have been arguing for quite some time. I want to know if that’s true and what its about. He seemed to let out a frustration too.

Its not that I don't sympathizes with him. However, I wasn't going to be swayed by his passionate plea. I ask, really. That’s news to me. Who told you that. He gets a little annoyed, don't hide it. Vanessa hasn't been talking to me no matter how many time I reach out to her. I want to know what did say to her. He is getting a little agitated. From his perspective it may seem I had something to do this. I say, you assume wrong. I didn't say anything to her. I made it that he is being presumption. He gets irritated, then what is going with you two. I say, nothing much. Just a silly argument.

He leans in, is this about Wagner. He knows about that too. There is only one person he would know this much and tell him. I say, what exactly did Siera say to you. He tried to hide the surprise, but I saw it. I say, I don't know what she said, but it’s a simple misunderstanding that I intend to clear up. He asks, that’s not good enough. She is dodging my calls, not allowing me any chance to talk. He sounds desperate to get to the bottom of this. I say, I am sorry for what's going between you both. But I am not going to make it messier by getting in the middle. He wasn't going to let it go. So I add, from what I heard, seems you started it. Though I don't know how or why.

He looks to the other people's gazes, wary of the buzzing people surrounding us. He says, it was just a stupid bet. She blown it out of proportion. She thinks only she gets to be angry. He then explained the bet which happened in the VIP room during the match. I actually knew all this already. I just didn't know this was how their fight started. He says, tell me how did I hurt her. It was a harmless gamble. I just chose Charles because I thought he had the best chance of winning. But Vanessa, she interpreted it that I never take her side. He was now less angry and more upset.

I had no intention of playing advocate for fixing their relationship. Vanessa is mad at both of us. However, its for different reasons. The way I see it, he would have been able to fix things with her much easier than me. But he has been making mistakes. Like I have done. I ask, what exactly do you want me to do. I already told you, I didn't say anything to her about you. And frankly, you are not having enough faith in her to think I influenced her in any way. His quiet indignation makes it clear I was right on the money. I say, I'll take a wild guess here. You both think that the other should apologize first. Well, I don't that will cut it. The issues you have run deeper than that.

If it were just about that, they wouldn't have been fighting this long. They don't seem to have some hidden securities of their relationship. I had daring and impertinent thought. I shouldn't get in the middle of this, but the curiosity got the better of me. I explain, if you want someone who you will understand your every decisions, get a different girlfriend. Because Vanessa deserves much better. He grumbles a little when I came out right. He snarls, are you telling me to break up with her. I smile, I didn't say that. That was you suggesting it yourself. See. I gesture my palm to him.

He says, I don't believe this. You don't want us to patch up. Do you? Don't tell me you are. I cut him off because I know what he was insulating, you got it wrong. Trust me. I am saying from experience. You both think that other is being irrational. But you can't accept it either. That, I shake my head, is not how you maintain a healthy relationship. He says, really. You are saying that. The guy who loves being logical and analytical for everything. A person with a checkered past. I don't know how much you said in the interview was true, but you at least have a questionable history of screwed up relationships.

He is deliberately taking a shot at me by bring up Liz. I feel a little angry swell in me. What the hell he knows about my past. But then a moment later I settle down. This is a reaction because I provoked him too much. I think I tested his resolve enough. He won't let go of Vanessa without a fight. I don't know if that’s good for her or bad for me. I sigh, I won't deny it. I mean, what do I know about being in love. Right. I give him a chuckle that confuses him. He scoffs, what the hell happened to you. You are different now. I reply, I am a changed man. I suggest you do the same. For Vanessa's sake.

I take a step away from him, you should talk to her instead of asking talking to Siera, me or anyone else. He says, I told you. She is. I pull my shades back on, tell me. Is this island so big that you can't find one person. You know her home, her work and the people she spends time with. And yet, couldn't find time to talk to her. Please, you are running out of excuses. Your believing that I am the problem is also an excuse. Don't waste looking for reasons that aren't there. You either fix it or pull the plug on this thing. But choose one. Because I don't want to see her hurt. Not more than she already has.

He gives a puzzled look. I am getting that quite a lot since yesterday. And now I beginning to get amused seeing different reactions. I say, hope you figure it out soon. I'll see you inside. I leave him to his thoughts and head inside. That felt gave me a bad taste in my mouth. I probably gave away a lot of my actual intent. I think I want them to break up. But I am conflicted hurting Vanessa. She will hate me even more when she finds that I basically told her boyfriend to confront her. I don't know what will happen. Truth be told, I don't think they are going to work things out. This makes me selfish, petty and jealous. I guess I should start owning my feelings from now.

I spend the remaining time talking to few admins. They had different scenarios of the exhibition match in mind. It was basically the same but with minor variations depending on how much Heraknus agree to it today. They knew some of the dangers of Charles overdrive. I hinted them that there is more and to keep all the options. When the time came Blake gestures me to meet up with him and Reinhart. We meet up and step into the conference room. Reinhart says, hey David. I heard about your little accident. A training exercise mishap? I chuckle, yeah. I got a little ahead of myself. But its all good now. He nods while talking the seat beside me and Blake.

Blake whispers to me, I saw you and Ned earlier. I saw his angry aura. I haven't seem him like that before. What did you do. I answer with a furrowed brow, he was blaming for the fight between him and Vanessa. He blinks a little, he was. Why would he think that. I say, he heard she is angry with me as well. So I guess he interrupted I said something to her to cause friction between them. Which I obviously didn't. Blake says, I am little confused why he would believe that. I sigh, when it comes to love, people don't make sense. Maybe he feels bad for what happened. But he is taking it on the wrong person.

He says, you sure you don't feel any guilt. You did cause their fight, maybe not indirectly. I scoff, maybe initially. But not now after all this time. I am not going to be sorry about something I shouldn't be. He whistles, whoa. I ask, do you think I was wrong. He tilts his head, I don't think so. But I am not sure they would feel it the same way. I say, I am okay with that. I can't be held responsible for everything. He nods, that I understand. We halt our whispering when people started to pout into the room. Luther sits beside Blake and the rest of the admins fill the other seats.

Soon all the high ranking officers came inside. I got strange looks from few of them. It made sense when it was from Vanessa, Ned, Catherine and Marina. But I felt a stare from Tess and June. I lightly waved at him with curious looks. They waved back and took the seats at the end with a pleasant smile in the end. So I didn't think much of it. Ned took his seat opposite to me. He was obviously shaken up from the earlier confrontation. Yet he had managed to settle down and have a stern face. Got to admire him for being able to set his priorities.

And then arrived the Heraknus. Based on the interactions I had with others and from M's recon, I had memorized their names and a very basic profile. They greet the admins and then take turns meeting me. First few were the warriors. Up close they all were normal Medrones. Even when I used a tiny bit of my Kuret, I couldn't see their Kuret. Just like Charles. Its eerie to see more people not exhibiting outright Kuret. One more noticeable trait was their lean frames. Their training must be heavily focused on Kuret and not much physical. They had different reactions to meeting me. Some were excited, few neutral and others were plain curious.

I met Bernard and Riena the last. He says, nice to meet you David. You have made quite the name for yourself as he takes the seat beside Reinhart. I say, thanks, but some credit goes to your alpha. Without him wouldn't be in the spot light. He gives me a laugh for my perspective. Beside her sat Riena, it’s pleasant to make your acquaintance David. I says, yours too. Finally, Rory their place beside her. She leans in closer, you caused a lot of stirs amongst us. She gestures to the warriors sitting at the end of the room. I reply, I have known to have that effect. That made all the admins snicker a little. Rory says, hey David. Dad says he is sorry he couldn't be here with us.

I wave at him, its fine. I understand you will be making decisions for him in his place. He nods, that’s right. But if you have any concern I can call him in a video. Reinhart says, hope it doesn’t come to that. With the current unrest within Citradel, an open communication there is not a good option. Rory says, dad will be on standby only for urgent messages. He then faces Blake, before we start I want to make one thing clear. We have no connection what so ever with Ryes or the smuggling criminal he is working with. Berner add, alleged criminals. Reina says, or with the current problems with the church. Bernard says, we separated from Citradel, so whatever they have done, please know we weren't part of it.

He was looking at me now. I waited for Blake to respond first. He says relieved, that's good to hear. Though I would like it if it came from your alpha, no offense. Riena says, no, you are right. Charles will reach out to you later today. Rory asks me, you gave Citradel a good beating for that interview Ryes did. Many us are still not accepting this is was you. I laugh, does it matter who did it. Besides, the credit actually goes to the people who helped me do this. I was merely the gravel that decided to retaliate in the most befitting manner. Blake asks, I hope things didn't blow back too much on you. Bernard nervously says, Charles had some troubles. Reina says, but nothing big enough to be of concern.

I don't think they would reveal that to us anyways. When the last of the crew entered the conference room. The meeting got started. Rinhart takes it away, thank you everyone for joining us. Especially to our guests from Citradel. A roar of cheers and claps came from the officers. He continues, its great to see so such a legendary bloodline amongst us. I am sure everyone will need some time to adjust in the city. So please, Heraknus, take your time settling in. You are here for 4 days, lets make the most of it.

I decided to use a little bit of my Kuret in my eyes to get hints of their state. It took a few seconds to adjust the new glimmer sensitivity. I see majority of the Heraknus being excited. A couple of them remained unconvinced or hide their apprehensions. Rinehart continues, let me introduce a few of them. For the time being he only formally mentioned the 3 Heraknus sitting on the table. Reina says, I am so happy to be here. I look forward to see your city. Bernard and Rory said the similar things. With the brief introductions done, Reinhart jumps straight in and explains todays agendas. He had two important discussion to have. About the rules of the exhibition match. And the other was about the broadcast. The second topic was perhaps due to the dangers of Charles overdrive.

The discussion went initially on how I learnt from the admins before. We were going to re use the coliseum for the match. Instead of a grassy ground, the battle area will instead be a landscape comprising a small forest, river and even hills. The Heraknus were very excited to see such a vivid battle ground. Few officers didn't understand the need for complexity. Ned answered saying that this technically not part of the tournament. We want to make sure people know I was the clear winner of the tournament. By changing the battle ground, it will bolster that fact. Few thought it was too gaudy, but it was a good promotion campaign. I wasn't choosy with any landscape.

Blake interjected to clarify the new changes when Riena and Bernard had questions. There were few changes here and there based on the discussion that the admins took note of. In the end they decided we need to expand the battle field by breaking down the seating areas and few rooms. I was actually happy with this decision. The last time one of my uncontrolled Kuret blast nearly burned a section of people. This time the people will be seating outside the whole stadium. Heraknus were stressing on that part. They didn't haven't said it outright, but they know that Charles could hurt others.

The broadcasting streams and channels would remain largely unchanged from the tournament. The media team has been reaching out to the other communities and Medrones living outside to view the match with their familiar setup. Ned claims the tournament was such a success, that more communities have reached out. They must have heard about Heraknus coming out of the shadows. This increases the workload of Neds media team, as well as Catherines external affairs team. Blake proposed to hire more people for their teams. Its good that we still have few weeks left to get everything ready.

I didn't have any issues with the discussion happening in front of me. The most my participation was agreeing to after their discussion. Rory was mirroring the same as me. It makes me even more curious why other Heraknus warrior were here. With just these three, the meeting would have progressed the same. There must be a reason and not just because its their first public Heraknus appearance. Around 12 the talk was moving towards the rules. The admins prepared a document for us and shared it to the tables on the table.

This part I have to be wary of. The last time someone found loopholes that caused a lot of problem for many people. The were less rules this time, but they were more concise and clear. Charles had pitched the match to be 10 minutes, but now its said until his overdrive is over. Blake says, this is different than what Charles said. Rory says, about that. We don't know exactly how long his overdrive will last. Dad said he wanted all the time he could get. It could be 10 minutes, like he said. But it might very well be less than 8 minutes. Blake says, but it could be 15 minutes too. Are you saying you don't want to keep a time limit.

This is rule is overwhelmingly favored for Charles. Reinhart says, since they asked for a personal bias, we decided to balance it with a few rules. The next one said that if he steps outside the barrier in his overdrive form, its an immediate forfeit and I win. Even if I get out along with him. But if either of us step out for more than 30 seconds, it’s their loss. That’s an interesting rule made just for us two. I chuckle, so I win if I manage to drag out Charles with me. Then I am okay with it, Blake. Riena says, that’s a relief. But you should know, getting away from him will be extremely difficult. Charles will not let go of his target in any circumstance, no matter who it is.

I wasn't scared of that. Since I wasn't planning to evade him all the time. Most people believed my only strategy for a guaranteed win is to be on the run. Perhaps that’s why the admins decided to add such mini landscapes. Even when he chases me around, the battle wouldn't be boring. But that will be boring for me. I haven't told this to anyone. If I could explain it, they will surely object and say I am insane. I will not be explaining my strategies to anyone except Blake and Marina. I say without any hesitation, I got no problem.

Blake asks me for silent confirmation with his face. I nod and he relents in the end. We move on to the rest of the rules. The barrier this time will not just be Kuret, but a carbine cage infused with Kuret. Marina told her plan to include another Averna charm to make this barrier even stronger than before. However, we learnt from last time and added a built in escape hatch. Marina says, if you become incapacitated for any reason, we will pull you out from a small hole in the barrier. Unlike last time, anyone can come in and out. Reinhart says, but if that happens and people rush in to get you, you lose immediately. Rory asks, and we can't really guarantee the response time.

Luther asks, how long are we talking about. Riena says, at least 20 seconds. That’s the best we can do. Our fastest people, with the necessary equipment, can reach in that time. It may look like another disadvantage for me. But I wasn't fazed by it. Actually I foresaw this sort of rule already. I smirk, that's fine with me. When I fell like I am done, I will step out myself. I won't risk my life unnecessary again. I hope people believed me this time. Especially the ones that were worried for me a lot, Vanessa and everyone else. I was way too arrogant and full of myself back then. The power up inflated my ego too much. I like to say it was due to Ketriya or my mental instability. I am not sure about the reason, but it doesn't matter now.

I was incredibly lucky that time. This time, I will be more strategic in my judgement. I am not making that mistake again. I give a confident smile to Blake, which he agreed not to censure this. The next rule was that I can quit anytime and I can't take it back no matter what happened next. Even if Charles overdrive is over the very next second. Next couple of rules were standard stuff, I can't cheat, or receive help from anyone. Charles also can't receive any help. To closely monitor any serious injuries, we will be chipped with a device to monitor our health. Its a small Kuretine circuit chip that will track the Kuret depletion in our bodies.

Blake says, ah, that will not work on David. Reinhart says, there is an alternate option for each of them to use their own tech to track their vitals. However, the tech have be verified by us and even share the vitals to both sides in real time. I nod, that’s fair. Bernard says, we have our own very unique way of monitoring and controlling Charles if he looses too much control. Things seems to going smooth. There were still few things to iron out, but they were minor logistic decisions that will be taken later.

Riena suddenly gets a little somber. I see dim orange glimmer from her. It wasn't just her, the other Heraknus were also suddenly serious or anxious. She asks, one last thing. She motions to her son beside her. He pulls out a document from his bag and gives it to me. A writing document instead of digital. They didn't want this to leak out. I read the first few lines and my smile dropped. I gaze up to look at the Heraknus with a shock on my face. Blake asks, what is it. I ignore him and continue to speed read the whole document. The admins were also confused as they showed streaks of yellow. Then they didn't know this too

I had to pull out my shades down to read the document more carefully. I don't care if people saw the fake black eye now. Is this for real. I can't believe they drew up such a contract. I turn to the next page that continued this ridiculous terms. After few minutes of tense silence from everyone I put the document down on the table. I should be offended by this piece of paper. It caught me so off guard that I stifle a chuckle. Luther asks me nervous, David? I slide the document to him and Blake, take a look at it yourself. It’s a freaking accidental death deniability and beneficiary contract.

The entire room broke into whispers and stupefaction. The admins had no idea as they try to look over the document these two were reading. Reinhart blurts out, Riena, what is the meaning of this. Instead of her, Rory says, it’s an unpleasant but necessary precaution in case David dies during the match. The whispers now turn to mild indignation discussion amongst people. While others were busy panicking, I calmed myself down and started to plan out my thoughts. Blake had read enough of the document. Luther picks it up and furiously reads it from his hands. Blake says, why did you decide to show this now. We needed to be made aware of it in advance.

He shows confusion and anger, which were justified reactions. Bernard says, I am sorry. It was a very sensitive topic, so we decided not to reveal it over your network. Blake says, I don't get it. Why did you prepare it at all. This whole time we are talking about different types of contingencies so that no one will get hurt. Including David. The commotion erupts louder. I turns to see the angered expression from my friends. I was strangely curious about Vanessa. Would she be worried or be conflicted. But from my angle, I couldn't see her face. I can't overuse my glimmers right now. Too bad, I will have to ask her separately.

Riena says, we are really sorry about this. But a majority of our house members would only agree to move here after this contract was brought in. Having read the document, it made sense how everyone collectively decided to move here. Luther hands over the document to Reinhart. He says, this is a bit outrageous. We need time to consult about this. Bernard says, yes. But we need David to put sign it. Rory says, and he also need to provide a admissible video explaining that he is aware of the risks and doing it on his own accordance. He seemed strangely less guilty sliding me another paper. It was a short paragraph. I read few lines understood the intent for this.

Blake is more confused than ever, is that for the public then. Riena nods showing more empathy than Rory. She says, the contract is between us. But the video is for court of public opinion. We can't have people blaming us for an accident when we were explicit about the risks. Rinhart puts down the document now, this is unacceptable Riena. This match is going to be broadcasted to the whole world. There is no future where we a death will be acceptable. Why is there such a risk. He doesn't the whole risks and to fix that misconception, Riena explains the dangers of Charles overdrive.

Until now they thought he couldn't control his overdrive, but now they know he isn't even cognizant of himself. She even reveals the dangers to people if anyone gets close to Charles. Few minutes later Ned asks, did you know this when you took the deal David. Several eyes fall on me. I reply, I did. Reinhart clenches his jaws, why didn't you tell us. Blake answers it for me, we wanted Charles, or Heraknus or Citradel to explain it. For all we know Charles and Kafar were exaggerating the side effect of his overdrive. Bernard says, trust us. Its all true. He gestures to the warriors, we all have seen him lashing out and had to work together to stop him.

Many of the officers and admins were speaking in low tones conveying bewilderment. Luther asks, Blake, you were there. Why didn't you stop David from taking the deal in the first place if his life was at such grave risk. Blake says, I tried. But, he faces me with sharp eyes, he was not backing down. I need to speak my mind before people think I was being dumb. I can't explain my actual reasons, or the ones I thought I did back then. Instead, I need to convince them I will be doing this no matter what happens and still not die.

I put my shades back on and turn around to see others. I was giving them all a silent but ominous expression to make it clear I was dead serious now. I say, I want to tell you all something. And I don't want anyone to interrupt me. I give a no tolerance bullshit until I had my piece. I continue, you all know my past is filled with mistakes and regret. And Ryes dredged up painful memories that I didn't want to relieve. One of them was about a human named James Noland. He was the first person to help me once the war with Hive escalated. And I wouldn't be here if it were not with him.

Rory asks me despite the warning I gave earlier, what is he got to do with this. I responded with a dead pan expression at him. He couldn't see my face, but my body posture scared him a bit. I could see a little bit of the glimmer. I continue ignoring him, his family died as part of collateral damage from a fight between Medrones and Hives. A killer with thrust for vengeance and anger was born. Even though it was Hive who instigated the war with us, he wowed to kill any alien he came across. I found out later he even had killed dozens of Medrones in his misguided attempt to get revenge. He would have killed me too had I showed any signs of normal Kuret.

I scoff, he helped me when no one did and I was floundering around like a helpless pup. He should me how to fight Hive and kill them. We made one hell of a team. I shake my head, but when he found out I was a Medrone, which at the time I myself didn't know, he turned against me. I didn't show me any pity and made his mission to kill me. He regrated helping me so much that he didn't even care the lives of human who got in his way. He killed innocent people, cops to try and rectify his mistake. He abandoned his quest to kill Hives in order to end me. And because of that I had to kill him.

A wave of murmuring float around the room. I never told this anyone before. Not even to Cass, or Siera or Vanessa. They only know few things about him. I continue, Ryes believes my first kill was a criminal, but it wasn't him. I had no choice but to stop James. He was planning to blow up the whole camp where the Hives were keeping the Medrones captive. I regret so many things. Maybe I had different words, I could have convinced him. Made him see reason. He was a man of sheer will and determination. He would have been our greatest ally. But he lost any good reason to live and I had to put him down.

I sigh, even in his last moments, he never let show his regrets. But I knew. He told me I was never going to change anything. That I was small compared to the colossal threat. And I believed I shared same fate like his, not able to accomplish anything. I knew he was talking about himself. He shouldn't had to die with so many regrets and nothing to show for. I then turn to Blake, I have no intention to die before I kill the Hive king. I am not going to waste my life like his. I turn to others officers, you all may think its not worth the risk, but I don't care. I had to take away a strong ally. I am not going to let go of another opportunity to get even stronger allies for the war ahead.

I can't tell how convincing I am. People should different glimmers. But I made it clear that I wasn't deter from anything they try to scare me. The room is silent with constant stares at me. I showed appropriate passion and reason. This had to resonate with few if not all. I ask Riena, tell me what happens if I don't sign this. She clears her throat and responds, this contract is represents a majority of Heraknus. Even if its not what Charles wanted, he would abide their decision and we will not move here.

This caused another panic among the people. Blake tightens his fist on the table, I know what you are trying to do. You failed to convince Charles to not take the deal. So now you are trying scare people into forcing David to drop the deal himself. None of the Heraknus made any signs of denying it. I agreed with his assessment. It was a contentious play. But Its also effective, especially when I just became famous. The response of explaining the dangers of Charles overdrive will have max impact now. The officers didn't know the whole risk, so now they want to drop this. They believed I will not be convinced directly, so people will do it for them.

Luther grits his teeth, are you planning to reveal this contract to the public too. Bernard says with somber voice, I know how desperate we sound. And I am not going to deny we are doing this to void the deal. But just like David doesn't want to loose us as ally's, we don't want to loose a powerful Medrone like him. If the worst happens, Heraknus will be forever tarnished. Many don't want Charles to test his our theory about controlling his overdrive like this. So please understand we will do everything possible to avoid that outcome.

Riena faces me, I believe you when you say you don't want to die like your human friend. But is that risk you want to take when its completely avoidable. Luther says, if the deal goes away, you will remain in Citradel. Blake says his thoughts, and there is a good chance with your support back with Citradel, they will pull them out of their current conflicts. The church may back down. And they will look for ways around their predicament of resources. All our efforts will be wasted. Rory says, we are aware. But like how dad told you once, we can't be responsible for others. We have to do what's right for us.

I looked at this from their objective and it made sense why they want to cover all their bases. If I back down, no one gets hurts. But if I die, Charles and I will be blamed for such a disaster. They want to avoid that at all cost. The admins are discussing amongst themselves to figure out a peaceful solution. I could settle the matter if I just signed the paper myself. I am resolved to do it. But that would make me incredibly selfish and reckless. I need some sort of agreement from Blake and officers before I make do it.

For now, at least people aren't trying to talk me out. They were clearly shaken when I declared I wasn't going to die no matter what. But they are just confident words and more than likely arrogance. I need to show them to prove it.

David (Chapter 105)

Sunday, March 1, 2026 22:11

As people debated on how to settle this, I was my mind went on different track. The Heraknus warrior were brought in to testify Charles overdrive dangers. Many, like Sommers, knew they were here for to talk about their Heraknus alpha. But now they realize they came to give credence to the risk. They want to scare people and convince me to not sign such a thing. However, I still believe they are here for other reasons too. Otherwise why send so many warriors. Few would get the job done.

Aside from their presence, I was beginning to see a new problem. Blake understood me the best and had resigned his opposition because I had PTSD. But recent events gave him confidence in my abilities, especially now that I have gone through Ketriya. But this contract in front of us has made him second guess his confidence in me. I didn't need to see his glimmer to see his resolve wavering. Its probably the same with others. The Heraknus kept apologizing but also kept insisting to either break the deal or sign the contract.

Rory was good at instilling fears. Him being Charles son made everyone believe him unequivocally when he said no one can stop Charles alone. At this pace, whatever I choose won't matter. People will make that decision for me. Even Ned believed this was crazy and backed me despite the verbal scuffle we had outside. He didn't want to show a match that could end in a potential death. Reinhart signs to Riena, you really should have told this much earlier. Or at least given us more time to consider this.

Riena says with a distraught voice, I don't like putting anyone in this position. We deliberated for long time, and decided to present it now. I don't have any good excuse. Just bad ones. Blake asks, at least tell me who came up with this contract first. You say it wasn't Charles, then who was it. I want to know their reasons. Bernard says, sorry. We can't tell you that. They would be singled out and be in a negative spotlight. Its not their fault for prioritizing Heraknus before anyone else. Blake had no argument to refute that. It was good attempt. But unnecessary. Its become a collective will of the entire Heraknus.

Luther asks, when if we David signs this contract, how will it uphold. We don't have laws and policies in place right now to adhere to the all the claims. Beneficiaries for getting his asset, cluses on abdicating repercussions and other stuff. Reina says, that is true. However, you are mistaking one thing about the validity of this contract. Blake rests his chin on the back of his palm, we don't have the laws, but it will change when Citradel council moves here. You are betting that they will come regardless who wins the match. She nods, its almost guaranteed they will join in the city. And when they do, these document will have value. We are preparing for that eventual administration.

We are in a deadlock situation. I am restrained due to others. Heraknus aren't backing down due to Charles selfish decisions. Quite a quandary I am stuck in. I heard a comment from an admin talking how they shouldn't have brought in the Heraknus warriors here. They were concerned it only aggravated the confusion and tension. Then I connected the dots. I remember Sommers saying Riena came to judge me. What if they came to do that too.

There were was the rumor about me cheating and they spent an entire day about proving that. Why haven't they mentioned it. I don’t think they have any new evidence to believe I wasn't cheating. With Riena and Bernard taking the lead, they have been obediently following their lead and only supported them. However, none of them has even said one about me possibly cheating. That’s what's been bugging me back when I heard they send half their strongest platoon.

I was caught off guard with this contract that I didn't realize the biggest reason they are here. I am sure many of them still feel unsure how I was able to copy others Kuret. They want to see me close and see if tricked them. I turn to Rory, who was the biggest reason why I thought its possible. He was asking about my Kuret sphere back then. I gather he must be the next strongest after his father. So his presence alone was enough to make us aware of the threat to my life. Its possible he brought others to make a prove them that I was cheating.

Maybe the next contention of topic after this would be about this. I would obviously not show how I can do it. It would bolster the fact to the warriors that I am cheating. Blake said to them a while ago that he can't trust them to not give other conditions. The admins also agreed with that point. While the Heraknus denied it, none of us were convinced. They were making an unexpected demand of me, so whose to say there won't be another. Maybe they will use it as leverage to break the deal. Unless I show proof I didn't cheat, they are sure to cock block us again.

I couldn't stop a sudden chuckle in the heat of the discussion among others. Few confused faces are directed at me. I know exactly what I need to do now. I turn to the Reina and gather everyone's attention, I want to propose something. A way to move forward this. She says, I will gladly take any suggestions. I say, I will sign the contract and even record a video for the public. Blake tries to lean in closer, but I raise my finger to him. I say, but it will not be disclosed to the public. I will not let you manipulate people with this. I will convince you that I can take on Charles with a demonstration.

This made everyone confused. She asks, what kind of demonstration. I say, I appreciate your position you are in. You all have seen Charles overdrive up close, so you know his full unbridled power. What you are worried the most that no can can't stop him. What if I convinced you I can do it, survive long enough till his overdrive runs out. Bernard says, its an overdrive. Only another. I cut him off, you are thinking of Medrine. But its gone. The rules have changed. People with unexpected powers are popping up everywhere. Is it so hard to imagine some irregular like me can't face him. You are sorely underestimating me.

Rory says, we aren't. You struggled in the match. I scoff, that was natural. I had never seen a Heraknus before. Forget about knowing how their Kuret works or any weakness. I smile, besides, I have leveled up since then. This bruise was from Blake. He packs mean right punch. He and others have been helping me whip into shape. I am very confident I will be more than ready to take him on. People were taken by my attempt at this persuasion. Rory asks hesitantly, in just over a week?

His skepticism was natural. I say, that’s why I want to show a demonstration. It will also help convince our officers that I am not foolish, but strong enough to fight Charles. I turn to the warriors, and your warriors can judge for themselves I can manage a caged Charles. This grabbed their attention as well. I need them to say it first before I do. The actual goal I have in mind. I say, I have requested the training center tomorrow. I invite you then, to see my demonstration of my Kuret. I am sure I can show enough abilities to manage Charles rampage.

This caused more commotion in the room. Blake whispers to me, I hope you know what you are doing. You aren't ready yet. I subtly nod at him. I am glad he wasn't stopping me and just warning me. Guess he also knows I won't back down. Luther asks, what if they are not convinced. You will allow this agreement to go public. I nod, sure. But I am confident people will not be scared after seeing what I have to offer. It will not be overly grand but it will to be enough that everyone here won't stop me.

I nudge them a little with a hint so that they go with a different idea I had in mind. I was waiting for someone to take the bait. Reinhart says, if we can keep this agreement hidden from people, we may be able to stop an uproar. Isn't that right. He confers with other admins. Ned says, I think its still a bad idea to sign that contract. However, he takes a pause, it would be better for moral if people not know the dangers of Charles overdrive. But how can you so sure Charles won't accidently kill you.

Actually I had a surefire answer to relieve everyone of their worries. If I reveal it here, then no one will stop me to sign this or disclose this contract it to the public. But it will only complicate things and also reveal a strategy against Charles. I have to an arduous route for now. I say, ask me that question again tomorrow. I wasn't going to give in to any pressure from anyone. I am very aware how arrogant I am being. I needed to appear this way for someone to take the bait. Bernard asks, what a bold suggestion. What do you intend to show. He gave me an opening. I say, you saw the preliminary rounds. There are so many ways I can prove it to you. Or better yet, you can suggest something. I leave more crumbs for someone to pick up.

Rory says, instead of an aimless demonstration. How about something specific. I gave him a sly smirk. He took my bait, that’s true. Its a caged match, not a marathon, or an obstacle or a test of strength. A survival match with my life is on the line. So how about a sparring match with your Heraknus warriors. He smiles in response thinking I caught on to his thinking. But actually it was me who gave it to him. I turn to others, you guys have seen Charles overdrive. I am sure you even restrained him on occasions. You guys are the best judge for this. Now peoples attention focus on the people at sitting at the end.

They all become anxious, but I could few glimmers of excitement too. I think I was right they wanted to see my Kuret up close. But none of them responded. At least not yet. I turn to Rory, how about you Rory. Are you game. He thinks for a second, sorry. I am still not sure if what you said about overdrive DNA theory was true or not. I don't want to give you any advantage. I wave him, that was just a theory. Its not an exact science. Besides who else better to judge me other than you. For a moment it looked like he would agree to it. But in the end he remained silent.

Too bad, I would have preferred him. Then I face back to the slightly anxious warriors. I say, you are here to guard others. But you have an opportunity to show others what Heraknus can do. I see some glimmer of peak curiosity and excitement. I add, don't tell me you are afraid of loosing. That did it. Eric stands up, I'll take up on your offer. We got our first contender. I raise my palm to him, we finally get someone with balls here. That’s great. Eric, right. Let me be honest here. You know I sort of goaded you into this. Are you still fine with it.

Many were bamboozled at my open provocation. Eric looks around to his people for a moment and then to me, doesn't matter. We were here to judge you if you were worthy to fight Charles in the first place. This is an excellent opportunity to test your so called confidence. See if they are just words or if you can back it up. I like him. He wasn't angry with me so much that he be bothered by this. I saw tinge of blue glimmer, he was composed and yet held enough pride. I reply, I just wanted to make sure you know what you are getting into.

I don’t believe this will appease everyone. I am sure not everyone understands how this convinces them and sign the contract. But it at least removes the deadlock we were stuck in. Eric suggests something more. He says, if we are going to check if you can survive Charles. I alone am not enough. I am curious how he indents to judge, Geroge, Lena. He points to them beside him. They both lacked the courage before, but now they gained enough to stand proudly. He says, I am not so stupid to fight you alone. You are strong enough to take on omegas.

The way he puts it makes one believe he wanted a particular type of team match up. I ask, you want me to fight you all three. All at once. He smirks slightly, I do. You don't think only one of us are strong enough to hold Charles overdrive on our own. It takes five of us. The last time Charles went berserk, we three were able to restrain him. Granted, we got lucky and it only happened once, but we are confident in our abilities to hold him down. If you want to prove you can survive alone. Then show us by doing the same. This wasn't what I expected, but he was right to test me in the right circumstances.

More people voiced their opinions now. The three of them were locked in and waiting for my decision. I say my chances have dropped a little. It will be very difficult. They only need to realize that I can carry my weight. I nod, fair enough. I am in. The room becomes slightly chaotic from this outrageous agreement. I turn to Reinhart, do you have a problem with this. He spoke to an admin for some time. He then says, we don’t have much choice right now. If Heraknus are prepared to keep this hidden, it could work. But are you sure about this. Rory says with a small smile, yeah. What if you get hurt or won't be able to convince Riena.

I turn to her, in that case you will get your wish. Many people will not be in favor of this and it most likely end with the match cancelled. She and Bernard were still amazed by how unfazed I was. The other warriors were ecstatic to get a chance to see me in action. I had the correct insight they came here to see if I am deceiving others. They won't mention it now since they think I will be showing it tomorrow. They in for a colossal disappointment. Luther says, this is nuts David. I thought you haven't trained enough your new Kuret form. How will you fight them off.

I say, I have other tricks my sleave. I was blatantly hinting that I will copy Kurets. Rory leans in closer with anticipation. I say, or maybe I just bluffing. We will see tomorrow. I think this improved many peoples anxieties, while it only increased in few people. No doubt its more in my friends. I say to Eric, since I am asking a favor from you guys. You can decide how you want to test me. He nods in agreement, I will discuss with others for the appropriate test. What time shall we meet tomorrow. I gave a thought, lets mee it same time tomorrow. Goerge and Lena gave their approval too.

Since it was lunch time now. After few final discussions about tomorrow we broke off. I am immediately swamped by the high ranking officers and Ned. Everyone else left us alone in the conference room. Marina yells, freaking

hell David. What in the world you did that for. Nathan says, taking on three of them together. That’s crazy, even by your standards. Vanessa gave me the silent treatment. I wonder if she heard about Ned confronting me earlier. Catherine says, hey, don't ignore us. I face her, I was just thinking how much time I have today to train. I was thinking of a targeting attack practice. This caused a nervous smiles and chuckles from everyone.

Blake says, you need a lot more time than just today. You just, ah, had an accident. You can't have recovered already. I say, I feel fine. Don’t worry. I did a light workout today, tested few things. I can take on them if I play my cards correctly. Many people didn't understand what I meant. June says, I think your under estimating them. I say, perhaps. But I had to do something. There was potentially another issue rising after this. Blake says, what do you mean. I explained them my reasoning why the warriors were here. I didn't have any proof, but turns out I didn't need it. None of them even mention it to anyone in the car as well.

They themselves realize the suspicious behavior. Luther says, I didn't notice that. I just believed they laid it to rest. But you are right. They stretched out the whole day due that rumor. Tina says, and they would taken longer if we hadn't forced their hand. Ruther asks, what if they just didn't care anymore. With all the publicity they got they might have thought you couldn't have cheated. I scoff, no way it will convince them of my innocence. If anything, they might be even more suspicious after Ryes going at my personal life. Any outsider would believe that if I can hide things about my past, I am not completely above board.

Deni says, still, they didn't demand for a proof yet. I say, no, they didn't. And maybe they never had any intention. But I wasn't going to take that chance. My Kuret techniques is my ace in the hole. The only advantage I have against Charles. And besides, this will put to a stop to any of further attempts to escape the deal. Even the two of them begin to realize I made a move that made the most sense.

Vanessa says, I know Rory was definitely suspicious of it. He told me outright that he thought David cheated. Despite no evidence. I don't think he let it go completely after meeting him today either. I didn't know about she had a honest talk with him. Catherine says, seriously. He seems so decent. Marina asks, why didn't you tell us.

She shrugs, I didn't think much of it. I just believed he was jealous of David or something like that. I smile at her, thanks for the compliment. I do agree with you. She gives me a confused look. June says, but to use it as another leverage. Do you think they would go that far. I pick up the document and raise it in front of her. She takes it and sighs, point taken. People take turns reading the document. Nathan says, I believe David. There is very good chance they ask this. It won't just prove he wasn't cheating, but also reveal his tricks. A double edged sword as a final act of desperation to get out of this deal.

Catherine asks me skeptically, how in the world did you figure that out. I thought you had changed. Her words hurt me so much, it left me a little berated. I say, I am still the same person, just better. The people who didn't understand her question gave her puzzled words. She shakes her head trying to hide her embarrassment. Chelsea says, back up a second. I heard from Catherine that all of you knew about Charles overdrive from the beginning. How are you guys so chill about it. Jess says, its not like we didn't know the dangers. But its David, I am sure he has some plan.

I raised by brows, curious why she thought that. She says, what. Am I wrong. You were acting a little crazy back in the coliseum when negotiating with Charles. But today you were different. Please tell me you guys saw it too. I mumble, clever girl. Ned asks me, so you already have a way to win. I thought for a second on how to handle this. I say, not exactly. I have a way to not die. No matter what situation I am in. People were waiting for me to explain. I tell, you really expect me to reveal such a strategy. I am in pins and needles with the stares I am getting. I sigh, but I know you can't just take my word for it. So here's what I am going to do.

I grab Blake's shoulder with one arm and Marina with the other. I jerk my head to motion them and come along with them. Tessa says, seriously. You trust them more than us. I felt another curious glimmer of suspicion from her. I say, ahm, yeah. They are Shadows. Then I had another thought, fine. I guess I include another person. Nathan, lend me your ear too for a second. I picked the most untrustworthy guy from the group. That turns a lot heads with confusion. He scoffs, you are not kidding. I would be your last choice. I say, that’s the point. No one will doubt me then.

He shows his teeth to others, very interesting. Blake asks, you sure. I tilt my head, trust me. Marina says, come on. Spit out then. The four of us left the others for a small while and I explained them my strategy. In about two minutes I return back to others. Ned asks, what did you say to them. They look so nervous. I say, they are just over reacting. Vanessa says, did you really them the truth. Or was it just a bluff. She is still so consistent in not trusting me. I say, ask them. Tessa asks, Blake. What is his plan. Blake expression changes to confusion, I don't believe it. I am going to have you show it to me. I gave him a subtle nod.

Marina was extremely excited, so you can actually do it. You can cut through my barrier any time. She plays on her hair ends with a nervous laugh. Nathan whistles, just how in the would did you acquire this Kuret. I click my tongue, spoilers. Come on. No more hints. Jess eyes Nathan, who just shakes his head laughing. Vanessa asks, did he really tell you his plan. Blake sighs, he did. Its unbelievable. Marina says, you guys are in for a treat. You could have told the Heraknus. They would have back down.

I say, there was no guarantee. Besides, I am going to use it tomorrow. Nathan says, you aren't. I thought the point was to shock and awe. You seem to have whole heatedly embraced that thinking. I say, there is a time and place for everything. I am not going to put my survival at risk. Then I smile, besides I have a different plan. You want a shock and awe, get your ass tomorrow and see it for yourself. He scoffs, nothing will stop me. I will clear all my meetings for it. Vanessa asks, wait. You don't plan to use your mystery Kuret. Then how do you plan to convince them tomorrow.

I say, I will figure it out. I always do. She wasn't really buying my confidence. She probably thinks I am just lying or bluffing. In that case I have an idea, since you don't know if you can't trust my decision. How about this, if you aren't convinced I can't handle Charles by tomorrow, I won't sign the contract. Her eyes narrows at me. I turn to others, actually, if even one of you think I can't do this, I won't go ahead. Frank says, whoa. You want us to decide this. Are you sure. I nod, I am not just doing this to convince Heraknus, but I am doing it for you all too.

Catherine says, you actually mean that. Deni says, that’s actually makes us even more nervous. June says, yeah. I don't like putting in a spot like this. Blake says, they have a point. You can't just pawn off your decision to them. I expected the resistance, this is not me making this difficult for you. I am trusting you guys to make the call for me. Its just as simple as that. Nathan says, what happens when you don't sign the contract. We loose Heraknus, then we loose Citradel. I laugh, that is fine too. Do you think I have only one arsenal in my bag to force Citradel to bend the knee.

Blake asks, please don't joke around. I say, I am not. Taking away their resources was a plan I had at one time. But I didn't do it until it was necessary. And given their current state, its possible to dismantle Citradel from inside out. I don't want to do that, but I will if Heraknus don't play ball. Chelsea asks, I am sorry, but how can you do that. Luther says, you say it like its no big deal. I say, I didn't say it will be easy. But its not impossible. Now that I am not crippling with trauma, my mind is much more clearer. Its like the time I was without my memories, but without the unnecessary burden I was placing on myself.

I then stared at the two people who recently leaned my true identity. They both had to realize its well within my skill set. Catherine speaks first, I see. Yeah, if its you. Then you can probably do it. Don’t you think Vanessa. Vanessa looks a little conflicted for few seconds. She then says, I guess. Nathan says, you seen to have something going on with them. Wonder what it is. I wasn't ready to reveal my identity. At least not yet. Ned asks, I am not a high ranking officer. Will you give me a say in it anyways. He probably thinks I am going to held the previous confrontation against him.

I nod, why not. You wouldn't be able to do you job if you constantly worry how the match will end. Wondering all sorts of precautions for any problems I might cause for you. Being blindsided after doing so much is a bitch. I was taunting him, possibly hint to fix or end his relationship with Vanessa. I don't know if he got that hint. He remained silent, contemplating his decisions. Marina says, you are being too cocky, you know that. I had to own that. I say, only if I can't back it up. And you know I can do. She bites her lips knowing I was right. I was taking a page out of her book.

Blake says, all right. If you insist, we will also be judging you. But be honest, what are your chances of winning tomorrow. I scratch my neck and give some thought, I say, less than 50 percent. Nathan says, its less than that. You don't know anything about those three Heraknus. You are going in blind. I say, so are they. They haven't seen what I can do now. He laughs, you take a big game. Its been only around 1 week and half. I say, a lot has happened since then. That makes some of them suspect of me. Blake says, regardless, lets wrap it up. We have still have jobs today.

Catherine says, that’s right. I need to take them a tour of the city and then Marina will take to the construction site. We have a full booked day today. Its time to take my leave, I will see you all tomorrow. And Blake, I like your help tonight. Meet me at the same place we did few days back. He takes a peek at his tablet, I will be free after 9. Will that work for you. I say, that’s fine by me. You can dinner at my place. Marina jerks, hold on. If you breaking open that wine bottle, I am coming by also. She has her own priorities set, that’s what I admire about her. She says, besides, I need to see what you said was true.

I nod, if you get time after your talk with Heraknus. You can drop by. I turn to others, apologies, but I can't invite others. You know how it is. I get few disapproving looks from people. June gives me a more suspicious look than others. Whatever it was for, it will have to wait. People begin to disperse. I peek at Ned who gave a wanting look at Vanessa, but decided to leave with others. Vanessa didn't follow him behind, but left separately with her IDF team. I feel a bad for interfering their relationship. But all I did was nudging Ned towards an ultimatum.

I tug on Catherine's arm, sorry. But we will have to do rain check on our date. My calendar is booked for the day. She pouts a little, yeah. I got it. Jeez. She leaves with Jess, who asks her, what was that about. A date with him. She scoffs, don't mind him. Nathan says, lets go wonder twins. Frank asks, where. He says, lets scope out some Heraknus. Aren't you curious. Because I am. Did he ask them because they were from Citradel. They chat a little bit and agreed to go with him. Marina strolls behind them, wait. If you are going to the guest house, I want to meet Melinda. I still haven't forgiven her.

Now it was just Blake and me leaving the room. He says, when you said you were going to put on a game face you weren't joking. We laugh sharing in our predicament. He asks, I don't know about others. But I really believe they were going to make another play. I say, I should have seen it coming. It was bugging me why their warriors were in the meeting. Did they say anything to you. He says, not much. They made me believe because Charles wanted them there. But I wonder, if it was Charles or other Herankus. Maybe someone else entirely. I say, you are thinking of Kafar. He says, makes sense right. He gave the impression he had given up, but did he really.

I can't tell it was his idea. I say, he does seem the possible suspect. Then again, it could be the people targeting us. He says, why they benefit from this. Jeopardize breaking the deal when they tried to manipulate the tournament. I say, I am just throwing out a possibility. Maybe we are overthinking and its just Heraknus wanting to cover their asses. We climb down from the stairs and step out the admin building. The crowd outside had gone away now and only officers were outside guarding at the gates.

I say, I agreed to meet Cassandra and Matt at lunch. But I can't make it now. He says, you want me to cover for you. I thought about it for a while, thanks, but its fine. I will message them I have urgent business. But if you can explain them whatever you can, that would be great. He nods, I obviously can't talk about that contract. I will tell them you will be preparing for a demo session with the Heraknus. He pauses for a second, I know you said its fine to bring all the officers, but are really okay with brining in people too. They might see you lose and your celebrity status will take a hit.

I answer flatly, if I lose, then so be it. At least I wouldn't regret not taking a shot at them. As for my popularity, it was always fickle. I accept my situation, whatever it will turn into. I'll just enjoy while it lasts.

Vanessa (Chapter 106)

Monday, March 2, 2026 23:01

Siera wraps her neck with a scarf in front of her bedroom mirror, is this better. I answer, its fine. You are being too weird about this. She sighs, I am going to meet Heraknus today. Even I feel anxious about certain things. You may not remember many stories, but back in Medrine they are legends. And now I am finally getting to meet them. She puts on her favorite jacket. I didn't know she can be such a fangirl. I decided to match her clothes and wore a casual dress with a blouse and jeans.

Yesterday after the meeting, my job was over and I went back to officers building. But my mind was elsewhere the whole day. David has changed so much. I thought he was faking it. Then I heard from Blake later what really happened. I couldn't believe he was stuck with such a sickness. I didn't know what Ketriya was. But when he explained it to me, I was dumbstruck. He has been going through Ketriya for decades. When I told Siera she couldn't speak for several minutes. What's more is that his PTSD, trauma and all the issues he has been suffering was due to Ketriya.

And now that his brain has been physically rewired, certain aspects of him has changed. I couldn't tell Siera what they were, because I was figuring out myself. Its not a personality change. If I had to say, he is become more like when me met and didn't have his memories. He is calculating, but now he knows when not to lie. Siera asked me a question that gave me a lot of headache. Did he combine his self of identity from Medrine and Earth into one, birthing a new one. Maybe she is right, he had to deal with his Shadow past and his experience from Earth. And the result is this, a guy who is jokes around and still schemes when needed.

He said he was going to earn my trust back. And he started by involving me in the decision of whether I allow him to sign that ludicrous death contract. I didn't read it, but Tessa told me the highlights of it. After the initial shock, some of us understood Heraknus point of view. Its their first public appearance after centuries and its already messy. Their alpha was beaten down to a draw and his overdrive danger exposed. They don't want to tarnish their reputation and trust before it even started. Siera calls for me, Vanessa. We don't have time for you to space out. Lets go. I shook off the thoughts and we left for the training grounds.

Blake gave most of the officers off for few hours. He invited all the officers who are available to see the sparring session. We opted to take my car this time instead of public transport. The training grounds were much father and would be slower to reach. On the way Siera asks me, its been some time I visited the place. I respond, same. It brings back memories that feels they were from years, not months. The big arena in sector 5 comes into the view. I see many people trying to get in. But only officers and their families were invited in.

Siera asks, was this wise to open to the civilians. I take the car towards the path the sign said for parking. I nervously say, Luther discussed with Heraknus and they agreed to bring in few people. But not the general public. She asks, why not. I say, Heraknus are not yet citizens of our city. They are not really our guest too. So for the time being they are given intermediatory provisions. So in the interest of protecting the general public, this compromise was done. Heraknus also want to take it slow. She says, I see. Sort of makes sense. So they are okay with few people, and not all. I correct her, only our families. Not even friends. That’s the deal for today.

I find a spot in the forest clearing and part my car. The last time I was here was when many people were busy training to improve their ranking. I reminisce a little when I see the track in the south. I took the first position in that, and I was so proud of it. But now it’s a distant achievement. After today, everyone who had fond memories of this place would be overlapped with Heraknus. Few volunteers officers guarded the arena. Even with the barricades around the facilities, we needed people to watch out for intruders.

The officer says, morning Vanessa. And this is. I introduce her to them. They take a look at their tablets and check her name. He says, all set. He gives her a card that assigns her a seat. He says, you can bring your phones inside, but we strongly discourage not to take photos or videos of Heraknus. I wave to them with a laugh, ah, guys. I gave that order myself. She already knows. The guy gets nervous at his clumsiness. He had other things to say, but he immediately steps aside, ah, I didn't realize. Apologies. We take the entrance door leading inside.

Passing through the hallways, we entered into a open ground covered with a thin semi transparent roof. Half of seats prepared for us were filled. I point out our seat to her, perks of being the chief. You get to enjoy from the best view. She smiles, show off. I signal her the way while I take a detour to meet few people. One of them that caught my eye was Freya. Nathan sat with Jess and her. Its been a long time since I saw her. She's been working with the scientists as a contractor and not as an officer. Nathan insisted she be kept away from us. She says, you look good Vanessa. Sorry, I haven't been in touch with you all more.

I say, you should get out more. I turn her brother, someone is being over protective of her. Nathan answers with scoff, you know why. She is not a fighter, and these are strange time to be out and about. Freiya gets annoyed at the trite reason. I know the main reason is because he isn't in control of the city. Unlike here, the Valley was his domain and he could let Freya free reign. We didn't force her to be more active because she was herself not willing. These two are the last two pure royals left and that comes with its own set of problems.

Jess stands up and pulls me aside. She whispers to me, I heard something from June yesterday. Is it true then. About David and you know what. My heart beats faster. I reply, don't know anything about that. She is confused, are you sure. Because I have been thinking about it for a while now. And it does makes sense. I need to get an excuse and leave. I found one from the crowd. I wave to Sommers, lets talk about it later. I didn't give her a chance to stop me again. This is bad, why did June gossip this to Jess. I curse at myself to be such a klutz yesterday. The best I can do right now is avoid talking about it. I pray they all think it was a joke or something.

Sommers came with his mom. She was in her late forties and came in with a sweater. He gets up, hi Vanessa. I greet his mother, morning. She smiles as waving to me, nice to meet you Vanessa. My son has told me a lot of things about his chief. I turn to Sommers who was gesturing her to stop. I smirk, has he been complaining about me as his boss. I want him to know how much trouble he is in. It was a harmless teasing that made her laugh. She says, oh he has told me enough. He scoffs, mom. Chill. She says, fine. I am here for the Heraknus anyways. She gestures to the Heraknus warriors around at the bottom near the edge of wall.

She says, its surreal to see them in person. I didn't notice they were already here. I ask Sommers, when did they arrive. He says, they were the first ones here. Deni said they have been here since 7:00. I see the three person discussing with others. I ask, what have they been doing for 2 hours. He says, meeting few officers and people. But mostly doing some Kuret warm up exercises. I heard one say it helps with their transformation. I see Eric using his Kuret on his body, not he wasn't really transforming. Guess they are very serious about it. His mom says, is he alpha's son. She points to Rory who was in deep conversation with others.

Sommers replies, yup. She asks, whey isn't he fighting David. He laughs, short answer. He is afraid David will figure out some clues about the alpha. She blinks a little hard, is that even possible. He shrugs. But I knew that this was a bluff from David. She sighs, David's been on the many peoples mind lately. However, I don't see him winning this session. Even after you helped him this morning. I ask, you two met today. He says, he messaged me yesterday to meet at 4 in the morning. My eyes widen, for what. He says, what else. He wanted to test out his new Kuret form against me.

I ask for details. He and David met in some cliff in sector 3 and had a spared till 7. Sommers Kuret is perfect to test out David's physical Kuret. He says, he has got some serious explosive blows. He can't maintain it for long though. We were testing his defenses too, which had the same limitations. He can physically block me with his Kuret now, but he doesn't have complete mastery. Its not surprising David would be so diligent. I am glad he wasn't being confident just for appearance. He says, its interesting that he was not trying to use his limbs. Blake gave him some pointers and he was focused on controlling his Kuret.

His jaws clenches, his Kuret has changed considerably since the tournament. Once in a while, his Kuret would suddenly act up and breaks my Kuret connection. It's very disorienting. He wants to monopolies this new side effect. I recall the fight after he destroyed his house. He was able to cut off Cass's Kuret completely. And it even effected Marina a little. He continues, If can do it consciously, then it will be highly effective on Heraknus Kuret. I ask, I doubt he learnt it in few hours. He says disappointed, unfortunately he couldn't do it a lot of times. Sort of happens on luck. So he ditched that plan and focused on Kuret attacks.

I ask him, do you think he is ready. He gives me a hesitant expression, I can't say. His Kuret is physical, but its slow. If he can get a clear shot while building enough momentum, then yeah. He has a chance. It was a little unrealistic to hope David would control his new Kuret so fast. He scratches his head, actually. I think this is his backup plan. Because after I met him, he went to meet Marina. I think they are working on his copy Kuret technique. I turn around and couldn't see either of them. I get a little nervous, if he exerts himself so much before this, he will be sapped of his strength.

He nods, can't argue there. But the guy is a freaking machine. His dedication is admirable. He wasn't arrogant for no reason. He hasn't seen his training style so its obvious he be surprised. I still have unresolved issues with him, but I know he his real skills and talent. I take my leave and let him enjoy the show with his mother. Siera was enjoying a little when I take my seat beside her. She asks, they look so normal and yet so mysterious. I think she is just letting her imagination go wild. They weren't looking physically beefed up like others, but that doesn't really matter to a Medrone. We chat a little bit what little I know about them.

In the corner of my I saw Blake coming with Catherine. They notice me and approach while talking about the Heraknus. She says, Heraknus come before us. He says, yeah. You are right. I thought they would have preferred to meet people later. They wave to Siera and me. Then proceed to take the seat in front of us. I lean forward, any idea where David and Marina are. They both turn their necks to us. Catherine asks, you mean they are together. Weird, I didn't hear anything about it. Blake says, neither did I. I just assumed David was alone. I told him about Sommers and Marinas early morning meeting. Blake scoffs, he should be saving his strength.

Catherine asks, when do you leave him last night. He says, around 12. I ask skeptically, did he even sleep at all? Catherine sighs, he didn't get any endurance increase from his Ketriya. He has a plan right? She faces Blake. He says, if he has, he hadn't come up with when I was with him. We worked on improving his Kuret control. He still has bad habit to do physical movements with his Kuret. So it was a challenge to just focus on his Kuret. Siera asks, did it bore any fruit.

He says, its not an easy thing to learn. We switched up his goals to prepare for Heraknus specifically at the moment. His Kuret reserve has improved, so he can afford some wastage. We worked on augmenting his movement with Kuret. Nothing fancy, just basic striking styles he has learned over the years. I ask, he meet with Marina later. What is his game plan. He thinks for a second, I didn't talk to him about that. Catherine asks, shouldn't he be here by now. There was only 15 minutes left. It was us now, others were getting restless too.

After a while, Tina comes up to us, morning guys. Bernard is asking how much longer they have to wait. Blake says, David messaged he will be here soon. Give it another few minutes. She goes back to report it to Bernard. Siera asks, why aren't you with them. Blake replies, they are having strategy discussion with Rory and others. I would just get in the way. I look down to the warriors who were putting on a different uniform. Catherine says, that’s their Heraknus uniform. Melinda told me about them yesterday. They are lined with a Kuretine made from their Kuret. Supposedly can stretch and also stimulates their Kuret body. The cloth was a mix of green and brown. A brown lining spread across their whole uniform.

Then a sudden roar of cheers comes across from the corner. The officers and their family cheer as two figures comes from the entrance. It was them two. David came in with a hoody over his head and a capri trousers. Marina followed behind him in a causal clothes. Catherine says, look who made an appearance. David waves others as he walks down to the ground. Marina navigates her way through the crowd high flying few people. Then takes a seat beside mine. She has her usual spark of enthusiasm, we are so late. She smirks, I am never going to hear the end of it from David. She told us they both were at her place the whole morning.

She scoffs, the bastard had the gall to use my conditioner. If we weren't pressed for time, I would have smacked him good. Blake asks, what did you meet him for. She says, its about his Kuret copy technique. I told you before I had some ideas about it. We went through a couple of them. I ask, did they pan out. She squints a little with her cheeks, I say it was a failure. He couldn't control his Kuret properly. Though his original technique is much faster now. Blake asks, how fast we taking. She says, he can load up one strong shot in about 40 seconds.

Catherine chuckles, isn't that still too long. She says, hey now. Getting to this point is pretty lucky. I got him to that point after many tries. She turns to the ground, but I doubt he be able to use it though. There are three opponents. The only opportunity he has got in the beginning, when he waits for them to transform. That gives him about 7 to 10 good shots. Maybe he uses a couple of Kuret to restrain them. Rory approaches David from their side while gesturing Blake to meet. Blake says, gotta go. He leaves us to discuss the game rules.

The other Heraknus were placing a red Kuritine paint around the field in a circle, marking the boundary. This paint floats in the air and glows all the way to the top. We waited in anticipation as David and Eric finish up their talk. Blake heads back up to us after few minutes. Catherine asks, I heard something about the changing rules. He nods, yeah. You see that line, Heraknus added few win conditions involving it. He tells us the line will be slowly moving inside and gradually limiting the area inside. While this won't happen in the actual match, they argue that David can just keep avoiding them. They do this maneuver for Charles too. Restrain him in a place.

Marina says, then is there a time limit until the circle closes them completely. What is it. 5 minutes ? He says, it was. But David wanted more time. Said he couldn't fight properly in short time. So they agreed for 10 minutes. I ask, he must want more time for his Kuret sphere. Marina says, that’s the right call. I heard from Melinda that those guys have excellent team work. Catherine says, Charles trained those three personally. Makes them the right candidates to test David. So that’s how Eric choose his teammates.

Siera says, but isn't that counter productive for David. Heraknus most dangerous ability is their Kuret endurance. Blake says, I told him the same. He said it was worth the trade, more time makes it easier for him to find their weakness. I can't say if it’s the right call, but if he think it was necessary he had to have a reason. Blake continues, they also added a rule that anyone who touches the line will cause a loss for David. I am confused, how does that makes sense. He says, Rory said it was to prevent David from taking advantage of the barrier in the real match. Since Charles wouldn’t be in control, he will likely use it as part of some plan.

Marina sighs, there is already a precedent. He used it in the match with Charles. Catherine says, but that’s so unfair. I say, why did David agree to it. Blake says, he already asked to increase the time, felt fair to him. He can't keep relying on same tactic. As long as Heraknus don't cross the line themselves, he will have to confront them eventually. Marina says, they want to force him to close combat. He says, that’s right. He ran around a lot against Charles. And while that is a valid strategy, they can't have him running around the place all the time. This is a fight for them to judge his skills.

The Heraknus logic made sense, but its weird they want to impose more stricter rules. Siera asks, what happens if the match ends in a draw. That’s something I haven't thought of until now. I am curious about that possibility. Blake says, I actually didn't ask. He smiles, perhaps they don't believe it will end it like that. Catherine says, or maybe they will do this again. That seems more plausible. Marina, if that really happened, wouldn't the Heraknus be satisfied with his ability to survive Charles overdrive. She made a point. I just hope no one calls for a redo in case anything goes wrong.

The Heraknus finish preparing the red line and clear away the ground. There are many cameras setup around the ground. They also put a big display beside the stadium wall that had something on it. My guess would a timer. Soon the only people left on the ground were the participants. David finally takes off his hoody. A round of cheers wave as he reveals his bare skin. I can't believe it, he is going shirtless for this. He had been insecure about the red scar he has from the poison that nearly killed him in the Valley. Not anymore, because he has tattooed all over the skin with a abstract design I didn't understand.

Catherine mocks at him, look at that relaxed smile. He is enjoying this. David waves to the crowd as he throws his hoodie on the side bench. I ask, when did he get that tattoo. I think he even shaved clean his chest. He picks up a thin white boxing bandages from a bag and wraps them on his palms. He deliberately makes a show of it by slow movements, gaining more excitement from people. I couldn't help but be a little jealous when few girls beside me get animated from the view.

I was annoyed so I ask, is he not going to wear anything to protect himself. Isn't that dangerous. Blake says, no need to worry about that. He can always dawn his Kuret armor. Having any cloth doesn't make much difference. Marina says, but it does make him look cool. I had to agree with her. He had lean muscle to look hot. I shake my thoughts, what am I thinking about. I get embarrassed by my own thoughts. On the other hand, he is leisurely walking through a small opening of the red barrier.

The three Heraknus follow him from behind. While they fill the gap with the Kuretine, David already starts to prepare for the battle. He brings out his Kuret and begins wrapping it around him. He did it while keepings his hands in his pockets. He seems so cavalier about the precarious situation he was in. Siera asks, that’s confidence I haven't seen from him before. Catherine says, no one has. His Kuret runs on his body like electricity. It wasn't the wild Kuret anymore. Instead they were dense and forming rings of spirals over his body.

The three Heraknus take position at the other end. Soon the stadium goes silent when the barrier is completed. Blake hesitation spills in his words, I sure hope he has more than just swagger and intimidation. He is up against three Heraknus for freak sake. Marina smiles hard, this is going to be fun. There is an chime alarm with a countdown starting. Everyone in the stadium get serious. The Heraknus also takes their stances to bring their Kuret. As the alert alarms begins to go slower, while the tension increases.

The Heraknus pull out their brown Kuret and begin to transform. Unlike Charles, they are more adept to transform. On the left, George begins to gain height while still being slender. The his skins starts to grow scales, few of them shimmering with Kuritine. His mass begins to get bulky and thicker every second. A single scaley tail begins to grow from behind that wags on the ground. His body takes a very different shape from Charles. I see his arms were bigger and large too. So was his elongated torso. He takes a stance on all fours. There is a single long horn like Kuritine coming from his head. Hold on, he looks like an animal from earth.

I can't believe what I am seeing, it’s like a rhino. He had such strikingly familiar appearance. Soon more Kuretines growing on his face and covers his head like an antler and appear as a crown. His budging neck had no much muscles, he looks like a bull from the torse. He looks so much heavier than Charles muscular form. But I don't doubt the power behind that heavy Kuret muscles. I dart my eyes to the right. Lena's Kuret was flowing more horizontally. Her arms grew in length. It didn't stop even they become twice as big before. Her arms turns into hoards of Kuretines.

Her face turned sharper and Kuritine grow from her thick chest. She even had a long Kuritine beak. Her legs too become longer. Her feet were shining with Kuritine. Are those freaking talons. Wait. That form intuitively feels like bird. My suspicion becomes true when two tails grew from her back that were swaying in air. Those tail ends had flat Kuritine like they were some like of gliding supporters. Her back also is covered with Kuritine feathers. The next instant she flaps her Kuritine wings and hits the sky. A pair of hundred gawking eyes look up she Lena became a flying Kuritine covered bird.

Then came the last Heraknus. He was also growing in size that is comparable to the other two. Unlike Geroge, his form remains standing on the ground on his legs. He is covered with an overwhelming less amount of furs or Kuritines. But then I saw his arms and legs. They were completely made of Kuretines. I thought they were just a Kuritine armor, but his joins protrudes out small sharp Kuritine ends. He had four saber tooth Kuritine coming out from his jaws. The Kuritine on his wrist comes like claws, they aren't big, but its too thick see where his palm and fingers join. His chest has a little bit fur, and there are few Kuretine stones growing there. Unlike others, he got no tail. His form looks that of bear and a chetah. He doesn't seem to have too much mass, so perhaps he was more agile.

Their complete forms left everyone speechless for a second, and then the people stood up shouting and howling marveling at the trio of humongous beasts. Lena flew low and hovers few feet above the other two. This makes them menacing and intimidating. Anyone would feel pressure from them. David was no exception. He had removed his hands from the pocket and postering with more seriousness now. His smile was replaced by a more stern expression. He had changed his Kuret to form a sphere with his hands. He should have had ample time to create multiple Kurets by now.

Soon the final alarm begins to countdown. Marina yells over the shouting people, oh boy. This is going to be a long and intense battle. Blake cries out, I sure hope David has plan that works. Because one of them is flying right above them. Catherine yells, how is planning to take down Lena. Can he fly yet. Blake and Marina shook their heads. We weren't expecting a flying Heraknus. The two on ground hold their positions, but their postures indicate they will be ready any second to pounce.

David Kuret sphere does something unexpected now. It begins to pulsate, appearing as though it was a propulsion engine. His Kuret vibrates vigorously, blowing off air around him. The vortex abruptly begins to wrap into his right arm. What is he planning to do with that. I couldn't figure out why he abandoned his Kuret sphere. I didn't have any thoughts to spare, because the siren goes off. The face off begins. Everyone expected David to stay in his position and analyze his opponents. Maybe let the trio make the first move. But that all shattered when he launched into a sprint.

He dashes in fast with Kuret straight into the trio. George and Eric run at him with gusty. George was slower, so Eric was first one to reach David. Eric slashes at David with his Kuret arm. David crouches down and slips past him. His aim was Geroge behind Eric. Lena took a swan dive at David, trying to block him. David won't be able to dodge her. He instead chose to jump high, kicks off the air like he is climbing invisible steps. With his Kuret vortex that was spinning on his arm, he throws a Kuret blast at her. She couldn't avoid it from this distance and brings her wings to defend. The force was so much that she was thrown up into the air unable to counteract.

He summersaults in the air, lands back on the ground and kicks off towards George again. Why is David diving into their group right from the beginning. David kicks off another dash towards George. George was charging in close and raised his torso in the air to pound on David with his heavy palms. With the Kuret on his arm, he blocks Georges arm and pushes it out of the way. David crouches down as he brings his arm to his waist creating a stance for a punch. All the while when his Kuret gathers over his arms even more. Before George could regain his balance, David throws down a right hook straight at Georges shoulder.

On contact, David's black Kuret tore though George from inside out. Blake Kuret dug into the Kuret body and George howls in pain. David's didn't stop his assault and instead propelled him sideways. George flings to the side, falling hard on the ground as David continued to put pressure on Georges shoulder. The impact caused the ground to split apart in contact and creates a tremble. Blake Kuret erupts from Georges body. After a second, David suddenly leapt into the sky. I thought he was going for another attack from the air. But he was thrusted into the air before Eric could grab him from behind.

He decided to head towards an incoming large bird. Lena flaps her wings and her Kuritine feathers turn into dozens of projectiles. David wraps his Kuret around himself to defend for few of them. The rest he dodges as he zig zags in the air, like scaling up between the gap of a building. What's up with David's aggressive head on assault. No one was expecting this, neither was Lena. She tried to bite him when he got closer. David pulls back and thrusts forward again. Lena tried to claw him with her talons. David blocks them with his Kuret arms. She tried to slash him with a wing. But at the last minute David kicks off into high gear and lunches himself above her.

Having gained a momentarily higher position, David pours in another ridiculous amount of swirling Kuret on his one leg. He twists down and lands his foot straight at Lena's neck. She makes a loud screeching noise when David Kuret dug into her and come out from her chest like a spike. With another thrust into the air upwards, David pushes Lena to a straight downward path. Lena was struggling to get out from David's kick. She tried to throw her Kuretines from her wings. But at the speed she was going, she was missing most of them. The rest, David disintegrated with a Kuret armor. They both crash into the ground.

Before the last moment, David leapt into the air again and stumbles down rolling at the side. Lean was writhing in pain, and couldn't get back up. Actually it wasn't just her. George was also immobilized, lying on the ground where he was knocked down. A chill ran though my spine. I stood up from my chair when others did the same. Everyone were so silent with jaws dropping everywhere. David Kuret wraps behind his back and uses it as a boast to run. Eric was genuinely surprised by his teammates sudden falling beside him. He was glued to the ground as David charges at him. I can't be sure, but was that fear from Eric.

David instantly closes the gap between them. He halts when he is at striking distance. He takes a fighting stance by extends one arm ahead while keeping the other close his chest. He looks like a martial artist preparing to throw down a single strike. Eric shakes off the confusion and goes in for an attack with his Kuritine arms. David calmly dodges those slashes while maintaining his distance. Eric suddenly jumps into the air and goes for a roundhouse kick. David blocks it with a Kuret armer around his arm while being pushed back. But the next instant David bends down and goes for a low kick while extending his leg. The vortex Kuret hits under the Eric armpit.

I didn't see enough force, but Eric made a painful scream. David black Kuret borrows deep into his thin body and pours out from everywhere. The Kuretines on his arms and legs starts to crackle. David rolls away from the kick and takes a few steps back. Eric stumbles down on one knee that was cracked. He was already healing it. But David wasn't going to let him. He approaches slowly towards Eric. Eric tried to slash him with his arms, but they had been so damaged, that David didn't even tried to defend himself. They broke when it came in contact with the Kuret armor on his neck.

David then places his palm on the same spot that he attacked earlier. Eric was healing the spot, but he was immobilized for the time being. With a yell from David, a wave of Kuret pulses through the spot causing more agonizing pain to Eric. The Kuritines on his body shatters. He wasn't able to maintain his form anymore. He just had one working leg, with which he somehow still managed to stop from falling down. His Kuret body was shattered and torn in so many places.

David slowly moves around to the front of Eric. He takes a stance for a palm thrust. Another vortex of pulsating Kuret form over the arm. Eric is helpless and watches in despair as dark Kuret begins to block his view. Then when the time was right, David yells out a war cry and thrust his Kuret palm into Erics chest. The attack was devasting that it ruptures Erics Kuret body from inside out. Like clothes being torn, he is flung backwards as his Kuret body stays behind. He is knocked on his ass and writhes in pain. The Kuret body left behind lumps down like a bag of dirty used Kuret clothes and begins to dissolve in air.

This can't be happening. I turn to look at the other two Heraknus. Surely they will bounce back. But they both are down. Not just that, their Kuret body is evaporating. They both are now lying in the ground unconscious as themselves. The only one left now was Eric, who was clutching his side chest and lying on the ground in total confusion. David is heaving hard and falls down on both his knees. He takes the support of one arm as his Kuret returns to him. Eric was struggling to get up. And after a while he got back up ever so slightly. He was bleeding from his chest where David had hit him.

David wasn't getting up, he slumps down on his back and lies on the ground. What the freak is going on. Just then the alarm goes off. The red barrier that was closing in begins to flicker near Lena. Her arm had touched the line. The buzzer rings on the display screen, which changes to an insignia. Its the same on the Heraknus clothes. Its their house marker. According to the rule they set, if anyone touches the line, Heraknus win. How in the bloody hell is this a win for them. Two unconscious, while one is barely handing on.

David begins laughing from the ground, damn. I lost. He yells aloud with an amusing tone. He leans up taking support of his one arm, lets do it again. I didn't think it would end so soon and with my loss. Eric slumps down on the ground with a dazed look on him. The red barrier goes away, but everyone here were frozen solid. Then Marina shouts, Freak yeah. She was yelling in sudden excitement with her palm over her mouth echoing her voice. Then came nervous claps, with slowly turns into a thunderous applause. Soon people began cheering like mad men. I couldn't hold it together and yell out raising an arm excited from this insane twist.

Blake yells, the freak was that. He crosses the crowd and ran down to the ground. Marina followed him behind. Actually everyone started to run. The officers down hold off the people. The frenzy was filling the whole stadium. Beside me Seira had a stone cold expression. She was in complete shock. I decided to let her process it while I go with others. It took a while, but the officers held of the families that were cheering from the walls. I scrummage though the crowd and navigated to the gate. I turn to the people, everyone. Go back to your seats. Please corporate with us. Thank you. That made few people back away.

Soon the rest of the officers managed to push the people back. I yell to Ruther, get more people from outside. Coordinate with them before this becomes a mess. He nods rushing off to the exit gate. I turn to Deni and Sommers to manage the crowd for now. I cross the gate, passing by a group of horrified Heraknus. The most confused one was Rory. He was siting on the bench with heavy eyes and palms to his chin. Marina and Blake helped David get up. He was sweaty and panting hard. He also limped a little, freak. I think I twisted my ankle. He squints his eyes when he put weight on his leg.

Marina yells, you are worried about that. What did you just do. Suddenly he yelps in another pain. He slumps straight on me. I hastily grab him by the shoulder. The excitement left me with a growing concern. He grumbles, holy shit. My shoulder. Its burning. I support him while he gains a little of his bearing. My eyes turn to his left shoulder. His arm seems odd at the joint. I blurt out, he's got a dislocated shoulder. Blake let goes of that arm, shit. Sorry. He yelps in more pain as Blake places his arm back down slowly. He hugs me more tightly from his other arm. If it weren't an emergency, I would be flushed from his sweaty skin in contact.

Marina says, I got this. She circles around me and prepares a charm over David socket. With one eye open he groans, careful. She nods, this is not my first time. She prepares a charms with which she analyses his bones and tendons. He says, wait. Towel. My bag. Blake runs back to the other bench and rummages inside. Davide under a painful grunts says, sorry. This is, ah, awkward. Ned is going to kill me. I yell, forget about that right. I can't believe he is worried about him at a time like this. Blake comes back a small white towel. David chomps down on it and then nods to Marina.

She then places her palm on his shoulder, this is going to hurt a lot. With a clean and precise movement, she throws a charms that displaced the arm back inside the socket. A small popping sound comes from the socket, following a David's muffled cry that tingles in my neck. A moment later Blake helps him get off me. The towel slips down revealing a heaving David. He still have a twisted ankle. So we help him get to the bench. He leans back to the wall still full of pain. He grips his arm that was hurting him. He has few scratch on his arm and a few bruises on his back.

He winces, that hurt Dammit. He then starts chuckles, what a poor finish. That’s so uncool. And in front of the whole world. I had the urge to slap him. If only he wasn't in so much in pain already.

Blake (Chapter 107)

Tuesday, March 3, 2026 18:48

I help him wear his hoodie back on. He shrieks when he moved his arm. We decided to leave that arm open. Once he was able to relax, he grabs another towel and starts scabbing himself from the sweat. Marina removes her charm she was waving on David's body, miraculously you haven't broken any bones. You have a sprain in your right wrist also, any minute you are going to feel that. His panting becomes slower and points to the bag beside him. I slide it towards him. He picks up a small case and gives to me, green pill. There are plenty of different colored pills. I pull out the one he needed and he swallows it.

He points to another item in the bag, blue strap. This one looks like a type of bandage. There are several of them in a bunch. He picks one to wrap it on his twisted ankle, one around his wrist and one over his shoulder. The strap begins to tighten on his skin. He bites his lips in pain for a second. The blue strap gradually turns into shades of brown and white, finally turning invisible. I ask, is this the same tech as your bots. He pulls up his sleeve nodding. Then his pale color turns back to normal. He sighs, the pain killer is kicking in. That was intense.

I had so many questions in my mind. But its not the right time to ask. Not when there are so many people behind the wall, confused, shocked and hyped. Marina says, is it okay to show this in public. He replies, someone made a bargain for taking my Hive bots tech few days ago. It was also used as an incentive to bring the scientists to us. There is no point in hiding it anymore. Vanessa just rolls her eyes at him. She blurts out, forget about that. Tell me how did you do this. He groans while standing up, not here. I ask, where are you going. You need to rest. He smiles, I am fine now. I want to check on them. Lets see if anyone else want to test me again.

Marina scoffs, tell me he is joking. I think he is just trying rub it in. We follow him from behind. The Heraknus warriors had grabbed the unconscious George and Lena and taken inside. The remaining hurdled around a wounded Eric. A guy sees us approaching and pats on Rory's back. He turns towards us with an annoyed look. Actually everyone one had a grim face. I bet no one thought this fight be over in just 53 seconds. Rory says, guys. Can you give us a minute. David says, I just need a moment with Eric. He asks, for what. David says, I think I went too far with him. I wasn't planning so much force.

He thinks for a second while eyeing others. Soon they part aside and we see Eric seating on the bench, clutching his side. David walks to him, Eric. Are you okay. He wasn't hurt anywhere expect his side where it was bandaged with a Kuretine strap. Eric turns his neck up with disappointed eyes. He lost that vigor he showed us few minutes ago. He didn't say anything while glaring at David. David nods, I just want to make sure that injury isn't severe. A girl says, he will be fine. The wound isn't deep, but its going to take some time to heal. David raises his unharmed arm, let me take a look at it. As an apology.

He begins to wrap his palm with a Kuret sphere. Everyone took a step back and David spins his Kuret into another vortex, the kind he was doing earlier as a feint. So he plans to use Jonathans healing Kuret. Its strange he is okay with doing it in the open, after all the effort to keep it a secret. I whisper to him, I thought you weren't planning to use it. He smirks, not in the match. This much is enough for now. He plans to use just one shot of that Kuret. A minute later his Kuret storm forms on one palm. It vibrates to shower the white Kuret over Eric. Eric shifts around his seat feeling uneasy about this. Yet he remained seated as the Kuret shines over his body.

David managed for about 30 seconds of that Kuret, but it was on par with an alpha level. The wound on the chest begins closes immediately and Eric looks significantly better now. Only the drops of blood trickled from the side remained from the healed spot. Eric stand up to check out his wound by moving his arm. A try's a few swings with slight ache, but he appears to have recuperated enough. He says, thanks. Feels much better. David disperses his Kuret sphere, you should still check it out. I am not proficient in compatibility healing unlike theirs's bloodline. Eric nods with a small guilt. He along with other warriors head back inside.

Only Rory, Bernard and Reina remained with us. David turns to Bernard, sorry about your son. But I have to ask. How did I do. He remains silent and couldn't form any response. Riena says, you don't need to ask David. You made your point very clear. She wasn't upset, but wasn't happy either. She sighs, I have never seen anything like this. How did you do that. He says, I found your Achillies heal. She asks, our what? Rory says, it’s a metaphor. There is a Greek mythology among humans about a immortal who was invulnerable to everything, except for one weak spot on his body. His heels. David smiles, someone's been paying attention to this planets history.

Rory answers not amused, you couldn't have found it already. Did someone told you. He says, maybe I figured it out on my own. I did fight your alpha up close and intimately. His cryptic answer left Rory in an even worse mood. I step in before David humiliates them further. I ask, Riena, you said you wanted to judge him. And even though we only got a minute of this, do you think it was enough. Or you have something else in your mind. She faces me, I am not going to pretend I understand how our three strong people lost. Nor can I deny the outcome. She turns to Bernard, are we still planning to tour the next part of the city. He takes a second to answer, yes.

She says, then let me discuss with others and get back to you later. Will that be okay. I reply, that works for us. The three of them left our side and David waves them away enjoying their retreat. Marina pokes David's stomach, stop antagonizing them. He coughs a little, they started it when he they gave me a death beneficiary contract to sign. He wasn't wrong though, they played a dirty trick trying to break that deal. Vanessa says, ah, the crowd is getting out of control. What should we do now, Blake. I gave it some thought, I was expecting this to go for few hours. Even if its over already, I don't want to take away the off hours from officers.

I signal to Tina from the crowd. She approaches with wide eyes on David, are you okay. He says, nothing I can't handle. I tell her, message all the officers to get resume their jobs second half of the day. She asks, so we still are off work until then. I nod, we gave the whole morning off for this. I doubt anyone would resume to work now. She says, I am on it. She nervously glances to David. He chuckles, impressed. I know I was. She could tried to hide a bashful smile. Vanassa says with a high tone, you should check on the Heraknus instead. She waves and goes back to the side hallway leading to Heraknus room.

I turn to Vanessa, tell the people that the show is over. Heraknus didn't say anything, but I doubt they want a rematch after that debacle. She leaves to join Ruther and Deni. David says, if there is nothing else, I like to take a nap. Marina says, you what. Right now. He says, I didn't get a wink of sleep last night. Spent about 20 hours in planning and practicing my Kuret. I feel like dead weight. We were right, he spent all the time since yesterday to prepare for this. Marina says, I'll take him back to his place. David says, thanks. I will see you in the evening. I ask, Marina, make sure he sleeps in before you leave him. She gives me a grin knowing my intention. I don't need him to rub his win over Heraknus more than he already did.

He yells as he is being dragged away by Marina, don't forget the vote on signing that contract. I say, I didn't forget about that. Meet us at officers building around 6. You can present your case. He asks, my case. I reply, I am not only one who wants to know what the hell your strategy was. Marina drags him away to the exit. I climb up the stairs and help Vanessa a little bit with the crowd control. May were asking for David and so I explained he is treating his wounds. Some even saw the ART tech he used on himself. I redirected those questions for Catherine to handle. I felt a little bad, but she is very good at mediating stuff like this. In an hour we wrapped up the training center.

I looked around the aura's of people as they begin pulling up their cars back into the city. Some still haven't shaken off their excitement. Many planned to follow David back to him home. Thankfully, I got a message from Marina saying she is taking him her place instead. He needs some space to rest up. Jess escorted the Heraknus back to their guest house. Vanessa and Tessa approach behind me. Vanessa says, they are going back to lick their wounds. I answer, they are. Must be a hell of a shock it's already over. Tessa says, he obliterated them in less than a minute. Their pride as Heraknus warriors was stripped in front of the entire world.

I just recently learned that even though we tried to not leak this to the public, someone was filming the entire fight. It includes everything, from him beating them down, to him helping Eric. It was posted on the network few minutes back. We tried to take it down, but its already gone to several servers. Vanessa says, its gone viral. No point in trying to stop it now. Its going to only stroke his ego now. That was definitely going to happen. He will be gaining even more attention than ever. Tessa asks, but he deserves that. Don't you think so. Neither of us deny this too. He said he found their weakness. I didn't hear anything about it last night.

But even then, he took out alpha level warriors in seconds. His Kuret has drastically changed his game. We had few hours off, but only in name. Even when I went back to officers building, people were giving us surprised looks. Many reporters tried to ask questions. We only gave them what they already knew. Few officers head towards the guest house in their free time. Hoping to catch the glimpse of the Heraknus. Luther, Tina and me stayed back in our offices to discuss the next plan of action. As time went, people started to resume their usual work.

Luther then presented me a daring suggestion. It was something he messaged David yesterday. And David's reply was to wait until the outcome of today's match. He says, guess this means we can do this. Right. I gave it a lot of thought before deciding it. I nod, yeah. Lets do it. I don't like to leverage this when they are already down. But we can't have them planning anything else to try and stop this. Tina says, at least this will make things equal for both of them. She had a point. Until now, we couldn’t present this to Heraknus. But now they can't reject it outright.

We met with Catherine and Jess at lunch. They didn't have anything new to report. Just that Riena and Bernard wanted some time privately to discuss their decision. Jess says, I heard the both of them woke up and have no serious injuries. They are very confused about the whole thing. Catherine says, and embarrassed. I heard Rory is mad upset by their performance. He may have believed that David cheated with the whole copy Kuret stuff. But even without it, they lost. Bernard practically kicked us out, while still being polite. I says, I am sure they don't know what to believe.

I do wonder why David showed his copy Kuret when he healed Eric. Was that just because he was feeling guilty from injuring him. Knowing him, there should be another reason. The video went viral and in few hours we learnt it even spread to other communities. At this point I suspect David himself of this. Did he plan to cause further divide between them and Citradel. Could be. I am sure soon it will reach to Citradel ears once Heraknus report back this to Charles. Many of us are wondering how Charles would react to this. Whatever his feelings were, it will not be pleasant at least.

Fortunately, todays part of the tour and surveying of the city went without any hitch. Catherine said neither the three warriors, or Rory came though. The rest of the Heraknus came as scheduled. Meanwhile I finally met the science team from Citradel today. They came yesterday evening and I allowed them to rest up from the long journey. Nathan introduced the key people from the 15. They were very delighted to be here after crossing many hurdles. Though their aura's should some resentment too. I assured them this wasn't how we planned to invite them. The circumstances change quickly due to many problems. Mostly from Citradel.

They understood for the most part it was Ryes fault. But they were surprised to see the encryption tech from Citradel here. That only gave credence in believing Ryes was behind the criminal smuggling operations too. I didn't want them distracted by the political agendas of others. So I mandated that their only concern was development of our city. They were sent to do a job, and that’s exactly what we want them to do. Marina explained all the preliminary work she did. Tina presented them will the materials we procured up till today. The lead scientist, Ivan, was grateful for our work.

He says, splendid. He hands over the inventory of the martials we have on standby to his team. They went through it with a fine combed teeth. One lady asks, we have enough platinum to perform Kuritine enrichment twice the size of this island size. Another guy asks, so the rumors are true. You stole them for Citradel. I chuckle, not me personally. But yes. And whatever you don’t need, we are hoping it can be used by our R & D team. Ivan asks, that’s our plan. We are fascinated by the technology, what do you call it. Nathan answers, ART. Autonomous Reconfigurable Technology.

Ivan says, we have tried our best to reverse engineer their tech. But not to this degree. Frank says, its by human research team. The lady asks, can we meet them or at least get their research. It will greatly advance our progress in using Kuritines as an alternative technology. Nathan says, like I said many times. That’s a hard no. You know the guy who is now on everyone lips, David. He has the humans tucked away secretly and no one knows who they are. Unfortunately, you all have to study the designs yourself and figure stuff out.

They were disappointed, but not discouraged. They understood this tech is very experimental and very controversial. Setting aside the weaponry advancement, there is a question of people's opinion. These tech killed their family and destroyed their planet. Even if they are just tools, they are subject to a lot of ire and hatred. Around 4:30, our long meeting came to an end. I took a break for next hour at the lounge. Between helping David and managing the day to day tasks, its been taking a toll on me. I have to work on a better balance of life for the next two weeks.

I head Catherine walking into the room, you look so exhausted. I know you are busy, but you should take care more. I leaned forward from the couch putting the coffee on the table, nothing I can't handle. Its what I signed up

for. She grabs another coffee mug from the counter and takes my couch and sits beside me. She says, how did the meeting with the Citradels science team go? I corrected her, they are now our team. She laughs, leave it to Nathan to sweat talk them. I told her the highlights of that. I say, it's interesting only if you are into the science. She says, I know, right. I try to flaunt a little, but my interest ends with what I use for surveillance and extracting information.

We had a good laugh from that quip. We chatted more about our daily struggles with brainiacs like David and Marina. I laugh at her joke about David finally becoming an attention hog. He is behaving like the old days again, serious but amusing too. But now he is blatantly about certain things. She says the fame is getting to his head. I couldn't deny it. He never had this much fan base. But I wonder what would happen if people knew he was a Shadow too. She says, I think many will be angry at him. You know, since he kind of abandoned us. I understand he was going through traumatic. But. I add, people won't care about it. Whatever the reason, he left us.

The would be natural from people's perspective. She says, well, even if it never comes out. This phase will die out eventually. Once Citradel joins us, things will rapidly change. I agreed with her. We still had some time left, so I brought up a question, did you decide what to ask David for your help. She smiles, its something personal you know. I get confused, what's so personal you can't tell me.. She laughs at my nervousness, just messing around. I haven't thought what I want from him. I offer, maybe get some answers about your family. She gets lost in her thoughts for a bit, perhaps. But then again I rather not know about them.

She jerks up realizing something, wait. He is a Shadow, then it means you know the same things as he. Don't you. She made the connection and I had to reluctantly nod, I do. And if you want, I can tell you myself. You can keep a different favor from him. She says, that's kind of you. But I don't know if I want to know. Do you know what happened between dad and me. I shake my head, that I don't know. I am not going to ask it if you don't want to. She takes a sip of the coffee while contemplating. She says, I want to tell you. But promise me you won't judge my family.

I assured her I won't. She then opens up to me about her dad's decision to send John instead of her. After listening to this I get a little angry. I promised her that I will keep an open mind. But I let my opinion, you have always said you loved your dad. I don't know about you, but it feels like he betrayed you. She gets upset, please don't. I say, I am sorry. I know it was a tough call. But choosing him over you for a simplistic reason like that. And such a sexist justification. That's bad. She sighs, ah, I shouldn't have said it. I didn't held back, no. I am glad I know. You should know you proved him wrong. You have become someone they should be proud of, not be ashamed.

She says, but its true. I don't remember my brother much, but he was much more capable than me. I am so conflicted. I can't tell her the truth about her brother. That would destroy her. Her self esteem already took a hit from her dad. She says, there's no point in discussing about that now. I had some time to think about it. I am sure it wasn't a decision made with malice or negligence. It was an desperate decision, He was just doing what he felt was best at the time. I learned I can't judge him harshly now.

She had a lot of time to sort her feelings about it. I am still a little enraged, but I guess if she is okay with it, I shouldn't cause her any more problem. She says, actually, if I think about it. I am glad I didn't know this before. I wouldn't be mature enough to understand that decision. I say, nah. You were plenty grown up already. He tease her to her body. That brings a smile to her face, was that a pick up line. Its good, but not good enough. I say, maybe I should be asking tips from David. She immediately shakes her face, never. He is like a horny teenage suddenly. Does Ketriya have a side effect like that. I joke, I think that's just him.

I was happy with this. Us talking together and just playing off each other, having fun. This years been a roller coaster ride and finding moments like this helps me have some balance. I spend an hour with her. It was more than I hoped to get given our busy work. It came to an end few minutes before the meeting. We set our mugs aside and climb the stairs to my office where I asked people to join me. When I opened my door, I hear someone snoring on my couch. It was David. He changed into a shirt and jeans and his dark shades over his eyes. He wasn't alone, there were already people inside.

Marina was talking funny pics of David. She is being childish by plugging a pencil in his nostrils. I had to stifle a laugh from this unexpected comedic scene. She put her fingers to her lips when she see's me and Catherine walking in. Behind her, half the IDF team were already here, only missing was June. Even Vanessa couldn't stop being amused by this. David snorts a little when Marina plug one of his nose with a pencil. I sure hope no one walks in and sees how unprofessional we were.

But David has bad luck. The rest of the high ranking officers walk and see the spectacle. Luther whispers to me with a giggle, how long has this been going on. I shrug. Before Marina would put another pencil in his nose an alert rang from his watch. David stirs up and flounders a little as the pencils slips past his face. He asks disoriented, what the hell. Why are all looking at me. He immediately pats his face when Marina burst out laughing. We couldn't help it ourselves. He straightens up realizing he was being punked. He looks down and picks up the pencils. Amongst our laughter he smiles, Marina. You know I am going to get good for this.

She opens up her phone, don't care. I got good blackmail material. She shows everyone of his snoring and pranking video. He straightens out his shirt, being both annoyed and still enjoying. He gets out of the couch, rubbing his eyes. He looks around, nice to see you all had a good laugh from it. He lightly moves his arm to check the spot he got injured in the morning. Once the teasing dimmed down, I ask, how's your arm. He says, sore. I couldn't get into the nano bot tank, so it's a slow process.

Everyone settles down and take the chairs. I say, all of us are here. So start talking. He sighs, sheesh. Give a minute. Nathan says, you had hours. I like to know how you decimated those Heraknus. You cost me a bet. Typical Nathan. Tessa asks, you bet on him loosing. Nathan scoffs, no. I bet he would win after struggle. But Jess said he win under 5 minutes. That's some high praise from Jess. David says, wonder why you thought I was capable of such feat. She gives a sly grin not giving us any explanation on why she was sure. Sommers says, when we meet early in the morning, you didn't once showed those Kuret attacks. When did you learn them.

He says, I will tell you. But before that, Blake, what did Heraknus decide. I answer, they said they will tell us soon. But they requested for more time. Luther says, I had a talk with Bernard an hour ago, they are waiting for Charles's order. Vanessa asks, isn't Rory here for exactly this reason. She is right, but if it were for normal decisions. I explain, turns out taking out three of their finest in such a bizarre manner has left them discombobulated. So they had to ask Charles for his advice.

Ruther says, they got their ass handed to them in front of everyone. I bet that is going to sting for a long time. June asks, is there really now way to stop the video from leaking out of the city. Nathan says, its hopeless. We might be able to track where all it was uploaded, but erasing or stripping is not possible. Luther asks, did you guys find out who uploaded that video at least. Deni says, it was a kid brother of one of our officers. We caught him later, but I don't know how to proceed with him.

Vanessa says, his is only 11. Apparently he wanted to show off to his friends. I don't think I can charge him for anything. But that officer I am going give him a suspension. Nathan ask, just a slap on the wrist. Come on, that stunt might have worsened our relationship with the Heraknus. Few people agreed with his sentiment. David says to me, and to think you were going to blame me for this. How in the hell did he know that. It had to be a guess since I never told I suspected that. But I wasn't going to give him that smug satisfaction.

I turn to Vanessa, if that was a genuine mistake. Fine, give me a 1 week suspension. But still investigate it was only negligence. I don't want to find out later that someone else put them to do this. Vanessa agrees, we will question them tomorrow. Lets hope it was a innocent mistake and nothing else. Nathan says, there you have it. Come on. Spit it out David. He didn't have anything else to ask us, if their decision is delayed, I can't help it. Just goes to show how awesome I was. Blatant narcissism aside, he seems to enjoy the duress he has put the Heraknus under. Some of us snicker at his snarky attitude.

He walks to my desk and leans against it. Like a teacher explaining to a class of students, he removes his shades and keeps it aside. He explains, truth be told I wasn't expecting to take them down so suddenly. I was aiming for an immediate victory, but I didn't expect it them to go down so fast. It might be self serving for me to say, but I think their legendary bloodline myth is greatly exaggerated. I couldn't refute him on that. Frank says, are you saying that just because you beat them easily. David says, no. I mean many of you could have beaten them too.

Nathan says, maybe Blake or Marina. But they weren't that weak. Marina says, I was analyzing them with a charm. They didn't have a strong Kuret like Charles, but they had the numbers. He says, sometimes having numbers doesn't mean they are collectively strong. Though, that's not what I mean. There are three things I did. First, I needed to get a modicum of practice of my new Kuret form. That I got from Blake and Sommers. You ask me when did I learn that attack, Sommers. I already was testing that with you. It was just not in that bigger scale. Sommers says, you did. Huh. Didn't clock that.

He says, I was really struggling back then. No, actually I still am. He grabs his arm, I overexerted my Kuret control. Those attacks may look cool, but it's a waste if keep getting blow backs like this. It was a desperate move on my side. If they had managed to survive those attacks, like Eric, things would have turned out differently. I did have an inkling that his wounds could have been worse if the match went longer. He says, I am glad it paid off. Still, I have a long road ahead me. Vanessa asks, so you what, let your semi controlled Kuret skewer the Heraknus from inside.

David says, not quite. The next thing I did was figure out a weakness. Charles may have led us to believe he doesn't have one, but what about others in his bloodline. We may call them alpha level, but technically they aren't one. So I spent yesterday afternoon going over the match with Charles. Did you notice how Charles changed tactics whenever he gets injure. Even if they were simple strategies, he changed his style at every turn. The memories aren't fresh, I haven paid attention to every little detail of their match.

He says, long story short. I thought hitting him where majority of his Kuret was stored on his body was key to deplete his Kuret reserve. That was a mistake. Because they have ton of endurance no matter how much I shaved. The only thing that did work was when I hurt Charles from the inside. Nathan says, that's obvious. We already knew that. He says, what was not obvious was where to attack. I noticed something in our match, while he was constantly changing his style of attack, he was also hiding his weak spots.

Marina says, weak spots? Is that where they have less Kuret. He answers, not exactly. Heraknus are crafty here. I don't know if they are doing it consciously, or it's a problem they have on Earth. These places on their body aren't defined by how much Kuret they have. Its where their Kuret flows from. I think I get what he is saying, some time ago, you mentioned that their Kuret flows around them. Are you saying it comes out from there. He says, you got it. Yeah, its easy to miss the how and where under all that Kuret meat. I couldn't see it back then too. But if you rewatch the match, you would see Charles blocking my attacks few times when he didn't need to. I initially interpreted as just a quirk of habit. But my AI, M, figured out a pattern from the recurrence.

Nathan says, fascinating. A sort of a spring well for their Kuret. Where was it on Charles. David says, that's the craftiness of Heraknus. The location keeps changing over time. Marina says, seriously. So that's a moving target. Chelsea says, then its like a whack a mole. You hit one place one time, and then it changes next time. David nods, I wish I had seen this back with Charles. Would have saved me a lot of trouble and pain. I suppose aimlessly pouching and kicking him with my Kuret was the brute force approach.

I recall the todays match, so for George it was his shoulder. Catherine says, Lena her neck, or was that her back. Vanessa says, Eric had one under his armpit. David says, I had only one chance before it moved to a different spot. If that happened, they realize I was targeting them at their weakness. I had the element of surprise for a short time. So I had to use my biggest shot. If I missed or took too long, they would have regrouped. And I would be on the ground instead of them.

Its actually impressive he found such a unique trait of theirs from that one time. Nathan scoffs, then the credit goes to M. David smiles, I would argue it was both of us. Sommers asks, but then how did you find those places on these Heraknus. I doubt you spied on them before. He says, lets just say that my eyes have become sensitive as of late. If I am up close, I can sort of vaguely see where they are. His Ketriya boasted his glimmer sight. What an upgrade to have. He says, that's why I believe they aren't invincible. If you find their Achilles heel, and strike with all your power, you will sabotage their Kuret supply. It doesn't have to be me, anyone with an opportunity and skill can do it.

Only he can tell something so casually. I say, that's how knock them down in only one or two punches. People begin to see the genius of his strategy. Tessa asks, your Kuret cut off their Kuret gate. He says, quaint term. I like it. I wonder if they have oma name for it already. When I told Rory about it, he didn't seem surprised by it. I say, they have been struggling with many weakness on Earth. And like you said, they are adept at hiding them. I doubt they

wouldn't try to mitigate this problem. Nathan says, they had to know it would be an issue if their opponent found out. David says, maybe one of them will be kind enough to tell us.

June says, that was one hell of a move David. You got each of them in one shot. Marina says, expect for Eric. Why did he not get knocked out. Vanessa says, same reason Charles is still so strong. Not everyone is totally susceptible to this. Am I right. David says, I had the same theory. He is closely related to Charles, so maybe he has stronger resistance than others. Catherine says, by that logic Charles children would also be strong. David shrugs, having no clue. But there is strong possibility of it. Charles children are direct alpha descendants. They must be stronger than Eric.

Marina asks, what about that last attack on Eric. How do you explain that. David smiles, I am just as clueless. I masked my own surprise from the pain of dislocating my shoulder. I don't expect it to happen many times. But I think its something to do with the side effect. Sommers asks, side effect? You mean the thing with the thing. He says, people who got caught up in the accident few days ago know about it. Ah, now I realize what happened. He cut off their Kuret connection. Damn, that translates very differently for a Heraknus. Tessa asks, we are missing something here. Aren't we.

David sighs, don't sweat the details. By my estimate, I have a one in ten chances of having that sort of effect. The probability is so low I got incredibly lucky with Eric. I think that makes me a feel relieved. The more he exerts, the more blow backs like that will happen. Vanessa says, you are one crazy but brilliant guy. That creates a wave of laughter among us. Its strange to see her saying it, especially given how she feels towards him. I ask, so what's the third thing. He says, that was making them believe I was going to use my copy Kuret. I told earlier I caught them off guard. That wasn't luck.

Nathan snaps his fingers, that feint of using your Kuret storm. You purposefully did that. He says, not just that. There is a reason I asked to meet at your place Marina. I wanted people to see me with you. Since that video of our training, I hoped that would spread to some Heraknus ears. Marina yells, you did that as a misdirection. Is that why you sucked bad at the designs I gave you. He is slightly offended, I didn't suck. I tanked it purposely. We were in your garden, I was hoping people saw me failing and kept pursuing it like a fool. And for the record, I still don't know if that worked out

Jess sigh, it actually did. I was the one who told Rory you were seen with Marina early morning. David gives a villainous smile, ha. So it did. Nice. I thought I suffered through Marina's harsh critiques for no reason. I actually feel pity for him imagining that. People get a laugh from their banter. Marina gives David her middle finger in response. David clears his throat, anyways. I hoped showing up you was enough for them to think that I was going to use my Kuret. I have been planting that idea to them since yesterday. Even when I asked to increase the timer. Despite an obvious disadvantage of their endurance, I sowed the idea I needed it to prepare my Kuret.

This is exactly what I expect him to do. Perform mind games even before the match had started. Vanessa says, you lied to them. He says, I bluffed them. The match was never about proving I wasn't cheating, it was whether I can survive Charles overdrive. I let them believe it I would be showcasing it today. That single, subtle thought changed their strategy for few moments in the beginning. I knew their teamwork would be hard to break. But if they thought I was going to keep my distance first, it might give me a chance to get in and take them down one by one. And fortunately, that’s what happened.

Vanessa asks, but what if they thought you were bluffing. They must have devised a strategy to counter that. He nods, I am sure they did. However, you saw how I was goading them on the field. Being all nonchalant and haughty. You think I was shirtless just to fault at girls. He chuckles, well, I am not denying that entirely. It was to throw them off even more. They might be level headed people, but I have been arrogant to them a number of times. How long can one remain calm in a battle when you know you have the advantage of numbers. Unless this was a full blown fight with Hive, they wouldn't have their guard up all the time.

I knew he was up to something. Playing such psychological games to manipulate them is right up his style. I thought he would be too much different after his Ketriya. But he still the same. Its a relief and concerning at the same time. Chatherine sighs, you played them good. He makes a show of slightly bowing to us. His smug face was plastered with a smile, so what's the verdict. Have I been satisfactory with abelites. Anyone objects to me fighting Charles. Its hard to say if this really proves he is ready to fight an uncontrolled overdrive user. But the confidence oozing out of him is very convincing.

He looks around to hear any objections. I peek at Vanessa, who was the most vocal in opposing the last time we discussed this sort of thing. However, even if she is at odds with him, he trusted her to decide. Just one vote is enough to stop him from sighing the deal. Her aura feels slightly conflicted. But she never raised any opposition. After several seconds of silence, he says, great. Luther, whenever Heraknus are ready tell them I have decided to sign their silly contract. Nathan says, hold on. We are forgetting one more vote. Vanessa's boyfriend is not here. David replies, he messaged me immediately after the match he is in.

That was surprisingly fast for Ned. David leans away from my desk, if there's nothing else. I need to rest before resuming my training. Class dismissed.

David (Chapter 108)

Wednesday, March 4, 2026 21:43

They are taking their sweet time. Its already been 20 minutes waiting at the guest lobby. Blake and Luther are talking to few other Heraknus while we wait. Melinda chatting up with Marina again today. I had some time to spare, so I ask M, any update on our contact from Citradel. M replies, the last message confirms everything is in place. They will be ready to leave in 36 hours. Everything is as scheduled. Lets hope that's true. So much can happen until then. I will be at ease only when I see him on the island.

I lean on the couch spreading my arms lazily. Its already three in the afternoon right now. They already had their lunch. Why are they delaying it the inevitable. Jess walks up to me, sorry David. They are still deliberating the contract Luther sent over. I wave at her, its fine. I have some business here anyways. She asks, oh. I didn't hear anything about that. I smile, I had a lunch date with Catherine, but she pushed it for a later time. I was hoping to meet her now. She laughs, I see. That's interesting. He sounded a little amused. I ask, what. You don't think that true. She says, about the talk. No. But a date. She shook her head.

I felt a little hurt hearing that from her. She blurts, not that anything is wrong you trying. But, she already has a boyfriend. I scoff, whom she hasn't met for months. You don't believe they have broken up. She thinks about it, don't think so. She didn't take any interest on guys when they tried to hit on her. I don't think she would do that if she wasn't interested. They were handsome guys. So she still holds that much feeling for Rob. That's good to know. I realize something, hold on. I was one of the guys. So you think I am handsome too. I was grinning ear to ear when she was lightly amused by my logic.

Catherine somehow serendipitously appeared behind her, who is a handsome guy. Jess says, someone with a big ego. Her eyes immediately fall on me. She says, really. I don't see anyone like that. They both laugh mocking me. I should be flattered she at least acknowledged me this much. I stood up when I see Heraknus coming out behind her. Catherine says, the waits over. She turns to others, everyone. Lets move to the club room. I followed her inside a room in the adjoining building. The main reps of Heraknus are here now.

There was square table laid out in the middle with two documents placed at the ends. I am relieved they finally agreed to do this. Blake says, they finally playing ball. It was just a waiting game in the end. We knew Heraknus were just procrastinating. Riena greets us first, morning everyone. We just finished speaking with Charles. Blake asks, how is he by the way. You haven't talked to him much since you been with us. She says, sadly the issues in Citradel is escalating. He hasn't been able to make time until this morning.

This was a unexpected news. Luther asks, escalating. How do you mean. Bernard says, we aren't sure. Charles was in a hurry. But you don't have to worry about it. He was wrong. That's something we should definitely know about. He turns to me for answers. I shake my head signaling I haven't heard anything new from Jack. The communication we have is very rudimentary right now as per protocol. I can't just ask him to pass sensitive message when is about to break out from Citradel. Blake says to Luther, we should investigate that later.

Rory approaches from the side, dad has agreed to it. He was surprised at first, but ready to sign it. There were resistance to him. Blake asks, may I ask who was it. He points to Melinda. I say, ah, obviously. He nods, Melinda wasn't going to just let him do it without having a long discussion. That's why it took us a long time. We had to make her see reason. Melinda notices Rory pointing at her and walks to me, I am guessing its about my concerns. Rory sighs, not again. Look, I appreciate your trying to do. But dad is just doing this to form an equal footing, politically speaking. She faces me directly now, I am really worried things will escalate because of this.

Marina says, don't be. David isn't vindictive enough to harm Charles. Are you. I reply, obviously not. This is just a standard double clause. You have seen it in Citradel also, right. She says, I never thought I had to agree to this. You know I opposed the first one too. But Charles was being pressured. Seems like we are again. She glances at Rory. He remains stoic at her worry. Blake decided to cut in, lets not create a mess. Shall we. He gestures Rory. He gives me a annoying stare. Guess Vanessa was right about him. He hides a petty side to him. He didn't object in his action though. Together, we walk over to the table and sign each others documents.

Luther brilliant idea was to draw up another deniability contract like theirs. Instead Charles name was in ours. If he died accidently by my actions, I wouldn't be sued or whatever policy we have when Citradel transition here. Luther was skeptical of their agreement to keep the contracts a secret from the public. It was just a verbal agreement in a heated discussion. He felt they would publicly release it even they were convinced I was skilled enough to fend off Charles. Its quite a bold move, and it was only viable after their spectacular defeat. Luther is a prodigy in political warfare.

Rory imprinted his Kuret signature with a quill. I was granted the leeway to use a simple signature. Blake collects both documents when its done. I offered to shake hands with Rory, but he took his leave the moment he signed. He left me hanging. I mumble, rude. The unexpected person approaches beside me. Its Eric. He says, don't mind him. He is in a fowl mood since yesterday. I say, I can see that. How are you. I eye his bandaged chest. He says, its fine. Thank you for that by the way for healing it. You didn't need to do that. He is oddly being cordial with me. I put him through a ringer yesterday. He says, something wrong.

He guessed my thoughts. I say, I should tell you. I use deception in my fights. People often label them as mind games. But it's a viable play I often use. He unexpectedly smiles, I heard. Marina told us. I turn to Marina who heard that and gave me a big smile. Why she had to say that before I had a chance to explain. I sigh, yeah. I just wanted to make sure you know I didn't do it to demean or hurt Heraknus. He says, you played us good. I heard rumors and we even prepared for different eventualities. But you began the fight even before the match. I smile, that's one way to look at it.

Sommers said he had a good head on his shoulder. I ask, I assume they aren't a fan of me. He says, you assume right. You tricked us. But we can't do anything about it. I raise my chin, because your defeat was unquestionable and direct. He scoffs, not the exact words they are saying. Its in a nut shell. Their pride as Heraknus legend was been hurt. They assumed it will be show to show Heraknus abilities, but it was a startling defeat. He says, Rory been asking around if anyone talked to you. Did you? I played dumb, about what. He says, you know what. You were able to locate our singular weak points.

I could tell him I didn't talk to anyone. But would he believe me is a different thing. I answer, it wasn't luck. That's all I am going to say about it. He says, Marina said you are hard to figure out. You know you are making us look bad and that is going to make us hate you. I laugh, hate is a strong wrong. I am not responsible here, you lost. But lets resume that judgement about it after the match with Charles. Everyone know it was a fair match and they lost. No matter how bad the optics are for Heraknus, I am not going to be held responsible for it. He raises his hand to me. I am little surprised, but shake his hand regardless. He says, next time will be different.

I answer, oh, I don't know about that. But miracles do happen. He dismisses me with a wave of his hand and leaves the roam. Soon the Heraknus clear out the room, heading back to the guest rooms. Blake asks, making enemies. I says, lets hope not. He seems more sensible that Rory at least. Blake rolls up the two documents and hands it to Tina. He says, this is the first legally binding document in the city ever. I know it was out of our hand to choose what it was about, but I wished it was less. He was at a loss of words. Luther says, morbid? Same. But it was worth it at least. Tina asks, we aren't out of the woods yet. This contract is not viable until Citradel council moves here.

Luther says, speaking of them. We should figure what's going on there. Blake gestures at Marina and Catherine to approach him. He told them what Riena told us. Catherine says, I haven't heard anything. Nor do I have any way to know. Marina says, my friends gone dark too. Sorry. Luther asks, should we press on Heraknus for answers then. Blake says, no. They already are facing people's mockeries over their defeat. Lets not ask more from them. At least not until Charles arrives and they officially become citizens. They discussed other options, but none were credible. I am also interested to know what's happening. Sadly we don't have a way to know currently.

We broke away after few minutes. I pat on Catherines arm before she leaves, did you forget. We have a date. We were walking a little far from others and walking back to the officers building. She sighs, you are being persistent. I reply, and you are being dodgy. She laughs, fine. But you are going to have come with me. Turns out she and Jess had a meeting with IDF. The most recent client who smuggled goods is a prominent person. She is one of the people in R & D. Nathan is asking to not charge her because she is vital to his team. But Vanessa isn't backing down.

When we arrive at IDF in Catherine's car, I ask, so you both are advocating for her. Jess says, more like mediating the discussion. Catherine says, we can't show favoritism, but at the same time we can't deny she broke the rules. She makes an exhausting sigh. I think its not the first time she had to deal with this kind of issues. Jess asks, you could have talk to Catherine later. I explain, as luck would have it, I was planning to come here later anyways. Catherine asks, why. I contemplated to whether tell her. After weighing my choices, I explain, did you know a guy name Dunkin. He is a prison guard here. I wanted to meet him for some time now.

Catherine and Jess shrug to each other. The moment I entered I got few cheers and applauds from the people. I positioned myself between the two women and gave a solute to everyone. Catherine scoffs, jeez. Cut it out. I fist bump a guy, you rock man. Vannesa comes out from the inside rooms hearing the small commotion. She is surprised to see me here, what are you doing here. I turn to Catherine. She feels cornered and looks guilty at her, sorry. I wasn't expecting him to tag along. Just give me some time. Jess, can you get started with prepping Saya. Jess replies, I got you covered. Vanessa gave me a confused look but didn't ask for my reasons for being here.

We decided to go to the lounge for some privacy. The girls already in here fluster at my entry and scurry off laughing. I say, I know I shouldn't say it. But man do I have fans now. She rolls her eyes, aren't you just not used to people interest in public. We take our seats, that's true. My predecessor would be flipping out from his grave had he knew a Shadow strategist has become popular. She asks, is it that really a bad thing. I reply, its not shadows choose to remain obscure. But it does complicate things. Everything I do is now in microscope. Did you know I had to lock my own house at night because people were trying to peek in at night.

She gives a scornful laughter, sounds like a hassle. I grin at her, jealously doesn't fit you. She clicks her tongue being called out. I say, anyways. Its not really a problem, at least for the moment. But people's tune can change any day. I dodged a bullet with Ryes, but the next one could be an artery, from which I won't be able stop the bleeding. She is curious about my thinking, you think you will be targeted again.

I answer, I do. I am enjoying this while it lasts. Because one way or another, this will end. Her eyes sharpen, so that's what going on in your mind. But it will be a while till things settle down. You taking down Heraknus has created big waves. You saw Cranston put out another piece last night. People are talking about it already. I put my shades on the table. He went to make another video and he somehow got hold of a Heraknus. He wasn't one of the warriors, and yet they had quite a lot to say. Wasim applauded me for my stunning win. I became a hashtag 52 from that video. Since I defeated them in that many seconds. He spoke a lot about Heraknus and their struggles.

Overall it was an effort to keep the Heraknus power still relevant. He elevated me, touting I was a once in lifetime prodigy and Heraknus had bad luck they fought me first in peoples eyes. They weren't wrong, but I still feel many others could also defeat them. I digress and say, enough about them. I want to talk to you something more important. She straighten her back at my sudden reaction. I gesture her to relax, its not what you think. She asks, how would you know. I sigh, because my thing is very different. I take a breathe, I want to talk about Branden and John. I didn't get to tell you everything last time. She shakes her head, you don't need to explain. I already forgave you for that.

I answer, I don't think its that easy to forgive me. And I am not asking for it. I will feel better when I you know what kind of people they were. She drops her eyes down to the table brooding a bit. She nervously asks, why. I tell, because I don't want you to remember them due to one desperate thing they did. You should know who they were. She is visibly curious from this. She says, did someone ask you to do this. Because you don't have to. I am fine. A little bit of glimmer appears on her. She is probably hiding her insecurities. I say, you may be fine. But I am not. I used my promise to your father as an excuse. And I have been reminded what I should have been doing.

She didn't understand what I meant by this. She turns her hand to a fist anxiously. I continue, it was part of my treatment with Drew. I need to fix my mistake. She asks, I don't understand. But I understand you that you want to clear the air. Are you sure though. Did Blake already tell her about his family's involvement in Shadows. I don't think he would do that to her. I say, lets talk about your dad first. The truth is that he was a, I pause a little as she anxiously looks to me, is a big goofball.

Her blank expression took a second to go away. She blurts out, what. I laugh, oh yeah. He talks a good game, but honestly, I think he gave me the scholarship not because of my ideas, but because he wanted me to be his personal slave driver. She was taken completely by surprise, what are you saying. I say, did you know one time he forgot his anniversary a third time. Your mom wasn't talking to him for days and he was annoying us at work. Talk about unprofessionalism and negligence in disclosing private things to students. I get he treated me as adult, but who wants to hear domestic problems.

I remember the atmosphere in lab was so bad that Zakerine insisted we do something to help me. I didn't want to meddle in their business. I say, It was so bad that me and a friend made a vacation plan for your parents. A weekend trip, while I covered the department. You see how I was carrying his water. How can such a responsible guy suck so bad at home. What a nincompoop.

Her jaw hangs loose, I have never heard anyone calling my dad a goofball before. You are making this up, right? I say, what would I gain by doing that. I am talking about things that makes him. Things that matter in the end, not his work or anything like that. She then pulls out a nervous smile, seriously. I nod, oh yeah. I hate to say this, but you mom wore the pants in their marriage. People call him responsible, but he was clumsy at his home. I wouldn't have cared to help him out, but I was being somewhat pressured into helping him. And John was a mutual friend too, so reluctantly I covered for his work.

She hysterically laughs, dad was like that. I can't believe it. My memories of him are different. I say, I am sure he was different with his children than with his wife. I sometimes think its good I never met your mom, I kind of had a mental picture of a scary women from all the stuff he dragged me through. She couldn't stop laughing. I then shared few more stories, like the time he was accused of cheating, or when he forgot the in laws visit. People all only hear stories of their Kuret or abilities. But not much about their day to day life. The thing that actually makes them decent and normal.

She only heard the stories of her dad's accomplishments. I decided to reveal his side that others don't see. I spent about 30 minutes dishing out all the quirks of her dad. Her earlier brooding expression was no more. She was so amazed, few people outside the lounge heard her. She says, I can't believe dad didn't know the difference between a frezerk and urezerk. Isn't he used to using them as genie pigs for his students. Hell, even I could tell the different back then. That’s so wired, he made such a blunder in that experiment. I would have given anything to be to see him nervous when that animal glow in red.

It felt nice to share this. I sigh, like I said, a goofball. But even with all those flaws, he was a decent person. I may be biased because he helped me, but I let you to decide that. She nods in agreement, this is gold. Damn. I so wish I could have this conversation with mom or John. Their mention brought a damper in her joyous mood. I tried to distract her, unlike your dad, I didn't know much about John. I wish I did. I hope you don't take this the wrong way, but he was probably going to be the next alpha. She gives me a pity smile, I know. I have so little memories of him. I wonder what kind of person he was.

I say, I do have one story so you can understand him. John once impersonated his friends place in an exam and saved him from flunking. I was in shadows at that time and coincidently auditing the class. I was given the exam papers to review the grade from the professor. I was testing his knowledge of the subject and thinking of adjusting his training based on that. But I never got to see that. She says, you caught him? How. I have heard his transformation is flawless. He can easily mimic your gait and behavioral style.

With a smirk, I answer, people with strong Kuret always prepare for a high detection. But forget about low specs. He didn't copy his friends handwriting flawlessly. In fact, I could match the same style of his letters from previous papers. She laughs, oh come on. That’s such an obvious blunder. I nod, it was. The prof didn't catch it, but I have keen eye for detail. Naturally I got him to admit it. But instead of reporting him, we made a deal with him to help us getting into a seniors party. She slaps her palm on her head, you blackmailed him. I scoff, you bet. And not just that. We made him do other simple favors in exchange of keeping silent about that.

I laugh, sort of. His dad is a prof in the same university. He was so conflicted that few juniors were making him do things. He once said we haunted him in his sleep. She says, I feel so bad for him. You bullied him. I say, don't think he didn't try to get out. He once transformed into me and caused an incident that would have gotten me into trouble. Fortunately for me, I was prepared. A well placed camera showed I was framed. And unfortunately for him, we got more black mail material for him. She chuckles, oh god. You were making him dance in your palm. Actually, it wasn't me at all. It was Zakerine. She was the prank master and blatantly pulling making decisions for me.

She says, he must be very angry with you. I answer, on the contrary, he kind of enjoyed the challenge. It was a race of who trips up first and gets caught. And besides, we only asked him favors inside the walls of the campus. We kept it fair since he didn't cheat for his friend unreasonably. She asks, what do you mean. Why did he do it. I remember the time Zakerine told me the reasons when he shared it to her privately. I answer, his friends parents were friends your parents. And there was some problem between. Honestly, I don't remember the detail. But the friend was caught up in it and was lagging behind his studies.

She blinks a little erratically, why. I shrug, no clue. But your valiant brother decided he didn't want their parents problem lead to kids to pay for unintentional mistakes. So he offered to help the only way he could. She says, he did that for such a reason. Whoa. That’s. I added, show's his character. He could have made us back down if told his reasons in the beginning. He may have thought it was too embarrassing to share to naïve juniors. But the problem with his friend escalated and he involved us. Despite all the pranks and blackmailing. He could have been kicked out of the university, so we made sure he got another chance.

Her brightens to hear her brothers personality, your brother made him help the guy. I tutored him where he lacked. And he just barely saved himself from dropping out. After then we dropped our ridiculous meaningless tit for tat battles. I won't say we became friends, but I understood how he was Branden's son. He smiles with tinge of regret. She says, he was like that, huh. I know it’s a little cliché, but I always wanted him to be a good elder brother. I reply, its not a wrong thing to want. But like I said, I don't know him very well. Aside from the 5 or 6 stuff we asked him as favor, I didn't have much contact with him.

I regret a little that I couldn't spend much time with him in Shadows as well. I say, one thing I did know. He had a lot of social credit going on for him. He probably was mischievous, but he was decent person. She closes her teary eyes. I waited for her wipe away the minute tears swelling in her eyes. She blurts out, I just have a dirt. Don't make a big deal. Okay. I raise my hand, I didn't see anything. She sighs, I have so many questions. Its frustrating I will never have an answer for them. She then looks up to me, I figured out one thing though. I raise my brows. She says, you have hinted it wasn't just you doing this. You had someone with you in all your escapades.

I didn't give her an answer. But she interpreted my silence as the truth, and I am very certain this person made him do this. Didn't they. I can't picture you doing all this. You were a very serious kid back then. You said it yourself many time. I don't think you are lying too. So fess up, who was it. Leave it her to her intuition. No, actually I was laying it very thin. I say, remember I told you about a mutual friend. I did all of this because she made me. She scoffs, it was a girl. She leans forward, do tell who was it. I shake my head, this isn't about me. Its about you. My reluctance only made her more persistent.

After few more insistence I gave up, she was a good friend. All right. Catherine wasn't so gullible, I don't buy it. You wouldn't so much for a friend. What are you hiding. Turns out there are still sensitive topics I don't like to share. I raise my arms, I am not ready to tell you about her. I pick up my shades and put it on. The glimmers of excitement and curiosity from her were starting to overwhelm me. She shakes her head, you had a girlfriend back then. I have to know. I can't picture anyone putting up with you. Was she like you, a brainiac. I take offend at she thinks my preference in women is so shallow. But I can't really deny how Zakerine managed to keep me grounded.

I say, she was special in her own way. She chuckles, wow. You have to tell me who she was. I sigh, I may be more open minded about things now. But I still want to keep certain people private. She finally understood I valued privacy on this matter, oh. I didn't realize it was this personal. Can I at least ask why. I say, you remember when I told she was there when John died. Well, I could have saved her back then. But I was too hurt to move. So I kind of blamed myself for her unnecessary death. That’s not all. She made a choice that still bothers me. She patiently waits for me to reminiscence about that horrifying memory.

I say, anyways. I have many reasons to not talk about her. Some are personal, others are because of who she was. I am sure she didn't understand what I mean. But it was enough for to not pursue further, I see. I am sorry. I didn't know. I wave her hand, its fine. She was one of reasons for my trauma. Or was it a pseudo PTSD from Ketriya. The line is so blur from the distinction I don't know what to believe. I will tell you about it when the time is right. She understands my sentiments, I know how you feel. I didn’t want to tell about dad's decision to anyone also. I only did it after I got over it.

She already told someone. Only one person comes to mind, how did Blake react to it. She scoffs at me for figuring out so quickly. She says, he was angry at my dad. It was sweet of him to defend me. A different reaction from hers, but I suppose she didn't mind it. She says, thank you David. And in case you still don't believe it, I forgive you. You were close to my dad, I am sure it was personal for you. I reply, I appreciate you saying that. But I still feel responsible for interfering too much with your relationship. She turns somber and mumbles, Robb. Hey eyes look far off even when she is staring at me.

I fished out a phone from my pocket, I can't take away the unreasonable demand I was putting on you. So this is me wanting to rectify it. I toss the phone to her. It was a small flip phone, a burner phone. I nod, with only one number programmed into it. Call it, there will be challenge phrase. Tell them, my cat Phillips needs an appointment. That will connect you to the person you want to talk to the most. She jerks up while opening the phone, you don't mean. I nod, yes. Robb will be on the other end. She stares at the phone widely, how. When.

I say, few weeks ago, I finally got hold of Robb, Nina and Maiyer. They have been running and hiding from Echo since a year. But once I got my memories back, one of the first orders I gave my contacts was to locate them and hide them in the safest place we can think of. She puts the phone down with a shock on her face, you found them. Where are they now. I say, WITSEC protection. Its the only way Echo can't find them. When was the last time you spoke to them. She says, I got a message from Nina about 5 months ago. Said they are going deep cover. That was you. I nod, I myself didn't know about it at that time. I was busy with the tournament. My associate did the arrangement. I still don't know how he got the into that program. Once you meet Robb, you can ask him all about it.

She got up from the chair with nervous reaction, say that again. For some reasons she is more anxious than happy to know her boyfriend is safe. I stand on my feet, I got their location once their cover was completed. It took few days, but I wrangled a way for you two to meet. She looks down at her phone in her hand. I am missing something. I am giving her a way to meet him and all I see is hesitation. I voice my confusion, I don't understand. I thought you be relieved. And happy that you can finally see him. She shakes off her ambivalence, no. Sorry. I am glad to hear that.

I ask, are you sure. Because you don't look seem happy. She gives a weak smile, I really am. Its just. She was loosing her words. I am clueless now, what's happening. I was expecting you to be in cloud nine. Did something happen between you and Robb. Did he already contact you. She replies, no. He didn't. Its just, I am ashamed to even say this. She pauses before recollecting herself, I don't know how I feel about him now. Did my ears heard that right. I scoff, you don't know how you feel. He did contact you then. It was my misguided attempt to look out for your best interest. Just tell him I was the one who tried to break up the two of you.

She shakes her head, no, we haven't spoken in a while. And its not because of you. She slumps down on the chair with a defeated expression, its me. I have changed. Living here for almost a year has made me look at things differently. I hesitantly wait for to explain more. She says, I know its not going to make sense. I was so mad at you for trying to stop me from seeing Robb, but I think that was just an excuse. Easier to blame you than myself. And now, I don't have that excuse anymore. I am the last person who should give any kind of relationship advice. But I made an attempt, you don't love him anymore?

She immediately replies, I still love him. But what you said about the consequences, you were right. I just didn't want to accept it. So I might have prolonged our fight, because I didn't want to deal this myself. This part I understood, you wanted me to stop you. You didn't want to meet Robb. She makes a mortifying smile, yes. Whoa, didn't see that coming. Jess said she was still committed to Robb. Was she just doing it out of guilt and didn't want to betray him. I ask, I won't ask how things changed for you. I know something about blaming others for something you fear. She says, then you know how messed up I am. I didn't want to admit it, but I was hating you for the wrong reasons.

I understand that too. I ask, when did you begin to feel that way. She snorts, honestly, its slowly just crept up to me. Maybe when I started to enjoy living with so Medrones again. Having a stable life, instead of missions and objectives. People depending on me. People I have grown to care about. Responsibilities. Children. All the stuff you warned us years ago, it came to pass. I hate that it really did change my feelings. I hate it. But I can't hide it too. She is reeling from a doubt and self pity. So that’s the core of her issue. I take the seat beside her and put my hands on her wrist, its okay. People change. Its okay to feel differently now. You be insane to not to.

She holds my hand tightly, you aren't going to say, I told you so. I gave her a smirk, I am dying to say it. But not today. You get a pass for now. She closes her eyes, what a mess. You gave me such an incredible gift and I can't be even be happy about it. I had a thought, I am the last person you should talk about this. But I have one suggestion though. She opens her eyes to me, you want me to meet him. Don't you. I reply, yeah. You can keep looking for advice from others, but that’s all its going be. Just advice. You will hardly act on them. She says, how would you know. You said you don't have experience in this.

I could tell her about Ned or Vanessa. But I am not okay going to risk it. I am trying to cause their break up selfishly. I say, its normal, you know. She might have guessed I was talking about Vanessa. Regardless she didn't ask about that further. She raises the phone on her hand, what should I do. He can't move here. And I don't want to leave anymore. But we want to be together. I ask, your original plan was to leave. When you would done your part? She gave me sorrowful and guilty look. I guessed right. I'll be lying if I didn't know how that felt. They are for different reasons. I say, go to him. Talk to him. Figure out a solution.

She takes away her hand, how does that work. I meet him over the weekends, maybe planed visit during the holidays. No way its going to work. I say, then I am going to give the same answer I am gave a while ago. Either figure out a way, or just pull the band aide. Its not fair to you. Or to Robb for leading him on, keeping up with the false hope. She gives weak scoff, I don't think I can cut ties with him. We have been together for so long. I answer, not anymore. I am sorry, but to have a working relationship, you need to be in one. I can't fathom what kind of fantasy or dysfunctional relationship you two planned.

She remined dead silent at that, or maybe you didn't thought of it. That’s something you can finally talk about. I push the phone on her hand, get this out of your system. Go tomorrow. She scoffs, its not that easy. I can't just leave. I click my tongue, take a sick day. Or tell you need to take a personal day. Say you have lady problems. She punches me on my arm. I say, hey. That’s a valid reason. Or do you want to explain how you have a secrete human boyfriend with whom you don't know where you stand anymore.

She puts the phone down, I can't leave the island unauthorized. I chuckle, you do realize who you are talking to. She raises her eyebrows at me, seriously? I answer, oh yeah. I wasn't joking when Ruther asked me if I have a way out of the city. I can get out without anyone realizing. And back in the same way. She still thought I was messing with her, no way. That’s crazy. I ask, why is that. The Heraknus are going to leave tomorrow morning. Jess can handle your affairs for a day. And you can hold your search for the people behind the smuggling criminals, they aren't going anywhere. No can stop you, except yourself. She finally entertains the possibility and contemplates.

She shakes her head, no. It's selfish. What if I am needed here. I scoff, if the city can't function one day without you, then we have failed this place. It took a lot of convincing, but she finally was taking it seriously now. She asks, I can meet him tomorrow? I nod, pick a place and time you two want to meet. I will book your travel discreetly. But for his safety, you will have only 15 to 18 hours. Anything more than that and they might suspect he is missing. That should give you enough time to catch up.

She finally sees the possibility of this, you can do that. I am hurt she is asking me that, I have done much more difficult tasks in less time. Arranging a meet between two love birds, I can do that in my sleep. She suddenly goes in for a hug, thank you David. You are the best. I pat her back when I feel her relieved. She didn't know it, but this is what she needed. A push and someone to have her back. I pull back, there is a catch though. Robb can't risk his safety. Because its not just him. She whispers, Nine and Maiyer. They would be exposed if anyone found out about him. I say, I have to keep him, and therefore you, under surveillance.

That put a damper on her chipper mood. I say, as much I like to give you your privacy, its very risky to meet without some protection. I can ask the team to keep an eye on you from far. They won't hear you, but keep you in their eyeline. And you won't even know who they are. She says, that’s. After a lengthy pause, fair. I don't want to jeopardize others from my selfish behaviors. I nod, pick a place you guys are familiar. And I have a favor. She waits for me to ask. I give her a wicker smile, when you two lost souls meet, make sure you keep all your nasty business stays inside. You have a lot of catching up to do. But don't waste it on canoodling all the time.

That resulted in another punch to my shoulder with a icy stare from her. She blurts out, don't be such an ass after I just complimented you. I scoff, someone had to say. And make sure to use protection. She shook her head in disgust, I meant take a gun. She finally gives a nervous laugh. That brought her worries down a little. I offer her some solace, its going to be fine. She resolves herself, you are right. I can do this. No, we can do this. I need to go prepare a go bag. I nod, checklist is important. Passport, spare clothes, pajamas, and lingerie. She cackles, you are incorrigible. Before we leave, I face her. I ask, just don't regret whatever you decide. But do decide. She nods, I will and thanks for.

Then her face turns a little pale. I ask, what. She raises her eyes to point behind me. I turn my to see two people gawking through the gap of the door. I should be worried they snooped in, but Catherine was being nervous for both of us. Blake and Vanessa step inside with confused face. This is awkward. Catherine was feeling their gazes a bit too much. She slipped out between them without uttering a word in embarrassment. They both see her with puzzled expression. I bite my lip, what brings you here Blake. He turns back to me, ah, I was called in to deal with a problem. I connect the dots, for Saya. I see. Well, Catherine might be a little preoccupied. So you may want to handle this without her.

Vanessa gives me a hard stare. I thought I play it cool, but here intense gaze was piercing me hard. I ask, ahm, I didn't know people were snooping in. But just to be on the same page, what did you guys here. Blake answers, enough to know what happened. I got caught red handed. I blame this on my stupid shades. I pull it off and keep in my pocket. Vanessa asks with a flat tone, since when did you decide to play cupid. I don't need that kind of judgement from her. I reply with a snappy comment, since your boyfriend accused me of causing problems with you both. Someone has to make things right again.

That shut down her any emotion she wanted to throw at me. Blake asks, so she is going to meet him tomorrow. He sounded disappointed. Is there something on between them. Hope not, that would complicate things even more. I say, any way you can forget this. She barely got the courage to do this. Last thing she needs is you to stop her from leaving unauthorized. He snaps back to reality, I won't stop her. Sounds like she is figuring out stuff with Robb. Good for her. I hesitantly ask, and good for Robb too. He didn't respond to that, just gave a bewildered look. I ask, you okay. He answers back enthusiastically, of course. Just forgetting this conversation happened.

I ask, what conversation. I already forgot. He smirks, right. I got to. Yeah. I need to. Ahm. See you later. He leaves in hurry without finishing his sentence. Guess he is bothered by this a little too much. From the looks of it, Catherine was to. I ask Vanessa, you know anything about that. She was lost in her own thoughts to answer that. Then she asks, I came here earlier. Heard you talking about her family, so I left. What did you tell her about them. Got to hand it to her, she is consistent in her accusations. I say, I didn't tell her everything. Only the stuff that really matters. And she knows that too. Why do you ask.

I actually didn't need to. We both know who she was referring to. I say, before you start arguing with me again. You should settle things with your boyfriend. She is flustered, you talked to him? I laugh, more like he was accusing me. You two have the same penchant for blaming me for stuff I am not responsible for. Talk to him before he gets in my face again. She was cowering a little from my pushy attitude. I continue, I am going to tell you, what I told Catherine. If you are don't want to find a way to resolve this. Then don't keep leading the poor bastard, and just end it for freaks sake.

This made her eyes widen. She asks, you. She was stuttering a little. I guess I am being way to impudent with her. I pull back, sorry. That was uncalled for. But still, just talk to Ned. I decided to leave a dazed Vanessa and head out to meet Dunkin. Jeez, now its my turn to run away cowardly. Turns out I am no better than those two.

David (Chapter 109)

Friday, March 6, 2026 22:17

I rang the bell hoping they are at home. I didn't find them back at the office, and its too late for a date night. I hear a rustle inside and the door opens. Matt has a dumbfounded expression on his face. He blurts out, dude. I was hoping he be here with her. I reply, hey Matt. Can I come in. He pulls out of the shock and waves in, sure. He looks around behind me to check anyone else. I help him out as I enter through the door, its just me. Felt I needed to explain myself. He closes the door and we walk to the dinning room where he and Cass were having dinner. Cass got up from the table, putting away the fork she was eating with.

She cries, what are you doing here. I smile at the food, isn't it late for dinner. She is naturally confused at my sudden visit to her house. Matt says, I had to cover an evening shift today. I told her I'll order in late, but she insisted we eat together. I take an empty seat beside theirs. They had almost finished their dinner, so at least I didn't interrupt them too much. Cass remains silent, while Matt just stands beside me looking at her. I say, I wanted to apologies from my behavior the last time we met. I am sure you heard from my doctors and others, but I was out of my mind at that time. Matt asks, we know. You scared the freak out of us.

Cass breaks her confusion, I am angry with you David. You could have come to visit us anytime, but you came to us last. Didn't you. She takes back her seat along with Matt. She sighs, you know how embarrassing it is to be the last one to hear anything about you. I get her frustration. Its been happening more last few months, but too much in the last two weeks. Matt says, I am with here. We are kept too much out of the loop. And I don't mean just about your work. I nod, I don't know how else to explain it. I wasn't doing it intentionally. Cass was more mad than Matt, so I had to disclose everything from three days ago.

Matt says, whoa. You went on training marathon the whole day. That’s some dedication. I smirk, you think that fight with Heraknus was a fluke, it was hard work. And I was so exhausted later, I needed to rest. And I knew you guys were busy with work, so I couldn't come until tonight. Cass had her arms folded. She was unimpressed by brilliance. She was angry with something else too. Matt had some hesitation also still with him. I ask, so I am guessing this about me being a Shadow. Matt swipes his lips with tongue, you are damn right. How can you not tell us you were a freaking shadow. That’s blowing my mind even now.

I take a short breathe, because its was very personal. It wasn't a simple for me to reveal such a massive past. My shadow identity coupled with trauma was complicated to figure out. Cass asks, and now? I heard from many people that you have changed. Matt says, you looked like a different person yesterday. I surmise they didn't hear about my condition. I didn't want to use my Ketriya as an excuse, but it was a crucial part of my emotional and mental state. Neither of them had heard about Ketriya before, so it took a while to explain.

Another 20 minutes go by and their confusion went up. Cass says, what kind of messed up experimentation did MAR's do to you. Matt says, is this why Kuret also changed weirdly over the years. Damn man, that’s so cruel. I scoff, cruel and lucky. My physiology wouldn't be able to handle my completed Kuret. I didn't tell anyone about Drews theory about MAR's experimentation. That would only throw more chaos among people. Cass sighs, let me get this straight. Now that Ketriya is over, your personality has changed. I know its hard to explain. In children it’s a common and natural phenomenon. But in adult, well, no one is sure. Drew, my doctor is giving me routine checkup to see the overhaul changes. I actually have been doing some test on my own.

Matt asks, and. What's the verdict. I shrug, this isn't something I can measure very accurately. I can tell you some objective scores, but they are not really conclusive. This didn't made them any less hesitant, you both don't need to worry about the details. All you need to know, I was sick. And now I am not. Cass asks, I heard you have been flirting with any girl you see. Is that true. Or just part of you being fine. She underscores the last word with a sarcastic tone. Matt mocks me, I heard you were trying to flirt and fail spectacularly too. You are behaving in ways you are not used to.

I could physically feel a gut punch. Just how bad have my cheesy comments have been. I ask, do people have no appreciation for me. I am doing something new here. My frustration made them giggle. Cass says, you are out of practice. I could have corrected her saying its more like awkwardness, but its best to get her sympathy than digging a deeper pit for myself. I say, I promise to be more forthright with you both. But I can't promise it won't happen again. Things have changed a lot and will change even more once Citradel comes. We all have responsibilities. There will be times when we can't be free or available to meet more often.

I came here so I can make them understand some things are out of control. They didn't like it. But thankfully, they didn't deny our situation. I wish we could have made them high ranking officers. That would keep them close to us. I asked them again about it, but they said they wouldn't be able to make the cut. Cass sighs, I don't think I can handle logistics like Tina. Matt says, I am good where I am right now. After few rounds of discussion they finally accepted the hard reality. Cass sighs, fine. I get it. I hate it, but I guess its not your fault. But, she points her index to me, I am not forgiving you for not telling us you were a shadow. You could have told us anytime before your issues were acting up.

Matt agreed with her, yeah. That was not cool man. I have a million questions for you. He started to ramble about rumored mission like decimation of a political group, stopping a terrorist plot and something about a circus. I crack up at his attempt to gather all the possible things we might be responsible for. I say, unfortunately, I am not going to comment on any of them. Setting aside that they are in past, people hold conflicting feelings about it. I am not going to disclose that cause me and others problem. Matt lightly taps the table edge, that’s no fun. I don't think he appreciates how sensitive shadows missions were. We weren't a group of peacemakers.

Cass didn't seem disappointed like Matt, I don't care about the secrets. What I care is how you were chosen, who picked you and what more do you know about Terrisa. Guess she has been thinking a lot about her. I say, I don't know much about her. She was two generations before me, I only know her public reputation. In fact I only met her a grand total of once. Cass scoffs, you met a single time? But you know she was a Shadow. I don't understand. I say, I know its frustrating, but that’s I got. Though I am sure she referred you onto the ship. I explained how each Shadow member had given a privilege to choose a family member. But only if they were capable.

She raise her chin, so that’s how I was allowed to board in even when Sommers was already inside. She then turns gloomy learning the meaning of this. She wasn't chosen because of her innate skills, but it was due to someone else. I didn't want to burst her bubble, but I didn't want to hide it anymore. Matt and I assure her she didn't need to feel guilty. She says, I do feel it. I mean, what if there was someone more capable. Maybe one with previous Kurets that went extinct. Its all too common with the kids from the first ship. Matt says, I know how you feel Cass. He turns to me, please don't tell me that happened for me too.

I shake my head, sorry. I have no idea who referred your name. All I can say is, like others, you were chosen for your potential. That was the truth. Matt looks relieved to hear. He probably wouldn't have cared either way, but it was still a burden he didn't want to bear. Cass lowers her head to me, hold on. Did you get selected by someone else too. She connected the hidden dots. I nod, I was. Yes. By someone in the shadows. I know who they were, but I am going to refrain revealing their name. She sighs, your damn secrets. I suppose you won't tell how you got into Shadows too. I give her a small smile to her query.

She shakes her head annoyed. Matt says, I figured you would not tell. But still, this is still so crazy. And yet, its not. You took on three freaking Heraknus. There is a rumor you manipulated them before they even had a chance to retaliate. You were probably born for this. Blake and Marina told us how excited they were when you turned out be another survivor. I have been getting praise by a lot of people. I try my best not to get swayed by it too much. But after a certain point I just have to accept their glazing of me.

We discussed a little about how I told them and what I have been doing since then. I couldn't tell them everything, but I hinted that I have been brewing many hidden agendas. Cass says, that’s explains why you have been distant this year. You been plotting things in secret. Matt says, like that house of yours. I saw you using a tech after your tussle with Heraknus. Is it like that. I answer, it’s an application of it. A kind of a hybrid nano tech.

I told them as much I could. I wasn't hiding about it, buts the science is too advance for me to talk about. I only have a cursory knowledge, just enough to know the mechanism. Cass wasn't impressed by it unlike Matt. He even decided to open a bottle of beer excited to talk about anything with me. Cass is making it hard to win over her. Guess this is perfect time to show them. I say to her, I know you were going to be tough to appease. I didn't came here empty handed. I took out a piece of paper and laid it on the table. Matt puts the beer down, what is this. Cass asks, I don't think you can give me anything that will make me get over this.

I grin knowing that her attitude is going to change. I was more sure of it when Matt's chokes while drinking the beer. He coughs will giving me wide eyes. Cass yells, oi, you are spilling at my table. She grabs the paper and begins reading it. Matt wipes his jaws, dude. Is this a joke. I wave my palm at him, I don't have the courage to mess around with she is like this. It was Cass to freak out. She yells, how in the hell. I grabbed the beer bottle from Matt's hand and enjoy seeing their panicked expressions. Matt asks with a gaping mouth, I don't understand. We were no where on the short list.

Cass asks nervous, what did you do. I take a swipe off the bottle, it wasn't easy. Had to bribe, arg, no, give favor to the estate heads son's birthday. I have to come over to their party and give sort of show to them. Honestly, that is such a pain. All the while I had a devious smile on me. Matt asks, seriously. She agreed with just this. I puff out my chest, there are many benefits of being a meteoric celebrity. Just don't tell anyone I helped you jumped the line, that would cause Bianca problems. Cass puts down the deed to their new house over in section 2. She gets excited, this is real, right. I say, if you still don't believe it, go check it tomorrow. That house is yours.

I have trying to find a gift for them, hoping it buy me some grace. I already knew they were trying to buy a semi condo apartment in section 2. It was weird they be interested when its technically for 3 people. Plus its barely inside their budget. They must have had a reason. Regardless, I went over to the section 2's estate head and greased over to get it for them. Matt goes straight in for a hug, spilling the bear from my hand, holy shit. You are a god send. I laugh while patting his arm. Cass came rushing behind him and gave a bear squeeze, I don't believe you. This is. She grips me tighter.

They both still didn't think this was real, and went over to check on the network. Sure enough, they got a message from her telling the good news. Cass yells to Matt, we got it. Matt locks in his arm to hers and they went for kiss. He shouts, I had lost hope. This is really happening. They both embrace rejoicing over the sudden fortune. I wasn't expecting this big of a reaction. Why are they acting like they just won the largest lottery of their life. I ask curious, what am I missing here. Cass says, how did you know we wanted this. With a flat expression I waited for them to figure it out. Matt chuckles, duh. He pokes his shoulder. Even if I wasn't a shadow, I would have figured it out.

They both settle down from their excitement. Cass says, why do you think Matt and I haven't moved in together. I didn't need to think much about it, Mel? Matt says, she has been a pain in the ass to deal with. Whenever one of stay in the others house, it becomes a mess if she ever wakes up. I take another sip of the beer, hold up. I thought you take some sort of Kuritine pill to block her at night. Cass pouts a little, I do, but lately its loosing its effect. I think I have built up a tolerance for it. Matt says, this one time we were sleeping at my place, I woke up to a Mel working out in my living room with loud music. I ask, that doesn't seem too bad.

Matt freaks out a little, oh yeah. How about in the middle of making out she accidently comes out and begins to strangle me. And it wasn't even a erotic chocking, it was gut retching cutting off air strangling. Cass gets mad that he fessed up something so intimate. But she was actually angry about the accidental part, I am telling you, that was really a mistake. Why would I consciously use my Kuret. Matt yells, I will tell you why. You were scared of doing that, he peaks at me for just half a second, you know what. I wave my arms, all right. That’s enough. TMI. I couldn't even enjoy them bantering now. I ask, what does this have to do with getting that specific house.

Cass calms down, the point is, Mel is not going to let us live together in peace. And she is to belligerent to live in a cramped up place. Matt chips in, so we came up with an idea. He picks up the deed, this house has and extra room and bigger garage space. Now I see their plan. Cass says, we are going to offer Mel her own space. Matt says, completely fitted with sound proofing walls, a workout space and even her own bed. Their solution for Mel is to treat her like a roommate. I nod, this is actually brilliant. Thats why you wanted to purchase that place. Its even a little further away from neighbors. So no one will be disturbed too.

Cass says, its our ideal house. Yeah. Then then she become less excited. Matt asks, you worried if Mel is not going to accept it. Cass answers in a despondent tone, I have no clue. The last video message she gave, it was almost a threat that she will hurt you. Matt clacks his jaw, I told you. I am not worried about that. She is just bluffing. And if you ask me, she is embarrassed to live with me. Cass scoffs, would you please stop that. I have lived with her more than you, she is only tolerating you. Matt brings a sly smirk, lets ask her then. Cass gets confused, what. You want to do it now. No. She nervously looks at me and I froze with the bottle end on my lips.

I guess this is my cue, maybe I should go. Seems you have a lot of discussing ahead. I might just get in your way. I prepared to leave, but unexpectedly Cass stops me. She exclaims, wait. Now that I think about it. She won't

believe me or Matt. But if you are here, she will be more tenable. I really didn't want to mediate things with her alter ego. Matt was already onboard with this, yup. Plus she wouldn't go on a rampage since the last time you kicked Mel's ass. Yesterday Mel was so furious at you, but I could tell she is troubled also. Your presence might yield a peaceful resolution. Cass agreed with Matt and gave me a pleading eyes.

I really didn't like being put in this spot. I say, okay. But I will not be negotiating in any capacity. That's all on you Matt. I am only going to sit here and drink, I look at the empty bottle, let me get another bottle. No, I need something stronger. I rummaged in their kitchen and brought a Kuritine rum. I sigh, only you like this stuff Cass. She is annoyed at me, what. Don't judge me. I blast the bottle with my Kuret, hoping to have removed most of the Kuretine mixed in it. From the glimmer I say about 10% still remained. Well, this will have to be enough. I gesture them as I pour myself a glass.

Cass tells Matt, remember what we discussed. Matt grabs Cass's hand, a recurring schedule, zero property damage warning and money allowance. Cass adds, don't forget about her breaking any rules. And their consequences. They have been planning this for a while. I clear my throat as I drank the rum. I still felt the taste of Kuritine in it, however, it was just enough for me to ignore it. I need to remain less sober to see a tumultuous negotiation. They both kiss for good luck and then whisper to each other. The next second Cass summons her Kuret. Her hopeful expression turns to an aggressive one as Mel appears. She barks, ah, what is it. Why did you.

Her voice breaks when she turned to see me setting and partaking in some beverage in her own house. She takes a step forward to me, what the freak are you doing in my house. I already said I wasn't going to participate in this. Matt takes over, Mel. David is helping us out. He points to the deed on the table, we have a proposal for you. She ignores him and glares at me, I don't care. You, she points her index finger at me, lets go another round. I am not going do anything, except kick that smug face off of you. I think Matt misjudged her. She wasn't afraid of me, if anything she is even more hostile. She leans in and grabs my by the collar.

The drink spills for the second time on their table. I am getting annoyed at wasting their drinks. Mel screams, you listen to me. You smug, arrogant, freak. I am going to shove my foot far up your ass and enjoy watch you squirm in agony. I should be irritated, but I couldn't help laugh from her vain attempts to corner me. Matt grabs Mel by the shoulder and copy's her Kuret, Mel. You need to listen to me. She tries to shove him, but he held his ground. Mel eyes was so red with anger, I thought she might burst a vein. Her grip on my collar was tightening. Matt pleads for her to get off, but she wasn't having any of it.

I wanted to remain a neutral party here, but she is making it tough for me to remain impartial. I turn to Matt, I am going to try something, try to get through her will you. He nods vehemently. I grab hold her wrist my one arm and pull all my Kuret into my grip. The Kuret starts to vibrate and she suddenly barks at me, oh. You want to go now. I will gladly knock your teeth and feed it to you. I smile, aren't you a bag of sunshine. I kept vibrating my Kuret on her wrist hopping it hits the mark. She thought it was my acceptance to a fight. She releases one hand and prepares a fist in the air. Matt grabs her by the arm, Mel. You need to settle down.

She barks at him, go away. Cass pulled me out to talk to you, right. I won't do it until I stomp his ass. I am used to think her as a petulant war mongrel. But now, I think she is just a child throwing a tantrum. She clocks the pity smile I was showing in my face, you freaker. You think you better than me don't you. Don't get ahead of yourself. One good punch, I will knock that big mouth. Maybe after defeating three alphas and Heraknus together has made me a bit prideful. Perhaps her anger towards me is what Matt was talking about earlier.

I didn't want to be stuck like this forever, the three of us in a standoff. Fortunately, my Kuret side effect finally kicked in after multiple tries. Mel winces in pain, ouch. What. Her grip on my shirt loosens, while mine gets stronger. It was an crude attempt which I wasn't sure would work. But I am glad it did. I was cutting her Kuret off in her right arm. She crouches down when I twist her wrist. She writes in confused pain, what the freak are you doing to me. She has never experienced a focused pain like this. I see glimmers of her Kuret from her elbow. So that's the limit. I signal Matt to let go of her other arm. Matt gives a shocked wow.

I twist her wrist even further and make her slump on the ground. She tried to punch me in the legs with her freed arm. Just before she reaches me, I twist her whole elbow in an angle she couldn't get away from. She twists her hip as I stand up and I put a palm on her back, keeping her elbow extended up. She kept cursing at me, even while in agonizing pain. I lean in, you aren't used to being restrained like this aren't you. Your Kuret gives me unimaginable strength, where is it now. Her slew of grunting curses still escapes from her lips. I sigh, I turn Matt, I am sorry for this. Tell Cass I had no choice. Sometimes you need to show who is someone's master and who is a bitch.

I intentionally provoke her to catch her off guard. And she did by loosing her body to turn around. That small angle was all I needed. I applied pressure with my Kuret and break her arm by the elbow. She creams with pain and I let go of her. She stumbles down grabbing her other arm. Matt watches in shock and crouches down, David. What did you do that for. I dust of my shirt and tied to spat away from the drinks spilled on the edges. Then I sat back on my seat, she wasn't being corporative. She now knows what happens if she messes with me. I pour myself another glass, all the while Mel writhes on the floor. Matt looks confused and helpless glancing between us.

I gesture him to get a move on. After a lot of contemplating, he says, Mel. Don't do it. You saw it yourself, didn't you. He is not to be messed around. She wriggles and crawls up to the side wall. Even though she is struggling, she is not giving up. She takes support from the wall and leans on it sitting. The arm I broke was twisted in odd angle from the elbow down. I made sure it was a clean break so that there wouldn't be any big damage. I feel a little guilt doing this to Cass, but I hope she can forgive me. Mel was irritatingly stubborn to me. So I had to take a drastic action so she learns to fear me.

And it worked. The red glimmers coming off her was now turning to yellow. Anger mixed with hint of fear. And yet she kept up with a outward expression in defiance. She is nothing but stubborn. I casually resume my drinking. Matt pleads, just hear me out. She wasn't in any mood to listen, but the pain kept her mouth shut. Matt explains her the situation. I got their names bumped up the waiting list and now they can own the house. He began listing out all the benefits to her. A room for just her, no more of those blocker pills. She gets to come out every now and then. Even allowing her to buy her own stuff.

I am impressed by Matt and Cass's resolve to do so much for her. They are essentially giving her more than an identity now. Even in the pain, Matt had gotten through to her. She peeked at me several times while Matt explained to her. I nonchalantly partake in another glass of the rum. If it weren't for Mel's stubbornness, I would have be more amazed by the arrangement Matt laid out. About 10 minutes of Mel grunts, she finally spoke aloud, I don't believe you. I am sure this deed is fake and you are trying to trick me. I stepped in to assure her of this, you don't have to take my word for it. Tomorrow you can visit the place and see for yourself.

He eyes sharpen at me and then turns to Matt, even if that's true. You think I would be okay with this. Living like a prisoner. Matt rebukes her, not a prisoner. But a housemate. You will finally have your own stuff. She scoffs in pain, I don't need stuff. He smiles, that's a lie. I distinctly remember you wanting to wear the skirt. You said you didn't like the skimpy outfit Cass wears. Mel scoffs, its just a silly dress. So what. He answers, its not just that. You have your own favorite dish you like. A song you listen to. So I know you have things you like to have. And now you can keep it with you.

Using that as leverage he begin listing out all the things she liked. Some of them she really didn't care if she had, but some caught her ears. Her own person gym and a foosball table. I didn't know she was a fan of that human game. Matt askes me if I can one for them. I answer, I can get them three if they had the space for it. I threw in a jacuzzi too in their lawn. Of course, they would have to build it on their own, but I can help getting the materials and designs for it. That actually piqued her interest, more than she was letting it show on her grunt refusals.

After Matt finish up's the discussion with a ground rules, he explained the consequences part that Cass mentioned. If Mel ever did anything to break any stuff or take away time from Cass, they are prepared to lock her and Cass inside a basement cell. I cough from my drink when I listen their plan is to build some sort of cage beneath their basement. Matt was very quiet as he explained this part. Glimmers of disgust and fear came from him, but he muddled threw them. Mel spats, lie. You cannot keep me locked up. I can just. Matt cuts her off, this bar will be lined with Kuret blocking Kuritines. The moment you touch it, your Kuret will bounce back.

I see. If she had a Kuret to throw, she had a chance of breaking out. But a physical constraint is a bad compatibility for her. Mel warns him, then I will just go back to sleep and your precious Cass will remain locked up. Matt gives a weak smile, you forget. The cage does not block your Kuret. It just repels it. Cass can anytime pull her Kuret out again, and you will be back in the cage. I can't believe how far these two have planned it. This way, a vicious cycle of both Cass and Mell will keep happen, both of them being locked up. Even Mel is frightened by the prospect of it. She tried to call Matt's bluff, you wouldn't dare do that. You love her.

Matt says, I do. And I want to be with her. We both know this is a desperate play. Cass hates it as much as I do. You have no idea how cruel it is for her to not being able to share a life with me because of you. He then takes a breathe, I take that back. You have idea of what it's like to only live a part of your life. She can never experience Kuret like you, and you can't feel normalcy like her. But this is a comprise she agreed to. And if you agree to it, we can make this work. And as for as the jail thing. That's only if you break the rules. Otherwise you are free to do whatever you want. Cass has accepted this living arrangement if it meant you can restraint yourself when we are together. So, you can either both win, or both loose.

That is probably the most important thing they want from her. Restraining her reckless behaviors. They are employing a sort of a reword and punishment type of system. The kind you train dogs in military. I am going to keep that one to myself. Mel nostrils flairs up knowing she will not like being caged up like a house pet. But she also knows that she if she showed some consideration, then she get her own piece of her house. She won't just be called for battle. The pain in her arm and numbed down, her healing had kicked in a while ago. But it wasn't enough to mend the bones and tendons I broke.

She is quietly thinking about this. I guess, I should show her some compassion now. That will earn some points from her. I prepare a Kuret storm with both my hands. I have been meaning to use the designs Marina gave me. I wrap my Kuret in a spiral oval shape. Then another spiral ring overlapping the previous one but running in different angle for its spin. She was inspired by the centrifugal force of my Kuret vibrations and using some Kuret physics, the ambient Kuret is sucked inside. I am not very proficient with its control. But even with the sloppy and inefficient use, I could see glimmers of pure Kuret forming in the middle.

After a minute, it was barely stable, so I waste no time to use the insignia and turn it into the healing Kuret. The Kuret didn't come out as strong as usual, but it was enough to free her from pain. Her bones slowly mend back in shape and relief washes her from face. I disperse my Kuret and inspect her arm my glimmers. There is still some lingering streaks of red and white mixed in, your should be fine in couple of hours. I see signs for another rebellion. I step forward with a intimidating posture, unless you want another reminder of that pain, I suggest you tone down that temper of yours. I crack my neck and knuckles while sitting back on the chair.

That was enough to stop from any stupid ideas. She stands back up and flexes her arms a little. I kept a cold stare at her, prepared for any hostility from her. She turns back to Matt, I have demands. I didn't expect her to just lay down and roll over. She takes the seat beside mine and grabs the whole bottle. Matt sighs a relief knowing she is open to this. But I wonder what kind of conditions she will put on them now. She raises two fingers from her hand, first. I am not a child that needs allowance or something like that. I will buy or use whatever I want when I am awake. Matt says, that's not going to fly. We aren't going to have enough money to afford your lavish style.

She points the bottle to me, just use this shmuck. He is loaded, isn't he. Matt gets offended, we are not going to ask anyone for money. And David's already got us the house offer. Forget it. Mel drinks directly from the bottle and says, stop your whining. You are such a pathetic guy. She turns to me, what does Cass see's in him. I don't think she is noticing how much she is hurting the poor guys ego. I remained silent and let him deal with this. Matt grabs the middle chair with an annoyed look. He grabs the bottle away from her before she empties it in one gulp and places on the table.

She grunts, the freak you are doing. He spits out, teaching you moderation. You have to learn from now on. She makes a scowl and tried to grab the bottle again. But I grabbed it first, sorry. But I am not finished it with yet. She throws a stare down, but only gives me angry look in the end. She knows who holds her leash. Actually, I had enough drinks tonight. I just didn't want to give her the satisfaction. Matt says, there is a compromise I am prepared to do here. Its tough, but I can convince Cass to let do some side jobs so you can earn the extra money.

That is the most ridiculous and genius idea I have heard tonight. Letting an alter ego earn her own money. That is some mega brain move. Even Mel was not expecting such an answer. She spats, what. You expect me to work. You are out of your mind. Matt rebukes her, no. You are out of your mind if you think we are going to give our hard earned money to you. You always complain to Cass about not wanting to do or have things you don't have. This is your opportunity to have your own freedom. That was such a good point it made Mel question it even more. She thought hard about it, how am I going to get a job.

Matt says, getting one is very simple. Cass will make an arrangement and you take over her. We already have the Kuritine storage that will keep you awake just enough for an hour or two. You won't be able to keep your full strength up all the time, but that's something you already know how to do. And as an added bonus, you won't be able to cause too much trouble. His plan actually made sense. When Cass goes to sleep, Mel takes over. And vice versa. Currently, both their jobs is regular patrols and inspections of the city. So it isn't complicated for Cass or Mel to create a sort of calendar schedules.

The only down side is that this effectively reduces the pay for Cass. I am sure all of them are aware of this. But the upside is they get to live peacefully in the same house. Well, maybe not peacefully. Co-habituating is much appropriate. Mel made a lot of physical annoyance over manual labor. But the freedom to do whatever she wants later is very enticing. After a while she finally relents, fine. Baby sitting few hours a day is such a hassle. What a pain in the ass. She makes it clear she isn't going to like it one bit. But Matt didn't care for her attitude as long she agrees to it. Matt asks, great. What's the other condition.

She grins from ear to ear and lowers her gaze to him, you and her being all intimate is going to be frequent thing. Isn't it. Where is she going with it. Matt and I feel awkward listening about it, but he shakes his head very slowly to her. He says, yeah. Its our house. She chuckles, then I want to experience a physical relationship of my own. I can't let her be the only one who uses our body. My arm slip from the table's edge when I realize what she meant. Freak me, is she seriously implying what I think. Matt kicked away the chair and stood up, you bitch. She laughs so arrogantly amused by our appalled reaction at such a scandalize insulation.

I scoff, you have lost it completely. How much do you resent them to want something like this. She waves her hand to me, stay out it. You are just an eye sore to me. I say I have been relegated to her higher status in her mind if that’s all she thinks of me now. Matt says, tell me you are joking. You are not going to hook up with strangers. She shakes her head, you are so damn naïve. You think she would let me. Even I know she will never allow that to happen. I am not asking some other guy. She points her finger to him. Then it downed on us what is she really meant. The disgust I had was now overridden with a big wave of anxiety.

Matt had the worse reaction. His eye begins to twitch, while his body rigid. Mell continues, why is this such a big deal. I have needs too. If I am going to play roommate, I want to enjoy all of it. She sighs, you aren't my first pick. I rather pick someone like Blake or Danny. Or maybe that hot Derek guy. She turns to me, even you seem pretty decent. But hey, if I am going to be living with you. I might as well enjoy you. I am so lost for words by her outrageous proposal. But even then I had spared a thought whether to be offended that I was low in her list or be glad that I was in it. Or maybe just be disgusted her suggesting it, someone who is almost like a sister to me.

Matt was dumbfounded and couldn't form a single coherent sentence. He finally managed to ask, what the what. Mel says, you aren't half bad. Its a good deal for you. I bet Cass is too vanilla. Who knows, you would prefer a more wild one like me. And besides, you won't be cheating on her. We both are the same person in the end. So come on, wear your big man pants. I know this is very serious situation. But I couldn't resist from laughing. This is messed up, but also the most incredible thing I have ever witnessed.

I stand and walk to Matt placing my palm on both his shoulder, I don't know what you will decide. And I said I was going to remain impartial. But this is an opportunity you can't let go. That pulls him out his daze. He asks confused, you are freaking joking, right. I shake my head, do you know what this means. A menage a trois. His eyes still didn't clear from the haze, a throuple you idiot. And this is a special kind where you still technically in a single relationship. You are the one the most, if not the only luckiest guy in all of Medrone. Be a man and seize this dream of every guy. My enthusiasm broke his trance. He shoves my arms away while I continue to laugh aloud.

He gets annoyed, not funny David. I had to agree, but I couldn't help it. He turns to Mel in a stern voice, is this sort of way to get out of the deal. She stand up behind me and I gave them a bit of space, oh I wish it was that simple. Call it revenge for making me do this. Or a compromise. Whatever works for you. I don't get why its such a big deal. You get to enjoy both of us. She has never shy away from anything, but being bold about intimacy and having sex on such an angry voice has its own sort of charm. I couldn't stifle the guffaws from my mouth on her last comment.

I know I am only irritating Matt, but I seriously couldn't keep a straight face anymore. Mel is asking such a ludicrous demand. But is she though. I am actually very stupefied that they never thought of this before. Or maybe they did but never decided to speak or act on it. After a while I finally calm down while they both stared hard at each other. Obviously, emotionally and morally this is not acceptable. Mel and Cass have some body, but not the same personality. That alone would make a loved one cringe away. However, from a social point of view, this is still an option. Hell, many humans do it openly without having such a technical excuse.

Mel sighs, you are such a wimp. Can't even make a simple ass decision. Arg, you probably want to talk to her about it. Well, good luck loser. Before Matt could give any answer, Mel releases her Kuret and Cass wakes up. Suddenly she bends over to her side clutching her arm, what the hell. What happened to my arm. It hurts. Matt grabs her by her waist and helps her sit on their living room couch. I still have an amusing face on me. which she got confused juxtaposed with Matt's serious and anxious face. She asks, she made a mess didn't she. I answer her because Matt is still too lip locked right now.

She grunts with a slight pain when she moves her arm, damn her. She knows it was futile to attack you. Matt brings over a bag of ice and places it over her elbow. She says, thanks. Much better now. So what happened she was ready to listen. I held back from a laugh, but I am still grinning. Matt didn't find this one bit funny, and I feel for him. But what kind of friend I would be to not enjoy in his awkward misery and envious situation. Cass couldn't fathom why we were behaving so strangely. She asks confused, what did she say that's so damn funny. Then she turns to grim Matt, and why are so upset.

Matt gathers the courage to say, she, had some demands. Cass sighs, of course she does. I swear, if she were physically real, I would wrangle her my own hands. This is my cue to this absurdity, yeah. I am going to let you sort through this. I have done all I can do. Cass, don't get angry with Matt. She made a preposterous demand. And Matt, I have only one thing to say.

I walk out from their living room and open the door, you are one lucky bastard. I honestly envy you. But not the position you are in. Good luck. I left before Matt gets more annoyed than he already was.

Vanessa (Chapter 110)

Monday, March 9, 2026 19:23

Final check of the cruise is completed. Ruther gives me the update while I watch the Heraknus arrive in their cars. Once they park, I signal to Sommers who opens the barricade for the Heraknus to walk in. Blake stands beside me, so we good. I nod, that was the final check. We wait until the Heraknus arrive with Jess. I still reeling from yesterday when David met Catherine. She really didn't arrive today morning. Jess said she is taking a personal day, citing she is sick with Kuretine deficiency. Its not uncommon for people to have it, but its rare in omegas. I never had it even once. But with not many omegas present, she got away with that excuse.

I turn to ask Blake, Catherine really left the island. Blake become slightly annoyed from it, yeah. She messaged me before leaving. Somehow she evaded the border patrols and even the barrier. David really has a way undetected out of the city. When I told Marina, she flipped out. We both thought David was half bluffing. But the guy really has a way in and out of the city. The only good thing about this is that only he knows about it. I am confused about something, won't Catherine know about it too now. Blake scoffs, not unless she was unconscious while he took her. She messaged me after she woke up.

That crazy guy didn't even trust enough to share the route with anyone. Though I understand why he wants to keep it to himself. He would want a sure shot way to escape or bring people in. I ask, you think its good idea for Catherine to leave alone. Blake says, I know. I am concerned too. But she insisted to go alone. But she has been outside with Humans for years. She knows how to avoid detection. Plus, no one can really track her as she assumes different identities. Anyone going with her would get in her way. She didn't give me any good excuse.

It made sense why she was confident. I think many of us forgotten we used to live outside, hiding among the humans. We have become too complacent living for months in the city. But few people have been circumventing the humans much better than us. The most proficient one among us is her. And with the Hive threat at is minimum, she may not be any danger. All to meet her boyfriend. I mumble, admirable or foolish. Blake asks, what was that. I need fix my weird habit of a loose tongue. I shake my head, just thinking when she will be back. Blake says, don't know. From what she told me, I am guessing anytime between tonight and tomorrow morning.

David said something was off about him, but I am only noticing it now. I couldn't ask more once Rory and Melinda came into view. Melinda says, its been another pleasure to visit your city. Blake shakes off his weirdness and says, its our pleasure. Marina tells me you found a good place for your family. She makes a warm smile, I did. It checks out most of the stuff our kids wants. I heard since there will be seven people living together, Marina gave a villa blueprint and also gave the top choice in sector 1. Blake says, I am looking forward to be neighbors. Rory says, yeah. We figured its best to stick with you. I hear a lot of high profile people living in that sector.

Blake chuckles, it wasn't intentional. But it happened anyways. Sector 1 is becoming more lavish and expensive to live. He was subtly telling him they will have to pull their weight if they are able to afford it. Rory nods agreeing that they will have to put effort. Melinda says, that's true. Since you brought it up, I want to ask if you are willing to take Charles as a high ranking officer. Rory asks, and maybe few of us too. Blake didn't look fazed from this question, at the moment, Luther and I will only consider Charles. We would like to conduct a comprehensive check on the responsibilities and abilities he will be undertaking. No offense, but we have certain criteria's to consider.

Melinda says, I heard about it from June and the twins. They said there are other aspects than just being warriors. Blake answers, it would be a mistake if we only recruited people who can fight. We have many non fighters who have other remarkable skills. They both listen earnestly as he praised people others. Luther, Tina, Ruther and Deni. He explained a little about how when more people join, we would recruit more. Rory says, that's a good balance to have. Before the tournament, we heard you were a group of pure warriors. Blake says, that's a common misconception we hope people will learn.

Blake asks about Rory and his siblings. He chuckles, I am not sure about myself yet. But I know Tory wants to join your IDF. That leaves one more elder sibling. I ask about Gina. Melinda says, she is not certain. Though I can see her joining Catherine's team. She has a knack for calming down hot headed people. Sounds like the perfect fit for hers. She looks around, I heard Catherine is sick. Will she be fine. Blake says, nothing to worry about. I back him up, it happens to best of us. Rory says, that I understand completely. Hope she gets better. But what about David. Haven't seem him after yesterday. Blake sighs, I didn't want him to publicly gloat his victory.

He snarls, you mean not meet us, Heraknus. Blake and him have tense atmosphere. Rory breaks it up, I can't argue many of us hold conflicting feelings about him. Something feels different about him. Was his Kuret the only thing changed about him. His intuition was spot on. Blake and I just gave him our silence, expressing confusion and hoping he doesn't deep much further. The Heraknus behind us, boarding the boat, were still on edge from their humiliation. Their pride as legendary bloodline has been called into question by more and more people. Some claim they were just hyped up and at the critical time, screwed the pooch. Their words, not mine.

I still view them a force to be reckoned with. If only we could tell David is on league of his own. Now more than ever. Melinda says, lets not fret over what's done. David is taking on Charles, if he wasn't this powerful, he wouldn't survive Charles overdrive. She talks about it like it was from experience. Then it something clicks for me, Charles said the only people safe are his immediate blood relatives. Does that mean, not even you are. She finishes my sentence, safe? No. I am not. The first time I was shown, he didn't hesitate even a second to tear me apart. Though I understand it wasn't his fault, but I reprimanded him good. I will spare you the details, but there were a lot of begging for apologies from the alpha.

That made us snicker in amusement. However, it reminded us how messed up Charles overdrive is. To not even recognize her own wife. I ask Rory, this may sound strange, but humor me. Now that you have seen David up close, how well do you think he will fare against Charles. I felt a tinge of regret from Rory. But he remained composed to my doubt. He says, if you ask me this two weeks ago, I would treat it as a fantasy. But now. He turn to his step mother. She nods, we chatted a little bit about it as well. And I agree that David is still not at his level. I am fully aware how biased we sound. But that's how we feel.

Blake asks, that's troubling. Rory says, without giving up any clues, dad is an even bigger menace. Think of him as a wild animal that only knows to follow his raw instincts. David played mind games with us, but it won't work on someone who doesn't have much thoughts to spare. I don't deny David's power is not lacking. But against dad. He shrugs, he is still behind. He wasn't being arrogant about it. I think that was his honest opinion, despite the claims he made about David cheating. Blake says, I appreciate your candor. He then chuckles, tell him I look forward to seeing his full strength when we return.

With the conversation concluded, we said our goodbyes and parted ways. Melinda waves to us from the boat as the engines roar to life. We waited at the pier until they cross the border. Ruther messages me that they have crossed undetected into the ocean. After that we all resumed our daily tasks. Blake gave us an update about the construction while we head back to the officer building. Yesterday we had finally started the first batch of Kuritine enrichment. He invited all of us to check out the factory in section 5 whenever we can. It was an important milestone in our efforts to expand the city. This also meant there will be general disruptions to the public.

We held a meeting later where Luther showed a timeline of changes coming soon. Public transport will be stopped for few days as they will the first to get upgrades. This will impact the commute, so they are going to suggest people to take personal cars or carpool with others. The transportation improvement will drastically shorten the time and make it easier for people. A scientist from the Citradel came to the meeting as well. Ivan was gleaming with hope as he should us the designs he came up with after inspecting the city yesterday. He designs were ambitious, but possible over time.

Their focus will be on constructing state of the art houses and enmities on the peripheral houses. Once they are completed, there will be few weeks of usage monitoring and feedbacks. Armed with those beta testing data, they will revamp the inner existing houses and infrastructure. This was slightly deviated from the initial plan Luther and Blake laid out, but Ivan and his reasoned its not a good practice to use enrich untested Kuritine materials directly. This place is open with ambient Kuret denser than Citradel. So there will be issues popping up that they themselves don't know. To avoid delaying the progress, they planned for simultaneous projects so that they don't have to wait for one complete before other. They didn't have that option since they thought we didn't have enough raw materials.

Curtesy of David robbing Citradel, we have an abundance of material. Tina gave her report saying all the mines David seized have nearly dried up and the last of the shipments will arrive in next 4 days. She also mentioned Citradel have continued their effort to steal back some of the ores. Sabotaging trucks, ships and cargo planes. They tried any and all ways to block those shipments. But the latest figured shared by David estimates about 10% to 15% are lost in transit. Marina says that's just what we lost, but David's been self sabotaging the shipments there were intercepted. So technically, Citradel gotten less than 5% of the total mined ores and materials.

Ivan didn't like the wastage of resources from this conflict. Actually, its not just him alone. But many argued David's action were justified at the time. Blake put an end to people's opinion. He censured Ivan for being too idealistic and wanted him to be more pragmatic of the current political climate. He says, science is important no doubt. But we can't ignore other things going on. I think Ivan role was very simple in Citradel, or maybe he was unaware of the dealings outside his purview. But now that they are here, they have to better adapt to this city.

Once the meeting was over, Marina approaches Blake, do you have some time to talk about a concern. She came with the other Citradel high ranking officers. Blake and Luther stayed back and signaled me to join in as well. We take the conversation to his officer. Marina says, Blake. You remember when Melinda told there are new issues happening in Citradel. Blake nods, about that. Fortunately, someone reached out to us after we send out a message to other communities. I realizing he anticipated this and called me to see what I found. I say, an old contact reached out to me personally today morning. She told me about they surveilled the Citradel for a bit.

Marina asks, why. I shrug, I am not sure. Maybe they wanted to gauge what's happening in Citradel after being cornered by us. She heard from someone who heard the intel. So I can't guarantee this. Luther says, I saw read the transcripts. It doesn't look good for the citizens there. June asks concerned, please, just tell us what's going on. With a disappointed tone I answer, a riot happened some time ago. I don't know who instigated or what it was about. All I heard was the church and council were involved. Franks makes a disappointed face, shit. Its worse than I assumed. Chelsea yells, mother of Kuret. June remains shocked and speechless.

Blake says, I wanted to meet you all later, but since you all are here now. Lets check our options. Luther steps in, there are a lot of things to consider. But the priority is to get your loved ones out of Citradel. That made the four of them even more anxious. Marina says, isn't that what you guys have been wanting not to do. Extracting people from Citradel will cause major problems. Luther says, that was before. As bad is the situation, its given us an opportunity. I propose we send out a message to Citradel, asking if anyone needs our help or wants to leave Citradel, we would gladly help them. Frank asks, but the communications are down.

Chealse says, and even if they weren't, the council will not allow people to make their own decisions. Luther nods, I agree. But this will give us some sort of legitimacy. If people leave on their own accordance, we would be blamed. But if we offer our help first, we become favorable. By giving an option, we will be currying peoples trust. That was a brilliant plan from him. Its like those asylum thing I heard from some humans before. June says, isn't David's friend leaving tonight. We don't have the kind of time to do this. Blake nods, and that's why we aren't waiting for the communication of the message to pass over.

He bring his tablet to Marina, I imagine you want your friend to also leave. Marina nods, yeah. I haven't heard from her in a while, but I imagine she is in hot waters. Blake turns to others, we aren't going to wait for things to worse. What Luther told was for posterity. So that when people do notice few people are missing, its because they asked for our help. Which they did, but the timing order was different. Which I hope no will figure it out. Luther adds, that includes people here. Another reason I was involved in this discussion. Once these people come to our city, it will me our job to vet their story.

After contemplating for any potential downside I decided it was worth it. I answer, I can cover their entry protocols. Though, as I understand 3 of them will be special case? I was referring to David's contact and his family. Blake says, let me handle that. I feel David will be involving them without our support. That includes their entry. He is subtly implying about the hidden passage into the city. Its not hard to imagine they will come through that. And I heard that Catherine has already prepared new identities for them. I feel conflicted about people circumventing our security, but since others agree it's worth it for the guy who helped us many times. Even if indirectly.

I made up my mind, then it makes my work even more simpler. That approval washed relief on few people's face. Marina was reading the text on the tablet Blake had provided earlier. She scoffs, is this some sort of transportation checklist. Allergies, medical issues, claustrophobia, nyctophobia, zoophobia and a dozen more stuff. Blake smiles, yeah. I don't even know what half of them meant. David gave it to me a while ago for whenever we decide to go ahead. Write down anything important about the people you want to bring in. others gather around Marina as they scroll down the list.

Luther asks, any idea how we are going to tell the people that they have around 8 hours to leave Citradel. And what about their escape plan. Not even David can reach Citradel right now. Blake says, ever since Citradel went dark, we looked for a way to communicate. Since we don't need a two way communication, the task is easier. I ask, how are you going to do it. He raises his chin well pleased with himself, an old school method. They only have internet and people on lockdown. Unlike us, they can't erect a physical barrier. Humans can go in anytime they want. Everyone realize the simplicity of the plan. We all thought it would be convoluted, but sometimes the right answer is the obvious.

Luther says, won't they have rigorous check on humans coming in and out. He smiles, they do. And similar to David's escape plan, this will only work one time. We will deliver the message to one of the people. It will be their responsibility to inform others. I wish we had a better way, but in the time crunch, it's the best we can do. Marina had filled her friends details and given the tablet to June. She says, that's Jenna's role. I am sure she will let others know. Luther takes her address and other information. I ask Blake about the details of the messenger. It will be a gift delivery from a website that operates in Citradels town.

Naturally, everything that crosses goes through is inspected. But the message he is going to have it written on the card will be written in Greek and German. The people won't look twice to see innocuous message like that. There is a slight chance someone reads it with a translator, but I doubt anyone would care to be this thorough. I turn to Marina, I am guessing you were the one who came up with this plan. She nods, Jenna can read both those languages. And besides, she has a secret admirer for some time who's been sending her bouquets and chocolates few times in that language. I figure this would make it even less suspicious to the security guys.

I don't know who the person was, but she does. Marina makes a scowl and hint of disgust thinking about the person. Maybe she thought such overly brazen way to show affection was too gaudy. Regardless, this was a good cover. I ask, any chance she will not read it. A lot is riding on her. Marina slips out of the anxiety, trust me. She will. She is a sucker for those kinds of things. She will read it out of curiosity regardless the circumstances. Besides, I won't be surprised if the security itself will be lax due to the riots you speak of. She had a good point. They discussed a little more about how the Citradel officers had already informed their families about this a week before.

David was right to let them be informed of this possibility. June says her boyfriend had already packed up everything. He wasn't happy leaving some of his stuff behind, but June made him see reason. He could buy the stuff here anyways. Chelsea's girlfriend was a wild card. She says, I don't know if she will go with this. The last time I spoke, she said she couldn't leave her friends behind. I got so mad at her, she hung up on me. Her distraught eyes made us give some sympathies. Luther asks, anyway to convince her. Maybe pass a message along in the letter to Jenna. Chelsea thought about it for a moment, I can try. I won't forgive myself if something happens to her while I am here.

I gave her a bit of encouragement telling it will be fine. I reminded her, the situation has changed. She would surely see the benefit in leaving after seeing the riots. That gave her hope with a little light in her eyes. Frank says, I had a terrible thought. What if the riot was hidden from people. I mean, its unlikely that people didn't notice it. But its Citradel we are talking about. I didn't even knew there were fires that was intentionally lit to burn down our farm. Damn. None of us thought about it until now. I was so preoccupied about the riots itself, I never bothered to think it could have been swept under like the other incidents Blake revealed that day.

Blake and Luther dawn a distressed expression. Marina says, freak. That's possible. We haven't seen anything in the local Human news also. Right. So the council definitely kept it under wraps. Blake says, is there a way for them to confirm the riots. I recall the message I had received earlier, unfortunately I didn't get any details, like people or location. Not even any physical evidence like a photo or something. Luther brings his fingers to his chin, I didn't see either. But maybe there is another way. He drops his arm, Blake, do you know who David's contact is ? Blake gives a curious nod. He wasn't going to tell who they were though.

Luther asks, whoever they are, they must be well connected to inform David things other tried to hide. Why not have Jenna verify it from them. Surely an incident like this wouldn't have escaped their eyes and ears. Blake turns to Marina who provides a nervous nod, yeah. That could work. Actually, it will work in our favor. I am sure Jenna and others will know the severity of the situation and encourage to leave. Chelsea and June agreed to this immediately. Frank was skeptical, but he didn't object to this. Blake says, David's contact was always going to meet them during their escape. Meeting a bit earlier wouldn't be a big problem. Lets do that.

I had a thought, so he already knows that others are going to escape with his family. He answers, he does. David informed him of the possibility. This eases Franks anxiety. I guess he was having similar doubts. Soon everyone filled up the questionnaire on Blakes tablet. After glancing over them he says, is that all. We don't have time to change anything after I send it to David. Hour nods made it official. Luther says in a low tone, I guess we are officially breaking out people from Citradel now. It's a political nightmare, but its also a little bit interesting. I wonder what kind of escape route they have to question such weird safety checklist.

That made many of us also anxious. I think I saw question about if they were afraid of animals. Is David planning to bring them in a animal shelter program? Whatever it was, I am sure it was constructed in a way Citradel won't be able to detect. The meeting was over and people got to work. Marina and Blake worked on crafting the message with others input. Luther prepared to send out a help relief message. My role was going to be later, so I excused myself and went to IDF to prepare for their entry.

I needed to give an entry permit to the border team and Deni as well. I told her it was sensitive issue and she was not to tell anyone about it. To assure her that this was approved I explained, talk to Blake or Luther. They know what we just talked about. Deni lips morph into a relief smile, I will. I guess its about June and the others. Their concerns they told us a week ago. She guessed right, but I wasn't going to explain it to here where there are prying eyes. She understood it was a matter of urgency and not to be disclosed. She gestures an okay sign to me and leaves to prepare the orders.

With that bit of arrangement done, I resumed my work. I had the task of viewing the latest arrest reports and smuggled item confiscation. It was some sort of early century pot looking artifact. I knew now that I couldn't really judge its value based on appearance alone. So far we have collected 42 of these items and there are still two dozen people left on the disk. We had retrieved the whole list few days ago, but the people weren't dumb. They used aliases and fake addresses. Our focus has switched from decrypting the list to associating the alias with people. The saving grace is that we know what item was sold, so we Tessa's team has been able to investigate the items.

While I was listening to a video interrogation of our latest culprit, I heard a knock on my door. It was Ruther, he peaks in, hey Vanessa. Someone's here to meet you. That's strange, I don't have any appointment now. Its around 7:30 tight now, my schedule was clear. I ask, who is it. If possible, tell them to meet tomorrow. I am just about to wrap it and clock out. He hesitates for a second, its well, Ned. He wants to speak to you. I pause the video immediately and froze up for a second. What is he doing here. After nearly two weeks of deliberately ignoring me he is coming to me here. Ruther was probably being weirded out seeing that I was icing my boyfriend.

I clear my throat, tell him I am busy. It was a blatant lie which both of us know. But his nervousness didn't dissipate, actually, he was very adamant he needed to speak with you. He is already inside and waiting in the lobby. I didn't want to kick him out. He seems, I don't know how to say it, desperate probably. I can't believe this. No, actually I can. We have been ignoring each other for almost two weeks. And David told Ned confronted him. Its not a coincidence he approached me now. I felt my cheeks turning hot from my heart beat. I wasn't mentally prepared to face him. I know I had to eventually talk to him, but I have been procrastinating this very conversation.

I remained silent for so long that Ruther asks me for in a soft tone, ah, Vanessa. What should I say to him. I didn't have the courage to give him an answer. He says, maybe I should tell him you are busy. His attempt to cover for me jolted me out of my anxiety, no. Sorry. Let him in. He raises his voice back to normal, you sure. Because you kind of looked. I added abruptly, its fine. I was just wondering about something else. Give me a minute and then send him here. He stares at me for few seconds. I thought he attempt to decide against me, but he nods and leaves. I close my laptop and decided to switch seats to the couch. I don't know why I am so self conscious of him being here.

I waited in tense anticipation for his arrival. My mind went racing in all direction. It had to be David. He said something earlier, saying I should either fix our relationship or end it. I don't doubt that he said something very similar to him. I was lost in thoughts and didn't notice the door open. I restrained my thoughts and gather them to focus on this. Ned walk in with a concerned expression, Vanessa. That's all he said as he stands there gawking at me. I should say something, but seeing his face brought all the bitterness back from slumber. The times he coldly ignored me. Even when we were in the same room, he gave me indifferent look.

He saw the anger underneath my skin despite the stern expression I had. He gesture to the seat beside me. I didn't give any permission, but he was too awkward to keep standing like this. He didn't wait for my approval and took the seat. Suddenly my temper explodes, why did you come here. Of the all places. This is where I work. Have you no shame. He gives a hesitant look, I didn't have a choice. You avoid my messages, never reply and never let me visit at your home. Most of the times we both are too busy. I scoff, seriously. That's all you got. You could have met me other times, post meetings in officer building, lunch time or even at the training center. So don't give me such pathetic excuses.

He sighs, you are right. I am tired of avoiding this with excuses. But why are being angry about this. I didn't see you making any attempt. Did you like watching me suffer in solitude. I reached out to Siera immediately after the tournament. And few times after then too. I even tried to see at you home, where you kept dodging me. So don't be mad at me just because its easier to blame me. He infuriated me with his cold logic. But I already knew all that, what would be the point. You remember the meeting on the day Citradel council left. You dreadfully ignored me. Like I didn't even existed. Did you really believe that wasn't you hinting how you felt about me.

He got a little annoyed, I didn't want to behave like that. But you were getting on my nerves. You think only you have the right to be angry. That I can't be mad at you instead. That thought had occurred to me. But I didn't care. That attitude pissed me off so much, I didn't want to seem him. Didn't matter how long he persisted. He sighs, this is wrong. I didn't came here to make things worse. I ask, then what did you come here for. An apology. Sorry, you are mistaken. Whatever guilt I felt in my part, that's long gone. If you hadn't given me that attitude that day, maybe I would have listened to you.

He pushes his lips to show more anxiety, like I said. We both angry doesn't solve anything. We didn't make the right decisions. I know I didn't. I am not expecting you to admit that anyways. I know I was an ass, but don't deny you weren't being unreasonable. I was about to flip him off, but I held back when I recalled the conversation I had with Matt and Cass. I said I don't feel guilty about that anymore, but it was a half lie. It still bothers me. Same way it does when I think about how I defend my brother to David. He didn't say it outright, but he implied I wasn't being fair with him too.

Ned interpreted my hesitance to acceptance. He says, do you see that now. Don't you. I remained silent calming myself. I should be angry, but not like this. Not for the wrong reasons. He continues, I didn't come here for an apology. Nor did I come here to give one. I wish I say I was shocked, but his demeanor was apparent. He says in low tone, did you know I talked to David. I scoff, talked? He told me you confronted him in the middle of a crowd. He is surprised I already knew, I sort of did. And he told you about that. He shakes his head, something changed about him. I can't explain what or how.

I didn't want to explain anything to him. He says, I don't know what he told you. He told me something along the lines of resolve our issues or break it off. I was right, he did gave us like an ultimatum. I think I heard him telling the same thing to Catherine. I don't understand why he suddenly became so passionate about butting into our personal business. I have all sorts of conflicting emotions from his actions. Should I be glad he cares so much or be even more mad at him. Ned says, he called me out on my excuses. Like you did just now. And that's why I am here. I don't want to avoid this anymore. I don't like how it happened, but I am glad I did it.

I ask, if you are not here for an apology or ask for one. What are doing here. He takes a brief moment to settle something in his mind. He whispers, I want explain why I was angry with you in the first place. That's not something he needed to tell me, I know why. You were being an ass with me. You got offended too much just because I angered you. He snarls, no. I mean, yes. Here you go again. Do you still think I shouldn't have my own opinion. Even Catherine was betting on Charles. Why do you keep insisting I was being unfair to you. I bark, Catherine had a grudge towards David at the time. You didn't. All you had was statistics, that you used to demean me.

He lowers his angry voice, that's not completely true. I ask, which part. You waited just that moment to humiliate with the number of people against David. He says, I didn't mean that. But, just to clarify, I am still justified about that. You can't be angry at me alone. There are ton of people who didn't know David back then. He then closes his eyes for a second, I digress. I was angry about the bet. I have to come realize I was angry about something else entirely. My brows arch at the confusion. What realization is he talking about. He says, it was him. David. The way you instantly went to defend him, it ticked me off.

All the frustration and anger I held turn into bemusement. My fist that was so tense, become even tighter. He adds, it wasn't just that. You spent so much time with him in the flag capture game. Instead of me. And even before, you both spent years with each other. While I didn't share the past, except in your stories to each other. He makes a shameful face, I was. He lost his words. I hesitantly ask, jealous? Of him. Seriously? That made him annoyed, of course. Why wouldn't I be. You are two are so close lately. I heard people taking that you both are also fighting. I was sure he tried to make a move on you because of our fight. That's why I confronted him then.

I am so flabbergasted that my thoughts left my mouth stunned. I couldn't bring a single word to explain how utterly insane that was. I blurt out, why in the world would you believe that. He slumps on the chair, you already said it. I was jealous of him. He seems to know more about you than me. I already knew that, but I didn't know it would effect me so much. And back in the VIP room, I couldn't take it anymore. Its embarrassing that I was so insecure about you and him. You have to see how close you two are. Can you blame me for thinking that. This brew my emotions into a turmoil. I can't deny much of what he said. But I knew what to tell him.

I open my mouth, there is nothing between us. Now more than ever. He jerks ahead, meaning there was something before. That caught me of guard. Its my turn to be mortified now. I can't deny I am attracted to him. But I wouldn't act on it. Not when I was with Ned. Then it downed on me a thought so shameful I couldn't bring myself to even think about it. Ned says, I know you didn't cheat on me. Maybe it was silly of me to even believe that. But the guy is too impressive for me not to worry. I hate that he is become so strong lately. Want to know something bad. I was so envious of him, I was wishing he be defeated by the Heraknus trio.

He waves his arm in anger, but behold the great David. He pulls out another trick. And this is after he already pulled something so messed up as copying Kuret. Think how I feel when I saw he can do what I can do. I know its not the same, but still. He isn't even an alpha, and yet he is now trying to reach heights of overdrive users. Do you know what he is doing today. Working out in the training center. Even I think how strong he already is, it terrifies me how strong he will become later. He places his palms on his face, like trying to hide under it. He scoffs, who wouldn't be jealous of a guy like that who is so close to his girlfriend.

I could feel just how resentful he was from his guilt ridden expression. I never once thought he held such feelings towards him. I can't believe I never saw signs of this before. His confession left him pale and defeated. His hands slips from his face, that’s what I was angry with you. Not because of some silly bet. I thought we would resolve it without me ever revealing this. But then the guy pressured me into believing I should either fix things with you or break up to stop hurting both of us. I was so infuriated the way he said. But what he said wasn't wrong. I don't want us to end. So this is me, reaching out. Hoping you can understand the real issue with us.

My breathing felt so heavy, it was like I was scared of it. Partly, because the shameful secrete he told me. And because I was confused at my own feelings. Is that why I have been so angry at David. He betrayed me. No, it can't be. I am mad at him because he thinks my brother is not the person I think he was. But then I recall the conversation I had with Siera. That had opened a whole new perspective. But that’s all why I am angry at him. But then why does it hurt when Ned pointed it out aloud to me. Ned sees my convoluted expression, this is why I didn't want to tell you. Because I just mess things even more.

I couldn't refute that. Now it makes sense why he suddenly got angry at the VIP room and has been for so long. I can't tell how he handled was right. But how can I judge him when I am responsible my own horrible ways to avoid having this talk. I murmur to him, where does it leave us then. He closes the gap between us, I told you, it was my pride or ego getting in the way. But David told he didn't have anything to do between us. I am hoping we can move past this now. I know its not fair to ask you to be okay with this. I am asking you to understand me for feeling this way. I don't want to lose you. And at the risk of being arrogant, I am sure you don't want to either. So please. Lets not give into hatred and jealousy.

I am speechless. His earnest request to move past this was genuine. But I didn't have the answer he was asking. I tell him in a somber voice, maybe you knows what to do. But I don't. I understand what really happened. I didn't know you had such petty side. I am sort of glad you told me. But maybe that’s my fault for not noticing you were hurting this much. He scuffs beside me and grabs my hand. His hands felt warm to touch. Like I have been missing it. He shouts, no. This isn't on you. It's a guy thing. Or rather, its my thing. I told you I am not here to apologize, but if that what it takes. So be it. I am so sorry that I got angry at you. It wasn't about you at all.

I didn't exactly feel any relief hearing that from him. I thought him apologizing was what I needed the most. Hoping that would magically fix the problem. But nothing of that sort occurred. The only thing left was embarrassment and regret. I grip his hand, I know this sounds strange. But I need some time to think. He nods, its not strange. Its normal. Take your time. But please, don't break up with me. Not for this. Those moist eyes of his made me realize how much this was hurting him. The constant weight he was carrying all this time, something I didn't notice.

I gave him a nod. His gloomy face perked up like a child. I don't want to break the trust he was giving me by telling his selfish feelings. I don't want to throw away our relationship. Not for Ned. Not for anyone. But. What about David. That single thought made my heart ache.

David (Chapter 111)

Wednesday, March 11, 2026 20:17

Sweat is dripping from my entire body. For two days, I have been training ceaselessly. I have been doing only five things. Eat, shit, sleep, train and strategize. I have completely zoned out everything else. No more distractions. I heard what Rory told Blake yesterday. Normally, he would be biased since it was his dad. But he had a lot of time to think about it. If that's the conclusion he reached, then I am sure he had a reason to believe I was still lacking. The one reason he did gave away was correct. My usual tactics wouldn't work on a person who can't think clearly. They are the most dangerous kind of opponents. Spontaneous and strong.

I preparation, I have been following Blakes guidelines. Using Kuret do the work for me, instead of my muscles. I didn't have much choice with the impromptu Heraknus fight. That was an emergency. And it was clearly evident that I was no where ready to fight at that capacity. Not when it meant joint sprains and shoulder dislocations. So I back to basics, learning to control this form of Kuret. I have been performing basic target defense and attack with just my Kuret. So far I have gotten the hang of it. Using M to track my unconscious reflexive movements, I am slowly improving. I still flex out my limbs few time in practice. Can't be helped, it's a habit.

I also drew out a whole regiment with Blakes help. Another two days of Kuret control training and then comes Kuret assisted movement training. He has shared some thoughts on how to better control my Kuret while I move. Till now, I was focused on a balance of efficiency, precision and endurance. But now I need to add Kuret control. It will be hard to add it to the mix I have been learning for years. But I feel confident about this. Especially since my brain has been rewired. Apart for social behavior changes, the main changes are of course to how I handle my Kuret. Like Drew said, few days in and I have begin to feel better than ever.

Today was a satisfying day. I was able to form different physical shapes with my Kuret. Like how do it with my dome. I am beginning to think I don't need to exert that kind of strain anymore. The experience of how I used my Kuret in the middle of the match with Charles was helping me. A wall, a thin blade and spikes. I can still see vestiges of the exploding Kuret time to time. There is still so much to learn. The Kuret threads are grouping on me is also not yet stable. I feel its still slow, because I have to keep them running on my body all the time. It would be much easier if I could make them move without mental effort.

One step at a time. Am I sure it will became as natural as breathing. A quaint notion Blake said it to me while explaining his ideas. The sun is almost gone as I walk back to my house. With no public transportation, I had to walk all the way. My car is still in the garage. I could have it fixed, but I wanted to try some of the Kuret assisted sprint. Though I quickly realized I was getting ahead of myself. I ran for a while, but I didn't have any coordination and hit few poles and buildings as I ran. Few people that did saw me were shocked and amused at my failed attempts. For the time begin, I will borrow someone's car from tomorrow.

M chimes in after a while from my watch, boss. I have an update about our contact in Citradel. I halt and take shade under a tree. M relays the message through the ear piece. They have crossed the first checkpoint safely. That's excellent news. M says, however, my analysis shows there will be even a bigger delay for the next checkpoint. The increase in cargo containers will add more scrutiny. The contact organizing the transport says expect delays for at least a day. We can't help it. There are now eight involved in this extraction. But this should be good news for the Citradel officers who have been worried about their loved ones whole day yesterday.

I tell M, send a message to Marina, June, Chelsea and Frank detailing the routes and checkpoints. We should be getting a photo or video proof. Send those too. M says, reminder set. Thinking back, I never expected Citradel to be in such a chaos that I would have to extract Jack like this. Protests was one thing. But riots. And particularly one that involves the church. Between Ryes betrayal and this insurrection, there had to be a connection. Maybe there is none, but I had a nagging feeling that this isn't all about the religious devotion to the overdrive people. That's I have, a mild intrigue. I am a hemisphere away and far to busy to do anything about it.

My thoughts drifted to Catherine. She had an exhausted look on her face after I saw her boat coming from the horizon. When our two speedboats dock, I ask, so, how was it. She gave me a weak smile, you don't know. I shrug, I only got rudimentary reports, like location and timings. Didn't want to pry into both your lives. She nods, I appreciate that. Really. She picks her bag and hands it over to me while boarding my boat. I tried to see her glimmer, but most of it was just exhaustion. I am sure the continuous traveling and changing identities had to leave her burnt out.

I programmed the auto pilot on the boat to return back to the hideout it came from. While returning back to the island barrier, Catherine kept quiet and just looked far off into the ocean. I would be lying if I saw I wasn't eager to know what happened. But I didn't want to force her to answer me. 15 minutes before we reached the island border, she speaks up, I am sorry. Its just a lot happened. I am trying to figure out how best to explain. She had a despondent expression. So either they broke up or something else bad happened. I attempted to raise her spirits. The only way I know. I twist my neck to her, I have some idea. You spent half the day in some hotel room.

My grin gave away the nasty thoughts I had. She looks away flustered, hiding her face. That actually caught me by surprise. I was only joking, but did they really spend half the time having sex. She cries out, you don't have to be crass about it. I don't think there was any other way to see it. I turn my back to her and focused on navigating the water. A while later she stands beside me with a small sigh, we got carried away. I am not going to deny that. I only smiled without looking at her. She says, we haven't seen each other in months. And I don't know how long it will be next time. That line gave me a chilling pull in my guts.

Damn it. So they didn't break up. This was supposed to be the end of it. I was hoping she gave him a break up romp in the bed. My disappointment slipped through my amused façade. She says, you are upset. I reply, no. well, a little bit. I promised not to butt in. Didn't say anything about not having an opinion. But its your decision in the end. She says, I couldn't do it. I couldn't tell him that I didn't want to leave the island. I thought I would have the courage to tell him. He was so happy and I felt guilty taking it away in the same day. I remained silent, hoping to avoid saying anything I would regret. I knew how incredibly difficult it is to know something to be right, and yet act on it.

She continues, we love each other. It's enough for now. For now is okay, But what's comes next for them. I don't think she leave her responsibility to be with him. So they decided to just continue this. Meeting once in few months. How long can they keep it up. Until they can't? It took a lot of restraint for me to not judge them. I understand matters of love is irrational, but they are pushing the bounds of it. I ask, is Robb really fine with this. He gets to talk to you for a day only. And when you do meet, its under surveillance. She closes eyes hiding her wave of emotions. The glimmers revealed the truth though. Shame and anger.

She gathers her words, we spoke about that in length before we left the hotel. He had the same concerns. Not seeing each other is cruel. So, we have found a way to contact each other. An encrypted video link over the internet. Its not the best, but we can work it out. A very convoluted type of long distance relationship that has no end goal. That's their solution to fix their relationship. I almost told her this was a bad idea. But I closed my mouth before I said anything that would ruin me again. I say, all the communications are monitored in and out from the island. How are you going to talk to him.

She turns to me with suspicious eyes, I am hoping you can help with it. Can you ask Ruther to give me unrestricted access for that link? We are going to need it every alternate days. I gave a flat response, yeah. No can do. I did enough to fix my mistake. You know my feelings about it. I won't stop you. But I won't endorse it either. If you want that link to be active, you should talk to him yourself. She wasn't surprised by my reaction. Maybe she already knew I wasn't going to help her with this. She smiles, I know. Just had to ask.

She looks away to the ocean, you already did a lot. It was just a silly thought. I should take responsibility for my own decisions. I know it doesn't make any sense to you. But I can't just cut Robb out of my life. I want to hold on every second I have with him. She faces me again, what would you have done if you were in my position. She put a reversal question to me now. Honestly, I already knew what my answer was. But I am hesitant to give it her because I know she wouldn't like it. So I just stayed quiet hoping she lets it go. But she wasn't backing down, tell me. I want to know. She pleads with a soft voice. With a heavy sigh I reply, I would have ended it.

She stares at me for a while, gauging my reaction. She says, how can you say that without hesitation. I didn't want to sound like a know it all. But since she asked, I should tell her about it. I ask, how much do you know about Sophie Monroe. She answers after giving it some thought, isn't that the daughter of Robert Monroe, the guy who you. I step over her voice, killed. Yeah. That's her. Most of you believe that I was just close with Sophie because our target was Robert and his connection with the Hive. But it wasn't simple as that. Talking about Sophie brought up the memories I had with her.

I tried to focus on only the good things, but I would be delusional to not be guilty about the bad things. She nervously ask, wait. You mean, you and her. I gave a nod. At the time Catherine was infiltrating the Valley, so she knows about Liz and me. But not what happened in San Francisco. She asks, I don't believe it. How did I not know about that before. I wave my hand at her, it was a long time ago. And one of the worst mistakes I ever did. If you saw me back then, you would see a guy believing he could have it all. In the beginning Sophie was just a means to get close to her father, but I got infatuated with her. She asks, does anyone knows about this.

I scoff, you think I like advertising something like this. That I was once in love with her. I am sure Cass, Blake and Vanessa have some idea about it. But I hid from everyone. Catherine was amazed that I was more or less in the same situation as her. She asks, but how. She was a human you just met. Its embarrassing to talk about it with her, but I had to tell her why I did what I did. I reminisce about the time with Sophie, I was naïve. Without my memories and it had been about 18 months into my new life of war and death. I was holding on a single strand of normalcy. And by some twisted coincidence, it was her. And she is still the most unique and fascinating person I have ever met. Her personality was alluring to me and I couldn't stop myself from being interested in her.

Catherine gawks at me like I was telling her a made up story. She asks, what the hell. You never once told me you were this serious about her. She then leans forward, did you two ever? Her words trails off but I gathered what was implying. I shake my head, no. But we came very close to it once or twice. I didn't want to take advantage of her, more than we were already doing. Catherine asks disappointed, you mean you chickened out. She goads me intentionally, call me whatever you want. I was being foolish, thinking there was any future with her. Every time we get closer, I pull away before it became serious. I realized what a mess I was entangling her in.

She knew what happened in the end, so I didn't had to explain it to her. She asks, but it ended because you shot her father. I answer, that's not entirely right. Liz made me realize I was being delusional. Forget about us two being aliens to each other, I was going to destroy her life in ways she didn't know. I was putting her in danger just by being near her. So a few days before the day everything went to crap, I broke it off. She says, just like that. She didn't fought back. I remember the time she showed the hint of emotion. I had broken her heart so bad she actually felt it. I tell, she wasn't completely okay with it. But I know doesn't have any regret.

Catherine rebukes me hard, how can you say that. Guys are so dumb. I needed to explain some things to her for her to understand, I am not being facetious. Sophie isn't like your normal human being. I told you, she is very fascinating creature I have ever met. She didn't buy it, doesn't matter. I know she lost her father later, but at the time you didn't know that. You could have made it work still somehow. Or maybe you could have said some good fake excuse. Now it makes sense why she is after you. Its not just about her dad, its personnel. I wait for her to calm down. Once she did, I ask, are you done. She gave me angry face.

I say, first of all. Don't try to make this about you and Robb. I am telling you all this because I wanted to show that I made a hard choice. So I know how you feel, how agonizing it is when you make up your mind, but back away when you are in front of them. It was a mistake to get involved with her in the first place. Case in point, she joined FBI to kill me. So don't assume I did it because it wasn't hard for me. That made her back off me. I know she meant well, but I wasn't going to be guilted by her own personal drama. I continue, secondly, I didn't need to make any story for her. Not because I didn't care. Its because she doesn't.

That made Catherine confused, what. I explain, she is a highly intelligent functioning psychopath. A diagnosed one, not a metaphor for her behavior. She doesn't feel remorse or guilt. And certainly doesn't have normal feelings of love. So when I say the reasons don't matter, because she wouldn't care why I broke up with her. Catherine stood there with her jaws dropped. Coincidently we were near the border, so I turned off the engine. Now there was just the waves of the ocean and a discombobulated Catherine. She finally find's her voice, say that again. I sigh, you heard me. I am not going to repeat that.

I walk to her rucksack bag and begin wrapping it in a plastic sheet. She scurries behind me, the freaking hell. You were in love with a honest to god psychopath. Mother of Kuret. I face her annoyed, see. This is why I don't tell people. Imagine what would people think of her, or well, me. She is horrified to know the truth about Sophie and me. I think she is getting the wrong idea, she isn't like the one you have heard in TV. She is manipulative, selfish, but only to a point. She hasn't hurt anyone or anything. Well, I can't say for sure now. She is intelligent though. A rare type of person, so she understands basic morality. That's one of the things I liked about her.

I didn't even realize I was rambling and completely distracted from the main point. I reeled in the emotions swelling up in me. Catherine gazes at me anxious. I say, I went off topic. I would appreciate it if you don't tell anyone about her. In my mind I relayed, especially Vanessa. She gives a very small nod, ah. Okay. I can see it's a sore topic for you. But why tell to me that just to prove a point. I sigh as I take the bench beside the railing. She takes a spot beside mine. I take off my shades and close my eyes, resting my head on the grills.

I say, because I don't have anyone to talk to about this. As much as it pains to me, you are probably the only person I know who knows what I have gone through. A relationship between a Medrone and a Human. How many do you know there are like us. Or better yet, how many do you know of. She leans back understanding my point, that's true. Quite a troublesome pair we are. I blurt out, tell me about it. Since I got my memories, I have been hording secrets and feelings that was in a way making me sick. Drew say it was PTSD, or Ketriya, but who the hell knows. So I don't want to keep hiding, even from myself. That's why I am telling you this.

She asks, and what about now. Do you still lover her. I open my eyes and stare at the open clear blue sky. I say, tell me, if you break up with Robb, would you have been still in love with him. She gets silent at my question. I answer for her, its complicated. Right? Well, for me, I feel obligated to say its over. I used to love her. At least that's how I want it to be. Because there is zero probability that's happening again. Besides, I still have the memories of us together. All the social experiments we used to do. Or the running joke how she can't tell why people blink. I feel I am okay with loving her, in those memories. If that makes sense.

I used to feel a compulsion to hide embarrassing feelings. But now, I am at ease talking it aloud. At least to the right people. Catherine says, you know, I still am not used to be see you so open about stuff like this. Now she is just teasing me. I put the shades back on my eyes, so now you know. What I would have done in your shoes. Or more to the point, I have already done. She brings her arm against the railing, its not the same though. She had a good point, that's true. Robb knows and accepts who you are. But everything else is the same. He and you live in different world. Very different. To be clear, this is not me judging you or him. But its plain facts.

She becomes forlorn, you remember what you said few years ago. When you found about us two. I recall the time we were looking for the weapon Hive was hiding. She continues, that this will not last. It has an expiration date. I was so mad at you back then. But you were thinking about Sophie back then too. Weren't you. I answer, I was. That was wrong of me to force it on you both. But again, I am not making you do anything. Just expressing my concerns. In the end, you do what your heart tells you. No matter what others say. Even if that's me. She chuckles at my suggestion, if only that were so easy.

I hear M's beeping, all right. Its time. I stand up prepared for her to bring her back, I have done all I every say or do about this. Its your decision in the end. I just don't want to be blamed if things go wrong, deal. That's rude to mention, but I wanted to be very clear about that point. She stand beside me with a determined expression, I understand. Thank you for doing all this. And trust me, whatever happens from now on. Its not on you anymore. I am glad you told me about Sophie too. But trust that I have so many questions about her. I shake my head with a smile. I shouldn't have told her. She won't let go of my questionable past relationship.

I begin to gather the Kuret in my hands. She turns a little irritated, do we have to do this way. I am not going to tell anyone. I chuckle, I am not worried about that. I can't have you leave the island every time you get hungry. That joke earned my an jab at my shoulder. After that I took a unconscious Catherine back inside the island without anyone knowing. Once at the shore on sector 3, she went home to sleep in few hours while I went to training center. Where I have been entire day working on my Kuret control. I honestly don't know what's going to happen with her. I am concerned she will never be able to make a decision. Seeing her continue like this, stuck here without moving on, I rather she left the island. Even if that is completely selfish and unreasonable to others, at least she be happy in that case.

Just few meters before I reach my house, M says, boss. You have an unexpected visitor. I groan with annoyed shout. Since my show off with Heraknus, I have been continuously hounded by people. Some don't believe it really happened, and many didn't care. But few have become obsessed. At the beginning, it was enduring. But now its slowly turning creepy. I gave a five minute interview yesterday to tell people that I need to focus on my training and not to disturb me. Not that I expected it will shoo away everyone. But I expected some distance for the ones who kept creeping at my house. Blake offered officers to guard, but that would be too condescending.

I ask M, who is it. I raise my watch and a hologram comes out of the surveillance camera outside the house. There is a blue car waiting at some distance. I don't recognize it. M runs the GPS signature to identify who was it. Molly, a cashier from sector 5. Don't know who that is. M shows the car's been here for more than an hour. How persistent is Molly. When my house is in view, I side step from the cars view. Well, Molly, unfortunately I am too exhausted to meet you. I would use my Kuret to hide my presence, but that be overkill. Besides, I needed to make her see that I am not interested in taking anyone right now.

I quickly make my way through the driveway hoping she doesn't see me until I was in. But no such luck. I hear the car door opening and a person's footstep approaching me. I increased my pace like a burglar running to his own house. Molly comes running yelling, wait. David. Is that you. I just need five minutes. The voice made my legs slow down and my eyes wide. That familiar voice was unmistakable. I turn my neck to see Elina in a coat, running at me. I gulped hard seeing her frantic expression. I should have rushed inside my house. But my mind was racing to figure out why she is here.

Did someone tell her about me. Who. Blake, Nathan, Marina, Catherine, Tessa. Or maybe Vanessa. No, why would anyone do that. I erased my involvement with her and the criminals. Does she know that I was Mack too. Before I can figure out, she stood beside me. She says, sorry to barge in like this. But please. I am not here to freak you out. I just want to talk with you. Its important. I small air passes through my lips. She doesn't appear to know who Mack really was. I pull of my hoodie and take off my shades. She gets nervous staring at her. I should say something, she herself is getting anxious from my silence.

But what to should I do here. Do I tell her to leave me alone, or tell her to come tomorrow. But that's delaying the inevitable. And who knows, maybe she did came here just because she is a fan. A small wishful hope still lingered in my mind. I ask her, and you are? She hesitantly says with a deep eyes, I am Elina. Nice to meet you. I tested her a little. Well, so far so good. I gesture my hand towards the door. The tense atmosphere begins to dissipate as we step into my house.

I take off my jacket and put in on the hanger, you look troubled by something. I am not sure what you want from me. She reply's, again. I am sorry to interrupt you. I know you are very busy. But I had to meet you. I have not been keeping tabs on her, but the last I heard she was still on a semi house arrest. She doesn't leave her house except for daily necessities. Even that she had purchases in bulk last week and hunkered down. Since I already invited her, lets see how this plays out. I gesture her to the couch, can I get you anything. She replies as she takes a seat at my couch, thanks. I am good.

I answer, well I am thirsty. Care to wait for a minute. I need to take a protein shake and probably get changed. She nods her head and wriggles a little in her seat. I quickly walk away and prepare my drink in the kitchen. Once I turned on the machine, I left to change out of my sweaty clothes. This is not I imagined seeing Elina. Certainly not like this and not in my own home. While she waited patiently, I hurriedly cleaned myself and put on fresh clothes. By the time I arrived back out, the drink was done. With a bottle in hand, I sat next to her. She caught me off guard earlier, but I had settled my thoughts enough to make a poker face.

So, what can I do for you Elina. I take a sip from the bottle. She says, do you know about the incident at the water plant two weeks ago. I make a show of snapping my fingers, that's where I remember that name from. You are the one who got tangled up in that business. I put the bottle aside, it must have been harrowing experience for you. I heard you siblings were there too. She becomes upset as I mention their name, yes. Peter and Ryan. My baby brother was there while I nearly died. A regretful expression appears on my face, I heard. I am glad you survived though. And what about Ryan. How is he faring.

She takes a moment while she gives me a hard look. She is trying to see something from my reaction. What game is she playing here. Finally she says, he is better now. First few days he was so terrified he couldn't speak or do much of anything for days. He wouldn't let me out of his sight as well. Its taken some time and counselling to get him on his feet. I tell her, that's good to hear. He seems resilient. And you. You nearly died, must be difficult to get over something so dreadful. She nods, it was. I was being held at IDF for a while, so the shock hadn't gotten a hold on me. But when I went back home, and be alone, I had a crash out.

She is trying to best hide her fears, but I could see the faint glimmers of resentment. Yet she seems better now. At least physically. I waited for her to tell her reason to visit me. Didn't seem the right to ask her myself. Her fist tightens on her knees, I can't take it anymore. You were there at the warehouse, with us. People keep telling me everyone took out each other. But that detective, Roland. He kept asking me and Ryan about someone else there. The reason finally comes out. I kept my cool as she blatantly exposes me about my involvement.

I am curious why now. Its been weeks since the investigation. And fortunately Roland has no evidence. So she didn't get any new information from IDF. I ask her, why do you think that. She explains, few days ago. Me and Ryan were watching your fight with Heraknus. Which by the way was awesome. I was completely in awe how you beat them down. She hastily adds that as compliment. Even in the predicament I was in, I couldn't resist a smirk. Considering she was bad mouthing me, in front of me, as Mack. I say my image has drastically improved since then. Or maybe she is just saying that because she is here.

She says, after the match. You healed the Heraknus guy. My brother said he remembers seeing that thing happening at the warehouse too. Oh shit. I made a mental kick to myself. I was only showing off in front of Rory and others. Bloody hell. I can't believe after all that careful planning, I am busted because of my ego. Maybe I can cover this up, I am sure he is mistaken. I used Jonathans Kuret, that's true. Maybe your brother had seen that somewhere else. She isn't buying my lie, Ryan was sure he saw that. He remembered someone telling him to get me help.

She leans forward, and you know what. I think I remember seeing that Kuret too. I asked around, there no one from Jonathans house was at the warehouse. Not among the criminals or anyone in the officers nearby. Her glimmer was steady, meaning she was confident in herself. That's bad for me though. I take a drink a little bit of the shake to figure out how I can convince her. She gathers more courage, you were there. You were the one who saved me. The doctor said I was very lucky to be alive. But that's not the whole truth. You saved me and Ryan. I slowly gulp down all the rest of the drink hoping to buy some time.

Maybe I can tell her some clever lie. I swipe away the few drops of my lips, look. You seem like a nice girl. And I don't mean to be rude, but its just a misunderstand okay. You and your brother went something traumatic. That changes your perception. Believe me, I know all about that. Best to confuse her rather than outright reject her, you saw my interview. The one where I was accused by Ryes. I am well verse in all the matter of trauma. I am flattered you think I saved you. But you have one brother in jail, and one in house arrest. I don't think you are seeing things clearly too.

Unfortunately, none of my words reached her. She still had a headstrong expression, I am not here to cause any trouble for you. I just want to thank you. For saving me and my brother. You even let Peter get out of there. Even though he doesn't deserve it. She was hesitant in her actions, but now she is her usual self. I can still salvage this, but should I even do that. Haven't I lied to her a lot already. And if just let her believe this, maybe she won't dig deeper and find out other things. I look away for a moment.

I chuckled a little when it downs on me what a mistake that was to show my Kuret sphere in front cameras. Turns out that was enough of a confirmation to her. She turns bright, like she just figured out a big mystery. I wasn't going to make it easy for her, lets hypothetically say that I was there. Just minding my own business. Then I saw suspicious activity at the plant. I saw few warriors who were guarding a place which was supposed to be empty at night. I looked in and saw some in a pinch. So maybe I stepped in and took down their operation.

She took the hint with a big smile and nodded along. I continue, now, I could have done it without hiding my involvement. But lets just say there were other stuff going on behind the scenes. More than just petty criminals and smuggling operation. Perhaps its so sensitive that its best that no one knows that I was ever there. That finally gave away my meaning. Hey sharpens and mumbles, oh. So, its something more. I got it. Her voice returns to normal, thank you. I gave her gesture to say I don't need it. She leans away sighing with relief, to be completely honest. I wasn't sure why I come here. Maybe I thought it help me make sense of things. For my sake and Ryans.

That's so like her, putting her brothers before herself. Even Peter. She says, anyway. That's all I had to say. She looks around my living room, its actually not how I pictured you living by the way. I scoff, please. Tell me what you thought. She teases me, I heard rumors you are hiding some insane tech. I laugh at that, well, I am. Would you like to see some killer robots. She snickers, wow. Really. Well, maybe next time. I answer, bring Ryan too. I know you don't are not into nerdy stuff, but maybe Ryan would most definitely would be. Her cheery attitude turns into a little amusement.

Oh shit, that just slipped out without meaning too. Now that the tense air was cleared, I fell back into the my comfortable mode with her. I clear my throat, I mean. I am assuming any 9 year old would be interest in robots. She has a sudden realization, I didn't think of this before. You already researched us, don't you. Makes sense you would do that. Because of Peter. She was only half right, but props to her for connecting the dots. She seems

much better in spirits from the interrogation with Vanessa.

That made me recall how Vanessa was grilling Elina for my information. And then what she said to me later in IDF that I didn't care about Elina. That brought up a lot more guilt than I thought I could handle. Now that she is at my home, laughing and being her usual self. I can't help feeling that I am chickening out. Letting her believe that Mack is only some guy who is overly zealous friend. If things go back to normal, would I down that disguise from my bedroom and visit her again. Or maybe I won't see her again. I kept hearing Vanessa's words about not trusting anyone. Her warn voice had lost its smoothness after repeating those words to me so many times.

Elina gets uncomfortable at my sudden quietness. Her glimmers showed some agitation. She stands up, look at the time. I took a lot of your time. I should get back home. She mouths me, thanks you as she walks to the door. She says, and good luck for your fight with the Heraknus alpha. You have my full support. Her enthusiasm and sincerity in giving me that encouragement had the opposite effect. I now really felt I was betraying her. I sigh, damn you Vanessa. Filling my head with things. Elina thought I was saying something to her, she turns back before she opens the door, sorry. I didn't catch you.

I gather my resolve, I was saying you don't need to leave yet. We have a lot to catch up on. Her curiosity peaked, I am sorry. About what. I stand up from the couch, maybe talk about Mack. That name surprises her, wait. You know Mack. I thought about what kind of hint I can drop to her. I didn't like playing like this with her, but lets see if she can really recognize me. I say, sure. I know all about your friend with benefits. Her brows raises as she takes a step closer, how did you. I say, I am sorry you weren't able to buy that bracelet. No actually, if you play your card right. You can get out of that house arrest.

She gazes at me with complete shock. I add, maybe if you sell me all the 1879 Tennessee Whiskey you have left in your cellar, you can probably buy it. Now she begins to stutter a little, how. Did Mack tell you. She had to know what I have been saying. She is probably only resisting to say it now. I gently ask her, ever wonder I would not ask you out. Its not because I am hung up on a girl. No, that’s not true. She is a big reason. Now more than ever. But mostly because of what my life is.

She finally understands with small shriek yells, holy shit.

David (Chapter 112)

Friday, March 13, 2026 11:53

Elina is showing a complete reversal of her attitude from earlier. I sat back on my couch, while she is fuming at the other seat. I couldn't stop her from hurling all kinds of insults at me. Some of them I deserved. But calling me a leacher was uncalled for. The best way to let her settle down was to let her finish her ranting. She shouts at me, you are the worst kind of person I have ever met. I knew you were a messed up person who does whatever he thinks he can. But this, you crossed a line. Did you enjoy lying to me all this time. Using me for, what, selfish pleasure. Arg, this is so humiliating.

I think its been already 10 minutes since she expressed all her feelings. She barks, you have nothing to say for yourself. She crosses her arms while her veins turns red on her neck. I knew it would turn out like this. I was actually expecting her to be storm out of here already. Maybe there is hope she will understand me after all. She cries, have you gone deaf now. Say something dammit. I shouldn't infuriate her more, but I couldn't help commenting about her anger, just thinking that I have never seen you this angry before. Not even when Peter skipped on your 6 months opening anniversary of your bar. I smiled recalling how hot she seemed when she was angry at that time.

Its was obviously not the right time to reminisce about our history. She threw another slur at me, you freaker. You think this is a joke. You toyed with me for months. I don't care you saved my life. I hate your guts. You are the biggest liar I have ever met. Apparently, this was her limit. She didn't want to talk to me anymore. Not when I was purposefully not giving her any explanation. The problem is I am too embarrassed to talk as myself with her. I was playing a character with her, but not anymore. Its awkward to not having that façade anymore. Even though my current personality is very close to the way I appear with her.

She got up and headed straight for the door. Before she left I say, takes one to know one. She yells, what did you say. I clear my throat, I am saying you are a liar too. So don't get judgy with me. That freaked her out. She says, I don't know what you are talking about. Unlike you, I never lied about who I was. I nod, you didn't lie about that. You lied about something else. You have been ever since you got detained by the IDF. Her arms froze at the door knob. Even just looking at her back, I could tell she was a nervous wreck. She probably thought she would get away without anyone knowing about her tragic secret.

I tell her, if are willing to listen to me, I can help you get our of your house arrest. But that’s your choice. She immediately pushes the door open and runs away. I may have been a little too hasty with my provocation. But she will be back. I casually walk to the kitchen counter and begin preparing for my dinner. I contemplated what to tell her. I have been mocking her because I was scared for a bit. I should have a more serious conversation with her. That’s the first thing I would do when she returns.

30 minutes go by as I prepare my dinner. M told me that her car is still outside. So I know she is deliberating what I said. That's a good sign. She can hate me all she wants, but I know her. Once she realizes I am the only one who can help her get out of this mess. I felt a little pang of guilt using this tactic to make her listen to me. But my lie is nothing compared to hers. Another 10 minutes go by and finally I hear footsteps at my door. And it was serendipitous that I was about to finish grilling my fish fillet. She quietly peeks through the already ajar door. I didn't gesture her in until she hesitantly walks to the living room.

The pan was just done sizzling as she approaches me, what did you mean that you can help me. Hook, line and sinker. I thought it was quite a poetic coincidence as I plated the baked fish. I ask, join me for dinner. She gives a annoyed look, I am not hungry. I chuckle as I grab the cutleries, I can actually see you are. I saw her glimmer showing streaks of grey. She watches me in silence as I set the table. I even pulled out the whisky bottle that I actually got it from her one time. She instantly recognized it, isn't that the one I gave Mack. Ah, I mean you. I gestured it to her, you did. You said it should breathe for another few weeks. I thought its appropriate for now.

I hope she isn't too offended by this. While I took my seat, she stood dazed at me. I sigh, you don't have to eat. But I have a schedule to keep. That means taking calories at certain intervals. So you can just stand there, angry at me, or you could eat. I could see glimmers of her hunger increasing when she sees the fish I cooked. I say, its not Kuret mixed, but its still good. Have a bite at least. After I chewed on a bite from my plate and she finally broke. She says, this is not me forgiving you. I nod, I am not asking for it. You aren't the first women to be so mad at me. I internally had a laugh thinking what a repeating theme this is.

She awkwardly sits opposite to me and cuts a piece for her self. I peek at her eyes as they widen from the taste. She was anxious about it initially, but then she slowly gives in. The first bite is slow, but she takes another bite in a hurry. I say, yeah. Not bad right. I recently acquired a new taste for this particular type of marine food. I swivel my fork on a piece thinking how I used to not like this very much a week before. One of the side effects of Ketriya. Elina was no longer hiding her insatiable appetite. She dug in taking another piece with no more of that unnecessary humiliation of hunger. She must have cooked only limited things stuck at the house for a while.

I pour some of the whiskey for us. Its not really a complementing with fish, but Elina didn't mind as she ate and drink in quiet. Half way though I saw her glimmers settling down. I put my fork down, now you know I wasn't lying that I can cook. You remember, you kept teasing me that one time that I am always eating outside. She momentarily stops chewing with angry look. I sigh, I didn't lie about everything. Just my name and job. Everything else was completely true. She gulps, how can I believe that. I clarify, I may have spoofed up some things. But that’s harmless white lies.

She was right to be skeptical. I gave her an example, remember I told you once about Mary. My friend who was a childhood friend and is very extrovert. She recalls that conversation, you told she was kicked out of your team and threw a tantrum. You had to console her that it was just bad luck. I am glad she remembers our talks, well, that was Marina. I was talking about how sad she gotten after she lost against Blake. She coughs a little, what. Marina, as in the omega Marina. Its been quite some time seeing reactions like that. I laugh. She gets offended by it.

I wave at her, sorry. Since I am surrounded daily with her and other officers, I forget how normal people react when I mention Marina. If I recall, you once said you were rooting for Marina all along. She shakes off her confusion, I totally forget. You are on a personal level with all of the high ranking officers. She grumbly resumes eating her food. I continue, I can keep telling you things like that. About my friends, but I am sure that won't make you believe me. The point is, every conversation we had, no matter how convoluted, trivial, or serious, they were all real. Maybe they weren't the whole truth, but they were a version of events I can talk to you with.

She get annoyed at my logic, why me then. Of all the people in the city, why choose me to get drunk. I lean back putting away my fork, would you believe if I say that’s because you were gorgeous and charming. She throws daggers at me with her eyes. She scoffs, I though you weren't going to lie. I say, I am not. I put my elbows on the table and rest my head on my knuckles. I tell her, you are a captivating women. I think I see her blushing a little. That’s a good sign. I continue, I wasn't planning to take things this far, but it evolved more than I thought. I couldn't be myself with others, but you were easy to be with.

She wasn't buying that it was simple attraction. I add, trust me. Mack wasn't the only identity I was using while visiting places. Your rivals in sector 3, I go by Gary there. And another noodle shop in section 2, the owner knows me as Lucas. My life is too complicated, that even before getting fame, I had a checkered past. I can't really be myself around normal folks. Tell me, if I had walked in as myself the first time in your bar, what would you have done. That question made her perturbed a little. She says, I don't know. That was her honest thought. I say, but I know what would happened. I was only a participant in the tournament. A guy with strange Kuret with friends in high places. I would be getting silent judgement, curious questions and people prying into my past. I don't want to deal with those things when I came just to unwind.

She shows the first signs of understanding, I guess so. I continue, I already have a big target on my back with Humans. And while its not the same here, but its just as troubling. So I had to use disguises. Make a persona that I can use to talk to people. She says in a low tone, you mean like those human celebrities that hide their identities when in public. That’s a decent analogy. However she immediately puts it away, no. They don't go around getting involved in other people lives, lying to them this much. I answer, that was a mistake. Like I told you, you charmed me. I didn't want to stop visiting you.

I sigh, but I also know that I was digging myself further into a twisted lie. So I purposefully made our relationship strictly at your bar. You were right when you thought I was using money to keep things simple between us. Just not about the reasons. At this point I had to gulp down half of the glass so that I don't loose courage to speak my mind. I thought I could maintain my composure, but I am anxious. Naturally, this was too much for her. She remains silent trying to figure out if what I said was true or not. I put the glass down, I have another reason to go out of my way to talk to you like this. I won't be divulging that. Though, I can assure you it wasn't about you.

She gives me a suspicious look, what does that mean. I say, just use whatever trust I earned to know that it was for a good reason. She clearly didn't understand what I meant. That’s all I could tell her without mentioning my therapy. Thankfully, she left it alone as she continued to eat the rest of her food. Once finished I tell her, you think I am not being serious. You didn't need to worry about things like Hive wars or Echo espionages. Or even Medrone politics. I was so sure I made a mess by being in your life, but that’s not true anymore. Is it.

I am ready to dive into the heart of her despair. I had called her an even bigger liar than me. Now that I came clean with reasons, she couldn't use them against me. Whether the reasons were moral or not, just or not, they were mine. She knows that. Just like her reasons were hers and hers alone. Her demeanor shifts into a meek under my intense gaze. She is immobilized with fear. I feel pity for her, but I setup the conversation so that she cannot continue using the same excuse to blame for my behaviors. I tell her, the fact is I lied only about me. But you have been lying to me, to others and to IDF.

She asks, I don't know what you mean. She was desperate to hide her crimes. I never seen her nervous habit of pricking her nails before. Its weird that I find it interesting seeing different sides to her. But I restrained myself against pointing them out since she is under duress. I say, see. How hard is to open up to someone you care about. I subtly I asked if she still cared about me too. She didn't deny it. That actually gave me another boast of hope. I patiently waited for her to reveal it herself. But after a minute of intense silence I realized she needed some help.

I turn to the display on the side wall, M. Initiate Umbrella protocol. M replies, authorized personal detected. Requesting clarification. I answer back, approved. Just do it. The house begins to lockdown and Elina turns frantic, what's happening. She jerks at the noise of doors and window shutting down. I explain to her, something to give us complete privacy. Whatever we say now, cannot be recorded, intercepted or hacked. She glances at M's hologram, oh her. That’s one of the crazy tech you mentioned. Say hi to my personal AI. M says, good evening miss Elina. And then blinks away from her hologram form.

Elina asks, no will know about us. I shake my head. That helped her settle down a bit. After mustering courage she asks me in a grim tone, how did you find about it. I reveal, I noticed how weirdly Wayn was convinced you were the one who stole the drugs. At the treatment plant, I didn't put it together. But then later I visited him in jail. He was sure solely based on his intuition and thin evidence that the their shipment ledger was stolen by you. I had a nagging feeling of your involvement. So I saw your interrogations at the IDF. She turns her gaze down from me to the floor, the slow flow of guilt creeping at her face.

She is distraught by my every word, Vanessa gave you a doctored manifest of your shipment orders to see if you can remember anyone that seemed out of place. Find that shipment records that was different than the actual one and forged by Peter. You only remember one. But then I had a look at the list myself. And that’s when I realized you lied. Others may not know you. But you are meticulous with your records. Why do I think so. Because once Peter messed up placing a shipment order for rum instead of distilled rum, which you still remembered after a month of that blunder. Her shoulder drops down further as she was crushed by the weight of a hidden burden.

I remove my hands from the table, I thought it was just trauma. You simply couldn't get your mind focused on that. But that bar is more than just your work, its your life. You love your job. That’s why you are so good at it. You would never make a mistake of not recognizing your own orders and Peters feeble attempts to change it. Even when he is attempting to copy your handwriting. And even if it was flawless, you would should have been able to point out plenty of other suspicious shipments. And yet, you told them about only one. No, you made a show out of it. I wondered why you would try to hide it. Then I looked at your behavior timeline, from patient to victim. Then to consoling sister to a victimized brother. And when things were becoming too much, you started showing reluctance.

She pleads, please stop. Don't say it. It hurts to see her drowning in sorrow, but she has to face reality. I continue, IDF thought that was normal for you to process the event. No, its accurate to say that you sold that behavior to them. You played the best card you had with you, the victim card. Even used Ryan as an excuse. She slams the table with her fist, I never used him. She glares at me with murderous eyes. But contrary to her outburst, her glimmer were saying something else. She clenches her teeth, he has nothing to do with this. I nod, I agree. But that doesn't mean you won't use him to your advantage. And I am not judging you. You did what you could to get out of IDF.

Her fury simmers down with my honest thoughts, I would have never looked this closely. But I cared about you, so I gathered all the evidence and that concluded one thing. I lean in closer, tell me what is Elina. She remains frozen and trembling. I urge her more, you can say it. No one is listening. She is still resisting so much. I slam my own fist, sticking near the edge and toppling the bottle onto the ground. As it breaks on impacts, so does her thin resistance. She shouts, I admit it. Okay. I stole the ledger. I slam my fist again on the table, what else. She cries, no. I yell, what else Elina. Shall I expose you to others. Even Ryan will know what you did.

That broke her last vestiges of self restraint. She yells, it was me. I doctored the shipment records after Peter so that no one will ever find out the truth. Her most shameful and guilty lie comes out spilling. And the tears began rolling down her cheeks. She pushes away the table and dashes away to door. But when the protocol in effect, she had no where to run. She yells, let me out. I don't want to be here. Her cries echo's from the door. Her stifling snorts eating away at her as she tried to slam and kick open the door. I went a little extreme with her, but she had to let it out. She was not facing reality.

I approach her from behind and place my arm on her shoulder, its okay Elina. Its going to be fine. She shoves me away, stay away. You are going to tell everyone now. Aren't you. You want to throw away me in jail with Peter. I won't let you. She kept hitting and scratching away at the steel door. I forcefully grab her arm and pull her into a hug. She tried to wriggle out of my arms, but all she had was a tantrum with no strength left in her. She suddenly grabs my back and behind to cry on my neck.

After that emotional crash out, I let settle down back on the couch. I waited for her to let all her anger and frustration out with her tears. Meanwhile I took a broom to clear the broken bottle with spilled whiskey all over my dining room. I could have had ART clean that up, but the combat bots would only agitate Elina even more. I didn't want to waste the whiskey, but it got the job done. Loosened up Elina just enough so that she reveal her secretes. Normally, I would have a post dinner workout by now. But obviously, I have more pressing concerns right now. I sat beside a bellowing Elina. I grab her hand in mine and say, what do you need.

I figure I should ask her that first. She shook her head while she wipes away her tears. Her hair is a mess as she tugs on the ends with her fingers anxiously. Now that's something I have seen her do many times. I offered her a glass of water to settle down. She denied it, but I insisted. She relents and drinks it all in one go. When that didn't calm her down, I gave her another glass. That seemed to do the trick. Its been a while since I have seen a normal nervous breakdown. Not to be rude to her, but its actually refreshing to see a normal natural response. She says, thank you. Her attitude has drastically dropped down now that she has nothing else to hide.

I grab her shoulders to comfort her, like I told you. No will know this happened. No one heard you. She gives me meekly question, why are you helping me. I am a horrible person. A strands of tears flow from her eyes. I had to assure her that's not true, you did a horrible thing. You aren't one yourself. I can't imagine what you have been going through. But whatever be the reason, it was a mistake. That doesn't mean you are bad. She leans away, that doesn't makes it okay. I lied to everyone. To Ryan. To IDF. Even to Peter. He is in there because of me. I tighten my grip on her shoulder, he is in there because of himself. Don't forget that.

She closes her eyes as tears kept coming. I think I need a different way to let her process this. I ask, tell me how this happened. I don't know the details. When did you notice Peter has been lying to you about the shipments. That distracted her own guilt. She wipes away her tears, 6 months ago. I forced myself to hide the shock on my face. I wasn't expecting this. I thought it was only few weeks, not freaking months. She saw through my face the shock and judgement I had. She looks away resentful of her decisions.

This isn't boding well, sorry. She scoffs, no. You should be mad at me. You lied to me. But that's nothing compared to what I was doing. Being a secret helper to Peter and his smuggling operation the whole time. I need to stop her from spiraling down. So I began my own assumptions, you found out one day that your shipments were different on paper. Did you confront Peter about it. She pulls herself a little, at first I thought it was it was a simple mistake Peter made. I corrected it immediately so to avoid any penalties from spot inspections. But. She lost her words. I help her, it happened again. You started to notice a pattern. Why didn't you ask why he did it.

She replies, I thought he would give me some made up excuse. And what was I going to do, fire him. He is my brother. So I took it upon myself to check why he did that. I ask, did you know he was smuggling in stuff. Her eyes widen and face turns red, no. Absolutely not. I had no idea he was mixed up in all that until he brought me to the treatment plant that night. She had no reason to lie about it. I ask, so you just assumed it was something illegal but not this. Nod nods adamantly, whenever he change the shipment, a few days later he deposit in money in the counter. He claimed it was some side business he was doing. But after the fifth time I know it was related.

That's how she made the connection. She is clever enough to unravel Peter's business. But I am anxious about her reasons, so you saw he was bringing in money with every shipment. And despite having a good enough evidence for a potentially illegal activity, you decided not to turn him in. She finishes the words for me, I was sacred of what would happen to Peter. I didn't want him to go to jail, or get tanged with his other criminals. You have no idea how hard it was for me to make that decision. I needed a cure for Ryan, so that he wouldn't develop the same problem I have.

That's what Wyan said to me. That lends credence to her morality choice. She gets teary, I hate myself. Instead of doing the right thing, I took the easy way out. I say, I already told you. I am not judging you. I may not seem like it, but you are talking to a wanted criminal, hunted by many Human agencies. I am the last person you should worry about making the moral choices. My crimes are nothing compared to yours. I would in fact say they are harmless. That actually brought a unexpected smile to her. Glad that amused her enough to pull her out of her misery, even if it was only temporary. I ask, what happened then.

Her smile breaks away, after months of watching him, I learned a little about his business. I knew there were others, just didn't know who they were. He made many mistakes while covering up the shipments. That idiot thought it was okay to put down a 10 cubic creates into a 50 cubic one. Maybe it would not cause suspicion at the border security, but the inspectors would flag it down immediately. So I corrected them, making them more realistic. I raise my hand, hang on. Let me get this right. With every shipment, you would write down the amount you ordered, which you knew Peter will alter it and then you further edit it to make it even less suspicious. Is that right.

She gives a guilty nod. But I was actually impressed the hell out of this, that's incredible. You were letting him believe that he was cooking the books, when you are cooking his records. I am impressed. I should hire you to run my counterfeiting operations. She spats out, what. I say, never mind that. Setting aside the morality of the situation, what you did was a stroke of genius. You were even better at covering your own records than him. I chuckle imagining how Peter would feel about this if he ever find out. Elina is shocked at how chill I was with this. She says, this isn't something to be impressed with. I am a criminal. I say, if you are going to do something, be the best.

She says, you are crazy. I nod, many would agree with you. But don't deny it. You must have felt a little bit of pride from this. She shake her head, never. I click my tongue, no judgement. Remember. Just an impartial observation. I release her shoulder and grab her hand, you outsmarted him and even Wyan. My excitement finally broke through her emotional guilt. She gives me a proper smile now, you jackass. Fine. Yeah. I admit it, sometimes I felt a little proud of myself. I knew it. I wasn't sure of it, but she was this running for months. She had a carefully crafted system. No matter how guilty you feel, they still have some pride over their efforts.

She says, I can't believe you are happy about this. I say, well, you haven't met the real me. Just the me I showed. She scoffs, its not funny. Her glimmers shows she is better now. I was right to evaluate her state by taking out the emotions from her decisions. I ask, tell me how did you get your hands on the ledger. She looks away as another crime of hers got revealed, few days before the treatment plant, overheard Peter talking to someone in his room. He was talking about some ledger. I realized they had their own copy of the shipments ledger. And if anyone saw that and then compared it to the records I changed, they would know I was involved.

I understand what happened now, so you stole it. What was your plan exactly. You had to know they would know Peter lost it and blame you soon. She frowns, after living him for years on Earth, I know where he hides his stuff. I made it look like Peter misplaced it. I was so scared of getting caught, I didn't thought about the consequences. I hoped they would just blame Peter for being careless and start a new ledger. I had a lot of thoughts about this impulsive decision. But the most prevalent one was disappointment. She had a good thing going, but ruined it with a careless mistake. All too common with unexperienced criminals.

She says, I know I messed up. You don't look so glum. I am not a master criminal like you. Its like she read my mind. I smile, just a silly thought. Who knows, maybe that would have really happened. Won't they probably have a locater type Kuretine on that book. If they did, they would know where to look. She says, I bought a Kuritine safe that blocks everything. That same material as the menage a trois are planning to use in their basement. I say, the stuff that repels away the Kurets. Must have been expensive. She says, I bought it from Peter's own money. Serves him right for making me suffer through all this. She peeked my interest with this again.

I say, that's brutal and righteous. I assume all the rest of the money is gone however. She nods, IDF seized it. But they didn't notice that amount missing. I had to applaud her for this, if are good at covering your finances too. She didn't deny it, she looks away in a little bit of shame again. I scoff, if I had known what an excellent criminal you were, I would have asked you out much earlier. That brought out a laugh from her and shoves me hard in the guts. But she never lets goes of my hand. She slightly strokes my hand in hers.

I was being honest. But truth be told, I was behaving all this to sway her a little. So that she wouldn't suffer under the burden of guilt anymore. I ask, and where is the safe now. She says, I hide it in one of Peters old spots. Buried it in our neighbors lawn. I scoff, bloody hell. You aren't just a unexpectedly tidy thief, you are incredible actress. I met you that evening and I didn't even see a hint of deception. You appeared your usual self, acting like everything is perfectly normal. Down to the quips and the flirting with me. I must be loosing my touch. Of course I had other stuff going on with me, Ketriya, PTSD, and a mental block curtesy of Zakerine. But that's no excuse.

She sighs, please tell me you are not being serious. I am horrified at myself. You can't be impressed at me for doing so many disgusting things. I knew I couldn't ease her guilt in just a short time. But I try what I can, you only did a crime guilty by association. Not even the crime itself. Besides, you nearly died for your decisions. I think that's punishment enough. I hoped that would make her feel it balanced out her guilt. It was hard for to accept that. What a coincidence that one of the client stole the drugs around the same time she stole.

I'll admit that for a time, I believed there to be some sort of connection. But it looks like it was just freaky twist of fate and luck. I imagined the people who used their services wanted this to happen. They probably wanted all of them to be caught. What better way to hide your involvement. Use them, steal those drugs from them and then bust their operations. Now I believe it was two separate events intertwined that caused them to meet that night. I lean back thinking on how to deal with those people. I have been very busy lately to do anything about them. I sure hope that Catherine or Citradel officers have found some credible leads.

Elina voice zaps me out of my thoughts, what are you thinking. I answer, nothing you need to worry about. Lets figure out what we can do to get you out of this mess first. Her grip tightens on my hand, I am going to turn myself in. I had a nagging feeling she would say that. Now that she revealed her actions, her sins are eating her from the inside. I already told her that I can help her. But if she is not going to ask for it, there is no point in me forcing her. Instead I nod, that's the right thing to do. You don't have to worry about Ryan. I will help him out without him knowing. I'll make sure he is adopted by some family, instead of placed in the youth center.

That eventual future instantly shook her to her core. I continued, he wouldn't have to worry about money for a while. Soon your assets will be released and he will inherit them. But, given how close he is with both his sister and brother, he will not make it easier. And its understandable. Loosing fist Peter and now you. But you said counselling is helping him. I can personally vouch it does wonders. Maybe in a few years he will be fine. And he can still visit you both in prison in the meantime. I am sure everything will be fine without you.

The conscious provocation finally snapped her out of her guilt, you are the worst. She scoffs at me while trying to remove her hands. But I pull it back from her, why. I am just saying what will happen. I will help him out however much I can. That should be good enough for you, isn't that right. She gets furious at me. I ask, that's your plan, right. Clear your guilt because its too much. She yells, just stop. I get it already. I can't do that to him. She angrily turns to me, you win. Anyone tell you how obnoxious you are. I shrug, why. Did someone say something to you. I smirk at her even furious eyes.

She sighs, just tell me what your plan is. I waited her for to ask me something before I say anything else. She closes her eyes for a second and then says, you want me say it, don't you. I didn't give agree or deny that. She says, please. Help me. That was all I wanted to hear. But I feel I can ask for something more. So I pushed my luck and waited until she says it. After a while she realized what I wanted this time. She says, I don't forgive you for lying to me. I don't care how petty it makes me look. Dang it, I though I curried enough good will from her. She then softly says, but if you help me. I will think about it.

I saw a small glimmer of anxiety. This wasn't from nervousness, but from suspicion. Her quiet demeanor painted the rest of the picture. I had a laugh, clever. You plan to keep me on hook so I help you out. I guessed right when she tries to hide a smile from me. I wasn't expecting her to forgive me anyways. I say, you got a deal. I gather a little bit of nerve and clear the strands of hair away from her head. I was sure she would strike me away, but she buries her eyes on the ground embarrassed. I realize I was sending mixed signals now and stop it. I say, sorry. She says, its fine.

What was I even trying to achieve. Take advantage of her current vulnerable state. I slide a little away, letting go of her hand and creating a distance. I was doing this only to help her, not make things more complicated. Even though my mind and body were at conflicts, I can't do that to her. I clear my throat, well. Since you asked me so nicely, let me tell you what happens after. I will tell you the details only after you accept that part. A confusion washes over her, okay. As long as I get to stay with Ryan. I nod, as much as I want to let you go scott free. I can't. You may not have smuggled any items, but you definitely gained from it.

She could deny all that. She was enticed by the money. Even if it were for noble reasons. She didn't deny this accusation, and you went as far to cover up their crimes. You may not realize it, but if you had reported them to the officers, we could have avoided few things. I am not talking about you dying. I am talking about things set in motion due these criminals activities. She asks, I don't understand. I wasn't going to explain how it indirectly impacted the tournament or other crimes linked. I say, just trust me. If people know you had chance to stop it, do the right thing, they would tear you apart. Marina comes to my mind. Well, I knew she would eventually understand it, but she wouldn't like this happened at all.

Elina realizes the seriousness of her actions. The unintended consequences. I tell her, it was out of your control. So you are not completely guilty. But the fact remains, people were hurt because of this. With a meek nod she agrees. Now came the hard part, once we get back your life, you will need to make big changes. She asks, like what. I reply, for one thing, you are out of the liquor business completely. It be better if sell your bar. She blurts out, what. You want to give away my bar. I nod, yeah. I am sure if things settle back, you can run the bar again. But your name is hidden only to the public, but not to the officers. You will constantly live under their presence. Like how they do now.

The possibility of the future downs on her. I ask, and how long until people learn about your brother. What happens to you and Ryan when they hear Peter was involved. I am not trying to hurt you, but this only bring unnecessary hurdles and more pain. She says, if I give away the bar, they will leave me alone. I nod, yes. That’s the only way you get your life back. You can argue that I am being harsh, but you did commit a crime. You can't think there will be no consequences. Maybe you will not be held accountable by Blake or IDF. So I am doing it on my own discretion. Feel free to hate me, but that’s what's needs to happen.

The whole plan hinges on this. If she can accept to let go the bar she loves. I could probably find a way to keep the bar for her, but that would be wrong. She did a crime, no matter how much I approve. There has to be some punishment. Besides, she might not get caught. Or maybe she makes a another blunder and gets caught red handed. There are several other ways things can go wrong. Best I deal with it now before others find about it. I patiently wait for her answer. She has a hard time accepting this. Anyone would be feeling it when they are asked to give away something they love.

She makes up her mind after a while, I don't understand you. You say you don't judge me for my mistakes. But then ask for this. I get her confusion, that’s true. I have to live by rules or laws from others. I am not Human and I am not subjected to even Medrones. That means living in a certain way. I want to help you, but there had to be a balance. If you hadn't approached me today, I would have eventually visited you. It maybe was next week, or after my match with Charles. But I would have given you the same choice then. She says, you are weird. I can hardly deny that. My life is strange. She says, I don't want to leave that place. Its more home than my actual house.

She closes her eyes and leans her head on the couch, giving it up for a chance to get my life back. That's, her voice trembles a little. She gathers enough muster, fair I guess. I don’t like it, but its like you said. I won't ever feel less guilty if there are no consequence for my actions. She opens her eyes and straightens her back, fine. I said I do anything to stay with Ryan. If that means saying goodbye to the bar, so be it. She gives off a weak resolve, you sure. Because once we do this you can't go change you mind again. You have to sure of this. She nods more confidently now, I understand.

Her glimmer showed stronger determination. So for now I can accept it. Then I tell her my plan. It was fairly simple, except it involves Vanessa. It took a while convincing Elina of this. She had legitimate concerns, but it was imperative that we got Vanessa's help. She understood that she can't really get away with her crimes without some risks. Vanessa is partially the reason I fessed up my lies to Elina. I feel like she will understand if Elina explains herself.
☐She says, I still don't think she will help me. Her worries was obvious. From her perspective, the chief officer of IDF has no reason to help her and every reason to lock her in. I tell her, c
may be okay with your actions, but others do not share my sentiments. What happens when I am not there to help you. She asks, what does that mean. You said you will help me. I reply, I am saying you shouldn't rely solely on me. I am saying this for your sake. If you rely on just me, it will not make you independent. Eventually you would feel indebted to me, more than you should. I don't want you to feel that way.

My reasons resonated with her now. She blinks hard at me, that’s crazy. You seriously go this far. I smirk, If I am going to make things right with you, I want to make sure I do it the right way. That might have earned me some good grace when I see glimmers of relief on her. She says, you aren't how I pictured you would be. I say, I get that a lot too. But I am still the hot headed guy who thought I could fight off a Heraknus overdrive user. I recalled the words she told me. That made her gush with mortification. She says, I can't believe I bad mouthed you, in front of you.

Then another realization came, wait. Then you remember what I told about others too. I chuckle, I am envious you once said Blake is so dreamy and you would do anything to spend a night with him. I wonder what he would think about that proposition. And how enraged you were he lost instead of me. That garner such a eye of hate and shame that I thought she would throw something at me. She glares at me, not funny. I smile, lets stay on topic. One last piece of warning. I am in hot waters with Vanessa at the moment. So she might not be willing if you say this was my idea.

She settles down a bit, why. What did you do go her. I ask, why you do you assume its my fault. She says, a hunch. Or maybe its because you said I wasn't the only one who is angry with you. She caught remark for earlier. I say, don’t worry. She doesn't hate me. We are just having a hard time. Just trust me. Avoid mentioning my name. You don't know her. But I do. She isn't how you all make her out to be. She is a lot more compassionate than you think. And she has her own fair share of demons. She will try to resist, but I am sure you could convince her. Just stick to the plan.

Elina had no choice but to accept it. She says, and you. How will you do your part. I say, leave that to me. You only seen Mack at his lowest, feeling down and wanting a talk with you to avoid his problems. Maybe even flirt around, testing how much is there to learn about women these days. She scoffs, in that case you aren't ready. Your pick lines are to flat and not at all charming as you think it was. I lean in closer, is that right. But I swear it worked on you. Besides, I heard you like me. So I must have done something right. She says, I never said that. I reminded her of the interrogation with Vanessa. That turns her cheeks red.

Ah, I did it again. I keep falling back to the way I used to talk to her. I can't keep doing this. I resumed the rest of the plan to which she agreed. Our conversation went till 10 PM, that’s not good. She prepares to grab her coat, what's wrong. I say, I wasn't on planning on keeping you this late. You must have noticed many people tried to talk to me, yeah. She nods. I answer, and most of them women. She begrudgingly nods again. I say, well, they camp outside around this time. Hoping to meet me when I go for a run around this time. She turns her back to me and tries to peak through the shut window. Naturally she couldn't see through the barricade.

I showed her the outside cameras and just like the last few days, there were some people in the car hiding out. She says, shit. What do we do now. Do you have a back exit for me to leave. I had one. But aside from revealing its secret existence there is a problem. I mention, your car is outside. Can't just leave there whole night. I am amusing Molly is a friend of yours who lend it to you. She curses herself, I forgot about that. You said you kept your involvement hidden for a reason. It will be bad for if people saw me with you. I nod. I was suggest her a way, but she begin to unbutton her blouse. Then she ruffles up her hair. Even removes one sleave of her coat.

I take a step away surprised. For just a tiny second an insane thought crossed my mind. She says, stop gawking. Get me a black color shade and a hat. I hope you have a scarf do. While she roughs up her dress, I realized what she is planning. A sinister smile forms on my lips, are you sure about this. People will talk. Maybe even try to find you. She says, then stall them. Make sure no one follows me. I don't think you would be worried what people will think about this. How you let gullible women into your home but don't even let them stay the night. She flaps her hairs around a bit more. She smirks, a added bonus. People will know exactly what a type of sleazy guy you are.

I, on the other hand, am already enjoying how this will switch up my public image. I say, on the contrary, I love this idea.

Blake (Chapter 113)

Saturday, March 14, 2026 17:09

Come in, I said to a knock on my office door. I didn't realize its already 12 and I had a meeting right now. Marina and Catherine walk into the room. My nerves were acting up a little when I see Catherine. I heard she rejoined us yesterday after lunch. But I couldn't talk to her again. Looking closely at her, her aura is brighter now. I hesitate to imagine what happened with her romantic getaway with Robb. Its troubling me even now that she went to meet him. I desperately wanted to ask what happened. But I feel that would be getting into her personal life. Which I tried hard to avoid. When I met David earlier, he told me the gist of it.

Neither of us are actually okay with what Catherine decided. But he is right, if we try to separate them, it will only hurt her. I think there is only one way this ends, in heartbreak. David didn't really say that, but I know he agreed with me. For now we have to just wait and hope it doesn't turn into a disaster. But personally, I just don't want to see Catherine in a hopeless future. Love or not, she is an omega and she belongs here. Not with Humans. If only I have the nerve to make her realize of that. For now, I shake away those thoughts. We have a job to do.

I close my laptop as they take the chairs opposite to my table. Catherine says, hey Blake. Missed in the morning briefing. Heard you were not in office yet. I am a little annoyed because of the reason, that's David's fault. He kept me occupied with his training. Marina asks, didn't you had one yesterday. I sigh, he missed last night's session, so asked to have it in the morning. Catherine and Marina turn to each other and snicker. I could have asked what happened, but I already know the answer.

There are rumors that people saw a woman leaving his house last night. Some dark and blurry pics were taken of her driving away from his house. No one know who the woman is or if this rumor is really true. Based on the tweets, they imply they tried to hook up. But she ran away before spending the night with him. Setting aside the fact that David is not that type of guy, I don't think he would allow this to happen. Marina asks excited, did he tell you anything about that. I ask, you think we gossip about each others night life. He didn't say anything, I didn't ask. She scoffs, boring. I am going to meet him tonight. There a bazillion questions for him.

Catherine asks, you think he will tell you anything. Marina says, I will make him. For a while I have been tell him to meet someone. Get a more normal life, and start dating. I ask, you think this is an attempt at that. Marina scoffs, if this is true, he skipped all the steps. He can't just invite woman in for a casual hookup. Catherine says, I don't think this is true. The guy is too much of a wimp to be do be so bold. I add, maybe the old David. But can you honestly say that after witnessing a post Ketriya David. That sent Catherine into a thought, while Marina got even more hyped up, he is got a point. We don't know how much of exploring he is doing. You remember what he told us during the dinner at his place.

Catherine says, that was just about his new preference and lifestyle. Marina scoffs, yeah. That includes dating. I am going to grill him and ask who the poor women is entangled in all his craziness. Honestly, I don't think anything happened. When I met him at the training center, he was just as focused on training like usual. But I can't deny he be able to hide any relationship he has with the women. To be honest, I was a little disconnected while sparing with him. Its bothering me that he encouraged Catherine to meet Robb. I would be lying if I wanted him to stay out of people's lives. Especially hers.

They both were discussing who the girl might be. But I put an end to it, lets stop here. As much as everyone wants to know her, if David doesn't want anyone to find her, no will know. Both of them had to realize the futility of this. Marina says, doesn't mean I can't try. I chuckle, I am sure you will. Lets get on with the meeting though. Catherine called ahead to meet me and Marina earlier. So we both didn't have any idea what this was about. She only mentioned its about her investigation. I motion Catherine to begin. She places her tablet on my desk, as you know. I have been conducting my own investigation.

She refers to what we discussed in Davids car ride from Drews place. Marina says, I thought you weren't going to share the intel with us. Why the change of heart. She smiles, don't worry. I am not giving away everything. But this is a heads up so you guys aren't playing catch up. I am intrigued by her confidence. She turns to Marina, I know about your little Citradel meeting last week. I am guessing you tasked the new jonnies to investigate something. Marina remains lip locked. So did I. She says, so I was right. You are looking for something, maybe even someone. And you can't trust our cities officers.

Just how did she uncover that meeting. I was sure to keep it hidden. Marina signals me in Shadow sign language, someone slipped up. She had the same thought as I. None of the Citradel officers were assigned to her department. So someone poked around and Catherine saw them in a place they aren't normally there. If it was Marina, she wouldn't be caught. So its one of those three. I like to ask who it was, but that would mean admitting he were actually searching for a mole. Catherine says, don't worry. I am not going to say anything to anyone. I don't know what really happened, but if you Shadows believe it to be important. I won't butt in.

That was considerate of her. I can't tell by her aura if she is in a good mood because she met Robb or just being herself. And I hate that I have to even question her like this. Catherine continues, that was just something I wanted to mention. But tell Chelsea that she needs to be more discrete when talking to Rose. Chealse made a mistake meeting her instead of, literally like anyone else. So it was her. And on top of that she tried to asses Rose. That would definitely attract attention if Rose caught wind of Chelsea's intentions. I motion Marina, who nods agreeing to talk to her later.

Catherine adds, I know about the drugs and you are trying to find the people who stole them from Wyan. What I don't know how it relates to the internal investigation you have going on. She hadn't connected that particular thread for now. She continues, anyways. I figured I focus on who made that poison. Marina leans in, you know who it was. She says, not exactly. Did you investigate the two drugs. MCTL and Hetrox. I nod. We even searched for the third critical drug, Pesphinate. Marina and me tasked our Shadow recruits. So far nothing has panned out of it. Marina says, we looked up who has the technical knowledge to make that poison.

I explain more, we have a list of the people who may have the skills and even those who may have access to places to make it. R&D labs, hospitals, maybe their own private labs. The list is not long. But we can't eliminate without more evidence. So far, we can only keep them under surveillance hoping someone trips up. Marina says, we even are looking into their financials. But much to our dismay, nothing stands out. I am sure whoever made it, was traded with something else than money. I agreed with her. They know what that poison would do, I doubt they wouldn't take extreme precaution to hide their identity.

Catherine says, that maybe true. But you are missing something. This peeked our interest, you are only looking at people who declared their skills. I am sure you at least thought about someone hiding themselves under the cover of mundane jobs. Like how David found his therapist, Drew. She is highly skilled, but works as a glorified farmer. I reply, we discuss that possibility in length. But we have no way to figure who they are. Marina says, yeah. Like you said, they could be undercover. But we can't investigate at blind. We had to start somewhere. Catherine says, only if you didn't have additional intel.

So that's what this meeting is about. She has her own way of figuring out who made the drugs. She explains, Marina, did you know where I was day before yesterday. A strange thing to ask her. She turns to me, yeah. Blake was being cagey about it, but I heard from David what you were up to. I shrug, I heard nothing at the IDF lounge, as you know. I emphasis that to Catherine. She says, and thank you for not asking about that. But why did David tell you Marina. It was supposed to be a secret. Marina waves her fingers at her, please give me some credit. He knows what will happen if he doesn't keep me in the loop. And besides, now that this is in the open. We have a lot of Shadow dealings going on. Maybe more than what Blake knows.

Her blatant provocation at me isn't half as endearing she think she is being. I am sure she knows we both have secrets of our own and trying to gauge what they are. I say, lets just move on. Marina lets it slide with her attempts to pry. Catherine says, okay. So as I was saying, I was outside the island. I went to meet Robb, but I also had an objective. During the week, I made my own pool of suspects. And I had pulled background information on what they did while they were living among Humans. That evoked some excitement between the two of us listening to her idea. Marina says, that's really good idea.

I ask, you still have contacts outside. She says, not many. But Robb still had his contacts active. I didn't want him to involve in our business. I just wanted the names of his contacts who run down the photos of the suspects. From her words, it looks like Robb wouldn't stay out of our business. Yet another reason I disliked the idea of Catherine visiting her almost estranged boyfriend. I had to quell the nasty feelings I had to ask, and so did you get any potential suspects. Catherine says, the first list of suspect pool should arrive tomorrow. But I need you approval to authorize the transaction over the network.

That's where she needs our help. Marina tells, this is good. Between our short list of suspects, and then the ones you will have. We can cross reference it and get a viable lead. I had to agree with them. This is potential breakthrough. I say, if we know who made it. We find them, and find who they made it for. That's really good news. Catherine says, lets not get ahead of ourselves. I don't know about you, but I have a long list. And getting background information about their time in hiding is very difficult. Robb says, Home doesn't have 80% of their surveillance data. And branching out to other groups investigating our people is risky.

I guess where she is going, you want to involve David too. She says, he has probably the best network of people who can do it. I don't know how effective it will be for Medrone related targets. Marina says, worth a shot. But I had other issues with this plan, no. Involving Robb and Home is already pushing it. But involving unrelated Humans. I am drawing a line there. They both find my rejection sudden. So I lay it out properly, you realize we asking to investigate a huge portion of innocent people. Home is different, they are group of people who know about our existence, and Medrones are more or less aware of them. But letting other Humans know about us, that is cause for major trouble.

Marina says, shoot. I didn't think about others. You think if we let other people investigate they might find about Medrones. I answer, its not might. Most definitely. A comprehensive background check. Even if they decompartmentalize their intel, someone will see something they shouldn't have. An injury healed in weeks rather than months. Or not eating the same things as humans. We are putting a microscope on their lives. I understand the importance of finding the culprit. But we did this and if it ever came out we dug up people's privacy. I can't imaging the scandal we face.

Catherine sighs, that will be a disaster. Marina says, so no involving other party into our midst. But you know, there is some group there we can still involve. I ask, within David's criminal gang. How. She says, I don't know if you know, but David's put up a five Millon dollar bounty on Ryes. And those people know about us, or at least aware of our existence. Maybe its relatively safer to involve them. I shout, are you kidding me. He did what. Catherine asks when did he do that. Marina says, I think before he came back after his overseas trip last week.

I always wondered how less vocal he was about Ryes. He caused a lot of hurt to his, and our reputation. Actually, he did more of a physiological assault on David. I say, is that why he isn't doing anything major. Marina nods, its because he already made arrangements. You gotta love his precise and ruthless attack. By now I think even Citradel would be aware such a price is made on their former chancellor. You guys really didn't know. I scoff, I had no idea. Catherine says, news to me too. Marina smiles, guess I am special. She really likes to rub it in. I had a concern that's been there with me for a while, did he tell you what he plans to do with Ryes if he ever found him.

Marina shrugs, that's something even I am clueless. Before his radical treatment, I assumed it would be anywhere from interrogation to negotiation. But now, given his new proclivities to certain things. I don't have the slightest idea. Her concern was mine now. I hadn't thought of what he might do now. I don't believe he would do anything radical, now that he is free from his trauma. And yet I can't say he wouldn't have a grudge. Catherine asks, guys. Lets trust him. I know he had changed, but its still him. I guess she would know the most out of us. Marina says, yeah. Let me talk to him tonight when I meet him. Is that okay with you Blake.

I take a moment to think about the risks. If David has is own group of people who can investigate a important person as Ryes. I have to believe they are somewhat trustworthy to keep whatever information they find restrictive. I ask, yeah. You can ask if he can allow investigation of normal people. But let me talk to him before we hand him the list. I want to asses the risk with him. That's what we all agreed for now. Catherine says, just to remind you all, what I find, I follow. You do the same. I wasn't really happy with this disjoint investigation routes, but its proven to be effective. And most of all, it protects Catherine from being targeted.

We conclude the meeting with a few follow ups. Marina left for an early lunch so that she could get to the construction site. Catherine asks me a moment alone, I wanted to explain myself. She is probably referring to her visit with Robb. I wasn't really in the mood to listen to her gallivanting date. I say, like I said. I heard nothing. You don't have to explain anything to me. She doesn't let it go, I am so sorry. I know it seems like I ditched you without even asking for permission. I wanted to talk to you before I left. But my head was in different places at once. I just didn't want you to get angry with me.

Her aura showed she feels very guilty about it. I don't know how to assure her I wasn't angry. Because, truth be told. I did feel annoyed at her. But David and I promised to keep our opinions to minimum. I tell her, I was a surprised. Not mad though. Never. Just worried about you. That was true. When Vanessa I shouldn't have let her leave alone, I personally agreed with her. If only someone trustworthy was there, who could keep an eye on her. At one time I thought I should go myself. But that was just a silly thought. She says, its okay if you were though. I was selfish. I am not going to deny how wrong I was.

I tell, you got back safely. That's all that matters. But I hope next time, you at least tell me in advance. I would feel less anxious about your safety. She feels even more guilty on her impromptu departure. I couldn’t tell her how, but I was thinking of assigning a Shadow to tail her. To think a Shadow spy would be tailing someone of the family who had that Shadow role for centuries. The irony would be enough motivation for that individual for this challenge. She speaks in a low voice, I will. I promise. Hold on. That meant there will more times like this. Argh. I didn't realize it until she just said it. I was so worried for her, that I didn't get what that really meant.

That wrapped me different kind of emotion. Jealously. Just what does she see in that Human. Do they really expect that they can keep this facade. Catherine picks on my frustration. She says, you are upset. I can tell. I don't expect you to understand me. I sometimes think I don't even understand myself. I should tell her I wasn't angry at her. But then I would be lying. I rather keep my mouth shut than say something wrong. Catherine says, I won't let this get in the way of my job again. Believing I wasn't onboard of her, she starts to assure me with promises. I feel a little tricked. Does she really want me to accept this crazy arrangement.

Things took even a crazy turn when she told about setting up a personal link with Robb. I held out my annoyance so that she doesn't think I was getting in the way of her relationship. I should have said this is unacceptable. Its definitely some sort of violation. But instead I said, that’s good. A balance in life is important. I decided to go with a lame comment. Even she realized I was just trying to appear polite to her, I shouldn't have said that. Again, I am so sorry. I am going to try and limit it once or twice a week. I almost said not to do it all. Aside from the obvious dangers, why she want to torture herself like this. Is this long distance relationship going to work as she hopes.

I may have not been the most appreciate of her efforts. Because she soon ends the conversation and leaves. I actually felt a relief from not showing the irritation. I had a lot to say to her, but David pretty much covered everything we had to say to her. I need a distraction. I went to Tina's officer and ask for the latest update on the public transport upgrade. She shows a report of the progress, which was at 25 %. The same as yesterday night, which she pointed out specifically to me. I can't tell her I was just stopping by to get my mind off things. Then Luther joins in and gives reports on the other infrastructure.

After hearing the report I ask, when will they be ready with the demo houses and buildings. Luther looks at his notes, Ivan gave a timeline of 10 days. Maybe 8 even if they sort out their problem with enriching Kuretine with the foundations. Said something about the levels in the ground more than anticipated. Tina asks, is that bad. Luther says, on the contrary. They say it's actually good news. But they have to adjust for it perpetually. I say, the ambient Kuret is flowing gradually becoming stronger around the island. Luther nods, that’s what they said. They think the tournament influenced it. With so many Medrones fighting, it behaved like an epi center.

Tina says, I thought that was just a theory. People can't really influence the island. She turns to me, can we? I answer, those scientist think we do. Even I am skeptical about that. Lets leave that to the experts. But if this is happening sooner than we thought, we should prepare for it. I remember on Medrine that whenever we flip a new land, there are sometimes unexpected stuff. Like a deposit of Kuritine or wild Kuretine vegetation. I don't know how that manifest on Earth. Tina says, for real. Luther says, I am sure Ivan's team are aware of it too. But I will mention it next time we meet.

We cover the rest of the development progress. We have gotten off course with our projected timelines. It was to be expected with the delayed start. We are soon going to have to prepare more teams to work on the expansion plan. The we move on to last priority, security. Tina says, R & D received their first batch of drones today. David supposed to give a demo to Nathan and Frank tonight. Ruther is acting as liaison for IDF with them for immediate use by IDF. Luther asks me, how is he doing by the way. I hate to ask, but is his training going well? I felt a hint of suspicion from him. I guess even they heard about the gossip from people.

Tina laughs, he really has changed. I know people are saying that, but I really think he has turned over something. I have always seen him serious or secretive. But now, having women over his place. Someone's enjoying their fame. Luther says, its true what people say, being famous changes you. I would argue that David is simply taking advantage of this brief time of popularity. But I can't deny he is not shying away anymore. I answer, I couldn't get an answer from my last session with him. Regardless, of whether its true or not. He had to be enjoying the attention. Tina says, I heard some girls are hoping to lucky next. I just hope David doesn't get notoriety from this.

For the second time I am a slightly jealous. Many people are making their opinions of him. Some are still bad, but most of them are in positive light. And I hate this feeling even more. Because I personally know how dedicated he is to his training. I know this is probably a stunt to maintain an image for the people. But I still couldn't fell envious of him. He is juggling a lot of things on his hands, and yet finds time to somehow involve with others. Ah, I did it again. Made it about Catherine again. I need to learn to let it go. Catherine is happy, that should be all that matters to me.

We went for lunch after our discussion. There we met with IDF team. Ruther was every excited with tonight's demonstration. Sommers asks, how much longer for it to be operational. Any idea. Ruther replies, I am guessing about a week. We only got about 100 today. And we only start with 20 or so. That depends on it goes with Nathan. I ask, I will be there as well. I have a just a brief experience with that drones. I am curious to see them in action. Ruther says, you and Marina. She was the first one to sign up for checking it out. Like I had a way to stop her. A laughter erupted among us.

The topic naturally went over to the mysterious women leaving David's house. A lot of blatant speculation were made. June says David tried to score and failed. While Sommers said she probably just ran away in the middle after seeing the weird tech he has in his house. I don't know he learnt about the killer bots in his house. Actually, that is very possible. Deni says she heard David tried to stop the women, but was stalled by few others. They also asked me, much to my disdain. I had to explain again that he didn't tell me anything. We were just focused on our usual drill.

I wonder what Vanessa would think of all this. She has been very subdued lately. Distracted and confused. When I asked about it yesterday, she said, just dealing a lot of pressure at work. I can only hope that’s the case. Unless David told her the truth about her brother. I don't think he would do that, but that’s the only thing I believe would make her so crestfallen. Well, that and her problems with Robb. People still walking on egg shells around the sore topic. Even the new officers like June knows things are shaky between them. I can't handle another omega relationship problem. I just hope its not that and some other reason. Regardless, she is doing her job properly. At least that’s going on for her. No one is really complaining. Unlike some other omega who just abandoned us for a day. Ah, shit. I can't keep bringing her into every thought I have.

We spent the rest of the afternoon with our usual work. I worked through most of them. When the clock hit 6:00, I decided to finish the rest tomorrow. It was the demonstration time. It's at the R & D HQ. Luther decides to stay back. So only Tina and I went. On the way we met up with Catherine and Jess. Catherine and I remained awkward even after all her apologies. I wish we could go back the way we were. But it feels like a delicate wall has broken between us. And now all the nasty feelings I was avoiding is flooding in. Thankfully, I remained civil in the group. As we crossed the HQ gate, I spot Ivans team. We chatted a bit about the demo and its expectation. They were the most hyped people among the officers.

Soon Luther strolls out with Nathan and Frank from the building. Nathan says, evening everyone. We are just finishing up setting up the demo. I am going to ask you to move towards the eastside, the yard. We have setup a temporary viewing station. People hustle to the other side of the building and gather around a barricade. David was already there, working busy with the a group of lab geeks. They had dozens of monitors and machines setup. Frank explains to us that their software's are being programmed to be run on their own dedicate AI. I recall they have their own version of AI like M. Though theirs is more focus driven on Medrone technology.

Soon Marina also joined us, hey guys. Anything I missed. I gestured her to the people at the side of the building still working. She sighs, still not done yet. Lets checkout those puppies out. While we waited for their preparation, we were allowed to see the spherical drones on the ground. People seems unimpressed by the ball of steel at first. But I remember how crazy fast and versatile they were. Marina tells other, don't be fooled by its appears. Once we were entrapped by these drones. Though, if I wanted to, I could have crushed them away without breaking a sweat. She somehow boasts both the tech and herself.

She wasn't wrong though, they don't feel intimidating enough to be a big threat. Like David told us before, they are recon drones with limited fire power. Soon the rest of the IDF officers arrive. So we should be getting started soon. I caught Vanessa looking somehow even more distracted today. He aura is fluctuating a lot wilder. I hoped nothing serious happened so I approached her, Vanessa. Are you okay. You seem more anxious than before. She sighs, sorry. I just had an expected visitor a while ago. Its nothing you have to worry about. I ask, are you sure. I don't mean to pry, but I am a little worried about you. She says, I appreciate the concern. But seriously, its fine.

She then looks at the direction of David. She says, has he been here all this time. I nod, I heard since 4:00. Why, did he do something again. She scoffs, maybe. I don't understand what she means by that. I don't think he told her about her brother. I don't think he even talked to her recently. So maybe it was about something else. I had a hunch, so I ask her, do you know who that women was at his place yesterday. She turns a grim on that question. I think I need to back off now. Her aura felt unpredictable right now. As long as she not makes any scene with David, I don't want to get in middle of them. I have enough drama of my own to deal with.

Few minutes later, we get an announcement from Nathan, thank you all for waiting. We are ready. He gestures to Frank and David. He then points to the spheres on the ground, first of all. Let me be clear. This tech is technically classified as a fusion between Hive transfigurable material and Earth's micro technology. Those of you who want to know more of the technical details, feel free to ask as after this. As you know, we have been trying to reverse engineer Hive tech. We haven't had much succuss in that research. But thanks to a certain celebrity, we have a better chance. I am going to spare you all the details on he got Humans to work on this. Needless to say, its highly experimental.

All of the scientist had their eyes on the prize on the ground. Nathan continues talking about some high level functionalities. I followed most of them, but some were very technical. He spent quiet some time on the theoretical aspects. Naturally, his words was targeted at the scientists who were the best people to understand its potential. The last part was about repurposing with Kuretine tech. He underlines the unique challenge to achieve it, but also the incredible benefits when we do figure it out. Our warfare capability will drastically change. We lost a significant portion of Medrines science and tech, and on top of that, we have even less people with the right skills. This will balance the scale.

He concludes, what we need is firepower. Hive will be back, and this time we have to be ready for them. Lets hope this gets us better chance to fight them off. His passionate words amassed a lot of appreciations from the crowd. Many applauded, leaving the scientist excited more than ever. He gestures, so lets get started. David, its your stage. David swaps in Nathans place on the pavement. He says, hello everyone. Lets dive in to the highly anticipated part of the evening. And at any time, if you have questions, I will answer them to best of my knowledge. Marina didn't even hesitate with her question, who's the girl at your place. Everyone wants to know.

Leave it her to ask outrageous questions at such a time. But people found her hysterical and brief wave of laughs flow in the crowd. David's gives us a wide grin, well, Marina, I would tell, but for the life of me, I don't know what you are talking about. He is overtly stating he won't reveal who it was. That didn't discourage Marina even a bit. She just gives him a subtle nod signaling she will continue that later. David says, gross invasion of privacy aside, I like to point out few things about how I use these tech. As you already heard, the tech name is aptly labeled as ART. Though, unlike the name its not completely a reconfigurable matter.

A scientist asks, we inspected the designs earlier, some of there core parts are not transfigurable. David nods, yes. Unlike Hives pure programmable matter, we can't really achieve the same level. What it means that there are restrictions to the tech. There are ways to circumvent the issues, like designing the core parts to the objective you want. Case in point, these spheres that you see here. These are the lowest level my team could achieve. He gestures to Frank, who punches in on the computer. The spheres roar to life as they begin to levitate in the air. Out of the 10, three of them reveal a weird shaped gun. That’s what Marina and I back at the cliff.

The three sphere scurry off fast, circling around the crowd with speed. After showing its speed, the trio spheres speed off towards the model of a few dummy Medrones. They fire the guns, which turned out to be concentrated laser blasts. With precision and different angles, they tore through the iron molted dummies in just 6 shots. Then they hover around another dummy, to which they zap it with a thin electrified net, presumably for capturing target. For the last dummy, the spheres shift their weapons into a sort of sphere. With those pointed ends, just one sphere was enough to ram it through it, leaving behind a decapitated dummy from the middle.

The crowd applauds after witnessing their capabilities. David speaks up while the spheres swing back onto the ground, as you can see. They are fast, coordinated, and precise. But they have limited firepower, only enough to subdue smaller targets. Because, as impressive they are, they aren't strong enough for targets that can fight back. They so have excellent coordination capability. For that reason, they have a much better usefulness. Next three drone activate. Unlike the previous one, they immediately transform, one changes into a large bird. But not the Earth bird, it turned into a Medrone bird that had Kuritine features.

People gasp at its appearance. I can't remember what this bird was called, but I am sure they are extinct now. The bird flaps its wings and soars through the sky. The next one turns into a four legged Medrone dog. I remember this animal, Lymons. We had a flock of them at our homes. Excellent guard dogs. Like Earth dogs, they had a excellent sense of Kuret smells. The ART Lymon starts to run around the group. Marina crouches down and tried to pet it. But the Lymon snaps and bares its teeth to her. She jerks, hey. Its not at all friendly. But then it moves towards Deni, who it just snugs around her feet. She hesitantly tries to pet at its head, which it liked so much it starts to wag its tail.

Marina snaps, what. You have bug in the software. David laughs, maybe it just doesn’t like people who stuck their nose in other people's business. That made her give a infuriating chuckle. He says, you can customize your targets

threat capability and make them behave appropriately. That cocky guy must have programmed to do this specifically for her. The last drone turns into a fish, this one was a normal Earth fish. The fish suddenly flies off in the air and dips into a miniature pond at the edge of the yard. Sommers ask, a flying fish. That’s like some fantasy game or shit like that. The fish swims normally in the water. Nathan smirks, don't get fooled by their appearance.

Ivan says, that’s right. They may look like animals, but there machines. They don't have the biological features, but they mimic them to hide their propulsion thrusts. David nods, yup. The bird that flew, it can fly without moving its wings, no problem at all. But it will no doubt be unrealistic and stand out immediately. What you is see an reactive behaviors. These drones can be deployed in civilian population for day to day surveillance. These don't have a lick of combat capability. And unfortunately, can't be programmed to other species. You can maybe change their colors, texture, body frames, and certain extraneous features. However, their core skeleton remains the same.

A scientists asks, what is the blocking for a free transformation. David says, their engine drives. At the moment, Hive is only one who can somehow change their energy into matter, and then change back to energy. That is too advance for us. And for Humans, he scoffs, its close to science fiction. Maybe you can figure out a way to change with some Kuritine type energy. That sparked a few hushed conversation among the scientists. People broke into groups to inspect the three surveillance animals. While they appear to react like animals, they had sensors and cameras working all the time. The bird was able to capture pics of people on the ground from high above. The fish had a radar and sonar. The Lymon had thermal imaging and far off audio listening capabilities.

Nathan gives us explanation how they can be modified to detect Kurets too. But that’s a far off future development. Ivan was more interested about its current usefulness. Since they don't have any Medrine tech, they aren't influenced by Kuret or vice versa. So they are already perfect as it is for some of the objectives we want right now. Soon we come to last four remaining drones. David says, these aren't configured for contain or ground surveillance. These are completely for stealth. The drones didn't change their shape, instead they went invisible. Audible gasps can be heard from people. I was not expecting this to happen. Like many, I looked around to notice there whereabouts.

But not even a sound was heard. Suddenly Marina shouts, I got one. She had a charm opened on one hand and viewing through the surroundings with it. David says, I guess its not really effective against certain brunets. Marina stands tall and proud. David gestures, what about the others though. Marina looked around, but she didn't find the others. Meanwhile, Frank brought a laptop that was linked to the drone. It was a shot of us from high above, which slowly zooms in closer to the ground. Marina turns her charms to the sky, but she still couldn't find it. David says, they are near the edge of the barrier. And sure, given time you may be able to pin point their position.

Marina sighs, but I can't really do anything about it. Unless I do this, she throws a super fast thin blast towards a direction. Like a homing missile, it locked on to the nearest drone position. Its too far off to see, but I could see the aura of Marina's Kuret. Its hits something and dissipates at impact. Frank shows a footage from a different drone that showed the collision. Marina's Kuret didn't even hit the drone. The drone has a thin red laser grid surrounding itself. Ivan asks, there is some sort of protective field around it. David explains, it’s a magnetic field running along a laser grid. Marina says, I have to say its impressive. There is not even a scratch on it. David points to the drones above, of course if she had hit up close, it would be destroyed. Its strength lies in the distance. It can fly about to a mile and half outside a targets range.

David tells, Instead of zero combat capabilities, I designed for operational oversight. Nathan says, its actually a clever system. Instead of letting the other bots rely on self governance, these bots coordinate the ART tech. They are the brains of the system. They fly above us, in completely hidden from sight. And have a complete picture of the target. Frank hits a button and it shows a topological grid view of the HQ. Even circles around the people and the ART bots lying on the ground right now. Frank says, David had an idea to turn into a sort of an mini satellite for the island. Which is a daunting challenge, but very crucial.

Jess asks, this is good for security and all. But isn't it a bit too intrusive. What about privacy and sensitive things people don't want seen. Nathan agrees with her, naturally we need a balance of that. We haven't even begin the planning stage, but this was already an argument we have to address. Of course, by the time this tech is progressed enough to be deployed, we will have to have some rules. I nod, like surveilling only pubic areas. Nathan smirks, more like restricting homes, private institutions or businesses. With this tech, restricting much easier than focusing on selective targets. I guess he had a point.

Tessa asks, can they be utilized in the ocean too. Nathan turns to David for that question. David says, the accuracy drops by 30 %. But yeah, they are fully functional. Like Nathan said, they are the controlling mechanisms for any underwater ART marina bots. I have been using them personally for my. He halts for a moment, never mind that. Like Vanessa wanted, the border security will greatly benefit from this tech. Vanessa says, good. We are struggling to keep up the defense tight right now. The four bots descend back down and people inspect them much closer. I place my hand over the invisible field. David warns, careful. Better to use your Kuret.

Without my Kuret, I would definitely get hurt. I wrap my elbow with Kuret and field. The field glowed red against my blue Kuret. It tried to push me back, but I held enough power that I was able to dig though the barrier without much resistance. Marina followed suit and got through in faster than me. Tessa, Vanessa, June and Sommers. They got through as well. The rest couldn't. If they really tried to cut through, they could, but that would mean more Kuret or weapons. Suffice to say these drone had the strongest defense system. I ask, what about Hive. Are they effective against them.

I am sure others wondered the same. Because while this is impressive, its not effective until its against Hive. David smiles goes away, unfortunately, I can only tell you about simulation probability wins. There is no way to test it against real Hive forces. The only thing we can do is prepare for any and all type of eventualities. Nathan says, that’s the down side. We can test it all day, but never be sure about it against Hive. But, who knows. If they ever come down knocking at our doorstep in a small, isolated and testable condition. We might try it against them. He spoke like they were control subjects, which is highly unlikely to ever happen in reality.

After a bit of more technical talk, David gathers everyone, there are hundreds of vulnerabilities and issues. However, you can realize their benefits are high too. Nathan chips in, once we fit it with Kuretine tech, we will a version suited to our needs. The drones then drop dead with the rest of the them on the ground. Marina asks with enthusiasm, this is not everything. Is there. Get those killer robots out, already. I have been dying to see it again. Her excitement, reignited peoples curiosity.

David replies with a big smile, all right. Lets move on to the real fun part.

Vanessa (Chapter 114)

Sunday, March 15, 2026 11:59

Last few days I have been able to focus on much. I do my work diligently, but I can't seem to enjoy it like I used to. Every now and then my thoughts would inevitability fall back to Ned. His confession, the actual reason for the fight still makes me wonder how I missed it. Maybe I did know, but just assumed he was fine. During the flag capture game, he was a bit more agonistics to David. He said it was just because they were direct competitors that time. But maybe it was more than that. Honestly, I mad at myself for not seeing it. David and I have been getting closer together this year. Any guy would be jealous of his girlfriend be spending time with another guy.

He has to know there is nothing going on between us. But if I am being honest, I feel conflicted. Was it easier for me to be angry at Ned than to reconcile with him. All because of an unreasonable excuse I was making about not taking my side. I have been questioning a lot ever since Ned told me that. He told me he loves me. But I couldn't say it back. And he knows that. The guilt is eating me up. Why couldn't I tell him back. Why couldn't I just forgive him. It was never about him not trusting me. I selfishly believed it was about me. Just like what I have been doing with David.

Arg, this is giving me a headache. I drank water from the glass at my desk. The officers building right now are buzzing with people in the hallway. In 4 hours, there is going to be some a demo at R & D HQ. Not many are invited, but that didn't stop them from approaching me and get a pass. I put my foot down explaining its not a tech exposition. They will be shown when Blake and I are ready for it go public. If people knew that it was Human and Hive tech, it would create a long unending debate amongst people. Scientific progress vs the morality and pride. We don't have time for people to be nit picky about how we fight our wars.

Sommer tells, that’s the latest on the latest arrest. We recovered something called Goya from their house. Hidden inside a the basement wall. Its a painting of some war with a guy named Napolean. I groaned a little, I still have no idea what its about. Sommers says, me too. But Deni almost fainted when an officer accidently dropped it. So no doubt very valuable. Its not that I don't appreciate art, but I don't have the same passion as others. But I didn't need to know the history to understand its value. If its old, its vital to Human history. And its best for everyone if we treat it with the respect it deserves.

Sommers asks, David hasn't visited the IDF storage vault. When is he planning to see the artifacts. I scoff, knowing him. He probably has already seen it. I won't be surprised if he checked it after that dinner meeting. He laughs, you might be right about that. Tonight, we will see what this artifacts buys us. For many people who haven't seen David's tech, it’s the first time. I seen a glimpse of that back at his house. I didn't get a good look at it, but even I am intrigued by this. Sommers leaves for IDF while I stayed here to deal with some of my work.

An hour later I hear a knock at my door. I reply, I am busy. Come back after the break. I had a deadline to finish tonight and can't really accommodate others right now. There is another knock, followed by an officer saying, sorry chief. But there is someone here who wants to speak to you. Says its urgent. I think you know her, names Elina. Her name surprised me. What's she doing here. Didn't she have a routine check for tomorrow. But Sommers is in charge of that. I reply back, Sommers went back to IDF. Tell her to meet him there. He replies, got it. I thought that would be the end of it. But he comes back with another knock, she says she is here for you.

I don't have time for this. But if she is being persistent about it, it might be some kind of emergency. I tell him, tell her to meet me here in 30 minutes. I will be taking a break then. He leaves to convey my answer. He didn't approach me again, so I guess either she left or is waiting. Either way I wrapped up my work by then. I opened the door and see Elina sitting at the hallway end couch. She wore a blazer and jeans. She really waited for me. Must be really important. I gesture at her to come on in. She notices me and frantically walks in my office. She says, thank you Vanessa. I am so glad I could meet you.

I reply, hey Elina. She takes the chair opposite to mines. She seems troubled a little, almost anxious. I ask, is everything all right. That forces her to settle down a bit, yeah. I mean, no. Not really. Its been tough this two weeks. I can only imagine the duress she is under. I ask, and Ryan. Is he doing better. He nods, much better. The other day he finally talked to his friends. Though he couldn't tell why he was away. So he is still upset. I say, but I heard you are helping him lot. His is lucky to have a sister like you. She makes a nervous giggle, yeah. Lucky him. I couldn't put my finger on it, but she acting very suspicious.

I ask, so, what can I do for you. You have any new information for us. I guessed she would approach me directly only if she had something to offer. Instantly she begins to freak out. Nervously fidgeting with her hands, even a makes a very somber face. I lean in a little worried, did something happen. She isn't able to for any coherent words. She is really struggling to say something. The curiosity was eating me up. I had no choice for her to speak up. After what seemed like a heavy silent minute, she blurts out, ah, freak this. I can't do it. I thought I can do it. The lying has to stop. I ask, what are you talking about. What lies.

Then she told her biggest regret. With every word she said, my anger rose up. I can't believe I ever felt pity to her. She covered up her own crimes and has the gall to walk in here. Her face is buried in the ground all the while she explains her how she covered for Peter. I almost loose it when I hear she even stole the missing ledger. I kept my anger in check. But that didn't stop my words, you are a piece of work. Aren't you. I defended you. Gave others my recommendation that you were innocent. I even tried to release your assets, so you get can get your life back. I can't believe you were in on it from the beginning.

Her voice is breaking when she looks up, I am so sorry. I never imagined this would have happened. I would have never done it otherwise. I scoff, people rarely know what their actions leads to. Do you have any idea what you have done. You covered up a massive smuggling operation. You nearly died because of your own selfishness. I shake my head, you have no idea what you could have avoided if you had reported it in. Elina begins to lightly sob. I shout, don't even try to gain for any sympathies. I am fresh out. I feel like a fool for the all the times I believed her. Even when many believed she wasn't just the victim, I kept the hope she was innocent.

My fury boils on how naïve I was. Elina speaks, I can't apologies enough. I don’t know what happened because of me. He didn't tell me anything. But I understand that my actions have hurt others. I ask, him. Who? Peter. Or you partner in crime Wayn. She cuts me off, I have no connection to that freaker. Believe me. I said aloud, I don't believe anything you say now. How can I. You have been lying to everyone for months. I don't care for your personal reasons. Whether it was for Ryan or your ambitions. You made a mockery of me. I am done listening to you.

I got up, I am going to drag your ass to jail myself. You might run away. Elina breakdown horrified at my response. What did she expect I was going to do. Forgive her. She shouts, please. Before you do anything, give me a minute to explain. I heard enough, I don't care. I walk around the table and grab her by the arm. She panics and yell, please. I want to make things right with you. I beg you, just give a chance. If you don't think its enough, I will go with you. I deserve any punishment you give. More tears roll down her face. I want to believe this is not an act. But I didn't have a shred of trust in her. But there must be something she has of value that made her confess to me.

With an arduous effort, I let get of her arm. I tell her, you have 5 minutes. If I don't like what you have to say. I am taking your ass. She nods and blurts out everything she knows. I slump back in my chair as she cries and tells me what her plan was. No, theirs. David finally fessed up and told her how he has been semi stalking her. She wails explaining he wants to help her. She sniffs, he made a plan. A plan to leverage my freedom for the ledger. It was so good that I honestly thought I could do it. But. Looks away in shame, I couldn't go through with it. I thought I can. But not anymore, because you still believed I was innocent.

I should feel pity for her, getting wrapped up with David's scheme. But something is not sitting right with me. I ask, I don't understand you. You know who David is now. He might be a world class jerk, but he is a bonified genius. If he says he had a plan to get you out of trouble. Why in the hell did you throw it away. She faces me back again, because I can't look at myself anymore. David made me feel I could do it. And until now, I thought I could do it. But lies got in into this, and I can't keep lying anymore. That was her limit, huh. Or wait. Maybe this was what David planned all along. I ask her, this is all him. Isn't it. He manipulated you into confessing. And wants me to get forgive you. That is not happening.

Elina replies, no. He said that I shouldn't mention his name or the his plan. Just about leveraging the ledger. I scoff, you poor pathetic girl. He are playing right into his hands. For the first time Elina gets angry, stop it. Its not his fault. I am amazed how gullible she is. She says while wiping away her tears, I had a lot of time thinking about it. He didn't need to have to tell me anything. But he did. And you are right about him getting his way. But he promised me it wasn't about him. He even forced me to agree to few conditions. I wasn't buying any of it. But then I realized how overzealous I always am in prosecuting him.

I hate it, but I think I am just letting my frustration at him because of what Ned said to me. I take a beat and pull back my emotions. Maybe I should listen to her first. I ask her, what were his conditions. Turns out I really jumped the gun. I thought David was just using Elina, maybe even trying to win her over in some sort of sick sadistic way. But when Elina pulls out the deed to her shop, my anger subsided. I have seen enough of Elina's interrogation to know that the only thing beside her love for Ryan, is her bar. She says, I tainted something I love with selfish desire. I can't in good conscious work there anymore.

I had to be a tactic. A ploy to gain enough sympathy from me. Especially since I couldn't read the dead myself and confirm if its real. She slides it to me, you can check with others. I am giving it up. I even locked the bar. She fishes out a key from her jacket and puts it on top of the paper stack. This seems more and more real now. I pick up the key and its exactly the one we gave her back when we released her. I ask, are you serious about this. She nods, I am. Its the right thing to do. I don't know about that, but this decision is something she didn't make her own. David really put her up to this.

Then she told the other condition. Meeting me and confessing her involvement. I listen to her reasons in confusion. David thought if I ever heard that if he was involved, I wouldn't believe anything. What's even worse is that, he is right. I am questioning everything ever since she told it was their plan. She is trying to justifying her actions to me. She says, like he said, I don’t want to rely on just his methods. But couldn't go through with his plan. Maybe I really shouldn't have told you everything. But, like I said. I am done lying. I just want to sleep peacefully at night, without looking over my shoulder.

I ask her, even if that means you don't get to be with Ryan. Because that’s what you have done. You could have stick the plan. She says, I don't know what's right. I only know what's wrong. I want you to trust me. I just didn't want to do that with more lies. If that costs me Ryan. She takes a short breath, so be it. I am begging you to please forgive me. But I will not be angry at you if you decide to still arrest me. I don’t have the right. At this point I think she is telling me the truth. I have seen her playing the victim before. But this time, its different. It feels more real. In the back of my mind, I still think this a way to get me to pity her.

But she is going against David plan. That strangely makes me want to believe her more. Where does that leaves me. I should arrest her. But she is ready to give up her life she built here. And, like she pointed out. It was Karma that she nearly died because she covered up for the very people who nearly killed her. If David had never met her, she be dead because of her own fault. A poetic justice. Ah, this is so damn infuriating. She says, please. Give me another chance. Don't you have regrets that you wish you can be forgiven for. I have plenty, but I wonder what she knows. I ask, what did he say about me.

She shakes her head, he didn't tell me anything. Just that you are willing to at least understand me, if not forgive me. I don't understand him. First he tells his secret to her and then makes her confess to me. He could have told her about my own crimes. She could have appealed that I had made far worse mistakes. But he didn't reveal any of that. Just convinced her without it. Her snuffed cries still echo in my silent office. I stare at the key and paper stack, I don't know what to do with you. Maybe this does balance out what you did. But asking me cover up this is incredibly arrogant of you both. What if I said that I will take it to Blake or others to decide what happens to you.

She gives a disappointed smile, I already told you. I will be fine with whatever you want. She looks away, I thought I need to be there for Ryan no matter what. But I never thought what happened to him because of me. He could have died at the treatment plant. The only reason he was there because Peter brought us. Which I could have avoided from the beginning. Maybe Ryan will forgive me for being so selfish, but I will never. So I am prepared to do whatever I can to make this right. I really want to believe her. After listing to the fake plan of theirs, she did held some merit. She wasn't really involved in the crime, only hiding her brothers sketchy business.

I was ready to blame her for all the things Wyan did. However, now that I have calmed down. I don't think she is responsible for everything. She made a choice to protect her family, her life she built. I know what's that's like. And no has really died due to this. At least not that we know of. Can she really be blamed for it if there were any. Like she said to me just now, she isn't a warrior, just a girl who made a really stupid mistake. I sigh, I need to talk to him. I don't know what I will do. But I know that I won't do anything until I speak with him. Elina nods and turns grim, I understand. But, are you going to tell him I told the truth.

This is so weird. She is scared of me, and yet she scared of him knowing she didn't follow the plan. Did they get bond over this. Then it hits me, hold on. Last night there was a rumor of a girl leaving his place. Was that you. When I heard it this morning, I immediately scrapped it from my thought. David maybe be many things, but he is wimp when it comes to this. He had a chance with Sophie, and he didn't take it. But maybe after his Ketriya, he has changed too much. Elina yells, nothing happened between us. I just wanted to talk to thank him. And it turned out very differently. And by the time we decided to call it night, people were outside his place.

She really was there. There sudden closeness is alarmingly suspicious. That photo of hers was taken to look like she had sex. This brought up a whole new wave of emotions within me. Elina saw through me, I swear. Nothing happened. It was the only way I could think of to get away. I didn't want to do it, but I had no choice. And he was more than happy to make people believe it was true. I didn't realize it, but I was extremely furious at him for taking advantage of a vulnerable women. But maybe they didn't do anything. It took a while for me simmer down from the shock.

I tell her, just leave. Go home and stay there until I figure what to do with you. I have her an order which she can't disobey. I haven't made any decision, but I rather not have her tell people about David. Elina stands up with a pale face, okay. I won't leave my home. She turns her back to me and walks away completely drained of life. Before she leaves, she stops for second, I apologies for all trouble I have caused. With that goodbye she steps out through the door. This is mess I seriously didn't want or need right now. I open my phone and send a pic of the deed to Luther. Let me first confirm that this is a not a forgery.

I tried to resume my work, but Elina's pleas occupied my mind. She may have not done it out of malice or greed. But its impossible for me to take a decision. I wish I can include others to help me figure out what to do. I spent the next hour reviewing the interrogations from Elina, Peter, Ryan and Wyan. I had already done this before, but with this truth I am looking for any collusion between Elina and any other member of the smugglers. So far I didn't find any connection, nor did Roland's and Tessa's assessments suggested anything out of the ordinary. Its fair to say they don't have any direct dealings.

Just before I got ready to leave for the R & D demo, I got a message from Luther. I heard his analysis and confirmed that it was the original document with real signature. He asked why its with me. I didn't want to lie to him, so I replied back saying Elina contacted me to discuss something. I told him that I might have a way find the ledger. That was the extent to which I can reveal things to him. I put the deed and the key in my safe. It would have been much easier if that document was fake. While heading back, I met up with the rest of the IDF people. Everyone were eager to checkout the demonstration, while I was yet again distracted.

We arrived on time and most people had already arrived. When Blake asked me if I was okay, I was really tempted to tell him about Elina. But then I saw David and decided to play it off. It feels weird that he is causally working with Frank while also imploding other people lives. When the event started, I brought my focus on assessing the tech. I was secretly hoping David tanks the demo. It would be a satisfying revenge to see his inventions fail. I chided myself at that thought all the time. Just how much petty can I behave. The fact that tech were very impressive were making me irrationally frustrated. I had to reluctantly agree about their usefulness.

One the sphere drones demo was done, he brough out a new bot. This one was different than the one I saw at his house. He says, meet ART bots. Two bots came from out from under a tent. They had square heads, two camera eye sockets with hour long metal arms. Theor bottom were half leg, half wheels. This one had a bulky frame and more equipped with different weapons. David explains, these are secondary combat bots. Or I S bots for short. These combat abilities are superior to the drones. The bots weapons transform into different weapons, a sword, gun, shield, flamethrower, emp, rifles and even a freaking bazooka. Their artilleries are anything compatible, from normal human weapons to sophisticated bombs.

People were completely enthralled with the capability of these bots. I was impressed by the implosion blasts and electrified ropes. Even just one of them might give the run for a money against a normal Medrone. David says, again. Warriors can take them out. Though I not without some risks. To show his point, one bot throws one laser blast, that tore through the same dummy from begore in one go. Marina says, jeez. That’s what was pointed at us that time. She laughs thinking about the their encounter. Ivan asks, and they run on the same energy? Another scientist asks, how do you account for the increase in heat dissipation and intra surface area stability when you scale up the energy distribution. Ivan asks, is it linear or non-linear.

Neither Nathan or Frank had an answer. They turns to David. David squints his right eye like he is trying hard to answer the question. Marina laughs, sorry guys. Those are some difficult questions. Not even he knows. She goads at a focused David. David didn't even respond to her. He thinks about it for a few seconds and says, there is an internal component which convert the excess energy into eddy currents. Those are nullified by a laminated magnetic ring component. The surface is specially designed to act as a kinetic absorbing material, to dissipate the friction and heat when changing form. The same technology DARPA uses is their sonic jets.

That answer went above all our heads. But the scientists seem to have understood and ask follow up questions. Marins bites her lips realizing she made a fool of herself. Oddly I understood how she felt, let it go Marina. You won't win against a scientific wits with him. She scoffs, I just need to try harder to knock his ego down a bit. Knowing she was only doing to having fun with him actually made me even more mad. I feel similar to when I was trying to expose Mack to Elina. The same petty grudges from the time I haggled him for his ART tech. I should have leant to out grow such childish feelings.

But Marina did get her wishes in the end. There were some very complex questions that not even David could answer, I have no clue how the non configurable components handle the energy spikes from the nano bots. How about we do this, I can't share the research. But maybe you can send me your questions and they might answer them. I don't think they will give away their secretes. But who knows, they might give some hints. One guy was already taking notes and videos with her Kuretine recorder. She says, that’s sounds like a wonderful idea. I will compile a list for you.

That eased up the hard questions from him. Marina laughs and points to him when he turns exhausted. He says, someone is having fun. She smiles, you finally tripped up. He sighs, my bad. I should have read the research once more. I will be more ready if it happens next time. He wasn't even bothered by her criticism. This left Marina a little irked. Their banter caused people to laugh at the two of them. He says, how about you checkout their non combat purposes. Blake asks, they have other uses. He nods, they are secondary bots. I have been exploring different applications.

To show his point, one bot begins wheels over to the lab setup and picks out a computer. Its hands turn into fingers like a persons and starts dismantling the computer in front of us. It was quiet a spectacle to see the bots arms coordinate so skillfully and with complete accuracy. Each arm screws out the bolts independently and yet coordinated with blinding skill. The whole computer is dissembled in pieces in minutes. Nathan says, whoa. You never told they are capable of delicate work like this. Everyone gawks at the bot as it begins to resemble it again. The reverse took a bit longer. But when the computer boots up normally, it shows its success.

Frank says, such meticulous work, its quite an efficient worker. Ivan asks, so it can be programmed to learn anything. David says, not anything. That feat may look impressive, but it took months to optimize it. There are many limitations. Ivan says, this will help us with some of critical Kuritine enrichment. He whispers something to a person beside him. David says, maybe. That’s up to you. I have been using them has house bots. I scoff thinking he is using lethal machines for chores. Nathan yells, seriously. What the freak man. Using Farari as a lawn mower.

David says, please. I have my things I find tedious. When I am too tired, it can cook for me. People mock at him as rants about food being his major problem. Even I found it amusing how our problem isn't his and the reverse is true as well. He says, and besides. I have another use for them. Without any hesitation, he pulls out the jacket and his shirt. People, especially women, stare at his bare chest. I would be lying if I wasn't among them. He turns his back and points to a faded stitch near his lower back, there are no surgeons in the city. Imagine how difficult it is for me to get patched up in hard to reach places.

He could have just said that, instead of stripping. He was aware of this and still enjoying himself. I think he just wanted to show off just to take even bigger spot light. When he wears his shirt back, I swear I heard Deni groaning. Argh, this is messing me up in ways I don't want to think about. If that wasn't enough, he wanted to show its even more meticulous movements. With a live performance for a tattoo. He asks around, any volunteer. How about you Marina. She scoffs, please. My skin is a temple. Sommers steps in, I'll do it. I wanted to have one for some time. Ruther slaps him on his back, you finally got the nerve to do this.

Frank brings in a chair and they quickly setup an open tattoo parlor with a bot. Beside me, Catherine asks Blake, you should get one too. It would look really cool on you. He awkwardly looks away, no thanks. I am going to ask Frank some questions, if you don't mind. Normally I wouldn't think twice about this, but he was giving off a different vibe. And so was Catherine, who looked dejected watching Blakes back. I ask her, you okay. She replies, I really screwed up. I gaze back to Blake, what do you mean. She says, he is angry with me. I don't think he was, but she clearly believed that. She says, I left the island to meet Robb without talking to him about it first. I think he feels I betrayed him.

So its about her impromptu rendezvous with Robb that’s got him lit up. I ask, but we heard you that day. Why would be still mad about it. She sighs, because he probably thinks I will leave the island to be with Robb. I couldn't suppress the shock on my face, what. Is that true. She says, no. I wouldn't never do that. I hadn't asked her what happened with Robb because I believed it was none of my business. But I had to ask now, did you not break up with him. She face with a sad expression, did you also thought I would break up with him. I guess that answers my question. I really didn't want to intrude, but I had to say my peace.

I tell her, to be honest, I thought it was inevitable. Is there an end goal or a future where an omega can remain with a human. Now, if you weren't an omega, I wouldn't have any issue with it. I am not trying to upset you, but that’s the harsh reality. She replies, I know. Believe me, I have been going through it all every day. Knowing is one thing. But actually ending a relationship is completely different problem. My head tells me one thing, but my heart says another. She looks away to David, and you know the sad part. I was mad at David for trying to keeping us apart for no reason. When I was mad at myself for not doing it myself.

I get a sense she, like me and Ned, as been blaming others for their problems. I know all to well how that’s like. I ask, so you forgave him? She nods, yeah. I did. He went out of his way to help me out. Even if that didn't pan out they way he wanted, he respects my decision at least. I can't be mad about that. Then she faces Blake, he on the other hand is not even saying anything to me. At times he doesn't even acknowledge that fact that I left. That’s even worse. It makes sense why he be frustrated with her. She is not leaving but not breaking up with the human.

I sigh feeling a more sad from my own decision with Elina. I say, meanwhile, the person responsible for all this mess is enjoying himself. I point my head towards David who was admiring at the tattoo Sommers choose for himself. Catherine laughs, you know what. He really is the biggest jerk. We both shared a melancholy laughter. Once the tattoo session was over, Sommers was now the model to showcase the sophisticated design of a wolf over his shoulder. The bot had drawn in vivid details and almost no visible mistakes. Nathan is excited with a new prospect, if we have dozens of these bots, we can manufacture our Kuritine circuit chips and micro processors.

The scientists found the idea very appealing. Nathan drapes around them like they were best buddies now. Deni asks Sommers, why a wolf though. He smiles, when I was living in the tropical islands, there was a herd of wolfs living. Their pack leader was menacing and ferocious. I figure I channel some of that attitude. Its nice to seem him get over the slump he had for a while. Marina says, you know what they call the wolf leader, right. The alpha wolf. He gives an innocent smile, coincidence. Marina shoves him over his tattoo with a laugh. David says, now that you have the ancillary benefits of these bots. Lets move on the final ART bot I have.

People prepare themselves for the climax of the demonstration. Nathan scoffs, even we haven't seen them yet. Its all very suspense and exciting. Marina yells, finally. David says, I haven't been able to configure them yet. I will only show one for now. But in few days, I will deliver them to you. He raises his watch to his mouth, initiate the bot. There has been a boxed up crate for a while, sitting at the edge of the building. Now, a mechanical sounds come from it. The next second, the wooden box is torn out from the inside and the huge spider looking bot comes out from air. The bot jumps into the air and lands in front of all of us.

Its the same bot we face at his place when David lost his mind. People gasp in awe and shock at the 10 feet tall bot. Nathan shrieks, you weren't kidding that its not public friendly. Marina frantically inspects it while circling around it, hmm, not bad. Frank says, Its looks like an insect. David says, nature has been the inspiration for many human inventions. I found arachnids to be very dangerous species in the animal kingdom. They are versatile, fast and strong. The bots arm shift into weapons, but instead of single type, they all six arms are different. A noticeable upgrade from the single weapon change from those previous bots.

David says, these, killer bots, as Marina says, are not designed for surveillance, stealth or even coordinating other bots. They have only one function, neutralize the targets. Blake asks, they don't transform like the bots before. David says, actually. They do. I have currently configured to one specific structure. The bot begins to change its shape, the three arms morphing into one on each side, same with the six legs. Soon it begins to shape like a person, even the head has features of a person with big hair. But the height remains the same. The shape transform very close to a person now. If I had to compare, it looks like statue matching one those old cities in the Rome.

Tina says, whoa. Is that freaking Michealangelo? Wait. Are you fan of Renaissance. I had no idea she would be so passionate about something like this. But she was very vocal at the dinner meeting too. I don't think many people understood the reference, including me. David says, I do enjoy the usual debate between philosophy of art and science. But this design was picked by a scientist from Rome. She probably wanted this as a homage to her home, I think. But I am down to chat the medieval times with you Tina. Catch me at my home whenever you can. That made her blush a little. Given the rumors, he is obviously living up the hype.

Nathan says, enough flirting around. What's the point it turning into a statue. David smiles, the thing is, these bot, it can transform into anything. But unfortunately, it will be immobilized in that state. I think its something to with

the Hive automatons processors we reverse engineered from the wreckage. There is some issue with the nano configuring unit that renders it useless in its transformed state. The best we could do is program the transfiguration the way we want. Marina asks, I think I get it. You can't use them as statues or objects, but you can keep them hidden in plane sight. Or even transport them with suspicion.

David says, that’s absolutely right. Imagine installing them all over the island, out in open. It can be a stump of a tree, or a pillar of a building. Maybe even a rock under the ocean. With a flip of a switch, they will active whenever there is a threat. I have to say this is most outrageously impressive part of the demonstration. The potential of our security with this is incredible. Blake asks, that's an ingenious idea. How about the combat though. Marina says, yeah. Where is the killer in these killer robots. David says, thought you never ask. We need a volunteer to test them out, because a dummy is far too easy target.

Marina raises her hand nearly jumping, me. Me. David says, anyone?. He purposefully ignores her. Marina shouts, oh come on. I want to check it out. David looks around us, anyone not an omega who cannot crush it with a flick of her fingers. I laugh picturing Marina stomping it without a sweat. Marina puts her arms down, this is some bullshit. Blake says, I'll give it a try. He was the least person I thought would want to try. Even David felt a little anxious, anyone who is not a Terra who would most definitely not disintegrate it without touching it. Blake laughs it off, but gives off the impression he could probably do it.

Jess says, I'll do it. Any problem with a dual Kuret user. David eyes fell on her, we have our contestant. Nathan says, kick that bots ass, babe. Jess mocks him away in front of everyone. The bot changes back to its original shape. We clear out some space for her as David stands between them as a referee. Jess prepares her Kuret with confidence, now don't get mad if I accidently destroy it. David laughs as he signals. Jess prepares a javelin with her Kuret. The bot dashes across grass slithering on six legs towards her with its arms pointed at her. The arms turn into cannons and guns, firring hail of bullets. Jess defends herself with a Kuret of wall around her.

She throws the javelin at the bot, which defects it with a propulsion blasts of its own. Jess side steps from the path of the bot and hurls more Kuret spears at it. The bot continues to defend against the number Kuret attacks. Some of the Kuret go past its defense, but turns out it also had red laser shield overs its main body. The same that stopped Marina's attack. Damn, David wasn't kidding that this was his ultimate combat bots. Marina cheers on, awesome. Jess changed her strategy, instead of throwing spears, she changed to big attacks. She forms a large cannon barrel in front of her. The bot stops its advance, sensing the danger.

Jess fires a big cannon. The bots' weapons shift into bomber, throwing grenades into the air. Before the Kuret cannon reached the bot, it exploded in mid air from the grenades. The collision dusts up a strong wind around me. That Kuret attack from Jess was no joke. And yet it deflected it with precision. That is one hell of an attack. While Jess loads up for another Kuret cannon ball, the bot changes its strategy. One of it arms starts to spray camouflaging gas on the ground. Its trying to obscure Jess's vision. Jess wasn't going to let it happen and creates a Kuret sheet and begins fanning it over the gas.

There a large explosion inside the gas and the ground shook a little where it stood. I ask, did Jess attack it from the underneath it. Blake says, no. I didn't see her Kuret connect. When Jess cleans up the gas, the aftermath caught me by surprise. There is a dug up hole where the bot was standing. I immediately turn my eyes to my feet. I could feel slight vibrations off the earth. Catherine says, its underneath the ground. Jess stays cautious, anticipating for the moment it dugs its way out. One of the bots arm shot straight up behind and tried to grab her. She ducks away in a Kuret slide and swings her Kuret sword.

Even though the bots body is buried inside, it knew what was happening and transformed the arm into a sword of its own. They began to fiercely strike each other. She was only focused on that one arm. The other five came out, surrounding her with a different kind of weapon. This one threw electric bolts. I thought Jess was going to be caught in the middle. But turns out she was already a step ahead, she pushes down her one leg and Kuret walls rise from the ground into the air. The Kuret wall breaks the bolts. She jumps into the sky with a spring Kuret on her legs and lands gracefully at a distance. The bot's entire body finally digs it way out.

People are cheering on for Jess. Even though its supposed to be a demo for the bot. She gets our encouragement and channels a massive amount of Kuret around her. They wrap her like a fire as she charges at the bot. The bot raises its arms and combines at its six arms into a single weapon. The weapon has two long barrels with a gap in the middle. Marina yells, is that a freaking railgun. There a soft static noise coming from the inside of the barrels. The excitement from the collision among people is reaching new heights. Jess charges with even more Kuret as they close the distance.

However, before she could reach it. David lands from the air in between them. He puts his one Kuret wrapped arm on Jess's elbow raised for a punch. And with his other arm, he threw a bunch of black Kuret of ropes at the bot and pulled it to the sky. When the bot's weapons discharge, it throws a white pulsating blast into the air missing them both. The pulse was so fast, it become a speck in a few second disappearing in the sky. Jess's Kuret breaks into pieces at David's presence. He says, that's enough. But Jess was in the zone. The broken Kuret pieces were but back by her, come on. I am not done.

David lets out a bigger wave of Kuret than hers and disintegrates her Kuret. That snapped her back to her senses. The bot also freezes and goes into standby mode. Jess releases her Kuret and breathes hard for a bit, sorry. I got carried away. David smiles, no worries. He disperses his own Kuret letting go of her elbow. Nathan claps as he walks to Jess, that was awesome. Why you stop there David. She was just getting serious now. David sighs, I know that. She would have taken out the arms of the bot with that move. But she would also not walk away from that railgun unscathed. I thought it was enough to show the bots abilities.

He was right, either of them getting hurt would be bad. Jess asks David, that underground move. You used something similar in our match. Did you program it to do that. David says, yes and no. He faces us, Hive tech are proactive. That's something we can't achieve, so instead I focused on these being reactive and adaptive. The AI behind the bot analyzed our match followed similar strategies. With every move you make, it adapts and reacts differently. Jess says, impressive. Unfortunately, after experience my mistake, I wasn't going to be taken down the same way again. David smirks at her confident expression.

Marina asks, was that a railgun? She looks away to the direction the pulse beam went. He nods, it is. Unless you know its coming, you are at severe risk. Its fired at 0.1 speed of light. You can defend against it, but never escape it. Holy shit. At that speed, you won't be able to see it. Before you blink, you will be bombarded with a electromagnetic force. Jess gives a horrified laugh, so glad it didn't get me. Ivan and his team inspect the killer bot with awe expressions. Marina places her hand on David's shoulder, let me go as well.

He replies, you just want to show off. She scoffs, look who's talking. He says, well, this is my show and I say its done. That put a damper on Marina's mood. But she remained excited asking about other weapons it has. I realize I will not be able to talk to David tonight. I am a little anxious about it, but I need to talk to him soon. Feel like I have a lot to say to him now.

David (Chapter 115)

Monday, March 16, 2026 19:35

M says, boss, the cargo has reached the port. They will be here in the another 9 hours. I swipe off the towel from the table and wipe off the sweat. I say, that's great news. My high voice echo's in the empty room of the training center. I take the corner bench of the gym, exhausted from the workout. Jack and others will arrive today evening. I need to intercept the boat they are in and have Jack and his family come with me separately. I also need to collect their new identities from Catherine. The Citradel officers will meet the rest of their loved ones at the south port.

I have just finished the last session I planned for my Kuret control. I flex my hand pouring out Kuret and play around my hands. Now that we are entering the third week after the tournament, I need to really kick into high gear. In just another 2 weeks, I am going to face off a wild overdrive user. I have made several strategies, yet I am not ready to execute any of them. Especially my failsafe Kuret. Its proving extremely difficult to control its direction. When I showed it to Marina and Blake, I only achieved a small Kuret. Enough for them to realize I had an ultimate move in case things go bad. But making it work on bigger scale needs time.

Yesterday, after the demo, I had my third session with Marina. We have worked on the final schematics for my Kuret technique. She said its probably the best one out of all the attempts. Now its matter to practicing and adapting to under pressure of a fight. Blake is supposed to meet me now. But he is already 30 minutes late. I messaged him a while ago remind him, but I haven't gotten a reply. M didn't have anything new to report in the officers building. He has been a slightly distant for me and Catherine. I think he hold us responsible for her leaving the island to meet Robb.

Maybe I was too hasty in believing that I was not causing problem for anyone when I proposed this to Catherine. It would be natural for him to be worried about Catherine. I should perhaps ease him of the doubts he harbor. I thought at least he will be sticking with the schedule he planned. Did I unintentionally gave him the wrong impression and he is avoiding me. No, that would be silly. He has never been one to hold grudge for things like this. I just hope it's a coincidence and nothing else.

As I rack my brain for the reason, I heard the door to the gym open. It had to be him, I was being paranoid for no reason. I grab my bag and walk to him, hey dude. You had me worried. Why so. I halt as the person comes into view. It wasn't him. She says in a grim voice, hey. Blake couldn't make it, so I came instead. My eyes twitch at the surprise guest. What is Vanessa going here. She came in her sports bra and tights. Her hair tied up in a pony tail. She caught me off guard with her dress and appearance. I ask, what's going on.

She says, I told you. Blake couldn't make it. He has an emergency meeting with Ivan in sector 5. Something about ground readings different than projected levels. Sounded like he was needed there more. So he asked me fill in instead of him. I ask, that makes no sense. She says, I am telling the truth. He is there in sector. I speak over her, 5. Yeah, I heard you. I am not talking about that. Why would he send you. And why would you agree to it. She stays silent while I had to think what really happened. She is the last person Blake would choose to send in place of him. He knows she is mad at me. Hold on. Maybe Blake really holds some resentment and ambushed me with her. Or she came after hearing about Blake being busy and got him to agree to let her meet me. Either case, Blake needs to explain few things to me.

She still didn't give me any explanation. But I didn't need one anymore, sorry you wasted your morning. But I am good. I will doing training alone today. She blocks my path, why. You scared of me or something. I scoff, no. I just don't want to get dragged into another drama. I have been dealing with many things lately. I need to focus, and you being here. That's the opposite. She wasn't letting go of her stare. I don't have the mental capacity to argue with her again. Maybe I should defuse the situation before she starts blaming for something again. I gaze down at her tights, you look hot in that tights by the way.

I thought that would invoke some reaction out of her. But she remained stoic, like she was unfazed by my obvious attempts to flatter her. She crosses her arms and continues to throw a stare down at me. Okay, something is definitely is up with her. Her vigilance means she is no mood for small talks. Well, too bad for her I can match her wits. I ask, sorry. But my training is for Charles. That means sparing with certain type of opponents. And as much as I want to check out your moves, I can't make time for you. I try to slither through the door. But she places her arm on the door, blocking me again.

She says, you really are scared of me, aren't you. I wasn't before, but I am now. Her demeanor is border lining at intimidation. I could force my way out, but I doubt that will stop her persistence. I make my mind and decide to just wait her out. She is bound to crack and tell me why she is here. After a some time passed with us staring at each other in heavy silence, she finally speaks, you really don't know why I am here. The first thought comes to mind was about Wagner. Then what I told her about Ned. But its possible its about Elina too. It would be easy to point out reasons she aren't here to meet me.

Seeing my confused face she sighs, for freak sake. You two seriously need to get your story straight. I think its safe to say its about Elina now. Did Elina do something. The plan was to meet Vanessa after the exhibition match. At least that's what we agreed to. Could Elina have met her earlier than we agreed. She says, your girlfriend came to visit me yesterday. She had a lot to tell me. Oh crap. Elina screwed up. I need to get out of here. I didn't want to do it, but I have to force my way out. I gently shove her hand and step out. She yells, hey. I am talking to you.

I reply, and I am busy. If you want to talk, you need to deal with it. I guess this is how I am going to handle the burning gaze from her. I take the hallway that takes to the open ground where they have the tracks and other obstacle equipment's. Today was the start of my Kuret assisted movement training. Vanessa rushes behind me, where are you going. I answer, you know it all too well. Coincidently, I am heading to the place where she scored first place in the tournaments preliminary rounds. The sun was just the horizon as I step out. Its still colder out here, but its getting warmer. Gives me a good workout environment.

She looks around the place, reminiscing the events that took place here. She asks, Blake said you guys had a training regime of running today. Should have known it be here. I drop my bag and prepare myself mentally for a slew of blames and anger. I can't really avoid her, but I can keep myself preoccupied in the meanwhile. I begin limbering up as she gawks at me. She says, are you serious. We aren't going to talk about her. I muster a bit of courage and reply, I am not sure what you mean. She steps closer, drop the act. She told me the whole truth. How she covered Peter crimes, stole the ledger and how two planed to leverage it for her freedom.

My fingers slipped when I was stretching my legs on the ground. I made a scowl trying to understand why Elina told her everything. Didn't I already explained how delicately this had to be handled. And most importantly, keep my name out of this. I couldn't keep procrastinating with deflection anymore. I face her square, she spilled the beans big time huh. I didn't realize the she was carrying a bigger guilt. That's why I wanted that she talk to you after taking some more time. Let her emotions simmer down before trying to do anything. I sigh, I should have kept an eye on her. I thought giving her space was in her best interest. Shame on me.

I really felt disappointed in not keeping track of her. I knew she wouldn't expose my involvement, not that she had any actual proof. I was going to be in touch with her frequently. To help her deal with this. I never imagined she run off to talk to Vanessa the very next day. Vanessa asks, you shouldn't have done this. Do you know how I worse feel about it. I am in a moral dilemma here. I say, this is why I wanted to avoid Elina mentioning I put her up to this. If she had approached you, alone, you wouldn't be pressured so much. She scoffs, how can you believe that. She needs to be locked up. Like her brother. Like Wyan.

I ask her, then why haven't you already. If she came to with the complete truth, then you shouldn't have to wait. You don't need the ledger anyways. Its pointless to know about the shipments when we have the names, aliases and smuggled goods. That got her tongue and pained eyes look away from me. I say, our plan wasn't about lies. It was just to help her, with a leverage and a promise to keep her crimes a secret. Think for a second, if you had no idea I was helping her, maybe you would have taken pity on her and agreed to it. That's all I wanted.

She had to know I wasn't favoring Elina because I was selfishly making decisions for her. Vanessa asks, you told her to sell off her business. She already handed me the dead to her bar. But is that really true. How much did Elina planned this before meeting Vanessa. I say, its true. She was responsible for Marina getting poisoned. Even if it was unintentional and indirectly. She had to pay for her crimes. I just didn't want that to be jail. She blurts out, why didn't you tell her everything about me then. She could have easily leveraged her freedom using my past as a bargain.

I had a visceral reaction to her horrible line of thinking, why in the freaking hell would I ever do that. You think I would use such a dirty tactic against you. When you how Ryes used it against me. I shake my head in disgust, I can't believe you. I knew you hate me, but to even think I would hurt you back in such a way. That's unbelievable. You seem to think every action I make is against you. You know what, go head. Lock her up. I don't care anymore what you think of me anymore. Elina did a crime and she should be punished the way you want. That broke her hardened wall and she becomes frightened at my reaction.

I turn my back to her and wrap my Kuret around me. I didn't realize she had this much animosity for me. Maybe I really shouldn't have provoked Ned. I am guessing that backfired in the worst possible way. My anger is reflected in my poor Kuret control. I can't do this without a straight head. So I settle my thoughts first while swirling my Kuret around my legs. My concentration breaks when Vanessa says, I am sorry. I went too far. My Kuret broke apart as I yell, you think. Argh, I can't really concentrate with her anxious glimmers around me.

I face her back, if you are here for this, I suggest you go back. Elina has told you everything and I don't have anything else to contribute. You do whatever you want. She retorts, easy for you to say. She wasn't crying in front of you begging to forgive her. That actually put my mood in distraught. I reply, she broke down when I confronted her about it. So I don't have to imagine it, I was there. And I gave her a choice, to either surrender, like Peter. Or be the sister Ryan deserves. I am sorry you are in a position like this. But I suspect Elina said she has made her peace if you decide to turn her in. Isn't it your job to weigh your options impartially.

She silence told me I was right, maybe I shouldn't have revealed things to her. And I was going to leave it alone. But you know what kept me from doing it. I waited for her to think about it. I answer, you. You told me how I was keeping Elina in the dark. So I decided to not hold back anymore. So if anything, you are complicit in this. That stunned her speechless. I realized what utter nonsense I spewed. I chuckle, that came out wrong. But hey, you made me want to do the right thing. Even if it was hard. So blame me all you want for trying to help Elina, but don't accuse me for things between us.

This made an impact on her. I was aware how harsh I was being, but I that's how I really felt. And it actually helped my calm my nerves. I went to my bag and grabbed a bottle of water. The ranting had made my throat dry. Vanessa looks at me with sad eyes, you told her. Because of me? She was confused why I would listen to her like this. Guess I can't blame her when I haven't been honest like this before. I put the bottle down, yes. And I am glad I did. Perhaps Elina would have been okay without me confronting her. She would continue keeping her secret. But maybe not. Now I know it was too much for her. She would have eventually give in. Then she would really be in jail, no compromise. At least I gave her an option.

She asks, you care for her that much. Its awkward to talk to Vanessa of all people about this. But I can't shy away now. I say, yes. She is special to me. She doesn't know it, but she helped me deal with my PTSD. Vanessa asks in low tone, do you love her. I should have seen that question coming. I answer, its not like that. She asks, but she likes you. I sigh, she likes Mack. The fun, easy to hang with and bad at flirting guy. I can never make things personal with her based on lies. You remember Sophie. I won't do the same mistake again. Lately I have been thinking about her a lot, and how she react if she know the whole truth.

The following silence was awkward too. Vanessa breaks it, the old you wouldn't have never brought Sophie's name. I had to agree on that, true. I would think about it, but probably wouldn't say it aloud. She then unexpectedly smiles, guess so. She then sits on the bench. I contemplate what I should do now. I have been trying to get away from her, but that hasn't worked out well. She turns up to me, I spoke with Ned few days ago. Oh boy. We are jumping from one mine to another. Maybe she decided to let the matter of Elina rest for the time being.

She had a strangely confused expression now. I hesitate to ask, I am guessing it went good. Since her mood didn't worsen, I had to take a stab in the dark. I was hesitant to even see her glimmers to figure out her feelings. She says, not exactly. He told me you gave him a stern talking and basically told him to break up with me. I scoff, I didn't make him do anything. I only gave him a push he needed. Something you needed too it seems. She lowers her gaze, well, it worked. We talked through our issues. And I have a lot to think about. So it was neither good or bad. There is still a good chance they break up.

I don't know how I still want that when she continues to behave towards me like this. She asks, you don't want to know what happened. I almost said yes, but held my tongue with great restraint. I so want to know what did they

said, its none of my business. I don't want to get in the middle of yet another omega relationship problems. I barely dodged the previous one. Then I remember about Blake. I felt a little sadness, maybe not completely. But lesson learnt. I held back my real thoughts about her. How I was hoping they really do break up.

She says, thanks. I mean it. Despite everything going on between us, if you hadn't made Ned see reason. Or force my hand too. Neither of us would have had the courage to try. She becomes despondent, I was angry at you for many things. But if you hadn't made us face this, we were likely going to break up. I don't know what I would have done then. I couldn't blink for few seconds. Hold on. Did I really helped them find a way to patch things up. Oh hell no. The irony is making me cringe. Got damn it. I should have left things alone. Why did I go and gave them a choice. I should have just said they don't work.

What's worse, I see steady glimmers from her. Meaning she truly was a honest appreciation. I feign happiness, well, that’s ah, great. Why are you telling me all this. Seriously, I wish I never heard this. She says, I don't know. Maybe its because you are the only one I can talk to about it. Isn't that we used to do for a long time. Its strange to see her being so less aggressive. Like she is done hating me. I ask, I am confused. You came here to ask why I helped Elina and now about Ned. What am I missing here. She says, honestly, I am too. I don't want to be angry with you. Its exhausting and frankly childish.

This should feel like there is hope for reconciliation. But when did she feel this way. She says, I have been trying to get back at your lying about Wagner. You already know about that. But yesterday I realized I was making things worse. I saw someone behaving differently towards others. Once I saw how it looked from an outside perspective, it opened my eyes. I thought my issues were unique and only mine. I never expected to see them manifest in others in same ways. I should be really happy about this. But I wasn't, you mean Blake. Did he say something to you. She shakes her head, not it many words. But Catherine saw it too.

This is bad. I need to make things right with him. But how do I even do when it was about Catherine. Should I leave it to Catherine to handle. Is that irresponsible of me. I can't tell. Vanessa says, you look panicked. You should be. You might have sorted things with Catherine, but messed up with him. She didn't need to make me feel even worse about it. I say, you seem to be enjoying me being in trouble. She scoffs, I do. You made me suffer a lot. Serves you right for not thinking things through. Like how Elina caught you.

I am so conflicted right now. But the most important thing I want to know is how Vanessa feels about me. I wish I could just ask her outright about it. She looks to the sky, I have been thinking a lot about what you said to me that night when you told you were a shadow. She has jumped into yet another dangerous land mine. It feels like she is checking of things from a list and keeping me on my toes with this. She says, did you know I talked to your shadow friends about it. What they had to say about it. My silence gave her the answer, they believed you. Despite knowing what it means about my brother. I hated that for so long. And every time I think about I get mad.

Ah damn. Hear we go again. I stop her, if we are going to open that particular can of worms. I am have to going to ask you to not do this. I have had enough of Wagner to last a lifetime. She turns her face to me. I expected her to be angrier. But she remained surprisingly composed. But I wasn't going to take any chance. I tell her, talking to you has calmed me down. You always had that effect on me. So I am going to go for a lap. I didn't wait for her stop me. I prepared my Kuret and sprinted off the track. Given what just happened, my focus was all out of whack. Naturally, I sucked at my coordination. I tried to keep Vanessa out of my mind. But I couldn't help gazing at her every chance I get. How pathetic I am. I can't let feelings get in the way of this. I don't have much time left for the exhibition match.

With a stronger resolve, I brought my coordination back on track. I decided to do brisk walking first. Baby steps, as they say. The Kuret around my joints kept pushing me ahead at odd times. I recall how Blake had showed me last time the correct way to utilize Kuret. Instead of focusing on just one single movement, I need to keep my Kuret in use even when not I am not movement. That’s the key to consistent. That's why I needed to learn to control Kuret output. I need to change the force of my Kurets physical when I need and keep it low when I don't. I shouldn't stop it mid stride, otherwise I stumble down.

After some awkward few rounds, I begin to get a feel for what works for me. Its more exhausting than I expected. Blake said not to let the Kuret control me, but I have been making that same mistake and losing control. So every time I have to consciously lessen the impulse pushing me ahead. Two more laps and I was drenched in sweat. This is not working. Without Blake to point my mistakes, I have to review things later with M. I crouch down on my knees and breath hard. My legs feels so heavy. I only ran for 2.5 miles, but it feels like it was way longer than that.

I didn't hear Vanessa approaching me until she was beside me, that was interesting. I had it in my head that you were quick to pick up things. Like how you beat up three Heraknus with just one day of training. I chuckle, then I must be doing things right. I stand up straight, I don't know if people told you, but I wasn't luck. I work hard. She nods, I never doubted that. She then thinks for a second, maybe I can help you after all. You are struggling with Kuret movements. I used to have same problem. I can help you.

At any other circumstance I would have been overjoyed she is finally coming around. Maybe her hate for me is slowly going away. But that’s just wishful thinking. I am sure she is just being polite since I basically told her I wasn't interested taking to her about Wagner. She probably doesn't know how to breach the topic without one of us getting angry about it. I should answer her objectively here. I tell her, your Kuret is slightly different. Mine is meta physical while yours is fully. You thrust your entire body with wind and fire. Not quite the same with mine or Blakes.

She had to know the difference wouldn't help me learn from her. She says, I figured as much. Just thought to ask anyways. This presents a rare opportunity though. Maybe a way to ask her something I have been wanting to for a time. I ask, you can help me with something else. She questions my motives with her eyes. I explain, I am not very good with flying. And it turns out Blake is too good at it. He couldn't really see the struggles with that particular ability. She smiles with curiosity, you want me to teach you flying. I say, if you are going to keep hovering on me, I might as well use you. You are the fastest Medrone here after all

I don't know how she respond to that. But I didn't expect her to giggle. She says, that I am. But you didn't ask for my help last time, like others. So you must already have a way to learn it yourself. I nod, I did. But it be faster to learn it from you directly. I was sure she wouldn't agree to it. But she agrees completely surprising me, I can. I don't buy this at all. I wait for the catch, which he realized I guessed. She says, I will gladly help, if you do one thing for me. I say, shocker. You want something. You have started a trend you know. Even Frank and Chelsea gave me hints that I sort of owed them. I had no choice but to get their people out of Citradel.

I had no doubt she what she wanted. She says, I want to know about Wagner. I make a scowl at her, you know what. I changed my mind. I can do this myself. She steps closer, I am not going to get mad at you. I scoff, sorry. I don't believe you. You made pretty clear that you don't trust me. She looks away with a curious eyes, I didn't. But I am willing to try now. You said you were going to earn my trust back. So here I am, ready to listen. I am confused how that happened. I ask, weren't you just mad at me for involving Elina. And even trying to middle between you and Ned. She answers, you could have gotten Elina her freedom without involving me. But you didn't want Elina to be like you, taking things on by yourself. I respect that.

It was hard to ascertain her emotional state now. She has had weird mood swings before, but not like this. She says she understand my intent, but I don't know if she is really okay with it. She continues, and my issues with Ned. Turns out that had nothing to do with the bet. I noticed how she omitted the fact that I wasn't the cause of it. I feel I did play some role in their fight. Wonder what it was about. I ask, you think you ready to listen to me now. I don't think so. The mere mention of Wagner makes you want to rip off my head. Nothings changed about that. She faces with determined eyes, I won't do that again. At least, I will try to hear you out.

This had to be the biggest change in her. Her willingness to listen to me. I was hesitant to even believe this. Maybe she is faking it and just wants me to talk. So that she could just tell me how wrong I am. She says, I don't blame you for not believing me. But I had a lot of time to think. I have been trying to convince myself I don't need to know about him. I know my brother, and anyone else are either jealous of him or don't know him. I have idolized him all this time, so I can't really allow anyone badmouthing him. Maybe you don't had to tell me about him, but you shouldn't have lied about not knowing him.

This is what I told her a week before too. I am beginning to think she is ready now. Maybe time was the only thing needed for her to realize how unreasonable she has been all this time. But I wanted to make sure, something must have happened. Otherwise you wouldn't ask me directly. Someone said something to you. I began listing out who would be even possible to make her see reason. Vanessa remained suspiciously quiet. And that answered my question, Siera. The only person in the world you trust more than anyone. She relents, she told me a story about my brother. I cock my head sideways puzzled.

Seira shouldn't know about Wagner, she was nowhere near him to know personal things about him. I ask her, what did she say to you. Vanessa says, promise me that you will tell me the truth. If you can't, there be no point. The tables been reversed now. She is trying to use that as a leverage to talk about him. However, despite what she thought about me, it hadn't had the same effect on my anymore. I shake my head, If you would have told me this a week before, I would jumped at the chance. But now, I feel its just sad. She yells, what. How is that fair. I raise my hand to her, I am not talking about you. Its me. I have been holding on so anger and hate towards him. Its just pathetic. I no longer need to know his reasons.

Vanessa's shocked asked, what does that mean. I sigh, I can see how hard it was for you to trust me again. So I am not going to squander it again by arguing over him. I don't want to fight over who is right and wrong. I just want us to get along again. Memories are all that left of them. Who am I to say what's wrong. You should cherish him as you remembered him. She is stunned by my thoughts on the matter. Now that I don't have PTSD, I feel lighter around this topic. Its shocking how much control he had over me until now.

She says, you maybe be fine with it. I am not. I haven't been listing before. But I want to. So many people trust you, despite all the truths you kept from us. I thought you just manipulated them. No, I believed you did. Eventually I realized how stubborn I have been. She snarls, Siera has repeatedly told me how Shadow strategists are. To be honest with you, I have not been thinking of you like Blake or Marina. At least not completely. Its hard to see you in new light with our past. She actually made a good argument. It would take people lot of time to reconcile with this concept of me being in Shadows. And in her case it would take a lot more effort.

She says, the way you operate is still the same. So maybe that’s why its been hard to see how different you are now. But I am willing to believe you changed. That you were chosen in Shadows for a good reason. I can't really deny that anymore. Not after you decimated Heraknus or raged war against Citradel like it was nothing. It finally happened. I didn't realize, but this is what I needed to hear from her. It’s a burden, I never knew was present, that has been lifted off me. Its similar to the vision trance I was in. She hasn't been this honest to me in a while. But she is showing a modicum of admiration. The knot in my throat feels unravelling now.

Maybe she really means it now. Siera told her something and now that she accepted I am a Shadow, so what I say or do matters a great deal. She even tried to her slight embarrassment praising me like this. And yet I couldn't bring myself to reveal things about Wagner yet. There is a difference in learning things about the past and dealing them. I ask, I am inclined to tell you about him. That brought a little bit of appreciation on her face. I continue, however, I don't want us to fight when I say something you don't like. So this is what I will say to you now. Whatever you may feel about me, he is your family in the end. Hate him or love him, that will never change. Hold on to that connection, regardless of what others think.

I had to be absolutely sure she wouldn't argue over her ideals anymore. She gives me a hard stare and then nods, I can do that. I thought you were about to say to keep an open mind. I scoff, I already know its hard for you when it comes to him. Though I prefer you not hate me anymore. She says quietly, I don't think I ever truly hated you. Maybe slightly distrusted you. I scoff, just a bit? I recall all the stuff she has been saying to me, you first told you will never ever trust me again. That’s the first thing you said to me. Then you revenge bait Elina to potentially ruining the plan with the smugglers. Then you haggle me for the ART bots. And yet unknowingly sick your boyfriend on to me.

She says, hey. I didn't tell Ned anything. He was angry with me, heard the rumors about us and assumed it had to do with you. That’s was all him. I had a suspicion she said something to him. But maybe she didn't. Ned came up with that idea on his own. She says, I know how childish I have been. Believe me, I can see it now. I really believed you don't trust me enough. I ask, and now you don’t feel that way. She says, I am not sure what I believe now. I am hoping if you tell me about Wagner, I might figure it out. I risked a bit and saw her glimmers. It was flickering like crazy, but it wasn't from anger. It was from fear and anticipation. Not enough to be dishonest.

There was any chance of ending our feud, this is it. I have a hard time putting my next words. I feel like I am playing with dynamite, and it will explode when I least expect it. In the tense moment, she says, how about this. You love technicalities right. So lets have a bet. That intrigued me more than I cared. She knows me so well. If it were a game of sorts, I would be compelled to answer. She says, if I win, you tell me about my brother. And I mean every question. I ask, and when I win. I didn't even know what it was, but I was already imposing on her. She scoffs at my arrogance, I will give you flying lessons. So, how about it.

This sounds good, but I had another condition in mind, I don't need the lessons. But if I win, you give Elina a fair chance. That made her brows arch. I explain, I am not asking you to cover for her. Just look at her without any prejudice against me. If she can do that, I am very certain she will help Elina, or come up with some sort of compromise at the very least. She thinks about it and says, fair enough. She extends her hand to me, which I gladly take. I ask eagerly, what's the bet. She gestures me to follow her inside the training center.

I didn't know what she had in mind. Could be anything from the rolling targets to the war room. The way she lead was different than I anticipated. She lead me to the hall were we had martial arts training. I ask, huh? Why here. She says, you are training for Charles right. Hand to hand combat is key part of your training. I ask, if its about him, sure. But its between us. She nods while removing her shoes beside the central mat, you know one of my biggest regret is that I never got to fight you in the tournament. You were clearly the most sought after opponent. You remember how Marina, Blake and Derek were gunning for you in the semis. I wanted to be there too.

Does she plan to finally get her wish with this. She then begins stretching her limbs, I can't risk hurting you when you have such a big match coming up. So I thought the next best thing. She crouches down on her toes, we duke it on the mat, without our Kuret. It will be the standard three point hit above waist. No time limit, just bare hand fight. I laugh, I don't know if you notice, even without Kuret I have the upper edge. She straights up and raises her arms, you did. But now that you are training solely with your Kuret in two weeks, I am sure you have gotten rusty. I think that will give me the edge.

Whoa, I didn't expect her to be this clever. Truth be told, I did want a battle with Kuret. Even before the match with Charles, I had been focusing on my Kuret dome and sphere. I say its been a good month and half when I had to use bare knuckle fight. She says, don't tell me the badass Shadow guy is afraid of losing to me. Her cheap provocation wasn't good enough. But I be lying if wasn't excited from this. If she thinks I am at a disadvantage, she is wrong. While she limbers up, I remove my shoes and my shirt. She gets annoyed, what's with the sudden interest to always strip. I throw the shirt over my bag, why. Can't resist me already.

She smirks, please. You don't even crack the top 100 muscular guys. I reply, I don't need to. You getting distracted is enough for me. I caught her staring at me a tinge longer than she should. That made her annoyed a bit. I say, I am already in your head. You should have not challenged me where I am at my best.

Vanessa (Chapter 116)

Tuesday, March 17, 2026 17:37

I had only one goal in my mind when I going to meet David. Get him to apologies to me for involving Elina. When I asked him why he only did half measures to help Elina, he got mad at me. I wasn't prepared to see that side of him that still cared so much that he be angry at me for saying that. He came clean to Elina because of me. I wasn't sure if was being serious or just saying to prove a point. But then he outright said he was genuinely helping her because she is special to him. I felt compelled to ask if he loved her. I thought he was just playing with Elina, get into her pants by first exposing her and then helping her.

I don't know why, but I believed him that there is nothing going on between them. But that could change now. He even made me remember about Sophie, who was being lied to like Elina. I think he now understands how relationship are ruined. I couldn't believe that I had a part in him opening up to Elina. That left bitter taste in my mouth. The same nasty feeling I had earlier with Ned crept up to me. I still question myself that I wanted to stay angry at Ned to avoid focusing my own feelings towards David.

I am sure that I was making things too complicated for myself. I am so jealous that he isn't being distracted by the stuff going in our lives. Or maybe he is and still is so focused on his training. If nothing else, his determination is inspiring. After being so mad at him, I wanted to just be done with it. I have been so acting so boorish with him all this time. It made me even more upset, because it meant I was the only one who was making things worse. I was the only one obsessing over being angry at him. Just like Ned, I was being making an excuse with him so that I don't have to face him.

Aside my confusing feelings for David, I am beginning to think what if he is right about Wagner. I wanted to know what he knows about my brother. But first I told him about Ned. I thought about what Catherine said last night. She had forgiven him for being a jerk and even letting her decide what to do. It felt like he was doing the same for me too. I was actually touched by his effort to make me and Ned face our issues. I thought we were soon going to break up. I really appreciated him for helping me, even when all I ever did was complain to him. Its so immature of me to not have the courage to face Ned without David.

I feel like I am finally at a point where I can forgive him for lying to me. It took a lot of convincing that I am ready to talk about Wagner. The last time we spoke about him, he become angry. But since undergoing the treatment, he is more calm about it. He once told us that Wagner was a trigger for him. It doesn't seem like it was one anymore. So if he can get past his issues, maybe I can too. When he said how he didn't want us to take a step back, I was glad he was being serious about this. And I wanted to move ahead too. That’s why I want to tell him about Siera's story. I had a small hope he knew about it. But it doesn't look like that.

I thought something new about Wagner would make him want to know more. But turns out he is already made peace with his trauma. Considering how has been acting since the tournament, its safe to think he has completely new outlook to life now. Won't let anything tied him down again. I admired him even more. Ever since I learned he was a Shadow, I have been acknowledging him. Because I was trapped in my own feelings. Now I can see them much better. Its taking every once of courage to be honest with him. I had to convince him that I won't accuse him any longer.

I felt so damn embarrassed at my behavior as he lists down everything I ever did to him as a petty grudge. He even thought I made Ned confront him. I guess, in his mind I was out to get him in any way. We both have made a mess of each other, but only I kept digging much deeper. Maybe time was all I needed to clear my head. And that’s how I knew the best way to make him tell me about Wagner was through a match. He is a stickler for making things even. So I had a thought about what to do. I didn't expect him to give Elina a benefit of the doubt. She is really special to him. I feel oddly jealous of her. That fueled me even more for a win.

Now that we are preparing for the match, I feel a little bit excited. Its been so long I felt like this with him. I miss it. I am sure he does too, because he is grinning like a mad man as he cracks his arms and hip. He has gotten a weird taste for being shirtless. Not that I complain. But I had to keep up appearance that I wasn't bothered by it. We take our place in the middle of the large Mat. The lights turn on at the sides and so does the camera. He says, remind me, who came in the first in this preliminary round. He knows who it was. He says, didn't Cathrine take the spot from Sommers who took it from someone else. Oh that’s right, Polly. And who beat them all.

He is trying to get in my head. I know every tactic in his book. I say, that was with Kuret. Are you really going to run just your mouth at me. He chuckles as we begin circling each other. I was smiling along with him, fully aware how dangerous my opponent is. But he is way too cocky. It might do him some good to be cut down a peg or two. Then he said even more aggravating, I can take you blind and one arm tied behind my back. And that’s what he did. He pulls out a black thin long cloth from his pocket and wrapped it over his eyes. Then he locks his left to his back. Just how much confidence he has got to hold back so much. He says, now it seems like a fair fight.

He can't see, so how does he intent to fight me. But then I shake it off. He is lying. Its a trick, making me hesitate. I charge in the next moment, not giving him a moment of reprieve. I approach him with a left hook, which he dodges at the last moment crouching down. I go in for a knee kick to his chest, but he blocks it with his free arm. He tried to make a sweep cut my legs, I jump away and take a step back. I knew he was lying, why the charade. You can see through that flimsy cloth. He replies, who knows. Maybe that was just luck. I jump off for a high kick, which stops by grabbing my ankle and pulling me away to the side.

He nearly yanked me down before I kick his hands. I went in for a barrage of jabs and punches. But he dodges or blocks them at the last moment. I saw an opportunity, I lean down and go for a back kick to his chest. He defends himself, but it was just a second late. I landed a clean kick to his chest and he stumbles on his ass. He winces as pushes himself up, damn. I am rusty. I felt jubilant, point one. Did you thought it was going to be easy. We walk back to the center of the mat. I thought he remove his bindings or use another arm. But he didn't remove either of them, interesting. Feigning a punch while going for a high angled kick from below. Someone's been practicing.

I answer, you thought you were the only one doing training. Losing to Marina taught me what I was doing wrong. And you showed me how to not depend on Kuret alone. Every day, I have been working out without my Kuret. He says, that’s why you went with this game. You are branching out different styles. I shouldn't need to feel this, but it was good to be validated by him. I tell him, remove those silly restraints. Or you will be down before you figure out anything. He says, thanks for the warning. But I am good. I got nothing to worry about. Its a little intimidating how casual is he bring about this.

He switches up his movement this round and longues in with a mid kick. I saw it coming and dodge to my right. I circle around, twisting my knee for a kick to his left side. If he is seriously going to be stubborn about not using his left arm. Then I will not miss the chance. He cartwheels away just before I lightly grazed his waste. He says, whops. Almost got caught. I didn't wait for him to gain his balance and went if for a elbow slam on his back. That should been a point, but he brought up his right hand to behind and blocked my elbow. That caught me off guard. He goes in for a kick from side, to which I bring in my own leg and block it. I pull out my arm and go for a jab on his neck.

But somehow, even his back faced to me, he caught my wrist from behind. This wasn't even about seeing through the cloth. Does he have eyes behind his neck or something. That thought cost me a momentarily setback, which he capitalized on. He shoves me with is elbow to my chest and I get thrusted back. Wind passes through my lips as I stagger a little on my feet. He nonchalantly says, point one. I am annoyed at myself. I was prepared to not be caught off guard by anything he does. How in the hell did he saw the exact spot I was targeting him. For some reason he panics a little, ah, did I get you in your tits. My bad. I can't see where I throw my punches.

This deranged sleezbag. I blurt out, you dick. He did hit me in my boobs. Not that it should matter. The gall of him to point out something so needless. He smiles, don't take it the wrong way, but you gotten more hot recently. I actually felt my cheeks burning a little at how enthusiastically he said that. He sighs, how in the hell is Robb still made at you. I got curious, what does that mean. He says, you should mess with his head. Make him believe he is stupid. You should wear a swanky dress. Maybe a lace back dress or something. One that shows a little bit of cleavage. He will be on his knees, begging you let him back in. I promise you that.

I can't tell if he is blatantly flirting with me or trying to get a rise out of me. Maybe even both. I never thought he would go this far, objectify me and stir me up. And yet, I feel flushed and also a little bit of pride my efforts have been paying off. Shit. I am getting sucked in by his outrageous compliments. I need to hit him back, at least I have a boyfriend. Who do you have. I went for the jugular. He chuckles, touché. I make the first more again with a punch aimed at his head. Before he could block it, I pull back a little and go for a low kick to his knees. He dodges it barely by side stepping away. He goes in for a punch at my waist, I block it with my knee and push him back.

My fist nearly connected to his shoulder, but he grabbed my wrist few centimeters away from his skin. He gasps, getting closer. I go in for a kick to which he backs before getting struck in his groins. He shouts, hey. Not cool. I laugh, that’s me getting back for hitting me in my boobs. He raises his one arm up to defend himself, that was an accident. You think Ned will let me live after hugging you and then groping you. My anger rose as he made me remember that time. If I keep letting him taunt me, I won't get anywhere. I take a few breathes to settle my thoughts. I already tested that he is wasn't able to follow the first feint.

It still don't know if can see and or just following my movements by sound. As outrageous that sounds, it doesn't explain how he caught me from his back. I know he used to fighting without his eyes, but this is beyond what I imagined. Instead of going in fast, I make small movements around him now. He suddenly waves his arm at the place I was just a second ago. I smile realizing I got him now. He scoffs, why so quiet. Don't tell me you are busy ogling me. Sorry, I don't go after other guys girls. I wasn't going to react to his cocky behavior. I know what game he is playing at. He wants me to make a mistake.

Too bad. This teasing won't make me stumble anymore. I manage to get behind him. Should I try attacking from behind again. Even if can sense me approaching again, he can't defend his back every time. But wait, what if he is planning for that, luring me in. So I decided to wait for another opportunity when I am at his left side. Once aligned, I sprint at him. He notices me coming, but he is a second too late. I slide down and sweep his legs. I knock him down as I have tangled his knees. He falls hard on his back. I raise my foot and hammer down with my heel. He garbs my foot just barely an inch away from his face. I laugh, you should start using both arms now.

He shoves my leg away and tried to elbow me at my neck. I roll away and kick up back on my feet. He was still struggling to get up, so I went in for a high jump kick to his head. My leg came straight at his face and he gets knocked straight into the ground like a rock. I yell in joy, point two. How about that. He yells in pain, agh. Good one. He laughs with me now. He rubs the side of his face as he gets up, what the hell was that woman. I thought you weren't going to let me get hurt. I spat at him, oh bite me. You have been through much worse. He rotates his head around a bit to shake off the bell ring I gave him, you got in good. Shit.

I enjoyed seeing that haughty face was now filled with nervousness. He checks for any damage inside his mouth his tongue, no bleeding. That’s good. We come back to the center of the mat. I thought for sure he fight me seriously. But he still locked his left arm behind. I grew tried of his unfounded confidence. He still is mocking me with this shit. But back in my mind, I am being cautious. That might be another trap and he might use his hand suddenly. I need to keep my cool. He says, I have seen enough of your style. You keep changing stuff to keep me off balance. That’s a good strategy. But you missing other crucial stuff.

I am not going to give him any opening, so I stayed quiet as I approach him. He doesn't even raise his right hand to guard this time. As I walk around him like a cat he says, your attacks are too linear. You need variable acceleration, to further keep your opponent from guessing their next move. Yeah, keep talking shit. You think I would fall for any of it. He continues, and you aren't using your hips to give power to your punches. I know you have a fine ass, but you need more than just nice figure to generate the impulse for a kick. Now he is talking about my ass. A minute ago, I would be so furious. But this is all a game to him.

This time, I am going to attack from his back. The way he is moving he head around, he is anticipating a straightforward attack, like he just said. This time I will go for a two fold attack and he will have no chance of blocking both my fists. With nimble steps I rush in with both my arms pulled in for jabs. I basked in victory as he didn't see me coming and remained still. With all my strength, I go in for a double fist punch on his backside. I didn't notice he already crouch down on this knees. With swift movement, he twists while leaning down. A chill went down and I realize I have to get away. I am too vulnerable. It was too late though.

He thrusts himself up and grabs me by the neck with one arm. The force is so much that he yanks my feet off the ground for a few seconds. I struggle under his tight grip on my neck, but he doesn't let me go. With a slam, he shoves me down by the neck and hit the mat straight on my back. He pants hard few inches away from my face. The warmth radiating from his burning sweat. He leans in closer to my ear, point two. And please don't tell anyone I chocked you. People will get the wrong impression. He releases my neck and slowly pulls himself up. I lay dazed for a second on the mat. What just happened. He shakes his arms says, great stuff. He thrusts his hand to me.

I am so irritated by that humiliating beatdown, I get back up shoving his hand. He closes his fist away, did you really thought you had me. I fix my bra in silence. What was that. That precise movement, he knew where I was going to attack him from. And he also knew I was going in for a punch. If only I had gone in with a kick. How did he do that. He says, I know you don't know how I got you. You haven't studied much in this form of fighting. So nothing to

be ashamed about. I wasn't, but I was sure I had him. I was convinced of it. Its not like his movements were fast or unpredictable. It was precise and simple. A felt a pit in my stomach when I think about what he said.

It means he wasn't teasing me, he really did figure out what I can do. No, it was just a coincidence. Nothing more. He loves to play off them like it was skill. I know him the best. That's what he does the best. I made a plan for this last point. I am not going to overthink it, and just let him struggle under faster attacks. This time, we both kick off and go in for blows. He blocks my jabs, I block his kicks. When I go for a karate chop, he yet again grabs me by the wrist. This time I twist my hand over his and pull him down. He stumbles forward and I go in for his guts with a knee kick. He had no way to defend. But then I felt his weight falling on me, he went if for full body slam on me loosing my balance for a kick.

He falls on top of me, his bare chest on mine and misty breath on me. He had to gall to be amusing by this sudden closeness and smiles, again, not intentional. I yell, yeah, right. I force my hand out from his and go in for a elbow jab to his scandalous expression. He gets off of me and rolls to the side, before the jab connects. My skin still tingles from being in contact with him in close proximity. I can't believe how inappropriately he is trying to get under my skin. I grit my teeth and kick up once more. David flings back up and goes in to grab my neck. Not going to happen again. I go in for a high angled kick and he had to block it with his arm.

I take a few steps back from him. This is bad, he is completely reading my movements now. He really was analyzing my attacks initially. I feel so dumb thinking he was weak without his eyes and use of one arm. Even with all the inappropriate jokes and flattery, I was angry and enjoying this at the same time. I say, how far you have come god dammit. I still feel like was yesterday when I punched you out the first time we met. You were barely able to stand up against other humans, let alone a Medrone or Hive. Why do you get to be this strong. This is so freaking humiliating. I wasn't on planning to let off so much steam. But I couldn't keep it in any longer.

I thought he joke around again. But his smiles drops a little, don't remind me of how I used to be. That guy got his ass kicked by so many people. He straightens up, its not like you to be so down. You changed too. You are just being blinded by your brother a little much. My face flushes with blood. He continues, I know you know this already. You respect your brother so much, that you don't think anyone, including yourself, can be like him. I feel even more anger, because he called me out on my most shameful thoughts. I yell, shut it. I want to be stronger like him, why is that bad. He shakes his head, like I told you before. Its not about you admiring him.

I shout, I remember. You think I am lionizing so much that I can't get stronger than him. He raises his arm, yeah. You need to understand, like I had to accept, you only get stronger by looking inside. Not by others. You can be inspired by them, but true strength, the kind your brother had, comes from inside. I didn't expect him to give me a profound lecture here. Its like he has gotten enlightenment or something. I such in with anger, I already know that. Its so obvious, everyone knows that. He dodges my fist and steps away, knowing and accepting is two different things. Trust me, I had to learn this the hard way.

He then laughs, well. I am sure you will learn. Unlike me, you aren't haunted by trauma or weird things like adult Ketriya. So that's enough chit chat about that. He goes in for a jab at my chest. I thwart it away with my hand, yeah. I like it more when you were taking shit and making bad flirty comments. He laughs as he catches my elbow before I could go in for a punch, try to be considerate. I haven't dated anyone in a while. And the girl I used to go out with wasn't really into flirting. So as humiliating it is, I need to learn what works and what doesn't. I pull my elbows in anger, and you found me to be your study date.

He smiles, someone getting ahead of themselves. He goes in for a kick, which barely missed my waist. He continues, I try it on all women I see. Well, except for Marina. She would absolutely roast me if I ever tried hitting on her. I know he is leading me on. But I didn't think before asking, and Elina. You have her wrapped in your fingers. That was probably a little mean, but he was caught off guard my back hand chop jab to his chest. I thought this was it was over. Before it connects, he twists around and crouches down. Then he pulls the exact move I hit him with in the beginning. A high kick from a low angle. I bring both my arms up to block that kick.

I stagger back a little. That was close. The bastard was only faking it, he give me an opening on purpose. He says, wow. Nice save. I thought I won just then. He shakes his head, should have just gone in for a punch. I blurt out, you can see then. This was all a trick, you bastard. There is no way that was a coincidence. He still doesn't give up, that's for you to figure out. I am so mad at him for playing so many dirty tricks on me. Even more furious that I got fooled. I know I shouldn't do it, but my emotions got the better of me. I dashed on instinct. At the corner of my eye I saw him bringing out his left hand.

So he finally feels its time to use it. I jumped up high with a aim to smash down my fist on his face. He was strangely not reacting to me. Just standing still while he raises his arm. That is my chance. I lounged in mid air, flipping to his side and then twist my around to lean on the ground and then cartwheel on my hands. Even David didn't see that coming when I aimed for a kick to his chest. I also saw his own kick coming straight at my face. Smack, my kick lands on his chest and his kick on my face.

We both get knocked away and fall on the mat. My eyes widens realizing what just happened. David's laughter echo's in the empty hall, a double knockout. How anti climactic. But I wasn't humored with this at all. Before he hand the chance to get up, I got up and ran at him. He says, Vanessa. What. I didn't care about the shock on his face, I fall hard on his chest and thrust in my thigh on his neck, you freaker. You did that on purpose. Didn't you. He taps on my thigh as I continue to put pressure on him. His face turns red in pain. The smile all gone with coughs and struggles. He tries to get up, but I force him down from my entire body's strength.

He groans under me. I shout, why did you that. I saw you hesitating with using your left arm. You could have won there. Did you feel pity for me. Did I ask for it. My fury boils even harder now. With his oxygen cut off, he begins to furiously taps on my thighs, gesturing to tap up. More painful noises comes from this lips. After I while my anger finally settles down. I let him go and he shoves me away, gasping and coughing for air. I sat, resting my hands on my bent knees with rampant breathing. David literally crawls away and lies flat on his back. I ask, tell me why.

Once he gets his breath back, were you trying to kill me. He leans down towards me. I ask, why didn't you use her left hand. Did it feel good to toy with me. The frustration and humiliation is consuming my every thought. He sighs, I am not saying anything, until you calm the freak down. Even I have a limit of how much of your bushtit I find it endearing. That outburst from him made me realize I let my anger control me. I close my eyes and let the adrenaline flush away. I hear a cloth rummaging, he is removing his eye band. We sat in a bit of silence with just heavy breathing.

Once I gather my emotions I ask, what was that. He says, I just let you believed I was going to using my arm. I knew you be wary of that. You would mess up a little. What I didn't expect was your desperation and persistence. You got me good, so I made a desperate move on the spot myself. I open my eyes to see him setting with his arms leaning on the ground behind him. He says, I wasn't pitying you. It was a trick which you fell for. Well, not all the way anyways.

Dammit. Why did I assume that earlier. I feel so ashamed of my behaviors. Off course that was a trick. That's all he has been doing this whole time. I tighten my fist in anger, but you still lied about not seeing. He says, of course I did. Did you honestly thought I can do all that, without my Kuret. He throws me the cloth. I pull it over my eyes to asses it, and I could see through the gaps of the fabric. Not completely, but enough to make out my moves. I felt so violated right now. I knew in my gut that he was lying. But then how did he do that, how did you defend your back.

He smiles, the first one was calculated. I figured you wouldn't want to take the chance in case I wasn't lying. I was waiting for you to attack me there. I even angled my shoulder so that I would catch your blows. I scoff, for freak sake. You got lucky then. He says, you can believe that if you want. But I really got lucky the second time. That was pure instinct and luck. It happens to people when they are locked in. Not at all uncommon with experienced people. So I just went along with the act. Damn him. Its so easy for him to say after the fact. But doing this in the middle of a fight is incredible.

I was both impressed and furious at him. I ask, what was with not using the arm thing then. He stand back up on his feet, I knew that I was in for a rough time even before you told me you were working out without Kuret. It was obvious you had the advantage. I was just talking shit earlier. He laughs, I am surprised you bought that act. That cocky grin on his face. I wish I could just punch him one more time. He comes over to me and extend his arm. The last time I refused, but this time I accepted it. He helps me get up, how does one get an advantage when you are loosing.

I wasn't interest in playing this, so I just wait for him to explain. He says, one way is to give an obvious weakness or restraint. Even if you believe I was lying about it, you would consciously pay more attention to it. Even make assumptions or mistakes. Its much difficult to ignore it in middle of a fight. I figured it was something like that. I was keeping a eye out for his left arm more cautiously than the rest of him. He says, I have seen Chinese Buddhists, practitioner of martial arts, not using hands or legs to attack. They just use their head, shoulder or waist to attack. Compared to them, I am but a fledgling. Trying anticipating their attacks and defend against that.

I shake my head, god dammit. Even when I prepared myself from your mind games, I fell into it. This leaves a bitter taste in my mouth. David grabs his aching neck, yeah, you paid a little too much to me. But, you still got the better of me. I feel immediate regret, are you okay. He smirk, not really. You chocked me with your leg. Under other circumstance, I be enjoying it. The nerve of him joking when its obviously hurting him. I step forward and grab his jaw. There are light bruising and marks around his neck. I say, sorry. I wasn't thinking straight. He walks to his bag and pulls out a bottle. He shakes it and sprays white liquid over his neck.

He sighs in a little relief, you thought I was not giving you the respect you deserved. I apologies if I gave you that impression. I was just doing my usual stuff. I thought you be used it by now. I sigh, I thought I did too. But you really got under my skin when you spoke about Wagner. She swipes his sweat with the towel, should have guessed that. I wanted to know how'd you handle it when I talk about Wagner. I ask, you think getting a rise out of me was the right thing to do. In the middle of that? He replies, it was actually the best time. Keep you unbalanced and also know how to react.

I didn't like being tested like this. But honestly, I don't like how I reacted to this. I got agitated too much, and felt insecure over it all too easily. But I still want to know about Wagner, no matter what. I ask, what happens to the bet then. It ended in a draw, shall we go at it again. David makes an annoyed face when I suggested that, the way I see it. We have three options, have another match, or we both loose or we both win. I rather not do this again or be the looser. That's so like him to got for the win-win situation. I scoff, wouldn't you love that. He puts on his jacket, I am not sure about that. Based on that little outburst, there is a good chance you will go for neck again.

I retort irritated, that was a mistake. Don't think I would just loose it again. I can tell he is not convinced. Then he stands up, well, doesn't matter. You made me promise, so I will tell you what you want to know. I just need to better prepare myself. I am hesitant to ask what he meant by that. But I didn't want to know if he really thought I would hurt him again. He is waiting for me to make a decision for him. I didn't have a real problem giving Elina some more leeway. And yet I am conflicted how he feels about her. But that's not fair to her. So I decided my choice, fine. I'll do it. Its funny how it became a deal into a bet.

I had a very good hunch that David's plan was always to end in a draw. He is more worried about my behavior than the fact that he has to tell me about Wagner. But whatever doubts he had, he stuck to his promise. Since I had busy work today, we agreed to meet tonight. I ask, why do you want Siera too. Are you still worried about that. He slides his hands on his neck. He smirk, I would feel safer with a witness the next time you do that. I roll my eyes at him. He is blowing it way out of proportion. He adds, but I want to hear from her directly, because whatever she told you, it had an effect on you. I couldn't deny it didn't. Its taken a lot of time for me deal with it.

So we break for the rest of the day. He resumed his training, while I went back home, got a shower and went to officers building. I need to figure what I'll do with Elina. Because I regardless of how feel about it, I can't let her get her life back without some more guarantees that she won't do something like this ever again. I spent the day reviewing our tech teams initials plans for using the tech bots. I discussed this with Ruther that we should have the bots up and running by this weekend. The R&D can tinker with it all they want, but Ivan said some we can use immediately without big changes. I want to tighten up our security in the next two weeks before Heraknus arrive.

The meetings and then reviewing the latest stats of the arrests we made took the rest of the day. We run running out of people to capture. Tessa says, we have about 27 aliases. Sommers says, that is a lot of names we don't know about. But at least we know what they bought. Any chance we try to track them. Tessa shows her analysis, I spent past few days researching on these items. I think I figured out somethings. She points to a picture of a teapot in her tablet. I ask, what is that. She replies, its very old Japanese clay teapot called Kyusu. Technically its not a relic, but there are only a few dozen of this particular type of teapot. But what's more important is something else.

She slides away to a different slide, which had some text over it. While others read, she explains to me, they need to be polished with oil every few weeks so it doesn't wither away. I want to track the purchases and put

surveillance on those people. I am concerned about this, won't that list be long. She nods, we don’t have a choice. Just like this, there few more items that needs special care or maintenance. I'll like to assign teams to work on this. It's going to be very tedious, but its all we got for now. I suppose we don't much of a choice. Sommers went to IDF to delegate the tasks and form teams.

Around 6:00, me and June went to the beach in section 2. She says, when will they be here. I answer, should be about 10 minutes. Deni messaged me they crossed the barrier few minutes ago. She nods in anticipation as I park my car in the lot. Others were also gathering here. Frank and Chelsea came with Marina in her car. And soon Blake, Luther and Jess arrives as well. Blake tell everyone, I know you all are very keen to see them, but we can't be seen in public for much long. We need to keep this under wraps from the people. Got it. Everyone understood the sensitivity of the arrivals. They escaped from a hostile Citradel, so they will be under major scrutiny.

Jess says, I will take them to different safe houses, but it would be better if you don't go with them immediately. I know its not ideal, but we can't have people see them with you. Luther had already explained the plan to the four of them days before. So they all had time to agree to this, even if they didn't like it. June asks, when can they come with us. Luther turns to Blake. He says, at least three days. It would be very suspicious if people saw five people from Citradel just few days later they broke out. Three days would be enough time to make the narrative that they left after our invitation of rescue.

Three despondent expressions appear on their faces. Marina says, its okay guys. I am sure we can see them at least. Can't we. Luther says, off course. You guys can meet them when you are off work. But inform Jess or Catherine before. Because only they will know where your people will be living temporarily. I ask, I assuming its not the guest houses or the home stays we usually use. Jess replies, we are setting them up with regular family houses. More importantly people who we can trust to keep quiet about it. I wonder who these people were. But Jess only mentioned they weren't linked to any officers. And that Catherine personally vetted them.

Speaking for her, why isn't she here. When others went to the edge of the beach, I asked Blake about her. He explains, I asked her to come. But she said she had a personal prior arrangement. His mood sours as he told me. I get the distinct impression that he doesn't want to talk about it. Then he asks, and what about this morning. How did David feel about you ambushing him. I had so much to tell, but it was one giant mess. My eyes drop down as my mind plunder with mixed emotions. He interpreted as anger, don't tell me you are fighting again. Because I thought he be less antagonist then before.

I blurt out, no. I mean we did fight. He raised his brows, we sparred over a silly bet. Its nothing serious. We did argue a little. And like you said, he was more amenable than previous times. He asks, that’s good right. I couldn't really be happy about it. He adds, unless you don't feel it was. I say, I am just confused about it. He agreed to tell me about Wagner. And wants to meet tonight with Siera at my place. I couldn't tell him about Elina yet. He is curious about this, when he says tell you about him. What did he mean exactly. I wonder if Blake something more than he is letting on. A week ago when he asked about Wagner, I gave him an awful attitude.

I wish I could take it bad. All the times I have been so overly judgmental and aggressive about it. Feels so different now that I can't believe how rude I was last time. I tell him, he didn't any specifics. But he told that he will tell the things that matter. Like what he told to Catherine. Whatever that means. Blake smirks, sounds like he is still sticking to his usual half truths. I nod, at least he is being honest about it instead of hiding it. Blake replies, I guess that's a refreshing change. Then I remembered what I told David earlier, I may have accidently led him on that you were angry with him. Because he meddled with Catherine and her human partner.

He jerks at me with a hard stare, and why pray tell did you believe that. I answer, because of you were behaving yesterday with Catherine. And I did notice some resentment at David too. Wasn't hard to guess why. His eyes sharpen for a moment and then he looks away to the boat arriving on the beach. He sighs, I am not an idiot. I know he only did it to fix things with Catherine. He would do this for anyone he cares about. I don't blame him for that. He pauses a while, but I don't like it how this lead to. So what you may saw is not anger, but maybe annoyance. I sometimes feel he shouldn't have interfered. Which I know I said it was to help her, but it didn't exactly turn out the way we hoped for.

I am sure even he assumed they would break up. He says, knowing the guy, know doubt he feel guilty about it. I should talk to him about that next time. Its eerie how they understood things about each other so easily. Unlike woman, men really does have easier friendship. I felt a little better knowing it wasn't anger that was directed at David. A minute later the boats dock at the beach and five people step out. Marina and others rush to greet their loved ones. A scrawny looking guy with scuffled hair, lifts June in the air hugging tightly. Chelsea kisses her girlfriend. Frank and his foster parents lock in arms and shoulders. Marina and her friend fist bump than turn into a bear hug.

We waited for them to let them have this moment. After several minutes of excited faces and joyous reunions. They begin to walk inward to us officers. Blake greets each of them individually. I and the test meet them with warm appreciations. I tell, welcome everyone to our city. I am Vanessa, the chief of IDF. Junes partner Sam, the one who apparently was smitten by me goes in hard for my hand as I reached for a handshake. He yells, I am huge fan of yours. I couldn't but smile how he was enthusiastically smiled. June, like a jealous girlfriend, grabs his arm away, stop grinning you idiot. You are being rude to her.

I answer back, nah. Its all fine. Its good to know I still got it. My boyfriend says that to me all the time. That made him a little less excited, oh. You really do have a boyfriend. That’s ah, awesome. I could literally see his eyes wonder around awkwardly. June drags him away mumbling, I told you. And he is an officer that will kick your ass if you give him trouble. I remember she told me to bring Ned when I met him. Unfortunately, this will have to suffice for now. Despite that, he waves me bye with a wide smile.

The alpha twins parents were nice and cordial. They were however very exhausted from the trip. Jess says, it must have been terrible. I don't know what the travel arrangements were, but it must have been harrowing. The mom, Betty, says, it was a unlike anything I have experienced before since arriving on Earth. Lionel, says, we moved around a lot. In shipping containers, storage trucks and even in a flight cargo space. Candice, Chelsea's girl friend with darker complexion and short hairs, says, at one time we were in some sort of farm animal trailer filled with goats and sheep.

Just what kind of escape plan did David cook up. Then came Jeena, who was a little older than the rest of us. I don't know why, but I assumed she was Marina's age. She looked in her late thirties with blonde hair and piecing on her ear and nose. She says, but what's even crazier was that we got everything we needed. There was this guy, who asked us to call him magic. He was with us the whole time and just his moniker, would magically bring us whatever we needed. Frank asks, seriously. A guy named magic. Chelsea says, a fake name for sure. Candice says, yeah. He also had a mask on him all the time. But props to him, he kept us from falling apart all the way here.

I ask, when you say he got you stuff. Was it like normal supplies and stuff. Betty answers, oh yeah. We wanted a board game to pass the time and he got it in the next few hours. And this was when we were in a plane. The guy was truly a magician. Jenna says, you should have seen it Marina. I somehow got a spa massage when we were on road, travelling in what I think was a transportation truck. Marina yells, the freak. A massage as you being smuggled out of Citradel and into our city. Frank says, all while being incognito from the humans. Who the hell did David hire to for this.

It really sounds ludicrous. Lionel says, the travel was cramped and at times uncomfortable, but I can't complain about the impressive treatment we got. Betty, it certainly helped the arduous journey. Jenna says, we talked a lot about it. We complained at times, but we were risking a lot leaving Citradel. Marina smiles suspiciously, I need to know who this magic guy is. Sounds like an interesting guy. Jenna says, not a boyfriend material for you. He might be able to tolerate you, but you aren't his type. Marina scoffs, and how would you know. He smiles, because I asked him as a joke and he said he wasn't interested in dating an alien. They both snicker enjoying the banter.

I can see now how she is so close to Marina. She gives off a elder sister vibe to Marina. Candice says, I was hoping to see David. Thank him for getting us out of Citradel. It took a turn for the worse last few days. Jenna says, he must be with those three. Blake asks, I have been meaning to ask. Where did they go. Jenna explains, unlike us, David's guy was more careful than us. Marina says, that’s understandable. This was planned for him, his wife and their son in the beginning. Candice says, they wore scarfs and masks all the way to protect their identity. Betty says, we hardly spoke to them. But the wife wasn't really too happy with their infant child.

Marina warns her friend, you sure you didn't tell anyone who they were. Jenna scoffs, please. Not my first smuggling experience. Was she being facetious or serious. I really couldn't tell. Candice says, don't worry. Only Jenna knows who they were. The guy was actually decent and seems polite. But he said he was sorry while keeping his distance from us. Just then Blake gets a call and he excuses himself for a while. Marina asks, when did they sperate from you guys. Candice says, I think when we got on the boat. Jenna says, I think it was before we got off the truck. Can't be sure about it.

I had a thought, David probably doesn't want to take any chance with them and personally escort them in. Luther says, and how exactly does he plan to cross the barrier without notifying us. Deni still hasn't heard from them. Jess says, I don't think he will ask for permission. Luther scoffs, you think he will smuggle them in undetected. She stares at me for a second, I don't know. Maybe. But I have a feeling he has many tricks up his sleeve. Oh damn, she still has suspicions about David being a Shadow. I gave her my best confused poker face to avoid giving her any answer. She then gives a similar look to Marina. She gave a much more convincing expression that she doesn't know anything about that.

Jess begins explain the plan after June brings back Sam. They way he was panicking could be anything, a quick making out with June or berating him for being overly friendly with me. Luther relays the same talk again to them about hiding them in the city, it's temporary. And you will be able to visit at your discretion. Jenna says, I sort of already figured we will have to remain quiet for a while. Chelsea asks, we will see you guys very soon. June says, I assume are you moving them to different place every day. Having spent a week as an officer, she had gotten a good grasp of how we do this. Jess didn't confirm nor deny it. She just smiles letting us believe whatever we want.

They all follow Jess to her jeep, while Luther and I get their additional luggage's from the boat. Blake returns after a while and asks, Marina. I need to talk to you for a moment. Marina nods and waves bye to Jenna, what's up. I listen in, but they went to talk separately. Once others leave, I mention June to wait for a moment while Blake and Marina finish their talk. I didn't think it was any serious because Marina was laughing, but also being confused at times. June asks, did something happened. I shrug. After a while Marina suddenly creates a charm and takes off to the sky. But the weird thing is that she is heading out, into the ocean.

Blake approaches us, Vanessa. I need you to authorize an emergency exit protocol for Marina. I am concerned about the timing, where is she going. Blake sighs, its actually not an emergency. Its just the wife is not really cooperating and David is being cornered by her. I need Marina to help smooth things out.

David (Chapter 117)

Thursday, March 19, 2026 15:54

M says, they are two minutes out. At this distance, I could see the glimmers already. The waves rock my boat while its docked at a small collection of rocks. The same place I picked Catherine from few days ago. The speed approaches closer in the dim glow of the sun. Once they dock beside my boat, I could make out two figures in coats, one small baby and four luggage's behind them. It took a while to realize how much Jack has changed over the years. His hair was cut shorter now and I think he put on a little muscles too. He waves to me, are you sight for sore eyes man. We pat each other backs, its been a long time coming. Sorry it had to be this way in the end.

We lean away. A much warmer smiles appears on his face, shitty luck of mine. Can't catch a break. He offers his hands to his wife, who was carrying their son. They board down my boat. She removes her hoodie to reveal a blue streaked hair and few freckles on the checks. She appears completely drained of live. Carrying a baby with you in cramped spaces will do it that to you. But I saw her glimmers more flickering and greenish. She is being anxious and might have doubts about this. That's is to be expected. Jack introduces her, meet Alishia, the love of my life. And that bundle of joys is Kelton.

I bring out a bring smile looking at the sleeping baby in Alishia's arms. I turn to her, I am so glad to meet you. She gives me a very subtle nod while gripping her son a little closer to her chest. Is it just me or she is being weird. I chalk it up to the stress and the arduous journey. And besides, I think meeting me is making her even tense about it. I turn to Jack who felt the awkwardness. He licks his tongue, she is just tired. We all are. I can only imagine that. I go over their boat to fetch their bags. Jack asks me, let me give you a hand. I stop him, I got this.

I raise my hands and throw out my Kuret like giant claws. I didn't want to flaunt my prowess to them at the get go. But I figured they be less tense if they saw I am capable. Plus, it was a good test to see using my Kuret on something other than just weights. I grabbed the four bags with my Kuret and hurl them into my boat. It wasn't very graceful, but put every effort to not break any fragile item in their luggage's. I think I even felt the physical strain on my arms, even though it was supposed to be just a psychic connection to the meta physical Kuret. Guess I still have a long way to go for anything beyond carefully handled weights at the gym.

Jack says, impressive. It wasn't a fluke you won the tournament. I laugh as I start our boat back up. I instruct M to take the other boat into the underground cave. Alisha and Kelton took the bench at the back while Jack and I spoke at the wheel. I ask him, are they okay. He says, they will be fine. Four days stuck with strangers, who I can't reveal much about us. It wasn't really comfortable. I apologies to him about the extra people, this is wasn't the original plan. But I had to help out the warriors who joined us. He replies, it was a shock. Not going to lie. But Jenna explained to me it why it was important. And after spending enough time with them, I understood.

He told me how they kept their faces and identified a secret. No one knows him personally, but he didn't want to take any chance. Then he asks, I have been meaning to ask you for a long time. Where did you disappear. You were missing for almost a year after the valley. Next thing I heard you were fighting in war with Hive. I told him a shortened version. I didn't have the time nor the temperament to explain that I lost my earth memories. So I told him what I told most people. I was gravely injured and in a coma for months. Which wasn't technically a lie, but I was in one only for few weeks.

He says, I heard you died at the time. Never thought it was a something as base as a human coma. shitty luck man. I tell you, we both are got the raw end of it. I chuckle, but you found a family though. Can't be all that bad. He gives a weak smile while turning back to his family, that’s true. He then leans in, just between us. I wasn't looking forward to getting married, let alone a kid. I say, says every guy ever. He shakes his head, no. I am being serious. Between getting my revenge and spying, I always left it wasn't in the cards for me. I ask, what changed then.

His smile begins bigger, Alishia. Before I knew it, I was madly in love her. I knew she was the one for me. I turn back to check on those two. Somehow they were asleep. I ask, what does she know about you. His smile drops and becomes a little sad, you mean what I told about you. I nod, and why you had a league with me in the first place. He takes brief pause to think about his words. He reveals, I made a mistake and she found about some intel I was gathering. And we almost broke up back then. I am a little shocked to learn he got caught and kept it quiet about it all this time. Then I settle my confusion realizing she is here with him now, so they had to patch things up.

But could it be because of their son, did she get pregnant that time? He scoffs, if that happened then, trust me, we would be in a completely different situation. So it happened before they even got married. He says, she found about me few weeks after your civil war with Nathan. I was much more clueless on covering my tracks intel back then. Alishia was a clerk at the councils office were I was poking around. We hit off from there. Though I think she always suspects I was using her to get info out of the council. It made sense she believe that. I ask him, and did you.

He gave a suspicious answer, yes and no. I did peek at her work, but stopped when things got serious. But don't tell her that. I assure him, I got you. I am assuming she understood and maybe even forgave you. He snickers, understood, yes. Forgive, I don't think she will ever. I was deliberating a lot to tell her. But if I wanted her back, I had to reveal I was there for my brother and how keeping my end of the deal to get justice for him. This was the first time I heard him tell me the reason why he out for revenge. He gets curious a bit, I think I never told you this before.

I answer, not you didn't. I never realized you had a brother. He becomes upset rehashing something so painful, it happened when we both were in Valley. Way before you stirred up shit back then. My brother got wind of those experiments with human children and he got caught. Nathan ordered him to be imprisoned, but our stupid alpha forgot the give the medication to my brother. He had Asma and died in the prison. Pain and sorrow drenched on his face, in star contrast when he spoke about his wife and son. I console him, my condolence. I may have not known your brother, but it seemed he wanted to do the right thing unlike others. He nods appreciating my words.

He says, he was kinder person than me, that’s for sure. But the freaked up part is I didn't even know he died in the prison. That freaker, Lorance told me he gave a long mission to my brother, which I was gullible to believe. I only found out when you broke out from the prison and I saw his rusted stuff and a note left carving on the wall left before he died. I confronted Lorance, I even tried to kill him. But with Nathan backing him up, I wasn't ever going to get a chance. He then looks at me hope, I sought you out soon after that. You know the rest.

I imagined it was very personal and something like this. That’s why he was desperate for a way to get back at them. But it was my turn to be upset, I had a chance to kill Nathan and his sorry ass group of cohorts. But I couldn't do it. You have no idea how much I wanted, but in the end Jess and Freya were begging for me to spare him. I am sorry I couldn't keep up my bargain. He says in a grim voice, when I heard you spared them. I was furious. I waited for you to finish them, but I heard you disappeared. But you had foiled their operations and control. I even thought of doing it myself.

I ask, why didn't you. Lorance no longer had any backing anymore. He smiles, what do you think. I met Alisha when I snooping around info about Lorance. She didn't know it yet, but she saved me a life of misery. I felt like I had found a better purpose in my life. Eventually I gave up looking for revenge. So you don't have to apologies to me. In hindsight, it was probably for the best. Killing them won't bring back the people we lost. Didn't you also stop because you found something else to strive for. I was going slowly insane by talking to an imaginary Liz. So yeah, once I found some clarity, I did settle for hope rather than unnecessary killing.

He took my quiet as understanding, that being said. I rather not see Nathan or Lorance ever. I smile, you won't have to. Nathan is on a tight leash. He makes one wrong move and he knows I am going to kill him. And Lorance is no longer an alpha. In fact, apart from few people, we have stripped off their alphas to others. He eyes seems brighter hearing their situations, Lorance is no longer an alpha huh. Guess that answers why he didn't participate in the tournament. Must be pretty miserable not having that power anymore. That actually make me happy. He then laughs, but oh man. You have changed a lot. I cannot believe how casual you are about threatening a royal alpha. I remember you struggled against Jess that one time. You have only gotten a lot crazier since then.

I answer, a lot as changed since you saw me all those years ago. Blake is a terra and we got more overdrive users than ever. And so have you. When I met you, we were brought together with pain and suffering. And owing others who wronged us. I can't believe the guy, who only ever cared was to throw Lorance into meat grinder, fell in love with a women while on the said mission. He laughs, there are shitty luck. And then there is the stroke of luck never known. He then gets a little distracted, but there was a time when I thought we were done. When I told her the truth about everything. It took a while, but we made it work.

He shakes his head, and then she got pregnant. It was the best day of my life. Knowing I will be a father soon, I should have stopped the dangerous stuff like spying. It was difficult to decide since I didn't want to dishonor our deal. It was the second time in our life that we were close to giving up on us. I grab his shoulder, and you thank you for sticking with me. I can't imagine that was easy. It is surprising that she let you continuing sending me intel. He gives smirk, love man. It makes you do crazy things, even if the other person does things that questions you about everything. He didn't need to explain further. I have been lately aware of that more than ever.

I ask, how did she take it when you told about leaving Citradel. He turns a little anxious, you won't believe this. But she was the one who asked me to leave. That was a surprise since I have been believing he had been the one to convince her. He explains how she had access to councils work orders before anyone. Before the tournaments final, it was all business as usual. That changed with Heraknus reveals and their departure. She saw documents suggesting they were looking ways to replace Heraknus military power. That in it self wasn't a problem, but she saw others plans for seizing power. Like stealing weapons and research from humans.

I actually didn't think it was a bad plan. But it seems Alishia was not okay depending on humans and inviting unwanted troubles that comes from it. I can't really deny that problem since I dealt something like that with the people I deal with on regular basis. But since then, the doubts been spreading for a while. And it became a legitimate concern after the riots. When Jack found about it, she jumped at the chance to leave Citadel, thinking it wasn't a safe place to raise a child. Again, can't argue on that. Jack is grateful that she understood it was right time to jump ships.

I asked about Selena and what's her motives. He says, I personally thought she was about inspiring people. I don't know how serious is she about Blake and Marina, behaving as if they were god send. Though, I met plenty people who accepted it completely. And Alishia herself is follower of one of the religion the priest is leading. But instigating riots is a line even she doesn't believe in. I asked him about the conditions and the reasons it happened. He explains how he has collected all the communique around the church and council. He didn't have the time to figure out what happened and was more focused on covering their escape.

Thankfully he has all the data in a disk. He turns anxious, I made a promise to Alishia that I will hand it over only when we step into our new lives. I ask, leverage, huh. Even after I got all of you out of there. He gulps a little after a tense moment. I nod after giving it some though, clever girl. You are lucky to have her. He sighs a little, don't I know. I was actually very interested on what happened in Citradel. Because whatever happened, in the end it worked out in our favor. More than me, Blake and Luther are very concerned and they are in the correct position to figure out this mess. That intel is vital. Which he plans to hand over once they are satisfied about their new life.

Soon we reach near the barrier and I turn off the engine. Jack wakes up Alishia and I explained to them about this secret passage way. Immediately Alishia yells, no way in hell I am letting go of my son. She was so exhausted I saw orange glimmers from her. Now slowly turning into a hue to red, anger. I try to convince her, I am not asking you to. He will be perfectly safe with me. But she wasn't having any of it, no. I didn't travel with goats for me to let of him now. Doesn't matter how many ridiculous things like barbers or masseuse you give us. I honestly had no idea what she meant by that. Did that strange guy with the moniker magic really giving a royal treatment.

I shake off the thoughts about him, I promise you. He will be fine. I can be trusted. Jack agrees with me, Lis, we have trusted him this much already. Why not a trust him little bit more. She gives Jack an honest to god death stare with unblinking wide eyes, how can I trust him. He used you for his crazy revenge against the royal alpha. I don't care if he is strong. I won't trust anyone who manipulate others and gets away with murders. I am so lost how distrustful she is with me. With confusion, I face Jack, who just gives me an apologetic expression in return. I realize she has bought into Ryes nonsense. Jack would know the truth about Nathan, but not about other things.

It crossed my mind that things in Citradel wouldn't be like here. While I am rivered here, I most definitely am painted in a different picture there. I should confirm this before I continue on. With a condescending tone I ask, tell me this. Do you believe I cheated during the tournament, and even tried to poison Marina. She faces me back with anxious look. She tried to look tough for others sake, but her glimmer now has a shade of yellow, fear. She remains quiet, but I got the answer I needed by her glimmers. Jack was terrified of the situation too. He says, of course we don't think that’s true. Tell him Lis.

I make my stance rigid, well, what do you think of me. She speaks up in a soft voice now that I was intimidating her directly, I don't know. People tell you cheated. I ask, I don't care about others. I want you to tell me what you think. That got her more scared. She even clutches her son more tightly. Jack gets a little bit defensive now, lets not make this a thing. There are lots of different rumors going around. You are stealing from Citradel. So people aren't happy about it. I tell him, well I am not happy Ryes dig up private things about me and twisted them to fit into his own agenda of slandering me. So I like to know much of a liability I have become.

That made Jack even more tense. I am sure that my interview was seen by everyone in Citradel. I take a little offense that even after deriding myself, lying about everything, people still don't believe me. Alishia tried to show some resolve, you want the intel Jack has right. If that's gets us a safer place for Kelton, that's all I care about. Doesn't matter what is truth about you. I have witnessing the first hand brainwashing of the people of Citradel. I wasn't expecting to get a chance to see it for myself. But its fascinating to know how she really feels about me. Unlike Jack, who she loves and trust, she doesn't have the same faith as him. So there are more like her in Citradel.

Even when I am intimidating her on purpose, she doesn't crack and stays true to Kafar's or someone else's agenda. I didn't think two weeks of rumors and secret ploys were this effective on Citradel. Goes to show how lucky I was here. Especially with people like Cranston. While Jack tried to convince her I thought of a different approach. She says, I don't understand how you can trust him with our son. You are not his friend, only an asset. She isn't wrong. Ours has always been a professional relationship. Jack gives a suggestion, can you let us in with blindfolds instead.

Before I could open my mouth, Alishia says, no way. We snuck out Citradel like thief's, I won't do it again. Not when you and Kelton are my only concern. Aside from her obvious distrust, its admirable how much she loves them. I think its more or less because of the long journey she had to endure. Exhausted and on the run from Citradel with strangers. Anyone would be cranky. Though she has her own issues also. Anyways, I can't complain since I didn't know Jack had a family to begin with. What should I do now. I look around the empty ocean. She immediately yells, we are not going back. We have no where to go.

I tell her, calm down. No is making you go away. I just turn my back to them and gaze towards the island. Then I had an idea. I ask, since you don't trust me. What if can get someone you do trust. Jack asks, who? And we are in the middle of the ocean. I face them back, don't worry about that. Alishia asks confused, what are you talking about. I fish my phone from my pocket, if I get Blake here, would you trust him instead to take your son inside through the barrier while I bring you inside myself. They turn to each other with confusion. She asks, by Blake you mean the prince. I nod, and the leader of this island. A Shadow. And not to forget a terra. You think you can trust someone chosen by Kuret itself.

That got her thinking hard. They whispers somethings and then after a while she says meekly, maybe. Though she still held a lot of doubt. Actually I had another person in mind. Someone far more trustworthy to them. I just named Blake to see how she perceived him. I ask, what's wrong. You don't trust him because I am his friend. That seems a little unfair. Her eyes gives off a lot of anger, but she couldn't really say her feelings aloud. I wonder to what extend her distrust goes. Is to me or just people around me. I ask, what about Vanessa. You must have heard her. How she fought against Hive for years.

That got the ball rolling, I know her. She was the one who lost to Marina, didn't she. I nod, she is leading the security of this island. I can get her instead in case you don't think Blake is not good enough. She says in disbelieve, you know her. I laugh at her oblivious attitude. Though I understand it might not be a common knowledge as others. Even Jack apparently didn't know, wait. That Vanessa, the omega. You are friends with her. Actually, I am more than that. But I if talk about our convoluted shared history, we be stuck in the ocean for days. For the time being I explain, she is one my closest confidants.

Well, just today we might have patched things up again. But they didn't know that. Alishia didn't believe me though, why would she associate with you. Because of you people died at that warehouse. I know that she has been furious with you for years about that. That bit of information told me everything about the slanders and public misinformation spreading. Even Jack, who probably didn't think that was true, is still puzzled by this. So I have been surgically isolated from the rest of the people. Making them believe I don't have close connection to other influential people.

I begin to smirk thinking how ridiculous that effort was. Soon they are going to join us and know what kind of lies they have been told. But its very suspicious that they go this far, even after knowing they are loosing this struggle. Jack asks, what's so damn funny. I shake my head, nothing. I was just thinking what Catherine, June or Derek would say about it. I mean they all believe I am being framed by Ryes. That's just sad. As soon as I said those big names their attitude becomes tense. Alishia asks, lies . They are all omega's who are being tricked by you. They wouldn't stand for any injustice when they uncover of the real truth. They are just tolerating you for now.

Hot damn. Now we are really digging deep. The way she just quoted injustice meant she thinks of them as righteous and I was the preverbal snake in the garden guy. Oh man, Nathan is going to love this. So the narrative is being stretched out like I am the lesser devil that people have to deal with. I wonder if church is also involved somehow in this. So far I haven't heard what they preached about me. They definitely had some opinions of me. Maybe that intel holds that particular answer. Jack realizes how Alishia is making things worse, stop this Lis. We don't know the whole story. But she remains adamant, I don't need to know everything. I know enough.

What a pain. I doubt she would believe anything short of a Ryes confessing that he lied. This is turning out to be bigger problem than I anticipated. Its something I need to deal with before people arrive. For the time being I got what I needed, I am glad we talked. I have a good grasp on how I am seen in Citradel right now. I used a more calmer voice now. They both are bewildered how nonchalant I was. I wave my hand to her, don't worry. I don't hold any grudge against you. I mean, if I was living in a Citradel and I heard so many things about me. I would believe it too. Jack asks, ah, you aren't mad.

I chuckle, nope. Actually, I am surprised you found a wife is so brave. I am being a little facetious about how naïve she is being. Alishia was stunned by her sudden compliment, even thought she hurled only slanders at me. I explain, its obvious she cares about you and your son. And that's what's more important. Doesn't matter what you think of others, good or bad. You need to be all kinds of things to survive from now on. Stubbornness can be a very good thing when its for the right reasons. I can't be mad at her for believing what powerful people say. That's just normal crowd mentality. She is speechless, but her glimmers show she is less scared now.

I pull out my phone and dial in Blakes number. Once it connects I ask, Blake. Did I catch you at a wrong time. He says, ah, I just met with the rest of the people at the beach in section 2. Where are you calling from. I never seen this type of alert call before. Its not a priority alert message. I tell him, you remember the software patch I had installed in your phone. Well, among many things, it lets you connect from outside the barrier. He scoffs, what. Are you kidding me. Is this even safe to use. I assure him, don't panic. With the amount of encryption, overlays and around the world signal hops this connection has, only god can figure out where you are.

I exaggerate a little. Of course If you have a cutting edge, state of the art tracing equipment's, one can triangulate the location. Too bad I own most of them myself. And the ones I don't, they have to know my cell number first. Which changes every week. Blake takes a pause, well, I know you won't compromise the safety of the island. So this better be important. I say, it is. We hit a little snag. Turns out my friends wife is not really a fan of mine. Doesn't trust me enough. She gives me a hard look when I say that in front of her. Blake says, that's what we were concerned about people from Citradel. Isn't it.

I tell, I will tell you about that later. First, you should talk to her directly. She needs a little bit encouragement that she can trust us. You know who best fits this particular job for recent Citradel escapee's with trust issues. It didn't take much long to figure out what I meant, I see. Fortunately, she is right here with me. Let me talk to the wife then. I held my phone to her. She becomes anxious and panics at Jack. I tell, its for you. He wants to welcome you and regrets couldn't come himself. I add in a little white lie to help her along. Jack encourages her, its fine. I got Kelton. After giving me her classic death stare, she hands over the baby to him.

With a hesitant expression, she grabs the phone from my hand. He meekly says, hello. I decide to give them some space while I talk to M, I need to run another behavioral prediction algorithm. M asks, what are the parameters. I explain, there is a dataset of highly unstandardized data between two major institutions. I need you to create search protocols. First, about anything related to me or Ryes. Then use them to create the model. I need to know how much damage I am looking at. M asks, please clarify the required analysis, boss. I was not happy about detailing negative things about me. But I had to remain objective here.

I gave M all the specific answers I needed before Citradel moved here. After some time, Alisha approaches me. Her worries were not yet gone. But her white glimmer were much more now. So she is at least less worried now. She hands me her phone and walks away without saying anything. I put it against my ear, so how did it go. He sighs, she is one tough lady. Wouldn't budge no matter how I explain things like misinformation and propaganda. Had your friend also bought into all this bullshit. I honestly can't say for sure. I tell, maybe not like her. But its hard for him to side against his own wife on this. Blake says, that is a mess, but obvious I suppose.

He clears his thought, anyways. I told her I am going to send Marina. I assume you can help get her come to you. Because I don't want to issue a boat. Just sending her in and out inconspicuously is pushing it. I says, I already sent out an ART boat she can use. Just tell her to fly about 8 miles in northwest from your beach. The boat will be glowing with lights to mark it. And it won't appear in the border sensors. Blake replies, okay. I am going to ignore your blatant breach in our security. I laugh as he hangs up. I turn to others who were still nervous. Alishia is in state of panic, talking to Jack in hushed tones. I continue to give them their privacy.

We waited for another 20 minutes until I saw the same boat that dropped off them approaching from a different direction. They both hustle up to get ready. They both wore their face masks and Alishia added a scarf wrapped around herself. Soon Marina joins us, hey guys welcome to the island. They both nervously shook hands with a cheerful Marina. She turns to me, I heard you are giving them trouble. Is that true. I think she is trying to get on their good sides. But I wasn't going to let her dictate unilaterally, you know me, a troublemaker. Unlike you. I flash her a smile that made her even more relish in her fake glory.

She turns to others, don't worry. With me around, he can't cause any trouble. The nerve of her, and yet I could only smile at her. I need to keep her in line and not get carried away, 11th birthday. The courtyard. And what was the poor guys name. hmm. That made her turn her smile into a scowl, give it a rest will you. Forget about that. I was a only a kid back then. I shrug, and what a mischievous one at that. Do you want me to tell you what your Istra thought of it when she told me. She clenches her jaws, damn you mom, telling unnecessary things to other. Now it was my time to enjoy in her misery.

Jack and Alishia were gawking at us so confused. They obviously didn't know we both were childhood friends. Now that they have seen a hint of our true dynamics, I ask, Marina, she actually believes I poisoned you. What do you think about that. Marina shakes off her frustration and faces them, don't tell me you got sucked into the nonsense from Ryes. Or was that from Kafar. Argh. Jenna was just telling me what a mess Citradel is in. Alisha is a daze, perhaps stunned by being near Marina. Jack speaks up, ah. Sorry. But you too seem awfully close. Do you two know each other on Medrine.

Marina gives a wicked smile, know him? She then faces me, I was his first crush. I made a loud tongue click, you actually believe that, don't you. She says, I know it. I was in Shadows, and practically an alpha. I had guys crushing on me all over the university. I scoff realizing she is juxtaposing herself with Zakerine. I didn't like that how eerily close they were with their Kuret hierarchy and similar inclinations towards secrete organization. I wonder what would have happened if they had ever met together. I can't even imagine that dangerous fantasy. Marina laughs, anyways. Trust me, David is the last person that will hurt me.

Alishia blurts, but you are being tricked by him. Marina's smiles disappear, please. I am easily tricked in things like this. Who told you that anyways. We wait for Alishia to explain, but she remained speechless. Jack says, its what the council and Ryes are telling. Marina shakes her head, I thought they be smarter than this. She turns to me, any idea why they continue to spread lies? Aren't they soon going to move here. She had the same questions I have. I tell her, don't know it yet. Its hardly enough of a reason to stop people from leaving Citradel. Even if they don't believe me, they have to know there are more than enough trustworthy people here.

She says, like me. Right, that's why I am here. I nod while eyeing Alishia. Lets see if her perception changes in any way after seeing the warrior she has known for almost a decade. All I see are more pink and brown glimmers. So she is only surprised, but not necessarily cleared from suspicion. It isn't possible to see things differently just in a short time. She says, see. This is how he really is. You think he is stupid enough to make enemies of us. She is getting a little defense of me. While I appreciate the frustration she shows for me, I can't let them trust her less for now. I gesture Marina with my hands in Shadow language, this should be enough. She get the message and calms down.

After a pause she says, well, regardless. I am here, so what I can do to help. She waited for them to speak up. They turn to me, but I also remained quiet. If they going to ask something, they should do it themselves. Jack speaks up, right. So, she, has some doubts. He gets pocked lightly by Alishia's elbow to his guts, I mean we both have concern about our child's safety. Alishia pulls out the blanket over their baby. Marina gleams with joy, look at those chubby cheeks. I just want to bite them. She leans forward to see Kelton more closely, look at those eyelashes, she is beautiful. I realize what she is doing.

I laugh, yeah well, once he grows up, people can tell how Marina called him that. Marina acts nervous, oh shit. Sorry. I mean your son is very cute. Jack chuckles, thanks. Hold on, you didn't know about him. Jenna didn't tell you about us. Marina acts a little bit frustrated, I heard she promised to keep your identities a secret. Even from me. That really irks me out. Alishia asks, but she got a message from you. Marina points to me, that was from him. I just passed the message to Jenna. Aren't you guys keeping your identities hidden because you don't know whom to trust. That seems a little excessive. Though I now understand a little better after seeing the baby boy.

That changed their glimmers to more whites. Marina's white lie is working. She already knows who they were. This is charade to let them keep their secret and feel more trustworthy towards her. Like Marina said, they weren't sure of anything and took precautions regardless. I don't know if they really bought this or not, but at least they want to trust Marina. She then faces me, I can't believe you won't even trust them to keep the route a secret.

Didn't they know the escape route from Citradel. This isn't any different.

I smile, nice try. You just want to about the way yourself. That got her tongue and mumbles, jerk. I tell her, the difference is that I am still living here. I can't burn this route like we did for Citradel. She knows that, but she has been obstinately asking about it for a while now. She sighs, at least tell me how you guys escaped. You had others in a blindfold for majority of the escape, so they don't know. Jack turns his head to me. I nod and gesture him its fine. He says, in the south downtown of Yukon, there is a deli shop. It had a entrance to an underground defunct train tunnel. In about 4 miles, it opens near to the great bear lake. We took a boat to the other side and met a guy called magic, said he was coordinating our escape.

Marina thinks about this for a moment. Then she shakes her head, no way. I know the layout of Citradel in my sleep. Yokan had a very old tunnel system that got scrapped in the 19 hundreds. Sure, the tunnels are big enough for people to move around. But there are no tunnel running under south downtown. Alishia says, I thought too. But we came from there. Marina says, I wouldn't make a mistake to not map that entrance. She waits for me to explain, but I just gave her a smile, letting her come to the conclusion herself. She gasps a little, bloody shit. How did the tunnel seem? Was it rusted and chipped off. Alishia says, yeah. It was very old.

Jack says, but I remember something odd. I saw some new wirings up in the ceiling in the beginnings, which wasn't there after a while. Marina scoffs at me, you freaker. You dug the tunnel yourself. Didn't you. You constructed a new tunnel that connects to the old one. She has glimmers of maroon now. Equal parts impressed and annoyed. I tell her, guilty. The only way you can get into and out of a very secure place is not you use existing routes, but to create one. I was fortunate enough to find the smallest route, roughly 400 meters, to connect to the nearest tunnel. I got very lucky when found the route.

Marina clicks her tongue frustrated, how in the hell did you build one. And how did know one heard when such a massive tunnel was being dug underneath Citradel. I could tell her that this project took nearly an year to complete. I got a construction crew working on it just before the valley war. I had the crew enter Citradel as human city water level inspectors and map out the entire grid. Later, they would enter the tunnels at night and worked on digging it silently and very slowly. Since it had to be in secret, it was stretched to months. I had initially done this for myself, in case I ever needed to use it.

Since tournament ended in pretty much our win, that secret tunnel is not longer needed. I should feel bad for wasting a quarter million on that. But at least I got some use of it in the end. I couldn't see the two people's expression, but their glimmers showed trepidation. They realize their city architect had no idea of this route. It did felt a little good. I signal to her, this evens us for the tunnels you build secretly in our Island. She begins to laugh knowing she couldn't complain more. I think Alishia wouldn't feel comfortable around me anymore. But I setup the conversation making seem like Marina didn't know everything about me. So in turn, Alishia can trust her.

This gives her the courage to ask, Blake told you are willing to take to our son. She nods, If you guys allow it. I will bring him to you after we get him our routine medical protocols. That was news to me. Blake must told her to do that since Kelton isn't brought in normally. Marina explains to them about the mandatory shots, the one which I credited to Nathan in my interview. I don't think they would even believe if it was my team who found that vulnerability and synthesized a practical version for newborns as well. Alishia didn't like the idea of giving her son something weird. Marina made a compromise, they can come to the hospital and meet with the doctors administering the vaccines.

Jack asks, won't people asks questions why we came so late for Kelton shot. He is 15 months old. I explain, actually, it works in your favor. I lot of people after my interview are getting their kids vaccinated. Like you, not many trusted it before. But now, a lot of them don't want to take any chance. You can make up any story you want. Marina says, just say you guys are finally ready. That's what I hear many people giving as reason. Marina convinced them it was for Kelton's sake. Alishia took a lot of time to agree. They finally gave in after Marina gave another compromise, a charm over Kelton in which no one can touch her. Only Marina and blood relatives can touch Kelton.

It was a clever idea that gave her enough trust. Once she prepared the charm on Kelton, she tested it with us. Jack and Alishia could grab Kelton without any problem. But when I tried to, it zapped me. Actually, I can still cut through her charm with my Kuret, but that would be counter productive with Alishia here. She didn't realize that I can that that, so its better to not say. With a lot of negotiation, Marina grabs Kelton. Alishia kisses on Kelton head, mum and dad is going to be with you soon. So don't worry. Jack says, if he wakes up, just give him this. He hands Marina a small cube shaped Kuret toy, he loves this.

Marina carries the baby to her boat, he is in good hands. I will see you soon. And then her boats leaves towards the barrier. Even I think it's a bit extreme to do all this just because I didn't want to show anyone my route. But its very important to me to have an escape route. I hope I never have to use it, but I will be more comfortable with the option. When the boat disappears into the night, I give out instructions to M for the passage protocol. They both at my request wrap their bags with the plastic I provided.

Jack approaches me sidebar from Alishia, David. Thanks for listening to Alishia. I should have tried more to convince her. I reply, its all good. Like I said, she is fiercely loves you both. She didn't give in despite knowing who I am. That's admirable. He smiles, I continue to be amazed by her. He then peeks suspiciously to his back, checking out Alishia. Then raises his hand to me inconspicuously. I saw a glimmer of something small and intangible in his hand. I grab it without looking at it. It felt like a small drive. He whispers, I made a promise to Lis about the communique intel. But not about the intel on files of Citradel citizens.

I am stoked to finally get my hand on this incredible data. I hastily put away the drive in my pocket, are you sure you should be handing me something so sensitive. He replies, I am. I don't know what people say about you, what's true or not. But I believe you won't use this data for anything nefarious. And you got us out and giving us a new life here. Consider this my apology for Lis. She just doesn't know you like I do. He really is a man of his word. I had messaged him to bring all the data he could before leaving Citradel. This was the one the crucial intel that I thought he couldn't get it. I say, thanks for this. I had a thought, just out of curiosity, does it have data about Heraknus. I know you said before you didn't know about them. But you had to hack into some database to get this intel. So maybe its there now.

He laughs normally now, not worried about Lis hearing us now. He leaves without revealing anything and helps Lis finish up the preparation.

Blake (Chapter 118)

Friday, March 20, 2026 17:37

Marina puts the tablet down yelling, is this right. We finally have a lead on those freakers responsible for creating that poison. I give her a grim expression. We are in my office room in my home. Marina jumps up from my bed and anxiously paces around a little, what are we waiting for then. Lets grab them. I raise my hand, we will. But lets be smart about it. I haven't told anyone, not even David. She asks, are you sure we should keep him away from this. I ask, you met him last night. How did he seem? She thinks for a second, he was brooding a little. But when we got started, he locked in. In fact, he is giddy about learning that Kuret technique.

I haven't spoken with since the call from the beach. I don't know what happened, but canceled the session this yesterday morning. When I messaged him about it, he told it was just a late start to the day. It is very suspicious, but he said its nothing serious. So for now I am chalking it to exhaustion. He has been training 14 hours everyday non stop for more than a week. He is bound to get hit by some blowback, even if he maintains his health rigorously. I say, didn't he tell us himself that he will be very busy with his training. What do you he do when he finds about this.

She sits back on the edge of my bed with a somber voice, he stop everything to get the culprits. I nod, he hasn't changed that much. He be distracted from his training. And right now, I don't want him to stress about other things. We only have a 11 days left for the match. She sighs, what if need him. I answer, then will tell him. Besides, we don't know if this women, Rebecca is really the one who made the poison. We have a very small thread connecting to her. Its a lead, but its very thin one. Marina grabs the tablet and reads her profile again.

Rebecca, an Kuret user that can produce static electricity, from a small community from Europe. Widower, husband died few years back and lives with her 7 years old son, Mark. She is currently employed in the cleaner team of sector 4. She has multiple jobs all over the island. Some jobs for private homes, few public buildings and more importantly, clinics, labs and hospitals. She doesn't have any medical training from Medrine, but Catherine's surveillance brought up an interesting background information. She worked as a lab assistant to a professor in some university called Haward for 6 years. Does that gives her enough skills to pull of such an incredibly complex chemical compound in Medrones, I have no idea.

However, she has access to labs all over the island and a modest knowledge in chemistry. That’s puts her top in our list of suspects. Marina asks me, what does Catherine think about her. I am hesitant to answer that. Its been few days I have a proper talk with Catherine. I shouldn't be so stubborn, but every time I tried to reach out, I pull back. I hate behaving such a way, but I can't help it. I am angry at her more than I care to admit. Even she could probably sense my awkward behavior around her. But she hasn't said anything to me. Does she think I will get out my funk soon enough. I get annoyed just picturing Catherine's talking about her human boyfriend.

I reply, I don't know. Marina scoffs, what do you mean you don't know. Didn't you share this with her. I sigh, you were their when she its basically a disjoint operation. We exchanged our list, so we do our own investigation. She says, dude. This is not a race. Shouldn't we let her know. I turn to my bedroom window, the night sky outside seems more peaceful than me right now. I say, its for her safety too. We don't know who these people are or what else they have. I don't want Catherine to get caught up in it. David may think she might be safe she isn't working with us, but do you want to really risk.

Marina had to know its dangerous for others. She squints her left eye, so that’s the only reason you have for not involving her. I remain quiet, Marina continues, don't think I didn't notice you both have been strange for a while. Did you both get into a fight too. I hastily answer, I don't know what you mean. Everything's fine. My weak lie wasn't going to fly with her. She crosses her arms, spit it out. Is still about her meeting that human boyfriend, Bob. I correct her in curt voice, Robb. And no its about that. She smiles, yeah right. You obviously seem fine. I get embarrassed a bit realizing that its now others are beginning to see it.

I got pressured by Marina's intense gaze and blurt out, fine. I am a bit angry at her. Marina nods quietly in resignation. I explain, tell me something. Is this a girl thing or am I missing something. How ridiculous it is that she is trying so desperately to hold on a doomed relationship. She says, its definitely a Catherine thing, that I am sure of. I thought they have been together all this time. Why are you getting angry now. I answer, its not like I was oblivious to that. But I assumed it would fizzle out. I get they have been together for years, but surely they thought it won't be the same anymore.

I want to hear another women's perspective. Marina pauses to think, I think she knows it’s a mistake, but she is dragging it out for that humans sake. I am sure she went with the thought of breaking up with him, but couldn't break his heart. That’s the same argument David gave. I really hoped Marina had a different opinion, something that makes more sense to me. I ask her the same question David discussed with me, why prolong this. Leading him on so cruelly. Marina smiles, maybe to her, breaking his heart is more cruel. I don't know, I haven't been in love like this. But there maybe some truth to what they say, love hurts.

I lean back on the chair. This is what I thought too. Catherine is scared of doing that. I ask, she has been telling everyone she is still in love with him. So couldn't it be that she is not leaving him because of that. Marina shrugs, I don't know. She might as be in love with him completely. She thinks for a second, or maybe she is trying to convince herself of that. She has been lately saying that a lot, like she is trying to make it a point. I jerk up, right. So she is being delusional. Marina stares a bit hard at me, wow. Okay, so we are throwing that word around now. What does David think about this.

I wave my arm to her, I think he has sort of given up on her. He says he helped Catherine to fix his mistake, but he no longer wants to meddle with her and Robb again. He also knows she is making a mistake, but has told its her choice in the end. Marina says, he has a point. I shake my head, sure, if she wasn't an omega. He has to know its imperative she remains with us, where we need every omega on our side. Not create a fantasy with a human. What happens one day she suddenly feels too much guilt and leaves. What do we do then. Let her go, because that’s what David will let it happen.

Marina says in low voice, that won't happen. She knows how important she is to us. I scoffs, but it could happen. Can you honestly say that will never happen. She stayed silent to my question. Marina tugs on her hair from her ear, maybe you are right. But at least for now, she isn't going anywhere. So lets not jump to any conclusion. I know what she said was partially true. But I can't feel it could happen as long as she is still hanging on to Robb. Marina than speaks very carefully, I am going to ask you something. So think before you answer me. Her sudden seriousness catches me by surprise. He clears her throat, do you like Catherine.

My finger twitch a little. I couldn't think straight for a second and then hastily replied, ah, what. I don't know what you are getting at. She speaks again, I mean do you like, like her. I scoff, I get what you are implying. Its not like, like that. She says, are you sure. There is hardly any difference between anger and jealously when it comes to this. I am so speechless. Now that I hear it aloud I feel even more embarrassed. Am I behaving like a jealous guy because I like her. No, it was just anger. And yet when am I so bothered when Marina points it out to me. I won't deny I have thought about it many times before. But its just flirting thoughts.

Marina stares at me while I contemplate on her words. I want to tell her she is wrong, but I feel that would just give more her more credence this nonsense. Marina backs off, seems you have a lot to think about. I didn't know you would be so shy though. Isn't it time you move on from Oriana. Nothing wrong with that. She smiles, well, except you had to choose an omega who is in a twisted relationship with a human. On the other you two would make a cute couple. A terra and omega. Hmm, I think more dangerous than cute. I ask her to simmer down, stop it. I don’t think of her that way. She is just a friend.

She chuckles raising her hand, whatever you say. She mumbles, guys can be so obtuse. I really didn't want to talk about Catherine anymore, lets not get distracted. You asked me a question, I answered. Lets not involve Catherine right now. We are Shadows, you think we need help from others? I goad her into so stops making a mess of my thoughts and feelings. Marina's isn't an idiot. She knows what I am doing, but she doesn't call me out. She sighs, when you put it like that, I can hardly deny that. Then what's our next move. We can't just sit and wait for Rebecca to confess she is involved.

I am glad we are back on track, right now, only we two know about her. I had some spare time this morning and ran the names against the list. I didn't get her name initially, but after I compared names in a secondary search. That's because she changed her name after arriving here. Marina says, its not really a surprise. Many came with baggage and want a fresh start. I nod, right. So that doesn't really help. I want to task our recruits for around the clock surveillance on her. Marina says, that probably the right thing to do. But shouldn't we at least check her out ourselves first.

I shake my head, and what exactly will that turn out. If she did make those poisons, she wouldn't have it in her house. And she doesn't really have a workplace. Marina says realizing the difficulty, that does feel like it wouldn't be productive. She works on contract basis over the city, so us following her, even incognito will be time consuming. Neither of us have that kind of time to spare. I ask, besides, we don't want to spook her. Lets tail her for a while, see who she meets or makes any suspicious movement. Marina says, I have an idea. I get that it would be a mistake to just grab her, but about testing her.

I feel intrigued by her suggestion, tell me more. She explains, we are flying blind and operating under many assumptions. While we tail her, lets see if she has the skills to pull of something like the poison. I ask, a trap. She nods with smirk, yeah. I have studied the poisons structure and behavior. I didn't have much to research after I was poisoned, but now we know more. I have a good grasp of the chemistry involved. And David already loaned out M to me earlier. I can use her discreetly for some of the minute details. I think she is on to something here. I ask, you want to trap her and see if she can figure her way out.

She snaps her finger, yup. Nothing dangerous, but I am sure we can cook up an elaborate trap for her. One she doesn't even know she is part of. If she doesn't figure it out, then we move on. But if she passes the test. Then. I add, then we know its her for sure. That’s good. Instead of waiting on our hands, we take the initiative. Any idea how to do that though. She picks up the tablet, she has a job that takes her in all sort of place. Trapping her in a lab or hospital setup would be too obvious and alert them. I peek at my laptop that that the same data, she has cleaning jobs in many houses. Maybe we target her there. Marina says, but where and how. That’s the question.

We spend a lot of discussing our options. We needed a place that we can control, something innocuous but also giving Rebecca access to certain chemical equipment's. Marina shot down my suggestion for a school we are soon planning to open. She knows about the place and said they don't have sophisticated stuff. So we had to keep looking at people's homes. Marina says, I would have preferred if this sting operation was in a officers house. But she has never worked even once on any officers house. I sigh, so we still need a regular persons house. Marina nods, more importantly, a place she visits regularly.

After spending more time we remain at an impasse. Marina and I began eating my dinner while we worked. While she chews she says, this would be much easier if we involved David. He is the brains of our group. He can probably figure this out much efficiently. I reply, I know. I also feel its kind of out our wheelhouse. But like I said. She says, I know, I am not suggesting to bring him in. Just saying we need his brains. I had a strange thought, or we just need to think like him. Marina laughs, yeah right. You and I have seen his training up close now. You think we can think like him.

I laugh, I know. I was just spit balling. Hoping to some inspiration. We review the list of candidate house again hoping to find the perfect house. Then suddenly she jerks, I got it. I ask her excited, who is it. She smiles, you got me thinking what would David do. So I thought how out of box solution, and yet a simple solution. I to ask her, were you thinking making a trap it in her own house. Because I thought about it too few times. Isn't that too risky? Marina shakes her head, not her house obviously. Plus we can't danger her son like that. We were thinking to make a trap in houses because that's part of her job. Since we can't do that, we should be looking when she isn't working then.

I catch her drift after realizing what she was looking in the tablet. She had all the routes Rebecca took over the past months. I say, interesting idea. When she is on the move. Marina nods, yeah. She travels in her own car, so what if she had an accidental car breakdown. I ask, isn't that a mechanical problem. What will that tell us. She says annoyed, hey. I am spit balling too you know. I have been staring at the houses, but none the people have any equipment with them that Rebbeca might use. So I am thinking outside the box. Something what David do.

Her idea is making more sense. We look at her routes. We looked at different scenarios and other possible events of trap we can trap her in. While looking at her routes, I accidently opened the profiles of her and the son. I had a radical idea. My brain juices flow and I jerk a little from my chair. Marina asks, you got something. I smile, maybe. You know how Alishia wouldn't let go of son until you met her. Marina is curious why I bring that up, yeah. I don't think she is particularly bad person. Just overly distrustful. I say, I was thinking along lines of over protective. Marina then peeks at my laptop that had the kids profile open.

Marina makes a horrifying expression, you aren't thinking of poisoning the kid or something like that. I rebuke, what. No. What do you take me for. I shake my head, I am saying we have fake an injury for a kid she finds on her way. She might be complicit in making that poison, but she is a parent. Any mother's maternal instinct would kick in if they see someone of her sons age in distress. She still has a scowl, whoa. Such a diabolical idea. I am a little

offended, its just an idea. We don't have to do it. Marina says, I didn't say it wasn't a good idea. I think it would work. I was just thinking its something David would come up with too.

I should take pride in that, but she is making it hard for me to feel that way. A while later we come with different plans. She then looks at the son, Hugo's photo, we make her believe some random child is in danger, and see if she can help him. I tell, the how is the bigger question. I am thinking we make it seem like there is no patrols around the area to help her. Marina adds, and no way to contact the emergency numbers. But how do we give her the tools to fake save a child. The plan becomes more practical after we look for the right place to do this.

A hospital is too convenient, she just get help from a doctor. A private lab would make her suspicious. Then Marina suggests a big pharmacy in sector 1, its close by to her usual route. There have numerous medicines, both the normal and Kuret kind available. They don't have a lab, just a kitchen where they make some rudimentary Kuritines. Its not the most ideal place, since it will still be suspicious. But we can make it work. Our plan begin to make shape. I suggested we do this with added restraints. We have one of our shadow recruits around the location, and them play the mediator role.

Marina says, I think I get what you are playing at. You want one of us to be there with Rebecca, so that she is lead to the pharmacy. That’s probably a good idea, we need to be up close at what she does. And obviously, none of us can do that role. I think she would be perfect for that job. She can be only talking about her. I nod, agreed. So now we need to find a kid to play this role. I joke, no biggie. Who wouldn't want to be involved in a sting like this. Marina says, you know who be perfect for this. Someone who wants to find out what we do and has a Kuret to turn into a young child.

I didn't like her amused by that prospect. Its true that Catherine would have been the most ideal person to act as the bait. But I already put my foot down about involving her into this. Turns out we didn't need to look harder. We both arrived immediately at the